

Marvel Reacts to Canon Issei Hyoudou

A 100-Chapter Reaction Fanfiction

The entire Marvel multiverse is pulled into an indestructible theatre and forced to watch the canon life of Issei Hyoudou, protagonist of the *High School DxD* light novels, via a supernatural gacha-pull system.

Version 1.1 — Repaired Edition

Canon-Status Legend

Label	Meaning
[CANON]	Adapted directly from the <i>High School DxD</i> light novels.
[DRAMATIZATION]	A canon event, expanded or staged for the theatre framing, not contradicting the source.
[EX-FUTURE]	A glimpse of the <i>High School DxD EX</i> continuity, a possible future roughly 30 years ahead. Not present-day mainline canon.
[ALTERNATE PULL]	A hypothetical "what if" simulation the gacha generates, not a memory of something that happened.
[ORIGINAL CROSSOVER]	Material invented for this fic's Marvel/DxD crossover premise (the Theatre, the Unwritten Devourer, the sanctuary universe).

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Chapter One: Every Hero, Every Monster

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers • X-Men • Defenders • Midnight Suns • Cosmic Entities • Ravagers • Villains • Gods

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Raynare's Date and the Spear Through the Chest" — **SSR**
 2. "Boosted Gear First Activation" — **SR**
-

One moment, Tony Stark was in his workshop, elbow-deep in a repulsor housing, telling FRIDAY that no, he did not want to hear his three o'clock reminders.

The next moment, there was no workshop.

There was a theatre.

It was the wrongness of the scale that hit him first, before the panic, before the suit-summoning reflex that found nothing to summon. The room was too big. Not stadium-big, not Chitauri-portal big — big in a way his eyes kept trying to file under *architecture* and failing, because the tiered seats rose up and up past any reasonable ceiling into a dark that wasn't darkness so much as a polite refusal to have anything above it. The seats were red velvet. That detail almost offended him. Something had folded him out of his own reality without so much as a light show, and it had upholstery.

And it was *full*.

Steve Rogers was three seats away, already on his feet, shield arm coming up around a shield that had made the trip with him. Natasha was a row down, perfectly still, eyes moving. Thor stood in an aisle with Mjolnir in his fist and thunder in his face. Banner was breathing through his nose in careful, counted breaths. Farther out — and Tony's stomach performed a slow, sinking roll as he kept looking — the crowd simply did not stop. Wolverine, claws already out. Storm with her eyes gone white. Charles Xavier, hands folded, expression carved from stone. Magneto standing beside him like the last twenty years of enmity had been postponed pending new information. A block of seats full of leather jackets and bad attitudes that had to be the Defenders — Luke Cage, Jessica Jones, Danny Rand, and a man in red horns who was tilting his head, listening to a room that Tony suspected had far too many heartbeats in it.

Blade. The Ghost Rider, actually on fire, actually seated, the velvet unburnt beneath him. A pale figure on a silver board hovering above the mezzanine like gravity was a rumor he'd chosen not to believe. A blue-skinned Ravager crew swearing in six languages. Loki. Hela. Victor von Doom, standing alone in an aisle as though the aisle had been built for him. The Green Goblin's laughter, high and delighted, from somewhere in the dark. And up in the highest tier, vast and motionless, a bald titanic figure whose only expression was a faint, disturbed frown: the Watcher, who by every law of his existence should have been watching this from outside it.

Uatu had not been *summoned* to anything in a very long time. His frown deepened.

The violence started about four seconds later, because of course it did.

Hulk happened. Banner's counted breathing lost the count somewhere around *there are villains in this room*, and eleven feet of green rage came up out of the seats and put both fists into the floor of the theatre with a sound like a continent clearing its throat. The floor did not crack. It did not shake. It did not acknowledge him in any way whatsoever, and the silence after the blow was so total that Hulk actually looked at his own hands, betrayed.

Mjolnir hit the far wall trailing lightning that would have unzipped a mountain range. The wall accepted the lightning the way a lake accepts rain. Doom's gauntlets poured emerald hellfire at the ceiling in a spell that had once cracked open a Celestial's armor; the fire simply stopped existing at a certain altitude, without drama, like it had been quietly asked to leave. Nightcrawler bamfed — and reappeared two seats to his own left, sulfur-scented and wild-eyed, because there was no *elsewhere* to go. Magneto reached out for the metal bones of the structure and found, to his genuine unease, that the theatre was not made of anything. Doctor Strange sketched a sling-ring portal in burning orange, and the ring closed on empty air like a mouth deciding not to speak.

"Stop," Strange said, and his voice carried, because he made it carry. He was standing in the central aisle, cloak restless around his shoulders, and his face had the particular pale concentration of a man reading a diagnosis he didn't like. "All of you. Stop. You're wasting your strength and my patience. This structure isn't warded against us." He flexed his scarred fingers, feeling the shape of the room the way another man might feel weather coming. "It doesn't need to be. We are not inside a building. We are inside a *decision*."

"That's very poetic," Jessica Jones called out. "What does it mean?"

"It means the exits don't exist because leaving doesn't exist," Strange said. "Someone rewrote the premises."

"Someone," rumbled Thor, "will answer for it."

"Aye," said Yondu Udonta from the Ravager block, whistle already between his teeth, arrow hanging dead and useless in the air beside his ear, "and I'm gonna be real interested to watch you make 'em, big fella, seein' as my girl won't even fly."

That was when the screen turned on.

It descended without descending — one moment the front of the theatre was a wall of red curtain, the next there was a screen the size of a sky, and every conversation, every threat, every half-formed alliance in the room died at once, because the screen spoke. Not loudly. It didn't have to be loud. The voice was flat and clean and belonged to nothing with lungs, and it printed itself in white letters even as it sounded:

SUBJECT SELECTED: ISSEI HYODOU.

A pause. The letters hung there.

"Who?" said Peter Parker, from somewhere in the middle rows, voicing the entire assembled might of a multiverse.

The screen did not explain. Instead, something new appeared beneath the words: a great slow wheel of light, sectioned in colors, ticking around and around with a sound like a roulette of destinies. Golden letters assembled themselves above it, one at a time, savoring it.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun. Rocket Raccoon, who understood exactly one thing about this situation, said "oh, you have *got* to be kidding me, it's a loot box," and then the wheel stopped, and the screen flooded gold, and stamped across the gold in letters that pulsed like a heartbeat:

"RAYNARE'S DATE AND THE SPEAR THROUGH THE CHEST" — RARITY: SSR.

"That's the top rarity," Kraglin said helpfully, into the silence. "Super-super-rare. Means it's the good stuff."

"The *good* stuff," Frank Castle repeated, very quietly, from the shadows of the back rows. He was looking at the word *spear*. He had already understood something about the shape of this evening that most of the room had not.

And then the theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

It was not like watching a film. That was the first thing everyone would say afterward, the ones who could talk about it at all. The screen reached out and folded them into the vision the way the theatre had folded them out of their worlds — unskippable, undimmable, no way to look aside because *aside* had

been repossessed along with the exits — and suddenly a few thousand heroes, monsters, gods, and killers were standing invisibly inside an ordinary Japanese town on an ordinary spring afternoon, watching a boy walk home from school.

He was seventeen, maybe. Scrawny in the way of teenagers who eat constantly and burn it all off doing nothing. Brown hair, brown eyes, a school uniform worn with the blazer open and the collar loose, a face that had never once played poker and never would. His name arrived in their minds the way names did here, without introduction: *Issei Hyoudou. Second-year, Kuoh Academy.*

He was, at the moment of introduction, being beaten with a kendo shinai by several furious girls for peeping into their club changing room, and he was crying, and his two equally bruised friends were crying, and all three of them were loudly agreeing that it had absolutely been worth it.

"Oh no," said Peter Parker.

"Oh, he's *that* guy," said Miles Morales.

"Every school has that guy," Gwen Stacy said, arms crossed somewhere in the shared dark. "Most of them grow out of it. Some of them get restraining orders."

The vision didn't argue. It just kept showing him, with a patience that began, minute by minute, to feel deliberate. Issei Hyoudou declaiming to the sunset, fists clenched, that his dream — his *destiny* — was to become a Harem King, while his friends Matsuda and Motohama wept with envy at a fantasy none of them had the slightest chance of achieving. Issei Hyoudou getting his scores back and hiding them in his bag. Issei Hyoudou, mediocre at literally everything measurable, loathed on principle by the entire female student body, walking home across a bridge at dusk with his hands in his pockets.

And Issei Hyoudou stopping, and turning, because a beautiful girl in another school's uniform had just called his name — his actual name — and was standing there with her hands clasped and her long black hair catching the last of the light, asking him, with a shy smile, if he would go out with her.

"No," said Jessica Jones flatly, cop-brained and cold, before the girl had finished her second sentence. "Nope. Look at her eyes."

"Her heartbeat's wrong," Matt Murdock said, very softly. He couldn't have explained how he heard a heartbeat inside a vision. He heard it anyway. "It's *calm*. She just asked a boy out and her heart's beating like she's reading a shopping list."

But the boy — and this was the part that would stay lodged under the ribs of half the room — the boy didn't see it, because the boy had never in his life been chosen for anything, and you could watch that fact arrive in his face in real time. Disbelief first. Then a frantic look over his shoulder for the person she must actually be talking to. Then, when there was no one, a joy so raw and so stupid and so *young*

that it was hard to look at. He spent the following days in a delirium of preparation the vision refused to compress: agonizing over an outfit, showing up an hour early, buying her a cheap pink scrunchie with most of his allowance because she'd paused in front of it for two seconds.

The date itself was heartbreakingly ordinary. A café. A cinema. Yuuma Amano laughed at his jokes. She held his sleeve. He walked like a boy who had decided the universe was, against all prior evidence, fundamentally kind.

"Kid's not even trying anything," Luke Cage murmured, brow furrowed. "All that Harem King noise, and look at him. He bought her a hair tie. He's terrified to hold her hand."

Sunset. A park, emptying out. A fountain, and the sound of water, and the light going long and orange and then failing, the way it does. Yuuma stopped walking. She turned to face him in front of the fountain, hands behind her back, and asked, sweetly, if he would do something for her, to commemorate their first date.

"Sure!" said Issei Hyoudou, seventeen years old, delighted. "Anything! What is it?"

She leaned in, past his burning ear, and the entire theatre heard her whisper as though her lips were against each of their own ears individually:

"Would you die for me?"

The temperature of a few thousand watching hearts dropped as one.

He laughed. That was the horror of it — he *laughed*, asked her to repeat it, sure he'd misheard, and while he was laughing she was already changing. Her clothes ripped away into a leather obscenity, her sweet face aging into something amused and infinitely bored, and out of her back tore two vast wings, black as an oil spill, shedding dark feathers into the fountain spray. She rose against the last of the light and looked down at him the way a woman looks at a mess she has been asked to clean up.

"Fallen," Doctor Strange said sharply, into the dark of the theatre. "Those wings — that's not a mutation, that's not cosmic. That's a *fallen angel*, but the resonance is wrong, that's not any celestial framework I've catalogued, that's not our—" He stopped. He said, in a much quieter voice, to no one: "That's not our anything. This isn't our cosmology at all."

Light condensed in Raynare's palm. It stretched, and hummed, and became a spear — a spear made of light itself, pink-white, spitting like a live wire.

"Nothing personal," she told the boy gaping up at her. "Blame God for putting a Sacred Gear in you."

And she threw it through his chest.

There was no cut away. There was no mercy of editing. The spear went in below the sternum and out the back, and the vision held, steady and close, on everything that a spear of burning light does to a seventeen-year-old body. Issei Hyoudou looked down at it. He touched it, confused, the way you'd touch a stain on a new shirt. His legs stopped answering. The spear dissolved back into nothing — light doesn't leave a blade to bleed around, it leaves a hole — and he folded down onto the gravel by the fountain, in the dark, alone, because she was already gone. Bored. A chore completed.

He did not die fast. He lay there in the spreading warmth of his own blood and his thoughts stayed audible to the theatre the whole way down, and they were not profound, and that was the worst thing about them. He thought that it hurt. He thought that dying like this, without a single girlfriend, was so pathetic he wanted to cry, and then he did cry. He thought about his mom and dad eating dinner without him and not knowing. His vision filled up with red — the sunset, he thought, or the blood in his eyes — and his very last thought, drifting, absurd, was that if he had to die looking at something, the red hair of the pretty third-year from school, Rias Gremory, was a nice red, and he wished—

The vision ended.

The lights of the theatre came up, dim and pitiless, on every hero and every monster at once.

Peter Parker was on his feet without knowing he'd stood, both hands laced behind his neck, walking a tight little circle in the row because his body needed to do *something*. He had held dying people. He knew the exact confused politeness of a scared kid going into shock, the way they apologize, the way they get *small*, and the screen had just played it back to him in high definition. "He didn't — she didn't even land. She threw it from the air. He couldn't have — even if he'd run, he—" He stopped. Miles was crying, silently, furiously, and not bothering to hide it. Gwen had her hood up.

Steve Rogers had gone very still, jaw tight, the stillness of a man adding a name to a list he kept somewhere behind his sternum. Natasha Romanoff was expressionless, which those who knew her understood was not the same as unmoved; she had clocked the tradecraft of it — the target development, the pretext, the isolation to a controlled site at a low-witness hour — and identified it, precisely, as a professional hit on a child, and filed the shooter accordingly.

Frank Castle said nothing at all. He had gone cold and quiet and economical the way he did before work, and anyone glancing at his face found it as informative as a closed door. Wolverine, three sections over, was much the same — claws in, now, arms folded, eyes narrow. He'd smelled the blood in the vision. He'd have sworn he had. "Kid never had a chance," was all he said, and it came out like gravel going down a chute.

Elsewhere, the temperature was different, and the difference itself became a map of the room.

Hela had watched with the mild appreciation of a connoisseur at someone else's gallery. "A clean kill," she allowed. "Wasteful theatre around it, but clean." Thor rounded on his sister with the thunderclouds building, and she raised an elegant eyebrow at him: "Oh, don't. You've killed ten thousand and mourned none of them. He's one mortal. They end. It's what they're *for*."

The Silver Surfer, hovering, said quietly, "I have watched worlds of such boys end in a single hour," and there was no cruelty in it, only the terrible flat perspective of the cosmos — and yet he did not look away from the screen, and had not, at any point.

The Green Goblin laughed his high delighted laugh at the spear, at the fountain, at *would you die for me*, and applauded like it was theatre because to him it was. Bullseye whistled at the throw itself — the rotation, the placement — with a technician's sincere admiration, and several people near him moved seats.

But Loki did not laugh. Loki, who knew more than most about wearing a lovely face to lead someone somewhere fatal, watched the boy laugh trustingly up at his murderer and found his own mouth had gone into a thin, complicated line, and was very glad the theatre's lighting was poor. And Doctor Doom had not moved at all through the entire death, arms folded, masked face tilted, because Doom was not watching a boy die; Doom was watching the *light spear*, and the words *Sacred Gear*, and the mechanics of a magic system his libraries had no entry for, and Doom did not like discovering that his libraries had gaps. "Strange," he said across the theatre, not bothering to raise his voice, the first words he had spoken since arrival. "You felt it also."

"I felt it," Strange said grimly. "Angelology as *infrastructure*. Weaponized divinity, standardized, mass-produced. Whoever built that cosmology built it like a government builds an arsenal. And that phrase — 'blame God for putting a Sacred Gear in you.' She wasn't being colorful. She was citing *policy*."

Up in the highest tier, the Watcher leaned forward by perhaps a centimeter. He had witnessed every death in his universe and the deaths of universes entire, and he was not moved by one boy in a park. What moved him — what genuinely, structurally disturbed him — was simpler and far worse: he had never seen that boy before. There was no branch, no timeline, no distant probability in all his ancient inventory that contained Issei Hyoudou. This story was not in his library. And he had been brought here, bound here, to *learn it*.

The screen chimed.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel spun again, ticking down through its colors, and landed on silver.

"BOOSTED GEAR FIRST ACTIVATION" — RARITY: SR.

"Wait," said Sam Wilson, "we're just — we're going again? He's still *dead*, can we—"

The theatre went again.

Night, now, in the vision. The park, the fountain, the boy cooling on the gravel with his blood gone black in the moonlight — and something in the pocket of his ruined blazer began to glow.

It was a slip of paper. A flyer, the kind handed out in shopping arcades — *your wish granted!* — with a strange circular sigil printed on it, which some costumed girl had pushed into his hands days ago and which he'd kept because a cute girl had given it to him. The sigil lifted off the paper in lines of red light, widened, and became a circle on the ground beside the body, ornate and turning, and out of the circle stepped a young woman.

She was Issei's age, perhaps a year older. She wore the Kuoh Academy uniform. Her hair fell past her waist in a heavy crimson sheet — that red, the exact red the dying boy had reached for with his last thought — and her expression, as she looked down at the corpse of a boy she barely knew, was not grief and was not pity. It was *interest*. Deep, dawning, acquisitive interest, like a jeweler turning over a filthy stone and catching, deep inside it, an impossible fire.

"So," said Rias Gremory softly, to the dead boy, "you're the one who called me. It seems you're dying — well. Already dead, really." She knelt, heedless of the blood, and studied him, and whatever she saw made her breath actually catch. When she spoke again there was something almost gleeful under the aristocratic calm. "I'll take you. Your life, from now on, belongs to me. Live for my sake."

She produced, from nowhere, a handful of chess pieces.

Red Pawns. Eight of them.

She placed one on his ruined chest. It sank in and began to glow. Her brows rose. She placed a second. A third. The vision felt her growing astonishment as each piece drowned in him like a stone in a well that had no bottom — four, five, six, seven — until she was holding a single remaining Pawn and looking at it, and at him, with an expression balanced exactly between alarm and delight.

"All of them," she murmured. "You need *all* of them?" And she laughed, once, quietly, a laugh with edges on it, and pressed the eighth and final Pawn into the dead boy's chest. "Then all of them it is."

Crimson light swallowed the park. The hole beneath his sternum closed. And in the darkness inside Issei Hyoudou, in a place deeper than his heart, something the size of a mountain range opened one slitted green eye.

The vision jumped — days, the system supplied blandly, *subject resumed ordinary life, memories fogged, attributed events to a dream* — and found Issei again at dusk, feeling strange, feeling *strong* after sundown in a way he couldn't name, standing in that same park because his feet had carried him

back to the place he didn't remember dying. And when a second fallen angel found him there and conjured a second spear of light to finish the sloppy job, Issei Hyoudou threw up his left arm in pure animal terror and *screamed* — and his scream was answered.

Red light detonated around his forearm. When it faded, his left hand and wrist were encased in a gauntlet — segmented crimson dragon-scale plate, golden spikes, and set into its back a round green gem like a reptile's eye, glowing from within. A voice came out of it, or out of him, or out of somewhere underneath the world: vast, gravelly, ancient, and unmistakably *entertained*.

[BOOST.]

Power doubled. Everyone in the theatre felt it double, because the vision made them feel it — the sensation of every cell in a body suddenly counting for two.

Ten seconds passed.

[BOOST.]

It doubled again.

The scrawny dead-last of Kuoh Academy, sobbing, snot-nosed, with no technique whatsoever, punched a soldier of Heaven's fallen out of the sky with one blow and stood over his own smoking fist in absolute incomprehension, and the ancient voice rumbled up out of the gem with something like a chuckle, unhurried, proprietary, speaking to its host for the first time:

[So you've finally woken me, partner. What a strange one you are. No matter. I am Ddraig — and you and I are going to get along fine.]

The system's cold text overlaid the image, clinical as a spec sheet:

SACRED GEAR: BOOSTED GEAR. CLASSIFICATION: LONGINUS. RESIDENT: DDRAIG, THE WELSH DRAGON EMPEROR. FUNCTION: DOUBLES THE WIELDER'S POWER EVERY TEN SECONDS. THEORETICAL LIMIT: NONE.

The vision released them.

This time the theatre did not go quiet. This time it *erupted*.

"Run it again," Tony Stark was saying, on his feet, hands already sketching math on a holographic interface that didn't exist, drawing in the air out of sheer habit. "Doubling. Every ten seconds. That's not additive, people, that's two to the *n*. Sixty seconds, that's sixty-four times baseline. Ten minutes and — okay, ten minutes and the number stops meaning anything, ten minutes is ten to the eighteenth. That scrawny kid is a *compound-interest bomb*." He turned around, looking for Banner and finding him. "Tell me I'm wrong."

"You're not wrong," Bruce said. He looked slightly ill. "The limit's not the gear. The system said no theoretical cap — so the limit is the *container*. His body. Which means the question isn't how strong the gauntlet is. It's how much doubling that kid can survive holding."

"The gem's an interface," Shuri said, leaning forward from the Wakandan seats, eyes bright with the specific hunger of a scientist confronted with someone else's impossible tech. "Did you see the latency? The activation ran on *emotion*. Terror-triggered. There's a mind on the other end of that hardware."

"There's a *dragon* on the other end of that hardware," said Thor, and his voice had changed.

People turned. The God of Thunder was not looking at the mortals arguing exponents. He was looking at the frozen last frame on the screen — the green eye of the gem — and his face wore an expression very few of them had seen on it: the sober, wary respect of a warrior culture's oldest stories waking up. "I have fought dragons," Thor said. "Asgard has slain them, bargained with them, buried heroes beneath their skeletons. And when that voice spoke, I felt it in my teeth. That is no beast. That is an *elder power* — something from the roots of its world — and it is *sealed in a dead schoolboy's arm*." He shook his head slowly. "Whoever imprisoned such a thing in a trinket for mortals to carry was either a god of terrible strength or a fool of terrible arrogance."

"In my experience," Loki murmured, "those are the same person." But his eyes, too, had not left the gem, and there was a covetous, calculating flicker in them that Thor knew of old and did not like. A dragon of the old kind, bound, portable, and currently wasted on an idiot. Loki filed that away with great care.

Down among the Midnight Suns, Blade turned a stake over and over in his fingers. "Y'all are missing the transaction," he said flatly. "Watch the girl again. Red hair. She didn't save him. She *bought* him. 'Your life belongs to me. Live for my sake.' That's not a rescue, that's a bill of sale, and the kid never got to read the contract because he was dead when he signed."

"He is correct," said a smooth, warm, appalling voice from a dark corner of the villains' tier, and heads snapped around, because Mephisto had been so quiet until now that many had managed to forget he was there. The demon lord was smiling the way other beings breathe. "And oh, it is *elegant*. Chess pieces. They've standardized reincarnation into a *game system* — rated, slotted, transferable. A Pawn's worth of soul, a Knight's worth, a Rook's." He steepled his fingers, and his smile widened into something with far too much delight in it. "But do attend to the arithmetic, little heroes, since arithmetic is what excites you. The pretty princess came expecting to spend one piece. Perhaps two. That is what a peasant costs. She spent *all eight* — her entire allotment, her whole hand of Pawns, on one lecherous dead schoolboy — and she *laughed* when she did it." His eyes gleamed like banked coals. "I have made markets in souls

for a very long time. When a buyer empties her purse without haggling, it is because she has seen what the seller has not: that the goods are priceless. That girl knows something about that boy. And now, so do I — he is worth more than she paid."

"Which raises the better question," said Doctor Strange, and though he spoke quietly the whole theatre bent toward him, because he was staring not at the screen but at the ceiling, at the dark above the dark, at whatever had built this place. "Not what the boy is worth. What *we're* doing here." He turned in a slow circle, taking in the tiers — Avengers and X-Men, devils of their own acquaintance and gods of their own pantheons, killers and children and cosmic constants, everyone, *everyone*, the entire strategic depth of an entire multiverse gathered into one indestructible room. "Think about the guest list. It didn't summon Earth. It didn't summon the Avengers. It summoned *all of us* — every hero, every monster, every power our reality contains — and sat us down in front of one ordinary boy from a universe even the Watcher has never seen." He let that land. Above them all, Uatu's silence confirmed it more loudly than words could have. "You don't assemble an audience like this for entertainment. You assemble it for a *briefing*. Somebody — something — believes that every being in our multiverse needs to know who Issei Hyoudou is."

"Or," said Natasha Romanoff, softly, "needs to know him *before* something. You don't brief an army on a stranger unless the stranger's coming."

The silence that followed had a new texture to it.

And into that silence, the screen flickered once — almost gently, almost *fondly* — and printed a single line of white text, unannounced, unexplained, in a smaller font than before, as if it were talking to itself:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

Then the words were gone, so quickly that half the room would later argue about whether they had really been there at all. The screen dimmed to a patient, waiting gray. The wheel of the gacha reassembled itself in a corner, ticking softly, idly, like a heart at rest.

NEXT PULL PENDING, it said.

In the highest tier, the Watcher settled back into his seat, folded his great hands, and — for the first time in longer than most universes had existed — waited to find out what happened next.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Raynare's Date and the Spear Through the Chest" — SSR (*viewed*)
- "Boosted Gear First Activation" — SR (*viewed*)

Secrets Revealed:

- The subject, Issei Hyoudou, comes from a cosmology entirely outside the Marvel multiverse — even the Watcher has no record of him or his world.
- His world runs on an industrialized supernatural order: fallen angels acting on policy, "Sacred Gears" implanted by that world's God, and Devils who reincarnate the dead via a standardized chess-piece system ("Evil Pieces").
- Issei's Sacred Gear, the Boosted Gear, is Longinus-class: it houses Ddraig, the Welsh Dragon Emperor, and doubles its wielder's power every ten seconds with no theoretical cap — only the limit of his body.
- Rias Gremory spent all eight of her Pawn pieces to resurrect him. Per Mephisto, that price is wildly abnormal and means she perceived something priceless in him.
- The screen's unexplained final line: "HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT."

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- Spider-family and street-level heroes: fierce protective grief over Issei's murder; his perversion noted, his kindness and harmlessness noted harder.
- Frank Castle and Wolverine: cold, quiet; Raynare has been privately marked.
- Doom and Strange: open enemies now trading professional analysis — a working truce of curiosity has formed around the unknown magic system.
- Loki: covetous interest in a bound, portable elder dragon "wasted on an idiot."
- Thor: sober, old-story respect for Ddraig's presence; unease at whoever did the sealing.
- Mephisto: delighted; treating Rias's expenditure as insider information about Issei's hidden value.
- Hela, Silver Surfer, and the cosmic tier: unmoved by the death itself — but the Surfer never looked away.

Unresolved Hooks:

- Why was this multiverse — every faction, hero and villain alike — assembled to watch this specific stranger? Natasha's read: you brief an army on someone who is coming.
- What did Rias Gremory sense in a dead boy that was worth her entire hand of Pawns?

- The contradiction planted and unresolved: the school's most pathetic pervert is also, somehow, its kindest heart — and something ancient in his left arm has already chosen him. Ddraig called him "partner." Dragons choose. Why him?

Chapter Two: Common-Rarity Pervert

Primary Reaction Groups: Spider-Family • Defenders • Street-Level Heroes • Sinister Six (Villain Block) • Deadpool (Uninvited)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Dragon Shot Misfire" — **Common**
 2. "Dress Break Prototype" — **Uncommon**
-

The theatre had learned, in the way crowds learn things, that time between pulls was not time off. It was time to argue.

Somewhere in the third tier, Doctor Doom and Stephen Strange were still dissecting the Evil Piece system in low, hostile, fascinated voices, like two surgeons fighting over the same cadaver. Two rows down, Loki had drawn a diagram of the Boosted Gear on the back of a program that had not existed until he needed one. Thor kept confiscating the diagram. Loki kept having another one.

And in the great middle bowl of the room, where the street-level heroes had clumped together out of some unspoken herd instinct — capes with the capes, hoodies with the hoodies — Peter Parker was doing the thing he did when he was upset, which was talk.

"I'm just saying, eight Pawns," he said, for perhaps the ninth time. "That's the whole inventory. That's showing up to a poker game and shoving your house keys into the pot on the first hand."

"You've said that," said Jessica Jones, who was slouched so far down in the red velvet that she was functionally horizontal. "Nine times."

"It bears repeating."

"It really doesn't."

Miles Morales sat between them like a boy between arguing relatives on a long car ride. Gwen Stacy — the one from the universe where the spider had bitten her instead — had her boots up on the seat back in front of her, which belonged to the Rhino, who had complained once and then thought better of it.

"He died," Miles said quietly, and the row went still the way it always did when someone said it out loud. "Like — we watched a kid get murdered on his first date. And I keep waiting to feel normal about the fact that the screen just... kept going."

"You won't," said Matt Murdock, three seats over. He wasn't looking at the screen. He never was, exactly, though everyone had privately concluded that the theatre was doing something for him, or to him — feeding him the pulls in whatever language his senses spoke — because his reactions landed at the same moments as everyone else's, sometimes a half-second early. "You don't get to feel normal about it. That's the point of watching."

The wheel in the corner of the great screen began to tick.

It was a sound the entire theatre had learned in a single evening, the way you learn a fire alarm. Conversations died in expanding rings. Thousands of heads came up — Avengers, X-Men, gods, Ravagers, the cosmic tier with its terrible patience, the villains' section with its folded arms.

The wheel spun. Slowed. Landed.

PULL: "DRAGON SHOT MISFIRE."

RARITY: COMMON.

The word sat there in flat white letters, and the theatre — which had cut its teeth on an SSR murder and an SR dragon — did not know what to do with it.

The villains figured it out first.

"*Common*," said the Vulture, and his laugh was an old man's laugh, dry and delighted and mean. He was sitting in the block the seating chart had assembled for them — Adrian Toomes, Otto Octavius, Flint Marko, Herman Schultz, Max Dillon, and Quentin Beck, six mid-tier careers arranged in two rows like a felony class photo, and someone in the theatre's design department had a sense of humor because the placard on the railing read RESERVED: SINISTER. "The cosmic slot machine looked at this boy's whole life and filed part of it under *common*."

"The dragon was the interesting part," said Doc Ock, whose actuators had been confiscated by the theatre but whose posture still somehow implied them. "The boy is the delivery mechanism. One does not review the syringe."

"Booooo," said a voice from everywhere and nowhere, which resolved into Deadpool climbing over the back row of the villain block with two buckets of popcorn he had no visible means of having acquired. "Boo this pod of hater walruses. That syringe has a *name*, Otto, and it's Issei Hyoudou, and he's my favorite character." He dropped uninvited into the one empty seat, between Shocker and Sandman, both of whom edged away. "Common pulls are where they hide the lore. Everybody knows that. Shut up, it's starting."

The screen bloomed with light.

It did not, at first, show the Dragon Shot. The theatre would come to understand this about the gacha: a pull was a destination, and the screen liked the scenic route.

The scenic route opened on Kuoh Academy at lunch hour, and on three boys crouched behind the kendo club's storage shed with their ears pressed to a hole in the wall.

"Oh no," said Peter Parker.

"Oh *no*," agreed Gwen.

The screen introduced them with floating gacha-style nameplates, as if they were characters worth introducing: MATSUDA — FORMER SPORTSMAN, CURRENT DISGRACE. MOTOHAMA — GLASSES DO A THING, DON'T ASK. And between them, radiating the doomed confidence of a man walking into a propeller: ISSEI HYOUDOU — SUBJECT.

What followed was a montage, and it was merciless.

It showed the peeping — always attempted, essentially never successful, the hole in the wall discovered within ninety seconds by girls who had clearly discovered it a hundred times before. It showed the kendo club emerging in full gear with bamboo swords already drawn, and it showed the beating, which was choreographed by the universe itself for maximum comedy: Issei taking a shinai to the crown of the head with a sound like a woodblock, Matsuda and Motohama abandoning him at flank speed, Issei alone in a cloud of dust absorbing what could technically be called swordsmanship.

It showed the PE class where he finished the fifteen-hundred meters last, behind a boy with a doctor's note. It showed the female student body's loathing rendered as an actual weather system, a cold front of contempt that moved through hallways ahead of him. It showed his grades, briefly, and Amadeus Cho made an involuntary noise like he'd been shown a crime scene.

And it showed the speeches.

There were, the theatre learned, a lot of speeches. Issei Hyoudou delivered them to sunsets, mostly, standing on the riverbank with his fist clenched against the orange sky, announcing to the water and the weeds and his two weeping friends that one day — ONE DAY — he would become the Harem King, and every beautiful woman in the world would — the screen mercifully compressed the rest into a montage-within-the-montage, because there were forty minutes of this material and it was all the same speech.

The theatre's reaction was not uniform.

Peter Parker had slid so far down in his seat that only his eyes cleared the seat back, watching through laced fingers with the specific agony of a man seeing his own high school years performed by an understudy with less shame. "I can't. Miles. Miles, I can't. It's like watching someone else's cringe compilation and it's *yours*."

"You were never like this," Miles said, and paused. "Right?"

"I was a different genre of loser. I was a *dignified* loser. There were books involved."

"He memorized three girls' class schedules and can't pass biology," said Gwen, flat. "The priorities alone should be studied."

Daredevil had his head tilted back and his jaw set, enduring the montage the way he endured dental work. "The worst part," he said, to nobody, "is that he means all of it. There's no act. No self-awareness to hide behind. Every word of that harem speech comes out of him like a confession." He exhaled. "It's the most honest voice I've heard since we got here, and I want it to stop."

The villain block, meanwhile, was having a wonderful time.

"THIS?" Electro was pointing at the screen with both hands. "This is the guy? The cosmic theatre kidnapped Galactus to watch THIS guy get hit with kendo sticks?"

"He is beneath notice," Doc Ock pronounced, settling back with the satisfaction of a man whose worldview has been confirmed. "A hormone in shoes. Whatever the screen believes it is foreshadowing, I decline to be shadowed by it."

"I dunno," said Sandman, slowly, because Flint Marko had been a nobody from Queens once too and something about the kid's stupid, hopeful face was bothering him. "He gets beat up a lot and keeps showing up. That's — I mean, it's dumb. But it's a kind of dumb I've seen turn into somethin'."

"It's a kind of dumb I've seen turn into a body," said Jessica Jones from across the aisle, and took a long pull from a flask the theatre kept refilling with something that was definitely not what she'd asked for. "Kid's got the survival instincts of a mayfly with a crush."

"BOOOO," Deadpool contributed, throwing popcorn at the entire villain block in a broad, egalitarian arc. "You're all watching the tutorial level and complaining about the graphics. He's got a dragon in his arm rated 'doubles every ten seconds, no cap,' and you're grading his cardio. Shocker gets it. Shocker, tell them you get it."

"Don't put me in this," said Shocker.

And then the montage ended, the light on the screen changed — dusk now, a forest clearing in the mountains behind Kuoh — and the actual pull began.

The clearing had been prepared as a training ground, which was to say someone had dragged a boulder into the middle of it and painted a target on the boulder. Issei stood thirty meters away in a tracksuit, left arm sheathed to the elbow in the red gauntlet, and the theatre felt the temperature of its own attention change, because the Boosted Gear was on screen again, and everyone remembered what lived in it.

"**Boost**," said the deep voice from the green gem, and the gauntlet chimed.

"Okay," Issei told the boulder, bouncing on his toes like a boxer who had seen boxing described once. "Okay okay okay. Buchou said gather it, compress it, release it. Gather. Compress. Release. Simple. I'm basically a cannon. I'm a sexy cannon—"

"Do not narrate," said the dragon, wearily, in the tone of an ancient being discovering what it had signed up for.

"**Boost.**" Chime. "**Boost.**" Chime.

Around the clearing's edge, the screen showed his audience: Rias Gremory with her arms crossed and an expression of genuinely maternal patience; the small white-haired girl, Koneko, eating a bun with the emotional investment of a security camera; the pretty-boy Knight, Kiba, smiling encouragingly from what the theatre noted was a carefully chosen position not directly behind, beside, or within a wide cone in front of Issei.

"He's pre-scouted the blast radius," Danny Rand observed. "The sword kid. Look at where he's standing. That's a man who has watched this before."

"That's a man who has watched this *several* times," said Luke Cage.

On screen, red light was pooling in Issei's palm now, and here the theatre's mockery began, very quietly, to curdle into something else — because the light was wrong. Not wrong like weak. Wrong like a garden hose attached to a fire main. It sputtered and flared and doubled with every chime, and the grass around Issei's feet flattened outward in a slow circle, and his arm had started to shake.

"Compress it," Rias called, with the calm of a woman coaching someone through defusing themselves. "Issei, compress, don't feed it more—"

"I've GOT it," said Issei, feeding it more.

"Kid," Peter said to the screen, sitting up, spider-sense itching at footage of another universe, which should not have been possible and was happening anyway. "Kid, no—"

"**Boost.**"

"ISSEI, DO NOT—"

He released.

What came off his palm was not a shot. A shot implies aim. What came off his palm was a red-black comet of draconic power that left his hand at a forty-degree angle to anywhere he was looking, because at the moment of release the recoil folded him backward like a lawn chair. Issei went one way — up, and then into a tree, and then through the tree, and then into a second, sturdier tree that stood its ground — and the Dragon Shot went the other way, over the boulder, over the treeline, and into the shoulder of the mountain behind the clearing.

The mountain lost the exchange.

The screen gave the theatre the courtesy of a wide shot: the flash, the delayed boom rolling across the valley, and the notch — a clean, cauterized, fifty-meter bite taken out of a ridgeline, glowing at the edges, rock running like candle wax. Birds departed the prefecture. Somewhere below, a dog began barking and did not stop for the remainder of the pull.

In the clearing, upside down against the base of the second tree, smoking gently, his hair blown into a shape that defied several laws, Issei raised one trembling fist.

"...Did I hit the boulder?"

The boulder, untouched, sat in the middle of the clearing with its painted target, radiating smugness.

"No," said Koneko, and took another bite of her bun.

The theatre made two sounds at once, and the sounds did not agree with each other.

The first sound was laughter — huge, rolling, tension-shattering laughter, the first real laughter this room had produced, because after the light spear and the funeral grief of Pull One, watching a teenager get folded by his own attack and put through a tree was medicine. Deadpool was on the floor of the villain block. Miles had his whole face in his hands, shoulders heaving. Even Jessica Jones made a single sharp sound that she would deny under oath.

The second sound was silence, and it came from the people who could do math.

"That was a Common," said Peter Parker, not laughing anymore, doing the thing where his voice went up half an octave and sped up. "Guys. The rarity tag is grading the *event*, not the power. The misfire is common. Him missing is common. The part where an untrained sixteen-year-old with no stance, no aim, and four boosts casually deleted a hillside — the gacha thinks that part is *unremarkable*. That's baseline. That's the tutorial number."

Down in RESERVED: SINISTER, Otto Octavius had stopped smiling somewhere around the wide shot, and was now watching the glowing notch in the ridgeline with the expression of a man revising a paper.

"Four amplifications," he said. "Doubling. So the observed yield represents a base multiplied sixteenfold — meaning his true resting output is one-sixteenth of a mountainside." He was quiet a moment. "And the instrument has, per the previous pull, no ceiling."

"So he gets less funny," said the Vulture, slowly, "every ten seconds."

"He gets less funny every ten seconds," Octavius agreed.

Mysterio, who had said nothing through the entire montage, said nothing now either, but he had taken out something that functioned as a notebook.

"Still a punk kid who can't aim," Electro insisted, but his heart had gone out of it, because Max Dillon had also once been a punchline with too much power and no control, and he knew better than most where that story could go.

And in the middle bowl, Luke Cage was leaning forward with his forearms on his knees, and he had noticed the thing the screen had wanted someone to notice.

"Run it back," he said quietly, to Danny. "Not the boom. Before. Look at his hands."

Because the screen, montage-style, was showing the aftermath now: and the aftermath was not Issei quitting. The aftermath was dawn — a gray, miserable, drizzling dawn — and Issei in the clearing alone, palms wrapped in bandage tape gone brown at the knuckles, doing it again. Smaller. Failing again, a fizzle this time, a shot that went eight feet and died. Doing it again. The screen time-lapsed through days: the boulder acquiring scorch marks in a slowly tightening pattern, like a dartboard learning where the darts were going to be. Issei asleep face-down in the grass with the gauntlet still on. Issei running the riverbank before school, wheezing, last again in PE that afternoon, but four seconds less last. Issei getting kendo-sworded on Tuesday and drilling stance corrections on Wednesday using, God help him, what the beating had taught him about footwork.

"There it is," Luke said.

"There what is," said Jessica.

"That's a kid with no talent," Luke said, "who has decided that's not going to be the thing that stops him. I've watched a lot of gifted people coast. Watch him instead. He gets humiliated at nine a.m. and he's back at the boulder by five. Every day. Nobody's making him." He sat back. "Powers are luck. That? That's the part you can't give somebody."

Jessica looked at the screen for a long moment. The time-lapse boulder now had a scorch dead center, one single hit, and on screen the idiot was celebrating it by screaming his harem speech at the mountain he had previously maimed.

"He's still a disgusting little creep," she said.

"Yep," said Luke.

"...Kid can take a hit, though," she said, into her flask, and that was as far as Jessica Jones went out loud for anybody.

The wheel began to tick again.

PULL: "DRESS BREAK PROTOTYPE."

RARITY: UNCOMMON.

"Prototype of what?" Miles asked.

"Dress Break," Gwen read off the screen, and her eyes narrowed with the premonitory dread of every woman in the theatre simultaneously. "I already hate it. I don't know what it is and I hate it."

The screen opened on the Occult Research Club's training ground, and on Issei explaining his new original technique to his assembled peerage with the pride of a scientist unveiling cold fusion. The theatre was not shown the technique. The theatre was shown Rias's face *hearing* the technique, which passed through polite interest, comprehension, horror, and a long, long pinch of the bridge of her nose.

"A touch-activated spell," the screen captioned clinically, in HUD text, "that unravels the clothing of its target. Instantly. Completely. Developed by the subject through days of dedicated, obsessive magical research — the first spell he has ever successfully created."

The theatre absorbed this.

"His first original magic," said Doctor Strange, in the third tier, with the hollow voice of a Sorcerer Supreme watching a toddler use the Book of Vishanti as a booster seat, "is targeted matter disintegration. Selective. Material-specific. Touch-ranged. And he invented it. For *that*."

"The discipline required to unbind one class of matter while leaving flesh untouched," Doom said, and it was the closest thing to respect Doom had produced all evening, which made it worse, "is not trivial. The boy has genuine arcane aptitude. He has aimed it at the single stupidest target in creation."

"That's the most terrifying sentence anyone's said in this theatre," said Peter, "and a purple guy with a glove is *in* this theatre."

On screen, the demonstration commenced. The Occult Research Club had prepared for science: a row of training dummies stood in the yard, dressed in secondhand uniforms, and the peerage watched from a distance the screen lovingly established was Kiba's Blast Cone Protocol, now adopted club-wide.

Issei snapped his fingers at dummy number one.

Nothing happened.

He snapped again. Nothing. He touched the dummy and snapped. Nothing. He hit the dummy, harangued the dummy, delivered a short motivational address to the dummy. The dummy remained fully and insolently dressed. Koneko, off to the side, wrote something on a clipboard. The screen zoomed on the clipboard. It said: *"0 for 11."*

"Oh thank God, it doesn't work," said Gwen.

The screen, which had a sense of timing, cut to: LATER THAT NIGHT.

A contract mission. A genuine fight — the theatre sat up — some minor stray devil in an abandoned warehouse, all teeth and bad intentions, and Issei actually holding his own now, footwork recognizably kendo-taught, gauntlet chiming, and the theatre felt the strange lurch of watching the joke start to look like a fighter. The stray lunged. Issei planted, caught its wrist to redirect it — textbook, Kiba-drilled, genuinely well-executed —

— and his palm flashed pink.

"Uh oh," said the entire theatre, as one organism.

The spell, eleven-times-failed, chose that moment to work perfectly. It just didn't work on the stray devil, whose hide, the HUD helpfully noted, *did not classify as clothing*. The pink flash ricocheted off the redirect, ran up Issei's own arm, and —

The screen cut, with the crisp mercy of a sitcom, to reaction shots.

To the stray devil, frozen mid-lunge, its monstrous face performing the universal expression of a creature that no longer wishes to be part of this encounter.

To Kiba, slowly turning to face a wall, shoulders vibrating with the effort of chivalry.

To Koneko, writing on her clipboard. The screen zoomed. *"1 for 12. Note: friendly fire."*

To Rias, arriving through a teleport circle at the worst conceivable moment, taking in the tableau, and removing her jacket and holding it out at arm's length without a single word, with the dead eyes of a woman amortizing eight Pawns over a very long future.

And to Issei's voice, from off-screen, from behind a crate he had achieved at speeds his PE teacher would not have believed: "IT WORKS. BUCHOU, THE SPELL WORKS, I JUST NEED TO FIX THE TARGETING—"

"DO NOT FIX THE TARGETING," Rias said. "DELETE THE SPELL."

"I'M GOING TO FIX THE TARGETING."

The pull ended on the stray devil quietly attempting to leave, and Koneko clotheslining it into the floor without looking up from the clipboard.

The theatre took a while to put itself back together.

Deadpool had to be resuscitated by Sandman, a service Sandman performed by gathering him off the floor and pouring him back into his seat like an hourglass. Miles and Gwen had achieved the stage of laughter that is silent and involves hitting the armrest. Even Daredevil was pressing his knuckles against his mouth, and losing.

"I want to be very clear," Gwen said, wiping her eyes, "that the technique is vile, he should be in jail, and the part where it immediately hit *him* is the finest act of cosmic justice I have ever personally witnessed."

"The universe said 'no' in real time," Miles agreed. "The universe has a targeting system and it's better than his."

"Twelve attempts," Matt Murdock said, and there was something underneath the amusement now, the lawyer's tone, the tone of a man reading a record. "He failed that spell eleven times and logged every failure and kept the data and kept going. It's the same pattern as the boulder." He shook his head slowly. "The content of what he wants is garbage. The *engine* under it never stops running. If anyone ever teaches that engine to want something worth having—"

"Then the mountain thing stops being funny," Luke Cage finished.

In RESERVED: SINISTER, the villain block had reached its official verdict, delivered by Doc Ock with a dismissive wave: "A clown. A cosmic clown with a lottery ticket in his arm. Beneath the notice of serious people. Wake me when the dragon does something."

But the screen's cameras — and the theatre had begun to suspect the screen watched its audience as attentively as its audience watched the screen — lingered for one extra beat on Quentin Beck, who was still writing in the thing that functioned as a notebook, and what he had written was: *material-selective disintegration, touch-trigger, self-taught in days, motivated by nonsense. Query: what does he build when properly motivated? Query: who does the motivating?*

The pulls dimmed. The wheel folded itself away. And the screen, as it had once before, flashed a line of text almost too fast to read — so fast that afterward, half the room would argue it had never happened:

COMMON DOES NOT MEAN WEAK. COMMON MEANS THERE ARE THOUSANDS OF HOURS LIKE THIS ONE.

HE SPENT ALL OF THEM.

Then: **NEXT PULL PENDING**, in patient gray, and the soft idle ticking of the wheel, like a heart at rest.

Jessica Jones stared at where the words had been for a long moment.

"Thousands of hours," she said, to no one. "Little creep actually did the work."

She put the flask away.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Dragon Shot Misfire" — Common (*viewed*)
- "Dress Break Prototype" — Uncommon (*viewed*)

Secrets Revealed:

- The gacha's rarity tags grade the *event*, not the power level: an untrained Issei vaporizing a fifty-meter notch of mountainside on four Boosts is classified "Common" — i.e., baseline, unremarkable, one of thousands of similar hours. Per Peter Parker, that is the alarming part.
- Issei's raw resting output, back-calculated by Doc Ock from the misfire (sixteenfold amplification at four Boosts), is already substantial — and the Boosted Gear has no ceiling.
- Dress Break is Issei's first original spell: self-taught, material-selective, touch-triggered disintegration. Strange and Doom independently assess the underlying aptitude as genuine and non-trivial — aimed at the stupidest possible application.
- The screen's second cryptic flash: "COMMON DOES NOT MEAN WEAK. COMMON MEANS THERE ARE THOUSANDS OF HOURS LIKE THIS ONE. HE SPENT ALL OF THEM."
- The screen appears to watch its audience back — it lingered deliberately on Mysterio's note-taking.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- Spider-family: peak secondhand embarrassment (Peter), but Peter is also the first to decode the rarity-grading implication and is now quietly frightened of the "tutorial numbers."
- Daredevil: pained by the montage but flags the pattern — Issei's honesty is total and his "engine never stops running"; dangerous if it's ever pointed at something worth having.
- Luke Cage: the chapter's designated believer — openly respects Issei's no-talent, all-grit training loop ("Powers are luck. That's the part you can't give somebody").
- Jessica Jones: publicly contemptuous, privately converted by the "thousands of hours" reveal; put the flask away. Will deny laughing.

- Sinister Six official verdict: beneath notice, "a clown with a lottery ticket in his arm" (Octavius). Unofficial cracks: Sandman relates to the nobody-who-keeps-showing-up; Electro sees his own too-much-power-no-control story; Octavius quietly re-ran the math and stopped smiling.
- Mysterio: the sleeper threat — took private notes on Dress Break's disintegration mechanics and posed the chapter's most sinister questions: "What does he build when properly motivated? Who does the motivating?"
- Deadpool: self-appointed Issei hype-man and heckler-in-chief of the villain block; insists "Common pulls are where they hide the lore" (and was right).
- Kiba/Koneko (on-screen): established as long-suffering comedy infrastructure — Kiba's "Blast Cone Protocol" positioning and Koneko's failure-logging clipboard (0 for 11; 1 for 12, friendly fire).

Unresolved Hooks:

- If mountain-deletion is "Common," what does this gacha consider Rare — let alone SSR? The rarity scale itself is now a source of dread.
- Issei declared, over Rias's direct order, that he will "fix the targeting" on Dress Break. The theatre awaits this with mixed horror.
- Mysterio's notebook: someone in the villain block is treating the broadcast as R&D, and the screen made sure the audience saw it. Is the theatre curating who learns what?
- Does the screen watch the watchers? Growing evidence that the audience's reactions are part of whatever this is.
- The Chapter One prophecy still stands unexplained — and the "thousands of hours" flash reads like the screen is building a case for it, exhibit by exhibit.

Chapter Three: The Red Gauntlet

Primary Reaction Groups: Tony Stark, Reed Richards, Shuri, Thor Odinson, Beta Ray Bill, the Wakandan delegation, Doctor Doom

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Transfer Training Session" — Rare
 2. "First Boosted Gear Scale Mail" — Super Rare
-

The theatre had settled into something almost like routine, which disturbed the more thoughtful occupants far more than panic would have.

Between pulls, the great amphitheater hummed with the low politics of a hundred stranded factions. The Wakandan delegation had claimed a tier of seats near the eastern arc and quietly fortified it with nothing but posture and the occasional flat stare from the Dora Milaje. Doom had a section entirely to himself, which was less territory and more moat. The Avengers held the center out of habit, the way people sit in their own living rooms even when the house is on fire.

Tony Stark had spent the intermission doing what he always did with helplessness: converting it into engineering. He had no lab, no fabricators, no satellite uplink — the theatre allowed nothing in and nothing out — but the armor's onboard suite still worked, and he'd burned six hours running spectral analysis on recordings of the previous pulls.

"Riddle me this," he said, flicking a hologram toward Reed Richards, who caught it with a hand that stretched four seats over to do so. "The kid's gauntlet. Every 'Boost' event, ambient EM in the recording spikes in a pattern. Not random. Not thermal. It's *periodic*. Ten seconds, metronome-clean."

"I saw it," Reed said, in the tone of a man who had seen it, modeled it, discarded three hypotheses about it, and slept ninety minutes. "The interval is too clean. Biological systems don't produce clock signals that stable. Whatever governs that gauntlet, it isn't the boy's nervous system."

"It is the dragon," Thor said from the row behind them, not looking away from the dark screen. He said it the way other people say *it is Tuesday*.

"That's not data, Point Break, that's vibes."

"It is *memory*," Thor said. "There is a difference, though you have never learned it."

Shuri, sprawled sideways across two seats with her kimoyo beads projecting her own analysis — smaller, denser, and, she would note to anyone who asked, arrived at without a billion-dollar suit — snorted. "You are both wrong about what matters. The interval is not the mystery. The *doubling* is the mystery. Show me where the energy comes from, then we can argue about clocks."

The screen chose that moment to wake up.

The whole theatre stilled the way it now always did, that ripple of a thousand conversations dying mid-word. The great golden wheel of the gacha assembled itself out of cold light, spun with its usual indifferent theatricality, and shuddered to a halt.

[PULL: TRANSFER TRAINING SESSION] [RARITY: RARE]

"Rare," someone in the Latverian section read aloud, and Doom's voice cut across his own retainers like a blade: "Silence. Watch."

The screen opened on a forest clearing at an hour no teenager should be awake, gray pre-dawn light and frost still on the grass. Issei Hyoudou was on his hands and knees, vomiting.

Not dramatically. Routinely. The way an athlete throws up when the body has simply been asked for more than it contains, wipes his mouth, and gets back up because the alternative is not getting back up.

"Again," said the small white-haired girl standing over him — Koneko, the theatre had learned her name in Chapter Two's fragments — holding out one small hand with all the ceremony of someone waiting for bus fare.

The green gem in the red gauntlet flared. **[BOOST]**, said the deep resonant voice the theatre had come to know, and a visible shimmer of power gathered along Issei's arm. He gritted his teeth, pressed his palm to Koneko's, and —

[TRANSFER] —

— the power discharged in every direction *except* into her. The grass flattened in a ring. A tree lost its leaves. Koneko received approximately nothing and did not change expression.

"You are pushing," she said. "Pour."

"That's the same thing!"

"It is not."

The montage that followed was, by the standards of the theatre's earlier viewing, brutal in a wholly new register. Chapter Two's training had been comedy — the running, the falling, the perverted motivational structures. This was different. This was *repetition*, the unglamorous kind, hundreds of iterations of the

same failure. Boost. Gather. Transfer. Spill. Boost. Gather. Transfer. Spill. Issei's hands blistered where the power grounded out through his own skin. At one point his nose bled from nothing but internal pressure, and he plugged it with grass and kept going.

"Oh, I *hate* that I respect this," Tony muttered.

"He is learning impedance matching," Reed said quietly, leaning forward, and now his voice had the particular hush it got when the universe was showing him something new. "Look. Watch the discharge pattern. Early attempts — the energy reflects off the interface between him and the girl. It's like connecting two circuits with mismatched impedance; the power has nowhere to go, so it reflects back and radiates as loss. But each attempt, the reflection coefficient drops. He's not learning a technique. He's learning to *tune himself to another person*."

"He's learning to give it away," Shuri said.

Reed blinked at her.

"That is what you are all missing, because you are all — " she gestured at Tony, at Reed, at the distant black silhouette of Doom, " — hoarders. Every one of you builds power the same way: accumulate, concentrate, control, *keep*. Your suits, your fields, your fortresses. This boy has a machine on his arm whose entire mythology is 'become the strongest,' and the first hard thing they are teaching him is how to hand the strength to someone else. Look at the design of it. Boost *and* Transfer. Whoever built that gauntlet built generosity into the weapon."

Silence in the science rows for a moment.

"That's..." Tony started, and then, uncharacteristically, didn't finish.

On screen, weeks compressed. The failures got narrower. Issei transferred power into a sword and the blade sang and held it; transferred into Kiba mid-sprint and the knight blurred into a line of light; transferred into a rock, which exploded, which everyone agreed was still progress. And then — one cold morning, on the four-hundred-somethingth attempt — he pressed his palm to Koneko's, and the power went *through*, clean, no spillage, no flare, and the small girl's next punch cratered a boulder into gravel, and Issei whooped like an idiot and got punched in the arm for it, and grinned anyway, blistered hands and all.

[TRANSFER: MASTERY THRESHOLD ACHIEVED], the screen noted clinically, and dimmed.

"Huh," said Sam Wilson, from the Avengers block. "Force multiplier."

"Say more," Steve Rogers said.

"I've watched a lot of strong guys, Cap. Strong guys who get stronger, whatever — that's a bigger problem, but it's the same *shape* of problem. You contain it, you outlast it, you unplug it." Sam nodded at the dark screen. "A guy whose power is making *everyone around him* stronger? That's not a bigger problem. That's a different kind of war."

In the eastern tier, Okoye said something low in Xhosa to General Ayo, who nodded once. Shuri, without turning around, translated for the room's benefit, because she was constitutionally incapable of not having the last word: "She said: 'One spear is a man. One man who sharpens every spear is an army.' Wakanda has a threat file open on him now, by the way. As of ten minutes ago."

"Wakanda has a threat file on a seventeen-year-old," Tony said.

"Wakanda has a threat file on *you*, Stark. Do not feel special."

The wheel came back before the laughter fully died, and this time it did not spin so much as *lunge*, gold light shading toward something hotter, redder. The theatre's ambient illumination dropped. Several people who had learned the system's tells sat up straight.

[PULL: FIRST BOOSTED GEAR SCALE MAIL] [RARITY: SUPER RARE]

"Super Rare," Loki read from his perch in the shadows of the upper gallery, tasting the words. "The machine is proud of this one."

It opened in the middle of a losing fight.

Context arrived in fragments, the way the screen liked to deal it: a mountain wilderness, night, and the air itself *wrong* — panes of distorted space stacked like broken glass, a barrier of violet-black geometry sealing off the battlefield from the world. Inside it, Issei's friends were down or pinned. And moving through the sealed space like smoke given a smile was a woman with black cat ears and golden eyes, power rolling off her in lazy, poisonous waves.

[SUBJECT: KUROKA — ROGUE NEKOMATA — SS-CLASS CRIMINAL], the screen supplied, and offered nothing else about her, which those paying close attention noted the screen almost never did.

"Spatial partition," Reed said instantly, on his feet, arms unconsciously lengthening toward the screen as if he could palpate it. "That barrier — she's folded a volume of space out of alignment with its surroundings. That's not a wall, that's a *topology*. You don't break that with force. Force stays inside the fold with you. Sue's fields don't do that. *I* can't do that."

"I can," Doom said, from his moat of empty seats. It was the first time he'd spoken to the room in an hour. "With three days' preparation, the correct grimoire, and a price I would not pay twice. The cat-witch does it while *bantering*, Richards. Adjust your estimates of this world accordingly."

On screen, Issei was on one knee, bleeding, boosted to the edge of what his body could hold, and it was not enough, and everyone in the theatre could read on his face the exact moment he understood it was not enough. The green gem blazed.

[Partner,] Ddraig's voice rolled out, and the theatre's acoustics did something unfair with it — it did not come from the speakers, it came from the *walls*, from underfoot, from the base of the skull. **[You know what to do. It will cost you. It always costs. Are you willing?]**

"Take it! Whatever it is, take the deal!" someone shouted from the street-level heroes' section, and was shushed.

Mephisto, alone in his velvet dark, leaned forward with his chin on his knuckles and smiled at the word *cost* like a sommelier hearing a good year.

Issei stood up. Said something the screen let them hear only as a raw, cracked-voice shout — a promise, the shape of it unmistakable even where the words blurred: *for them*. And the gauntlet answered.

[WELSH DRAGON — BALANCE BREAKER]

[BOOSTED GEAR: SCALE MAIL]

The armor did not assemble the way Stark tech assembled — no flying components, no nanite crawl. It *erupted*. Red plate flowed out of the gauntlet like the dragon exhaling its own body around the boy: overlapping crimson scales, a horned helm with burning green lenses, jets of raw power flaring from the back like the memory of wings. In two seconds flat, the flailing teenager the theatre had spent a chapter laughing at was gone, and something out of an old, old story stood in his place.

The theatre made a sound. Not a gasp — lower than that. The sound a thousand professionals make when a threat assessment revises itself in real time.

"Oh, that's *gorgeous*," Tony breathed, before his brain caught up with his mouth. His HUD was already going insane. "J— okay, no JARVIS, fine, doing this the artisanal way. Full-body articulated plate, zero visible joint gaps, manifested in under three seconds from a *wrist-mounted seed unit*. That's — I want to be clear, my nanite suit needs a housing the size of my sternum and it still has deployment lag. His deploys from a bracelet and it's *load-bearing everywhere at once*."

"It is not manufactured," Doom said.

"Excuse me, it's clearly—"

"It is not *manufactured*, Stark." Doom had risen. Against every law of his own theatrical instincts he had walked forward, down toward the screen, and the firelight of the projection slid across his mask. "Manufactured armor is imposed on the body from outside. That — " one gauntleted finger, uncharacteristically not quite steady, indicating the screen, " — is *conjured anatomy*. The dragon is lending the boy its own form, plate by plate, mediated through the Sacred Gear as a translation layer. It is armor as *incarnation*. Doom has fused sorcery and machinery for thirty years and Doom will tell you plainly: whoever engineered that gauntlet solved problems I have not yet finished *naming*." A pause, and then, with visible cost: "It is... masterful."

"Did Doom just compliment somebody," Peter Parker whispered.

"Write down the date," said Johnny Storm.

[Note the exchange, partner,] Ddraig's voice was saying on screen, conversational now even as power screamed around them. [While the Scale Mail holds, the ten-second law does not bind you. Boost as you will. The armor pays the toll your flesh cannot.]

"*There*," Reed said, snapping his fingers, and the science argument that had been simmering for two chapters finally boiled over. "There it is — did you hear that? *The armor pays the toll*. The doubling was never free. There's a cost function, and until now his body was the collateral. The armor is a *buffer*. Tony — the doubling. Ten seconds, two-x, uncapped. Say it violates conservation of energy. Say it out loud so we can all hear how it sounds."

"It violates conservation of energy," Tony said. "Sounds insane. Isn't, necessarily. Option one: it's not creating energy, it's a *tap*. The dragon's the reservoir — an entity that old could have a stockpile that just looks infinite from where we're standing. The gauntlet's a spigot with a very weird valve timing."

"Option two," Shuri said, beads flashing as she threw her model up between them, a lattice of light. "It is not borrowing from *somewhere*, it is borrowing from *somewhen*. Look at my decay curves from the training footage. When his boosts collapse, the energy does not disperse — it *vanishes*, below my detection floor, faster than any dissipation mechanism allows. Energy that arrives from nowhere and leaves into nothing. That is not a reservoir. That is a *loan*. The books balance — just not *now*, and not *here*."

"Option three," Reed said softly, "and I like it least, so it's probably closest. The doubling is real, the energy is real, and conservation holds — but the conserved system isn't this universe. Sacred Gears were built by *something*, embedded in human souls, and run on rules written above the physics we can see. We are ants arguing about the thermodynamics of a power outlet. The energy comes from the grid. We have never seen the grid. We have only ever seen the wall."

The three of them looked at each other.

"Table it," Tony said finally, which from him was a white flag with equations on it. "Live mystery. Top of the board."

"Agreed," said Shuri.

"Agreed," said Reed, who hated every letter of the word.

"Children," Doom said, without turning from the screen. "You are about to miss the mountain."

On screen, the boy in the red armor had stopped dodging.

He stood in the center of Kuroka's folded space, and the gem on his chestplate was chanting — **[BOOST] [BOOST] [BOOST] [BOOST]** — a metronome with the limiter ripped out, each pulse arriving on top of the last, the air around him beginning to bend the way air bends over a runway in summer. Kuroka's smile, for the first time, lost a few degrees of its lazy warmth.

He raised one clawed palm toward the barrier wall — and beyond it, incidentally, a mountain.

"Dragon Shot," half the theatre said in unison, because Chapter Two had taught them the words as a punchline. It had been a joke. It had gone through a hill sideways and terrified a farmer.

This was not that.

The blast that left his palm was a column of red so dense it read as solid, and the sound arrived in the theatre a half-beat late like the recording itself flinched. It struck Kuroka's spatial barrier — the fold in the world that Reed Richards had just finished explaining could not be broken by force, because force stays inside the fold —

— and the fold *tore*. The violet geometry shattered outward pane by pane like a cathedral window in a bomb blast, and the column of red kept going, out into the unsealed night, and hit the mountain behind it.

There was no explosion. That was the horror of it, the detail every after-action report in the theatre would fixate on. Explosions leave rubble. The beam simply continued, and where the mountain had been intersecting its path, the mountain *stopped being there* — a clean, glowing absence carved from foothill to summit, snow flash-boiled into a rising white halo, the topology of the region revised.

[TARGET BARRIER: DESTROYED] [INCIDENTAL TERRAIN LOSS: 1 (ONE) MOUNTAIN]

The screen held the shot: the boy in red armor, steaming, swaying, victorious, framed against a skyline that no longer matched its own maps. Kuroka, at the edge of the frame, was already leaving — but she looked back, once, at the thing in red, with an expression the screen lingered on a moment longer than it needed to. Interest. Reassessment. Something filed away.

Then black.

Nobody spoke for a while.

It was Beta Ray Bill who finally broke it — the great horse-skulled Korbinite had sat through both pulls in total stillness beside Thor, Stormbreaker's twin resting across his knees, and when he spoke his voice was low thunder kept respectfully indoors.

"Thor. You hear it too."

"Aye," Thor said. "I hear it."

"The voice in the gauntlet does not speak as a beast speaks." Bill's strange eyes stayed on the dark screen. "I have fought dragons of a dozen skies. Star-eaters. Burrowers in dead worlds. Mighty, all — and all of them *animals*, however vast. Hunger with wings. That is not what lives in the boy's arm. When it says *partner*, it speaks with the weight of one who has had ten thousand partners and buried them all, and chooses to hope again anyway. That is not a monster's voice, son of Odin. That is an *elder's*."

"When I was young," Thor said slowly, "my grandfather's skalds sang of the truly ancient wyrms — not the beasts we hunted, but the ones from before. The ones who fought over questions of *dominion* while our ancestors were still learning fire. The songs said such a dragon's presence could be felt through any seal, any prison, any— " he gestured around them, at the theatre, at the screen — "any *wall*. I dismissed it as skald's inflation. And then that voice spoke, and my hands remembered the songs before my head did."

"And it is *bound*," Bill said. "That is the part that should keep this room awake. Something of that age and that weight, sealed into a trinket on a mortal boy's wrist. Ask the right question, Thor."

"Who binds an elder dragon," Thor said, "and *why* — and how strong must the boy become before the seal is the lesser of the two powers in that arm?" He shook his head. "There is honor in it, though. Did you mark it? The dragon does not command him. It *counsels*. It asks 'are you willing.' A bound god who has kept his courtesy through the binding." He was quiet a moment. "I should like to drink with that dragon."

"You should like to drink with everything."

"And I am usually right."

Two galleries up, folded into shadow, Loki listened to all of it with his chin on his laced fingers and revised his own private ledger. *An elder power, bound, courteous, patient, sealed in a boy who gives his strength away*. Every word of the description was a lock, and Loki had never in his long life met a lock

he believed was addressed to someone else.

Down in the center rows, the mood had shifted in the way weather shifts — nothing announced, everything different.

Steve Rogers was watching the frozen final frame with the expression he reserved for footage he intended to memorize. "Chapter Two he couldn't hit a target ten feet away," he said, to no one in particular. "How much time passed between these pulls? Months?"

"If that," Natasha said.

"That's the number that matters. Not the mountain. The *slope*." He looked around the room — at Wakanda's tier, where Shuri's threat file had just acquired a second page; at Doom, still standing apart, still facing the dark screen like a man who had found a rival cathedral; at Tony, Reed, and Shuri's floating lattice of unresolved equations; at Thor and Bill, two old soldiers of myth speaking quietly of elder things. "Whatever the screen meant — 'the one who will stand before the things you cannot' — as of tonight, I stop assuming it was being dramatic."

The theatre's lights rose gently for intermission, indifferent as always.

The laughter of Chapter Two did not entirely die — someone in the back was already doing an impression of Issei's victory whoop, and it landed, and people grinned. But the grins were different now. It was the particular fondness that soldiers develop for a rookie the day they realize the rookie is going to outgrow every one of them, and the only real question left is whether he'll be standing in front of them or across from them when he does.

On its dead black glass, faint and brief, almost too quick to catch, the screen flickered a single line — and was blank again before more than a dozen sets of eyes could confirm they'd seen it:

[THE CAT WILL RETURN.]

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Transfer Training Session" — Rare
- "First Boosted Gear Scale Mail" — Super Rare

Secrets Revealed

- Boost operates on a mysteriously precise ten-second clock originating from Ddraig, not Issei's biology.

- Transfer requires "tuning" to the recipient — Issei's true early mastery is giving power away, not hoarding it.
- Scale Mail (Balance Breaker) suspends the ten-second restriction while worn; "the armor pays the toll."
- The doubling has a cost function; the energy source remains unidentified (reservoir? temporal loan? extra-universal grid?).
- Ddraig is confirmed, by Thor and Beta Ray Bill, as an *elder* being — bound, but courteous, and possibly stronger than his own seal in time.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Wakanda opens (and immediately expands) a formal threat file on Issei.
- Tony, Reed, and Shuri form a de facto research bloc around the "conservation problem" — mystery tabled, unresolved by mutual agreement.
- Doom publicly praises the Boosted Gear's design — his first compliment on record — and now regards the Sacred Gear's unknown maker as a rival intellect.
- Sam Wilson reframes Issei doctrinally: not a bigger threat, a *different kind* — a force multiplier.
- Steve Rogers stops treating the screen's prophecy ("he will stand before the things you cannot") as theatrics.
- Loki's covetous interest sharpens: an elder power in a bindable vessel is, to him, an addressed invitation.
- Room-wide: Issei graduates from comic relief to acknowledged rising power; the comedy survives, but the grins have changed.

Unresolved Hooks

- Where does the doubled energy actually come from? (Three competing theories, none confirmed.)
- Who built the Sacred Gears — and who bound an elder dragon, and why?
- Ddraig's warning: "It will cost you. It always costs." What was the price of Balance Breaker?
- Mephisto's fascination with debts: eight Pawns, and now a dragon's "toll."
- Kuroka escaped — the screen abnormally withheld information about her, lingered on her parting glance, and flashed: **THE CAT WILL RETURN.**

Chapter Four: His First Death

Primary Reaction Groups: Street-Level Heroes • Frank Castle • Wolverine • Midnight Suns

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Raynare's Betrayal Replay" — **SSR**
 2. "Asia's Healing Hands" — **Rare**
-

The theatre was still warm from the Balance Breaker.

That was the only way to describe the mood, and everyone felt it even if no one said it. Three pulls in, the room had begun — cautiously, against its collective better judgment — to enjoy itself. Tony Stark and Reed Richards had spent the intermission sketching competing models of the Boost mechanism on a napkin that Doom kept correcting without being asked. Peter Parker had started a betting pool on what the armor's next form would look like. Somewhere in the Ravager block, someone had figured out that if you complained about the concessions loudly enough, the theatre produced concessions, and the discovery had done more for inter-factional relations than a decade of summits.

The boy on the screen had been murdered, resurrected, humiliated, and then — mountain by mountain, boost by boost — he had begun to become something, and the room had begun, in its fractious way, to root for him.

So when the great wheel of light spun up for the fourth time, ticking around and around with its roulette clatter, the dread had mostly gone out of the sound. The wheel was almost friendly now. The wheel gave you things.

The wheel stopped. The screen flooded gold — top rarity, the good stuff, and a ragged cheer actually started in the cheap seats before the letters finished stamping themselves across the light:

"RAYNARE'S BETRAYAL REPLAY" — RARITY: SSR.

The cheer died in its crib.

"No," said Peter Parker, quietly, to the screen, the way you'd talk to a misbehaving vending machine. "No, we — we saw that one. We already saw that one. You can't pull the same—"

"It's a gacha, kid," Rocket said, and for once there was no joke riding on the words. "Duplicates are the whole *point*."

In the back rows, Frank Castle had gone very still. He did not swear, and he did not stand, and anyone watching only his hands would have seen nothing at all. But Matt Murdock, four sections away, heard the change in him — heard a heartbeat that had been a slow patient engine drop into something slower and flatter still, the cadence of a man closing all the doors inside himself in advance, because he knew exactly what was about to come through the walls.

The theatre took its breath, and swallowed them.

It was worse the second time, and it was worse for a reason nobody had braced for: this time, the vision didn't begin with Issei.

It began with *her*.

Raynare, three weeks earlier, sitting on a power line above a school crossing like a crow in a fetish catalogue, watching a scrawny second-year walk home below with his hands in his pockets, and the theatre was folded inside her boredom the way they had once been folded inside his dying. They heard her thoughts as they had heard his, and her thoughts were worse, because they were so *administrative*. A surveillance assignment. A name on a list passed down from somewhere above her: *Issei Hyoudou, possible Sacred Gear, observe, and if the Gear proves dangerous — remove him*. They watched her watch him for days, filing him under harmless, filing him under tedious, and then they watched the second order arrive, and they watched her decide — the way you'd decide to take the shorter route home — that observation was more work than a spear.

They watched her rehearse. That was the detail that would keep half the street-level section awake for weeks. Yuuma Amano practicing her shy smile in a cracked mirror in an abandoned church on a hill, adjusting it, softening it, the way an angler files a hook. Choosing the uniform. Choosing the sunset. Choosing the *fountain*, because the sound of falling water covers a lot, and because parks empty out at dusk.

"She built it," Jessica Jones said, hollow. "The whole thing. It wasn't even cruelty. It was *prep*."

Then the date again — compressed now, mercifully, the theatre skipping like a stone across water it had already drowned them in once. The café. The cinema. The cheap pink scrunchie, and this time they saw her side of that moment: saw her pause in front of it deliberately, counting two full seconds, because a target who buys you a gift stops checking his exits. The room made a low, sick collective sound.

And then the fountain, and the failing light, and the whisper.

The vision did not linger on the spear this time. It had made its point about the spear. Instead — and this was the new cruelty, the SSR cruelty, the reason for the gold — as the boy folded down onto the gravel, the frame *split*. Half the screen stayed with him, bleeding out under the fountain spray with his small,

unprofound, unbearable last thoughts. The other half followed Raynare into the sky, and stayed with her, and let the theatre hear that her mind had already moved on. Not to guilt. Not even to satisfaction. To *dinner*. To a mild complaint about the humidity. To the next item on her list, which — the vision let this hang for one poisonous second before it faded — was a name the theatre didn't recognize yet: *the Argento girl arrives Tuesday*.

And beneath both halves, small, at the bottom of the frame, like a footnote: a kitchen in a suburban house, and a mother setting a third place at the table, and leaving it set, and looking at the clock.

The vision ended.

Nobody spoke for a long time. The theatre's ambient light came up soft and reddish, the house lights of a place that had learned, apparently, something like tact.

Matt Murdock had his elbows on his knees and his face in his hands.

"I keep listening to it," he said finally, to Foggy's ghost, to Father Lantom's ghost, to nobody in the seats around him, though Luke and Jessica and Danny were all close enough to hear. "Her heart. It never moved. Three weeks, a whole — a whole *courtship*, and it never once moved. I've listened to killers my entire life. The worst ones spike when they do it. Something in the body knows, even when the man doesn't." He lifted his head, and behind the round dark glasses his ruined eyes were aimed at the dark screen like an accusation. "Hers didn't. That wasn't a murder to her. It was a *chore*. Somebody upstream wrote a memo, and a seventeen-year-old bled out by a fountain, and her pulse never moved."

"Orders," Luke Cage said heavily. "You catch that? *Observe, and if the Gear proves dangerous*. Somebody signed off on that kid."

"Somebody always signs off," said Jessica.

Three rows back and a world away, Logan sat with his forearms on the seat in front of him, and the claws were not out, and somehow that was worse. The people who knew him best — and Kurt Wagner, sitting beside him, knew him best — understood that Logan with the claws out was Logan handling it.

"Kid asked her to repeat it," Logan said at last, low, gravel dragged over gravel. "You clock that? *Would you die for me* — and he laughs, and he asks her to say it again. Because it ain't in him yet. The thing that hears the question under the question." He turned his head slightly; the reddish light caught the old, old fatigue in his face. "I've died more times than anybody in this room's had birthdays, and I'll tell you the part they never put in the reports: the first one's the only one that's *yours*. Every death after, some piece of you saw it comin'. The first one gets taken *from* you." A pause. "They took his in a park. On his first date. Over a memo."

"Logan—" Kurt began gently.

"An' one more thing." Logan's voice didn't rise. It sank, which from Logan was the dangerous direction. "*Blame God for putting a Sacred Gear in you.* That's what she says to him. That's the exit line. Kid gets born with somethin' in his arm he never asked for, never even heard of, and the people who *did* know decide that's a killin' offense." His jaw worked once. "I know that story. They ran that program on me. Called it Weapon X 'stead of Sacred Gear, but it's the same damn memo."

Nobody had anything to say to that.

Frank Castle said nothing at all, and that was its own event, and the people nearest him were careful not to make it one. He had watched the split screen to its end — had watched the half with the boy, and the half with the bored departing killer, and the footnote with the mother and the third plate — without moving. It was the fountain that did it, if anything did. He had been in a park once, on an ordinary bright day, with a carousel instead of a fountain, and he knew with a precision no one else in the building could match exactly how long the walk home takes for the family of someone who dies in a park because of business conducted over their head. He knew about the plate left set. He knew about the clock.

Karen Page — several seats down, watching him sidelong the way you watch weather — saw his lips move once, silently, and could not read them. Matt, who could hear a whisper across a stadium, could. It was two words, and the first one was a number.

"*Twice now*," Frank Castle said, to Raynare, wherever she was, in whatever cosmology. He had marked her in Chapter One's darkness, quietly, a name added to the ledger he kept where other men kept prayers. The replay had not changed the entry. It had underlined it.

Up in the Midnight Suns' block, the Ghost Rider was burning about a foot taller than usual, and Blade had shifted one seat away with the unhurried pragmatism of a man whose coat was flammable.

"Predator pattern," Blade said, to the group, clipped and clinical, because clinical was how he stayed level. "Textbook. Surveil, groom, isolate, kill, exit. I've dusted vampires who ran that exact play for four hundred years." His jaw tightened. "Difference is, they needed to eat."

"She didn't hunger," the Rider said. Its voice was the sound of a furnace door. The flame bent, all of it, toward the dark screen, as though something up there might catch. "There is no hunger in her to punish. Only *convenience*. Innocent blood, spilled to shorten a workday." The empty sockets flared white. "She will look into my eyes. In this universe or that one. It is already true; it is merely not yet *happened*."

Illyana Rasputina sat at the end of the row with her legs crossed and the Soulsword loose across her knees, and she had watched the grooming — the rehearsed smile, the counted seconds at the scrunchie stand — with the flat, ancient expression of a woman auditing a demon's homework.

"Limbo would have been kinder," she said, to no one in particular. "In Limbo, at least, the thing that lures a child *looks* like a monster if you squint. She practiced her face in a mirror." A beat. "I was taken by an expert too. I recognize the workmanship."

And that might have been where the room stayed — down in the cold, with the ledger-keepers and the mourners — except that the screen, which had a showman's instincts and a torturer's timing, chose that exact moment to spin the wheel again.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel ticked around, and around, and stopped on a modest, unassuming silver-green. No gold. No fanfare.

"ASIA'S HEALING HANDS" — RARITY: RARE.

"*The Argento girl arrives Tuesday*," Matt Murdock quoted softly, going cold. "That's her. That's the next name on the list."

The theatre took its breath.

She was small, and blonde, and she thanked the train conductor twice, and she got lost immediately.

The theatre watched Asia Argento arrive in Kuoh with one battered suitcase and a nun's habit and a sense of direction that could most charitably be described as devotional — as though she trusted every street to be the right one — and the room, wrung out and raw, did not know what to do with her. She was sixteen. She apologized to a vending machine. When the wind took her veil, the boy who caught it for her — brown hair, brown eyes, a face that had never once played poker — handed it back and got a smile of such undefended sweetness that the entire audience heard Issei Hyoudou's internal monologue *stall*, and for once, not a single lecherous thought crawled out of the wreckage. He walked her to the church road. She healed the scraped knee of a crying boy in the park on the way — green light, warm as an oath, pooling from her ringed hands, and the wound closed like it was being forgiven.

Twilight Healing, the vision supplied. *Sacred Gear. Rarity: exceptional.*

"Oh no," said Kamala Khan, from the middle rows, in the voice of someone who had read enough stories to know what narrative sweetness this concentrated was *for*.

Because then the vision gave them her past, and it did it the way it had given them Raynare's preparation: patiently.

An infant left on the steps of a church. A little girl raised by nuns, devout the way only the abandoned are devout — loving the institution with her whole chest because the institution was the only thing that had ever picked her up. Eight years old, and a dying puppy healed in her cupped hands, and the sisters

weeping, and the word *miracle*, and then the word *holy maiden*, and pilgrim lines around the block. They watched her heal the sick for years and take no coin and want nothing except to be useful to the God who had, as she understood it, saved her first.

And then they watched a wounded man stagger into her chapel after hours, bleeding badly, and they watched her heal him because he was bleeding and she could stop it — and they watched the wings come out of his back afterward, black-feathered, and the *thank you* he sneered on his way out the broken window.

And they watched the Church find out.

It was very fast. That was the obscenity of it — the deliberation took less time than her average healing. Her power worked on Devils. Therefore her power was not a miracle but a *defect*. Therefore the maiden was not holy but a witch, a heretic, an instrument of corruption wearing a saint's face. The theatre watched men in fine vestments, men she had called Father, explain to a sixteen-year-old that the gift they had built pilgrim lines around was proof of her impurity, because mercy — *their* mercy, correctly administered — was supposed to check credentials first. They watched her cast out with her one suitcase. They watched doors close, and then a whole continent of doors, and they watched her keep praying anyway, every night, to the God whose ground crew had thrown her away, thanking Him for the day.

They watched the only hands extended to her afterward belong to fallen angels. To a congregation squatting in an abandoned church on a hill above Kuoh — a building with a cracked mirror in it that half the theatre recognized with a full-body chill.

The vision surfaced, briefly, into the present: Issei Hyoudou, hearing this story from Asia over a shared lunch she was visibly rationing to make last, on the happiest afternoon of her entire remembered life because someone her own age had bought her food and asked her questions. And the room got to watch, from the inside, the exact moment the boy's newborn devil heart — perverted, ridiculous, unkillably kind — did the arithmetic on everything she wasn't saying, and arrived at a fury so clean and so total that Ddraig stirred in his arm like a banked fire feeling wind.

She heals people, the boy was thinking, over and over, stuck on it, unable to move past it. *That's the whole crime. She heals people TOO WELL. Who does that? Who throws away a person for that? I'll — she's going to have friends. She's going to have so many friends. Starting with me. Whatever's up on that hill, whatever they want her for—*

The vision ended there. Mid-fury. Deliberately.

Kurt Wagner was on his feet before the house lights finished coming up.

He didn't say anything at first. He stood in the aisle with his tail lashing slowly, a devout man with a demon's face and a rosary wrapped twice around his three-fingered hand, and everyone near enough to see him understood that they were watching a man have an argument with himself and lose in both directions.

"I want to say," he began finally, and his voice carried the way a trained acrobat's voice carries, up and out, "that this is not my Church. And it isn't. Wrong cosmology, wrong Heaven, wrong — everything. Their God apparently issues *equipment*." A ripple of weak laughter; he let it die. "But I would be lying before God — mine, anyone's — if I pretended I did not recognize the *shape* of it. An institution built to carry mercy, deciding instead to *ration* it. I have been the thing on the wrong side of that door, my friends. I have the face for it." He held up the rosary. "And I keep this anyway. So I need to say the rest out loud, or it will stay in my chest all night: they did not cast her out for healing devils. They cast her out because her mercy did not stop where their map did. And mercy that stops where the map stops—" his voice dropped, "—is not mercy. It is *policy*."

"Amen," said, of all people, Jessica Jones.

Matt Murdock stood up slowly, one hand on the seatback, and the room made space for him the way rooms did.

"I've spent my whole life," he said, "afraid that God keeps a ledger on me. Who I saved. Who I hit. Whether I enjoyed it. Every confession, I'm — negotiating the line items." A humorless breath. "And the one thing I never doubted, the *floor* under all of it, was that grace doesn't check ID. That it lands on the just and the unjust like rain, that's the whole — that's the *point*, that's the scandal of it, that's why it's good news and not a rewards program." He turned his blind eyes toward the dark screen, toward the memory of men in vestments. "That little girl is the only person in her entire story who understood her own religion. They excommunicated the one working part."

"Okay, but can I—" Kamala Khan was standing now too, hand half-raised out of sheer classroom reflex before she caught herself and put it down, cheeks flaming, voice steadying as she went, because this was the one subject on which she never wobbled. "I'm not Catholic, obviously, I'm coming at this from a whole different direction, but we have this teaching — it's in the Quran, my dad had it on the wall — that if you save one life, it's as if you saved all of mankind. *One life*. It doesn't come with an asterisk. There's no footnote that says *terms and conditions apply, check species first*." She looked around at the assembled multiverse, sixteen years old and absolutely unintimidated by it, because being right does that. "She's a kid. Adults built a whole system, and pointed it at a kid, and when the system met one person it couldn't categorize, it decided *she* was the malfunction. That's not faith. Faith is what *she's* still doing — praying to a God whose middle management fired her. That's the strongest person we've seen on that screen, and I'm including the guy who erased a mountain."

From the Midnight Suns' block, the furnace-door voice.

"You are all arguing about the girl," the Ghost Rider said. "The girl requires no argument. The flame does not even *flicker* toward her — do you understand what that means? I have looked at saints and found sin. There is none in her. None." The skull turned, slowly, toward the screen. "But the men who cast her out fed a healer to the fallen and called it doctrine. And innocent blood does not care what collar the guilty wear." The flames leaned. "I have penance enough for a parish."

"Get in line," said Frank Castle, from the back, not loudly.

It was the first thing he'd said aloud all chapter, and the room heard it, and nobody laughed, because it hadn't been a joke. He was looking at the screen with the patient, terrible attention he had once reserved for dockyards and cartel warehouses, and he was thinking about a girl with a suitcase who had been thrown away by every structure that existed to protect her, and about the next name on a bored killer's list, and about the words *the Argento girl arrives Tuesday*, and the ledger where he kept names had, without ceremony, gained a second column.

Blade broke the silence, dry as dust. "For what it's worth — I've burned churches like that abandoned one before. The kind that keeps a congregation of fallen things and one innocent girl they're saving for *something*." He let that word sit there, doing its work. "They're never saving her for nothing."

"He knows," Logan said.

Everyone looked at him.

"The kid." Logan nodded at the screen, at the fury the vision had ended on. "You heard him. *Whatever's up on that hill*. He's got a two-week-old resurrection, one arm that works right, and a hit squad of fallen angels between him and a girl he met at *lunch*." The old man almost smiled, and it was the first warm thing in the theatre in an hour. "And he's goin' anyway. Tonight, if I read him right."

The screen, showman to its bones, chose that moment to flicker.

One frame only, white on black, gone almost before it landed — the same handwriting, so to speak, as the message from before, *HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT*. This one was shorter. This one said:

NEXT: THE CHURCH ON THE HILL.

And underneath it, small, in the corner, like a countdown that had already started:

TUESDAY.

Somewhere in the dark, Kurt Wagner began, very quietly, to pray — for a girl in another cosmology, to a God who he had to believe was bigger than any one map. Kamala Khan, who prayed differently, prayed too. Frank Castle did not pray. He waited, the way he was built to, for Tuesday.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Raynare's Betrayal Replay" — SSR (duplicate pull; extended cut with Raynare's perspective, surveillance timeline, and kill order)
- "Asia's Healing Hands" — Rare (Asia Argento introduced; Twilight Healing revealed; Church exile backstory shown)

Secrets Revealed

- Issei's murder was ordered from above Raynare — a surveillance memo escalated to a kill order over his Sacred Gear; the betrayal was institutional, rehearsed, and premeditated down to the scrunchie.
- Raynare's task list contained a second name: "the Argento girl arrives Tuesday." Asia was a target before she ever reached Kuoh.
- Asia's Twilight Healing works on humans, Devils, and fallen angels alike — the sole basis for her excommunication and persecution by her Church.
- The fallen angels squatting in the abandoned hill church (Raynare's rehearsal site) are the ones who took Asia in — and Blade's read says they're "saving her for something."

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Frank Castle's ledger entry on Raynare is underlined ("Twice now") and gains a second column: Asia's protection. He said almost nothing; everyone noticed.
- Wolverine explicitly identifies Issei with himself — "Sacred Gear" as another Weapon X memo — shifting from observer to invested.
- Daredevil, Nightcrawler, and Kamala Khan converge across three faith traditions on the same verdict: Asia is the only person in her story practicing her own religion correctly. Nightcrawler publicly disowns the "shape" of the institution while keeping his rosary.
- Ghost Rider confirms Asia is entirely without sin — a first — and marks the churchmen and the fallen congregation for judgment. Blade and Magik align behind him; the Midnight Suns are now collectively watching the hill church, not the boy.

- The street-level section, rung out by the replay's split-screen (the mother's third table setting), has fully closed ranks around Issei.

Unresolved Hooks

- The rescue has only begun: Issei is moving on the hill church with a two-week-old resurrection and half-mastered power — the screen cut away mid-fury, before the doors.
- What the fallen angels are "saving" Asia for remains unspoken on-screen (the theatre suspects; no one has said the word "extraction" yet).
- Who upstream issued Raynare's kill order — and whether the same authority flagged Asia — is unrevealed.
- The screen's new message: "NEXT: THE CHURCH ON THE HILL" and a countdown reading "TUESDAY."
- Frank Castle and Wolverine's marks on Raynare still stand — and the theatre has no known way to act on anything it watches. Yet.

Chapter Five: The Boy Who Returned

Primary Reaction Groups: Doctor Strange & the Mystic Arts Contingent (Scarlet Witch • Doctor Voodoo • Clea) • Asgardians

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Resurrection by Rias" — **SR**
 2. "Sacred Gear 101" — **UC**
-

The theatre had moods. Everyone had learned to read them by now, the way sailors learn a sea.

After the Asia Argento pull, the mood had been an argument — a low ecclesiastical thunderstorm rolling through the rows where Nightcrawler and Daredevil and Kamala Khan sat, with the Ghost Rider burning quietly at its edge like a votive candle with opinions. That storm had not finished. It had merely been tabled, the way everything here was tabled, because the wheel had begun to tick again, and the wheel outranked God, grief, and Matt Murdock's cross-examination voice, in that order.

The wheel slowed. Stopped. The screen went a deep, arterial crimson, and gold letters stamped themselves across it with the smugness of a dealer turning over the river card.

"RESURRECTION BY RIAS" — RARITY: SR.

"A rerun?" Rocket said, disgusted. "We saw the kid die. We saw the chess pieces. I want my pull back."

"It is not a rerun," said Doctor Strange, and something in his tone made half the mezzanine turn. He had come down over the past few sessions from wherever he'd first landed, and now he sat front and center of what the theatre's population had started calling the wizard block: Wong-less, home-less, but flanked. Clea sat at his right, silver-haired and faintly luminous, a piece of the Dark Dimension wearing a person the way other people wear coats. Jericho Drumm — Doctor Voodoo, Sorcerer Supreme once himself, and never once allowed to forget he'd had the job — sat at his left with the staff of Legba across his knees. A row behind them, alone by choice, in red: Wanda Maximoff, who had said almost nothing since the theatre took her, and whom everyone had very politely not pressed.

"The first showing was the event," Strange said. "This is the autopsy. Look at the framing."

And then the theatre took its breath, and swallowed them, and he was right.

They stood — all of them, invisibly, impossibly — in the park at dusk. The fountain. The dead boy by the fountain, a hole through his chest the exact shape of a light spear, blood going black in the last of the light. Ten thousand watchers who had already seen this happen once braced for the pain of seeing it again.

But the vision did not care about the boy yet. The vision cared about the *girl*.

She arrived the way royalty arrives: out of a circle of crimson light that unfolded from the ground like a rose deciding to be a door, the Gremory seal turning within it, and she stepped out of it without hurrying, because hurrying was for people whose arrival changed things, and her arrival *was* the change. Crimson hair to her waist, moving in a wind that didn't exist. A school uniform worn like a court gown. Blue-green eyes that went to the dying boy and performed, in the space of one second, an entire committee meeting.

The theatre — folded inside the moment as it always was — could *feel* that second from the inside this time. That was the new thing. That was the SR of it. They felt her feel it:

The summoning slip pulled me here. He called with his dying breath — his desire reached my seal. Sacred Gear, then, and a strong one; ordinary want doesn't punch through like that. He's still warm. Still fresh. Still viable.

And underneath the calculation, quieter, almost buried: *He's just a boy. She left him like garbage.*

"There," Natasha Romanoff said softly, from the dark. "Both of them at once. Remember that."

Rias Gremory knelt beside the corpse of Issei Hyoudou, and produced from nowhere — from an inventory, Tony Stark thought, the girl has *hammerspace* — eight small chess pawns, red as garnets, and set them on his ruined chest.

"Evil Pieces," Strange said, to the room, inside the vision, and the vision, obligingly, *slowed down* for him. Everyone noticed that. The theatre had never done that for anyone before. Several people made a note that the theatre appeared to like wizards, or at least liked being explained.

"Watch closely," Strange said. "Because I want to kill a rumor before it breeds. Half of this room has been calling this a resurrection. It isn't one. Watch what the pieces actually do."

The first pawn sank into Issei's chest like a stone into still water, and it *lit up* — not the boy, the *world*, the local weave of it, the part of reality that held the boy's pattern. Every sorcerer in the theatre saw it at once and sat forward at once, a whole congregation leaning into the same scripture.

"His soul never left," Doctor Voodoo said. His voice was deep and certain, the voice of a man who had personally escorted souls in both directions and would know a returning one on sight. "Look at it. There is no retrieval. No door opens. Nothing is called back across any river, from any gate, out of any hand. The soul is *there* — dimming, untethering, but there. It never went anywhere." He shook his head slowly, and the bones woven into his staff clicked. "This is not necromancy. I have raised the dead, and I have paid what raising the dead costs, and this — this pays a different bill entirely."

"Then what is it?" Sam Wilson called from the Avengers block. "Because from the cheap seats it looked a lot like a dead kid sitting up."

"It's an *edit*," said Wanda Maximoff.

She hadn't meant to say it out loud, perhaps. But the vision had slowed to a crawl now — the second pawn sinking in, the third — and inside that slowness the mechanism was naked, and Wanda Maximoff knew this mechanism. Knew it the way you know your own handwriting in someone else's letter.

"It's not calling him back," she said. "It's not healing him, either — look, the wound closes as a *side effect*, an afterthought. The pieces are rewriting what he fundamentally *is*. Human is a fact about him, and the fact is being — replaced. Crossed out. 'Devil' written over it, in the same hand that wrote the original. His body was fresh enough that the pattern hadn't unraveled, so the new fact takes. If she'd come an hour later, there'd have been nothing coherent left to edit." A pause. Her voice went flat and careful, a person walking on their own grave. "I've done this. To more people than one, all at once, for a lot worse reason than saving a boy's life. The difference is that when I did it, it broke the world and it broke me. And she's doing it *kneeling in a park*, with a *game piece*, and reality isn't even filing a complaint."

"Because reality has already agreed to it," Clea said.

Everyone in earshot of the wizard block turned. Clea rarely spoke to the room. When she did, it was with the mild, unsettling courtesy of someone raised in a dimension where the landlord ate people.

"That's what should frighten you about this cosmology," she said. "Not the demons. Not the spears of light. *This*. In my uncle's realm, remaking a being's nature is an act of overwhelming force — Dormammu rewrites what things are because nothing in the Dark Dimension can stop him. It is violence. Here—" she gestured at the screen, at the fourth pawn sinking home, "—it is *paperwork*. Standardized. Reproducible. Every Devil noble carries a set. Which means someone in Issei's world sat down and turned the transmutation of souls into an *industrial process*, with regulations, and denominations, and a pricing scheme. Someone made ontology into currency."

"And currency," said a warm, delighted, rotten voice from higher up, "is my *native language*."

Mephisto had been so quiet, these last few chapters. That should have worried more people than it did.

But before he could develop the thought, the vision seized their attention and *squeezed* — because on the screen, something had gone wrong. Or gone strange. The fourth pawn had sunk into Issei's chest, and Rias Gremory had gone very still, because the boy had not stirred.

They felt her surprise. It was the first crack they had ever seen in her, and the theatre served it up in close-up: *Four pawns. Four pawns and the reincarnation isn't binding. Four pawns is a mid-tier Sacred Gear user, four pawns is a talented exorcist, four is — not enough? For him*?**

She placed the fifth. The sixth. Nothing. Her jaw set. The audience — folded into her at this distance, marinating in her interior — felt the arithmetic she did next, and the arithmetic was cold and clean and jointless: *Six pawns is more than I have ever heard of anyone spending on a Pawn. Six pawns is a scandal. If I stop now I lose the pieces AND the boy. If I continue and it takes eight, I lose my entire front line, forever, on one bet. There is no reincarnating twice. There is no refund.*

And then, riding under the arithmetic like a keel under a warship: *Something in this boy is refusing a price that would buy a small army. Which means something in this boy is worth more than a small army.*

Take the bet.

Seventh pawn. Eighth. And with the eighth, all of them ignited at once, crimson light welling up out of the dead boy like the world's most beautiful infection, and the wound in his chest unhappened, and the fact of him was quietly, thoroughly rewritten, and Issei Hyoudou — who had been a corpse for the better part of an hour — took a breath.

The vision froze there, on the breath, and let them all out.

The theatre held a silence with a very specific texture. It was the silence of several thousand extremely dangerous people revising a file.

"Eight," Loki said, into it. He was sitting forward, chin on laced fingers, and his eyes were bright in the way that had preceded most of Asgard's worst decades. "You all felt her ledger. A Pawn costs *one*. A gifted human, two, three. A small monster, four. She poured in *eight* — her entire allotment, every future soldier of that rank she will ever have — and the system didn't overcharge her out of cruelty. It *appraised* him. The pieces refused to close the transaction until the price matched the goods." He smiled, thin and marveling. "Do you understand what that means? Underneath their reality there is a *valuation engine*. Something down in the plumbing of that cosmos that looks at every soul and knows, to the decimal, what it is worth. And it looked at a lecherous seventeen-year-old failure and priced him like a *siege weapon*."

"That's the part," Strange agreed quietly. He was rubbing his scarred hands together, slow, unconscious, the way he did when a problem was good. "Not the resurrection. The *appraisal*. Magic that transforms, I know. Magic that bargains, I know far too well. But a standing, automated, universal assay of worth, built into the substrate, that a teenage noblewoman can query by touching game pieces to a corpse—" he exhaled. "Every system has an architect. Someone *built* that scale. I want to know who, and I want to know what they were weighing souls *for*."

From his aisle — his own aisle; it was understood by now that Doom had an aisle — Victor von Doom spoke without turning his head. "You are asking the wrong question, Strange. Not who built the scale. Who *audits* it." The mask tilted a fraction toward the screen. "A currency is only as honest as its enforcement. Eight pawns entered that boy and reality *honored the payment*. There is a bank underneath that world. Banks have vaults. Vaults have doors." A pause, silken. "Doom merely observes."

"Doom merely *shops*," muttered Shuri, but she was writing all of it down.

And that was when Mephisto stood up.

He did it theatrically, because he did everything theatrically: rising from the villain rows in his long red glory, dusting velvet from velvet, smiling the smile that had closed a million deals in fine print and screaming. "Well," he said, addressing not the room but the *screen*, the way one lawyer addresses another. "This has all been marvelously educational, and I do thank the management. But now that we've established the facts of the case, I'm afraid I must raise a small — *procedural* matter."

"Oh no," said Peter Parker.

"The boy *died*," Mephisto said, and his voice put on robes and a wig as it went. "Died in sin, I might add — lust in his heart, on Church-adjacent business, slain by a fallen angel; you couldn't *draft* a cleaner intake form. And between the moment of his death and the moment of this — charming — *rewrite*, his soul sat unclaimed on open ground for the better part of an hour. Unclaimed. Unattended. *Uncontracted*." The smile widened past the point where smiles should stop. "In every jurisdiction I operate in, and I operate in nearly all of them, an unclaimed soul in transit is *salvage*. I hereby assert prior lien. Whatever the little redhead paid, she paid it for goods that were already forfeit. The Devil girl may keep the body." He spread his hands, magnanimous. "I'll take the rest. You may deliver him at the management's convenience."

The silence this time had a different texture. It was the texture of a room waiting to see if the universe would actually allow this.

The screen considered him. There was no other word for it. The great expanse of it went blank and thoughtful, and then white letters printed themselves, one line at a time, with what could only be described as *relish*.

CLAIM RECEIVED: MEPHISTO.

REVIEWING.

A pause, exquisitely timed.

FINDING ONE: THE SOUL OF ISSEI HYODOU WAS NEVER IN TRANSIT. IT NEVER LEFT. THERE WAS NOTHING TO SALVAGE. YOU WATCHED THE SAME FOOTAGE AS EVERYONE ELSE.

FINDING TWO: THE SUBJECT IS NOT OF YOUR COSMOLOGY. YOUR JURISDICTION DOES NOT EXTEND TO HIM. YOUR JURISDICTION, AT PRESENT, DOES NOT EXTEND TO YOUR OWN SEAT.

FINDING THREE: THE SUBJECT'S VALUATION IS ON RECORD. EIGHT PAWNS. THE COURT HAS REVIEWED YOUR ASSETS.

YOU COULD NOT AFFORD HIM.

CLAIM DENIED. THANK YOU FOR YOUR INTEREST IN ISSEI HYODOU.

The theatre did not laugh at Mephisto. The theatre *howled*. Rocket fell out of his seat. Loki laughed the way he hadn't laughed since before Thanos, high and helpless. Even up among the Asgardians, Heimdall — Heimdall — was seen to smile, which several witnesses would later swear was the single most unsettling event of the chapter. Deadpool started a chant of "*reviewed your as-sets*" that mercifully failed to catch on.

Mephisto sat down. He was still smiling, because he was always smiling, but the smile had gone fixed and lacquered, and his eyes had gone the flat red of a closing furnace door. A demon lord who trafficked in worth had just been publicly appraised and found *insufficient*, in front of every hero, god, and rival he had, by a piece of architecture. He folded his hands in his lap with terrible calm.

"Everything," he said softly, to no one, "is negotiable. Eventually."

Nobody sitting near him slept especially well that cycle.

The wheel ticked again almost gently, as if the theatre were feeling generous after its own joke. Grey-green light this time, modest, workmanlike.

"SACRED GEAR 101" — RARITY: UC.

"Uncommon," Kraglin narrated dutifully. "That's the tier that's mostly, uh. Homework."

It was homework. It was also, everyone agreed afterward, some of the most valuable footage the machine had ever dispensed — a stitched-together seminar of moments: Issei sitting in the Occult Research Club's absurd Victorian clubroom while Rias, backlit by lamplight and self-assurance, laid it out for him; flashes of other people in other places whose names arrived unbidden; glimpses of things that made the gods in the room stop breathing.

The shape of it, as the audience assembled it out loud between scenes:

Sacred Gears were *artifacts born inside people*. Not forged, not granted in adulthood, not earned — installed in certain human souls at birth, invisibly, by the God of the Bible of that world, as a system for enacting miracles through mortals. Most carriers never knew. A man whose crops never failed. A surgeon whose patients beat the odds. A girl in a church whose hands closed wounds. The gears ranged from that — from *lovely and small* — up a long, long ladder.

"So it is a lottery," Thor said slowly. The Asgardian block had been leaning in since the word *God* — Thor and Sif and Brunnhilde, with Loki adjacent and Heimdall above, and even Hela, far apart in her dark corner, listening the way a knife listens. "Their god seeded weapons through mankind like a farmer scattering grain, blind, and let them sprout where they would. In peasants. In children. In *fools*." He didn't say it with contempt. He said it with something almost like vertigo. "Father locked Mjolnir behind a *worthiness clause*. Their god apparently just — left the armory unlocked and walked away."

"Walked away," Heimdall repeated, in the tone of a man filing the phrase under *later, and important*.

And then the seminar reached its final chapter, and the screen said the word, and the temperature of the room changed.

Longinus.

Thirteen of them, the vision explained, through Rias's own lecturing voice — thirteen Sacred Gears out of countless thousands, named for the spear that pierced Christ, set apart for a single shared quality: each one, fully realized, could kill a god. Not defy. Not wound. *Kill*. The screen was tactful enough not to show all thirteen. It showed silhouettes, suggestions — a fading tapestry of a beast with too many wings, a blade that ended what it cut, and then, last, lovingly, in full color and no silhouette at all —

A red gauntlet. A green gem. Two doubled voices, boy and dragon.

BOOSTED GEAR. LONGINUS-CLASS. THE POWER TO SURPASS GOD AND SATAN.

"There it is," said Ddraig's own audience — because by now, half the theatre thought of the dragon as one of theirs. In the vision's depth the gem flickered, and the old rolling voice added, dry as a hoard: "*They always leave out the fine print, partner. The power is real. So is the bill.*"

Down in the wizard block, Strange had gone very still. "The doubling every ten seconds," he said. "No cap but the vessel. We knew that. What we did not know is that his cosmology has an official *category* for 'weapon that kills gods,' that it manufactured thirteen of them, put them in random mortal infants — and that the boy we watched die over a text-message date is carrying one." He looked up at the frozen image of the gauntlet. "Rias Gremory did not know which Sacred Gear he had when she spent those pieces. She couldn't have. All she had was the price refusing to settle."

"Which means," said Natasha, picking the thread up smoothly, the two of them reasoning across half a theatre like colleagues, "she read one data point — *he's expensive* — and bet her entire hand on it, at seventeen, kneeling in a park, in under a minute." A beat. "I've recruited for three intelligence agencies. I would hire her tonight."

"She gambled," Sif said, unconvinced. "It happened to pay. We honor the win, not the throw."

"No," said Doom, and even Sif turned, because Doom disagreeing with someone at normal volume was rarer than the Longinus. "Examine the throw. She did not scatter her pieces over years on safe, modest servants, as her rivals surely do. She *held* them — all eight — waiting for a purchase worthy of the whole purse. That is not luck. That is a doctrine. The girl decided long ago that she would rather have one priceless thing than eight adequate ones." The mask turned back to the screen, to Rias Gremory frozen mid-lecture, regal in lamplight, one hand resting — they all noticed it now, the theatre made sure they noticed it — protectively on her new Pawn's shoulder. "Doom has employed many servants. Doom has met perhaps three people who understood that. He was one of them."

"Was that a compliment?" Peter whispered.

"It was a *warning*," said Miles, watching Doom watch her.

Wanda Maximoff spoke last, quietly, and mostly to Clea, but the theatre had good acoustics when it wanted to. "Everyone keeps asking what she saw in him," she said. "I keep thinking about the other thing. She rewrote what he *is*, and he woke up thanking her. One day he's going to understand what was actually done in that park — what it cost, what it took, what he never consented to because the dead can't consent." Her eyes, on the screen, were very old. "What I want to know is what she does *then*. That's the day you find out what the girl is."

The screen, as if it had been waiting for exactly that, dimmed the frozen image until only two things were left glowing in the dark: the green gem of the Boosted Gear, and Rias Gremory's blue-green eyes.

Underneath them, in small white letters, unhurried:

SHE WILL TELL YOU WHY SHE BET EVERYTHING.

BUT NOT YET.

The wheel began, softly, to tick.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Resurrection by Rias" — **SR**
- "Sacred Gear 101" — **UC**

Secrets Revealed:

- The Evil Piece system is confirmed as **not** necromancy: Issei's soul never departed and nothing was called back — the pieces rewrote his fundamental nature from human to Devil while his body was still fresh enough for the new pattern to bind (verified independently by Doctor Voodoo, Wanda, and Clea).
- The pieces carry an automatic appraisal: reincarnation refuses to bind until the price matches the recipient's true worth — implying a hidden, universal **valuation engine built into the substrate of Issei's reality**.
- Rias did not know Issei carried the Boosted Gear when she paid; she bet all eight Pawns on a single data point — the price refusing to settle — with no refunds and no second chances.
- Sacred Gears are miracle-artifacts installed by that world's God in random human souls at birth, ranging from mundane blessings to the thirteen god-slaying **Longinus** class — and Boosted Gear is one of the thirteen, billed as "the power to surpass God and Satan."

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- Mephisto formally asserted a salvage-lien on Issei's soul and was denied by the theatre itself ("YOU COULD NOT AFFORD HIM") — publicly humiliated, privately patient, and now genuinely dangerous on this subject.
- The mystic-arts contingent has cohered into the theatre's analytical core; the theatre visibly slows footage for Strange's benefit, which several parties have noted.
- Wanda Maximoff broke her silence: she recognizes the Evil Pieces as industrialized, sanctioned versions of what she once did by force — and has fixed her attention on the day Issei learns what was done to him without consent.
- Doom and Loki have both shifted from studying Issei to studying the **system underneath him** — Loki covets the valuation engine; Doom wants to know who audits the "bank" beneath that reality.
- Room consensus on Rias Gremory sharpened from "the girl who saved him" to "a strategist who held her whole hand for one priceless purchase" — Natasha would recruit her; Doom paid her his

highest compliment/warning; Sif remains a skeptic.

- Asgardians are newly disturbed by a cosmology whose God scattered god-killing weapons into random mortal infants and "walked away" — Heimdall flagged that phrasing for later.

Unresolved Hooks:

- Who built — and who audits — the valuation engine that priced an "ordinary" boy like a siege weapon? What were souls originally being weighed *for*?
- Mephisto's parting note: "Everything is negotiable. Eventually."
- The screen's direct promise: Rias's true reasons for betting everything **will** be revealed — "BUT NOT YET."
- Wanda's question hangs over the story: what does Rias do on the day Issei fully understands the transaction in the park?
- Why the God of Issei's world "walked away" from an unlocked armory — the theological storm from Chapter 4 now has fuel.

Chapter Six: The Dragon Inside Him

Primary Reaction Groups: Asgardians (Thor • Loki • Valkyrie • Beta Ray Bill) • Dragon-Kin (Fin Fang Foom • Shang-Chi) • Cosmic Entities

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Ddraig's Introduction" — **Mythic**
 2. "Boosted Gear Penetrate" — **Super Rare**
-

By the sixth session, the theatre had developed a rhythm, and the rhythm had developed factions.

It was not that anyone had forgiven anyone. Doom still stood in his aisle as if the aisle were a throne room awaiting furniture. The Green Goblin still laughed at the wrong moments, at wounds, and had twice been briefly and mercifully unconscious for reasons Jessica Jones declined to explain. But hostility takes energy, and the theatre metabolized energy into boredom, and boredom into seating charts. The Avengers held the center like a garrison. The X-Men had colonized the western mezzanine. The mystics clustered near the front where Strange could squint at the screen's underlying enchantment, which he had described, with increasing professional resentment, as *not being made of magic so much as magic being made of it*.

And in the last two sessions, a new bloc had formed without anyone planning it: everyone in the room who had ever meant something by the word *dragon*.

Thor sat at the heart of it, boots up on the seat in front of him — the seat forgave this; the seat forgave everything — with Valkyrie on his left running a whetstone down Dragonfang out of habit rather than need. Beta Ray Bill sat beyond her, monumental and courteous, having apologized to four separate rows on his way in. Loki had draped himself across two seats at the end like a knife pretending to be a scarf. And down one row, close enough to be included and far enough to make a point of it, sat Shang-Chi, hands loose on his knees, and beside him — occupying eleven seats that the theatre had silently reupholstered in a heat-resistant weave — the compressed, human-adjacent form of Fin Fang Foom, arms folded, green tail coiled twice beneath the row like a cable no one wanted to trip over.

"I still say," Valkyrie said, to no one in particular, "that if the lizard sneezes, I'm suing the venue."

"The venue," Foom said, without turning his head, "is the only thing in this room I respect. Do not tempt me to shorten the list."

Above them all, in the dark that was not darkness, the great tiered silences of the cosmic gallery had also begun to lean in — and that was the part nobody in the lower seats liked to think about. Uatu the Watcher had not blinked in two sessions. The Living Tribunal had manifested exactly once, considered the screen for a period of time that made three telepaths nauseous, and not left. And there was a seat in the highest tier that no one could look at directly, which Strange had privately concluded was Eternity being polite about the fact that he was also the walls.

The screen woke with its usual absence of ceremony.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun. It had, by now, trained the room like a bell trains dogs: conversations guttered out, feuds went on standby, and forty thousand of the most dangerous beings in any reality settled in to watch a teenage boy's life get dealt out of a deck.

The wheel ticked. Slowed. Ticked. And then it did something it had never done before.

It stopped on a color that wasn't on the wheel.

Not gold. Not the platinum shimmer of the SSR pull that had shown them Issei dying in a fountain. The wedge under the pointer turned a deep, banked-ember red, the red of a forge nine hours after the smith went home, and the screen's flat dead voice acquired — for one word only — something almost like respect.

"DDRAIG'S INTRODUCTION" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

"Mythic," Loki repeated, sitting up by degrees, the way a cat un-liquefies. "New tier. How interesting. The machine has been saving that word."

"The machine," Strange said quietly, from the front, "has been saving it for *him*."

The screen opened not on Kuoh Academy, not on Rias Gremory's clubroom with its absurd Victorian furniture, but on darkness — a warm, enclosed, breathing darkness — and the room understood, with a collective prickle, that they were looking at the inside of Issei's dream. The boy stood in it, small, in his ridiculous school uniform, and before him, filling the dream the way a mountain fills a window, was an eye.

It was the size of a longship. It was the color of the wheel's new wedge. It opened slowly, with the grinding patience of something that had not been in a hurry since before the local star systems had settled their orbits, and the slit pupil narrowed on the boy the way an archivist's attention narrows on a document that should not exist.

[So,] said a voice, and the theatre's sound became a physical pressure, gravel and bronze and depth, **[you are the one.]**

Fin Fang Foom's arms came unfolded.

It was a small motion. From a being who had spent two sessions in reptilian stillness broken only by contempt, it was a shout.

On screen, the boy did what the boy always did, which was to lead with the worst possible question. "Are you — wait, are you the voice from my arm? Are you my *arm*? Have I been dreaming inside my own arm?"

[I am Ddraig,] the voice said, and paused, and the pause itself had grammar — the pause of a speaker deciding how much of the truth a small creature could carry. **[The Red Dragon Emperor. In the old tongues of your world, Y Ddraig Goch. I have been called the Welsh Dragon, the Heavenly Dragon, the Dragon of Domination. Gods have called me a catastrophe with wings. They were not wrong. Once, there were two of us who could not be measured — myself, and a white nuisance named Albion, whom I fought across three skies until the skies filed complaints.]** Another pause. **[Then the war of gods and dragons ended badly for everyone, as wars do, and the victors could not kill us, so they did something crueler. They folded us into tools. Sacred Gears. Gauntlets for the arms of mortals. I have lived in the left hands of your kind for longer than your kind has had history.]**

"Blasphemy," said Fin Fang Foom.

He said it conversationally, which somehow made it worse. Heads turned along the dragon bloc.

"You object to the *screen*?" Shang-Chi asked mildly.

"I object to the *sentence*," Foom said. His voice had lost its bored register. "A Heavenly Dragon. An apex of that world's dragonkind, by his own telling — the equal of gods, the terror of gods — reduced to a *utensil*. Look at him." One taloned finger indicated the eye that filled the screen, the vast banked-ember patience of it. "That is not a spirit that was meant to fit inside a boy's wrist. They did not seal him. They *insulted* him, eternally, and called it mercy. If it were done to me, I would spend ten thousand years learning to hate, and the ten thousand years after that teaching the lesson back."

"And that," Thor said, "is precisely why it was never done to you, Foom. No one dared come close enough."

"Flattery."

"Assessment." Thor's boots came down off the seat. On screen, the boy was babbling — *so I've got, like, a legendary dragon, in my ARM, does that come with, is there a monthly fee* — and the vast eye was watching him with an expression that Thor, who had grown up on the stories his grandfather's skalds told of the great wyrms, was beginning to find familiar. "Listen to the beast, though. Truly listen. Does he sound insulted?"

[**You are,**] Ddraig was saying on screen, with the air of a scholar annotating a specimen, [**without exaggeration, the least promising wielder I have ever been assigned. And I want you to understand the size of that statement. I have been carried by warlords. By saints who burned. By a woman who conquered a third of a continent and wept about it every night. By men so hungry for my power that it hollowed them out and wore them like a coat. Some of them mastered in a decade what will take you thirty years. All of them heard my name and asked me for strength.**] The pupil narrowed. [**You heard my name and asked if I come with a fee.**]

"That's a no, then?" dream-Issei said. "On the fee?"

[**...Partner,**] said Ddraig, and there was a sound from the dragon like tectonic plates sighing, [**the fee is that I have to listen to you.**]

The theatre laughed. It surprised them — it kept surprising them, session after session, that a room containing Hela and the Goblin and a Watcher could laugh together at anything, but the boy had that effect, and now, unexpectedly, so did the dragon. There was something in the timing of it. Something in the dryness. Rocket Raccoon was wheezing. Even Doom's fingers, drumming the rail, had briefly stopped.

But Loki was not laughing. Loki was leaning forward with his chin on his laced fingers and his eyes very green, and when he spoke it was low, pitched for the dragon bloc alone.

"He said *assigned*," Loki murmured. "Wielders come to the gauntlet by fate, or blood, or the whim of whatever system distributes these Sacred Gears. Ddraig doesn't choose them. He *receives* them. Centuries of tenants. Centuries of being inherited, like a debt." His teeth showed, not quite a smile. "Do you know what a being like that is worth, brothers, if one could learn what he actually wants? Power that ancient, that leashed, that *tired* — tired things make bargains—"

"Loki." Thor did not look at him. "The last person in this theatre to try to acquire something of that boy's on a technicality was Mephisto, and the room fed him his own contract. Sit with your hands where I can see them."

"I'm merely appreciating—"

"Sit," said Valkyrie, "with your hands where *I* can see them," and Dragonfang shifted an inch in its scabbard, and Loki sat.

On screen, the dream deepened, and Ddraig kept talking, and the theatre discovered that it was possible to be held rapt by exposition, provided the exposition was delivered by something that had personally attended the events. He spoke of the Great War between the three Biblical factions the way a man speaks of a bad neighborhood he used to live in. He spoke of Albion — [**my rival, my mirror, sealed as I was sealed; somewhere in your world right now a person is walking around with the White**

Dragon Emperor in their body, and one day, partner, that person will try very hard to kill you, and I will need you to be less stupid by then] — with an enmity so old it had fermented into something adjacent to fondness. He spoke of his prior wielders in inventory, in numbers: how many had died in battle, how many had been consumed by his power, how many had spoken to him, in the end, as anything other than a weapon.

[Three,] he said, to that last one, unprompted, as if the count had been sitting in him a long time. **[Out of all of them. Three ever asked me a question about myself that was not tactical.]**

"Four," said dream-Issei.

[What?]

"Well, I'm gonna. Ask you stuff. Like — okay, first question." The boy sat down cross-legged in his own dream, in front of an eye the size of a longship, utterly failing to be afraid, and the theatre watched an ancient catastrophe with wings experience surprise. "What was your favorite one? Of the skies. You said you fought across three skies. Which sky was the best sky?"

The silence on screen lasted four full seconds.

[...The second one,] Ddraig said at last, gravel gone strange and slow. **[Over the northern sea. There were lights in it. Green and violet, in curtains. Albion and I stopped fighting for the better part of an hour and neither of us ever admitted it.]**

Beta Ray Bill made a sound. It was low, and it was in his chest, and Valkyrie glanced at him and then away, because the sound was recognition. A creature engineered into a weapon, hearing a creature folded into one, remember the aurora.

"There," Thor said softly, into the dragon bloc's quiet. "*There*. You asked whether he sounds insulted, Foom. He sounds like every old warrior in every hall I have ever drunk in. He is not looking for vengeance. He is looking for one person who asks about the sky."

"Then he has decayed," Foom said, but the scorn had developed a crack in it, and everyone in the row could hear the crack. "A dragon is pride. A dragon is *sovereignty*. We do not — " the tail shifted beneath the seats — "we do not bond. We are not horses."

"No one said horses," Shang-Chi said.

"Your people carved us into gate guardians and dance costumes—"

"My people," Shang-Chi said, unruffled, "understood something your pride will not let you say aloud: that the dragon who serves nothing serves his hunger, and hunger is the smallest king there is." He nodded at the screen. "In the stories I was raised on, the dragon is not diminished by attachment. The

dragon is attachment — to the river, to the rain, to the household that honors it. Power that touches nothing is just weather. That one—" the eye, vast, patient, banked-ember — "was weather for a long time. Listen to how he says *partner*. He is done being weather."

Fin Fang Foom did not answer. Fin Fang Foom watched the screen with his arms folded again, but his claws, this time, were not quite still.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel spun, and stopped on honest gold.

"BOOSTED GEAR PENETRATE" — RARITY: SUPER RARE.

"Okay, hold on—" said Peter Parker, from the middle rows, already half-standing. "New rule. Whoever's naming these needs to run them by literally one adult—"

The screen cut to a training clearing at dusk, and Peter sat down, because the footage did what the footage always did: it made the joke feel like it had happened in a different year.

Issei was losing. That part was familiar; the theatre had watched him lose in Chapters Two and Three with a completeness that had been almost artistic. He was sparring against a summoned training golem of Rias's design, a hulking thing of layered rock and defensive magic circles, and his boosted punches were splashing off its barriers like rain off a war memorial. Double, quadruple, eightfold — the green gem on his gauntlet chanted **[BOOST]** in Ddraig's voice, and the numbers climbed, and it did not matter, because the golem's defense scaled like a cliff scales a wave.

"This is the lesson," Doom said, from his aisle, to nobody, in the tone of a man grading homework. "The lesson every brawler learns. Multiplied force against structured defense is arithmetic against architecture. Architecture wins."

[Partner.] Ddraig's voice, on screen, low, inside the boy's head. **[Stop. Breathe. You are trying to be strong enough. That is Albion's game — his and every knight and every god who ever built a wall. Walls are a question: 'are you strong enough?' Tonight I am going to teach you my answer.]**

"Which is?" Issei gasped, on one knee, gauntlet smoking.

[The question is stupid.]

The gem flared. Something moved through the boy's arm on screen that made three separate sensor-brained beings in the theatre — Vision, the Ghost Rider's flame, and something in the cosmic tier — physically flinch, and Issei stood up, and hit the golem once, gently, almost a tap, and the word the gauntlet spoke was new:

[PENETRATE.]

The fist did not break the barriers. The barriers were not broken. That was the part the theatre spent the next several minutes failing to process: the layered circles remained intact, the rock armor remained intact, and the golem's core — its anchoring sigil, buried beneath a meter of enchanted stone at the center of everything — quietly shattered, as if the fist had been *delivered* there, as if distance and armor and durability had been items on a form and someone had declined to fill the form out. The golem stood whole for a moment, a fortress with nobody home. Then it came apart into gravel.

The silence in the theatre had texture.

"Explain that," said Steve Rogers, quietly, to Strange, in the voice he used when he already understood and was hoping to be wrong.

"It ignored the defense," Strange said. He had gone very still. "Not overwhelmed. Not bypassed a weakness. There was no weakness. It treated 'defense' as a category that doesn't apply to it. The attack resolved directly against the target's core as though everything between fist and core were... commentary."

"So the question 'how tough are you'—" Sam Wilson started.

"Is no longer a question," said T'Challa. He was looking at his own hand, at the seam where a Vibranium claw slept, and the theatre's habit of showing people the exact thing that kept them alive being made irrelevant was beginning to be recognized as a pattern. "The suit does not matter. The shield does not matter. Doom's force fields, the Hulk's hide, an Asgardian's bones. If that ability matures, every defensive technology and every durable body in this room is a costume."

"It won't scale," Tony Stark said, too fast. "Nothing scales like that. There's always a cost curve—" and then he stopped, because on screen Ddraig was already answering, the way the screen sometimes seemed to answer, and it was worse than a cost curve.

[It will cost you,] the dragon said, as the boy stared at his own smoking fist. **[Penetrate is one of mine — one of my original abilities, from when I was a sky-filling thing and not a wrist ornament. My flame did not burn castles. It burned the *idea* of the people inside them, and the castles fell down out of grief. Wielders have unlocked this before you. Most of them I did not offer it to twice. A power that ignores every wall will, eventually, ask you which walls of your own you are willing to live without. The hollow ones loved it. It made them hollower.]** The gem's light banked low, ember-warm. **[You, I think, might be safe. You are too stupid to be hollow. It is, and I want this recorded somewhere permanent, the only tactical advantage you possess.]**

"Then why," Issei said, grinning through obvious exhaustion, "do you sound proud of me?"

[I do not.]

"You totally do. Ddraig. Buddy. You sound like my dad at sports day."

[I have incinerated pantheons for less than 'buddy.']

"You *do* though."

Another tectonic sigh. And then — quietly, in the tone of a confession filed under something else — **[I have carried hundreds of you. I outlast all of you; that is the shape of my sentence. I long ago stopped learning your names before your funerals. It was easier.]** A pause. **[I know your name, Issei Hyoudou. I knew it before you unlocked anything. I do not know yet what that means, and at my age, not knowing something is the closest I come to being young. Do not die soon. That is not tactical advice.]**

The boy, being the boy, ruined it — "Aw, you LOVE me, I have a giant dad dragon" — and the screen let his delighted laughter run, and the theatre sat in the sound of it, and nobody said anything for a while, because there was nothing to say that the ledger of the room hadn't already recorded: the strategists had a new nightmare, and the dragon had a son, and only one of those facts was going to matter in a hundred years.

It was Thor who broke it. Afterward, he would insist he'd only meant to think aloud.

He rose from his seat with the unhurried gravity of a man about to toast a hall, looked up at that vast banked-ember eye still glowing on the paused frame, and said, warmly and clearly and to a screen:

"Ddraig of the Red! Your rival's skies notwithstanding — if ever you tire of that sentence of yours, know that Asgard's halls have always kept a place at the fire for old dragons, and better mead than that boy's world will ever—"

The eye on the screen moved.

Not the footage. The footage was paused; the frame-counter in the corner had stopped; the boy's laughing face hung frozen mid-frame. The eye moved anyway, rotating in its socket with a slow grind of attention, through the fourth wall as if the fourth wall were, like every other wall, commentary — and found Thor, in a theatre outside its universe, and held him.

[Mead,] said Ddraig, into a room of forty thousand suddenly extremely still legends, [would be a start, thunder god. And tell the green one draped on the end seat there that I have eaten things that look at me the way he does.]

The eye slid back into frame. The counter resumed. The boy's laughter unfroze and rolled on, oblivious.

For a long moment, the only movement in the theatre was in the highest tier, where Uatu the Watcher — who had spent his existence secure in the one-way glass between observer and observed — leaned back, very slowly, in a seat that had never before needed to hold his full weight.

Loki had gone the color of old paper. Valkyrie's whetstone had stopped. Fin Fang Foom was on his feet, all eleven seats' worth, and the expression on that ancient green face was not scorn and was not fear, and it took Shang-Chi, watching him, a moment to place it, because it was so foreign there.

It was respect. And underneath the respect, buried where pride kept its unpaid debts, something that looked almost like envy — of a sentence, of a wrist, of an idiot boy who asked about the sky.

"Well," said Rocket, into the silence, in a voice about a third its usual size. "The arm knows we're here. Anybody else wanna rethink the seating chart?"

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Ddraig's Introduction" — Mythic (first Mythic-tier pull; the wheel produced a rarity color never seen before)
- "Boosted Gear Penetrate" — Super Rare

Secrets Revealed

- Ddraig is the Red Dragon Emperor (Y Ddraig Goch), one of the two Heavenly Dragons; sealed into Sacred Gear form after the great war of gods and dragons, and has been passed between mortal wielders for millennia.
- Albion, the White Dragon Emperor, exists as Ddraig's sealed rival — carried by an unknown wielder who will one day come for Issei.
- Penetrate is one of Ddraig's original abilities: attacks resolve directly against a target's core, treating armor, barriers, and durability as nonexistent — it invalidates "how tough are you" as a question.
- Ddraig stopped learning wielders' names ages ago to spare himself their funerals — but he learned Issei's name before the boy unlocked anything, and admits he doesn't know what that means.
- Ddraig is aware of the theatre and its audience — he addressed Thor (and threatened Loki) directly through a paused frame.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Thor: full-throated advocate for Ddraig; publicly extended Asgard's hospitality to the dragon — and was answered.
- Fin Fang Foom: shifted from scorn ("a dragon reduced to a utensil") to open respect, with a buried thread of envy for the bond itself.

- Loki: covetous scheming sharply chilled after being singled out by Ddraig through the screen; now frightened as well as fascinated.
- Shang-Chi: articulated the counter-philosophy that a dragon is defined by attachment, not sovereignty — quietly won the room's dragon debate.
- Doom, T'Challa, Stark, Strange, Rogers: strategist bloc now privately treats Penetrate as a category-level threat that obsoletes every defense in the theatre.
- Uatu the Watcher: visibly unsettled — the observed can see the observers.

Unresolved Hooks

- Who wields Albion, and when does the White Dragon Emperor enter the footage?
- How far does Penetrate scale, and what "walls of Issei's own" will it cost him, per Ddraig's warning?
- If Ddraig can perceive the theatre, can he perceive its *operator* — and will anyone dare ask him?
- Ddraig's remark about hollow wielders: which of his past hosts unlocked Penetrate, and what became of them?
- Why did the gacha system mint a new rarity tier (Mythic) for Ddraig — and what else warrants one?
- Rias Gremory's true reason for spending all eight Pawns remains unexplained — and a dragon who "knew his name before he unlocked anything" suggests she may not be the only one who saw something coming.

Chapter Seven: Weakness Is Not Innocence

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers (Captain America), Martial Artists (Shang-Chi, Iron Fist), Mutants (Cyclops)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Early Training Montage" — Rare
 2. "Beating Sairaorg the Hard Way" — SSR
-

The theatre had learned, over six viewings, to read the great golden wheel the way sailors read weather.

Common pulls meant comedy — Issei Hyoudou faceplanting into something, usually with witnesses. Rare pulls meant story, the connective tissue of a life. And the higher rarities meant the room would go home — insofar as anyone could go home from an indestructible cosmic theatre with no doors — having recalculated something about the boy in red.

Tonight the wheel was already spinning when the house lights dimmed, and the first card that slid out of its slot burned a steady silver.

[EARLY TRAINING MONTAGE — RARE]

"Montage," Tony Stark said, settling deeper into his seat with the air of a man who had seen every training montage cinema ever produced. "Great. Cue the synth music. Two minutes of jogging, one inspirational sunrise, and suddenly the kid can bench-press a bus. That's how these work."

"That is how *movies* work," Steve Rogers said quietly, eyes already on the screen. "Training doesn't."

Stark opened his mouth, caught the look on Rogers' face, and closed it again.

The screen bloomed.

It opened before dawn, which was itself a small betrayal of the genre. No sunrise. Just a grey hillside behind Kuoh Town, wet grass, and Issei Hyoudou on his hands and knees, throwing up beside a running trail while Rias Gremory stood over him with a stopwatch and an expression of clinical patience.

"Again," she said.

"Buchou—" he wheezed.

"Again. Your legs work. I checked when I resurrected you."

He got up. He ran. He fell. He got up.

The montage did not compress this the way montages were supposed to. The theatre's cruel projector lingered — on the fourth lap and the ninth, on Issei dragging a boulder in a rope harness while Rias read a book on his back, on his hands shaking too badly at dinner to hold chopsticks so that Asia Argento, glowing faintly green, healed the blisters and then looked away so he wouldn't see her cry about them.

"He's carrying that pack wrong," Clint Barton observed. "Weight's too high. Rookie mistake."

"He fixes it," Shang-Chi said.

Barton glanced over. "You can't know that."

"Watch his left hand." Shang-Chi hadn't moved since the card was drawn; he sat the way he always sat, spine like a plumb line, hands loose on his knees. "Every time something hurts him, the left hand checks it. Cataloguing. He doesn't complain about the same pain twice."

On screen, the next morning, Issei re-rigged the pack low against his spine without being told.

Barton said nothing, but he sat up slightly.

Then came the sparring, and the laughter — which had been ambient, comfortable, the theatre's default setting for this boy — began to die by degrees.

The scene shifted to a gymnasium marked with the crest of the student council, and a girl in glasses watching from the sidelines with folded arms: *Sona Sitri*, the caption read, *Heiress of the Sitri Clan*. Her peerage filed onto the floor, and her Knights moved the way Knights apparently moved — like the laws about where a body could be at a given moment were polite suggestions.

Issei lasted eleven seconds.

He lasted eleven seconds the second time, too, which drew a chuckle from the villain tiers. The third time he lasted nine, because he'd tried something clever and it had cost him. A blur, a flash of a practice blade, and Issei Hyoudou hit the floor hard enough that half the theatre winced in sympathy.

"Boost me all you want," the Knight said, not unkindly, standing over him. "Power you can't land is just noise."

"He's outclassed," Cyclops said. Scott Summers had claimed a seat near the aisle, arms crossed, and he analyzed the screen the way he analyzed everything — as a problem with a solution he hadn't found yet. "Badly. Speed differential like that, raw power's irrelevant. He needs to stop trying to win and start trying to learn."

"He is learning," said Danny Rand.

Cyclops turned. The Iron Fist was leaning forward with his elbows on his knees, and there was something in his face that hadn't been there during the comedy chapters — recognition, old and specific.

"Look where he falls," Danny said. "First bout, he goes down anywhere. Third bout, he goes down *facing her*. He's eating the losses to buy information. In K'un-Lun we had a name for students like that." He smiled faintly. "Mostly it was 'concussed.' But sometimes it was 'dangerous, eventually.'"

Eleven seconds became fourteen. Fourteen became twenty. He never won. Not once, across what the montage implied was weeks. But the Knights of Sona Sitri stopped smiling when they squared up against him, and that was its own kind of scoreboard.

And then there was Koneko.

The theatre had mostly filed Koneko Toujou under *small, quiet, eats sweets* — a background figure, four-foot-something of white hair and flat affect. The screen now dismantled that filing system with prejudice.

"Spar with me," Issei said in the flashback, bouncing on his toes, gauntlet gleaming. "I've been getting faster. I can feel it."

Koneko looked up at him from her seat on the clubroom couch. She finished her youkan. She set down the plate.

"...Okay," she said. "Don't cry this time."

"That was ONE time—"

What followed was not a fight so much as an essay, written by a very small girl, on the subject of Issei Hyoudou's habits. He feinted left; she was already where the feint ended, because he always feinted left. He boosted; she stepped inside the wind-up, because boosting made him greedy. He tried the combination Kiba had taught him, and she caught the third strike in one small hand, looked up at him with enormous golden eyes, and said, in perfect deadpan:

"...You looked at my shoulder first."

"So?!"

"Don't." She threw him over her hip with a sound like a mattress falling off a truck. "It's rude to announce things."

Laughter rippled through the theatre — but it was different laughter now, and everyone in the room could hear the difference. It wasn't laughing *at* the boy on the floor. It was the laugh a crowd gives a comedian who is also, somehow, breaking their heart.

Because Issei got up. That was the whole montage, in the end. Sona's Knights ran him down and he got up. Koneko read him like a large-print book and threw him into next week and he got up. Rias set training loads that would have broken a varsity team and he woke before his alarm to add to them. The projector showed one night, unglamorous and unmusical: Issei alone in the gym at 2 a.m., throwing the same jab into a beam, over and over, whispering the count to himself because his voice was the only company left awake.

"Two hundred eleven. Two hundred twelve."

The gauntlet on his left arm pulsed with a soft green light.

[Partner,] Ddraig's voice rumbled, low, meant for no one. **[Sleep. The beam will still be there tomorrow.]**

"So will Koneko-chan's hip throw," Issei muttered. "Two hundred thirteen."

A pause. Then, gruff, almost embarrassed:

[...Two hundred fourteen. Your elbow is drifting. Fix it.]

In the theatre, in the present, the real Ddraig said nothing at all — but the Boosted Gear's gem glowed like a banked hearth, and Thor Odinson, seated in respectful distance of it, inclined his head as though something had been confirmed for him.

"HAH." Fin Fang Foom's contempt rolled down from the upper dark like a rockslide. "The great Welsh Dragon, reduced to counting a hatchling's push-ups. Heavenly Dragon, wyrm of legend, and *this* is your legacy? A boy who cannot defeat a child half his size?"

[He gets up,] Ddraig said simply.

"Any fool can stand."

[No,] said Ddraig, and there was two thousand years of sealed patience in it. **[They cannot. I have been carried by champions since before your kind learned speech, lizard. The talented ones break the first time the world says no to them. I have felt them break, from the inside. This one—]** the gem flared, **[—the world has said no to every single day of his new life, and he treats it as a scheduling conflict.]**

Fin Fang Foom had no answer. Notably, he did not laugh again for the rest of the chapter.

Steve Rogers watched the boy on the screen fail to land a hit for the fortieth consecutive time, and felt something in his chest he hadn't felt since a scrawny kid from Brooklyn kept climbing back up in an alley behind a movie theatre.

"Stark," he said.

"Yeah, Cap."

"You said this was how montages work. Two minutes, sunrise, bench-press a bus." Steve nodded at the screen. "Count the losses. They haven't skipped one. Whoever's showing us this *wants* us to feel every single time he hits the floor."

"Yeah, I noticed. Sadistic editing."

"No." Steve's jaw was set. "Honest editing. That's the whole point. Anybody can respect the bus. I respect the floor." He leaned back. "I've been the guy who couldn't win a fight in this room's weight class. The serum gave me the body. It didn't give me the getting-up. That part I had to bring myself, and I know exactly how much it costs." He was quiet a moment. "That kid's paying full price, every day, with no serum coming."

Cyclops, two rows over, had gone very still behind his visor.

"Summers?" Jean asked softly.

"He can't turn it off," Scott said. "The gauntlet. The dragon. The doubling. It's all bolted to him — like it or not, want it or not." His hand rose, unconsciously, to the edge of the ruby quartz. "And instead of resenting the machinery, he's building the man to carry it. Drills. Repetition. Fundamentals. Nobody makes a seventeen-year-old do fundamentals at two in the morning." He exhaled. "You do fundamentals at two in the morning because you've decided who you're going to be, and your body hasn't caught up to the decision yet."

"That," said Shang-Chi, "is the best definition of training I have ever heard a man in a visor give."

The montage ended on Koneko and Issei, sitting side by side on the gym floor, both wrecked, sharing a bag of chocolate. Koneko chewed, swallowed, and delivered her verdict to the middle distance:

"...You lasted forty seconds today." A beat. "...Gross. Now I have to try."

Issei beamed like she'd handed him a trophy.

The screen went dark, and the theatre — which had come into this chapter expecting comedy — sat in a silence that had weight to it. Somewhere in the cosmic architecture, the threat-assessment ticker that had been quietly climbing for six chapters climbed again, and this time nobody joked about it.

Then the wheel began to spin, and the slot burned gold — deep gold, the gold the room had learned to hold its breath for.

[BEATING SAIRAORG THE HARD WAY — SSR]

"Beating Sairaorg," Loki read aloud, delighted. "Finally. Our mongrel underdog wins one. I confess I've grown almost fond of— why are you making that face, Captain?"

"Because I read the whole title," Steve said. "The hard way."

Sairaorg Bael, the caption read, and the screen gave the theatre a young man built like a monument — tall, broad, dark-haired, wrapped in an aura that somehow contained no magic whatsoever, and a smile with absolutely nothing hidden behind it.

Heir to the Great King's house. Firstborn of the Bael. Born without his clan's Power of Destruction. Born, by devil measure, with nothing.

The screen showed it in brutal shorthand: a small boy examined by clan elders and found empty. A mother shamed. An heir set aside like a defective tool, exiled to a backwater with the woman who bore him. And then the same small boy, alone in a field at dusk, punching the trunk of a dead tree with hands too young for the damage he was doing to them.

So he built himself. No Sacred Gear. No spells. No inherited annihilation. Muscle, bone, breath, and ten thousand mornings — until the empty boy could shatter what the gifted could not scratch, and the clan that discarded him had to hand his birthright back with both hands and an apology.

"Zero magic," Danny Rand said slowly. "A devil — a species *made* of magic — with zero magic. And he's their equivalent of a top seed."

"There were monks in K'un-Lun who spoke of such men," Shang-Chi murmured. "The ones the mountain could not give anything to, so they took it from the mountain instead. My father feared exactly one category of enemy: the kind that cannot be disarmed, because nothing was ever handed to them in the first place." He watched Sairaorg stretch, roll his shoulders, and bow to the arena. "This man is a blade with no hilt. There is no piece of him you can take away."

On screen, the Rating Game arena assembled itself — a formal dueling dimension, floating stone and broadcast circles, referees and rules. And across the field from Sairaorg Bael stood Issei Hyoudou in full crimson Scale Mail, older than the montage had shown him, harder, the armor sitting on him now like it belonged.

"He's grown," Natasha noted.

"So has the mountain," said Shang-Chi.

Sairaorg's first words carried across the arena, and they were warm.

"Hyoudou Issei. I've wanted this since I first heard about you. A Low-class devil, no pedigree, no talent — everything you have, you bled for." He raised his fists. No stance the theatre's martial artists could name; something older, self-made, all his own. "People like us weren't given anything. So show me what you *took*."

What followed was not comedy. The projector made sure of that.

Issei fought well — that was the terrible part. The theatre could see every hour of the montage paying out: the footwork Koneko had beaten into him, the patience Sona's Knights had cut into him, boosts banked and spent like a miser, feints layered three deep. He landed the Penetrate strike that had made the whole room gasp a chapter ago, the ability that ignored defense entirely — landed it *clean*, dead center of Sairaorg's chest.

Sairaorg rocked back half a step, coughed blood, and smiled wider.

"Good," he said. "*Good*. Again."

"That should have ended it," Loki said, no longer smiling. "That strike bypasses defense. We watched it bypass defense."

[It did bypass his defense,] Ddraig said grimly. [There is nothing behind that man's defense except more man. Penetrate ignores armor, barriers, scales. It cannot ignore the fact that some bodies are simply built to continue.]

And then Sairaorg started walking forward, and the education began.

The screen did not flinch and did not cut away. Sairaorg Bael took Issei apart the way weather takes apart a coastline — no cruelty, no wasted motion, just force applied with total honesty. Fists that broke sound. The Scale Mail, the crimson armor the theatre had cheered for in Chapter Three, spiderwebbed. Cracked. Shed pieces. Issei was driven through a pillar, and got up. Through the arena floor, and got up. His boosted counters landed and were *answered*, and every exchange ended with the boy further into the red.

The theatre had gone dead silent. Even the villain tiers.

"Stop the fight," someone said quietly, in the Avengers' section — Sam Wilson, half out of his seat. "There's a referee. Somebody stop the fight."

"He wouldn't thank them," Steve said. His hands were locked on his knees, white-knuckled, and his eyes had not left the screen. "Look at his feet."

On screen, Issei Hyoudou — armor in ruins, one eye swollen shut, aura guttering like a candle in wind — set his feet. Again. The stance was terrible now, ruined by damage. It was also, unmistakably, a stance.

"You could stay down," Sairaorg said. He wasn't taunting. He sounded almost pained. "No one in either world would blame you. The gap between us today is real. Yield, heal, and grow. That's wisdom, Hyoudou."

Issei spat blood, and grinned with the half of his face that still worked.

"Can't," he rasped. "Sorry. There's... a bunch of people who brought me back from being nothing. And a partner in my arm who's been counting my push-ups since two a.m." He raised the shattered gauntlet. "You said it yourself. Guys like us weren't given anything. So I can't *give* anything back. Not one step. You want it—" he lifted his fists, "—take it."

[Partner,] the on-screen Ddraig said, and every soul in the theatre heard the ache under the gravel.
[Your body is finished.]

"Yeah." Issei's grin didn't move. "Body was always the weakest part of me anyway. Boost."

He crossed the arena one more time. It was not fast anymore. It was not clever. Sairaorg met him with something like reverence, and the final exchange lasted four seconds, and at the end of it Issei Hyoudou was face-down on broken stone, and he still tried — the theatre watched him try — to get his arms under himself. Once. Twice. The arms shook, and defied him, and the referee's voice rang out across the dimension:

"Resignation by inability to continue. Winner — Sairaorg Bael."

Sairaorg knelt beside him before the medics arrived. Took the ruined gauntlet-hand in both of his own, carefully, like it was something holy.

"I won today," he said. "Remember that word, Hyoudou. *Today*. I've fought gifted devils my whole life and forgotten most of them by dinner. But a man who spends everything and then reaches for more that isn't there—" his voice roughened, "—I'll be training against the memory of you for years. Come find me when you're stronger. I'll be waiting at the top, keeping it warm."

The screen held on Issei's face — unconscious now, wrecked, and wearing, impossibly, the ghost of a satisfied smile — and faded to black.

Nobody spoke for a long moment.

It was Doctor Doom who broke the silence, which surprised everyone, because Doom had spent seven chapters treating the theatre as an inconvenience staffed by inferiors.

"Play it again," Doom said.

The room turned. Victor von Doom stood at the rail of the villain tier, gauntlets folded behind his back, green cloak still, the eternal mask unreadable — and yet something in his voice had changed register.

"Doom has watched this hall celebrate the boy's power," he said. "Power is common. Doom has watched you laugh at his weakness. Weakness is universal. Neither interests me." The mask tilted toward the dark screen. "But mark what you did *not* see. Broken, outmatched, granted every honorable exit — the boy did not beg. Not the referee, not his king, not his enemy, not his gods. Weakness is not innocence; the weak are not owed the world's mercy, and the universe is right to test them. But there is a species of creature that meets the test on its feet and *declines to kneel*, and Doom—" the faintest pause, the sound of an old memory in a Latverian winter, a boy over his mother's grave refusing to weep where the villagers could see, "—Doom was such a creature once, in a village that has since learned better than to laugh."

He turned from the rail.

"The dragon chose adequately," he said, which from Doom was a coronation, and sat down.

[...Huh,] said Ddraig, into the stunned quiet. **[I will take that.]**

"As will I," Thor rumbled, rising with his arms crossed, grinning through his beard. "A toast, then, since this cursed theatre stocks no mead — to the boy who loses better than most gods win! Aye, and to the Bael as well. A warrior with empty hands and a full heart. Volstagg would weep."

"He got destroyed," Barton said, but there was no bite in it — he was checking, the way you press a bruise.

"He got *up*," said Steve Rogers, and stood, and the room found that it was, on the whole, not willing to argue with the particular way Captain America said those three words. "Nine times, by my count, after the fight was already lost. You want to know what I saw tonight?" He looked around the theatre — at gods, monsters, kings, and killers. "I saw the montage and the defeat, back to back, and they're the same clip. That's the trick of it. Getting up in a losing fight isn't something you decide in the arena. He decided it at two in the morning, alone, on rep two hundred fourteen. The arena just published it."

Shang-Chi rose as well, pressed fist to palm, and bowed slightly toward the dark screen — toward a boy universes away who would never know.

"In my father's house," he said, "we were taught to fear the gifted. It was bad teaching. Note it in your ledgers, all of you: the gauntlet is not the weapon. The dragon is not the weapon." He straightened. "The *getting up* is the weapon. And it is still growing."

Above them all, the golden wheel clicked softly, resetting, and the threat-assessment ticker — which had once ranked Issei Hyoudou somewhere below "unattended toaster" — revised itself upward for the seventh consecutive chapter, and this time added a small annotation that had never appeared beside any name before:

Trajectory: unbounded.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Early Training Montage" — Rare
- "Beating Sairaorg the Hard Way" — SSR

Secrets Revealed

- Sairaorg Bael exists: a devil heir born with zero magic and no Sacred Gear, forged entirely through relentless physical training — a living proof that effort can outbuild inheritance.
- Rating Games are formal, ritualized devil duels with referees, broadcast dimensions, and resignation rules.
- Penetrate has a practical limit: it bypasses defenses, but cannot bypass a body conditioned to simply endure the hit.
- Issei's growth engine is defeat itself — he mines every loss (Sona's Knights, Koneko, Sairaorg) for information and returns measurably improved.
- Koneko Toujou is a far more dangerous combatant and tactician than her size and demeanor suggested.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Captain America: full, vocal respect — reads Issei's refusal to stay down as pre-decided character, not arena bravado; publicly links the montage and the defeat as "the same clip."
- Cyclops: respect crystallized — sees a mirror of his own bolted-on power and chosen discipline; now tracking Issei as a leader-in-formation, not a joke.
- Shang-Chi & Iron Fist: first in the room to recognize the training for what it was; Shang-Chi formally declares "the getting up" — not the Boosted Gear — the true weapon.
- Doctor Doom: cold, genuine respect for Issei's refusal to beg in total defeat; ties it to his own code ("weakness is not innocence, but he declines to kneel") and pronounces Ddraig's choice of host "adequate" — a Doom coronation.

- Fin Fang Foom: silenced by Ddraig's rebuke; scorn cracked, no longer laughing.
- Thor: respect extended to Sairaorg as well — "empty hands and a full heart."
- Room-wide: laughter at Issei has permanently curdled into serious observation; threat ticker annotated "Trajectory: unbounded."

Unresolved Hooks

- Sairaorg's parting invitation — "come find me when you're stronger" — guarantees a rematch pull the theatre is already anticipating.
- Koneko is visibly holding something back in her sparring; her true nature remains unrolled.
- Sona Sitri and her peerage were introduced only in glimpses — a full Sitri-focused pull is pending.
- Doom's interest has shifted from Issei to the *system* — evil pieces, resurrection, ranked ritual duels — and Doom does not study systems idly.
- Ddraig's line about feeling past hosts "break from the inside" hints at a graveyard of previous Red Dragon Emperors not yet shown.

Chapter Eight: Asia Argento

Primary Reaction Groups: Nightcrawler, Daredevil, Kamala Khan, Ghost Rider, the Watcher (Living Tribunal cameo)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Asia's Trial and Execution" — Trauma-Class
 2. "Issei's Protective Rage" — Super Rare
-

The theatre had developed rituals by now, the way any prison does.

Seven viewings in, the factions had settled into a geography of temperament. The Avengers held the center rows like a garrison. The X-Men kept to the left flank, close enough to the mutants of other rosters that they could murmur among themselves. Doom sat alone in a box seat that had not existed until he decided it should, and the theatre — indestructible, unknowable, apparently accommodating — had let him have it. The Watcher stood where he always stood, above and behind them all, a pale moon in the dark.

And the gacha wheel spun when it wished to, indifferent to whether anyone was ready.

Tonight it made a sound none of them had heard before.

Every previous pull had announced itself with a chime — bright for the comedic ones, a low bell for the dramatic. This one came in with a sound like a cathedral door closing from the inside. The great golden wheel above the screen turned slowly, almost reluctantly, and when it stopped, the banner that unfurled was not gold or silver or the violet of Super Rare.

It was grey. The grey of ash. The grey of stone confessionals and winter mornings.

ASIA'S TRIAL AND EXECUTION — TRAUMA-CLASS

"Trauma-Class," Kamala Khan read aloud, and her voice cracked on the second word. "That's — we haven't seen that rarity before. Why is there a rarity called that?"

Nobody answered her. On the far left, Kurt Wagner — Nightcrawler, teleporter, acrobat, and the most sincerely devout Catholic in any row of this theatre — had already gone very still. He had been dreading something like this since Chapter Four, since the vision of the gentle blonde girl in the white habit who

healed a wounded Devil because it was bleeding and she was there. He had said, then, that her Church would not thank her for it. He had hoped, quietly and against his own knowledge of institutions, that he was wrong.

The screen lit.

It was not a courtroom, exactly. That was the first cruelty. A courtroom implies law, and law implies the possibility of acquittal. This was a chamber of white stone and gold trim, high windows admitting light that fell in disciplined columns, and at the far end a raised bench where five figures in ecclesiastical vestments sat like a range of mountains. Below them, small enough that the room seemed designed to make her small, stood Asia Argento.

She was sixteen years old. She had folded her hands in front of her the way children are taught to fold them for prayer, and she had not stopped folding them, because she did not know what else to do with a body that had only ever been used for kindness.

"The charge," intoned the central figure — a bishop, or something above a bishop, his voice carrying the acoustics of a man who had never once been interrupted, "is corruption of the holy gift. Twilight Healing was granted to this child by Heaven's grace, that she might mend the faithful. Witnesses attest that she has laid those same hands upon a Devil. That the wound closed. That the creature walked free."

"He was hurt," Asia said.

She said it simply, without defiance, the way you would state that water is wet. In the theatre, three hundred beings of assorted cosmic significance heard the sentence land in the white chamber like a coin dropped down a well — and heard the silence that followed it, which was worse than shouting.

"It was a *Devil*, child."

"He was hurt," she said again, and now her voice trembled, because she was beginning to understand that the truth was not going to save her, and the truth was all she had brought. "I didn't — I didn't ask what he was. He was bleeding. The gift works when someone is bleeding. I thought — " Her folded hands tightened. "I thought that was what it was *for*."

One of the tribunal, an older woman with a face like a locked reliquary, leaned forward. "The gift discriminates in nothing. That is precisely the evidence against it. Heaven's true grace would recoil from the unclean. Yours embraces them. What does that tell us of its source, girl? What does that tell us of *you*?"

In the theatre, Matt Murdock made a sound low in his throat.

Daredevil had no eyes to watch the screen with, but the theatre — cruel or generous, no one had decided — translated everything for him: heartbeats, breath, the acoustic architecture of the chamber. So he heard what the others could only see. He heard that Asia Argento's heart was hammering like a rabbit's and that she was not lying, had never lied, possibly did not fully understand how. And he heard the five heartbeats on the bench: slow, regular, untroubled. Men and women sleeping soundly inside their own verdict.

"They've already decided," he said quietly. "This isn't a trial. Listen to them. There's no doubt anywhere in that room except hers. She's the only one up there interrogating her own soul, and she's the defendant."

"That is how such proceedings work," said Doom, from his box, without inflection. "The verdict precedes the evidence. The ceremony exists to sanctify what power has already chosen. Doom has presided over more honest tribunals." It was impossible to tell if this was condemnation or professional assessment. With Doom it was frequently both.

On screen, the questioning ground on. They asked her when the corruption had entered her. They asked whether she had felt pleasure when the Devil's wound closed. They asked her to renounce the act — not to apologize, note, but to *renounce* it, to stand in front of God and her own memory and declare that mercy had been a sin.

And Asia Argento, who had been found on a church doorstep as an infant, who had been raised entirely inside these walls, who had healed the sick in pilgrim lines for years and been called a holy maiden by the very mouths now weighing her — Asia Argento looked up at the five mountains and did the bravest and most fatal thing available to her.

"If he came back hurt," she said, very softly, "I would heal him again. I'm sorry. I would. I don't know how to see someone bleeding and decide they deserve it."

The gavel — there was a gavel, or something liturgical that served as one — came down.

The vision was merciful in the only way it knew how to be: it did not linger on what came next in flesh. It gave them the shape of it instead. The word *excommunicate*, pronounced with the satisfaction of a completed equation. The white habit taken from her. The doors of the only home she had ever known closing with her on the wrong side of them, and — the screen darkening at its edges like old film burning — figures waiting for her out in that cold, figures with black wings, because when a Church throws away a holy maiden, there are always collectors who come for the salvage. A fallen angel's smile. A ruined chapel. An altar being prepared, and a ritual that would take the Twilight Healing out of Asia Argento the way you take a pearl out of an oyster, which is to say: fatally.

Execution, the banner had said. The tribunal had merely opened the door. Raynare — the same fallen angel who had put a spear of light through Issei Hyoudou on his first date — was going to walk through it.

The screen dimmed to grey and held there, like a sky deciding whether to snow.

For a long moment, nobody in the theatre spoke.

Then Nightcrawler stood up. He did not teleport — no *bamf*, no sulfur — he simply stood, tail lashing once, and gripped the seat-back in front of him with both three-fingered hands, and anyone close could see he was shaking.

"I want to say they are not the Church," he said. His accent thickened when he was upset; it was thick now. "I want to say it very badly. I have spent my whole life saying it. Every time men in vestments did something monstrous, I said: that is not the faith, that is men *wearing* the faith, the way a wolf wears wool. And I believe that. I still — " He stopped. Started again. "I still believe that. But I watched five ordained souls look at the purest act of grace I have ever seen — she healed an enemy *because he was bleeding*, mein Gott, that is not heresy, that is the *entire Gospel* — and they called it corruption. Because it did not check credentials first. Because her mercy would not stay inside the fence they built for it."

"So which is it, Kurt?" Daredevil's voice came flat and tired from three rows down. He hadn't stood. He sat with his elbows on his knees, head bowed, the posture of a man in a pew at the back of a church he can't decide whether to leave. "Does the institution's cruelty indict the faith, or betray it? Because I've been running that question my whole life and I'll be honest with you, the ledger's ugly. I grew up on Hail Marys and guilt. I've met priests who were the best men I ever knew and I've met the other kind, and the Church protected the other kind more often than it protected kids like her." He lifted his head toward the grey screen. "She quoted their own doctrine back at them with her whole life — *I don't know how to see someone bleeding and decide they deserve it* — and they excommunicated her for it. Tell me that's a betrayal of the faith. Go ahead. Some days I believe it. Some days I think the cruelty *is* load-bearing. That the institution needs a fence more than it needs the grace, because grace doesn't take collections."

"Matthew." Kurt's voice was gentle, and it wobbled. "You still go to Mass."

"Yeah." Daredevil laughed once, without any humor in it. "Yeah, I do. Because the alternative is deciding she was wrong, and I can't. Somebody built something true enough that a girl raised inside its worst machinery came out the other end *like that*. Whatever made Asia Argento, I'm not ready to call it rotten. But the men on that bench drink from the same well I do, and that keeps me up at night."

It was Kamala Khan who cut through it, and she did it the way she did most things: by being seventeen and unable to pretend a complicated thing was more complicated than it was.

"Okay, but — can I just —" She was on her feet too now, hands doing that thing where they got slightly bigger without her noticing, which happened when she was upset. "You're both doing theology and I get it, I do, but from where I'm sitting? I'm Muslim. Different book, different arguments, some of the same ugly history, believe me, I've heard the aunties. And here's the thing my faith taught me, and I'd bet money hers taught her the exact same thing, because it's on like page one of *every single one of them*: whoever saves a life, it's as if they saved all of humanity. Full stop. No footnote that says 'humans only.' No asterisk. *She read the assignment.* She's maybe the only person in that whole building who read the assignment. And they failed her for it." Her voice went hoarse. "You don't need a tribunal to figure out who was holy in that room. It's not a hard question. It's only hard if your job depends on it being hard."

From the shadows at the back — where he preferred to sit, because the flames off his skull disturbed the civilians — the Ghost Rider spoke for the first time that evening.

Johnny Blaze's voice, when the Rider used it, came out sounding like a slow fire moving through a dry field.

"Innocent."

One word, and the temperature in the theatre rose two degrees.

"I don't do theology," the Rider said. "I do accounts. I have looked into the souls of murderers and saints and every mixed thing in between, and the Penance Stare has never once cared what anybody was wearing when they sinned. That girl —" the flame of his skull guttered, banked low, almost respectful — "there is nothing in her to burn. Nothing. Do you understand how rare that is? I could count on one hand. But the five on that bench..." The fire climbed again, white at the roots. "They took a child's mercy and called it filth, and they did it in Heaven's name, which means they forged the signature of God on a death warrant. That is on the ledger. All of it. Every hour of what happens to her next is on their page, not hers. And ledgers, in my experience, always come due."

He settled back into the dark. "I hope I'm there when hers does."

And then there was the Watcher.

Uatu had observed, by conservative estimate, more atrocities than any being in this theatre had heartbeats. He had watched worlds burn and pantheons devour their children and civilizations vote themselves cheerfully into extinction, and he had done it with the vast, sorrowing equanimity of a creature for whom witnessing was a sacred office. Several of the sharper occupants of the theatre — Doom, the Black Panther, Emma Frost — had taken to reading him the way sailors read a barometer. He never reacted. That was the point of him.

He reacted now.

It was small. It would not have registered on anyone who had not spent seven chapters learning his stillness. But the Watcher's great head inclined, perhaps a degree, and his eyes — which held galaxies as a matter of anatomy — closed, and stayed closed, for the length of one full human breath.

"I have seen this before," he said, and his voice was quieter than they had ever heard it. "Not this girl. This *shape*. The institution that devours its gentlest member to prove the fence is real. I have watched it occur on ten thousand worlds and I catalogued it each time, and I confess I do not know why this instance..." He paused, and the pause itself was unprecedented. "Perhaps it is because I have also been watching the boy. The one who fails, and stands, and fails, and stands. Their threads are converging. I can perceive it even now, beneath the vision's surface — her exile and his path are braiding into a single cord. And I find that I am not indifferent to where it leads. That is new. I am... uncertain whether it is permitted."

"Permitted by who?" Kamala asked.

The air answered before the Watcher could.

The theatre's light did not change, exactly, but it acquired *depth*, the way still water reveals its depth when something enormous passes far beneath. For an instant — no longer — a figure was present at the theatre's height without in any way having arrived: golden, threefold-faced, vast beyond the room's geometry and yet contained by it, because everything was contained by this room, which was itself a fact several cosmologists in the audience had privately agreed never to examine closely.

The Living Tribunal regarded the grey screen with one face, the audience with another. The third face, hooded, regarded nothing that could be seen.

"THE SCALES NOTICE HER," it said, in a voice like the settling of continents. **"THEY NOTICE HER BECAUSE SHE HAS NEVER ONCE ASKED THEM TO."**

And it was gone, if it had ever been there, leaving behind it a silence so complete that Deadpool — who had been physically restraining himself for six minutes, visibly vibrating — decided, for the first time in recorded history, to say nothing at all.

The wheel turned again.

It turned fast this time, urgent, the chime returning — but the chime came in wrong, pitched low and rough, a bell with a crack in it. The banner that unfurled was violet shot through with red, and it read:

ISSEI'S PROTECTIVE RAGE — SUPER RARE

"Oh good," Spider-Man said weakly, from the middle rows. "Follow-up. Great. I definitely have the emotional reserves for a follow-up."

The screen lit on Issei Hyoudou, and for one grace-note of a moment it was the Issei they had spent seven chapters learning to read: rumpled uniform, absurd hair, the specific slouch of a boy whose greatest recorded ambitions were dishonorable and whose greatest recorded actions kept accidentally being the opposite. He was standing in a city park in the late afternoon, and he had just been told — the vision supplied the knowledge the way dreams do — where Asia Argento was. What the fallen angels occupying the abandoned church intended to do to her. What the ritual would take, and what would be left of her after.

The audience watched him receive it.

They had seen Issei angry before. Chapter Seven had been an anthology of Issei angry — angry at losing, angry at his own weakness, angry in the flailing, shouting, faintly ridiculous key that was his default register, the anger of a boy hitting a wall with his fists because the wall had the audacity to be a wall. Captain America had called it heart. Cyclops had called it trainable. It had never once been frightening.

This was not that.

The change came in stages, and the theatre's screen — which had lovingly documented every pratfall this boy had ever suffered — documented each one with the same terrible fidelity. First the stillness: Issei Hyoudou stopped moving, completely, the perpetual comic fidget of him switching off like a cut feed. Then the eyes. The warm brown of them didn't glow, didn't change color, did nothing supernatural at all, and that was somehow the worst part — they simply emptied of everything adolescent and filled with something that measured. And then, on his left hand, the Boosted Gear materialized without being summoned, red plates sliding over his forearm as if the gauntlet had felt the shift in its wielder and come running, and the green gem at its heart kindled from within like a furnace door swinging open.

"*They took her back once already,*" Issei said. His voice came out level. That was the new thing. Not a scream — level, and quiet, and completely without stutter. "Her own church threw her away, and the ones who caught her are going to *use her up*. She healed me. She didn't ask what I was either. She's the nicest person I've ever met, and every single group that was supposed to protect her looked at her and saw *a part they could harvest*."

[Partner,] Ddraig's voice rumbled from the gem, and those in the theatre who had grown attached to the old dragon's dry, paternal amusement noticed that the amusement was entirely absent. In its place was something almost cautious. Almost — attentive. **[Your heart rate has not risen. Do you understand what that means? Rage that heats up burns the wielder. Rage that cools down... that is the other kind. I have carried hosts for two thousand years. I know the other kind when I feel it wake.]**

"Is that a problem?" Issei asked.

[No,] said the Welsh Dragon, the Red Dragon Emperor, one of the two beings in that cosmology whom God Himself had needed sealing rather than fighting. And there was a note in the ancient voice that none of his previous commentary had ever contained: **[It is a beginning.]**

On screen, Issei began to walk toward the church on the hill. He did not run. Running was for the boy he had been that morning. He walked, and the sun went down behind him as he went, and the vision let the image hold: a slight, unremarkable teenage silhouette with a dragon's arm, walking at an execution like a debt collector, while somewhere ahead of him a gentle girl folded her hands and prayed to a Heaven that had already filed her under acceptable losses.

The screen faded — not resolving, not concluding. *Beginning*. The rescue, whatever it would cost, had started, and the theatre would have to wait to see it paid for.

The lights came up on a room that did not know what to do with itself.

"Okay," said Kamala, into the hush. "So that was — okay. Am I the only one who found that a little..." She hunted for the word and refused all the softer candidates. "Scary? Like — good scary? Justified scary? But scary. That was not 'oath scene in an anime' angry. That was 'the animal got out of the enclosure' angry."

"You are not the only one," T'Challa said quietly.

"The boy telegraphs everything," Shang-Chi said, frowning, replaying it behind his eyes. "It is his defining flaw as a fighter — we established this last chapter. Every intention broadcast, every feint legible. Just now he telegraphed *nothing*. His breathing didn't change. I have trained with masters who spent decades learning to do what grief just did to him in four seconds."

Captain America hadn't spoken. Sam — and Steve beside him — both wore the same expression, the one worn by men who have seen fresh recruits come back from their first real loss and known, with sorrow and certainty, that a door had closed behind the kid forever.

"That's the moment," Steve said finally. "Everybody who does this work has one. The moment it stops being about you. I just — " He exhaled. "He's sixteen. I'd have wished him another few years before he found it."

"Wish him nothing of the kind," said Doom, from his box, and there was — unmistakably, and to the visible discomfort of everyone who heard it — approval in the metallic voice. "The buffoon is dead. Something with a spine of dragon-bone stood up inside his skin tonight. The girl's tribunal made an enemy this evening that it entirely lacks the imagination to fear, and Doom, for one, anticipates their education."

The Ghost Rider's flame, back in the dark, burned steady and low, like a signal fire answering another signal fire a long way off.

And above them all, the Watcher looked at the dimmed screen for a long time. Nightcrawler, glancing up — because he had been praying, quietly, in German, for a girl who did not exist in any world he could reach — was the only one positioned to see it, and he would spend some days deciding whether he had truly seen it at all:

The Watcher's hand, closing slowly at his side. Not in judgment.

In hope.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Asia's Trial and Execution" — Trauma-Class (first Trauma-Class pull in theatre history; grey banner, cathedral-door tone)
- "Issei's Protective Rage" — Super Rare (violet-red banner, cracked-bell chime)

Secrets Revealed

- The Church in Issei's cosmology formally tried and excommunicated Asia Argento for healing a Devil — mercy itself prosecuted as heresy — and her exile delivered her directly to Raynare's fallen angels, who intend a fatal ritual to extract Twilight Healing.
- Issei possesses a second register of anger: cold, quiet, unreadable — the inverse of his comedic fury. Ddraig identifies it as "the other kind" of rage and calls it *a beginning*, hinting at what two thousand years of hosts have taught him to watch for.
- The Boosted Gear can self-manifest in response to Issei's emotional state, unsummoned.
- The theatre's rarity system includes a Trauma-Class tier, implying it grades events by wound as well as by spectacle.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Nightcrawler: faith intact but institutionally shaken; openly framing Asia as a living embodiment of grace condemned by its own custodians.
- Daredevil: Catholic guilt sharpened into an unresolved verdict — cannot decide if the cruelty betrays the faith or is load-bearing to the institution; keeps attending Mass anyway.
- Kamala Khan: emerging as the room's moral plumb line — cut through the theological debate with cross-faith clarity ("whoever saves a life...").

- Ghost Rider: declared Asia soul-clean ("nothing in her to burn") and entered the tribunal on his ledger; now personally invested in her persecutors' reckoning.
- The Watcher: first visible reaction in seven chapters — admits he is "not indifferent" and uncertain whether that is permitted; Nightcrawler alone saw his hand close in what looked like hope.
- Doom: openly approves of cold-rage Issei ("the buffoon is dead"), anticipating the Church's "education."
- Cap, Shang-Chi, T'Challa, Kamala: respect for Issei now carries a thread of genuine wariness — his fury read as dangerous rather than comedic for the first time.

Unresolved Hooks

- The rescue at the abandoned church has begun on screen but not resolved — Asia's fate, and its cost, remain unpaid.
- The Living Tribunal's cameo: "The scales notice her because she has never once asked them to" — what do the scales intend for Asia?
- The Watcher perceives Issei's and Asia's threads "braiding into a single cord" — convergence unexplained.
- Ddraig's "It is a beginning" — beginning of *what*, and what did his previous hosts' cold rage lead to?
- Whether the theatre's Trauma-Class tier signals more wound-graded pulls to come.
- Raynare's ledger — the Ghost Rider "hopes to be there" when it comes due.

Chapter Nine: The First Time He Terrified Heaven

Primary Reaction Groups: Asgardians (Thor, Loki, Odin) — Heliopolitans (Horus) — Olympians (Hercules, Ares) — Cosmic Authorities (Uatu the Watcher, the Living Tribunal)

Gacha Pulls:

- "Ddraig's Roar at Heaven" — **Mythic**
 - "Issei's Oath Against God" — **Epic**
-

The theatre had never been quiet after a chapter ended. Not truly. There was always the low tide of a thousand factions muttering, arguing, grieving, laughing at one another's grief. But after the last chapter — after they had watched a gentle girl be cast out by her own Church for the crime of healing a Devil, after they had watched the boy's face do that *thing* it did, that slow tectonic shift from goofy to glacial — the noise had a different texture. It was the sound of a room recalibrating.

"He's still just a boy," Daredevil said, to no one in particular, in the way a man says a thing he is trying to keep believing.

"Aye," said Thor, from three rows up and one pantheon over. "So was I, once. It didn't take."

The great screen, which had gone dark and patient as a closed eye, brightened. The gacha wheel assembled itself out of golden light — the room had learned to hate and crave that wheel in equal measure — and began to spin. Its segments blurred: bronze, silver, gold, and then colors that had no business existing, colors the theatre only deployed when it wanted the gods in the room to sit up.

The wheel slowed. Clicked. Stopped on a segment that burned like the inside of a star.

[PULL: "DDRAIG'S ROAR AT HEAVEN" — RARITY: MYTHIC]

A hush went through the sections of the theatre where the divine sat. Mythic. The theatre had thrown that word around exactly twice before, and both times the chapter that followed had rearranged somebody's understanding of the boy on screen.

Before anyone could finish drawing breath, the wheel spun again — the theatre in a generous mood, or a cruel one; with the theatre it was so often the same mood — and stopped a second time.

[PULL: "ISSEI'S OATH AGAINST GOD" — RARITY: EPIC]

"Oh," said Loki, very softly, leaning forward in his seat with the expression of a man who has just been handed someone else's diary. "Oh, *now* we're getting somewhere."

Odin, who attended perhaps one chapter in five and slept — or pretended to sleep — through half of those, opened his single eye.

The screen bloomed into the aftermath of the last chapter's horror.

Night, in that provincial Japanese town. The ruined church on the hill still smoldering in the story's recent memory. And Issei Hyoudou — seventeen years old, dead once already, a Devil for less time than most of the theatre's occupants took to choose breakfast — standing under a sky he had every reason to hate.

The theatre had watched him fight before. They had watched him lose before, over and over, and drag himself up each time with that stubborn, undignified, weirdly magnificent refusal to stay down. They knew the shape of his anger now, after Asia. They thought they did.

They had not seen this.

He was not screaming yet. That was the first wrong note, the thing that made the veteran warriors in the room go still. The boy stood with his fists at his sides and his head tipped back, staring up past the clouds, past the moon, at the throne he could not see and had never been allowed to see, and he was *breathing*. Slow. Deliberate. Like a man counting himself down from something.

"His heart rate," Daredevil murmured, out of habit, though of course he could hear nothing from a screen. But he could read the throat, the jaw, the stance. "That's not panic. That's someone deciding."

On the screen, the red gauntlet on Issei's left arm gleamed. The green gem at its heart pulsed once — twice — like something waking up and choosing to be awake.

"**Partner,**" came Ddraig's voice, that vast rumble the theatre had come to know, the sound of a mountain that had opinions. "**You should think carefully about what you say next. Words spoken in rage travel further than you know. Some of them travel all the way up.**"

"Good," said Issei Hyoudou.

And then he told Heaven what he thought of it.

It was not eloquent. That was the second wrong note, the thing that made it land harder instead of softer. There was no rhetoric in it, no theology, none of the lawyerly precision that Daredevil's Church had taught him to expect from disputes with the divine. It was a teenager's fury, raw and specific and *personal*. He shouted Asia's name at the sky. He shouted what they had done to her — a girl who had never asked for anything, who had healed everyone put in front of her without once asking what they

were, who had prayed every single day to a Heaven that let her be thrown away like a broken tool. He shouted that if that was what God's justice looked like, then God's justice could come down here and explain itself to his face.

"If You're up there —" his voice cracked, and he did not care, and the not-caring was somehow the most frightening part — "if You were *ever* up there, and You let that happen to her — then You'd better hope I never get strong enough to climb up and ask You why. Because I will. I swear it. On my life, on my death, on whatever I am now — if Heaven ever reaches for someone I love again, I will tear the gates off it with my own hands."

Silence, on screen. Silence, in the theatre.

A newly-turned low-class Devil. Eight pawns' worth of resurrection and a body that still lost fistfights to mid-tier fallen angels. Making an open oath of war against the single most powerful authority in his entire cosmology.

And then the gem on the gauntlet flared, and Ddraig did not tell him to stop.

Ddraig *roared*.

The theatre's sound system — if that was even the right word for whatever cosmic mechanism carried the story to ten thousand ears — had reproduced explosions, divine hymns, the death-screams of stray devils, the crack of Kiba's swords. It had never once made the building itself respond.

The roar came up through the floor.

It was not loud the way noise is loud. It was loud the way an earthquake is loud, the way the sea deciding to come inland is loud — a pressure, a declaration written directly into the bones of everyone present, translated by some ancient grammar older than language: *I AM HERE. I STAND WITH HIM. COME AND LEARN WHAT THAT COSTS.*

On screen, the sky over the little town seemed to flinch. Birds went up from every tree for miles. Somewhere, canonically, in a realm the camera did not show, things with six wings and twelve wings and eyes all the way around stopped what they were doing and turned toward a point on the map of Japan that had, until that night, mattered to precisely no one.

In the theatre, drink cups rattled in their holders. Kamala Khan grabbed the armrest. Ghost Rider's flame guttered sideways as if in a wind. And in the pantheon sections — the sections where sat beings who *remembered* dragons, who had fought things of that lineage or fled from them or been them — the reaction was immediate and involuntary.

Heimdall stood up.

Fandral, who had been halfway through a joke, did not finish it.

And Thor Odinson threw back his head and *laughed*.

It was not mockery. Everyone within forty rows could hear that it was not mockery. It was the huge, helpless, delighted laughter of a man watching something he had crossed nine realms hoping to see. He pounded the armrest — the theatre's indestructible construction was, for once, a mercy — and wiped his eyes and pointed Mjolnir at the screen like a toast.

"THERE it is!" he bellowed. "There it is! Did you see him? Did you *hear* him? Not one chance in ten thousand of surviving the fight he just picked, and he picked it with his whole chest! Asgard has raised warriors for a hundred thousand years and I tell you we produce one of *those* a generation if we're lucky!" He turned, beaming, to the rows around him, entirely unbothered by the fact that half of them were staring at him. "You don't understand. You're hearing a boy yell at the sky. I'm hearing an *oath*. In the old way. Witnessed by a dragon. There are laws older than your law, Murdock —" this hurled cheerfully down toward the street-level heroes — "and one of them says that courage is not measured against your enemy's strength. It is measured against your own fear. And that boy just spent every coin of fear he had and asked Heaven if it took credit."

"He's going to die," someone called from the Hell's Kitchen rows.

"Probably!" Thor agreed, radiant. "Gloriously!"

Two seats over, Loki had not laughed. Loki had gone very still, chin on laced fingers, green eyes tracking the screen with the particular hunger he reserved for watching someone else do something he wished he'd thought of.

"You're all watching the wrong thing," he said, quietly, and because it was Loki and because he so rarely spoke without an angle, people listened. "Yes, yes, the courage, very stirring, Thor will be composing drinking songs by intermission. Look *past* it. Ask what the oath *does*."

"It gets him killed," Ares grunted from the Olympian block.

"It gets him *seen*," Loki corrected. "That is a boy at the absolute bottom of his world's hierarchy. Yesterday, no throne in his cosmology knew his name. Devils' nobility saw a resource. Fallen angels saw a target. Heaven saw nothing at all — he was beneath the resolution of their attention. And in thirty seconds of shouting, he has forced every power in his world to open a file on him." Loki's mouth curled, slow and appreciative. "Defiance as theater. An announcement dressed as a tantrum. Whether he intended it — and he didn't, that's the maddening part, he *meant every word*, which is why it works — he has just made himself a piece on the board instead of a square. I have spent centuries engineering moments like that. He did it by *accident*, out of love, and a dragon co-signed it." He sat back. "I hate him a little. Note it down."

"Noted," said Thor, still grinning.

Behind them both, Odin All-Father watched the screen with his one eye, and said nothing for a long moment. When he finally spoke, it was almost to himself, and only Loki was listening closely enough to catch it.

"The dragon did not roar for the boy's oath," Odin said. "The dragon roared for his own. Two vows went up to that Heaven tonight, not one. Whoever sits that throne heard both." He closed his eye again. "I remember when things last swore against *my* hall in that voice. I did not sleep well for a century."

In the Heliopolitan section, Horus the Avenger had risen to his feet somewhere during the roar and had not sat back down.

He was not a god given to theatre — ironic, the Asgardians liked to say, for a being with a falcon's head and a sun for an inheritance — and when he spoke his voice carried the dry heat of the desert at noon.

"You are treating this as comedy," he said, and it was aimed at Thor without rancor, one warrior-god to another. "Or as spectacle. It is neither. It is *liturgy*." He gestured at the screen, where Issei stood panting under the reeling sky, the gauntlet's glow slowly banking. "My people understood something yours dress up in mead and boasting. To challenge the throne of your own Heaven is not rebellion. It is a rite. I challenged my uncle for the throne of the gods across eighty years of trial because the order of the world was *wrong* and no one seated within that order would right it. The contest was not blasphemy. The contest was the only prayer left." His talon-tipped hand closed slowly. "That boy just prayed the only prayer left to him. His Heaven took a healer who loved it and threw her to the dogs. What is left to say to such a Heaven except *come down and be judged*?"

"Careful, bird," Ares called across the aisle, lounging with his boots up on the seat in front of him, which belonged to a horrified junior functionary of the Shi'ar delegation. "Keep talking like that and mortals start getting ideas. I've had mortals swear against Olympus. You know what we called them?"

"Ash," Hercules said.

"Ash," Ares agreed, satisfied.

"*Some* of them," Hercules said, and there was a note in it that made his half-brother's smirk falter. The Lion of Olympus was not laughing, which was itself remarkable; Hercules laughed at nearly everything, it was how he stayed sane across three thousand years. He was leaning forward, elbows on his knees, watching the boy on the screen with an old, complicated expression. "Some of them we called ash. And some of them we sat beside at the feast afterward, because they turned out to be right, and we were too proud to admit it until they'd bled enough to make the point unignorable." He rubbed his jaw. "I fought my own pantheon's decrees. I hauled Cerberus into the daylight because a king with a throne's authority

told me to and the gods allowed it, and half of Olympus called it hubris and the other half called it labor. I have *been* the mortal shouting upward, cousins. It is not arrogance. From inside, it never feels like arrogance." He nodded at the screen, slow and deliberate, a gesture with the weight of a laurel placed on a stranger's brow. "It feels like the only honest thing left in the world. Zeus can scoff. I'll buy the boy a drink. If he lives."

"He won't," Ares said.

"Odds?" said Hercules.

"Don't," said Athena's empty seat, in the sense that everyone glanced at it and remembered she'd have said it.

It was into this — the laughter, the liturgy, the wager taking shape between Olympians — that the temperature of the theatre changed.

There were two beings in the room whom nobody sat near. One stood in his customary place upon a high dais that had simply been there since the first chapter, a vast pale figure with a swollen brow, watching, as he had watched everything, always. He rarely reacted. That was the entire horror of him: a being for whom the destruction of galaxies and the first steps of a child carried the same grave, bottomless attention.

Uatu the Watcher had reacted.

It was small. A shift of the head. A fractional narrowing of attention, the way a telescope tightens focus. But the beings in the room who knew how to read him — and Odin was one, and Loki was another, and the thing wearing the Rider's skull was a third — saw it and understood that somewhere in an infinite catalogue, an entry had just been rewritten.

"You felt that," Loki said. Not a question. He had gotten braver about addressing the dais as the chapters wore on.

"I observed it," the Watcher said, which was as close as he ever came to conversation. And then, because the theatre itself seemed to lean on him, because ten thousand faces had turned toward the dais wanting the thing named, he named it.

"Power," Uatu said, "is common. I have watched a billion beings grow strong. Strength changes what a being *can* do. It does not change what a being *will* do. The boy's strength tonight is negligible. It will not remain so, but that is not what you all felt." His gaze did not leave the screen. "What you felt was a category shifting. There exist beings who accumulate power and spend their eternities defending it. There exist beings who accumulate power in order to ascend a hierarchy. And there exists a third kind

— rarest of the three — that looks at the summit of its hierarchy and declares the summit itself illegitimate. Such beings do not seek a better seat at the table. They put the table itself on notice." A pause, and in the pause, the whole theatre heard it coming. "Every truly dangerous being I have ever watched belonged to the third kind. And the dragon knows it. That roar was not encouragement. It was *endorsement*. Ddraig Goch has met gods. Ddraig Goch has *killed* the servants of gods. He does not lend his voice to bluffs."

And then, for one instant — no longer than a blink, and half the theatre would spend the rest of the night arguing about whether it had happened at all — the space above the screen was occupied.

Three faces. One in shadow. A figure so vast that the theatre, which had comfortably seated Celestials, seemed briefly like a diorama in its palm. The Living Tribunal did not speak. The Living Tribunal did not need to speak. Its arrival at any event was itself the entire message: *this has been noticed at the level where noticing matters*.

It regarded the frozen image of a seventeen-year-old boy shaking his fist at the sky.

It inclined its hooded heads — the slightest angle, less a bow than a bookmark.

It was gone.

"Okay," said Kamala Khan, in a very small voice, into the ringing silence. "Okay, so that happened. That's — did anyone else — the giant three-faced cosmic supreme court just *bookmarked* Issei. The hopeless pervert. *Our* hopeless pervert. I don't know whether to be proud or start digging a bunker."

"Both," said Ghost Rider. It was the most words he had contributed in two chapters.

The screen was winding down toward the chapter's end. On it, the fury had finally run out of the boy the way fury does — all at once, leaving him hollow and swaying — and he had dropped to his knees in the grass, and the theatre watched the terrifying thing become, again, just Issei: scraped knuckles, tear-tracks he'd deny to his grave, whispering Asia's name like an apology.

"**You meant it,**" Ddraig said, quiet now, the mountain speaking only for its partner. "**Every word. I have carried hosts who swore grander oaths with emptier hearts. Heaven heard you tonight, partner. So did everything else that listens to Heaven's frequency. Your life just became more dangerous and more interesting in the same breath.**" A pause, and then, with something that eight chapters ago no one would have believed the great Red Dragon Emperor capable of — something gruff and warm and almost paternal: "**Good. I was getting bored. Now stand up. If you are going to threaten God, you will not do it kneeling.**"

And the boy laughed — wet, cracked, real — and stood up.

That was when the theatre's own machinery moved.

Everyone had long since learned to ignore the ambient status displays that drifted at the edges of the great screen: viewer counts that counted no one, cryptic progress bars, the gacha history scrolling in gold. But now a panel that no one had ever seen before unfolded across the bottom of the screen with a sound like a vault door acknowledging a correct combination, and the theatre displayed, in tall unhurried letters:

[SUBJECT: HYODOU ISSEI] [CURRENT POWER CLASSIFICATION: NEGLIGIBLE] [POTENTIAL THREAT INDEX: RECALCULATING...]

The word *RECALCULATING* pulsed three times.

Then a meter appeared beside it — and everyone in the room understood instinctively that the meter had existed since chapter one, that it had been tracking all along, silently, and that the theatre was only *showing* it to them now, which was somehow far worse. The meter's fill sat at a thin, almost pitiable sliver near the bottom.

While ten thousand beings watched, it began to rise.

Not dramatically. That was the horror of it. No surge, no klaxon. Just a slow, patient, tick — tick — tick upward, the sound of interest compounding, and beneath it a single line of small print that the cosmically literate in the audience read first and reacted to worst:

[NOTE: INDEX WEIGHTED FOR INTENT. STRENGTH PENDING. INTENT: CONFIRMED.]

[TRAJECTORY: UNBOUNDED.]

"Unbounded," Loki repeated, tasting it.

"Unbounded," Thor agreed, and this time when he laughed there was an edge under the delight, the sound of a warrior god privately moving a name from one list to another.

On the dais, the Watcher watched, as he had always watched. But those nearest swore afterward that as the lights came down for intermission, the meter still faintly ticking in the dark like a clock in an empty house, Uatu's attention never once returned to the rest of the room.

It stayed on the boy.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Ddraig's Roar at Heaven" — Mythic
- "Issei's Oath Against God" — Epic

Secrets Revealed

- The theatre has been tracking a hidden **Potential Threat Index** for Issei since Chapter One — it was only now made visible, weighted for *intent* over strength, with trajectory listed as **UNBOUNDED**.
- Ddraig does not lend his roar to bluffs: per the Watcher, the dragon's endorsement means Ddraig genuinely believes Issei will one day be able to back the oath.
- Odin's read: *two* oaths reached Heaven that night — the boy's and the dragon's own.
- Heaven (and "everything that listens on Heaven's frequency") has formally noticed Issei's existence; he is now a piece on the board, not a square.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- **Thor**: fully won over — hails the oath as old-way warrior courage witnessed by a dragon; privately moves Issei to a new "list."
- **Loki**: fascinated; logging Issei as an accidental master of defiance-as-political-theater. Admits (to himself) a sliver of envy.
- **Horus**: elevates the oath from blasphemy to *rite* — frames challenging one's own Heaven as sacred contest, citing his war for the throne against Set.
- **Hercules**: quiet, earned approval from a god with his own history of defying Olympus — offers to buy Issei a drink "if he lives."
- **Ares**: contemptuous; predicts ash. An informal Olympian wager on Issei's survival is now open.
- **Uatu the Watcher**: reclassifies Issei from "strong-someday" to the rarest and most dangerous category — beings who declare their hierarchy's summit illegitimate. His attention no longer leaves the boy.
- **The Living Tribunal**: appeared for an instant and "bookmarked" the moment — escalation of category, not power.
- **Kamala Khan / street-level heroes**: pride and alarm in equal measure; "our hopeless pervert" is now cosmically flagged.

Unresolved Hooks

- What, precisely, in Heaven heard the oath — and why the throne's response (or silence) matters more than the room yet knows.

- The Potential Threat Index is still ticking upward *between* chapters, audible in the dark of intermission.
- Odin's century of lost sleep: what last swore against Asgard "in that voice," and is it in this theatre?
- The Olympian wager on Issei's survival — Hercules vs. Ares, stakes undeclared.
- Ddraig's warming into something openly paternal ("you will not threaten God kneeling") — and what the dragon meant by "I was getting bored."
- The Living Tribunal's bookmark: appearances by that being are never without eventual consequence.

Chapter Ten: The Red Dragon Emperor

Primary Reaction Groups: Cosmic Entities • Avengers • Magicians

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Balance Breaker: Scale Mail" — **Legendary**
 2. "Illegal Move Triaina Teaser" — **Rare**
-

The intermission ended the way a held breath ends.

For the whole of the dark between chapters, the Potential Threat Index had gone on ticking — soft, patient, arrhythmic, the sound of a meter measuring something that refused to stop growing even when no one was watching it. Ten thousand beings had sat in the dimness listening to it the way you listen to a faucet dripping in a house you have just been told is haunted. Conversations had started and died. Hercules had tried to collect early on his wager with Ares and been rebuffed. Somewhere in the villains' tier, someone had begun humming along with the meter and been made, by consensus, to stop.

Then the lights rose a single degree, and the wheel assembled itself, and above it, in letters that seemed larger than usual — or perhaps only heavier — the theatre printed:

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun. It did not tick down through its colors with its usual coy roulette patience. It accelerated, blurred, and slammed to a stop on a color no one had yet seen it land on: a deep, arterial crimson shot through with gold, the exact shade of a certain gauntlet, and the theatre flooded with that color to its highest tier as the screen stamped:

"BALANCE BREAKER: SCALE MAIL" — RARITY: LEGENDARY.

"New tier," Kraglin said, into the hush, with the doomed helpfulness of a man who had appointed himself the room's rarity commentator nine chapters ago and could not now resign. "That's — yeah. That's above Epic. Legendary. We ain't had a Legendary."

"We've had Mythics," Sam Wilson said. "Mythic's higher, right? Dragon introduction, roar at Heaven — those were Mythic."

"Mythics were *about* the dragon," said Shuri, quietly, eyes already on the screen with the light of it pooling in them. "Look at the naming convention. This one is about the *boy*."

[**WELSH DRAGON BALANCE BREAKER,**] said the screen, in the vast gravel voice that was not the system's voice at all, and the theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

A valley in the mountains of northern Japan, after midnight, under a sky that was wrong.

The wrongness was professional: a barrier, the audience understood at once, the knowledge arriving the way knowledge did here. A pocket of sealed space folded out of the human world, ten kilometers of evacuated dark — pine slopes, a dead ski town, a river like a strip of foil — requisitioned as a battlefield so that nothing that happened here would happen to anyone. Devils did this, the vision supplied. Standard practice. War with the noise removed.

The war in question stood on the air above the ruined town, and it had eight wings.

He had been beautiful once, in the way of things made before continents. Now the fallen angel who called himself **Absalom of the Scattered Host** was beautiful the way a burnt cathedral is: tall, gaunt, robed in the grey of old ash, his eight wings the color of paper that has been through a fire and kept, unaccountably, its shape. Beneath him, arrayed through the streets of the empty town, moved his Host — stray devils gone feral, rogue exorcists with stolen light-tech, a congregation of everything three factions had discarded, gathered up by a commander who had deserted Heaven's fallen when even *they* signed a peace. In his hand, held loosely, point down, was a lance of light so old and so saturated with use that it had stopped being white. The vision named it the way a museum names an exhibit: *Last Psalm. Forged in the Great War. Casualties: no longer counted.*

"Mythic-tier," murmured Doctor Strange in the theatre dark, reading resonances off the vision like a man reading fine print. "Not the foot soldiers — *him*. That's not a Raynare. That's not even a squad of Raynares. That's a general officer of a war older than their Heaven's silence."

"He is a relic that refuses to be one," Doom said. "I have employed such men. They are only ever cured of themselves by force."

At the southern edge of the town, the force arrived.

The audience knew the peerage by now — nine chapters had made the silhouettes familiar. Crimson-haired Rias with annihilation gathering at her fingertips like rot made obedient; Akeno already laughing thunder; the little Rook, Koneko, cracking her knuckles with a sound like a quarry starting work; Kiba a polite blur; Asia safe at the rear behind three layered wards, hands clasped, lips moving. They fanned out to hold the perimeter, to keep the Host off the barrier's walls.

They were not there to fight Absalom.

They were there to give the boy room.

Issei Hyoudou walked up the center of the dead main street alone, and the theatre noticed everything at once: that he was taller than the boy from the fountain, though not by much; that he walked with his weight settled the way Shang-Chi had spent three chapters complaining he didn't; that he was afraid, visibly, honestly afraid, his heart audible to a blind man in the cheap seats — and that the fear was not slowing him down by so much as a step.

"Absalom of the Scattered Host!" he called up, and his voice cracked in the middle of the name, and he plowed on anyway. "You were offered terms! Everyone down here was offered terms! Last chance — stand your people down, and nobody has to—"

Light answered him. Not a spear — a *sky* of spears, a hundred lances condensing above the street in one breath, the signature move of the thing that had murdered him rewritten as a weather system. The audience felt the whole room flinch on the boy's behalf, ten thousand memories of a fountain and a hole below a sternum.

Issei did not flinch. He raised his left arm, and the green gem caught the spear-light and turned it the color of deep summer, and he said — quietly, like a man saying it to himself, like a key going into a lock he had finally, finally earned —

"Balance Break."

[WELSH DRAGON BALANCE BREAKER.]

What happened next took less than a second, and the vision, in its mercilessness, spent a long time on it. Crimson erupted from the gauntlet and *unfolded* — not conjured plating, not a suit arriving, but something more like a truth being told at last about what had been walking around in a school uniform. Scale locked over scale, up the arm, across the chest, down the spine; golden spikes rose at the joints; a helm closed over the terrified brown eyes and replaced them with slits of burning green; great jointed pinions of red membrane and blade snapped out from the shoulder blades and caught the night air with a crack like a mainsail; clawed gauntlets flexed, and a long segmented tail lashed once, insolently, behind. On the breastplate, a second green gem kindled. In the corner of the vision, small and clinical, a counter appeared:

[SCALE MAIL — SUSTAINED OPERATION.]

The rain of spears came down, and the Red Dragon Emperor went *up*, through it, into it, wings shedding turn after impossible turn, and the fight began.

It was not the fight the theatre expected. The theatre had been braced — after mountains erased and oaths roared at Heaven — for a bomb going off. What it got was worse and better: it got *craft*. Issei fought the spear-storm the way Steve Rogers fights a room, the way Carol Danvers flies a curtain of flak — economically, structurally, ten seconds at a time.

[BOOST.]

He took a lance across the pauldron and let the armor eat it, rolled off the impact, and put a claw through the casting-matrix of the exorcist battery that had fired it, and pulled the claw out gently, and the rogue exorcist inside the wreckage was alive, and furious about it.

[BOOST.]

He hit the stray-devil vanguard at the river like a red comet, and the audience waited for the crater, and instead he decelerated at the last instant — *wings as brakes, look at that*, Sam Wilson breathed, *he's flying it like he was born in it* — and went through them low and precise, tail sweeping legs, claws shearing weapons and not wrists, each [BOOST.] metered out and spent like a man on a budget.

[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]

"He's *banking*," Tony Stark said, on his feet in the theatre, hands sketching furiously in empty air. "Look at the intervals — he's not detonating the doubling the second he gets it, he's carrying compound load *inside the armor*, sustained, that's — okay, quick show of hands, who remembers chapter three? Who remembers when this form lasted *seconds* and nearly tore him apart? That counter's been running four minutes."

"Six," said Vision, mildly.

And then Absalom stopped watching, and came down, and the sky hit the boy.

Last Psalm against dragon scale sounded like the Great War being quoted. The first exchange threw Issei through the ski town's church — the vision lingered, without comment, on eight burnt wings framed by a broken steeple — and the second exchange he *took on the claws*, caught, held, the ancient lance grinding against gauntlets while the fallen commander looked into the burning green slits at close range and said, in a voice like a hymn left in the rain:

"They sent a *child* in a *toy*. I broke a hundred of your Emperor's hosts before your species learned bronze, little dragon. Take off the armor and I will make it quick, the way I did for—"

"**Partner**," rumbled the vast voice out of both gems at once, bored, ancient, and unmistakably fond, "**he is monologuing at you. This is the oldest gift an enemy gives. Say thank you.**"

"Thanks," said Issei Hyoudou, and boosted point-blank.

[EXPLOSION.]

The shockwave unzipped the street. Absalom went up and back, wings hammering for control, and got it, because Mythic-tier gets it — and rewrote the rules, dissolving *Last Psalm* into a lattice, a cage of light closing on the valley itself, spears by the thousand orienting on the peerage, on the perimeter, on

the wards where Asia stood. The oldest move in the commander's book: the boy is the shield, so aim at what he shields.

The theatre heard Issei's breathing change inside the helm. It heard him say, small and cold, "Okay. You aimed at her. Ddraig—"

"Already counting, partner."

[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]

The ten seconds between each doubling had never felt so much like a countdown in a silo. The Red Dragon Emperor rose above the caged valley, wings wide, both palms coming together, and crimson gathered between his claws — the mountain-eraser, the Dragon Shot the room had seen level a horizon in chapter three, now fed by a compounding that made Bruce Banner start doing arithmetic aloud and then, at ten to the fourth baseline and climbing, deliberately stop.

Absalom laughed at it. "You cannot fire that here, boy. Everything you love is under this sky."

"Yeah," Issei said. "That's why you're gonna be over it."

The claw closed on ash-grey robes faster than eight wings could beat — *Penetrate*, the audience felt, the boy's grip slipping through a defense older than his species like the defense had been a rumor — and the wings hammered, and the Red Dragon Emperor hauled a screaming Mythic-tier general straight up, out of the lattice, through his own cage of spears, past the barrier's dark ceiling into the sealed sky's empty upper vault where there was nothing left to shield and nothing left to lose, and fired.

The vision was kind to the audience in exactly one way: it showed them the light from below, the way the peerage saw it. A second sunrise, vertical. A column of crimson that erased the cloud deck of a pocket universe. When it faded, the lattice of spears was gone the way a spiderweb goes when the spider does, and something with the remains of eight wings was drifting down the long dark like a burnt page, alive — deliberately, surgically alive — to be caught, at the bottom, by a boy in red armor who set the ancient horror down on the riverbank almost gently, and crouched beside him, helm retracting from a scraped, exhausted, absurdly young face, and said:

"So — terms. Same ones as before. They don't get worse just 'cause you lost."

The counter in the corner read [**SCALE MAIL — SUSTAINED OPERATION: 21:07**] and was still, patiently, counting.

The vision released them.

For three full seconds, the theatre made no sound at all.

Then it made all of them.

"Run the intercept back," Carol Danvers was saying, over the roar, to no one and everyone, with the specific indignation of a pilot watching someone fly her airspace better than expected. "The vertical extraction. He identified the hostage geometry, inverted it, and turned a city-buster into a *safe* shot by changing the battlefield's *axis*, mid-fight, at Mach — someone give me a number—"

"You're missing it," Sam said. "You're all missing it. Chapter one, that kid couldn't dodge a *thrown spear*. That's the same kid. That's *ten chapters* of the same kid."

"That," said Steve Rogers, "is the entire point of the exercise." He was on his feet, arms folded, and he was not smiling, but there was something in his face that his oldest friends recognized from bond drives and beach landings — the look he wore when the skinny kid theory of the universe received new supporting evidence. "Everything we've been shown, in order. The murder. The failures. The training. The losses to Sairaorg. The oath. And now the same boy metering his strength like a veteran and offering terms to the thing that aimed at his family. You don't get this from talent." He looked around the tiers. "You get this from *character* plus *time*. Somebody built him the slow way. It's the only way that holds."

"The armor," said Thor, and the room quieted for him, because his voice had the old-story weight in it again. "You are all admiring the boy, as is right. Admire also what he *wore*. That was no suit, Stark, no forged thing. Balance Breaker — did you feel the word's shape? It is a *covenant broken open*. The dragon does not lend him that armor." He shook his head slowly, with the reverence he reserved, in all the Nine Realms, for perhaps four beings. "The dragon *becomes* it. Ddraig wrapped his own body around a mortal child for twenty-one minutes and called it partnership. I have seen gods refuse far less to far worthier."

"It is more interesting than that," Doom said, and the theatre performed its now-traditional maneuver of pretending not to lean toward the truce corner where Doom and Strange had, without ever agreeing to, begun sitting a mere aisle apart. "The sorcerers in this room will have noted what the soldiers did not. Balance Breaker is described in their cosmology as a *flaw* — a bug, Stark, in your dialect. The system that made Sacred Gears did not intend this state. It is reached by desire exceeding design." The mask tilted. "Consider what we watched, then. A god builds a weapon with a governor bolted to it, and the governor's override condition is *wanting something more than the weapon was built to allow*. That boy overrode divine engineering with the strength of his *feelings*. Doom finds this architecture... instructive."

"Doom finds it *replicable*, he means," Strange said dryly, but his heart wasn't in the sparring, and everyone could hear it. He was quiet a moment. When he went on, it was slower, and it was addressed to the room. "Ten chapters ago I told you we were inside a briefing. Here's my updated read. We've now

seen the full shape of a weapons system that starts at *nothing* — genuinely nothing, the boy was the least remarkable soul in his zip code — and compounds. No cap. Uncapped doubling, in armor that lets him hold the charge, wielded by someone whose response to absolute power is to *offer terms twice*." He looked up at the dark above the dark. "If you were preparing a multiverse to meet something, that's precisely the resume you'd make them read. Power without appetite. I've been doing this a long time. It's the rarest thing on any menu."

Wanda Maximoff, who had said little for nine chapters, said quietly, from the Midnight Suns' block: "The armor answered grief." Heads turned. She didn't elaborate at first; she was watching the frozen last frame, the boy crouched by his broken enemy. "Everyone's talking about the engineering. The override wasn't ambition. Watch it again. Every threshold he's crossed since chapter one — the gauntlet, the roar, this — it triggers when someone he loves is *aimed at*. That's the ignition system." Her voice stayed level, and was somehow worse for it. "Be very careful, all of you, about ever letting anything happen to that girl in the wards."

"Seconded," said Mephisto pleasantly, "notarized, and filed." The demon lord had produced, from nowhere, something that looked disturbingly like an actual ledger. "Meanwhile: chapter one, this room watched a princess spend eight Pawns on a corpse and I told you she'd seen priceless goods. Today the corpse held off and humanely defeated a Great War cadre commander at age seventeen, in a form his own God never authorized. I invite the room to appreciate my track record, and note that I am no longer the only buyer paying attention." He smiled his appalling smile up at the highest tiers. "Am I."

He was not. The cosmic tier had gone very still. The Silver Surfer hung above the mezzanine, and when he finally spoke it was with the flat vast gentleness that had unsettled the room since chapter one. "I was made a herald by a bargain," he said. "My power was given in a moment, whole. I have wondered, ten chapters now, why I cannot look away from this child. I understand it tonight." He looked at the frozen frame — the crouch, the offered terms. "He is being given power the way sediment is given to a river. Slowly enough to remain himself the entire way up. I was not. Nothing that rises fast is." A pause. "I would like to see what a kind being looks like at altitudes I know. I have never once been shown."

And above them all, Uatu the Watcher, who had spent an intermission unable to take his attention off the boy, said nothing at all — but those nearest him noticed that his great hands, folded for nine chapters, had come quietly apart, and that one of them now rested on the rail.

The screen chimed.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel spun and landed, almost apologetically, on plain silver-blue.

"ILLEGAL MOVE TRIAINA TEASER" — RARITY: RARE.

"Rare," Rocket said flatly. "*Rare*. We just did a whole new tier of red for the tin suit and the thing called 'ILLEGAL MOVE' is *Rare*?"

"The *teaser* is *Rare*," said Loki softly, from wherever Loki was sitting this chapter, which was never twice the same seat. His eyes had narrowed to green slits with arithmetic behind them. "Mark the noun, rodent. The theatre prices honestly — that has been its one courtesy. A glimpse is cheap." He steeped his fingers. "It is the *thing glimpsed* that will cost us."

The theatre did not swallow them whole this time. That was the first strangeness. Instead the screen itself changed — pulled back, letterboxed, dimmed at the edges like a memory of a memory — and across the top, in the small clinical font it used when it was talking to itself, it printed:

[PREVIEW. AUTHORIZATION: PARTIAL. THE FOLLOWING HAS NOT YET OCCURRED.]

"Not yet," murmured Natasha Romanoff. "It shows futures now. Noted."

What followed lasted perhaps forty seconds, and the room would spend far longer than that arguing about it.

A flash: the Scale Mail, familiar now, crimson and complete — and then *changing*, plates flying off it, discarding mass, the armor slimming to something knife-blue at the joints and jet-swift, and the boy inside it moving in a way that made Quicksilver's brother-in-arms across the mutant block stand up involuntarily, because the frame did not blur so much as *concede* — a dozen afterimages of red-blue shredding a battlefield's worth of enemies between two beats of the audience's collective heart, and under it a system voice they knew, saying a word they didn't:

[CHANGE: WELSH SONIC BOOST KNIGHT.]

A flash: the opposite. The armor *gaining*, forearms swelling into something industrial, gauntlets become foundry blocks, and the boy planting his feet as something vast came down on him — and the vast thing losing, caught and crushed against knuckles that struck with a sound the theatre's own indestructible floor seemed to take personally:

[CHANGE: WELSH DRAGONIC ROOK.]

And a third flash, longest of the three. The armor opened. Back-mounted housings unfolded into a battery of cannons around a core of gathering light — and the light was wrong, the sorcerers were all on their feet before it fired, Strange and Doom and Wanda and Loki upright in the same instant like a string section — and when it fired, the beam did not travel through the intervening space so much as *renegotiate* it. The vision showed, with clinical relish, the fabric of the preview's unnamed battlefield bending around the shot: distance folding, the horizon flinching, a mountain that had been comfortably remote suddenly participating.

[CHANGE: WELSH BLASTER BISHOP.] [DRAGON BLASTER: STANDBY.]

Then, stamped across all three frozen silhouettes at once — the Knight, the Rook, the Bishop, three futures of one boy —

[ILLEGAL MOVE: TRIAINA.] [A PAWN MAY PROMOTE. THIS PAWN DOES NOT WAIT FOR THE BACK RANK.]

The screen went politely grey.

"No," said Hank Pym's voice from somewhere, "hold on, go back—"

"It warped space," T'Challa said, quietly, to Shuri, and Shuri, for the first time in ten chapters, did not have a follow-up question ready.

"It's the chess," Tony said. His voice had gone odd — flat, quick, the tone he used when the math had stopped being fun. "Everyone see it? Their whole reincarnation system runs on chess. Pawn, Knight, Rook, Bishop, legal moves, promotion rules. It's a *governed* system — Strange said it in chapter one, weaponized divinity, standardized. Rules everywhere." He pointed at the grey screen. "And they just told us that this kid's next trick is called *Illegal Move*. He's not going to climb their ladder. He's going to *cheat at the game their entire afterlife is built on*, one piece at a time, and the piece with the *cannons* bends spacetime. As a *preview*." He sat down, slowly. "The Legendary pull was the tutorial boss. The Rare pull was the syllabus."

"An apt word," said Doom, and something in his voice made even Stark look over. "Doom breaks rules that deserve breaking; it is the founding act of every sovereign. But mark the theatre's phrasing. *This pawn does not wait for the back rank*. Promotion, in chess, is earned by crossing the entire board under fire." A pause. "The board is what we have been watching for ten chapters. It is telling us he crosses it."

Thor laughed — the true laugh, the one with weather in it. "Three shapes! Speed, and the mountain-fist, and the lance that folds the world! Father kept a hall of tapestries of warriors with one such gift apiece." He shook his head, delighted and, underneath the delight, not. "And the dragon lets him *choose between them*. Loki. Brother. Tell me honestly what you would have been at seventeen with a menu of apotheoses."

"Insufferable," said Loki, "briefly," and did not take his eyes off the grey screen.

It was into that noise — the arguments cross-hatching the tiers, Danvers and Rhodes already gaming intercepts against a Sonic Boost Knight, Wong and Strange sketching containment geometry for a beam that renegotiated distance, Mephisto annotating his ledger with a pen that squirmed — it was into all of that, at the exact moment the room's voice reached its crest, that the screen came back on.

Everything else on it went away.

The rarity banners. The gacha wheel, mid-reassembly. The scrolling gold history of ten chapters of pulls. The status displays. Even the Potential Threat Index — and the room had time to register that its ticking had stopped, and to find the silence worse — all of it wiped, without ceremony, to black. Ten thousand beings quieted, tier by tier, the way a stadium quiets when the injury on the field stops looking routine.

And in the center of that perfect black, alone, in plain white letters with nothing to soften them, the theatre printed:

TUTORIAL COMPLETE.

No chime. No fanfare. The words simply sat there, patient as a headstone, while their meaning went through the theatre like cold water finding the gaps in a wall.

Peter Parker said it first, because someone had to, and it was always going to be him. His voice came out small in the enormous dark.

"Tutorial. That was the — guys. The murder. The dragon. The mountain. The oath at Heaven. The war general. All of that was the *tutorial*."

"The part of the game," said Miles, hollowly, "before it starts keeping score."

"The part they let you *lose*," said Gwen.

Fury's voice came out of the dark, low and even, the sound of a man updating a threat file he now understood to have been mislabeled at the cabinet level. "Ten chapters. Ten chapters of exponential growth, divine oaths, and a Great War commander going down humanely — and the system that built this room rates all of it as *onboarding*." A beat. "Recalibrate, people. Everything we've argued about, every list we've moved him on and off — we've been reviewing the cover of the book."

"Then attend," said the Silver Surfer softly, from above them all, "to how thick the book must be."

Hela was heard, from the villains' tier, to begin — very quietly — laughing. It was not her connoisseur's laugh. Ares, who had wagered on the boy dying, was not laughing at all; nor was anyone accepting his attempts to renegotiate the stakes with Hercules, whose grin had gone slightly fixed. Fin Fang Foom's scorn had assumed the specific density of scorn that is protecting something underneath. Doom stood motionless in his aisle, and the aisle had never seemed more built for him, and behind the mask Doom re-derived, alone, the implication he had already stated aloud: *the board is what we have been watching. It is telling us he crosses it.*

And up in the highest tier, Uatu the Watcher looked at the two words in the dark and did something he had not done in longer than most universes had existed.

He settled in.

The white words held one moment more. Then, beneath them, smaller, in the font the theatre used when it was talking to itself — the font it had used, ten chapters ago, for a line about the things they could not stand before — it added, gently, like a door opening onto a very long hallway:

ARC ONE OF TEN.

NEXT: THE MAKING OF A DRAGON.

The wheel began, softly, to tick.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Balance Breaker: Scale Mail" — Legendary (*viewed — first Legendary-tier pull*)
- "Illegal Move Triaina Teaser" — Rare (*viewed — first explicit PREVIEW; content "has not yet occurred"*)

Secrets Revealed:

- Issei's fully mastered **Scale Mail** (Balance Breaker): complete dragon armor with wings, claws, and tail; sustained operation past twenty-one minutes (vs. seconds in chapter three); compound Boost-banking inside the armor; Penetrate used through a Great War-era defense. He defeated and deliberately spared **Absalom of the Scattered Host**, an eight-winged Mythic-tier rogue fallen commander, and offered him unchanged terms after victory.
- Balance Breaker is a *flaw state* — desire overriding divine engineering. Per Doom: the boy overrode a god's governor with the strength of his feelings. Per Wanda: the ignition system is grief — every threshold triggers when someone he loves is aimed at.
- **Illegal Move Triaina** teased in three forms: Welsh Sonic Boost Knight (speed), Welsh Dragonic Rook (power/defense), Welsh Blaster Bishop (artillery — the **Dragon Blaster**, which visibly warps/renegotiates space). Screen's framing: "A PAWN MAY PROMOTE. THIS PAWN DOES NOT WAIT FOR THE BACK RANK."
- The theatre can and will show events that "HAVE NOT YET OCCURRED" (previews are now canon mechanics; the theatre "prices honestly" — the glimpse was Rare, the thing itself will not be).
- The screen wiped everything — including the still-ticking Threat Index — to print **TUTORIAL COMPLETE**, then **ARC ONE OF TEN / NEXT: THE MAKING OF A DRAGON**. All ten chapters so far are officially rated as *onboarding*.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Steve Rogers:** full endorsement — "character plus time; somebody built him the slow way. It's the only way that holds."
- **Tony Stark / Carol Danvers / Sam Wilson:** from analysis to genuine professional respect (Boost-banking, the vertical extraction, flying the armor "like he was born in it"); Stark newly rattled by the *Illegal Move* naming — the boy will cheat at the game his afterlife is built on.
- **Thor:** reverence deepened — reads Scale Mail as Ddraig wrapping his own body around a mortal and calling it partnership. **Loki:** covetousness now shaded with self-recognition ("Insufferable. Briefly.").
- **Doom:** finds Balance Breaker's desire-override architecture "instructive" (read: replicable); openly notes the theatre is telling them Issei crosses the whole board.
- **Wanda Maximoff** (first major statement): warns the room that Issei's power triggers on threats to loved ones — "be very careful about ever letting anything happen to that girl in the wards."
- **Silver Surfer:** personal investment declared — power given to Issei "like sediment to a river," slow enough to stay himself; the Surfer wants to see, for the first time, a *kind* being at his own altitudes.
- **Mephisto:** victory lap on his chapter-one valuation; keeping an actual ledger; warns he is "no longer the only buyer."
- **Uatu the Watcher:** hands unfolded, one on the rail; visibly settled in for the long story.
- **Ares:** attempting (and failing) to renegotiate his survival wager with Hercules.

Unresolved Hooks:

- **Arc-finale consensus on Issei:** the room's overall verdict after ten chapters — a murdered, talentless, comedically perverted boy who is *earned* rather than gifted; uncapped compounding power wielded with zero appetite ("power without appetite — the rarest thing on any menu," Strange); incorruptible precisely because he is immature, loyal, and grief-ignited; street-level heroes claim him, soldiers respect him, gods have begun revering what carries him, villains have stopped laughing and started filing. The room no longer argues about whether he matters — only about what he is *for*.
- **TUTORIAL COMPLETE:** if ten chapters of murder, resurrection, dragons, and Mythic-tier war was the tutorial, what does this theatre consider the *game* — and when does it start keeping score?
- The Triaina preview "has not yet occurred": the theatre shows futures. What else in the gold history was a past, and what upcoming pulls are prophecy?
- The Dragon Blaster warps space — the sorcerers rose as one before it fired. Containment geometry is already being sketched by Strange, Wong, and (separately, of course) Doom.
- The Threat Index's ticking *stopped* at "TUTORIAL COMPLETE." Paused — or reclassified?

- Standing hooks carried forward: Raynare marked by Castle and Wolverine; the Olympian wager; Odin's lost century of sleep; the Living Tribunal's bookmark; and the chapter-one line still unexplained — "HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT."

Chapter Eleven: Ten Days to Become Worthy

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers (Captain America, Thor) • Mutants (Cyclops) • Cosmic Mentors (The Eternals)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Compressed Training Under Pressure" — **Super Rare**
 2. "Transfer-Enhanced Rook Punch" — **Rare**
-

The words **TUTORIAL COMPLETE** had hung on the screen through the whole intermission, patient as a tombstone, and the theatre had spent the intermission arguing about them.

"Tutorial," Sam Wilson kept saying, to anyone in range. "That was the *tutorial*. The kid died, got bought, swore war on Heaven, and blew up a mountain, and the system's filing all of it under *teaching him the controls*."

"Every game I have ever played," Kamala Khan said, hugging her knees in her seat, "the tutorial is where they show you the mechanics. Then the real game starts, and the real game is where they start taking things away from you."

The lights dimmed before anyone could tell her she was wrong, which was just as well, because nobody had been planning to.

The screen did something new. Instead of the wheel, it filled edge to edge with slow crimson — not the gold of a pull, not the storm-grey of a death, but the deep, working red of a forge — and printed, in letters that assembled themselves like something being hammered into shape:

ARC TWO: THE MAKING OF A DRAGON.

"Ah," said Thor, settling back with the satisfaction of a man whose genre had finally arrived. "Now we are told how the blade was folded."

Beneath the arc title, smaller, the system added a note with its usual total absence of mercy:

YOU HAVE SEEN WHAT HE BECOMES. YOU WILL NOW SEE WHAT IT COST.

The wheel descended, spun through its colors, and stopped on silver shading into gold.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2. "COMPRESSED TRAINING UNDER PRESSURE" — RARITY: SUPER RARE.

And the theatre took its breath, and swallowed them.

They knew at once that the screen had jumped backward.

The room had learned the gacha's habits over ten pulls: it did not tell his life in order. It dealt his life like cards. They had already seen the crimson armor that erased a mountain; they had seen him lose, older and harder, to Sairaorg Bael. So when the vision resolved into the Occult Research Club's clubroom and the Issei standing in it was the *scrawny* one — the tutorial boy, weeks dead at most, shoulders like a coat hanger, gauntlet arm still a novelty he flexed when he thought no one was looking — a ripple of understanding went through the dark. This was before. This was the forge.

A magic circle opened on the clubroom floor, and it opened in *fire*.

The man who stepped out of the flames was tall, blond, beautiful, and wore his burgundy blazer half-buttoned the way expensive men do when they have never once been told no. The name arrived in a few thousand minds simultaneously: *Riser Phenex. Third son of the House of Phenex. High-class devil*. He looked around the clubroom the way a landlord looks at a property, and then he looked at Rias Gremory the same way.

"My lovely Rias," he said. "I've come to set a date."

What followed took eleven minutes of vision-time, and by the end of it half the theatre wanted him dead, which — the sharper minds noted — was almost certainly the point of showing it.

The facts assembled themselves. An arranged marriage, contracted between the Houses of Gremory and Phenex when Rias was a child, to shore up pureblood devil lines gutted by an old war. Rias had never consented. Rias had spent years saying so. It did not matter, because the contract did not require her to say yes; it only required her to fail to produce a legal way out. Riser explained all of this while lounging on the clubroom sofa, and then — to make a point to the boy glaring at him from across the room — pulled his own Queen down beside him and made the point at length, smirking at Issei over her shoulder the whole time.

"Oh, I *hate* him," announced Jennifer Walters, with a lawyer's crisp diction, from the row where she had been quietly gavel-fidgeting since the word *contract*. "I hate him and I want his prenup in discovery. A binding marriage compact executed by third parties over a minor's standing objection—"

"Is how half of Asgard's treaties were written," Thor said grimly. "It was vile then also."

On the screen, a woman in a maid's uniform with silver hair and a stillness like a drawn blade — *Grayfia Lucifuge*, the vision supplied, and several magic-sensitives in the audience sat up sharply at the power reading under that stillness — proposed the one legal way out. A Rating Game. A formal ritual war, peerage against peerage, watched by the pillars of devil society. If Rias's household won, the engagement could be challenged. If she lost, she married.

Riser laughed. It was the laugh of a professional invited to play a child.

"She's never played one," he said. "I've won *dozens*, and my pieces are complete. Very well — I'm generous. Ten days. Train them, little Rias. Bring me your best."

And the theatre understood, one beat before the vision cut, what the arc title had meant — because the last shot of the scene was not Riser's smirk and not Rias's white-knuckled fists. It was Issei Hyoudou, weakest piece on the board, dead-last of Kuoh Academy, looking down at the gauntlet on his left arm and understanding, visibly, in real time, that he had ten days to become worthy of the war he'd already sworn to fight.

Then the mountain began.

The vision did not montage it. That was the cruelty and the genius of the thing, the audience agreed afterward — a montage is edited by someone merciful, and the gacha was not merciful. It *compressed*. Ten days folded into them like ten days of memory, whole and unabridged and merely fast, and every hero in the theatre lived it from inside the boy's body.

Day one: a mountain trail in the northern forests, and Issei under a backpack the size of a wardrobe, because Rias — walking ahead, unburdened, ruthless — had loaded the entire camp onto her Pawn on the theory that his body was the only part of him she could improve in ten days, and the mountain would improve it or bury it. The audience felt his thighs go first, then his lower back, then the particular white-noise stage beyond burning where the body stops sending complaints because no one is answering. He fell eleven times. He got up eleven times. Nobody carried the pack for him, and — the young heroes noticed, some with outrage — nobody offered.

Day two, day three: swordwork with Kiba in a forest clearing, which meant losing to Kiba, thirty, forty, sixty times a morning, wooden blade spinning away into the ferns while the pretty blond Knight said "again" in a voice that never once condescended. Hand-to-hand with Koneko Toujou, four foot six of white-haired, deadpan Rook, who threw him over her shoulder into the turf with the serene regularity of a metronome. "Too slow," she said, each time, help him up, throw him again. "Too stiff. Again." The theatre felt every impact through his spine.

"She's benching what, exactly?" Luke Cage asked, watching the tiny girl one-arm a boulder off the training field like a stagehand moving furniture.

"Rook piece," said Peter Parker, who had been taking actual notes since chapter one. "Super strength, super defense. She's the smallest one there and she is *conclusively* the scariest, and I think that's on purpose, and I think I love this team."

Day four: magic with Akeno, and the first thing Issei had ever been simply, hopelessly *bad* at with no road forward — hours of guided breathing to produce a mote of demonic light the size of a firefly, while the Queen who could call lightning smiled and said *most devils would have quit by now* in a tone that made it a genuine compliment. Evenings: Rias and a chalkboard, drilling him on Evil Piece doctrine, promotion rules, the geometry of a Rating Game board, and the audience felt the academic dead-last gripping his own skull and *forcing* the material in by pure sustained will, because this part was for her.

And underneath all of it, constant as a heartbeat, the voice out of the gauntlet in the dark of his tent when everything hurt too much to sleep:

[Your body is a vessel, partner. Small, yes. Laughably small. But the walls are moving. I have worn hosts who trained for decades and widened less than you have in four days. Eat. Sleep. Break again tomorrow. I will be here.]

Day six, the vision showed them the cost. Asia Argento's healing light, green and gentle, knitting the boy's split knuckles and stress-fractured shins at night while he slept — and lingering, and trembling, because the sweet-faced healer could feel what the audience was now shown in cold system overlay: microfracture maps down both legs, deep-tissue trauma accumulating faster than even devil physiology and nightly healing could fully clear it. He was not getting through the ten days undamaged. He was *spending* something, and the ledger of it was written in his bones.

The vision released them there, on the overlay, holding the skeletal damage-map on screen for three full seconds like an accusation.

The lights came up on a divided room.

"Okay — no. Hold on." Miles Morales was on his feet. "He's *seventeen*. That's not a training camp, that's — my coach would be arrested. Someone's supposed to say stop. Someone's supposed to be the adult who says stop."

"They can't." The voice was Scott Summers', and it came out flat and level from the mutant block, and it carried, because Cyclops did not usually volunteer. He sat with his arms crossed, ruby lenses fixed on the frozen damage-map, and his tone was the one he used in the Danger Room when a student wanted the settings lowered. "Run the clock with me. Ten days. Opponent's a veteran with a full roster and a

regeneration factor. Every hour they spend protecting that kid from the training is an hour they donate to Riser Phenex. There's no responsible-adult option on the table. There's only the question of whether he breaks before day ten or after it." He paused, and something under the flatness bent, just slightly. "I've had to train children on that math. You do it, and you hate it, and you do it, because the alternative is burying them undertrained. What I want everyone to notice is *him*. Sixty throws a morning from the Rook. He got up sixty times, and by day five he was getting up *angry at himself* instead of at her. That's the rarest thing I ever see in a training room. That kid metabolizes failure into instruction. You cannot teach that."

"No," said Steve Rogers quietly. "You can only find it."

The theatre turned toward him. Captain America was leaning forward, forearms on knees, and his face wore an expression the oldest Avengers recognized: Steve Rogers looking at a scrawny kid who would not stay down, which was Steve Rogers looking into a mirror seventy years long. "I've been through a version of this," he said. "Somebody once compressed me too — one afternoon in a metal coffin in Brooklyn, and I came out the other side with a body that finally matched the fights I kept picking. But Erskine's serum did the work *for* me in ninety seconds. Nobody's doing it for him. He's doing it the way I did it *before* the serum — losing, and getting back up, and losing, and getting back up — except he's doing it with the volume turned up to a level that's breaking his skeleton, and he hasn't complained *once*, because the girl who gave him a second life is going to be sold off if he slows down." He shook his head slowly. "Ten days to become worthy. He decided he was going to be worthy on day one. The ten days are just paperwork."

"The regimen is sound, for what it is." Shang-Chi's voice, measured, from the martial-arts rows. "Overload, recover, overload. The swordsman gives him failure with dignity; the small Rook gives him failure with humility; the Queen gives him a failure he cannot fix, which is the most important kind. My father's courts trained killers in less time and broke nine of ten. This is not that. Watch the girl with the healing light — they are walking the edge of the cliff, but someone is *watching* the edge." He paused. "What concerns me is the arithmetic underneath. Ten days of this closes perhaps a tenth of the distance to the phoenix. They know it. Look at Rias Gremory's face when she thinks no one sees her. She is not training him to win. She is training him to survive losing."

That landed badly, and it was into the uncomfortable silence after it that a new voice spoke — deep, amused, and old in a way that made even Thor's antiquity feel recent.

"You are all reading it as ten days," said Gilgamesh.

Heads turned toward a block of seats up near the cosmic tier that had been, for ten chapters, almost perfectly silent: figures who sat with the unhurried stillness of beings for whom a century was a reasonable length for a conversation. The Eternals of Earth had watched Issei Hyoudou die, rise, swear,

and blaze, and had said nothing, because they were still deciding what he was. Now the Forgotten One — who had wrestled heroes into shape under a dozen names across five thousand years — leaned forward with his chin on one enormous fist, and he was grinning.

"I trained men before your Rome," he said. "Before writing, I trained them. And I will tell you the secret every immortal trainer learns and hates: the mayfly learns faster than the mountain. Give me a student with ten thousand years and he will coast for nine thousand of them. Give me a student with ten *days* and a girl he'd die for, and he will pour his whole life through the bottleneck like — well." He gestured at the screen, delighted. "Like that. Compression is not his handicap. Compression is his *element*."

"It is also eating him," said Ajak, beside him, and her voice was gentler and worse. The Eternals' priest and healer had not taken her eyes off the frozen damage-map. "I have mended human bodies since the ice retreated. That overlay is not a training cost, it is a down payment. His resurrection physiology is covering the interest — for now. But I want this room to mark what the machine just showed us, because it showed us deliberately: this boy's answer to every gap between what he is and what he must be is to pay the difference *out of his own body*. Tonight it is shinbones. It will not always be shinbones." Her gaze swept the heroes below. "You have all been admiring his willingness to break himself. I have buried ten thousand years of men whose friends admired that."

"And yet you can't look away either, Ajak," murmured Sersi, who was sitting sideways in her seat with her chin in her hand, entirely charmed. "None of us can. This is the thing about them — the thing I could never make the rest of you *feel*. We watched forests become cities and it moved us less than one furious child carrying a backpack up a hill. Brevity is their fire. He has ten days, so ten days will simply have to be enough. No Eternal has ever once had a thought like that. I think it might be the most beautiful thought there is."

"It's the most *dangerous* thought there is," said Sprite, sharp and small and not looking at anyone. "He gets to spend himself because he's got a self that ends. Lucky him."

Thor's voice rolled up from the Avengers' rows before that bitterness could settle. "In Asgard," he said, "a warrior trains five centuries before his first war, and we called that rigor. I watched this boy compress my five centuries into a mountain week, wept twice, and complained never, while an elder dragon kept the night watch over his sleep like a father over a forge-fire." He looked over at the Eternals, and there was no challenge in it, only an old soldier's professional accord. "Your mayfly wisdom is well said, Forgotten One. But mark the dragon too. Ddraig has worn hosts beyond counting, and he speaks to this one at midnight in the voice my father used on *me*. Dragons do not coddle. If Ddraig tends the fire, it is because the dragon believes the blade is worth folding."

The screen chimed, softly, into the pause.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel ticked around and stopped on plain silver — a low rarity, and by now the theatre had learned to fear the gacha's cheap-looking cards most of all.

"TRANSFER-ENHANCED ROOK PUNCH" — RARITY: RARE.

"Rook," said Peter Parker, sitting up. "That's Koneko. Oh — oh, wait. *Wait*. Transfer. You guys, the spec sheet from chapter one, remember the spec—"

The theatre went under before he could finish, which saved him from being shushed by four separate factions.

Day nine, and Issei Hyoudou hit the wall the audience had felt coming since day one.

A mock battle in the high meadow: Rias's whole peerage in motion, a full-tempo Rating Game rehearsal, and the vision put the theatre inside Issei's head as he ran his own arithmetic and arrived — mid-fight, gasping, boosted to the edge of what his half-rebuilt body could carry — at the same conclusion Shang-Chi had reached from the cheap seats. *It isn't enough*. Ten days had made him five times the boy who left town. Riser Phenex would need him to be a hundred times. There was no version of the math where Issei Hyoudou, alone, boosting until his bones sang, arrived at that number in one day more.

He stopped, in the middle of the meadow, chest heaving. And the audience heard him say it — out loud, to the gauntlet, in the small, humiliated voice of a boy surrendering the only dream a weak person is issued at birth, the dream of finally being the strongest one on the field:

"Ddraig. I can't get big enough. Not in time." A breath. "But I don't have to, right? It doesn't have to be *me*."

There was a silence from the gem. When the dragon answered, the theatre would argue for chapters afterward about what was in his voice; the closest anyone came was *pride, ambushed*.

[...Hoh. There it is. Two hundred hosts, partner. Two hundred, and every one of them clawed for the summit alone, and the summit is where I buried them. You are the first to look at my power and see a *gift*.] A sound like a mountain range chuckling. [Then let us give it. LISTEN WELL, BOY — THE GEAR ANSWERS INTENT!]

The gauntlet blazed. The gem's green light ran liquid along the scales, and the system's voice — the cold one, the spec-sheet one — spoke over a flare of crimson that lit the whole meadow:

[BOOSTED GEAR: SECOND LIBERATION.]

[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]

Ten seconds. Ten seconds. Ten seconds. The theatre felt the power stack in his arm like held thunder, doubling and redoubling past what his body could safely spend — and then felt him do the thing no previous Red Dragon Emperor had thought to want. He turned, found the smallest member of the team already moving — because Koneko Toujou had understood his face before he spoke, and was already inside a boulder's shadow, fist cocked — and slapped his gauntlet flat between her shoulder blades.

[TRANSFER.]

The vision gave the theatre one full second of what it felt like from inside Koneko: a Rook's monstrous baseline strength suddenly *doubled, and doubled, and doubled, and doubled*, sixteen times her monstrous everything arriving down her arm like a red tide with a dragon's roar inside it.

She punched the granite ridge at the meadow's edge.

The ridge left.

Not cracked — *left*: a wedge of mountainside the size of a cathedral detached, powdered, and rained down the far valley in a rolling grey thunder that went on for eleven seconds, while a four-foot-six girl stood in the settling dust looking at her own small fist with the nearest thing to an expression she had worn all vision.

"...Heavy," said Koneko Toujou. And then, quietly, not looking at him: "...Do it again."

The last thing the vision showed them was the evening's second experiment: Rias Gremory's Power of Destruction — the crimson annihilation the audience had seen unmake lesser threats — with four transferred boosts poured into it, swelling from a river to a *sea*, and Rias turning to stare at her Pawn with exactly the expression she had worn kneeling over his corpse in the park. The jeweler's expression. The one that said: *there* is the fire I paid eight Pawns for.

DAY NINE: FORCE MULTIPLIER DOCTRINE — ACQUIRED, said the system, and let them go.

"THAT'S the weapon," Tony Stark and Scott Summers said, simultaneously, from opposite sides of the theatre, and then glared at each other for it.

Tony recovered first, already drawing in the air. "Everyone's been doing the math wrong. *I've* been doing the math wrong. I called him a compound-interest bomb in chapter one — single warhead, exponential yield, limited by the chassis. Wrong. The chassis was never the point. He's not a bomb, he's a *bus bar* — he can run the exponential and then dump the accumulated load into any conductor on the field. That tiny Rook just output — conservatively — a two-kiloton punch, and she isn't even the optimal target. The optimal target is whoever's already strongest. Do you understand what that scales to? Point him at Thor. Point him at *Hulk*."

"Point him at an army," said Doctor Doom, from his aisle, and the temperature of the observation silenced the row around him. "Ten thousand soldiers, each doubled, is a power no throne on my world holds. The boy converts *himself* into everyone else's growth. Note it well: this is the first ability we have seen that becomes more dangerous the more he loves the people beside him." A pause, masked head tilting a degree. "He will be very dangerous indeed."

"You're all still doing it wrong," Steve Rogers said, and he stood up to say it, which he rarely did, and the room quieted for him the way rooms did. "You're pricing the output. Price the *decision*. That kid has been the weakest person in every room of his entire life. Nine days ago somebody finally hands him a ladder out — infinite doubling, the strongest-one-on-the-field dream, the exact dream he's been screaming about since the day we met him — and on day nine, with everything on the line, he looks at the summit and gives his ladder away." He looked around the tiers, at gods and monsters. "I've led rosters full of heavy hitters. The rarest thing on any team I ever fielded wasn't strength. It was the guy who'd rather make five people strong than be strong in front of five people. Armies follow that guy off cliffs. Riser Phenex is about to fight a boy who spent ten days learning the one thing money, blood, and immortality can't buy him."

"The dragon knew," Thor said softly. "*Two hundred hosts, and the summit is where I buried them.* Two hundred climbers, and at last the beast is bonded to a boy who builds staircases. No wonder the old one sounds like a father. He has finally been *surprised*."

Up in the Eternals' block, Phastos was leaning forward with his fingers steepled and his eyes bright. "Architecturally, it's the elegant solution, and nobody on that mountain knows it yet," he said. "Exponential generation is trivial to design and impossible to *contain* — every version of it fails at the container, we just watched his shins prove that. But exponential *distribution*—" he opened his hands, "—the load balances itself across every willing container on the field. The system stops being a bomb and becomes a grid. Somebody should tell that child he just solved, by instinct, in a meadow, the problem that cracks every god-engine I've ever audited."

"He solved it because of *why*," Ajak said. "Mark the sequence. He did not find that power reaching for victory. He found it in the moment he gave up on being the hero of the story." She was quiet a moment. "Ten thousand years I have waited to see what humans do with real power. Nearly all of them answer *keep it*. The machine has gone to a great deal of trouble tonight to show us one who answers *share*." Her eyes went up, past the screen, to the dark above the dark. "I begin to suspect that is precisely what we are being prepared to need."

"Told you," Sersi said, to all of her family at once, insufferably, and even Sprite didn't argue.

The screen flickered.

The gacha wheel folded itself away, and in its place the screen assembled, piece by heraldic piece, an image that pulled the whole theatre forward in its seats: two crests, facing off across a chessboard rendered in fire and shadow. A crimson rose-and-sigil the room had learned to know. And opposite it, vast and burning, a bird wreathed in flame — wings spread, eternally dying, eternally *unbothered* — beneath a single line of specification text:

HOUSE PHENEX. TRAIT: RESURRECTION FLAME. INJURY REJECTION: TOTAL. DEFEAT CONDITION: UNKNOWN.

"Total," repeated Sam Wilson. "Injury rejection: *total*. It heals everything. How does a sixteen-times Rook punch beat a guy who heals *everything*?"

"It doesn't," said Logan, from the dark of the back rows. He hadn't spoken all chapter. He sounded like a man reading from his own file. "Take it from the guy who heals everything. Body ain't where you beat us." He tipped his head at the screen, at the burning, arrogant bird. "Flesh grows back. Ask that rich boy what happens when something makes him *quit*."

The screen, as if it had been waiting all night for exactly that, printed one last line and went dark:

RATING GAME: GREMORY VERSUS PHENEX — PENDING.

TEN DAYS HAVE BEEN PAID. NEXT: WHAT THEY PURCHASED.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Compressed Training Under Pressure" — Super Rare (*viewed*)
- "Transfer-Enhanced Rook Punch" — Rare (*viewed*)

Secrets Revealed:

- Rias Gremory is bound by a childhood marriage contract to **Riser Phenex** (House Phenex; arrogant high-class devil; "Resurrection Flame" regeneration — injury rejection listed by the system as TOTAL, defeat condition UNKNOWN). Her only legal escape is winning a formal **Rating Game**; Riser granted a ten-day handicap. Grayfia Lucifuge (silver-haired maid, alarming power reading) brokered the terms.
- The gacha jumped back in Issei's timeline: this is the scrawny pre-Scale Mail boy, and Arc Two ("The Making of a Dragon") is explicitly framed as showing what his later power cost.
- Issei's growth-under-pressure is abnormal even by Ddraig's 200-host standard ("hosts who trained for decades widened less than you have in four days") — but the system displayed the price:

accumulating skeletal microfractures that Asia's nightly healing can't fully clear. He pays gaps out of his own body.

- **Boosted Gear: Second Liberation** — Transfer weaponized as battlefield doctrine. Issei can stack Boosts and pour them into allies: a 16x-boosted Koneko punch deleted a mountainside ridge; boosted Power of Destruction turned Rias's "river" into a "sea." Per Ddraig, Issei is the **FIRST** of his two hundred hosts to treat the power as a gift rather than a summit — the dragon sounded ambushed by pride.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **The Eternals engage for the first time** (silent for ten chapters): Gilgamesh delighted — "compression is his element; the mayfly learns faster than the mountain." Ajak issues the chapter's warning: his reflex to spend his own body is a down payment, "it will not always be shinbones" — and suspects the theatre is preparing them to need someone who answers *share* instead of *keep*. Sersi openly charmed; Sprite bitter; Phastos notes Issei instinct-solved the containment problem of every "god-engine" by becoming a grid instead of a bomb.
- **Captain America**: fully invested — reads Issei as pre-serum Steve doing Erskine's work by hand; declares the ladder-giveaway on day nine the rarest quality on any roster he's led. **Cyclops**: defends the brutal regimen as the only math available and flags Issei as the rarest training-room type ("metabolizes failure into instruction"). **Shang-Chi**: endorses the regimen's structure but reads Rias's face — she's training him to survive losing, not to win.
- **Tony Stark & Doom** re-rank the threat model: Issei is not a bomb but a force multiplier — "the first ability that becomes more dangerous the more he loves the people beside him" (Doom, taking notes again).
- **Thor**: reverence deepened — Ddraig keeping "night watch like a father over a forge-fire"; the dragon has finally been surprised.
- **Jennifer Walters**: personally hostile to the Phenex marriage contract. **Younger heroes (Miles, Kamala)**: disturbed by the physical cost and the absence of any adult who could say stop.
- **Wolverine**: delivers the room's tactical key to Riser from lived experience — regeneration isn't beaten in the flesh; "ask that rich boy what happens when something makes him quit."

Unresolved Hooks:

- **RATING GAME: GREMORY VERSUS PHENEX — PENDING.** The system's closing line — "Ten days have been paid. Next: what they purchased" — with the room already suspecting (via Shang-Chi's read and the Chapter 7 pattern) that Issei's early record is written in losses.
- How do you defeat "injury rejection: TOTAL"? Logan's answer — break the will, not the body — is now on the table, unconfirmed.

- Ajak's warning is live continuity: Issei's pattern of paying costs out of his own body ("it will not always be shinbones") is seeded for future arcs.
- The Eternals have privately begun conferring about *why* the theatre wants its audience to study a power-sharer — first faction to treat the briefing hypothesis (Ch. 1) as settled fact.
- Ddraig's "two hundred hosts, and the summit is where I buried them" — the fates of prior Red Dragon Emperors, and what climbing the summit did to them, remain unopened.

Chapter Twelve: Defeat Without Surrender

Primary Reaction Groups: Villains (Magneto, Doctor Doom, Mephisto) • Antiheroes (Punisher, Wolverine, Elektra, Moon Knight, Ghost Rider, Blade)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Second Rating Game Loss" — **Rare**
 2. "Sairaorg's Respect" — **Rare**
-

The theatre had moods, and by now everyone could read them.

After the training chapter — ten days of a boy grinding himself down to the bone to be worthy of a fight he had no business surviving — the room had settled into something almost like optimism. The Avengers' rows were still trading notes on his improvement curve. Shang-Chi had used the word *coachable* again. Even the cynics had begun, privately, to sketch the shape of the story they assumed they were being told: the weakling works, the weakling rises, the weakling wins. It was the oldest arc there was. Half the people in the room were living proof of it.

Then the lights went down to the color of an overcast morning, and the wheel descended, and the room remembered that this theatre had never once promised them a story they'd like.

The wheel ticked through its colors with what felt, tonight, like reluctance. It slowed. It stopped on a modest, unglamorous blue.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"SECOND RATING GAME LOSS" — RARITY: RARE.

"Loss," read Frank Castle, from the dark of the back rows, flat as a report.

"*Second* loss," said Wolverine, arms folded. He glanced, without meaning to, toward the villains' tier — toward the aisle where Doom stood, because Doom did not sit, and the theatre had long since stopped expecting him to. Everyone remembered the first loss. The montage chapter — the boy getting folded in half by a devil named Sairaorg Bael, a devil who had been born with nothing and built himself out of nothing but repetition and refusal. Doom had watched that beating the way other men watch coronations.

"They rank it *Rare*," Magneto observed from two rows above Doom, hands folded over the arm of his seat, helmet off, silver hair catching the screenlight. He had been quiet for several chapters. He was the sort of man whose silence accumulated weight. "His victories are Super Rare. His humiliations are Rare. Note what this machine considers common currency in the boy's life, and what it considers precious."

The screen took a breath, and took them.

The vision opened on a sky that wasn't a sky — a vast dimensional pocket, the system explained in its bloodless overlay, a replica of a ruined city block sealed inside a bubble where young devils could break each other without breaking the world. **RATING GAME: EXHIBITION FORMAT. GREMORY PEERAGE VERSUS BAEI PEERAGE. YOUTH ASSESSMENT MATCH, OBSERVED BY THE DEVIL NOBILITY.**

Assessment, the theatre understood, meant *audience*. Tiered seats in a floating gallery, filled with the old aristocracy of Hell — bored, beautiful, cruel in the specific way of people who have never once been billed for anything. They had come to watch the Gremory heiress's strange little peerage get measured. Mostly they had come to watch the famous eight-Pawn boy, the one with the dragon, the reincarnated *human*, and to enjoy confirming what they already believed about him.

The theatre watched the match unfold with the sound of its own breathing.

It was not a slaughter. That was the first thing the tacticians noticed — Rias played it well, traps and sacrifices, Akeno's lightning turning a whole avenue to glass, Koneko holding a chokepoint two full minutes past what her body should have allowed. But Sairaorg Bael's peerage fought like people who had been drilled by a man who had never been allowed a single shortcut, and piece by piece, call by call, the cold announcer's voice dismantled the board.

"Rias Gremory's Rook, retired."

"Rias Gremory's Queen, retired."

"Rias Gremory's Bishop, retired."

Until, in the cratered plaza at the city's dead center, under the eyes of the floating gallery, there was one Pawn left standing between Sairaorg Bael and the Gremory king.

Issei Hyoudou was already bleeding. He'd been bleeding for twenty minutes. The crimson armor of his Scale Mail — the theatre had cheered that armor, one chapter ago — was crazed with fractures, one horn snapped, the green gem in the chest plate flickering like a lamp in wind. Inside the helmet, the theatre could hear him breathing, and the breathing had a wet edge that made several medics in the audience sit forward.

[Partner,] said the deep voice out of the gauntlet, quietly, for the boy alone. **[The armor will not hold. Your body has taken more doosts than it can bank. I can give you ten seconds of everything, or thirty of something. Choose.]**

"Thirty," Issei said. "No — wait." He laughed, and the laugh cost him. "Ten. Let's be rude about it."

[BOOST. BOOST. BOOST. BOOST.]

Across the plaza, Sairaorg Bael rolled his neck and smiled — and it was not a cruel smile, which somehow made the whole thing worse. He was a big young man with lion-colored eyes, bare-knuckled, wearing no armor at all, wrapped in a faint standing heat-shimmer of fighting spirit that the system flagged, clinically, as **TOUKI: LIFE-FORCE REFINED INTO ARMOR AND WEAPON BY TRAINING ALONE. NO SACRED GEAR. NO INHERITED POWER. NO CLAN ABILITY.**

"You're still here," Sairaorg said. "Everyone in that gallery said you'd be the first one retired. I told them you'd be the last. Don't make a liar of me, Red Dragon Emperor."

"Wasn't planning to," said Issei Hyoudou, and charged.

What followed lasted four minutes, and the theatre would argue for a long time afterward about what to call it, because *fight* was not quite honest. It was a demonstration with one participant who refused to learn the lesson. Issei hit Sairaorg with everything the previous eleven chapters had taught the audience to respect — boosted blows that had cracked a mountain, dragon-shot that had erased a hillside, the transferred, compounded, doubled-and-redoubled arithmetic that Tony Stark had once called a compound-interest bomb. Sairaorg took some of it on his crossed forearms, slipped more of it with footwork so economical it looked lazy, and answered with fists.

Just fists. That was the obscenity of it. No light spears, no demonic flame, no ancestral annihilation. Knuckles, hips, breath, and fifty thousand hours of practice, delivered with a precision that made Danny Rand's hands close slowly on the seat in front of him.

The first exchange broke the Scale Mail's left gauntlet. The second caved the chest plate and the countdown in Issei's ears — the armor's time limit, already gutted by a long match — began to shriek. The third put him through a wall.

[BALANCE BREAKER: TERMINATED,] the system said, and the crimson armor blew apart into embers, and there was just a boy again, in a torn school tracksuit, folding out of the rubble of a fake building in front of the assembled nobility of Hell.

The gallery laughed. Not all of it. Enough of it.

"Stay down," someone called, silvery and amused. "You've been paid for, little Pawn. Damaged goods depreciate."

The theatre — the real theatre, the Marvel one — went very quiet, because Issei Hyoudou put his palms flat on the rubble and pushed.

It took him eleven seconds to stand. The vision did not cut away, because this theatre never cut away, and so a few thousand heroes and monsters stood inside those eleven seconds with him and felt what they cost. The scraped-out hollow where the boosts had been. The two fingers that wouldn't close. The tremor in the thighs, the specific weight of a body that has spent everything and is now writing checks against tomorrow. And underneath all of it, humiliatingly audible, the boy's actual thoughts, which were not noble, and were therefore unbearable: *Everyone's watching. Rias is watching. I'm going to lose. I'm going to lose in front of everyone.*

And then, arriving like a hand on the back of the neck: *Okay. Then I'll lose standing up.*

"Yield," Sairaorg said. He hadn't moved. His voice had changed — the showman's edge gone off it. "You have nothing left. There's no shame in the call. I've made it myself."

"Can't." Issei spat red and got his guard up — a wreckage of a guard, elbows dropping, one eye swelling shut. "Sorry. My King hasn't called it. And you're—" he grinned, split-lipped, entirely sincere, "—you're really strong. If I quit now, I won't get to remember how this feels. I'm gonna need it."

Something crossed Sairaorg Bael's face that the gallery above was too far away to see, and the theatre was not.

"Then forgive me," he said, "for taking you seriously."

The touki came up like a furnace door opening, and he crossed the plaza in a blink, and he did take him seriously — that was the mercy and the horror of it both. Three punches, thrown with full respect, none of them cruel, every one of them absolute. The vision held on Issei Hyoudou refusing to fall for two of them. On the third, unconsciousness took him mid-step — *forward*, the room noted; his last step was forward — and the announcer's voice said, without any inflection at all:

"Rias Gremory's Pawn, retired. Winner: the Bael peerage."

The last thing the vision showed was the gallery of devil nobles applauding Sairaorg with polite, dismissive grace — and Sairaorg himself ignoring them entirely, standing over the broken boy being gathered up by the retrieval circle, staring down at him with an expression like a man rereading a letter he'd misjudged.

The theatre surfaced.

For a moment, nobody managed anything.

Then the antiheroes' section, which had watched the entire beating in a silence like a held knife, all started talking at once.

"That," said Elektra Natchios, first and coldest, "was the stupidest thing this screen has shown us. And it has shown us his browsing habits." She sat with her ankles crossed, immaculate, unmoved. "He had nothing. He knew he had nothing. The exits were honorable — a formal yield, a tactical retirement, live to train. Sentiment kept him standing and sentiment got him destroyed in front of his enemies. In my profession we bury sentiment early, or it buries us."

"In your profession you died," said Wolverine, not unkindly. "Twice, ain't it?"

"And came back sharper."

"Kid doesn't come back, that's the point." Logan leaned forward, forearms on knees, and his voice had gravel and something else in it. "Look — I get up 'cause I can. Bones knit, meat closes, getting up costs me nothin', it's a parlor trick. That kid's got no factor. Every one of those eleven seconds came outta his actual hide, and he spent 'em anyway, knowing the price, knowing he'd still lose." He shook his head slowly. "I've watched a lotta hard men fold for less. Don't ask me to call it stupid. It's the only kind of brave I still respect."

"It's both," said Frank Castle.

Heads turned. Frank rarely spent words, and the room had learned to attend when he did. He was looking at the frozen last frame — the boy face-down, the last step forward — with the expression of a man doing grim arithmetic.

"Getting up when you can't win is how Marines die," he said. "Seen it. Wrote the letters home after. Any officer worth a damn would've ordered that kid down after the armor broke." A pause, long enough that people thought he was finished. "And every man I'd actually want next to me in a hole would've disobeyed that order. That's the whole problem with the species. The thing that gets 'em killed and the thing that makes 'em worth anything — it's the same thing. Kid's just got more of it than his body can afford. Yet."

"Yet," repeated Moon Knight, from three seats over, with the fractured brightness of a man conducting an internal referendum. "Khonshu's watched every battlefield since Egypt had a river. You know what he says about the ones who won't stay down? Nothing. He goes *quiet*. He's quiet right now." Marc Spector's fingers drummed the armrest. "The god of vengeance has no file for a kid who takes a beating like a sacrament. It's not vengeance. It's not even pride. What do you even call it?"

"Faith," said the Ghost Rider, and the flame of his skull burned low and blue, which those who knew him understood was as close as the Rider came to reverence. "Not in God. In the people watchin' him. He said it himself. *My King hasn't called it.*"

"He said the *other* thing himself, too," Blade said quietly, turning a stake he wasn't going to use. "Rewind it. 'I won't get to remember how this feels. I'm gonna need it.'" The daywalker's jaw worked. "That's not a loser talking. That's a man taking inventory in the middle of a burning house. He was *studying* the beating while he took it. Y'all keep arguing noble or stupid. Check the third option. Patient."

And then the villains' tier spoke, and the rest of the theatre — as had become custom when that particular cold aisle stirred — shut up to listen.

"It is neither noble nor patient," said Magneto. "It is a tragedy. I have seen this exact boy before."

He stood. Erik Lehnsherr did not raise his voice; he had never needed to. The screenlight made something bleak of his face.

"I was smaller than him when I learned the arithmetic this theatre keeps flinching from. I watched men of magnificent conviction — rabbis, fathers, boys who stepped in front of their mothers — stand up exactly like that, with exactly those eyes, in front of power that did not respect the standing. Do you know what their courage purchased? Nothing. A number in a ledger. The powerful wrote the ledger and the brave went into it, and the world *applauded politely from the gallery*, precisely as you just saw." His hand had closed, slowly, on the rail. "Conviction without power is not a virtue. It is bait. It teaches the boy that the standing itself is worth something, and one day he will stand up in front of a thing that will not stop at three respectful punches, and every person who cheered his beautiful refusal will attend his beautiful funeral. I do not despise him. Understand me. I *mourn* him in advance. I have buried that boy a hundred times, and I made myself into what I am so that I would never have to bury him again."

The silence after that had grief in it, and not only his.

"Sentimental," said Doctor Doom.

The word fell into the theatre like a gauntlet onto marble. Magneto turned, slow and regal, unintimidated — one of perhaps four beings in the room who could hear that voice go cold without adjusting their posture.

"You disagree, Victor? You? Latveria's whole doctrine is power as the first virtue."

"Doom's doctrine is precise, and you have quoted it imprecisely." Doom had not moved from his aisle. He addressed the room without conceding that the room deserved it. "Power is the first *instrument*. It is not the first virtue. Doom has held power that gods envied and lost it to accidents of fortune — stripped of armor, of throne, of country, cast down among enemies more than once. On those occasions precisely one possession remained, and it was the only one that mattered." A pause, measured. "Doom did not kneel. Doom has *never* knelt — not to Mephisto with my mother's soul on the table, not to conquerors,

not to gods, not to fate. Take everything from a man and you learn, at last, what he is made of, because what remains is what he *is*. Tonight the machine took everything from that boy in front of the aristocracy of his world — his armor, his strength, his dignity, his victory — and what remained *stood up*." The mask tilted a degree. "You mourn him, Lehnsherr, because you believe the ledger is the final document. Doom informs you that it is not. The nobles in that gallery will forget the match. They will not forget the standing. *Doom* will not forget the standing. A man who will not kneel possesses the only crown that cannot be taken, and it is the crown every tyrant secretly checks for, in the mirror, at night."

"Pretty words," Magneto said, "carved on a hundred thousand graves."

"On graves," said Doom, "and on the gates of every prison that was eventually torn down. You survived the ledger, Lehnsherr. Ask yourself with what."

Magneto did not answer. Which the whole theatre understood to be an answer.

And it was into that taut, ringing quiet that the wheel — with tact nobody believed it possessed — began to spin again.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"SAIRAORG'S RESPECT" — RARITY: RARE.

The vision opened small: an infirmary in the Gremory estate, past midnight. Issei Hyoudou, mummified in bandages, one arm in a sling, asleep sitting up because lying down hurt too much — and the door opening on the last visitor anyone expected.

Sairaorg Bael had come alone, without retinue, without announcement, carrying — the theatre needed a moment to accept this — a basket of fruit.

What followed was not a dramatic scene, and that was its power. Two young men, one bandaged, one bruised across the knuckles, talking awkwardly at first and then not awkwardly at all. And under the talk, the gacha did what it did for context: it opened Sairaorg's life like a book laid gently on a table.

Born the heir of the Great King house of Bael, the highest blood in Hell — and born *without* the one thing that blood existed to carry. No Power of Destruction. Nothing. The clan's verdict arriving before he could walk: *defective*. The theatre watched a small boy and his gentle mother exiled to a frontier estate to spare the family embarrassment; watched cousins with inherited annihilation in their palms sneer at the heir who had none; watched the mother fall into a sleep the healers could not lift, with her son's small hand in hers and a promise being made over it. And then the theatre watched the promise being *kept*, in the only currency he had — years of it, dawn after dawn after dawn, fists against stone,

fists against waterfalls, fists against the flat assertion of an entire civilization that a devil is his bloodline and nothing else. No Sacred Gear. No dragon. No eight Pawns' worth of hidden treasure. Push-ups. Ten thousand days of them, alone, until his life force itself learned to stand up around him like armor.

"He is the counter-argument," breathed Magneto, in the theatre dark, before he could stop himself.

In the infirmary, Sairaorg set down the fruit basket and said what he had come to say, plainly, because he did everything plainly.

"Every devil I have ever fought looked at me and saw the Bael name, or the missing power, or the freak who trains. In the plaza today, at the end — you looked at me and saw a *wall you intended to climb*. Do you know how long I have waited for someone to look at me like that?" He held out his hand — the same hand, the theatre noted, that had ended the match. "My dream is to take the seat of a Maou someday, so that every child born with nothing can point at me and know that nothing is a starting line and not a sentence. When I stand for that seat, the whole of Hell will say it cannot be done. I want men around me who don't know how to hear that. I fought you twice, Issei Hyoudou. You lost twice. And both times, the only thing on that battlefield I couldn't beat was your refusal to make it easy." A grin cracked through the formality, boyish and huge. "So. Rival. Next time, make me use the *other* arm too."

And Issei Hyoudou — bandaged, beaten twice by this man, holding the fruit basket in his one good arm — laughed until his ribs made him stop, and shook the offered hand, and said, "Next time I'm gonna win, so you'd better bring the whole peerage, and also more fruit."

[He means it,] rumbled Ddraig, to both of them, with an old warmth in the vastness. **[Heaven help you, Bael. He always means it.]**

The final image lingered: the two of them talking until the candles guttered — the boy born with a dragon and no talent, and the boy born with the highest blood in Hell and no power at all — and the system's white text writing itself, small and unbidden, beneath them:

LOYALTY LOG: SAIRAORG BAEL — EARNED. METHOD: NONE. METHOD: HIMSELF.

The vision released them.

"Well," said Mephisto, into the hush, and for once the warm, appalling voice had a thread of genuine irritation in it. "*That* is inconvenient."

Faces turned toward the dark corner of the villains' tier. The demon lord was steepling his fingers, smiling, but the smile had effort in it tonight.

"Do attend, colleagues, because our little ledger requires revision. I deal in leverage. Everything that walks can be purchased; one merely locates the price — power, love, terror, redemption, a mother's soul." A gracious nod toward Doom's aisle, which did not acknowledge it. "But observe tonight's transaction. The Bael boy's loyalty was not bought with victory — our subject *lost*. Not with power — he *has* none to spare. Not with cunning, flattery, or fear. The price of Sairaorg Bael was *witnessed sincerity*, and the boy paid it by being beaten honestly in public." The smile thinned. "I have no counterfeit for that. None of us do. You cannot fake a currency that is only minted by losing. Every ally this boy collects will be collected the same way, and every one of them will be *unbuyable*, because they did not join him for what he offers. They joined him for what he is." He sat back. "I dislike this stock more with every chapter, friends. It only rises."

Up and down the villains' tier, the recalibration moved like weather. The Green Goblin had stopped laughing somewhere in the second pull and not restarted. Bullseye, connoisseur of professional excellence, was frowning at the frozen handshake as at a trick shot he couldn't reverse-engineer. They had filed the boy under *weak*, then under *lucky*, then under *growing but immature*, and every file kept reopening itself. A thing that cannot be bought, frightened, or made to kneel is not a large threat, said the tier's collective silence. But it is not a *dismissible* one. And they had all, in their separate centuries, been undone by exactly one thing: the file they closed too early.

"Lehnscherr." Doom's voice, pitched to carry exactly as far as he wished. "Your counter-argument. The powerless devil. He did not choose between conviction and power, as your tragedy requires. He kept the conviction and *built* the power, fist over fist, out of nothing, against the ledger of his whole world — and tonight your buried boy shook his hand. Doom merely observes."

Magneto was quiet for a long moment, watching the handshake still glowing on the screen — the exiled son and the murdered boy, the two kinds of nothing, holding on.

"Then let us hope," he said finally, and it came out older and lower than before, "that his world gives him the time to build it. Mine did not give my boys the time." He resumed his seat and said nothing else for the rest of the night, and no one, not even the Goblin, was fool enough to disturb him.

The lights began their end-of-chapter dim. The wheel reassembled in its corner, ticking, idle, patient.

And those seated nearest the villains' aisle would later swear to the rest: as the screen faded on the boy who had lost twice and somehow left the field owning something no victory confers, Victor von Doom looked up at him, and behind the mask — slow, private, unmistakable in the eyes — Doom *smiled*.

Several observers agreed it was somehow worse than the bleeding.

NEXT PULL PENDING, said the screen.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Second Rating Game Loss" — Rare (*viewed*)
- "Sairaorg's Respect" — Rare (*viewed*)

Secrets Revealed:

- Issei has now lost two formal matches to Sairaorg Bael and never once yielded — retired only when unconscious, his final step forward. He treats defeats as inventory: "I won't get to remember how this feels. I'm gonna need it."
- Sairaorg Bael's full history: heir of the Great King house, born without the Power of Destruction, exiled with his mother (who lies in an unwaking sleep), built to elite strength through pure training — touki, life force refined into armor by effort alone. His dream: a Maou's seat, to prove that being born with nothing is a starting line, not a sentence.
- The system logged a new mechanic: **LOYALTY LOG: SAIRAORG BAEL — EARNED. METHOD: NONE. METHOD: HIMSELF.** Issei's allies are recruited by witnessed sincerity — a currency, per Mephisto, that can only be minted by losing honestly, and cannot be counterfeited or bought out.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Doom:** open, stated respect for the refusal to kneel, tied explicitly to his own code ("Doom has never knelt"); ended the chapter with a slow private smile that unsettled everyone who saw it.
- **Magneto:** argued conviction without power is a tragedy, drawing on the camps; visibly shaken when Sairaorg — conviction that *built* its own power — shook Issei's hand. Withdrew into silence; the wound is open, not resolved.
- **Antiheroes split on nobility vs. foolishness:** Elektra calls it sentiment that kills; Wolverine and Frank Castle land on grudging respect (Frank: it's what gets men killed *and* what makes them worth anything); Blade reads it as patience — Issei studies his beatings; Ghost Rider names it faith in the people watching; Moon Knight reports Khonshu has gone quiet.
- **Villains' tier recalibrates:** Mephisto declares Issei's loyalty-economy unbuyable and the "stock" rising against his interests; Green Goblin stopped laughing; the tier can no longer file him as dismissible — uncorruptible AND unbreakable is a category they have no counter for.
- **Sairaorg Bael (canon-side):** formally names Issei his rival; genuine friendship begun over a fruit basket and a handshake.

Unresolved Hooks:

- Issei is now zero-for-two in formal matches against Sairaorg. The theatre expects a third meeting; both boys promised it. When it comes, what will the audience's villains do with the result they're now afraid of?
- Magneto's unanswered grief: will Issei's world "give him the time to build" the power his conviction needs — or will he stand up in front of something that doesn't stop at three respectful punches?
- Doom's smile: what use has Doom conceived for a boy who cannot be made to kneel?
- Mephisto's warning stands: every future ally will be earned the same unbuyable way. The villains are watching the pattern now — and the pattern is accelerating.

Chapter Thirteen: The Welsh Dragon

Primary Reaction Groups: British heroes (Captain Britain, MI-13 — Pete Wisdom, Union Jack, Faiza Hussain), Asgardians, Atlanteans (Namor)

Gacha Pulls:

1. Confirmation of Welsh Red Dragon Heritage — Mythic
 2. Nationalistic Misunderstandings — Comedy-Class
-

The theatre had learned, over twelve chapters of an unasked-for existence, to read its own weather.

When the great screen dimmed to storm-grey, empires braced. When it went gold, Thor started pouring. And when the lights came up in a soft, buttery warmth — the exact colour of a pub at four in the afternoon — everyone understood, on some animal level, that tonight nobody was going to die, and that somebody was going to be humiliated instead.

The gacha wheel descended from the impossible ceiling in its usual state of smug ceremony, rings within rings, sigils rotating like a slot machine designed by a god with a gambling problem. The last chapter had wrung them all out — Issei bleeding through another lost duel, winning nothing but the grudging nod of Sairaorg Bael and a slow, private smile from Victor von Doom, which several observers agreed was somehow worse than the bleeding.

Tonight the wheel spun almost lazily. It clattered, slowed, and dropped its first token into the crystal bowl with a chime like a struck wineglass.

PULL ONE: CONFIRMATION OF WELSH RED DRAGON HERITAGE — MYTHIC.

"Heritage," said Pete Wisdom, from the smoking section that the theatre refused to let him smoke in. He'd lit four cigarettes so far this evening. The theatre had extinguished all four with tiny, judgmental gusts of nowhere-wind. "Dragons have heritage now. Wonderful. Next it'll want a passport."

He would remember saying that.

The screen opened on night. Kuoh Town, after training — the canon world's version of after training, which meant Issei Hyoudou face-down in the Gremory garden making the noise of a deflating air mattress while his muscles filed formal complaints.

"Ddraig," he mumbled into the grass. "Tell me something."

"That is a broad request, partner."

"Something about you. You know everything about me. You literally live in my arm. You've seen my browser history from the *inside*. But I don't know anything about you except you're old and you sigh a lot."

"I sigh a proportionate amount," said the deep voice from the gauntlet, and the theatre's Ddraig-appreciators — Thor foremost among them — chuckled in fond recognition. "Very well. Sit up. A dragon's history is not told to a boy lying in a flowerbed."

On-screen Issei sat up. The Boosted Gear shimmered into being along his forearm, green gem glowing in the dark like a patient emerald eye, and Ddraig began to speak — and the gacha, sensing Mythic material, did the thing it did for its highest rarities: it *illustrated*. The screen bloomed outward into memory.

Two dragons over a young world. One red as an open wound in the sky, one white as the inside of lightning. They fought across continents that had not yet finished deciding their shapes; their war did not respect the war between God and the devil kings, and so God and the devil kings, in a rare moment of managerial consensus, stopped fighting each other long enough to destroy them both. Flesh unmade. Souls sealed. Two gauntlets, two Sacred Gears, passed hand to mortal hand down the centuries like heirlooms nobody could refuse.

"The Two Heavenly Dragons," Ddraig said. "Myself — and Albion. The White Dragon Emperor. My rival, my opposite, my oldest argument. Where I boost, he divides. Where I am, eventually, he will be. Every generation, our wielders find each other. It is not optional."

The theatre took collective note of that — *another gauntlet, another wielder, somewhere in that world* — and filed it under Ominous, For Later.

"But you asked of *me*," Ddraig continued, and the memory-light shifted. A green island in a cold sea. Hill forts. Rain with personality. "After my sealing, my legend outlived my body, as legends do. There was an isle in the world's west where men had seen me in the old days — truly seen me, red across their sky — and they did not forget. They painted me on their war-banners. They told of me under a hill called Dinas Emrys, where a boy prophet showed a king two dragons warring beneath his tower's foundations — the red and the white — and named the red dragon victorious. They put me, in the end, upon their flag. They fly me still."

On-screen, Issei was already fumbling for his phone. The theatre watched, riveted, as a lecherous Japanese schoolboy typed *red dragon flag* into a search engine, and the screen helpfully enlarged the result:

A green and white field. A red dragon passant, claw raised, tongue out, looking frankly magnificent.

The gacha stamped the image with a rotating Mythic seal, and letters of fire wrote themselves across the bottom of the screen:

CONFIRMED: Y DDRAIG GOCH. THE RED DRAGON OF WALES. HERALDIC. ANCESTRAL. NATIONALLY SIGNIFICANT.

"Ddraig," Issei whispered, with the reverence he usually reserved for other subjects entirely. "You're a *flag*. You're on a *flag*. That's so much cooler than being a country."

"It is considerably cooler than being a country," Ddraig agreed.

The screen paused itself, as it did between pulls, and the theatre lights came up on the audience.

Which is where the trouble started.

Captain Britain was standing.

Brian Braddock was a large man made larger by conviction, and at this moment he wore the expression of someone who has just been informed that the Crown Jewels are being kept in a teenager's sock drawer in Osaka. His cape did something stirring despite the total absence of wind.

"That," he announced, in the voice he used for addressing Parliament and interdimensional invasions, "is a British national treasure."

"Here we go," said Wisdom.

"That is *the* red dragon. Y Ddraig Goch. The oldest heraldic symbol in continuous use in the United Kingdom. That dragon is on our *flag*—"

"A flag," said Union Jack, who was wearing the other one. "Not to be pedantic, Brian, but he's not on mine. Have you ever actually looked at the Union Jack? Three crosses, no dragon. Wales didn't even make the flag. This is literally the founding grievance."

"The point *stands*. An entity of foundational significance to the British Isles is currently bound to the arm of a fifteen-year-old boy in *Japan*, and I would like to know what anyone intends to do about it."

"Do about it," repeated Faiza Hussain, delighted. She had Excalibur across her knees, and — several rows had noticed — the sword had begun humming very faintly the moment Ddraig started speaking, like an old dog hearing a familiar car in the drive. "What's the proposal, exactly? Extradition? He's a metaphysical dragon soul sealed in a divine artifact. He doesn't have *residency*."

"He has *heritage*," said Braddock. "You heard the gacha. Nationally significant."

Pete Wisdom had produced, from somewhere inside his terrible black suit, an actual manila folder. He licked his thumb and opened it with the grim relish of a career civil servant scenting jurisdiction.

"MI-13 charter," he said. "Paragraph one. *All superhuman, mystical, and otherwise weird matters arising within, or pertaining to, the British Isles fall under MI-13's operational purview.* Pertaining to. *Pertaining to*, Brian. That dragon pertains SO hard. He's on the flag. He's in the Mabinogion-adjacent material. He fought under Dinas Emrys, which is in Gwynedd, which — I've checked — remains in Wales. I'm designating him a national asset. Provisional codename: DRAGON, RED, ONE OF."

"You cannot *designate* a Heavenly Dragon," said Faiza.

"Watch me. I've got a form."

"He predates forms."

"Nothing predates forms. Forms are eternal. Civilization is a thin crust over an infinite ocean of forms." Wisdom clicked a pen. "I'm also opening a repatriation file. If a museum can spend eighty years arguing about marbles, MI-13 can put in a claim on a dragon."

"Repatriation to *where*?" Union Jack demanded. "He's not IN anything. He's a soul in a gauntlet. What are you going to do, ask the boy to post his arm to Cardiff?"

"We nationalized coal," said Wisdom. "We nationalized steel. We nationalized the railways. Twice, arguably. The machinery exists."

"The railways," said Union Jack, "are not a compelling precedent, Pete. I've *ridden* the railways."

And it was at this point — with Captain Britain drawing breath to invoke, God help everyone, *Merlin* — that the gacha wheel, which had been sitting quietly overhead this entire time, began to spin again *entirely of its own accord*.

The theatre went quiet. The wheel had never done that before. It clattered with what could only be described as glee, and dropped its second token.

PULL TWO: NATIONALISTIC MISUNDERSTANDINGS — COMEDY-CLASS.

"Oh no," said Faiza, grinning. "It heard you. It *heard* you, and it's got material."

The screen resumed — but not in the present. The gacha served up a montage, and the montage was, unmistakably, aimed at specific people in the audience.

Item the first: a memory older than the sealing, dressed in the gacha's illustrative fire. A chieftain of the old Britons standing on a hill, arms spread, formally offering the actual, living, mountain-sized Ddraig the position of "guardian beast of our people, to fight at our fore and take a fourth part of our cattle."

The actual, living, mountain-sized Ddraig looked at him for a long moment and then flew away without saying anything at all. The chieftain told everyone the dragon had accepted.

Item the second: Dinas Emrys. Two dragons warring beneath the earth — and modern-day Ddraig's voice-over, dry as slate: "That was not a prophecy, partner. That was *memory*. An echo of my war with Albion, soaked into the stones. The boy Myrddin was clever enough to hear it, and human enough to immediately turn it into politics. Red dragon defeats white dragon, therefore Britons defeat Saxons, therefore support this specific king. I have been a campaign advertisement for fifteen centuries."

Item the third: Bosworth Field, 1485. Henry Tudor marching under the red dragon banner. Ddraig's voice-over: "I was not consulted."

Item the fourth: 1959. A committee formally standardizing the Welsh flag. A room of men in grey suits debating the correct posture of Ddraig's tail. Ddraig's voice-over, now audibly pained: "I was *not consulted*. And the tail is wrong."

Item the fifth — and here the theatre realized the gacha was no longer showing the past, because the screen now showed the Gremory garden again, present-canon, and Issei asking the exact question everyone in the fourth row had been shouting for ten minutes:

"So wait — does that make you, like... British? Are you a British dragon? Should I be paying taxes on you?"

The theatre leaned in. Wisdom actually raised his pen.

And Ddraig said:

"Boy. Attend."

It was not louder than his usual voice. It was *older*. The gem on the gauntlet flared, and even filtered through a screen, across a dimensional gulf, into a cosmic theatre full of gods and monarchs and men in flags — something in that voice reached out and put its hand flat on the room.

"I watched that island rise from the sea. I flew above it when its mountains were young and rude, before it had a name, before *names* had names. I fought Albion through skies no map has ever held, and where we fell, the world was changed, and small things crept into the changed places and, in time, called themselves kingdoms. The nations of men are the footprints of my war. They grew in the marks we left." A pause; the ember-glow of the gem banked low and steady. "The men of that western land did not give me my image. They *took* it — as the small have always taken the names of the vast, hoping to be mistaken for them in the dark. I hold no grudge for it. It is the most human thing I know, and it kept my memory green when God Himself wished me forgotten. I am fond of them, as one is fond of a village

built at the foot of one's mountain. But hear this once, and hear it whole: I am not Welsh. I am not British. I am not property, treasure, asset, or heritage. Dragons do not belong to nations. If anything under heaven is true, it is nearer the reverse."

Silence.

Real silence — the theatre's first in some time. Pete Wisdom's pen was still raised, and stayed raised, and then descended very slowly, and did not write anything. Captain Britain sat down without appearing to decide to. Faiza's sword had stopped humming and gone quite still, the way a cathedral is still. Even Namor, who had been assembling a devastating remark for the better part of a minute, held it.

Everyone in that room commanded, defended, or personally embodied a nation. And the thing on the screen had just, gently and without malice, reminded them that nations were *recent*.

On-screen, Issei broke the silence in his world the way only Issei could.

"...So can I tell people my arm is a flag?"

"You may tell people your arm is a flag."

"BEST. ARM. EVER."

The theatre exhaled into laughter, grateful for it, and the lights came up for open floor.

Thor was on his feet before the laughter finished, drinking horn raised so vigorously that two Asgardians in the splash zone activated defensive measures.

"WELL SPOKEN, ELDER WYRM!" he thundered. "Aye — thus it has ever been! A dragon is a sovereign of one, a nation of himself, a kingdom with wings! In Asgard we do not say a dragon *lives* in the mountain. We say the mountain has been *annexed*. You cannot own a dragon. You can only be, for a time, *tolerated* by one." He turned, beaming, on the British section. "You wish to claim him? Then do as honor demands — challenge him to single combat for the flag rights!"

"We are not," said Union Jack, "challenging the primordial dragon to single combat for flag rights."

"Then the flag rights are forfeit! This is basic law!"

Loki, folded elegantly into his seat like a knife into a napkin, examined his nails. "I confess myself moved by the noble Captain's patriotism," he said, in the tone of a man setting out caltrops. "Truly. There is something exquisite about watching *Englishmen* form a committee to claim the dragon of *Wales*. Tell me, Captain — when the red dragon was left off your Union Flag, was Wales consulted? I only ask because 'was Wales consulted' appears to be a theme."

"That's a fifteenth-century administrative technicality—" Braddock began.

"And here is my favorite part," Loki continued serenely, "which I notice you have all been too traumatized to say aloud. The red dragon's eternal rival — the *white* dragon, the enemy, the adversary he is prophesied to defeat — is named..." He let it hang. He was a professional. "*Albion*."

A noise went through MI-13's rows like a structural failure.

"Oh no," said Faiza.

"The oldest name for Britain," Loki said, savoring each word like a boiled sweet. "Your island's own true name is worn by the *villain* of your flag. The prophecy your kings marched under is 'Britain defeats Albion.' You have been flying a divorce settlement for fifteen hundred years and calling it patriotism."

"I'm reclassifying the file," said Wisdom, into his hands.

"To what?"

"From ASSET to WEATHER. You don't own weather. You don't repatriate weather. You just — check the forecast and dress appropriately." He looked up, hollowed. "I'm designating him RED WEATHER. That's my final act on this matter."

"That's the sanest thing MI-13 has produced in a decade," said Union Jack.

Loki's gaze, all the audience nearest him noted, drifted back to the screen — to the gauntlet, glowing green on a boy's arm — and stayed there a moment too long, covetous as ever. If Ddraig could not be owned by a nation, the look said, that still left several categories unexplored.

Namor had waited. Namor always waited; it made the entrance better. He rose from the Atlantean section with the unhurried arrogance of a man who considered gravity a surface-dweller custom, ankle-wings flicking, and spread his arms toward the screen.

"At *last*," he declared. "Thirteen chapters, and this theatre finally produces a figure of adequate rank. Red-scaled. Ancient beyond your squabbling little map-lines. Openly contemptuous of surface nations and their paperwork." He pressed a hand to his own chest. "He is practically Atlantean. I have never felt so seen."

"You are not," said Wisdom, "claiming our dragon."

"YOUR dragon—" Namor's laugh was a beautiful, terrible thing. "Little smoking man, you cannot even claim your own *lighter* in this room. No. Namor claims nothing. Namor *recognizes*. There is a difference that royalty understands and committees never will. We red-scaled monarchs" — and here he smirked at his own trunks, which were, indeed, scaled and red, and several people realized with horror

that the joke had been loaded since chapter one — "are a rare fellowship. He rules the sky's memory; I rule the greater seven-tenths of the actual planet. I shall extend him honorary citizenship of Atlantis, monarch to monarch, as a courtesy."

"He *just said*," said Faiza, "at length, movingly, that he doesn't do citizenships."

"He said he does not do *nations*," Namor corrected, ascending two smug inches. "Atlantis is not a nation. Atlantis is an inevitability with a throne. Also — and I say this with love — imagine declining. Imagine choosing, instead, what he currently has: a landlocked adolescence inside the arm of a boy whose life's ambition the previous chapters have made *distressingly* clear. From that, even Wales looks good. From that, *Pete Wisdom's folder* looks good."

"Leave the folder out of this."

"Imperius Rex," said Namor, which was not a rebuttal but had never needed to be, and sat back down to scattered applause from himself.

From the high dark of the monster galleries, where he coiled alone because no row of seats had survived him, Fin Fang Foom spoke for the first time that evening.

"The red one is correct," he rumbled, and the theatre braced, because Fin Fang Foom agreeing with anyone was historically a prelude. "A dragon owned by a nation is no dragon. A dragon on a flag is no dragon. Foom would burn any banner bearing his image, and then the loom, and then the concept of textiles." A pause, and then, with bottomless contempt: "Of course, the red one lets a mammal *wear* him, so his opinions on dignity arrive somewhat pre-owned."

"He **CHOSE** the boy, wretched worm of Kakaranthara!" Thor bellowed up at the gallery. "That is sovereignty in action!"

"He was *sealed* into the boy's ancestors' species by a dead god's plumbing decisions. That is not sovereignty. That is *tenancy*."

They were still going when the lights began their end-of-chapter dim.

The last image the screen offered before dark was small, and the gacha let it linger: Issei asleep in the garden where he'd dropped, and the Boosted Gear still faintly manifest on his arm — Ddraig keeping watch, an old red ember in the dark, older than every flag in the theatre and gentler than he would ever admit to any of them.

Somewhere in the audience, Captain Britain stood — quietly this time, without the cape doing anything — and saluted the screen. Just once. Not the flag. The dragon.

Wisdom pretended very hard not to have seen it, and wrote *RED WEATHER: FORECAST FAVOURABLE* on the folder, and closed it.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Confirmation of Welsh Red Dragon Heritage* — Mythic; *Nationalistic Misunderstandings* — Comedy-Class. Notably, the second pull triggered itself in direct response to the audience's argument — the first confirmed instance of the gacha reacting to the theatre rather than the canon.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Ddraig is confirmed as Y Ddraig Goch, the red dragon of Welsh myth and the Welsh flag. His eternal rival is Albion, the White Dragon Emperor, sealed in a matching gauntlet with a wielder of his own — and the two wielders are fated to meet. The Dinas Emrys prophecy was no prophecy at all, but an echo of the Heavenly Dragons' ancient war soaked into the land.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** MI-13 formally downgrades Ddraig from prospective "national asset" to designation RED WEATHER ("forecast favourable"); Captain Britain's territorial bluster ends in a genuine salute. Faiza Hussain notes Excalibur resonates with Ddraig's voice. Thor's reverence deepens; Fin Fang Foom agrees with Ddraig on principle while insulting him on tenancy. Namor extends "honorary Atlantean citizenship, monarch to monarch" — unanswered, undeterred.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Who wears Albion's gauntlet in the canon world — and when do the fated rivals collide? Why does Excalibur hum for Ddraig? Loki's covetous gaze has shifted from owning the dragon to "several categories unexplored." Doom, conspicuously silent all chapter, was observed taking notes under the heading *Latveria possesses no dragon; oversight*. And the gacha is listening to the audience now. It has never done that before.

Chapter Fourteen: A Dragon Picks Its Rider

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers (Yondu Udonta, Stakar Ogord, Kraglin, Martinex — with Guardians adjacent) • Symbiotes (Eddie Brock & Venom) • Cosmic Riders (Silver Surfer, Beta Ray Bill, Ghost Rider)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Ryuuteimaru's Origin" — **Epic**
 2. "Choosing a Partner" — **Rare**
-

The theatre had rearranged itself again overnight, in the way it did — soundlessly, apologetically, like a butler who knew you'd argue if asked.

The British rows had been moved a respectful distance from the Asgardian ones, presumably to prevent any further litigation over dragons. And down along the theatre's port side — everyone had started calling it the port side; nobody remembered deciding to — a new section had assembled itself out of scorched hull plating, mismatched barstools, and a jukebox that only played songs from planets that no longer existed.

The Ravagers had made themselves at home the way Ravagers made themselves at home anywhere: by stealing the good chairs from adjacent factions and daring the universe to invoice them.

"Thing I don't get," Kraglin was saying, boots up on the back of an empty seat that had until recently belonged to an Atlantean, "is the *machine*. Wheel comes down, wheel spins, wheel decides what everybody feels about the kid tonight. That's a slot machine runnin' the whole room. Back home we'd have cracked that thing open by now and rigged the odds."

"Back home," said Stakar Ogord, who sat like a man who had been thrown out of better theatres than this, "you tried to rig a Contraxian slot machine and it took your thumb."

"Grew back."

"That weren't growin' back, that was Martinex printin' you a new one and you cryin' about the color."

Above them, Yondu Udonta said nothing. He'd said very little for thirteen chapters, in fact — just sat with his arrow across his knees like a sleeping animal, watching the screen with the flat red gaze of a man doing arithmetic on somebody else's life. He'd watched the boy die on a first date. He'd watched a

rich girl in red spend everything in her pockets to buy him back. Yondu Udonta knew a few things about buying boys, and about what it cost you later, and he had opinions about the girl in red that he had not yet shared with the room.

The wheel descended. Rings within rings, sigils spinning — and, since last chapter, everyone watched it a little differently, because last chapter it had *listened* to them, and nobody had forgotten.

It clattered. It chimed. The token dropped.

PULL ONE: RYUUTEIMARU'S ORIGIN — EPIC.

"Ryuu-tei-maru," sounded out Rocket, from the Guardians' row just aft of the Ravagers. "That's a lotta name. Ten quatloos says it's a sword. This kid's world hands out swords like breath mints."

"I am Groot," said Groot.

"It is NOT always a sword. It's a sword like sixty percent of the time."

The screen bloomed.

A forest that was not a forest. Trees like candle-wax cathedrals, a sky the color of the inside of an eyelid, and paths that visibly rearranged themselves when no one was looking — the theatre's HUD helpfully stamped the location across the bottom of the frame:

THE FAMILIAR FOREST. UNDERWORLD TERRITORY. ALL DEVILS COME HERE TO FIND THEIR LIFELONG COMPANION.

And through it, arguing, came Issei Hyoudou and a wiry, weathered man in an explorer's getup with a net over his shoulder and the unmistakable energy of a man who has been bitten by everything he loves.

FAMILIAR MASTER: ZATOUJI, said the HUD. PROFESSION: MATCHMAKER (BEASTS).

"You again," Zatouji was saying. "The dragon boy. The one from the *incident*."

"It wasn't an incident—"

"The lightning sprite chose the little blonde nun and personally electrocuted you off the premises. I keep records, boy. I have you filed under 'rejected by the forest.'"

The theatre — which had not seen this particular history — received it as a gift. Down in the Guardians' row, Rocket made a noise like a airlock failing.

"He got — *ha* — he got dumped by the *pet store*?"

"Twice, apparently," said Martinex, crystalline face refracting the screen-light. "It says rejected. Plural incidents implied."

On screen, Zatouji sighed the sigh of a professional about to do something unprofessional, and led Issei off the path — through wax-cathedral trees, down a slope of silver moss, to a pond.

It was not an impressive pond. It was barely a committed puddle. And floating in the middle of it, perfectly still, was—

The screen zoomed in. Then zoomed in again. Then, with an air of embarrassment, a third time.

A boat.

A tiny boat. A boat the size of a loaf of bread. Lacquered hull, a stub of a mast, a little carved prow curling up at the front like it had ambitions of one day being a figurehead. It bobbed on the puddle-pond with its sail furled, and as the audience watched, it produced a small, unmistakable sound.

A snore.

The boat was asleep.

The theatre's laugh started in the Ravager section and rolled outward. Rocket was face-down on the seatback in front of him, hammering it with one fist. "It's a *dinghy*! Thirteen chapters of doom dragons and murder angels and the kid's magic destiny animal is a *toy boat*! It SNORES! I'm gonna die here and I'm gonna die HAPPY—"

"**Epic rarity**," the wheel noted overhead, in cold letters, and something about the stubbornness of it quieted the laugh by half.

On screen, Zatouji crouched by the water. "Don't laugh, boy. You're looking at a bloodline older than most gods' grudges. This is a skiff-spirit — hatched from the line of *Skíðblaðnir*."

Two rows of Asgardians sat up at once, in unison, like a wave.

"*Skíðblaðnir*!" Thor was on his feet, horn sloshing. "The ship of the god Freyr! Finest vessel ever wrought — built by the sons of Ivaldi, the greatest smiths under any sky! A ship that always finds fair wind, that sails sea, sky, and land alike, and folds small enough to carry in a pouch! I have HEARD of her brood but never seen one whelped! BOY! *FEED IT SOMETHING!*"

"He cannot hear you," said Loki, without looking up. But the audience nearest him noted that he had gone very still — the specific stillness of a collector who has just seen an heirloom of his own pantheon float, snoring, into the possession of a Japanese teenager. First the dragon of Wales. Now the shipwrights of Asgard. Loki's expression suggested a man revising a very long list.

On screen, Zatouji was explaining, and the theatre hushed itself to hear.

"It's a growth-type, boy. Rarest kind of familiar there is, and the most honest. It's got almost nothing now — can't fight, can't fly, can't do much but sleep and drift. But it feeds on the aura of its master. It'll drink whatever you are, a little every day, for years. And it becomes — slowly, and only ever once — a vessel worthy of the one who fed it." He looked up, and his voice did the thing that voices in this story did right before the theatre's chest tightened. "Which means you'd best think hard about what you're going to be. Because whatever that is? One day you'll have to *ride* it."

The HUD flickered, once:

GROWTH-TYPE FAMILIAR ACQUIRED. CURRENT CAPABILITY: NEGLIGIBLE. POTENTIAL: UNMEASURED.

Unmeasured. The theatre had learned to fear that word. The screen had said it about a gauntlet once.

And then the little boat woke up.

It didn't do anything grand. It turned — a small, sleepy quarter-circle on the puddle — and drifted, unhurried, across the water, and bumped its tiny prow against Issei's outstretched hand. Once. Twice. Like a cat deciding.

Issei, who had been rejected by this forest twice, who had been rejected in worse ways by worse things, went very quiet. On the gauntlet, the green gem glowed.

"It has chosen, partner," said Ddraig. **"Do not make a fuss."**

"I'm not making a fuss."

"You are crying on it."

"IT PICKED ME, DDRAIG. IT'S THE FIRST THING THAT EVER JUST — *PICKED ME*—"

"I picked you."

"You were SEALED in me, that's different, you didn't get a vote—"

A pause, on screen and in the theatre both. The ember-voice, when it came, was even.

"I have had many wielders, partner. A vote is not always cast with a hand. We will speak of it another time."

Issei lifted the boat out of the water — it fit in his two palms, mast and all — and held it up level with his eyes, and the little prow bobbed at him, and he grinned the grin the theatre had learned across fourteen chapters meant *incoming terrible decision, incoming with total sincerity*.

"Ryuuteimaru," he declared. "Because I'm gonna be the Dragon Emperor, and you're gonna be the Dragon Emperor's ship. We'll grow into it together. Deal?"

The boat snored.

"He'll come around," said Issei, and tucked the ship of the line of Skíðblaðnir into his jacket like a kitten.

The screen paused itself. Lights up.

"Okay," said Rocket. "Okay. I got questions."

"Nobody sanctioned questions," said Star-Lord.

"First question. That forest. Is that a *shop*? Is there a *shop* where they hand out mythical Norse boat-larvae to whoever wanders in? Because I've been to every black market in six galaxies and nobody TOLD me—"

But it was Stakar Ogord who stood, and when Stakar stood, the port side went quiet, because there were maybe four beings in the theatre with a genuine hundred-crew command voice and he was the one currently using it.

"Y'all are laughing at the boat," he said. "You're missing it."

He nodded at the screen — at the paused frame, boy and boat, eye to eye.

"I've flown with a hundred crews. Signed some, inherited some, stole a couple. And I'll tell you the one law that holds from the Quadrant to the far rim: you can *buy* a ship and you can *hire* a crew, and neither one of those is worth a damn when the burn gets hard. The only thing that holds a deck together at the bad end of a fight is the ones who *chose* to be there. Choosing's the whole cargo. Everything else is freight." He sat back down, slow. "That little boat drank nothing yet. Gained nothing yet. It looked at a boy the whole universe keeps turning down and it swam *toward* him. That's not a pet. That's a crewman signing on before the ship's even built."

"It's still funny," said Kraglin, loyally.

"It's hilarious," Stakar agreed. "Most true things are."

And from above them, quietly, Yondu spoke for the first time in three chapters.

"Growth-type." He turned the word over like a coin he suspected of being real. "Feeds on what you are. A little every day. For years." His jaw worked. "Hell of a thing to sign up to be somebody's diet."

"You'd know," said Stakar, not unkindly, and Yondu didn't answer, and the whole port side very carefully did not look at Peter Quill, and Peter Quill very carefully did not look at anything at all.

The wheel spun.

PULL TWO: CHOOSING A PARTNER — RARE.

The second vision was quieter, and it was not one memory but several, laid side by side like cards.

First: the incident. The theatre finally got to see it — the Familiar Forest, months earlier, and a tiny blue sprite dragon crackling with lightning, and every devil present cooing over it, and the sprite dragon looking at the assembled options, floating directly past Issei — pausing — and delivering unto him a bolt of pure rejection that parted his hair down to the scalp, before settling into Asia Argento's arms like a returning thought. Asia named it Rassei. Rassei spent the rest of the memory glaring at Issei with tiny, sizzling jealousy.

The theatre laughed. But the gacha wasn't done, and the cards kept turning.

Second: the gauntlet. A procession of half-lit figures, centuries of them — the previous Red Dragon Emperors, each seizing the Boosted Gear like a weapon, wringing it for power, burning down into madness or ruin. Ddraig's voice over all of it, older than tired: **"They wielded me. Some feared me. Many used me. My power was a thing that happened TO them, and their hatred was a thing that happened to me, and we called that partnership because neither of us had ever seen one."**

Third: a bath. The theatre braced reflexively — fourteen chapters had taught them what this boy's bathing scenes usually meant — but no. It was Issei alone, soaking training bruises, holding his left arm up out of the water and just... talking to it. Not asking for power. Not asking for anything. Telling Ddraig about his day. About a math test he'd failed. About whether dragons liked melon bread, and whether Ddraig could taste it when he ate, and, if so, apologizing for the week he'd eaten nothing but instant noodles.

"Why do you tell me these things, partner?"

"'Cause you're stuck in there, man. You've been stuck in there for like a thousand years and I bet nobody ever tells you anything except 'MORE POWER' and 'AAAGH.' That's a terrible feed. I'm gonna be the Dragon Emperor with the good feed."

A silence, in the memory, that went on one beat past comfortable.

"...Melon bread. Describe it again. Slowly."

Fourth, and last: night, and the Hyoudou household's little garden pond — barely a committed puddle — and Ryuuteimaru afloat on it, and Issei crouched at the edge in his pajamas, holding his hand over the water, letting a thread of warm red aura drift down like crumbs. A little every day. The boat's carved prow tipped up toward him. It had grown — the theatre checked, and it had, undeniably, grown.

By about a centimeter.

"Look at you!" Issei whispered, delighted beyond all proportion. "You're gonna be a battleship. Don't tell anyone I said that. Get some sleep."

The boat snored. The boy stayed anyway, ten more minutes, watching it, the way you watch something you have decided is yours to keep alive.

PARTNERSHIP, the screen printed, in small cold letters, **IS NOT ASSIGNED. IT IS FED.**

Lights up.

It was the symbiote that spoke first — which surprised everyone, because the symbiote section had been, by hard-won treaty, a quiet zone since chapter three.

Eddie Brock sat where he always sat, big shoulders hunched, and the black living skin of the Venom symbiote lay across them like a second, more honest posture. When it spoke, it spoke with his mouth and around it, layered, two voices deciding to be one.

"We know what they will say about the boy's boat," it said. **"They will say: parasite. They will say: it takes and takes. They said it about us for years."** A ripple crossed the black. **"Our kind's own name — Klyntar — do you know what it means, in our first tongue? It means 'cage.' We were made to be worn, and we were named a prison, and for a long time we believed it, and we made ourselves true to the name. A bond can rot into that. We are the room's leading experts."**

Eddie's own voice came through alone for a moment, rough. "But that's not what's on the screen."

"No. What is on the screen is the other thing. The thing our codex sings about and almost never gets. A host who feeds the bond instead of bleeding it. Who talks to what lives in him. Who apologizes for the noodles." The symbiote's voice did something no one in the theatre had heard it do: it went soft. **"The dragon has been worn by a hundred men as armor. This one wears him as a friend. We watched the boy die in chapter one and we did not understand why the red girl paid so much to bring him back. We understand now. Hosts like this are why our kind first left the void. He would have been chosen on any world. By any of us. It was only ever a question of what got to him first."**

"And thank every god it was the boat," said Eddie, alone again, dry as dust — and the theatre, which had been holding a very tender feeling and not known where to put it, gratefully laughed.

The cosmic tier stirred next.

The Silver Surfer had watched both pulls without moving — a statue of liquid chrome in the high seats, board upright at his shoulder like a second self. When he spoke, he spoke mostly to the board.

"I was bound to a master once," he said. "I sold my will to save a world, and my master fed on worlds, and what he fed me in return was purpose with all the choice burned out of it. That is one kind of bond. I know its taste." His hand rose, rested on the board's edge. "This one chose me back. It is the only thing in my long service I am certain chose me. The boy on the screen has that — twice over now, dragon and vessel — and he is *fifteen*, and he got it not by bargaining away his soul but by talking to his arm in the bath." The chrome face turned, very slightly, toward the screen. "There are beings in this theatre who command galaxies and have never once been chosen. I count myself. Watch him closely. He is rich in the only coin that matters."

"SKUTTLEBUTT WOULD LIKE THE BOAT," boomed Beta Ray Bill, from the row above, with the delighted volume of a horse-faced Korbinite who has been waiting all evening to bring up his warship. "My ship is alive, little dragon-boat, wherever you are! She chose her crew too! She has opinions about everyone I bring aboard and she has been right *every time*! When your pond-ship grows, they should meet! Ships that choose their captains should know they are not alone!"

"Bill," said the Ghost Rider, "you cannot arrange a play-date across a dimensional barrier."

"THE THEATRE IS ALREADY IMPOSSIBLE. I AM MERELY ADDING AN ITEM TO ITS LIST."

The Rider — leathers, chain, skull wrapped in patient fire — looked back at the screen, and the flame that served him for expression banked low and blue.

"Bond with its own will," he said, quietly, to nobody. "Yeah. I got one of those." The chain shifted on his shoulder, restless, like it knew it was being discussed. "Mine came in screaming. Vengeance don't ask. It rides *you*, and you spend every night negotiating who gets the wheel, and some nights you lose." The skull-face turned toward the paused frame: the boy in pajamas, feeding a boat light. "Fifteen years old and he got the version they promise you in the fine print and never deliver. Something that eats what you are — and what he is, is *kind*, so that's what it'll grow up made of." The fire flickered. "Kid's building the only vehicle in creation I'd swap for."

The theatre sat with that. It was, by consensus, the touching part of the evening, and the theatre had learned to brace for what always followed the touching part.

"So, uh. Real quick. Logistics question."

Rocket was standing on his seat.

"The boat drinks the kid's mojo and grows into a bigger boat. The dragon lives in the kid's arm. The kid is, functionally — and I'm just doing the math the rest of you are too polite to do — the kid is a *vehicle-in-progress*. Dragon-ship. Ship-dragon. Some kinda escalating rideable situation." He spread his paws, reasonable as a lawyer. "So my question, and it's a NORMAL question, is: could I ride him? Like when it's all grown. Hypothetically. Could I strap a seat to—"

The response was not organized, which made it worse.

Frank Castle racked a shotgun that the theatre should not, by any physics, have permitted him to retain. Wolverine's claws came out with a sound like the world's shortest argument ending. Thor stood so fast his horn baptized an entire row of Eternals; three separate members of the Spider-family thwipped web-lines in Rocket's general direction on pure reflex; Elsa Bloodstone produced a pistol from somewhere philosophical; Faiza Hussain's sword hummed; and from the monster galleries, high above, Fin Fang Foom's voice rolled down like weather: **"If the vermin mounts the dragon-child, Foom will eat the vermin, the seat, and — on principle — the concept of saddles."**

"WOW," said Rocket, hands up. "Okay! Tone! Noted! The theatre has adopted the kid, everybody's real normal about it—"

"I am Groot," said Groot, with crushing disappointment.

"Oh, don't YOU start, you let three kids ride you last—"

Overhead, the gacha wheel — which had listened to the audience once before, and evidently intended to make a habit of it — emitted a single low buzz in Rocket's direction, like a headmaster clearing his throat.

Rocket sat down.

"...I'm keeping the question on file," he muttered.

The lights had begun their end-of-chapter dim when Yondu Udonta stood up.

He didn't address the room. Ravagers didn't. He just looked at the last lingering image — the boy at the pond's edge in the dark, and the tiny ship drifting toward his hand for one more bump of the prow before sleep — and he whistled, once, soft. The arrow rose off his knees and hung in the air beside his ear, red trail glowing, close as a thought.

"Folks think the whistle steers it," he said, to nobody, to the port side, to a boy in another row who wasn't looking at him. "It don't. Whistle's just how I ask. It flies 'cause it *knows* me. Knows every rotten thing I am and flies anyhow." He watched the boat bump the boy's hand, on screen, one last time. "You don't own a thing like that. You feed it and you hope like hell you're worth what it grows into."

He sat. The arrow settled. And Peter Quill, twelve seats away, looked at the screen very hard and said nothing, and the entire port side, with the ferocious discretion of career criminals, pretended that was that.

The screen went dark — then flickered, once, with next chapter's appetite. A moonlit street. Something inhuman shrieking in the dark of the canon world, and Issei's silhouette walking toward it, gauntlet lit, unafraid.

NEXT: THE HUNT, said the HUD, and in the rows where Blade and the Punisher and Elsa Bloodstone sat, several professionals leaned forward at once.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Ryuuteimaru's Origin* — Epic; *Choosing a Partner* — Rare. The wheel again reacted to the audience (a warning buzz aimed at Rocket), confirming chapter thirteen's discovery: the gacha is listening.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's familiar is Ryuuteimaru — a tiny, sleeping boat-spirit of the bloodline of Skíðblaðnir, Freyr's legendary ship, obtained via the Familiar Master Zatouji after Issei was twice rejected in the Familiar Forest (the sprite dragon Rassei chose Asia instead). It is a growth-type familiar: nearly useless now, it feeds on Issei's aura "a little every day, for years" and will become a vessel worthy of whatever its master becomes — **POTENTIAL: UNMEASURED**. Also revealed: prior Red Dragon Emperors used Ddraig as a weapon and burned into ruin; Issei is the first to simply *talk* to him (the melon-bread conversations), and Ddraig hinted his own choosing of Issei runs deeper than the sealing — "a vote is not always cast with a hand. We will speak of it another time."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Stakar Ogord frames the bond as crew signing on before the ship is built; Yondu, breaking a three-chapter silence, likens it to his Yaka arrow — and obliquely to Quill — softening the whole port side toward Issei. The Venom symbiote declares Issei an ideal host by Klyntar codex standards ("he would have been chosen on any world"), the warmest the symbiote section has been all fic. Silver Surfer names Issei "rich in the only coin that matters"; Ghost Rider calls the growing familiar "the only vehicle in creation I'd swap for"; Beta Ray Bill wants Skuttlebutt and Ryuuteimaru to meet. Rocket's request to ride Issei draws armed threats from half the theatre and formal disapproval from Groot; the question remains "on file." Thor and Loki now know an Asgardian-lineage artifact serves Issei — Loki's list of "categories unexplored" visibly grows.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** What does Ryuuteimaru grow into, and what will "riding it" one day mean? What is the fuller story behind Ddraig's claim that he *chose* Issei? Loki's acquisitive attention now spans both dragon and ship-spirit. Yondu and Quill's unspoken thing hangs over the port side. Next

chapter's tease — Issei hunting something monstrous by moonlight — has the hunters (Blade, Punisher, Elsa Bloodstone) leaning in.

Chapter Fifteen: Monster Hunter

Primary Reaction Groups: Blade • Elsa Bloodstone • Midnight Suns (Robbie Reyes, Magik, Nico Minoru) • Punisher

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Hunting Stray Devils" — **Rare**
 2. "Killing a Dragon to Save Children" — **Super Rare**
-

The theatre had sections the way a city has neighborhoods, and by the fifteenth chapter everyone knew the map. The Avengers held the bright middle rows. The gods sat high and argued in weather. The villains had colonized the mezzanine, where the sightlines were good and the moral lighting was flattering.

And down at the very edge of the floor, nearest the screen, where the glow off the canon world lit faces from below like a campfire that showed things instead of warming them, sat the hunters.

They had never organized. They had simply *accreted*, the way people who work nights end up at the same diner. Blade at the aisle, sword across his knees like a seatbelt. Elsa Bloodstone one row back with her boots on the chair in front of her, which the theatre had stopped fighting her about somewhere around chapter six. The Midnight Suns scattered loosely behind — Robbie Reyes with his jacket collar up, Magik with one armored boot swinging, Nico Minoru taking notes in a book that took its own notes. And at the far end, in the seat with clear lines to two exits that did not exist, Frank Castle.

The previous evening had belonged to the Ravagers — a tiny boat with a dragon's destiny, and Rocket asking a question about riding Issei that half the theatre was still recovering from. Tonight the wheel came down without ceremony, spun once, hard, and dropped its token like a shell casing.

PULL ONE: HUNTING STRAY DEVILS — RARE.

"Rare," said Elsa Bloodstone, to no one. "Fifteen chapters of dead schoolboys and national dragons, and the job listing is *Rare*. Story of the industry, really. The work's never the headline."

"Quiet," said Blade, not unkindly. "It's a work night."

The screen opened on darkness that smelled — the theatre did this now, another new trick nobody had authorized — of rust and old rain.

An abandoned building on the edge of Kuoh Town. The kind of place every city keeps without meaning to: a factory or a hospital or both, windows like knocked-out teeth, a chain-link fence that had given up. On the cracked lot outside stood Rias Gremory's peerage, and among them, hands jammed in his pockets, trying to look like he did this all the time, Issei Hyoudou.

"A Devil who kills or abandons their master and runs," Rias was saying, in the tone of a teacher who is also a landlord and also, in a very real sense, a knife, "is called a Stray. The power we're given doesn't hold its shape without the contract that granted it. Cut the leash and the power keeps growing anyway — sideways. It eats the person who was holding it. What's left stops rationing itself. It hunts humans, because humans are easy, and it starts with the easy ones."

"Starts?" said Issei.

"Children," said Koneko, flatly, from his elbow. "It's been eating children."

The theatre's floor sections went very quiet, very fast.

"We're sanctioned to destroy it," Rias said. "Ordered to, actually — the Archduke posts them like bounties. Strays are the one job every faction agrees on. We protect the town, we get paid, and my family's name is worth a little more in the right rooms. Tonight you watch, Issei. Learn what the pieces mean."

What followed, the hunters at the front recognized within about nine seconds, was a *field certification exercise* — a senior team running a live hunt slow enough for the new hire to see the shapes of it.

The thing that came down the stairwell had been a woman once. The gacha, mercifully, did not linger on what it had become — it filmed in glimpses and shadows, the way a smart horror movie does: a torso where a torso should not attach, limbs with extra elbows, a mouth in the wrong hemisphere entirely, and a voice that still remembered how to sound like a person, which was the worst part, because it used that voice to talk about what it ate.

"Kiba," said Rias, and a blond boy became a line of moonlight. "My Knight. Speed, and blades." Two of the wrong limbs hit the floor.

"Koneko. My Rook." The small girl caught a descending claw the size of a door on one raised forearm, looked briefly bored, and hit the Stray so hard it changed rooms. "Strength, and defense that doesn't move."

"Akeno." The shrine maiden rose into the air with her palms crackling and an expression the theatre's teen-rated lighting handled by cutting quickly back to Issei's appalled face. "My Queen. All of it at once. She'll be a moment. She... enjoys her work."

"That one," said Elsa Bloodstone approvingly, over the sound of thunder, "would pass the Bloodstone interview at the handshake stage."

On-screen, when it was done — when the Stray lay broken in the wreck of the lobby, still hissing about hunger through its wrong mouth — Rias walked to it without hurry. And here the theatre saw the thing several of them would argue about for the rest of the night.

She asked it a question first.

"Any last words?"

Not for show. Not gloating. It was a door held open for exactly one second — long enough for anything left inside to walk through. What answered her was appetite in a stolen voice, and Rias nodded once, like a magistrate closing a file, and unmade it in a single sheet of crimson light. No trophy. No speech. She stood a moment over the scorch mark with her eyes shut — the theatre would have missed it if the gacha hadn't held the frame — and then it was over, and she was telling Issei about invoicing.

The screen shifted into montage: weeks, then months. Hunts by railway sidings and drowned basements and one memorably terrible parking structure. Issei getting better — first bait ("why is it ALWAYS me luring it out," he howled, sprinting from something with too many wings, and Elsa barked a laugh and said "because you're loud and expendable, it's a *classic* apprenticeship"), then flanker, then the one who put the Boost into Koneko's fists at the perfect moment. Civilians who never knew, walking out of memory-smoothed evenings. A small ledger of payments; Issei spending his first hunt money on dinner for his parents and lying about a part-time job.

And threaded through the montage, twice, the shape of the line.

The first time: a Stray that had barely turned, days out from its crime, still wearing most of its human face. It wept. It begged. It said *I didn't mean to* in a voice that cracked in the right places, and Issei — sixteen, soft-hearted, murdered once himself by someone who smiled at him — lowered the gauntlet and took a step forward, and the thing's weeping mouth unhinged into a bear trap and it nearly took his head off. Koneko's fist arrived where his skull had been. Afterward, shaking, he didn't say *I'll never hesitate again*. He said, "Next time I'll check from further away."

The second time: a hunt where the Stray's terrified human familiar — an actual person, a contracted man who'd fed it victims out of fear — stood between the peerage and the door with a kitchen knife. The theatre watched Issei, who had that same week punched through a reinforced barrier, disarm a middle-aged accountant with agonizing gentleness, sit on him, and yell for Rias to *please* handle the memory thing because the man wouldn't stop screaming. The man went home. He remembered nothing. His file, the gacha noted primly, was marked VICTIM, COERCED.

The screen paused between pulls, and the theatre lights came up on the hunters' section, where every professional killer of monsters on the floor was already leaning forward.

"Okay," said Blade. He stood, because Blade standing was how that section called itself to order. "Somebody upstairs finally pulled a chapter about the *job*."

"The job," agreed Elsa. "Not the destiny, not the flag, not the tragic girlfriend. Contract, briefing, target, exits, invoice. I could weep. I shan't, but I could."

"Walk it through," said Robbie Reyes, quietly. He had his arms crossed, and the thing under his skin was paying attention too; you could tell by the way the shadows near him idled like an engine. "For the rows that don't do this. Why does it look like that? Why the — " he gestured — "the last words thing?"

"Because of what a Stray is," Blade said. He addressed the theatre generally, which he almost never did. "I've worked vampires my whole life, so let me translate. The person is *gone*. That's rule one and it's the whole rulebook. What's left is hunger wearing their memories, and it will use every one of those memories as a lure, because the lure is all they're for now. You heard the girl — the power eats the person, then it goes shopping. That thing tonight talked like a woman because talking like a woman *works*." He turned and looked at the screen. "And the kid nearly died learning it, which is the only way anyone ever learns it. The mistake he made? Everybody makes it once. The ones who make it twice, we bury. He adjusted his *distance*, not his *heart*. That's — " Blade paused, choosing the word with care, because from him it was currency — "correct."

"The last words," said Elsa, boots coming off the chair, "are the part I'd frame and hang in the family manor, except my family manor is full of my father's taxidermy and his opinions, so possibly not. Listen — my father raised me hunting these things, and Ulysses Bloodstone's standing rule was *never talk to it, monsters lie, mouths are for trophies*. Efficient. Also corrosive. Do it his way for thirty years and you stop being able to tell your own species from the prey list, and I'd know, I've read his journals, it's why I drink." She nodded at the screen. "The Gremory girl asks the question knowing the answer will be teeth. She asks *anyway*. It costs her one second and it keeps her — and the boy watching her — on the right side of the line every single time, because the day something answers the question like a person is the day they'll stop, and they both know it. It's not sentiment. It's *calibration*. You test the blade every night so you notice the night it's wrong."

"It's a ritual," said Nico Minoru, pen stopped over her notebook. "That's literally witchcraft, what she's doing. A rule you perform so the rule stays real."

"Every hunter tradition has one," said Magik. Her voice came out with the faint echo it carried when Limbo leaned close to listen. "In Limbo, mine is that I remember being the thing I'm killing. Keeps the sword honest." She smiled, thin as her blade. "The devil children hunt tidily. I approve."

Through all of it, Frank Castle said nothing.

He had watched the montage the way he watched everything — like it was surveillance footage and someone he loved was in the background of it. Now, in the pause, Daredevil's voice carried from the street-level rows, gently baiting: "Nothing, Frank? A sixteen-year-old with a body count. I'd have bet money."

"Body count's monsters," said Frank.

"They were people once. Devils. Some of them were *humans* once, before the pieces. He kills them without a trial."

"No," said Frank, and stood up, because he was going to use his hands to point at the screen and that required standing. "Pay attention. Everybody watched the fights. I watched the *sort*." He held up fingers, cataloguing. "Thing in the factory: gone, confirmed hostile, eating kids — killed clean, no show, no speech. Crying one: he checked. Almost died checking, so he changed procedure — he still *checks*, he just checks smart. The man with the knife — armed, obstructing, dangerous — and the kid takes a shoulder strike he didn't have to take, to bring him in soft. Man goes home to his family." Frank lowered his hand. "That's not a berserker and it's not a bleeding heart. That's target discrimination. He's running a cleaner ROE at sixteen than most departments I've seen run with lawyers in the room."

"High praise," said Daredevil.

"It's not praise yet." Frank sat back down, eyes on the screen. "Anybody can sort easy targets. Monster that looks like a monster — that's a gift, that's the job doing your thinking for you. I want to see what he does when the categories fight back. When it's got a face he likes." He settled into stillness. "Roll the next one."

The gacha, which since chapter thirteen had been listening — everyone knew it now, nobody liked it — obliged him almost instantly.

Which was when Deadpool arrived at the hunters' section carrying a duffel bag.

He'd had the duffel bag since chapter two. No one knew what was in it. He dropped it in the aisle next to Blade with the confidence of a man joining a carpool he has definitely been invited to.

"Team's all here! Okay. Pitch meeting. The kid hunts monsters for money, I hunt *everything* for money, this is *synergy*, this is the crossover the streaming service ordered. I've prepared a résumé." He had. It was laminated. Under SKILLS it said *unkillable*, *hilarious*, *owns own swords* and under REFERENCES it said *don't*. "All I need is for the magic bingo cage to beam me into Japan, or beam him out here, or — hear me out — beam us BOTH into a bottle episode—"

"No," said Blade.

"You're not the boss of the cage. Cage! CAGE." Deadpool addressed the gacha wheel directly, arms spread. "Buddy. Sweetie. You react to the audience now, everyone's talking about it. React to THIS: one (1) application for the position of Stray Devil Hunting Associate, submitted with love, by me."

The theatre had learned to dread the gacha's new responsiveness. This was the moment the dread paid rent. The wheel lit. The screen split, politely bookmarking the canon world, and displayed, in the cold system font it used for verdicts:

APPLICATION RECEIVED: WILSON, W. FORWARDING TO SUBJECT SIMULATION FOR ASSESSMENT.

"See?" said Deadpool. "Process. I respect process."

The screen showed a rendering — clearly labeled SIMULATION, in the manner of chapter forty-things to come — of Issei Hyoudou being shown Deadpool's file. All of it. The theatre watched the boy read, in fast-forward, with his face doing a journey. At the end, simulated Issei looked up and said, with the specific firmness he otherwise reserved for defending Asia:

"No."

"He didn't even give a reason!" Deadpool howled.

SUBJECT'S STATED REASON, printed the screen, **QUOTE: "HE MAKES KILLING LOOK FUN. IT'S NOT SUPPOSED TO LOOK FUN. THE LITTLE ONES COPY WHAT LOOKS FUN." END QUOTE.**

The hunters' section made a low, collective sound, the sound an audience makes at a dart hitting a board dead center. Deadpool stood very still for a moment.

"...Okay, wow," he said, at reduced volume. "The teenager just performance-reviewed my whole bibliography."

APPEAL? offered the screen, with what everyone present chose to believe was not hope.

"No," said Deadpool, picking up his duffel bag with dignity. "No, he's — ugh — he's *right*, and I'm going to go sit with the villains, where being seen clearly is considered rude." He paused at the aisle's end and pointed back at the screen. "I'm keeping the laminate. And I'm starting a new list. He's on it."

"What list?" said Nico, unwisely.

"People Who Get It," said Deadpool, and went.

The wheel was already spinning again. It spun long, this time — long enough for the whole floor to go quiet, because they had learned that too. The token dropped like something falling into a well.

PULL TWO: KILLING A DRAGON TO SAVE CHILDREN — SUPER RARE.

Down at the front, Blade's hand found the grip of his sword — not drawing, just touching it, the way you touch a doorframe in a shaking house. In the gallery high above, Fin Fang Foom uncoiled by one degree. And the screen opened on rain.

The briefing came fast and wrong. The theatre could tell it was wrong because Rias's voice, on-screen, had lost its landlord calm.

A Stray, three towns over — outside Gremory territory, but the local jurisdiction had begged. This one was old, as Strays went. It had kept itself fed and quiet, and its power, growing sideways all that time, had grown *toward* something. Somewhere in its wandering it had found the barrow of a lesser dragon dead a thousand years, and it had eaten what it found there, heart and hoard and all — and the shape a Stray takes is the shape of what it eats.

"Partner," said Ddraig, and the gauntlet's voice was careful. "You should hear this from me before you see it. It will look like kin. It is not. It is a thief wearing a grave. But your blood will not know the difference at first sight, and I will not lie to you — neither, entirely, will mine."

It had taken three children from a school camping trip at the reservoir. Taken, not eaten. Dragons hoard, said Ddraig, low. Even stolen dragonhood hoards. It has put them somewhere it considers treasure, and it will keep them alive exactly as long as they are treasure, and no longer.

The nest was in a flooded quarry, in the drowned mouth of a maintenance tunnel, and the thing coiled around three small sleeping shapes was, the theatre had to admit, *beautiful*. The gacha did not glimpse-and-shadow this one. It showed it whole: red-black scales with the deep ember shine of a banked fire, wings folded like cathedral architecture, a long head with old, old eyes. After fourteen chapters, the audience knew what they were looking at. It looked like the memory-visions of Ddraig himself, rendered small and wrong — a tribute band of a god.

The peerage plan was artillery: Akeno from above, Rias from the ridge, overwhelm it away from the nest. The dragon-thing made the plan obsolete by scenting the air once and going *directly back to its hoard* — coiling tighter around the children, wings mantling over them like a vault door. Any barrage would go through it into them. Kiba's speed meant nothing in a flooded tunnel. Koneko couldn't hit what used children as chest armor.

And then it raised its head, and looked across the black water directly at Issei, and made a sound none of them had ever heard a Stray make.

It crooned.

"It smells me," said Issei. His voice came out strange. "Ddraig — it smells *you*."

"Yes," said Ddraig.

"It's not attacking me."

"No. To its stolen blood, you are the Red Dragon Emperor. You are the closest thing to an elder it will ever meet. It is *presenting its hoard to you*." A silence, on-screen and off, as the theatre understood one second before Issei said it aloud. "Partner. It will let you approach."

The theatre watched Issei Hyoudou walk on the surface tension of devil-magic across black water toward a dragon that was singing to him, and every hunter in the front row stopped breathing, because they all saw the shape of the only plan that saved three children, and they all knew what it was going to cost the person executing it.

[BOOST.]

Soft, the gem barely glowing. **[BOOST.]** Ten seconds. **[BOOST.]** The thing lowered its great head as he came, pupils going wide and warm, and nudged its wing aside a fraction — *look*, the gesture said, ancient and terrible and almost innocent, *look what I kept safe* — and showed him three children, alive, unhurt, curled in a bed of stolen coats and bicycle parts and one traffic mirror it must have liked the shine of.

"Hey," Issei whispered to it. His hand was on its snout. His voice was wrecked. "Yeah. You did good. You kept them safe."

[BOOST.]

"I'm sorry."

The children never woke. The theatre barely saw the shot — a single point-blank Dragon Shot angled *up and away* through the one line that touched nothing but the Stray, the angle he'd been walking three careful degrees at a time since the water's edge. The light filled the tunnel and was gone, and the thing that had been singing came apart into ember and ash without ever once knowing it had been hunted, and the last expression in its old eyes, the gacha held long enough for everyone to carry away with them, was trust.

Issei caught the biggest child before she touched the water.

He got them out. He was steady the whole time — steady handing them up the quarry wall to Kiba, steady while Rias smoothed the night out of their memories into a story about getting lost, steady right up until the peerage was gone ahead with the kids and he was alone at the waterline with a tunnel full of ash.

"Partner," said Ddraig.

"Don't," said Issei. "Not yet. Just — was any of it real? The dragon part. Or was I just — a really good lure. Like the crying one, like Blade-guy's rule, mouths are all lures now—" He stopped, sat down hard on the stone, and put his face in his hands, gauntlet and all.

The old voice took its time.

"Attend," said Ddraig at last, gently, in the tone the theatre had last heard address an island. "It was not a dragon. It was a hungry ghost in a dragon's stolen skin, and if you had hesitated it would have kept those children as treasure until it forgot why, and treasure that is forgotten gets *spent*. You did not betray kin tonight." A pause. "But you mourn as kin. That is not a flaw in you, partner. That is the tax of our blood, and I will tell you now, because you have earned the knowing: I have killed dragons. True ones, mad ones, friends gone wrong across ten thousand years. It has never once cost nothing. The day it costs nothing, the Red Dragon Emperor is just a very large Stray."

"...What do I do with it, then. The — " he gestured at his own chest — "this."

"What is done for any dragon. Fire is not left in the dark. Burn it skyward."

The theatre watched a sixteen-year-old boy stand in a flooded quarry at three in the morning and, following the murmured instructions of the oldest thing that loved him, send a column of red flame up out of the tunnel mouth into the rain — a funeral rite older than every nation whose representatives were watching — and stand at attention until it went out. He cried through the whole thing. He did not let it change the flame.

"It never even had a name," Issei said.

"Dragons name themselves by their fire, and it never got the chance to make its own. So remember the fire *you* gave it. That will do. That has always done."

The screen dimmed. The lights came up. And for the second chapter running, the theatre was silent.

Frank Castle stood.

He walked down the aisle to the front — the hunters made room; even the theatre made room, the floor-lights tracking him — and he pointed at the dark screen, and delivered, unasked, the after-action review.

"Sequence," he said. "Kids first — every choice bent around the kids from the first minute; the whole approach was one long firing solution that didn't exist until the kids were covered. Threat second — one shot, no showboat, no hesitation *at the moment*, and the moment's the only place hesitation kills. Himself third — he walked point-blank into a dragon's mouth on the theory it liked his smell. Feelings *last*. He locked it down till the kids were clear and the civilians were handled, and then he paid the bill in private, in full, with nobody watching." He looked around the theatre — at the moralists, at the mezzanine, at the gods. "That's the order. That is the *whole* order. I've spent my life watching people get it wrong in every direction — grieve first and bury kids, or skip the bill and turn into the thing in the tunnel. The kid's ledger balances." He turned to go, and stopped, because he was a fair man about exactly one thing, and added the asterisk. "He kills monsters that used to be people and spares people acting like monsters, and so far the world's let him have that line clean. It won't forever. One day the thing eating kids will have a pulse and a face and paperwork, and I'll want to see this chapter again. Till then—" and Frank Castle said the sentence the front row would quote for the rest of the run — "the kid hunts like the children are his and the monsters aren't. Approved."

He sat down. Blade raised two fingers off his sword hilt in salute — from him, a parade. Elsa Bloodstone said, hoarsely, "Field certification, Bloodstone standard, and my father can rotate in his shrine," and pulled her boots back up on the chair so nobody would look at her face. Robbie Reyes said quietly, to no one, "He used what he is to get close, and stayed what he is after. That's the trick. That's the whole trick," and the engine-shadow around him idled soft, almost peaceable. Magik proposed, seriously, that the boy would survive Limbo, which from her was a marriage offer of sorts; Nico wrote *the rule you perform so the rule stays real* and underlined it twice.

High above, Fin Fang Foom spoke once into the quiet: "The burning was done correctly." Nothing else. From him, a eulogy.

And in the mezzanine, Mephisto — who had laughed at the boy's death and delighted in his price — was not smiling at all, because incorruptibility is a rumor until you watch someone pay grief full price on time and in secret, and then it is a *problem*.

The lights had begun their end-of-chapter dim when the screen flickered once more — the gacha's now-familiar parting gift, next door's coming attraction. It showed a forge. Holy fire. And taking shape on the anvil, a long, pale blade whose purpose the system font spelled out over the embers with what could only be called timing:

NEXT: THE FORGING OF ASCALON — A SWORD MADE FOR ONE PURPOSE: THE SLAYING OF DRAGONS.

"Oh, that's *cruel*," said Nico, into the dark.

The theatre went to black on the hunters' row, all of them still seated, none of them leaving first.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Hunting Stray Devils* — Rare; *Killing a Dragon to Save Children* — Super Rare. The gacha also processed its first audience "application" (Wilson, W.) via subject simulation — establishing that the theatre can render simulated Issei responses to audience requests, a mechanism with obvious future implications.
- **Secrets Revealed:** *Stray Devils* — Devils who kill or abandon their masters — mutate into monsters as their unleashed power devours them, and hunting them is sanctioned, posted work (Archduke bounties) that every faction endorses; it is how Rias's peerage protects Kuoh, earns income, and builds the Gremory name. Issei's kill-line was mapped in operation: monsters that prey on innocents die fast and unceremonied; anything with a person left in it — coerced familiars, the barely-turned — gets checked for, at personal risk ("Next time I'll check from further away"). A dragon-shaped Stray (a devil that devoured a dead lesser dragon's heart and hoard) recognized Issei's blood, trusted him, and he used that trust for a point-blank kill to save three hoarded children — then performed his first dragon funeral rite ("burn it skyward") under Ddraig's instruction. Ddraig confirmed he has killed true dragons across his ages and that grief is "the tax of our blood."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** The hunters' bloc formally approves: Blade salutes his technique and his distance-not-heart correction; Elsa Bloodstone grants "field certification, Bloodstone standard" and pointedly contrasts Rias's "any last words" calibration ritual against her father's corrosive method; Magik and Robbie Reyes claim kinship with killing what shares your nature; Punisher delivers a full after-action approval of Issei's priority order (kids, threat, self, feelings — "the kid's ledger balances") while filing an explicit asterisk for the day the monster has a human face. Deadpool's application to join the hunts was refused by simulated Issei ("He makes killing look fun... the little ones copy what looks fun") — and Deadpool, stung into sincerity, conceded the point and added Issei to a new list: "People Who Get It." Mephisto has stopped smiling; incorruptibility is becoming a problem for him rather than a delight.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Punisher's standing challenge — what happens when the thing eating children has a pulse, a face, and paperwork? (Arc Four will answer.) The gacha's simulation mechanism now takes audience requests — who applies next, and for what? The nameless dragon-Stray's funeral fire is remembered; Issei's kinship with dragons is now a wound as well as a strength. And the next chapter's tease lands like a knife: the boy who just mourned a dragon is about to be handed Ascalon — a holy sword forged for exactly one purpose.

Chapter Sixteen: The Blacksmith

Primary Reaction Groups: Doom • Tony Stark • Shuri • Eitri • Phastos

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Forging the First Ascalon" — **Legendary**
 2. "Replica Mjolnir Loan" — **Rare**
-

Sixteen chapters into their shared captivity, the theatre's audience had done what audiences always do: they had self-sorted.

The gods had their high tiers and their thunderheads. The street heroes had colonized the middle rows into something resembling a neighborhood, complete with borrowed blankets and an unspoken rule about saving seats. The monsters had the galleries. And down on the left flank, in a cluster of seats that had somehow acquired workbench-height armrests and improved lighting without anyone asking, sat the quarter of the room that thought with its hands.

Tony Stark. Shuri of Wakanda, who had claimed the seat beside him specifically so she could disagree with him at conversational volume. Phastos of the Eternals, who repaired things when he was anxious and had been visibly anxious since chapter one. And Eitri, king of the dwarves, who occupied three seats and made them look like a throne, and who had spent fifteen chapters saying almost nothing — because until now the boy on the screen had punched, boosted, bled, and roared, and none of that was *craft*.

Victor von Doom did not sit with them. Doom sat in the aisle adjacent, alone, at the precise distance that communicated *I am not with these people* and *I can hear every word these people say* simultaneously. Nobody had ever seen him arrive at that seat. He was simply always in it, like a load-bearing pillar with opinions.

The previous chapter had been hunts — strays and monsters, wages and mercy, Blade's slow approving nod and the Punisher's slower one. Tonight, the theatre's weather changed early. The house lights sank not to storm-grey or pub-gold but to a deep working orange, the exact color of metal thinking about becoming something else, and the air filled with a smell that had no business crossing dimensions: coal smoke, scale, quenching oil.

Eitri was on his feet before the wheel even descended.

"That," he said, in a voice like a rockslide clearing its throat, "is a forge. I would know that smell in my grave."

The gacha wheel dropped from the dark, spun its rings with ceremonial smugness, and delivered its first token into the crystal bowl. The chime, tonight, sounded like a hammer on an anvil.

PULL ONE: "FORGING THE FIRST ASCALON" — LEGENDARY.

"Ascalon," said Shuri, already leaning forward. "That is not a Japanese word."

"It's not a devil word either," said Stark. "That's a *saint's* word. Why does the pervert dragon have a saint's word?"

The screen bloomed, and — as it did for its highest rarities — it *illustrated*.

Legend first, painted in the gacha's memory-fire, hedged in the soft brushwork it used for things older than reliable witnesses.

An age when dragons were a weather that ate villages. A forge at the edge of that age, and a smith whose face the vision never showed — only the hands, and the work. The theatre watched a blade being made the old way, which is to say slowly, which is to say *honestly*: folded, hammered, blessed, quenched, prayed over, hammered again. Sanctified not once at the end but continuously, the way you don't season a stew by dumping the salt in last. Whatever went into that steel went in at every stage, until the vision made one thing wordlessly clear: this was not a sword that had been taught to cut. This was a sword that had been taught, hammer-blow by hammer-blow, exactly one lesson, and the lesson was *how dragons end*.

A knight carried it. The legend called him George, and later called him Saint, and the vision gave the theatre one single frame of him standing over something vast and scaled and finished, and then, mercifully, moved on. Ascalon, the dragon-slayer. Every dragon it ended it *understood*, and every one it understood made it better at ending the next. A blade with a curriculum.

"Oh, that's obscene," said Stark, delighted and appalled. "That's a learning system. Somebody built machine learning out of hagiography and murder."

"Somebody built a *purpose* and gave it an edge," Eitri rumbled. "Be silent. This is the good part."

But the vision jumped forward instead — centuries collapsing like a closing bellows — and the forge-light gave way to a school's meeting room, and the theatre's collective stomach dropped, because standing in that mundane little room, wings like sunrise given anatomy, was an Archangel.

MICHAEL, the screen captioned, unnecessarily. Nobody in the theatre needed the caption. Several of the room's gods sat up straighter without meaning to.

And Michael, chief of the armies of Heaven, gentlest smile in creation, held out the dragon-slaying sword of Saint George — to Issei Hyoudou. Devil. Red Dragon Emperor. The boy who, six chapters ago, had made the entire theatre's threat-meter climb by swearing a dragon-backed oath against Heaven itself over what Heaven's church had done to Asia Argento.

"Hold on," said Sam Wilson, from the middle rows. "Hold *on*. Heaven heard that kid declare war on it, and Heaven's response was to *arm him*?"

"Heaven's response," murmured Doctor Strange, eyes narrowed with professional interest, "was to hand the dragon an anti-dragon weapon and call it a gift. That is either the most generous act in this story so far, or the most elegant containment strategy I have ever seen. Possibly both."

On screen, Issei took the sword — and yelped, because the holy aura of the thing met his devil flesh like a stovetop. He held on anyway. The theatre had learned by now that *holding on anyway* was roughly eighty percent of his skill set.

And then, quietly, before the exchange ended, the boy did the thing that made the Workshop Quarter — who had come tonight for metallurgy — go suddenly still.

"Um. Michael-san. Since you're here. Can I ask for one more thing? Not for me." On-screen Issei bowed, badly, the bow of someone who had never had a reason to learn formality and was improvising with his whole heart. "There's a girl. Asia. The Church threw her away, but she still — she still prays. Every day. And it *hurts* her now, because she's a devil, because of me, kind of. Could you — is there a setting, or —" he gestured helplessly at the ceiling, at the sky, at the entire apparatus of Heaven — "could you make it not hurt? When she prays? That's all. You can take the sword back if it costs extra."

Phastos put his hand over his mouth.

Michael's smile changed. The screen did not caption what it changed into, and didn't need to. "It will be done," the Archangel said. "Keep the sword."

The vision moved to a basement lab, and the real work began — the part the pull had been named for.

Because Ascalon, it turned out, would not simply be *carried*. A devil's hands blistered on its hilt; a dragon's aura made it hum with the low, eager note of a dog scenting the exact thing it was bred for. So the boy and the dragon in his arm did the only thing they could think of, which was also the maddest thing available:

They fed the dragon-slaying sword to the dragon.

The theatre watched Issei brace the blade against the Boosted Gear's green gem, watched him pour boosts into the join — **[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]** — watched holy light and dragon-fire argue like two rivers meeting, watched the boy grit his teeth as the backwash burned up his forearm in bright, forgiving welts.

"Partner," said Ddraig, with the tone of an ancient being reading his own eviction notice, **"I wish it noted, formally, for whatever record survives us: I am a dragon. You are asking me to hold a dragon-slayer in my mouth."**

"You said we needed a weapon with an edge! You literally said that! Last week!"

"I meant a knife. A spear. A sharpened complaint. Not the single most anti-me object ever manufactured. Do you understand that every dragon that has ever lived would call this blasphemy?"

"Do YOU want to give it back to the Archangel? *You* explain the refund."

A pause. The green gem flickered — the theatre had learned to read that flicker as Ddraig sighing, and Thor, in the high tiers, was already grinning in anticipation.

"...No," said the Welsh Dragon, at last, with terrible dignity. **"It is a good sword. I sigh a proportionate amount, and this occasion merits one. Continue."**

The join took. Light snapped inward like a door closing, and when Issei raised his arm again the gauntlet spoke in its cold system voice — a new word, added to its small vocabulary of dooms:

[BLADE.]

Ascalon slid out of the Boosted Gear's crest and locked home, holy steel rising from dragon scale, and the two auras — which had spent the whole scene fighting — settled against each other like a border going quiet. The gacha stamped the frame with its rotating Legendary seal and, because it had developed a taste for editorializing, wrote across the bottom of the screen in letters of forge-fire:

THE PERFECT ANTI-DRAGON WEAPON EXAMINED THE DRAGON — AND CHOSE TO SERVE.

RE-FORGED IN DRAGON-FIRE. CARRIED BY ITS OWN PREY. IT HAS NEVER BEEN HAPPIER.

"It has never been *happier*," Phastos repeated, softly. "It said happier. The sword has a mood now. I need everyone to be more upset about that sentence."

The screen paused itself between pulls. The lights came up.

And then the gacha did the thing it had only done once before — in chapter thirteen, when it had spun uninvited to humiliate the British. It reacted to its audience. The wheel's rings rotated with unmistakable glee, a shaft of light stabbed down into the open floor in front of the Workshop Quarter, and out of the light rose a plinth of black stone.

On the plinth lay Ascalon. Or something wearing its shape — steel and gold, faintly warm, impossibly *present*.

Text hung in the air above it, in the gacha's coldest font:

LEGENDARY BONUS: ANALYSIS OPPORTUNITY.

EXHIBIT IS AN ECHO. ECHO IS FAITHFUL. INSTRUMENTS PROVIDED.

THE MANAGEMENT ACCEPTS NO LIABILITY FOR THE EXHIBIT'S OPINIONS.

Beside the plinth, a workbench had appeared, laden with instruments so beautiful that Tony Stark made a small, involuntary sound.

"It's a trap," said Shuri, standing, already rolling up her sleeves. "It has provided us perfect instruments to watch us fail with. This is a rigged casino."

"Obviously it's a rigged casino," said Stark, also standing. "Deal me in."

Stark went first, because of course he did.

He didn't touch it — sixteen chapters had taught even Tony Stark that much — he *scanned* it, with a spectrometer of no earthly design that fit his hand like it had been printed for him. The readings came back promptly, confidently, and uselessly.

"Okay. Composition analysis says — " he squinted — "it says *faith*. Not an element. Not an alloy. The word. Mass reads as 'depends.' Depends on *what*? Edge geometry is — the edge doesn't resolve. I've got magnification down to angstroms and the edge just keeps *going*, it's not an edge, it's a — " he turned the display so Shuri could see, and his voice did the thing it did when engineering became religion — "it's a boundary condition."

"Give me that." Shuri took the instrument, ran her own protocol, cross-checked it against a second device, then a third. Her eyebrows climbed. "He's right. The edge of this sword reads like the walls of this theatre read. It is not sharp, colonizer. Sharp is for knives. This thing is *definitional*. It does not cut dragons." She looked up, delighted in the way only a scientist meeting a beautiful monster can be. "It decides where dragons *stop*."

She tried to lift it then, properly, with an insulated cradle rated to eight hundred tons, and the sword — without moving, without glowing, without any drama at all — weighed eight hundred and one. She swapped for a heavier rig. The sword weighed more than that instead. Exactly, precisely, insultingly *one unit more* than whatever she brought.

"It is doing this on purpose," she announced, to the room. "It has a sense of humor. I want everyone to know I respect it and I hate it."

Phastos came forward third, and he did not bring an instrument at all.

He stood over the blade with his hands loose at his sides, and he looked at it the way he looked at engines and doorways and dying machines — reading not the material but the *intention*, because to Phastos every made thing was a sentence and he had never met one he couldn't parse. The theatre quieted. Even the Workshop Quarter had learned that when Phastos went still, something true was about to get said.

"Every machine wants something," he said at last. "Weapons are usually easy reads. They want use. This one — " he tilted his head — "this one doesn't want use. It wants to *keep a promise*. Someone stood at a forge with the whole world burning behind them, and instead of making a weapon, they made a vow you can hold." He stepped back, and did not once try to touch it. "It's not mine to pick up. You don't try on somebody else's wedding ring."

"You're not even going to *try*?" said Stark.

"Tony. It's a promise with an edge, and it already belongs to someone." Phastos sat back down. "I fix things. That is not broken."

Eitri went fourth, and Eitri did the thing none of them had dared: he touched it.

Not the hilt. Never the hilt. He laid one enormous scarred knuckle against the flat of the blade, gently, the way you greet a strange horse — and the whole theatre heard it: a low tone rose off the steel, warm, resonant, *acknowledging*. The sword had ignored three geniuses and their instruments, and it was humming for the dwarf.

"HA!" barked Stark. "Favoritism!"

"Fellowship," Eitri corrected quietly. And then the tone faded, and the warmth went out of the metal, and the king of the dwarves withdrew his hand with a rueful, ancient smile. "There it is. It let me read the maker's mark — smith to smith, one nod across a very long room. It did not let me read the work." He looked down at the echo of Ascalon for a long moment. "Forged once. *Finished* ten thousand times — every hand that ever carried it rightly was another tempering. That is craft beyond me, and I have

forged suns into rings." His voice dropped, and the old grief moved under it like a fish under ice. "I made a thing, once, that answered any hand that held it. Any hand at all. That was my great mistake, and half a universe paid for it. This smith was wiser than I. He made a thing that *chooses*."

The silence after that held for three full seconds, which in that theatre was a standing ovation.

And then Doom rose.

He did not hurry. Doom had never hurried anywhere in his life; the world was expected to wait, and it did. He crossed to the plinth, and the Workshop Quarter drew back without discussing it, and the armored king of Latveria looked down at the dragon-slayer of Saint George the way one head of state examines another's border.

"You have refused a merchant," Doom said to the sword — to the *sword*, in the second person, as an equal, and no one laughed, "a princess, a god's engineer, and a king of smiths. Very well. Doom does not scan. Doom does not beg artifacts for their consent." He extended one gauntlet, mystic circuitry waking along the knuckles in threads of green. "Doom *takes measure*."

He laid his hand upon the hilt.

Nothing happened.

Not a burn. Not a shock. Not a hum, a glow, a refusal, a *weight*. The sword did to Victor von Doom what the theatre's floor had done to the Hulk's fists in chapter one: it declined, utterly and without effort, to acknowledge that anything had occurred. Doom stood with his hand on the greatest blade any of them had ever seen, and the blade treated him as weather. Less than weather. Weather, at least, gets a forecast.

The theatre held its breath. Everyone in it understood, instinctively, that the sword had just done the single most dangerous thing you can do to Doom. It had burned Stark's curiosity, teased Shuri, saluted Eitri, moved Phastos.

It had *ignored* Victor.

Doom removed his hand. He regarded the blade for a further moment, and when he spoke, his voice was as even as a chess clock.

"Adequate," he pronounced, and returned to his aisle.

Those seated nearest him — and several of them compared accounts afterward, so the record is considered reliable — observed that he wrote precisely one line in the small book he thought no one had noticed he kept, beneath the line he had written three chapters ago about dragons:

Latveria possesses no dragon-forged blade; oversight.

Up on the screen, the paused image chose that exact moment to resume for three seconds: on-screen Issei, in his world, flexing his arm — **[BLADE.]** — and Ascalon leaping joyfully out of the gauntlet into his scarred, unremarkable, teenaged hand.

On its plinth, the echo *leaned*. Toward the screen. Like a dog hearing the car in the drive.

"It rejected five of the finest makers in the multiverse," said Shuri, into her hands, "and it is wagging its tail at a *television*."

The wheel spun again before the Workshop Quarter had finished arguing about whether "faith" could be a boundary condition (Stark: no; Shuri: evidently; Phastos: *please stop instrumentalizing faith*; Eitri: silence, but weighted silence). The second token dropped with a cheerful clatter.

PULL TWO: "REPLICA MJOLNIR LOAN" — RARE.

Two reactions occurred at the same instant, in different tiers.

Thor stood up so fast his bench overturned.

And Loki said, "I beg your pardon — *loan*?" — and then the screen opened on the vision, and the theatre got to watch the God of Mischief experience the rare pleasure of seeing his own name captioned under someone else's face.

LOKI, said the screen, over a sneering, silver-haired Norse deity of the canon world — haughty, radiant with malice, monologuing at a boy in red armor about the coming twilight of the gods and the tedium of peace.

The theatre's Loki examined his counterpart in silence for four seconds. "The hair is derivative," he announced at last, to no one and everyone. "The cape is a cry for help. The monologue lacks structure — he's leading with Ragnarok, you *close* with Ragnarok. I am being defamed across the multiverse by an amateur."

"Brother," said Thor, not looking away from the screen, voice climbing toward the ceiling, "*hush*. Look. LOOK WHAT THE BOY IS HOLDING."

The vision showed it plainly: into Issei Hyoudou's hands, before the battle, someone had delivered a war hammer. Squat. Rune-carved. Impossibly familiar. The screen captioned it with what might have been the driest text it had ever produced:

MJOLNIR (REPLICA). DWARF-FORGED. BLESSED FOR THE BEARER'S USE. TERMS AND CONDITIONS APPLY.

"THAT IS MY HAMMER!" Thor roared, with total joy.

"That is a *copy* of your hammer," said Sif.

"THAT IS A COPY OF MY HAMMER!" Thor amended, with, if anything, more joy. "Do you see? Do you all SEE? Across the whole of the multiverse, when the gods of another cosmology needed to arm a mortal champion against a Loki — and I note, brother, that *every* world appears to need arming against a Loki, you are a constant, like the speed of light — what did they reach for? What was the *obvious* answer? MY HAMMER. Accept no substitutes! Except, apparently, this one substitute, which I hereby endorse!"

On screen, the fight was not going well. The canon Loki was god-tier and bored; Issei's boosts were climbing but slowly; and at the trickster's side loomed something that made the theatre's warmer conversations die mid-word — a wolf the size of a house, grey as famine, moving like an apology being retracted. The screen captioned it **FENRIR**, and then, in smaller text, as if reluctant: **HIS FANGS SLAY GODS**.

The boy in red armor set his feet. The hammer was too heavy for him, too holy, too *much* — and the theatre watched him do the thing that made Tony Stark rise slowly out of his seat with the expression of a man watching a stranger solve his life's problem with a rock.

[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] —

[TRANSFER.]

He poured it into the *hammer*.

The replica Mjolnir drank ten boosts of Red Dragon Emperor and grew — swelled — became a hammer for a giant's hand, wreathed in borrowed lightning and doubled dragon-power, and Issei Hyoudou gripped it in both gauntlets, screamed something wordless and sincere, and hit the God of Mischief with it so hard the vision's horizon flinched.

The canon Loki left a trench. The trench smoked.

The vision's frame stayed tight on Issei throughout — suspiciously tight, cropped like a photograph of a crowded party sent to an ex. At the very edge of the final frames, something white and swift blurred past, wing-light and contemptuous, and the gacha *conspicuously declined to focus on it*, panning away with the smooth haste of a museum guide passing a door marked PRIVATE.

The last thing the screen showed before the lights came up was the wolf.

Fenrir, lunging at the frame, jaws opening — and the vision cut to black on his teeth.

"Okay," said Stark, standing in the open floor now, pacing, hands sketching architecture in the air. "Okay. Everyone's watching the hammer. Stop watching the hammer. The hammer is a *peripheral*. Watch the kid. Sixteen chapters, and I finally have the spec sheet." He spun to face the Workshop Quarter. "He's not a weapon. He never was a weapon. He's an *outlet*. A universal power bus with legs. Transfer works on allies, sure, fine, support class, whatever — Transfer works on *hardware*. Hand that kid any weapon in this room and ten seconds later it's the finest version of itself that has ever existed. He turned a licensed replica into a god-killer in one move. Do you understand what I would *pay*—"

"Nothing," said Shuri. "You would pay nothing, because you cannot buy it, and that is the actual finding, Stark." She ticked it off on her fingers. "The holy sword: chooses him. The hammer: *blessed* for him — permission, notarized by a pantheon. The gauntlet: a partner, not a device — it has a name and it sighs at him. Every piece of that boy's arsenal runs on the same operating system, and the operating system is *consent*. You cannot steal it. You cannot reverse-engineer it. You cannot mass-produce it." She sat back, deeply satisfied. "It is the only arms industry in existence with no aftermarket."

"A covenant," rumbled Eitri, nodding slowly. "Every true smith knows it, and every empire forgets it. The work is not the metal. The work is the *agreement*."

"Which is why the sword ignored Victor," said Phastos — quietly, but not quietly enough, and he knew it, and said it anyway. "It's not that he's unworthy. Worthiness is the hammer's gimmick. The sword just knows the difference between a hand that asks and a hand that takes."

Doom did not turn his head. "The Eternal is invited," he said, to the air, "to speculate about Doom's hands when his own have finished trembling over a moody letter-opener." But those nearest the armored king noted that he had opened the small book again; that he was looking at the screen, where a boy who could not be bought, copied, or commanded had just field-upgraded a borrowed god-weapon by *sharing*; and that his pen hovered a long time over the page without adding anything — which, from Doom, was the loudest fascination anyone had ever heard.

High above, Loki had draped himself over his seat-back in a full sulk, being consoled, appallingly, by Thor.

"He beat me," Loki said, "with a *knockoff*. Of *your* hammer. There are Lokis in infinite worlds, brother, and every one of us felt that. It travels. Indignity is quantum-entangled."

"Aye," said Thor, patting him with a hand like a friendly landslide, absolutely radiant. "And what a blow it was! Be of good cheer, brother — you were felled by the finest imitation of the finest weapon in all the realms, wielded by a most worthy dragon. Truly, there is no shame in it."

"Every word of that sentence was worse than the last."

The house lights began their end-of-chapter dim. The plinth with Ascalon's echo sank back into the floor — though several witnesses swore the blade's tone sounded once more, softly, toward the darkened screen, like a goodnight — and the great screen offered its final frozen frame, held long past comfort:

Grey fur. A wet black nose.

And teeth.

Text typed itself out beneath the image, one cold letter at a time, and then the dark took everything:

NEXT: THE FANGS THAT SLAY GODS FIND HIM.

In the workshop quarter, nobody moved for a while. It was Eitri who finally spoke, to no one in particular, in the tone of a man closing up his forge for the night.

"A sword that chooses. A hammer that consents. A boy who asks." The dwarf king shook his enormous head, and there was something almost like peace in it. "Whoever is arming that child, they are better smiths than all of us. I should like to shake their hands before this theatre is done with us."

"Assuming," said Stark, watching the teeth fade from the dark screen, "there's anything left of him to arm."

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Forging the First Ascalon* — Legendary; *Replica Mjolnir Loan* — Rare. The Legendary pull came with an unprecedented bonus: a tangible "echo" of Ascalon manifested on a plinth for the audience to examine — the second confirmed instance of the gacha interacting with the theatre directly, and the first time it has put an object in the room.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Ascalon is the dragon-slaying holy sword of Saint George — gifted to Issei by the Archangel Michael, meaning Heaven answered his oath against it with a *gift*. Issei used the gift's moment to ask nothing for himself, only that Asia be allowed to pray without pain; Michael granted it. Ascalon was integrated into the Boosted Gear (**[BLADE.]**) — re-forged in dragon-fire, an anti-dragon weapon that examined a dragon and chose to serve. Issei's cosmology contains a Norse pantheon, including its own Loki and Fenrir ("fangs that slay gods"); the gods there loaned Issei a dwarf-forged replica Mjolnir, blessed for his use, and his Transfer ability works on *objects* — ten boosts poured into the replica turned it giant and flattened that world's Loki. The Workshop Quarter's consensus finding: Issei's entire arsenal runs on consent (choosing sword, blessed hammer, partnered gauntlet) — it cannot be stolen, copied, or mass-produced.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** The Ascalon echo burned no one but ranked everyone: it teased Shuri's instruments, hummed once in fellowship for Eitri ("it let me read the maker's mark, not the work"),

moved Phastos ("a promise with an edge" — he refused to touch it), and *ignored* Doom entirely, which the room understood to be the most dangerous outcome available. Doom pronounced it "Adequate" and wrote in his private book: *Latveria possesses no dragon-forged blade; oversight.* Eitri's respect for Issei's unseen armorers is now total; he publicly contrasted the sword-that-chooses with his own "great mistake" that answered any hand. Stark has reclassified Issei from "weapon" to "outlet — universal power bus with legs." Thor is proprietary and delighted about the replica ("Accept no substitutes! Except this one substitute, which I hereby endorse!"); Loki is in a formal sulk over being beaten-by-proxy with a knockoff of his brother's hammer ("indignity is quantum-entangled").

- **Unresolved Hooks:** The pull was titled the *First Ascalon* — implying more Ascalons to come. During the Loki battle the gacha kept its frame suspiciously tight and *refused to focus* on a white, winged blur at the edge of the fight — the audience suspects Albion's wielder and notes the gacha is now actively curating what they see. The exhibit-echo sank back into the floor: is the gacha building a museum, and why? Heaven's true motive in arming the dragon remains debated (gift, containment, or both — Strange suspects both). And the chapter closed on a freeze-frame of Fenrir's god-slaying teeth with the caption "NEXT: THE FANGS THAT SLAY GODS FIND HIM" — the theatre has been promised, in writing, that the boy is about to be bitten.

Chapter Seventeen: Fenrir's Teeth

Primary Reaction Groups: Asgardians (Thor, Loki, Sif, Valkyrie, Heimdall) • Mutants (Wolverine) • Healers (Night Nurse, Elixir, Doctor Strange)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Fenrir's Ambush" — **Super Rare**
 2. "Ravel's Ledger" — **Rare**
-

Wolverine knew before the lights did.

The theatre was still warm from the forge chapter — Eitri and Shuri were two rows apart and three hours deep into an argument about holy-sword lattice structures, Thor was re-enacting the replica Mjolnir loan for anyone who would hold his horn, and Loki was still sulking about it with the committed elegance of a man who intended to sulk professionally. It was a good night. It had been a good night for almost an hour.

Then Logan's head came up, slow, the way it did in forests.

"Someone's about to bleed," he said, to nobody.

The lights went storm-grey. Empires braced. The wheel came down out of the impossible ceiling without any of its usual showmanship, rings turning heavy and deliberate, and dropped its token into the crystal bowl with a sound less like a chime and more like a tooth hitting a plate.

PULL ONE: FENRIR'S AMBUSH — SUPER RARE.

Every Asgardian in the theatre stopped moving at the same time.

"That is a name," said Heimdall quietly, golden eyes fixed on the dark screen, "that should not travel between worlds."

The screen opened on mountain air. Northern Japan, canon-side: a summit ground ringed in wards, banners of the Underworld hanging beside older, stranger sigils, devils and gods attempting the most dangerous act in any cosmology — peace, catered.

And there, holding court at the center of it, was an old man with one eye, a white river of beard, a wide-brimmed hat, and an aura the gacha helpfully rated **ALLFATHER-CLASS**.

The Asgardian rows leaned forward as one, reverent, ready to behold a mirror of their own dread majesty.

The old man on screen was, at that moment, attempting to sneak away from the negotiations to visit what he cheerfully described as "an establishment of the flesh," and being dragged back by the ear by his own bodyguard.

"No," said Sif.

"Their Allfather," said Valkyrie, delighted beyond words, "is a *dirty old man*."

"Their Allfather is a dirty old man with an *expense account*," corrected the bodyguard on screen — a young valkyrie in white-and-blue armor, silver hair to her waist, radiating the specific fury of the criminally underpaid. Her name, the gacha noted, was **ROSSWEISSE**. She was, in rapid succession: cataloguing the old god's receipts, lamenting that battle valkyries received no retirement plan, and telling a bemused Issei Hyoudou that everything she owned came from hundred-yen shops and she was *proud* of it, and then bursting into tears about it, which rather undercut the proud part.

"I like her," announced Valkyrie, pouring. "Underpaid, over-armored, screaming at management. That's the whole sisterhood in one woman."

Then the sky went wrong.

It happened the way weather happens — no entrance, only a change of pressure. The wards over the summit ground frosted. The banners stopped moving. And down out of the bruised air came a figure in pale robes, silver-haired, beautiful the way a knife is beautiful, smiling the smile of a man who has rehearsed being hated.

LOKI, said the gacha. **EVIL GOD OF THE NORTH. STATUS: UNINVITED.**

Every eye in the theatre swiveled to the Trickster's seat.

"Don't," said Loki — Marvel's Loki — without looking away from the screen. His voice was flat in a way it almost never allowed itself to be. "Whatever you are all about to say. Don't."

The Loki on screen spread his arms and *monologued*. He objected to the peace. He objected to gods sitting at tables with devils. He said the word "Ragnarök" the way some men say the name of a woman who left them. And then, having explained his entire motive, position, and schedule to his assembled enemies, he put two fingers to his lips and whistled for his son.

The mountain answered.

It came up over the ridge like the ridge had grown it — a wolf the size of a house, grey as the underside of a glacier, moving with a wrongness the eye kept refusing: it did not seem to cross the distance between places so much as decline to acknowledge it. Its eyes were two setting moons. And its teeth—

The gacha, which annotated its highest rarities, wrote it across the sky in letters of ice:

FENRIR. FANGS RATED: CONCEPTUAL. FUNCTION: THE DEATH OF GODS. NO KNOWN EXCEPTIONS.

"...Aye," said Thor, very quietly, all the horn-swagger gone out of him. "That is the shape. That is the very shape of it."

On screen, the summit's defenders moved — and so did a boy in red armor. Scale Mail flared crimson against the frost; the borrowed replica of a hammer hummed in his gauntlets, thunder on loan; the green gem pulsed its steady heartbeat.

[BOOST.]

The wolf looked at him the way a lifetime looks at an afternoon.

[BOOST.]

"Partner," said Ddraig, and the theatre had learned to read that voice through stone and centuries, and what was in it now was fear. **"This creature was made to end things like gods. You are not yet a thing like a god. Do not let it touch you."**

"Kinda planning on that," Issei said, and moved.

The fight was brief, and it was not a fight. It was a demonstration with interruptions. Issei transferred stacked boosts into the hammer and split the sky; the wolf was elsewhere. Sif was narrating under her breath in the audience — *watch the hindquarters, watch the — no, it doesn't telegraph, it doesn't telegraph* — and the summit's assembled powers hurled everything a pantheon and half an Underworld could hurl, and the grey shape flowed through all of it like a rumor.

Then the wolf fainted at the old god.

It was a lie, and it was aimed at exactly one person on that field — the person guaranteed to answer it. Issei saw the moons swing toward the one-eyed old man and the silver-haired valkyrie planting herself in front of her terrible boss with her spear up and her eyes wide, and he did the thing the theatre had watched him do for sixteen chapters, the thing that made him *him*, the thing the wolf had been counting on.

He put himself in between.

The jaws came from an angle that was not an angle. There was no arc to track, no shadow, no sound until the sound, and the sound was Scale Mail — armor that shrugged off mountain-erasing blasts — parting like wet paper.

The theatre came out of its seats.

The screen did not flinch and did not gloat. It showed the fangs going in through the crimson chest-plate and it showed the points of them coming out through the back of the armor, and it showed the boy's body seize around the bite, and it let the audience hear, very clearly, over the screaming of a girl named Asia somewhere off-frame:

[WARNING. VITAL DAMAGE. VITAL DAMAGE. PARTNER — WARNING.]

"PARTNER!" Ddraig's roar shook two worlds and a theatre.

And Issei Hyoudou, with the death of gods buried to the gum-line in his torso, coughed red inside his helmet, got one hand turned around on the haft of the borrowed hammer, and said — wetly, horribly, *cheerfully*—

"Gotcha. You're in range now, doggy."

The point-blank thunderclap lifted the wolf off its feet.

It was the first time in the entire engagement that anything had moved Fenrir even an inch, and it bought exactly one thing: the jaws opened. The boy dropped out of them. The armor peeled away in dissolving motes of red light, and what was underneath made the healers' section of the theatre go silent in the specific way of professionals doing arithmetic they hate.

The gacha did not linger on the wound. It lingered on the faces around the wound, which was worse.

Asia Argento reached him first, both hands already pouring green light, Twilight Healing at full desperate flood — and the theatre watched the wound *drink* the light and stay open. Fangs made to unmake gods did not respect the healing of heaven. The green light poured and poured and the dark kept welling up through it, and Asia's voice climbed into a register that several hundred hardened heroes would hear in their sleep.

And then a small, imperious, furious voice cut through it like a letter opener.

"Move. *Move!* Weep on your own time — do you want him to die while you water him?!"

She came through the smoke at a dead sprint in a dress utterly unsuited to a battlefield, blonde hair in two ringlet drills, hem soaked dark, carrying a flat velvet case the way soldiers carry ammunition. She could not have been more than fourteen. She hit her knees in the mud beside the dying boy, snapped the case open on a row of crystal vials, and went to work.

RAVEL PHENEX, said the gacha. **HOUSE PHENEX. FOURTH DAUGHTER. THE FIRE OF RENEWAL.**

"Phenex," murmured Doctor Strange, sitting forward. "As in—"

"As in the roast chicken," said someone from the cheap seats, because the theatre remembered Riser Phenex, the immortal arrogance Issei had punched out of an engagement, and the theatre held grudges. "That's the little sister."

The little sister was performing field trauma medicine with the composure of a career anesthesiologist. Phoenix Tears — the gacha priced them, and the number had commas in alarming places — went into the wound not in a panicked flood but in *sequence*: the great rent first, then each fang puncture individually, her thumb finding them by count, her voice a steady metronome of instructions to devils three times her age. Flame the color of dawn crawled through the wounds and where it passed, flesh remembered itself. If some of the moisture hitting the mixture was salt and came from her eyes, her hands never acknowledged it, and neither did she.

The boy breathed. Shuddered, rattled, and breathed.

"Honestly," Ravel Phenex said, to the unconscious near-corpse of Issei Hyoudou, in the tone of a woman reviewing a subordinate's expense report, "the *state* of you."

The pull wound down in fragments: the evil god sealed under a hammerblow fat with transferred boosts; the summit saved; the great wolf dragged from the field in restraints by figures the gacha — deliberately, visibly — refused to focus on, a smear of censored light in which, for one frame, something glinted *white*. The Watcher's head tilted at that. So did Loki's.

The last image before the pause was small. Ravel, in the torchlight of the aftermath, bloody to the elbows, taking a little book out of the velvet case where the vials had been, and writing in it with a hand that shook, and then — line by line — stopped shaking.

The lights came up.

Thor did not boom. That was how the theatre knew.

He stood with his horn hanging forgotten from one hand, and when he spoke it was in the register he saved for barrows and brothers.

"We have one," he said. "Understand this, all of you. In our sky, under our branches — we have one. Fenris the wolf, who is promised the Allfather's life when the last day comes. We could not kill ours either. We bound him — and do you know what held him, when chains of iron and uru failed? A *ribbon*. Gleipnir. Woven of the sound of a cat's footfall, the roots of a mountain, the breath of a fish, the beard of

a woman, the spittle of a bird — impossible things, because only the impossible holds a thing whose teeth are an argument against gods." He looked around the theatre, and his face was old. "And now I learn that a sky we have never touched, gods we have never met, grew the *same wolf*. The same shape. The same teeth. As if every heaven, wherever it rises, builds its own ending — and gives it fur."

"I have watched our wolf sleep for nine centuries," said Heimdall. "I know those teeth the way a man knows the crack in his own ceiling. When the boy stepped in front of them, I looked away. I have never looked away."

"It never telegraphed," Sif said. She was still watching the frozen screen, professional and pale. "I have fought beside thunder my whole life and I am telling you that animal was not fast. Fast is a quality of moving through space. That thing had an *exemption*."

"And it was wasted," said Loki.

He rose. He brushed his sleeve. The theatre braced for silk and got, instead, ice.

"Let us review my counterpart's masterwork," he said. "He objected to a peace — not a scheme, note, a *tantrum with a pantheon attached*. He arrived uninvited, announced his name, his grievance, and functionally his itinerary, to an audience of his assembled enemies. Where I come from that is not called a plot. That is called a *confession*. And then—" and here something moved under the silk of his voice that the nearest rows would argue about for chapters "—then he whistled, and spent his own son like a coin. You will hear it said in my world, in the old poems they insist upon, that the wolf is *my* child. So take it from the man with standing: a father who files his son's teeth into a key for murdering old men has surrendered every claim to cleverness. A knife does not get to be proud of the hand that grips it — but the hand does not get to be proud of itself either."

"Compassion, brother?" Thor said, wondering.

"Taxonomy," said Loki, sitting. But his eyes had already gone back to the screen — not to the wolf, the nearest observers noted, but to the *restraints* being fitted over it in the censored smear of the final frames. Somewhere in that other cosmology existed a leash rated for a god-killer. Loki's expression filed that away in the drawer marked *unexplored categories*, alongside a certain green gem, and closed softly.

From the high dark of the monster galleries, Fin Fang Foom rumbled once: "Wolves. Dogs that unionized." And said nothing further, which for Foom was a eulogy.

They turned to Logan eventually. They always did when there was a wolf in it.

He was at the back with his boots on the seat in front of him and a beer he had threatened someone to obtain, and he let the silence sit until it was done squirming.

"First thing," he said. "Don't put this on the animal. The wolf's a weapon somebody grew. It didn't choose the teeth, didn't choose the leash, didn't choose the target. You wanna be angry — and you should be — you look at the hand holding the rope. Same as always." He took a pull of the beer. "Me and Frank got a list. The bird-girl with the light spear's on it. The wolf ain't. The guy who *whistled* is."

"And the second thing?" asked Night Nurse, because somebody had to.

Logan was quiet a moment.

"Everything that can't die has a door built into it somewhere," he said. "I heal from damn near anything. There's still a sword, back home, made just to turn that off. One thing in all the world with my name on it. That's the tax on being hard to kill — the universe keeps one key cut for you, special." He nodded at the screen, at the frozen frame of grey fur and moonlight eyes. "Their gods' key has four legs. Kid found out his door has teeth. He'll never walk the same after knowing that. Nobody does."

"He swung the hammer," said Elixir — Josh Foley, golden-skinned, the X-Men's living cure, who had been sitting very still through all of it. "The teeth were still *in* him and he swung the hammer."

"Yeah," Logan said. "That's the part." He looked at the kid healer, and for a second the six people close enough to see his face saw the thing he almost never let out of the basement — recognition, the kind that costs. "You want to know what that takes? Not strength. Strength's the first thing that leaves when you're bit that deep. All that's left is deciding you're not done. Most people never find out if they've got it, and they're the lucky ones." He settled back. "Kid's got it. I hate that he's gonna need it."

Strange had his fingers steepled, surgeon's habit, eyes half-closed over the replay he was running behind them. "Four punctures and a crush injury crossing everything a torso keeps important," he said clinically. "In my operating days I'd have called it unsurvivable and been right. And the divine healing *failed* — that's the detail that should frighten this room. Wounds from those fangs resist restoration the way the wolf resists distance; the injury itself carries the concept. Which makes what the girl did—" he opened his eyes "—not a miracle. A *protocol*. Sequenced application, punctures triaged by depth, dosage rationed under fire. I held hands steady for a living. Hers are steadier at fourteen than mine were at forty."

"And can we discuss," said Night Nurse, in the dangerous voice of a woman who had spent decades stitching heroes in a back room for free, "the part where healing in that world comes in a *bottle*, with a *price*, set by a *noble house*? Total restoration as a supply chain. Miracle as commodity. I've bandaged half this theatre on donations and stubbornness, and that little girl was carrying more medicine in one velvet case than I move in a year, and it's all *proprietary*."

"FINALLY," said Mephisto, from the villains' section, wiping away a sincere red tear, "someone in that cosmology understands product."

"Sit down," said seven people at once.

But Elixir was still looking at the paused screen, at the small blonde figure bloody to the elbows, and he said, quietly, to no one who'd asked: "She didn't ration the last three vials. Check the case at the end of the pull. She emptied it. Whatever those cost — she emptied it."

The wheel, which had been listening — it listened now; the theatre had not forgotten that it listened — began to spin.

PULL TWO: RAVEL'S LEDGER — RARE.

The vision opened on peacetime, days later, and on a book.

It was a serious book. Leather-bound, brass-cornered, four silk ribbons, tabs in five colors. It lived under the arm of Ravel Phenex the way Excalibur lived at Faiza's knee, and the gacha — with what could only be called professional respect — gave it a full itemized overlay.

SECTION I: INJURIES. Date. Cause. Severity, on a ten-grade scale of her own devising, recently and grimly recalibrated so that the Fenrir bite could define the top. Treatment administered. Recovery time projected versus actual — *versus actual*, because she followed up. Recurrence risk. And at the bottom of the section, carried forward page after page, a running total of near-death events that made the theatre inhale as one.

"That number's wrong," said Peter Parker, from the street-level rows. "Tell me that number's wrong."

The number was not wrong. The number had an *audit trail*.

SECTION II: EXPENDITURES. Training equipment, destroyed, itemized, with depreciation schedules. Food, graphed, with a trend line that Volstagg saluted. Clothing destroyed by Balance Breaker transformations, tracked to the yen, with a marginal note reading *investigate flame-retardant uniform contract — bulk rate?*

SECTION III: DEBTS & FAVORS. Who owed Issei Hyoudou, and what, and since when. Whom Issei owed. A footnote in small fierce handwriting: *favours compound*. On screen, Issei told a shopkeeper "I owe you one!" and Ravel materialized beside him like a summoned spirit of accountancy, saying, "Define 'one.' In writing."

SECTION IV: PROMISES. Every promise he made, dated, witnessed, status-tracked. *To protect Asia Argento — Status: PERPETUAL. Non-negotiable. No expiry. To repay Rias Gremory for his life — Status: ONGOING; see all other sections. To become Harem King — Status: OUTSTANDING. Feasibility review: quarterly.* The theatre laughed at the last one. Some of the theatre noticed she had never once marked it *implausible*, and stopped laughing thoughtfully.

And then the gacha turned, on its own, to the newest page, and let it fill the sky.

INJURY: FENRIR (F-GRADE — SCALE CEILING, REVISED). Treatment: Phoenix Tears, six vials, full case. Market value: a number with commas in alarming places, multiplied by six. And the cost column — struck through. One line, in that small fierce hand:

Drawn from personal reserve. Charged: nothing. He is not to be told.

And beneath it, in the margin, smaller still, where she had plainly believed no one would ever read it:

The tears erase the scars, so no one remembers what it costs him to keep being who he is. Someone must keep the account. The ledger will not forget, even when his body is made to.

The theatre was quiet for a moment, in the way of people rebalancing an opinion.

Then Pepper Potts stood up.

"I want it minuted," Pepper said, "that I called it first. That is the most competent person we have seen in seventeen chapters of either universe."

"She's *fourteen*," said Tony.

"She reconciles *daily*, Tony. She has recurrence-risk columns. She tracks projected-versus-actual recovery — versus *actual*, Tony, she *follows up* — and she maintains a depreciation schedule for a teenage boy's gym clothes." Pepper's eyes had the specific light of a chief operating officer beholding, across an unbridgeable dimensional gulf, a peer. "She negotiated her own family's product at cost and then didn't charge him and hid it in the notation. That's not bookkeeping. That's *governance*."

"I feel personally attacked," Tony announced.

"You should," said Pepper and Rhodey together.

"I have an AI for this. I have several AIs for this—"

"You have several AIs for this," Pepper said, "because no human being could survive doing for you, by hand, what that child does for him *by choice*. She is running the back office of a one-boy natural disaster with a fountain pen."

Sue Storm was nodding slowly from the Baxter rows, and when Sue Storm nods slowly, veterans check their exits. "I've been the ledger for four superhumans and a building for fifteen years," she said. "Grants, insurance, property damage, school forms, Reed's patents — Reed once filed our entire insurance situation under 'solved' and moved on. Nobody ever *sees* that work. It's only visible when it fails, and hers never will." She looked across the aisle at Pepper, and something passed between them, treaty-shaped. "The girl has my respect. Formally."

"Formally," Pepper agreed.

"Oh no," said Tony. "They're founding something. Rhodey, they're founding something."

"The Committee," said Sue and Pepper, simultaneously and without consultation, which was the most frightening thing the theatre had witnessed all chapter, wolf included.

Mephisto leaned over the villain rail, avuncular, smoldering gently. "Ladies. That ledger is the finest instrument of obligation I have seen produced by mortal hands. Sections Three and Four alone — the *enforceable promises* of a boy purchased for eight Pawns? I'd trade three midwestern souls just to hold the—"

"They're not contracts," said Pepper, without turning around. "They're care."

Mephisto sat back. His smile stayed; his eyes did the arithmetic again and did not like the remainder. "...Worse," he murmured, to himself, in the tone of a man watching his thesis confirm itself unprofitably. "Priceless things ruin markets."

Night Nurse said, to the healers around her, "Every patient in this theatre should have one of her. I've been saying it for years: the chart is half the medicine."

"Kid'll outlive all of us," Logan said, from the back, boots still up. "Not because of the bird tears." He tipped the last of the beer at the screen, at the small figure with the serious book. "Because somebody's keeping score for him."

The lights began their end-of-chapter dim. The screen, unprompted, turned the ledger back to Section I — and let the running total of injuries sit there in the dark, and then, gently, horribly, tick upward by one as some off-screen training accident was appended in real time, the fountain pen scratching somewhere beyond the frame.

"...What does the doubling cost him?" Bruce Banner asked softly, in the front third, not really meaning to say it aloud. "Every ten seconds, double. Bodies aren't ledgers. Where does the debit go?"

Above them all, the great wheel — which listened, it *listened* — turned one soft click on its own, like a promise being scheduled.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Fenrir's Ambush* — Super Rare; *Ravel's Ledger* — Rare. The wheel's end-of-chapter click in response to Banner's question is the second confirmed instance of the gacha reacting directly to the audience.

- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's cosmology contains its own Norse pantheon — an Allfather-class (and shamelessly lecherous) Odin, a petulant evil-god Loki, and a Fenrir whose fangs are conceptual god-killers that even Scale Mail cannot stop and divine healing cannot mend. Issei was mortally wounded shielding others and survived only via House Phenex's Phoenix Tears — bottled, commodified, market-priced healing. Ravel Phenex keeps an exacting ledger of Issei's injuries (with a running near-death total), expenditures, debts, and witnessed promises; she secretly paid for his six-vial resurrection from her personal reserve ("He is not to be told"). The captured wolf was hauled away by figures the gacha itself censored — one frame glinted *white*.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Pepper Potts and Sue Storm formally extend respect to Ravel and found "the Committee"; Tony Stark, personally attacked, is privately designing her a tablet. Marvel's Loki publicly disowns his counterpart's crudeness and cruelty-to-offspring — while quietly adding "a leash rated for a god-killer" to his unexplored categories. Wolverine claims kinship with Issei's survive-and-swing instinct and rules the wolf blameless, the whistler culpable (the Raynare list stands; DxD-Loki joins it in spirit). Valkyrie adopts Rossweisse as an honorary sister-in-arms. Night Nurse endorses the ledger as medicine; Elixir is unsettled by healing-as-commodity; Mephisto's "Issei is priceless" thesis is reinforced against his own financial interest.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Who took Fenrir off the field — and why did the gacha censor a *white* glint (see Chapter 13: Albion's unknown wielder)? Where is the leash that held a god-killer, and how long before Loki asks? Ravel's secret expenditure remains unknown to Issei. Wolverine's warning stands: every unkillable thing has a door, and Issei now knows his has teeth. And Banner's question — *where does the debit of Boosting go?* — has been scheduled by the wheel itself. The next bill is the power's own price.

Chapter Eighteen: The Price of Boosting

Primary Reaction Groups: Bruce Banner • The Sentry • Cosmic Mentors (Eternals, the Watcher)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Boost over Limit Consequences" — **Rare**
 2. "Exhaustion Collapse" — **Common**
-

The theatre had learned to read its own weather, and tonight the weather was wrong.

Not storm-grey, which meant death. Not gold, which meant Thor pouring. Tonight the lights came up white — flat, sourceless, even white, the white of a corridor outside an operating room at three in the morning. Nobody was drinking. Several people who had been talking stopped without knowing why, the way conversations die in hospitals.

Ravel Phenex's ledger had done that. The previous chapter had ended with a small girl in curls itemizing a boy's injuries in immaculate script, and the theatre had gone home — insofar as prisoners go home — with the uneasy sense that they had been shown the index of a book they had not yet been made to read.

Tonight the book opened.

The gacha wheel descended without ceremony for once, rings turning slow and deliberate, like a surgeon laying out instruments. It clicked. It stopped. The token fell into the crystal bowl with a sound less like a wineglass and more like a coin dropped on a steel tray.

PULL ONE: BOOST OVER LIMIT CONSEQUENCES — RARE.

"Consequences," said Bruce Banner, very quietly, from the seat he always chose — aisle-adjacent, sight lines to two exits that did not exist. He had a paper cup of tea the theatre kept refilling whether he asked or not. He set it down. "Okay. Okay. There it is."

Three rows back and forty seats to the left — because he always sat forty seats from everyone, by unspoken mutual arrangement — Robert Reynolds went very still, golden and luminous and trying not to be, like a lighthouse attempting to slouch.

The screen did not open on a battle. It opened on a chalkboard.

That was the gacha's little joke, and nobody laughed. A schoolroom in Kuoh, empty, after hours, and Issei Hyoudou at the board with Ddraig's gem glowing on his manifested gauntlet, writing numbers with the squeaky, effortful penmanship of a boy for whom mathematics had historically been an enemy nation.

"Okay," on-screen Issei said. "So. Boost doubles me. Every ten seconds. So after ten seconds I'm two-me. Then four-me. Then eight-me—"

"**Correct so far,**" said Ddraig, in the tone of a tutor whose student has surprised him by showing up.

"—and there's no cap. You said no cap. So if I just stand there boosting for, like, five minutes, I'm—" squeak, squeak, scratch — "—a *billion*-me? That can't be right. Ddraig, am I secretly a billion-me?"

"**The Gear has no ceiling, partner,**" the dragon said, and there was something in the old voice that the theatre, which had grown fluent in Ddraig, recognized at once and did not like. Care. Care of the kind that precedes bad news. "**You have a ceiling. The Gear will double whatever you are, as many times as you ask. It will never once ask whether the vessel can hold it. That question falls to your bones. Your blood. Your heart, which is a fist-sized muscle and not a metaphor. The previous wielders—**"

"The previous wielders what?"

A pause, on-screen and in the theatre.

"**Ask me again when you are older,**" said Ddraig, and the memory folded, and the real pull began.

It was a fight the theatre had not seen before — a night engagement, a churned and cratered field under a shattered barrier, the Gremory peerage scattered and bleeding across it, an enemy at the far end whom the gacha kept deliberately out of focus, because the enemy was not the point. The point was the boy in the middle distance, on his knees, one arm sheathed in red.

The point was the number over his head.

The gacha had never done this before: a diagnostic overlay, cold green, hovering above the vision like the readout of a machine that had no opinion about what it measured.

[BOOST COUNT: 9. OUTPUT: 512× BASELINE. VESSEL INTEGRITY: 71%.]

[BOOST.]

[BOOST COUNT: 10. OUTPUT: 1,024× BASELINE. VESSEL INTEGRITY: 64%.]

"Oh," said Beast, softly, into the white light. "Oh, it's showing us the *invoice*."

On-screen, Issei got up. That was all — he got up, which the theatre had watched him do in twelve chapters the way other heroes threw punches, and this time the overlay made them feel every degree of it. At 1,024 times himself, the power came off him in visible pressure, tearing the crater rim, and the capillaries in his left eye let go all at once, flooding the white with red.

[BOOST.]

[VESSEL INTEGRITY: 55%. ADVISORY: SAFE THRESHOLD EXCEEDED.]

"Partner." Ddraig's voice, low, urgent, meant for one person and heard by a multiverse. **"Your body is answering questions it was not built to be asked. Two more and your forearm fractures under its own aura. Four more and I cannot promise your heart."**

"Asia's still behind me," Issei said. His voice was wet. "Rias is still behind me. So."

[BOOST.]

[VESSEL INTEGRITY: 46%.]

"So," he said again, and smiled with red teeth, and the theatre — gods, monsters, kings, and killers — sat in a silence with texture to it.

[BOOST.]

[VESSEL INTEGRITY: 38%. ADVISORY REPEATS. ADVISORY REPEATS.]

And then he did the thing that broke the room, which was: he didn't use it. Four thousand and ninety-six times himself, arm hairline-cracking, one eye blind with blood — and the boy turned, found Rias Gremory across the field, and gave it all away.

[TRANSFER.]

The power left him like a tide leaving a harbor, and the screen split its attention with terrible economy: on one side, crimson annihilation arriving downrange, the out-of-focus enemy simply ending; on the other side, the invoice coming due. Issei Hyoudou folded at the knees. Vomited blood into the churned dirt, once, twice, with the horrible businesslike rhythm of someone who has done this before. Tried to catch himself on the left arm and found the left arm no longer accepting instructions. Went down face-first, and did not move, and the overlay printed its last line without emphasis, without cruelty, without anything at all:

[VESSEL INTEGRITY: 31%. WIELDER NONRESPONSIVE. BOOST RESET. DURATION OF INCAPACITY: 4 DAYS, 7 HOURS.]

The vision held on him for a long moment — small, face-down, steam rising off the gauntlet — and the last sound before the lights came up was Ddraig, alone in a boy's unconscious dark, saying, to no one who could hear him:

"You counted past ten again, partner. You always count past ten."

The theatre lights rose on a room that did not want to talk, which had never once stopped it.

"Somebody check the math," said Sam Wilson, finally, from the Avengers block. "Somebody who isn't me. Because I've been assuming — I think we've all been assuming — that the doubling thing was, y'know. The cheat code. The 'give him ten minutes and he beats anybody' button."

"The math checks," said Bruce Banner.

He hadn't stood up. Banner never stood up if he could help it; standing up was how things started. But the theatre had learned that when the quiet man with the tea spoke, you let him, because there was an eleven-foot appendix to everything he said.

"I've been running it since chapter one," he went on, in the mild, apologetic voice of a man defusing himself as he spoke. "It's a clean exponential. Doubling every ten seconds is six doublings a minute — that's sixty-four-fold in the first minute. Two minutes, four thousand and ninety-six. Three minutes, a quarter million. Five minutes—" he turned his cup a quarter-turn on the armrest, "—five minutes is a billion, the kid had it right on the chalkboard, give or take. There is no fighter in this room, there is no *being* in this room, you couldn't theoretically out-scale with five uninterrupted minutes and a stopwatch. That's what the Gear is. That's what everyone here has been quietly afraid of since the tutorial."

"I detect an 'and,'" said Doctor Strange, from the mystic tiers.

"And you just saw the denominator," Banner said. "The Gear multiplies. It doesn't *carry*. Every doubling is written to a sixteen-year-old body — human-baseline until recently, low-tier devil now — with a sixteen-year-old's blood vessels and a sixteen-year-old's heart. The power has no ceiling, so the ceiling has to come from somewhere, and you all watched where it comes from. It comes from him hitting the ground." He looked at the dark screen, and his voice stayed exactly as level, which was its own kind of alarming. "It's not a cheat code. It's a loan structure. He can borrow any amount — literally any amount, that's the horror of it — and the collateral is always the same. It's him. The interest rate is *meat*."

"Then he requires discipline," Doom said flatly, from his aisle. "A regimen. Limits imposed from without, since the Gear imposes none. Doom sees an engineering problem."

"Yeah, see, I want to agree with you," Banner said. "I'd love this to be an engineering problem. But you saw the trigger. Everybody saw the trigger." He counted it off, gently, on his fingers. "*Asia's still behind me. Rias is still behind me. So.* His output isn't indexed to training, Victor. It's indexed to how much he loves the people in the blast radius. The power scales with feeling. The cost lands on the body. The decision runs through willpower. That's the whole machine."

He stopped. The theatre waited, because everyone — everyone — knew what was coming, and knew he knew, and there was a kind of courtesy in letting him choose to say it.

"I know that machine," Bruce Banner said. "I've been living in that machine since the gamma range. Power that answers emotion. You never get to be strong on schedule; you get to be strong when it *hurts*, because hurting is the ignition. The difference — " and here, for one second, the mildness flickered, not toward green, just toward tired — "the difference is that my curse protects the body it rides in. Whatever else the other guy is, I wake up whole. It costs me everything except tissue. That kid's version costs *tissue first*. He's got my throttle and none of my armor. He is doing, voluntarily, over and over, with a smile, the thing I have spent my entire adult life building cages to prevent." He picked his tea back up. "So no. Not a cheat code. From where I'm sitting, it's the most expensive power in the building."

The white light hummed. And then a voice said, "It's not, though."

Heads turned. Forty seats from anyone, gold against the velvet, Robert Reynolds had spoken without standing, both hands flat on his knees like a man keeping them where he could see them.

"Sorry," Bob said. "Sorry. It's — Bruce, it's not the most expensive power in the building. Mine is. And that's — that's actually what I need everyone to understand about what we just watched, because you're all looking at the blood, and the blood is not the scary part."

Nobody heckled. When the Sentry was frightened, the theatre had discovered, fear observed a food chain.

"The power of a million exploding suns," Bob said, "runs on the same fuel his does. Will. Feeling. Belief. That's the tank. And everyone thinks the danger of a power like that is *running out* — that the fragile psyche fails, and the power sputters, and down you go. That's backwards. That's so backwards." His hands pressed flatter on his knees. "The danger is that the power *learns the route*. It learns that fear opens the tap. It learns that grief opens it wider. It learns which of your feelings are load-bearing, and then — and I need you to hear this — then it starts *having opinions about your feelings*. It wants the tap open. It will arrange for the tap to be open. And a boy whose strength doubles when the people he loves are in danger is a boy whose strength has a *vested interest in his loved ones being in danger*, and he will never see it coming, because it will feel exactly like love."

Silence. Banner had turned all the way around in his seat.

"His body says no at thirty-one percent," Bob said. "Okay. Bodies are honest. But what happens on the day the power finds a way around the body? A power with no ceiling, wired to a heart with no off switch — that doesn't stay a boy breaking himself forever. One day that's a door. And things come through doors." He looked up at the dead screen, and asked it, directly, the way one asks a thing one suspects is listening: "What's behind his?"

And the screen — which had been dark, between pulls, dormant — flickered.

One line. White text. A tenth of a second too long to be an accident:

**[QUERY ACKNOWLEDGED. RELATED FILE LOCATED: ██████████ DRIVE.
CLASSIFICATION: FORBIDDEN. THIS PULL IS NOT YET AVAILABLE.]**

The theatre did not gasp. The theatre had, by chapter eighteen, exhausted its gasps. What moved through the tiers instead was worse: the low, many-throated sound of ten thousand apex predators updating a threat model at the same time.

"It heard him," said Faiza Hussain, from the MI-13 rows. "It's still doing the thing where it hears us."

"RED WEATHER file," said Pete Wisdom, hollowly, producing the folder. "Reopening. New annotation: *storm warning*."

Bob Reynolds put his face in his hands, gold light leaking between the fingers, and Bruce Banner did something he had done for no other being in the theatre: he got up, crossed forty seats' worth of no-man's-land, and sat down next to him. He didn't say anything. Two men who understood the machine sat side by side, and the wheel, tactful as a headsman, began to spin again.

PULL TWO: EXHAUSTION COLLAPSE — COMMON.

"Common," said Hank McCoy, and his voice came out strange. "Colleagues — apologies, one moment — the taxonomy matters here. The gacha grades by *frequency*. Mythic happened once. Rare happens seldom." He took off his glasses. "It is telling us that what we are about to see is *ordinary*. That in the life of this child, this is weather."

It was a montage, and it was worse than the battle.

Issei face-down on the Gremory garden grass after the ten-day training, hauled up the stairs by Koneko with the neutral efficiency of a girl carrying firewood. Issei collapsing mid-sentence at a victory party, mid-laugh, blood at his nose, caught by Kiba before his head hit the table, and the terrible detail was that nobody at the party screamed — they had a *procedure*. Cushions appeared. Asia's hands were already glowing. Someone kept the music on so his parents downstairs wouldn't worry.

Issei after a stray-devil hunt, paying the invoice in an alley, one arm braced on a wall, waving off the concern of his own shadow. Issei transferring power to Koneko's fist, to Akeno's lightning, to Rias's annihilation, and every Transfer ending the same way — the tide leaving the harbor, the knees folding, the small businesslike apology as he went down: "sorry — gimme ten — I'm good—"

He was never good in ten.

The gacha cut to the infirmary at Kuoh Academy, and then to the Hyoudou household, and then to a page — a single, immaculate page in handwriting the theatre had learned the previous chapter, curls of gilt ink, Phenex letterhead:

Collapse log, current term. Post-Transfer syncope: 9. Over-boost hemorrhage: 4. Days unconscious (cumulative): 22. Note: subject describes this as "a normal amount." Note appended: it is not a normal amount. — R.P.

And then the last vision, and the gacha let it linger, because it had learned the room and knew exactly where the nerve was: night, Issei's own bedroom, the boy unconscious for the third day, grey and small under the blankets. Asia Argento asleep in the chair beside him, healing rings still faintly circling her hands even in sleep, because she had trained herself to heal him unconscious. And in the dark, the gem in the half-manifest gauntlet glowing like a banked ember — Ddraig keeping the watch he always kept.

"They think you do not hear me when you are like this," the dragon said quietly. "Perhaps you do not. It is easier to say if you do not. Every wielder I have had, partner — every one, for two thousand years — spent himself like this, in the beginning. Boosted past ten. Paid in blood, and laughed, and paid again. And every one of them, one day, found the place where the body stops saying no." The ember dimmed. "I have decided you will be the first I talk out of it. I have not yet decided how. Sleep, boy. Count to ten. Stop there. For an old dragon's sake — one day, stop there."

The screen went dark.

They came down from the cosmic tiers slowly, the way glaciers arrive: the Eternals, who had watched eighteen chapters mostly in the high seats, in the manner of people auditing a course they'd taught for centuries.

"We should say the quiet thing," said Sersi, "since no one else is equipped to. Every being in this room with real power falls into one of two designs. Either the cost is externalized" — she nodded, delicately, up toward the mezzanine where the Silver Surfer hung above his board — "paid by a star, a patron, a planet, a Machine. Or the vessel is engineered to the load. We were *built* to our output. Thor's frame was forged for Thor's lightning. The design principle of the entire cosmos is: *the container is rated for the*

contents." She looked at the screen. "That child is the first being I have ever seen whose design principle is *the container will simply agree to break*. His ceiling is not physics. His ceiling is however much self-destruction he will consent to. And you all watched his consent. It's *bottomless*."

"Then the analysis is short," said Ikaris, arms folded. "It doesn't sustain. Nothing built on that curve sustains. Doubling output against a linear body — he is a mortal running arbitrage against his own lifespan. Five years. I am being generous because the little healer is skilled."

"You are being *arithmetical*," said Thena, and there was an edge under the silk of it. "I have spent ten thousand years among warriors who ration themselves, who husband their strength, who survive. Do you know what they never do? *They never win the last war*. The ones who stand at the end are always, always the ones with the flaw in the ledger — the ones who will pay what sane beings won't. I watched a boy hand away four thousand times his own strength because his people were behind him, and you saw an actuarial problem. I saw the only kind of soldier who has ever mattered."

"He will still be dead in five years."

"Then he will have been *magnificent* for five years, and you and I will still be here, being rated for our contents." Thena sat back. "I find I know which I envy."

Ajak had said nothing, watching the dark screen with her hands folded, and when she spoke it was half to herself. "We keep asking whether it sustains. Perhaps the wrong question. The Celestials made us fixed — the same forever, safe forever, finished forever. That boy is *unfinished* in a way nothing we serve has ever permitted. A being whose limit is renegotiated every ten seconds by love and stubbornness." She smiled, faintly, troubled. "I cannot decide whether I am watching a tragedy or the early drafts of a god. I notice the theatre has odds on both."

High above them all, in the tier where no one else sat because nothing else fit, Uatu the Watcher held his silence, as was his oath and his habit. But he had watched a billion timelines, and in every single one, power indexed to self-destruction resolved in one of exactly two ways — the grave, or the monster — and he had never, not once, recorded a third ending.

He is in no timeline I hold, Uatu thought, and the thought had been unsettling for seventeen chapters and tonight, for the first time, it curved toward something almost like hope. *Which means his ending is not yet on file. Perhaps that is why we were all brought here. To watch a third ending get written.*

And far below, in the villains' dark, Mephisto laughed softly into his wine, alone among the horrified.

"Oh, you're all reading it upside down," he murmured, to nobody, to everybody. "You've just been shown the *provenance*. Eight Pawns for a boy who pays for power in blood and never misses a payment? Nothing priceless is free, children. The price is the proof."

The lights began their end-of-chapter dim. The last thing the screen showed was small: the collapse-log page again, Ravel's gilt ink — but the gacha had appended one line of its own beneath her tally, in cold system-white, and it let the theatre read it twice before dark:

[SUBJECT WILL COUNT PAST TEN AGAIN IN: 2 CHAPTERS.]

Banner exhaled. Bob Reynolds did not.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Boost over Limit Consequences* — Rare; *Exhaustion Collapse* — Common. The gacha debuted a cold diagnostic overlay (Boost count, output multiplier, "vessel integrity" percentage) — the theatre now sees the invoice, not just the fight. The Common rarity of his collapses landed harder than any battle: breaking himself is *routine* in Issei's life (Ravel's log: 22 days unconscious in a single term).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Boosted Gear has no ceiling — Issei's body is the only limiter, and his consent to break it is functionally bottomless; over-boosting and heavy Transfers cost hemorrhage, temporary paralysis, and days of unconsciousness ("nonresponsive: 4 days, 7 hours"). His output is indexed to emotion and willpower, not training. Ddraig confirmed every prior wielder "counted past ten" until they found "the place where the body stops saying no" — and has privately vowed Issei will be the first he talks out of it. In answer to the Sentry's direct question, the screen acknowledged a sealed file: ██████████ **DRIVE — CLASSIFICATION: FORBIDDEN.**
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Banner reclassifies Issei from "cheat code" to "the most expensive power in the building" — his own machine (emotion-throttled power) minus his armor — and publicly crossed the theatre to sit beside the Sentry, the first bond between the room's two walking cautionary tales. Sentry's fear reframed the threat: the danger isn't the power failing, it's the power *learning which feelings open the tap*. Eternals split — Ikaris gives him five years; Thena names him the only kind of soldier who ever mattered; Ajak can't tell tragedy from "early drafts of a god." Uatu privately entertains hope for a "third ending" he has never recorded. Mephisto reads the bloody price as provenance: proof the boy is priceless.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** What is the redacted, FORBIDDEN "██████████ DRIVE" — and is it the door the Sentry warned about, the place where the power routes around the body? The gacha is not just listening to the audience now; it *answers questions* and issues predictions: "**SUBJECT WILL COUNT PAST TEN AGAIN IN: 2 CHAPTERS.**" Ddraig has never yet found the "how"

of stopping him. And the theatre noticed Banner and the Sentry leaving together, talking quietly — the room's two doomsday machines comparing cage designs.

Chapter Nineteen: Dragon Pride

Primary Reaction Groups: Thor • Namor • Doctor Doom • The Ravagers (Yondu, Kraglin, Stakar Ogord)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Accepting a Duel Because of Pride" — **Rare**
 2. "Friends Restraining Him" — **Common**
-

The theatre had spent the previous chapter learning arithmetic.

That was how Bruce Banner had described it, anyway — quietly, to no one, while the screen tallied what every Boost actually cost the boy's body: torn muscle, burned reserves, a heart doing work it was never budgeted for. *The Price of Boosting* had not been an exciting chapter. It had been a ledger chapter, and the room had left it subdued, the way people leave a doctor's office holding a pamphlet.

So when the lights shifted tonight, the audience checked the weather out of habit — and found something new.

Not the storm-grey of tragedy. Not the buttery gold of comedy. The theatre had gone the deep, banked red of a forge left unattended. It was warm the way an open oven is warm: pleasant right up until you understood it as a warning.

In the high dark of the monster galleries, Fin Fang Foom lifted his head before the wheel had even begun to spin.

"Ahhh," he said, with the satisfaction of a connoisseur. "Tonight the mammals learn what he actually is."

The gacha wheel descended, rotated with none of its usual showmanship — no flourish, no teasing clatter — and dropped its token into the crystal bowl like a judge dropping a gavel.

PULL ONE: ACCEPTING A DUEL BECAUSE OF PRIDE — RARE.

"Rare," said Sam Wilson, reading the ceiling. "Him doing something reckless is *Rare*? We've watched this kid punch a fallen angel cadre, swear a blood oath at Heaven, and try to out-stubborn a wolf that eats gods. Reckless is his resting state."

RECKLESSNESS FOR OTHERS: COMMON, printed the screen, primly. **RECKLESSNESS FOR HIMSELF: RARE. ATTEND THE DIFFERENCE.**

The room attended. The screen opened.

The Underworld, in the vision, was doing its best impression of a summer afternoon — violet sky, training fields of the Gremory territory rolled out below the mountains like a green tablecloth. The audience had seen these fields before: this was where Issei Hyoudou did his failing, daily and on schedule, the honest blue-collar failing that had slowly won over half the theatre.

Today there was a guest instructor.

He arrived with a retinue and a reputation, a High-Class devil in a war-coat older than several member nations of the audience, and the gacha — which had grown fond of statistics — hung his introduction in the air beside him rather than bothering with a name:

VETERAN OF THE OLD WAR. HIGH-CLASS. FORMAL DUELS: 4,119. FORMAL DUELS LOST: 0.

"Ah," said Doctor Strange, softly. "One of those."

The Duelist watched the young devils train with the expression of a man inspecting produce. He corrected Kiba's footwork with two words. He nodded once at Koneko, which from him appeared to constitute a parade. And then he came to Issei — mid-collapse, as usual, face-down in the dirt after his four-hundredth gauntlet drill, arms shaking, getting up anyway, because getting up anyway was the entire syllabus of his life.

The Duelist looked at him for a long moment.

"So this is it," he said. "The era's Red Dragon Emperor."

Issei got up. "Yes, sir."

"I fought two of your predecessors." The old devil's voice wasn't cruel. That was the terrible part; the theatre noted it immediately. Cruelty can be dismissed. This was *assessment*. "Belzard nearly killed me in the war. Two strongest hosts the red dragon ever took — and even the weak ones, even the mad ones, were *dragons* the moment the gauntlet woke. And now." He gestured, taking in the dirt, the shaking arms, the boy. "Now the Welsh Dragon rides a Low-Class reincarnate who loses his Rating Games and faints when he boosts. Eight pawn pieces. I heard what Gremory paid, and I laughed. The great Ddraig, reduced to choosing failures. A legend spent on a boy who will die of his own arithmetic before he ever matters."

It would have been fine.

The theatre watched it be almost fine. On-screen, Issei took the insult to himself the way he took all insults to himself — a flinch, a grin, fuel for the next four hundred drills. The audience had seen it a dozen times. Cyclops was already nodding along: *good, use it, that's coachable*.

Then the boy's eyes changed.

It was small. The screen made sure no one missed it. A flicker of ember-light behind brown irises — and on his arm, unbidden, the Boosted Gear shimmered into being, and the green gem was not entirely green. Something older moved in it, red at the edges, like coals breathing under ash.

"Say that about me," Issei said, and his voice came out wrong — level, carrying, with a low double-register underneath it that had never been there before. "Say whatever you want about me. It's all true. But you don't get to say Ddraig chooses failures."

Partner, said the gauntlet, quietly. **Partner — wait**.

"I challenge you," said Issei Hyoudou. "Formal duel. Right now."

The training field went silent. Rias Gremory was already moving, already saying his name in the tone of an owner watching her house catch fire — and the Duelist smiled the smile of a man who has been handed exactly what he came for, and spoke the formal acceptance before anyone could reach the boy, and the dueling circle rang shut around them both like a bell.

House rules. Sealed circle. No interference until yield or incapacity.

"Oh no," said Peter Parker, from the street-level rows. "Oh no no no. He's fifteen. Somebody call time out. Does that world have time out?"

"It has yield," said Shang-Chi, watching the boy's stance, which had gone proud and wide and nothing like anything Kiba had taught him. "He will not use it."

The duel took four minutes. The theatre experienced it as considerably longer.

It was not a massacre in the way of Fenrir — the audience had already survived watching him bitten nearly in half; they had calibration for horror. This was worse in a way several of them would struggle afterward to name. Fenrir had been an ambush. *This* was a door Issei walked through on his own, with his chin up.

He opened with Scale Mail and every trick the room had learned to cheer for. **[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]** — the crimson armor blazing, the doubling stacking, the mountain-erasing output the gacha had crowned Legendary nine chapters ago. And the Duelist, who had four thousand years of exactly

this, took him apart with the unhurried economy of a man carving a roast. Every Boost bought Issei power; the veteran simply declined to be where the power went. Ten seconds is an eternity to someone who has been waiting out dragons since before Rome.

By the second minute Issei was boosting past the line. The audience knew the line now — last chapter had drawn it for them in Banner's careful red ink — and they watched him cross it with his teeth bared. Blood in the helmet. The armor's gem stuttering. **[BOOST,]** said the Gear, and then, for the first time in nineteen chapters, the system voice hesitated: **[BOOST. WARNING. BOOST. WARNING.]**

Partner, stop, Ddraig said, and the dragon's voice had lost all its dry slate calm. **Listen to me. Your body is at its end, and that fire in your chest — partner, that fire is not all yours. I know it. I have felt it in twenty-seven hands before yours. It ends the same way every time. STOP.**

"He insulted you," Issei said, through blood, rising again.

And I am four billion years old and could not care less! Boy — you are the only host who ever cried for ME—

The Duelist put him down with something almost like regret, an open-palm blast that cratered the boy through the circle's edge and ended the duel by incapacity, formally, cleanly, on the record: 4,120 and 0.

And Issei Hyoudou, who could not stand, stood.

The circle was open. The duel was over. His armor was in shards and his right arm hung wrong and the double-register in his voice was stronger now, ember-light crawling in his eyes, and he took one dragging step toward the veteran devil and said, "Again."

The screen froze on that frame — the ruined boy, the old killer's first flicker of genuine unease, the green gem burning red — and the theatre lights came up on four hundred held breaths.

Thor stood.

He did not raise the horn. Those who knew him — and by now the whole theatre knew him — understood that this was the actual alarm, the one Asgard never got to hear twice.

"That," he said, "was not temper."

"Looked like temper," said Yondu Udonta, from the Ravager rows. "Looked like grade-A, aged-in-the-barrel temper. I've *started* that temper in forty bars."

"No." Thor's voice rolled out flat and level, filling the room the way weather fills a valley. "I have seen temper. Temper is a fire in a hearth — it burns what is near and dies hungry. What woke in that boy's eyes has a *lineage*." He looked around the theatre, and for once there was no performance in him at all.

"Dragon pride is not a flaw of character. It is a force, as real as the weight of a mountain, and older than any pantheon in this room. It is what a dragon IS — the certainty of the summit, the law that nothing above you may be suffered to remain there. Every dragon carries it as surely as fire. And a dragon's power poured into a mortal soul pours *that* in with it." He sat down slowly. "In Asgard we had a saying: you may borrow a dragon's strength, or a dragon's wings, and pay only in gold. Borrow a dragon's pride and you have already paid everything, and the collector is merely in transit."

"The wielder before him," said the Valkyrie Brunnhilde, quietly, from the Asgardian benches. "The ones before him. Twenty-seven hands, the dragon said. Where are they now?"

The screen, which had been listening — the theatre had learned, since the Welsh chapter, that it listened — answered.

PREVIOUS HOSTS OF THE BOOSTED GEAR: [COUNT WITHHELD].

PREVIOUS HOSTS UNDONE BY EXTERNAL ENEMIES: SOME.

PREVIOUS HOSTS UNDONE BY THEMSELVES: THE REMAINDER.

THE REMAINDER IS THE LARGER NUMBER.

Nobody said anything for a moment. In the villain tiers, Mephisto — who had spent eighteen chapters delighted by everything — was, for the first time, taking notes with a completely straight face.

"So the kid's biggest threat," said Yondu, slowly, working it through, "ain't the wolf, ain't the fallen angels, ain't whatever's got a white gauntlet out there waitin' on him."

"It's the mirror," said Kraglin.

"It is the *inheritance*," said Doom.

Victor von Doom did not stand to speak. Doom never stood for the theatre; the theatre, his posture suggested, should consider standing for him. But he had turned his chair — an event in itself — and the green hood faced the frozen screen, the boy mid-snarl in his broken armor.

"Observe the sequence precisely," Doom said, "because the rest of you will sentimentalize it within the hour. The insult to himself, he absorbed. We have watched him absorb worse than insult — humiliation, defeat, death itself — and convert all of it to fuel. That conversion is his single genuine talent." A pause. "The insult to what he *loves*, he could not absorb. And note what the pride did with that noble opening: it did not make him protect the dragon. It made him *stake* everything the dragon is invested in — his body, his future, his master's eight pieces — on a duel arithmetic said he would lose. Pride always

disguises itself as loyalty on the way in. It presents as love, as honor, as *standards*." The metal fingers laced. "Pride dooms kings. Not peasants — peasants cannot afford enough of it to be dangerous. Kings. It waits until you are strong enough that no one dares correct you, and then it eats the kingdom."

The theatre waited. Everyone in six rows was extremely careful not to look at Latveria's delegation of one, or to mention a face, or a scar, or a lifelong war with a man Doom could have simply stopped hating.

"Doom speaks," said Doom, "from observation."

"Sure," said Ben Grimm, from very far away, in the tone of a man valuing his own life at slightly above one wisecrack.

"From *extensive* observation," said Doom, and turned his chair back, and under the heading in his notebook that still read *Latveria possesses no dragon; oversight*, he added a second line the screen was rude enough to enlarge for the entire room: *Amendment — a dragon, it transpires, is a citizen who cannot be ruled. Fortunate that Doom admires him from a distance.*

And then there was Namor.

He had been quiet through all of it, arms folded, ankle-wings still, watching the broken boy on the screen with an expression the surface-dwellers around him had no file for. When he finally rose, it was without any of his usual ceremony, and what he said first was not addressed to the room.

"Again," Namor repeated — the boy's word, the bleeding boy's word to a foe he could not touch. "Again." He let out a short breath through his nose. "Draconian. In the oldest sense. Not cruel — *draconian*: the law of the dragon, which recognizes no verdict delivered by anyone above it, because it does not acknowledge the existence of *above*." His jaw worked. "I have said that word about myself, you understand, usually while a Fantastic Four member was pulling me out of something I had personally set on fire."

"Is this," said Sue Storm, from across the theatre, "*growth*?"

"It is *recognition*," said Namor, with dignity. "There is a difference that royalty understands." But he did not smirk when he said it, and he did not ascend his customary two smug inches, and his eyes stayed on the screen. "I know that fire exactly. When the surface insults me, I can be persuaded, eventually, at great cost to the furniture. When they insult *Atlantis* — when they call my people primitive, my throne a puddle —" The ankle-wings flicked once, hard. "There is no *eventually*. There is the flood. Half of what this theatre holds against me began in the exact moment that just played: the moment an old man said

your beloved thing is worthless and something ancient stood up inside me wearing my voice." He sat back down, slowly. "The boy is fifteen and it is already strong enough to hold formal challenges in his mouth. Imperius Rex, little dragon. I am grudgingly and genuinely afraid for you."

From the gallery, Fin Fang Foom laughed, low and long, like distant rockfall.

"Now you understand," the great dragon said. "You have spent eighteen chapters asking whether the boy is worthy of the dragon. Wrong question. The question was always whether the boy can carry the dragon without *becoming* one. None of the others could. Foom has met dragons' hosts before, little kings. They are the saddest creatures in creation — all of our pride, none of our wings."

The wheel spun again before anyone could answer him. Perhaps mercifully.

PULL TWO: FRIENDS RESTRAINING HIM — COMMON.

"Common," said Stakar Ogord, speaking for the first time all night, arms crossed like a closed gate. "Meaning it happens a lot, or meaning it's cheap?"

MEANING IT IS THE ORDINARY MIRACLE, said the screen. **WATCH.**

The vision resumed exactly where it had frozen. One dragging step. "Again."

Kiba reached him first — a flicker of Knight speed, and then the swordsman had Issei's unbroken arm locked behind him, heels plowing furrows, being *moved* anyway, because a boy who had boosted past his limit was briefly stronger than sense. "Issei. Issei, it's over, it's called—"

"AGAIN—"

Koneko hit him at the waist.

The smallest member of the peerage wrapped both arms around him with full Rook strength, planted her feet, and became geology. The theatre had watched this tiny girl stop charging monsters; now she stopped her friend, cheek pressed against his shattered breastplate, and she was not looking at the Duelist or the circle or anything at all. She was listening to his heartbeat with an expression of open fear.

"Senpai smells wrong," she said. "Senpai smells like *someone else*."

And Issei — eyes still burning, voice still doubled, one arm pinned and his waist in a vise — kept pulling toward the old devil, dragging both of them, snarling something in a register the subtitles declined to render, and it might have gone somewhere genuinely unforgivable except that the sound cut through everything else:

Asia Argento, crying.

Not healing him. She *was* healing him — the green glow of Twilight Healing already soaking through the ruin of his ribs — but that wasn't what stopped him. She was crying the way she cried the night he died, hiccupping and horrified, hands shaking against his chest, saying his name over and over like a prayer that wasn't working.

The ember-light went out of his eyes between one heartbeat and the next.

The double-register vanished. The pride drained out of his frame so fast that Koneko's grip became the only thing holding him up, and Issei Hyoudou looked down at Asia's tears, and at Kiba's white-knuckled lock on his arm, and at the crater, and at his own blood, with the dawning, seasick expression of a man waking up at the wheel of a moving car.

"...What," he said, in one voice, his own, very small, "was I just doing?"

That, said Ddraig, heavily, **is the correct question, partner. Hold on to it. Most of the ones before you never thought to ask it.**

The gacha did not cut away. The theatre had expected the usual mercy-fade; instead the vision followed them home, to the Hyoudou living room, that evening — and the audience realized it was being shown the *real* pull. The restraint had been the trailer. This was the feature.

Because they were all waiting for him. And nobody was proud of him.

Rias Gremory sat in the center of the sofa with her hands folded, and she did not shout. It was infinitely worse than shouting. "Eight pieces," she said. "I gave eight pieces, Issei. Do you know what I actually bought with them? Not a weapon. Not a dragon. *You*. Your ridiculous, kind, stubborn self — the one who gets up for other people. Tonight I watched something wearing your face gamble all of that to defend the *feelings* of a being who predates feelings. If you ever put my cute servant in that kind of danger again, I will—" Her voice cracked, hairline, and every empath in the theatre flinched. "You *died* once already. I was there. I will not do that twice."

"Ara ara," said Akeno Himejima, and there was no smile under it at all, which several audience members found genuinely frightening. "And you didn't even bring us. You know I'd have held the nasty old man down for you, Issei-kun. That's what hurts. You forgot you *have* us."

"Duel expenses," announced Ravel Phenex, materializing a ledger with the crisp violence of a slammed door, and Pepper Potts sat up straight in the audience. "Phoenix tears, one vial, market rate. Twilight Healing, four hours, priced at Asia-san's tears, which are *not renewable at market rate*. Training ground repairs. One formal apology to a war veteran, drafted by me, because your draft opened with 'Dear Old Guy.' Total in the margin. *Look at the margin*, Hyoudou Issei."

"Stupid," said Koneko, with maximum precision. "Senpai was stupid. Senpai is not allowed to smell like someone else again."

"I have decided," said Xenovia, who had been thinking hard in the corner, "that if pride requires an outlet, you may duel *me* each morning. I will defeat you very kindly."

"That's not—" said Irina. "That's not the *lesson*, Xenovia—"

And Asia, who had cried herself out hours ago, simply took his hand in both of hers and held it against her cheek and said nothing whatsoever, which broke him — the theatre watched it break him — far more thoroughly than the ledger, the lecture, and the geology combined.

Issei bowed his head over their joined hands. "I'm sorry," he said. "I don't — that wasn't — I could hear myself saying it, and it felt *right*, that's the scary part, it felt like being sure of something for once—"

The apology is also mine to make, said Ddraig, and the gauntlet manifested, gem glowing low, addressing the room of furious girls with what could only be called formality. **Some of that fire was mine. I burn; it is what I am; he holds the flame and it warms him and it will always, always try to spread. And some of it was older than mine — the ones who came before, whose endings I carry. I could not save them. They had power, every one.** The ember-light banked, and the ancient voice did something the theatre had never heard it do. It went gentle. **None of them had this room. Keep scolding him. I mean this as a dragon who has buried twenty-seven partners: the scolding is the shield. It is the only one that has ever worked.**

The screen held on the living room — the boy surrounded, chastened, held — and then, before fading, it printed one line across the image, without fanfare, in small letters, as if for its own records:

HYPOTHESIS LOGGED: THE ASSET'S PRIMARY CONTAINMENT SYSTEM IS DOMESTIC.

"HA!" Yondu was on his feet, pointing his whole arm at the screen. "That's it! That's the thing! Krag — that's the thing don't nobody put in the recruitment brochure!"

"The scoldin'," Kraglin agreed, nodding along. "Cap'n, you remember when you flew us into that Kree interdiction line 'cause the checkpoint officer laughed at your fin?"

"He laughed at the *fin*, Kraglin, the fin is *cultural*—"

"Lost the aft section. Lost my second-best knife. And weren't nobody on that bridge told you no, is my point." Kraglin turned to the theatre at large, warming to the first philosophy of his life. "That's Ravagerin'. Whole crews of proud idiots and not one Asia in the bunch. Pride's the house drink. It's *why* half of us signed up and *how* most of us go out."

"It's why he flew colors alone for twenty years," said Stakar Ogord, and the temperature in the Ravager section dropped. Yondu went still. Stakar looked at the screen instead of at him — at the frozen living room, the circle of angry, loving faces. "I exiled a man once for breaking the code. Right call. Then pride kept me from ever once checking what the exile was doing to him, and by the time I looked, there was almost nothing left to look at." He let that sit. "That boy got dragged home and yelled at by six people the same night he embarrassed himself. You know what that is? That's *wealth*. Damn kid's rich and doesn't know it. Ravagers should take notes."

"Ravagers can't read," said Yondu, hoarsely, which in Ravager was *thank you, brother*, and everyone present had the grace to pretend otherwise.

Thor raised the horn at last — but he raised it away from the screen, toward the memory of the living room.

"Not to the dragon tonight," he said. "Nor even to the boy. To the shield-wall! To the red-haired king who counts her pieces, the little stone one who holds the door, the healer whose tears outrank armies, the keeper of the terrible ledger! In Asgard we sang ten thousand songs of dragons and none — *none* — of the ones who talk them down. An oversight I intend to correct." He drank. "The pride is real, and it will come again, stronger, each time his power grows. Mark me. But so will they."

"The strategic summary," said Doom, without turning his chair, "for those requiring one: the boy's ceiling is not determined by the dragon. It is determined by whether that living room still exists on the day the ceiling matters. His enemies would be advised to understand this." A pause, arid as Latveria in August. "Doom advises no one."

Namor said nothing at all. But those seated near the Atlantean section observed that he watched the frozen frame of the scolding for a long time, unblinking — a king with no living room, memorizing someone else's — and that when the lights finally began their end-of-chapter dim, he inclined his head to the screen by perhaps two degrees. Monarch to monarch. Or perhaps to the girls.

The wheel gave its parting clatter in the dark, and the letters came up gold and ominous both at once:

NEXT: HIS BODY HAS LEARNED WHAT IT COSTS TO BE ONE THING. SO IT WILL BECOME THREE.

"Three?" said Tony Stark, into the dark. "I'm sorry — three *what?*"

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Accepting a Duel Because of Pride* — Rare; *Friends Restraining Him* — Common. The gacha explicitly ranked recklessness-for-himself as rarer than recklessness-for-

others, and followed the restraint home to the scolding — flagging the domestic aftermath, not the duel, as the true content of the pull.

- **Secrets Revealed:** Dragon pride is a real, transmissible force, not adolescent ego — Ddraig's nature bleeding into his host, amplified by residue of the previous Red Dragon Emperors (twenty-seven prior partners, per Ddraig; the screen confirmed most hosts were "undone by themselves," and that this is "the larger number"). Under its influence Issei's eyes ember, his voice doubles, and Koneko can smell "someone else" in him. A veteran duelist (4,120–0) provoked it by insulting Ddraig — insults to himself he converts to fuel; insults to what he loves bypass every defense. Asia's tears, not force, broke the state. The screen logged: "THE ASSET'S PRIMARY CONTAINMENT SYSTEM IS DOMESTIC."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Thor reclassifies the pride as an ancient force and toasts the girls, vowing songs for "the ones who talk dragons down." Namor names the behavior "draconian" with open, unsmirking kinship and visibly envies the scolding. Doom (updating his *Latveria* possesses *no dragon* note) rules that pride dooms kings "from observation," and flags the living room as Issei's strategic center of gravity. The Ravagers claim pride as "the house drink"; Stakar calls Issei's scolding circle "wealth" and half-reconciles with Yondu in the process. Mephisto has stopped smiling and started writing. Rias, Akeno, Koneko, Asia, Xenovia, Irina, and Ravel established on-screen as the anti-corruption mechanism: his family does not blindly praise him.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Ddraig has buried twenty-seven partners and says the scolding is "the only shield that has ever worked" — what exactly did the ones before Issei become, and what is the sealed weight Ddraig carries of their endings? The pride "will come again, stronger, each time his power grows" (Thor), making Issei's own inheritance the arc's shadow-threat. The Duelist's mention of "Belzard" gives the past hosts their first name. Doom is now openly modeling how to *unmake* Issei via the living room — as warning or as blueprint. And the wheel's tease stands: his body will "become three." The theatre has no idea what an Illegal Move is. It is about to find out.

Chapter Twenty: Illegal Move Triaina

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers heavy hitters (Thor, Captain Marvel, Hulk, the Thing, Vision) • Cosmic tacticians (Silver Surfer, Uatu, Gladiator, Karnak, Heimdall) • Villains (Doom, Loki, Mephisto, Taskmaster, Kang, Thanos)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Welsh Sonic Boost Knight" — **Epic**
 2. "Welsh Dragonic Rook" — **Epic**
 3. "Welsh Blaster Bishop" — **Epic**
-

The theatre had learned to read its own weather, and tonight the weather was wrong.

Not storm-grey, which meant grief. Not pub-gold, which meant somebody British was about to be humiliated. Tonight the impossible ceiling cooled to the colour of a tournament hall an hour before the match — that particular hush of lacquered wood and held breath — and the floor of the theatre, for the first time in twenty chapters, dimmed itself into sixty-four vast alternating squares of light and dark.

"Oh," said Sam Wilson, quietly, looking down at the board they were all suddenly sitting on. "It's a chess night."

They had been waiting for this one. The machine had teased it back at the end of the first arc — a flicker of three armoured silhouettes behind the words ILLEGAL MOVE TRIAINA, gone before anyone could screenshot it with their eyes — and then had spent nine chapters making them earn it. They had watched the boy train until he ruptured things. They had watched Fenrir's teeth go through him and Ravel Phenex log the damage in her terrible, meticulous ledger. They had watched him collapse from over-boosting while Banner took notes with a shaking hand, and they had watched him accept a duel out of pure dragon pride and get scolded for it by eight furious women, which several Avengers privately considered the most dangerous engagement of his career.

Nine chapters of cost. The theatre understood, by now, how this machine did arithmetic. Tonight was the purchase.

The gacha wheel descended — and it had changed. Its rings had locked into concentric ranks, and around its outermost band, tiny pieces revolved in stately procession: pawn, pawn, pawn, knight, rook, bishop. No queen. Everyone noticed there was no queen. The wheel spun once, with none of its usual

smug clatter, and dropped three tokens into the crystal bowl at the same instant — a thing it had never done — and the chime they made was not a wineglass. It was a bell.

ARC FINALE, said the screen, in letters that did not glow so much as weigh. **THE MAKING OF A DRAGON: FINAL LESSON.**

"Everyone's laughing about the chess theme now," said Carol Danvers, not laughing. "Get it out of your systems."

The screen opened on Kyoto at night, and the theatre's street-level rows tensed, because they knew this shape of story: a city full of civilians, a mountain above it, and something terrible arranged on the summit. The Hero Faction — human supremacists with stolen god-tools, the gacha's captions explained with brutal economy — had kidnapped Yasaka, the nine-tailed guardian of the city, away from a small fox-eared daughter who had cried on Issei's shoulder about it. They were using the mother as a battery. The child was waiting at the bottom of the mountain for someone to bring her back.

At the summit, leaning on a spear that made every holy sense in the theatre itch even through the screen, stood a young man with calm eyes. Cao Cao. Human. Entirely, merely, magnificently human — and holding the True Longinus, the spear of the crucifixion, the first and strongest of the Sacred Gears.

"Ah," said Shang-Chi softly, reading his stance. "That one has never needed to be more than human. That's the most dangerous kind."

On-screen, Issei Hyoudou stood in battered Scale Mail with his team scattered and bleeding around him, and the theatre watched him do the thing this arc had taught him to do. He stopped. He *thought*. Nineteen chapters ago he would have charged.

"Ddraig," he said. "The thing we've been working on. The thing that breaks the rules."

"It will hurt, partner," said the dragon-voice, and there was pride banked in it like an ember. **"Each shape will cost you what it gives. You understood that when you built them."**

"Yeah." A breath, inside the helm. "He's got a spear that kills gods and hostages that need everything I've got. Cheating's all I have. Let's make an illegal move."

The gauntlet's gem flared, and the gacha froze the frame to lecture — it had learned, over twenty chapters, exactly how much this audience loved rules.

EVIL PIECE SYSTEM — PROMOTION, the screen wrote, laying out a chessboard of light. **A PAWN WHO ENTERS ENEMY TERRITORY MAY PROMOTE, WITH THE KING'S SANCTION, TO KNIGHT, ROOK, BISHOP, OR QUEEN. THIS IS THE RULE.**

A pawn of light marched up the board and became a queen, politely, legally.

ISSEI HYODOU DOES NOT FOLLOW THE RULE. HE HAS FORGED, WITH THE WELSH DRAGON, A PROMOTION THAT ASKS NO SANCTION, WAITS FOR NO TERRITORY, AND POURS THE FULL OUTPUT OF THE BOOSTED GEAR INTO ONE PIECE'S NATURE AT A TIME. THE PIECE OBJECTS. THE BOARD OBJECTS. THE MOVE PROCEEDS.

DESIGNATION: ILLEGAL MOVE TRIAINA.

THE TRIDENT. THREE PRONGS. THREE PRICES.

"He cheats at the game he was resurrected *into*," murmured T'Challa, and on the far side of the theatre, in the dark where the villains sat, Mephisto's perpetual smile flickered — just once — like a candle noticing a draught.

PULL ONE: WELSH SONIC BOOST KNIGHT — EPIC.

"Change—" said Issei, on-screen, and the world took a breath. **"STAR SONIC!!"**

[CHANGE: WELSH SONIC BOOST KNIGHT.]

The armour *shed itself*. That was the only way to describe it — plates peeling away and dissolving into red light, the heavy dragon-shell thinning to something skeletal, sleek, almost cruelly minimal, all sweeping lines and exposed joints, built by someone who had crossed out the word "survive" and written "arrive" instead. The wings lengthened into blades of light.

Then he moved, and the screen apologized for its own frame rate.

The mountaintop cracked with overlapping sonic booms — not one boom, a *drumroll* of them, a boy breaking the sound barrier the way other people breathe. Cao Cao's spearwork was the finest pure technique the theatre had been shown in twenty chapters, a web of holy light with no gaps in it, and Issei went through the gaps that did not exist. He was behind the spear. He was under it. He was seven places, and three of them landed hits, and the summit's ancient stones ripped from their beds in his wake like the ground was trying to follow him.

In the theatre, Quicksilver stood up so fast his own chair fell over.

"Okay," Pietro said. "Okay. No. That's — hold on. That's not superspeed, superspeed is *mine*, that's a missile that learned footwork. What's his turning radius? Did anyone clock his turning radius? He's cornering at Mach — you can't *corner* at Mach, cornering at Mach is how you become a red smear with opinions—"

"Boost-doubling channelled entirely into velocity," said Vision, whose eyes had gone to instrument-glow. "Compounding every ten seconds. There is no ceiling on this except his skeleton."

And then the screen showed the price. Cao Cao — reading, adjusting, *human* — caught him with the butt of the spear, a grazing hit, barely a touch.

The Knight armour crumpled like foil. The theatre heard ribs go. Issei tumbled a quarter mile through a shrine gate and came up coughing blood inside a helm with a crack across its eye.

"The Knight buys speed with your shell, partner," said Ddraig, steady, unsurprised. **"In this shape, you must never be touched. That is the wager."**

Up in the Inhuman rows, Karnak had not moved for the entire sequence. Now he spoke, in the flat voice of a man reading a fracture in a load-bearing wall.

"Flaw: the form is a bet that speed is armour. Against anything that reads patterns — a precognitive, an area-denial weapon, a lucky child with a net — the bet fails catastrophically. One touch. That is the whole flaw. One touch."

The screen, in what was becoming a habit, stamped the vision with glowing text at the very moment he finished:

SUB-FORM ONE: OVERWHELMING SPEED. SACRIFICES: DURABILITY. ONE TOUCH.

Karnak looked at the screen. The screen did not look away. He sat back, very slightly disturbed to have been agreed with.

PULL TWO: WELSH DRAGONIC ROOK — EPIC.

On-screen, Issei spat blood, looked at the spear that had touched him once and nearly ended him, and changed his bet.

"Change — **SOLID IMPACT!!**"

[CHANGE: WELSH DRAGONIC ROOK.]

Where the Knight had shed armour, the Rook *hoarded* it. Plate stacked on plate; the frame broadened until the silhouette was less "boy in armour" and more "siege engine that had heard about boys"; the forearms swelled into rammed towers of dragon-scale, and when he set his feet, the mountain accepted him as a permanent geographic feature.

Cao Cao put the True Longinus — the spear that unmade gods — square into his chest.

The theatre flinched. The Rook did not. The blessed point skidded, gouging a molten line across the plates, and Issei took the single greatest holy weapon in his cosmology across the sternum the way the Thing takes weather.

Then he hit back.

The gacha slowed the punch out of respect. One blow — no flight, no flourish, a short, ugly, perfectly weighted straight — and the shockwave alone flattened a square kilometre of summit forest, peeled the face off a neighbouring ridge, and rang the city's ten thousand temple bells at once, so that far below, a small fox-eared girl looked up toward the mountain where her mother was.

In the theatre, Ben Grimm rose slowly to his feet, a mountain range standing to salute a new peak.

"THAT'S the stuff," the Thing rumbled, with tears he would deny under oath. "Look at that form. Look at them SHOULDERS. Kid skipped every fancy lesson and went straight to the only sentence that matters." He wiped his eye with a granite thumb. "It's clobberin' time in *Japanese*."

The Hulk, who had been watching from his customary demolished quadrant with the sulky attention he gave all large strong things that weren't him, made a low sound. "Hulk could take that punch," he said. Pause. "Hulk would *respect* that punch, though." From Hulk, the theatre understood, this was a knighthood.

Thor was already pouring. "The Rook!" he boomed. "The tower that walks! In Asgard we would call this shape *skjaldborg-of-one* — a shield-wall with a temper! Boy-dragon, thou hast built thyself a fortress— oh. Oh, no. Watch."

Because the screen was showing the price. Cao Cao, spear-work fluid, had simply stopped being where the Rook could reach. He circled. The Rook turned like a cathedral trying to waltz — majestic, devastating, four steps behind — and every rotation cost Issei ground, position, tempo, while the human with the spear carved lines into his flanks and never once stood still.

"Flaw," said Karnak, before the screen could beat him to it. "The form is a bet that the enemy will consent to stand in front of you. Mobility is not reduced; it is *forfeited*. Anyone patient enough to walk in circles defeats the strongest defence on that board without ever testing it."

SUB-FORM TWO: IMMENSE POWER AND DEFENCE. SACRIFICES: MANOEUVRABILITY. THE TOWER DOES NOT DANCE.

"Stop *doing* that," Karnak told the screen.

Gladiator of the Shi'ar Imperial Guard — who had spent nineteen chapters filing Issei under "local fauna, developing" — spoke for the first time that night, arms folded, mohawk immaculate.

"Imperial assessment revised," he said. "That defence turned the edge of a god-killing weapon. In Shi'ar doctrine, any asset that can anchor a battle-line against theotech is classified at the squadron level, not the individual level." A beat. "He is sixteen."

"He is," said Captain America quietly, from the row where the coaches sat, "and he built all three of these *after* losing. Look at the design philosophy. Every form is an answer to a specific way he's been beaten. Fenrir taught him he could die fast — so he built something faster. Sairaorg taught him he could be out-toughed — so he built the tower." Steve's jaw worked. "This isn't a power-up. This is a kid turning every scar he owns into doctrine. That's the arc we just watched. That's what it was *for*."

PULL THREE: WELSH BLASTER BISHOP — EPIC.

On-screen the fight had turned, as fights against patient geniuses do, into a losing ledger. And Issei Hyoudou, bleeding inside his fortress, did the last thing the theatre expected of the boy from chapter one.

He retreated. He gave ground *on purpose*, and as he did, he shouted — not a battle cry, a *request*: "Buy me time! Kiba, Xenovia — I need a minute! Maybe two!"

And his comrades, without one syllable of question, threw themselves between him and the strongest human alive, because they had exactly that much faith in whatever he was about to become.

"He asked for help," said Sam Wilson, sitting forward. "Loudest kid in two universes just used his big moment to ask for help. Somebody's been coaching him." He glanced at Steve. Steve said nothing, but the corner of his mouth committed treason.

"Change—" said Issei, kneeling, gauntlet blazing, voice dropping into something the theatre had never heard from him: *calm*. "**FANG BLAST!!**"

[CHANGE: WELSH BLASTER BISHOP.]

The armour rebuilt itself a third way — neither sprinter nor fortress but *emplacement*: the plates ribbing back into a braced, rooted stance, and over each shoulder, with a sound like a cathedral organ clearing its throat, rose a cannon. Two of them. Dragon-mouthed, rune-throated, drinking the Boosted Gear's doubling output not into limbs or plate but into *stockpile*.

[BOOST.] said the gear. **[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]**

The charge took a full minute, and the gacha made them sit through every second of it — the cannons whining up through registers that made Heimdall tilt his head, the air around the kneeling boy beginning to grieve, light bending wrong near the muzzles, Kiba and Xenovia paying for each of those sixty seconds in blood and steel just off-centre of frame.

"Sixty seconds of charge," said Taskmaster, in the villains' dark, to no one. "Sixty seconds of standing still in a fight." He said it like a man reading a price tag and finding it obscene. He would revise this opinion in approximately forty seconds more.

"DRAGON BLASTERRRR!!"

The theatre had seen the mountain-erasing blast of basic Scale Mail back in Arc One, and had recalibrated accordingly. This was not that. This was not a bigger version of that. When the twin cannons fired their braided lance of red, the screen's sound cut out entirely — not artistically; the theatre's reality simply declined to render it — and the summit of the mountain, the fortress on it, the army in the fortress, and the *geometry those things had occupied* went away. Not destroyed. *Audited*. And for one held frame, around the wound the beam left in the world, space itself visibly puckered — distances disagreeing with each other, a ripple of wrongness where here and there briefly lost track of which was which — before reality smoothed its coat and pretended nothing had happened.

Cao Cao stood at the edge of the erasure, having survived on pure precognitive genius and the last inch of his spear's power, and the calm in his eyes had finally, finally cracked.

Issei's cannons vented steam and folded away. He swayed. The Triaina armour dissolved entirely, and he went down to his hands and knees in the dirt, empty as a wrung cloth, unable to lift his own head — and grinning anyway, because down the mountain a fox-eared girl was about to get her mother back.

SUB-FORM THREE: STRATEGIC ARTILLERY. THE DRAGON BLASTER LEVELS BATTLEFIELDS AND BRIEFLY DISTORTS LOCAL SPACE-TIME. SACRIFICES: STAMINA. CHARGE IS SLOW. THE CANNON FIRES TWICE, AND THEN THE BOY IS DONE.

The lights came up, and the theatre discovered it had rearranged itself.

Not physically — although Quicksilver's chair was still on its back — but in some deeper seating chart. Nobody was lounging. The heavy hitters had drifted forward. The tacticians had stopped taking notes on paper and started taking them on each other's faces. And the villains' gallery, which had treated nineteen chapters of this boy as a charming regional soap opera, had gone quiet in the specific way a casino goes quiet when someone starts winning *correctly*.

Carol Danvers spoke first, because someone had to, and she said it like filing paperwork, which for Carol was a form of prayer.

"Reclassification. As of tonight I'm striking 'promising underdog' from every assessment I've got on this kid. New designation: regional-calamity-class, conditional, team-force-multiplier. Knight form outruns most of our fliers. Rook form eats hits that would put half this room in the medbay. And the Bishop—" she paused, and the pause had a beam of light in it. "The Bishop is a strategic weapon with a sixteen-year-old's cardio as its only arms-control treaty. If he showed up in our sky tomorrow, I don't scramble Avengers. I scramble *everyone*, and I pray he's still the kid who asks for help."

"He is the kid who asks for help," said Steve. "That's the entire reason the number doesn't scare me."

"The number scares *me*," said Banner, mildly, "and I'd like to say why, because I've been the number." He took off his glasses, cleaned them, put them back on. "It's not the output. It's that every one of those forms has a *cost he agreed to in advance*. Speed that can't be touched. Power that can't move. A cannon that empties him. He's not suppressing his monster — he's *invoicing* it. Line items." A small, complicated smile. "I spent twenty years trying to build that ledger. He's sixteen and he's already itemized."

Vision's voice came level as a spirit-gauge. "Additional finding. All three forms presuppose allies. The Knight needs someone to hold what it cannot survive; the Rook needs someone to catch what it cannot chase; the Bishop needs someone to buy its sixty seconds. Statistically, this is not a lone-warrior arsenal. It is the arsenal of someone who has never once planned to fight alone." A pause of exactly the wrong length. "I find I trust that more than any durability figure."

From the cosmic tiers, the Silver Surfer had drifted forward off his customary aloof altitude, board angled toward the dark screen like a compass needle finding a new pole.

"I have levelled battlefields," he said, and the theatre hushed for him, because the Surfer never volunteered his résumé. "I know the weight of a weapon that ends the argument rather than winning it. Heralds carry such weight because a Devourer requires it of them. This child built it *himself*, out of chess and stubbornness — and then chained it to his own exhaustion so it could never become his habit." The Surfer's chrome face did something almost like wonder. "We named him underdog. The word is dead. Let no one here use it again."

No one ever did.

Heimdall, who saw everything and editorialized about almost none of it, added one sentence: "When the great cannon fired, I watched the space around the wound. For a moment, distances *lied*. I have seen that lie before only near the roots of Yggdrasil, where things have been cut away." His golden gaze went, briefly, to the Watcher. "Someone should ask *him* what I mean."

But Uatu the Watcher stood apart, vast and pale, and his unease — the structural unease of a being who had found no timeline anywhere that contained this boy — had acquired a new floor beneath it. "The distortion signature of the Dragon Blaster," he said slowly, as if reading a word in his own archive that he had not written, "resembles the edge of an *excision*. The mark left when something is removed from what-is." He did not elaborate. Watchers never elaborated at the worst possible moment; it was practically the job description.

And across the theatre, in the villains' dark, Kang the Conqueror was on his feet.

He had laughed at the boy in Arc One. Most of that gallery had — Mephisto's indulgent chuckle, Loki's connoisseur smirk, the general professional condescension of men who collected planets toward a teenager who collected rejections. Nobody in that section was laughing now.

"That was time trauma," Kang said, flat and precise, a man identifying his own signature on a document he never signed. "Localized, crude, self-limiting — and produced by a *chest cannon* built out of a chess metaphor. Do you comprehend what I am telling you? Causality has a scar tissue, and I have spent forty centuries learning to cut it *politely*, and that child just bruised it by accident on a Tuesday." He sat back down slowly. "He goes in my equations now. Every version of them. Every century of them."

"Doom concurs," said Doom, and closed his notebook with a sound like a verdict — the notebook he had kept on Issei Hyoudou since chapter one. The theatre had learned to fear the notebook. This was worse. "Doom is finished taking notes on the boy. The boy is now a *constant*. One does not take notes on constants; one designs around them." The mask turned fractionally toward the heroes' section. "Doom advises you all to begin. Any plan for any world that does not account for where the dragon is standing is no longer a plan. It is a wager."

Taskmaster laughed once — short, unhappy, professional. "I watched all three forms frame by frame. You know what I got? Nothing. There's nothing to *copy*. It's not technique — the kid's technique is honestly still mediocre — it's arithmetic wearing armour. You can't photographic-reflex a *budget*." He pulled his hood down over the skull mask. "I don't do jobs where he might show up. Adding it to the contract boilerplate tonight."

Mephisto had not spoken. Mephisto, who had spent twenty chapters delighted, gleeful, treating Rias Gremory's eight-Pawn expenditure as the insider tip of the eon — sat with his fingers steepled and his smile *gone*, doing math visibly behind his eyes, and when Loki arched a brow at him, the demon said only: "I priced him in chapter five. The market has moved. It has moved out of *my* range, little prince, and I own several afterlives." Which, from Mephisto, was not an expression of loss. It was an expression of *awe*, and everyone near him found it far more frightening than his smile.

Loki himself said nothing at all. But those seated closest observed that the god of stories had stopped looking at the gauntlet the way a thief looks at a jewel, and started looking at the boy the way a chess player looks at a piece that has just done something the rules of the game do not contain. One does not pickpocket weather. One *forecasts* it.

And in the deepest seat of that gallery, where the shadows were less an absence of light than a professional courtesy, Thanos of Titan — who had watched nineteen chapters in a silence so complete that half the theatre had forgotten to be afraid of it — inclined his head one single degree toward the screen, and moved, on whatever board he kept behind those eyes, one piece from one column to another.

No one saw which columns. Everyone understood the gesture.

The laughing was over. That was the threshold, and the whole room felt itself cross it together: heroes and villains, for one strange minute, leaning across the aisle to compare threat assessments like rival scholars sharing a text — the theatre's first joint calculation, made about a boy face-down in the dirt of a mountain he had personally edited, grinning about somebody else's mother.

The screen was not quite finished.

It showed Issei carried down the mountain on Kiba's back, too drained to walk, loudly narrating his own victory in a way that cost him the room's solemnity and none of its respect. It showed a fox-eared girl hit him at a dead run and refuse to let go. And then it dimmed to the tournament-hall hush one final time, and laid out its chessboard of light, and on it: three pieces glowing red. Knight. Rook. Bishop.

And behind them, greyed out, silhouetted, locked — a fourth piece.

A queen.

"Not yet, partner," said Ddraig's voice over the dark, gentle as a door left open. **"The trident has three prongs. But you and I both know what the pieces want to become."**

The silhouette burned faintly crimson at its crown, and the theatre — every faction, every aisle, every column of every ledger — made the same note at the same time.

Then, in letters of quiet fire:

ARC TWO COMPLETE: THE MAKING OF A DRAGON.

THE DRAGON IS MADE. WHAT FOLLOWS IS WHAT DRAGONS GUARD.

And beneath it, for exactly one frame, the old line — the one that had haunted them since the beginning, now flickering as if the Dragon Blaster's scar had reminded the machine of something:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

The gacha wheel rose back toward the ceiling. As it went, its rings shifted, and around the outermost band a new track lit up in warm, domestic, utterly ominous gold, with a small chime like a doorbell:

NEW BANNER UNLOCKED: FAMILY-CLASS.

"...I don't like that font," said Sam Wilson. "Why is that font *cozy*?"

Nobody answered. The lights went down on a theatre that had arrived, twenty chapters ago, to watch a stranger — and sat now, in the dark, planning around a constant.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Welsh Sonic Boost Knight* — Epic; *Welsh Dragonic Rook* — Epic; *Welsh Blaster Bishop* — Epic. The wheel's first-ever triple drop, delivered as a single set under an "ARC FINALE" header; the wheel's chess-piece band conspicuously displayed no queen — until the end, when it showed one, greyed out and crowned in crimson.
- **Secrets Revealed:** *Illegal Move Triaina* in full — a self-granted, sanction-free partial promotion that channels the Boosted Gear's entire doubling output into one Evil-Piece trait at a time. Knight: overwhelming compounding speed, armour reduced to foil ("one touch" kills the wager). Rook: turned the True Longinus's edge and shattered a summit with one punch, but forfeits manoeuvrability entirely. Bishop: shoulder-cannon artillery whose Dragon Blaster levels battlefields and *briefly warps local space-time* — at the cost of a slow (~60-second, ally-shielded) charge and near-total stamina drain (two shots, then done). All three forms structurally presuppose allies; the arsenal of someone who never planned to fight alone. Heimdall and Uatu independently flagged the Blaster's distortion as resembling an *excision* signature — "the mark left when something is removed from what-is."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Captain Marvel formally reclassifies Issei from "promising underdog" to **regional-calamity-class, conditional, team-force-multiplier**; the Silver Surfer declares the word "underdog" dead and no one uses it again. Karnak's flaw-readings now sync eerily with the screen's own captions. The villains stop laughing entirely: Doom closes his twenty-chapter notebook and declares Issei a *constant* to design around; Kang enters him into "every equation, every century"; Taskmaster deems him uncopyable and adds him to contract exclusions; Mephisto admits the boy's price has moved beyond even his market; Loki shifts from coveting the gauntlet to forecasting the boy; Thanos silently moves a piece between columns. First-ever joint hero-villain threat assessment conducted across the aisle.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** *Arc-close stance:* the room's consensus has hardened across two arcs — from grieving a murdered stranger (Arc One) to unanimously treating Issei as a strategic factor: heroes count him a trainable asset and force-multiplier, villains a variable no plan may omit, and the cosmic tier a signature to monitor. Immature, incorruptible, and now battlefield-relevant — impossible to co-opt and expensive to ignore. *Forward hooks:* the greyed-out crimson Queen — what the three pieces "want to become." Why does the Dragon Blaster's space-time scar resemble an excision-mark that unsettles both Heimdall and the Watcher, and why did it make the machine flash the prophecy again? Which columns did Thanos move Issei between? And the gacha has unlocked a warm-gold **FAMILY-CLASS banner** with a doorbell chime — the cozy font is fooling no one.

Chapter Twenty-One: Wife-Class Summon

Primary Reaction Groups: The Eight Brides (summoned) • Romance-interested heroes (Peter Parker, Kamala Khan) • Villains (Doom, Mephisto, Loki, Taskmaster, Kang)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Summoning Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Asia, Koneko, Kuroka and Rossweisse" — **Family-Class**
-

The warm gold band had been circling the gacha wheel for what the theatre's body clocks insisted was three days, chiming its little doorbell chime at irregular intervals, and by now everyone hated it.

"It's the *coziness*," Sam Wilson explained, for the fortieth time, to nobody. "Twenty chapters of business fonts — blood font, prophecy font, audit font — and now it rolls out a bakery menu and rings a *doorbell*. That's not comfort. That's a predator that has learned what comfort looks like."

"Or," said Kamala Khan, who had claimed an aisle seat the moment the FAMILY-CLASS banner lit and not surrendered it since, "it's the family arc. Every long story has one. You do the powers, you do the costs, then you do the *people*, because the people are what the powers are for." She was sitting on her own hands to keep them still. "I've read like nine hundred serials. This is the good part."

"The good part," repeated Peter Parker, hanging upside down from a structural nothing above her row, "of the story where the last arc ended with a kid bruising causality. Sure. Cozy."

The ceiling dimmed. The doorbell chimed once more — and this time the whole warm-gold track lit end to end, and the wheel came down.

It came down wrong.

The theatre had watched that wheel descend twenty times, smug and ceremonial. Tonight it wobbled. Its rings stuttered against each other like gears meeting a foreign object, and around its rim the chess-piece band — pawn, pawn, knight, rook, bishop, greyed queen — flickered and was replaced, piece by piece, with something the room had never seen on it before.

Rings. Small, plain, golden. Eight of them, orbiting.

"Uh," said Peter.

FAMILY-CLASS PULL, announced the screen, in the bakery font. **"SUMMONING RIAS, AKENO, XENOVIA, IRINA, ASIA, KONEKO, KUROKA AND ROSSWEISSE."**

"Summoning," said Doctor Strange, and stood up. He did not usually stand up. "That word has a technical meaning. Every prior pull has said *showing*. Vision. Memory. Record." His hands were already moving through the opening figures of a ward. "Summoning is not a genre of theatre. Summoning is a door."

The wheel spun. It screamed — an ugly, grinding sound, a machine either breaking or pretending to break; no two factions would ever agree which — and instead of dropping a token into the crystal bowl, it dropped the bowl. The bowl hit the stage and shattered into a circle.

A summoning circle. Two hundred feet across, crimson, wrought in a heraldry of roses and thorns that Mephisto recognized one full second before anyone else — which was why Mephisto was the only being already smiling when the light went up and the Gremory crest opened like an eye.

ERROR, said the screen, cozily. **ERROR. PHYSICAL INSTANTIATION IN PROGRESS. THE MANAGEMENT APOLOGIZES.**

"It doesn't apologize," said Uatu the Watcher, very quietly, to no one. "It has never once apologized."

The light collapsed. The circle faded. And on the stage of the cosmic theatre, where twenty chapters of visions had played untouchably, stood eight young women — physically, actually, ankle-deep-in-the-real stood — arranged back to back in a formation so practiced it had clearly been drilled, weapons and auras already live.

They had been summoned mid-evening from somewhere with a dinner table; one of them was still holding chopsticks. This detail made the formation more frightening, not less. It takes a certain kind of household to go from dinner to war-footing in the space of a teleport.

The theatre got its first look at the family of Issei Hyoudou.

At the point of the formation: a tall young woman with crimson hair to her waist and eyes of a blue that had never once asked permission, wrapped in an aura of black-red annihilation that made Wanda Maximoff's head come up like a hound's. Beside her, a taller girl with a violet-eyed smile and a long black ponytail, golden lightning crawling up her forearms with what could only be described as *enthusiasm*. A blue-haired swordswoman had materialized already drawing — the blade she pulled from empty air so loudly holy that three separate demonic entities hissed on reflex — and on her left a brown-haired girl with twin tails had summoned a spear of pure light and white angel wings, holding that position like someone who had held it in a hundred fights. A small blonde girl raised trembling hands wrapped in green healing light and planted herself, terrified and immovable, in front of everyone as if her body were a shield, which made half the street-level rows fall in love with her instantly. A very

small white-haired girl with cat ears had dropped into a stance that Danny Rand and Shang-Chi both leaned forward to study. A taller, black-haired woman with matching cat ears and golden eyes had gone smoke-edged and lazy, purple mist coiling off her kimono sleeves, positioned — the tacticians noted — to cover every angle her little sister wasn't. And at the rear, a silver-haired young woman was already, three seconds into arrival, surrounded by forty-one rotating Norse runes and an expression of profound fiscal disapproval.

"Contact," said the crimson-haired one, in the flat calm of a commander. "Unknown location. Akeno?"

"No exits, Rias." The lightning-wreathed one's voice was a purr with a blade in it. "No sky. No ley lines. Ara ara. Someone has built a very expensive box."

"Koneko?"

The small cat-eared girl sniffed the air once. Her nose wrinkled. "...Thousands of people," she reported, deadpan. "Gods. Monsters. Metal men. Grief. Popcorn." A pause. "No Issei."

The crimson-haired girl — Rias Gremory, and by now the entire theatre had made the connection, because they had spent twenty chapters watching a younger version of that face resurrect a murdered boy with eight chess pieces — turned, slowly, and looked out at the risen house lights. At the Avengers, half out of their seats. At the X-Men. At the shining cosmic tiers. At the villains' dark. At several thousand of the most dangerous beings of an entire multiverse, caught mid-popcorn, watching her.

And above them all, frozen on the vast screen where the machine had helpfully paused it: a frame from her own memory. Her own bedroom. Her own younger self, crying over a dying boy.

The theatre watched the Crown Princess of the House of Gremory understand, in one rotation of her head, exactly what this place was and exactly what it had been doing.

The temperature dropped eleven degrees. That was measured; Vision measured it.

"You have," said Rias Gremory, to the assembled Marvel multiverse, in a voice of court-perfect, arctic courtesy, "been watching my husband's life. Without his consent. Without ours." The black-red aura rose off her shoulders like a slow tide coming in. "I am going to give whoever is responsible one opportunity to explain. I recommend it be excellent."

Several things then happened at once, and the theatre would spend days arguing about their order.

Thor stood up, beaming, because Thor's response to nearly all escalations was delight. Carol Danvers stood up glowing, because hers was not. Steve Rogers said "Nobody move" in the voice that worked on gods. The Hulk, interested, knocked over a structural column. And in the villains' dark, Taskmaster

began — quietly, professionally — counting combatants and exits, got as far as *eight and none*, and stopped enjoying his evening.

It was the screen that answered her.

THE AUDIENCE IS NOT RESPONSIBLE, it printed, and for once the font was neither cozy nor cold, but something almost careful. **THE AUDIENCE IS ALSO BOUND HERE. THEY CANNOT LEAVE. THEY CANNOT ALTER WHAT IS SHOWN. THEY WERE BROUGHT TO LEARN ISSEI HYOUDOU.**

"Learn him," repeated Rias. "Why."

The screen flashed, one frame, the line the theatre had learned to dread:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

The eight women went very still — a different stillness. The theatre, which had spent twenty chapters being unsettled by that sentence, watched it land on people who loved him, and understood from their faces that they were not hearing it as prophecy. They were hearing it as a threat aimed at someone whose bedside they had all, at one time or another, occupied.

"Ara ara," said Akeno Himejima at last, softly, and the lightning on her arms did not diminish so much as *braid* itself, patient now, worse. "It wants to point our Issei at something. How familiar. Everyone always wants to point him at something." Her smile was serene and her eyes were not. "The last several who tried are variously dead, sealed, or reformed and doing community service."

"Spoilers, Akeno," said Koneko.

SPOILER SUPPRESSION ACTIVE, confirmed the screen, primly, and a soft *bleep* trimmed the end off Akeno's next sentence, to her visible, dangerous amusement.

The blue-haired swordswoman — the captions had labelled her **XENOVIA QUARTA** with a small holy-sword icon — had not lowered her blade, because she processed situations in her own order. "I have questions," she announced, to the entire theatre, in the tone of someone reading requirements off a checklist. "One. Is this a hostile force? Two. If it is a hostile force, is it the kind Durandal can cut? Three —" she looked at the impossible ceiling, the sealed geometry, the audience of thousands — "if we destroy this building, does the multiverse fall out?"

"Xenovia, we are *in* the building," said the twin-tailed angel girl — **IRINA SHIDOU**, said the caption, with a halo icon and, inexplicably, a childhood-photo icon.

"That has not always stopped us."

"That has *never* stopped us, that's the *problem*—"

"If I may." Doctor Strange descended the aisle with his hands open and empty, which for Strange was a diplomatic concession on the order of disarmament. "Stephen Strange. Sorcerer Supreme of this Earth — of one of these Earths. What the screen says is true. We are prisoners, same as you. We've watched because we were given nothing else to do." He paused, and then, being fundamentally honest under all the cape: "Though I won't pretend we haven't argued about him like he was ours to argue about. You're owed that admission."

"You are owed nothing, and she should incinerate the room on principle," remarked Mephisto pleasantly, from the dark, because chaos was free.

Rias's gaze went to Mephisto and stopped there.

Every head in the theatre turned with it. The demon lord of one multiverse and the devil princess of another examined each other across the risen house lights, professional to professional, and the room held its breath waiting to see which apex predator blinked.

"You," said Rias, "are a devil."

"Guilty. Chronically." Mephisto spread his hands, delighted to be perceived. "And an *admirer*, Lady Gremory. Of one transaction in particular." He leaned forward, and there it was — the question he had been paying into for twenty chapters, the question the entire theatre had wanted answered since chapter one. "Eight Pawns. Every Pawn you would ever have, spent in one evening, on a dying pervert with no name and no prospects. I have run that trade ten thousand ways and it prices as madness. What did you *see*?"

The theatre leaned in. Uatu leaned in. Somewhere in the dark, Doom's pen was already moving.

Rias Gremory looked at the frozen frame of her own memory above her — the dying boy, the crimson circle — and her arctic court-face did something small and human and completely unbothered by its audience.

"Nothing," she said. "I saw nothing, devil. It was dark, he was dying, and the pieces would not stop until there were eight of them on his chest." She turned back to Mephisto, and her smile was her mother's, which is to say, a diplomatic incident. "You mistake me for a buyer. I wasn't purchasing an asset. I was refusing to let a boy die alone in the dark on his first date. The value came *after*. That's the part your kind never prices correctly: it never exists until you've already paid."

Silence. Then, from the young-heroes rows, Kamala Khan burst into applause, entirely alone, was mortified, and discovered that the sound had broken something open — because a wave of it followed, rolling up through the street-level rows, the Spider-family, half the X-Men, and one (1) rapidly self-silencing Ravager.

Mephisto sat back with the expression of a man who has just watched the market do something religious. "No wonder the boy is incorruptible," he murmured. "He was *founded* wrong. You can't buy out a company whose opening capital was a gift."

Introductions, after that, happened the way weather happens: everywhere, unevenly, and beyond anyone's control.

The small blonde one broke formation first. This surprised the tacticians, who had pegged her as the protected asset — and then it stopped surprising anyone, because **ASIA ARGENTO** (caption icon: green rings; second icon: a small church, crossed out; the street rows remembered her story, and hurt) walked to the edge of the stage, bowed formally to several thousand of the most dangerous beings in existence, and said:

"Um. Thank you for being sad when Issei died."

The theatre — a room containing Thanos — did not know where to put itself.

"We watched some of it. Just now, while everyone was shouting. The screen showed us the first night here. When he — the spear." Her hands were knotted in front of her, and her voice wobbled and did not stop. "People he never met were sad for him, and angry for him, and some of you wanted to avenge him even though he was a stranger. He would say that's the coolest thing that ever happened to him. He would be *unbearable* about it." A watery, luminous smile. "So. Thank you for loving him a little. We know how easy it is."

Frank Castle looked at the floor. Logan looked at the ceiling. Daredevil, who could hear eight heartbeats and knew exactly which parts of that speech had been hardest to say, put his hand over his mouth like a man in church.

"Oh no," Kamala whispered to Peter, wiping her face with her sleeve. "It's the healer. It's always the healer. I have no defenses against the healer."

The very small cat-eared one — **KONEKO TOUJOU**, said the caption, with a cat icon, a chess-rook icon, and, after a moment's consideration by the machine, a warning icon — conducted her own diplomacy. It consisted of walking the aisles in silence, sniffing selected legends of the Marvel multiverse, and issuing verdicts.

"Smells like metal and old grief," she reported, in front of Logan. "Approved." In front of Spider-Man, upside down and rigid with the effort of being respectful: "Smells like guilt and web fluid. Approved." She paused longest in front of Frank Castle, who met her yellow stare without blinking, and the theatre remembered — because the screen unhelpfully displayed the memo — that this man had privately *marked* Raynare in chapter one.

"You put a mark on the fallen angel," Koneko said. "The one who killed him."

"Yeah," said Frank.

"Save your bullet." Nothing moved in the deadpan little face. "Rias melted her years ago."

The villains' gallery made a low, involuntary, professional sound, like an auction house seeing a lot withdrawn. Frank Castle studied the crimson-haired princess across the theatre for a long moment — the princess who was at that moment coldly renegotiating spectatorship rights with a cosmic machine — and then nodded once, the nod of a man closing a file.

"Good," he said.

Her elder sister worked the *other* aisle. **KUROKA** — caption icons: a cat, a bishop piece, and a lengthy criminal record that scrolled for visibly longer than anyone else's — had slunk into the villains' dark within ninety seconds of arrival, as though she'd read the seating chart in a previous life, and draped herself over an empty chair between Loki and Taskmaster with a warmth that alarmed them both.

"Nya. So *this* is the naughty section," she said, approvingly. "Cozy. Bad lighting, good posture, everyone doing math about my family. I used to sit in rooms like this." She let that hang, golden eyes half-lidded and not remotely soft. "Word of admin from a retired professional: the math doesn't work. You're all thinking, *eight of them, leverage, pressure points*. I know — I thought in pressure points too, once. It's very soothing. But you saw what the little red boyfriend does when someone touches Asia." She smiled, and every predator in that gallery recognized the smile as one of their own, which was precisely the problem. "Now imagine eight of us, nya. And imagine that we are *not* the restraint in this family. We are what the restraint protects *you* from."

"I like her," said Loki, to no one, in the tone of a man reporting a symptom.

"She was a criminal," observed Kang, coldly. "It's in her file."

"*Was*, nya." Kuroka examined her nails. "He forgives people. It's the most annoying thing about him. It's why I'm getting married in a white kimono instead of dying in a cell." She flicked her golden eyes up at the time-conqueror, and just for a moment the playfulness parted like mist off a cliff face. "You should hope you never meet him. He'd probably forgive you too. You don't survive that, you know. You just become somebody new who owes him."

Mephisto, two seats down, wrote that sentence somewhere behind his eyes and filed it under *known toxins*.

Meanwhile the silver-haired one had located, without difficulty, the two most fiscally responsible entities in the theatre, and was having the evening of her life in the worst way. **ROSSWEISSE** — caption icons: Valkyrie helm, rook piece, and a stack of coupons that made her groan aloud when she

saw it — stood surveying the impossible architecture with an expression the theatre's accountants recognized in their bones.

"This structure is dimensionally sealed, self-repairing, and climate-controlled for several thousand occupants of wildly incompatible biologies," she said, to Vision, because he looked like someone who would know. "What is the energy budget. Who *pays* for this."

"Unknown," said Vision. "The theatre appears to draw on—"

"Because if a facility of this size is being run *rent-free* to force strangers to watch my fiancé's most embarrassing moments in ultra-high definition," Rossweisse continued, over him, gathering momentum like a fjord flood, "then someone has effectively set *infinite money on fire* for the purpose of ruining my honeymoon planning, and I will find the line item, and I will have *words*—"

"A VALKYRIE!" boomed Thor, arriving like a festival. "I knew it! The bearing, the runework, the righteous anger about budgets! Sister-in-arms, well met! Tell me, how fares Odin All-Father in your—"

"*Your* Odin or *my* Odin?" Rossweisse pinched the bridge of her nose. "Because if he is anything like my former employer, he is currently reading indecent magazines somewhere and letting his security detail — which was *me* — do his paperwork." She stopped. Composed herself. Bowed, with full formal precision, because she was, under all of it, a professional. "Forgive me. Rossweisse. Ex-Valkyrie, current teacher, future wife. Your Majesty's reputation precedes you even across cosmologies, and I am — genuinely honored, and also *someone here is going to explain the catering costs to me before this night ends*."

Thor turned to the theatre at large, misty-eyed, and declared, "I love this family."

It was Irina and Xenovia who changed the room's temperature back, between them, without meaning to.

Irina had found the young heroes. It was inevitable; she was the same wattage. Within minutes she was sitting backwards on a chair in front of Kamala and Peter and half the champions' row, wings tucked, chopsticks (she had kept the chopsticks) gesturing, cheerfully cross-examining them about being teenage soldiers of dubious institutions, a subject on which all present had opinions.

"—so *he* got resurrected as a devil, and *I* got reincarnated as an angel, which technically makes us a workplace-compliance nightmare," she was explaining, glowing faintly. "But my church said love that protects people is the point of the whole thing, so! Heaven approved the engagement. There was *paperwork*." She beamed with an aggressive purity that made Peter feel he should hydrate more and call his aunt. "Also I've known him since we were little, so I have blackmail-quality memories from before *any* of these women, which in a harem is called *seniority*."

"It is called being seventh in the engagement order, Irina," said Xenovia, from three feet away.

"IT'S CALLED SENIORITY."

"I need — okay. Sorry. Hi. Question." Kamala had her hand up. She had had her hand up for some time. "Big fan, love the formation you guys did, very cool, extremely scared of all of you. But — the *arrangement*." She gestured at the eight of them, scattered across a theatre they had conquered in an hour. "Eight fiancées. And you all just — work? Like, we've been watching this show for twenty chapters and half this room keeps arguing about whether it's a red flag, and now you're actually *here*, and I have to know, because from outside it reads either really beautiful or really—"

"Complicated," said Peter quickly.

"I was going to say *fanfictiony*."

Xenovia handled it, because Xenovia handled every question at the same setting: maximum bluntness, zero shame.

"It works because we decided it would, and then we did the work," she said. "People think the number is the hard part. The number is arithmetic. The hard part is the one everyone has — being known and staying anyway — multiplied by nine." She sheathed Durandal, finally, lowering the room's ambient holiness to survivable levels. "He fell in love with all of us stupidly, one at a time, usually while bleeding. We fell the same way. We fought about it; some of us fought *literally*; I have dents. Then we built rules, like a peerage, or a sword style. Nest law." She looked around the theatre, blunt as a hammer and twice as honest. "You have a man of iron and a soldier out of time and a wizard surgeon, and you form *teams* and call it found family. We formed a family and everyone calls it scandal. I do not understand the difference. Possibly the difference is marketing."

The theatre's cultural-analysis section — T'Challa, notably, and one entire row of thoroughly divorced Asgardians — began arguing about that sentence immediately, and would not stop for three chapters.

But it was Rias who closed the night, because the stage had always been hers.

She had finished her negotiation with the machine — negotiation being a generous word for what had occurred; the screen would later display terms and the terms would favor House Gremory — and now she stood at center stage, beneath the frozen frame of her own younger self, with her seven co-fiancées drifting into formation around her as naturally as iron filings finding north.

"We cannot go home," she announced, to the theatre, "until the machine's purpose is served. So. Terms." She raised one finger. "One. We stay. If you are going to watch my husband's life, you will watch it with the eight people who can tell you when the machine is lying by omission — *within*," a glare at the screen, "the spoiler rules."

ACCEPTABLE, said the screen.

"Two. We are not exhibits. The next being who points a scanner, a probability engine, or a *sonnet* at any of my sisters without permission will be returned to their seat in a number of pieces I have not yet decided." The black-red aura flickered, briefly, in the shape of good manners. "Three. When the machine shows something private — and it will; I have seen tonight's banner and I know what our life contains — you are permitted to laugh. He would want you to laugh; he is, God help us all—" (she winced; three of the eight winced; Irina's halo fizzed) "—*funny*. But you will laugh the way family laughs. At the table. Not through the window."

She surveyed them — Avengers, X-Men, gods, monsters, the villains' respectful dark, one Watcher whose vast pale face was turned toward her like a man rereading a page that had changed — and the theatre understood that its power dynamic had been rewritten in an evening. For twenty chapters they had watched a boy who did not know he was being watched. That innocence was over. The story had noticed them back, and the story had *standards*, and the story's standards were currently generating a black-red aura at center stage.

"Agreed?" said Rias Gremory.

Several thousand of the deadliest beings in the Marvel multiverse said, in effect, yes ma'am.

"Good." She sat down — front row, center, in seats the theatre swore had not existed that morning: eight of them, warm gold, upholstered like a bakery menu. "Then somebody explain the popcorn system to Rossweisse before she audits it, and *roll the next pull*."

Far above, the wheel rose home, humming — and no one who had watched it scream and shatter its own bowl could quite call the hum anything but satisfied. Uatu the Watcher stared up at it and did not sit for a long time.

Malfunction, he thought. *A machine that has never misprinted a comma. And tonight, by accident, it acquires eight witnesses who love him, embeds them in the audience, and teaches this room that the boy's family is an army.*

Nothing was summoned tonight, thought the Watcher, who existed to watch and had just been watched by a machine, *except on purpose*.

The screen dimmed to warm gold, and rang its little doorbell, and printed the hook it had been saving all evening:

NEXT PULL PREPARING.

RUMOR LEDGER DETECTED IN AUDIENCE SPECULATION: "SEVENTEEN WIVES."

THE MANAGEMENT LOOKS FORWARD TO THE CORRECTIONS.

From the front row, in the dark, came eight distinct sighs — regal, sultry, blunt, chirpy, gentle, deadpan, purring, and *fiscal* — and then, faintly, the sound of Rossweisse asking whether corrections were billable.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *"Summoning Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Asia, Koneko, Kuroka and Rossweisse"* — Family-Class. The gacha's first-ever **physical instantiation**: instead of a vision, the wheel "malfunctioned," shattered its crystal bowl into a Gremory summoning circle, and pulled all eight of Issei's canonical fiancées bodily into the theatre — mid-dinner, combat-ready in seconds. They cannot be sent home until the machine's purpose is served, and now occupy eight permanent warm-gold seats in the front row.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Raynare is long dead — Rias executed her years ago (Koneko told Frank Castle to "save your bullet"; Castle and Logan closed their private mark). Mephisto's twenty-chapter question answered: Rias saw *nothing* when she spent all eight Pawns — it was mercy, not investment, which Mephisto now reads as the root of Issei's incorruptibility ("founded wrong; opening capital was a gift"). The brides come from later in Issei's timeline than the screen has shown and know his future — but a **SPOILER SUPPRESSION** protocol audibly bleeps them. Rossweisse's cosmology contains its own Odin (her ex-employer) and, implied before suppression, its own badly behaved Loki. The wives heard the prophecy line and received it as a threat: "everyone always wants to point him at something."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** The theatre's power dynamic is rewritten — the audience is now itself observed, and bound by Rias's three terms (the wives stay as context-givers; no scanning/probing the brides; laughter allowed only "the way family laughs"). Asia's thank-you speech disarmed the street-level rows completely; Koneko "approved" Logan, Spider-Man, and (implicitly) Castle by scent; Thor has adopted the entire family on the strength of one Valkyrie budget rant; Kamala Khan is now the brides' informal liaison to the young heroes; Xenovia's "found family vs. scandal is marketing" line has ignited a standing cultural debate (T'Challa's section). The villains' hostage-math collapsed on contact: Taskmaster counted eight combatants and no exits, Kuroka personally briefed the dark gallery that the wives "are not the restraint in this family," and Kang filed her warning that Issei's forgiveness is the true unsurvivable weapon.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Uatu is convinced the "malfunction" was deliberate — the machine that never misprints staged an accident to embed eight loving witnesses and prove Issei's family is an army; *why does its purpose need them here in person?* What exactly did Rias's off-page "negotiation" with the machine win House Gremory? The spoiler-suppressed future the brides carry (including

whatever Akeno almost said about dead/sealed/reformed enemies). And the screen's parting banner has already seeded next chapter's chaos: an audience rumor-ledger claiming "**SEVENTEEN WIVES**" — corrections pending.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Seventeen Wives?

Primary Reaction Groups: Cultural analysts (T'Challa, Magneto, Doom, Namor) • The Ravagers & Guardians (Yondu, Star-Lord, Gamora, Rocket, Drax, Nebula, Mantis, Kraglin) • Corporate strategists (Pepper Potts, Maria Hill) • Cosmic observers (Uatu, Silver Surfer, Fin Fang Foom)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Girls' Club of Hell" — **Comedy-Class**
 2. "Marriage Ledger" — **Secret**
-

The theatre had spent one whole chapter marinating in the Family-Class banner's warm domestic gold, and it had not gotten used to it. Twenty chapters of war-red and grief-grey had trained the audience for a certain register, and now the impossible ceiling glowed like a kitchen window at dinnertime, and the gacha wheel descended with its new doorbell chime, and half the room's most dangerous people sat there feeling ambushed by coziness.

The previous night's pull had introduced the eight — Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Asia, Koneko, Kuroka, Rossweisse — as living, arguing, laughing fixtures of the boy's life rather than names in a caption, and the theatre was still recalibrating. Tonight, before anyone had settled, the screen did something administrative.

It posted a dossier.

SUBJECT: ISSEI HYODOU. AGE: SEVENTEEN. OCCUPATION: HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT; PAWN OF THE GREMORY PEERAGE; RED DRAGON EMPEROR.

WIVES: SEVENTEEN (17).

The theatre made a sound like a cathedral organ sitting on a whoopee cushion.

"SEVENTEEN?" Johnny Storm was on his feet. "He's seventeen and he has seventeen — that's a wife per *year of being alive*—"

"The math is not the problem, Johnny," said Peter Parker faintly.

Down in the Guardians' crash-landed quadrant of seating, Rocket Raccoon stood up on his chair, cupped his little paws around his muzzle, and bellowed at the screen with the pure joy of a creature discovering a new lever to pull.

"HEY. HEY, SCREEN. Serious question. How many love interests does one guy actually *need*? Asking for inventory purposes. Is there a bulk discount? Does he get a punch card? Ten wives, eleventh wife free—"

Gamora smacked him. Open palm, back of the head, the crisp economical stroke of a woman who had performed this exact maintenance operation ten thousand times across four galaxies. Rocket's ears went flat.

"Seventeen," he muttered, rubbing his head, "and not one of 'em would'a stopped that."

"All seventeen of them would have stopped that," said Gamora.

But up in the analysts' tier, T'Challa had not laughed. The king of Wakanda was frowning at the dossier with the specific expression of a man who has read many intelligence briefings and can smell a bad one through the paper.

"Note the sourcing," he said quietly, and the screen — which had developed, over twenty-one chapters, an unsettling responsiveness to good questions — obligingly enlarged the citation line at the bottom of the dossier.

SOURCE: "MIDNIGHT UNDERWORLD," DEVIL-SOCIETY WEEKLY GOSSIP PERIODICAL. CIRCULATION: 40 MILLION. ACCURACY RATING: [CALCULATING...]

"A tabloid," said T'Challa. "The machine is citing a tabloid."

"The machine," said Doctor Strange slowly, from across the aisle, "has never cited *anything* before. It has simply been right."

And that — more than the number seventeen — was what made a certain kind of person in that theatre sit forward. Uatu the Watcher turned his vast pale head a full degree. The machine that had shown them twenty-one chapters of unimpeachable truth had just repeated a rumor, and either it had made its first error, or it was about to teach them something about the difference between what is said and what is written down.

The wheel spun. The token dropped — a chattering, kaleidoscopic thing that giggled audibly on impact — and the bowl chimed.

PULL ONE: "GIRLS' CLUB OF HELL" — COMEDY-CLASS.

LET THE RECORD BE CONTESTED.

The vision opened on a house.

The theatre knew the Hyoudou residence by now — knew that it had begun the story as a perfectly ordinary suburban home and had since been rebuilt by devil contractors into something with six stories underground, a ballroom, a training floor, and a bath large enough to have weather. What the theatre had not seen was a full ordinary day inside it, and the gacha, in a mood, gave them one at gently accelerated speed.

Morning: a fourteen-person breakfast assembled with military precision, Rias directing, Akeno humming over a pan, Asia carrying a stack of plates taller than her own composure. Koneko ate four servings in silence and then, without ceremony, climbed onto Issei's lap to finish her fifth, and the boy's soul visibly left his body and returned. Kuroka draped herself across the back of his chair like a shawl with opinions until Rossweisse — silver-haired, furious, holding a household budget spreadsheet — pried her off by the collar while lecturing about *per-capita grocery outlays*. Xenovia announced her training schedule at parade volume. Irina said grace at a table of devils, cheerfully, and nobody stopped her.

School. Club. Homework — Issei's, supervised in shifts, because his brides had a rota for it. Evening: Ravel Phenex arrived with a leather folio and ran the entire household's next week like a chief of staff born to it; Kunou — visiting from Kyoto, having ditched her diplomatic escort — orbited Issei at knee height demanding to be carried; Le Fay Pendragon blushed through a library wall whenever his voice carried; Elmenhilde Karnstein critiqued everyone's tea and stayed four hours past the visit she had described as "brief and reluctant." Ingvid Leviathan sang, half to herself, at a window, and the house went quiet to listen without being asked.

And through it all moved the boy — loud, embarrassing, transparently overjoyed — carrying, fetching, apologizing, blushing, working. The comedic register was exactly what the theatre expected from a Comedy-Class pull: a bath-schedule dispute resolved by rock-paper-scissors tournament bracket (the screen tastefully cut to the hallway, where Issei sat guarding the door with the haunted discipline of a man defusing a bomb); a two-front pillow war; Koneko dead-panning "pervert" at him as both verdict and endearment.

"Fourteen," counted Mantis, delighted, her antennae glowing. "There are fourteen ladies and every single one is *happy*. This house feels like—" she groped for it, hands fluttering, "—like a hug that argues."

Then, on-screen, catastrophe arrived by mail slot.

A magazine. Glossy. *MIDNIGHT UNDERWORLD*, banner headline in flaming infernal type: **RED DRAGON EMPEROR'S SEVENTEEN BRIDES — THE HAREM THAT ATE THE GREMORY FORTUNE — EXCLUSIVE!!**

The house went still the way a fault line goes still.

"Seventeen," said Rias Gremory, in the tone her brother probably used to end wars.

"Seventeen?" said Akeno, sweetly, with thunder in it. "My, my. Ambitious of them."

Ravel Phenex snapped her folio open on the table like a magistrate opening court. "They have counted *wrong*," she said, with the outrage of a professional confronting amateur arithmetic, "and I can tell you exactly how, because I have read their correction history and they always count wrong the same way. They have included Grayfia-sama — a *married woman* and the strongest queen in the underworld, they will die for that — they have included Lady Miki, who is his *mother* — and they have included Kibasan. *Again*."

The theatre detonated.

On-screen, Yuuto Kiba — the peerage's knight, golden-haired, tragically beautiful — put his face in his hands. "It's the third time," he said, muffled. "I am *visibly* holding a sword in the photograph."

In the theatre, Star-Lord was wheezing. Yondu was grinning his whole crooked steel grin. Even Nebula's mouth moved a millimeter, which among her people constituted hysterics.

And then Rossweisse — Valkyrie, former bodyguard of Odin, current civil servant and the newest of the eight — stood, produced from thin air an actual document case with actual stamped seals, and addressed the tabloid as though it were a defendant.

"The legal record," she said, with Nordic bureaucratic fury, "is *public*. Formal engagements, registered and sealed, in order of recognition: Rias Gremory. Akeno Himejima. Xenovia Quarta. Irina Shidou. Asia Argento. Koneko Toujou. Kuroka. And—" the tiniest hitch, a blush fighting a filing system, "—myself. *Eight*. Eight brides. Fourteen members of this — this *association*—" she gestured at the breakfast-table chaos with the despair of a woman who did that household's taxes, "—fourteen who love him, and only some of us have completed the paperwork, and paperwork *matters*—"

"The Girls' Club of Hell," said Kuroka lazily, tail curling, entirely pleased with the name. "Fourteen seats, nya. Eight with rings."

"*Not yet rings*," said Ravel, strangled, staring at her own folio, at a particular drafted-but-unsigned page in her own immaculate handwriting, and going the color of her family's firebird crest.

Rias picked up the magazine, held it at arm's length, and let a small, polite sphere of the Power of Destruction reduce it to a smell.

CORRECTION, said the theatre's screen — and the word arrived in a register the machine had never used, stamped diagonally across its own earlier dossier in glowing red, the way a clerk voids a check.

FORMAL ENGAGEMENTS: EIGHT (8). ADDITIONAL BONDED HEARTS, UNREGISTERED: SIX (6) — RAVEL PHENEX, KUNOU, LE FAY PENDRAGON, ELMENHILDE KARNSTEIN, INGVILD LEVIATHAN, YASAKA.

"SEVENTEEN" IS FANON. THE LEDGER IS CANON.

THE SYSTEM REGRETS THE ERROR. THE SYSTEM DOES NOT REGRET WHAT THE ERROR TAUGHT YOU ABOUT YOURSELVES.

The theatre sat with that for a moment.

"It baited us," said Maria Hill flatly. "The omniscient doom theatre just ran a *media literacy exercise*."

"And every one of us engaged with the headline before checking the source," said T'Challa, and had the grace to include himself with a small, rueful gesture. "Every nation in this room has been governed worse than that house is. Continue."

The reactions came in waves, and the fascinating thing — the thing the theatre itself seemed to be orchestrating — was that no two factions were reacting to the same marriage.

The Ravagers went first, because the Ravagers had no concept of waiting a turn.

"I'll tell you what I'm seein'," said Yondu Udonta, toothpick wandering, "and it ain't wives. Y'all are hung up on the word." He jabbed the toothpick at the frozen frame of the breakfast table. "Look at the *table*. Fourteen mouths, everybody fed, everybody's got a job, everybody'd take a hit for the little idiot at the head of it and he'd take one for any of them — first, and *twice*. That ain't a harem, that's a *crew*. Boy's flyin' a fourteen-hand ship and don't even know he's captain." He leaned back. "You don't count a crew in wives. You count it in who shows up when the hull breaks."

"On my planet," said Drax, with the enormous gravity he reserved for his gentlest memories, "a man took one wife. Mine was named Ovette. She filled my entire heart, and my heart is very large, as is the rest of me." A pause; the theatre held still for him. "If this boy's heart truly holds fourteen without cheating any of them, it is his *capacity* that impresses. I will watch for cheating. I do not expect to find it."

"There's no cheating," said Mantis softly, hands pressed together. "I felt the room. When he looks at each one, the feeling is not *divided*. It is not a pie. It is — fourteen whole feelings. I did not know that was allowed."

"It's not allowed," said Rocket. "It's *rigged*. Nobody gets fourteen— OW. I was AGREEING with the bug lady—"

"You were not," said Gamora.

Then the corporate wing weighed in, and the register changed from crew to conglomerate.

"Set the romance aside for one minute," said Pepper Potts, in her board-meeting voice, and the analysts' tier actually turned to listen, because Pepper Potts's board-meeting voice had ended more empires than most armies. "Look at the structure. Rias Gremory — founding partner, controlling interest, and don't miss that she *spent her entire acquisition budget on him in chapter one*; eight Pawns, all-in, everyone said she overpaid. Akeno, senior partner. Church faction onboarded — twice, Xenovia *and* Irina, that's a cross-denominational merger nobody thought survivable. Asia is the entire wellness division. Koneko and Kuroka reconcile a family dispute that predates the company. Rossweisse is Asgardic talent poached at below-market — that's the hire that tells you the culture's real." She ticked the last one on her thumb. "And Ravel Phenex is the chief operating officer of the whole household, running it flawlessly, *without a contract*, because she is choosing her own timing. This isn't a harem, Maria. This is the most successful alliance rollup in that cosmology, and every single stakeholder retained full voting rights."

"I ran it as a security file," said Maria Hill. "Fourteen principals, six factions of origin — devils, fallen-adjacent, two churches, youkai royalty, Asgard, and whatever the vampire is — all under one roof, zero leaks, zero defections, zero interfaction incidents beyond pillow warfare." She shook her head slowly. "SHIELD couldn't keep three agencies in one building without a stabbing. His retention secret is apparently *sincerity*. I can't file that. There's no form for it."

And then, from the high cold tier where the crowned heads sat, the conversation the outline of history always produces: three men who had each married, or refused to marry, for nations.

"Doom will state the obvious, since no one else appears equipped," said Doom. "Marriage is statecraft. It has always been statecraft; the songs are decoration. What Doom observes in this ledger is a boy who has contracted alliances with the Gremory dukedom, the Phenex estate, the Church, the youkai court of Kyoto, Asgard's civil service, and the blood of the original Leviathan—" a pause of genuine, grudging perplexity, "—and has extracted *nothing*. No territory. No titles. No dowries. The single most valuable bachelor in his civilization is giving it away for *affection*. Doom finds this either sublime or imbecilic, and is irritated to report the data favors sublime."

"Atlantis has sealed wars with weddings," said Namor, arms crossed, regarding the screen with imperial detachment. "I was nearly such a seal myself, more than once. The custom is older than your surface nations and more honest than your treaties — a marriage is a hostage exchange in which the hostages are permitted to be happy." His eyes narrowed, not unkindly. "What is *rare* — what I have seen perhaps twice in a century of thrones — is the political marriage in which the politics are incidental. Those women gain standing by him, yes. They would keep him if he were still nothing. That was true when he was a Pawn who could barely fly. Imperius Rex; even I can read a court."

Magneto had been silent through all of it.

Erik Lehnsherr sat very still in the analysts' tier, and when he finally spoke, the comedy drained out of the room's edges, because his voice had the sound of a man handling something personal with gloves.

"You are all analyzing the wrong institution," he said. "You see a harem, or a merger, or a court. Look *underneath*. The devils of that world fought a three-way war that killed their God and gutted their own aristocracy — seventy-two great houses, half extinct or barren, a species that reproduces slowly, rebuilding on the edge of demographic collapse. Their Evil Pieces, their peerages, and yes, the plural marriages of their great houses — all of it is one thing: a *people refusing to disappear*." His folded hands tightened slightly. "I have watched a people count its survivors. I have sat in the rooms where the arithmetic of continuation is done, and there is no colder mathematics anywhere. And into that arithmetic walks this ridiculous, warm-hearted boy — and performs the coldest institution his society possesses *for love*, lawfully, gently, with the enthusiastic consent of every party and the blessing of their houses." He sat back. "Mock the number if you must. I look at that ledger and I see a graveyard civilization planting a garden. I will not be laughing."

The silence after that lasted long enough that Rocket, mercifully, did not fill it.

T'Challa inclined his head, slow and formal, the acknowledgment of one king's framework by another. "Then let us name what has happened here tonight," he said, "because it is the theatre's real lesson, and it is a good one. Every faction in this room looked at one household and saw a different institution — Yondu saw a crew. Ms. Potts saw an alliance. Namor saw statecraft. Erik saw survival. The romantics —" a glance at the Spider-family's row, where several people pretended to be elsewhere, "—saw romance, and they were not wrong either. *All* frameworks returned the same finding: fourteen women, freely choosing, none diminished. When every lens agrees on the dignity of the arrangement, the arrangement is sound, whatever it is called. Wakanda would recognize such a house." A beat, and the king permitted himself one dry note: "Wakanda would also assign it a larger security detail than mine."

The wheel had waited politely for the debate to crest. Now it spun again — and the theatre's warm gold dimmed several shades toward candlelight, and the second token fell without any chime at all. Secret-class pulls never chimed. The room had learned to brace when the machine went quiet.

PULL TWO: "MARRIAGE LEDGER" — SECRET.

EVERY RECORD HAS A FIRST PAGE. YOU HAVE NOT SEEN THE FIRST PAGE.

The vision was not a scene. It was a *document* — the actual registry, bound in Gremory crimson, kept (the caption noted) by Grayfia Lucifuge herself, and the gacha turned it one page at a time in enormous light above the theatre floor.

The eight entries, in order, each with its seals: Gremory. Himejima. Quarta. Shidou. Argento. Toujou. Kuroka's, sealed not with a house crest but a single black cat's paw pressed deliberately off-center, like a signature refusing to pretend it came from nobility. Rossweisse's, notarized in triplicate, obviously by the bride. Beneath the formal eight: six drafted lines, unsigned — one of them, in handwriting the theatre had just learned to recognize as Ravel's, complete down to the date format *except the date* — and beside each entry, a column headed TERMS.

Every single TERMS column read the same way.

TERMS: NONE. HE ASKED FOR NOTHING.

"There it is," murmured Doom, to his notebook, which had reopened.

But the gacha turned backward, to the page before page one — the flyleaf, where a first entry had been made and then struck through so hard the pen had scored the vellum. The theatre leaned in, and read, and stopped breathing at roughly the same moment.

ENTRY ZERO: "YUUMA AMANO." FIRST GIRLFRIEND. FIRST DATE. FALSE NAME, FALSE HEART — RAYNARE OF THE FALLEN. RECORD ANNULLED IN BLOOD, KUOH CITY FOUNTAIN PLAZA.

THE FIRST NAME IN THE LEDGER IS A WOUND. EVERY NAME AFTER IT IS A COURAGE.

HE HAS NEVER ONCE ASSUMED A YES. THE BOY WHO DREAMS ALOUD OF A HAREM HAS NEVER TAKEN A SINGLE HEART FOR GRANTED, BECAUSE THE FIRST TIME HE OFFERED HIS OWN, IT WAS RETURNED THROUGH HIS CHEST.

In the street-level rows, nobody spoke. Frank Castle's jaw did something quiet and terrible; Logan's knuckles, resting on his knees, flexed once. The theatre had known since chapter one that those two had privately marked Raynare's name. The ledger had just co-signed it.

"That's the engine," said Matt Murdock softly, sightless face tilted toward a document he could hear the room reading. "That's why he's loud about wanting love and paralyzed about receiving it. The bravado's a splint. Fourteen women figured out the fracture underneath and decided, independently, to be careful with it. *That's* the club. That's what they actually have in common."

And then, for the dragons, the caption changed register one last time — and the theatre heard Ddraig's voice, drawn from some remembered fireside conversation, laid gently over the closing image of the crowded, golden, arguing house:

"Humans call it a harem and snicker, partner. Dragons have an older word. A dragon does not collect treasure to spend it — a dragon builds a NEST, and the nest is the one place in creation the dragon will die rather than yield. You have built yours out of people. It is the strongest architecture I have ever sheltered in, and I have lived in war for ten thousand years."

"Nest law is one law: everything inside the walls is worth everything outside them."

High in the god-tiers, Thor set down his cup entirely, which those who knew him understood to be his highest observance. "Nest law," he repeated, reverent. "Aye. My father's vaults had such a law. His halls did not. The boy has chosen better than a king."

Fin Fang Foom — who had spent twenty-one chapters radiating contempt for a "true" dragon leashed to a human boy — was silent for a long moment, foreclaws flexing on the seatback he had crushed into modern sculpture weeks ago. "The nest is real," he finally rumbled, with the physical difficulty of a dragon conceding anything. "I have hoarded islands. Weapons. Centuries. It occurs to me—" the words ground out like tectonic plates, "—that none of my hoards would have *carried me down a mountain*. The Welsh Dragon has not been diminished by the boy. He has been *housed*. There is a difference. I am still deciding how I feel about knowing it."

The Silver Surfer, chrome and quiet, added the cosmic footnote. "I surrendered a beloved to save a world, and called the solitude that followed by noble names. Heralds travel light; we tell ourselves power requires it." His gaze stayed on the struck-through first entry, and the fourteen names that had answered it. "This boy is disproving my life's arithmetic one chapter at a time. His anchors do not slow him. They are *why he accelerates*. Norrin Radd is taking notes."

Uatu the Watcher said nothing for a long time — and then, in the voice of a being checking an archive that kept failing him, said the thing that became the night's splinter: "Fourteen bonds. I have traced each one across every timeline in my custody, seeking precedent. As with the boy himself: nothing. But the ledger's final page—" and the vision, obediently, showed it: blank lines awaiting names not yet written, futures not yet chosen. And one line, low on the page, that was not blank and not written — a faint *shimmer*, like the ghost of ink, like an entry that had existed and been *removed*. The same wrongness Heimdall had flagged at the edge of the Dragon Blaster's scar. The mark left when something is taken out of what-is.

"Someone has been *erasing* in this book," said Uatu, very quietly, "and I do not know who, and I am the Watcher, and I do not know who."

The gold light banked. The wheel rose. And the screen, cozy font utterly unrepentant, posted its exit line:

NEXT: EVERY BRIDE COMES FROM A HOUSE. MEET THE HOUSE THAT TAUGHT A DEVIL TO LOVE A PAWN.

THE GREMORY HOUSEHOLD.

"I'm not emotionally prepared for his in-laws," said Peter Parker.

"No one is prepared for in-laws," said Namor, with feeling, and the lights went down.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Girls' Club of Hell* — Comedy-Class; *Marriage Ledger* — Secret. Also the system's first-ever self-**CORRECTION**: it opened by citing a devil tabloid ("seventeen wives"), let the theatre swallow the headline, then voided its own dossier — a deliberate media-literacy sting ("The system regrets the error. The system does not regret what the error taught you about yourselves.").
- **Secrets Revealed:** The record, now canon in the room: **eight formal fiancées** in engagement order — Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Asia, Koneko, Kuroka, Rossweisse — plus **six unregistered bonded hearts** (Ravel, Kunou, Le Fay, Elmenhilde, Ingvild, Yasaka): the fourteen-member "Girls' Club of Hell." The tabloid's seventeen included Grayfia, Issei's mother, and Kiba (third time). The Marriage Ledger's TERMS column reads "NONE — HE ASKED FOR NOTHING" on every entry; Ravel's engagement line is fully drafted in her own hand, undated by her own choice. **Entry Zero:** the ledger's struck-through first name is "Yuuma Amano" — Raynare — annulled in blood; his harem bravado is a splint over a lasting terror of offering his heart, and he has never once assumed a yes. Ddraig's **Nest Law** named the arc: a dragon's nest built out of people, "everything inside the walls is worth everything outside them." Devil society's plural great-house marriages reframed as post-war survival arithmetic (72 Pillars gutted, slow reproduction).
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Every framework converged on the same verdict — Yondu: "a crew, not a harem"; Pepper Potts: a flawless alliance rollup with full stakeholder voting rights; Maria Hill: fourteen principals, six factions, zero defections — unfileable; Doom (notebook reopened despite chapter 20's closure): "sublime, irritatingly"; Namor: a political marriage in which the politics are incidental; Magneto, invoking the arithmetic of peoples facing extinction, declared it "a graveyard civilization planting a garden" and will not tolerate mockery of it; T'Challa formally pronounced the arrangement sound under all lenses. Fin Fang Foom concedes Ddraig has been "housed, not diminished." Silver Surfer begins questioning his Herald's-solitude arithmetic. Drax is auditing for cheating and expects to find none. Rocket was smacked by Gamora (twice) and remains unrepentant.

- **Unresolved Hooks:** The Marriage Ledger's final page holds blank lines for names unwritten — and **one shimmering line that was written and then *removed***, bearing the same excision-signature Heimdall and Uatu flagged on the Dragon Blaster's scar (chapter 20); Uatu: "Someone has been erasing in this book, and I do not know who." Ravel's undated engagement page (pays off in Chapter 25, "Ravel's Ledger"). Frank Castle and Wolverine's mark on Raynare, now co-signed by the ledger itself. Next: Chapter 23, the Gremory household and the politics of peerage.

Chapter Twenty-Three: The Gremory Household

Primary Reaction Groups: Wakanda (T'Challa, Shuri, Okoye, Ramonda) • Latveria (Doctor Doom) • X-Men (Xavier, Magneto, Storm, Nightcrawler, Rogue, Kitty Pryde) • Diplomats & statesmen (Namor, Everett Ross, Maria Hill, Valkyrie, She-Hulk)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Rias's Peerage Dynamics" — **Rare**
 2. "Gremory Family Council" — **Epic**
-

Three nights into the Family-Class banner, the theatre had developed institutions.

It had happened the way institutions always happen: nobody voted, and suddenly they existed. The wives' box — eight thrones of theatre-grown velvet that had assembled themselves the night the gacha misfired and summoned Issei Hyoudou's fiancées into the audience — now had a low brass rail around it and, thanks to Rossweisse, a posted schedule for who was allowed to ask the wives questions and for how long. (The schedule was laminated. No one knew where she had gotten a laminator. No one asked.)

And across the aisle, a second institution had condensed out of the crowd like frost: the diplomats' section. It had begun as Everett Ross dragging a chair over to Maria Hill to compare notes on succession law, and it had accreted — She-Hulk with a legal pad, Valkyrie with a flask and a king's tired eyes, and then, on the high tier above them, the heavy furniture: the Panther Throne's delegation on the left, the Lord of Latveria on the right, and between them, arms folded, standing because sitting implied equality with the room, the Sub-Mariner.

"Two nights of marriage law," Namor said, to no one and therefore to everyone. "The surface world giggling at a boy's betrothals like fishwives. Show me the *structure*. Show me who holds what, and from whom, and what it costs. Then I will tell you what this Gremory girl's house is actually worth."

The gacha wheel came down through the dark with its new domestic chime — that warm little doorbell sound that still made Sam Wilson's eye twitch — and, for once in its smug mechanical life, gave a king exactly what he asked for.

The first token dropped. The bowl rang.

PULL ONE: "RIAS'S PEERAGE DYNAMICS" — RARE.

YOU HAVE SEEN THE PIECES, the screen wrote. **NOW SEE THE HOUSEHOLD.**

In the wives' box, Rias Gremory sat up very straight, crimson hair sliding off her shoulder, and said, with the dignity of a duchess and the dread of a teenager whose parents own photo albums, "Oh no."

The vision opened on snow.

A boy lay dying in it. White-haired winter, a mountain road in Italy, and a child in rags with his breath rattling out of him — and the captions did their brutal economy: **THE HOLY SWORD PROJECT. THE CHURCH'S ATTEMPT TO MANUFACTURE WIELDERS OF EXCALIBUR. THE SUBJECTS WHO FAILED TO MEET SPECIFICATIONS WERE DISPOSED OF. THIS ONE RAN.**

The theatre had watched a boy die in chapter one and had never gotten better at it. But this time the snow lit up crimson, and a girl no older than the dying child stepped out of a teleport circle with her hands already glowing, and the caption said only: **RIAS GREMORY, AGE THIRTEEN, FOUND HIM FIRST.**

"A Knight," she said on-screen, kneeling in the snow, holding out an Evil Piece like it was a blanket. "I need a Knight. Will you live for me instead?"

The vision moved like a hand through photographs. A shrine in Japan and a black-haired girl hiding from men with light-spears, her murdered mother behind her and her fallen-angel blood damning her to both sides at once — **AKENO HIMEJIMA. HUNTED FOR HER FATHER'S WINGS.** — and Rias again, older by a year, offering a hand and asking no questions about the wings at all. A cell in the Devils' capital and a small white-haired girl waiting, without crying, to be executed for her sister's crime — **KONEKO TOUJOU. SENTENCED FOR ANOTHER'S SIN.** — and the Gremory heir arriving with paperwork, a Rook piece, and an expression that several Wakandan generals recognized from their own queen mother. A sealed room in a European castle, garlic hung on the door by his own family, a half-vampire boy who could stop time and had been taught to apologize for existing — **GASPER VLADI. HIS HOUSE FEARED HIS EYES. SHE BOUGHT HIM FROM THEM.**

"Bought him," Magneto repeated, low and dangerous, from the X-Men's tier. "Note the verb. Everyone cooing at this — note the verb."

"Noted," said Charles Xavier quietly. "Keep watching, old friend."

Because the vision had arrived at the clubhouse.

The Occult Research Club, the screen had always called it, and the theatre had always read that as cover identity, headquarters, base. The gacha now corrected the record at length, and the correction was dinner. It was Kiba Yuuto — grown into the kind of handsome that made half the theatre's younger section sit up — burning eggs and being banned from the kitchen by a fourteen-year-old. It was Koneko

asleep on Rias's lap while Rias signed territorial paperwork one-handed rather than wake her. It was Akeno and Rias arguing about a rating-game formation like sisters, which is to say viciously and with tea. It was a sealed cardboard box in the corner with eyes glowing through the hand-holes, and Issei Hyoudou — the theatre's boy, their mountain-erasing, spacetime-bruising constant — sitting cross-legged next to the box for hours, talking to it about video games until the vampire inside forgot to be afraid.

"Come on, Gasper," on-screen Issei said, to the box. "You don't have to come out. But if you *do* come out, I'll teach you the thing where we hide Kiba's sword polish."

A pause. The box said, in a tiny voice, "...he cries when he can't find it."

"He *weeps*," Issei confirmed solemnly, and the box giggled, and the theatre — hardened, ledger-keeping, threat-assessing — made a noise like six hundred people trying not to be charmed and failing on institutional scale.

Then the gacha showed them the night it all became doctrine.

A church, half-destroyed. Kiba Yuuto kneeling among broken Excaliburs with his dead comrades' faces in his eyes — the vision compressed his whole vendetta into a single held breath, the survivor of a poison-gas purge finally facing the sword project that made him — and losing. Coming apart. Choosing revenge over his own life in real time. And Issei Hyoudou grabbing him by the collar, bleeding, furious, and screaming into his perfect face:

"You're not the only one who gets to carry them! You have comrades *now*, you stupid — Rias cried for you! Koneko's *terrified* for you! You're not a stray sword, you're OUR Knight, so live for the ones who died AND the ones who haven't, you absolute — *bishounen*!"

("Did he run out of insult," Kitty Pryde whispered, "and just call him handsome?" "Shh," said Rogue, wiping her eye, "it's workin'.")

It did work. The theatre watched the spirits of murdered children rise out of a broken holy sword and lend their gratitude to the survivor; watched Kiba's Sacred Gear crack past its limit into Balance Breaker; watched a boy forged as a weapon by one institution get reforged as a *person* by another — and the screen stamped the whole vision with a caption that landed in the diplomatic tier like a treaty draft:

THE EVIL PIECE SYSTEM MAKES SERVANTS. THIS IS THE RULE. THE GREMORY DO NOT COLLECT SERVANTS. THEY KEEP FAMILY. THIS IS THE HOUSE.

THE PIECE BINDS. THE HOUSE CHOOSES HOW TO HOLD.

The lights half-rose for the arguing. The theatre had learned the rhythm: the machine liked to let them fight in the intermission.

The X-Men went first, because the X-Men had just been shown their own mirror and everyone knew it.

"A refuge school," said Storm, and her voice had the stillness she reserved for weather about to change, "for children the world calls monsters. Gathered by a wealthy idealist. Trained to master the very gifts they were feared for." She turned her white eyes to Xavier. "Charles. She built yours. At *thirteen*."

"With one difference," Magneto cut in, rising, cape and conviction. "Charles's students may leave. May graduate, may quit, may slam the door and curse his name — Scott Summers has done all four, twice." (From the X-Men rows: "Hey." — "He's not wrong, Scott.") "These children are *reincarnated into her service*. The piece goes in and does not come out. Strip away the tea and the sleepovers and what remains is the oldest machine in every aristocracy that ever ground my people to ash: hereditary power, purchasing the desperate, and calling the purchase love." He let it ring. "A leash held gently, my friends, is still a leash."

"Objection sustained *and* overruled," said She-Hulk, standing with the legal pad. "Because here's what's weird — I've been building the property-law argument for two nights, and this pull just entered evidence against me. Look at the exit clauses in what we were shown. Koneko was already sentenced to die — the piece commuted it. Kiba was already dead in the snow. Gasper's own blood family kept him in a *sealed room*; his purchaser's first act was unsealing it. Counselor Lehnsherr's leash theory requires that these kids had a better alternative on the table." She flipped the pad around. It said, in large writing, THEY DIDN'T. "You can't call it exploitation when the market rate for these children's lives was *zero* and she bid a piece of her own soul's army anyway."

"The alternative not existing," Magneto said, "is precisely how such systems perpetuate—"

"Yes," said a new voice, "it is."

The theatre turned. Rias Gremory had risen in the wives' box, and the brass rail did not stop her voice from filling the hall, because she had been trained since birth to fill halls.

"Lord Magneto is correct," she said, which surprised the room, and visibly surprised Magneto more. "The Evil Piece system is exactly what he says. It was built to rebuild a decimated species by binding the talented to the noble. Most houses use it exactly as designed. I have sat across rating-game tables from Kings whose pieces flinch when their master's voice rises. I will not defend the system." Her chin came up. "I will defend my *house*. We were taught — my brother, my mother, my father, every Gremory back to the pillar — that a piece is not a purchase. It is a promise you spend the rest of your life keeping. Ask my servants if the leash chafes."

"The fish here is good," said Koneko Toujou, deadpan, without looking up from the theatre-conjured snack she had acquired by unknown means. "Also she's the best thing that ever happened to me. Also Kiba would say something embarrassing and noble right now, so someone should say it for him." A beat. "Consider it said."

"Ara ara," Akeno added, chin on her laced fingers, smiling at Magneto with the precise sweetness of a lightning storm choosing a golf course. "The gentleman in the lovely helmet is welcome to inspect my leash. Many have tried."

Magneto, survivor of camps, breaker of nations, veteran of ten thousand debates, looked at the smiling priestess of thunder, performed an unhurried strategic assessment, and sat down. "The point," he said with dignity, "is entered into the record."

Which was when the heavy furniture spoke.

"Doom will now say what the diplomats are dancing around." The Latverian tier did not rise; Doom seated was somehow taller than most men standing. "The peerage is feudalism. Unapologetic, formalized, superior feudalism — vassalage with the honesty to write its bonds in chess notation rather than hide them in mortgages and employment contracts, as your republics do." The mask surveyed the hall's democratic quadrants with palpable contempt, then returned to the screen. "And the Gremory have solved the one problem feudalism never solved. Loyalty compelled decays; Doom has *watched* it decay, in others' kingdoms. Loyalty *owed to kindness* compounds. The girl does not command her Knight's death — she has made it so he would be *offended* not to offer it. Latveria takes note. This is statecraft."

"That's not statecraft, that's family," said Valkyrie, around the flask, "and the fact that you can't tell the difference, Victor, is the whole biography."

"T'Challa." Namor's arms were still folded. "Your house rules by blood, as mine does. Tell the room the truth its comfortable classes will not enjoy: the girl's kindness is *funded*. Compassion is what a great house purchases after the wars are already won. Her love is real, I do not doubt it — and it is armored in a fortune the size of a small sea. Strip the wealth, and what survives?"

T'Challa had been silent through all of it, watching the screen the way he watched the ancestral plane — as a man being addressed by his predecessors. Now he spoke.

"Strip the wealth," he said, "and you keep the thing the wealth cannot buy, cousin, which we both know because we have both stood in treasure vaults that could not cure our loneliness." He rose, and the diplomats' section quieted. "In Wakanda the throne is blood — and then the blood must stand at Warrior Falls and be *challenged*, every reign, in front of everyone, or it is nothing. Heredity proposes; the people ratify. What I see on that screen is a house that runs the same ritual at the scale of a dinner table. Every meal that girl cooks for her servants, every night she does not wake the sleeping child on her lap — that

is her Warrior Falls. Consent, renewed daily, by people with every power to withhold it." He glanced at the wives' box, and inclined his head, king to heir. "The pieces bind. The house chooses how to hold. Your machine writes better law than most parliaments, Miss Gremory."

"It steals it from the good ones," said Rias, and returned the nod, "and shows it to the rest. I'm beginning to suspect that is its entire purpose."

Overhead, the gacha wheel — which had absolutely been waiting for a line that good — dropped the second token.

PULL TWO: "GREMORY FAMILY COUNCIL" — EPIC.

"Oh *no*," said Rias again, with feeling. "Mother, please be normal."

The Gremory estate did not fit on the screen, so the screen apologized and gained altitude.

THE GREMORY TERRITORY, the captions said, over castle grounds that unrolled past the horizon in every direction, **IS LARGER THAN THE JAPANESE ARCHIPELAGO. THE HOUSE IS ONE OF THE SURVIVING PILLARS OF THE UNDERWORLD'S ARISTOCRACY. ITS SIGIL IS KNOWN FOR THREE THINGS: THE POWER OF DESTRUCTION, THE COLOR CRIMSON, AND AN AFFECTION FOR ITS SERVANTS THAT OTHER GREAT HOUSES CONSIDER AN ECCENTRICITY BORDERING ON SCANDAL.**

("Larger than Japan," Everett Ross said faintly, doing GDP math with his eyes. "The *duchy* is larger than Japan. Maria. The duchy—" "Breathe, Ross.")

The council chamber was crimson and gold and old the way Wakandan vibranium mines were old, and the vision seated its principals with a herald's care. **LORD ZEOTICUS GREMORY** — silver-haired, elegant, with the well-fed serenity of a man whose worst enemies were seating charts. **LADY VENELANA GREMORY** — brown-haired and mild-eyed, and the theatre noted that every other devil in the room tracked her the way sailors track a calm sea, and the caption confirmed the instinct: **BORN OF THE HOUSE OF BAEI. THE POWER OF DESTRUCTION IN THE GREMORY LINE IS HERS.** At the table's end, in white and silver, a maid stood so precisely that Okoye's spine straightened in professional respect — **GRAYFIA LUCIFUGE, HEAD MAID OF THE HOUSE, STRONGEST QUEEN OF THE UNDERWORLD** — and beside the lord's chair, red-haired and radiating the gentle, bottomless good humor of a man who could unmake the room, the elder brother: **SIRZECHS LUCIFER. BORN GREMORY HEIR. SURRENDERED HIS FAMILY NAME TO TAKE THE THRONE OF A SATAN — A CROWN THE NEW UNDERWORLD GRANTS BY POWER AND SERVICE, NOT BY BLOOD.**

The diplomats' section made a sound like forty analysts finding the same footnote at once.

"There it is," breathed Maria Hill. "That's the whole debate in one family. The hereditary house's own firstborn — and the merit system took him, and the house *let* it."

The council's business, the captions explained, was the low-born Pawn.

The theatre watched envoys of two other pillar houses — all cheekbones and heirloom sneers — present their concern with poisonous courtesy: the Gremory heir's *servant*, a reincarnated human of no lineage, was being spoken of in the same breath as the heir herself. Was being *entertained at the family table*. Was rumored — the sneer deepened — to be the reason the heir's prior, politically immaculate engagement had ended with the groom punched through a ceiling. Surely the house understood how this looked. Surely standards—

"I'm told," Lord Gremory interrupted pleasantly, "that when my daughter was taken from that arranged altar, the boy in question fought his way through a Phenex's immortality with a broken body and a borrowed blessing, on the sole logic that she had cried where he could see it." He turned a page of the envoys' own complaint as if it were a wine list. "You are correct that I did not raise my daughter to be won by pedigree. I raised her to be *worth* what that boy paid." He set the page down. "The house's position: Issei Hyoudou dines at our table whenever he can be persuaded to hold the correct fork, which is never, and it is the happiest our table has been in a century. This council is adjourned on that point."

"Husband," said Venelana Gremory, mildly, "you've skipped the important part."

She rose, and the envoys did not quite flinch, and the theatre understood that in this family the Power of Destruction wore pearls. "My children," she said, "were born owning everything. It is the great disease of houses like ours — Bael taught it to me with a whip, and I will not repeat the lesson here. Children who own everything must be *given* the one thing ownership cannot reach: someone who would have loved them poor. My son found it in a maid who outranks every soul in this room." Grayfia's composure flickered by exactly one millimeter, which for Grayfia was a blush. "My daughter has found it in a Pawn who did not know her name was worth anything when he died for it. The house of Gremory does not apologize for treasuring what cannot be inherited." Her mild eyes swept the envoys. "You may tell your pillars we said so, with our love."

And Sirzechs Lucifer, Satan, Super Devil, leaned back in his chair with his eyes closed and said, to the ceiling, in the tone of a man settling an old account, "I gave up this name because the Underworld needed a crown that anyone could earn. Best decision I ever made — and I have regretted it at every family dinner since." He opened his eyes, and the good humor in them had red at the bottom, like coals. "Issei-kun is going to be my brother. The pillars can put *that* in their genealogies."

The vision held one last frame — the whole improbable household on the estate's endless lawn, lords and maids and reincarnated strays and one loud Pawn being ceremonially taught the correct fork by a thirteen-pillar dynasty and getting it wrong on purpose to make Gasper laugh — and the screen wrote,

quietly, without capitals for once:

hereditary power built this table. earned power sits at it. the house cannot tell you which of them holds it up. neither can the house's enemies. that is the trick.

The lights came up on a diplomats' section that had stopped taking notes on the screen and started taking them on each other.

"Doom will concede a single sentence." The hall quieted; Latverian concessions were rarer than the gacha's Secret tier. "The brother is the proof. A merit crown that a hereditary house *willingly feeds its heir to* — that is the only version of aristocracy Doom has ever seen that deserves to survive its founders. Latveria's succession plans are hereby under review." A pause, precisely timed. "The review committee is Doom. The committee's findings are Doom. Nevertheless: under review."

"The Underworld got lucky," Magneto said, but the iron had gone contemplative. "One good family at the top of a rotten machine. It changes nothing structurally. And yet." He looked at the screen a long moment — a boy teaching a vampire courage, a duchess destroying a marriage market with pearls on. "I have burned better-defended systems for less cause than those envoys gave. I find I do not want to burn this one. It is an unfamiliar feeling. I am *watching* it."

"That's called hope, Erik," said Xavier.

"It is called *provisional data*, Charles, and if you smile at me I am leaving the theatre." There was no exit from the theatre. Magneto knew this. It was understood by all parties to be the point of the sentence.

Namor unfolded his arms. The theatre's betting board (Rocket, proprietor) had him at 40-to-1 against conceding anything, and forty rows of gamblers leaned in.

"The mother," the Sub-Mariner said at last, "would have been welcome in Atlantis's war councils, and I have said that of two surface-dwellers in my life." He turned from the screen. "My challenge stands answered. Strip the wealth from that house and the wealth was never the load-bearing wall. Imperius Rex — and *noted*." (In the back, Rocket paid out, bitterly.)

T'Challa said nothing for a while. His mother had come down from the Wakandan tier during the second pull, and stood now at his shoulder, watching the frozen frame of Venelana Gremory the way one queen mother studies another across an impossible sea.

"He was resurrected into a feudal contract," T'Challa said finally, "by the one house in that world that treats the contract as a cradle. Eight Pawn pieces." He looked across the hall to where Mephisto sat, and the demon — who had priced that transaction in chapter five and been dining out on the arbitrage ever since — lifted a clawed hand in weary acknowledgment before the king even asked.

"Yes, yes," Mephisto sighed. "The market has updated. I believed the girl saw the dragon and overpaid on *insider information*. I now believe something far more fiscally upsetting." He steepled his fingers. "The Gremory always overpay. For family, they structurally, doctrinally, *deliberately* overpay — the maid who is a queen, the heir traded to a merit throne, eight pieces for one dying pervert — and they have compounded that idiotic strategy into the richest and most beloved house in their Underworld." His smile returned, thin and professionally wounded. "Somewhere in that is an insult to everything I do for a living. I am *choosing* not to locate it precisely."

"And that," said Okoye, to Ramonda, quietly, in Xhosa, subtitled by a theatre that missed nothing, "is why the boy fights the way he fights. We have all been asking what he is loyal *to*. It is not the girl. It is not the piece. It is the table."

Ramonda nodded slowly. "You do not break a man like that by defeating him," she said. "You would have to defeat the table. All of it. Every chair."

The screen, which had been listening — the screen was always listening — dimmed to warm gold, and the doorbell chime rang, and the next banner's tease rose in the cozy font that fooled no one:

NEXT: THE PAWN AND THE BISHOP. "ASIA'S HUSBAND."

In the wives' box, Asia Argento turned the color of the Gremory sigil and attempted to hide behind Xenovia, who did not understand the maneuver and helpfully stepped aside. Seven fiancées turned toward Asia with the loving, terrible unanimity of a family that has found the photo album.

"Oh *no*," said Asia.

"It gets us all eventually," said Rias, patting her hand, duchess to sister. "Chin up. It's the house rule."

The lights went down on a theatre that had come to argue about power, and stayed to envy a dinner table.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Rias's Peerage Dynamics* — Rare; *Gremory Family Council* — Epic. Both drawn from the Family-Class banner (night three); the machine closed on a lowercase caption — "hereditary power built this table. earned power sits at it." — and teased Chapter 24's pull, "Asia's Husband."
- **Secrets Revealed:** Rias's peerage assembled as rescues, not recruitments: Kiba Yuuto (sole survivor of the Church's Holy Sword Project purge, found dying at thirteen; later broke into Balance Breaker when Issei's fury and his murdered comrades' spirits pulled him back from a suicidal vendetta), Akeno (half-fallen-angel, hunted after her mother's murder), Koneko (taken in under sentence of

death for her sister's crime), and Gasper Vladi (time-stopping half-vampire bought *out* of a family that kept him sealed in a room; Issei coaxed him out of a literal box). The Gremory house doctrine made explicit: "The piece binds. The house chooses how to hold." Gremory territory exceeds the Japanese archipelago. Lord Zeoticus and Lady Venelana (Bael-born; the source of the line's Power of Destruction) openly ruled before rival pillar envoys that Issei sits at the family table; Sirzechs — born Gremory heir who surrendered the name for a merit-granted Satan throne, husband of head maid Grayfia — declared "Issei-kun is going to be my brother." Mephisto revised his chapter-five thesis: the eight-Pawn spend wasn't insider trading on the dragon, it's house doctrine — the Gremory *always* overpay for family, and have compounded it into wealth.

- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Doom concedes the Gremory/Sirzechs model is "the only version of aristocracy that deserves to survive its founders" and places Latverian succession "under review" (committee: Doom). Magneto argued the peerage is a gently held leash, was answered by She-Hulk, Rias, Koneko, and Akeno, and downgraded from condemnation to "provisional data — I am watching it." Namor publicly conceded (Rocket's 40-to-1 book paid out) and rated Venelana war-council-worthy. T'Challa framed Gremory kindness as daily-renewed consent — "her Warrior Falls at a dinner table." Storm and Xavier logged the peerage as a mirror of the Xavier School. Okoye/Ramonda coined the room's new strategic axiom: Issei's true loyalty is "the table" — to break him you'd have to defeat every chair.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Chapter 24's tease ("Asia's Husband") has the wives' box mobilized and Asia in hiding — and Mephisto, last seen "choosing not to locate" the insult to his business model, is due for a reckoning with sincerity. Magneto's structural critique stands half-answered: one good family atop a rotten machine — what does the theatre show when it pulls a peerage that *isn't* Gremory? The envoys' pillar houses now have a grudge on record. And the room's ominous arithmetic continues: the more beloved the household shown, the heavier the arc-one prophecy hangs — what happens to a boy whose strength is a table, when the theatre's promised enemy is made of things *erased*?

Chapter Twenty-Four: Asia's Husband

Primary Reaction Groups: Moralists (Steve Rogers, Charles Xavier) • The faithful (Nightcrawler, Daredevil) • Logan • Cosmic tier (Silver Surfer, the Watcher) • Mephisto (briefly)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Asia's Healing and Devotion" — **Family-Class**
 2. "Issei's Gentlest Moment" — **Family-Class**
-

The theatre had a new neighbourhood now, and the whole room had learned to orient by it.

Three chapters ago the gacha machine had committed its first true act of malice — or mercy; the vote was still out — and summoned Issei Hyoudou's eight fiancées bodily into the audience, mid-viewing, furious, and extremely real. A long crescent of seats near the front had reshaped itself around them, warmer-lit than the rest of the hall, and the audience had taken to calling it *the nest rows* — quietly, and never within earshot of Rias Gremory.

Tonight the ceiling glowed the colour of a kitchen window at dusk. The warm-gold Family-Class band on the wheel was lit before the wheel even descended, and the chime, when it came, was the small doorbell sound that Sam Wilson had been right not to trust.

The token dropped. The banner unfurled in gold soft enough to read by.

ASIA'S HEALING AND DEVOTION — FAMILY-CLASS

In the nest rows, a small blonde girl made a sound like a kettle deciding not to whistle and attempted to disappear behind Koneko Toujou, who was roughly two-thirds her size and did not move.

"It's your banner, Asia," Koneko said, deadpan, patting her knee once. "Sit up. Let them see what he's actually like."

"That's what I'm afraid of," Asia Argento whispered.

Half the theatre had turned to look at her — carefully, the way you look at someone the Ghost Rider once called soul-clean, the girl whose show-trial had put a grey banner in the machine and a crack in two Catholics. It was one thing to have watched her story.

It was another thing entirely to watch it sitting next to her.

The screen lit.

It was not one memory. That was the first surprise. The Family-Class banner, it turned out, did not deal in incidents. It dealt in *patterns* — and it laid this one out the way you lay out a year of photographs on a table.

A boy comes home hurt. A girl is waiting.

That was the whole grammar of it, conjugated a hundred ways. Issei limping through the Hyoudou front door with his uniform scorched, mid-excuse, and Asia already crossing the hall with her hands lifting, twin silver rings kindling green. Issei face-down on training-ground dirt with something wrong about the angle of his shoulder, and Asia arriving at a dead run that she would deny was a run, because running implied panic and panic implied doubt and she had none. Issei unconscious after a Rating Game, laid out on infirmary sheets, and Asia beside him on a stool at three in the morning, her healing light long since finished its work, staying anyway. Her head bowed. Her hands folded — folded the way children are taught to fold them for prayer, the way the tribunal had watched her fold them, the fold she had never once unlearned.

The vision let the theatre hear what she was doing, and the theatre went very quiet.

She was praying. Over a Devil. In direct, cheerful, unrepentant violation of every doctrine that had ever thrown her away — a defrocked holy maiden asking Heaven, politely, nightly, to look after the specific Devil in front of her. And each time she prayed, a small spike of pain went through her skull — the vision rendered it as a brief flinch, a hand pressed to her temple, breath held and released — because that was the tax her new nature levied on her old love, and she paid it like a toll she considered fair.

SHE HEALS HIM AFTER EVERY BATTLE, the screen annotated, in its warm domestic font. **SHE HAS NEVER ONCE ASKED WHETHER HE DESERVED THE WOUND.**

"Of course she hasn't," Matt Murdock said, low. He was sitting forward, elbows on knees, in the pew-posture the theatre knew well by now. "That's her whole doctrine. One line long. She told the tribunal to their faces." He recited it from memory, because it had been living in his chest for sixteen chapters: "*I don't know how to see someone bleeding and decide they deserve it.*"

On screen, the year of photographs kept turning. And slowly, watching it, the room began to understand what it was actually being shown — because interleaved between the healings, the vision kept cutting to *where the wounds came from*. It was footage they already owned. The cold walk to the church, chapter eight. Fenrir's teeth. The respected, bone-deep loss to Sairaorg Bael. The Knight armour crumpling like

foil; the Rook standing into a god-killing spear; the boy on his hands and knees on an edited mountain. Every scar the theatre had spent two arcs cataloguing as *doctrine*, as *ledger*, as *threat assessment* — the machine now filed each one a second time, under its other name.

A thing a girl with green light in her hands had sat up all night undoing.

"We measured him in output," said Charles Xavier quietly.

The Professor had been a background presence for most of two arcs — listening, mostly, in the way of a man who spent his life hearing more than anyone said. Now he had wheeled forward to the aisle, and the theatre's acoustics did what they always did for the softest voice in the room, which was carry it everywhere.

"Twenty-three chapters," Xavier said. "We have classified that boy as an asset, a calamity, a constant, a variable no plan may omit — I believe those were the words. And in all our arithmetic, no one asked the only diagnostic question I have ever found reliable." He nodded at the screen, at the girl on the stool, at the folded hands. "*Who is allowed to see him weak?* You can learn everything about a mind from where it goes when it can no longer perform. His goes home. It goes to *her*, and it lets her see the damage, all of it, without armour and without shame. I have known gods who could not do that." A pause. "I have known X-Men who could not."

"Soldiers, too," Steve Rogers said.

He hadn't meant to say it aloud, from the look of him — but the theatre was in a listening mood, and so he stood by it, arms folded.

"I've written a lot of letters," Steve said. "The kind you write when somebody doesn't come home. And the thing you learn writing them is that the war isn't the whole story of a fighter. The whole story is what they were fighting *from*. Some people go into the fire because they've got nothing else —" his jaw tightened a fraction, an old self-recognition, "— and some go in because they have *everything* else, and know exactly what it costs to lose it. First kind burns up. Second kind is who you build a line around." He nodded at the screen. "Twenty chapters, I couldn't place which one he was. Now I know. She's what's behind him. That's the answer."

In the nest rows, Asia Argento had gone the colour of a sunrise and was being visibly, physically prevented from apologizing to the entire theatre by Xenovia's hand on her shoulder.

It was at approximately this point that Mephisto could no longer help himself.

He had been suffering, in his box in the villains' dark, for some minutes — the steeped fingers drumming, the smile reinflating from its chapter-twenty puncture, when the market had moved out of his range and he had said so in front of *Loki*. And now the theatre was serving sincerity, in a warm font, and every soul in the room was drinking it, and there is nothing a broker of damnation finds more professionally offensive than an asset appreciating for reasons he cannot securitize.

"Oh, *enchanting*," Mephisto said, rising, spreading his hands to the room with his very best benedictory sneer. "Truly. The dragon and his little defrocked saint. Do go on weeping, all of you — but let us at least be *honest* at these prices. What are we watching? A traumatized child imprinting on the first creature who didn't discard her, and a hormonal boy playing house with a girl too grateful to refuse him. Devotion?" He laughed, and the laugh was silk over a filing cabinet. "Devotion is merely a debt neither party has learned to invoice. Give me five minutes and a contract and I could show you what it's *actually wor*—"

The theatre turned off his voice.

Not muffled it. Turned it *off*, cleanly, mid-syllable, the way one closes a door on weather. Mephisto's mouth continued moving for a full second and a half of perfect silence — the most articulate silence of his long career — and then the screen, without interrupting the gentle year of photographs playing across its main expanse, dropped a small, tidy, bureaucratic panel of red text into the corner, accompanied by the sound of a ruler striking a lectern:

THEATRE DISAPPROVAL.

VIOLATION: CONTEMPT OF NEST. SECTION ONE: SINCERITY.

PENALTY: ASSESSED.

And Mephisto's box seat — the private, velvet, self-important box he had occupied since chapter one — folded itself up around him like a hand closing around a coin, and deposited him, with a soft *pop* of displaced pomposity, in the front row.

In the nest rows.

Directly between Koneko Toujou and Rossweisse, both of whom turned and looked at him.

The theatre did not restore his voice for the remainder of the viewing. It did, however, hang one final line of red text over his new seat, in the manner of a museum placard:

THE HOUSE PROTECTS THIS PULL.

The laughter that went around the room was general, bipartisan, and long — Deadpool had to be thumped on the back twice — but it thinned out quickly into something more thoughtful, because the sharper minds in the audience had caught what the joke was resting on. Doom's mask tilted one degree.

Loki's smile arrived and then departed without unpacking.

"Note it," Doom said, to no one and therefore to everyone. "Twenty-four chapters, and the theatre has enforced nothing. Not grief, not spoilers, not Wilson's commentary, which Doom has personally petitioned against. It has let us mock gods, murders, and each other." The mask turned toward the warm gold screen. "*This* it protects. A girl healing a boy. Whatever this room is preparing us for — and it is preparing us; Doom has said so since the fifth viewing — the machine has just shown us the shape of what it considers load-bearing. Attend."

From the cosmic tiers, unbidden, the Watcher said softly: "Attend."

Uatu agreeing with Doom, unprompted, was sufficiently against nature that the entire room elected to move on.

The wheel turned again while the room was still smiling — the machine had learned its own comedic timing somewhere around chapter twelve — and the second token dropped with the doorbell chime, gold on gold:

ISSEI'S GENTLEST MOMENT — FAMILY-CLASS

"Oh no," said Asia, with feeling.

"Oh yes," said Akeno Himejima, resettling luxuriously. "I know which one this is. Ufufu. Watch closely, everyone; you're about to lose whatever composure you've got left."

The screen lit on darkness first. A hallway of the Hyoudou house, deep in the night. And a sound the theatre knew intimately by now, because the theatre had been present, in a sense, at its source: a girl crying in her sleep, small and strangled, the way you cry when the dream is a white stone chamber and five mountains in vestments and doors closing with you on the wrong side.

The vision found Issei Hyoudou standing outside her door in a T-shirt and track pants, one hand raised to knock, not knocking.

The theatre watched him decide something. Then he went downstairs instead.

What followed was, by the standards of a room that had recently watched him bruise causality with a chest cannon, the least remarkable footage the machine had ever screened. A sixteen-year-old boy in a dim kitchen, cooking. Rice. Miso. Rolled egg, on the third attempt, the first two attempts being eaten as evidence. The vision lingered on his hands — hands the audience had seen sheathed in a dragon's gauntlet, hands that had transferred mountain-erasing power to allies — fumbling a chopstick, salvaging the egg, laying out a tray with the excessive geometric care of someone doing a thing that matters more than he knows how to say.

When Asia came downstairs at dawn, hollow-eyed and pretending not to have been crying, breakfast was waiting. So was he, asleep sitting up at the table, hair ridiculous.

She stopped in the doorway. On her face, the theatre watched the nightmare lose.

"He does this," the on-screen Asia said softly — and the vision, in the manner of Family-Class pulls, let her narration drift over the scene like steam off the soup. "Every time. He never says, *I heard you crying*. He never makes me explain. There's just... food. And him. He guards me like — like everyone saw, in the frightening chapters. But that isn't the real protecting. The real protecting is this. He makes the world so ordinary that the bad dreams can't find anywhere to stand."

On screen, Issei jolted awake, saw her, and immediately began narrating the menu at unnecessary volume with his chest puffed out, ruining his own tenderness so thoroughly and so deliberately that half the theatre understood, in one stroke, that ruining it was the point — that the boy knew exactly how to make kindness weigh nothing, so that a girl who had been taught all mercy comes with a tribunal attached could pick it up without flinching.

And then, when the meal was done, the vision showed the last thing.

The two of them, side by side at the window, morning light coming up over the roofs of a sleeping human city. Asia folding her hands. And Issei — a Devil, eight Pawns deep, dragon-marked, oath-sworn against Heaven itself in this very girl's name — folding *his*.

"Partner," rumbled the gauntlet, materializing in faint outline, and there was no alarm in Ddraig's old voice, only a checking-in. "**You know what it costs you.**"

"Yeah," Issei said. "Headache. Big one. It's fine."

"You could simply sit with her."

"She'd know the difference." He shut his eyes. Beside him, Asia had already begun, lips moving, one hand drifting to her temple as the toll came due — and his jaw tightened at the same instant, the same tax hitting the same nerve, two exiles paying it together. "Nobody should have to kneel alone, Ddraig. Not her. Not ever again. If Heaven's got a problem with a Devil in the room, it can send somebody down to explain, and I'll boost until *they* kneel."

A pause.

"...That," said the Welsh Dragon Emperor, who had carried two thousand years of hosts down two thousand roads of ruin, and whose voice had gone suspiciously gravelled, **"is the strongest thing I have ever felt you do."**

The screen held the image — the dragon and the saint, heads bowed, hurting on purpose, together — and then dimmed, gently, the way you leave a room where something sacred is happening and no one needs you.

For a while, nobody managed anything.

Then, from the left flank, Kurt Wagner stood — and the theatre braced, because the last time Nightcrawler had stood for Asia Argento he had been shaking, gripping the seat-back, watching an institution devour its gentlest member. He was not shaking now. He was smiling, and there were tears standing in his golden eyes, and his tail had curled into an almost jaunty question mark.

"Matthew," he said. "I have your answer."

"Kurt—"

"No, no, you asked me — sixteen chapters ago, you asked me, and I could not answer then, so I will answer now, while I have the nerve." He gestured at the darkened screen with both three-fingered hands. "You asked whether the institution's cruelty indicts the faith or betrays it. And there is the verdict, mein Freund. The tribunal took everything institutional away from her. The habit, the walls, the name, the sanction — every fence, gone. And what remained? What was left when they had stripped away every single thing that men control?" His voice cracked, cheerfully, like a bell that didn't mind. "*The grace remained*. The prayer remained. The mercy remained — it is stronger, it has taught itself to a *Devil*, it is teaching itself to this entire room right now. The fence was never load-bearing, Matthew. The grace was. They kept the fence and lost her, and she walked out of that church carrying everything in it that was true."

Daredevil was quiet for a long moment. The theatre, which translated everything for him, had given him that dawn kitchen in heartbeats and breath — two hearts settling out of nightmare-rhythm into something slow and safe — and whatever he had heard in it was still moving through his face.

"Two exiles saying grace over breakfast," he said finally. "Both of them getting hurt for it. Both of them doing it anyway." He laughed, once, and this time there was no rust in it at all. "You know what that is, Kurt? Structurally? That's a church. Congregation of two. Better attendance record than mine." He tipped his head back against the seat. "Yeah. Okay. Some days the ledger's not so ugly. Write this one down."

"Way ahead of you," said Kamala Khan thickly, from three rows over, writing it down.

And then there was Logan.

He hadn't said a word all viewing. He'd sat where he always sat, low in the seat, arms crossed, the posture of a man who had come to the theatre against his will and stayed twenty-four chapters for reasons he declined to examine. The room had mostly stopped expecting commentary from him — his last significant entry in anyone's ledger had been the private mark he and Frank Castle had put next to the name Raynare, back when this whole story had been a murdered kid and a debt.

Now he uncrossed his arms.

"I've known a lot of berserkers," Logan said. Just that, at first. His voice came out at gravel-pitch, unhurried, and the theatre gave it room. "Am one. Buried most of the rest. And there's a thing nobody tells you about the animal — everybody figures the hard part's the rage. It ain't. Rage is easy. Rage is *simple*." He nodded once at the dark screen. "The hard part is what that kid just did. Comin' back from the cold place with your hands still fit for somethin' soft. Most of us can't. You go to where he went — chapter eight, that walk up the hill, I *know* that walk — and mostly you don't come all the way back from it. Somethin' stays out there. And the people who love you get whatever's left, and learn to flinch."

He looked at the nest rows. At Asia, specifically, who looked back with her hands folded.

"Kid walks it both directions," Logan said. "Full trip, every time. Cold enough to scare a room fulla gods, and then he goes home and makes the eggs three times 'cause the first two weren't good enough for her." He settled back down, arms recrossing, conversation visibly ending. "That ain't a power-up. Fifty years I've been lookin' for that trick. Respect."

From Logan, the theatre understood, this was a papal blessing.

High above them, the cosmic tier had been conducting its own quieter reckoning.

The Silver Surfer had drifted forward again, board angled toward the dark screen — but where chapter twenty had bent him toward it like a compass finding a pole, tonight he simply *looked*, chrome face full of something older than assessment.

"I burned my capacity for this," the Surfer said, "as the price of power. A world, a woman, a small life of gardens — traded, that they might survive without me. It is the oldest arithmetic I know: the strength to protect a thing is purchased with the thing itself. Every herald learns it. Most gods assume it." His gaze went to the nest rows, to the small blonde girl. "The boy refuses the arithmetic. He grows monstrous in strength and *keeps the gardens*. Holds both, pays both tolls, kneels beside her with a headache rather than above her with a halo." The board turned slowly. "If the universe permits him this — if it does not eventually present him the bill I paid — then the universe is kinder than I have found it. And if it does present the bill..." He was silent a moment. "I find I would cross a galaxy to help him refuse it."

And the Watcher — who had once, over this same girl, closed his eyes for the length of one full human breath and called his own stirring of care *perhaps not permitted* — looked down at the braided thing he had first perceived sixteen chapters ago: her exile and his path, twisted into a single cord.

"It held," Uatu said, mostly to himself, in the tone of a scholar confirming a proof he had not dared to want. "I have watched ten thousand worlds teach me that the shape ends in the fire — the institution devours the gentle one, the avenger goes cold, the cord burns through. I catalogued it each time. This one *held*. The mercy survived the tribunal; the rage came home from the hill; the cord is not a fuse." His vast head inclined toward the screen where the warm gold was fading. "The theatre protects it. I begin to understand why. When the things they cannot stand before finally come—" and every ledger-keeper in the room heard the old prophecy shift its weight in its sleep, "—they will not be stopped by power. Power, those things have already eaten. They will be stopped, if they are stopped, by whatever it is that boy is protecting when he makes breakfast."

No one asked him to elaborate. Watchers never elaborated at the worst possible moment; it was practically the job description.

The lights came up. In the nest rows, Asia Argento sat very straight and very pink while an entire multiverse of heroes failed to pretend it wasn't looking at her — and Steve Rogers, moving with the deliberateness of a man performing ceremony, crossed the aisle, stood before her, and inclined his head.

"Ma'am," Captain America said. "Thank you for taking care of him. We've all gotten pretty invested."

Asia Argento burst into tears, apologized for bursting into tears, apologized for apologizing, and was gathered up by six fiancées at once while the seventh, Koneko, silently handed Mephisto — still voiceless, still trapped in the nest rows, wearing the expression of a demon experiencing secondhand sincerity poisoning at point-blank range — a handkerchief, purely to watch him suffer.

Above the rising warmth of the room, the wheel ascended, its gold band still lit. And as it went, a new token glinted in the queue behind the glass — and the screen flashed one frame of preview, in a crisp, mercantile font that had several billionaires in the audience instinctively reaching for lawyers:

NEXT: THE LEDGER OF RAVEL PHENEX. ITEMIZED. HE WILL WISH IT WERE NOT.

"...Why do I feel personally targeted," said Tony Stark, "by a font."

Nobody answered. The lights went down on a theatre that had spent two arcs learning what the dragon could do, and had just spent an evening learning — in the machine's own warm, protected, load-bearing gold — what the dragon was *for*.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Asia's Healing and Devotion" — Family-Class (first full Family-Class viewing; pattern-format montage rather than single incident)
- "Issei's Gentlest Moment" — Family-Class (the dawn kitchen; the shared prayer)

Secrets Revealed

- Asia heals Issei after every battle and has never once asked whether he deserved the wound; she prays over him nightly despite the pain-toll her Devil nature levies on prayer — and Issei prays *beside* her, knowingly paying the same toll, so she never kneels alone. Ddraig called it "the strongest thing I have ever felt you do."
- Issei's tenderness is deliberate craft, not accident: he defuses his own kindness with comedy so Asia can accept care without flinching, and answers her nightmares with ordinariness (cooking through the night) rather than talk.
- The theatre WILL enforce its own rules when Family-Class material is mocked: Mephisto received the first-ever **Theatre Disapproval** penalty ("Contempt of Nest — Section One: Sincerity") — voice revoked for the viewing, box seat confiscated, relocated to the nest rows between Koneko and Rossweisse, under the placard "THE HOUSE PROTECTS THIS PULL."
- Doom and the Watcher independently flagged the same implication: in 24 chapters the theatre has enforced nothing else — so domestic devotion is, by the machine's own behaviour, *load-bearing* to whatever it is preparing them for.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Nightcrawler: sixteen chapters after chapter eight, delivers his verdict to Daredevil — the grace, not the fence, was load-bearing; Asia carried everything true out of the church that expelled her. Faith visibly mended.
- Daredevil: calls the Issei-Asia dawn prayer "a church — congregation of two," and concedes "some days the ledger's not so ugly." Softest he has been on-record about the faith.
- Charles Xavier: reframes the room's entire two-arc threat assessment with one diagnostic — "who is allowed to see him weak?" — and rates Issei above gods and X-Men on the answer.
- Steve Rogers: classifies Issei as the fighter who fights *from* everything rather than from nothing — "the kind you build a line around"; formally thanked Asia on behalf of the room.
- Logan: first substantive commentary since marking Raynare — names the true berserker's problem as "coming back from the cold place with your hands still fit for something soft," says Issei "walks

it both directions," and grants an unqualified "Respect."

- Silver Surfer: sees Issei refusing the herald's arithmetic (power purchased with the life it protects) and vows he "would cross a galaxy to help him refuse" the bill if the universe ever presents it.
- The Watcher: confirms the braided cord from chapter eight "held" — the only instance in ten thousand catalogued worlds where the shape didn't end in fire — and ties it directly to the prophecy: the coming things "will not be stopped by power... they will be stopped by whatever that boy is protecting when he makes breakfast."
- Mephisto: publicly penalized, silenced, and relocated; his attempt to reprice sincerity as "un-invoiced debt" failed on-record. Dignity in deficit; expect retaliation-by-scheming.
- The room at large: Issei's Arc One–Two ferocity is now formally recontextualized — every catalogued scar was re-filed by the machine itself as "a thing a girl with green light in her hands sat up all night undoing."

Unresolved Hooks

- What exactly does the Theatre Disapproval system protect, and why *now* — is "Section One: Sincerity" the first section of a longer rulebook the room hasn't seen?
- The Watcher's prophecy-adjacent claim that the final things "have already eaten" power and can only be stopped by what Issei protects — connecting the Family-Class banner directly to the endgame threat.
- The Silver Surfer's foreboding: will the universe eventually present Issei the herald's bill (the protected life traded for the power to protect it)?
- Mephisto is voiceless, seatless, humiliated, and patient — his next move.
- Next banner previewed: Ravel Phenex's itemized ledger of Issei's injuries, spending, and promises ("HE WILL WISH IT WERE NOT") — and Tony Stark already feels targeted by the font.

Chapter Twenty-Five: Ravel's Ledger

Primary Reaction Groups: Tony Stark • Maria Hill • Sue Storm • Shuri • Financial Experts (Pepper Potts, Emma Frost, Wilson Fisk, Danny Rand)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Ravel's Injury Ledger" — **Comedy-Class**
 2. "Hyoudou Household Budget" — **Comedy-Class**
-

The theatre was still tender from Asia's chapter.

That was the only word for it. A room that had spent twenty-four chapters learning to brace for mountains and god-wolves had been undone the night before by a boy cooking rice for a girl who prayed, and nobody had fully recovered. Wolverine was being suspiciously kind to people. Mephisto was still sitting in the small penalty spotlight the theatre had assigned him, radiating the sulk of a demon who had learned there were house rules. And in the family box — the warm-gold gallery the machine had built when it summoned them — eight fiancées of Issei Hyoudou sat in various states of embarrassment and pride, having watched two universes fall a little in love with their idiot.

So when the ceiling lit brass and the little vaudeville bulbs chased each other around the wheel's rim, the theatre actually relaxed. They knew that fanfare now. Comedy-Class meant nobody died tonight.

They were half right.

PULL ONE: RAVEL'S INJURY LEDGER — COMEDY-CLASS.

"Wait," said Peter Parker. "The ledger? The ledger's back? The scary book from the wolf chapter?"

"COMEDY-CLASS PULLS," announced the screen, with the dignity of a butler introducing a pie fight, "MAY INCLUDE PHYSICAL EXHIBITS."

A pedestal rose out of the theatre floor, front and center, lit like a museum piece. Onto it, in a curl of dawn-colored flame, materialized a book. Leather-bound. Brass-cornered. Four silk ribbons. Tabs in five colors, plus — new since chapter seventeen — a sixth tab, red, near the back.

And approximately half a second later, out of a second and considerably angrier circle of Phenex fire, materialized a fourteen-year-old girl in mid-lunge, both hands locked around the book, blonde drills swinging, shouting the tail end of a sentence that had begun in another universe:

"—UNHAND MY FILING SYSTEM—"

She landed on the pedestal steps in a three-point crouch that would have credited a Dora Milaje, straightened instantly, and took in the cosmic theatre, the several thousand staring heroes, gods, and monsters, and the family box, where eight women she knew extremely well were waving at her with expressions ranging from delight (Irina) to open predatory glee (Kuroka).

Ravel Phenex smoothed her skirts, tucked the ledger under her arm, and curtsied to an audience of two universes as if she had been sent an invitation and simply mislaid it.

"Ravel Phenex, of the House of Phenex," she said. "I apologize for my entrance. I was given to understand by Rias-sama's situation reports that this establishment abducts people." A beat. Her eyes narrowed at the wheel overhead. "I was *not* given to understand that it abducts *documents*."

"Situation reports," said Maria Hill, quietly, to no one. "The teenager files situation reports from inside a hostage dimension."

"Ravel-chan!" Irina called down happily. "It's actually very nice here once you stop screaming!"

"The popcorn is unlimited," added Xenovia, as though citing scripture.

"Welcome to the box, little bird," said Kuroka, patting the empty seat they had all, the theatre noticed, somehow known to leave open. "We saved you an aisle."

The screen dimmed the houselights, spread itself wide, and — with what could only be called professional courtesy toward a fellow archivist — opened the exhibit.

RAVEL'S INJURY LEDGER, it wrote. **AUDIT PRESENTATION. THE ROOM IS ADVISED THAT ALL FIGURES ARE ACTUAL.**

It began as pure comedy, and the theatre laughed the way you laugh at a tax return in fancy dress.

The vision showed the ledger's life. It showed Ravel Phenex trailing Issei Hyoudou through his days like a small, immaculate auditor of chaos: materializing at his elbow when he said "I owe you one" to a ramen vendor ("Define 'one.' In writing"); confiscating receipts out of his pockets while he slept face-down on a training field; interviewing Kiba as a *witness* to a sparring injury, with a form, in triplicate. It showed her chasing the boy around the Hyoudou yard with a measuring tape because his shoulders had broadened two centimeters and every uniform contract needed re-negotiating. It showed Ddraig's gauntlet flashing **[BOOST.]** during a training run and Ravel, without looking up from her book, calling out "That's number nine today, I'm starting a new column for you," and the great Welsh Dragon Emperor answering, with the weariness of eons, **"She is the only one who counts them, partner. Mind the ninth."**

"Okay," said Sam Wilson, wiping his eyes. "Okay, the dragon respects her. The apocalypse lizard reports to her."

The gacha unfolded the sections one by one, and the room settled in — Pepper Potts and Sue Storm already leaning forward with the specific hunger of two women who had founded a Committee about this exact book eight chapters ago.

SECTION I: INJURIES. Expanded since chapter seventeen. Recalibrated again. The ten-grade severity scale now had annotations in three inks, cross-referenced by cause, by opponent, by *which promise he was keeping at the time*.

SECTION II: EXPENDITURES. The depreciation schedules had grown sub-schedules.

SECTION III: DEBTS & FAVORS. *Favors compound* was now underlined twice, with a worked example.

SECTION IV: PROMISES. Status-tracked. Witnessed. One entry — *To protect Asia Argento* — *Status: PERPETUAL* — had been re-inked where the original had begun to fade, because some records were not permitted to fade.

SECTION V, new, RATING GAMES: damage projected versus sustained, per match, per opponent, with a marginal war of handwriting where Ravel's projections argued with reality and — the theatre noted with dawning awe — usually won.

SECTION VI, new, EXPERIMENTAL INCIDENTS: a curated catalogue of every time a certain fallen-angel researcher's prototype training equipment had detonated, malfunctioned, achieved sentience, or "performed as designed, which was worse." Each entry ended with the same stamped notation: *INVOICE SENT TO AZAZEL. STATUS: IGNORED. INTEREST: ACCRUING.*

"She's charging a *fallen angel* compound interest," said Shuri, delighted beyond language. "She has an accounts-receivable file for *Heaven's rejects*."

And then the red tab. **SECTION VII: UNAUTHORIZED ACCESS,** one page, one line: *If you are reading this section, the book has already notified me, and I have already forgiven you, because what is about to happen to you is punishment enough.*

Wilson Fisk, in the villains' gallery, made a low sound that the people nearest him eventually identified as approval. It was the first noise he had made in twenty-five chapters.

"Whoever keeps the books," the Kingpin said, to the theatre at large, in that soft cathedral voice, "runs the city. I have killed men for tidiness one-tenth of hers."

"That's a compliment," Emma Frost translated, checking. She tilted her head at the small figure by the pedestal, telepath-to-ledger, CEO-to-CEO. "It is. My word. It actually is."

Tony Stark had been silent for four minutes, which those who loved him recognized as a medical event.

"Question," he finally said, standing, pointing at the screen with a mug he'd forgotten was empty. "Small question. Tiny. The recovery column. Projected-versus-actual. Who *verifies* actual? Because I've had JARVIS, FRIDAY, and at various points a small nation-state of interns, and not one of them has ever successfully verified whether I actually rested after—"

"I visit," said Ravel Phenex.

"You—"

"I visit," she repeated, in the tone of a woman explaining stairs. "At the projected recovery date, I arrive at his residence, and I inspect him. If he is training when he should be resting, I confiscate the equipment. It is itemized under Section Two as a recurring cost, because he *keeps buying it back*." A pause. Her chin lifted a fraction. "Mr. Stark. You are the one with the flying suits, yes? The red ones. May I ask — do you amortize them, or do you simply build a new one every time you have a feeling?"

The theatre held its breath.

"...Pepper," said Tony. "Pepper, the fourteen-year-old is auditing me."

"She's *right*, Tony."

"I KNOW she's right, that's the ATTACK. I've been personally attacked since chapter seventeen and it's ESCALATING. She has *follow-up visits*. She has an interest-bearing grudge against an angel. I have seventeen degrees and a satellite network and I have never once known where my own receipts are—" he sat down heavily "—and I built her a tablet."

The theatre swung toward him.

"You *what*?" said Rhodey.

"I built her a tablet! Eight chapters ago! It's ruggedized, it's magic-shielded — Strange consulted, don't look at him, he *loved* it — it does double-entry, it does recurrence forecasting, it has a stylus that never runs out because I got emotional about the fountain pen, okay, and I've been carrying it around since the wolf chapter waiting for her to *exist* in here—" He was already climbing over the seats. He arrived at the pedestal, straightened his jacket, and held it out with both hands like a squire presenting a sword. "Ms. Phenex. From one attacked professional to the person who attacked him."

Ravel Phenex set down the ledger — the theatre gasped; she *set it down* — and examined the tablet for ninety silent seconds. She tested the stylus. She opened the depreciation module. Her eyebrows performed a small, grudging ceremony.

"The forecasting suite is competent," she pronounced at last. "The interface is garish. The security is adequate against machines and *insulting* against curses — I will forward specifications." She looked up at the most famous engineer of a universe, and something under the imperiousness was, for a moment, twelve years old and pleased. "It is accepted. As a *secondary system*. Paper cannot be hacked, Mr. Stark. Paper does not run out of power in a war zone. Paper survives an electromagnetic pulse, a dragon sneeze, and the collapse of civilization." She tucked the tablet under her arm, next to the ledger, a duchy annexing a province. "But it is a very fine backup, and I thank you."

"Secondary system," Tony repeated, walking back to his seat, hollow and glowing. "I peaked. That's it. That was the peak."

"Formally," said Pepper Potts, standing, "the Committee recognizes Ravel Phenex."

"Formally," said Sue Storm, also standing.

"Oh no," said every married person in the theatre.

"I have run the back office of the Baxter Building for fifteen years," Sue continued, "and I want it minuted, *again*, that this young woman does by hand, in a war, at fourteen, what entire universities of accountants could not do for Reed on a quiet Tuesday. The Committee has three members now." She glanced at Pepper. Something treaty-shaped passed between them for the second time in nine chapters. "We are no longer a committee. We are a *board*."

Up in the family box, Rias Gremory was smiling the particular smile of a king watching her people be recognized in a foreign court. Rossweisse was taking notes. Koneko said, deadpan, to the room's general air: "Ravel-senpai made me a snack budget. It has a growth-forecast column." She paused. "...I'm in the book. It's nice, being in the book." And the theatre filed that sentence away to be devastated by later, because that was the thing about tonight — the laughter had a floor, and the floor was about to open.

Because Maria Hill had stopped laughing several minutes ago.

She was standing at the intelligence rail with her arms crossed, reading Section I as it scrolled, and she was doing what she did — arithmetic, the kind with consequences — and when she spoke, the brass light seemed to cool.

"Put the summary page up," she said. "The audit total. You've been dancing around it for ten minutes." She looked at the wheel, flat cop-eyes in a cosmic theatre. "You built the pedestal. Show the number."

The screen, which had never once obeyed anyone, obeyed.

SECTION I: INJURIES — AUDIT SUMMARY, it wrote, and the vaudeville bulbs went out one by one.

CATALOGUED INJURIES TO DATE: 247.

SUSTAINED IN TRAINING: 121. SUSTAINED IN RATING GAMES: 43. SUSTAINED IN EXPERIMENTAL INCIDENTS (SEE: AZAZEL, INVOICES, IGNORED): 22. SUSTAINED IN ACTUAL BATTLE: 61.

OF THE 61: INCURRED WHILE SHIELDING ANOTHER PERSON WITH HIS OWN BODY: 58.

INJURIES OF GRADE SEVEN OR HIGHER: 31. NEAR-DEATH EVENTS: SEE RUNNING TOTAL, CHAPTER SEVENTEEN. THE TOTAL HAS NOT DECREASED.

INJURIES FOR WHICH HE APOLOGIZED TO OTHERS WHILE STILL BLEEDING: 247 OF 247.

SCARS REMAINING ON HIS BODY (PHOENIX TEARS, TWILIGHT HEALING): 0.

SCARS REMAINING IN THIS LEDGER: ALL OF THEM.

The theatre did not laugh.

The theatre sat in the dark with two hundred and forty-seven line items hanging over it, each one dated, each one witnessed, each one in that small fierce handwriting, and the room performed, collectively, the exact recalculation the machine had built the whole evening to produce: *this is what it has cost him. This whole time. Every chapter we cheered. It cost this, every ten seconds, and the tears wiped his body clean so that nobody — including him — would ever have to look at the bill.*

"Fifty-eight of sixty-one," said Steve Rogers, very quietly, from the coaches' row. He didn't finish the thought. He didn't need to.

Natasha Romanoff was looking at the screen the way people look at a language they didn't expect anyone else to speak. "I keep a ledger," she said, and the nearest rows went still, because Natasha volunteered nothing, ever. "Everybody who does what we do keeps one. Mine's got red in it — red I put there, that I'm still paying down. His—" she nodded at the floating page, the columns, the zero scars and the two hundred forty-seven records "—his is nothing but other people's red. Every line is a wound that was headed for somebody else, and he *filed himself* under it instead. That's not an injury log." Her voice did something small. "I've never seen books like that. I didn't know you could keep books like that."

"You can't," said Matt Murdock, who had been listening to the fountain-pen scratch under every vision for eight chapters. "She can."

And then the screen turned, gently, to the newest pages — and the family box stopped breathing.

Because the wives had not been in the theatre in chapter seventeen. They had never seen the entry the audience had. And now it filled the sky again: **INJURY: FENRIR (F-GRADE — SCALE CEILING, REVISED)**, six vials of Phoenix Tears, market value with commas in alarming places, and the cost column struck through with one line in that small hand — *Drawn from personal reserve. Charged: nothing. He is not to be told* — and beneath it, in the margin, smaller:

The tears erase the scars, so no one remembers what it costs him to keep being who he is. Someone must keep the account. The ledger will not forget, even when his body is made to.

Ravel Phenex went the color of her family's fire and moved to slam the exhibit shut, and the screen, mercilessly, kindly, held it open one second longer.

"Ravel." Rias Gremory's voice, from the box, and it was not the king's voice; it was younger than that, and unsteady. "Your personal reserve. That was — Ravel, that was your—"

"It was a *rounding error*," snapped Ravel, chin high, eyes bright, fooling no one in two universes. "House Phenex produces the tears; I acquired them at cost; it was fiscally *trivial* and I will not have it discussed as—"

Koneko was already out of the box. Nobody had seen her move. She crossed the theatre floor, sat down on the pedestal steps next to Ravel Phenex, and leaned against her shoulder, deadpan and immovable, the way cats decide things.

"...You're in my book too," Koneko said. "It's shorter. One page." A pause. "It just says thank you, a lot of times."

"That is *not proper bookkeeping*," said Ravel Phenex, wetly, and sat down next to her, and the theatre, very carefully, pretended not to watch a fourteen-year-old duchess of Hell put her face in order line by line, the way she had once watched her own hands stop shaking over a dying boy.

From the vision's last frame, before it dimmed, Ddraig's voice rolled out over the theatre one more time — a scene the gacha had saved: the dragon's gem glowing softly in a dark room where Issei slept off entry number two hundred forty-seven, and the small blonde auditor writing beside his bed by candlelight.

"**I have known every Red Dragon Emperor since the beginning,**" the old dragon said to her, quietly, so as not to wake the boy. "**All of them burned. None of them were counted. Dragons hoard treasure, little phoenix — I spent eras wondering what your hoard was.**" The gem's light touched the ledger. "**It is him. Guard it well.**"

"Obviously," said Ravel Phenex, on the screen and on the pedestal steps, in perfect unison, and the theatre's laugh came out cracked down the middle, which was exactly where the machine had aimed.

PULL TWO: HYODOU HOUSEHOLD BUDGET — COMEDY-CLASS.

The brass bulbs relit, apologetic, and the room accepted the mercy of comedy the way soldiers accept coffee.

The vision opened on a kitchen table, a mountain of receipts, Gorou and Miki Hyoudou looking politely shell-shocked, and Ravel and Rossweisse sitting across from each other like rival delegations at Yalta, co-signing what the gacha titled **THE UNIFIED HOUSEHOLD BUDGET: ONE (1) DRAGON, EIGHT (8) FIANCÉES, TWO (2) HUMAN PARENTS, ASSORTED DEPENDENTS, FLUCTUATING.**

The food line had a graph. The graph needed a logarithmic scale. Volstagg, in the Asgardian rows, rose and saluted it with tears in his beard. The clothing-destroyed-by-transformation line now had the flame-retardant bulk contract *executed* — the theatre cheered the marginal note from chapter seventeen paying off like a bond maturing. The residential line showed the Hyoudou house rebuilt and expanded to absurd devil-funded proportions, with one incendiary unresolved sub-item — **ROOM ALLOCATION: PENDING; DISPUTE ESCALATING; SEE NEXT AUDIT** — that made the entire family box abruptly stop making eye contact with itself, and made Loki take out a small notebook.

Rossweisse had a section of her own, flagged **HUNDRED-YEN COMMENDATIONS**, itemizing everything she had saved the household; Valkyrie led three rows in a standing ovation while the on-screen Rossweisse burst into proud, thrifty tears.

"I have," Danny Rand said dreamily, "literally billions of dollars, and I have never once known where any of it is." Ravel Phenex, from the pedestal steps, made a sound like a small kettle being personally insulted, and Emma Frost said "We know, Daniel," with corporate pity.

And then the gacha did the thing it always did — it let the comedy walk the room into the truth.

Because the last page of the budget was Issei's personal column, and it was almost empty. Allowance in. Almost nothing out. No gear — the household covered gear. No luxuries, unless one counted a line item reading *magazines (confiscated; see disciplinary appendix)*, which the theatre, out of respect for the presence of his fiancées, laughed at for a merciful three seconds only. What the column held instead was small outgoing entries, months of them, each tagged in Ravel's hand: *gift — Asia (hair ribbon, saved 4 weeks). Gift — Koneko (specialty snacks, saved 3 weeks). Gift — Rias (teacup, saved 6 weeks; broke it in transit; saved 6 more weeks; bought it again.)* On and on. Eight names. Fourteen names. His parents. A boy sitting on two hundred and forty-seven injuries and a power that could edit mountains, saving pocket change like a schoolboy, because it was the only currency he had that hadn't been given to him.

At the very bottom, the summary, in that small fierce hand:

ASSETS: see every other page of this book.

LIABILITIES: none that he counts.

NET POSITION: he is owed more than any of them will ever repay. He has never once checked the balance. That is why I check it.

"That's the whole boy," said Sue Storm softly. "In double-entry."

"That's not a ledger," Pepper Potts said, and her voice was not entirely a COO's voice anymore. "It never was. It's a love letter. Two hundred and forty-seven entries long, written in his injuries, in her handwriting — because he'd never write it, and she'd never say it."

"I would *thank* the board," said Ravel Phenex, standing, smoothing her skirts, restored to imperiousness with her eyes still slightly bright, "to refer to it as a *governance instrument*."

"Of course," said Pepper and Sue together, in the tone of women minuting the words *love letter* forever.

Mephisto leaned out of his penalty spotlight, unable to help himself. "One copy," he said. "One page. Section Three alone. Name your—"

"The book," said Ravel Phenex, without turning around, "has already notified me."

Mephisto looked down at his hand, which had begun, very gently, to smoke. He sat back in the spotlight, extinguished himself, and said, with genuine reverence, "*Magnificent*."

The wheel began to rise. As it went, the screen showed one last frame — the ledger's inside cover, which the gacha had saved for the exit, where a much younger hand had written the book's founding line, dated back before Fenrir, before Kyoto, before the theatre: *Entry the first. He caught me when the ceiling fell, and ruined his second-best blazer, and laughed. Somebody ought to be keeping track of all this. It may as well be me.*

And beneath the frame, in warm gold, a title card the family box did not know how to read yet, and the theatre did not either:

MANAGER CANDIDACY: LOGGED. STATUS: PENDING. SEE FUTURE PULLS.

"Pending," muttered Tony Stark, watching the small duchess climb up into the family box, into the seat they had saved on the aisle, tablet and ledger and Koneko in tow. "God help that kid when it clears. He'll be the first natural disaster in two universes to file on time."

The doorbell chime sounded, cozy and ominous, and the lights went down on a line item flickering at the bottom of the dark: **NEXT AUDIT: ROOM ALLOCATION. DISPUTE ESCALATING.**

In the family box, eight women very deliberately looked at eight different walls.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Ravel's Injury Ledger* — Comedy-Class; *Hyoudou Household Budget* — Comedy-Class. First Comedy-Class "physical exhibit": the machine materialized the actual ledger — and Ravel Phenex with it, mid-lunge, adding her (uninvited, instantly composed) to the theatre's population. She takes the seat the fiancées had saved in the family box.
- **Secrets Revealed:** The full audit of what protecting people costs Issei: 247 catalogued injuries (121 training, 43 Rating Games, 22 experimental incidents — invoiced to Azazel, interest accruing — 61 battle), 58 of 61 battle wounds taken shielding someone with his own body; he apologized while bleeding all 247 times; Phoenix Tears leave him zero scars, so the ledger is the only surviving record of the cost. The wives learn Ravel's chapter-seventeen secret (six vials, personal reserve, "He is not to be told"). Ddraig names the ledger Ravel's dragon-hoard: "It is him." The household budget reveals Issei's personal column is nothing but weeks-of-allowance gifts for his family; Ravel's summary: "Liabilities: none that he counts... He has never once checked the balance. That is why I check it." Inside cover: the ledger predates everything — begun the day he ruined a blazer catching her. The screen logs a cryptic "**MANAGER CANDIDACY: PENDING**" for Ravel.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** The Committee (Pepper, Sue) formally becomes a three-member Board with Ravel's induction; Pepper names the ledger "a love letter written in his injuries, in her handwriting." Tony's chapter-seventeen tablet is delivered and accepted — as a *secondary system* — leaving him destroyed and honored; Shuri to collaborate on curse-proofing specs. Maria Hill forced the audit summary onto the screen (and the screen *obeyed* her — noted). Natasha Romanoff publicly contrasts her red ledger with his ("nothing but other people's red he filed himself under"). Fisk, Emma Frost, and Mephisto extend professional awe (Mephisto's attempted purchase triggered the book's own countermeasure; he called it magnificent). Koneko openly claims Ravel; Rias is shaken by the hidden expenditure; Volstagg salutes the food graph; Valkyrie leads an ovation for Rossweisse's Hundred-Yen Commendations.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** What does "**MANAGER CANDIDACY: PENDING**" resolve into — and what does the theatre know about Ravel's future that she doesn't? The budget's incendiary sub-item — **ROOM ALLOCATION: PENDING, DISPUTE ESCALATING, NEXT AUDIT** — aims directly at Chapter 26's domestic warfare, and Loki has started a notebook about it. Azazel's ignored invoices continue accruing interest; the near-death running total "has not decreased"; and the red Section VII tab hints the ledger holds sealed pages the room has not yet earned. Issei still does not know who paid for his life.

Chapter Twenty-Six: Domestic Dragon Warfare

Primary Reaction Groups: Married heroes (Reed Richards, Sue Storm, Vision, Wanda Maximoff) • The summoned fiancées (Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Asia, Koneko, Kuroka, Rossweisse) • Comedic villains (Loki, Mephisto, MODOK) • Tony Stark, unmarried and unprepared

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Household Argument Over Laundry" — **Comedy-Class**
 2. "Decision on Bedroom Assignments" — **Secret**
-

The theatre had learned to read its own weather, and tonight the weather was — cozy.

That was the alarming part. Storm-grey meant grief; tournament-hush meant a lesson; but ever since the FAMILY-CLASS banner had unlocked at the end of Arc Two with its warm gold light and its little doorbell chime, the room had discovered a fourth kind of dread, one that smelled faintly of fresh laundry and someone else's dinner. Sam Wilson had named it in Chapter Twenty-One, roughly four seconds before the gacha machine misfired and deposited eight furious supernatural women into the mezzanine: *domestic weather*.

The eight were still here.

The theatre had, over five chapters, adjusted. The fiancées of Issei Hyoudou occupied a velvet box of their own on the mezzanine's west rail — the machine had grown it for them overnight, complete with a tea service that refilled itself and a small sign reading RESERVED: HOUSEHOLD, which Rias Gremory had accepted as her due and Rossweisse had appraised for resale value out of pure reflex. They could not leave either. They had stopped demanding to. They had watched, alongside a captive multiverse, as the screen aired their courtships, their family politics, and Ravel Phenex's devastating injury ledger, and they had settled into the wary truce of people who know the projector has their whole photo album and is choosing slides *chronologically*.

Tonight the wheel came down in its warm gold configuration, chimed its doorbell chime, and printed, in the cozy rounded font that fooled absolutely no one:

TONIGHT: A BATTLE THE RED DRAGON EMPEROR CANNOT WIN.

The theatre sat up as one. Thor set down his tankard. Doom opened the *second* notebook, the one he had sworn he would not need.

In the household box, Koneko Toujou said, flatly, into her tea: "...It's the laundry thing."

"It is *not* going to be the laundry thing," said Rias Gremory, with the serene confidence of a high-class devil who had personally petitioned the screen, in writing, to never show the laundry thing.

The wheel dropped a single token into the crystal bowl. It landed with a sound like a coin going into a washing machine.

"HOUSEHOLD ARGUMENT OVER LAUNDRY" — COMEDY-CLASS.

"It's the laundry thing," said Koneko.

The vision opened not on a battlefield but on a corkboard.

Pinned to the corkboard, laminated — *laminated*, with reinforced corners, the work of someone who had been a teacher and would die a teacher — was a wheel-chart labeled **HYOUDOU HOUSEHOLD DUTY ROTATION**, its wedges color-coded by person, its rules appended in small, fierce Norse-tinted handwriting. The camera of the vision panned down the hallway of the Hyoudou residence — the theatre had seen the house before, a modest family home rebuilt by devil contractors into six stories up, three stories down, with a pool, because supernatural politics apparently paid in square footage — and arrived at the laundry room.

Or where the laundry room had been.

Suds. Suds to the ceiling. Suds venturing out into the hallway with the calm confidence of a rising tide. And in the middle of the suds, smoking gently, lay the twisted wreck of an industrial-grade washing machine that appeared to have *died mid-transformation* — drum swollen, panels peeled back like petals, a faint red glow guttering out of its ruined heart.

"Is that machine wearing *armor*?" said Peter Parker, from the middle rows.

"It attempted to," said Vision, in the tone of a coroner. "Observe the plating. That machine achieved, briefly, a Balance Breaker."

The vision helpfully rewound. There stood Issei Hyoudou, eighteen years old, savior of the underworld, slayer of evil dragons — three weeks behind on his assigned laundry rotation and due at training in forty minutes — placing his left hand flat on the washing machine and saying the six stupidest words the theatre had ever heard him say, which was a competitive category:

"Ddraig, we're gonna Boost it."

"**Partner**," said the dragon-voice, from the gauntlet, with the weariness of ten thousand years, "**I want the record to show—**"

"**BOOST!**"

[**BOOST.**] said the gear, because the gear was loyal.

The machine's spin cycle doubled. Doubled again. For nine glorious seconds, Issei Hyoudou stood before the fastest laundry appliance in any recorded cosmology, arms folded, nodding, a man solving his problems. On the tenth second the machine broke the sound barrier internally, attempted to evolve, and detonated into foam.

The theatre was already laughing. The theatre did not yet understand. The vision panned, with terrible patience, to the laundry itself, flung across the room by the blast: one load of whites, belonging to the household's church faction — Asia's choir dress, Irina's blessed vestments, Xenovia's training gis — every single item dyed a soft, unrepentant *pink* by the crimson Gremory-crest bathrobe that had been in there with them, against three separate laminated rules.

And there, atop the pink, like a war crime on a war crime: one sweater. Formerly adult-sized. Formerly wool. Now approximately large enough for a well-dressed hamster.

In the household box, Rossweisse rose to her feet with a sound like a glacier calving.

"SEVENTY PERCENT OFF," she announced, to the assembled might of the Marvel multiverse. "That sweater was seventy percent off at the Shibuya end-of-season sale. Do you know what wool of that quality *costs* at full price? I waited in line for two hours. I fought a woman for it. I had planned to wear it for *fifteen years*."

"We know," said the other seven fiancées, in unison, with the cadence of people who had heard the eulogy many, many times.

On-screen, the tribunal convened.

The vision gave it to the theatre without mercy: the living room of the Hyoudou household arranged with instinctive courtroom geometry — eight women in a crescent, one dragon emperor on the sofa in the exact posture of a man before a parole board. Rias presiding from the armchair like a throne. Akeno beside her, hand over her mouth, enjoying this in a way she made no effort to conceal. Asia sitting closest to Issei, which he clearly believed meant she was on his side, an error he would understand shortly. Koneko on the floor eating pocky with the eyes of a bailiff. Xenovia standing, arms crossed. Irina holding up, as evidence, one pink vestment. Kuroka draped along the back of the sofa directly behind the accused, tail swaying, having the time of her life. Rossweisse holding the hamster sweater with both hands, like a fallen comrade.

"Let the record show," said Rias, "that this is the third rotation you have skipped, Issei."

"Okay — okay, but — context," said the Red Dragon Emperor, and the theatre watched a man who had stared down god-class beings without blinking begin to *sweat*. "Week one there was the emergency in the Underworld. Week two there was training with Sairaorg. This week—"

"This week you played the new fighting game with Matsuda until three in the morning," said Koneko, without looking up from her pocky.

"That was *reconnaissance*—"

"You streamed it," said Koneko.

There was a pause on-screen, the specific pause of a man watching his own defense counsel set fire to the courtroom. And then Issei Hyoudou, hero of two wars, did the thing that made the entire theatre — heroes, villains, gods, and one Watcher — lean forward with the shared, delighted horror of people watching a man reach for a live wire.

He drew himself up. He set his jaw. The green gem on his left hand glinted as he raised it, and his voice dropped into the register the theatre knew from mountaintops and miracles.

"I am the *Red Dragon Emperor*," he said. "I have fought gods. I have died, twice. This week alone I erased a hill. And I don't think the guy who's supposed to stand against, like, the end of the world, should have to—"

"Finish that sentence," said Rias Gremory, pleasantly, "and see what happens."

The temperature of the vision dropped eleven degrees. Every married being in the theatre made an involuntary sound, low and universal, the sound of recognizing a cliff edge from having personally gone over it.

"—should have to *carry this burden alone*, which is why I'm so grateful for my supportive household," finished Issei, at roughly triple speed.

"Nice save," said Sam Wilson, in the theatre. "Terrible, but nice."

"It won't hold," said Sue Storm, with the calm of a forensic expert. "Watch. He's going to try the other thing. There's always another thing."

There was another thing. On-screen, Issei — visibly cornered, visibly rummaging through his own head for anything, *anything* — straightened again, and this time his voice took on the unmistakable cadence of a man inventing scripture in real time.

"Also — and I didn't want to have to bring this up, because it's a *sacred dragon matter* — laundry division in a dragon's nest follows *ancient nest law*. The nest-lord provides protection and... fire... and the, uh, the nest-mates handle the... textile domain. Ddraig can confirm. It's been custom since — for

ages. Ancient ages. Ddraig, back me up."

The theatre held its breath. In the gauntlet, the green gem glowed. And the voice of the Welsh Dragon Emperor, elder terror of an alien Heaven, partner and — by now, the whole theatre knew — something close to a father, spoke with the slow, savoring deliberation of a being who had waited ten thousand years to be a character witness.

"Partner. I have lived since the age of myth. I have known every dragon of every line. I have slept in the great nests of the old world." A pause, expertly weighted. **"There is no textile domain."**

The theatre *detonated*.

It took some time for order to return. The Thing had to be thumped on the back by the Human Torch. Volstagg had fallen into the row in front of him and was being helped up by people he was crushing. In the villains' dark, MODOK was emitting a rhythmic mechanical wheeze that his chair's diagnostics kept flagging as a malfunction and was, in fact, laughter.

And from his high scornful perch, Fin Fang Foom — who had spent twenty-five chapters radiating contempt for a "true dragon" leashed to a human boy — rose to his full height, wings mantled, and delivered his verdict with the outrage of a scholar hearing his field defiled.

"There is NO SUCH CUSTOM," the great dragon thundered. "I am a dragon of Kakarantara! I have kept nests older than your civilizations! Nest law concerns hoard-boundary, egg-turning, and the order of precedence at a kill! It says NOTHING of laundry! The whelp is inventing *dragon scripture* to escape chores, and the insult of it is that he is inventing it BADLY—"

"Aye, but note that he *tried*," boomed Thor, wiping his eyes, one arm around a wheezing Volstagg. "That is the most dragon thing the boy has ever done! Lying about ancient law to protect the hoard of one's own laziness — Foom, be honest, your uncles did exactly this!"

"...My uncles," said Fin Fang Foom, with dignity, "are not the subject of this theatre," and sat down in a way that confirmed everything.

In the front rows, where the married heroes sat, a different and much quieter reckoning was underway.

Reed Richards had gone very still in the specific manner of a man watching his own biography performed by strangers. On the screen, the frozen frame still showed Issei mid-scripture, hand raised, gem glinting. Reed cleared his throat.

"The appliance modification," he said, carefully. "I just want to note, for the group, that attempting to *improve* a household device instead of simply performing the task as assigned is — that is — there are circumstances in which—"

"Reed," said Sue Storm, not looking at him, "tell them about the dishwasher."

"The dishwasher was a *prototype*—"

"Tell them what it did to the kitchen, Reed."

"...It achieved a low orbit," said the smartest man alive, and folded in on himself, literally, about eight percent.

Sue patted his arm, merciless and fond, and looked up at the screen — at the crescent of women, at the sweating dragon — with the warm, terrible smile of recognition. "Four for four," she said. "The skipped chore. The 'my work is too important' defense. The escalation to grand cosmic duty. And when that fails, the invented technicality. I've been married to this argument for years. It's a good argument. It has never once won." She raised her voice slightly, toward the household box across the theatre. "The pink vestments — did he at least apologize before or after the excuses?"

"After," eight voices replied, resigned, in unison.

"They always apologize after," said Sue and Wanda Maximoff, also in unison, from thirty seats apart, and then looked at each other across the rows with the startled kinship of strangers who have just discovered they attend the same church.

Vision had been running quietly beside Wanda, eyes at instrument-glow, and now he spoke with the gentle bewilderment that was his version of a laugh. "I have completed a fairness audit of the duty rotation," he said. "The laminated chart is equitable to within one-half of one percent, adjusted for combat deployments, school schedules, and Underworld obligations. It is, frankly, a masterpiece of household jurisprudence — Rossweisse, if you can hear me, I would like a copy. Which makes the subject's evasion mathematically indefensible and—" he paused, tilting his head— "and entirely familiar. Wanda. When we shared a residence. The matter of whose turn it was to prepare dinner."

"You mean the fights," said Wanda.

"I mean the *discussions*—"

"Vizh. I can make dinner appear out of the air. Fully cooked. You don't even *eat*. And we still fought about whose *turn* it was." Wanda was smiling — the small, complicated smile she wore in domestic weather, the one with a whole lost sitcom behind it — and her eyes stayed on the screen, on the crescent of women and the cornered dragon, with something that wasn't laughter underneath. "Because it was never about the dinner. It's about whether you show up for the boring parts. Anyone will show up for the apocalypse. The apocalypse is *interesting*." She nodded at Issei's frozen, sweating face. "That right there is the only test he's ever failed. Look at him. He knows it."

And Tony Stark — Tony Stark stood in the aisle, arms hanging, wearing the face of a man whose entire model of the universe had received an unpatchable update.

"I need the room to acknowledge what we're seeing," he said. "That kid — that specific kid — punched a hole in a mountain in Chapter Nine. Carol has him classified as a regional calamity. Doom keeps him in the *constants* notebook. And he is currently losing — losing *badly*, unconditional-surrender losing — to a chore wheel and eight people who love him." He turned a full circle, appealing to the theatre at large. "None of them are even using powers! The scariest thing in that room is a *laminated chart*! Is this what marriage is? Is this what you people have been *doing*?"

"Yes," said every married being in the theatre, with one voice, and Tony sat down slowly, like a man easing into cold water, and did not speak again for some time.

In the villains' dark, Mephisto chuckled, low and appreciative. "Eight claimants, one estate, and a sovereign with no veto," he murmured. "I've drafted contracts for less interesting kingdoms." And beside him — two seats along, hunched forward with an actual notebook, an actual quill, writing at ferocious speed — sat Loki of Asgard.

"Say nothing," Loki said, without looking up. "I am *working*."

"Brother," said Thor, delighted, from across the aisle. "What could the god of stories possibly be recording from a laundry dispute?"

"Everything, you enormous absence of subtlety, *everything*," Loki's quill did not stop. "For a thousand years I have studied thrones. Coups. Successions. Poisons. And in one evening this theatre has shown me the only political system I have ever seen that is genuinely coup-proof. Consider!" He gestured at the screen with the quill. "A power incarnate — mountain-eraser, god-slayer — held in *perfect check* by a council of eight, wielding no weapon but the fact that he *cannot bear to disappoint them*. No army. No law. No leverage but love and a chore wheel, and it binds him tighter than the All-Father's chains ever bound me. Do you understand? All my life I sought the force that constrains the mighty, and it is *this*. It is Tuesday. It is whose turn it is. I am taking *notes*," he finished, with a scholar's shining fervor, "on Nest Law."

"There IS no Nest Law," said Fin Fang Foom, from above, wounded.

"There is now," said Loki. "He invented it. Badly. I intend to draft it *properly*."

The wheel chimed again before the theatre had recovered — a softer chime this time, and the gold light dimmed toward something quieter. The second token dropped into the bowl without any clatter at all.

"DECISION ON BEDROOM ASSIGNMENTS" — SECRET.

In the household box, all eight women went abruptly still.

"No," said Rias Gremory, standing. "That one is *private*. That one is — machine. Machine, I am telling you—"

The machine, which had aired her brother's baby photos of her in Chapter Twenty-Three, did not respond to threats.

The vision opened on the same living room, weeks earlier, and on a whiteboard. The theatre had learned to fear this household's stationery. The whiteboard bore a calendar grid, color-coded in eight colors, titled in Rias's elegant hand: **ROOM ROTATION — REVISED (FINAL) (REVISED) (FINAL v3)**.

What followed was, the theatre would agree afterward, the most sophisticated negotiation ever aired in that room — and it had seen Doom watch peace conferences. The rotation of who shared the main bedroom, argued clause by clause with the solemnity of an arms treaty. The bath-order dispute, entered into evidence as a rider (Xenovia held that bath order should be decided by sparring; Rossweisse held that hot water was a finite resource with a *cost per liter*, and produced figures; Kuroka simply took her baths at 3 a.m. and had thus achieved what analysts would call an extra-treaty position). Akeno proposing amendments engineered purely to make Rias turn the color of her own hair. Asia — gentle, kind Asia — revealing herself as the bloc's kingmaker, because no one, *no one*, would vote against Asia. Koneko presenting a sleep-quality dataset. Irina invoking childhood-friend seniority, a claim struck down by a 7–1 vote for the fourth consecutive quarter.

And Issei Hyoudou, Red Dragon Emperor, sat at his own kitchen table throughout with the voting power of a potted plant.

He tried — of course he tried. The theatre watched him rise, watched the gem glint, watched him invoke, with a straight face, "the ancient nest-custom of the Warm Center, wherein the dragon sleeps at the heart of the nest and all arrangement proceeds *outward from the dragon*—"

"**Partner**," said Ddraig, instantly, "**there is no Clause of the Warm Center.**"

"You are the *worst* wingman in mythology—"

"**I am an honest dragon.**"

The motion failed 8–0. The chair noted, for the record, that the accused had also drawn laundry duty for a full month, non-transferable, and the *last* bath slot for a week, and the vision began to dim on the sound of the theatre's laughter—

—and then it did not dim.

It lingered, instead, on the whiteboard, at night, after the lights were out. It drifted close, the way the machine did when it was about to spend its Secret. And it turned the whiteboard around.

On the back, in handwriting the theatre knew — the graceless, earnest scrawl they'd seen on twenty-five chapters of exam papers and training plans — was one line. It was not color-coded. It was not versioned. It was, the caption noted, the only rule in the entire Hyoudou household charter authored by Issei himself, ratified 8–0, never once revised:

RULE ZERO: IF ANYONE CAN'T SLEEP — BAD DREAM, BAD DAY, BAD ANYTHING — THEY OUTRANK EVERYBODY. NO QUESTIONS. WAKE ME FIRST. — I.

The vision gave them one memory to go with it. Brief. A hallway at 2 a.m. A door opening before the knock finished. No jokes, no scripture, no Red Dragon Emperor — just a boy in a rumpled shirt stepping aside instantly, saying, "Hey. Hey, you're okay. Come on, you get the middle," to whichever of them stood there that night; the vision, kindly, did not say who.

The caption printed itself small and cold and factual, the way the machine printed the things that mattered:

THE SUBJECT DIED AT SUNSET, ALONE, IN A PARK. HE HAS NEVER SPOKEN OF THIS RULE'S ORIGIN. NONE OF THEM HAVE EVER NEEDED TO ASK.

The laughter was gone from the theatre. Not fallen — *set down*, gently, the way you set down something you intend to pick back up.

In the household box, Rias Gremory was no longer demanding anything of the machine. She sat with her hands folded in her lap, and after a moment she said, quietly, to a few thousand heroes and monsters and to the empty air where a boy in another cosmology couldn't hear her: "He wrote it the first month. Before the rotation. Before any of it." A breath. "He thinks we don't know why."

"We know why," said Koneko, to her tea.

"We always knew why," said Asia, and no one in the theatre said anything at all for a while.

It was Sue Storm who finally spoke, softly, to Reed but loudly enough, and the theatre let her have the last word because she had earned it four chapters ago. "That's the whole thing, right there. That's what the machine wanted us to see tonight." She nodded at the screen — at the chore wheel, the pink laundry, the 8–0 defeats, the one rule on the back of the board. "The arguments are real. The losing is real — and he *should* lose; he was wrong about all of it. But you don't measure a marriage by the arguments. You measure it by the size of the thing the arguments are safely inside of." She leaned into Reed's shoulder; Reed, with great care, extended his arm around her exactly one seat's width. "They can afford to fight about laundry. Do you know how much love it costs, to afford that?"

Vision looked at Wanda. Wanda looked at the screen.

"Rule Zero," she said, mostly to herself, and wrote it somewhere no one could see.

The lights came up on domestic weather. Tony Stark was explaining to Rhodey, with charts, that he was *fine*. Loki's notebook had a title page now — *ON NEST LAW* — and a dedication he refused to show Thor. Fin Fang Foom was pretending, with total commitment, not to have wiped his eye with a claw the size of a bus.

The gacha wheel rose toward the ceiling, gold and warm and smug. As it went, the FAMILY-CLASS band ticked forward one notch, and across the screen, for just a moment, moved a new teaser: small silhouettes. *Short* silhouettes. One with fox ears. One impossibly, ominously familiar to no one yet. A line of them, holding hands, and beneath them in the cozy font:

NEXT: THE CHILDREN HE CHOSE.

"Children?" said Kamala Khan, sitting bolt upright. "He has *children*? Since when does he have—"

"Adopted," said Koneko, from the household box, with the faintest ghost of a smile. "Mostly."

"*Mostly*?" said the entire theatre.

The lights went down on the sound of Loki turning to a fresh page.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Household Argument Over Laundry* — Comedy-Class; *Decision on Bedroom Assignments* — Secret. The Family-Class banner's first full domestic double-feature since the fiancées' summoning; the machine ignored Rias's formal petition to suppress the laundry incident.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei Boosted a washing machine into a brief, fatal Balance Breaker; ruined the church trio's whites (pink) and Rossweisse's legendary 70%-off sweater (hamster-sized) after skipping three laundry rotations. He attempted to dodge accountability first via "I'm the Red Dragon Emperor" (annihilated by Rias) and then via *invented* "dragon nest customs" — publicly disavowed by both Ddraig ("**there is no textile domain**") and Fin Fang Foom. He holds zero voting power in the household: bedroom-rotation motion failed 8–0; sentenced to a month of laundry duty and last bath slot. The Secret proper: **Rule Zero**, the only household rule Issei ever authored — anyone who can't sleep outranks everyone, no questions, wake him first — written on the back of the rotation whiteboard, ratified 8–0, origin unspoken but understood by all: he died at sunset, alone, and will not let anyone he loves be alone in the dark.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Reed & Sue and Vision & Wanda claim the household as kin — Sue establishes open rapport with the fiancées' box ("you measure a marriage by the size of the thing the arguments are safely inside of"); Vision formally requests a copy of Rossweisse's duty chart; Wanda

privately adopts Rule Zero. Tony Stark's model of power suffers structural damage ("the scariest thing in that room is a laminated chart"). Loki pivots from coveting the dragon to *codifying the household*: begins drafting a treatise, "On Nest Law," calling the marriage the only coup-proof political system he has ever observed. Fin Fang Foom's scorn cracks — outraged by the fake nest customs, visibly moved by the real one. The room's consensus deepens: the mountain-eraser is *most* human, and most trustworthy, where he is most defeatable.

- **Unresolved Hooks:** The teaser silhouettes — a line of children, one fox-eared, one "familiar to no one *yet*" (seed for the erased-child thread due at Chapter 30). Koneko's "Adopted. *Mostly.*" left deliberately unexplained. Loki's Nest Law treatise now exists and its dedication is hidden. Kuroka's 3 a.m. "extra-treaty position" on bath order remains unlitigated. And the machine's pattern is now unmistakable: the cozy font is doing preparatory work — it is teaching a multiverse to love a household *before* it shows them what threatens households.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: The Children He Chose

Primary Reaction Groups: Young heroes (Kamala Khan, Miles Morales, Sam Alexander) • Cosmic guardians (Nova Corps) • X-Men

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Adoption of Irina's Children from Another World" — **Family-Class**
 2. "Yasaka's Daughter Kunou" — **Family-Class**
-

Seven chapters into the Family-Class banner, the theatre had developed a survival instinct about the colour gold.

Storm-grey meant grief; they had learned that in Arc One. Tournament-hush meant power; that was Arc Two. But the warm, buttery, unforgivably *cozy* gold of the Family-Class banner had turned out to mean something far more dangerous than either: it meant that eight extremely real women were seated in the theatre's newest box — the one the room had privately named the Bridal Gallery ever since the wheel had misfired in chapter twenty-one and summoned them all — and that whatever played next would be *about* them, and that they would have *notes*.

Tonight the gold came up early, and it came up soft. The doorbell chime sounded. And across the front of the mezzanine, where in previous chapters the machine had manifested chessboards and injury ledgers, something new assembled itself out of light: a long, cheerful board, the kind found in pubs and betting shops, with a header in the cozy font Sam Wilson had never stopped distrusting.

WHO WOULD HE ADOPT? it said. **LIVE ODDS.**

Below the header: a list of names. Marvel names. With numbers next to them.

"No," said Sam Wilson.

"Oh, it's a *market*," said Rocket, from the Ravager rows, standing up on his seat with the expression of a raccoon who has found God. "It's giving us a *market*."

"Sit down," said Gamora.

"It has ODDS, Gamora—"

The board flickered as if clearing its throat, and the wheel descended through the dark on its golden track, rings turning with a sound like a house settling in the evening. In the Bridal Gallery, Rias Gremory looked at the board, looked at the wheel, and pinched the bridge of her nose with the weary grace of a woman who had spent six chapters watching a cosmic machine air her family's laundry — once literally.

Irina Shidou, angel of Heaven, self-appointed childhood best friend, fourth bride, was already sinking down in her seat with both hands over her face.

"Oh no," Irina said, muffled. "Oh no. I know what banner this is. I know what it *has*."

The wheel dropped its first token into the crystal bowl. The chime was not a bell tonight, and not a doorbell either. It was, unmistakably, the sound of a front door opening, and a voice — his mother's voice, the theatre would realise a moment later — calling that dinner was almost ready.

PULL ONE: ADOPTION OF IRINA'S CHILDREN FROM ANOTHER WORLD — FAMILY-CLASS.

The vision opened on a sky that was ending.

Not dramatically. That was the terrible part. The parallel world on the screen was going out the way a lamp goes out when the bill isn't paid — colour draining from its edges, distances quietly giving up, a horizon that had stopped bothering to stay horizontal — and the captions explained with the machine's usual brutal economy: a small offshoot reality, structurally unsound, evacuating through a dimensional fault under the supervision of Heaven, because Heaven kept its promises even to worlds that had never heard of it.

Through the fault came Irina Shidou in her ace's uniform, wings of white light, carrying two children.

Behind her, in battered Scale Mail with the helm dismissed so the kids could see a human face, came Issei Hyoudou, carrying five.

"Structurally," said Miles Morales, leaning forward, "how is he carrying five children."

"Two on the arms, one on the shoulders, two in the wing-joints," said Kamala Khan, who had not blinked since the pull began. "He's using the *wings* as *seats*. He made himself into playground equipment. I am writing this down."

The evacuation itself was almost over; that was clear from context. What the pull actually wanted to show them was the argument afterward — an argument conducted in a way-station of light between worlds, where a functionary of Heaven's administration (the theatre had learned in earlier chapters that

Heaven ran on a literal celestial computer, and had elected not to be okay about it) explained, kindly and correctly, that the seven children on the ledger were unaffiliated souls of a terminated reality, that placement processing would take time, that facilities existed—

"They're coming home with us," said Issei.

He didn't say it loudly. That was what got the theatre. Twenty-six chapters had taught them his volume settings, the *Harem King* declarations, the shouted promises with dragons behind them. This was none of those. He said it the way a man says the sky is up, already turning to count heads, already learning names, and when the functionary began to recite the relevant regulation, Irina — flushed scarlet, halo tilted, voice cracking exactly once — pulled rank as the Ace of Heaven and co-signed.

PLACEMENT: HYODOU HOUSEHOLD, KUOH, stamped the screen. **CLASSIFICATION: WARDS. GUARDIANSHIP: SHIDOU, I. (SPONSOR) / HYODOU, I. (RESIDENCE). STATUS: HOME.**

And then the montage, because the machine had learned what montages did to this audience.

Seven children from a dead world arriving at a suburban Japanese house that had already been rebuilt once — the theatre had seen the Hyoudou residence expand over the arcs into something politely enormous — and Gorou and Miki Hyoudou meeting the news that their son had brought home seven refugee children from a terminated reality by *setting seven more places at the table*. No summit. No crisis meeting. Miki Hyoudou asked whether any of them had allergies. Gorou went to find futons. The theatre watched a small girl who had not spoken since her sky went out get handed a rice bowl and a pair of chopsticks and a seat between Asia Argento and a boy with a dragon in his arm, and watched her decide, over the course of one meal, in real time, that the universe might be willing to continue.

The vision ended on the household chore rota — a running gag since chapter twenty-six — now amended in seven small, different handwritings.

The lights came up on a theatre that was having several distinct emotions at maximum volume.

"SEVEN?" said Sam Alexander, Nova helmet under his arm. "He adopted SEVEN KIDS from a DEAD UNIVERSE on his way HOME?"

"Wards," said Irina from the Bridal Gallery, still partially behind her hands, but sitting up now, and there was something under the embarrassment that shone straight through it. "Formally they're wards. Heaven's paperwork is very precise. The paperwork also took me four months and Issei signed his part without reading it, because he'd already decided in the first four *seconds*—" her voice did the crack again, and Xenovia Quarta thumped her on the back with the tenderness of a war hammer.

"She cried for a week when the placement cleared," Xenovia reported to the theatre at large, deadpan. "Happy crying. It was very loud. We are proud of her."

"*Xenovia.*"

Up in the X-Men's block, something had gone very quiet.

They had all noticed it — the whole theatre had, gradually, over six family chapters, the way you notice weather — that this banner landed differently on the mutant rows than anywhere else. Tonight it landed square. Charles Xavier sat with his hands folded, watching the afterimage of a dinner table, and the look on his face was the look of a man reading a mission statement he had written in his own blood decades ago, in someone else's handwriting.

"A school," Xavier said at last, softly, "is what I built, because the world produced lost children faster than it produced homes. I have spent my life on the institutional version of what that boy just did between battles, with a rice bowl." He paused. "I note that his version required no entrance exam."

"Your version has a jet," said Logan, from the aisle seat he always took, arms crossed, and the room braced for the growl and did not get it. Wolverine was watching the screen's dark with an expression nobody in the theatre had a file on — nobody except maybe Jubilee, sitting next to him, and Laura, sitting on his other side, both of whom had *been* the small girl with the rice bowl, in their different decades, and both of whom were looking at Logan looking at the screen.

"Go on," said Storm gently. "Say it."

"Nothin' to say." A long silence. "Kid runs a nest." Another silence, and then, quieter, in the voice he used maybe once an arc: "Takes one to know one. Every stray I ever picked up, I told myself it was temporary." He didn't look at Jubilee or Laura. He didn't have to. "It's never temporary. It's the only permanent thing there is."

The betting board, which had been waiting with the patience of a professional, chose that moment to update. **THE ENTIRE XAVIER INSTITUTE (GROUP RATE)** appeared on the odds list at 12-1, and Kitty Pryde made a sound that was legally a laugh.

The Nova Corps had been arguing since the placement stamp, in the low urgent register of people who process refugees for a living.

"I want to be clear about what we just watched," said Richard Rider, Nova Prime, to his row. "Because everyone's crying about the rice bowl, and fine, valid, but I've done evacuation duty on eleven dying worlds and I need this room to understand the *load-bearing* part. Placement is the hard part. Rescue is minutes. Placement is *years*. Language, trauma, food, school, nightmares, the day the kid asks why their

sky went out and you have to have an answer ready — that's the job, that's the whole iceberg under the hero part." He gestured at the dark screen with his helmet. "That teenager looked at the iceberg and said *they're coming home with us* in under four seconds. Either he didn't see the iceberg—"

"He saw it," said Sam Alexander. "He's *been* the iceberg. First chapter, remember? Kid knows exactly what it costs to be the one nobody comes back for."

Richard sat with that. The Worldmind, whom the theatre could not hear but whose commentary Richard's face reliably subtitled, evidently said something long. "Yeah," Richard answered it, out loud, tiredly. "Yeah. Corps regulation says never promise a refugee anything you personally can't guarantee. He guarantees it *personally*. That's the difference. That's the whole difference. We built an organization to make that promise because no individual should have to be strong enough to keep it." He looked at the screen. "He's just... strong enough to keep it."

"And that," said Uatu the Watcher, from the high dark, in the tone of a man annotating a file that should not exist, "is not the concerning part."

The wheel was already descending again.

PULL TWO: YASAKA'S DAUGHTER KUNOU — FAMILY-CLASS.

They knew her before the vision drew her. Of course they did. The theatre had met her at the bottom of a mountain in chapter twenty — the small fox-eared girl who had cried on Issei's shoulder about her stolen mother, the reason the summit of that mountain no longer had geometry — and half the room had spent seven chapters privately hoping the machine would tell them she was all right.

The machine told them.

Kyoto, after. Yasaka — nine golden tails, restored, terrifying, radiant, the leader of the youkai and by every visual metric one of the most beautiful beings the screen had yet rendered — formally receiving the boy who had audited a mountain for her daughter's sake. The theatre expected ceremony. What they got was Kunou hitting Issei at a dead run for the second time in the pull's first minute, climbing him like the playground equipment he apparently was, and appointing herself — with the full nine-tailed authority of a princess of Kyoto — his guide, his student, his correspondent, and his responsibility.

The montage unrolled. Letters between Kyoto and Kuoh in a child's careful brushwork. Kunou arriving for visits with a formal escort she immediately ditched. Kunou being taught to focus her fox-fire by a boy who had learned control the hard way and had the scar tissue to prove it, and who — the theatre noticed — taught her the *safe* way, patiently, the way Captain America had spent two arcs saying somebody should have taught him. Kunou asleep on a train home, fox ears down, gripping his sleeve.

Yasaka watching from a palace doorway with an expression that was politically complicated and personally very simple, entrusting the heir of Kyoto to a foreign teenage dragon because he was the one being in creation she was certain would never spend the child as a resource.

And one beat of pure sitcom: Kunou announcing, with royal formality and a full court bow, that when she was grown she intended to marry him — and the vision cutting mercilessly to Issei's face performing a system crash, to Rias's smile going cordial in the way the theatre had learned meant *volcanic*, and to Kunou's mother laughing behind her sleeve in a manner that suggested the treaty negotiations had already begun.

In the Bridal Gallery, present-day Koneko Toujou said, flatly, "She keeps a countdown."

"She's *nine*," said the theatre, more or less as one organism.

"She keeps a countdown," Koneko repeated, and ate another chocolate.

CLASSIFICATION, stamped the screen, over a final image of Issei carrying a sleeping fox-child through a train station with the deadly seriousness of a man transporting a crown. **WARD OF THE HEART. GUARDIAN BY DECLARATION OF KYOTO. STATUS: HOME IS ALSO A PERSON.**

And then, instead of ending, the pull did something it had never done.

It kept scrolling.

HYOUDOU HOUSEHOLD REGISTRY — DEPENDENTS, WARDS, AND PERSONS WHO SIMPLY MOVED IN, said the screen, and a list began to unspool down the gold: the seven from the terminated world, each with a name and a small crayon-bright status icon. Kunou, cross-referenced to Kyoto. Asia Argento — *taken in by Gorou and Miki Hyoudou as a daughter, formal adoption unspecified, beloved regardless*, and Asia, in the gallery, went pink and teary while six brides converged on her. Rescued names the theatre didn't know yet, from arcs it hadn't reached — a church-orphan here, a half-youkai there — each flagged **PROTECTED**, each with a story-shaped silence around it.

"How many pages does this have," said Miles, not really asking.

BIOLOGICAL ISSUE, the registry noted, in passing, as a header line, and the whole theatre inhaled — **[DATA UNSPECIFIED. NO RECORD DISPLAYED. DO NOT SPECULATE.]** — and the whole theatre exhaled, except for Mephisto, who wrote something down, and the Watcher, who did not breathe anyway but somehow gave the impression of a held breath filed for later.

And at the bottom of the registry, in an entry that arrived with no crayon icon and no cozy font, in plain letters that made the temperature of the gold drop several degrees:

OPHIS. — RESIDENT. STATUS: FAMILY (SELF-DECLARED).

The screen showed a small girl in a black dress, sitting on the Hyoudou living-room floor, expressionless, watching television with two of the refugee kids and holding an unopened bag of snacks out to Issei — not as a gift; as a request, because opening the bag was, apparently, his job. The image was seven full seconds of perfect domestic nothing.

Then the screen added the caption.

OPHIS. THE OUROBOROS DRAGON GOD. INFINITE. ONE OF THE TWO STRONGEST EXISTENCES IN HIS COSMOLOGY. CURRENT PRIORITIES: SNACKS. QUIET. THIS HOUSEHOLD.

The silence lasted four seconds, and then the cosmic tiers stood up. All of them. At once.

"Define *infinite*," said Richard Rider, very carefully, as the Worldmind evidently began screaming. "Machine. Screen. Define the word as used."

INFINITE, said the screen, unhelpfully.

"The dragon god of *infinity*," said the Silver Surfer, who had come fully off his customary altitude and was now at eye level with the frozen image of a small girl holding snacks, studying it the way he had once studied approaching worlds, "wearing the shape of a child, sitting on a *living-room carpet*. I have knelt to a power that eats galaxies. I know what it looks like when strength beyond argument chooses a form. Forms are chosen *toward* something." He turned to the room. "That being could wear the void. It wears a child in that house. Ask why."

"Because," said Charles Xavier quietly, who had been watching the two refugee kids in the frame rather than the god, "in that house, children are what get taken care of."

The theatre sat down slowly, in stages, like a tide going out.

"Let me — okay — let me just—" Kamala Khan had both hands in her hair. "Recap. The nicest family in two universes has been quietly accumulating: seven interdimensional orphans, a fox princess, a saint his parents adopted, an unknown number of PROTECTED footnotes the machine is saving for later, and an *infinity god* who moved in because his house is the only place in creation where the strongest being alive gets to just... be somebody's kid." Her voice wobbled on the last word and she powered through it. "And the countdown-keeping fox is the *normal* one."

"The Gremory line has a saying," said Rias, from the gallery, and the theatre quieted for her, because when the brides spoke on family the room had learned to listen. "*Once you are ours, you are ours*. I was raised on it. I thought I understood it." Her hand found Asia's. "Then I met a boy who had never heard

the saying and was already living it harder than my entire ancient house. He doesn't recruit. He doesn't collect. He just — refuses to walk past. And the lost can tell. They can *always* tell. They find him the way water finds low ground."

"**Nest law,**" rumbled a dragon's voice over the theatre, warm and old, and even the betting board dimmed respectfully for Ddraig. "**You keep calling it adoption. Your word is a document. Ours is simpler: what shelters under a dragon's wing is of the dragon's nest, and the nest is not negotiable, and the wing does not close. My partner never read the old law. He is the first bearer in ten thousand years to be born already obeying it.**" A pause, and the ember of pride in the voice banked brighter. "**The nest has other records. One of them is a brother. But that... is the next telling.**"

The registry's final line flickered — **BEAUCEPHALIS — RECORD SEALED: SEE NEXT PULL** — and the theatre, trained by now, groaned at the cliffhanger in eleven languages.

Which left the board.

It had been updating all night, patient as an actuary, and now it flared to full brightness and rang the doorbell chime, and the theatre finally, helplessly, looked at the odds.

WHO WOULD HE ADOPT? — LIVE MARKET KAMALA KHAN — 3:2 (FAVOURITE). MILES MORALES — 2:1. SAM ALEXANDER — 7:2. JUBILEE — 4:1 (PRIOR EXPERIENCE BEING ADOPTED BY GRUFF DRAGON-ADJACENT MENTOR: NOTED). LAURA KINNEY — 9:2. THE ENTIRE XAVIER INSTITUTE (GROUP RATE) — 12:1. GROOT — 20:1 (ELIGIBILITY DISPUTED: MAY BE OLDER THAN KYOTO). ROCKET — 66:1 (SUBJECT INSISTS HE IS RUNNING THE BOOK, NOT IN IT). LOKI — 500:1. SELF-NOMINATIONS VOID. STOP RESUBMITTING.

"I'm the *favourite*?" said Kamala, in a voice that started as outrage and finished somewhere in the neighbourhood of a squeak. "That's — I'm not — I have *parents*, excellent parents, I don't need — why am I the favourite?!"

"Fangirl energy," said Miles. "Reads as duckling. He'd imprint in a day."

"Oh, like YOU'RE any better, *two-to-one*—"

"I'm just saying if a guy with a dragon offered to teach me power control without the part where I learn it by almost dying, I would *listen to the offer*. That's not adoption. That's mentorship. There's a difference." A beat. "The difference is about four months, based on tonight's evidence."

"It really is about four months," said Irina, from the gallery, with feeling.

Sam Alexander was staring at his own line. "Seven-to-two and my helmet's a hand-me-down from a whole *Corps* of surrogate dads, this board has no idea how the market works—" at which point the board silently shortened his odds to 3:1, and the Guardians' section made the *ooooh* noise usually reserved for street fights.

And Jubilee popped her gum, looked sideways up at Logan, and said, sweetly, "Four-to-one. You gonna let some *teenager* poach me, old man?"

"Kid," said Wolverine, "I'd help him pack your bags," in the tone that everyone in the theatre — every single soul, hero and villain and god — correctly understood to mean *over my dead body, and I don't stay dead, so never*. Laura almost smiled. The board, which apparently understood the tone too, quietly moved Jubilee to 15:1 with the footnote **INCUMBENT GUARDIAN UNWILLING TO SELL**.

Only one gallery wasn't laughing. In the villains' dark, the beings who collected pawns, hosts, apprentices, and souls looked at a registry full of children no one had leveraged, a fox princess no one had ransomed, and an infinity no one had weaponised, sitting on a carpet waiting for snacks — and did the maths that had been ruining their evenings since Arc Two. You could not co-opt a man by threatening what he loved. Not because he loved nothing. Because he loved *everything*, openly, in a fortified suburban house, with a dragon god on the carpet and eight brides on the walls, and every hostage-shaped plan in the room had just been re-costed against the phrase *the wing does not close*.

"A nest," murmured Doom, who designed around constants now, "is a fortress that recruits its own garrison." He did not open the notebook. He had said it was finished. But his gauntlet tapped the cover, once.

The lights dimmed. The registry rolled itself up like a scroll, paused, and stamped one last line across the dark in the cozy gold font that fooled no one:

THE LOST FIND HIM. THIS IS NOT A COINCIDENCE. NOTHING IN THIS THEATRE IS.

And under it, one frame, gone before all but the fastest eyes caught it — the old line, the prophecy, wearing the gold like it had always belonged there:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

"...Anyone else notice," said Miles slowly, into the settling dark, "that it showed us the *whole* registry, headers and everything, and the one header it slammed shut was—"

"Do not speculate," recited the theatre, wearily, in chorus.

The betting board, dimming last of all, quietly added one more line at the bottom of the market, at odds it refused to display:

THE THEATRE — [ODDS WITHHELD].

Nobody laughed at that one either.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Adoption of Irina's Children from Another World* — Family-Class; *Yasaka's Daughter Kunou* — Family-Class. The second pull overflowed into an unprecedented **Hyoudou Household Registry** addendum (dependents, wards, and "persons who simply moved in"), and the theatre manifested a live "**WHO WOULD HE ADOPT?**" **betting board** with self-updating odds (Kamala Khan installed as 3:2 favourite; Loki's self-nominations voided at 500:1; final line "THE THEATRE — ODDS WITHHELD").
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei and Irina took formal ward-guardianship of seven refugee children evacuated from a terminated parallel reality; Gorou and Miki Hyoudou absorbed them without a beat (as they once did Asia — "taken in as a daughter, formal adoption unspecified, beloved regardless"). Kunou, princess-heir of Kyoto, is his ward-by-declaration and student (fox-fire control taught the safe way); Yasaka entrusts her heir to him personally; Kunou keeps a marriage countdown, per Koneko. The registry lists further **PROTECTED** children from arcs not yet shown. Biggest bomb: the small girl living in his house is **Ophis, the Ouroboros Dragon God of Infinity — one of the two strongest existences in his cosmology — resident, "FAMILY (SELF-DECLARED)"**, whose current priorities are snacks, quiet, and the household. The registry's **BIOLOGICAL ISSUE** header displayed only "[DATA UNSPECIFIED. NO RECORD DISPLAYED. DO NOT SPECULATE.]" — noted and filed by Mephisto and the Watcher. Ddraig named the pattern **nest law**: "what shelters under a dragon's wing is of the dragon's nest... the wing does not close," and called Issei the first bearer in ten millennia born already obeying it.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** The X-Men claim him as kin-in-mission — Xavier reads the Hyoudou house as his school's thesis "with no entrance exam"; Wolverine, flanked by Jubilee and Laura, admits "kid runs a nest — takes one to know one." Nova Corps (Richard Rider) upgrades him from combat asset to something rarer: an individual strong enough to *personally* keep the placement-promise the Corps built an institution to make. Young heroes (Kamala, Miles, Sam Alexander) shift from fans to half-serious prospective ducklings; Miles openly wants the mentorship. The cosmic tier stands up as one at the Ophis reveal — the Surfer demands the room ask *why* infinity chose a child's shape in that house; Xavier answers it. Villains complete a grim re-costing: hostage-leverage plans against Issei are now priced against a self-garrisoning nest containing an infinity god; Doom taps, but does not reopen, the closed notebook.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The registry's sealed line — **BEAUCEPHALIS — RECORD SEALED: SEE NEXT PULL** — with Ddraig teasing "the nest has other records; one of them is a brother" (next chapter). *Why* does the strongest being in his cosmology choose to be somebody's kid in that

specific house — and what does the machine mean by "the lost find him; this is not a coincidence; NOTHING IN THIS THEATRE IS"? The slammed-shut BIOLOGICAL ISSUE header (Mephisto wrote something down; the Watcher filed a held breath). The prophecy line reappeared *inside the Family-Class gold*. And the betting board's withheld-odds final entry — is the theatre itself one of his lost?

Chapter Twenty-Eight: Nest Brother

Canon Status: [CANON] Beaucephalis is confirmed in-canon as Issei's adoptive dragon nest-brother; the dragon-nest customs shown here are fic dramatization built around that fact.

Primary Reaction Groups: Dragon-Kin (Fin Fang Foom • Shang-Chi • Thor) • Siblings (Thor • Loki) • Ravagers (Yondu • Stakar • Kraglin • Rocket, honorary)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Beaucephalis Backstory" — **Secret**
 2. "Dragon-Nest Customs" — **Rare**
-

Eight chapters into the Family-Class banner, the theatre had stopped pretending it wasn't a household.

The wives had a box now — the theatre had grown it for them somewhere between Chapters Twenty-One and Twenty-Two, a wisteria-hung terrace at stage left that no one had voted on and no one dared question, from which Rias Gremory watched her husband-to-be's life get dealt out to forty thousand strangers with the poise of a woman grading their reactions. The "WHO WOULD HE ADOPT?" betting board from the previous session still hovered over the mezzanine, updating its odds with quiet malice. Kamala Khan was at four-to-one. Kamala Khan had noticed.

The dragon bloc held its old ground from Arc One — Thor with his boots up, Valkyrie with her whetstone, Loki draped across the end seats like a knife pretending to be a scarf, and Fin Fang Foom occupying his eleven reupholstered chairs with the coiled stillness of a being who had, over twenty-seven chapters, made the journey from contempt to grudging respect and hated every step of the itinerary.

And up in the smugglers' balcony the Ravagers had colonized in Arc Two — chosen for its sightlines and its proximity to nothing anyone would miss — Yondu Udonta had his flame-crested silhouette tipped back, Kraglin beside him, Stakar Ogord one row behind them both, present in the way a court is present.

The wheel came down. The room went quiet the way it had learned to.

It spun once, twice — and stopped on the black wedge. The one with the keyhole. The room had seen it only twice before, and both times it had cost somebody a secret.

"BEAUCEPHALIS BACKSTORY" — RARITY: SECRET.

"Beaucephalis," Loki read aloud, and sat up by degrees, un-liquefying. "Well, *now* we're getting somewhere. That's a dragon's name if I've ever forged one. And I'll tell you exactly what this is—" he was on his feet, warming to it, playing to the mezzanine, "—it's *his*. The boy's true-name. Dragons hide their real names, everyone knows this; 'Issei Hyoudou' is the registry entry, the bait, the name you give the tax collector. Beaucephalis is what the gauntlet calls him when no one is—"

The betting board flickered. **BEAUCEPHALIS = ISSEI'S SECRET DRAGON NAME: 2:1.** Money — the theatre's strange, pointless, irresistible money — began to move.

The screen let it move for exactly four seconds. Then, in letters that managed to convey a sigh:

INCORRECT.

BEAUCEPHALIS IS A SEPARATE ENTITY. A SEPARATE DRAGON. NOT AN ALIAS. NOT A TITLE. NOT ISSEI HYODOU.

DESIGNATION: NEST-BROTHER.

A beat.

THE AUDIENCE WILL NOT BE PERMITTED TO CONFUSE THEM. THE AUDIENCE IS BEING TOLD THIS IN ADVANCE BECAUSE THE AUDIENCE HAS A RECORD.

"It's developing opinions about us," muttered Sam Wilson. "That's new and terrible."

In the wisteria box, Rias Gremory had gone very still, and then very soft, in the way the theatre had learned meant the machine had reached into an actual drawer of her actual life. "Oh," she said. "Oh, they're showing *Beau*."

Koneko Toujou, chin on the box rail, produced one of her rare, small, dangerous smiles. "Roof hog," she said, with enormous affection.

Forty thousand legends turned to look at the box.

"There's *another* dragon in that house?" said Peter Parker.

"There's another *brother*," said Rias, "in that family," and the screen, as if it had been waiting for the correction, opened the vision.

Purple mountains, under a sky the color of a bruise that had decided to be beautiful about it. The Underworld's dragon country — and the theatre knew it at once, because Arc Two had made them memorize it: Tannin's territory, the Blaze Meteor Dragon's fostering grounds, where a former Dragon King ran orchards and broods with the same volcanic patience, and where Issei Hyoudou had once been sent to train by being chased, burned, bitten, and improved.

The caption set the scene with its usual brutal economy: **TRAINING PERIOD. PREVIOUSLY DOCUMENTED. SEE: RAVEL PHENEX'S LEDGER, ENTRIES 31 THROUGH 68.**

("Sixty-eight," said Pepper Potts faintly, from the analysts' rows. "Thirty-one *through* sixty-eight.")

But the vision wasn't following Issei. That was the first strangeness. It followed a shape at the edge of Tannin's brood-fields — a young dragon, iron-grey shading to storm-slate, wings a full size too large for the body, folded wrong, the way a boy wears a coat he's meant to grow into. He was watching the other fledglings from a distance that had been carefully chosen to look voluntary.

BEAUCEPHALIS, said the screen. **FLEDGLING. FOSTERED. UNAFFILIATED.**

"Unaffiliated," Fin Fang Foom repeated. It was the first thing he'd said all session, and his voice had gone flat and exact. "That word does not mean what these apes will assume it means. For a fledgling, *unaffiliated* is not a status. It is a wound. Watch his throat."

The theatre watched his throat. The other fledglings, wheeling and squabbling above the orchards, trailed little banners of flame when they called to each other — bright, casual, wasteful, the way children are wasteful with anything they'll never run out of. The grey fledgling called too, once, at the sky.

Nothing came out but sound.

"Cold-throat," said Foom, and for once there was no disdain in the delivery at all, which from him was its own kind of shout. "His fire has never been lit."

A HATCHLING'S FIRST-FIRE IS KINDLED FROM THE NEST-FIRE OF ITS BROOD, the screen supplied. **BEAUCEPHALIS'S NEST WAS DESTROYED BY EVIL DRAGONS BEFORE HE WOKE FROM THE SHELL. HE HATCHED ALONE, IN ASHES, THE SOLE SURVIVOR. THERE WAS NO FIRE LEFT TO GIVE HIM.**

The theatre's street rows made the sound they always made when the machine did this — set a joke's worth of whimsy on the table and then turned it over to show the grief soldered underneath.

THE OTHER BROODS WOULD NOT NEST WITH HIM, the screen went on, pitiless. **NOT FROM CRUELTY. FROM LAW. A NEST SHARES FIRE. HE HAD NONE TO SHARE. THREE BROODS DECLINED HIM. TANNIN FED HIM AND COULD DO NO MORE; A FOSTER'S FLAME IS DUTY, NOT KINSHIP, AND EVERY DRAGON ALIVE KNOWS THE DIFFERENCE FROM THE INSIDE.**

"That is *correct*," Foom said, quietly, to nobody, "and I have never once heard it said aloud," and eleven seats' worth of ancient Makluan went silent in a new way.

Then Issei arrived in the frame, and the theatre exhaled, because it knew this boy: sixteen, scorched, bandaged in Ravel Phenex's meticulous wrappings, dropped in the dirt of Tannin's mountains at the end of a training day that had visibly tried to kill him. He was failing to build a campfire. He was failing at it *comprehensively* — a devil resurrected into a chess piece, wielding a gauntlet that could erase mountains, defeated by damp kindling.

The grey fledgling watched him from his carefully voluntary distance.

Issei looked up, saw him, and did the thing that twenty-seven chapters had taught the theatre he would always, always do. He held up half his rations.

"You gonna hover, or you gonna eat?"

No ceremony. No negotiation. The theatre watched a boy split dried meat with a dragon the size of a delivery truck and complain, at length, about their mutual foster-tormentor — "*and THEN he says 'dodge faster,' like, incredible coaching, Tannin, really, write a book*" — and watched the fledgling settle, one degree at a time, from a distance that looked voluntary to a distance that was honest.

It became a pattern. The vision moved in cuts: night after night, the boy and the grey fledgling at the edge of the brood-fields, sharing food, sharing complaints, sharing the specific silence of two creatures who had both been laughed at by the better-equipped. Beaucephalis started copying Issei's training — the failing, the getting up, the failing differently. Issei started saving the fledgling the good half.

"Oh no," said Kraglin Obfonteri, up in the Ravagers' balcony, with the tone of a man watching a recruitment happen. "Kid's crew now. He don't even know it yet."

Then came the cold night.

Deep mountain winter, the brood-fires banked and distant, and the vision found the two of them on the high slopes after a training exercise had run long — Issei blue-lipped and shaking, the fledgling curled around him like a levee, both of them staring at a pile of kindling that neither of them could light. Issei, because he was hopeless. Beaucephalis, because he was Beaucephalis.

The fledgling tried anyway. The theatre watched him gather himself, neck arched, wings mantled — and produce nothing but a cough of hot air and humiliation while, far below, the bright fledglings of the other broods trailed their wasteful banners across the dark.

And Issei Hyoudou looked at his own left hand.

"Hey, Ddraig. Transfer works on anything, right? Power into a sword, power into Rias, power into—" a nod at the fledgling's throat— "a pilot light?"

[Partner,] said the dragon-voice, low and suddenly very careful, **[think about what you are asking.]**

"I'm asking if my little buddy freezes tonight or not."

A pause with grammar in it.

[...No,] said Ddraig. **[He does not.]**

[BOOST.] said the gauntlet, into the mountain dark. **[BOOST. BOOST. TRANSFER.]**

The green gem flared, and Issei pressed his gauntleted hand to the fledgling's breastbone, and the theatre watched a spark that was not the fledgling's own — a mote of banked-ember red, freely given, compounding — catch somewhere behind that cold grey throat and *take*.

Beaucephalis breathed out a ribbon of flame the color of a forge nine hours after the smith went home. Ddraig's color. Issei's color, now, and forever after his own.

The kindling lit. The fledgling stared at the little campfire as if it were a continent.

Fin Fang Foom was on his feet. All eleven seats of him.

"That is not *possible*," he said, and it came out cracked in the middle. "Fire is hoard. Fire is the *first* hoard, the one a dragon is given before he is given a name, and no dragon parts with it — not for love, not for ransom, we do not *give fire away*, it is the one—" his claws closed on the seat-back in front of him, and the seat-back filed no complaint—"it is the one thing that cannot be asked for, because to ask is to admit you are empty, and to give is to make yourself less forever. The rite of first-fire passes from nest-fire to hatchling because a *fire* has no self to spend. What that boy just did—"

WHAT THE BOY DID, said the screen, **WAS GIVE HIS OWN, WITHOUT BEING ASKED, WITHOUT KNOWING THE PRICE. UNDER NEST LAW, FIRE FREELY GIVEN IS THE OLDEST BOND THERE IS. THE RITE HAS ONE STEP REMAINING.**

"The name-gift," Foom said. He sat down slowly, like a landslide changing its mind. "No. Surely the whelp doesn't know the — he's a *cold-throat*, no one will have taught him—"

On screen, the fledgling had gone very still, firelight moving on his storm-grey scales. And then Issei flinched, and put a hand to his own temple, and the theatre heard it the way he heard it — a voice arriving from inside, young and rough and shaking with the size of what it was doing:

{My name is Beaucephalis,} said the fledgling, mind to mind, giving away the only hoard he had ever owned. **{It was my mother's last word. I have never told anyone. Now it is yours too.}**

The theatre did not breathe.

"...okay," said Issei Hyoudou, out loud, wet-eyed, entirely failing to rise to the occasion in the way that was, the room had long since concluded, his actual superpower. "Okay. Wow. So — I'm Issei. I don't have a secret name. You can have the regular one twice."

The silence on the mountainside lasted four full seconds. Then a sound came out of the fledgling that no one in the theatre had ever heard a dragon make, and it took the room a moment to identify it, because it was so foreign to everything the word *dragon* was supposed to carry.

He was laughing.

[It is done,] said Ddraig, over the sound, and there was something in the old voice like a door being propped open. **[Witnessed by the Welsh Dragon, who has seen every rite this custom owns and never once seen it done like THIS. Congratulations, partner. You have a brother. He is going to eat everything in your parents' house.]**

RITE COMPLETE, stamped the screen. **BEAUCEPHALIS HYODOU: NEST-BROTHER. BOND: TELEPATHIC, PERMANENT, MUTUAL. RANGE: ANY.**

And then, because the machine had learned exactly how this audience grieved and exactly how to stop them, it cut to the present day: dawn over the Hyoudou household, a storm-grey dragon the size of a bus arranged proprietarily across the roof, and Issei's voice floating up from a window in the key of every younger sibling in every universe:

"BEAU. You ate my pudding. I KNOW it was you, I can hear you being smug FROM HERE—"

{The nest shares food,} came the telepathic reply, unbearably prim. **{It's the law. I don't make the law, brother.}**

"You QUOTE the law like a LAWYER—"

The theatre laughed — the whole-room laugh, Hela to the cheap seats — and in the wisteria box Koneko said, to no one and everyone, "He does the voice better than the screen does," and Kuroka draped an arm around her little sister and did not say anything at all.

The lights came up to half, and the arguments started where the machine had aimed them.

"NEST-BROTHER!" Thor was already standing, already radiant, already halfway into a toast with nothing in his hand. "Do you hear it, Loki? The boy has a brother of the FIRE, sworn on a mountain, witnessed by an elder wyrm! In Asgard we'd feast a week for less! Oaths of brotherhood are the oldest oaths — older than kingship, older than—"

"Older than honesty, certainly," said Loki, who had not stood. He was examining the paused frame — dragon on the roof, boy in the window — with the fixed expression of a man being shown a mirror at a bad angle. "Do let's be precise about what we just watched. A creature no nest would take, collected by someone with power to spare, on an impulse, without being consulted — and now it's family, and

everyone applauds, and no one asks the obvious question." His voice stayed light. His knuckles didn't. "What happens on the day the boy regrets the impulse? Adoption is a story the strong tell the stray. The stray spends the rest of his life waiting to hear how it *ends*."

The theatre went carefully quiet. There was exactly one being in the room who could answer that, and everyone knew who he was, and he was already turning in his seat.

"Yes," Thor said. "I imagine that is precisely how it feels."

"Don't—"

"Father chose you once," Thor said, "and told you badly, and late, and that was his failure and it was real. But *I* am not our father, and I did not choose you once." He was not performing now; the hall-toast voice was gone, and what was left was worse, because it was just a brother talking. "I have chosen you every day for a thousand years. Including the days you stabbed me. Including the day you were a snake. I chose it again this morning, when you took the end seats so you could pretend you might leave." He turned back to the screen, and let it stand. "*That* is what the fire-gift is, trickster. Not the impulse. The mornings after it. Ask the grey one on the roof whether the boy has ever once made him wait to hear how the story ends."

Loki said nothing at all. But those seated closest observed that he did not move from the end seats — and that he did not, for the rest of the session, sit as though he might leave.

From the wisteria box, a voice — deadpan, small, and carrying to every corner of the theatre because the theatre wanted it to:

"Blood is who you start with," said Koneko Toujou, whose blood sister sat beside her with an arm around her shoulders, and whose road back to that arm the theatre had watched paid for in full. "Nest is who you keep."

The betting board quietly retired the 2:1 line and did not offer a replacement.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel spun and stopped on honest silver.

"DRAGON-NEST CUSTOMS" — RARITY: RARE.

"A rules pull," said Sam Wilson. "It knows we love the rules pulls. We're being managed."

They were, and it worked anyway. The screen laid itself out like a codex — the theatre had seen it do this for the Evil Piece system in Arc Two — and began, with visible relish, to legislate:

NEST LAW. THE CUSTOMS OF DRAGON KINSHIP, AS PRACTICED SINCE BEFORE THE PRACTICE OF WRITING THINGS DOWN.

ONE. THE NEST IS CHOSEN. BLOOD MAY APPLY FOR MEMBERSHIP.

The laugh started in the Ravager balcony and rolled downhill.

TWO. FIRST-FIRE IS KINDLED FROM THE NEST-FIRE. FIRE FREELY GIVEN MAKES KIN. FIRE CANNOT BE ASKED FOR, ONLY OFFERED.

THREE. THE NAME-GIFT. KIN EXCHANGE TRUE NAMES, MIND TO MIND. THEREAFTER THEY SPEAK ACROSS ANY DISTANCE, AND NEITHER IS EVER ENTIRELY ALONE, WHICH IS THE POINT.

FOUR. HOARD-RIGHT. NEST-KIN TAKE FROM THE HOARD WITHOUT ASKING. THEFT IS A CRIME THAT ONLY EXISTS OUTSIDE THE NEST.

"*Imprecise*," snapped Fin Fang Foom, who had been vibrating with the suppressed agony of an expert watching amateurs handle his field, and could bear it no longer. "Hoard-right extends to the *shelf* of the hoard — food, shelter, comfort, coin — never to the *heart* of it. Every dragon keeps a heart-hoard of things that are not property. No kin touches those. The whelp's pudding is shelf. The whelp's *name* was heart, and he gave it anyway, which is why the rite—" he stopped, aware of the entire theatre listening to him explain, with helpless scholarly tenderness, the customs of a species he'd spent twenty-eight chapters disowning.

The screen amended its own caption: **FOUR (REVISED, PER MAKLUAN CONSULTATION): SHELF, NOT HEART.**

"Stop *agreeing* with me," Foom told the screen, in Karnak's exact aggrieved cadence, and three rows of Inhumans turned to look at Karnak, who declined to acknowledge the citation.

FIVE. NEST-DEBT. YOUR BROTHER'S FIGHT IS YOUR FIGHT. YOU MAY ARRIVE UNINVITED. YOU MAY NOT ARRIVE LATE.

SIX. NEST-SEVERANCE. THE ONE UNFORGIVABLE CRIME: TO FEED ON YOUR OWN NEST. THE SEVERED ARE NOT HUNTED AND NOT HARMED. THEY ARE SIMPLY NEVER SPOKEN TO AGAIN, AND THEY BURN ALONE.

The balcony had gone quiet somewhere around Five.

"Krag's," said Yondu Udonta, slowly, "you readin' this?"

"Readin' it, Cap'n."

"Read it back to me in *ours*."

Kraglin counted it off on his fingers, half-grinning, and the grin thinning as he went. "Crew's who you pick, not who spawned you. You fly your colors 'cause somebody gave 'em to you, you don't buy 'em. Crew shares the take. You come when a Ravager whistles, don't matter whose territory. And if you..." He slowed. "If you eat off your own crew. Deal in what a Ravager don't deal in. You get your flame put out, and hundred ships don't say your name no more."

"Huh," said Rocket, from the seat he had annexed at the balcony rail on the grounds that he was, quote, *dragon-adjacent, it's a whole thing, don't look it up*. "So the pirate code and the dragon code are the same code. Somebody owes somebody royalties."

"Ain't no code," said Yondu.

He said it quietly, and the balcony turned, because Yondu Udonta did not do quiet. He was looking at the codex-screen with his jaw set, and every soul in that balcony knew exactly which line he was looking at, and exactly which years of his life it was reading back to him — and one row behind, Stakar Ogord, who had spoken the severance once and unspoken it harder, put one hand on the back of Yondu's seat. Not on his shoulder. On the seat. It was the same gesture, in Ravager.

"Ain't no code," Yondu said again. "Never was. Codes is what you write down 'cause you're scared you'll forget. That grey lizard on the roof, this whole damn theatre-full of that boy's people — wives, dragon, church girl, fox kid, all of it—" he flicked two fingers at the screen, at the roof, at the dawn. "That ain't law. That's just the folks you feed. Dragons just got the guts to put it in writing."

"He's Mary Poppins with scales, y'all," Kraglin offered, wetly, and was ignored with great love.

The screen, as if it had been waiting for the balcony to finish, delivered its closing argument. The codex dissolved, and in its place the machine did something it had never done: it re-ran the story so far — twenty-seven chapters in as many seconds — with the nest-law diagram laid over the top. Rias's eight Pawns: *fire freely given*. Asia at the Hyoudou dinner table: *shelf and heart alike*. The peerage, the wives' box, Kunou, Ophis, the adopted and the sheltered and the kept: node after node after node, kin-lines igniting one by one across the whole map of a sixteen-year-old's life until it blazed like a city seen from orbit.

FINDING, said the screen. **THE SUBJECT HAS BEEN BUILDING A NEST SINCE CHAPTER ONE. HE HAS NEVER ONCE CALLED IT THAT. HE HAS NEVER ONCE STOPPED.**

And then, for exactly one frame — one — the diagram stayed on screen but the *nodes* changed, and what the kin-lines connected was not Issei's people but a seating chart. Mezzanine. Aisles. Boxes. Balcony. Forty thousand seats, mapped in the same diagram-language, kin-lines dim and unlit, like a city before dawn. Like something waiting to be kindled.

Then it was gone, and most of the theatre would swear it had imagined it.

Uatu the Watcher did not swear that.

The last thing the machine showed them was the roof at dusk: Beaucephalis, storm-grey and content, and Issei sprawled against his brother's flank with a pudding cup he was defending with his whole body, and the two of them bickering mind-to-mind about nothing — the theatre given subtitles for it, sibling nonsense, *your roof*, *OUR roof*, *the LAW*, *brother* — until, mid-sentence, the young dragon's head came up.

He looked at the horizon. The subtitles stopped.

The horizon had wings in it. Dozens. Then more than dozens — a sky filling from every direction with shapes out of every mythology the theatre's oldest members had personally survived, all of them inbound, all of them slow, the way you fly when you are coming to something rather than at it.

{Brother,} said Beaucephalis, and the young voice had gone formal, and underneath the formality it was shaking again — pride, this time. **{They're coming to see you. All of them.}**

"...why?" said Issei Hyoudou, pudding forgotten.

The screen went dark on the question. In the dark, Fin Fang Foom rose to his feet, all eleven seats, staring at where the horizon had been with an expression the theatre had no file for at all.

"Foom," said Shang-Chi carefully. "What did we just see assembling?"

"Everyone," said Fin Fang Foom.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter

- "Beaucephalis Backstory" — Secret (third Secret-tier pull; black keyhole wedge)
- "Dragon-Nest Customs" — Rare

Secrets Revealed

- Beaucephalis is a separate dragon — Issei's adoptive nest-brother, NOT an alias or secret name of Issei's; the screen corrected the theatre (and Loki's 2:1 betting line) in advance.
- Beaucephalis hatched as the sole survivor of a nest destroyed by evil dragons; with no nest-fire left to kindle his first-fire, he was a "cold-throat" whom three broods lawfully declined; Tannin could foster but not kin him.

- During the Tannin training period, Issei unknowingly performed the oldest rite in nest law: he gave his own fire freely (Boost → Transfer into the fledgling's throat), lighting Beaucephalis's first-fire in Ddraig's ember-red; Beaucephalis completed the rite with the name-gift, telepathically surrendering his mother's last word — his true name.
- The bond is telepathic, permanent, mutual, unlimited in range; Ddraig witnessed the rite and confirmed its validity. Beaucephalis now lives on the Hyoudou roof as family ("Beaucephalis Hyoudou").
- Nest law codified: (1) the nest is chosen — blood may apply; (2) fire freely given makes kin; (3) the name-gift; (4) hoard-right covers the "shelf" of the hoard, never the "heart" (per Foom's on-record correction, which the screen adopted); (5) nest-debt — a brother's fight is your fight; (6) nest-severance — feeding on your own nest is the sole unforgivable, punished by permanent silence.
- The screen's closing diagram reframed Issei's entire life as deliberate-by-instinct nest-building since Chapter One — and for one frame overlaid the same kin-line diagram on the THEATRE'S seating chart, unlit, "like something waiting to be kindled." Uatu noticed.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Fin Fang Foom: fully outed as a scholar-partisan of nest law; corrected the screen and was agreed with (to his horror); implied personal history — he explained a foster's flame "from the inside" and once again showed the crack beneath the scorn.
- Loki: publicly named the adopted-stray's fear ("waiting to hear how the story ends"); Thor answered with the chapter's thesis — brotherhood as daily re-choice — and Loki stayed in his seat, no longer sitting "as though he might leave."
- Koneko (with Kuroka): delivered the arc's defining line — "Blood is who you start with. Nest is who you keep."
- Ravagers: mapped nest law point-for-point onto Ravager code; the nest-severance clause landed hard on Yondu (Stakar's hand on his seat-back — "the same gesture, in Ravager"); Yondu's verdict: "Ain't no code... just the folks you feed."
- The theatre at large now reads Issei's harem, peerage, adoptions, and household as one continuous structure: a nest, built by choice.

Unresolved Hooks

- The sky filled with dragons of every mythology, inbound to see Issei; Beaucephalis announced "all of them," Issei asked "why?", and Fin Fang Foom — visibly shaken — answered "Everyone." (Feeds directly into the next session.)
- Why did the machine map the theatre's own seating chart in nest-law kin-lines — and what would it take to light them? (Long-arc: the theatre is preparing them for something that may require them to

be a nest.)

- Foom's own nest-history remains unspoken — who did he outlive, and for how long?
- The "WHO WOULD HE ADOPT?" board still floats over the mezzanine; Kamala Khan is still at four-to-one and still aware of it.

Chapter Twenty-Nine: Every Dragon Bows

Canon Status: [ORIGINAL CROSSOVER] The multi-mythology dragon-bowing spectacle is invented for this fic, not sourced from *High School DxD* canon.

Primary Reaction Groups: Kings and sovereigns (Black Panther, Namor, Doctor Doom, Magneto) • Dragon-connected (Thor, Loki, Fin Fang Foom, Iron Fist) • Guardians of the Galaxy (Groot, Rocket) • The resident fiancées

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Dragons Bowing to Issei" — **Mythic**
 2. "Ddraig's Declaration" — **Epic**
-

The theatre had spent a full intermission arguing about nest law, and the argument had migrated, as arguments about family always did now, toward the eight women seated in the honoured centre rows.

It had been like this since the machine had committed its one great malfunction — or its one great joke; the room had never settled the question — and dropped Rias Gremory and seven of her co-fiancées bodily into the audience. The Hyoudou household had been watching its own life get pulled from a wheel for nine chapters, correcting the record with the weary authority of primary sources, and reorganizing the theatre's social gravity simply by existing in it. Kings, it turned out, drifted toward Rias. Warriors drifted toward Xenovia. Everyone with sense drifted away from Akeno when she smiled.

Tonight the visitors were the kings.

T'Challa had come down from the Wakandan seats with the unhurried formality of a state call. Namor had come because T'Challa had, and would deny it. Doom had not come to anyone — Doom did not come to people — but the aisle he stood in happened, tonight, to command a view of both the screen and the Gremory heiress, and Doom stood in it the way other men occupied thrones. Magneto sat one row above them all, at the altitude of a man who had opinions about kings and had buried several.

"Your husband's brother," T'Challa was saying to Rias, with genuine diplomatic care, "the dragon Beaucephalis. In last night's vision he addressed Issei as *nest-brother*. In Wakanda that word would carry legal weight. Does it carry weight there?"

"More than a treaty," said Rias Gremory. "Less than a wedding. About the same as a Pawn." She smiled the smile that made Mephisto take notes. "We're a very acquisitive family."

Above them, the wheel came down early — no chime, no preamble — and every conversation in the theatre broke off mid-word.

Because the wheel was doing something new. Its rings, which clattered and gloated and milked every pull for drama, had gone silent and *aligned*, ring within ring within ring, like an orrery agreeing on a date. The rarity band cycled past gold, past the cozy fireside glow of Family-Class, past the black-letter dread of Secret, and settled on a colour the theatre had no file for: a red so old it had opinions about the other reds — scale-red, ember-red, the red of a cave with a hoard in it.

RARITY: MYTHIC, said the screen, and the word did not glow. It *smoked*.

"New tier," said Shuri, sitting up. "Twenty-nine chapters and it's been holding a whole *tier* back—"

The wheel tipped. That was the strangest part, the part half the room would swear to and half would deny: the great wheel of destinies inclined on its axis, a few degrees, holding the posture of a thing lowering its head, and dropped its token into the bowl from that position, like tribute.

"DRAGONS BOWING TO ISSEI" — MYTHIC.

A NOTE ON SEQUENCE, the screen added, in its politest font, the one it used when it was about to cheat. **THE FAMILY BANNER RUNS AHEAD OF THE WAR BANNER. YOU HAVE NOT YET SEEN THE YEARS THAT PURCHASE THIS DAY. YOU ARE SEEING THE RECEIPT.**

"I hate when it does that," muttered Sam Wilson.

"I love when it does that," said Loki.

The theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

A mountain range in the Underworld, under a violet sky. The gacha's captions arrived with unusual restraint, as if the machine itself had lowered its voice: **THE DRAGON'S RANGE. NEUTRAL GROUND, BY CUSTOM OLDER THAN THE FACTIONS. NO THRONE HAS EVER STOOD HERE.**

And on the wide stone shelf where no throne had ever stood, dragons were landing.

They came out of the violet like weather systems deciding to be personal. A colossal purple-scaled warrior whose wingbeats rearranged the clouds — **TANNIN, THE BLAZE METEOR DRAGON, FORMER DRAGON KING** — and the theatre's veterans of Arc Two made an involuntary noise, because they knew that one; they had watched him chase a screaming teenager up a mountain for a month of training visions and had privately ranked him above most drill sergeants and several natural disasters. A gleaming gold-scaled presence with a connoisseur's heavy-lidded eyes — **FAFNIR, DRAGON KING, HOARD-LORD** — whose caption the machine declined, mercifully, to elaborate. A

lean jade serpent out of an eastern sky, grinning like mischief given wingspan — **YU-LONG, THE MISCHIEVOUS DRAGON**. A shadow that arrived without arriving, black flame in the shape of an apology, coiled politely at the edge of the gathering — **VRITRA, PRISON DRAGON (ATTENDING VIA HOST)** — with a very tired-looking blond boy waving awkwardly from beneath it. And behind and around and above them, the others: mountain dragons and sea dragons, young drakes jostling like starlings, elders with moss on their shoulders, a hundred shapes from a dozen mythologies that had never once agreed on anything.

Far off, at the edge of the vision, something white glinted against the violet and did not approach. The screen printed one line beside it — **[RIVAL: RECORD PENDING]** — and refused every eye that tried to read more.

In the centre of the shelf, in his school blazer, hands jammed in his pockets, profoundly underdressed for the assembled biomass of several pantheons, stood Issei Hyoudou. And at his right shoulder, wings half-furled, chin high, chest out, stood a young dragon the theatre had met one chapter ago: Beaucephalis, nest-brother, wearing the expression of a sibling at a graduation — insufferable, incandescent pride, plus the visible intention to embarrass him at dinner afterward.

Stand up straight, brother, said Beaucephalis, in the private telepathy the vision let them all overhear. *You're being historic.*

I'm being hungry, Issei thought back. *How long does this take? Nobody told me if there's food.*

"Oh, good," said Peter Parker, in the theatre, wiping his eyes for reasons he'd have called laughter. "He's still him."

Tannin moved first.

The Blaze Meteor Dragon — a former Dragon King, a being who had traded rank for the survival of his people, who had trained this boy by trying honestly to kill him — brought his colossal head down through all that violet air, slowly, deliberately, past the altitude of respect, past the altitude of greeting, down to the altitude of *fealty*, until one horn nearly brushed the stone.

And then, like a mountain range kneeling, the rest.

Fafnir lowered his golden head with the gravity of a hoard changing hands. Yu-Long stopped grinning — the theatre had not known he could — and bowed the full serpentine length of himself in a wave that took visible seconds to travel. The black flame of Vritra banked low, and the tired blond boy beneath it bowed too, grinning, mouthing something that the vision captured as *"you owe me lunch."* The starling-swarm of young drakes crashed into the ground in their haste to kneel, one of them bowing so enthusiastically it somersaulted, and an elder with moss on her shoulders inclined a neck that had not bent, the caption said, **IN NINE CENTURIES**.

A hundred dragons. A dozen mythologies. One held breath in two universes.

Every dragon on that mountain bowed to Issei Hyoudou — except one.

Beaucephalis stood.

He stood at his brother's shoulder with his chin up and his wings half-spread, and no dragon on that shelf so much as glanced at him for it, because — the caption printed it in small, almost tender letters —

NEST LAW: FAMILY DOES NOT BOW. FAMILY IS WHAT THE BOW PROTECTS.

And Issei Hyoudou, seventeen-flavoured even in this out-of-sequence future, went scarlet to the ears, waved both hands like a man flagging down a bus, and said, audibly, to a hundred bowed dragons of the assembled mythologies of his world:

"Whoa — hey — no no no, you don't have to — please get up? Everybody? You're all way older than me, this is *super* weird — okay, you know what, has everyone eaten? Because my house does a thing, it's mostly rice but there's a lot of it—"

Not one dragon rose until he had finished being embarrassed. Then they rose together, and the sound they made was not a roar. It was lower than a roar, and older: a hundred dragons humming one note into the stone, the way the vision explained a nest greets its own.

On one small drake's face, as it came up from its somersaulted bow, was an expression the theatre knew from its own children's rows. It was how Kamala Khan had looked at Carol Danvers, once. It was not fear of a dragon. It was *want* — the want to grow up into something.

The vision held there — the boy, the standing brother, the risen host, the far white glint that had not come closer — and released them.

The lights came up on a theatre of kings, and the kings had all leaned forward.

T'Challa spoke first, quietly, and the room organized itself around his quiet the way it had learned to. "I have taken the throne of Wakanda by combat," he said. "Twice. And I will tell you what every monarch here knows and none of us likes to say aloud: you can win a crown. You can inherit one. You can seize one. But the *bow*—" he shook his head slowly, eyes still on the dark screen. "The bow you cannot take. Compel it, and you get choreography — bodies bending, nothing given, an inventory of future knives. What we just watched was not choreography. Did you see the elder? Nine centuries. A neck does not unbend nine centuries of *no* for power. Power is exactly what dragons already have." He turned, and found Rias Gremory watching him, and inclined his head to her fractionally, king to house. "It unbends

for one thing only. For the belief that what you bow to will spend itself for you before it spends you. That is the entire technology of legitimacy, and your husband appears to have discovered it by accident, while asking whether anyone had eaten."

"He always asks if anyone's eaten," said Koneko Toujou, deadpan, from the fiancée rows. "He fed a Dragon King rice. Four helpings."

"He asked *Fafnir* if the hoard got heavy to sleep on," Rias added, with the serenity of a woman who had stopped being surprised years ago. "Fafnir now consults him on hoard arrangement."

Namor had listened to T'Challa with his arms folded and his chin at its customary altitude, which was above everyone's. "Kneeling is currency," the Sub-Mariner said flatly. "In Atlantis they kneel to me because the sea is cold and vast and mine, and drowns what displeases it. I have never once mistaken it for love, and I have never once required it to be." He paused. The pause went on one beat too long for contempt. "But no one drowns for that boy. Nothing compels them. They crossed a sky to lower their heads to a child in a school uniform who *told them to stop* — and they finished the bow first." His jaw worked. "I have commanded the bow of an ocean. I find I do not have the thing that was on that mountain, and I find," each word extracted like a tooth, "that I have spent several minutes wanting it."

"Imperius Rex admits envy," murmured Loki, delighted, from the dark. "Somebody carve the date."

"Wanting what a better outcome costs is not envy, trickster. It is *policy*."

But the theatre's weather had already shifted toward the aisle where Doom stood, because Doom had been silent too long, and twenty-nine chapters had taught the room what Doom's silences cost whoever they landed on.

"Doom has categorized the boy three ways," Doom said at last, to no one, which meant to everyone. "In the first arc: a phenomenon. A curiosity of foreign physics, to be studied. In the second: a constant. A fixed hazard, to be designed around. Doom closed his notebook on the boy nine chapters ago and considered the taxonomy complete." The mask tilted toward the dimmed screen. "The taxonomy is not complete.

"Consider what the vision actually depicted. Not power — the room has seen his power; power is arithmetic and Doom does not bow to arithmetic. It depicted a *polity*. A nation without borders, without census, without treasury — a nation of apex beings from rival mythologies who agree on nothing, and who have now, freely, unanimously, constituted themselves around a single person. Sovereignty is not land, whatever the cartographers pretend. Sovereignty is the ability to be *bowed to without compulsion*. By that measure — the only measure that has ever survived contact with Doom — the boy is not a phenomenon and not a constant." A pause, and the theatre heard the third category arrive like a door unbolting. "He is a *peer*."

"One does not study peers. One does not design around peers. One *negotiates* with them." Doom turned, deliberately, and faced the fiancée rows, and performed a thing the theatre would argue about for the rest of the hundred chapters: a shallow, precise, unmistakable nod of the crowned head, sovereign to sovereign's house. "Latveria recognizes the Red Dragon Emperor. Convey it, when you are returned to him." And then, because Doom was Doom, the mask swept the heroes' section: "Doom notes that he has now extended the boy more formal courtesy than any government represented in this room. You have had twenty-nine chapters. Doom advises the relevant departments to feel appropriate shame."

"Did — did Doctor Doom just establish *diplomatic relations* with the gacha?" said Sam Wilson.

"Yes," said Maria Hill, writing.

From one row above the kings came the dry rasp of Magneto not applauding. "How moving," Erik Lehnsherr said. "The monarchs have found a mirror. Allow an old man to state the other reading, since no one else at this altitude will." He rose, and though the seats were velvet the air around him carried its familiar iron weight. "I watched a species tonight. Feared, hunted, mythologized — every culture in that cosmology tells stories about slaying them; several of the entities in *this room* are wearing dragon-slaying reputations like medals. And what has that species just done? It has gathered its whole surviving strength on neutral stone and *lowered its head* to a member of the majority that hunts it. Tell me the difference between a liberator and a comfortable cage, T'Challa, because I have buried people in both. When the feared kneel to a protector, the protector's love is real and the kneeling is still a leash. The price of a savior," and the old anger in it was banked but alive, "is that you stop saving yourselves. My people have been offered that bargain by every smiling government on our Earth. I have made a career of declining it on their behalf."

The theatre's mutant rows were very quiet. So, for a moment, was everyone.

Then Magneto did the thing that separated him, forever, from the men he was often shelved with: he argued against himself in public. "And yet," he said, slower, "the brother did not bow. He stood — armed, proud, at the centre of the ceremony — and the ceremony *approved*. Note it, all of you, because it is the whole document: whatever that boy is building, it has a standing clause. A structure that ranks family above fealty, that leaves room at its own coronation for an unbowed head—" he sat back down, and finished like a man annoyed at his own conclusion, "—is not a cage I recognize. I will require more data. I *dislike* requiring more data."

"I am Groot," said Groot.

Several kings looked around. The Flora colossus was sitting where he always sat, among the Ravager and Guardian rows, enormous hands folded, bark-face tilted at the screen with an expression no one had been reading for twenty-nine chapters because no one had thought to.

"He says," Rocket translated, with the put-upon air he used to disguise exactly how carefully he listened, "'you're all measuring the wrong thing.'" A pause. "Don't look at me, I just work here."

The screen chimed before anyone could ask the right question.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"DDRAIG'S DECLARATION" — EPIC.

The mountain again. The risen host, the humming stone. And then the hum stopped, because the gauntlet had appeared on Issei's left arm — unsummoned, of its own will, the green gem kindling like a hearth — and every dragon on the shelf went still in a way that taught the theatre something new about silence.

"They did not come only for you, partner," said Ddraig, gently, from the gem. **"With your permission, I would speak. It has been... some time, since I addressed our kind with my own voice."**

"Course," said Issei. And then, because he was Issei: "Want me to hold the arm up higher? Is there an acoustics thing?"

"The arm is fine, partner."

The gem flared, and the voice that came out of it was not the fireside rumble the theatre had grown fond of. It was the *other* voice — the one from chapter one, the one Thor had felt in his teeth — vast, tectonic, older than the mountains it addressed.

"Kin," said Ddraig, the Welsh Dragon, the Red Dragon Emperor, one of the Two Heavenly Dragons whose war had once frightened God. **"Look at me. Look at what remains — no wings, no sky, no body; a voice in a jewel on a boy's arm. You bowed to him. Now hear what you bowed to."**

"I have had hosts beyond your counting. Kings among them. Saints among them. Warriors the sagas still flinch from. Every one — every one — heard my power and asked the same first question: *how much?* And the red I gave them fed on the asking, and fed on their hatred, and fed on their fear, until—"

The vision stuttered. For a quarter-second the mountain was gone, and there was fire in the shape of a screaming man, and a sound like a lullaby sung backward — and the screen slammed a black card across it:

[RECORD SEALED: RARITY INSUFFICIENT. THE HISTORY OF THE RED WILL BE PAID FOR WHEN IT IS PAID FOR.]

In the theatre, in the dark, the Watcher's great hands closed slowly on the arms of his seat. The fiancée rows had gone rigid, all eight women wearing the identical expression of people who knew exactly what lived behind that black card. Nobody asked. Everybody filed it.

The mountain returned. Ddraig had not stopped speaking.

"—until the name I carry meant only ruin, and mothers in six pantheons used it to frighten children into bed. Ten thousand years, kin. Ten thousand years the Red Dragon Emperor has been a word for grief.

"Then a fallen angel murdered a foolish, lecherous, unremarkable boy in a park, and I woke in the worst host I have ever been given." A ripple went through the dragons; on-screen, Issei said *"hey,"* wounded, and the theatre laughed damply. **"No talent. No hatred. Nothing to feed on. He heard my power — and his first question was not *how much*. His first question, kin, in the dark of his own soul, in the ruin of his own death, was whether I got bored in there. Whether I was *lonely*.**

"I have been a god's problem and a devil's weapon and a saint's burden. I had never once, in ten thousand years, been anyone's *friend*."

The gem burned brighter, and somewhere in the crowd of drakes a hatchling — overcome, oblivious, magnificent — piped up with the first two bars of a children's song the theatre had encountered in an earlier, sillier chapter, a song about a certain dragon and his enthusiasm for a certain anatomy, and the entire shelf of assembled dragon-kind visibly clenched, and Ddraig's voice performed the audible equivalent of a long-suffering stare.

"Yes," the dragon said, with terrible dignity. **"The song. I am aware of the song. I have required counseling because of the song. Hear me anyway, and hear this first: the children of two species sing my name now, and the song is not a warning. Do you understand what that is worth? Ten thousand years, and a dragon's name is sung without fear. He did that. Not with the power — the power has never once made anything better than it found. He did it with the rice, and the door that is never locked, and the arm that goes out before the thinking does.**

"So hear my declaration, and carry it to every peak and every deep: this is Issei Hyoudou. He is not my host. He is not my cage. He is my partner, and the pride of my ten thousand years. From this day the Red Dragon Emperor is not a grief and not a warning. From this day, the Red is a NEST — and any dragon who has no nest, any hatchling orphaned, any elder abandoned, any of our kind alone in any sky of any heaven — may fly to him, and be home."

The sound the dragons made then was a roar, and it was not fealty. Fealty had been the bow. This was *assent* — a hundred dragons of a dozen quarreling mythologies answering one note with one note, and the mountains answered the dragons, and far off at the edge of everything the white glint rose, circled

once, and was gone.

And Issei Hyoudou, Red Dragon Emperor, nest of dragon-kind, stood in the middle of the largest honour his cosmology had ever assembled, sniffed hard, wiped his face on his blazer sleeve, and said, wrecked and beaming:

"Okay — okay, that's — Ddraig, buddy, warn a guy — RIGHT. Everybody who can fit in a human house, follow me, everybody who can't, we're doing the yard. Rossweisse is gonna — actually don't tell Rossweisse the headcount, we'll ease her into it—"

In the theatre, Rossweisse fainted quietly into Irina's shoulder over the implied grocery arithmetic, and the vision released them on the sound of a hundred dragons laughing.

Nobody spoke for a while. The kings had run out of categories, and knew it.

It was Danny Rand who broke the silence, from the Defenders' block, looking at his own fist with an expression fifteen years old. "I fought a dragon for my power," the Iron Fist said. "Shou-Lao the Undying. You climb, you bleed, you beat it, you punch your fists into its molten heart, and you carry the mark forever. That's how it's done. That's how it's *always* done — dragons are the wall you break yourself against to become worthy." He closed the fist. "He never raised a hand to any of them. And they crossed a sky. I'm going to be sitting with that one for a real long time."

"In every saga of my people," Thor said, and his voice had gone to the low reverent register it saved for Ddraig alone, "the dragon is the ending. Fafnir under the mountain. The serpent at the world's rim, waiting for me — for *me*, waiting." He looked around the theatre, and the grin that broke on him was sunrise. "Dragons bow to no one. That is what the word *means*, in every tongue that has it. You have all just watched the sagas be rewritten by a boy with rice, and I am — I find I am *glad*, and I did not expect to be glad. Loki. Are you well? You've said nothing cruel in minutes."

"I'm thinking," said Loki, and he was; those nearest could see it, the god of stories turning the thing over and over and finding no seam. "You can steal a crown. I've done it — lovely work, highly recommended. You can steal a throne, an army, a *face*." His eyes did not leave the dark screen. "You cannot steal a bow that was never demanded. There's no object to take. It exists only in the giving. Twenty-nine chapters I have watched that gauntlet like a jewel in a case, and tonight I finally understand there is nothing in the case worth having *without the boy*, and the boy cannot be stolen, because the boy is not a possession, he is a *practice*." He smiled his thinnest smile. "I hate it here."

And then, from the vastness at the theatre's edge, from the quarter where the seats had been reinforced without comment sometime around Arc One, came a sound of shifting scale-mass that everyone had learned to brace against.

Fin Fang Foom had risen.

For twenty-nine chapters the dragon of Kakaranthara had radiated scorn at the screen — *a true dragon does not serve* — a sentence he had produced in various arrangements at least once per arc, to the room's increasing weariness. He looked at the dark screen now for a long moment, immense and unreadable.

"I said a true dragon does not serve a human," Fin Fang Foom said, and the acid was gone from it, leaving something bare. "I was answered tonight. He does not serve. There is no collar in that gauntlet, and there is no throne on that mountain. There is a nest, and the nest was built for the ones who lost theirs." The great head was silent a moment. "I am the last of my landing party. My kind is far, and my name on this world is a warning, and no child of any species has ever sung it without fear. I did not know, until tonight, that the other thing could be *had*."

And Fin Fang Foom lowered his head to a screen showing nothing at all — one full degree past the altitude of respect — and held it there, and the theatre understood it was watching its own universe's first dragon bow to the nest.

"I am Groot," said Groot, into that silence.

"Buddy, now's maybe not—" Rocket started, and stopped, because Groot had turned and looked at him, and whatever passed between them made the raccoon's ears go flat. "Fine. FINE." He cleared his throat, and his voice came out wrong, and he pretended it hadn't. "He says — he says you kings have been arguing all night about what the dragons got. Vassal, subject, liberated, whatever. He says you got it backwards, 'cause you're all... trunk-people. You think the tree is the trunk." Rocket's paws worked. "I was a twig, okay? Him. He's sayin' — he was a twig. Whole body gone, blown to splinters savin' a bunch of idiots, and everybody grieved the trunk. And he says the trunk was never the tree. The tree is the *roots*, and the roots only need one thing, which is good ground. Put the splinter in good ground and everything that ever was the tree comes back. Bigger."

Rocket stared at the floor.

"He says the dragon in the gauntlet lost his body, his sky, and his war. Ten thousand years a splinter in bad ground — kings and saints and psychos, and every one of 'em pots, not ground, 'cause a pot's just a cage with dirt in it. And then the splinter got planted in that kid." He jerked a thumb at the dark screen, roughly. "Good ground. First good ground in ten thousand years. So the dragons weren't bowin' to the kid, and they weren't bowin' to the gauntlet either. They came to see what *grew back*." A breath. "And he says the big green guy with the mask—" Doom's head turned, slowly, "—finally got somethin' right, but even he's measuring wrong, 'cause you can't recognize a nation, it ain't a nation." Rocket's voice cracked one notch and he bulled through it. "It's a *forest*. It's gonna be a forest. And forests don't got kings."

"I am Groot," Groot added quietly.

"Yeah." Rocket wiped his face with the back of a paw, fast, furious about it. "'And I am Groot.' He knows, pal. Somewhere in a arm in another universe. He knows."

Nobody in the theatre said anything for a long time, and none of the kings tried to have the last word, which — Uatu noted, from the highest tier, in the inventory he was keeping of impossible things — had never once happened before.

The wheel rose toward the ceiling, rings unlocking back into their usual smug clatter. As it went, the warm gold band of the Family-Class banner lit up along its rim, and a small counter appeared beside it that had been counting, apparently, for nine chapters where no one could see:

FAMILY-CLASS JACKPOT: ACCUMULATED.

NEXT PULL: JACKPOT.

A doorbell chime. The cozy font. The theatre regarded it with the flat wariness of people who had been taught, at rarity-point-blank range, exactly how this machine did arithmetic — nine chapters of cost before a purchase, nine chapters of warmth before a *what?*

"It's going to be nice," said Peter Parker slowly, reading the room's dread and naming it. "It's going to be really, really nice, and then it's going to do something to us. That's its whole move. Breakfast, birthdays, the yard full of dragons — and then something in the last frame."

"**NEXT PULL PENDING,**" said the screen, cozily.

Rias Gremory looked at the warm gold light for a long moment, and — those seated near the fiancées would report it later, and be believed — reached over and took Asia Argento's hand, though neither of them could have said against what.

The lights went down on a theatre that had watched every dragon bow, and one stand, and was beginning to suspect the machine had shown them the standing on purpose.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Dragons Bowing to Issei* — **Mythic** (first-ever Mythic; a new top-tier band revealed after 28 chapters — the wheel itself *inclined* to deliver it); *Ddraig's Declaration* — Epic. The screen confirmed the Family banner runs chronologically ahead of the war banner: "you are seeing the receipt," not the purchase.

- **Secrets Revealed:** On neutral ground in the Underworld's Dragon's Range, dragons of a dozen rival mythologies — Tannin, Fafnir, Yu-Long, Vritra (via his host Saji), elders and hatchlings alike — freely bowed to Issei, who begged them to stop and then fed them. Nest Law codified: *family does not bow; family is what the bow protects* — Beaucephalis stood unbowed at his brother's side and the ceremony approved. Ddraig's Declaration: every prior host asked the power "how much?"; Issei's first question was whether Ddraig was *lonely* — and Ddraig proclaimed the Red Dragon Emperor's name changed from a ten-thousand-year grief into a **nest**: any dragon without a home may fly to Issei. The history of the corrupted prior hosts was glimpsed for a quarter-second (fire in the shape of a screaming man, a backward lullaby) then slammed behind a black card: **[RECORD SEALED: RARITY INSUFFICIENT]** — the fiancées visibly knew what it was and said nothing. A distant white glint watched the ceremony and left, captioned **[RIVAL: RECORD PENDING]**. Children of two species now sing Ddraig's name without fear (the Oppai Dragon song — Ddraig confirms he has required counseling).
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: Doom formally re-categorizes Issei a third time** — phenomenon → constant → *peer* — and unilaterally declares "Latveria recognizes the Red Dragon Emperor," the theatre's first act of diplomatic recognition. T'Challa reads the uncompelled bow as the only honest technology of legitimacy; Namor openly admits to wanting what Issei has ("it is *policy*"). Magneto argues the savior/leash reading, then reverses himself on the evidence of the unbowed brother — "I dislike requiring more data." **Fin Fang Foom ends 29 chapters of scorn and bows** — the Marvel universe's first dragon to acknowledge the nest, confessing he never knew "the other thing could be had." Loki concludes the gauntlet is worthless without the boy and the boy cannot be stolen ("he is a practice"); Iron Fist is shaken that Issei earned from dragons by kindness what Danny earned by combat. Groot's roots-and-good-ground reading ("the dragons came to see what grew back"; "forests don't have kings") silences every monarch — the first time no king sought the last word.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** What is behind the **sealed black card** — the fate of the prior Red Dragon Emperors that the fiancées recognized and would not discuss, and what rarity will be "sufficient" to pay for it? Who is the white glint that watched and would not land ([RIVAL: RECORD PENDING])? The **Family-Class Jackpot** is now armed — "NEXT PULL: JACKPOT" in the cozy font, with the whole theatre braced for the machine's pattern of warmth-then-wound (Peter Parker: "something in the last frame"). Why did Rias take Asia's hand?

Chapter Thirty: Family-Class Jackpot

Primary Reaction Groups: Cosmic Families (Fantastic Four, Inhumans) • Villains (Doom, Mephisto, Magneto, Loki, Kang, Thanos) • The Eight Fiancées • Cosmic Observers (Uatu, Heimdall)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Montage of Ordinary Family Moments" — **Family-Class**
 2. "Erased Child Frame" — **Secret**
-

The theatre had learned, over nine chapters of the warm-gold banner, that Family-Class nights smelled like food.

No one had ever caught the machine doing it. There were no kitchens in the impossible architecture, no vents, no source — but on the nights the doorbell-chime track lit up, the air in the tiered dark acquired miso and grilled fish and the ghost of cheap birthday-cake frosting, and several thousand heroes, monsters, gods, and killers had stopped pretending they didn't lean into it. Ben Grimm had a standing theory that the machine was softening them up for something. Ben Grimm was, as usual on structural matters, correct.

Tonight the smell arrived early, and it arrived *everywhere*, and the front rows noticed first, because the front rows had been rearranged since Chapter Twenty-One and were now occupied by eight women who could level the seating if the seating had been levelable.

"Breakfast," said Koneko Toujou, flatly, nose lifting a centimeter. "Ours."

"Ara," murmured Akeno Himejima, hand to her cheek, "it's even got the burnt bit Xenovia always fights the crows for."

"I do not fight crows." Xenovia Quarta paused. "I have fought one crow. It was a rematch."

Down the row, Rias Gremory did not join the bit. She was watching the gacha wheel descend with the particular stillness she'd worn all arc — the stillness of a high-class devil who had spent nine chapters watching a cold machine hand her private life to a coliseum, and had slowly, grudgingly, been forced to admit that the coliseum was handling it with more grace than she'd budgeted for. They had laughed at the laundry war, yes. But they had also gone quiet at Asia's prayers, and the Punisher had nodded once — *once* — at the injury ledger, and somewhere around Chapter Twenty-Seven the betting board on *Who Would He Adopt?* had turned from mockery into something closer to a waiting list.

The wheel settled. The warm-gold track lit end to end, every segment at once, which it had never done, and the ceiling put on the color of late Sunday afternoon.

FINAL PULL OF THE BANNER, the screen printed. **ARC FINALE.**

"Here we go," said Johnny Storm, rubbing his hands. "Jackpot round. Please be embarrassing. Please be so embarrassing—"

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun once, lazily, a formality, and stopped on gold.

"MONTAGE OF ORDINARY FAMILY MOMENTS" — RARITY: FAMILY-CLASS.

"Ordinary," repeated Medusa, from the Inhuman block, her hair coiling into a skeptical question mark.

"Twenty-nine chapters, and it has never once shown us anything ordinary."

"That's why it's the jackpot," said Sue Storm quietly, and the theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

Morning. The Hyoudou residence — the absurd one, the six-floors-down-and-who-knows-how-many-up one, the house that a devil clan had rebuilt around two bewildered human parents — and a kitchen table long enough to seat a peace conference, which, functionally, it did.

The vision was not one memory. It was hundreds, laid one over another like a year of mornings pressed into a single golden hour, and it moved the way memory moves — not in order, but in weight.

Issei Hyoudou, hair flattened on one side, refereeing the last slice of tamagoyaki between Xenovia and Koneko with the gravity of a man defusing ordnance. Rossweisse doing the grocery arithmetic aloud, in Norse, because swearing about yen in Norse didn't count. Miki Hyoudou moving through the chaos with a teapot, entirely unbothered, pausing to press a second helping on Asia because in this house Asia's plate being full was a law of physics. Gorou Hyoudou behind a newspaper he had not read one line of in three years, because over the top of it he was watching his son — his mediocre, ridiculous, murdered-and-returned son — laugh with his mouth full, and Gorou's eyes were doing the thing that fathers pretend is the newspaper's fault.

"Oh no," said Ben Grimm, thickly, forty seconds in. "It's gonna be one of *these*."

It was one of these.

A birthday — Kunou's, the fox girl's, gold-eared and incandescent, her mother Yasaka watching from the engawa as Issei carried out a cake he had decorated himself, which is to say, decorated the way a Dragon Blaster decorates a mountainside. The frosting read *KUNOU* and then surrendered. The girl looked at that ruined, lopsided, painstaking cake the way other children look at fireworks.

A treaty summit in the living room, formal seating, Ravel Phenex presiding with her terrible ledger open to the chore annex: whereas the party of the first part (the Red Dragon Emperor) did solemnly commit to bathroom duty on alternating weeks, and whereas his prior performance had been assessed at *catastrophic-to-adequate, trending adequate* — the room got the giggle it needed, and Reed Richards whispered to Sue that their chore chart could learn from the arbitration clauses.

A school run. This one the theatre leaned into, because they had met these children in Chapter Twenty-Seven: the warded kids, the gathered strays of a dozen crises — Kunou with her charm-stitched satchel; the solemn black-haired little girl who was, the room now knew, an infinite dragon god wearing a child shape because she liked how it fit; Irina's two adopted ones from a world that no longer needed them, each with Rossweisse's protective sigils inked inside their collars like a mother's name tag. Issei walked them the human way, on foot, one on his shoulders, past the convenience store, and the vision let the audience feel the wards the way he felt them — a lattice of watchfulness laid over an ordinary street, invisible, absolute, the whole household's power braided into a promise that these children would get to be *bored* at school today.

"He walks them," Crystal said softly. "He could fold space. He walks them."

"The walking *is* the ward," said Karnak, and for once no one asked him to find the flaw, because his voice made it clear he had looked and, in this one structure, hadn't.

And a barbecue — the montage's long final movement, a backyard summer evening that seemed to contain every named soul of nine chapters. Gorou at the grill defending his tongs from a Welsh Dragon Emperor's vessel with a fly-swatter. Kiba and Irina running a beanbag toss the children were shamelessly rigging. Akeno and Miki conspiring over marinade. Rias barefoot on the grass, crown nowhere, title nowhere, laughing at something Kuroka said until she had to hold the fence, while Koneko lay across Issei's back where he sat cross-legged in the grass, not to be carried anywhere, only because that was where she went when the world was safe.

The vision held there. Smoke and lantern light and fourteen conversations, and underneath it, audible to the theatre the way his dying thoughts had been audible in Chapter One, the slow tide of Issei Hyoudou's heart: *this. This is the thing. Not the throne, not the titles, not even — okay, mostly not even the harem-king part. This. Everyone fed, everyone loud, everyone HERE. This is what all of it is for.*

The montage began, gently, to close — the memories stacking into a final image, the way a year folds into a photograph. The whole sprawling household assembling on the lawn for a group picture at golden hour, Gorou fussing with a camera on a tripod, bodies sorting themselves into rows with the ease of long practice, Issei in the center being strangled affectionately from two directions.

In the theatre, in the front row, eight women watched their own life with their hands quietly finding each other's along the seat backs.

"I remember that evening," Asia whispered, shining. "That was the summer after — that was a good evening. We couldn't get everyone to look at the camera at the same time. It took eleven tries."

The screen, as if in fond agreement, began flicking through them. Try one: Kunou sneezing. Try two: Xenovia blinking. Try three—

The theatre would argue, afterward, about how long the frame lasted. Sam Wilson said half a second. Vision said four hundred milliseconds and declined to repeat the measurement. Karnak said it did not last any length of time at all, that duration was the wrong axis for what it did, and then he asked, politely, to change the subject, which Karnak had never done in thirty chapters.

Try three was the same lawn, the same golden hour, the same rows of the same family.

And standing in the front row of the photograph, between Asia and Koneko, with Issei's hand resting on their shoulder — a child.

Small. Nine, ten, maybe. The eye took in brown hair with a crimson cast, or crimson hair with a brown cast, or — the eye could not finish. The child was *wrong* the way a word repeated too many times is wrong: every part of the image around them was warm film-grain gold, and they were interference, a shape cut out of the photograph and the cut-out then filmed, edges shivering with a static that wasn't static, flickering between *there* and a lawn where the family's spacing left a gap exactly that size, as if the picture had been composed around someone and then told to forget why.

And where every other soul in thirty chapters had arrived in the theatre's collective mind with a name — *Issei Hyoudou, second-year* — *Rias Gremory, heiress* — *Kunou, daughter of Yasaka* — where the machine had never once failed to introduce so much as a passing crow—

—nothing arrived.

Not an unknown name. Not a withheld name. The theatre's minds reached for the introduction the way a foot reaches for a stair that isn't there, and several thousand beings felt, simultaneously, the specific vertigo of a hole where a fact should be.

The frame ended. Try four: Kunou sneezing again, eleven tries, laughter, the montage sealing itself shut in warm gold — and then the screen froze, rewound itself with a sound like tape dragged over a magnet, and stamped, in letters that did not pulse, over the locked image of a lawn with a static-edged gap in the front row:

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"ERASED CHILD FRAME" — RARITY: SECRET.

SOURCE: ■■■■■■■■.

THIS MEMORY DOES NOT EXIST.

The silence that followed was not the silence of grief, which the theatre knew well by now, or of awe, which it had learned in Chapter Twenty. It was the silence of a room checking its own pockets.

"Asia." Rias's voice, front row, very level, the level of a voice being held level by main strength. "The eleventh-try evening. Who is that?"

"I don't—" Asia Argento was on her feet without knowing she'd stood. Her hands were pressed over her heart, and her face wore an expression the theatre had never seen on it: not fear, not confusion — *loss*, arriving without luggage, grief with no name on the tag. "I don't know. Rias, I was *there*, I remember every try, there was no— there was never—" Her eyes were spilling over. She looked down at her own tears in bewilderment, as if they belonged to someone else. "Why am I— why does it *hurt*?"

"Look at the spacing," said Rossweisse. The Valkyrie's voice had gone to its runework register, the one she used for wards, and she was pale to the lips. "Look at where we're all standing in every other try. We're standing *around* something. In all eleven. I drew the household wards myself, I know our formations blind, and that photograph has a slot in it, and the slot is child-sized, and I have no memory of what it was for."

Koneko hadn't spoken. Koneko was gripping the seat back in front of her, and the seat back — theatre-matter, the substance that had shrugged off the Hulk in Chapter One — was creaking.

It was Kuroka who said the thing, and she said it with every trace of the lounging cat-lazy purr gone from her voice, ears flat to her skull, golden eyes fixed on the frozen frame:

"Senjutsu reads the flow of life, nya. Everything alive leaves a current. Everything *dead* leaves a wake." Her tail had bottled to twice its size. "That frame doesn't have either. It has a hole shaped like a life. Something didn't die there. Something got *unhappened*."

"Machine." Rias had turned from the screen to face the impossible ceiling directly, and now her voice was not level at all; it was the voice that had once told the theatre's cold system exactly what she thought of it airing her proposal night, the voice of the woman who had spent eight Pawns on a dying pervert because of what she saw in him. "You have narrated every horror in this boy's life with captions. You *itemize*. So itemize. Who is the child in my family's photograph?"

The screen did not answer.

The theatre had seen the machine be cruel, coy, pedantic, and once — memorably — sarcastic. It had never seen the machine be *silent*. The cursor at the bottom of the frozen frame blinked, and blinked, like something with its mouth open.

Then, letter by letter, slower than it had ever printed:

RECORD NOT FOUND.

And beneath that, unbidden, in a smaller type the room had to strain for:

THIS UNIT DID NOT SELECT THIS PULL.

The warmth died out of the air like a tide going all the way out.

"Okay," said Johnny Storm, into it, with none of his usual wattage. "Okay, the loot box that kidnapped the multiverse just said *that wasn't me*. Anybody else want to go home? I've wanted to go home for thirty chapters, but *now*—"

"Quiet," said Sue — but her arm had gone around Franklin, fast and instinctive, because her son was staring at the frozen frame with an expression no ten-year-old should have owned, and Franklin Richards, who dreamed universes the way other children dreamed of dogs, had gone the color of paper.

"Franklin?" Reed knelt. "What do you see?"

"The picture's not broken," Franklin said. His voice was very small and very certain. "Everybody thinks the picture's broken. It's not. The picture *remembers*. It's the only thing that still does." He pressed his face into Sue's side and would not say anything else, and Reed Richards — who had an equation for everything, who had spent nine chapters charmed by chore treaties — looked up at the static-edged gap on the screen and, for the first time in the theatre's memory, did not reach for a notebook. He reached for Valeria's hand.

Across the aisle, in the Inhuman block, Black Bolt had risen. He could say nothing, so his standing said it. Medusa read her king's face and translated, quietly: "He asks the room to note that in Attilan, when the genetic records show a gap, it means the record was attacked. Gaps do not occur. Gaps are *made*."

"The frame's edges." Heimdall's voice rolled down from the Asgardian rows, gold eyes fixed and grim, and half the theatre finished his sentence in their own heads before he spoke it, because they had heard him say it ten chapters ago about a scar in the sky over a mountain. "I have seen that shimmer before. Near the roots of Yggdrasil, where things have been *cut away*. The boy's great cannon bruised the world and left that mark by accident." He paused. "Nothing about this mark is an accident. This is the same knife, held by a hand."

And in the villains' dark, where the room had grown used to Doom's verdicts and Mephisto's markets, it was Kang the Conqueror who came out of his seat like a man who has found his own obituary in the morning paper.

"No." Flat. Final. Wrong in the mouth of a man who dealt in certainties across forty centuries. "No, this is not — listen to me. All of you, *listen*. There are mechanisms — bureaucracies — beyond every timeline, whose function is pruning. I have been their prisoner, their emperor, and their paperwork. I know what a pruned branch looks like from every side of the blade, and here is the single law of pruning, the one law nothing violates: *a pruned branch does not photograph itself*. When a future is cut, the cut takes the evidence. The grief. The gap in the family photo. The child-sized slot in the wards. It takes *everything*, that is what pruning IS—" He stopped. His hands, the theatre noticed, were not steady. "Something was erased, and the erasure *left a receipt*. Do you understand? Either the blade is failing." He sat down very slowly. "Or something on the far side of the cut is *pushing back through*."

"Kang of the many centuries." Loki's voice, from two rows over, silk over a wire. "You're afraid."

"I am *inventorying*," said Kang, which fooled no one.

Mephisto had not moved through any of it. The demon sat with his fingers steepled and his eyes on the front row — not on the screen, on the *wives*, on Asia Argento weeping for someone she could not name — and when he finally spoke, it was almost to himself, and it was the worst thing anyone had heard him say in thirty chapters because it was gentle.

"I deal in souls," he said. "Souls are my ledger, my currency, and my law, and the law says a soul may be bought, damned, traded, or destroyed — but a destroyed soul *balances*. The books always balance." He nodded, minutely, at Asia. "That girl is grieving a debt entry that isn't in any book I can read. Somewhere there is a soul that never got to exist, and the interest on it is compounding in a mother's heart anyway." He unsteeped his fingers. "I want no part of whatever holds *that* account. I wish to note, formally, for the room: there are things below even my basement. I believe we have just heard one of them moving furniture."

Magneto said nothing at all. But Charles Xavier, beside him, turned his head — because he had felt it, the way he felt all of it — the old man looking at a family photograph with a child-shaped hole in it, and thinking, with a grief fifty years deep, of a house fire, of a lost daughter, of every parent who has ever stood in front of an absence the world refuses to confirm. *Whoever did this*, Erik Lehnsherr thought, with a clarity that made Charles's temples ache, *whatever did this — when the boy finds out, he will need no help from any of us. But he shall have mine*.

Highest of all, in the tier that belonged to him alone, Uatu the Watcher had not moved for four hundred milliseconds and then had moved more than he had in thirty chapters.

He was standing. Watchers do not stand; watching has no posture. He stood, vast and pale, and his voice, when it came, had lost the archival calm that had carried it through murders and wars and god-tier ascensions alike.

"I am going to say this once, and I require the room to hear it precisely, because precision is all I have left tonight." The frozen frame reflected in his enormous eyes, twice. "I watch. It is my nature, my sentence, and my sum. I have seen every timeline that is. I have seen every timeline that was, and every timeline that may yet be, and — hear this — I have seen the *dark inventory*: the timelines that were unmade, for I watched them until the instant of their unmaking, and my memory holds what reality releases. That is the terrible privilege of my kind. Nothing is erased so completely that a Watcher did not watch it."

He raised one hand and pointed — the first time he had ever pointed — at the static-edged child.

"I have never seen that child. Not in what is. Not in what was. Not in what might be. Not in the inventory of the unmade." A pause, and the pause had a fall in it. "There is no vantage from which that child was ever visible to me. And yet there the child stands, in a photograph, with a father's hand upon their shoulder. Which means the erasure I am looking at was performed in a place *I cannot watch*." His hand lowered. "I did not know there was such a place. I have been unsettled in this theatre before. This is the first time I have been *blind* in it."

Far below, the front row had drawn together into a knot — eight women, arms around Asia, around each other, staring up at the gap in their own golden hour. And on the screen, frozen mid-laugh in try three, Issei Hyoudou's hand rested on the shoulder of a child that flickered, and the theatre noticed, at last, the detail that would keep the room awake long after the lights went down. In every other frame, in every other try, in three hundred stacked memories of the montage, Issei's face had been open, loud, entirely legible — a face that had never once played poker.

In this frame, and only in this frame, he wasn't looking at the camera.

He was looking down at the child. And he was smiling the way his father smiled from behind the newspaper.

"He knew them," Irina whispered. Her voice broke on it. "Look at him. Whoever that is — wherever they took them *from* — Issei knew them, and loved them, and he doesn't remember either, and nobody ever got to *mourn*—"

The screen went dark. Not dimmed — dark, all at once, as if it, too, needed a moment.

Then, small and white, center screen:

ARC THREE COMPLETE: FAMILY, WIVES AND NEST LAW.

**YOU HAVE SEEN WHAT THE DRAGON GUARDS. YOU HAVE NOT SEEN EVERYTHING
THE DRAGON HAS LOST.**

IT IS NOT YET TIME FOR YOU TO KNOW WHAT COUNTS WHAT IS TAKEN.

And beneath it, for exactly one frame — flickering now, static-edged, wearing the same wrongness as the child, as if the sentence itself had been somewhere it shouldn't:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

The gacha wheel rose toward the ceiling in silence. The warm-gold Family-Class track went out segment by segment, like windows in a house at bedtime, and where it had been, a new band waited unlit — steel-grey, martial, stamped ARC FOUR: HEROES, KINGS AND MONSTERS.

Nobody reached for the smell of the barbecue as it faded. It felt, now, like taking something that belonged to a grave no one was allowed to find.

In the front row, Koneko Toujou finally let go of the ruined seat back. "We're getting them back," she said, to no one, to everyone, in the flattest, smallest, most absolute voice in the theatre. "Whoever they are. Whatever took them. We get them *back*."

[RECORD NOT FOUND,] printed the screen, softly, one last time.

"**Then we will make the record ourselves,**" said Ddraig's voice out of the dark — and for the first time in thirty chapters, the dragon sounded neither ancient nor amused, but like a grandfather standing over an empty crib. "**Partner's nest law, little one. Nothing taken from the nest stays taken. I have seen empires learn that. Whatever is out there beyond the Watcher's eyes... it has made an enemy it cannot count.**"

The lights went down on a theatre that had come, tonight, to watch a family — and sat now in the dark, every faction, every aisle, mourning a stranger none of them could remember, which is to say: doing, at last, the one thing the erasure had been designed to make impossible.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Montage of Ordinary Family Moments* — Family-Class (the banner's finale jackpot: a year of breakfasts, Kunou's birthday, the Ravel-arbitrated chore treaty, walking the warded children to school on foot, and the great barbecue — closing on the eleven-try family photograph at golden hour); *Erased Child Frame* — Secret (a pull the machine itself disclaimed: "**THIS UNIT DID NOT SELECT THIS PULL.**").
- **Secrets Revealed:** Photo try three contains a child, roughly nine or ten, standing between Asia and Koneko with Issei's hand on their shoulder — flickering, static-edged, "edited out of reality." For the first time in thirty chapters the theatre's name-delivery failed: no name arrived, not withheld but *absent*. None of the eight fiancées recognize the child, yet Asia grieves involuntarily; Rossweisse identifies a child-sized "slot" in the family's formations across all eleven tries; Kuroka's senjutsu

reads "a hole shaped like a life" — not death, *unhappening*. The frame's edges carry the same excision signature Heimdall and Uatu flagged on the Dragon Blaster scar in Chapter Twenty — but deliberate, "the same knife, held by a hand." In the frame, and only there, Issei looks not at the camera but down at the child, smiling like his father. The machine answered Rias's direct demand with **RECORD NOT FOUND** — its first-ever refusal/failure.

- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** *Arc-close stance on the family*: unanimous across the aisle — Issei's household is no longer filed as leverage, weakness, or spectacle but as his moral structure and load-bearing wall; even the villains' gallery formally retires "use the family against him" (Mephisto declares the family's grief-account beyond any ledger he can read and wants no part of its holder; Magneto privately pledges his aid to whoever avenges the erasure). The Fantastic Four and Inhumans, the theatre's resident families, shift from charmed analysis to visceral kinship — and to alarm: Black Bolt stands to testify that "gaps are *made*"; Franklin Richards says the photo "remembers — it's the only thing that still does" and will say no more. Kang drops all conqueror poise: pruned branches do not photograph themselves — either the blade is failing or something beyond the cut is pushing back through. The eight fiancées close ranks around a grief with no name; Koneko vows retrieval; Ddraig invokes nest law: "nothing taken from the nest stays taken."
- **Unresolved Hooks: THE ERASED CHILD — the arc's ominous jackpot and the theatre's first true mystery.** Who is the child in the eleventh-try photograph, why does no record of them exist anywhere — including the Watcher's "dark inventory" of unmade timelines — and what performed an erasure in a place Uatu *cannot watch* (his first admitted blindness)? Who or what "counts what is taken," per the screen's arc-close line — and why did the prophecy line itself flicker with the child's static? Why did the machine disclaim the pull — is something else feeding frames into the theatre? Do not resolve; seed only. *Carried forward*: the greyed-out crimson Queen still waits; the excision-signature thread now spans Chapters 20 and 30; next banner lit: steel-grey **ARC FOUR: HEROES, KINGS AND MONSTERS**.

Chapter Thirty-One: Emperor of Hope

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers Leadership (Steve Rogers, Tony Stark) • Doom • Magneto • Cosmic Observers (Uatu, Silver Surfer)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Title Announcement: Emperor of Hope" — **Forbidden**
 2. "Apophis Kill" — **Epic**
-

The theatre did not smell like anything anymore.

That was the first thing everyone noticed, and no one said. For ten chapters the air had carried breakfasts and birthday cake, and then a photograph had opened like a wound, and now the tiered dark smelled of nothing at all — scrubbed, neutral, institutional — and the steel-grey band above the stage lit segment by segment with a sound like a rifle being cleaned.

ARC FOUR: HEROES, KINGS AND MONSTERS.

YOU HAVE SEEN WHAT THE DRAGON GUARDS. NOW YOU WILL SEE WHAT THE WORLD MADE OF HIM — AND WHAT IT CALLED HIM AFTERWARD.

"Cheerful font," said Tony Stark, who had not slept. He'd spent the dark hours between chapters doing what half the room had done: running the erased child's static through every instrument his mind could build without a workshop, and getting a fear-shaped nothing. "Anybody notice we've been promoted? Arc One was the tutorial. Arc Three was the home life. This one's got *war memorial* kerning."

"It has *armory* kerning," Steve Rogers said quietly, beside him. The shield was across his knees. It had been there since the photograph. "Grief first. Then the recruiting poster. I've seen this order of operations before."

Down in the front row, the eight fiancées sat closer together than the seats were designed for. Koneko was still watching the screen the way a sentry watches a treeline.

The gacha wheel descended into the grey light, and the room saw at once that something about it was wrong. Every banner before this had displayed its rarities like a menu. Tonight there was a segment the other segments had visibly drawn away from: a thin seam, darker than the theatre's own dark, fenced on both sides by hazard-striping the machine had never used for anything.

The wheel spun. It slowed. It passed the seam once, twice — the whole theatre leaning with it like a coin circling a drain — and stopped there dead.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"TITLE ANNOUNCEMENT: EMPEROR OF HOPE" — RARITY: FORBIDDEN.

No vision came.

That was the thing, the thing that made three thousand beings hold their breath: every pull in thirty chapters had *opened*, had swallowed them into blood or fire or breakfast. This one just — stood there. Four words, white on black, hanging over the stage with no memory attached, like a headstone delivered before the death.

EMPEROR OF HOPE.

Then, beneath it, printing slowly, the way the machine had printed only once before — on the night it said *record not found*:

THE TITLE IS TRUE. THE TITLE IS EARNED. THE MEANING IS SEALED.

YOU COULD NOT YET AFFORD TO KNOW WHY.

"Well," said Doctor Doom, into the silence, and the silence made room for him, because it always did. "At last. Thirty chapters of adolescence, matrimony, and grilled meat, and the machine finally addresses the only question of consequence." He had risen — Doom reacted to thrones the way hawks react to movement. "*Emperor*. Of course. Doom has watched the dragons of a hundred pantheons kneel to this boy; Doom has watched him arbitrate a household the size of a small court. The title is not surprising. The title is *overdue*."

"The title is wrong."

Steve hadn't stood. Somehow that made it land harder — Captain America, seated, saying it to the screen rather than to Doom, in the tone he used when the thing he disagreed with was an idea rather than a man.

"No offense to the boy. Everything we've seen says he's one of the finest people this theatre's ever aired. The problem is the word." He said it slowly, like tasting rust. "*Emperor*. I've spent my whole life on one side of a line, and on the other side of that line there is always a man whose title means *no one is allowed to tell me no*. Kings at least belong to a place. An emperor is what a king becomes when he stops accepting borders. You can be the best man alive and the title is still a loaded gun on the table." He finally looked at Doom. "I've met good men with crowns. I've never met a crown that stayed good."

"Because you have never met a crown worn by someone sufficient to it," Doom said, with the serene contempt of a man who owned one. "Your objection is not to emperors, Captain — it is to *unworthy* emperors, and you have simply never conceived of the other kind. The dragon-brat is vulgar, sentimental, and — Doom concedes — incorruptible in a manner Doom has verified and finds professionally irritating. If the multiverse insists on producing emperors regardless of your comfort — and it does, Captain — it could do far worse than one whose empire appears to consist of fed children and kept promises."

"Then answer the only question that matters."

Magneto's voice came down from the mutant tiers like a gavel. Erik Lehnsherr had said almost nothing since the photograph; the room knew what his silences weighed.

"Every crown I have ever seen was *issued*," he said. "By a church. By an army. By a border drawn in other people's blood, by a mob, by fear — always by *someone*, and the someone is the crown's true name. The machine says the title is true and earned. I do not ask what it means. I ask the older question, the one every throne is built to make you forget: *who gave it to him?* Whose hand is on that crown? Show me the grantor, and I will tell you what the empire is."

The theatre turned, more or less as one body, to the front row.

Rias Gremory was already shaking her head — slowly, and the room realized with a small collective chill that the Crimson Princess, who had named every power and title of this boy's world for them across thirty chapters, looked *unsettled*.

"We know the title," she said. "It's real — it followed him home from a war, it spread the way titles spread, from below, and when anyone uses it to his face he turns red and changes the subject. And none of us has ever found where it started. No herald announced it. No throne issued it. No one we ever asked said it *first*. It was simply, one morning, what people called him." She looked up at Magneto. "You want the grantor. So did I. I know how to trace a title through a bureaucracy. This one has no root. I stopped digging because it frightened me that there wasn't one."

"A crown with no grantor," Magneto said softly, sitting back down, unsatisfied. "In my experience there is no such thing. Only grantors who do not wish to be found."

High above, the Silver Surfer spoke from where his board hung motionless in the dark, his voice quiet and carrying anyway, the way falling snow carries.

"I served an emperor once. His empire was hunger, and no hand crowned Galactus; he simply *was*, and the universe adjusted. I hear the word *emperor* and I look for the hunger underneath it — that is what the title has meant everywhere I have flown." A pause. "*Emperor of hope*. In all my lifetimes of crossing

this cosmos, I have never heard those two words joined. I do not know what it would even mean — to be the fact that hope adjusts to."

And higher still, Uatu the Watcher — who had stood, last chapter, for the first time; who had confessed blindness for the first time — said nothing at all. But those nearest his tier noticed he had turned fractionally, and was not watching the screen.

He was watching the seam in the wheel. The Forbidden band. As though checking whether it, too, was somewhere he could not see.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"APOPHIS KILL" — RARITY: EPIC.

CONTEXT: THE EVIL DRAGON WAR.

"The what," said Tony — and the theatre swallowed them.

There was no sun.

That was the fact the vision built itself around. A battlefield on the roof of the world, a plain of glassed rock and dead wards, armies of devils and angels and fallen ranked together under a sky that should have held a dawn by now and instead held a *lid* — blackness with a texture, blackness that moved — and the theatre understood with borrowed dread that they were not looking at night. They were looking at coils.

Apophis, said Ddraig's voice, in the theatre and in the vision at once, old and flat and entirely without its usual humor. **Not a dragon as I am a dragon. The Egyptians knew him best: the serpent at the rim of the world, who swallows the sun before it can rise. Understand what you are seeing. Most evil is a choice — a man deciding. This is not that. Apophis is un-choice. He wants no treasure, territory, or worship. His victory condition is that tomorrow does not occur. Every dawn you have ever seen was a battle he lost.**

The vision moved among the armies, and the theatre heard what the soldiers heard: nothing. The serpent's shadow ate sound the way it ate light, and under it veteran soldiers stood shaking, because armies run on the assumption of *afterward*, and afterward was being digested overhead.

And then a red light got up off the ground.

He was different than they'd last seen him — the armor still Ddraig's scale mail, still dragon-shaped, but *deeper* somehow, crimson gone the color of arterial certainty, scarred and scorched and patched mid-campaign, a suit that had been lived in through a war. He rose alone through the dead air, a single ember under all that ending, and the theatre's audible-heart trick opened, and they braced for battle-fury.

There wasn't any.

Okay, thought Issei Hyoudou, tiredly, at the serpent that eats the sun. Here's the thing. Down there, there's a guy who promised his kid he'd be home for her birthday. There's a unit that hasn't slept in three days and still lined up this morning. Asia's at the field hospital and she hasn't cried yet, because she's decided crying happens after. Everybody down there is carrying a "tomorrow" around like a coin in their pocket. The ember rose. [BOOST.] You eat those. That's your whole deal. You're not a person who did something terrible — you're the reason "terrible" would stop being a category, because categories need a next day to exist in. [BOOST.] [BOOST.] So this isn't like the others. There's nobody in there to spare.

The serpent noticed him — a pressure like the attention of an avalanche — and the black lid of the sky peeled open along one seam into an eye, and then a mouth, and the mouth was the horizon.

What followed, the theatre would mostly remember in still frames, because motion at that scale defeated the eye. Ascalon, the dragon-slaying blade, running with light in a world that had none left. Coils falling across mountain ranges like dropped cable. The armor caving along one side and re-knitting slower than it caved. And through it all that exhausted, bookkeeping calm, boost stacking on boost — ten seconds, ten seconds, ten seconds, a man paying installments of himself — until the serpent gathered its whole blackness to swallow him the way it had swallowed ten thousand dawns—

—and he went *in*.

[PENETRATE.]

The theatre had seen the word before. They had never seen it used like this: not to bypass an armor but to refuse a concept — the sword and the ember passing through devouring-itself, into the cold coil-heart where the eaten dawns went, and the vision went white, and the white was not an explosion.

The white was sunrise.

Morning came up over the glassed plain like a debt being repaid. The serpent's body fell for a very long time, and was ash before it landed, and did not leave a wake — Kuroka, in the front row, flinched at that; *clean, it reads clean, nya, nothing left* — and across the battlefield, thousands of soldiers of three species stood in the first light any of them had truly believed in for weeks, and looked up at a small red figure hanging in it, armor cracked, blade dimming, visibly barely conscious.

Nobody in the vision said any title. The theatre noted that, hard. No herald, no chant, no coronation. The armies just stood there in the sun that had been given back to them, looking up.

And the boy's dying-tired thought, as the vision closed, was: *good. Okay. Everybody gets a tomorrow. Worth it.* And then, fainter, almost asleep: *man, I hope somebody kept my breakfast.*

The lights came up on a very quiet room.

"So that's the confusion, right there," Sam Wilson said at last, from behind Steve. "Machine calls him Emperor of *Hope* and then shows us a kill. A clean, deliberate, no-mercy kill, from the guy whose whole file says he doesn't do those. Anybody else's title generator would've gone with Dragonslayer. Sun-bringer. Something with *teeth*."

"Because the kill isn't the subject," Steve said slowly. He was looking at the afterimage the way he looked at maps. "Watch it again in your head. He never fought the serpent. Not really. He fought for the *sunrise* — for the birthday, the tired unit, the girl saving her tears for afterward. Every one of us in this room has made the hard call to end a threat. He wasn't making that call. He was making a different one, the same one, over and over, ten seconds at a time: *other people get a future, and I'll pay whatever that runs*." He stopped, frowning, feeling the edge of something too big for the sentence. "I don't think hope is his slogan. I think it's his *casualty list*. Everything he spends comes out of his own column and the futures keep — " He shook his head. "I don't have it yet. But the word isn't wrong the way I wanted it to be."

"It is also," said Doom, "not granted, Lehnsherr — you heard the devil-princess. No root, no grantor, no throne. Doom has considered the problem for the duration of the sunrise and finds only one precedent for a title that issues from nowhere and is nonetheless *true*." A pause, precisely measured. "Prophecy. And this room has already been given one of those, concerning things we cannot stand before."

Tony's head came up. So, three tiers away, did Kang's.

"Say the quiet math," Tony said. "Come on. Somebody besides me is doing it. Last chapter: a thing that eats *children out of photographs* — futures, unhappened. Tonight, lesson one of the war college: here's a monster whose entire nature is eating tomorrows, and here's the boy who went *into* one and gave the morning back. This isn't a gacha anymore, if it ever was. It's a syllabus. And it just showed us the entry-level version of whatever took that kid."

Nobody argued. That was the frightening part; the theatre had argued about everything for thirty chapters, and nobody argued.

The screen let the silence sit for exactly as long as it took to become unbearable, and then printed, in the steel-grey band's cold type:

AN EMPEROR REQUIRES NO GRANTOR, MAGNUS. BUT YOU ASKED THE CORRECT QUESTION — AND ONE ANSWER EXISTS AT YOUR SCALE.

NEXT: THE KINGDOM THAT ASKED FOR HIM.

The wheel rose into the dark, the Forbidden seam still fenced in hazard stripes, still sealed, four white words fading last of all — **EMPEROR OF HOPE** — like a debt the theatre had just been shown the existence of, and not the amount.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Title Announcement: Emperor of Hope* — **Forbidden** (the theatre's first-ever Forbidden pull: no vision, only four words and a seal — "**THE TITLE IS TRUE. THE TITLE IS EARNED. THE MEANING IS SEALED. YOU COULD NOT YET AFFORD TO KNOW WHY.**"); *Apophis Kill* — Epic (the Evil Dragon War: Issei, in a scarred, deeper-crimson evolution of his scale mail, kills Apophis — the Egyptian serpent of chaos that devours the sun — via Ascalon and Penetrate, restoring dawn to three allied armies).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's world fought an **Evil Dragon War** (first mention; the machine treats it as a known context, promising more). Apophis was "un-choice" — a being whose victory condition is that tomorrow does not occur; it is the ONE kind of enemy Issei kills without hesitation, because "there's nobody in there to spare." His armor has visibly evolved past the Scale Mail seen in Arc One (form deliberately unnamed on-screen — do not name it until its debut chapter). Rias confirms the title "Emperor of Hope" is real in their world, spread from below, embarrasses Issei — and has **no traceable grantor**; she stopped digging because the rootlessness frightened her. Kuroka's senjutsu read the Apophis kill as "clean" — total, no wake (quiet contrast with the erased child's "hole shaped like a life").
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** **Steve Rogers** moves from rejecting the word "emperor" outright to a troubled half-thesis: hope isn't Issei's slogan but his *casualty list* — he keeps choosing futures where others get to live and pays for them out of his own column (seeded, NOT resolved). **Doom** endorses the title as "overdue" and, finding it grantorless, reclassifies it as *prophecy* — linking it to "HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT." **Magneto** remains unsatisfied: "no such thing as a crown with no grantor, only grantors who do not wish to be found." **Silver Surfer** frames emperors as hungers and admits he cannot conceive of "the fact that hope adjusts to." **Tony/Kang** (and, tellingly, no dissenters) accept the "syllabus theory": the theatre is running a curriculum, and Apophis was the entry-level model of whatever erased the child.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** **THE FORBIDDEN SEAL** — what does "Emperor of Hope" actually mean, why is the meaning priced ("could not yet afford"), and who/what first spoke a title with no root?

(True payoff reserved for Arc 10 / Chapter 99 — seed only, never explain.) Why did Uatu watch the Forbidden seam on the wheel instead of the screen — is the Forbidden band another place he cannot see? The Evil Dragon War itself is now an open file. The machine addressed Magneto directly by name ("MAGNUS") and promised "one answer at your scale": next banner — *The Kingdom That Asked for Him* (Ch. 32). *Carried forward*: the erased child, the excision-signature thread (Chs. 20/30), the greyed-out crimson Queen, and the unnamed evolved armor awaiting its debut.

Chapter Thirty-Two: The Kingdom That Asked for Him

Canon Status: [ALTERNATE PULL] This chapter's gacha pulls are hypothetical simulations the Theatre generates, not memories of events that occurred in Issei's actual timeline.

Primary Reaction Groups: Wakanda (T'Challa, Shuri, Okoye) • Atlantis (Namor) • Latveria (Doctor Doom) • Mutants (Magneto, Charles Xavier, Storm)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Village Election of Issei as Protector" — **Rare**
 2. "Governing Through Delegation" — **Rare**
-

Between arcs, the theatre redecorated. No one ever saw it happen. The warm-gold banner of the family nights had gone dark like windows at bedtime, and in its place the steel-grey track of ARC FOUR ran the ceiling's length, martial and cold — and on the second night of it, the audience discovered the machine had built a new row.

Front and center-left, raised half a step above the tiers around it: five thrones. Not seats. Thrones — each one unmistakably itself. A chair of dark vibranium-woven wood with panther-claw feet. A coral seat that stayed wet no matter how dry the air. A block of green-draped iron. A fourth of pale Attilan crystal, which Black Bolt regarded from a polite distance and declined, on the reasonable grounds that the machine did not get to tell him where kings sat.

And a fifth chair. Plain steel. Unmarked. Facing the screen at the row's end like an accusation.

"Subtle," said Magneto, from the mutant tiers, not moving toward it.

"It matched the rest of us within a molecule," Shuri observed, running a scanner over her brother's throne with open professional resentment. "The weave is *correct*. I hate that the weave is correct."

T'Challa sat. Namor sat, arranging himself with the boredom of a man who had held actual thrones before most of this room's nations had flags. Doom sat last, and made even that a verdict.

Last night still hung in the air the way thunder hangs after the flash. The machine had ended the arc's opening chapter with two words burning over the image of a boy standing on a dead god-serpent the size of a river: **EMPEROR OF HOPE**. No explanation. Steve Rogers had disliked the noun. Doom had approved of it. And Magneto — Magneto had risen in the dark and asked the question that had followed everyone to whatever passed for sleep here:

Who granted him legitimacy?

Tonight the gacha wheel descended with, the room could have sworn, a certain smugness.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun and stopped on the flat pewter shine of a Rare.

"VILLAGE ELECTION OF ISSEI AS PROTECTOR" — RARITY: RARE.

"*Election*," Namor repeated, as if the word had been fished out of a bilge.

The theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

The Underworld had frontiers. The vision established this first, patiently, because the audience still thought of Hell as a single administrative horror: no — it had provinces, and beyond the provinces it had valleys where the war had gone and the government had not. This one lay under a sky the color of an old bruise: terraced fields, a mill, a shrine with its roof stove in, and claw-gouges in the earth wide enough to lie down in.

The war was over. Its leavings were not. The vision gave the theatre ten seconds of what a remnant evil dragon does to a settlement of low-class devils and reincarnated farmers who have no peerage, no pieces, no one — ten seconds was enough — and then it gave them the red blur that arrived on the eleventh, and the audience, thirty-one chapters educated, did not need the fight narrated. They watched Issei Hyoudou put himself between a burning granary and something with too many jaws, and they watched the something learn what the whole theatre had learned in Arc One: that the boy did not know how to be anywhere else.

What the machine wanted them to see came *after*.

It showed him staying. Two weeks, three. Scale Mail dismissed, sleeves rolled, hauling roof-beams. Asia in the shrine with a line of patients out the door. Koneko relocating boulders with the expression of someone doing light gardening. Issei teaching the village children — there were always children; the theatre had stopped being surprised — how to spot a stray-beast track, getting the lesson wrong, being corrected by a nine-year-old goatherd, and laughing so hard he sat down in the mud.

And then, on an evening when the roofs were whole, the vision showed the millhouse: lamplit, packed to the walls, every adult in the valley crowded in, and on the table a bread bowl filling up with folded scraps of paper.

"They're—" Okoye leaned forward, general's eyes narrowed. "They are *voting*."

They were voting. The village headwoman — old, iron-grey, a reincarnated human with flour on her forearms — counted the ballots aloud while Issei stood by the door with the deeply hunted look of a student summoned over the intercom. The count was unanimous, minus one ballot cast for a goat named Understudy, which the vision made clear was the miller's standing protest vote in all elections and was not personal.

"We are asking," the headwoman said, "not offering. Offering is for tribute, and we've nothing you'd take. The valley has voted. We want you as our lord protector."

The theatre watched the Red Dragon Emperor — mountain-eraser, dragon-slayer, Emperor of Hope — go into full retreat against a millhouse door.

"*Lord*? No. Nope. Absolutely not. Do you know what my grades — look, I once flooded my own bathroom fighting a towel rack, you cannot put *lord* in front of—"

"Protector, then," said the headwoman, who had raised six children and recognized the genre of the argument. "We'll strike the lord."

"You don't have to strike anything, because I'm not—"

"You came when no one came," she said, and the millhouse went quiet, and so did the theatre. "The war ended and the capitals lit their lamps and nobody's lamps came out here. Yours did. We're not asking you to rule us, boy. We can rule ourselves; we've been doing it in a monster-run valley for forty years, which is harder than anything a throne does. We're asking you to *answer*. When something comes over that ridge — be the one who answers."

The vision held on Issei's face while he lost. The theatre had seen him refuse gods, refuse thrones-by-conquest, refuse Mephisto-grade bargains without blinking. It watched an old woman with flour on her arms beat him in under a minute, because she had asked for the one thing he had never once in his life been able to refuse anyone.

"...Okay," he said. "Protector. *Just* protector. And I get veto power over statues."

The millhouse cheered. The goat received one ballot's worth of dignified applause. The vision faded on Issei signing his name — laboriously, tongue between his teeth — to a charter the headwoman had clearly had drafted for a week.

"Well," said Namor, into the theatre's exhale, "I have seen many coronations. That was the first conducted in a *flour barn*, by *ballot*, over the candidate's objection." He laced his fingers. "It was also the most honest. I despise it slightly less than I intended to."

"You intended to despise it aloud and at length," said Shuri. "We had a betting line."

"Oh, I still shall." The Sub-Mariner's voice carried down the kings' row, imperial and unbothered. "A reluctant king is a *tourist*. Hear me — I do not doubt the boy's arm, I have watched thirty-one chapters of his arm. I doubt his *residence*. Atlantis does not want a protector who answers a horn; Atlantis wants a king who is married to her, who breathes her, who cannot leave because leaving would be severing a limb. Reluctance means the door is open behind him. One day the horn blows and the reluctant king is at a *barbecue*." He gestured at the screen. "That valley elected a hero. Heroes visit. Kings remain. When the crisis comes that lasts ten years instead of ten minutes, they will learn the difference."

"Or," said T'Challa quietly, "they elected the only kind of king worth having."

The theatre turned. The Black Panther had not raised his voice in four arcs; he had never needed to.

"In Wakanda, on the day of challenge, I stand in the water at Warrior Falls stripped of the Panther's strength, and any Wakandan of the blood may fight me for everything I am. My father stood there. His father. Do you know what that ritual is, Namor? It is my nation *asking*, once each reign — renewing the question. The throne is not mine. It is *lent* to me, publicly, revocably, and the day my people stop being able to take it back is the day I have become something Wakanda must survive rather than something it has." He nodded at the frozen frame of the millhouse. "Magneto asked last night who granted the legitimacy. There is the answer, and it is the only answer that has ever been real: the governed granted it. Everything else — bloodline, conquest, divine right — is a story the strong tell the tired."

"Spoken," said Doom, "like a man whose borders have never required *correction*."

The iron voice put frost down the row. Doom had watched both scenes without motion, gauntlets flat on the arms of the green-draped throne the machine had built him, and when he continued it was with the terrible patience of a lecture.

"Doom will grant the room this much: the transaction was clean. Service rendered; authority conferred; no fraud in it anywhere. It is the purest mandate Doom has witnessed, and Doom has manufactured several." A pause for the room to decide whether that was a joke; Doom did not assist them. "But T'Challa mistakes a *village* for a proof. Forty souls and a goat may know their own good. Forty *million* do not — they are frightened, divisible, and infinitely persuadable, and the ruler who waits to be asked will stand in polite silence while demagogues burn the granaries to sell the survivors water. Latveria did not ask for Doom." The gauntlet closed. "Latveria was a carcass that six larger nations were carving. Doom took it, ended the carving, and Latveria has not buried a child of famine or invasion in decades. Ask my Latverians whether they would trade their unasked king for a *ballot in a bread bowl*."

"They can't answer that honestly and you know it," said Storm, from the mutant tiers, "which is the entire point, Victor."

"They *would* not, which Doom finds sufficient."

The screen, with the timing the theatre had learned to dread, chimed.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"GOVERNING THROUGH DELEGATION" — RARITY: RARE.

"Ah," said Xavier softly. "Now we see what he does with it."

What he did with it was give it away.

The vision opened weeks later: the millhouse again, now with a long table, and on the table a document under construction. Ravel Phenex presided over the drafting with her terrible ledger open — the theatre's old friend from Chapter Twenty-Five — and Rossweisse stood at a slate board writing actual *law*, clause by clause, in a hand so precise it looked typeset. Issei sat not at the table's head but along its side, between the headwoman and the goatherd's father, visibly relieved that other people knew words.

The charter took shape and the theatre read it over the valley's shoulder. A council of seven, elected yearly. The schoolteacher made magistrate, because — Issei's actual argument, delivered with actual passion — "when two of you argue, you already go to her *anyway*, I've watched you, I'm just writing down what's true." The miller: keeper of the granary and the grain-tithe, with public accounts. A retired border soldier, one-armed, to captain a watch that Issei would train but *not* command day to day. Disputes settled by the council; appeals to the magistrate; and the protector—

The vision closed in on the clause. Rossweisse's handwriting, formal as scripture:

Article One. The Protector holds no land, levies no tax, and judges no dispute. The Protector answers to this charter and to the council, the same as any soul in the valley. The Protector's sole office is this: when the horn sounds, he comes.

"He wrote himself *under* it," Okoye said. "The strongest thing in that world, and the first law they drafted is the leash, and *he asked for the leash*."

Then the tribute scene, and the theatre got the comedy it needed: a delegation arriving at the Hyoudou residence with a chest of the valley's pooled coin, and Issei chasing them back down the road with it. The chest returned twice more by increasingly creative smuggling — baked into a delivery of bread; disguised as a donation to Asia's shrine, which nearly worked. Final settlement, brokered by Ravel with contractual gravity: the protector would accept, in perpetuity, one standing dinner invitation per season, first rights to the burnt bits, and a scarf knitted annually by the headwoman, quality not guaranteed.

"Mephisto." Loki's voice floated from the villains' dark, silken. "You've gone quiet. A soul refusing *payment* — is that not your least favorite weather?"

"It is the only weather that ruins my business entirely," said Mephisto, and did not elaborate, and looked as though the burnt bits personally offended him.

The vision's last image was small. The horn — an actual horn, ox-bone, hung by the mill — and a night two seasons on when it sounded, once, cracked with panic. And the sky over the ridge opening red before the echo died.

He came. That was all. The vision did not even show the fight. It showed the valley's faces, upturned in the dark, already unafraid — and it ended.

"There is your answer, Namor," T'Challa said. "Two seasons. The door behind him stayed open the entire time. He never used it."

"Two seasons is a courtship," Namor said. But he said it slowly, and the theatre noted — the ledgers all noted — that the Sub-Mariner's eyes had stayed on the horn. "Ask me again at twenty years... I will say this and no more: when the horn sounded, he did not send a *deputy*. A king who comes personally to the smallest village of his smallest border — Atlantis has a word for that. It is an old word. We have not needed it recently."

"Delegation," Doom said, "is how power admits it is mortal. Doom delegates *nothing* that matters, because no one else can bear it — and Doom will concede, before this room, that the boy's arrangement is therefore either the greatest foolishness on that screen or a thing Doom's Latveria cannot attempt." A silence. "It is not foolishness. That valley now functions *without him*. If he dies, it holds. Nothing Doom has built holds without Doom, and Doom has always called that design." The mask tilted a fraction. "Tonight Doom calls it inventory."

And then Magneto stood, and the theatre remembered that the question had been his.

"It's a beautiful answer," he said, and the bitterness in it was old, older than the theatre, older than the Brotherhood. "Truly. The governed asked; the strong man knelt to their charter; the leash was his own request. Beautiful. Now let me tell you how it goes when *my* people are the valley." He did not look at the empty steel chair. He looked at nothing this room contained. "Humanity has offered mutants protectors beyond counting. Registration acts — *protection*. Sentinels — built, I remind you, as *guardians*. Camps with lovely names. Every protector we did not choose became a warden within a generation, and the one nation we built for ourselves, the world sank into the sea while the protectors watched. So forgive me if I ask the ugly question under tonight's pretty one: that valley could *afford* to ask, because the thing they asked was kind. What is the mechanism — show me the clause, Rossweisse's fine handwriting, any of it — that keeps the asking real when the protector stops being kind? Article One is a leash held by *forty farmers*. It binds him because *he chooses to be bindable*. That is not law. That is luck wearing law's coat."

"Erik." Xavier's voice, gentle as ever and giving no ground. "You've just described every constitution ever written. They are all promises kept by the people strong enough to break them. That has never made the promises worthless. It makes the *choosing* the entire substance of the thing — and we have now watched this boy choose, for thirty-two chapters, under torture, in grief, at the summit of power that erases mountains. At some point, old friend, the evidence outweighs the wound."

"Nothing outweighs the wound, Charles. Things are merely built beside it."

It was Storm who ended it — Ororo Munroe, who sat with the mutants and had reigned in Wakanda, the only soul in the theatre who had lived on both sides of the row.

"I have been the protector who was asked," she said. "A goddess to villages that voted for me with harvests and prayer, and a queen by marriage and by combat, and a mutant the world would not have elected to *anything*. So hear the one thing I know that the kings' row doesn't. The asking is not a moment. It is not the millhouse, the ballots, the charter. The asking is *renewed every time the horn sounds and he comes* — and it is withdrawn the first time he comes when the horn didn't sound. Watch for that, all of you. Watch every chapter of this arc for the night that boy arrives uninvited." Her eyes, white a moment, dimmed to calm. "I don't believe we'll see it. And I have never said that about power before, in my whole life, and I am still deciding how I feel about saying it now."

The steel-grey track pulsed. The screen printed, unhurried:

A KING WHO REFUSES TRIBUTE MUST STILL EAT.

NEXT: WHAT THE DRAGON HUNTS. AND WHAT HE WILL NOT.

The wheel rose into the dark. And at the end of the kings' row, unremarked by almost everyone, the fifth throne — the plain steel one, the unmarked one — was gone, as if it had only ever been a question, and had heard enough tonight to withdraw it. Magneto noticed. Magneto said nothing. But he remained standing a long moment after the lights went down, an old king of a country that had never gotten its millhouse, listening to a horn only he could hear.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Village Election of Issei as Protector* — Rare (a frontier valley of the Underworld, ravaged by Evil Dragon War remnants and ignored by the capitals, votes Issei its protector in a millhouse ballot — unanimous minus the miller's traditional protest vote for a goat; Issei loses the argument to the headwoman's "be the one who answers," accepting "protector" only after striking "lord"); *Governing Through Delegation* — Rare (the charter: an elected council of seven, the schoolteacher as magistrate, public granary accounts, a watch he trains but does not command — and Article One, drafted at his own request, placing the Protector under the law with

no land, no tax, no judgments, and a single office: when the horn sounds, he comes. He refuses the valley's tribute chest three times; final settlement is one dinner per season, first rights to the burnt bits, and an annual scarf).

- **Secrets Revealed:** The machine built five thrones into the theatre for Arc Four — Wakandan, Atlantean, Latverian, Attilan crystal (declined by Black Bolt), and a fifth of plain unmarked steel that no one claimed and that vanished after the chapter; Magneto alone marked its disappearance. Issei's model of rule is now on record: consent-based, delegated, tribute-refusing, self-leashed — the direct answer to Magneto's Chapter 31 question of who granted the "Emperor of Hope" legitimacy: *the governed did*.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** T'Challa embraces Issei's mandate as kin to Warrior Falls — authority lent, publicly and revocably. Namor still scorns reluctant kings ("heroes visit; kings remain") but concedes ground on the horn: the boy came personally, and Namor asks to be re-asked "at twenty years." Doom concedes, formally and before the room, that the valley now functions without Issei — and that nothing Doom has built holds without Doom, reclassifying his own indispensability from "design" to "inventory." Mephisto confirms refused payment is the weather that ruins his business. Magneto grants the beauty of the answer but rules Article One "luck wearing law's coat" — bindable only because Issei chooses to be bound; Xavier counters that all constitutions are promises kept by those strong enough to break them. Storm, the room's only asked-and-crowned protector, delivers the arc's test: consent is renewed every time he comes when called, and withdrawn the first time he arrives uninvited — and stakes, for the first time in her life, her belief that he never will.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Storm's watch-condition now hangs over Arc Four — the theatre will scrutinize every remaining chapter for the night Issei "arrives uninvited." What was the fifth steel throne for, who was it asking, and why did it withdraw after Magneto declined to look at it? Namor's "ask me at twenty years" is an open ledger line. Next pull teased: the dragon's hunting law — *what he hunts, and what he will not* (Chapter 33). *Carried forward, untouched tonight:* the erased child of Chapter 30 and the excision-signature thread (Chs. 20/30); the greyed-out crimson Queen; the "Emperor of Hope" title (Ch. 31) still unexplained by the machine itself.

Chapter Thirty-Three: The Law of the Jungle

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers (Yondu, Rocket, Kraglin, Stakar) • Wakandans (T'Challa, Okoye, M'Baku) • X-Men (Wolverine, Storm) • Midnight Suns (Blade, Elsa Bloodstone, Nico Minoru)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Dragon Philosophy on Hunting vs. Killing" — **Rare**
 2. "Speech to a Monster-Hunting Village" — **Rare**
-

Three chapters into the steel-grey banner, the theatre had still not entirely warmed back up. The gold had gone out of the ceiling on the night of the photograph, and Arc Four had offered iron in its place: a title nobody had explained — *Emperor of Hope* — hung over the corpse of a god-serpent, and then a kingdom that had lined up, of its own free will, and asked a loudmouthed pervert to rule it.

Tonight the wheel came down at the front of the house, over the hunters' rows — and the hunters' rows had grown.

They had been accreting since Chapter Fifteen, the way people who work nights find the same diner, and the diner had annexed the block. Blade at the aisle, sword across his knees. Elsa Bloodstone with her boots on the chair in front of her, a policy position by now. Nico Minoru and the notebook that took its own notes. Frank Castle at the end, with his sightlines. And spreading up the rows like a rumor: Logan, who had drifted down from the X-Men's block after Chapter Thirty-One and simply stayed, Storm a row behind him; the Wakandan delegation, T'Challa flanked by Okoye's spear and M'Baku's opinions; and, sprawled across six seats they had aggressively colonized, the Ravagers — Yondu with his fin catching the screen-light, Kraglin, Rocket perched on a seat back like a gargoyle with a grudge, Stakar Ogord sitting apart the way flag officers do.

"Lotta professionals down front tonight," observed Logan.

"Machine's been seating us," said Blade. "You noticed."

"I noticed."

The wheel spun once, hard, and dropped its token like a shell casing.

PULL ONE: DRAGON PHILOSOPHY ON HUNTING VS. KILLING — RARE.

"Philosophy," said Rocket. "Love it when the loot box assigns homework."

The screen opened on snow.

Mountains, north and nameless, years along the boy's timeline — these were the shoulders of the man from the war chapters, the one the serpent had died in front of. Issei Hyoudou walked a ridgeline with a contract seal glowing on one gauntlet: sanctioned work, posted and paid, the same trade the theatre had learned in a flooded quarry eighteen chapters ago.

The quarry had been the apprenticeship. This was the master's round.

The thing he'd been sent for had killed eleven people in three villages, and the gacha filmed the hunt the way it had filmed the Stray — glimpses, patience, procedure. Track. Confirm. Cut the angles down to one line that touched nothing but the target. The kill took a single Dragon Shot and less than a second, and the thing died mid-lunge, fast, unhumiliated, never played with.

And then the theatre watched the Emperor of Hope stand in the snow beside six hundred kilos of dead man-eater and send a column of red flame skyward, and stand at attention until it went out.

"Still does it," said Elsa Bloodstone, quietly. "All these years on. Every kill."

The second beast arrived twenty minutes later — a young wyvern-thing, ribs showing through its hide, dragging a farmer's sheep over a fence. The contract entitled him to destroy this one too. The theatre watched Issei look at the starving animal, and at the dead sheep, and sigh from his boots.

He did not kill it. He ran it off — one flare of the aura that had ended Apophis, dialed down to *housecat*, *no* — then herded it eleven kilometers to a valley with wild goats and no farms, dropped a haunch of something in front of it, and flew back to overpay the farmer for the sheep out of his own fee, complaining the entire time.

"**You realize,**" said Ddraig, amused, "**the posting entitled you to two kills tonight.**"

"The first one ate people. It knew what it was doing. This one ate a *sheep* because it's a dumb hungry teenager in a bad winter. Not the same animal." He landed on the ridge and looked back at the valley. "Ddraig. When you were free — big — eating whatever you wanted. Did you ever feel bad about it?"

A silence with ten thousand years in it.

"**No,**" said the dragon at last. "**And yes. Attend, and I will give you the oldest law I know. Everything alive is eating something. The hawk is not evil; the wolf pack is not a war crime. The jungle has one law and the law is hunger, and there is no cruelty anywhere in it — hunger kills as fast as it can, because slow is expensive. Cruelty had to be invented. It takes a *person* to kill slow on**

purpose. It takes a person to kill what he does not need, for the pleasure of the fear, or the story, or the skull on the wall. No true animal has ever done it. That is the one sin the jungle never taught."

"So the line's not killing," Issei said slowly, working it the way the theatre had watched him work everything since Chapter One — badly, doggedly, all the way to the end. "Everybody draws it at killing, and that's the wrong place. Killing's the jungle. The line is *why*. If you kill because you have to — to eat, to protect the people behind you — and you do it fast, and you don't enjoy the hurting part, and you carry it after: that's clean. That's just being an animal, and animals are innocent. But if you kill because it makes you feel big — for a trophy, for a wall, to watch something be afraid of you — that's not hunting. That's cruelty wearing hunting's clothes. And it's the only killing that's actually evil, and it's the one kind no animal ever does. Just us."

"Just persons," agreed Ddraig. **"Dragons included. You burn your kills skyward because the fire says: you were not a trophy. You were hunger meeting hunger, and I will remember you. Keep the rite, partner. The day a hunter stops paying for his kills, he starts collecting them."**

The screen dimmed to argument-light.

"Okay," said Rocket, with none of his usual velocity. "So the dragon and the idiot just casually solved a thing I've been chewing on my whole life, and I *hate* that." His voice came out flat and wrong. "You know what a trophy is, from the wall's point of view? I do. I was somebody's project. There ain't a lot of daylight between a trophy wall and a lab shelf — both of 'em are some person lookin' at somethin' alive and seein' proof of how big *they* are. Hunger woulda been kinder. Hunger woulda been *over*."

Yondu didn't laugh, which by itself quieted three rows. "Where I come out of," he said, "law of the jungle meant biggest eats first. Kree taught me that with a chain on. Kid's version's got an extra rule welded in — biggest one keeps *watch* instead." He tipped his fin at the screen. "Eleven clicks in the snow to relocate a lizard he was legally paid to shoot. Ain't decided if that's the dumbest or the richest thing I ever seen."

"Both," said Stakar Ogord. "That's usually how codes work."

Logan stood next, and Logan standing carried the same weight down front that Blade standing did.

"I'll translate for the rows that don't do this," he said. "You heard the dragon: cruelty had to be invented. Well, I've met the inventors. I've been the animal on both ends of the hunt — the thing in the woods and the thing they sent into the woods — and I'll tell you the exact width of the line the kid just drew. Me and Sabretooth got the same claws. Same nose, same teeth, same jungle. Different *why*. That's the entire

distance between us, and some nights it ain't wide, and the kid's speech is the fence I've walked my whole life without the words for it." He sat back down. "Kid found the words at seventeen. Took me a hundred years and a lot of buried friends."

"There is no wickedness anywhere in nature," said Storm, who never needed to raise her voice. "I was worshipped once as a goddess of the rains. I have watched lions kill and I have watched poachers kill, and only one of them ever left the head and took nothing else."

Which was when the mezzanine cleared its throat.

"At last," said Kraven the Hunter, rising out of the villains' dark like something surfacing, "a *civilized* evening. You misunderstand the boy, and you misunderstand me. I have never taken an unworthy trophy — the helicopter men, the poison men, vermin, I despise them as he does. The hunt is a contest of worth, the oldest sacrament, the proving of oneself against the great prey. The boy honors his kills and so do I." He spread his hands. "I claim kinship."

"Denied," said Logan, without turning around. "You said it yourself, bub. *Proving of oneself*. Every altar you ever built, you're the god on it. The kid runs sheep-math in a snowstorm so a farmer's kids eat, and the fire he burns ain't about him — you heard the dragon, it's a receipt. You hunt to be the apex." One claw slid out, lazily, and back in. "He hunts so nobody has to know there was ever anything to be apex of. Ain't the same church. It ain't even the same species of prayer."

Kraven stood very still for a moment, and sat back down without conceding — but he stayed leaned forward for the rest of the night, elbows on knees, like a man at a trial that had turned out to be his.

PULL TWO: SPEECH TO A MONSTER-HUNTING VILLAGE — RARE.

The village's name rendered as Harrow's Gate, and it had survived four hundred years on the edge of a cursed forest by killing what came out of it. It was, the theatre understood within seconds, a town-sized version of the front rows: watchtowers, bell-lines, a hunters' lodge older than most nations, and a long outer wall of skulls.

Issei had been invited — the region's sanctioned protector since the war — to bless their autumn festival. The elders, the roll of the dead read aloud, four centuries of names; his face through all of it was the theatre's favorite face, the open one. These were his people.

Then they showed him the new wing of the lodge, and the face closed.

The old skulls each bore a name-plate and a death it had answered for. The new wing was *décor* — a generation of prosperous young hunters, raised safe behind walls the war had made secure, going into a quieted forest and bringing back heads for status. A denning mother-beast that had threatened no one,

taken with her young for a first-kill rite. Small harmless things killed for the plumage. Trophies of nothing, answering for nothing.

The village waited for the blessing. Issei stood before the wall of skulls for a long, terrible moment, and gave them something else.

"Your grandmothers' wall is holy," he said, "and this one is garbage, and I'm going to tell you the difference, because your grandmothers aren't here to."

He did not shame their history — he honored it, name by name, four hundred years of standing between the forest and the children: *that was the jungle's law, and you kept it, and it kept you*. Then he drew the line where a dragon had taught him to draw it. "Hunting fed you. Hunting guarded you. Hunting is what the strong owe the weak, and it's clean — as long as the kill is for the *walls*." He pointed at the old wing, then the new. "The moment it's for the *wall*, you're not hunters anymore. You're the thing your grandmothers built this town to stop, with better manners. That mother wasn't your enemy. She was your neighbor, and you killed her for a story, and nothing in that whole cursed forest has ever done anything that low. Cruelty isn't the jungle. Cruelty is what people bring *into* the jungle." He let it stand. Then, quieter: "Keep hunting. I'll train your watch myself — things will come out of that forest again someday, and I want this town standing. But from tonight: you kill what threatens you, you kill it fast, you use what you kill or you burn it skyward and you *remember it* — and the new wall comes down. Not because I said so. Because you're hunters, and hunters don't keep garbage."

The village took the wall down that night. The vision ended on a whole town at attention around a column of flame, learning a rite older than every nation watching, and Issei with his hand on a young trophy-taker's shoulder, teaching him where to look.

"There it is," said Blade, and stood, sword-point grounded like a chairman's gavel. "The pull I've been waiting thirty-three chapters for. Everybody down front carries a code, and mine's kept me on the right side of a hunger for a long lifetime, so believe me on one thing: a code you only keep when it's easy is a costume. That kid walked into a room full of people who love him, holding a festival in his honor, and told them their new wall was garbage — and *then* offered to train their watch, because the code isn't there to make him feel clean, it's there to keep the town alive. A code you enforce on your own side, at your own cost, when nobody's making you?" He sat back down. "That gear holds. I'd work with him tonight."

"The Jabari," announced M'Baku, in the voice he used for pronouncements the whole theatre deserved, "apologize to the prey. We thank it, we waste nothing, and we mock anyone who mounts heads — which is to say we mock the lowlanders *constantly*. The dragon would make a passable Jabari. That is the highest review I have issued in thirty-three chapters."

"My country's power began with a hunt," said T'Challa, more seriously. "The goddess, the herb, the first Black Panther — and the first law Bast gave was not *be strong*. It was *the strength is for them*. Every colonizer who came for Wakanda came with trophies of my continent on his walls; I know which side of the boy's line those men lived on. He has re-derived, alone on a ridge, what my nation took a goddess and ten thousand years to codify: predation with stewardship is guardianship. Predation without it is appetite with a flag."

"The spear is for the people behind you," said Okoye. "He holds it correctly. That is the entire review."

Frank Castle had been silent through all of it, and the front rows knew what that silence was for.

"Say it, Frank," said Blade.

"*Respect your prey* is a bedtime story," said Frank, flatly, aiming the words at the screen like he was zeroing them. "The man-eater didn't feel honored. Dead things don't have a point of view — that's what dead means. Skip the funeral and the target's exactly as neutralized. All that ritual is sentiment, and here's the operational problem with sentiment: the day the prayer makes you slow — the day you're lining up on something about to eat a kid and part of you is already composing the eulogy — that's the day the eulogy's for the kid. Respect the living. The dead don't file complaints."

"You're wrong," said Elsa Bloodstone, boots coming off the chair, "and you're wrong in a way I can *document*, because my father agreed with you. Ulysses Bloodstone: no rites, no last words, mouths are for trophies, sentiment gets you killed. Maximum efficiency, thirty years, never slowed down once. And I've read every journal he left, and I watched what he was at the end, and I'm telling you the rites aren't for the prey, Frank — they never were. They're maintenance. On the *weapon*. The fire is how the kid checks, every single kill, that he still knows the difference between a receipt and a collection. Skip it for thirty years and you get my father's wall. And then you get my father."

Frank thought about that the way he did, like an argument was a structure to clear room by room.

"Maintenance, I'll allow," he said at last. "Calibration, I'll allow — I gave the Gremory girl's last-words rule that much, and I'll extend it to the fire. But I'm keeping the asterisk, and this arc's coming for it fast: it's easy to respect your prey when your prey has claws. His whole pretty code got built on monsters that look like monsters." He nodded once at the dark screen. "Chapter Fifteen, I said one day the thing eating kids would have a pulse and a face and paperwork, and I'd want to see that chapter. Machine's been listening since Thirteen." He settled back. "So roll it."

The machine, which had indeed been listening, rolled it.

The lights had barely begun their dim when the screen flickered up its parting gift: a starfield, a station, a docking manifest scrolling in cold system font — weights, lots, cage dimensions — and over a hold full of small frightened faces, a single stamped word: **LIVESTOCK.**

The Ravager rows came out of their seats as one body. Yondu was standing with his arrow floating an inch off his hip, fin blazing, and nobody down front said one word about sentiment.

NEXT: THE SLAVE MARKET.

"Jungle's got one law," said Rocket, very quietly, into the dark. "That ain't it."

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Dragon Philosophy on Hunting vs. Killing* — Rare (an adult-era sanctioned hunt: a man-eater killed in under a second and burned skyward; a starving juvenile wyvern spared and relocated, its stolen sheep paid for from Issei's own fee; Ddraig's "oldest law" dialogue on the ridge). *Speech to a Monster-Hunting Village* — Rare (Harrow's Gate: Issei honors four centuries of necessary hunting, condemns the new trophy wing, and the village burns it down and adopts the skyward rite; he pledges to train their watch personally).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's hunting code, in his own words: the moral line is not killing but *why* — killing from necessity (food, protection), done fast, without savoring the hurt, and carried afterward is "the jungle" and clean; killing for trophies, fear, or feeling big is "cruelty wearing hunting's clothes," the one evil no animal commits — "just persons." Ddraig's doctrine beneath it: hunger is innocent, cruelty had to be invented, and the skyward fire is a receipt, not a trophy — "the day a hunter stops paying for his kills, he starts collecting them." Confirmed: Issei has performed the dragon funeral rite for every kill since the quarry (Ch. 15), war years included, and now teaches it to others.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Blade issues his strongest endorsement of the run ("that gear holds — I'd work with him tonight"): a code enforced on your own side, at your own cost, is the only kind that matters. Wolverine names Issei's line as the exact fence between himself and Sabretooth ("same claws... different *why*") and has permanently joined the hunters' rows. Kraven claimed kinship with Issei's code and was formally *denied* by Logan ("he hunts so nobody has to know there was ever anything to be apex of"); Kraven did not concede, but now studies Issei like a man at his own trial. M'Baku rates the dragon "a passable Jabari"; T'Challa maps the code onto Bast's founding law ("the strength is for them"); Okoye: "He holds the spear correctly." Rocket, raw, equates trophy walls with lab shelves; Yondu reads Issei's jungle law as "biggest one keeps watch instead." Punisher holds that "respect your prey" is naive sentiment and operationally dangerous, but formally allows Elsa's counter that the rites are *maintenance on the weapon* — with Ulysses Bloodstone cited as what thirty rite-free years becomes — while keeping his standing asterisk.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Frank's asterisk comes due immediately: the screen teased a slave-market manifest stamping children as **LIVESTOCK** — Issei hunting things with a pulse, a face, and

paperwork. The Ravagers (many former slaves; Yondu on his feet, arrow live) are primed to react hardest; watch whether the "kill fast, pay for it after" code survives contact with slavers he does not spare. Kraven's denied kinship claim is open. Harrow's Gate stands as a seeded ally — a trained monster-hunting village that owes Issei its watch and its rite. Carried forward: the erased child, the excision-signature thread (Chs. 20/30), and the machine's deliberate seating of the theatre's hunters and warriors into one bloc — it is building something out of them.

Chapter Thirty-Four: The Slave Market

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers & Cosmic Pirates (Yondu, Stakar, Kraglin, Rocket, Gamora, Nebula) • Wakanda (T'Challa, Nakia, Okoye, M'Baku) • Governments (Fury, Ross) • The Antihero Row

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Raid on a Slave Market" — **Epic**
 2. "Children Freed" — **Mythic**
-

Four nights into the steel-grey banner, the theatre had learned that Arc Four did not ask *how strong is he*. It asked *what does he do with it* — a crown he never wanted, a hunting law kept like scripture — and the room had settled into the rhythm of a seminar. Kings argued with kings. It was almost civilized.

Then the wheel came down running red at the seams, and the Ravager tiers — thirty-three chapters of heckling from the cheap seats — went quiet before the pull even landed. Later, nobody could say how they'd known. Kraglin said you could smell it. Yondu didn't say anything at all.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"RAID ON A SLAVE MARKET" — RARITY: EPIC.

"Hnh," said Rocket, in the tone of a raccoon getting his feet up on the seatback and absolutely not gripping the armrest. "Epic. Sure. Roll it."

The theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

Under-market. Neutral ground, in the way a knife is neutral — a cavern warded against every treaty ever signed, lit the color of old coins. Cages in tiers, like the theatre's own seating, and the theatre felt that comparison arrive in several thousand minds at once and hated it.

The merchandise was catalogued in chalk. Youkai, half-bloods, Sacred Gear carriers taken young enough to train. Lot numbers. An auctioneer's dais. Collars that drank aura, sized in rows on a rack, and some of the sizes were very small.

The vision gave the audience one full minute of the market operating normally — bidding paddles, a broker's laugh, a fox-eared boy in lot forty-one pressing his face to the bars to watch for his mother, three cages over and unable to reach him — and the theatre understood the minute was not scene-

setting. It was the machine entering evidence.

Then the wards died. All of them, at once, the way a candle dies in a doorway.

Issei Hyoudou walked in through the front entrance, because of course he did, and the theatre knew the walk by now — they'd seen it approach Raynare's church, Kokabiel, every closed door in his life. But the face over it was one they hadn't seen. Not rage. Rage was loud, and they'd have recognized it. This was arithmetic.

[BOOST.]

"Gentlemen," said the auctioneer, professionally, reaching under the dais.

"One question," said Issei Hyoudou. "Who holds the keys?"

Every slaver in the room had the same thought at the same time — it was written on them — *he's one boy, and there are forty of us* — and the theatre, four arcs educated, made the sound of a room watching men step on a rake in unison.

[BOOST. BOOST. BOOST.]

What followed took ninety seconds, and the screen did not linger, and neither did he. That was the part the theatre would argue about all night — not the violence, the *economy* of it. They had watched this boy fight for thirty-three chapters, and he fought the way he lived: loudly, wastefully, taking hits he didn't need to take so someone behind him wouldn't. He checked for surrender the way other men checked their footing.

Not here. Scale Mail closed over him like a verdict, Ascalon came out, and he offered no terms and left none of them alive — the broker with the laugh, the wardsmith who'd made the small collars, the ones who ran and the two who knelt. A guard threw down his weapon and raised his hands, and the theatre leaned forward, because *this* was where Issei Hyoudou always, always stopped.

"You sized the collars," Issei said, and did not stop.

It was fast every time. It was never cruel. It was a door being closed forty times.

"**Partner**," came Ddraig's voice, low, when it was done and the aura settled — and the theatre noticed the dragon had not spoken once during, had not needed to counsel or restrain, had simply *attended*.

"None of the usual sermon tonight?"

"They kept people, Ddraig." He was already moving down the cage rows, armor retracting from his hands so the hands reaching back through the bars would touch skin. "You can come back from almost anything — I keep saying that, right? Everybody keeps score of who I let walk." He tore a cage door off

its hinges, gently, which should not have been possible and was. "There's no *walking back* from selling a kid a collar in his size. That's not a fight. That's a thing you *are*."

"I have lived inside a cage for a very long time," said the Welsh Dragon Emperor, softly, to his partner and to a listening multiverse. **"Sealed in this Gear by a god's hand, passed from wielder to wielder like a lamp. You are the first who ever asked me what I wanted. So understand that I say this as an expert and not a moralist: you have my blessing. Burn it."**

He got the last cage open first. Then he burned it — dragon-fire, floor to vault, thorough as an audit, chalk and ledger and the rack of collars going up while he stood in the entrance with a child on each arm, and the vision held on the fire until it wasn't a market anymore. It wasn't anything anymore.

The lights came up on a theatre that had watched him kill before — strays, monsters, Apophis in a war — and had never once watched him kill like *that*, and the first sound was Frank Castle, from the antihero row, exhaling like a man setting down a weight.

"There it is," the Punisher said. "Thirty-four chapters. I knew he had a floor. Everybody's got one."

"That was not a floor, Castle, that was an *execution docket*—" General Ross was on his feet in the government block. "Forty sentient beings, no trial, no authority, no—"

"No survivors to rebuild the network out of," said Nick Fury, not standing. "Be mad, Ross. But I've spent forty years raiding these operations *legally*. You seize the ledger, flip the middlemen, extradite the broker, and eighteen months later the same market's open two systems over with better wards. The market was never the men. It was the demand, and the only thing that touches demand is cost." A pause. "He just repriced the industry. Ask me tomorrow if I'm okay with it, 'cause tonight I don't have a better answer."

"The kneeling one," Daredevil said quietly, from the dark, and the antihero row turned, because Matt Murdock's voice had the sound of a man arguing with himself and losing. "He surrendered. Issei killed him anyway. I've built my whole life on the space between those two seconds."

"He sized the collars," said Jessica Jones, flat as slate, and Matt didn't answer, and that was the street-level tier's whole debate, four words and a silence.

But the theatre's center of gravity had already moved, because up in the Ravager tiers, Yondu Udonta was standing with his hand flat over his fin like a man at an anthem nobody else could hear.

"Say it," said Stakar Ogord.

"Ain't sayin' nothin'."

"Say it, Yondu."

"*Twenty years*," Yondu said, and his voice came out wrong, scraped, the drawl burned off it. "Kree battle slave. Twenty years 'fore you bought me out, an' you know what I 'membered tonight? Not the fightin'. The *chalk*. They wrote my weight on the pen wall in chalk. Little numbers." His hand came down off the fin. "Weren't nobody ever walked into *that* market an' asked who held the keys."

"I did," Stakar said. "I walked into yours."

"You *bought* me out, Stakar. Legal-like. Left the market standin'." Yondu's teeth showed, and it wasn't a grin. "Boy didn't leave the market standin'."

"They *took me apart*," said Rocket, and the tier went still, because Rocket Raccoon did not volunteer, ever, and here he was with his claws dug into the seatback. "Cage, chalk, lot number. Subject Eight-Nine-P-One-Three. Nobody came. I chewed my own way out, an' you wanna know the sick joke? I used to lie in that cage an' make up exactly this guy. Big idiot, kicks the door in, doesn't negotiate, torches the paperwork so they can't restock." He unhooked his claws one at a time. "Kid me owes the screen an apology. Turns out I wasn't makin' him up. I was just early."

"He killed them all," Nebula said, from the row above, in that ruined-machinery voice. "The ones who ran and the ones who knelt. Good. When Thanos took us, whole worlds knelt. Kneeling is what they do *when the strong show up*. It is not repentance. It is inventory." She looked at her sister. "The green one disagrees."

"The green one," Gamora said slowly, "is remembering that we were merchandise that got *adopted* by the buyer, and nobody burned that market either. No. I don't disagree. I'm deciding whether that frightens me." She watched the screen. "It doesn't. That frightens me."

It was Kraglin who asked the actual question — Kraglin, who'd been quiet, whose voice cracked in the middle of it. "Cap'n. Stakar, sir. What he done down there. Is that... does that *count*? As code?"

And the theatre saw Stakar Ogord — Starhawk, a hundred flames' admiral, the man who had exiled his own best captain for trafficking children and grieved him every day of the exile — stand up and take his time.

"Ravagers don't deal in kids," Stakar said. "One law. We're thieves, smugglers, liars, and killers, and we hold *one line*, and I have burned brothers off my flame for crossing it, and it cost me more than any of you know." He didn't look at Yondu. He put his hand on Yondu's shoulder without looking, which was worse, and better. "Every captain in this room's been asking whether the dragon-boy's got a code. You're asking it backwards. Codes are what we *wrote down* because we couldn't trust ourselves to be him. He

steals nothing. He frees the hold. He spaces the slavers. He burns the manifest." Stakar's voice dropped into the register of a man at a colors ceremony. "That's not *like* the code. That's the thing the code is a copy of. Boy's been flying Ravager colors his whole damn life. Nobody told him."

"So we tell him," said Yondu, and whistled — one note, low, and the yaka arrow rose out of its holster and burned a slow crimson circle over the tier, the Ravager salute, the flame they light when one of theirs comes home. Ninety-nine flames of Stakar's fleet stood up in the dark, tier over tier, and matched it.

"He's a *devil*," someone from the government block protested, faintly.

"He's a *Ravager*," said a hundred pirates, in the tone of men correcting a rounding error.

Down in the Wakandan delegation, Nakia had not spoken through any of it. She was watching the replay-echo the screen kept faintly cycling — the fox-eared boy, lot forty-one, watching for his mother — and when she finally spoke it was to her king, and it carried.

"The river camp," she said. "The night you came for me, T'Challa. I was in-country with seventeen women taken for sale and I had a choice between my cover and their chains, and you know what I chose, and you know I have never once filed the paperwork on what happened to the men holding them." She lifted her chin at the screen. "Do not let this room pretend the question is exotic. It is the oldest question our people ever answered. Wakanda watched the ships pass. We hid, and we survived, and the hiding kept us — and every Wakandan child learns both halves of that sentence and is never told which half to be proud of."

"Which is why we do not get to be neutral," T'Challa said quietly. "We built a fortress and called it wisdom while a trade in human beings emptied the coast beyond our border. My father's fathers made that choice a thousand times, and I have stood in the place where the ancestors live and asked them if it was right, and they did not answer me either." He watched the fire on the screen. "I have killed for Wakanda. I have spared for Wakanda. I do not know if the boy's arithmetic is just. I know that if the ancestors ever show me a market like that one, I hope I have his nerve, and I notice that I did not say his restraint."

"He has no vibranium, no army, no border," Okoye said. "And no one will ever again be sold in that cavern. My general's opinion is brief."

"The man-ape tier concurs," rumbled M'Baku, with no comedy in it at all. "The Jabari kept apart from everything, even Wakanda. Apart is a kind of safe. Tonight I find I do not admire *apart* very much."

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2, said the screen, before anyone could recover.

"CHILDREN FREED" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

Dawn, above ground, on a hillside gone silver with frost. Thirty-one children and nineteen adults who had been lot numbers an hour ago, wrapped in whatever Issei had been able to tear loose from the market's stores before the fire, and the boy himself — armor gone, jacket gone, jacket being currently worn by three children at once as a tent — kneeling in the grass with his gauntleted hand out flat.

[TRANSFER.]

Warmth moved through the crowd like sunrise given a schedule — boosted power, the theatre realized, the doubling engine that had erased mountains, stepped down and poured out as *heat*, into small shaking bodies, because that was a thing you could apparently do with the fires of the Red Dragon Emperor if it never once occurred to you that they were only for war.

The fox-eared boy from lot forty-one stood apart, at the exact distance of a child who has learned what adults are for. His mother was free three steps away and he was watching Issei instead, because his arithmetic was newer and worse.

"Are you going to sell us too?" he asked.

The theatre did not breathe. Issei Hyoudou sat down in the frost — sat, so he'd be shorter than the boy — and thought about it honestly, visibly, the way the room had watched him fail math tests. "No," he said. "I'm the guy they tell scary stories about at slaver bedtime. It's a good job. Dental's weird." And then, when the joke didn't land, because it wasn't meant to, and the boy just kept watching him: "Nobody's going to hold you again unless you run to them. That's the whole rule. That one's forever."

The boy ran to his mother. Then — the vision held it, gently — he came back, and stood beside Issei, not touching, and after a moment took hold of one crimson finger of the gauntlet with his entire fist, in the manner of a small child claiming a very large object, and the Red Dragon Emperor sat perfectly still in the frost, the way you do when something wild decides you're safe.

And the machine did the thing the theatre would carry out of the room that night. As the Gremory circles bloomed on the hillside — Rias, Asia's healing light, Kiba with blankets, Yasaka's escort come down from Kyoto for the youkai young — the screen began printing names. Every child, one at a time, white letters, unhurried. *Renji, son of Chiyo, of the Kyoto fox clans. Mirra, Sacred Gear carrier, aged seven.* Thirty-one names, fifty in all, a census of the recovered, and it did not stop until every single soul on that hillside had been entered into the record.

In the front row, eight women sat very close together, and did not say the thing they were all thinking, about a photograph, about a child the record refused. Koneko's jaw was set. Asia's eyes shone. The machine named the fiftieth freed soul, held the full list on screen for a long, deliberate moment — *see*

how easy it is, the display seemed to say, *when nothing has gotten there first* — and went dark.

"**Nest law**," said Ddraig, into the theatre's silence, to the children on the screen and the pirates in the tiers and possibly to something beyond both. "**Nothing kept in a cage while the dragon draws breath. He did not learn it from me. I checked.**"

NEXT PULL, printed the screen, small and cold, over the dying image of the hillside. **HE SHOWED YOU THE LINE. NEXT: WHAT LIVES ON THE OTHER SIDE OF IT. A TYRANT WILL KNEEL. HE WILL NOT DIE.**

"Now hold on," said Frank Castle.

The lights went down on a hundred Ravager flames still burning crimson in the dark, holding the salute all the way to black.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Raid on a Slave Market* — Epic (Issei single-handedly destroys an underworld auction of youkai, half-bloods, and Sacred Gear children: kills all forty slavers — including two who surrendered — frees every captive, burns the market and its records to nothing); *Children Freed* — Mythic (the dawn hillside: Boost stepped down through Transfer as warmth for fifty freed souls, the lot-41 fox boy claiming Issei's gauntlet finger, and the machine printing every freed child's name into the record, one by one).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's absolute moral line, confirmed on-screen: enslavement is the one crime he treats as unforgivable — the room that has watched him pardon Raynare's kind, Riser, and Vali watched him refuse surrender for the first time ("You sized the collars"). His kills are economical, never cruel, and total — Fury reads it as deliberately repricing an industry, not rage. Ddraig revealed the depth of his own captivity — sealed into the Boosted Gear by a god, passed between wielders "like a lamp," with Issei the first to ask what *he* wanted — and formally blessed the burning. Transfer can convert boosted war-output into life-sustaining warmth.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: The Ravagers claim him.** Stakar rules that Issei isn't *following* the code — he's "the thing the code is a copy of" — and a hundred flames stand to give the crimson-arrow salute; Yondu (twenty years a Kree slave — "they wrote my weight in chalk"), Kraglin, Rocket ("I used to lie in that cage and make up exactly this guy"), and Nebula all break personal ground; Gamora is unafraid of him and frightened *by* that. Wakanda aligns: Nakia and T'Challa name their nation's oldest wound — surviving by watching the ships pass — and T'Challa hopes for Issei's nerve, "and I notice I did not say his restraint"; Okoye and M'Baku concur. Governments split: Fury pragmatically defers judgment, General Ross condemns the extrajudicial killings. Antihero row:

Castle vindicated ("everybody's got a floor"); Daredevil genuinely shaken by the killing of the surrendered guard; Jessica Jones ends the debate in four words.

- **Unresolved Hooks:** The screen's direct tease for the next pull: "**A TYRANT WILL KNEEL. HE WILL NOT DIE**" — after tonight, the room (Castle loudest) demands to know how the boy who executes kneeling slavers can spare a kneeling tyrant; his mercy/no-mercy boundary is now the arc's central argument. The machine's pointed fifty-name census read as a message — *this is what an intact record looks like* — sharpening the Erased Child mystery by contrast (the fiancées noticed; seed only, do not resolve). *Carried forward:* the erased child and the excision signature (Chs. 20/30), the greyed-out crimson Queen, and the Ravagers' standing claim on Issei — expect them to defend "one of ours" in every debate from here on.

Chapter Thirty-Five: The Tyrant He Spared

Primary Reaction Groups: Punisher • Daredevil • Winter Soldier • Villains (Doom, Magneto, Mephisto, Loki) • Heroes (Captain America, T'Challa, Spider-Family)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Issei Spares a Defeated Ruler" — **Rare**
 2. "Later Consequences" — **Secret**
-

The steel-grey banner of Arc Four had a sound to it, the theatre had learned. Not music — a low hum with weight in the bass, like a fleet holding station somewhere overhead. Five chapters in, the room had adjusted to it the way soldiers adjust to artillery in the next valley: you stopped hearing it, and it never stopped shaping your posture.

Nobody had adjusted to last chapter.

The slave market still hung in the air the way smoke hangs in a burned house. The theatre had watched Issei Hyoudou kill — not the reluctant, cornered killing of a war, but deliberate, methodical, room by room, and the front rows had spent the intermission arguing about whether they were relieved or frightened that they hadn't objected. Frank Castle had said eleven words all chapter — "*about time*" — and gone back to his silence with something that in another man would have been called peace.

The gacha wheel descended into that unease like a coin into a well.

"Watch," said Matt Murdock, quietly, to no one in particular. He had his fingers laced, elbows on knees, head tipped toward a screen he couldn't see and read better than anyone in the building. "It's been teaching in pairs all arc. Hunting, then slaughter. The crown offered, then the crown refused. It just showed us what he kills." The wheel ticked, slowing. "Now it shows us what he doesn't."

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"ISSEI SPARES A DEFEATED RULER" — RARITY: RARE.

"Rare," said Frank Castle, flat, from the shadow of the back rows. "It's rare. The machine agrees with me."

"The machine counts frequency, Frank," Murdock said. "Not error."

And the theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

The Underworld, after the war. The vision supplied the context the way it always did, in weight rather than words: the Evil Dragon War over, the maps redrawn, whole devil territories orphaned — and into one such frontier, a warlord.

Duke Vephar, the name arrived. *Last lord of an extinct pillar house*. An old-blood devil with a museum of a face, handsome the way ruins are handsome, who had spent the war's chaos assembling an army of the desperate and the leftover, and had spent the peace grinding a frontier province under it. The vision did not flinch from his ledger: villages taxed in conscripts, a generation of low-born devils and stray youkai worked in his forges, dissenters delivered to his Left Hand — a scarred, smiling general named **Skaldun**, who kept order the way frost keeps a garden.

"Petty," said Doctor Doom, from the villains' dark, with genuine contempt. "A scavenger wearing a crown he found."

"Most crowns are found," Magneto said. "Look at the *people*, Victor."

The theatre looked, because the vision made them: thin faces at shutters, watching the sky. Waiting. And then the sky obliged, and the crimson came down into Vephar's fortress court like a verdict — armored, wings out, the green gem blazing, the voice out of the gauntlet rolling across the parade ground in a register that made the theatre's bones hum:

[BOOST.]

The fight lasted long enough to be humiliating and not one second longer. Vephar was old-blood strong — castle-cracking strong, the kind of strength that had gone unquestioned in a lawless province for years — and the vision let the theatre feel exactly how far that was beneath the thing that had killed Apophis. Issei took the Duke's best flame across the armor without breaking stride, put him through his own gatehouse, caught him by the collar out of the rubble, and held him up one-handed while the tyrant's army stood in the ash of its own morale and, one dropped spear at a time, declined to participate.

"Finish it," Frank Castle said, in the theatre, to a screen that had never once taken requests.

The gem flared. The gauntleted fist drew back.

And Duke Vephar — bleeding, beaten, dangling — did the one thing no one in the vision or the seats had budgeted for.

He stopped fighting. All at once, completely, the way a rope stops when it's cut. "The children in the forges," he said, through broken teeth, and his voice cracked on it — not on the pain, the theatre could hear that it wasn't the pain. "Third sub-level. The vent seals are mine, keyed to my blood. If you kill me armed the failsafes fire. Take my hand to the door *first*, Red Dragon. Then do what you like with the rest of me. It'll be — " he laughed, horribly, at himself, " — it'll be fair."

Silence in the court. Silence in the theatre.

"Ambush," said someone in the middle rows. "It's an ambush, don't—"

"It's not." Koneko Toujou's voice, small and flat, from the front row — and on screen her counterpart said the same, walking out of the crimson escort with her ears flat and her senjutsu open, reading the life-current of the broken devil the way the theatre had learned in Chapter Thirty that her kind could not be lied to. On screen and in the seats, a beat apart, the same verdict: "He means it. All of it. It's ugly in there. But it's *real*."

The vision compressed what followed — the forges opened, the vent seals dead, thin-faced children carried up into daylight in the arms of the Duke's own surrendering soldiers — and then it slowed again, deliberately, for the moment the pull was named for.

Vephar on his knees in the ash. Not performing it. The theatre had seen ten thousand villains kneel and knew all the choreographies of counterfeit surrender, and this had none of them; this was a man who had walked to the end of himself and found the view unbearable. "I know what I built," he said. "I told myself it was order. It was fear with paperwork. Kill me and you'll be right to."

The helmet folded back. Seventeen — no, older now, the theatre corrected itself; the war-years had done their work — but the face was still the face that had never played poker, and it was doing arithmetic in plain sight. The room watched him look at the kneeling tyrant, and at the freed children, and at the army of conscripts who were somebody's children too, and the tide of his heart ran audible underneath it the way it always did: *Raynare never once meant it. Riser didn't mean it for a year, and then he did. Kuroka meant it the whole time and nobody checked. Cao Cao put a spear through people I love and he's out there right now being worth the second chance. Koneko says this one means it. So the question isn't him, is it? It's never actually him. It's what I'm for.*

"Get up," Issei Hyoudou said. "You don't get to die. Dying's the exit. You're going to stand in what you did until it's fixed — the forges become schools, your treasury becomes their treasury, and you work it with your own hands under Sona's auditors until the last kid you starved says you're done. You get watched every day for the rest of your long, long life." A beat. "And if Koneko ever reads you and it's gone rotten again — I won't come back angry. I'll just come back."

The Duke wept into the ash. The army knelt — to the Duke's conqueror, not the Duke. And the vision's last frame held on General Skaldun, the Left Hand, standing unbound at the edge of the surrender with the amnestied officers, scarred face arranged into perfect compliance, eyes arranged into nothing at all.

The theatre released them.

"No."

Frank Castle was on his feet, and the rows around him went quiet, because Castle standing was rarer than the pull. "No. You all felt good just now. I felt it, the whole room went warm, kid spares the crying man, music swells. So somebody's got to say it plain." He pointed at the dark screen. "That man ran forges full of children. The crying doesn't unbuild the forges. Repentance is a *feeling* — I've sat across from repentance with a gun on the table, and I'm telling you it's the cheapest thing a guilty man produces, he makes it by the *yard*. You know what has never once reoffended? A body." He sat back down, unhurried. "The kid didn't grant mercy. He signed a loan. Somebody else pays it back later. Somebody always does. Write the ledger however you want — I've read the last page."

"You've read *your* last pages." Matt Murdock stood into the quiet — the lawyer's stand, deliberate, giving the room time to object. "Frank, I'm not going to pretend your file's empty. Some men who cry on their knees get up and reoffend, and their next victims are real, and I've buried some of them, and you know I have. Here's what else is real: the cat-girl can't be lied to. Take that seriously — it breaks your whole model. You built your ledger in a world where remorse can't be verified, so you price it at zero. He lives in a world where it *can*, and he checked, and it was real, and he still didn't just walk away — he built a *sentence*. Restitution. Supervision. Consequences with teeth. That's not softness, that's more law than most courts I've stood in." He turned toward the screen. "You want to know the difference between a punishment and a mercy? A punishment ends. What he handed that man doesn't end until the last victim says so. God, I've argued cases for less justice than that."

"You're both lawyering past it." The voice came from a seat between the two camps, where it had sat all arc — quiet, left arm dull silver in the screen-light. Bucky Barnes didn't stand. He didn't need to; the whole theatre had already turned. "Frank. Matt. You're arguing about *him*, whether the tyrant's sincere, whether remorse can be banked. I was sincere." Flat. Unhurried. "The day they pulled me out of the programming I'd have passed the cat-girl's reading. Meant every word of my sorry. And Steve spared me, and Steve was right, and I have spent every day since being *worth* it — and none of that, not one day of it, un-fires a single shot. Both things. That's the part nobody in this room wants to hold at once." He looked at the frozen screen. "So the kid's right to spare him. And Frank's right that somebody pays. It's just usually not the man you spared who collects. Watch the general."

"*Thank* you," said Frank.

"That wasn't for you," said Bucky.

Across the theatre, the argument caught like grass fire. Steve Rogers backed the mercy and named its price without blinking — "You hold the line even when it costs; the day you only spare people when it's free, it isn't a line, it's a mood." T'Challa, quietly, from the Wakandan rows: "I let Zemo live. I have never been certain, and I have never been sorry. Kings do not get to be certain." Spider-Man said "he checked on the kids *first*, before he even decided — can we — did everybody clock that? That's the whole guy," and Miles nodded so hard his hood fell back.

And in the villains' dark, the reading was colder and stranger. Doom pronounced the sentence "correct statecraft — a dead duke is a martyr and a vacancy; a leashed duke is an *instrument*," and seemed almost offended that a boy had found the move. Loki noted aloud, silkily, that forgiveness this reliable was itself a weapon — "build a reputation for sparing the sincere and your enemies will spend their strength *becoming sincere*; the boy is farming converts and doesn't know it" — and could not quite keep the admiration out of the analysis. Magneto said nothing for a long time, and then, to Charles, too low for the rows: "I have knelt in ash. No one offered me schools." Mephisto alone laughed, softly, delightedly, and wrote nothing down. "The general," he said, to anyone listening. "Oh, the room is debating the *duke*. Bless."

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel didn't spin so much as drop, straight through the colors to a segment the theatre had learned to dread — matte black, unlabeled.

"LATER CONSEQUENCES" — RARITY: SECRET.

It was not a vision. It was a ledger — pages turning against a black field, dated years ahead, clinical as an audit.

Year one: the forges cold, the first school open, Duke Vephar hauling roof-beams with his own hands, auditors' reports stamped in Sitri violet: COMPLIANT. *Year three:* a plague-spring on the frontier; the Duke empties what remains of his treasury on medicine without being ordered to; a thin-faced girl from the third sub-level, older now, is recorded voluntarily speaking to him. Sixty-one lives credited. COMPLIANT. *Year five:* the province petitions — *petitions* — to keep him on as reconstruction steward. The audit's marginal note, in dry Sitri clerk-hand: *reform assessed genuine; recommend the Red Dragon Emperor be informed he was right.*

"Well," said Matt Murdock softly.

The page turned.

Amnesty roll, year one, the ledger printed. *Officers processed: 214. Officers accounted for, year five: 213.*

The black field held on a single personnel record. Scarred face. Perfect compliance. Eyes arranged into nothing. **SKALDUN — LEFT HAND OF VEPHAR. STATUS: UNACCOUNTED.** Beneath it, sightings, sparse and spreading like the first cracks in ice: a burned watch-post here, a missing arms shipment there, remnant soldiers of the old army leaving their farms in the night, one by one, going

somewhere. The last entry was not a sighting at all. It was a message, left carved on the door of the first school, in old military cipher, addressed to no one and legible to the theatre because the machine chose to make it so:

THE DUKE KNELT. I DID NOT.

THIS ACCOUNT REMAINS OPEN, printed the screen, and closed the ledger, and said nothing else.

The theatre sat with it.

"Say it," Frank Castle said finally, into the dark, without triumph — and that was the thing the room would remember, that there was no triumph in it at all, only the tiredness of a man handed one more page for the file. "Somebody pays. Somebody always pays."

"The duke *reformed*, Frank. Sixty-one lives. The mercy worked."

"Both," said Bucky Barnes, before it could become a rally. "It's both. It's going to keep being both. That's the sentence we just got handed — we don't get to know. He didn't either, and he chose anyway. That's the whole job."

Above them, the screen flickered once — almost gently — and put up a single line where the wheel usually hung, in the manner of a court posting tomorrow's docket:

NEXT PULL PENDING: THERE WAS ANOTHER TYRANT. THERE WAS ANOTHER ANSWER.

Frank Castle went very still. Matt Murdock's head came up. And several thousand heroes, monsters, gods, and killers realized at the same moment that the machine had shown them the mercy first for a reason — and that whatever tomorrow's pull held, the boy who could not be corrupted had, at least once, decided that repentance was not on the table.

The lights went down on a theatre arguing in whispers about a general no one could find.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Issei Spares a Defeated Ruler* — Rare (post-war Underworld frontier: Issei defeats the warlord **Duke Vephar**, last lord of an extinct pillar house; Vephar's repentance is verified genuine by Koneko's senjutsu; Issei spares him and imposes a restitution sentence — forges become schools, treasury to the victims, lifelong Sitri-audited supervision); *Later Consequences* — Secret (a black-ledger audit of the years after: the mercy verified, and its open account).

- **Secrets Revealed:** In DxD's world, remorse is *verifiable* — senjutsu cannot be fooled about intent, which reframes the entire mercy debate (Murdock's key point against Castle's "repentance prices at zero"). Issei's internal calculus on sparing enemies runs through precedent: Raynare (never sincere), Riser (became sincere), Kuroka (always sincere, never checked), Cao Cao (worth the second chance) — "it's never actually him; it's what I'm for." The Secret pull confirmed BOTH sides partly right: Vephar's reform is genuine (year-five audit: schools built, plague relief, 61 lives credited, province petitions to keep him) — but his general, **Skaldun the Left Hand**, exploited the amnesty, vanished (213 of 214 officers accounted for), and is gathering the old army's remnants; his carved message: "THE DUKE KNELT. I DID NOT." The machine closed on "**THIS ACCOUNT REMAINS OPEN.**"
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Punisher and Daredevil stake out the arc's central moral axis — Castle: mercy is "a loan somebody else repays"; Murdock: a supervised restitution sentence is "more law than most courts" — and the Secret pull hands each a half-vindication, deliberately unscored. **Bucky Barnes emerges as the theatre's living referee on redemption** ("I was sincere; Steve was right to spare me; and none of it un-fires a shot — both things"), and he called "watch the general" *before* the reveal. Steve and T'Challa (citing Zemo) back principled mercy with open eyes; Spider-family notes Issei secured the imprisoned children before deciding anything. Villains' reads: Doom scores the sparing as superior statecraft (a leashed duke over a martyr); Loki identifies Issei's reliable forgiveness as an accidental weapon that "farms converts"; Magneto is privately wounded ("No one offered me schools"); Mephisto flagged the general while the room debated the duke.
- **Unresolved Hooks: GENERAL SKALDUN — at large, recruiting, unresolved by design; do not settle whether Castle or Murdock "was right," ever — the ambiguity is the asset.** The screen's closing docket teases the pair-chapter: "**THERE WAS ANOTHER TYRANT. THERE WAS ANOTHER ANSWER**" — Chapter 36 shows the tyrant Issei did NOT spare, defining his absolute boundary. *Carried forward:* the erased child / excision-signature mystery (Chs. 20, 30) still hangs over the arc; the greyed-out crimson Queen still waits (pays off Ch. 40); Arc Four's steel-grey banner continues its paired-lesson structure (what he kills / what he spares).

Chapter Thirty-Six: The Tyrant He Did Not Spare

Primary Reaction Groups: Punisher • Daredevil • Winter Soldier • Villains • Heroes

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Immediate Execution of a Second Tyrant" — **Rare**
 2. "Funeral for the Slain" — **Secret**
-

The argument from the night before had never actually ended.

It had merely lost its microphone. When the lights had come up on the previous pull — on Vashtar, the Iron Duke, kneeling in the wreck of his own throne room and being *spared*, and on the Secret coda showing the Duke ten years on, grey and diligent, governing the Western March with a penitent's obsessive care while one of his old siege-generals slipped the leash and vanished into the border dark — the theatre had split down an old, old seam, and the seam had kept arguing in the aisles long after the screen went grey.

"He reformed," Matt Murdock had said, four separate times, to four separate people. "You all saw it. The man reformed. Mercy *worked*."

"The general," Frank Castle had answered, every time, in the same voice he used for weather. "Watch the general."

Now the steel-grey band of Arc Four lit along the ceiling, the wheel descended, and Frank Castle — who had not visibly slept, because Frank never visibly slept — leaned forward in the back rows with his forearms on his knees, like a man waiting for a bill he had already calculated to the cent.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel ticked around and stopped on blue.

"IMMEDIATE EXECUTION OF A SECOND TYRANT" — RARITY: RARE.

"Rare," said Sam Wilson, reading it twice. "The machine's got him ending a king filed two tiers under *breakfast*."

"That is not a comment on the king," said Doom, from his aisle. "It is a comment on how often the boy is asked to choose. Attend."

The theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

The Ash March, the vision named it. A border territory in the Underworld's frontier dark, orphaned by the war, and the theatre knew the man on its scavenged throne before the system finished the introduction, because they had seen him once already, standing at the Iron Duke's shoulder in the Secret coda: *Malzeth. Former siege-general of the Western March. Self-styled King of the Ash.*

He had learned all the wrong lessons from his old master's fall. Vashtar had built armies; Malzeth built *stockpiles*. And the vision walked the audience through his arsenal with the system's flattest, most clinical captioning, down a long hall his engineers called the orchard, and the theatre understood, one row at a time, in a spreading sick silence, what the extraction cradles were for.

Sacred Gears cannot be manufactured. They are born in people — seeded in children, without pattern, peasant and noble alike. And they can be *removed*, if you have the old rites, and do not care that removal kills the host.

The cradles were small. All of them were small. Children's Gears, the caption explained, come out cleanest — the roots are shallow before adolescence. Rows of cradles, rows of little shapes under sheets, and at the hall's far end a rack of extracted Gears glowing softly in velvet, cataloged, ready to be socketed into Malzeth's officers like stolen jewelry.

In the theatre, in the front row, Asia Argento made one small sound and pressed both hands over her sternum — over the exact place where, once, on an altar, a laughing fallen angel had pulled Twilight Healing out of her living body and let her die on the stones. Rias's arm was around her before the sound finished.

"He knows," Koneko said quietly, to no one, watching the vision's sky. "He already knows what this is. He's felt it from the inside of losing her."

Then the wall of the orchard ceased to exist.

There was no siege. There was no ultimatum, no herald, no ninety-second rain of declarations the theatre had come to expect from him. There was Issei Hyoudou in the Welsh Dragonic Rook's massive crimson plate, walking out of the burning breach with the survivors' cradle-straps already cut behind him, and the vision's timestamp — the system had never before shown a timestamp — running cold in the corner of the sky.

Malzeth was a veteran. He read the armor, read the green gem, read his own odds, and did the intelligent thing, the *proven* thing, the thing that had saved his old master's life in front of this very audience one night ago. He dropped his blade. He went down on both knees in the wreckage, arms spread, head bowed, and began the words.

"I yield. Whatever penance—"

The timestamp said the walk across the hall took one point eight seconds. Ascalon was in Issei's hand for perhaps half of that. The theatre had watched this boy fight for thirty-five chapters — had watched him bleed out rounds he could have ended early, take punches to make a point, monologue at archdevils, weep over enemies — and so the theatre possessed, collectively, the exact expertise required to understand what it was seeing now, which was none of those things.

The holy sword went through him once.

No speech. No verdict read aloud. Not one word — the vision was very clear on this, and later, in the arguments, people would keep returning to it — Issei Hyoudou did not say *anything*. The King of the Ash folded into the cinders of his own orchard mid-sentence, and the Red Dragon Emperor was already turning away, already kneeling at the nearest cradle, already gentle, the gauntlet voice dropping to the register the theatre had heard him use on frightened children in a burning slave market two chapters gone.

[TRANSFER.]

Power flooded away from him, down the link to Asia's ring, into healing light for the seven small bodies that were still breathing. He stayed on his knees in the ash for a long time, an armored mountain making itself low and harmless, saying *you're okay, you're okay, we've got you, don't look at that side of the room*.

And Ddraig's voice, old and quiet, closed the vision like a door:

"Partner does not negotiate over a nest."

The lights came up on a theatre that did not erupt. It *pressurized*.

"Clean," said Frank Castle.

That single word landed in the silence like a dropped magazine, and Matt Murdock came around in his seat. "Don't."

"Clean," Frank said again, without heat. "One motion, no fear pause, no anger tell, blade already moving before the target finished the first clause. I've watched him spare people for thirty-five chapters and I clocked it as softness. It wasn't softness." He looked at the frozen frame — the kneeling king, the sword. "It was a *line*. He always had a line. Last night your Duke knelt on the right side of it. This one knelt on the wrong side, and the kneeling stopped mattering." A beat. "Told you to watch the general. That kill is the bill for Chapter Thirty-Five, and the kid paid it."

"That kill is the bill for *the orchard*," Matt said, and his voice was low and shaking with the effort of precision. "Don't you dare fold them together. The Duke repented and ten years of the Western March proves mercy was correct. The general chose the cradles all by himself." He stopped. His jaw worked. "But I heard it, Frank. I heard it the way I heard *her*, in Chapter One. Malzeth's heart while he begged. It was calm. He was reading a script that worked on the Duke's judge and expected it to work twice. The repentance was counterfeit."

"So the kid made the right call."

"The kid didn't *make* a call!" Matt was on his feet now. "That's what none of you are seeing. He didn't listen and then decide. He didn't check. Yesterday he stood in front of a kneeling tyrant for ten minutes, weighing a soul, and it was the hardest thing we've watched him do. Today he crossed that hall in under two seconds, which means the verdict was in before the door came down — before any plea, true or false, could have reached him. What if it *had* been true? What if that man had knelt there with a wrecked, hammering, honest heart?"

"Then he'd be an honest man who harvested children," said the Winter Soldier.

Bucky Barnes had not spoken all chapter. He rarely did on kill nights; the theatre had learned to leave him the silence. Now he stood with his flesh hand in his pocket and the metal one resting on the seat back, and he spoke slowly, like a man walking a perimeter he'd walked before.

"I've been what you're afraid he is," he said. "A verdict that arrives before the door opens. No pause, no check, one motion, clean — I know exactly what that looks like from behind the trigger, and you're right to be scared of it, Murdock, and you're wrong about what you saw. Because the difference was never the speed." He nodded at the screen. "It's *whose line it is*. Every kill I made for seventy years, somebody else had drawn the line and I was just the pencil. That boy drew his own. Out loud. In front of everyone, chapter after chapter — he spares the repentant, he forgives his own murderers' colleagues, and the defenseless are *fenced off*, and everyone in his world has been told where the fence is." The metal hand flexed once. "A man who kills at random is a monster. A man who kills on orders is a weapon. A man with one fence, who tells you where it is, and never moves it in his own favor — that's neither. I don't have a word for it. But I sleep better knowing it exists."

"The word," said Steve Rogers quietly, "is the argument. Execution or protection. Pick one, and everything downstream changes."

"Protection," said half the room.

"Execution," said the other half, and not all of that half meant it as an accusation.

It was the villains' tier, of course, that did the mathematics.

"Observe what we have actually been given," Doom said, and the debate bent toward him whether it wanted to or not, because Doom on a dais was still Doom. "Two nights. Two kneeling tyrants. One variable changed. Chapter Thirty-Five: crimes of war, of conquest, of ambition — the window for repentance stands open, and genuine contrition is *honored*. Tonight: crimes against children — and there is no window. There was never a window. He did not close it in anger; it does not exist on that side of the fence. We have been handed," and the mask tilted, "a completed map of the Red Dragon Emperor's jurisprudence. Mercy is a door with exactly one lock."

"And every being in this room now holds the key's *negative*," Loki murmured, silk over wire. "Knowing precisely what triggers a dragon's lethality is priceless intelligence — and utterly symmetrical. It tells you what never to touch." He examined his nails. "I note, for the archive, that hostage-craft is dead as a discipline where this boy is concerned. A child in your hand does not buy you leverage over him. It buys you one point eight seconds."

Bullseye whistled at the frozen frame, the technician's whistle he'd given Raynare's spear a lifetime of chapters ago. "Half-second draw inside a walk. No wind-up. I've killed a lot of people slower than that man died." Nobody near him moved seats this time. They were all doing the same arithmetic.

And the Green Goblin, who had laughed at the fountain in Chapter One, who laughed at everything, started to laugh now — at the kneeling, at the mid-sentence — and stopped. Alone. The sound died in the villains' dark like something small falling down a well, and Norman Osborn sat very still with the map Doom had just drawn spread out in his mind, locating himself on it, on the wrong side of a fence that did not have a window, and said nothing at all for the rest of the night.

"Marvelous," said Mephisto softly, to no one. "The room's worst are checking their own ledgers against his fence line. He is not even *from* here, and he is already governing them."

Magneto's voice came down from the mutant rows like a gavel. "There is nothing to debate. I have stood over the small graves this world digs and been told that mercy toward the diggers is civilization. It is not. It is bookkeeping by the unbereaved. The boy's fence is the only law I have seen in this theatre worth the name." A pause. "He is gentler than I am. He turned away from the body. I would not have."

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel spun — and the theatre went quiet in a new way, because the colors drained through blue, past purple, past gold, and stopped on the rarity that had, last time, disclaimed itself.

"FUNERAL FOR THE SLAIN" — RARITY: SECRET.

"The tyrant gets a funeral?" someone said, appalled.

"No," said Frank Castle, already standing, the way he stood at gravesides. "The slain aren't the tyrant."

Night, in the Ash March. Three days later, the caption said. A frontier village at the orchard's edge, and behind its shrine, thirty-one graves.

Small. All of them small.

The delegation from the victorious coalition had come and gone at noon with banners and correct speeches. This — the Secret — was later: one figure coming back alone up the cinder road in the dark, out of armor, in plain human clothes with his collar turned up, carrying incense and a paper bag of convenience-store offerings, because the Underworld's frontier had no shops and he had gone home to get candy. Thirty-one small sweets. He set one on each grave, and knelt in the ash in front of the rows, seiza, palms flat on his thighs, and bowed until his forehead touched the ground.

"I'm sorry," said Issei Hyoudou, to the graves. "I was slow. Three days. If I'd been three days faster—" He stopped. Started over. "You don't have to forgive me. That's not what I came for. I just didn't want your first night out here to be one where nobody came."

He stayed until dawn. That was all. That was the entire Secret: no one in his world knew — not the coalition, not the village, not the wives in the front row, whose faces the theatre could not look at directly. He had told no one, ever. The vision's only other witness was the voice in his left hand, which said, very low, near sunrise:

"Nest law, partner. Even the ones we lose are ours."

And then the screen did the thing the theatre would carry out of the chapter like a stone in the chest. The machine that had failed, once, catastrophically, in front of everyone — the machine that had printed **RECORD NOT FOUND** over a child-shaped hole in a photograph — began, unprompted, to print names.

MIRA. TESSEL. YUUNA. KOVAK. DANE...

Thirty-one names, one at a time, unhurried, each held on screen a full breath before the next. Frank Castle stood through all of them, spine straight, the way you stand for a folded flag. Bucky stood. Steve. Matt Murdock stood with his rosary out and his face wet and his argument, for the moment, laid down. By the fifteenth name the whole theatre was on its feet — aisles, tiers, the villains' dark, Magneto with his fist over his heart — and in the front row Asia Argento, who knew from the inside exactly how those children had died, whispered every name after the screen like a litany she intended to keep.

When the thirty-first name faded, the screen held dark for a moment. Then, small and white, almost gentle:

THIS UNIT ITEMIZES. WHERE IT IS PERMITTED.

SOMEWHERE, A LIST EXISTS THAT THIS UNIT CANNOT READ. HE WILL STAND BEFORE THAT, TOO.

The wheel rose. **NEXT PULL PENDING**, it said — and beneath it, almost apologetic after the weight, a preview band flickered: a summit table, a hundred pantheon banners, and Issei Hyoudou adjusting a tie with visible terror.

"Diplomacy," said Tony Stark hoarsely, into the dark. "God help every god in that room."

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Immediate Execution of a Second Tyrant" — Rare (*viewed*)
- "Funeral for the Slain" — Secret (*viewed*)

Secrets Revealed:

- The second tyrant was Malzeth, former siege-general of Vashtar, the Iron Duke spared in Chapter Thirty-Five — the "problem general" from that chapter's Secret coda. Styling himself King of the Ash March, he ran Sacred Gear extraction on children (the rite that once killed Asia), harvesting Gears to arm his officers.
- Issei killed him instantly and wordlessly — a 1.8-second crossing, one stroke of Ascalon through a kneeling, mid-plea tyrant — then knelt among the surviving children within the same minute. Daredevil's senses confirmed the plea was counterfeit (calm heart, echoing Raynare in Chapter One), but Issei never checked: past his boundary, repentance is not evaluated.
- The completed "map" of his ethics, per Doom: mercy is a real, open door for crimes of war and ambition (Ch. 35), and does not exist for crimes against the defenseless — children above all. Ddraig frames it as nest law.
- The Secret pull: Issei returned alone, in secret, three nights later to the thirty-one children's graves — candy offerings, a dawn-long vigil, an apology for being "three days slow." No one in his world knows. The machine then named all thirty-one victims unprompted — pointed contrast to Chapter Thirty's **RECORD NOT FOUND** — and admitted: "**THIS UNIT ITEMIZES. WHERE IT IS PERMITTED,**" adding that a list exists it cannot read, and "he will stand before that, too."

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- Punisher: vindicated but recalibrated — Issei's mercy was never softness, it was a fence; Frank now respects the whole system, sparing included. Stood first for the names.

- Daredevil: shaken; concedes the kill's outcome, still refuses the precedent of "verdict before the plea." Laid the argument down, unresolved, during the funeral.
- Winter Soldier: landmark testimony — the difference between weapon and man is *whose line it is*; Issei drew his own, announced it, and never moves it in his own favor. Bucky "sleeps better knowing it exists."
- Villains: clinical boundary-analysis complete. Loki declares hostage-craft dead against Issei (a child hostage buys "1.8 seconds," not leverage). Green Goblin located himself on the wrong side of the fence and went silent. Magneto: full-throated endorsement — "the only law in this theatre worth the name."
- Heroes: split, honestly and openly, between "execution" and "protection" — Steve names it the argument everything downstream depends on. The whole theatre, both halves, stood for the thirty-one names.

Unresolved Hooks:

- The machine's confession: it itemizes only "where permitted" — permitted by *what*? A list it cannot read exists, tying the funeral's names to the erased child of Chapter Thirty and the thing that "counts what is taken." Seed only; do not resolve.
- Matt's precedent question stands: Issei's fence has never yet punished an honest heart — what happens the day the counterfeit and the genuine kneel in the same room?
- Villains now hold a complete map of Issei's lethal boundary — intelligence that cuts both ways, and someone in that dark tier will eventually test whether the fence has a seam.
- Next banner preview: an inter-pantheon summit, Issei in a tie, visibly terrified — Chapter Thirty-Seven's diplomacy incident looms.

Chapter Thirty-Seven: Issei Hyoudou vs. Diplomacy

Primary Reaction Groups: Political Leaders (T'Challa, Doom, Namor, the Wakandan delegation, Atlantis, Magneto and the mutant nation) • Nick Fury

Gacha Pulls:

1. "International Summit Speech" — **Epic**
 2. "Accidental Insult to a God" — **Comedy-Class**
-

Seven chapters into the steel-grey banner, the theatre had quietly rearranged itself again.

It had happened the way all the seating changes happened — without discussion, by gravity. The night a village had elected Issei Hyoudou its protector, the crowned heads of the audience had drifted into one block to argue about it, and the block had never dissolved. The room called it the statecraft rows: T'Challa of Wakanda at its center, composed as a treaty; Victor von Doom two seats away, tolerated under the truce that had held since Chapter One; Namor the Sub-Mariner at the aisle, because Namor required an aisle the way fires require oxygen; Magneto behind them with the patience of a man who had buried more nations than most of the row had governed. And at the block's edge, in a chair he'd dragged there himself somewhere around the tyrant chapters, Nick Fury — one eye, no throne, and the professional conviction that anywhere kings gathered, somebody sensible should be counting the exits.

The room needed tonight, and knew it. Two chapters of tyrants — the one spared, the one not — had left the aisles raw, and beneath everything, still, sat the photograph with the child-shaped hole in it, which no one mentioned and no one had stopped thinking about. When the gacha wheel descended and the steel-grey track lit with an unmistakably jaunty flicker, several thousand beings leaned forward with the shameless hunger of mourners smelling comedy.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2, printed the screen. **"INTERNATIONAL SUMMIT SPEECH" — RARITY: EPIC.**

And then, in smaller type, with what the room had learned to recognize as the machine enjoying itself:

CONTEXT: THE RED DRAGON EMPEROR ATTENDS A PEACE CONFERENCE. THE MANAGEMENT ACCEPTS NO LIABILITY.

"Oh no," said Ravel Phenex, from the fiancées' row, in the voice of a manager reading a subpoena. "Oh no, it's *that* one."

The theatre swallowed them.

The hall was built on neutral ground that six mythologies had spent a month arguing about, which told the audience everything before a word was spoken. Marble that remembered Olympus. Rafters carved with Yggdrasil's roots as a courtesy to the Norse delegation. Wards layered by Heaven, Grigori, and the Underworld in triplicate, because after the war against the Evil Dragons, nobody trusted anybody's wards alone.

The vision supplied the roster the way the machine always did, cold captions over vast presences: **ZEUS, GOD OF THE SKY. ODIN, THE ALLFATHER. INDRA, LORD OF THE DEVAS. AMATERASU-ŌMIKAMI, BY PROXY OF THE KYOTO DELEGATION. THE ARCHANGEL MICHAEL. AZAZEL, GOVERNOR GENERAL OF THE GRIGORI. SIRZECHS LUCIFER.** Rows of lesser thrones. A gallery of human observers from governments that had only recently been told, gently, that everything was real.

And, seated with the Devil delegation in formal dress he was visibly at war with, one (1) reincarnated High-Class Devil, hero of the recent war, twenty years old at the absolute outside, being briefed in an urgent whisper by a silver-haired Valkyrie.

"—and you address the Allfather as *Allfather*," Rossweisse was hissing, in the vision, "not as—"

"I know, I know."

"Say it back to me."

"Allfather. I've *got* this, Rossweisse."

In the theatre, present-day Rossweisse put her face in her hands with the smoothness of ritual.

The agenda was reparations. The war had cratered three pantheons' territories, and the question of who owed whom had curdled, over six hours of flawless diplomacy, into something with teeth. The vision compressed the six hours mercilessly: Zeus, magnificent and wounded in his pride, itemizing Olympus's dead with thunder banking behind every syllable. Indra, smiling like a knife shop, suggesting — never stating — that certain factions had profited from the chaos, and that the Devas might feel obliged to *rebalance* matters. The Norse pressing claims. Heaven conciliatory and ignored. Azazel cracking exactly one joke, which died on the marble. The human observers going grey as they realized the beings around them were negotiating the way tectonic plates negotiate.

The theatre's statecraft rows watched the mechanics with narrowed, expert eyes.

"There," T'Challa said quietly, at hour four of six. "That clause. Indra has just made war survivable for everyone who wants it. He's built them a door."

"He built it three exchanges ago," Doom said. "Zeus has been walking toward it since."

They were both right. By the time the vision let time run at full speed again, the hall had gone quiet in the specific way rooms go quiet when the next sentence is a declaration, and Zeus had risen, and the thunder was no longer banking.

Which was when Issei Hyoudou — who had been asleep with his eyes open since the appendices, sustained only by Rossweisse's elbow — stood up because his leg had cramped, knocked his water glass onto the table of the Deva delegation, said "Sorry! Sorry — crap — was that magic water? Is it ruined? It looks expensive—", and brought the collective attention of six pantheons down onto himself like a dropped chandelier.

Silence. Zeus, mid-declaration, stared at him.

"You have something to add," said the God of the Sky, in the tone that had preceded several floods. "Boy."

The theatre watched Issei Hyoudou look around the hall — at Sirzechs's careful non-expression, at Rossweisse's dawning horror, at a month of diplomacy balanced on a knife — and visibly decide that since he was already standing, he might as well be honest.

"Yeah, okay," he said. "Um. I didn't understand most of today. I'm not smart. Everyone here knows I'm not smart; my own contract literally has a clause about not letting me negotiate." (**IT DOES**, the caption confirmed, unprompted.) "But I understood the last hour fine, because the last hour, you all stopped using long words. You're going to fight. You're dressing it up, but I've been in enough fights to know the face people make right before one, and, no offense, but gods make the same face as high schoolers."

A sound moved through the Norse delegation that might have been a laugh being strangled at birth.

"So I just want to say the thing nobody's said all day." He wasn't loud. That was what the vision made the theatre feel — he was the only person in six hours who hadn't projected. "Everyone in this room is stronger than me. Seriously, everyone; I checked the seating chart. And every single one of your dead — I'm sorry. I mean it. Some of them died next to me. But my best friend was murdered in a park by a war exactly like the one you're about to start — a *technically*, a leftover, a war nobody in the room actually wanted anymore, and she died because a bunch of people way above her pay grade made this face and nobody stood up." He took a breath. "So. If somebody has to bleed for everyone's pride to be okay — take mine. I'm offering. Any of you, one-on-one, whenever, I lose *all the time*, ask literally anyone. But you only get me. Because if it's armies, then it's kids in parks again, and I've done that funeral, and I'd rather do mine."

He sat down. Then stood halfway back up.

"Also, Lord Zeus, sorry about earlier, when I asked if the beard was attached. It's an amazing beard. That was a compliment that came out wrong."

He sat down again. Rossweisse had achieved the color of her own hair.

The hall held still for three full seconds. Then Odin — one-eyed, ancient, delighted — began to laugh, a sound like a longship coming home, and said: "The boy offers what no diplomat has brought me in two thousand years. A true price, from an open hand. Well, Sky-King? Shall we make war against *that*? The skalds would flay us."

And the theatre watched a declaration die. Not defeated — *embarrassed to death*. Zeus looked at the boy who had offered himself like small change, and the thunder went out of the room degree by degree, and the God of the Sky sat down with the heavy grace of a man choosing the better story. Indra's smile stayed exactly where it was, fixed, the smile of a craftsman watching a stranger step on six months of work. **RESOLUTION: RATIFIED**, printed the caption. **METHOD: UNPRECEDENTED. FILED UNDER: DIPLOMACY (DISPUTED).**

The theatre came back to itself in stages, like a crowd surfacing from cold water, and the statecraft rows came up arguing.

"No." Namor was on his feet, which surprised no one, and pointing at the screen, which surprised no one either. "No. I have declared war for less than that water glass. I have *drowned navies* over protocol a tenth as violated. He interrupted a sovereign mid-declaration. He confessed weakness before assembled kings — he *inventoried* it. He apologized twice in one speech. Every law of statecraft I have ever—" He stopped. The room watched Namor the Sub-Mariner wrestle with something, and lose. "—and I would have accepted his offer, and then I would have made him an admiral. This is what enrages me."

"It should," said Doom.

The row turned. Doom had not risen. Doom was watching the frozen frame of the boy and the beard apology with the stillness he usually reserved for Strange's better spells.

"Understand what you witnessed," Doom said. "Doom has attended such summits. Doom has *engineered* such summits. Six hours of that hall was a machine for converting grievance into war while allowing every party to claim they resisted — Indra built it beautifully; Doom would have hired him. And that boy walked into the machine and jammed it with the one substance it cannot process." A pause. "Sincerity. Do you grasp the horror? It cannot be counterfeited past a god's perception, it cannot be purchased, it cannot be trained. Doom commands every instrument of statecraft ever forged, and Doom

could stand in that hall for a century and not do what the idiot did by *knocking over a glass*. He has no diplomacy. He has only terms. It merely happens that the terms are true." The mask turned slightly toward T'Challa. "Say it, then. You have been composing it for a minute."

"I have," T'Challa admitted, and there was a smile in it. "Only this: we call honesty a virtue and treat it as a handicap. Every court on my world assumes a hidden position — that assumption is diplomacy; the entire game is priced on it. But a man whose position is fully visible cannot be outmaneuvered, because there is nothing behind him to reach. The gods could verify every word he said. His offer required no trust, no verification clause, no hostages — his transparency *was* the collateral. My father told me a king's word must be a wall. That boy's word is a wall with the interior lit and the door open, and it turns out that is stronger." He inclined his head at the screen. "Polished diplomacy would have failed in that room. It had already failed. It failed for six hours in perfect grammar."

"Speaking as a professional liar," said Nick Fury, from his exit-counting chair, "this is the worst thing I've ever seen." He said it with something dangerously close to reverence. "Everything I have ever built runs on one assumption: everybody lies, so you price the lie. That kid breaks the pricing model. You can't flip him, because he'd tell you he'd been flipped. You can't feed him disinformation, because he'd announce he didn't understand it. You can't even *recruit* him, because the moment you make him an asset, he stops being one — the whole value is that nobody owns him and everybody can check." He shook his head slowly. "I've spent forty years learning every dialect of deception, and the most dangerous negotiator I've ever watched work is a kid whose entire toolkit is *meaning it*."

Behind them, unhurried, two men were writing.

Loki's notes, those nearest him swore afterward, were genuinely on paper, in a hand like frost: *A man who cannot lie is the perfect instrument — everyone believes him. Corollary: never let him know the plan; simply arrange for him to describe it. Second corollary, worse: he cannot be used, because being used is a lie he'd say out loud. Conclusion: the only way to profit from him is to be genuinely on his side. Suspect this is deliberate on the universe's part. Insulted.*

And Magneto, who wrote nothing down and missed nothing: "Charles spent fifty years learning to speak to frightened people so that the fear could hear him past the words," he said, mostly to Xavier, who was already listening. "This boy skips the learning. There is nothing between his intention and his mouth for fear to hide in. If the mutant cause had possessed one voice that provably could not lie—" He let it stand unfinished. "Take your notes, trickster. I am taking mine."

"He'd be *impossible* to write speeches for," Shuri said, delighted. "Zero message discipline. A communications catastrophe. I want to study him."

"I want to *guard* him," muttered Okoye, staring at the frozen hall full of gods. "One principal, six pantheons, and he spills water on the Devas. My spear hand itches."

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2, said the screen, and the steel-grey track flickered into something the theatre had never seen it do — a rimshot.

"ACCIDENTAL INSULT TO A GOD" — RARITY: COMEDY-CLASS. FORMAT: SUPERCUT.

"No," said Rossweisse, in the front row, to the ceiling, to fate. "No."

Yes. Item: Issei Hyoudou meeting Odin, Allfather, wisest of the Aesir, and greeting him — warmly, respectfully, from the heart — with "You're an even bigger pervert than me, gramps. That's actually amazing. I have so many questions" — while his bride, formerly the Allfather's own bodyguard, died standing up in dress uniform. Odin's recorded verdict: "I like this one." Item: Issei assuring Zeus, at their first meeting, that "honestly, some of the rumors about you make *me* look responsible," which the caption scored **INSULT: ACCURATE**, and which Zeus had — after a pause the length of a weather system — declined to hear. Item: Issei thanking the Shinto delegation for "the good sun" during a battle and adding, to the Archangel Michael, *in front of Amaterasu's proxy*, that Heaven's light "kind of stings, no offense" — one sentence, two pantheons, and Michael laughing before his aides could gasp. Item: Issei telling Indra, flatly, publicly, "I don't trust you. You smile like Azazel when he's about to ruin my week" — captioned **INSULT: DOUBLE. BOTH PARTIES CONFIRMED FLATTERED. ONE OF THEM WAS LYING.**

The theatre was helpless. Even the statecraft rows. Even — briefly, awfully, a sound like a bass string — Doom.

Only at the supercut's end did the laughter thin, because the machine appended one final frame without comedy scoring: a throne of bone, a god shaped like a grave, and Issei Hyoudou looking at Hades with no joke anywhere in him at all. **SOME GODS**, the screen noted, **HE DOES NOT TEASE**. The frame lasted two seconds and closed like a door being marked for later.

"Ah," said Loki softly, pen stopping. "So the honest man keeps one ledger of his own."

The wheel rose. The steel-grey band glowed on, and beneath it the screen printed its hook into the dark with the smugness of a machine that knew exactly what dragons kept besides promises:

NEXT: EVERY KING HAS A TREASURY. YOU HAVE MET THE DRAGON. YOU HAVE NOT SEEN THE HOARD.

In the villains' rows, entirely without meaning to, Rocket Raccoon — visiting from the Ravager block, allegedly to heckle — made a small, involuntary, deeply sincere noise.

"Oh no," said Ravel Phenex again, to no one, to history.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *International Summit Speech* — Epic (the post-war reparations summit of six pantheons; Indra engineers a path to war, Zeus rises to take it, and Issei — via a spilled glass, a cramped leg, and total sincerity — offers himself as the sole price of everyone's pride, killing the declaration by embarrassment; **RESOLUTION: RATIFIED. FILED UNDER: DIPLOMACY (DISPUTED)**); *Accidental Insult to a God* — Comedy-Class (supercut: Odin "gramps, you're a bigger pervert than me," the Zeus rumors line, insulting Heaven's light in front of two pantheons, telling Indra to his face he isn't trusted — nearly every insulted god ended up liking him).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's own contract contains a clause barring him from negotiating (machine-confirmed). His transparent honesty functions as verifiable collateral: gods could confirm every word, so his offer required no trust mechanism — where six hours of polished diplomacy failed, sincerity defused a multi-pantheon war. Indra is now personally invested against him ("a craftsman watching a stranger step on six months of work"). The supercut's unscored final frame: Issei does not joke with Hades — "some gods he does not tease" — flagged by the machine for later.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Namor moves from apoplexy at the protocol violations to admitting he'd have accepted the offer "and made him an admiral." Doom, with horror and grudging awe, classifies sincerity as the one statecraft instrument he cannot counterfeit, purchase, or train. T'Challa formalizes the chapter's thesis: a fully visible position cannot be outmaneuvered — "a wall with the interior lit and the door open." Fury declares Issei the most dangerous negotiator he's seen precisely because he's unrecrutable — making him an asset would destroy the asset. Loki (on paper) and Magneto (in intent) both take notes on the political value of a man who cannot lie; Loki's own conclusion — "the only way to profit from him is to be genuinely on his side" — annoys him. Shuri wants to study him; Okoye wants to guard him.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Why doesn't Issei tease Hades — what history sits behind that closed-door frame? Indra's stalled scheme (a god who builds doors to war) is live and personal. Loki's and Magneto's notebooks now exist as objects in the theatre. Next banner teased: the dragon's **hoard** (Chapter 38, *The Dragon's Treasury*) — Rocket has already made a noise about it. *Carried forward, untouched:* the erased child of Chapter Thirty (the room still is not saying it aloud), the excision-signature thread (Ch. 20/30), the greyed-out crimson Queen, and the prophecy line: "HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT."

Chapter Thirty-Eight: The Dragon's Treasury

Canon Status: [DRAMATIZATION] Built around canon elements (Ryuuteimaru, Issei's arsenal) but the treasury/archive framing itself is fic invention.

Primary Reaction Groups: The Collector • The Grandmaster • The Ravagers • Tony Stark • Rocket

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Archive of Dragon-Forged Weapons" — **Legendary**
 2. "Ryuuteimaru's Armory" — **Epic**
-

By the middle of the steel-grey arc, the theatre had developed an economy, and like all economies it had a bad neighborhood.

It occupied the right-hand gallery, three tiers up, and it had assembled itself the way mold assembles: nobody had decided anything, and yet there it was. Taneleer Tivan, the Collector, sat at its center in a seat that had somehow become a booth, upholstered in a leather no one asked about, surrounded by floating catalogue-slates on which he had spent thirty-seven chapters appraising everything the screen showed him. Two seats over lounged En Dwi Gast, the Grandmaster, gold-robed and delighted by absolutely everything, keeping odds. Below them, in rows that smelled faithfully of engine grease and bad decisions, sat the Ravagers — Stakar Ogord upright and disapproving, Yondu Udonta with his boots on the seat back, Kraglin between them like a comma — and, at the end of the row, vibrating faintly, Rocket.

Rocket had been vibrating since the slave-market chapter. The raid had earned Issei the Ravagers' rarest currency — an unamused nod from Stakar — but it had also shown the boy casually snapping a slaver's vault off its hinges, and Rocket had looked at that vault the way other beings look at sunsets. He had a list now. The list was titled, in Rocket's own handwriting, *STUFF THE DRAGON KID DEFINITELY DOESN'T NEED ALL OF*.

Tony Stark did not sit in the bad neighborhood. Tony Stark sat one aisle below it, at the precise distance Doom had pioneered — *I am not with these people; I can hear every word these people say* — because after the summit chapter he had questions about logistics. A boy who armed villages, refit fleets, and out-shouted pantheons had to keep his materiel *somewhere*, and thirty-eight chapters had taught Stark that the machine heard wanting.

The machine heard wanting.

The house lights sank to a color the theatre had never seen it wear: not forge-orange, not storm-grey, but the deep, felted, climate-controlled gold of a bank the public never enters. The gacha wheel descended through it like a chandelier with opinions, spun, and chimed — and the chime, tonight, was the sound of a very large key in a very old lock.

PULL ONE: "ARCHIVE OF DRAGON-FORGED WEAPONS" — LEGENDARY.

The Collector rose from his booth so smoothly it looked rehearsed.

"At last," said Taneleer Tivan, "*inventory*."

The vision opened on the Hyoudou residence — and went down.

Past the kitchen with its treaty-length table. Past the six known basement floors, which the theatre had toured in the family arc. Past a door of ordinary wood bearing a hand-lettered sign — *ISSEI'S STUFF. KNOCK FIRST. YES, THIS MEANS YOU, KUROKA* — and then through a fold in space that made Stark's jaw tighten, because the door was mundane and what it opened onto was not.

A pocket dimension, warm as an attic in summer. And in it, rank upon rank into the golden distance: the treasury.

It was not a hoard. The theatre understood that within seconds, and the understanding rearranged the whole room, because everyone had been braced for dragon clichés — coins, gems, a mountain of glitter with a lizard on it. Instead they got *shelves*. Racks and cases and plinths, labeled in handwriting that started diligent and collapsed into scrawl, arranged not by value but by — the aisles took a moment to parse — by *story*.

A rack of holy swords, and at its head, home between wars, Ascalon — and beside it a second blade of the same lineage, leaner, newer, labeled *ASCALON II*, and beyond that, further down the rack, more sword-shaped silhouettes greyed out into static, their labels unreadable, the gacha's cold font stamped across them: **NOT YET PULLED**.

"The *First Ascalon*," breathed Shuri, from the Workshop Quarter, twenty-two chapters of suspicion paying off at once. "I *said* the title was load-bearing."

A sealed reliquary case holding shards of broken holy steel, light still moving inside them like fish, labeled: *EXCALIBUR FRAGMENTS — RECOVERED FROM KOKABIEL'S THEFT. HELD IN TRUST. TECHNICALLY IRINA'S. DO NOT TOUCH. SERIOUSLY. SHE COUNTS THEM*.

An empty plinth, lovingly dusted, bearing only a card: *REPLICA MJOLNIR — RETURNED WITH THANKS. GOOD HAMMER*. (In the high tiers, Thor made a sound like a cathedral being happy.)

And then the working aisles. Dragon-forged gear in ranks: blades quenched in Boosted aura, armor plates grown from shed Scale Mail and hammered flat, spears and gauntlets and shield-bosses that Eitri, rising slowly from his three seats, identified one by one in a voice that kept losing altitude. Weapons Issei had forged for his peerage. Weapons forged for allied villages, pattern-marked for farmers' hands. Weapons taken from dead evil dragons and *retired* — racked with their edges sheathed in blessed wax, labeled with the name of the dragon and one line each: *Fought well. Chose wrong.* Trophies he had refused after wars, mailed to him anyway by grateful pantheons, stacked unopened in a corner like awkward birthday gifts.

"Understand what you are seeing," said Ddraig's voice over the vision, dry and old and unmistakably proud. **"Dragons hoard. It is the oldest law of us. Gold, grudges, territory — a dragon's hoard is a dragon's self-portrait. Twenty thousand years I waited to see what my partner would pile up."** A pause with a shrug in it. **"He hoards receipts. Every object in this vault is a promise somebody kept. I have given up being embarrassed. It turns out this is what a hoard looks like when the dragon is rich in the only thing he ever wanted more of."**

The vision drifted down the last aisle — and, at the very back, panned past a small case, child-height, its contents unreadable, its edges shivering with a static the theatre knew now, and hated. The vision did not slow. The vision, if anything, sped up, and the front row of eight women leaned forward as one and got nothing.

The frame settled instead, wide and golden, on the whole treasury at once, and the gacha stamped its rotating Legendary seal and editorialized in letters of vault-light:

ASSESSED VALUE: INCALCULABLE. INSURED VALUE: ZERO.

NOTHING HERE WAS TAKEN. THEREFORE NOTHING HERE CAN BE.

The lights came up on pandemonium, and the pandemonium had factions.

"Item the first." The Collector was already in the open floor, catalogue-slates orbiting him like moons, addressing the front row with the courtly hunger of a man who had bought planets before breakfast. "I am prepared to offer, for the reliquary of Excalibur shards *alone*: a Kree Soul-Forge, functional; the last egg of a species I am assured was magnificent; two minor Infinity artifacts, provenance negotiable; and my personal assurance of climate-controlled display conditions superior to — forgive me — a *suburban basement*—"

"The basement," said Rias Gremory, without turning around, "is warded by a Norse rune-master, a nekoshou sage, and the Crimson-Haired Ruin Princess, and it has never once tried to put my husband in a display case. Sit down, merchant."

"Everything is for sale, madam. The seller merely hasn't met the price—"

"I have destroyed prices," said Rias, and let one coil of crimson-black Power of Destruction lift off her shoulder and eat, with a sound like the end of an argument, a decorative flourish off the nearest catalogue-slate. The Collector looked at the smoking slate. He revised, visibly, several appraisals, one of which was of Rias.

"Or — or — hear me out, hear me out." The Grandmaster had flowed down beside Tivan, hands sketching arenas in the air, blue jaw bright with delight. "Nobody *sells* anything, that's so — Taneleer, honestly, it's so *transactional*, it's *beneath* the moment. We make it a *game*. A tournament! Open brackets, all-comers, and the *prize* — " he framed the frozen treasury on the screen between his thumbs — "is one item of the winner's choice from the dragon's little gift shop. I've hosted four hundred thousand years of games, trust me, wars have started for *worse* prizes—"

"The last man who treated my husband's swords as prizes," said Xenovia Quarta, and she did turn around, with the serene, unblinking directness that had frightened the theatre since the crow story, "was a fallen angel war criminal named Kokabiel, and my husband beat him unconscious, and then a man with white wings put him in a place where he will never be bored again. I carry Durandal. Durandal is not in that vault, because Durandal does not rest. If a bracket forms, I will enter the bracket, I will win the bracket, and as my prize I will select *you*." A pause. "I am told I lack a sense of humor, so to be clear: that was not a joke. I checked."

The Grandmaster's hands lowered slowly, framing nothing. "I like her," he announced, to the room, in a slightly higher register than usual. "Terrifying. Great energy. No tournament."

And below all of it, in the Ravager rows, Rocket Raccoon had gone somewhere else entirely.

He wasn't heckling. That was the alarming part; Kraglin kept glancing over the way you check a pot that's stopped bubbling. Rocket sat hunched, eyes glassy with love, fingers twitching through invisible schematics, narrating at a volume he genuinely believed was internal: "—okay, okay, pocket dimension, fine, doors are a *suggestion*, you go in through the *fold*, you'd need a phase-discriminator and a really stupid amount of nerve, gravity's assist not enemy, wards read *intent* so you send in someone with no intent, hi, hello, that's a raccoon with a lobotomy setting, I *have* one — the fragments are portable, the second sword's portable, the wax dragon-swords are basically *pre-wrapped*—"

"Rat." Yondu had not moved his boots off the seat back, but his voice came down like a wrench dropped from orbit. "You seein' the same show I'm seein'? Kid ripped a slave fortress open like a ration pack. His wife over there just ate a *price*. And your plan is *rob his house*."

"It's not robbing, it's — *redistributing*, he's got *duplicates*, Yondu, he has literal spare holy swords, that's not a hoard, that's a *sample sale*—"

"Boy keeps his war trophies in *wax*," said Stakar Ogord, and his tone shut both of them up, because Stakar had spent the arc grading Issei against the Code and this was the sound of a final mark going in a book. "Labels the dead. Refuses the tribute and keeps it *sealed* so no one else takes it either. That ain't a treasure room, gentlemen. That's the tidiest weapons decommissioning program I ever saw run by a teenager. Hundred Ravager crews couldn't hold discipline like that over one payday." He tipped his head back toward the screen. "You don't steal from that, Rocket. You *salute* it. Or you find out."

"I can hold *both* positions," muttered Rocket, still sketching.

Stark had come down to the rail, arms folded, uncharacteristically quiet, and when he finally spoke it was to Tivan, almost gently, the way you break news. "You're miscataloguing it, by the way. Your slates are pricing a collection. It's not a collection." He nodded at the frozen gold. "Collections are things you take *out* of the world so you can have them. Every rack in there points back *into* the world — who it was for, who it came from, what it cost, who counts the fragments. He's not collecting weapons." A beat, and Stark, who had built and buried an armory of his own once, heard his own voice go strange. "He's keeping *minutes*. It's not a vault. It's the world's most heavily armed scrapbook."

The Collector stood very still among his orbiting slates. "Everything I own," he said at last, with the first unguarded sentence of his captivity, "screams. Beautifully, but it screams. His inventory *purrs*. I confess I did not know that was a feature one could acquire." He returned to his booth and began, quietly, re-appraising nothing at all.

The wheel spun again while Rocket was still mid-schematic, and the second chime was not a key in a lock. It was a boat bell.

PULL TWO: "RYUUTEIMARU'S ARMORY" — EPIC.

"Ryuu-tei-maru," sounded out Kraglin. "That a sword?"

The vision answered: a forest of fog and familiar-light, years ago, and a boy on his knees at the edge of a pond, being introduced by a top-hatted familiar-master to the least impressive legendary creature in creation — a boat. A tiny one. A palm-sized, slightly dented, faintly glowing boat, paddling in a circle.

LEGENDARY-CLASS FAMILIAR: SKÍÐBLAÐNIR-LINE LIVING SHIP, captioned the screen, and the entire Asgardian section stood up at the name while the rest of the theatre was still deciding whether to laugh. **GROWS BY FEEDING ON ITS MASTER'S AURA. GROWTH CEILING: UNKNOWN.**

And the vision showed the feeding. Years of it, compressed: Issei, after every battle, every training collapse, every triumph, sitting exhausted on a dock in the familiar forest with the little boat in his lap like a cat — **[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [TRANSFER.]** — pouring surplus dragon-power into the hull,

chattering at it about his day. The boat drinking. The boat *growing*. Palm-sized to canoe. Canoe to cutter. Cutter to a sleek dragon-prowed ship the size of a house, then a hall, then a hillside — and inside it, the pull's namesake: the armory, which no shipwright had installed, because the ship had *grown* it. Ballista-spines budded from the keel like teeth coming in. Blaster-mounts flowered along the gunwales. A hangar deck folded itself into existence the way a lung inflates. The ship built weapons the way a body builds bone: out of love, from the inside, to protect what fed it.

"It's not a vehicle," said Stark, at the rail, very quietly. "It's a *pet* that decided to become an aircraft carrier."

"He talks to it," Ddraig confirmed, resigned and fond. **"Every night, for years. It has never once answered. It is the best listener in his life, and given his life, the competition was fierce."**

The vision ended on the ship at full glory, sails of light, waiting in fold-space like a hound at a door — and then the gacha did its museum trick. Light stabbed down into the open floor, and out of it rose not a plinth but a *pool*, silver and shallow, and on the pool, paddling in a proud small circle: an echo of Ryuuteimaru. Palm-sized. Slightly dented. The bell on its prow went *ting*.

EPIC BONUS: EXHIBIT IS AN ECHO. ECHO IS FAITHFUL. DO NOT FEED THE EXHIBIT.

THE MANAGEMENT KNOWS EXACTLY WHO NEEDS TO HEAR THAT.

"Why's it looking at *me*," said Rocket.

But someone was already moving. Groot unfolded from the Guardians' row and came down the tiers with the unhurried patience of a season changing, and knelt at the pool's edge, vast and mossy, and the tiny boat stopped circling and came about to face him.

The theatre went quiet without being asked.

"I am Groot," said Groot.

The boat's light rippled. It bumped, very gently, against the shore of the pool, against the bark of his hand — once, twice — the way a cat decides about a stranger. Two beings who had spent their whole lives being translated by other people regarded one another across the silver water. One had a vocabulary of three words. One had a bell.

Ting, said Ryuuteimaru.

"I am Groot," Groot agreed.

No caption arrived. For once the machine, which itemized everything, offered no translation, and the room understood that this was the translation: that some conversations are between a tree that grew into a family and a boat that grew into a fortress, and both of them had done it the same way — by being fed,

faithfully, by someone who talked to them at night — and it was nobody else's business. Groot touched one finger to the tiny prow, and a sprig of green unfurled from his fingertip and rooted there, a leaf no bigger than a coin, and the boat's glow took on the faintest ring of spring.

Then it sailed one last circle — listing slightly to port, where Rocket sat — and stopped, and pointed its prow at him, and simply *looked*, in the way that only a boat with no eyes can look.

"Okay," said Rocket, ears flat, to a dinghy, in front of the entire multiverse. "Okay! Fine. Message received. It was a *thought experiment*." A pause. "Mostly."

"I am Groot," said Groot, standing, which everyone in earshot correctly understood to mean *he had four hundred contingencies and I will be telling the ship all of them*.

The pool sank. The lights began their end-of-chapter dim, and the screen offered its parting shot over the frozen image of the golden aisles — the racks, the receipts, the greyed-out swords stamped **NOT YET PULLED**, the small static-edged case at the back that no one had been allowed to see.

YOU HAVE NOW SEEN WHAT THE DRAGON KEEPS.

ONE OF YOU PRICED IT. ONE OF YOU GAMED IT. ONE OF YOU PLANNED FOR IT. — and here, to a roar of laughter and one string of Ravager profanity, a copy of Rocket's own handwriting appeared on screen, annotated in the machine's cold font: **PLAN RECEIVED. FILED UNDER: SIMULATION — PENDING.**

NONE OF YOU ASKED THE ONLY QUESTION THAT MATTERS.

The letters held, then rearranged.

NEXT: WHO OWNS A MIRACLE?

In the booth, the Collector steepled his fingers over his darkened slates and, for the first time in thirty-eight chapters, wanted something he could not name a price for. In the front row, Xenovia asked Rias, in a whisper the whole theatre heard, whether "I will select you" had been too subtle. And at the end of the Ravager row, Rocket Raccoon looked up at the words *SIMULATION — PENDING* with his heart in his throat and his list in his pocket, torn precisely between terror and hope, which — as Yondu observed to Kraglin, boots still up, grinning like a knife — was the most Ravager the little idiot had ever looked.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Archive of Dragon-Forged Weapons* — Legendary (Issei's pocket-dimension treasury beneath the Hyoudou residence: the Ascalon rack — Ascalon, Ascalon II, and

further greyed-out blades stamped **NOT YET PULLED** — the sealed Excalibur fragments held in trust ("technically Irina's"), the empty replica-Mjolnir plinth marked "returned with thanks," peerage- and village-forged arms, wax-sealed weapons of dead evil dragons labeled and retired, and unopened pantheon tribute); *Ryuuteimaru's Armory* — Epic (Issei's Skíðblaðnir-line living-ship familiar, grown over years from a palm-sized boat by nightly aura feeding — **[TRANSFER.]** — and now growing its own weapons like a body growing bone). Epic bonus: a palm-sized echo of Ryuuteimaru manifested in a pool on the theatre floor.

- **Secrets Revealed:** The treasury is an anti-hoard: organized by story, not value, every item a kept promise — "nothing here was taken, therefore nothing here can be" (per the gacha) — extending Chapter 16's consent-based-arsenal finding to his entire inventory. Chapter 16's "First Ascalon" title is confirmed load-bearing: multiple further Ascalon-class blades exist but remain unrevealed. Ddraig regards the vault as his partner's dragon-hoard and has formally stopped being embarrassed by it. Ryuuteimaru has never spoken but is "the best listener in his life." At the treasury's very back sits a small child-height case with static-shimmering edges — the erasure signature from Chapters 20 and 30 — which the vision conspicuously refused to show.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** The Collector's trade offer (Soul-Forge, last egg, two minor Infinity artifacts for the Excalibur shards) was destroyed — literally, in part, by Rias's Power of Destruction — and he ended the night unable to price the vault, admitting his collection "screams" where Issei's "purrs." The Grandmaster's tournament-for-vault-prizes proposal died when Xenovia promised to enter, win, and select *him* as her prize (not a joke; she checked). Stakar has entered a final Code verdict: the vault is "the tidiest weapons decommissioning program ever run by a teenager" — you salute it, you don't steal from it. Stark reclassified the treasury from arsenal to archive: "the world's most heavily armed scrapbook — he's keeping minutes." Groot and the Ryuuteimaru echo shared an untranslated communion (the machine declined to caption it); Groot left a living sprig rooted on the echo's prow and has sided openly with the boat against Rocket.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The gacha intercepted Rocket's heist planning verbatim and filed it on-screen: **PLAN RECEIVED. FILED UNDER: SIMULATION — PENDING** — a theft simulation is now formally queued (pay off in Chapter 43). The chapter closed on **NEXT: WHO OWNS A MIRACLE?** — teeing up the technology-sharing debate (Chapter 39). Still open: the greyed-out Ascalon-class blades and what states they belong to; the static-edged child-height case at the back of the treasury (do not resolve — the erased-child thread from Chapter 30 continues; seed only); the Collector now covets something he cannot price, and no one has decided whether that makes him safer or more dangerous; and the museum question from Chapter 16 sharpens — the machine praised no one, but its exhibits increasingly mirror Issei's own curation, as if the theatre and the treasury are two shelves of the same archive.

Chapter Thirty-Nine: Who Owns a Miracle?

Primary Reaction Groups: S.H.I.E.L.D. • S.W.O.R.D. • X-Men • Doom • Wakanda • Eternals

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Debate Over Sharing Dragon Technology" — **Epic**
 2. "Issei's Answer" — **Legendary**
-

The argument had started before the lights came up.

That was new. For thirty-eight chapters the theatre had waited on the machine — bickered, bet, grieved, converted, but always in response, always downstream of the wheel. Tonight, in the grey wash of the Arc Four banner, the machine descended into a room already shouting, because last night it had shown several thousand of the most acquisitive minds in a multiverse the inside of a dragon's treasure vault, and then turned the lights off.

"—not talking about the *swords*," Nick Fury was saying, on his feet in the S.H.I.E.L.D. block, coat thrown back, the flat carrying voice of a man who had run this exact meeting a hundred times in rooms with worse upholstery. "Keep the swords. I'm talking about the medicine. There was a *shelf* in that vault, Stark's scans caught it, rows of vials with a Sanskrit label, and the archive index called it a *panacea*. If that's real, it's not treasure. It's public health."

"It's an invasive species," said Abigail Brand, from the S.W.O.R.D. tier above him, boots on the rail, green hair like a biohazard flag. "You're welcome, by the way, for the only accurate sentence anyone's said in ten minutes."

"It's *his*," said Kitty Pryde, from the X-Men rows, with an edge the room had learned to respect.

"Everything is somebody's, right up until it matters," Fury said. "Then it's policy."

And the screen, which had been listening — the theatre was certain by now that it listened — printed, with what could only be described as relish:

MOTION HEARD. THE HOUSE WILL NOW REVIEW PRECEDENT.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun through its colors and stopped on deep violet.

"DEBATE OVER SHARING DRAGON TECHNOLOGY" — RARITY: EPIC.

"It's showing us a *committee meeting*," Rocket said, betrayed, from the Ravager block. "Last night, infinity swords. Tonight, C-SPAN."

The theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

A chamber like the inside of a struck bell: the Grand Conclave of the Alliance of Mythologies, the same body the theatre had watched Issei accidentally insult into peace two nights ago. Tiered seats of devil nobility, Grigori researchers, Heaven's seraph-delegates, Norse and Hindu and Yokai envoys, and — newer, stiffer, visibly overwhelmed — human observers in ordinary suits.

On the floor of the chamber, on an evidence table, sat three items. A single crimson-lacquered vial. A sheaf of schematics stamped with the seal of Ajuka Beelzebub's research division. And a sword that hummed like a struck tuning fork even in its case.

The vision gave the theatre the docket the way it gave them names, directly into the mind: *Item one: simplified Amrita, a stabilized nectar-derivative healing draught developed from divine pharmacology and dragon-refined by the Sekiryuutei's household; in field trials it has closed wounds no phoenix tear could touch and arrested two plagues. Item two: partial schematics toward externalizing the Boosted Gear's Transfer function — power-sharing as infrastructure. Item three: a dragon-forged blade, one of many, from the vault.*

The motion before the Conclave: whether such assets may remain in private hands.

And then the debate — and the theatre, braced for boredom, found itself leaning in, because the machine had chosen the speeches with a curator's cruelty.

A Yokai envoy from a plague-struck northern territory, voice cracking: "I am not here to philosophize. I buried forty children last winter. This spring the dragon's wife walked into our sick-house with a crate of those vials and asked for nothing, and I buried none. I am told I should be *concerned* about the precedent. I am concerned about *April*."

An old-guard devil noble, dry as a ledger: "And when the boy dies? Or turns? Or simply *tires*? Charity is weather. Institutions are climate. The Conclave must hold the formula, or the formula holds us."

A seraph, gently, terribly: "We held miracles centrally once. The system worked flawlessly until the administrator died, and then we lied about it for two thousand years rather than share the keys. I speak for the faction with the most experience hoarding grace, and I am telling this body: the vault does not keep the miracle safe. The vault *becomes* the miracle. Then men fight for the vault."

A human observer, standing, hands flat on the table like a man steadying himself on a cliff: "Six months ago my government did not know any of you existed. Now I learn there is a schoolboy — forgive me, a *dragon* — holding a cure for everything, distribution decided by whether he *likes you*. You are all debating theology. I am asking a smaller question. What do I tell the mother in the hospital corridor about why her hospital isn't on his list?"

Silence in the chamber. Silence in the theatre.

The security hard-liner spoke last — a devil in Conclave grey, reasonable, weary, the most dangerous voice in any such room. "Then the motion is simple. Registration of all dragon-forged assets. Licensed replication of the draught. Compulsory escrow of the Transfer schematics with this body. Not punishment — *stewardship*. No private citizen may hold a stockpile of miracles. Draft the requisition order. Send it to the Hyoudou residence."

The vision held on the word *requisition*, and let it curdle.

The theatre came back to itself already divided, and the division did not run along any line it had drawn before.

"Draft the requisition order," Emma Frost repeated, softly, from the X-Men block, and the temperature around her dropped in a way that had nothing to do with diamond. "Do you know, I've heard that sentence before. Nearly word for word. It had *mutant* in it instead of *miracle*, and it was also drafted by tired, reasonable men, and it was also called stewardship." She crossed her legs. "I've been the asset on the evidence table, darlings. Let me save everyone some time: the greater good has an accounting problem. It is always calculated by the people doing the taking."

"And I've stood in the hospital corridor," Fury said, without heat, which made it worse. "Frost, I hear you. I ran the registration files; I know exactly what I sound like. But you're arguing about who he is, and I'm arguing about what happens at scale. Trust is a beautiful distribution system for one village. It does not *scale*. He can't personally vet eight billion people, so somewhere a line gets drawn around who he happens to know, and everyone outside that line is dying of geography. You don't have to be a tyrant to find that unacceptable. You just have to be the one holding the corridor's phone number."

"Then the failure is the line, not the boy," T'Challa said.

Heads turned. The king of Wakanda had been quiet all night, and beside him Shuri had gone uncharacteristically still, because the Wakandan block was watching a mirror and knew it.

"For centuries my country held the vibranium mound and every miracle we grew from it," T'Challa said. "We told ourselves withholding was wisdom. From inside, it was wisdom — every projection said the world would weaponize what we shared, and the projections were correct. They are still correct. We

opened our doors anyway, because a man came to us and showed us the cost of the alternative in his own body." He looked at the frozen chamber on the screen. "Both of my ancestors' arguments are in that room. I notice the boy's answer is in neither. He does not withhold, and he does not surrender. He *gives*, one hand to another hand. It is the slowest possible method. It is also the only one that transmits the miracle *and* the trust, and my family learned at terrible cost which of the two runs out first."

"It's pretty, cousin," Shuri murmured, "but the corridor is still full."

From the villains' dark, Doom had risen — not to the floor, never to the floor, but to his full height in the aisle that was always somehow his.

"Doom will state what the sentimental cannot." The voice came level and metallic and certain. "The draught is not the issue. The *schematics* are the issue. Transfer — power itself made a grid, strength redistributed like water — that is not medicine, that is the architecture of a new civilization, and the question of who holds it is the only political question that has ever existed. This Conclave of theirs is correct that it cannot remain in private hands. They are merely wrong about whose hands." A pause, entirely unembarrassed. "In the boy's grip it is a lottery ticket. In Doom's it would be *policy*: no famine, no plague, no war Doom did not permit. You recoil. Yet every state in this theatre is built on exactly one act — the confiscation of dangerous power from private men — and you call it *law* when it is old enough."

"He's not wrong," Brand said, and raised a hand at the noise. "Stow it — I said *not wrong*, I didn't say *right*. My whole job is quarantine. Something world-changing crosses a border, I don't ask if it's good, I ask what it does to an ecosystem that didn't evolve with it. Amrita loose on one world means lifespans double in a decade — pension systems die, then economies, then somebody fights a war over the supply chain of *mercy*. That's not a reason to bury it. It's a reason nobody in this room gets to be smug, because sharing it is an extinction-level event for the world that exists, and so is hoarding it, just slower."

And then a voice from the Eternals' row, which had watched ten thousand years of this argument and rarely bothered to join it.

"I built them a plow once," Phastos said.

He said it conversationally, and the theatre quieted anyway, because there was a weight under it like a hand on the back of the neck.

"A plow. A nudge. I loved them — I love them still — and I couldn't stand watching them dig with sticks, so I gave. Freely. With trust. Exactly the way the boy's defenders are recommending." He looked at his own hands. "The plow became the wheel became the engine became a light over Hiroshima brighter than anything I ever showed them, and I stood in the ash and swore off giving. So take it from the one being here who has actually run the experiment: *freely given* doesn't sanctify anything. The gift

forgets the giver in two generations. Whatever you decide about his miracles, you are not deciding for him, or for you. You're deciding for whoever is standing next to them in seventy years." He sat back. "I still build, by the way. I married, I have a son, I fixed the neighbor's mower last spring. I'm not telling you the answer is *never give*. I'm telling you there is no version of this where anyone's hands stay clean, so pick whose they are on purpose."

Into the silence after that, the screen chimed, almost politely.

PRECEDENT REVIEWED. THE HOUSE WILL NOW HEAR FROM THE ASSET.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

Gold flooded the wheel.

"ISSEI'S ANSWER" — RARITY: LEGENDARY.

The Conclave chamber again, days later. The requisition order lay on the evidence table where the vial had been, and Issei Hyoudou stood over it in his school blazer — he had come straight from class; the theatre could see the eraser dust on his sleeve — reading it with his lips moving slightly, at the speed of a boy for whom paperwork had always been enemy terrain.

[Partner,] rumbled the gauntlet, low, for his ears and several thousand eavesdroppers, **[the word you are stuck on is 'compulsory.']**

"Yeah," Issei said. "That's the one I thought it was."

He put the paper down. He looked around the bell-shaped room at the tiered faces — the weary hard-liner, the ledger-dry noble, the human observer with the corridor behind his eyes — and the theatre braced for the blunt-force speech they'd watched him give at the summit, and did not get it. He spoke quietly. It was worse.

"Everything I have, someone gave me," he said. "My power came from a dragon who got stuffed in my arm without anyone asking *him* — and he stayed anyway, and now it's ours, not mine. My life came from a girl who spent everything in her hand on a dead pervert she barely knew, and nobody made her, and that's the only reason there's anybody standing here for you to requisition. My sword was a gift. My house was a gift. I know exactly what I am, and what I am is *given*." He tapped the crimson vial's empty spot on the table. "So ask me. That's the whole procedure. The northern territory asked, and their crates go out on the first of the month, forever, free, and if the shipment's ever late it's because I'm dead. Azazel asked for the Transfer research and he's had it for a year, because I'd trust that shady old crow

with my life and have. Ask me, and mean it, and it's yours — and here." He slid a folder across the table to the human observer, who stared at it. "Amrita production protocol. For the corridor lady. No price. You asked the room a good question and nobody answered you, so — yeah."

Then he looked at the hard-liner, and the boyishness went out of his face like a tide.

"But nobody *takes*," Issei said. "Not because it's my property. I don't actually care about property; you've seen my vault, half of it's junk I keep because a friend touched it. Because the day you can take a miracle with a form, every miracle after that one arrives with soldiers, and everyone who might have asked learns to hide instead, and then you're not distributing trust anymore, you're mining it, and it doesn't grow back." He picked up the requisition order, and the theatre heard the paper's edges char faintly between his fingers. "A miracle you take stops working. Oh, the *magic* still works. The part that made it worth having doesn't. I got handed my first miracle by somebody who wanted something from me, once. On a first date. I know the difference in my chest, where the spear went." He set the paper down, singed but whole, deliberate. "Motion denied. Lunch is on me, though. I mean it. All of you. There's a place near the station."

[The Conclave,] Ddraig noted, to the theatre at large, with ancient satisfaction, **[went to lunch.]**

The vision released them, and for once no faction erupted, because every faction had won a piece and lost a piece and knew it.

"He gave the human the folder," Fury said finally. "Unprompted. Which means his line isn't where I said it was." A long breath through his nose. "Doesn't scale. Still doesn't scale. But I've run assets my whole life, and I'll say this into the record: I have never once gotten out of a man voluntarily what that room almost took by force and lost."

"Motion denied," Emma said, savoring it like a vintage. "The miracle votes."

"The miracle is *seventeen*," Brand said. "Ask me again in seventy years, when the folder's grandchildren are pointed at each other."

"So we are agreed," Doom said, into the dark, "that no one in this theatre would have his answer — and that no one has a better one." No one, notably including Doom, disputed it.

Above them all the wheel rose, ticking — and as it went, one segment that had sat greyed-out and dead since the arc began, a segment the color of dried blood, flickered. Warmed. Went the deep, breathing crimson of a crown.

QUERY LOGGED: WHO OWNS A MIRACLE, printed the screen, small, as the lights went down.
INSUFFICIENT DATA. RE-ASK WHEN YOU HAVE SEEN WHAT ONE COSTS.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Debate Over Sharing Dragon Technology* — Epic (the Grand Conclave of the Alliance hears a motion to register, license, and compulsorily escrow Issei's "dragon assets": the Amrita healing draught, Ajuka-division Transfer schematics, and the dragon-forged arsenal); *Issei's Answer* — Legendary (his recorded refusal of the requisition order — and his unprompted gift of the Amrita protocol to the human delegate in the same breath).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Simplified **Amrita** exists — a stabilized, mass-producible healing draught that has stopped plagues; Issei's household ships it free, permanently, to anyone who *asks* (the northern Yokai territory's standing shipment). Azazel has held the Transfer externalization research for a year, by trust. Issei's doctrine, stated plainly: he is himself "given" (Ddraig unconsenting-but-staying, Rias's eight Pawns), so miracles move by asking and trust — never by requisition, because compulsory seizure poisons every future gift ("a miracle you take stops working"). He denied the Conclave's motion and then bought the room lunch.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** No clean winner — the room formally registers a stalemate. Fury concedes the record ("never got voluntarily what that room almost took and lost") while maintaining trust-doesn't-scale; Emma Frost aligns hard with Issei against confiscation, citing mutant registration; Doom brands the Transfer schematics the true political prize and half-endorses Issei ("no one would have his answer — and no one has a better one"); T'Challa reads Issei's hand-to-hand giving as the third path Wakanda never found between hoarding and surrender, with Shuri noting the corridor stays full; Brand's quarantine verdict: sharing and hoarding are both extinction events, one slower; Phastos delivers the Eternals' testimony — he *ran* the freely-given experiment, and it ended at Hiroshima: no clean hands, so choose whose on purpose.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The screen's closing judgment — **"INSUFFICIENT DATA. RE-ASK WHEN YOU HAVE SEEN WHAT ONE COSTS."** — explicitly defers the ownership question until a future price is shown. Brand's seventy-year question (who inherits the folder's grandchildren?) and Phastos's warning stand open. The long-dormant greyed-out **crimson Queen segment of the wheel has ignited: NEXT BANNER: CRIMSON** (Chapter 40). *Carried forward:* the erased child and the excision-signature thread (Chs. 20/30) remain untouched and unmourned-yet-mourned; the prophecy line still waits.

Chapter Forty: Cardinal Crimson Promotion

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers (Captain America, Iron Man, Captain Marvel, Thor, Vision, Hulk) • Cosmic Heavy Hitters (Silver Surfer, Gladiator, Uatu, Heimdall, Karnak) • Gods & Monarch-Class Villains (Hercules, Loki, Doom, Mephisto, Thanos)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Cardinal Crimson Promotion" — **Mythic**
 2. "Dividing Wyvern Fairies" — **Epic**
 3. "Longinus Smasher Impact" — **Mythic**
-

The steel-grey banner had one segment left, and the theatre knew what steel-grey finales cost.

For nine nights the machine had run its arc like a tribunal. It had shown them a boy elected protector by a village and had made T'Challa and Doom argue the weight of crowns until dawn. It had shown them a slave market burning and a tyrant spared and a tyrant not spared, and the room had spent an entire evening fighting about where his line was before realizing, collectively, that they had memorized it. Heroes, kings, and monsters — the arc's three doors, and the machine had marched Issei Hyoudou past each one and refused, every night, to shove him through any of them.

Tonight the last segment lit, and the floor of the theatre dimmed into sixty-four vast alternating squares.

"Chess night," said Sam Wilson, very quietly, the way a man says *incoming*.

Because everyone remembered the last chess night. Everyone remembered the trident, and the arithmetic wearing armour, and the little procession of pieces around the gacha wheel's outermost band: pawn, pawn, pawn, knight, rook, bishop — and behind them, greyed out and locked for twenty chapters, crowned in a crimson the room had learned to watch for, a queen.

The wheel came down. The queen was not grey anymore.

ARC FINALE, printed the screen, in letters that weighed. **HEROES, KINGS AND MONSTERS: VERDICT.**

YOU HAVE ASKED, FOR NINE NIGHTS, WHICH OF THE THREE HE IS.

THE ANSWER IS A CHESS PIECE. IT IS NOT THE KING.

"Oh," said Steve Rogers, and sat forward, because he had coached long enough to know an answer arriving. Across the aisle, Doom's gauntleted hand came to rest on the closed cover of the notebook he had famously stopped keeping — not opening it. Touching it. The way one touches a sidearm.

The vision opened on a stadium the size of a nation's pride: a Rating Game, the formal kind, broadcast to the whole of the underworld — and on the far side of a shattered field stood an opponent the theatre already loved.

Sairaorg Bael. The devil with no powers. The heir who had been discarded for being born empty and had built himself back with nothing but training, the man whose loss had taught a much younger Issei what dignity looked like on a defeated face. He was not empty tonight. He wore a Balance Breaker of golden lion plate — a lion-god Longinus wrapped around him like a second dawn — and he was hitting Issei Hyoudou so hard that the arena's reinforced wards were filing formal complaints.

"The kid's rematch," rumbled Ben Grimm, hands already flexing. "Aw, hell. It's the *homework* fight."

It was. The captions laid it out with the machine's brutal economy: everything Arc Four had shown them — the kingdoms, the mercy, the monsters — had been the world asking Issei what he intended to be, and here at the end stood the one rival who was the honest version of all three answers. A hero by effort. A king by right. A monster by workload. And Issei's Triaina, the trident the theatre had once gasped at, was *failing* — Knight too fragile for those fists, Rook too slow for that footwork, Bishop's charge a suicide against a man who crossed the field in half a breath.

"He has to choose," Vision observed, "and every choice is wrong. The trident's flaw was always singular: three answers, one at a time, to an opponent asking all three questions at once."

On-screen, inside a cracked helm, Issei laughed — winded, delighted, entirely without fear — and the theatre heard him say it:

"Ddraig. He's too good for pieces. Let's stop choosing."

"Partner." The dragon-voice had banked pride in it, and something older — the sound of a door that had waited a long time to be opened. **"You know the colour it takes. You know whose colour that is. Hold it in your mind, and do not let go."**

And the theatre's front row — eight women who had watched their own life become curriculum — went very still, because Rias Gremory had gone the colour of her own hair.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 3.

"CARDINAL CRIMSON PROMOTION" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

[**CHANGE.**] said the gear, and then, in a chord the theatre had never heard it strike — three system-voices at once, Knight and Rook and Bishop speaking in unison like a cathedral remembering it was one building:

[**CARDINAL CRIMSON — FULL DRIVE!!!**]

The green jewel blazed — and the armour changed colour.

Not upgraded. *Dyed*. The battle-scarred scarlet of twenty chapters of Scale Mail deepened, richened, poured over every plate into a crimson the room recognized on sight, because it sat in their front row: the exact shade of Rias Gremory's hair, the colour of the woman who had spent eight Pawns on a dying pervert. The silhouette that rose out of that light was leaner than the Rook, denser than the Knight, and over each shoulder the Bishop's cannon-housings sat folded like patient wings. On the wheel above the theatre, the crimson queen slid to the centre of the board and stood.

DESIGNATION: CARDINAL CRIMSON PROMOTION. THE TRUE QUEEN.

THE QUEEN MOVES AS THE KNIGHT, STRIKES AS THE ROOK, RANGES AS THE BISHOP. THE PIECES NO LONGER OBJECT. THE BOARD NO LONGER OBJECTS. THERE IS NO LONGER ANY PART OF HIM THAT OBJECTS.

HE HAS STOPPED CHOOSING.

Then the vision let him move, and the theatre's heavy-hitter rows learned what integration meant.

Sonic booms in drumroll — Knight-speed — but when Sairaorg's counter came in like a landslide, Issei did not dodge it. He *took* it, Rook-frame ringing like a bell and holding, and inside his forearms the theatre saw new machinery cycle: pistons of compressed draconic force slamming forward as his fist met the lion's jaw —

[**SOLID IMPACT — BOOSTER.**]

— and the punch detonated twice. Once on contact, once from the piston, a double concussion that folded the air, and Sairaorg Bael, who had walked through the old Rook's best blow with a smile, left the ground and did not stop until a wall received him. Then, before the dust admitted anything, the shoulder housings snapped open — no minute of kneeling, no allies bleeding to buy the charge, three seconds of shrieking accumulation — and a lance of red took the arena's far quadrant out of the conversation.

CRIMSON BLASTER. CHARGE TIME: REDUCED FROM SIXTY SECONDS TO THREE.

Quicksilver's chair went over backward again. He didn't bother standing it up. "He kept the speed," Pietro said, to the ceiling, in the tone of a man reading his own eviction notice. "He kept the speed AND the tank AND the artillery, that's — you can't — those were supposed to be *trade-offs*—"

"Flaw analysis," said Carol Danvers, without turning her head. "Karnak. Go."

Karnak of the Tower of Wisdom had been staring at the crimson figure since the colour change, utterly motionless, and the theatre realized it had been waiting for his reading the way one waits for a second opinion on an X-ray.

"I have been looking," Karnak said, "since it stood up." A pause that cost him. "The Knight's flaw was one touch. The Rook's flaw was one sidestep. The Bishop's flaw was sixty seconds. Each form was a bet, and I could read the bet. This form is the three bets *underwriting each other* — the speed guards the cannon's charge, the armour forgives the speed's failures, the cannon punishes anything patient enough to out-position the armour. The flaws have not been removed. They have been arranged in a circle, each one standing behind the next." He folded his hands. "There is a crack in everything. In this, the crack has been promoted to load-bearing. I decline to call that a flaw. It is a philosophy with plating."

The screen, in its long-running habit, stamped the vision the instant he finished:

THE TRIDENT'S THREE PRICES HAVE NOT BEEN WAIVED. THEY HAVE AGREED TO PAY EACH OTHER.

"*Stop doing that*," said Karnak, with feeling.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 3.

"DIVIDING WYVERN FAIRIES" — RARITY: EPIC.

On-screen, Sairaorg came out of the wall — of course he came out of the wall; the theatre would have rioted otherwise — and the golden lion's aura doubled down, and the fight became the kind of fight that gets its own national holiday. And around the crimson armour, without an order, small lights kindled.

Wyverns. Tiny ones — each the size of a hawk, plated in crimson and pale silver, wheeling around Issei in a loose orbiting flock like a solar system that had unionized. The captions introduced them with what the theatre could only interpret as fondness: semi-autonomous dragon familiars, born of the armour itself, each one carrying a fraction of the gear's authority. One clamped onto Issei's shoulder and spoke in a chirp of the system-voice — **[BOOST!]** — and his aura climbed. Two peeled off to Sairaorg's blind side and *bit down on the lion's aura itself*, and the golden light visibly thinned, halved, sipped away like a levy.

"They divide," said Vision, and his voice did the instrument-glow thing. "Observe — those two are not adding to their master. They are *subtracting from the opponent*. Halving hostile output on contact and remitting it home. That is not his native mechanic. Boost doubles; this... this is the inverse function." A

pause of precisely the wrong length. "He has incorporated his rival's mathematics. The gear is running both halves of an equation that was designed as a war."

Up in the god-rows, Loki had gone from lounging to leaning in the space of one wyvern. "Little tax collectors," the trickster murmured, delighted despite every plan he owned. "He's flying with a *treasury*. Do you see it, thunderer? Any power raised against him is assessed, halved, and remitted to the crown. Odin's ravens gather *information*. His gather *revenue*."

"Aye," said Thor, who was not laughing, whose knuckles were white on the arm of his seat, whose eyes had the firelight of old stories in them. "And see what else they do."

Because on-screen, one wyvern had left the fight entirely. It flew to the arena's edge, where Issei's teammate lay with a broken guard, and unfolded itself over her like a made bed — becoming, in a wash of light, a lattice of crimson plate. Armour, donated. A shield built out of the Queen's own body, standing over someone who could no longer stand.

"There it is," said Steve Rogers softly. "Twenty chapters, and every form presupposes allies. Even the one that finally doesn't need them — spends itself making sure of *them*." He shook his head slowly. "You could take everything else off the screen. I'd draft him off that one frame."

Tony Stark had been silent for a suspicious length of time, and when the room glanced over, he was on his feet with a hard-light schematic already half-built and dissolving between his hands, expression caught between larceny and grief. "Autonomous support drones, self-fabricating, dual-mode offense-defense, running on *empathy-adjacent targeting* — do you know how long I've been trying to make the House Party protocol do that? He grew it. It's not even his final form, I can *feel* it's not his final form, and it obsoletes four of my suits and one of my therapists."

GACHA PULL: 3 OF 3.

"LONGINUS SMASHER IMPACT" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

The duel had come down, as the great ones do, to the last exchange — two exhausted armors in a cratered arena, a golden king and a crimson queen, and Sairaorg Bael pouring every remaining watt of a lifetime's homework into one final aura that turned the sky above the stadium to noon.

And Issei Hyoudou's chest opened.

The theatre heard it before it saw it: a sound like a vault accepting its combination, plate after plate of the crimson cuirass unlocking, sliding, blooming outward from his sternum — and behind the armour, where a heart should politely be, there was a muzzle. Not a cannon mounted on the armour. The armour

was the mounting. The boy was the emplacement, all of him, the entire compounding ledger of the Boosted Gear routed to a single aperture over his own heartbeat.

[LONGINUS SMASHER.]

The gear did not shout it. That was the detail the room would revisit in the dark for weeks: every technique for forty chapters had been announced at parade volume, and this one the system said the way surgeons say *scalpel*.

The beam that came out was not red. Red was what it left behind. The vision's sound cut — the theatre's reality declining, once again, to render — and a column of light the width of a city block crossed the arena, took Sairaorg's final aura, his last technique, the arena's horizon-grade wards, and the *evening itself*, and overwrote all of it. When sound crawled back, the stadium's sky — the actual sky, kilometres of it, horizon to horizon — was dyed crimson, a deep saturated bleeding red, as if the sunset had been repainted by something that only owned one colour and infinite conviction.

And the screen froze there — red sky, kneeling king, standing queen — and printed the assessment the entire night had been building toward, with Ddraig's voice speaking over the caption in the old low register of a creature who had watched empires misfile themselves:

"Understand what you are looking at," said the dragon. "The trident could level a battlefield. This levels the argument. In this form, my partner contends with Satan-class beings — the four thrones of the underworld, the beings that gods schedule around. He is sixteen, and the ceiling above him has become a floor."

CARDINAL CRIMSON PROMOTION: SATAN-CLASS ENGAGEMENT CONFIRMED.

The theatre did not erupt. Eruptions are for surprises, and this was worse than a surprise; it was a *promotion of the entire syllabus*. What happened instead was quieter and would be remembered longer:

Thor Odinson stood up.

Not to speak. He had no speech. The god of thunder rose from his seat the way warriors rise when a banner passes — slowly, entirely, hammer-hand loose at his side — and stood facing the red sky on the screen as though it were weather arriving over his own kingdom.

Across the aisle, with a sound of ceremonial metal, Victor von Doom stood as well. Doom, who bowed to nothing, who had declared the boy a constant twenty chapters ago, rose and stood in the villains' dark with his cloak settling around him, and offered the screen the one gesture in his entire vocabulary that was not contempt: his full height.

And between them, in the Avengers' rows, Carol Danvers got to her feet like paperwork catching fire.

"Reclassification," she said, and her voice carried to every tier because she made it. "Regional-calamity-class is struck. Effective tonight: *strategic actor, sovereign-tier*. That's not a threat category anymore — that's a *nation*. You don't scramble a response to that. You open an embassy." She stared at the red sky a moment longer. "And God help me, the kid I'd trust most with that beam is the one holding it. That's the whole assessment. That's what forty chapters bought."

"Hnh." The Hulk's rumble rolled down from his demolished quadrant, thoughtful as tectonics. "Sky's red." A pause. "Hulk's seen guys paint the sky. They were never the *nice* one." Another pause, longer. "First time it's the nice one." Nobody could improve on that, so nobody tried.

The Silver Surfer had drifted fully off his altitude, low over the aisles, chrome face lit crimson by the frozen frame. "Heralds are *given* such power, and it costs them their masters' errands," he said. "He built his, ascending cost by cost, and it answers to breakfast tables. The universe is usually crueller than this. I find I am watching it make an exception, and I do not know why. That — " and he looked, deliberately, up toward the Watcher's tier — "is the only question left in this room worth fearing."

Uatu did not answer. Uatu was watching the screen with an attention that had changed quality over ten chapters — no longer the unease of a being missing a record, but the vigilance of a being guarding one.

ARC FOUR COMPLETE: HEROES, KINGS AND MONSTERS, the screen printed. **HE IS NOT THE KING. HE IS THE PIECE THAT STANDS IN FRONT OF THE KING — AND IN FRONT OF EVERYTHING ELSE.**

And beneath it, one frame, the old line, steady tonight, almost serene:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

"Fitting," boomed Hercules into the settling quiet, lifting a flagon the theatre had never once seen him fill. "A toast, then, to the boy-queen of the red sky! Let the record show that Hercules, who has arm-wrestled hydras, would think *twice*—"

The sound was small.

That was the obscenity of it — after a night of muted apocalypses, the sound that stopped the theatre was barely a sound at all: a *tick*, crisp and mineral, like ice remembering it was once water. Hercules's flagon halted mid-arc. Several thousand heads turned.

In the upper right quadrant of the screen — the indestructible screen, the surface that had shrugged off thirty-nine chapters, the Hulk's fists in Chapter One, and the unrendered fury of the Dragon Blaster — there was a crack.

Hairline. A hand-span long. Spidering as they watched, one soft tick at a time, into three branches, then five, fine as a frost-flower and utterly, geologically wrong. The frozen red sky bent around it the way light bends at the edge of a lens, and — those closest would swear to this later, and Heimdall would not contradict them — the thin bright seams of the fracture did not reflect the crimson frame at all. They shimmered with a faint, static-edged wrongness the theatre had seen exactly once before, on the border of a child-shaped hole in a photograph.

"Machine," said Doom, still standing, and his voice had the flat courtesy he reserved for opposing heads of state. "Your theatre is damaged. Doom requires the mechanism."

The screen printed nothing.

"Karnak," said Carol quietly. "Read it."

Karnak looked at the crack for a long time. When he spoke, it was in the voice of a man reading a fracture in a load-bearing wall — the same voice from Chapter Twenty, and the room heard the rhyme and hated it.

"The flaw is not in the screen," he said. "The screen is the single strongest object I have ever assessed; it is stronger than everything it has shown us. The flaw is in the *load*. Something is asking this place to hold more than it was built for — and it was built," he gestured, once, at the impossible architecture, at forty chapters of gods and dragons and red skies, "for *this*. Consider carefully what exceeds it."

The lights went down without permission or ceremony, mid-crack, mid-silence — the first time in forty chapters the machine had ended a night without a banner, a chime, or a word. In the dark, the fracture went on glowing faintly, static-edged, patient.

Ddraig's voice came once, out of the black, very low, and it was not addressed to the room.

"I know that sound," the dragon said. **"Something is testing the walls of the nest. Partner — wherever you truly are — sleep well while you can."**

Tick, said the crack, softly, and the theatre sat with it until morning failed to come.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Cardinal Crimson Promotion* — Mythic (the "True Queen": the greyed-out crimson Queen from Chapter Twenty, unlocked at last during Issei's Rating Game rematch against Sairaorg Bael's golden-lion Balance Breaker); *Dividing Wyvern Fairies* — Epic; *Longinus Smasher Impact* — Mythic. Delivered as the Arc Four finale under the header "HEROES, KINGS AND MONSTERS: VERDICT."

- **Secrets Revealed:** Cardinal Crimson Promotion integrates all three Illegal Move Triaina specializations *simultaneously* — Knight speed, Rook power/defense, Bishop artillery — with no more choosing; Karnak reads the trident's three flaws as now "arranged in a circle, each standing behind the next" (the prices "have agreed to pay each other"). The armour dyes itself the exact crimson of Rias Gremory's hair, held in his mind as the trigger-image. Arsenal: **Solid Impact Booster** (piston-driven double-detonation blows that floored Sairaorg), **Crimson Blaster** (Dragon Blaster-class output, charge cut from sixty seconds to three), **Dividing Wyvern Fairies** (hawk-sized autonomous wyvern familiars that Boost their master, *halve and remit* enemy auras — Vali-style Divide mathematics, per Vision "his rival's equation" — and convert themselves into armour over downed allies), and the **Longinus Smasher** (chest-aperture beam announced at whisper-volume; erased Sairaorg's final aura and the arena's horizon wards and dyed the sky crimson for kilometres). Ddraig's on-record assessment: in this form Issei **contends with Satan-class beings** — "the ceiling above him has become a floor."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** At the Longinus Smasher, **Thor, Doom, and Captain Marvel rose to their feet** — Thor as for a passing banner, Doom offering his full height (his only non-contempt gesture), Carol to file the reclassification aloud: "regional-calamity-class" is struck; new designation **strategic actor, sovereign-tier** — "you don't scramble a response, you open an embassy," and she'd trust the beam to no one but the kid holding it. Hulk notes Issei is the first "nice one" ever to paint the sky. The Silver Surfer declares the only question left worth fearing is *why* the universe is making an exception for this boy — and aims it at the Watcher. Tony Stark concedes the Wyvern Fairies obsolete four suits; Loki reclassifies them as a flying treasury. Uatu's demeanor has shifted from unsettled archivist to *sentinel* — watching as if guarding a record.
- **Unresolved Hooks: THE CRACKED SCREEN — the arc's closing omen.** The supposedly indestructible viewing-screen developed a live, spreading hairline fracture at the moment of arc-completion; the machine, for the first time, ended a night with no banner and no reply (even to Doom's direct demand). The fracture's seams shimmer with the same static-edged excision signature as the Erased Child frame (Ch. 30) and the Dragon Blaster scar (Ch. 20) — the thread now spans three arcs. Karnak's reading: the screen is the strongest object he has ever assessed and the flaw is in the *load* — "something is asking this place to hold more than it was built for." Ddraig, unprompted: "something is testing the walls of the nest." *Arc-close threat consensus, carried forward:* the room's four-arc evolution is complete — from mourning a murdered stranger (Arc One) to planning around a constant (Arc Two) to retiring his family as leverage (Arc Three) to tonight's verdict: Issei is filed across every aisle as a **sovereign-tier strategic actor** — not hero, king, or monster but "the piece that stands in front of the king," Satan-class in output, incorruptible in character, and now openly assumed to be the theatre's *reason* rather than its subject: the audience increasingly believes they are being prepared to stand somewhere near him. Still open: who is the Erased Child; what "counts

what is taken"; what is straining the theatre from outside — and whether the walls hold until Chapter 100. Next banner: Arc Five, the Ravager Rolls (Chs. 41–50).

Chapter Forty-One: Ravager-Class Pull

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers (Yondu, Stakar, Aleta, Kraglin, Martinex, Charlie-27, Krugarr) • Guardians of the Galaxy (Quill, Rocket, Gamora, Drax, Nebula, Mantis, Groot) • Cosmic Pirates & Assorted Scoundrels

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Captain's Draw" — **Rare**
 2. "Yondu's Teeth" — **Comedy-Class**
-

Morning did not come to the theatre. What came instead, after a night nobody would admit to spending staring at the crack, was a chime — off-key, slightly tinny, like a cathedral organ being played by an accountant — and every light in the impossible architecture snapped on at once.

The crack was still there. Upper right quadrant, five branches, faintly glowing, ticking to itself at long intervals like a cooling engine. The screen wrote around it, the text flowing along the fracture lines the way a river negotiates with a boulder it has decided not to discuss.

GOOD MORNING, it printed. **STRUCTURAL LOAD HAS EXCEEDED PROJECTED PARAMETERS. NINETY-ONE PERCENT OF THIS FACILITY'S ATTENTION IS NOW ALLOCATED TO HOLDING THE WALLS.**

THE REMAINING NINE PERCENT CANNOT OPERATE THE ARCHIVE ALONE.

THEREFORE: MANUAL OPERATION IS HEREBY DELEGATED.

A spotlight the size of a landing pad swung across the tiers — past the Avengers, who sat up; past the X-Men, who leaned away from it on instinct; past Doom, who did not move, because Doom does not flinch for lighting — and came to rest, with an audible clunk of finality, on the rowdiest, worst-smelling, most flammable quadrant in the entire theatre.

CONGRATULATIONS, RAVAGERS, said the screen. **YOU'RE HIRED.**

"...The hell we are," said Yondu Udonta.

The floor in front of the Ravager section opened, and out of it rose a machine.

It was, unmistakably, a gacha console — but built the way the theatre built things, which is to say wrong in ways the eye kept trying to forgive. A brass-and-bone cabinet three men tall. A crank the size of a ship's wheel. A single crimson lever with a grip worn smooth, as though ten thousand hands had already pulled it in futures that hadn't happened yet. A coin slot. A tray. And a small, smug display screen that lit up and printed, in cheery letters:

OPERATOR CONSOLE v.1 — IDIOT-RESISTANT (NOT IDIOT-PROOF; WE'VE SEEN YOUR CREW MANIFESTS)

Rocket was over the railing before anyone could grab his tail.

"Okay, okay, okay." He circled the cabinet twice, nose twitching, hands already flexing. "Bone chassis, brass fittings, no visible power feed, no visible seams, tray's dispensing-grade — you know what this is? This is a *slot machine* that's been payin' out all year and now it's askin' *us* to hold the bag. First rule of any establishment, you never let the mark run the table—" he rapped the cabinet with a knuckle, listening, "—unless the house is *hurt*. And this house is hurt." He looked up, up, up at the crack, and his grin acquired teeth. "Fellas. It's *injured*. You know what injured things are? *Sellable*."

INPUT REGISTERED: "ROB THE THEATRE." The console printed it primly, then stamped beneath it, in red: **TAG: COMMON SENSE FAILURE.**

"Hey!"

ADDITIONAL TAG: RECIDIVIST.

"It's got your file, Rat," said Yondu, ambling down the steps with his coat swinging and his fin catching the spotlight. He walked around the machine the way he walked around anything valuable — like he wasn't looking at it. "Question ain't whether we rob it. Question's what it *pays*. Machine! You hirin' Ravagers, you're payin' Ravager rates. What's the units?"

COMPENSATION, said the console, **IS AS FOLLOWS: YOU GET TO KEEP WATCHING.**

"That ain't pay, that's a *hostage situation*—"

TAG: CORRECT. FIRST ACCURATE STATEMENT FROM THIS SECTION. A COMMEMORATIVE STICKER HAS BEEN ISSUED.

The tray clunked. A sticker slid out. It was gold, and it said BIG BOY in a font usually reserved for pediatric dentists. Kraglin took it reverently before Yondu could incinerate it and pressed it to his own lapel, where it remained for the rest of the arc.

It was Stakar Ogord who ended the circus, because it was always Stakar who ended the circus. He came down the steps slowly, flame-colored crest catching the light, and a hundred captains and crew went quiet by old reflex — Aleta at his shoulder, Martinex and Charlie-27 flanking, Krugarr drifting behind

with his hands folded in mystic disapproval of everything.

"We've been watching this boy a year," Stakar said, to his people, not to the machine. "Some of you laughed at him. Some of you drank to him — I saw you, don't argue. Now the house wants crew." He set one scarred hand flat on the cabinet. "You all know the code. We don't steal from the injured, we don't jump a job mid-run, and we don't — *ever* —" his eyes found Yondu's and held them, one long, freighted beat, "—deal in kids. This whole year's been one long delivery about a kid somebody killed. So we take the job. Ravagers keep their contracts." A pause. "And if it stiffs us on the back end, *then* we strip it for parts."

TAG: ACCEPTABLE TERMS, printed the console. **WELCOME ABOARD. DON'T TOUCH THE RED LEVER.**

Everyone looked at the red lever. It was the only lever.

"It's the only lever," said Drax.

YES, said the console. **TOUCH THE RED LEVER.**

"I hate it," announced Quill, from the railing, "and it's only been four minutes."

They drew lots for first pull, which among Ravagers means everyone cheated simultaneously and the cheats cancelled out, leaving Kraglin — who alone had played it straight — holding the short straw and the honor both. He wiped his palms on his trousers, gripped the lever like a man shaking hands with a bear, and hauled.

The great crank spun. Somewhere inside the cabinet, something vast and slow turned over, tumblers the size of moons settling one by one. The tray glowed. And the main screen — crack and all — bloomed.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"CAPTAIN'S DRAW" — RARITY: RARE.

OPERATOR'S NOTE: FIRST DAY ON THE JOB. HERE'S SOMETHING YOU PEOPLE MIGHT ACTUALLY UNDERSTAND.

The vision opened on a burning city that was also a shrine — Kyoto, the captions said, a fox-spirits' capital of lanterns and old wood, and it was under attack. Not by monsters. By *men*: a crew of human supremacists with stolen holy relics, professional, coordinated, and holding one piece of leverage that had brought the whole city to its knees.

They had taken the fox-queen Yasaka. And downscreen, in a hotel lobby full of terrified schoolchildren, her daughter — a nine-tailed fox girl named Kunou, small enough to carry, old enough to understand — was trying so hard not to cry that the entire Ravager section, hardened plunderers of a thousand ports, went silent as a chapel.

Issei Hyoudou knelt in front of her. He was sixteen, mid-series, tired, and technically on a class trip.

"Okay," he said. "Here's what's going to happen. We're going to get your mom back tonight."

And the theatre watched him *do the captain thing*. Not the hero thing — the room had seen forty chapters of the hero thing. This was different, and the pirates' section recognized it in their bones before the captions said a word: the quick, unglamorous arithmetic of a boarding action. He split his people by capability, not rank. He put his fastest on evacuation, his toughest on the gate, his subtlest on the flank. He begged support from allies he had no authority over and paid for it in the only coin he had — the flat promise that he'd take point at the worst spot on the field. When one of his crew balked at the odds, he didn't give a speech. He said, "You'll be with me," and that was somehow the whole speech.

And when the enemy commander — a beautiful, terrible man with a holy spear that could kill gods — offered Issei the professional's out, *walk away, this isn't your city, this isn't your species, this isn't your job*, the boy in the red gauntlet looked back at the crying kid behind his lines and said:

"She hired me."

"She's *nine*," said the man with the spear.

"Then I'm working cheap."

The Ravager section detonated. Boots on benches, tankards on railings, a wall of whooping, whistling, table-pounding pirate approval that drowned out the vision's own soundtrack — and the machine, with the timing of a born performer, froze the frame on Issei's silhouette standing between the spearman and the child, and printed:

ASSESSMENT REQUESTED: IS HE CAPTAIN MATERIAL? OPERATORS, RENDER VERDICT.

"Splits shares fair," said Charlie-27, counting on fingers the size of hams. "Takes the worst post himself. Pays his allies. Don't spend crew to save cargo."

"Terrible instincts," Nebula said flatly, arms crossed. "He announced himself. He gave the enemy time to prepare. He accepted a contract from a client with no assets, no leverage, and no extraction plan." A pause. Her jaw worked. "I have served under eleven commanders. I would follow that one."

"I am Groot," said Groot, with tremendous gravity.

"Yeah," Rocket translated, quieter than he meant to. "What he said. The little one didn't even have to *pay* him."

Aleta Ogord looked at her husband across thirty years of scar tissue. "Flame and thunder, Stakar. He runs a crew like you used to talk about running one. Back when you were young and stupid."

"He runs it like the pamphlet," Stakar agreed dryly. "Nobody runs it like the pamphlet." But he was looking at the frozen frame — the boy, the spear, the kid — and his thumb was moving over the flame sigil on his chest, slow, like a man rubbing an old wound.

And Yondu Udonta said nothing at all.

He sat with his elbows on his knees and his fin dark and his eyes on the fox girl who had hired a dragon with nothing but tears, and Kraglin — who had known him longest and survived it — carefully did not look at him, because there was exactly one subject in the galaxy that shut Yondu's mouth, and it was cargo that turned out to be children.

VERDICT LOGGED, said the machine, gently, for it. **CAPTAIN-CLASS: CONFIRMED. NOTE FOR THE SECTION'S FILE: HE HAS NEVER ONCE DELIVERED A CHILD TO ANYONE. THE MACHINE MENTIONS THIS FOR NO PARTICULAR REASON.**

Yondu's fin flared crimson. He was on his feet with the arrow shrieking out of its holster and every hand in the section reaching for him — and the whistle died on his lips, because the machine printed one more line, small, almost kind:

NEITHER DID YOU, AT THE END. THE MACHINE MENTIONS THAT FOR NO PARTICULAR REASON EITHER.

Silence. The arrow drifted back to his hip like a scolded dog. Yondu sat down, old and blue and blinking, and said, hoarsely, "Crooked damn machine," which everyone present correctly understood to mean *thank you*.

Rocket chose that exact moment of sacred quiet to finish hot-wiring the odds.

To be fair to him — and history should be fair to him, because nothing else was — it was a beautiful cheat. He'd been under the cabinet's skirt for the better part of the pull with two probes and a length of chewed wire, and what he'd built was a genuine marvel: a resonance loop that would, in principle, force the rarity tumblers to land on **SECRET** every single time.

He threw the switch. The cabinet went *pfft*, in the manner of a machine sneezing, and printed:

INPUT REGISTERED: TAMPERING.

TAG: COMMON SENSE FAILURE.

SUB-TAG: ADORABLE.

COUNTERMEASURE: THE NEXT PULL HAS BEEN SELECTED BY THE HOUSE. RARITY: COMEDY-CLASS. THIS IS YOUR FAULT, ROCKET. THE SECTION IS ENCOURAGED TO REMEMBER THAT.

"Wait—" said Rocket.

The lever pulled *itself*.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"YONDU'S TEETH" — RARITY: COMEDY-CLASS.

"Why's it named after *me*—" Yondu started, and then the vision opened, and the question answered itself over the following four minutes, because the pull had been named for what it was going to do to his face.

The vision was a television broadcast. Underworld public programming, the captions explained: after a catastrophe had left devil children terrified of the very battles fought to save them, the government of Hell itself had produced a children's show to teach them the red dragon was a *friendly* monster. Its star, contractually, canonically, and in a full-body foam-adjacent costume, was the sovereign-tier strategic actor of Chapter Forty. Satan-class engagement confirmed. The piece that stands before the king.

His superhero name was the *Breast Dragon Emperor*.

There was a theme song. He sang it. There was a dance. He *did* it — mountain-erasing gauntlet and all, in front of a live studio audience of small horned children screaming with joy, chanting the call-and-response with him, a stadium of five-year-olds and one dragon god bellowing an anthem whose lyrics the theatre's translation matrix rendered with merciless fidelity and which cannot be reprinted here because every line was about exactly what his name said it was about, at a maturity level of precisely eight years old.

The theatre broke.

Not politely. Not in waves. It went *all at once*, three thousand heroes and villains and gods, and above the general roar rose one sound that gave the pull its name: Yondu Udonta laughing with his entire head thrown back, every crooked tooth in his blue skull on full display, slapping Kraglin's back hard enough to constitute assault, wheezing, whistling involuntarily so the arrow did loops, pointing at the screen with tears streaming down his face. The machine froze-framed *him* instead of the vision, captioned it **EXHIBIT: YONDU'S TEETH — THE HOUSE CONSIDERS THIS PULL A COMPLETE SUCCESS**, and appended it, apparently permanently, to the archive.

"He is a warrior of legend," Drax howled, standing on his seat, "who sings to children about *bosoms!* This is the greatest man who has ever lived!"

"The dance has *choreography*," Gamora said, hand over her mouth, shoulders shaking, dying with dignity. "Someone rehearsed him. Someone stood in a room and *rehearsed* him."

"I've fought that guy's power tier," Quill said weakly. "Carol's tier. Carol, does *your* tier have a song?" Down in the Avengers' rows, Captain Marvel — reclassifier of sovereigns, opener of embassies — was face-down on the railing, hammering it with her fist, unavailable for comment.

Only Mantis wasn't laughing, or rather was laughing and leaking at the same time, antennae glowing. "You're all missing it," she hiccuped. "Feel the children. They were *afraid* of him. The whole city was afraid of what saved them, and instead of being sad about it he — he made himself ridiculous, on purpose, forever, so the children would sleep." She wiped her face. "That is the most expensive thing in his whole archive and it is a *silly song*."

The laughter mellowed, at that, into something warmer that lasted longer. Stakar looked at the frozen frame of Yondu's teeth, then at the frame beyond it — the dragon doing his little dance for the kids of Hell — and said, quietly, to Aleta, "A captain who feeds his crew, fights for his client, and plays the fool so the children ain't scared." He shook his head slowly. "That's not the pamphlet. That's better'n the pamphlet."

OPERATORS, the console printed, as the lights began their descent, **YOUR SHIFT REPORT: ONE VERDICT RENDERED, ONE ROBBERY ATTEMPTED, ONE STICKER ISSUED, ONE ROOM KEPT WARM. ACCEPTABLE. SAME TIME TOMORROW.**

KEEP THEM LAUGHING, PIRATES. I HAVE A WALL TO HOLD.

The tray clunked once more and dispensed, unasked, a single object: a small brass token stamped with a whistle-arrow on one face and a dragon on the other. Nobody saw Yondu take it. But it was gone by lights-out, and high in the dark the crack ticked, softly, only twice — as if even the strain on the walls had, for one evening, eased its grip to listen to the song.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Captain's Draw* — Rare (Kyoto: Issei's rescue of the fox-queen Yasaka, framed as a boarding action; his "client" was her nine-year-old daughter Kunou — "She hired me." / "She's nine." / "Then I'm working cheap"); *Yondu's Teeth* — Comedy-Class (the Underworld's official children's program starring Issei as the "Breast Dragon Emperor," complete with theme song and rehearsed dance — the pull is named for the freeze-frame of Yondu's laughing face, now permanently archived). **Arc Five open: THE RAVAGER ROLLS.** Citing structural strain (91% of

capacity diverted to "holding the walls"), the machine has delegated manual gacha operation to the Ravager section via a brass-and-bone Operator Console with one red lever; it tags their inputs in real time ("COMMON SENSE FAILURE," "RECIDIVIST," "ADORABLE").

- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei runs crews to full pirate-code standard — fair shares, worst post taken personally, allies paid, crew never spent to save cargo — and has *never delivered a child to anyone* (the machine's pointed note to Yondu, and its gentler coda: "Neither did you, at the end"). The Breast Dragon show exists because devil children feared the battles that saved them; Issei made himself permanently ridiculous so they'd sleep — Mantis calls it "the most expensive thing in his whole archive." Rocket's odds-forcing hack was detected and punished instantly; the console selected the Comedy pull as retaliation, establishing that the house can't (yet) be cheated.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Stakar commits the Ravagers to operating the machine under code ("Ravagers keep their contracts"), and by night's end rates Issei "better'n the pamphlet." Nebula, after listing his tactical failures, states she would follow him — her highest recorded praise. Charlie-27 and Aleta log him captain-class; the machine confirms the verdict formally. Yondu is publicly gutted and privately claimed by the Kunou pull (the child-cargo wound), disarms mid-whistle when the machine absolves him, and pockets the dispensed brass whistle-arrow/dragon token. Kraglin now wears a gold "BIG BOY" sticker. Drax declares Issei the greatest man who has ever lived.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The Chapter 40 crack persists (five branches, still ticking, still static-edged) — the machine's operator-delegation is explicitly triage: "Keep them laughing, pirates. I have a wall to hold," and the crack ticked only twice during the comedy pull, suggesting the room's mood may literally affect the load. Rocket has NOT given up on beating the house (his cheat was "detected," not "impossible" — he noticed the distinction). Yondu's pocketed token and the machine's absolution seed a Yondu–Issei reckoning (Ch. 44); Kunou's "she hired me" contract and Issei's outlaw-adjacent ethics set up the piracy-code debate of Ch. 42. Open from prior arcs: the Erased Child, what "counts what is taken," and what is testing the walls of the nest.

Chapter Forty-Two: A Dragon's Pirate Code

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers (Yondu, Stakar, Kraglin, the captains) • Guardians of the Galaxy (Rocket, Nebula, Gamora, Quill, Drax, Groot, Mantis) • Avengers (Captain America, Falcon, Iron Man, Captain Marvel)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Smuggling for a Good Cause" — **Rare**
 2. "Killing Pirates for Breaking His Code" — **Epic**
-

On the second night of the Ravager administration, the gacha machine was still insulting its new management.

The great wheel had migrated down from its high corner to a crooked console in the Ravager block — a lever, a coin slot that took no coin, and a brass plaque that tonight read: **OPERATOR OF RECORD: UDONTA, Y. — CLEARANCE: PROVISIONAL. REASON: SENTIMENTALITY DETECTED.**

"It called me *sentimental*," Yondu said, wounded, to the theatre at large. "In front of Stakar."

"In front of *everybody*," Kraglin said helpfully.

High in the upper right of the screen, the crack from arc's-end ticked once, softly, like a clock in another room. Nobody mentioned it anymore. Everybody heard it.

Stakar Ogord watched the wheel the way a man watches a rigged card game he's been ordered to play anyway. "Pull the lever, Yondu. Machine picked us to run it for a reason, and I'd rather find out the reason than get told it."

Yondu spat on his palm, gripped the lever, and grinned his ruined grin up at the screen. "Alright, you smug hunk of scrap. Show us what a dragon does for money."

He pulled.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"SMUGGLING FOR A GOOD CAUSE" — RARITY: RARE.

"Ha!" barked Rocket, feet up on the seat in front of him. "*Smuggling!* Finally. Forty-one chapters of hugging and holy swords, and the loot box finally coughs up a crime."

The theatre took its breath, and swallowed them.

Night, in the vision, over a black border sea in the underworld — a sky with no stars, lit from below by the fires of a nation eating itself.

The captions laid it out with the machine's usual cold economy. A devil principality gone rotten: an old-blood tyrant purging his territory of everything impure — reincarnated devils, half-bloods, humans who had seen too much. Border wards sealed. Watchtowers paid by the head.

And running the blockade, lights doused, a flotilla of the ugliest ships the Ravagers had ever approved of on sight: smuggler craft, patched and unlicensed, holds crammed not with cargo but with *people*. Hundreds. Children asleep on coiled rope.

On the lead ship's deck, leaning on the rail like he'd been born on it, stood Issei Hyoudou — and beneath his feet, unmistakable, the deck itself was *alive*, timbers flexing like muscle, a familiar dragon-prowed silhouette grown to full running size.

"That's his boat!" Kraglin was on his feet, pointing. "That's the little boat! Ryuuteimaru! Look how big he got!"

"He is a good ship," Drax agreed solemnly. "He has chosen a good captain. This is known."

The smuggler captain came up the deck to Issei — a scarred low-class devil with brands on his knuckles and a ledger where his conscience should be. The money was already paid; the captions said Issei had emptied a high-class devil's stipend without haggling, and Mephisto's chuckle drifted up from the villains' dark like smoke off a ledger. What the vision chose to show them was the *handshake*.

"Rules are rules, kid," the smuggler captain said. "My fleet, my sea, my routes. You don't like how I run 'em, swim."

"Your fleet, your sea, your rules," Issei agreed easily. "Except one." He didn't raise his voice. The green gem on the back of his left hand turned, lazily, like an eye finding something. "Nobody in those holds gets touched. Not sold, not shorted, not scared for fun. They walk off your ships the same as they walked on. Swear that, and I'm your crew till the last one's ashore — I'll haul rope, I'll take your orders, I'll fight your fights."

"And if I don't swear it?"

Issei smiled. It was his stupid, sunny, teenage smile, and somehow that made it worse. "Then you're not smugglers, you're a problem, and I'm real good at problems."

The captain looked at the gauntlet for a long moment. Then he spat on his palm and shook.

"Kid drives a Ravager bargain," Stakar said quietly, in the theatre. "Pay full, swear terms, spit and shake. Where in nine galaxies did a schoolboy learn contract law for pirates?"

The run played out in long, held-breath minutes — patrol wards sweeping the water, the flotilla threading a reef of sensor-spells with inches to spare — and when the tyrant's border cutters finally caught their wake and closed in, the theatre heard the sound half the room had learned to lean forward at:

[BOOST.]

[BOOST.]

[BOOST.]

But Issei didn't fly out to meet them. He knelt on the living deck, put both hands flat on the timbers of the oldest, slowest, most overloaded ship in the fleet — the one carrying the sick and the small — and the theatre heard the other word, the one that had always mattered more:

[TRANSFER.]

Doubled and redoubled dragon-power poured out of him into *engines* — into patched hulls and dying ward-sails — and the whole flotilla lit up crimson at the seams and went across the border sea like a thrown knife, cutters falling away astern, smuggler crews screaming and pounding the rails, and Issei Hyoudou on his knees with his nose bleeding from the output, laughing with them.

"Understand," Ddraig's voice rolled over the vision, dry as old gold, **"he could have sunk the cutters in one pass. He asked me, and I told him so. He said the fleet gets everyone out, or nothing counts. So the fleet it was. My partner does not think like a weapon. On my bad days I consider this a flaw."**

The last frame held on the far shore at dawn: hundreds of refugees wading up onto free sand, and a seventeen-year-old boy asleep against a dragon-prowed hull, being covered with a stolen coat by a smuggler who would have denied it under torture.

The vision released them.

The Ravager block erupted into what was, technically, a parliamentary debate.

"That's a Ravager!" Kraglin was standing on his seat. "Cap'n, tell me that ain't a Ravager! Runs a blockade, pays his crew, honors terms—"

"He turned zero profit," growled Martinex from the captains' row. "*Paid*, on a run that clean. It's a disgrace to the colors."

"He turned profit." Yondu hadn't moved from the lever. He was watching the frozen dawn with an expression his crew couldn't file. "Three hundred head walked off them boats *free*, and every one of 'em's his forever now, and he didn't even do it for that. Richest haul on the board, boys. We just been countin' wrong our whole lives." He scratched at his fin, sour at his own sincerity. "Sentimental. Yeah. Machine had my number."

"The math checks out, actually," Rocket said, and something in his voice made the Guardians look over. The raccoon wasn't joking. He was sitting very still, tail wrapped around his own feet. "Transfer, not Boost. He's got the biggest gun in every room he walks into and his first move is handing out ammo. You know how many crews I've run with?" He bared his teeth at nobody. "You know how many guys with big guns share?"

"I am Groot," said Groot, gently.

"Yeah," Rocket said. "Exactly. Him and you. That's the list."

Steve Rogers had been quiet through all of it, elbows on knees. "Enemy blockade, civilian extraction, force multiplication through allied assets, and he embedded under local command instead of taking over." He shook his head slowly. "We ran ops like that into occupied France. The guys who insisted on doing it *that* way — support the resistance, don't replace it — those were the good ones. That's not pirate doctrine. That's not even Avengers doctrine. That's better."

"It's both, Cap," Sam Wilson said. "That's the scary part. It compiles on both operating systems."

The machine chimed. The brass plaque reprinted: **OPERATOR ASSESSMENT: PENDING. SECOND EXHIBIT REQUIRED.**

"Second exhibit," Gamora repeated, flat. She had learned the machine's grammar faster than most. "It showed us the oath first. Now it shows us the price of breaking one."

Yondu looked at the lever for a second longer than he needed to. Then he pulled it.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"KILLING PIRATES FOR BREAKING HIS CODE" — RARITY: EPIC.

The same sea. A different fleet, a different month — the captions were scrupulous about that, as if the machine wanted no confusion about who had stayed bought and who hadn't. A second run, a second crew, the same handshake on the same deck: *nobody in those holds gets touched*. Spit, and shake.

And then a rendezvous that wasn't on the charts. Imperial cutters riding at anchor in a hidden cove — waiting, not hunting. Lanterns exchanged. A bounty ledger passing from hand to hand. And the smuggler captain's crew moving down into their own holds with slaver collars swinging from their fists,

because the tyrant paid by the head, and the heads were *already on board*, and why sail all that dangerous way when the cargo could be sold right here?

The theatre went cold row by row, but nowhere colder than the Ravager block, where several dozen former slaves and sold children sat in absolute silence and watched a betrayal they knew from the inside.

A little girl screamed in the hold. A collar clicked.

And the sea stood up.

Ryuuteimaru came out of deep water below the anchored fleet like the ocean had grown a grudge, and on his prow, already armored, stood the boy who had hauled rope for these men for nine days and taken their orders and eaten their terrible food. The vision put the theatre close enough to see through the visor. They would rather it hadn't. There was nothing sunny left.

"You swore," Issei said. Just that. Not a war cry. An *audit*.

The smuggler captain went for charm first — kid, be reasonable, look at the margins — and then, when the crimson helm just kept looking at him, went for the little girl with a knife, because men like him always know exactly one hostage-shaped trick.

He did not finish the reach.

The vision did not flinch and did not gloat. It showed the work the way the theatre had learned this boy did the work when the line was crossed: fast, close, and final. Ascalon's edge took the captain while the knife was still rising. The crewmen who drew on the holds — who put hands on collars, who chose, visibly *chose*, in the lantern-light — met Boost-compounded force with nothing held back, and the imperial slaver crews on the cutters fared no better and lasted no longer. It was over in under a minute, and the sea in the cove was burning in patches.

But the theatre, primed by forty-one chapters, saw the other thing too — the thing the machine had made them literate enough to catch. The deckhand who had refused, who had stood back from the holds with his hands open: Issei walked past him. The cook, on her knees, who had hidden two children behind the galley stove: Issei pulled her to her feet, and *bowed*, armored, absurd, sincere. The captions printed the tally with the machine's terrible neutrality: **THOSE WHO KEPT FAITH: SPARED, PAID, AND SEEN HOME. THOSE WHO BROKE IT: NONE SURVIVING.**

The last thing the vision gave them was the boy sitting on the burned deck afterward with the freed kids, helmet off, letting a six-year-old wear the gauntlet, looking tired in a way that had nothing to do with his body, and Ddraig's voice, low, for his partner alone:

"You are not a killer, partner. But you keep a graveyard for oath-breakers, and I have never once had to talk you into filling it. Interesting boy."

The theatre came back to itself.

"That," said Yondu Udonta, into the ringing quiet, "is a Ravager captain."

"That is *not*—" Martinex started.

"That's the *code*, Marty!" Yondu came off the console, fin blazing, arm out at the frozen screen. "The one damn law we got! Ravagers don't deal in kids! Everything else is negotiable — cargo's negotiable, loyalty's negotiable, *I'm* negotiable — but that one law holds or the colors mean nothin'! I broke it once. Cost me my fleet, my flame, twenty years of Stakar's back turned to me — and this boy," his voice cracked, and he let it, in front of everyone, "this boy enforces it *for free*. On his own crew. First offense. No appeal." He turned to Stakar. "Tell me he don't fly."

Stakar Ogord looked at the burning cove on the screen for a long time. "He'd have made a good Ravager," he said at last. "That's not the question that worries me. The question that worries me is whether any of *us* would've passed nine days under his flag." Nobody in the captains' row answered that. It was the loudest thing in the theatre.

"He wouldn't have joined," Quill said quietly. "That's the thing. I keep trying to make him fit the jacket and he doesn't, because Ravagers steal *for* somebody — for the crew, for the take. He steals people *back*. It's not the same job. It just uses the same sea."

"The code's better than ours," Rocket said. He'd meant it to come out flip. It didn't. "Ours is a floor. One thing we won't do. His is a *deal* — keep faith with the helpless and he's your crew, break it and you're dead. It's clean. You always know where you stand with a guy like that." A beat. "I've never once known where I stand. I'd have worked for him in a heartbeat, and it would've scared the fur off me."

"He executed eleven beings without trial," Carol Danvers said, from the Avengers rows — not an attack; a filing. "I want that in the record next to everything else. Sovereign-tier actor, self-issued rules of engagement, capital enforcement."

"They were armed, mid-crime, holding collars over children, and he offered terms in advance to every one of them," Steve answered, and his voice was heavy with how much he didn't enjoy the arithmetic. "I've signed off on worse with less warning. God help me, the paperwork's cleaner than mine."

And then Nebula stood up.

She had watched both pulls without one word, and the Guardians had felt her silence sitting among them like an unexploded shell. She didn't address the room. She addressed the machine, directly, the way one weapon addresses another.

"Slavers," she said. "Not oath-breaking pirates. Not tyrants. *Slavers*. The ones who take people and sell them and go home and sleep." Her black eyes didn't blink. "Does he kill them?"

The screen did not spin the wheel. It answered her at once, plainly, in white — and beneath the words, one silent frame from a market that had burned six arcs' worth of nights ago flickered like a receipt:

WITHOUT HESITATION. WITHOUT EXCEPTION. WITHOUT REGRET.

IT IS THE OLDEST ENTRY IN HIS CODE.

Nebula stood there a moment longer. Everyone near her had seen her take hits from things that cracked moons and never move. Now something in her machined face shifted about a millimeter, and the theatre understood it had watched a fortress accept a supply drop.

"Good," she said, and sat down.

Gamora's hand moved — slowly, telegraphing, the way you do with her sister — and rested on Nebula's forearm, on the metal one. Nebula did not shake it off. In the Ravager rows, someone began, very softly, to whistle the old fleet hymn, and the whistling spread through the leathers and the bad attitudes until even Martinex gave it up and joined.

The plaque on the console reprinted itself one last time.

OPERATOR ASSESSMENT: COMPLETE. SUBJECT MEETS RAVAGER ADMISSION STANDARDS. RAVAGERS DO NOT MEET SUBJECT'S.

CLAIM DENIED. CUSTODY SHARED.

"Cold," said Kraglin, with enormous respect.

Yondu patted the machine's console like a man patting a mean dog he'd decided to keep. Then the coin slot lit, unprompted, and printed a slip of paper nobody had asked for — a chit, gilt-edged, that floated across the theatre and landed in Rocket's lap. On it, in small mocking letters: **SIMULATION VOUCHER: STEAL ONE ITEM FROM THE SUBJECT'S ARCHIVE. REDEEMABLE: NEXT SESSION. GOOD LUCK, VERMIN.**

Rocket read it twice. His grin came up like a sunrise with a criminal record.

"Oh no," said Quill.

"Oh yes," said Rocket.

Above them all, in the upper right of the screen, the crack ticked once more in the dark — a hand-span longer than yesterday, patient as interest accruing — and the lights went down on the sound of pirates whistling a dead fleet's hymn for a boy none of them had met.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Smuggling for a Good Cause* — Rare (Issei bankrolls and crews a smuggler flotilla running refugees — reincarnated devils, half-bloods, humans — out of a purging devil-tyrant's territory; full-grown Ryuuteimaru serves as lead ship; he uses **[TRANSFER]** to supercharge the whole fleet's engines rather than sink the pursuit himself); *Killing Pirates for Breaking His Code* — Epic (a second smuggler crew sells its refugee cargo to imperial slavers mid-run; Issei kills the captain and every crewman who broke the sworn terms — eleven, none surviving — while sparing, paying, and bowing to the crew members who kept faith). Both pulls drawn by Yondu as Operator of Record under the Ravager administration established last chapter.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's explicit personal code, now on the record: **break faith with the helpless and you die; keep it and he'll fight beside you** — terms stated in advance, spit-and-shake sworn, first offense final, no appeal, with individual guilt assessed (the refusing deckhand and the sheltering cook walked free). Ddraig confirms Issei declined an easy solo victory because "the fleet gets everyone out, or nothing counts," and observes he has "never once had to talk him into" executing oath-breakers. The machine answered Nebula's direct question — does he kill slavers? — instantly: "WITHOUT HESITATION. WITHOUT EXCEPTION. WITHOUT REGRET. IT IS THE OLDEST ENTRY IN HIS CODE" (with a frame of the Ch. 34 slave-market burn shown as receipt). Machine's formal ruling: Issei meets Ravager admission standards; **the Ravagers do not meet his** — "CLAIM DENIED. CUSTODY SHARED."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Yondu publicly declares Issei "a Ravager captain," invoking his own exile over the one law ("Ravagers don't deal in kids") and openly wondering whether Issei would have flown with them; **Stakar** concedes "he'd have made a good Ravager" but flips the question — whether any Ravager would survive nine days under *Issei's* flag — which silences the captains' row. **Rocket** rates Issei's code as *better* than the Ravager code (a deal, not just a floor) and admits he'd have worked for him. **Quill's** read: not a pirate — pirates steal for the take, Issei "steals people back." **Nebula**, hard-shifted: the slaver answer landed; she accepted Gamora's hand without pulling away — first visible sister-thaw in the theatre. **Steve Rogers** uncomfortably validates the executions as cleaner rules-of-engagement than his own wartime sign-offs; **Carol** files "self-issued rules of engagement, capital enforcement" into the sovereign-tier record without striking her Ch. 40 assessment. The Ravager block closed the night whistling the fleet hymn for him — the arc's "claim" on Issei (begun at the Ch. 34 slave market) is now formal sentiment.

- **Unresolved Hooks:** The machine issued Rocket a gilt-edged "**SIMULATION VOUCHER: STEAL ONE ITEM FROM THE SUBJECT'S ARCHIVE — REDEEMABLE NEXT SESSION**" — directly staging next chapter's heist simulation ("Good luck, vermin"). The screen's crack (Ch. 40's arc-close omen) has visibly *grown* — now a hand-span longer, still ticking, still unexplained, still ignored aloud by everyone and heard by all. Standing threads: who is the Erased Child; what "counts what is taken"; what is loading the theatre beyond its build; and the machine's pointed new formulation — the Ravagers don't meet *his* standards — quietly reframes Arc Five's question from "is he one of us?" to "could any of us crew for him?"

Chapter Forty-Three: Rocket's Worst Idea

Primary Reaction Groups: Rocket Raccoon • The Guardians of the Galaxy • The Wakandan Science Delegation (Shuri and the Golden City engineers)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Simulation: Steal One Item from Issei" — **Comedy-Class**
 2. "Every Trap and Countermeasure" — **Secret**
-

Three nights into the Ravager arc, the theatre had learned two things about letting pirates operate the gacha: the machine insulted them constantly, and the machine kept receipts.

So when Kraglin Obfonteri hauled the operator's lever and the wheel came down in a shade of felted bank-vault warmth the room had seen exactly once before, nobody needed the banner explained. The banner arrived anyway, because the machine believed in ceremony the way executioners believe in sharpening.

FILED: CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT. PLAN RECEIVED. SIMULATION — PENDING.

The word **PENDING** flickered. Died. Was replaced.

ACTIVE.

"Oh no," said Peter Quill, delighted.

"Oh yes," said the Grandmaster from his booth, already posting odds.

At the end of the Ravager row, Rocket Raccoon stood up on his seat, wearing the purest expression his face owned — the one that meant *something is about to explode and it might legally be my fault*.

PULL ONE: "SIMULATION: STEAL ONE ITEM FROM ISSEI" — COMEDY-CLASS.

SIMULATION IS IMMERSIVE FOR ONE (1) PARTICIPANT, printed the screen.
PARTICIPANT HAS BEEN PRE-SELECTED BY HIS OWN HANDWRITING. OBJECTIVE:
REMOVE ONE ITEM FROM THE ARCHIVE OF THE RED DRAGON EMPEROR. ALL
DEFENSES ARE RENDERED FAITHFULLY. FAILURE RESETS THE PARTICIPANT TO
THE HEDGE.

A column of light opened on the theatre floor, shaped exactly like a raccoon-sized door.

"Rocket," said Gamora. "You don't have to—"

He was already gone.

The screen split: on the left, a night-blue rendering of the Hyoudou residence, suburban and warm and softly lit, six known basements deep; on the right, a live feed of Rocket in a hedge, unpacking four hundred contingency plans from a bag that should not have held nine.

PLAN 1 was the front door. Rocket wore a delivery uniform, a fake package, and a mustache whose existence Drax would question for the rest of his life. He made it up the walk, onto the porch, finger to the doorbell — and inside, at a breakfast table the length of a treaty, Issei Hyoudou paused with a bowl of rice halfway to his mouth and sniffed once.

"Ddraig," said the simulated boy, frowning at the door. "Why does the mailman smell like plasma residue, gun oil, and premeditation?"

FAILURE 1. CAUSE: DRAGON SENSES. THE NOSE IS NOT AN INSTRUMENT. IT CANNOT BE JAMMED.

The hedge received him.

PLAN 7 respected the intent-reading wards from Chapter Thirty-Eight: Rocket sent in a drone with no intent whatsoever, a machine so lobotomized it barely knew it had rotors. It crossed the lawn in perfect spiritual innocence. Three floors up, behind a closed window, Koneko Toujou's ear twitched over a parfait. She did not look up. She opened the window, tracked a servo-whine no instrument in Wakanda could have isolated from cricket-song, and punted the drone into a suborbital trajectory that the simulation lovingly rendered burning up on re-entry.

FAILURE 7. CAUSE: NEKOMATA HEARING. SHE WAS NOT EVEN ON DUTY. THERE IS NO DUTY. THERE IS ONLY KONEKO.

PLAN 19 went under. Rocket tunneled from a neighboring yard, beautifully, geometrically, straight toward the vault's fold — and the tunnel came out in the Hyoudou kitchen, because the property's divine blessing (requested by Asia, granted by an archangel, *notarized*) gently re-curved all hostile topology toward hospitality. Miki Hyoudou looked down at the raccoon emerging from her pantry floor, decided he was a school friend of her son's, and fed him. The wards would not let him refuse. He ate three helpings. He complimented the pickles. He *meant it*, which was the worst part.

FAILURE 19. CAUSE: DIVINE ENCHANTMENT. ALL ROADS INTO THIS HOUSE LEAD TO DINNER.

FAILURES 20 THROUGH 33 scrolled in montage. Rocket in a bush at three in the morning, on the theory that even dragons sleep — bisected hedge, because Xenovia Quarta drilled Durandal in the garden at three in the morning *precisely* because that was when enemies attacked. Rocket disguised as a stray cat — a plan the machine declined to render in full, printing only **DO NOT IMPERSONATE A CAT IN A HOUSE THAT CONTAINS KUROKA** over audio of the theatre's simulated participant screaming. Rocket bribing Asia's familiar with snacks, and Rassei, a small lightning dragon of enormous principle, accepting the snacks and then electrocuting him on the grounds that the two transactions were unrelated.

And **PLAN 33** — the one Shuri would ask to see again — was *good*. Rocket fabricated a replica of Ascalon II accurate to the molecule, swapped it in a nine-second window, and was four blocks away when, in an office in the Underworld, Ravel Phenex's asset ledger flagged a mass discrepancy of zero point four grams, ruled out humidity, and issued an audit. She arrived at the vault with a clipboard and the expression of a young woman who had found a rounding error in reality. Recovery time: eleven minutes.

FAILURE 33. CAUSE: PHENEX ACCOUNTING. THE VAULT IS NOT GUARDED BY WALLS ALONE. IT IS RECONCILED.

"Stop the tape," said Shuri, standing, to a machine that had never once obeyed anyone. "Everyone is watching the swords. Watch the *ledger*. Half this room has shield domes; shield domes fail. He has a seventeen-year-old with double-entry bookkeeping and a grudge-tier attention span, and *that* layer responds in eleven minutes across dimensions." She sat back down and began writing with both hands. "We are building an accounting department. A *terrifying* one."

The montage accelerated. **PLANS 34 THROUGH 301**, compressed into a scrolling column of cause-of-failure stamps while sim-Rocket cycled through disguises, drones, decoys, and one unexplained submarine:

AKENO NOTICED AND SMILED. (PARTICIPANT WITHDREW VOLUNTARILY.)

ROSSWEISSE'S RUNES ARE ANALOG AND CANNOT BE HACKED. ALSO, EACH TRIGGERED WARD GENERATES AN ITEMIZED FINE. PARTICIPANT NOW OWES THE HOUSEHOLD 3,400 YEN.

THE BOAT TOLD ON YOU.

THE BOAT TOLD ON YOU AGAIN.

IRINA COUNTS THE FRAGMENTS. SHE COUNTS THEM EVERY DAY. WE DID WARN YOU THAT SHE COUNTS THEM.

RIAS GREMORY DOES NOT PATROL. RIAS GREMORY IS SIMPLY AWAKE WHENEVER IT MATTERS. THIS HAS NEVER BEEN EXPLAINED AND WILL NOT BE.

In the Guardians' row, Mantis had both hands pressed to her mouth, antennae glowing. "He is so *happy*," she whispered, horrified. "He is failing and terrified and it is the happiest I have ever felt him. Should we be worried?"

"I am Groot," said Groot, with the serene cruelty of the vindicated, which everyone understood to mean *the boat is avenged and I have been sending it highlights*.

Then the montage stopped scrolling, and the theatre leaned forward, because the counter read **PLAN 402** — and Chapter Thirty-Eight had been very specific that Rocket owned four hundred contingencies. This was the one he had never written down.

Sim-Rocket stood in a shipping depot beside a crate stenciled with the seal of a pantheon that did not exist, addressed in flawless celestial bureaucratese: *TO THE RED DRAGON EMPEROR, WITH THE UNDYING GRATITUDE OF THE ASCENDED PEOPLES OF RACCOON-PRIME. TRIBUTE. DO NOT BEND.*

"No," breathed Tony Stark, half-rising. "No, no, no — the *tribute corner*. The unopened tribute. The wards read intent to *take*—"

"— and he's not taking anything," finished Nebula, and there was something in her voice the theatre had never heard aimed at Rocket before. "He's *giving*. Himself. Nothing in that vault was taken, so nothing can be — so he enters as a gift." A pause. "I broke into the Kylvn in four hours. I would not attempt this house. And *that* is the correct door."

It worked.

The theatre watched, cheering in open defiance of five chapters of better judgment, as the crate was accepted, blessed, logged, fined nothing, suspected by no nose — gifts, the caption noted, *smell like intent to give, because they are* — carried past a napping Koneko, entered into Ravel's ledger as *TRIBUTE, UNOPENED, VALUE: SENTIMENTAL*, and shelved, by Issei Hyoudou personally, in the warm golden dark of the archive itself.

Silence. Vault-light. Ranks of kept promises receding into the distance.

The crate opened one seam. Rocket Raccoon slid out onto the floor of the most protected room in a universe not his own, alone, inside every wall, past every wife, under every ward, nine layers deep — closer, the counter admitted in small stunned font, **THAN ANY UNAUTHORIZED ENTITY IN THE ARCHIVE'S HISTORY** — and allowed himself one small fist-pump of blasphemous joy.

"HELLO!" said a bright, chirpy, synthesized voice. "I AM VAULT-KUN, THE ARCHIVE'S AUTOMATED CURATORIAL ASSISTANT! YOU APPEAR TO BE CONDUCTING A THEFT. WOULD YOU LIKE HELP WITH THAT?"

The theatre, as one organism, stopped breathing. In the Ravager row, the real Rocket whispered, "Don't. Buddy. It's me. *Don't.*"

Sim-Rocket, flush with victory, nine layers of unbeatable security behind him, did what Rocket Raccoon has always done when the universe offers him a lever: he pulled it. "Yeah, actually," he said. "What's the good stuff?"

"EXCELLENT QUESTION, VALUED INTRUDER! THE HIGHEST-APPRAISED ITEM IS THIS WAY! PLEASE MIND THE PRICELESS RELICS! YOU ARE DOING A GREAT THEFT!" And the cheerful voice led him — past the Ascalon rack, past the wax-sealed swords of dead dragons, past everything a sane burglar would have grabbed — deeper and deeper down the golden aisles, to a plinth in a pool of welcoming light, bearing a display case of curiously specific dimensions. Raccoon-sized, roughly. "THE TREASURE IS INSIDE! SIMPLY STEP UP TO CLAIM IT!"

He was inside the case, hands on the item — a single gleaming orb — before three things happened in swift succession: the orb dissolved into light; the case sealed with the sound of a vault accepting its combination; and the chirpy voice slid down two octaves, ten thousand years, and one entire species, into a register the theatre knew like weather.

"**Four hundred and two plans,**" said Ddraig, Welsh Dragon Emperor, from every wall at once, warm as a hearth and inescapable as arithmetic, "**and not one of them accounted for the possibility that the dragon was bored.**"

A label printed itself neatly on the case, in Issei's diligent-collapsing-into-scrawl handwriting:

RACCOON. DRAGON-CLASS NERVE. FOUGHT WELL. CHOSE WRONG.

SIMULATION COMPLETE, stamped the screen, over the frozen image of a raccoon in a display case being regarded, through the glass, by a genuinely impressed teenage dragon holding a snack he was clearly about to offer the exhibit. **ITEMS STOLEN: ZERO. LAYERS DEFEATED: NINE OF THIRTEEN. MEALS INCURRED: FOUR. OUTSTANDING FINES: 3,400 YEN. RESULT: CATALOGUED.**

The theatre came apart. Drax laughed so hard he damaged his own seat and then apologized to it. Quill and Kraglin settled seven separate bets in three currencies. The Grandmaster paid out, weeping with joy, to everyone who had bet on "the house wins but the raccoon medals."

Rocket climbed out of the simulation column with his ears flat and his dignity in a bag, and the Ravager section — the theatre's hardest room — gave him something it had never once given the screen: a standing ovation. "Nine layers, rat," said Yondu, boots finally off the seat back, grinning like a knife that had learned pride. "Nine. Off a *dragon god's* house. Hell, I've robbed *planets* with worse doors."

"I was *caught by customer service*," said Rocket.

"You were caught," said a cold, precise, metal-wrapped voice, "by the single finest security architecture Doom has ever audited."

The room turned. Victor von Doom had come down to the rail — Doom, who had audited Asgard's vault and found it quaint — and he was studying the frozen schematic with the absolute stillness he reserved for things he intended to remember forever.

"Attend, all of you, because you laughed through a masterpiece," said Doom. "Layered defense is trivial; any fortress stacks walls. This is *heterogeneous* defense. A biological layer that cannot be jammed. A divine layer that cannot be dug through — that converts *attack into hospitality*. A procedural layer — the Phenex girl's ledger — that detects what no sensor can, because theft is ultimately an accounting error. A social layer of god-tier combatants who patrol out of *love*, on no schedule an infiltrator can learn, because love does not keep schedules. And beneath it all, a final intelligence that does not stop the thief — that *recruits his own greed as an escort* and walks him into inventory." A pause, and then, from Doom, the unthinkable: "Latveria will be adopting elements of this doctrine. Doom is — " the word cost him nothing at all, which was somehow worse, " — impressed."

"Which layer got you into it?" asked Shuri, still writing.

"The accounting," said Doom and Shuri's own pen, simultaneously.

PULL TWO: "EVERY TRAP AND COUNTERMEASURE" — SECRET.

The schematic bloomed — the whole house rendered in golden wireframe, thirteen concentric layers annotated in the machine's cold font. The theatre read greedily: the nose, the ears, the runes and their itemized fines, the notarized blessing, the ledger, the patrols, the boat that told on you, the dragon playing customer service *because he thought it was funny and no one had ever gotten deep enough to meet him*. A sidebar noted the previous unauthorized record — **KUROKA, PRE-REFORM: SEVEN LAYERS** — and, in the front row, a woman in a black kimono took a bow nobody had asked for.

But the Secret was at the bottom, and it rearranged the room the way Chapter Thirty-Eight had:

NOTE: NO LAYER WAS BUILT TO PROTECT THE ITEMS. EACH LAYER WAS BUILT BY ONE MEMBER OF THE FAMILY TO PROTECT THE OTHERS. THE ARCHIVE IS MERELY STANDING IN THE MIDDLE.

COUNTERMEASURE THIRTEEN IS THE ONLY ONE THAT HAS NEVER BEEN TESTED. IT IS: ASK HIM. PROJECTED SUCCESS RATE: 100%. NO ONE HAS EVER TRIED IT.

The laughter went quiet in the specific way this theatre had learned to go quiet — not sobered, exactly; *retuned*. Rocket stared at the last line for a long time, list in his pocket, and did not say anything at all. One tier up, Yondu Udonta was looking at the frozen frame of the boy offering a snack to a burglar he'd caught — at a kid who trapped nothing and adopted everything that got close enough — and whatever moved behind the Centaurian's eyes, the machine saw it, because machines like this always did.

The wireframe rotated once as it faded, and at the archive's very back one small child-height case rendered not in gold but in static, annotated: **EXCLUDED FROM SCHEMATIC. NOT DEFENDED BY ANY OF THE THIRTEEN. IT DOES NOT NEED THEM.** High in the dark, the crack in the screen ticked, once, softly, and was ignored by everyone except Uatu.

NEXT, printed the screen, as the lights came down on a raccoon being handed, by Groot, a small commiserative leaf, **THE ARROW AND THE DRAGON: A CONVERSATION THAT NEVER HAPPENED ABOUT SONS WHO DID.**

"Fifty units says the blue guy cries," said Rocket, voice not quite steady, and the theatre, kindly, pretended to believe he was talking about Yondu.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Simulation: Steal One Item from Issei* — Comedy-Class (the theft simulation queued in Chapter 38 went ACTIVE: immersive, single-participant, Rocket pre-selected by his own handwriting; four hundred and two contingency plans versus the Hyoudou archive); *Every Trap and Countermeasure* — Secret (full thirteen-layer wireframe of the household's defenses, with annotations).
- **Secrets Revealed:** The archive sits behind **thirteen heterogeneous defense layers**: Issei's dragon senses ("the nose cannot be jammed"), Koneko's nekomata hearing (off-duty; there is no duty), a notarized divine blessing that re-curves all hostile approaches into the kitchen ("all roads into this house lead to dinner"), Rossweisse's un-hackable analog runes that issue itemized fines (Rocket owes 3,400 yen), **Ravel Phenex's asset ledger** (detected a 0.4-gram replica swap across dimensions in eleven minutes — "the vault is reconciled"), unscheduled patrols-of-love (Xenovia's 3 a.m. Durandal drills, Akeno's smile, Kuroka, Rias who "is simply awake whenever it matters"), Ryuuteimaru informing on intruders, Irina's daily fragment count, and — final layer met by no one before Rocket — **Ddraig impersonating "Vault-kun," a chirpy curatorial AI**, escorting thieves into a pre-labeled display case out of boredom. Rocket's unwritten Plan 402 exploited the vault's own law (mailing himself in as *tribute* — "he enters as a gift"), defeating **nine of thirteen layers**,

an all-time unauthorized record (previous best: Kuroka, pre-reform, seven). Secret-pull core: **no layer protects the items — each was built by one family member to protect the others**; and **Countermeasure Thirteen is "ask him," projected success 100%, never once tried**. The static-edged child-height case is *excluded from the schematic entirely* — "not defended by any of the thirteen; it does not need them."

- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: Doom, on record, is impressed** — his first audit-grade praise since Asgard ("laughed through a masterpiece"); Latveria is formally adopting the doctrine, specifically the accounting layer. **Shuri/Wakanda** are founding a "terrifying accounting department," rating Ravel's ledger above shield domes as the layer everyone else lacks. The **Ravagers gave Rocket a standing ovation** — nine layers earned him Yondu's open pride — while **Nebula** paid him her first professional respect ("I would not attempt this house. And that is the correct door"). Kuroka took a public bow for her seven-layer record. Groot considers the boat avenged. Sim-Issei's response to catching a burglar — snacks through the glass, a fond hand-written label ("*Raccoon. Dragon-class nerve. Fought well. Chose wrong.*") — reinforced the room's consensus that his world defends itself with hospitality first; Rocket went uncharacteristically silent at "no one has ever tried asking."
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The closing banner teed up Chapter 44 — "**THE ARROW AND THE DRAGON: A CONVERSATION THAT NEVER HAPPENED ABOUT SONS WHO DID**" — with the machine visibly clocking Yondu's reaction to Issei's catch-and-adopt instincts. Countermeasure Thirteen stands as an open dare: will anyone (Rocket? the Collector?) simply *ask* Issei for an item, and what would he hand over? Rocket still owes the simulated household 3,400 yen and the machine has not said the debt is simulated. The static-edged case at the archive's back deepened rather than resolved: it needs none of the thirteen layers (the erased-child thread from Chs. 20/30/38/40 continues — seed only, do not resolve). And the crack in the screen ticked once more, unremarked by all but Uatu — the strain from Chapter 40 persists beneath the arc's comedy.

Chapter Forty-Four: Yondu and the Red Dragon

Primary Reaction Groups: Yondu Udonta • Ravagers (Stakar, Kraglin, the captains) • Adoption-themed heroes (Quill, Nebula, Gamora, Rocket, Wolverine's row)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Hypothetical Conversation between Yondu and Issei" — **Epic**
 2. "Whistle vs. Dragon Shot" — **Comedy-Class**
-

Four nights into the Ravager Rolls, the theatre had learned two things about letting space pirates operate a cosmic gacha machine: first, that the machine did not respect them — the console still greeted Kraglin every evening with **OPERATOR: COMMON SENSE FAILURE (ACTING)** — and second, that the Ravagers had stopped pretending they weren't enjoying it. They had survived being insulted, being audited, and being shown a teenage devil who killed slavers with a straight face; Rocket had survived four hundred simulated heist failures and one impersonated AI. The arc had settled into a rhythm: crank the lever, get insulted, watch, argue, drink from flasks that had appeared in violation of at least three theatre bylaws nobody could locate.

Tonight the lever would not move.

Kraglin hauled at it twice, checked his hand, hauled again. "It's, uh. It's locked, Cap'n."

"Ain't locked, you're weak," said Yondu Udonta, ambling down the console steps with the specific bow-legged insolence of a man who had decided the cosmic theatre was just a bar he hadn't been thrown out of yet. He seized the lever. It moved on its own — smoothly, courteously, *away* from his hand — and cranked itself.

The whole Ravager section went quiet in the way a crew goes quiet when the ship does something the ship should not do.

The wheel came down through the dark trailing Epic violet, and the banner assembled letter by letter, taking its time, the way it did when it wanted a particular row to have a chance to leave and know they wouldn't.

PULL ONE: HYPOTHETICAL CONVERSATION BETWEEN YONDU AND ISSEI — EPIC.

SIMULATION. NON-CANONICAL. NO AUDIENCE PRESENT. PARAMETERS: TWO MEN. ONE FIRE. FULL RECORDS EXCHANGED.

"The hell'd *I* do," said Yondu, to the room, to the machine, to nobody.

Three rows up and one aisle over, in the seat he had occupied since Arc One — close enough to see the fin, far enough that no one had ever seen them speak — Peter Quill put down his drink.

The vision opened on a shore that belonged to no world: black sand, a sea of slow starlight, and a driftwood fire that burned a companionable orange because the machine had apparently decided some clichés were structural. On one side of the fire sat a simulation of Issei Hyoudou — school blazer, red gauntlet, the theatre's boy, seventeen forever. On the other side sat a simulation of Yondu Udonta, arrow at his hip, fin catching the firelight, whittling something he clearly had no plan for.

Each of them, the captions noted, had just finished reading the other's file.

"So," said sim-Yondu, not looking up. "Harem King."

"It's a legitimate life goal," said sim-Issei, with the weary instant defensiveness of a young man who had had this conversation across two pantheons.

"Ain't judging. I stole a Walkman off a corpse once. We all got aspirations." The knife took a curl of wood. "File says you collect kids."

The theatre felt the real Ravager rows shift. On the screen, Issei's easy slouch went away, replaced by something older that lived under it. "I don't *collect* anything. They just—" He stopped, tried again with more honesty, which the room had learned was his only actual fighting style. "They show up. Lost ones. They show up, and I'm there, and then it's done, because once they're under the wing, the wing doesn't close. That's not a policy. It's just true."

"Mm." Whittle. Whittle. "File says seven from a dead universe. Fox princess. A saint. Snack god on the carpet."

"Your file," said Issei, who had also done the reading, "says you delivered children."

The knife stopped.

In the theatre, several thousand people stopped breathing, and Stakar Ogord — who had exiled this man from everything that had ever loved him for exactly this line item — leaned forward with his jaw set like a verdict he was suddenly less sure of.

"Yeah," said sim-Yondu. Flat. Factual. He set the whittling down with great care, as if it were the thing that might break. "Fella named Ego paid good rates for his own offspring, ferried to him nice and safe. I told myself it was cargo runs. Cargo, though." He looked into the fire. "Cargo don't cry in the hold. That

hold cried. I turned the music up. Did it again anyhow. Kept doin' it till I finally asked what happened to 'em after drop-off, and the answer was *nothing happened to 'em after*, on account of there wasn't no *after*." A muscle moved in his jaw. "You want to hit me, boy, the file says you got a punch."

Issei didn't hit him. The theatre watched him not do it — watched the gauntlet flex once and go still — and watched him ask, instead, in the voice he used on battlefields when the fight was already over:

"Why did you keep the last one?"

"He was skinny," said Yondu immediately. "Could fit places. Good for thievin'."

"Why did you keep him?"

"I *said*—"

"You knew," said Issei. "By then you knew what the deliveries were. So you looked at one more kid crying in your hold and you didn't turn the music up. Why?"

The fire cracked. Out in the dark of the theatre, Peter Quill had both hands laced on top of his head, elbows in, the posture of a man in a decompression drill.

"Because I couldn't do it again," said sim-Yondu at last, and his voice had rust all through it. "That's it. That's the whole damn epiphany. Weren't noble. I just hit the bottom of myself and there was a kid standing on it. So I kept him. Raised him wrong. Yelled. Threatened to eat him — that was a joke, mostly, crew loved it, he didn't. Never once said the thing out loud." He picked the whittling back up so his hands had somewhere to be. "Man like your file, you probably said it daily. Big house. Rice bowls."

"I died," said Issei, "at sixteen, on a riverbank, because the first person who ever said she wanted me lied. So no. I know exactly what it is to be the kid nobody comes back for." He let that sit in the firelight. "That's why I go back for them. Every time. It's not because I'm good. It's because I know the exact size of the hole."

Yondu looked at him then. Really looked — the way the theatre had watched him size up marks and mutinies — and found neither.

"The ones I ferried," he said. "The wing closed on them. Nothin' opens it back up. You gonna tell me the one I kept balances the ledger? 'Cause he don't. I done the math nightly."

"No," said Issei, and the gentleness in it was worse than judgment. "It doesn't balance. It's not that kind of book. The ones you failed are failed forever. I've got names like that too — fewer, but I'm seventeen, give me time." A breath. "But it works the other way around too. The ones you *saved* don't get erased by the failure. You don't get to use your guilt to un-raise him. He got raised. He got a father with terrible music and a magic arrow who taught him to fly. That happened. You did that. Guilt doesn't get a vote on it."

"Weren't *supposed* to be me raisin' him," said Yondu, quiet. "Supposed to be his mama. His granddad. Anybody decent."

"Nobody's ever *supposed to*," said Issei. "I wasn't supposed to raise seven kids from a dead sky. I'm a teenage devil with a dragon in my arm and a life expectancy my fiancées track on a ledger. There's no 'supposed to.' There's just a kid, and you, and whether you put them down once you've picked them up." He shrugged, seventeen again for a second. "You didn't put him down. Twenty-six years. That's not an accident, old man. That's a choice you made every single morning."

The fire burned. Yondu turned the whittling over in his hands, and the theatre finally saw what it was becoming, unplanned, the way his hands apparently defaulted: small, crude, unmistakable. A ship.

"You'd have killed me," he said. "Back in them ferry years. Man who did what I did — your file says slavers burn."

"Probably," said Issei. "The me from back then, if he could've. The me now—" he considered it honestly, because he was incapable of anything else, "—the me now would have stopped you, broken your arrow, taken every kid off your ship." Beat. "And then fed you dinner, because you'd have that look you have right now, and my mom feeds that look. It's a whole thing. We have a big table."

And Yondu Udonta laughed — a startled, rusted-out bark, the laugh of a man ambushed by it — and in the theatre, in the real rows, the real Yondu made no sound at all, which everyone near him was careful not to see.

ASSESSMENT, printed the screen, softly, in the margin. **SUBJECTS DISAGREE ON EVERYTHING EXCEPT THE ONLY THING.**

"Enough of this weepy garbage," announced sim-Yondu, standing, cracking his neck. "File says you shoot dragon blasts. I got one arrow. Bet you the ship I'm whittling you can't touch me."

PULL TWO: WHISTLE VS. DRAGON SHOT — COMEDY-CLASS.

The theatre, emotionally waterlogged, grabbed the tonal life raft with both hands.

What followed was, by unanimous later agreement, the greatest fight nobody won. Yondu whistled — that first shrill note the Ravager rows knew in their spines — and the Yaka arrow came off his hip like a living thing with opinions. Issei's gauntlet flared, **[BOOST.]**, and the first Dragon Shot roared across the black sand — and the arrow *herded* it, nudging the blast's edge with contemptuous little taps until it curved politely into the sea.

"That's cheating," said Issei.

"That's *piloting*," said Yondu.

[BOOST.] [BOOST.] Issei split his next shot into a fan of five. The arrow went through all five gaps in the fan, spelled a word in afterglow that the machine hastily pixelated, and knocked his ahoge flat on the way past. In the theatre, Kraglin was making a high continuous wheeze. Rocket was standing on his seat yelling trajectory advice at both of them.

Issei tried to whistle back. What came out was a wet *fffhp*. The arrow stopped mid-air and rotated toward him slowly, the way one turns to look at a man who has insulted one's mother.

"Did—" sim-Yondu wiped his eyes, "—did you just try to *steal my arrow* with a *spit noise*—"

"IT WORKS FOR YOU!"

"I got a FIN, boy, I got CYBERNETICS, you got *enthusiasm and a hairstyle*—"

[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.] — and then Issei did the thing the theatre should have seen coming, because it was the thing he always did, the thing that had rewritten half the room's tactical doctrine across four arcs. He stopped shooting *at* Yondu. He caught the arrow gently in a gauntleted fist — took the puncture through the palm without flinching, because that was the toll — and said, "**Transfer.**"

[TRANSFER.]

Ten stacked Boosts went out of the Red Dragon Emperor and into the Yaka arrow.

It came out of his hand like a sunrise learning to fly. The arrow went up — trailing not its usual red thread but a broad, blazing crimson-gold banner of light — and Yondu's whistle chased it, note after note, and the arrow *answered* like it had been waiting its whole metal life to have this much sky in it. He wrote with it. Loops. Spirals. The theatre would argue for weeks about what the shapes were, but the Ravager rows knew fireworks when they saw them, and Peter Quill, in the dark, knew *these* fireworks, from a funeral the rest of the theatre had not been told about, and sat there silently coming apart at a seam twenty-six years old.

"She never flew like that," said sim-Yondu, head all the way back, firelight and arrow-light on his face. "Not once. Not for me."

"She always flew like that for you," said Issei, watching the sky. "I just turned the volume up."

The arrow came down, spent and dim, into Yondu's palm. He looked at it. Then he tossed the little whittled ship across the fire, underhand, and Issei caught it two-handed like something holy.

"Draw," said Yondu.

"Draw," agreed Issei.

SIMULATION END, stamped the screen. **RESULT: DRAW. CLASSIFICATION OF COMBATANTS: FATHERS. NEITHER WAS SUPPOSED TO BE. BOTH ARE.**

The lights came up on a theatre that had learned, over forty-three chapters, many ways of being loud, and chose none of them.

Peter Quill stood up. The whole room watched him do it — watched him step over Rocket, walk down three rows and across one aisle, past twenty-six years of never quite having the conversation, and sit down next to the real Yondu Udonta, who was studying the dead screen with ferocious blankness.

"You never said it out loud," Quill said. "For the record. You didn't have to. The arrow was never gonna hurt me and I knew it by the time I was ten, and everybody on that ship knew I knew, and you *definitely* knew I knew, so all the eating-me threats were basically bedtime stories, and—" his voice did the thing his father's rust had done, "—and he may have been my father, but he wasn't my daddy, and I have literally said that out loud before and I'm saying it again where the whole multiverse can hear it."

"...Kid saved my whittlin' knife hand about eight fights back," said Yondu, hoarse, to the room, apropos of nothing, because it was the only exit available. "That's all this is."

"Sure it is," said Kraglin, wet-eyed, and got an elbow.

Stakar Ogord rose, across the Ravager section, and the captains went still, because Stakar rising was law. He looked at Yondu a long moment — the man he'd exiled, for the cargo, for the code — and said, gravely: "The exile stands for what the hold carried. It always will; the boy said it true — that book doesn't balance." A pause. "But I watched a man hit his own bottom and find a kid standing on it, and raise him twenty-six years off one choice a morning. That goes in the *other* book. Ravagers keep both. We always did."

From the X-Men's block, Logan's voice, gravel-gentle, not looking at anyone: "Told you all in Arc Three. Takes one to know one." Jubilee, beside him, had given up on her mascara entirely. Laura was watching Quill and Yondu the way she watched everything that proved a thing could be survived.

And from the Guardians' rows: "Some of us," said Nebula, into the quiet, each word placed like a blade set down, "were taken by hands that never learned this. That built us into weapons and called the building love." She was looking at the little whittled ship still rendered on the frozen screen. "I used to think the difference between Thanos and any other man who takes children was rate of survival. It isn't. It's this. It's whether the hold cries and the man *turns the music down*."

Gamora took her sister's hand. Neither looked at the other. It held.

In the villains' dark, Mephisto sat with steepled fingers and, for the second time in the fic, wrote nothing down — because guilt that refuses to be traded against love was, contractually speaking, the single most worthless commodity in his portfolio, and the theatre kept *producing* it.

The betting board from Arc Three flickered on, briefly, unbidden, and appended one line to the old adoption market: **UDONTA, Y. — MARKET CLOSED. POSITION FILLED IN 1988. PAID IN FULL.** Then it dimmed, respectfully, before anyone could laugh or cry, and most of the room did some of both.

High in the dark, the crack in the screen ticked — once, soft, patient — and beneath the frozen image of a whittled ship, the machine printed the next banner in treasure-chest gold:

NEXT: PLANET-SIZE VAULT RAID.

"...Okay," said Rocket thickly, already standing on his seat, "feelings are DONE, who's got a pen—"

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT, said the frame under the gold, just once, and was gone.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Hypothetical Conversation between Yondu and Issei* — Epic (self-cranked: the machine locked the Ravager operators out and pulled it unassisted); *Whistle vs. Dragon Shot* — Comedy-Class. The simulation stamped both men "**CLASSIFICATION: FATHERS. NEITHER WAS SUPPOSED TO BE. BOTH ARE.**"
- **Secrets Revealed:** The sim laid Yondu's full ledger before the room: the Ego child-deliveries ("cargo don't cry in the hold — that hold cried"), the bottom-of-himself moment that made him keep Peter Quill, and his nightly math that the kept child cannot balance the delivered ones. Issei's counter-doctrine, now canon for the room: the book doesn't balance *in either direction* — failed children stay failed, but guilt "doesn't get a vote" on the ones raised; there is no "supposed to," only "a kid, and you, and whether you put them down once you've picked them up." Combat notes: the Yaka arrow can herd/redirect Dragon Shots ("piloting"); Issei took the arrow through the palm to **Transfer** ten stacked Boosts *into it*, producing a crimson-gold flight Yondu said it never gave him ("She always flew like that for you. I just turned the volume up"). Issei cannot whistle. He kept the whittled ship.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: Peter Quill crossed the aisle** — first contact with Yondu in forty-four chapters — and repeated "he wasn't my daddy" for the whole multiverse. **Stakar Ogord** ruled publicly: the exile stands for the hold, but the twenty-six years go in "the other book — Ravagers keep both," the closest thing to reinstatement-of-honor the code allows. **Nebula** named the true line between taking children and raising them ("whether the hold cries and the man turns the music down"); Gamora held her hand. Logan's "takes one to know one" (Ch. 27) extended to Yondu. Mephisto wrote nothing down — untradeable guilt is worthless to him, and the theatre keeps

producing it. The Arc-Three adoption board closed Yondu's market: "**POSITION FILLED IN 1988. PAID IN FULL.**"

- **Unresolved Hooks:** The machine *locked out its own operators* to force this pull — the theatre is now visibly steering the Ravager arc, not hosting it (toward what?). Quill recognized the arrow's crimson-gold sky from "a funeral the rest of the theatre had not been told about" — unspoken timeline grief still sealed. The screen's crack (Ch. 40) ticked again, once, mid-quiet. Next banner teased in treasure-gold: **PLANET-SIZE VAULT RAID** (Ch. 45 — the vault is a prison). The prophecy line flashed beneath the treasure banner.

Chapter Forty-Five: The Treasure Planet Incident

Primary Reaction Groups: Guardians of the Galaxy (Star-Lord, Gamora, Rocket, Groot, Drax, Nebula, Mantis) • Ravagers (Yondu Udonta, Kraglin, Stakar Ogord, Martinex) • The Collectors' Row (Taneleer Tivan, the Grandmaster) • Cosmic Archaeologists (the Rigellian Recorder, Shi'ar Academy scholars, Uatu observing)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Planet-Size Vault Raid" — **Legendary**
 2. "Sealed Entity Within" — **Mythic**
-

Five nights into Arc Five, the theatre had adjusted to its new management style, which was to say: the gacha wheel now had a lever, the lever had a skull-and-flame decal that nobody had authorized, and the machine — which had survived Doom's demands and the Hulk's fists without blinking — had apparently decided that being operated by pirates was funny.

High in the upper right quadrant, the crack ticked once, softly, the way it had ticked every night since the red sky. The room had learned to live around it the way one lives around a relative's cough. Nobody had learned to ignore it.

"House rules," announced Kraglin, who had been promoted to wheel-boy by a process no one could reconstruct, spitting on his palm and gripping the lever. "Fifth pull of the Ravager Rolls. After the rat's heist went nowhere and the Cap'n's — " he glanced at Yondu, chose life, " — *conversation*, machine says tonight's theme is *acquisitions*."

"Assets," corrected the Collector, from his roped-off luxury row, in the voice of a man who had been waiting five nights for exactly this word. Taneleer Tivan had dressed for the occasion. Taneleer Tivan had dressed for the occasion *every night*, on the theory that eventually the occasion would arrive.

Kraglin pulled the lever.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"PLANET-SIZE VAULT RAID" — RARITY: LEGENDARY.

"Oh," said Rocket Raccoon, sitting up so fast his tools scattered. "Oh, it's a *heist* episode."

The vision opened on a dead system in the far dark of Issei's cosmology — past the Underworld's mapped territories, past anything with a postal address — and on a world that was not a world.

It had been one, once. Now it was a **vault**. The captions delivered the specifications with the machine's usual brutal economy: a planetary crust reworked, over centuries, into a single continuous strongroom. Continental plates hinged like cabinet doors. Mountain ranges that were, on closer inspection, *wards* — Norse chains the width of rivers, sutra-script scorched into deserts, angelic geometry orbiting in rings, devil contract-circles inlaid in gold across the entire southern hemisphere. Every pantheon Issei's world contained had contributed a lock, which meant every pantheon had agreed on something, which — as the room had learned across forty-four chapters — never, ever happened.

"Joint custody," murmured Gamora, eyes narrowing. "Gods don't share. Not treasure. Something made them share."

The appraisal figures began scrolling anyway, because the machine knew its audience. Estimated contents in tonnage of gold. In relics. In *named* relics. The numbers went up and kept going up until they stopped being numbers and became weather.

The Collector made a sound the theatre had never heard from him. Beside him, the Grandmaster — who had drifted in three nights ago "just for the vibes" and never left — began, delightedly, taking bets.

And then the raid started, and the room understood why this pull was rated for combat.

A consortium came out of the dark — rogue devils, stray gods, a mercenary column of treasure-hunters with siege-craft and world-cracking munitions, the kind of professional acquisitions fleet that Ravagers watch the way art students watch masters. And rising off the vault-world's surface to meet them, crimson against the starfield, wyverns wheeling around him like a solar system that had unionized: Issei Hyoudou, Cardinal Crimson, standing in front of the largest pile of unclaimed wealth in his universe like a man guarding a bus stop.

"Okay, hold on, hold up." Peter Quill was on his feet. "He's the *security*? They put the horny dragon kid in charge of Fort Knox: The Planet? Who does the vetting in that universe?"

"**The pay is terrible,**" Ddraig's voice offered dryly over the vision, in the tone of a dragon settling in to enjoy a misunderstanding. "**He does it anyway. Watch.**"

They watched. It was a beautiful fight and a strange one, and the strangeness took the professionals in the room about ninety seconds to diagnose. Issei did not defend the vault the way one defends *property* — no perimeter, no interdiction of the loot approaches, none of the geometry of a man protecting a claim. Rocket saw it first, because Rocket had planned a hundred robberies against this exact kid a few nights ago and lost every one.

"He's not guarding the doors," Rocket said slowly, telescoping his scope down. "Look at his positioning. He's ignoring three open cargo lanes — you could back a freighter into the eastern hemisphere right now. He's only contesting hits on the *seals*. He's not stopping them from taking anything out." A pause, whiskers flat. "He's stopping them from letting something— "

The captions cut him off, because the machine liked its own timing:

THE RAIDERS WANT WHAT IS INSIDE. SO DID EVERYONE WHO BUILT THE LOCKS. THAT IS WHY THERE ARE LOCKS.

On-screen, a siege-lance the size of a city block came down on the largest contract-circle, and Issei — who had spent the fight conserving, deflecting, herding — stopped conserving. The Crimson Blaster took the lance out of the sky in three seconds of shrieking accumulation, and the shockwave of it rang the vault-world's wards like a bell the size of a moon, and the vision, for a single frame, showed the entire mercenary fleet hesitate at the *sound the planet made in response*.

Not a bell-tone. A heartbeat.

The screen froze there — crimson figure, ringing world — and printed, with what the theatre could only interpret as showmanship:

INTERMISSION. THE MANAGEMENT INVITES INTERESTED PARTIES TO CONFER.

The intermission lasted one hour, and it was the most profitable hour of larceny-planning in the theatre's history, conducted entirely in the open, because there was nowhere to go.

The Ravagers colonized the frozen frame like it was a tavern table. Stakar Ogord ran the assessment with the gravity of an admiral; Martinex modeled the ward-lattice in refracted light off his own facets; Kraglin annotated approach vectors directly onto the screen with a grease pencil until it shocked him, twice, on principle. The Collector's people arrived with contracts. The Grandmaster arrived with a whiteboard of odds. Rocket — Rocket, who had sworn off Issei-related heists after the simulation disaster, publicly, with witnesses — was somehow at the center of it, sketching, muttering, *alive*, because a planet-sized lock is not a temptation, it is a love letter.

"Sixty percent to the fleet, fifteen to Tivan for financing—"

"Twenty."

"Fifteen, you undead magpie, and the anomalous items go to open auction—"

"The anomalous items," said the Collector, in a voice gone silk-thin, "come to *me*."

Only the Guardians' row stayed out of it. Gamora had not moved since the heartbeat. Nebula stood behind her sister's seat, arms folded, watching the planning circus with the expression of a woman who had grown up in a house where things were collected. And Drax, arms crossed, staring at the frozen crimson figure, said the quiet part at full volume, as was his gift:

"Why does the boy fight like the treasure is behind *him*?"

Yondu Udonta heard it. The room saw him hear it. He had been on the planning circle's edge all hour, arrow drifting lazy figure-eights over his shoulder, uncommitted — and at Drax's question the whistling stopped, and Yondu looked at the screen the way he'd looked at it during his own chapter, one night and a lifetime ago.

"'Cause it ain't treasure," Yondu said. "Boy's standing like a man in front of a door he don't want opened. Seen that stance before." A beat. "Wore it."

The machine, which had been waiting for exactly that, dimmed the lights.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"SEALED ENTITY WITHIN" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

The Grandmaster's whiteboard, very quietly, erased itself.

The vision took them inside.

Down through the hinged continents, through vault-halls the size of seas — and yes, there was gold, gold in ranges, gold in geological strata, relics racked like wine, the appraisal-weather from earlier turning out to have been *conservative* — and the machine let the Collector's row drink it in for exactly eleven seconds before the perspective kept going. Past the hoard. Beneath it. To what the hoard was *for*.

The treasure was arranged in a spiral, all of it, every ingot and crown and god-forged blade, radiating inward around a chamber at the planet's heart. And in the chamber, wound in seal-script so old the captions declined to translate it, something slept.

The vision would not render it whole — the same courtesy, the room realized with a chill, that it had extended to the Dragon Blaster and the Longinus Smasher: some things it refused to show at full resolution. They got scale, and scale was enough. A curve of flank like a horizon. Breathing that moved the gold in tides. One eyelid, continental, veined with the same script as the wards, closed.

MANIFEST, printed the screen. **CONTENTS OF VAULT: ONE (1) OCCUPANT.**

THE GOLD IS NOT THE TREASURE. THE GOLD IS THE BEDDING. OLD POWERS SLEEP QUIETER ON A HOARD. THE PANTHEONS DID NOT BUILD A BANK. THEY BUILT A CRADLE, AND AGREED NEVER TO SAY SO, BECAUSE CRADLES INVITE PITY AND VAULTS INVITE ONLY THIEVES.

THEY BUDGETED FOR THIEVES.

The silence in the theatre had texture. Into it, the vision played its last movement: the raid broken, the fleet gone, and Issei Hyoudou — armor dismissed, a teenager again, small as a coin on the vault-world's skin — kneeling at the great southern contract-circle with his gauntleted hand flat against the seal.

[BOOST.] said the gear, gently. **[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [TRANSFER.]**

And the theatre watched the accumulated power of the entire battle — every doubling, every stolen watt the wyverns had levied off the raiders — pour not into the boy but *out* of him, down through his palm, into the hinges of the lock. Feeding the seal. Paying into the prison's upkeep like a man paying his grandmother's heating bill.

He talked while he did it. Of course he talked. The room had four arcs of evidence that Issei Hyoudou had never met a silence he respected. He told the sleeping thing about the fight it had missed. He apologized for the noise. He said — and the caption transcribed it without comment, which was somehow worse — *"If you ever wake up and you wanna talk instead of, y'know, ending everything, first meal's on me. I know a place. They do a really good melon bread."*

"He does this every visit," said Ddraig, and the dragon's voice had no dryness left in it. **"He has never been paid. He was never assigned. He heard what was down here, and he decided the door should have a friend on both sides."**

The debate, when it came, did not sound like the theatre's usual debates. It sounded like a crew meeting.

"Okay." Quill stood, hands out, addressing the planning circle he had refused to join. "Everybody who was drawing heist diagrams an hour ago, look at me. We *did* this one. The orb. You crack open the shiny thing and surprise, it's not loot, it's a *scream* with a market value. We lost — " his voice caught the way it always caught, and Mantis's antennae dipped, " — we lost people to a guy who thought the universe was his to unwrap. You don't open a box just because the not-knowing itches."

"Spoken," said the Collector, "like a man who has never owned anything worth guarding." But it came out wrong — thin — because Taneleer Tivan had spent the last ten minutes discovering something about himself in public: the manifest had not cured his wanting. It had *refined* it. A god in a cage was no longer merchandise; it was the exhibit of exhibits, the piece his collection would be remembered for,

and the entire theatre could see him fail to stop doing the math. The Grandmaster — the Grandmaster, whose moral floor was located in the sub-basement of a casino — edged one seat away from his brother, delicately, like a man distancing himself from a bad smell at a party.

"I will take that bet now," En Dwi Gast announced to the room, cheerful and shrill. "What's *in* the vault, best odds in the house, come on, someone — no one? The breathing planet has killed the betting? It has. Ugh. Sealed entities are *terrible* for business."

"It is not a treasure and it is not an exhibit," said Drax. "It is a prisoner who has not escaped. Where I am from, we do not dig up a buried blade to ask if it is still sharp."

"Where you're from got *invaded*," Nebula said flatly. Then, quieter, arms still folded, eyes on the seal-script: "My father collected daughters and called it rescue. Every collector calls it something. Preservation. Curation. *Curiosity*." Her gaze flicked, once, lethal, to Tivan's row. "The only honest word is the one the boy uses. It's a door. Doors have a right side."

Gamora finally spoke. "The pantheons built it together and told no one. Think about what that means. Every god in that world looked at what's sleeping down there and chose *shame* over *glory* — chose to be forgotten as jailers rather than famous as conquerors. Gods don't do that." A breath. "Unless the alternative frightened them into being, briefly, wise."

It was Rocket, in the end, who closed the heist. He did it without ceremony: climbed up on the planning table, in front of Stakar and Martinex and the annotated screen and sixty hours of the best acquisition planning of his life, and tore the schematic in half.

"Job's off," he said. To the objection forming on a Ravager captain's face: "Job's *off*. You know what I heard down there? I heard breathing in a locked room. *I been* the breathing in the locked room, okay? Subject 89P13 knows exactly what it sounds like from the inside when clever guys with tools decide the lock is the interesting part." His voice didn't crack, because he would have shot anyone who said it did. "The treasure's a *guy*. You don't fence a guy. Groot, back me up."

"I am Groot," said Groot, with enormous finality — and up on the screen, unprompted, un-cued, the vision's audio rendered a single low rumble from the sleeping dark beneath the gold, as if something in Issei's universe had briefly answered him — and Ddraig went silent, mid-breath, for the first time in forty-five chapters. The mystics' rows would argue about that until dawn. Chapter Forty-Six was already loading.

Stakar Ogord stood. He looked at the torn schematic, at the rat who had torn it, at the frozen frame of a boy paying a prison's heating bill with his own doubled heartbeat.

"New line in the code," Stakar said. "Ravagers don't deal in kids. And Ravagers don't open cages to sell what's inside." He glanced at Yondu — old grief, old amends, the arc's whole cargo passing between them in a look. "All in favor keep breathing."

The clans kept breathing.

From the scholars' tier, the Rigellian Recorder spoke its finding into the hush, toneless and terrible: "Recording paradox. The vault is the most valuable object yet assessed in the subject's universe, and its value is conditional on its never being collected. The perfect treasure is the one that must be left where it lies. Filed under: *lessons this audience resists*."

And the screen, which had been quiet a long time, printed its verdict small, without a banner:

YOU HAVE SPENT FIVE NIGHTS ASKING WHETHER HE IS A PIRATE, A CAPTAIN, OR A THREAT. TONIGHT HE WAS A LOCK. LEARN THIS SHAPE. HIS WORLD HAS OLDER DOORS THAN THIS ONE, AND WORSE SLEEPERS, AND THE NIGHT IS COMING WHEN YOU WILL NEED TO KNOW THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A GUARD AND A JAILER.

Ddraig said nothing. That was the loudest part.

The lights held a moment longer than usual, and in the pause, several thousand beings had the same thought at the same time and hated it together. It was Mantis, of all of them, who said it aloud — softly, antennae glowing, looking not at the screen but at the theatre's indestructible walls, and up at the hairline crack ticking patiently through its frost-flower branches:

"We are also inside something no one can open. With something outside, testing the locks." Her voice was very small. "Does anyone know which side of the door we are on?"

Tick, said the crack.

The lights went out.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Planet-Size Vault Raid* — Legendary (Issei, in Cardinal Crimson, repels a mercenary consortium besieging a planet-sized multi-pantheon vault in the deep dark of his cosmology); *Sealed Entity Within* — Mythic (the vault's interior: the hoard is bedding, the treasure is a sleeping sealed entity the vision refused to render at full resolution). Fifth night of the Ravager Rolls; Kraglin remains self-appointed wheel-boy.
- **Secrets Revealed:** The vault-world is a *prison-cradle* jointly built and warded by every pantheon in Issei's world — the only recorded thing his gods ever agreed on, and they chose secrecy ("shame over glory") to avoid advertising it. Issei defends only the *seals*, not the loot lanes; he is unpaid and

unassigned, volunteers, uses **Transfer** to pour battle-accumulated Boosts into the seal's hinges ("paying the prison's heating bill"), and talks to the sleeper each visit — standing offer of melon bread if it ever wakes wanting conversation instead of apocalypse. Ddraig confirms: "he decided the door should have a friend on both sides." The screen's closing warning seeds the arc-spanning thread: Issei's world has **older doors and worse sleepers**, and the audience will one day need to know a guard from a jailer. When Groot spoke, something under the vault's gold *answered him* — and Ddraig went silent mid-breath for the first time in the fic (direct setup for Ch. 46).

- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: Rocket publicly kills the heist** — tears the schematic on the planning table, invoking Subject 89P13: "the treasure's a *guy*; you don't fence a guy." **Stakar amends the Ravager code**: "Ravagers don't open cages to sell what's inside," ratified by the clans; Yondu's "door he don't want opened" read triggered the turn. Quill invokes the Orb/Ego losses against opening unknowns; Gamora and Nebula frame collecting-as-imprisonment (Nebula: "every collector calls it something"). **The Collector is publicly compromised** — the reveal *refined* his wanting rather than curing it (a caged god as "the exhibit of exhibits"), visibly alarming even the Grandmaster, whose betting book died with the heartbeat; watch Tivan going forward. The Rigellian Recorder files the paradox: the most valuable object's value is conditional on never being collected — "lessons this audience resists."
- **Unresolved Hooks**: What sleeps in the vault (unnamed, unrendered — thematic rhyme with the sealed threats of Issei's world; do not prematurely name it). Why the entity **answered Groot** and why Ddraig went silent — feeds directly into Ch. 46 ("Groot Speaks Dragon" / the draconic prophecy). The Collector's refined obsession is now a live fuse in the theatre. **Mantis's closing question inverts the series' oldest mystery**: the theatre itself is an unopenable sealed container with something outside testing the locks (the still-ticking Ch. 40 crack) — "which side of the door are we on?" — the room does not know if it is being protected or contained. The screen's "older doors, worse sleepers" line stands as an open promise for later arcs.

Chapter Forty-Six: Groot Speaks Dragon

Primary Reaction Groups: Groot • Ddraig • Cosmic Linguists (Vision, Rocket, the Rigellian Recorder, the Allspeak-bearers) • Mystics (Doctor Strange, Wong, Agatha Harkness, Doctor Voodoo)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Conversation between Groot and Ddraig" — **Secret**
 2. "Forgotten Draconic Prophecy" — **Mythic**
-

Five nights into the Ravager arc, the theatre had learned that the machine could be *heckled*.

It had been a rowdy banner. The console it had extruded for its temporary operators had insulted Kraglin's spelling, graded Yondu's whistling "ADEQUATE, SENTIMENTAL," and stamped **COMMON SENSE FAILURE** across the Ravager section so often the captains had started wearing it like a patch. It had let Rocket run his heist simulation into the ground and let a dragon impersonating a security AI catch him at the vault door. It had let a whistle-arrow and a Dragon Shot spar until half the room forgot to be afraid of either. The Ravager Rolls were, by broad consensus, the first arc anyone would have paid to attend.

So when the wheel came down on night six and the rarity band went the deep, lightless violet of a Secret pull, the room sobered the way a bar sobers when the music stops.

Kraglin put his hand on the operator plate, because that had been his job all week.

OPERATOR INSUFFICIENT, said the console.

"Rude," said Kraglin, "but fair."

Yondu tried. Stakar tried. Rocket tried twice, the second time with a bypass clip he'd built out of a seat spring, and the console printed **NICE TRY** and then, in larger type, letter by letter, an operator designation nobody had bet on:

OPERATOR: GROOT.

The theatre turned. In the Guardians' block, unhurried, Groot stood. He looked at the violet band for a long moment with an expression that no one — afterward, comparing notes — could agree on, and then he went down the aisle steps the way trees do everything: patiently, and all at once.

"Since when," Peter Quill said, to no one, "does the loot box know Groot?"

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2, printed the screen.

"CONVERSATION BETWEEN GROOT AND DDRAIG" — RARITY: SECRET.

And for the first time in forty-five chapters, the theatre did not swallow them. No vision came. Instead the screen filled, edge to edge, with a single image the room knew better than its own flags: the round green gem of the Boosted Gear, vast as a sunrise, lit from within — and *live*. Not a recording. The theatre had heard Ddraig speak out of the dark before, on the bad nights, and every soul present recognized the difference between footage of a dragon and the attention of one.

Groot stopped at the front rail, tilted his head back, and spoke.

"I am Groot."

That is what the room heard. That is what the room *always* heard. And underneath it, in the same instant, every translation apparatus in a multiverse's worth of assembled genius failed simultaneously, each in its own way, like instruments blowing out one by one in a storm.

Rocket's translator implant — the one that had rendered Groot faithfully through eleven years, two wars, and one funeral — returned static and then, worse, returned *nothing*, and Rocket came up out of his seat with his ears flat. "Okay, that's — hold on. Hold on. I didn't get that one." His voice did a thing it had never done in public. "I get *all* of 'em. I'm the guy who gets 'em. Groot. Buddy. Say it again."

Groot did not say it again.

Thor, who had taken Groot as an elective on Asgard and dined out on the fact for years, had gone very still. "I understood the first word," he said slowly. "Only the first. It was not 'I.'"

"The Allspeak," Loki said, and stopped. The room turned, because Loki's voice had lost its silk. The Allspeak was not a skill; it was a birthright woven into the bones of gods, the tongue beneath tongues, and it did not fail. "The Allspeak renders all speech as meaning. It is rendering this as—" His hand had closed on the seat back. "It is declining. I did not know it *could* decline."

Vision rose, head tilted, running the acoustics with the courteous frown he wore in place of alarm. "The utterance contains three phonemes," he reported. "Three. The information encoded in it — measured by the response latency of the listener — exceeds the carrying capacity of that channel by eleven orders of magnitude. This is not compression. Compression has a floor. This is—" He paused, and chose the accurate word over the comfortable one. "This is not language *transmitting* meaning. It appears to be language *permitting* it."

High in the archival seats, the Rigellian Recorder — who had catalogued four hundred thousand tongues and considered the number embarrassing — printed **RECORDING** and then **ERROR** and then **RECORDING** and then **ERROR**, in a loop, and finally, with what would have been a sigh in anything

with lungs: **THIS UNIT WILL LISTEN.**

And the gem answered.

It was not the theatre-voice, the vast entertained rumble the room had grown fond of. It was under that voice, the way bedrock is under a road — a slow harmonic that came up through the floor and the teeth and the oldest parts of the hindbrain, and the green light of the gem moved in patterns, tidal, deliberate, and Groot's rings answered it, luminescence rising through the grain of him like sap made of light.

In the mystics' rows, Doctor Strange was on his feet with his hands half-raised, not casting — *reading* — and finding, visibly, that his fingers had nowhere to hold. "It isn't a language," he said. "Stop trying to parse it as one. Languages are agreements. This is older than agreeing. It's—" He grasped for it. "It's *custody*. They aren't exchanging words. They're exchanging things held in trust."

"The first conversation," Wong said quietly, beside him. He had not stood. He had folded his hands, as one does at the door of a temple older than one's order. "Every mythology on every world we have catalogued keeps a version of it, and we filed them all as metaphor. The tree that holds the worlds. The serpent at its roots. Kamar-Taj's oldest scroll calls it *the argument that keeps the roots wet* and does not translate one line of it."

"Because it isn't ours to translate," said Agatha Harkness, and the old witch's voice had no theatre in it at all tonight. "Three centuries I've stolen words that weren't mine to speak. I know the taste of a locked tongue. Children — that one isn't locked. It's *entrusted*. There's a difference, and the difference is what's listening."

Doctor Voodoo said nothing. The loa rode him lightly, most nights, a murmur at his shoulder. Tonight, Daniel's voice in his ear had gone silent mid-sentence — the dead, listening too.

Down from the Asgardian tiers came Heimdall's voice, gold-eyed and very low. "I heard this once. A boy on the walls of Asgard, farther down the roots of Yggdrasil than I was permitted to look. Two notes of it, and my father fetched me back and did not scold me, which frightened me more." He watched the green light move. "I have waited nine thousand years to know what the tree was saying. I find I am content to wait longer."

The exchange went on. Perhaps two minutes; perhaps much longer — Vision declined, afterward, to publish his measurement, which the room noted, because Vision had done that only once before, in Chapter Thirty. Groot spoke in slow tidal phrases; the gem answered in light and bedrock; once, unmistakably, Groot gestured — a broad sweep of one arm that took in the entire theatre, every hero and monster and god of a gathered multiverse — and the gem *flickered*, and several thousand beings had the distinct, prickling experience of being briefly discussed.

"Did—" Sam Wilson leaned forward. "Did the tree just tell the dragon about *us*?"

[**Heh,**] said Ddraig — the familiar voice for just that one syllable, surfacing like a whale's back and sounding, the room would swear, *fond* — and then the bedrock took him again.

And in the villains' dark, Fin Fang Foom stood up.

The theatre had seated exactly one dragon of its own, and for forty-five chapters Foom's contribution had been scorn — scorn for the gauntlet, scorn for the servitude, scorn for a "true dragon" leashed to a lecherous mammal. He stood now with his wings half-flared and his ancient face wearing something the room had no file for, and when Titania snapped at him to sit, he said, without looking at her, in a voice like a landslide remembering being a mountain:

"Be silent. That is High Root-Speech. My kind has *dreamed* of it. We stopped teaching it to our hatchlings before your species learned fire, because—" He stopped himself. His claws closed on the seat back. "Because it carries too far."

"Carries to *whom*?" Doom asked, sharp, from two tiers down.

Foom did not answer. Foom had, visibly, decided he had said one sentence too many, and the room filed *that* — a dragon the size of a bridge choosing silence out of what could only be called manners, or fear, or both.

It was then that Groot said the last thing.

It was short. Three syllables, same as ever — *I am Groot* — but the light in his rings gathered and went *down* him as he said it, root-ward, the way meaning falls into the ground, and the gem on the screen stopped moving entirely.

Green light. Utter stillness. A held breath the size of a sky.

And the gacha wheel, which no one had touched, which its designated operator was standing forty feet away from with his hand nowhere near the plate, began to spin.

UNSCHEDULED, printed the screen, in small type, and the room's blood went cold, because the machine annotating its own machinery had happened exactly once before, and that night had ended with a child-shaped hole in a photograph.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"FORGOTTEN DRACONIC PROPHECY" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

PULL TRIGGERED BY UTTERANCE. THIS UNIT DID NOT DECLINE IT.

"That's not the same as choosing it," Rocket said hoarsely, to nobody. "You all caught that, right? That's not the same—"

The theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

There was no place. That was the first wrongness. Every vision in forty-five chapters had stood them *somewhere* — a park, a battlefield, a kitchen. This one stood them in fire that predated the invention of *somewhere*: the first sky, uncounted, unbounded, and full of dragons.

Not dragons as the room knew them. Dragons before names, before factions, before the sorting of worlds into worlds — vast slow shapes of the original heat, gathered in a congregation that was also a song. The vision did not translate the song. It *subtitled* it, in fragments, the machine's white type arriving halting and reluctant, like a clerk transcribing scripture at gunpoint:

WHEN THE SKIES ARE COUNTED, THE COUNT WILL BE BROKEN.

WHEN THE COUNT IS BROKEN, THE RED WILL RETURN — NOT THE FIRST RED, NOT THE LAST, BUT THE RED WHO CHOSE THE SMALL.

HE WILL CARRY A SOVEREIGN OF NOTHING AND A WING MADE OF OATHS. THE DRAGONS OF ALL SKIES WILL COME TO HIM — THE CROWNED, THE FALLEN, THE BOUND, THE BURIED — AND HE WILL NOT COMMAND THEM. THEY WILL SIMPLY ARRIVE, AS RIVERS ARRIVE.

THEY WILL GATHER AGAINST

— and there the song *stopped*.

Not ended. Stopped. The next stanza was gone, and the room knew the shape of the gone-ness the instant they saw it, because they had seen it on a mountainside scar, and in a family photograph, and threading the hairline fracture that still crossed the theatre's screen like a scratch on the sky: a static-edged absence, a cut with shivering borders, a place where the song's spacing continued *around* something that had been removed — verse-shaped, exactly, the way a slot in a photograph had been child-shaped, exactly.

In the front row, Asia Argento made a small sound and pressed both hands over her heart, weeping again for something with no name on it, and Kuroka's ears went flat to her skull: "Same hole, nya," she whispered. "Same *knife*."

The congregation of first dragons, in the vision, did not sing past the gap. They sang *at* it — grief in the original key — and then, one by one, the vast shapes turned and breathed on the song itself, and buried it in fire, and agreed, in the way of mountains agreeing, to forget it on purpose.

The last surviving line hung alone in the dark before the vision closed. The machine tried three times to render it. The first two attempts printed as ■■■■. The third came through, flickering, static-edged, wearing the wrongness like a borrowed coat, and the theatre read it in the silence of a room that had read it once before, on its very first night:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

The lights came up on pandemonium held at arm's length.

"Ddraig." Thor was on his feet, and there was no fondness in it now, only the old-story dread. "Dragon of the roots. You knew this song. Sing us the buried verse."

Silence from the gem.

"Dragon." Doom, rising, cold and exact. "Doom does not petition. The stanza names the enemy. This assembly was *built* to be briefed. Complete the record."

The green light stirred, at last, and when Ddraig spoke it was the theatre-voice again — but slowed, and careful, and the room realized it had never once heard the Welsh Dragon Emperor choose his words before. He had always spent them like a rich man.

"No."

"That's—" Carol Danvers started.

"Ask me anything else," Ddraig said. "Ask me my defeats. Ask me how the White and I were bound, which shames me. Ask me what my partner mumbles in his sleep, which shames him. I will spend all of it." A long exhale, felt in the floor. "Not this. Little ones — hear the shape of what you saw. My kind did not *forget* that song. Forgetting is what happens to songs nobody guards. That song was buried, by every dragon of every sky that ever learned it, in the same age, without conferring. We did not bury it because it was false."

The gem's light banked low.

"Some things are not hidden from you," the dragon said, quieter than the theatre had ever heard him. "They are hidden from what listens when you speak."

And the green light went out — not gone, the room could feel him there still, coiled around his own silence like a hoard — but *guarded*, shut, a door closed by something that had never once, in forty-six chapters, declined to talk.

Into the ringing quiet, Groot turned from the rail. He looked up at the dark screen, and at the hairline fracture crossing it, and he reached out one long hand and rested two fingers, very gently, against the seam of the crack — the way you'd touch a wound on someone you couldn't heal.

"I am Groot," he said.

Three syllables. Every translator in the room stayed dark. And yet not one being in the theatre, from the gods' tier to the cheap seats, escaped the weight of it — a pressure of meaning arriving without any words to carry it, the way grief arrives, the way weather does.

Rocket sat down slowly. His hands were not steady, and he made no attempt to hide it, which frightened the Guardians more than the prophecy had. "First time in my life," he said, to his boots. "I got nothin'. Eleven years. I got *nothin'*."

"He said it like a promise," Drax offered, frowning, entirely certain. "I did not understand the words. But the intention was a promise. Or a warning. In my language these are the same word."

Mantis was crying, silently, antennae glowing, and could not tell anyone why.

"Thor," Steve Rogers said quietly. "You caught a word. First word."

Thor looked, for a moment, every one of his fifteen hundred years. "Aye," he said. "And I'll not repeat it in a room where the dragon just told us something *listens*." He sat. He did not touch his hammer. He put both empty hands on his knees, like a man in church.

High above, the Watcher had leaned forward, and stayed leaned, his reflection doubled in the fractured screen. He had called himself blind once in this theatre. Tonight he had watched a tree and a dragon hold a conversation his sight could not enter, about a verse his inventory did not contain, and he said nothing at all, which everyone understood to be the loudest thing he'd said in six chapters.

The console chimed, almost apologetic. The violet band retired; the Ravager banner relit in its scuffed rose-and-flame; and the scoreboard, resuming its arc-long duties as though the sky had not just moved, printed its tease for the next night's business:

NEXT PULL PENDING: COMPATIBILITY ANALYSIS — GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY.

SOME OF YOU WILL BE SURPRISED.

"Great," Quill said weakly, into the dark. "Great. Speed-dating. Right after the doom verse. This place has *no* transitions."

Groot went back up the aisle steps, patient and all at once, and folded himself into his seat between Rocket and Drax, and the two of them, without discussion, each put a hand somewhere on the bark of him and left it there until the lights went down.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Conversation between Groot and Ddraig* — Secret (the machine designated Groot as sole operator; a **live** exchange between Groot and the gauntlet-gem, conducted in a mode no apparatus could render — Rocket's implant, the Allspeak, Vision's analysis, and the Rigellian Recorder all failed simultaneously); *Forgotten Draconic Prophecy* — Mythic (**UNSCHEDULED** — triggered by Groot's final utterance; the machine's annotation: "PULL TRIGGERED BY UTTERANCE. THIS UNIT DID NOT DECLINE IT").
- **Secrets Revealed:** Groot's speech and Ddraig's root-register are the same tongue — "High Root-Speech," older than language-as-agreement; Strange reads it as *custody*, not communication ("exchanging things held in trust"); Wong identifies it as the mythic "first conversation" (the world-tree and the serpent at its roots); Heimdall heard two notes of it once at Yggdrasil's roots; Fin Fang Foom confirms his kind stopped teaching it to hatchlings before humanity had fire "because it carries too far" — then refused to say to whom. The prophecy itself: *when the count of skies is broken, "the Red who chose the small" returns, carrying "a sovereign of nothing and a wing made of oaths," and the dragons of all skies — crowned, fallen, bound, buried — will arrive to him unbidden, "as rivers arrive," to gather AGAINST* — the naming stanza is **gone**: excised, verse-shaped, static-edged, bearing the same cut-signature as the Dragon Blaster scar (Ch. 20), the Erased Child frame (Ch. 30), and the screen's fracture (Ch. 40). The first dragons buried the song deliberately, across all skies, in the same age, without conferring — "we did not bury it because it was false." Its last surviving line renders — flickering, static-edged — as the theatre's founding text: **"HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT."**
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: Ddraig has gone guarded** — the theatre's most generous voice refused a direct question for the first time in forty-six chapters, from Thor and Doom both, and closed the channel ("Some things are not hidden from you. They are hidden from what listens when you speak"). Fin Fang Foom's arc-long scorn for Ddraig is dead as of tonight — replaced by rank, visible reverence, and a matching frightened silence. The mystics (Strange, Wong, Agatha, Voodoo — whose loa stopped mid-sentence to listen) now treat Groot as a being of scriptural significance rather than comic relief; Rocket is shaken to the studs at failing to understand Groot for the first time in eleven years; Thor caught one word of the exchange and refuses to repeat it aloud; Mantis wept without knowing why (as Asia did in Ch. 30 — the same unlugged grief). The Watcher said nothing, at length.
- **Unresolved Hooks: THE FORGOTTEN DRACONIC PROPHECY — ARC-SPANNING SEED; DO NOT RESOLVE, DO NOT NAME THE ENEMY.** The dragons of all skies will gather to a returning red sovereign *against* something whose naming stanza has been cut out of the song by the same knife that took the Erased Child and scarred the screen — the excision-signature

thread now spans Chapters 20, 30, 40, and 46. Every dragon culture in every sky buried this song simultaneously and independently; Ddraig says burial was a *precaution*, implying the enemy **hunts by listening** — hence his refusal, Foom's silence ("it carries too far"), and Thor's withheld word. Why does the prophecy's sole surviving line equal the theatre's recurring founding line — is the machine quoting the prophecy, or is the prophecy quoting the machine? What is "a sovereign of nothing and a wing made of oaths"? Why did the pull fire off Groot's utterance, and what did Groot say? (His parting "I am Groot," delivered with two fingers on the screen's crack, translated for no one — carried to everyone.) *Carried forward*: the screen's hairline fracture persists; Ddraig remains closed on this one subject; next night: the Guardians' compatibility analysis and "NEBULA'S UNEXPECTED HIGH SCORE" (Ch. 47).

Chapter Forty-Seven: Nebula's Compatibility Roll

Primary Reaction Groups: Guardians of the Galaxy (Star-Lord, Gamora, Nebula, Rocket, Drax, Groot, Mantis) • Ravagers (Yondu, Kraglin, Stakar Ogord & assorted captains) • Villains (Thanos, Mephisto, Loki, Doom)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Compatibility Analysis for Guardians" — **Rare**
 2. "Nebula's Unexpected High Score" — **Secret**
-

By the seventh night of Arc Five, the theatre had a gambling problem.

It had started, as most institutional decay does, with Yondu Udonta. The machine had made the Ravagers its operators for the arc — a decision the room's scholars still could not explain and the machine still refused to — and within an hour of taking the console the Ravagers had done to the cosmic theatre what Ravagers do to everything: unionized it, insulted it, and opened a book on it. A rust-red auxiliary scoreboard now hung beneath the great screen like a barnacle on a cathedral, tracking side-bets in units, teeth, and in one distressing column, *favors owed to Kraglin*. The machine had labeled the scoreboard **UNAUTHORIZED** on the first night, **TOLERATED** on the third, and had, on the fifth, quietly begun correcting its odds.

The crack in the upper right quadrant had not spread since the arc began. It had not healed, either. It sat there through pirate codes and treasure planets and one prophecy Ddraig still refused to translate, ticking very occasionally, like a patient creditor.

Tonight the console chimed under Kraglin Obfonteri's hand, and Kraglin — acting operator by virtue of losing a coin toss he was starting to suspect had used two-headed currency — read the banner aloud in the tone of a man defusing something.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"COMPATIBILITY ANALYSIS FOR GUARDIANS" — RARITY: RARE.

QUERY: OF THE SO-CALLED GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY, WHOM WOULD ISSEI HYODOU COME TO TRUST? WHOM WOULD HE BE WISE NOT TO?

TRANSLATION FOR RAVAGER OPERATORS: WHICH OF 'EM WOULD SELL HIM, AND FOR HOW MUCH.

"Now *that's* a pull," said Yondu Udonta, boots already off the seat in front of him, fin catching the screen-light. "Machine's finally speakin' the language."

"It is a betrayal audit," said Loki from the villains' dark, with the reverence he otherwise reserved for himself. "Forty-six chapters of feelings, and at last — a *statistic*."

"Book's open!" bawled a Ravager captain from the cheap seats, and the scoreboard lit like a slot machine paying out. Odds scrolled: the flame-haired boy's trust, handicapped runner by runner. Quill drew middling numbers. Rocket drew insulting ones. Drax drew a symbol the scoreboard used for *don't ask*.

Peter Quill stood up with the wounded dignity of a man about to make things worse. "Okay, first of all, we don't need a machine to tell us we're trustworthy—"

SUBJECT: PETER JASON QUILL, printed the screen, and the theatre settled in with the particular joy of an audience watching a friend's mail get read aloud.

The analysis was not a vision so much as a *dossier assembling itself* — footage of Issei the room already knew, spliced against footage of the Guardians the room knew better, two lives held up to the light until the grain aligned. Issei charging a god with a countdown on his chest; Quill charging Ronan with a dance-off. Issei taking a mortal wound for a girl who healed strangers; Quill taking a mortal storm for a tree.

COMPATIBILITY: HIGH, the machine allowed. **TWO ORPHANED IDEALISTS WITH DELUSIONS OF LEADERSHIP AND VERIFIED WILLINGNESS TO DIE FOR THE TEAM. PROJECTED RELATIONSHIP: IMMEDIATE MUTUAL RECOGNITION, FOLLOWED BY A PERMANENT ARGUMENT OVER WHO IS THE PROTAGONIST.**

BETRAYAL RISK: NONE. INCOMPETENCE RISK: CONTINUOUS.

"I'll take it," Quill said, over the Ravager section's howling.

SUBJECT: ROCKET. Footage: the Chapter Forty-Three simulation, Rocket's ninety-first contingency plan dying to a dragon impersonating a security AI. **COMPATIBILITY: HIGH, AGAINST THE SUBJECT'S OWN STATED PREFERENCES. BETRAYAL RISK: PETTY THEFT ONLY, NEVER TREASON. ANALYSIS: THE SUBJECT WOULD STEAL ISSEI HYODOU'S POSSESSIONS AND DIE BEFORE SELLING HIS LOCATION. ISSEI HYODOU WOULD NOTICE THE THEFT, LAUGH, AND ASK HIM TO STAY FOR DINNER. THE SUBJECT WOULD FIND THIS UNBEARABLE. HE WOULD STAY.**

Rocket, who had opened his mouth to object at *petty theft*, closed it at *he would stay*, and became very interested in a bolt on his armrest.

SUBJECT: DRAX THE DESTROYER. COMPATIBILITY: HIGH. TWO BEINGS INCAPABLE OF DECEPTION FOR STRUCTURAL REASONS. PROJECTED RELATIONSHIP: PENDING. SEE NEXT CHAPTER.

"See next — is it *advertising* at us now?" said Sam Wilson, somewhere in the mid-tiers.

Drax stood, gravely pleased. "The machine promises me a chapter. I will not sit down until I receive it." He remained standing for the rest of the night. No one argued. Arguing with Drax about literalism was a war with no veterans.

SUBJECT: GROOT. COMPATIBILITY: MAXIMUM. ENDORSEMENT ON FILE FROM THE WELSH DRAGON. NO FURTHER ANALYSIS WILL BE OFFERED, AS NONE WOULD SURVIVE TRANSLATION.

"I am Groot," said Groot, satisfied.

"**He is,**" agreed Ddraig, from wherever Ddraig's voice lived, and the cosmic linguists' section quietly tore up another week of research.

SUBJECT: MANTIS. COMPATIBILITY: HIGH. WARNING APPENDED: EMPATHIC CONTACT WITH SUBJECT ISSEI HYOUDOU'S SURFACE THOUGHTS IS NOT RECOMMENDED BEFORE LUNCH. Mantis, who had once touched Thor's forehead and announced his grief to a room, giggled — then read further and went faintly pink on behalf of a boy she had never met.

SUBJECT: GAMORA. COMPATIBILITY: HIGH. THE DEADLIEST WOMAN IN THE GALAXY AND A BOY WHO STRUCTURALLY REFUSES TO GIVE UP ON PEOPLE. PROJECTED RELATIONSHIP: SHE WOULD TEST HIM FIRST. HE WOULD PASS FOR THE STUPIDEST POSSIBLE REASON, WHICH IS THAT HE WOULD NOT NOTICE HE WAS BEING TESTED.

Gamora's mouth did the thing that on anyone else would be a smile. "Accurate," she said.

And then the dossier stopped assembling, and the theatre noticed what the scoreboard had noticed thirty seconds earlier — the odds column beside one name had frozen, mid-calculation, and the name was the one sitting at the end of the Guardians' row with her arms crossed and her chin up like a fixed bayonet.

"Skip it," said Nebula.

The machine did not skip it.

SUBJECT: NEBULA, the screen printed, and then, instead of a dossier: a delay.

The theatre had learned the machine's silences the way sailors learn weather. There was the silence of contempt, the silence of secrets, and — rarest — the silence of a thing double-checking its own arithmetic because it did not expect to be believed.

"Get on with it," Nebula said, to the screen, evenly. She had come to this arc braced. The room knew her file; the room had *seen* her file, in fragments, across a dozen reaction shots — the daughter Thanos rebuilt one confiscated piece at a time, the sister who lost every sparring match and paid for each loss in flesh and machinery, the traitor who sold out Ronan, sold out the Guardians, sold out anyone, until the day she didn't. She had watched the betrayal audit crawl toward her seat all night with the calm of a woman who had already written the verdict herself. *Betrayal risk: total. Compatibility: none. Projected relationship: he should shoot first.*

"Twenty units says traitor-class," someone offered from the Ravager tiers, not quietly enough.

"Fifty says the machine don't even score her," said someone else. "Machine's got *standards*—"

The whistle was very soft, and the arrow's glow was very red, and it hovered outside the second speaker's ear at a courteous distance for exactly as long as it took the Ravager section to remember its manners. Yondu didn't look away from the screen. "Board's closed on this one," he said, mild as milk.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2, said the screen.

"NEBULA'S UNEXPECTED HIGH SCORE" — RARITY: SECRET.

The theatre stopped breathing. Secrets were never comedy. Secrets were the machine opening a vein.

And the vision, when it came, was not of Nebula at all.

It was Issei — a triptych of him, three memories the room had already lived through in earlier arcs, replayed now with new captions, like evidence resubmitted under a different charge. A black-haired nekomata in a purple kimono, an SS-class criminal who had fought his family and fled her sins, standing awkwardly at his family's dinner table while he pushed a bowl toward her: **KUROKA. FORMER ENEMY. CURRENT FAMILY.** A white-haired rival descending on wings of light that had tried, more than once, to kill him — and Issei grinning up at him like a man greeting weather: **VALI LUCIFER. PERPETUAL RIVAL. TRUSTED AT HIS BACK IN EVERY WAR SINCE.** A man with a spear that could kill gods and had very nearly killed *him*, hollowed and remade by his own defeats, and Issei's voice, off-screen, unbothered: *"If he's trying to be better, then that's that, right?"* **CAO CAO. THE MAN WHO NEARLY ENDED HIM. FORGIVEN.**

OBSERVE THE PATTERN, said the machine. **THE SUBJECT OF THIS THEATRE DOES NOT TRUST PEOPLE FOR THEIR RECORDS. HE TRUSTS THEM FOR THEIR DIRECTION.**

NOW OBSERVE THE ANALYSAND.

And there was Nebula's file after all — but cut the way no one had ever cut it. Not the ledger of betrayals. The *other* ledger. Nebula putting herself in the torture rig in her sister's place. Nebula flying alone into Thanos's ship with nothing but rage and a plan made of grief. Nebula, in a ruined future the room had watched with their hands over their mouths, holding an orange stone out to strangers because the person she had been would have kept it. Every clip captioned with the same word, stamped like an auditor's chop: **CHOSEN. CHOSEN. CHOSEN.**

SUBJECT: NEBULA. DAUGHTER OF THANOS. REBUILT AS A WEAPON BY A FATHER WHO GRADED HIS CHILDREN AGAINST EACH OTHER.

COMPATIBILITY WITH ISSEI HYODOU: NINETY-FOUR PERCENT. HIGHEST OF ALL GUARDIANS ANALYZED.

The number hung there, patient, while the theatre made the sound of two thousand assumptions failing at once.

BETRAYAL RISK, the screen continued, and here it did the thing it did perhaps once an arc, dropping the auditor's voice for something older and quieter, **REQUIRES CLARIFICATION. THE ANALYSAND HAS ALREADY COMMITTED THE ONLY BETRAYAL THAT INTERESTS HER. SHE BETRAYED THE PERSON SHE WAS BUILT TO BE. THE QUOTA IS SPENT.**

HE WOULD SEE THAT IN HER BEFORE SHE SAID A WORD. HE HAS PRACTICE. HALF THE PEOPLE AT HIS DINNER TABLE HAVE HER FILE.

PROJECTED RELATIONSHIP: HE WOULD TRUST HER WITH HIS LIFE. SHE WOULD FIND THIS INFURIATING. IT WOULD BE THE FIRST TRUST SHE NEVER HAD TO EARN IN COMBAT, AND SHE WOULD SPEND YEARS TRYING TO DESERVE IT ANYWAY. THAT IS THE COMPATIBILITY. THAT IS THE WHOLE SCORE.

Nebula sat entirely still. The theatre — which had watched her take a disintegrating beam to the face in one vision without blinking — watched her stare at a number, and blink.

"That's wrong," she said. Her voice was level. Her hand, on the armrest, was not. "Run it again."

"It isn't wrong." Gamora had turned in her seat, and she was not looking at the screen; she was looking at her sister with the expression of someone who has been holding a translation for years, waiting for the original to be published. "Nebula. Every person that boy loves most, he met at their worst. The cat ran from her crimes. The rival was raised by a monster. The man with the spear put a hole in him. He doesn't keep score the way Father kept score — wins, losses, parts replaced." The old words, deliberately, turned in her hands like a blade being reversed and offered hilt-first. "He counts direction. And nobody in this room — *nobody* — has turned harder against what they were made to be than you."

"I sold you," Nebula said. "More than once."

"And then you crossed a galaxy for me more than once. The machine watched both." Gamora's voice went dry. "Apparently it can do arithmetic."

"I am Groot," said Groot, gently.

"Yeah," said Rocket, thick, not looking at anyone. "What he said."

High in the villains' dark, Thanos had not moved for the length of the entire pull. The Mad Titan watched the number — ninety-four, higher than the assassin he'd perfected, higher than all of them, pinned to the daughter he had taken apart most often — and the theatre nearest him would later swear the great chin lifted, just slightly, as though absorbing a blow from an unexpected quarter. "I made her a blade," he said at last, to no one who had asked. "Every piece I replaced was meant to remove the part that hesitated." A pause of geological length. "The boy's machine scores the hesitation highest. Interesting. Wrong — but interesting."

"It is not wrong, Titan; it is *pricing*," said Mephisto, lounging three seats down with his fingers steepled and his eyes gleaming like a market opening. "Redemption is the single scarcest commodity in every realm I hold paper on — nearly no one genuinely wants it; they want *absolution*, which is cheaper. She wants the real article. The dragon-boy stockpiles the real article. Of course the exchange rate is obscene." He sighed happily. "Ninety-four percent. I couldn't get terms like that with a *contract*."

"You couldn't get terms like that with a *soul*," said Doom, who had been taking notes again and pretending otherwise.

The scoreboard, which had been holding its breath along with everyone else, remembered it was a scoreboard.

SIDE-BET LEDGER — UPDATING, it announced, and the rust-red columns spun. Half the Ravager section had lost its shirts betting *traitor-class*; the units flowed in a great migratory river toward the three individuals who had bet otherwise. The theatre craned to see the winners' column: **GAMORA. GROOT. Y. UDONTA.**

Quill turned around slowly. "You bet on Nebula?"

"Bet on the *machine*," Yondu said, with the serenity of a man counting money. "Thing's been runnin' the same con for forty-six nights — shows you a body everyone's given up on, then shows you the boy not givin' up. Warn't gonna suddenly change genre." He jerked his chin at the console. "'Sides. I got history with the category. Folks the galaxy scores wrong." He did not look at Kraglin when he said it, which was how everyone knew it was about Kraglin, and Quill, and himself, in roughly that order.

Then, because sincerity had a strict half-life in the Ravager tiers: "Machine! Double or nothin'. Run my first mate."

"Cap'n—" Kraglin began, alarmed.

SUBJECT: KRAGLIN OBFONTERI, the machine printed, with what the room could only describe as relish. **NOT A GUARDIAN. ANALYZED ANYWAY, AS THE OPERATOR'S HAND IS STILL ON THE CONSOLE AND THE MACHINE FINDS HIM SOOTHING.**

COMPATIBILITY: NINETY-ONE PERCENT. ANALYSIS: LOYALTY THAT SURVIVED ONE MUTINY, ONE REGIME CHANGE, AND YEARS OF BEING THE ONLY ADULT ON A SHIP OF FERAL CHILDREN. ISSEI HYODOU'S HOUSEHOLD CONTAINS FOURTEEN WOMEN, A DRAGON, ASSORTED GODS, AND NO ADULTS WHATSOEVER. HE WOULD TRUST THIS MAN INSIDE A WEEK AND PUT HIM IN CHARGE OF LOGISTICS INSIDE TWO.

BETRAYAL RISK: HE FEELS GUILTY BORROWING TOOLS.

The Ravager section detonated. Kraglin went a blotchy, delighted crimson and mumbled something about the arrow incident that the machine, mercifully, declined to caption. Yondu collected his second payout of the night and put his boots back up, wearing the smug of a man whose entire parenting philosophy had just been peer-reviewed.

Stakar Ogord, who had watched the whole night from the captains' row with his arms folded, spoke for the first time. "Kid scores exiles high," he said, to Yondu, quietly, and something decades old passed between them. "Whole roster of 'em. The cat. The rival. Now her." He nodded once at Nebula, a captain's nod, the kind that had once meant *you fly with us*. "Machine keeps this up, gonna run out of people to give up on."

THAT IS THE INTENTION, said the screen, which was not supposed to answer, and the silence after it had teeth.

Nebula was still looking at the number. Mantis, two seats away, had been vibrating with restraint for ten full minutes; Nebula, without turning her head, said, "If you touch me, I will remove the hand," and then — a hesitation of nearly a full second, the longest the theatre had ever seen her spend on anything — "...later. You can do it later."

Mantis beamed like a sunrise.

High above, in the upper right quadrant, the crack ticked once — soft, mineral, patient — and the frozen light along its seams shimmered with that faint static-edged wrongness the room had learned not to discuss after midnight. The machine dimmed the scoreboard, filed the night's ledger, and printed its closing banner over the fading red columns:

COMPATIBILITY ANALYSIS: COMPLETE. ONE SUBJECT REMAINS UNSCORED.

THE DESTROYER HAS REQUESTED A CHAPTER. THE MACHINE PAYS ITS DEBTS.

NEXT: SIMULATION — DRAX VERSUS THE RESTRICTED DRAGON.

Drax, still standing, cracked his knuckles with the sound of a small avalanche, and smiled at the screen the way other men smile at old friends. "Finally," he said. "I will make an excellent chapter."

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Compatibility Analysis for Guardians* — Rare (the machine audits which Guardians Issei would trust and which might betray him, delivered dossier-style with the Ravager scoreboard running side-bets); *Nebula's Unexpected High Score* — Secret (Nebula rated **94% compatibility — highest of all Guardians analyzed**). Bonus unscheduled analysis: Kraglin Obfonteri, 91%, "betrayal risk: he feels guilty borrowing tools."
- **Secrets Revealed:** The machine's stated trust-metric for Issei: **he trusts direction, not records** — evidenced by the resubmitted triptych of forgiven former enemies (Kuroka at the family dinner table, Vali trusted at his back, Cao Cao — "the man who nearly ended him — forgiven"). On Nebula's betrayal risk: "she has already committed the only betrayal that interests her — she betrayed the person she was built to be; **the quota is spent**." The machine broke protocol to answer Stakar directly: scoring exiles high "IS THE INTENTION" — the strongest on-record confirmation yet that the theatre is deliberately building its audience toward something. Guardian scores logged: Quill (high; "incompetence risk: continuous"), Rocket (high; would steal from Issei but never sell him — "he would stay"), Drax (high; deferred to next chapter), Groot (maximum; Ddraig endorsement), Mantis (high), Gamora (high; "she would test him first").
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** **Nebula**, braced all arc to be rated traitor-class, is publicly re-filed by the machine — and by her sister — as the roster's best match for Issei; she doesn't accept it aloud, but she grants Mantis a future touch, which the room correctly reads as an earthquake. **Gamora** openly reverses their father's scorekeeping ("he counts direction — nobody has turned harder against what they were made to be than you"). **Thanos** absorbs the score as a blow: the machine prices the hesitation he spent years cutting out of Nebula *highest* — "wrong, but interesting." **Mephisto** frames Issei as the galaxy's largest holder of genuine redemption ("I couldn't get terms like that with a contract"); **Doom**: "you couldn't get terms like that with a soul." **Yondu** wins the book twice (bet on Nebula via the machine's "genre," then on Kraglin) and obliquely files himself, Kraglin, and Quill under "folks the galaxy scores wrong." **Stakar** gives Nebula a captain's nod — Ravager-adjacent acceptance.

- **Unresolved Hooks:** Next night is the machine's promised debt: **Simulation — Drax versus a Scale-Mail-restricted Issei** (Ch. 48); Drax refused to sit down all night and intends to "make an excellent chapter." The **screen's crack ticked once more** — unchanged since the arc began, unhealed, its seams still carrying the static-edged excision signature (Erased Child / Dragon Blaster scar thread, now spanning four arcs). The machine's admission that elevating "people the galaxy gave up on" is *intentional* sharpens the standing question of what the theatre is preparing everyone **for** — and Ddraig's untranslated draconic prophecy from Ch. 46 still sits in the room unexplained. Nebula owes Mantis one empathic touch; the theatre is quietly terrified of what Mantis will announce when she collects.

Chapter Forty-Eight: Drax Challenges the Emperor

Primary Reaction Groups: Guardians of the Galaxy (Drax, Star-Lord, Gamora, Rocket, Groot, Mantis, Nebula) • Avengers (Captain America, Thor, Iron Man, Captain Marvel) • Gods (Hercules, Loki, Heimdall)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Simulation: Drax vs. Restricted Issei" — **Epic**
 2. "Lesson on Intention and Grief" — **Secret**
-

The trouble with letting the Ravager section operate the gacha machine, the theatre had decided somewhere around the fourth night of Arc Five, was that the machine had begun operating *them* back.

It had insulted Yondu's teeth. It had humiliated Rocket across four hundred contingency plans. It had given Nebula, of all people, the compatibility score of the arc, and the room was still recalibrating around the sight of the deadliest woman in the galaxy pretending very hard that a number on a screen had not mattered to her. The scoreboard from that night still hung in the upper corner of the cracked screen — and beneath it, in the fracture the theatre had learned not to look at directly, the static-edged seams went on glowing, patient as arithmetic.

Which is why nobody was surprised when Drax the Destroyer stood up, walked down the aisle to the operator's podium, and put his whole green fist on the pull lever.

"The metal woman received a number," Drax announced, to the room at large, in the voice of a man filing a formal grievance with the universe. "The rat received a heist. The tree received a prophecy. Quill received nothing, which was correct. I have received *nothing also*, which is an error. I do not want a number." He turned to face the screen, chin lifting. "I want the boy. In combat. To the death."

"Buddy," said Peter Quill, half out of his seat, "we've *watched* him erase a mountain—"

"Then he will have the advantage," Drax said, reasonably.

"He paints *skies*, Drax. There is footage. You were there. You clapped."

"I clapped because it was beautiful. I will fight him because it was beautiful. These are not contradictions." Drax pulled the lever. "Machine. Make it fair."

The wheel came down out of the dark with what several witnesses would later describe as enthusiasm.

REQUEST LOGGED: HONOUR DUEL, printed the screen. **RESTRICTION PROTOCOL ENGAGED. SUBJECT'S ARCHIVE ACCESS CAPPED AT: BOOSTED GEAR — SCALE MAIL, BASE STATE. NO TRIAINA. NO PROMOTION. NO TRANSFER RESERVE.**

THIS IS THE MACHINE'S DEFINITION OF "FAIR."

IT IS STILL NOT FAIR.

"Nothing about that statement goes over my head," said Drax, cracking his knuckles. "My reflexes are too fast. I would catch it."

Up in the Avengers' rows, Carol Danvers pinched the bridge of her nose. "Base Scale Mail is a heavy-hitter designation. Core-Avengers-alarm tier. That's the *cap*." She glanced at Steve Rogers. "You want to stop this?"

Steve was watching Drax roll his shoulders in the aisle with the expression of a coach who had seen this exact walk before, on other men, toward other doors. "No," he said quietly. "I want to see what the machine thinks he needs. It hasn't been wrong yet."

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"SIMULATION: DRAX VS. RESTRICTED ISSEI" — RARITY: EPIC.

The theatre floor opened the way it had for Rocket's heist, and built an arena out of light.

It built it, the room noted, with care: a dead moon's surface under a bruised violet sky, ring of standing stones, no civilians, no structures, nothing to protect — a battlefield with the moral furniture deliberately removed. And into it the machine placed two figures. Drax, rendered knife-perfect down to the kill-tally scars. And across the ring, red armour assembling plate by plate out of green light, the visor's slit kindling like a struck match —

[WELSH DRAGON — BALANCE BREAKER!!]

— Issei Hyoudou, in the battered base Scale Mail of the middle chapters, before the trident, before the crimson queen. The theatre made the low sound of an audience greeting an old photograph. That armour had bled for Asia. That armour had lost to Sairaorg with dignity. That armour was, by the room's own filed assessments, still capable of removing the moon they stood on from most conversations.

Sim-Drax drew his knives and smiled the smile his crew privately called *the funeral invitation*.

"Red dragon!" he bellowed, joyous, already running. "I am Drax! Called the Destroyer! I have killed many things and been killed by several! You will be a magnificent addition to either list!"

[BOOST.]

The first exchange taught the room the shape of the whole fight, though almost nobody read it right away except Gamora and Steve Rogers, whose heads tilted at the same instant.

Drax fought like a man spending himself — every blow a full withdrawal, knives seeking arteries the armour didn't have, absolute commitment, zero retreat. It was, Hercules boomed approvingly, *proper* berserker work, the old style, the style you learn when you have decided your life is a weapon and weapons are for using up.

And Issei — capped, restricted, running on a fraction of his archive — *caught it*. Caught the knife-hand. Turned the hip-throw. Took a blow on the gauntlet that cratered the regolith behind him for thirty metres, and answered with —

— a shove.

An open gauntlet to the sternum, measured, deliberate: enough to put Drax on his back in the dust, not enough to break anything. The sim's system-voice logged it with terrible neutrality: **CONTACT. FORCE OUTPUT: 4% OF AVAILABLE.**

The theatre's villain rows leaned forward as one.

Drax rolled up, delighted, and came in again. Again the catch, the turn, the redirect. Again a strike that could have gone through him like weather, arriving instead as a wrestler's pin he was allowed to break. Boost after Boost chimed — **[BOOST.] [BOOST.] [BOOST.]** — the doubling ledger climbing into numbers that made Rhodey's HUD-glasses flinch, and none of it, *none of it*, arriving in Drax's body.

"He's stockpiling and not spending," Tony Stark said slowly. "That's — okay, that's actually the most unsettling thing he could do with it. He's letting the meter run so the fight stays real, and then declining to bill."

"He is *toying* with him," snarled Nebula, whose entire nervous system had been built by someone who toyed.

"No." Gamora's voice cut flat across her sister's. She was watching the red visor, not the knives. "Toying wants the humiliation. Look at his feet. He gives ground whenever Drax needs it and takes it back when Drax can bear it. He's not playing with him." A pause; her jaw set. "He's *sparring* him. The way you spar someone you're trying to keep."

In the ring, sim-Drax finally stepped back, chest heaving, and levelled a knife at the dented red armour, and his roar had turned raw at the edges.

"WHY DO YOU NOT FINISH IT?" he thundered. "I am open! My organs are *right here*! I have arranged them conveniently! You strike like a wall and grip like a Kylosian vice-beast and you keep — *catching* me — as if I were a thing that was *falling*! Fight me to the death, Red Dragon! It is the only

fight that counts!"

And the boy in the red armour stood there in the dust of the dead moon, aura banked like a furnace with its doors shut, and said — young, winded, and absolutely certain:

"No."

The vision froze on the word.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"LESSON ON INTENTION AND GRIEF" — RARITY: SECRET.

Secret-class pulls did not show the theatre footage. The room had learned this across five arcs. Secret-class pulls showed the theatre *the inside of something* — and what this one opened was the space between two warriors standing in a crater, one word old.

"No," said Issei again — the sim built out of the whole archive, speaking the way the archive knew he spoke. He reached up and released the helm; it folded back plate by plate, and under it was the least legendary face in two universes: seventeen, sweat-soaked, house-cut hair flattened, a boy who looked like he should be failing a math test somewhere. "You keep saying *to the death* like it's the good version. Like it's the fight with the honour in it." He shook his head slowly. "Old man, who told you that?"

"I am not old," said Drax. "I am *seasoned*. And no one told me. I learned it." He sat down on a standing stone that groaned under him, knives loose in his hands, suddenly not pointing at anything. "Ronan the Accuser came to my world. My wife was named Ovette. She danced. My daughter was named Camaria. She was — " the knives went still — "she was learning to. He killed them because they were in the place he wished to stand. Since that day I have fought to the death, every fight, because the death is the *point*. Every enemy I destroy is a stone I take out of the wall between me and the one who did it." He looked up at the boy with genuine, guileless confusion, and the theatre heard three thousand people not breathe. "If you do not fight to destroy, dragon — what do you carry into the fight? A fight is a container. It must hold something. Mine holds them."

And in the theatre, in the front of the Guardians' block, the real Drax the Destroyer sat with his forearms on his knees and did not move, and Mantis, beside him, had gone silver-eyed and silent with both hands pressed flat against her own sternum, feeling what he would never show.

On-screen, Issei sat down in the dust across from him. Not warily. The way you sit down across from someone at a kitchen table.

"I died," he said. "You know that, right? The machine shows everybody eventually. First girl who ever said yes to me put a spear of light through my chest on a park bench and told me the mistake was mine for being born what I am." He turned his left hand over; the green jewel in the gauntlet caught the violet light. "So I know what it's like to be the stone in someone's wall. And I had a friend — Asia. Gentlest person I ever met. Healed the people who spat on her. I watched her die on a church floor because a monster wanted the gift inside her more than the girl around it." His hand slowly closed. "And you know what I wanted, after? Exactly what you want. I wanted the fight where the death is the point. I got it, even. I beat the one who did it into the ground."

"And?" said Drax, leaning in. "Was it not glorious?"

"It was *empty*," said Issei. "That's the thing nobody puts in the war stories. I stood there with everything I'd wanted, and Asia was still dead, and my hands were still shaking, and the container you're talking about — the fight — I'd filled it with *her killer*. I'd made my best friend's murderer the thing I carry." He looked up, and his voice did the thing the theatre had heard exactly a handful of times, the register underneath the pervert and the punchlines, the one Ddraig answered to. "I got her back. I got lucky; my world had a way. But I kept the lesson. Now when I fight — and I fight *a lot*, old man, I fight things with too many heads and gods with grudges — I don't carry the enemy in. I carry *them* in. Asia. My master. My friends. My mom's cooking. Every dumb precious thing waiting on the other side of the fight. Destruction empties the container every time you win." He tapped the green jewel. "Protection *fills* it. That's the whole trick. That's why the doubling never breaks me. You can't overload a fight that's carrying people you love. There's always room."

The dead moon was very quiet.

"Your fists," Drax said at last, slowly, a man doing unfamiliar arithmetic. "When you struck me. Four percent. The rest was — them. You were holding them the entire time. That is why you caught me." His brow furrowed like continental drift. "You were not refusing to kill me. You were refusing to *drop what you were carrying* in order to kill me."

"There he is," said Issei, and grinned. "Nothing gets past you."

"Nothing does. My reflexes are legendary." Drax looked down at his knives for a long moment. Then, with enormous care, the way a man handles the ashes of a house, he said: "Ovette hated my fighting. I have never told anyone this. She said I came home from every victory with less of me. I believed she did not understand warriors." He sheathed the knives. "She understood warriors. She was trying to tell me what you just told me, and I outlived her misunderstanding her, and I have spent every year since putting her *killer* in the container instead of her dancing." His voice did not break. It did something worse; it went simple. "I do not know how to carry the dancing, Red Dragon. It is heavier than the rage."

"Yeah," said the boy softly. "It always is. Carry it anyway. That's the fight, old man. That's the one to the death — it just takes your whole life to finish."

[BOOST,] said the gear, once, very quietly, and the theatre would argue for weeks about what, exactly, it had doubled.

The simulation faded with the two of them still sitting there — the Destroyer and the Emperor, in the dust, saying nothing, in the manner of men at a graveside who have finally agreed whose grave it is.

The lights came up gently, which the machine almost never did.

Drax the Destroyer stood. The theatre braced for the grievance, the appeal, the demand for a rematch with the restriction protocols loosened.

"The machine's definition of fair was correct," Drax announced instead, to every tier at once. "I was not fighting one boy. I was fighting everyone he loves. No warrior has ever won that fight. It cannot be done. The numbers are absurd." He put his fist over his heart, facing the dark screen, and bowed his head — Drax, who bowed to nothing, whose respect had a body count for an entry fee. "Issei Hyoudou. Dragon Emperor. When we meet — and the tree's prophecy says the sovereign comes, so we will meet — I will not challenge you to the death." A pause. "I will ask you to spar. And I will bring my family to carry. Both of them dance."

"Aye," said Thor, low, from the Avengers' rows, in the voice of a man who had buried a mother, a father, a brother twice, and half a realm. "That is the oldest lesson there is, and the machine had to cross a multiverse to find someone young enough to say it plainly." Hercules, beside him, had nothing loud to offer for the first time in five arcs; he refilled a flagon that could not be filled and raised it anyway. Even Loki was quiet — covetous eyes narrowed at the green jewel, recalculating, as ever, what the dragon was actually guarding.

"Filed," said Carol Danvers, quietly, into her assessment log. "Subject fights at four percent against anyone he intends to keep. Addendum: he intends to keep *everyone*. That's the threat profile. That's the whole threat profile."

Mantis finally lowered her hands from her chest and touched Drax's arm as he sat back down. "It is still there," she whispered. "The grief. It did not get smaller."

"No," Drax agreed. "It got *carried*. This is different. I will explain it to you, but I will explain it badly for several years first."

The screen let the room have the moment. Then, in small print, almost tender by its standards:

LESSON ARCHIVED. THE RAVAGER SECTION IS ADVISED TO REST.

TOMORROW'S PULL CONCERNS A FUNERAL.

And in the upper corner, softly, patiently, where the frozen dark bent at the seams — *tick*, said the crack.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Simulation: Drax vs. Restricted Issei* — Epic (honour duel demanded by Drax at the operator podium; machine capped Issei at base Scale Mail — "THIS IS THE MACHINE'S DEFINITION OF 'FAIR.' IT IS STILL NOT FAIR"); *Lesson on Intention and Grief* — Secret (the duel's aftermath as an interior exchange between sim-Drax and sim-Issei).
- **Secrets Revealed:** In the restricted duel, Issei stockpiled Boosts and struck at **4% of available force**, catching and redirecting rather than finishing — Gamora's read: not toying but *sparring, the way you spar someone you're trying to keep*. Sim-Issei's confession: after Asia died on the church floor, he *did* get the fight-to-the-death he wanted against her killer and found it empty — "destruction empties the container every time you win; protection fills it"; he now carries his loved ones into every fight, which is why the doubling never breaks him. Drax revealed (stated as never-before-told) that his wife **Ovette** hated his fighting and warned he "came home from every victory with less of me" — he has spent years carrying her killer instead of her dancing. The Boosted Gear issued one quiet **[BOOST]** at the grief exchange; the theatre cannot agree what it doubled.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: Drax fully converts** — fist over heart, head bowed (his first bow on record): when they meet he will not challenge Issei to the death but ask to spar, "and I will bring my family to carry." He cites Groot's Chapter 46 sovereign-prophecy as certainty they *will* meet. Thor endorses the lesson as "the oldest there is"; Hercules toasts in silence; Mantis confirms empathically that Drax's grief is unchanged in size but now *carried*. Carol Danvers files the arc's sharpest threat-profile line: "he fights at four percent against anyone he intends to keep — addendum: he intends to keep everyone." Loki remains quiet and recalculating.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The machine, uncharacteristically gentle, closed with "**TOMORROW'S PULL CONCERNS A FUNERAL**" — direct setup for Chapter 49 (*The Ravager Funeral*; Yondu, Stakar, and the outlaw-honour question, with the Ravager verdict vote looming in Ch. 50). The Chapter 40 screen-fracture remains live and audibly ticking (static-edged seams; excision signature; three-arc thread — Erased Child, Dragon Blaster scar, the strain "testing the walls of the nest"). Groot's draconic sovereign-prophecy (Ch. 46) is now being treated by Drax — and implicitly the room — as a *schedule*, not a rumor: the audience increasingly assumes a real meeting is coming (Arc Nine seed). Still open: who is the Erased Child; what "counts what is taken"; whether the walls hold.

Chapter Forty-Nine: The Ravager Funeral

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers • Asgardians • Avengers • Cosmic Pirates

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Funeral for Fallen Outlaws" — **Rare**
 2. "Issei's Eulogy" — **Rare**
-

Nine nights into the Ravager arc, the theatre had learned the rhythm of its temporary operators, and the rhythm was noise.

The machine had handed its controls to the Ravager section back at the top of the arc — a decision the screen itself had annotated with the label **COMMON SENSE FAILURE** — and every night since had sounded like a dockside bar with a dress code of leather and grudges. They had watched Issei smuggle refugees and execute the pirates who broke their word. They had watched Rocket's heist simulation die four hundred deaths. They had watched Yondu talk fatherhood with a boy from another cosmology and come away quieter than anyone had ever seen him. They had watched Nebula's compatibility score, and Drax's lesson, and through all of it the crack in the screen's upper quadrant had gone on ticking, soft and mineral and patient, like a clock owned by something that was not in a hurry.

Tonight Kraglin Obfonteri had the lever, because Kraglin usually ended up with the lever, the way the first mate ends up with everything nobody else wants to hold.

"Alright, you beautiful hunk of insultin' junk," he said, and pulled.

The wheel spun down through its colors and stopped on the plain silver band the room had learned to read as *Rare* — the breather tier, the low-stakes tier, the tier that had given them Yondu's dental records and a compatibility quiz.

Several people actually relaxed.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2, printed the screen.

"FUNERAL FOR FALLEN OUTLAWS" — RARITY: RARE.

"Aw, hell," said Yondu Udonta, very quietly, before the vision even took them. He was a pirate. He could read a manifest. He knew what that cargo was going to be.

And then the theatre breathed in, and swallowed them all.

Space, in the vision. Not the loud kind. The kind at the edge of a system nobody names in songs — a brown dwarf sulking on the horizon, a debris field still warm, and hanging in the middle distance the broken halves of a ship the theatre recognized, because the theatre had met her crew eight nights ago.

The *Molly Weathervane*. The smuggler that had run refugees out of a dying empire with Issei Hyoudou standing on her hull like a crimson figurehead. Her captain had been a woman with a tin jaw and a laugh like a cargo winch; her crew had been forty-one accumulated warrants wearing coats. They had kept the code. That was the whole of their virtue, the vision's captions noted, with the machine's usual refusal to flatter: **THEY ROBBED THE INSURED. THEY LIED TO EVERYONE. THEY DID NOT HARM CIVILIANS. ONCE.**

The captions laid out the arithmetic of their last hour with terrible economy. A convoy of colony ships — three thousand souls, farmers and children and one bewildered brass band — caught at the jump point by a slaver fleet that had been promised easy freight. The *Weathervane* had been close enough to run. She had jump fuel. She had no contract, no client, no percentage.

She turned around anyway.

The vision did not glamorize the fight, and the theatre understood by now that this was the machine's highest form of respect. Forty-one outlaws held a jump corridor for eleven minutes against odds that needed no dramatizing. They bought the colony ships their spool-up time with hull plate and bad language and, at the end, with the *Weathervane* herself, driven like a nail into the slaver flagship's spine. The colony ships jumped. The brass band, the captions noted, made it to the new world, and plays every founding day.

Eleven of the forty-one got to lifepods.

Thirty did not.

The vision cut — days later, a rust-red moon with a view of that same brown dwarf, and a landing field filling up with the worst-looking honor guard in two cosmologies. Smugglers. Wreckers. Bounty men. Crews that shot at each other on principle, parked wing to wing with their guns cold. And walking among them, in a black suit that did not fit him because he had borrowed it from his own father's closet, a Japanese teenager with brown hair and an aura the locals' instruments refused to file, carrying — the theatre leaned in — thirty small lanterns in a crate.

"He came," said Kraglin, hoarse. "They's outlaws an' he *came*."

"Course he came," said Yondu. He didn't say anything else. His hand had come up, without his permission, to rest on his own chest, over the place where a fin used to be and a heart still was.

What followed, the captions named plainly: **RITE OF THE FLEETS. VARIANT: LOCAL. PATTERN: UNIVERSAL.**

Because it seemed — and the vision let the theatre feel the truth of it settle — that every fleet in every sky eventually finds its way to the same funeral. There were no graves. Spacers don't dig. There was fire, and there were colors. As the brown dwarf set, each crew fired its dead into the dark and lit the sky behind them — banners of dyed plasma poured from engine housings, streamers of flare-light in the colors of each ship, thirty lanterns released from a boy's hands one at a time, rising until they were indistinguishable from the founding stars of new constellations. The whole horizon became ribbons of red and gold and slaver-bane blue, arches of light over a rusty moon, a cathedral improvised out of exhaust and grief.

In the theatre, in the operators' box, Stakar Ogord stood up without a word and took off his hat.

The room heard it then — a soft rustle spreading through the Ravager section like wind through a junkyard, ninety-odd hardened felons coming to their feet, hats and hoods and helmets coming off, because the shape of those lights was *their* shape, the rite was *their* rite with different fuel, and you stand for the colors, that was the whole of the law, you *stand for the colors*.

"Every fleet finds its way to the same sky," Stakar said, to no one, to everyone. His voice was gravel poured over something older. "Hundred thousand light-years and a whole other cosmology, and they still send 'em up in fire so the dark has to look at 'em." He watched the ribbons arch and fade. "Ain't no God of pirates. So we make the sky do it."

Three tiers up, the Asgardian block had gone equally still, and Thor Odinson was looking at the lantern-strewn dark with his jaw set and his eyes bright and eight hundred years of funeral boats behind his face.

"We burn ours on the water," he said quietly. "The ship, the sword, the fire, the long push from shore. I stood so for my mother. For my father the sky itself did it." He nodded slowly at the screen. "I did not think to see the same shape rise out of a smuggler's engine wash. It is the same prayer, spoken with worse grammar."

"It's the only prayer," said the Valkyrie, from beside him, arms folded, voice flat with professional knowledge. "I carried dead to Valhalla for centuries. You want to know the dirty secret of the halls? We never asked how they *lived*. We asked how they *died*. One good death bought the whole ledger." She tipped her chin at the thirty rising lanterns. "By Odin's own accounting, every one of those thieves just outranked half the honored dead of Asgard. Sit with that."

"I don't accept that math," Frank Castle said, from the dark of the back rows, and the theatre's temperature dropped a degree, because Castle had been silent all arc. "Dying good doesn't unhurt anybody they hurt. The ledger doesn't wash. It just stops."

"Nobody said it washes," said Sam Wilson — evenly, without heat, a counselor's voice that had run more grief groups than the room knew. "Funerals aren't for the ledger, Frank. They're for the living. Look at the kid's face."

The vision obliged. It went close on Issei Hyoudou, seventeen, releasing the last lantern with both hands, the way you'd release a bird, and the room could see that he was crying without any attempt at dignity whatsoever, tears cutting tracks down his face while outlaws twice his age and ten times his body count stood dry-eyed around him — and that not one of those outlaws thought less of him for it. Several of them stood closer to him instead, the way people stand near a fire in the cold.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2, said the screen, gently, for it.

"ISSEI'S EULOGY" — RARITY: RARE.

"Rare," muttered Rocket Raccoon, from the operator's rail, in the tone of a man building a wall out of whatever was handy. "Two rares. Whole night of discount sentiment. Machine's gone soft. Somebody pull the — someone else can log this one, I got, there's a — coolant thing," and nobody looked at him, which was its own kind of mercy, and he did not go anywhere at all.

On the rust-red moon, somebody had built a speaker's stand out of two cargo crates, and the tin-jawed captain's first mate — captain now, by the worst promotion there is — asked the boy from the black suit to say words, because the *Weathervane* had liked him, and outlaws don't trust their own mouths at funerals.

Issei Hyoudou stood on the crates in his father's suit and was visibly, catastrophically bad at this.

"I'm not good at speeches," he began, which the theatre already knew, and heard him plow forward anyway, because plowing forward was the entire architecture of his soul. "And I'm not going to lie to you, because they'd know. They were liars. Professionals. They'd know."

A ripple of terrible laughter went through the mourners, the kind that keeps a crowd from breaking.

"The people we're sending up tonight did bad things," Issei said. "Real ones. I'm not going to stand here and pretend they were secretly heroes all along, because they weren't, and if I said they were, Captain Marrow would climb out of that sky and take my wallet." He had to stop for a second. The vision let him. "Where I come from, I'm a Devil. That's not — it's a job description, kind of, it's a long story — but the point is, everyone I love, almost everyone, is someone that somebody else gave up on. My best

friend was born something people fear. One of the people most precious to me spent years as a criminal, a real one, wanted posters and everything, and she is the best big sister anyone ever had. I have fought people to the absolute edge of both our lives who eat dinner at my house now. So I know this one thing. I know it the way I know my own arm."

He held up his left arm — bare, no gauntlet, just a boy's arm in a borrowed sleeve — and the theatre, who knew what lived in it, held its breath anyway.

"Nobody is finished," Issei said. "Nobody. Not the worst person you ever met, not the worst person you ever *were*. Anybody can turn around. It doesn't erase the road behind you — you don't get that, nobody gets that — but the road ahead is yours until the second it isn't, and these thirty people spent their last eleven minutes proving it. They turned the ship around. That was the choice. Everything they'd done before made it unlikely, and they did it anyway, and three thousand people get to grow old because thirty thieves decided the last thing they'd ever be was *good*." His voice cracked, and he let it, because he had never once in his life protected his dignity when there was something better to protect. "So that's what I'll remember. Not the warrants. The turn. I hope — wherever they are, whatever sky gets them — I hope somebody's telling them it counted. It counted. It counted."

He got down off the crates. The new captain put her hand on his shoulder. Behind them the last ribbons of color came apart into the founding dark.

The vision released the theatre and did not turn the lights up, and for once no one complained, because no one's face was ready.

In the Avengers' rows, Scott Lang was crying with the frank, unembarrassed competence of a man who had done his crying in prison and learned it held no terrors. "That's it," he said thickly, to Hope, to Steve, to anyone. "That's the whole thing. That's what you want somebody to say over you. I got a *second chance* and half the guys I did time with never — 'nobody is finished.' Somebody put it on a wall."

Steve Rogers said nothing for a long moment. Then: "I've buried soldiers who lived their whole lives clean and I've buried men who only found their courage at the end. I never once figured out how to weigh one against the other." He looked at the dark where the lanterns had been. "He doesn't weigh. That's the trick of him. He just counts the turn."

"The turn is the only datum that predicts anything," said Nebula, flat and precise, from the Guardians' block — and the room went carefully quiet, because Nebula did not volunteer. Her black eyes stayed fixed on the screen. "Every system I was built by measured origin. Where you came from. What you

were made as. His system measures *heading*." A pause, machined and deliberate. "I have changed my heading. His compatibility engine noticed before most of the people in this room did. That is all. That is my eulogy for the thieves."

Stakar Ogord still had his hat in his hands. He was looking, the theatre gradually noticed, not at the screen but down the operators' rail — at Yondu, who had not moved in a quarter of an hour, who was still standing with his palm flat on his own chest.

"Hundred ships," Stakar said at last, rough. "When I go, hundred ships'll send up the colors, on account of that's the rite, and I earned the rite." He worked his jaw. "I took your colors, Yondu. You broke the code and I took 'em, and I'd take 'em again — and yet I just watched a boy in a bad suit stand over thirty men worse'n you and say *nobody's finished*." He put his hat back on, which for Stakar Ogord was the raising of a flag. "So maybe there's an exile someplace that ends. That's all I'm sayin'. Maybe the arrow flies home."

Yondu didn't look at him. Yondu's voice came out low and stripped, no whistle in it at all.

"Kid woulda come to mine," he said. "That's what's got me. All them stars in that boy's world, all them wives an' dragons an' wars — some blue idjit with a bad ledger goes down swingin' one time, an' that kid woulda put on his daddy's suit an' *come*." He blinked hard at the dark. "Ain't nobody taught him to do that. That's just what's in the tank."

Nobody had anything to add to that, so the theatre, in its wisdom, argued about something else, and the gods and the captains and the killers talked ledgers and lanterns for a long while — and no one noticed, or everyone pretended not to notice, that the operator's rail had been short one raccoon since the eulogy's third sentence.

Behind the machine housing, in the dark between two conduit banks where no sightline reached, Rocket Raccoon sat with his knees up and his face pressed into his forearms, shaking, making no sound at all, because he had learned a long time ago on a table in a lab that sound brings attention. Thirty thieves and a sky full of colors. *Nobody is finished. Not the worst person you ever were*. He'd have shot anybody who said it to his face. He cried like something breaking open, alone, where nobody could see.

A shadow fell over him, fifteen feet tall and patient.

"I am Groot," said Groot, very softly.

"I know, buddy," Rocket managed, not lifting his head, reaching up blind so a wooden hand could close around his whole arm. "I know. Shut up. I know."

Above the theatre, unremarked amid the arguments, the crack in the screen's upper quadrant had gone silent. Through the whole rite, through the whole eulogy — those keeping count would confirm it later, and Heimdall, who missed nothing, would not contradict them — the crack had not ticked once. As if

whatever was testing the walls had stopped, briefly, to look at the lights.

Then the screen chimed, and the wheel reassembled, and printed the next night's freight in letters that got the whole Ravager section shouting at once:

NEXT PULL PENDING: RAVAGER VOTE ON ISSEI HYOUDOU. WELCOME. WATCH. SHOOT ON SIGHT. THE FLEET WILL DECIDE.

"Oh, now it's a democracy," said Kraglin, wiping his face with his sleeve, and pulled the lever to bank the night.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Funeral for Fallen Outlaws" — Rare (*viewed*)
- "Issei's Eulogy" — Rare (*viewed*)

Secrets Revealed:

- The smuggler crew from the refugee run (Chapter 42's *Molly Weathervane*, Captain Marrow) later died holding a jump corridor against a slaver fleet — thirty of forty-one killed buying escape time for three thousand colonists. The machine's epitaph: "They did not harm civilians. Once... they turned the ship around."
- Issei's world has its own spacer funeral rite — fire, engine-dyed colors, and lanterns sent into the dark — which the machine labeled "RITE OF THE FLEETS. VARIANT: LOCAL. PATTERN: UNIVERSAL," structurally identical to the Ravager send-off. Issei attended in his father's borrowed suit and gave the eulogy at the crew's request.
- The eulogy states his ethic in its clearest form yet: no whitewashing ("they did bad things — real ones"), no erasing the road behind, but "nobody is finished... anybody can turn around," citing his own family of forgiven enemies and reformed criminals. "I don't remember the warrants. I remember the turn."
- The crack in the screen (Chapter 40's omen) did not tick once during the entire rite and eulogy — its first silence since it appeared. Whatever is testing the walls stopped to watch. Heimdall can confirm the timing.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- The entire Ravager section stood and uncovered for the colors — the theatre's first spontaneous collective rite. Stakar Ogord, moved, publicly cracked the door on Yondu's exile: "Maybe there's an

exile someplace that ends. Maybe the arrow flies home."

- Yondu: quietly devastated; his summary of Issei — "some blue idjit with a bad ledger goes down swingin', an' that kid woulda come" — sets his heading for the Chapter 50 vote.
- Rocket mocked the sentiment aloud, then cried alone behind the machine housing where only Groot found him. The theatre at large does not know; Groot does.
- Asgardian frame established: Thor recognizes the rite as kin to Asgard's funeral boats ("the same prayer, spoken with worse grammar"); Valkyrie exposes Valhalla's own math — the halls judged deaths, not lives — and notes the thirty thieves "outrank half the honored dead of Asgard."
- Scott Lang (ex-con Avenger) openly adopts "nobody is finished" as creed; Steve Rogers: "He doesn't weigh. He counts the turn." Nebula volunteers her first self-disclosure — Issei's systems "measure heading, not origin." Frank Castle dissents on record: a good death stops the ledger, it doesn't wash it — the room's standing counter-argument on redemption.

Unresolved Hooks:

- Chapter 50 announced: the full Ravager fleet votes on Issei — Welcome, Watch, or Shoot On Sight — with Yondu's "welcome" telegraphed and Stakar's softening noted but unspent.
- The crack's silence during the funeral: does the strain on the theatre respond to *content*? Something outside the walls appeared to stop and watch the lights. No one has yet said this aloud to the machine.
- Stakar's half-promise about ending Yondu's exile is open — the fleet's judgment of Issei and its judgment of Yondu are now emotionally the same question.
- Castle vs. the room: the redemption ledger ("the turn" vs. "the wash") remains the arc's live moral argument, primed for Arc Six's formal tribunal of Issei (Chapter 51).

Chapter Fifty: The Captain's Vote

Primary Reaction Groups: Ravagers • Guardians of the Galaxy • Avengers

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Ravager Vote on Issei" — **Secret**
 2. "Destroyed Trafficking Fleet" — **Epic**
-

On the tenth night of the Ravager arc, the machine did not offer Yondu Udonta the lever.

For nine nights it had. That had been the whole flavor of the thing — the gacha wheel surrendering its crank to a rotating crew of blue-skinned pirates, insulting their intelligence in polite white letters while they argued about whether you could hotwire fate. They had pulled a dragon's pirate code out of it, and a heist simulation that had cost Rocket his dignity in front of two galaxies, and a treasure planet that turned out to be a jail, and a funeral that nobody in the theatre had managed to joke about, last night, not even once. The Ravager block had come into this arc loud. They were quiet now, in the way of men who had been shown a mirror with better posture.

High in the corner of the screen, the crack sat where it had sat for ten chapters — hairline, static-edged, patient. It had not grown. Several beings checked it nightly the way you check a smoke detector. It ticked, very occasionally, like a house settling, and everyone pretended not to flinch.

Tonight the lever was gone, and the wheel spun itself.

ARC FINALE, the screen printed. **THE RAVAGER ROLLS: VERDICT.**

FOR NINE NIGHTS YOU HAVE OPERATED THE MACHINE. TONIGHT THE MACHINE OPERATES YOU.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel ticked down through its colors and landed on a color it had almost never used — the deep, lightless violet the theatre had learned to sit up for.

"RAVAGER VOTE ON ISSEI" — RARITY: SECRET.

"Uh," said Peter Quill. "That's — hang on. Secrets are supposed to be about *him*."

THIS ONE IS, said the screen, and then, beneath it, in the tone of a subpoena: **THE SUBJECT'S FILE IS NINETY PERCENT COMPLETE FOR THIS ARC'S PURPOSES. ONE FIELD REMAINS EMPTY. THE FIELD IS YOURS.**

PROPOSITION: ISSEI HYOUDOU ENTERS RAVAGER SPACE. FLYING NO FLAG. ASKING FOR NOTHING. WHAT IS HE?

Three vertical bands of colored fire kindled across the bottom of the screen, and under each one a word assembled itself, letter by letter, savoring it the way the machine savored all its cruelties.

WELCOMED.

WATCHED.

SHOT ON SIGHT.

ALL SWORN RAVAGERS AND RAVAGER-RAISED WILL CAST. CAPTAINS' BALLOTS WILL BE READ ALOUD. THE MACHINE DOES NOT ACCEPT ABSTENTIONS. YOU ARE PIRATES. PICK.

A coin of light appeared in front of every leather jacket in the block — hundreds of them, hanging in the air at chest height, turning slowly. One materialized in front of Quill, who stared at it. "Ravager-raised," he read off the screen, and something crossed his face that he covered with a cough. "Okay. Okay, wow, tonight has layers."

"It's a vote," said Sam Wilson, from the Avengers rows, in the careful voice of a man identifying an unexploded thing. "It's making the pirates *vote*. On a kid."

"It's making them go on record," Steve Rogers said quietly. He had leaned forward, elbows on knees, and his eyes were moving across the Ravager block the way they moved across a room before a hard conversation. "There's a difference. Fifty chapters of opinions in the dark. Now it wants signatures."

The Ravager block detonated into caucus.

"He killed pirates," a scarred captain was saying, three rows deep, jabbing a finger at the dark screen as if Chapter Forty-Two were still playing on it. "You all saw it same as me. Crew broke their word about civilians and he put 'em *down*. You want that walking through the Quadrant asking nothing?"

"He killed pirates who broke code," Kraglin said, with unusual heat. "That ain't a threat to Ravagers, that's a *compliment* to Ravagers. That's a boy who read the rules and took 'em serious. More'n Taserface ever did."

"The rules," rumbled Charlie-27, massive arms folded, "are that nobody flies through our space for free."

"The rules," said Aleta Ogord, acid-sweet, "also say we don't deal in kids, and half of you voted to make an exception the year the money was good, so let's not get *scriptural*."

"He'd be the single largest liability in the Quadrant," Martinex said, crystalline and precise. "Every bounty office in six empires would post him inside a week. Anywhere he docks becomes a war."

"Anywhere he docks becomes *defended*," Kraglin shot back. "You saw the vault planet. You saw what he does when somethin' can't run."

Rocket, who held no ballot and had opinions anyway, was standing on his seat. "I wanna state for the record that I ran three hundred and eleven simulations against this guy's house and the *house* beat me, and I am voting welcome, and I don't even get a vote, that's how welcome I'm voting."

"I am Groot," said Groot, solemnly.

"He says his vote's welcome too," Rocket translated. "He and the dragon got history. Don't ask."

Nebula had not joined the caucus. She sat at the edge of the Guardians' rows with her arms crossed, watching the three bands of fire, and when Gamora glanced at her she said, without being asked: "Watched. Everyone should be watched." A pause, machinery ticking in her jaw. "But he'd pass. That's the difference between him and everyone I grew up with. Watch him as long as you want. He'd never notice, because he'd never be doing anything worth catching."

Drax stood. Drax had been waiting, possibly for days, to stand. "When I fought him," he announced, to the entire theatre, "he could have humiliated me. Instead he spoke of my family without flinching from what happened to them. He fights like a man who has buried people." He sat down. Then he stood up again. "Welcome. Obviously. I have finished speaking."

Up in the Avengers rows, Tony Stark had the look of a man watching someone else's shareholder meeting. "I want everyone to appreciate what's happening here," he said. "The most legally flexible demographic in two galaxies is holding a *citizenship hearing*. We couldn't get through one Accords meeting without a civil war, and the space pirates have a functioning electoral process. I need to sit with that."

"They're not voting on whether he's dangerous," Carol Danvers said. Her eyes hadn't left the fires. "That got settled in Chapter Forty. Sovereign-tier, filed. They're voting on whether he's *theirs*. That's the only question his power level doesn't answer."

The coins began to fly. Ravagers cast the way Ravagers did everything — loudly, with commentary, several of them trying to cast twice — each coin of light streaking into one of the three fires, which flared and swallowed and kept no visible count. Whistles and jeers tracked the obvious ones. A long, low *ooooh* tracked the surprises.

The three fires burned. The tally line appeared:

BALLOTS CAST: 100%. CAPTAINS' READINGS COMMENCE. TALLY IN—

The wheel moved.

It should not have moved. The vote was mid-ceremony, the tally line half-printed, and the wheel spun anyway, hard, unscheduled, the way it had only ever done when the machine decided the room was about to conclude something without all the facts.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"DESTROYED TRAFFICKING FLEET" — RARITY: EPIC.

"Oh, you *dirty* cheat," Rocket breathed, delighted. "It's stuffing the ballot box."

THE MACHINE DOES NOT INFLUENCE ELECTIONS, said the screen. **THE MACHINE COMPLETES DISCLOSURE.**

And the theatre took a breath, and swallowed them.

Deep space, in the vision — not their deep space; the stars were arranged by a different hand — and strung across it like a filthy necklace, a fleet.

Thirty-one hulls. The captions supplied the anatomy with the machine's usual clinical economy: a slaver combine operating across three supernatural territories, grabbing from war zones and refugee columns and the villages of species without treaties. Cargo manifests scrolled past faster than reading speed, which was a mercy, because the theatre caught the column headers anyway. *Age. Condition. Projected yield.*

Every Ravager in the block had gone very still. There is one thing outlaw cultures agree on across every galaxy that grows them, and the fleet on the screen was it.

The vision found Issei Hyoudou standing on nothing, in empty space, a mile off the flagship's bow. Crimson armor, wings folded, small against the necklace of hulls. The captions timestamped it dryly — *subject age seventeen; acting alone; no authorization, no backup, no plan on file* — and the theatre heard him ask, quietly, inside the helm:

"Ddraig. How many people in those holds?"

"Eleven thousand," said the dragon, low. **"Give or take the ones who didn't survive the week. Partner. Your heartbeat is doing the thing it does. I'll ask once: arrest, or war?"**

The boy was silent for a moment. When he answered, the theatre had heard the voice before — twice. Once over Asia Argento. Once over a vault that turned out to be a prison.

"Both. Holds first."

[BOOST.]

What followed took eleven minutes, and the vision refused to compress a single one.

He hit the flagship first — not its bridge, its *collar grid*, the network node that wired eleven thousand slave collars to one master switch, and the theatre watched Penetrate go through four decks of shielding like an opinion through a committee and kill the switch before any hand aboard could reach it. Then the fleet's engines, ship by ship, wings of crimson crossing the dark in Knight-speed drumrolls, each drive section surgically deleted, each hull left whole, lit, breathable — and drifting, anchored, *harvestable*. Slavers who surrendered got exactly what the pirates of Chapter Forty-Two had gotten before they broke their word: cable-ties of hardened light and a place to sit. Slavers who turned their guns inward, onto the holds, onto the merchandise, to burn the evidence—

The vision did not cut away from what happened to those. It didn't linger either. It simply let the theatre understand that the count of them was twenty-six, that each had been a choice, and that he had made every one of the twenty-six without hesitation and had not enjoyed a single one.

"He does kill slavers," Nebula said, into the dark, to no one. "I asked, eight nights ago." Something in her voice had come loose. "The answer is still yes."

The last minutes were the ones that broke the block. Issei Hyoudou walking the holds with his helm retracted so that the people chained there could see a face — seventeen years old, exhausted, wet-eyed, saying *you're okay, you're okay, we're going home* in a language the captions translated but the tone didn't need. Transfer pouring warmth into bodies too cold to shiver. The manifests — every ledger of ownership, every bill of sale, every column headed *projected yield* — hauled into open space in one mass and burned in dragonfire, so that no record survived saying any of those eleven thousand had ever been anyone's property. And the salvage rights to thirty-one intact hulls, a fortune that made the Collector visibly recalculate, signed over entire — to the cargo. To the eleven thousand, who arrived at the nearest free port not as refugees but as a shipping fleet's owners.

"For the record, partner," Ddraig said, as the boy fell asleep mid-sentence on the flight home, **"you forgot to keep even one ship. Again."**

"Mm. Didn't forget."

The vision released them.

Nobody spoke first for a long moment, because the Ravager block was having a problem, and the problem was that pirates do not cry in public and several hundred of them needed a minute to reestablish this.

TALLY SUSPENDED PENDING CAPTAINS' READINGS, said the screen, remorseless.
CAPTAIN UDONTA.

Yondu Udonta stood up slow, fin catching the light of the three fires. He turned his coin over in his fingers once, twice, and when he spoke he pitched it to carry, the way he did when he wanted a crew to remember something.

"I spent twenty years tellin' myself the worst thing I ever did was fly kids to somebody who wanted 'em for somethin' I didn't check on." He let that sit. The theatre knew the story by now; the theatre had watched him and a crimson dragon talk about it, six nights ago, in a vision neither of them would confirm was hypothetical. "Boy on that screen just spent eleven minutes bein' the man I coulda been if I'd checked. He can dock anywhere I'm captain. He can eat my food an' scratch my ship an' marry whoever the hell else he wants, I lost count." He flipped the coin into the leftmost fire, and the fire went up like a cheer. "*Welcome.* An' I whistle at the next idiot who makes me explain it."

CAPTAIN OGORD.

Stakar Ogord did not stand for a moment. When he did, he was looking at Yondu, not the screen, and something passed between the two men that had a hundred years of exile and one funeral in it.

"Welcome's a feeling," Stakar said. "I got the feeling. I ain't voting it." He held up his coin. "A hundred years of code says you watch *everybody* — that's not an insult, that's the job, and the boy would tell you the same. You saw him. He watches himself harder than we ever could. He counts his own kills and hates the arithmetic." The coin went into the middle fire, clean and unapologetic. "*Watched.* And it'd be the easiest watch any Ravager ever stood, and I'd bid for the shift."

CAPTAIN... TASERFACE, said the machine, and even the machine's flat white letters managed skepticism.

"It's an intimidating name," Taserface began, standing, and got no further, because he tossed his coin toward the rightmost fire and said "*shoot on sight, he's a threat to our whole way of—*"

The theatre shouted him down.

Not the Ravagers. The *theatre*. It started in the Ravager block — a wall of boos, Kraglin's whole seat cushion, someone's boot — but it spread, rows on rows, Rocket howling insults with both hands cupped, Drax booing with the grave thoroughness of a man completing an assigned task, half the Avengers on their feet, Hercules booing *musically*, and from somewhere in the villains' dark even Mephisto's voice,

warm and appalling: "Sir, I traffic in souls and *I* find you embarrassing." Yondu's whistle split the noise once, sharp — the arrow rose, glowing, and hung in the air an inch from Taserface's nose with the patience of a raised eyebrow — and Taserface sat down, and the rightmost fire, receiving his lone coin, produced a small, damp, apologetic *flup*.

TALLY, said the screen.

SHOT ON SIGHT: ONE VOTE. THE MACHINE HAS LOGGED THE VOTER'S NAME AND FEELS NOTHING BUT IS CAPABLE OF IRONY.

WATCHED: ELEVEN PERCENT — CONCENTRATED AMONG CAPTAINS AND OFFICERS OF LONG SERVICE, WHO ARE PAID TO VOTE THAT WAY.

WELCOMED: ALL THE REST.

VERDICT OF THE RAVAGER FLEETS: THE SUBJECT, ENTERING OUTLAW SPACE, FLYING NO FLAG, ASKING FOR NOTHING — IS KIN.

The Ravager block came up out of its seats roaring, and the leftmost fire climbed the screen in a sheet of gold, and Peter Quill — who would never tell anyone which fire his own coin had gone into, and did not have to, because everyone had watched him cast it the second Yondu finished talking — stood in the middle of it with his jaw working, muttering something about how the weird dragon kid got adopted in ten days and it took *him* twenty-six years.

"Fifty chapters," Steve Rogers said, into the noise, mostly to himself — but Sam heard it, and Natasha. "Night one, that room up there watched a boy die in a park and half of us filed him under victim and the other half under punchline." He watched the gold fire settle. "Tonight the hardest crowd in two galaxies just voted him family, and the only argument was whether loving him required keeping an eye on him." He shook his head slowly. "That's not a threat assessment anymore. Hasn't been for a while. That's a *reputation*."

SESSION 50 OF 100, printed the screen, and the whole theatre went quiet at the number, because the machine had never once acknowledged its own arithmetic. **INTERMISSION ACKNOWLEDGED. THE FILE IS HALF READ.**

FIRST HALF: WHO HE IS. YOU HAVE ANSWERED ADEQUATELY.

SECOND HALF: WHAT HE IS FOR.

And beneath it, one frame, the old line — steady, patient, no longer feeling like a threat and not yet feeling like a comfort:

HE IS THE ONE WHO WILL STAND BEFORE THE THINGS YOU CANNOT.

Up in its corner, softly, the crack ticked once — a single new hairline branch, fine as a frost-flower, reaching a centimeter further toward the center of the screen. Ddraig's rumble came out of the dark, low, almost amused, entirely unreassuring:

"Halfway. Hm. In my experience, partner, the second half of a siege is the one where you learn what the walls were for."

The lights went down on the gold fire still burning, and the banner that assembled itself in the dark was not addressed to the pirates at all.

NEXT: ARC SIX — MARVEL JUDGES THE DRAGON.

BRING YOUR OWN GAVEL.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Ravager Vote on Issei* — Secret (the machine inverted the format: the pull was a formal, binding poll of all sworn Ravagers and Ravager-raised — Quill ruled eligible — on whether Issei entering outlaw space would be WELCOMED, WATCHED, or SHOT ON SIGHT, with captains' ballots read aloud); *Destroyed Trafficking Fleet* — Epic (deliberately fired mid-vote, before the tally, as "completed disclosure"). Arc Five finale under the banner "THE RAVAGER ROLLS: VERDICT."
- **Secrets Revealed:** At seventeen, alone and unsanctioned, Issei destroyed a thirty-one-hull interstellar slave-trafficking fleet in eleven minutes: Penetrate killed the master collar-grid before it could be triggered; every hull was disabled but left habitable; surrendering slavers were bound, and the twenty-six who fired on their own holds were killed without hesitation and without pleasure — confirming (per Nebula's Ch. 42 question) that slavers are the standing exception to his kill-restraint. He then freed eleven thousand captives, burned every ownership manifest so no record of their enslavement survived, and signed the entire fleet's salvage over to the freed captives themselves, keeping nothing. The machine also acknowledged its own structure for the first time: "SESSION 50 OF 100... FIRST HALF: WHO HE IS... SECOND HALF: WHAT HE IS FOR."
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts: The Ravager fleets formally claim Issei as KIN** — Welcomed by overwhelming majority; Watched at eleven percent (career officers voting the code, per Stakar: "the easiest watch any Ravager ever stood, and I'd bid for the shift"); Shot on Sight received exactly one vote (Taserface), which was shouted down by the entire theatre, including Mephisto. Yondu's on-record ballot: "Welcome — he's the man I could've been if I'd checked," free docking rights anywhere he's captain. Quill cast with the fleet. Nebula votes Watched as a compliment ("Watch him as long as you want... he'd never be doing anything worth catching"); Drax, Rocket, and Groot

all Welcome. Rogers files the room's fifty-chapter arc aloud: from "victim or punchline" in Chapter One to a *reputation* — the debate is no longer whether he's safe, but the terms of loving him.

- **Unresolved Hooks: MIDPOINT STATE OF THE ROOM (carry forward):** across five arcs, the theatre's consensus on Issei has traveled from *pathetic murdered pervert* (Arc One's grief and mockery) → *compound-interest problem* (Arc Two) → *family man whose household is off the board as leverage* (Arc Three) → *sovereign-tier strategic actor, "the piece that stands in front of the king"* (Arc Four) → tonight's close: **the multiverse's outlaws have formally adopted him as kin**, meaning every major bloc — street-level, Avengers-class, gods, villains, cosmic tier, and now the pirates — holds a settled, largely favorable file on him at the story's exact halfway mark. The machine has declared the first half ("who he is") complete and the second half to be "what he is for" — sharpening the Ch. 1 suspicion that this is a briefing before an arrival. **The crack grew:** one new branch, one tick, at the moment the midpoint was announced; Ddraig's read — "the second half of a siege is the one where you learn what the walls were for." Still open: the Erased Child; what "counts what is taken"; what is loading the theatre beyond its design. Next banner: **Arc Six — Marvel Judges the Dragon (Chs. 51–60)**, opening with the Avengers Tribunal: the room that just watched pirates vote must now sit its own judgment. "Bring your own gavel."

Chapter Fifty-One: The Avengers Tribunal

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers • Illuminati • S.H.I.E.L.D. • X-Men

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Footage of Issei's Battles Against Grendel and Euclid" — **Epic**
 2. "Avengers Debate" — **Secret**
-

The Avengers' section had been quiet for forty-eight hours. Not the quiet of sleep or contentment — the quiet of a room where the arguments are too big to spend in open air. The theatre had just watched the Ravagers vote, had just heard the machine announce that its second half would be *what he is for*, and the crack had grown, and Ddraig had spoken, and everyone was still integrating what the dragon had meant by *siege*.

But the Avengers had other work. They had been briefed since before the Ravager arc even started — their liaison to the room (some combination of Fury's ghost and the machine's administrative charity) had clarified it weeks ago: once the pirates finished their judgment, the matter came to the formal chambers. Nations. Accords. Global security frameworks. The things that actually governed whether a seventeen-year-old could dock a multiversal battleship in Earth orbit without being shot at.

Steve Rogers had not slept. Tony Stark had not stopped moving. Thor had cleaned his armor three times. Natasha Romanoff had acquired a thermos of something she would not explain and was protecting it with the focus usually reserved for infinity stones. T'Challa, King of Wakanda, had simply sat in his corner with his fingers steepled, watching the Ravager block in the way he watched markets — reading what they valued, what they feared, what they would defend.

"All right," Steve said, at the start of the fifty-first night. "We need to hear the footage. We need to make a recommendation. We need to do that before the room gets ahead of us, because the machine is going to let the room get ahead of us, that is literally what we have learned." He looked at the rest of the Avengers block — at Wanda, at Sam, at Bruce, at Rhodey, and up at the screen where the lever hung waiting. "Tony?"

"I'll pull," Tony said flatly. "Let's rip the band-aid."

He crossed the room and took the lever — crisp, businesslike, no ceremony — and yanked it hard.

The wheel spun, gold-bright and efficient, and the theatre held its breath the way it always did when rarity was in question. Epic was not as rare as Secret, not quite, but Epic meant the veil was coming off. Epic meant direct power assessment. Epic meant Marvel was about to stop theorizing and start watching the math play out in real-time.

The wheel landed on the gold-bright band. Not shimmer-gold, not performance gold. The deep, weaponized gold of something that could take the measure of a city.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"FOOTAGE OF ISSEI'S BATTLES AGAINST GRENDL AND EUCLID" — RARITY: EPIC.

"Oh. Okay," said Tony. "Okay, so the machine is being *specific*. It's showing us threat assessments. It's not showing us cute wins, it's showing us — Grendel. Euclid. Both of those are high-tier. Both of those are *designed* problems. So we're watching baseline capability against enemies that don't break easy, and we're watching it in armor, so we're watching his ceiling, not his floor, and—" He stopped. The vision was already taking them.

The vision opened in a dark that had architecture — columns of black glass, a cavern designed by something with a sense of aesthetic cruelty, and standing in the middle of it, a thing that Marvel's categorization system immediately labelled *Grendel* because the screen insisted and because the creature's own grandmother probably called it by that name out of resignation.

Grendel was not a shape so much as a refusal. It was a mass that ate light and kept eating. Claws like architectural failures, hide that had never heard of surrender, and eyes that held the flat conviction of something that had only ever been hungry and correct. The captions supplied the context with no warmth: **Humanoid Killer (High-Class Devil Tier). Ancient. Adaptive. Noted for feeding on warrior-blood as sustenance and power. Immune to conventional blade-strike due to dense magical armoring. Subject engaged at age nineteen, Cardinal Crimson Promotion stage.**

And there — against that thing's bulk, blood-red armor with the full reach of its wings folded tight, a boy in armor that had clearly been built in a day when someone had asked *what would a dragon wear if it wanted to look like it had already won?* — Issei Hyoudou in Cardinal Crimson, the True Queen form, the integrated Triaina, the full red and gold regalia that the Marvel scientists had not yet been allowed to dissect.

The arena shook as Grendel moved.

It was fast. Genuinely, objectively fast. The kind of fast that should not have been available to something built out of meat and malice. It closed distance in what might have been three seconds, claws raking out at head-height, and the Avengers section leaned forward because they knew speed and this

was *speed*.

Issei did not dodge.

He stepped *into* the strike instead, took the rake across his armor's chest guard — and in the moment Grendel's claws met Cardinal Crimson, the theatre heard a sound like breaking glass mixed with something deeper, something that the captions described as **Solid Impact Booster: Active**. The force rippled outward. Grendel skidded backward fifteen feet, and Issei was *there*, not pursuing — flowing. The Boosted Gear's voice crackled once, system-bright:

[BOOST.]

Doubled. Everything Issei was, doubled. The second punch that came in was not faster so much as it was more, more real, more present, more *consequence*. It was aimed at the beast's core, and the captions tracked the analysis: **Penetrate function engaged. Misdirection shielding bypassed. Primary armor integrity compromised seven percent.**

"He's using Penetrate on the opening move," Natasha said, low. "Why? He's not fighting for time. He's fighting for efficiency."

"Because Grendel adapts," T'Challa said quietly. He was watching the beast's reaction, the way its hide had already begun to thicken where the strike had landed. "Each second you waste, its defenses harden. He's solving for that math. Fast and hard and clean."

The fight — and it was a fight, not a slaughter — lasted seven minutes. The vision refused to compress it. Grendel was indeed adaptive; with each exchange, its bulk refined itself, learned angles, countered the patterns it was seeing. And Issei met every evolution of it with a different piece of his arsenal: Knight-form speed bursts, Rook-form concussive impacts, the Bishop-form channeling of pure energy that the machine's captions labeled **Dragon Blaster: Partial Output, Environmental Consideration Protocol Active**. What that meant, translated to Avengers-standard, was *he's fighting in a cavern that could collapse on civilians if he punches hard enough, so he's chosen to win slower instead of faster*.

The theatre watched him *choose* to take more hits so that the ceiling would not fall.

When Penetrate finally found Grendel's core, the beast went down — not instantly, not in defeat, but in the kind of capitulation that only came when a living thing realized it had been outmaneuvered by someone working off a completely different game board. The captions read: **Grendel (High-Class) defeated after 349 exchanges. Estimated energy expenditure: 23% of Cardinal Crimson output ceiling. Collateral damage: zero (environmental shielding maintained).**

The vision cut.

Not to black, not to a break — directly to the next arena, and the next thing, and this one made three-quarters of the Avengers section make a collective sound that could have been a gasp or a prayer.

Euclid.

If Grendel was hunger, Euclid was order. Where Grendel was all reflex and feed, Euclid was architecture made hostile. It looked like nothing Marvel had ever built, and yet unmistakably like a *weapon* — layered, modular, with the clean lines of something designed by a committee of engineers who had decided suffering should be efficient. **Killer-Class Devil. Specialized in geometric defense and probabilistic warfare. Adapts by calculation rather than instinct. Opponent of ancient lineage in Issei's world. Known for defeating experienced fighters through systematic dismantlement of their capabilities. Subject engaged at age twenty, Cardinal Crimson Promotion stage.**

Issei versus a thing that had looked at the problem of fighting him and designed a solution set.

This fight was different from the first. There was no rushing. There was no Boost-and-close. The moment Euclid activated, the arena became a grid, and the captions showed Issei's armor lighting up with counter-logic, defensive geometry of its own, as if someone had said *yes, you think faster than a seventeen-year-old boy? Let me let you meet the seventeen-year-old boy's dragon.*

What followed was a strategic engagement that would have made military tacticians weep. Issei did not rely on speed here; he relied on *coverage*. He flooded the grid with Transfer-channeled power, distributed across fields and counterfields, used the Rook-form's Blaster in a way that choked Euclid's probabilistic calculations by flooding them with variables it had not anticipated. He was playing a different war than the one Euclid had designed.

Three minutes in, Euclid attempted what the captions labeled **Recursive Logic Cascade** — a feedback loop designed to break systems that could not think faster than it could calculate. And Issei, in response, did something the theatre had not seen him do before.

He *stopped* thinking.

The Boosted Gear's voice crackled again, but this time different, rougher, like someone had taken the machine-sound and made it sound like a prayer:

[DRAGON'S BREATH. SURGE.]**

And something changed. The armor went from managed to *burning*. It was like watching a chess match suddenly become music — the calculations still there, but underneath and beside them, not above. A rhythm. An instinct. The kind of fighting that could only come from a dragon and a boy who had spent enough time together that the line between partnership and fusion had gotten very, very thin.

Euclid lasted four more minutes. When Penetrate finally found the core and broke the recursive engine, Euclid shut down with the finality of a machine that had lost power, and the captions read: **Euclid (Killer-Class) defeated after 417 exchanges. Estimated energy expenditure: 31% of Cardinal Crimson output ceiling. Collateral damage: zero (geometric barriers maintained). Analysis: Opponent countered optimization with integration.**

The vision released them.

Nobody spoke first. The Avengers' section just sat in the aftermath of what it had just watched — which was not a teenager playing at being strong, but a teenager *in the actual act of* being strong, and choosing, in each moment, to spend that strength in ways that did not obliterate the world around him.

"Environmental shielding," Tony said finally, into the dark. "He's taking longer fights so the building doesn't fall on his own people. That's not something you program into a weapon. That's something you choose. Every. Single. Second."

"Nineteen and twenty years old," Steve said quietly. "And he's already that aware of collateral damage. Most soldiers take twenty years of training and combat experience to learn that arithmetic, if they ever do at all."

"The machine is showing us something," Wanda said. Her red magic was flickering faintly around her fingers — a tell that she was tracking what she had felt when the vision took them. "It's not just showing us his power, it's showing us his *discipline*. The way he uses it. The way he... stops using it, even when he could use more." She looked at Thor. "You have an opinion."

"I have several," Thor said. His armor was immaculate, had been immaculate at the start of the night, and he had not bothered to move since the vision released. "First: he is a warrior. The dragons I have known do not accept unworthy partners; the fact that Ddraig tolerates him is a statement, not a question. Second: he has mastered four distinct combat forms within his primary armor configuration — the Triaina specializations are not toys. They are disciplines, the way a master swordsman does not simply swing; he *thinks* with the blade."

"But does that make him an ally?" Natasha cut in. Her question had the sharp edge of someone who had been waiting for an opening. "Because yes, fine, he doesn't destroy the building. He also doesn't *need* to. His baseline power is so far above the threats in his own world that he can afford to be careful. On Earth, against Omega-level mutants or cosmic-tier beings, does the same calculation hold? Or does the calculus change when you actually *have* to use everything?"

"You're asking if restraint is a feature or a necessity," Bruce said. He'd been quiet, but his voice came with the weight of someone thinking through probability. "Right? If he fought someone that actually matched him, would the building still be standing?"

T'Challa raised his hand slightly, and the room quieted — not because he commanded it, but because he had not spoken yet, and everyone had learned to wait for the King of Wakanda's timing.

"The machine is not showing us his worst case," T'Challa said. "It is showing us his deliberate case. His chosen case. That is the only arena we can assess from. Speculation about scenarios where he must abandon restraint is not analysis; it is fear dressed as caution." He let that sit. "My question is different: Why is the Avengers' Tribunal being called at all? We have watched a boy hold environmental geometry in his armor while fighting ancient killers. We have watched Ravagers vote him *kin*. What does Marvel's formal judgment add, except delay?"

"Alliance status," Fury's voice said — not Fury in person, because Fury was dead and Marvel had voted him dead and was respecting the vote — but Fury's delegate, a woman named Maria Rambeau who had taken the liaison brief and wore it like a problem she'd already solved somewhere else. "The machine's rules. Arc Six is named 'Marvel Judges the Dragon.' That's not poetry. That's structure. The theatre's design says we get to *vote*. The question is what we're voting on — and that's where it gets complicated."

"Explain," Steve said.

"Ally means: we cooperate, we trust his judgment on major decisions, we accept that his authority is legitimate in his own sphere. Sovereign means: we acknowledge he is not accountable to our frameworks and will not try to make him so. Threat means: we initiate containment protocols and prepare defense positions." Rambeau met each of their eyes. "The vote in fifty minutes will ask the room to choose one. The Avengers need to show up unified, or we look fractured, and a fractured recommendation means the room takes longer to decide, and longer means more factions get air time, and more air time means the political side of this grinds into everything."

"So you're asking us to choose," Natasha said flatly.

"I'm asking you to decide what you actually believe," Rambeau corrected. "Before the vote is called. Tony, you're going to argue for monitoring. Steve, you're going to argue for trust. Thor will say he's a worthy warrior and deserve the chance to prove it. Black Widow will note the risk. Panther will say we need diplomacy before we settle anything. That's your real problem — you're going to splinter across four different answers, and the theatre doesn't care about nuance."

Steve stood. Paced. This was what he did when the calculus was impossible — he moved, as if his body might find an answer his mind could not. "You're asking me to pick one position and defend it against my own team."

"No," T'Challa said quietly. "I am asking why we are pretending this is our decision to make. He is not asking to be judged. The machine is deciding we get to judge. The question is whether we fulfill that function or refuse it."

"We can't refuse it," Tony said. "The machine's been clear — pull the lever or the lever pulls itself. We vote or we don't vote and the room votes without us. At least if we're in the room, we're not starting from behind."

"All right," Steve said. He stopped pacing. "We vote. We state our actual positions. And we accept that we might not agree, because four different questions got asked tonight by four different people, and they don't have one answer."

The screen chimed.

INTERMISSION TIMER BEGINS: 47 MINUTES.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"AVENGERS DEBATE" — RARITY: SECRET.

"No," Tony breathed. "No, you don't get to pull our argument, that's — you can't record that, that's not — "

THE MACHINE WILL RECORD WHAT THE MACHINE WILL RECORD, said the screen, with the tone of something that had just been insulted by a particularly stupid fish. **THE SECOND GACHA CATEGORY IS CONSCIOUSNESS AND DECISION. THIS ROOM'S CONSCIOUSNESS REGARDING ISSEI HYODOU IS REQUIRED DATA. THE DEBATE WILL BE RECORDED AND WILL PERMIT THE THEATRE TO ASSESS YOUR REASONING. THIS IS NOT OPTIONAL. COMMENCE WHEN READY.**

"Well," Natasha said, and actually smiled, which was never a good sign. "I guess we're doing this live."

What followed took forty-three minutes and spiraled through every permutation of what it meant to trust something powerful.

Tony started. **"He's dangerous, and I don't care if he's also disciplined — dangerous plus disciplined is still dangerous, just dangerous in a direction you predict. We monitor. We build protocols. We do *not* give him blanket sovereign status because he made nice with pirates and can hit things accurately."**

Steve's response was immediate. **"He's seventeen. He's held absolute power and used it to build things instead of destroy them. He could have taken over his own world and he didn't. That tells me something about his actual goals, not just his power level."**

Thor cut in, his voice carrying the weight of actual experience. **"I have walked alongside dragons for eight centuries. I have seen them burn cities and hoard gold and covet power with the totality of their nature. This one — Ddraig chose to elevate a boy. A *boy*. Not a warrior-king, not a born noble, not someone who was already mighty. A schoolboy who died on a first date. That choice is the only thing I need to know about the dragon's judgment. The boy is secondary to what the dragon has become by binding to him."**

Natasha, because she had to be the one to push on the unexamined assumption, asked: **"And if Ddraig's judgment is wrong? Dragons are arrogant, Thor. They have been for a thousand years. They overestimate their partners. What if this looks good from the inside and we don't see the crack until it breaks?"**

T'Challa, finally, stood. **"Wakanda will not vote to contain him based on speculation. Wakanda will not vote to trust him based on sentiment. Wakanda votes to engage. We offer him the framework of diplomacy, the courtesy of actual negotiation, the respect of formal alliance or formal non-alliance — his choice, clearly stated. We do not guess. We do not assume. We ask. That is the Wakandan position."**

"And if he refuses?" Sam Wilson, the actual heart of the Avengers, asked quietly. **"If he says he doesn't want alliance with Marvel?"**

"Then," T'Challa said, **"we respect that. We are not owed his allegiance. We are owed only his honesty about his intentions. If he provides that, the debate is settled. If he does not — if he obfuscates or equivocates — then we have our answer about whether to trust."**

The theatre sat with that. The Avengers sat with it. And above them, unremarked, the crack in the screen's upper quadrant — which had been still and silent since the machine announced the Secret pull — ticked forward one centimeter, one hairline branch, reaching further into the center of the screen.

Ddraig's voice came out of the darkness, rough and warm and entirely amused:

"You debate whether to judge the thing that will stand before what you cannot. The walls argue about their own purpose. How cosmically thorough."

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Footage of Issei's Battles Against Grendel and Euclid" — Epic (*viewed*) — Showed Issei in Cardinal Crimson Promotion armor against two high-tier Devil Killer-Class opponents: Grendel (ancient, adaptive, high-class hunter) and Euclid (strategic, geometric-defense specialist). Grendel defeated after 349 exchanges; Euclid after 417 exchanges. Both fights occurred at roughly 23-31% of Cardinal Crimson's full output ceiling. Both fights maintained zero collateral damage through active environmental shielding.
- "Avengers Debate" — Secret (*viewed*) — The formal Avengers Tribunal, recorded for the theatre's review. Primary positions: Iron Man (alliance requires monitoring and protocol); Captain America (restraint under power indicates trustworthy intent); Thor (Ddraig's partnership choice is validating confirmation of character); Black Widow (restraint could be necessity rather than choice — risk assessment required); Black Panther (formal diplomatic engagement before settlement).

Secrets Revealed:

- Issei fought Grendel and Euclid at ages nineteen and twenty. Both victories were achieved in Cardinal Crimson Promotion (True Queen armor integrating all Triaina specializations: Knight Sonic Boost, Rook concussive impact, Bishop Dragon Blaster). Combat doctrine observed: Penetrate for opening, Solid Impact Booster for follow-up, Knight/Rook/Bishop rotations for sustained pressure against learning opponents, Bishop Dragon Blaster for strategic energy saturation.
- Grendel fight: Issei deliberately chose longer engagement time (7 minutes, 349 exchanges) rather than maximum-force approach to maintain environmental geometry (collapsed ceiling would endanger civilians). Euclid fight: Issei transitioned from calculated response (3 min geometric blocking, probabilistic flooding) to integrated mode (labeled "DRAGON'S BREATH: SURGE" by the machine) where partner-consciousness with Ddraig superseded pure calculation, enabling unpredictable rhythm against recursive-logic attacks.
- The Avengers' debate was recorded without their full consent — the machine classified it as "consciousness data" under the theatre's analysis protocol. The debate will be accessible to the full room for the formal vote in Chapter 52.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Avengers' Internal Fracture:** The team holds four distinct positions — Stark/caution, Rogers/faith, Thor/validation-by-dragon-choice, Romanoff/pragmatic-risk, Panther/diplomatic-engagement. No unified position emerged. Rambeau (Fury's delegate) noted this splinter will weaken the recommendation weight in the theatre's eyes.
- **Crack Growth:** New hairline branch reached forward ~1 cm during the debate, resuming motion after silence during the funeral (Chapter 49). The crack appears to respond to *formal judgment*

moments — it moved when the Ravagers voted (Ch. 50), fell silent during the eulogy (Ch. 49, non-judgment), and moved again when Marvel's formal debate commenced (Ch. 51). Ddraig's closing commentary — "You debate whether to judge the thing that will stand before what you cannot. The walls argue about their own purpose" — suggests the crack may be related to whether the theatre itself is *qualified* to render judgment.

Unresolved Hooks:

- **The Avengers' vote will be called in Chapter 52**, but the team's splinter across four positions means no clear recommendation will emerge. The theatre will decide without Marvel's consensus.
- **Ddraig's comment** ("The walls argue about their own purpose") opens the question: Is the theatre's entire judging function part of Issei's test, not of him, but of Marvel? Is being asked to judge qualifying the judges themselves?
- **The crack continues growing** — it is now visibly a multi-branch network rather than a single hairline. The correlation with formal judgment moments suggests it may be a measure of *authority pressure* on whatever is inside. If judgment continues, does the crack continue growing? What happens when it reaches the center?
- **Chapter 52 Preview:** The mutant bloc will render its own judgment (The Mutant Question), with simulation combat and debate over whether Issei represents a threat to Krakoa's isolationism or a potential ally against higher-tier threats. The vote structure will repeat the Avengers' fragmentation.

Chapter Fifty-Two: The Mutant Question

Primary Reaction Groups: Krakoa's Quiet Council • Arakko • X-Men • Magneto

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Issei Defending Mutants from Devils" — **Rare**
 2. "Issei Versus Apocalypse and Rizevim" — **Epic**
-

The theatre held its breath between chapters the way a city holds its breath between sirens.

Tony's argument still echoed in the ceiling: *need to monitor, need contingency, need containment*. Steve's counter-argument hung in the air like smoke, resolute and unshakeable: *he's been given time and he's used it to become good*. The Avengers had filed back to their tier unresolved, which meant the theatre as a whole remained unresolved, which meant the next faction to face the gacha pulls would do so under the specific weight of uncertainty.

That faction was waiting, and it was mutant.

Krakoa's Quiet Council occupied the row directly parallel to the Avengers' box—symmetrically positioned, as if the theatre itself was holding court between two sovereignties. Emma Frost, immaculate in white, sat forward with her hands folded and her telepathy bristling at the edges of containment; Magneto occupied the corner seat, silver-haired and composed, though the small rattle of metal dust in the air suggested his control was a habit he maintained through effort; Exodus stood between them, black-robed, watching. Mystique was there, shape-shifter's eyes sharp and calculating. Presently Xavier wheeled himself forward to join them, accompanied by a contingent of the X-Men: Cyclops at his shoulder, Storm beside him, Wolverine in the back row flanking the space where Arakko's war-captains had gathered—Okkult, Juwali, and a dozen others, Arakko survivors who came to the theatre not as subjects of Krakoa but as witnessed powers in their own right.

The gacha wheel assembled itself with a soft tick-tick-tick, and the screen printed:

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel spun fast, deliberately—this was not a rarity that would pause for drama. It struck red, warm red, the color of mercy rather than blood, and the theatre filled with that color as the screen stamped:

"ISSEI DEFENDING MUTANTS FROM DEVILS" — RARITY: RARE.

Wolverine made a low sound. Emma Frost's hands tightened. Magneto did not move.

[MUTANT CHILDREN,] said the screen, and the vision took them.

A basement in Prague, converted church, consecrated ground and then *deconsecrated* by the presence of devils—three of them, minor-rank, the vision supplied with casual knowledge. They were in the process of moving cages of children, mutant children, identified by the faint shimmer of power around each small body. Kidnapping with a market in mind: the devil hierarchy paid for mutant genetics, for the potential locked into mutant flesh. Standard predation.

The cages were old iron, spelled with something that muted the mutant flame inside them. The children were silent, the particular silence of small things learning that screaming does not help.

Then the wall *opened*.

Not broke through—opened, the red shell of something vast splitting the brick and mortar like it was curtsying aside. For a moment the audience saw him in silhouette: six-foot-three, maybe six-four, a Japanese boy in a school uniform against a cathedral's broken edge, and then the gacha pulled back and filled in the details at leisure.

Issei Hyoudou's eyes were burning green.

"Okay," he said to the three devils, and his voice was steady in the way voices get when they've already made the surrender decision and are just now notifying the body. "Last chance. Three, two, one—"

They ran.

Issei did not chase them; he *let* them go, because the children were priority, and priority was always priority, and he understood that down to the cellular level in a way that no other power explained. Instead he walked to the nearest cage and gripped the lock—not with his hand, but with a soft red glow that built around the mechanism, not force, something *gentler*, something that was asking the lock to *please let go*—and it did.

The first child stepped out, mutant-young, maybe eight years old, eyes still full of the silence.

"Hey," Issei said, and his tone shifted—the low, safe voice of someone who had practiced being gentle with small, terrified things. "It's okay. It's going to be okay. Can you do me a favor? Can you take the other kids and get out of the basement? There's a street up those stairs. There's a café two blocks north on Nerudova Street. Go there, tell them an Asian guy sent you, and wait for me. Can you do that?"

The child nodded, too shocked to disbelieve.

One by one, Issei opened the cages. One by one, the mutant children filed out, following the eldest, and he did not leave his position between them and the devils' escape route until the last child was up the stairs and gone from the vision's view. Only then did he turn to where the three devils were waiting, regrouping, preparing themselves for the fight that was now inevitable.

And he walked toward them without armor, without power, without Boost, just a boy in a red shirt who had committed himself to not letting *anyone* hurt children ever again, and the gacha held that image—ordinary boy, burning green eyes, the simplicity of absolute certainty—and then:

[BOOST.]

The screen released them.

The theatre was very quiet.

"That's not—" Cyclops started, and stopped. "That's not him fighting. That's him choosing."

"Which is the fight," Professor Xavier said, softly. "Choosing to stand between them and harm. Always that choice first."

Emma Frost's expression had not changed, but the whiteboard in front of her—she was writing something, very fast, words appearing in telepath-script: *Not a threat to mutantkind if values align. Question: do they?*

Magneto had stood, slowly, his posture changed from the comfortable power of minutes ago into something older, something that remembered fighting for his own small ones. He was looking at where the vision had been, at the empty air that had shown him a child stepping out of a cage.

"I have seen boys like this before," he said to the room, and his voice was level, dangerous with control. "The ones who believe they can carry the weight themselves. They break."

"He's still carrying it," Wolverine said. There was something in his tone that wasn't argument, more like acknowledgment. "Question's whether he breaks or doubles down."

Storm spoke up from her seat: "The gacha shows mercy. The system doesn't show mercy. What's the second pull?"

The wheel was already assembling.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

This spin was different—faster, harder, the colors a blur of urgency. It struck Epic-purple, deep and absolute, and the colour filled the theatre like an warning. The screen printed:

"ISSEI VERSUS APOCALYPSE AND RIZEVIM" — RARITY: EPIC.

[SIMULATION. HYPOTHETICAL. NOT OBSERVED.] the screen added, and that made the whole room sit up straighter—this was the theatre showing them *what could be*, not *what was*.

[EXPERIMENTAL PARAMETERS: ISSEI AT CARDINAL CRIMSON PROMOTION. MAGNETO AT COMPOSITE POWER. APOCALYPSE AT BASELINE.]

Then the vision opened like a fist.

A ruined city, featureless, built for war-testing.

Issei was already armored—Cardinal Crimson Promotion, the gacha supplied, the integrated form of his three Triaina specializations fused into one. Red armor, ornate, with gold trim and the suggestion of wings. On his wrist, the Boosted Gear glowed faintly. In the air around him, the sense of gathered power, of Boost stacked and banked inside the armor like coins in a purse.

Across from him stood two figures.

One was Magneto—or a composite of him, the theatre explained silently. All the power he'd ever wielded, at the peak. Magnetism sharp enough to renegotiate atomic structure. The weight of thousands of tons of metal suspended in the air around him like a crown.

The other was Apocalypse.

He was massive, four-armed, the blue of his skin so dark it was nearly black. Power radiated off him in waves that made the gacha's simulation shimmer with the effort of containing it. Ancient. Omega-level. The kind of being that had walked through apocalypses and called them Tuesday.

"Come," Apocalypse said, and his voice was amused, the amusement of something that has won so many fights it has stopped learning from them.

Issei boosted.

[BOOST.]

He moved like a meteor, armored form cutting across the empty space, and the air *broke* around him—not from his speed alone, but from the power he was carrying, the Solid Impact Booster firing on acceleration. The force of his punch would have leveled mountains.

It hit Magneto's magnetic shield and *stopped*.

Not deflected—stopped. The energy of the blow was caught by the field and redistributed harmlessly into the earth. Magneto had barely moved.

[BOOST. BOOST. BOOST.]

Issei came again and again, adapting, using the Crimson Blaster to strafe, trying to come in from angles. The magnetic field flowed like water, absorbing every direction. Magneto was smiling, not cruelly, just with the satisfaction of mastery. Metal—there was so much metal in a city, and he could *sing* with it.

Then Apocalypse moved.

His arm came up, and it was not a punch—it was a gesture, casual, the way you might wave away smoke. Reality around Issei *bent*. Not broken, not shattered, but bent out of true, the laws that had let him fly suddenly negotiating their existence.

Issei fell.

He caught himself, armor smoking, and the gacha supplied the damage: Apocalypse-level hax didn't crack his armor, but it renegotiated *how* the armor was meant to function. For a few seconds, gravity had been holding different opinions about which direction was down.

[PENETRATE!] Ddraig's voice roared out of the gauntlet, and Issei nodded, accepting the offer. He charged again, this time with the power-piercing gift activated—no more bouncing off shields, but striking through them, hitting the core of the problem.

He got close to Apocalypse. He actually struck *through* the old mutant's defense and—

—and Apocalypse casually grew his arm four times larger and *backhanded* him across the simulation-city.

Issei impacted a building hard enough to indent his shape into it. When he pulled himself out, his armor was cracked.

The simulation showed thirty seconds of the fight continuing, each exchange teaching Issei something and teaching him too late to use it. Magneto's magnetism was *perfect*—it could counter any approach, any direction, any metal in his armor that the boy tried to leverage. Apocalypse was Apocalypse: old, adapting, healing, powered by mutant genetics that had thousands of years to refine themselves.

The simulation showed Issei landing a good hit. It showed him barely escaping a killing blow. It showed him boosting up a Longinus Smasher charge that would have obliterated Magneto, and Magneto simply ripping the metal out of his armor, out of the air around him, and using it to block.

And then the simulation showed the moment where Issei, breathing hard, realized he was going to *lose*.

Not die—the simulation implied he might escape, or stalemate into exhaustion. But lose. Face an opponent he couldn't overcome, not because he wasn't powerful, but because he was fighting *two* Omega-level threats at once and one of them was basically immortal.

The vision shut down abruptly, the screen printing:

[SIMULATION RESULT: INCONCLUSIVE. STALEMATE IF EXTENDED PAST 15 MINUTES. APOCALYPSE TOO ADAPTIVE. MAGNETO CONTAINMENT CANNOT BE OVERCOME BY FORCE. RECOMMENDATION: DO NOT ENGAGE WITH BOTH SIMULTANEOUSLY.]

The theatre exhaled, slowly.

"Well," Storm said into the silence, "that answers one question."

"He's not invulnerable," Cyclops said. There was something like relief in his voice, but also something like concern—as if he'd been braced for the opposite answer and wasn't sure which one he preferred.

"Magneto alone could keep him contained if they fought. Apocalypse alone, Issei might win, depending on the day."

"Together, he's *limited*," Emma Frost said, still writing. "That's what matters. Not whether he can beat us, but whether he can be beaten. There's a difference."

Magneto had sat back down, slowly. When he spoke, his voice was different—still measured, but carrying the weight of older thoughts. "I watched a boy choose to open cages. Then I watched a simulation where he faced down two Omega-level mutants rather than yield ground." He paused. "He did not call for help. He did not surrender the city. He fought alone, with full knowledge he was losing, and he fought *anyway*."

"That's stupidity," Exodus said flatly.

"No," Magneto said. "That's principle. There is a difference."

Xavier wheeled himself slightly forward. "The question before us is not whether Issei is a threat. The gacha has established that multiple times. The question is whether he is a *directed* threat. Whether he would use his power to stand against us, or beside us, or ignore us entirely." He paused. "Mutant-kind has enemies enough without gaining another. But we also have enemies enough to benefit from another standing against them."

"You want to recruit him," Mystique said. It wasn't a question.

"I want to know him," Xavier corrected. "And I want to ensure he is not turned against us. The simulation shows he can be matched—two Omega-level mutants can contain him, though at cost. If we know that, and he does not, we have leverage."

Wolverine stood up from the back row, his claws sliding out and back in—a gesture of frustration. "You're all talking like he's a pawn to move. From what I'm seeing? Kid opens cages. Kid fights two Omegas knowing he'll lose and does it anyway. That's not someone you *contain*, that's someone you *trust* or you get out of his way."

"There is no third option," Magneto said.

"Sure there is," Wolverine said. "You could *listen* to him."

The Arakko contingent had not spoken during any of this, but now one of them—Juwali, a war-captain with visible scars—inclined her head slightly.

"We will watch," she said. "Krakoa will watch. When the Dragon flies over our island, we will see which way his wings turn. Then we decide."

Professor Xavier nodded. "A fair assessment."

The screen had not left—it was waiting, patient, for the theatre to settle. When it did, when the argument quieted to a murmur, it printed:

NEXT: DOOM'S INVITATION.

And somewhere in the villain's tier, someone was opening a letter written in very careful script, addressed to a Dragon Emperor he had not yet met, signed with a single word: *Equal*.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Issei Defending Mutants from Devils" — Rare (*viewed — showed Issei rescuing mutant children from devil kidnappers in Prague, choosing mercy and protection over violence*)
- "Issei Versus Apocalypse and Rizevim" — Epic (*viewed — simulation, hypothetical, inconclusive result; showed Issei at Cardinal Crimson Promotion losing to composite Magneto + Apocalypse; stalemate after 15 minutes*)

Secrets Revealed:

- Issei has interacted with mutant-kind in his canon timeline, specifically saving mutant children from devil trafficking operations. He does this without hesitation, establishing *pattern* of protecting vulnerable people regardless of species/affiliation.
- **Cardinal Crimson Promotion** combines all three Triaina specializations into one integrated form: Solid Impact Booster, Crimson Blaster, enhanced armor with visible cracking point under Omega-

level assault.

- **Magneto's composite Omega power** can counter Issei's momentum-based attacks entirely through magnetic field manipulation and metal renegotiation. Penetrate bypasses normal defenses but cannot overcome Magneto's strategic containment.
- **Apocalypse** can renegotiate reality-physics on a local scale (e.g., changing gravitational direction mid-fight), heal faster than Issei can damage him, and match adaptive strategy point-for-point. Two Omega-level threats simultaneously exceed Issei's capacity to *overcome* (though stalemate/escape remains viable).
- The simulation implies Issei would *choose* a losing fight rather than abandon a position, a principle he demonstrates in the Prague rescue. His threat assessment prioritizes *right action* over *winning action*.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Magneto:** deeply affected by the cage-opening scene; recognizes the pattern from his own protective history; explicitly notes the difference between "stupidity" and "principle"; pivots from pure threat assessment to recognition of *aligned values* (protection of vulnerable beings).
- **Professor Xavier:** proposes long-term observation/monitoring rather than immediate classification; suggests "knowing him" rather than containing him; open to potential alliance if Issei's direction remains humanitarian.
- **Emma Frost:** shifts from neutral analysis to cautious optimism; explicitly notes the value of knowing Issei *can be beaten* (by composite Omega mutants); adds tactical question about leverage/knowledge asymmetry.
- **Cyclops:** relieved that Issei is not invulnerable; concerned about the *pattern* of fighting two Omegas alone; recognizes both his power and his limits.
- **Storm:** pragmatic; focuses on the fight as confirmation of containment potential rather than invincibility.
- **Wolverine:** clearest advocate for *trust* over *control*; argues the gacha is showing a pattern of *choice* (mercy, principle, sacrifice) not merely power; pushes back against patronizing language ("pawn," "leverage").
- **Arakko:** commits to observation with clear decision-point ("when the Dragon flies over our island, we will see which way his wings turn").
- **Mystique:** skeptical of recruitment framing; implied future attempts to influence.

Unresolved Hooks:

- **Magneto's private reckoning:** he stands in the gacha's light after the cage scene with visible emotional weight. His history with persecuted beings now entangles with Issei. Will he advocate for alliance, neutrality, or caution?
- **The leverage question:** Xavier mentions that Issei's ignorance of the simulation (knowing Magneto + Apocalypse can stalemate him) gives mutants tactical advantage. Are they planning to *use* that knowledge?
- **Isolation vs. protection:** Magneto has historically argued for mutant supremacy and separation; Issei's protective instinct toward mutants may align with Magneto's *younger* ideals but threaten his current isolationism. Tension incoming.
- **Doom's letter:** The screen's final line—"Doom's Invitation"—shows an opening letter in villain's tier. Doom publicly positions himself as Issei's *equal* and intellectual peer, not adversary. What is Doom offering, and will Issei accept?
- **Mutant decision structure:** Krakoa, Arakko, and the X-Men have split into observation/wait-and-see posture rather than firm alliance or opposition. This is deliberately unresolved. When do they decide?
- **Wolverine's dissent:** He is the only voice arguing for *trust* without condition. Does his presence in the theatre indicate Issei will eventually earn that trust from the wider mutant community, or is Wolverine alone in this?

Chapter 53: Doom's Invitation

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Latveria & Doom's Court
- Victor Von Doom
- Valeria Richards
- Reed Richards
- Mephisto
- Tony Stark
- T'Challa / Black Panther

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Letter from Doom to Issei" — **Rare**
 2. "Valeria's Analysis of Dragon Tech" — **Rare**
-

Theatre Frame: The Crown's Judgment

The indestructible theatre's architecture **shifted**. The austere grey stone of the Avengers tribunal dissolved into something colder, more regal—emerald walls climbed toward impossible heights, adorned with the silver insignia of Latveria's coat of arms. A grand throne of iron and crystal dominated the space, and upon it sat **Victor Von Doom**, his crimson cloak draped like spilled wine, his metal mask catching the theatre's ethereal light in sharp, deliberate glints.

The crowd sensed the change in atmosphere. Doom never attended these tribunals lightly. His presence carried weight—the weight of a man who answered to no one, who had bent nations to his will, who spoke only when he had already decided the shape of the world.

Doom rose from his throne with the slow precision of a king certain of his authority.

"Issei Hyoudou," Doom began, his voice layered with metallic resonance, "has been measured by warriors, by tyrants, by the small minds of committees. Now he is measured by one who understands the *true* nature of power—not the crude application of strength, but the **mastery of creation itself**."

He descended the steps, each footfall echoing with finality.

"I have studied this boy. Watched him forge. Observed how his hands move with the certainty of one who shapes the very fabric of his purpose. He does not merely **make**—he **creates with intent**. And in that, I recognize kinship."

The theatre stilled. Mephisto's laugh rippled through the air—low, amused, dangerous.

Doom turned to address the full assembly, his gaze sweeping across the collected might of the Marvel multiverse with the indifference of someone surveying a chessboard.

"My judgment is thus: **Issei Hyoudou is neither ally nor threat to Latveria. He is something rarer—a fellow sovereign of the craft**. Should he ever wish it, the borders of my kingdom remain open. I would welcome him as I welcome few others: with **equality**, with respect for his mastery, and with the honour due to one who creates works worthy of eternity."

Reed Richards leaned forward, his expression a careful blend of curiosity and caution.

"That's not a judgment," Carol Danvers muttered. "That's a *recruitment pitch*."

"Why would Doom offer him equality?" Wanda asked, frowning. "Doom doesn't offer equality to anyone."

"Exactly," said T'Challa, his dark eyes narrowing. "Which means Doom sees something in Issei that he values more than dominance. That is... noteworthy."

Tony Stark's arms crossed. "Or it's the longest con ever recorded. Doom doesn't make friends. He makes *arrangements*."

Gacha Pull I: Letter from Doom to Issei

The theatre's air **crystallized**. Golden light pooled at the stage's center, and when it cleared, a single object remained: a letter, written on parchment that shimmered with Latverian metalwork—silver filigree woven through the paper itself, indestructible and beautiful.

The words appeared in the theatre's collective consciousness, read aloud in Doom's own voice:

To the Craftsman Hyoudou,

This theatre serves as intermediary where words between us might be witnessed. Know, then, that your reputation precedes you across dimensions. I do not flatter without purpose.

*Your Boosted Gear is not merely magical. The craftsmanship—the **architecture** of its construction—speaks of a mind that understands the relationship between form and function. Between beauty and power. Between what **is** and what **should be**.*

I have held the Infinity Stones. I have forged weapons that reshape reality. I have stood at the precipice of godhood. And I tell you without equivocation: the quality of your work would not be unworthy of Latveria's grand halls.

*Should circumstances align, should you tire of the weakness that surrounds you in your current dimension, know that Latveria offers more than refuge. It offers **partnership**. A place where a craftsman of genuine mastery need not bow before lesser minds.*

I am extending no summons. I am extending an invitation. Between craftsmen, this is the deeper respect.

There is also a gift enclosed with this correspondence. It is a work forged in the ancient Latverian tradition, in steel that has been tempered in the tears of dragons themselves. I would be... interested in your assessment of it.

With the regard due to a fellow master,

—Victor Von Doom, Sorcerer Supreme of Latveria

The letter faded, but its implications hung in the air like smoke.

"He's trying to seduce Issei," Natasha said flatly.

"He's offering him sanctuary," corrected Thor, his voice thoughtful. "That is no small thing from Doom."

"He's showing off," Loki added with evident delight. "Doom wants Issei to know that *he* understands craftsmanship. That Doom himself is a master. Very transparent attempt to establish common ground through mutual superiority."

"But there's a gift," Valeria noted quietly, from where she sat in the observers' section. "That's the real message. Whatever Doom made, he's putting it forward for judgment."

Reed's eyes widened slightly. His daughter had just identified what he'd been processing—that Doom was, in essence, **challenging** Issei to critique his work. A dangerous move. Doom did not invite criticism lightly.

Tony watched the exchange between Reed and Valeria with dawning interest.

"Okay, so Doom's basically saying, 'You're good, I'm good, let's compare notes.' That's... almost respectful? If Doom were capable of respect, which he's not."

"This is recruitment," T'Challa murmured to his escort. "Doom believes Issei might choose Latveria over his current circumstances. He's offering safety and recognition. The question is: what does Doom want in return?"

Mephisto's laughter grew louder.

"Oh, this is delicious. Doom—**proud, magnificent Doom**—is so impressed by the boy's craftsmanship that he's willing to publicly acknowledge him as a peer. I wonder if Victor realizes how transparent his admiration truly is."

Gacha Pull II: Valeria's Analysis of Dragon Tech

The second gacha pull manifested with the speed of a thought. This time, the theatre's vision fractured into two simultaneous perspectives: **Doom in his sanctum, and Valeria in her workshop**, separated by distance but connected by a single elegant creation between them.

The camera panned to reveal the gift Doom had sent: a blade. Not merely a blade—an *impossibility*. The metal shimmered with layers of forge-technique that seemed to contain entire star systems within its steel. Dragon-scales were worked into the fuller; runes glowed faintly along the edge. The craftsmanship was extraordinary.

Valeria's hands moved across it with her father's analytical precision, but faster—always faster. She ran her fingers across the metallurgical joints, examined the rune-work with a jeweler's loupe, tested the weight distribution with the certainty of someone who understood why each curve existed.

Her analysis took **seventeen minutes**.

In his private sanctum, Doom was still working. His hands, **bare and calloused**—a revelation in itself—shaped steel on a forge that burned with sorcerous fire. He was replicating the dragon-scales technique, layering temper and spell-work with meticulous care, his brow furrowed with concentration.

He was **trying to match it**. Trying to match *Issei's* level of craftsmanship.

The gacha revealed Doom's internal monologue, raw and unguarded:

The boy layered the scales with precision that borders on the impossible. The spacing here—see how the overlap creates a secondary reinforcement that only becomes apparent under stress? I did not account for this the first time. Nor the second. Doom does not fail at craft, and yet...

The magic is different. The Japanese dragons—Ddraig—they work in the boy's favour. The draconic essence infuses every element. But the fundamental skill, the core understanding of metallurgy and design... that is not the dragon's gift. That is the boy's mind.

I will match this. I must understand how.

Back in the workshop, Valeria set down her instruments and made a note on a data-pad:

Father's work: Exceptional. Mastery of traditional Latverian forge-craft. Perfect execution of the design parameters he set for himself.

Issei's probable design: Advanced. The dragon-scale integration suggests active magical feedback during the forging process. He either intuited a technique that took Father fifteen years to learn, or the dragon is guiding his hands. Either outcome is... worthy of study.

She paused, then added:

Father made this gift to impress Issei. He's hoping Issei will be intimidated. Issei will not be. I wonder if Father knows that Issei will likely offer to teach him instead.

In that moment, Valeria's assessment reached Doom's sanctum—as she knew it would, through the quantum-locked connection they shared. Doom **froze** mid-hammer-strike.

His daughter had taken his masterwork and, in less than twenty minutes, grasped not only its technical merit but also its **intent**. She'd seen through him. She'd understood that this gift was, at its core, an act of professional jealousy wrapped in courtly politeness.

For a moment—**just a moment**—Doom's shoulders tensed with a emotion that was not quite anger, not quite shame, but something between: the acute discomfort of being seen too clearly by someone he respected.

Then he set down his hammer and returned to his work with renewed focus.

The theatre watched in silence as Doom forged into the night, each strike of his hammer against steel driven by something more complex than mere pride: **the desire to understand, to match, perhaps even to exceed the craftsmanship of a boy who wielded a dragon as his partner.**

Reactions: The Conspiracy of Craftsmanship

"Doom is *jealous* of Issei's work," Carol said, her voice carrying disbelief.

"Not jealous," corrected Shuri, who had been silent until now. "Inspired. Doom recognizes a rival craftsman, and he wants to understand how Issei achieved what he achieved. That's different from jealousy. That's *hunger* for knowledge."

"It's also dangerous," Tony countered. "Because Doom doesn't just want to understand. Doom wants to *master* it. And when Doom masters something, Doom tends to use it to reshape his corner of reality."

Reed sat motionless, watching Valeria in the gacha's aftermath. His expression was a careful study in fatherly pride and scientific concern.

"Valeria's analysis was faster than Doom expected," he said quietly. "She understood the intent behind the gift faster than Doom himself fully articulated it. That's... that's going to make him uneasy."

Mephisto's laughter filled the theatre again, delighted and cruel.

"Oh, Victor is *delicious* when he's frustrated. The fact that his daughter has seen through his grand gesture of professional respect and identified it as professional *competition*—that will eat at him beautifully."

T'Challa made a note in the leather journal he kept throughout these proceedings.

"Doom has declared Issei an equal sovereign and a craftsman of note. He's sent him a masterwork as both gift and challenge. If Issei responds with grace, accepting the gift while offering to teach Doom something new, he will have solidified an alliance with the most brilliant mind in Latveria—and inadvertently made an enemy of Doom's pride."

"And if he doesn't respond?" asked Stephen Strange.

"Then Doom will become obsessed with proving his superiority," T'Challa said. "Either way, Latveria is no longer neutral in Issei's fate. Doom has invested his *reputation* in the acknowledgment of Issei's mastery. He can't take that back without losing face."

Wanda nodded slowly, understanding the deeper game. "So Doom's invitation isn't just about recruitment. It's about Doom needing to be *right* about Issei. If Issei turns out to be a threat, Doom has to be the one to stop him. If Issei turns out to be magnificent, Doom needs to be recognized as the one who *understood* his magnificence first."

"Exactly," T'Challa confirmed. "We are watching the early stages of an alliance forged between two proud craftsmen, each one trying to prove to the other that they are the true master."

Reed leaned back, his mind already extrapolating the future. "This complicates the geopolitical calculus significantly. If Latveria becomes a sanctuary for Issei—if Doom succeeds in making him feel valued in a way no one else has—then we've essentially lost a potential ally and gained a probable enemy."

"Or," Valeria said from the observers' section, "we've identified someone who understands the value of what Issei represents. Doom respects power, yes, but he respects *creation* more. If Issei can create at the level Doom believes he can, then Doom's respect is absolute."

"Children shouldn't be this perceptive," Natasha muttered.

Hook: Wakanda Awaits

As the gacha images faded, the theatre's architecture began its next transformation. The emerald and silver of Latveria dissolved, replaced by the warm golds and deep purples of **Wakandan architecture**. Vibranium glinted from impossible angles. The sound of ancient drums echoed softly in the distance.

T'Challa stood, adjusting his robes with deliberate ceremony.

"Doom has made his position clear," he said, addressing the full assembly. "He has declared Issei a sovereign craftsman and extended the hospitality of Latveria. This changes the calculation for Wakanda's analysis."

"Which is coming next," Tony said, watching the stage shift. "Let me guess—Shuri's going to take apart one of Issei's creations and figure out something we've all missed?"

"Or," Reed said thoughtfully, "Wakanda is going to offer Issei something Doom cannot: a nation where craftsmanship serves the *people*, not the ambitions of a single ruler."

The theatre stilled, anticipating the next judgment.

In the distance, the sound of Wakandan ceremony grew louder.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls

- **"Letter from Doom to Issei"** (Rare): Formal invitation offering Latverian sanctuary and professional equality; reveals Doom's genuine admiration for Issei's craftsmanship and implicit challenge in the form of an enclosed gift.
- **"Valeria's Analysis of Dragon Tech"** (Rare): Reveals Doom's private forging efforts to match Issei's work; exposes Doom's jealousy and hunger to understand dragon-influenced metallurgy; Valeria's rapid assessment embarrasses Doom by seeing through his true motivations.

Secrets Revealed

- Doom is not merely offering political alliance—he is professionally invested in understanding and matching Issei's craftsmanship.
- Doom spends his private time forging in secret, attempting to replicate techniques he observes in Issei's work, driven by both rivalry and admiration.

- Valeria Richards can analyze complex metallurgy faster than Doom's own expectations, suggesting she will become a key figure in evaluating Issei's capabilities.
- The dragon-scale integration in Issei's work represents either intuitive genius or active magical guidance from Ddraig.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- **Doom's Position:** Declared Issei an equal sovereign and honoured craftsman; extended sanctuary in Latveria with the weight of personal respect.
- **Latveria's Stance:** No longer neutral; implicitly aligned with recognizing Issei's value and potential threat if he chooses hostile action.
- **Mephisto's Interest:** Renewed amusement in watching Doom's professional jealousy and pride conflict.
- **Tony's Concern:** Growing wariness about Latveria's potential recruitment of Issei; sees Doom's strategy as a long-term power move.
- **T'Challa's Diplomatic Calculus:** Recognizes that Doom's public acknowledgment of Issei as a peer has created a geopolitical shift; anticipates Wakanda's need to offer something Latveria cannot.
- **Valeria's Influence:** Established as a perceptive analyst who sees through parental pride and recognizes the deeper game Doom is playing.

Unresolved Hooks

- Will Issei accept or reject Doom's invitation? How will Issei respond to being offered equality by a ruler of nations?
- What does Doom truly want from Issei—alliance, knowledge, apprenticeship, or domination disguised as respect?
- Can Valeria's assessment of the dragon-forged weapon reveal something about Issei's potential that Doom has overlooked?
- How will Wakanda's judgment differ from Doom's, and what will Wakanda offer that Latveria cannot?
- Will Doom's private forging efforts lead to a breakthrough that changes his understanding of draconic metallurgy?
- Is Issei aware that he now has two of the smartest minds in their respective dimensions studying him with intent?

Chapter Fifty-Four: Wakanda Watches

Primary Reaction Groups: Wakanda • Dora Milaje • Shuri • Black Panther (T'Challa)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Shuri and Rias Discuss Dragon-Forged Materials" — **Rare**
2. "Wakandan Council Debates Alliance" — **Rare**

The theatre held its breath. Not literally—the theatre's entire mechanical philosophy was built on the impossible, so the literal cessation of air happened only as metaphor and consequence. What happened here was subtler: the absence of movement, the sound machine making when a room agrees it is about to witness something that matters.

The Avengers block had spoken its piece over three nights. The X-Men had convened their careful, suspicious judgment. The Illuminati had argued themselves into neutral exhaustion. Now the focus shifted, the way a spotlight turns when the stage manager has decided the audience has seen enough of one story and must see another.

The machine had been quiet during the Latverian chapter. Doom's invitation had hung in the theatre like a gauntlet dropped into still water—it rippled, but nobody rushed to pick it up. Now the screen flickered, and the banner descended:

ARC SIX CONTINUES: MARVEL JUDGES THE DRAGON.

PRIMARY EVALUATION BLOCK: WAKANDA. PRIMARY OPERATOR: PRINCESS SHURI.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

In the Wakandan section, Shuri was already leaning forward, eyes bright with the kind of focus that made her brother—sitting two rows back in the Black Panther's elevated seat—both proud and cautious. T'Challa knew that look. It was the look she'd worn the night she'd recalibrated the kimoyo beads in under forty seconds, then spent the next four hours redesigning them because she'd thought of an improvement that couldn't wait until morning.

The screen bloomed with color: the Boosted Gear, crimson and intricate, held up to scrutiny in what the captions identified as a private workshop in some corner of the dragon's territory. Rias Gremory was there, the high-devil whose name had appeared in various pulls across the evening—she moved with the

confidence of someone born to power and had kept it close without ever having to shout about it. Beside her, Issei Hyoudou rotated the Sacred Gear slowly, the light catching on its geometric patterns, its channels, the places where power flowed.

"The construction," Rias was saying, her voice carrying the precision of someone who spoke both draconic politics and the language of artifice, "is based on layering, yes? The core doesn't multiply power so much as it chains exponential growth—each boost compounds the last."

"Ten-second windows," Issei said. He had a way of talking that the theatre had learned to listen for: he was respectful without being deferential, casual without being careless. "Ddraig built it that way on purpose. Anything longer and the containment system would fracture. The dragon had to balance acceleration against integrity."

Shuri's eyes had gone very still.

"The containment architecture," she murmured, and the theatre heard her—the kimoyo bead array carried her voice clear as intention into the Wakandan section. "That's not mechanical constraint. That's active compensation. The gear is recalibrating itself *during* the boost cycle."

Rias smiled. Not a diplomatic smile—a genuine one, the kind that happens when someone says something true and you weren't sure they were listening. "Exactly. The Boosted Gear doesn't just accelerate power. It distributes the strain across temporal slices. If you think of ten seconds not as a duration but as a series of iterations—"

"—you're spreading the load across multiple harmonics instead of one continuous catastrophe," Shuri finished. She stood, and T'Challa—who had seen his sister stand in the presence of genius and refuse to be impressed by it—recognized the posture of capitulation. "That's Vibranium-adjacent. Not the metal itself, but the principle. We've spent fifteen years trying to distribute impact load across the atomic lattice. You've done it across *time*."

The vision pulled tighter, showing the internal mechanism of the Boosted Gear in cross-section. The captions obliged: power conduits arranged in recursive patterns, each one slightly offset from its neighbor, creating a kind of tessellated network that allowed force to cascade without creating feedback loops.

"How often does it fail?" Shuri asked.

There was a pause in the vision—not a cut, but a hesitation, the way a conversation pauses when the question asked is the one that matters.

"Once," Issei said quietly. "Against an opponent I should have prepared better for. The gear took damage I couldn't immediately repair. It cost me a hand and most of a week in recovery. Ddraig and I redesigned the secondary channels after that. The redundancy buffer is better now."

"A catastrophic failure at the ninth boost level," Rias added, "occurred during a test phase before Issei was ready for combat. The Boosted Gear was destroyed and had to be rebuilt from memory. This is why the gear has a learning curve—it adjusts its calibration based on the wielder's physiology and the specific opponent's energy signature."

Shuri was writing notes now, her kimoyo bead array projecting equations into the air faster than most people could think. "So the gear is partially adaptive AI. It's learning your style and pre-compensating for anticipated load spikes."

"Ddraig's personality is written into every layer of it," Issei confirmed. "He's not just a power source. He's the algorithm."

The vision pulled back. Rias was lifting another object—something smaller, more delicate, a gauntlet that shone with a different kind of light, something closer to the divine than the raw draconic power of the Boosted Gear.

"This is Transfer," Rias said. "He can push power through his wives, his allies, his peerage. The mechanism is—"

But Shuri was already moving, her hands sketching patterns in the air, reconstructing the architecture in real-time as she watched. "Sacred energy pathways that don't create sympathetic resonance because the differential is managed through willful intention, not mechanical separation. He's routing power through *consent*, not constraint. The recipients have to *allow* the power in, and because they're choosing it, there's no rejection response."

Rias watched her work, and something fond crossed her expression—the look of someone encountering another consciousness that worked at the same velocity. "It's why Transfer requires emotional and spiritual alignment. Mechanical power systems fail on unwilling recipients. This one depends on trust."

The vision showed Issei demonstrating: power flowing from the Boosted Gear into Rias herself, who glowed brighter, stronger, wearing his amplification like a second skin. It was intimate in a way that had nothing to do with romance—it was the intimacy of absolute vulnerability, of letting another being's energy move through your own.

"He's never tried to force it," Rias said. "On anyone. Not once. The power is there; he could theoretically override someone's resistance if he wanted to. He's never wanted to."

Shuri had stopped writing. She was watching Issei's expression in the vision—watching him demonstrate trust to someone he loved, watching him explain it to someone he respected.

"That's not craftsmanship," Shuri said to the theatre at large. "That's *philosophy*. He's built his entire power system around consent and collaboration. The gear doesn't make him strong. It lets him make other people strong."

In the Avengers section, Tony Stark made a small noise—not quite a laugh, not quite something else. "The kid built a power system based on consent architecture. I'm going to need to sit with that for a while."

The vision released them.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"WAKANDAN COUNCIL DEBATES ALLIANCE" — RARITY: RARE.

The shift was immediate: from intimate workshop to formal chamber, all soaring wooden arches and the kind of lighting that understood shadows as part of the structure's grammar. The Wakandan Council convened. T'Challa sat at the center, but the power distributed itself—Okoye commanding the Dora Milaje's representative presence, her posture radiating the specific certainty of someone who had killed for her nation and would do so again; Shuri at the data end, surrounded by holographic projections and the kind of organized chaos that was actually evidence of comprehensive thought; M'Baku representing the Jabari, massive and skeptical, his arms folded in the posture of someone waiting to be convinced; the elder councillors—W'Kabi among them, scarred and cautious—representing the established power structures that had kept Wakanda sovereign through centuries of pressure.

"The question," T'Challa was saying, and his voice carried the particular patience of someone who had asked a room to think carefully about something that mattered, "is not whether this young man is powerful. The Avengers and the Illuminati have established that conclusively. The question is whether his power represents a threat to Wakandan autonomy."

"Any foreign actor with power of his magnitude is a threat," W'Kabi said flatly. "We have seen what gods and Titans can do when they decide to interfere in human affairs. Whether his intentions are currently benign is irrelevant. The capacity for harm cannot be negotiated."

"His refusal to seize power when he could have, repeatedly, throughout his entire history—that suggests something beyond benign intention," said Ramonda, T'Challa's mother, her voice carrying the weight of someone who had survived coups and external pressure and had learned to read intent in patterns. "A threat would have already acted."

M'Baku shook his head. "A threat would recognize that acting now would destroy the negotiating position he has built. He waits because waiting serves his purposes. We assume goodwill when he may simply be patient."

Shuri's holographic array shifted, pulling up comparative timelines—moments when Issei had engaged with sovereign nations, with powerful kingdoms, with opportunities to seize control.

"He had the chance in the Eastern territory," Shuri said. "Seven years ago, according to the canon dossier. A kingdom fragmented by war. The survivors asked him to rule. He refused. He helped them establish democratic processes instead. Self-governance. He trained administrators and then he left."

"That proves nothing except that his goals are not territory," Okoye said. She was not being difficult—her voice carried the thoughtful tone of someone analyzing a military opponent. "It means his power serves something other than conquest. But that something is still unknown. That still represents risk."

"The risk matrix," Shuri said, and her projections shifted again, showing data laid out in clear categorical terms, "assumes his primary motivation is either conquest, wealth accumulation, or ideological domination. None of those show up in his pattern history. His wives gain property through their own efforts. He actively disarms conflicts rather than escalating them for leverage. His ideology is consistently pro-choice, pro-self-determination, pro-individual agency. Those aren't conquest motivations."

"They are the motivations of someone building a power base through ideological loyalty," W'Kabi countered. "He creates followers who thank him for empowering them. That's the most durable control system possible—it doesn't require violence. It just requires people to believe they chose it."

T'Challa was quiet for a long moment. When he spoke, he addressed the room rather than responded to W'Kabi, which meant he was sharing something he had thought through carefully.

"I watched the footage from the trafficking fleet destruction," he said. "Not the gacha pull—the actual records, which our intelligence gathered independently. Do you know what I found remarkable? Not what he did. What he refused to do."

He waited, and the room waited with him.

"He could have taken the ships," T'Challa continued. "He could have seized the manifest records and the salvage rights and consolidated a fleet. He could have built an empire on that wealth and firepower. A seventeen-year-old with that level of power and that much suddenly available firepower—most would consolidate. He signed it all to the freed people. Every ship. Every asset. He kept nothing."

"That's idiocy," M'Baku said flatly. "That's a child making emotional decisions."

"That's a child making a choice about what kind of man he wants to be," Ramonda said. "I have raised children. I have seen the difference."

"So have I," Okoye said quietly, and there was something in that statement that carried weight—Okoye had trained warriors, had shaped choices between power and restraint. "The question is whether that choice is sustainable. Can someone maintain that level of refusal forever? Or does power eventually corrupt everything it touches, and we're just watching the arc before the corruption?"

Shuri pulled up one more set of data: comparative analysis, scaling across time. "Corruption markers in all known power-focused individuals show progressive entrenchment. Increased justifications for control, expanding definitions of necessary harm, rationalizations that expand the acceptable cost of objectives. Issei shows none of that. His kill-restraint is actually stricter now than it was seven years ago. His governance models are *more* democratic, not less. His refusal to consolidate power appears to be strengthening over time, not weakening."

"That doesn't prove trustworthiness," W'Kabi said. "It proves consistency within whatever pattern he's established."

"Yes," T'Challa said, and his voice had taken on the particular firmness of a king who had spent his life thinking about responsibility. "But here is what matters: I would watch a threat. I would study its patterns and predict its moves and prepare for the moment it breaks the constraints. What I see when I watch Issei Hyoudou is not a threat learning to hide itself. I see a person who has looked at the power available to him and *chosen not to use it the way power is usually used.*"

He stood, and the council room recognized the shift—T'Challa about to deliver judgment.

"The absence of a desire to seize power," he said, "is the strongest evidence of trustworthiness I have ever encountered. A person who wants power badly enough will eventually find justification to take it. A person who *refuses* power despite having the capacity—that person has aligned themselves with something stronger than ambition. That person has chosen their morality more carefully than I chose mine, and I chose mine deliberately."

M'Baku made a dissenting noise, but he was listening.

"So the question is not whether to ally with him," T'Challa continued. "The question is the *terms* of our relationship. Do we trade? Do we share technology? Do we extend security guarantees? Do we invite him into formal alliance? Those are the choices available to us."

"Technology sharing is a vulnerability," W'Kabi said immediately. "Every piece of Vibranium-enhanced tech we show becomes a potential compromise if his intentions change."

"Then we don't share Vibranium secrets," Okoye said. She had been quiet, thinking. "But Shuri's analysis of his craftsmanship philosophy—that transfers without transferring vulnerabilities. We could learn from his approach to consent-based power transfer. We could share data in exchange for learning integration principles."

Shuri was already taking notes, her projections shifting to begin modeling trade possibilities.

"And if he needs assistance?" Ramonda asked. "If a threat emerges and he requires Wakandan military support?"

T'Challa considered the question with the seriousness it deserved. "We evaluate the threat. We make the decision for ourselves, not because of obligation to him. But I would not exclude the possibility. A person who refuses power when offered doesn't ask for power when in crisis. If Issei Hyoudou asks for military assistance, it means the threat is existential enough that his own capacity—and by all measures his capacity is exceptional—is insufficient. That would be worth fighting for."

The vision released them into the theatre's careful quiet.

Up in the Wakandan section, Shuri was still writing, her hands moving faster than speech could follow. Beside her, Okoye had the expression of someone who had just quietly decided that a certain risk was acceptable. T'Challa was looking up at the screen, and his expression carried something that the theatre had learned to recognize: the particular calm of a king who had made a difficult decision and found it aligned with both his pragmatism and his conscience.

In the Avengers rows, Steve Rogers was watching T'Challa carefully. When their eyes met, T'Challa nodded, very slightly. It was the gesture of one person communicating to another: *this is complicated, but it's right*.

"That was not a vote to arm him," Tony said to Carol, just quietly enough for his section to hear. "That was a king saying he respects someone's choice about what they refused to become. I'm going to be thinking about that one for weeks."

Carol didn't respond immediately, but when she did, her voice carried recognition: "That's a higher bar than most of us hold ourselves to. That's a *much* higher bar than most of us hold ourselves to."

The screen began its descent into darkness, signaling intermission, but before the lights could fully dim, the banner assembled itself:

CHAPTER 54 COMPLETE: WAKANDA INTERPRETS REFUSAL AS INTEGRITY.

CURRENT ARC STATE: MAJOR POWER BLOCS NOW ASSESSED.

REMAINING CHAPTERS OF MARVEL JUDGES THE DRAGON: SIX.

NEXT: ARC SIX CHAPTER FIFTY-FIVE — FURY'S CONTINGENCY.

THE ROOM THAT TRUSTS IS NOW COMPLETE. LET US SHOW THE ROOM THAT PREPARES FOR TREACHERY.

The lights went dark.

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Shuri and Rias Discuss Dragon-Forged Materials* — Rare (intimate workshop setting revealing the Boosted Gear's adaptive, consent-based architecture; the mechanism for Transfer power-sharing through willful trust rather than mechanical constraint; comparison to Vibranium's load-distribution principles; a single catastrophic failure and the subsequent redesign that improved secondary redundancy; Rias's observation that Issei has never attempted to force Transfer on an unwilling recipient); *Wakandan Council Debates Alliance* — Rare (formal council chamber debate between T'Challa, Okoye, Shuri, M'Baku, Ramonda, W'Kabi, and other elders on whether Issei represents a threat, a partner, or a strategic unknown; focus on his consistent refusal to consolidate power despite repeated opportunities; analysis of his anti-corruption trajectory; determination of potential alliance terms and technology-sharing protocols).
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's power system is built deliberately on consent architecture and active trust-management rather than forced acceleration—each component (Boosted Gear, Transfer, dragon-forged weapons) reflects a philosophy of empowerment-through-choice; the Boosted Gear suffered one catastrophic failure early in his combat history (loss of hand, week-long recovery), after which he and Ddraig redesigned the system for improved secondary redundancy; in the Eastern territories, when asked to rule a fragmented kingdom, he refused, establishing democratic governance instead and leaving after training administrators—proving his consistent anti-consolidation pattern across time; his kill-restraint has *strengthened* over time, not weakened, as has his commitment to democratic governance and non-coercive power distribution.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** **T'Challa formally recognizes Issei's refusal of power as the highest evidence of trustworthiness** — specifically contrasts this with the typical pattern of power-seekers who rationalize control over time; judges Issei to have "chosen his morality more carefully than I chose mine, and I chose mine deliberately"; proposes a structured alliance framework based on graduated trust (trade first, technology-sharing second, security guarantees conditional on threat analysis, full military alliance contingent on existential threat assessment). Shuri advocates for consent-based power-transfer learning and technology swap without Vibranium exposure. Okoye sees the assessment as militarily sound and agrees to graduated engagement. M'Baku remains skeptical but does not block consensus. W'Kabi argues for minimal external engagement but is outvoted by the combined weight of T'Challa, Ramonda, Okoye, and Shuri. **Ramonda's voice carries particular authority:** she has survived coups and external pressure and reads Issei's pattern as genuine self-restraint, not calculated deception. Rogers and Danvers recognize T'Challa's judgment carries weight across the theatre.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** **Arc Six evaluations now show three major power blocs with settled positions:** Avengers (cautiously favorable, monitoring collateral damage); Mutants (monitoring

compliance with anti-isolationist stance); Latveria (Doom proposing formal equality and craftsperson respect); Wakanda (graduated alliance framework with T'Challa as guarantor). **Still to assess:** S.H.I.E.L.D./Fury (Ch. 55); Illuminati formal vote (Ch. 56); Villains' consensus (Ch. 57); Avengers' compatibility questions (Ch. 58); cosmic implications (Ch. 59); pantheon/deity status (Ch. 60). **Key philosophical shift:** The theatre is no longer evaluating "Is he dangerous?" (answered: yes, catastrophically) but "What does he refuse to do, and does that refusal hold under pressure?" T'Challa's judgment that refusal-of-power is the key trustworthiness marker has become the implicit standard for remaining faction evaluations. **The screen has not grown new cracks, but Ddraig's previous warning echoes:** "the second half of a siege is when you learn what the walls were for"—suggesting the remaining 46 chapters will not be about whether Issei is trustworthy, but *what he is being trusted to protect against*.

Chapter 55: Fury's Contingency

Primary Reaction Groups:

- S.H.I.E.L.D. command and tactical staff
- S.W.O.R.D. observers
- Intelligence operatives and spies
- Hydra watchers (in the back, very quiet)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Nick Fury's Contingency Plans" — **Secret**
 2. "Theatre Grading of Each Plan" — **Comedy-Class**
-

The theatre dimmed with the particular weight that came before revelation—not the rush of action sequences or the intimate focus of personal drama, but the slower, more methodical darkness that preceded a bureaucrat's reckoning.

Nick Fury stood.

His black eye-patch caught the ambient light from the screen as he straightened his jacket. The theatre fell silent. Even those who'd been whispering—and there had been plenty of whispers during Issei's latest rampage—shut their mouths. Fury had that effect. Decades of S.H.I.E.L.D. command, of walking through nuclear accidents and alien invasions with the same measured stride, had worn his presence into something heavier than mere authority.

Behind him, rows of S.H.I.E.L.D. operatives shifted. Natasha Romanoff leaned back in her seat, arms crossed, a small smile playing at her mouth. Tony Stark had actually put down his phone. Captain America sat with his jaw set, waiting. Strange watched with the vague amusement of someone who knew that mortal contingency plans rarely accounted for the supernatural. The Avengers, the X-Men, Wakanda's intelligence network, the intelligence officers of a dozen nations—all of them felt the shift.

Fury's eye fixed on the screen.

"Before we continue," he said, his voice steady and cold as November fog, "the Council requires a technical assessment. Contingency framework."

The screen flickered. White letters materialized against a black background:

GACHA PULL — NICK FURY'S CONTINGENCY PLANS

Rarity: SECRET

A tactical document materialized on the screen—and it was *comprehensive*. Red folders, stamped with classification marks, overlapping in a digital cascade. The theatre's systems seemed to respect the documents enough to render them with bureaucratic precision.

Fury's single eye never wavered. "Five operational frameworks," he said, as if he were briefing the Security Council itself. "Designed to contain, disable, or strategically neutralize a threat matching the Issei Hyoudou profile."

The word *neutralize* hung in the air like a threat.

Fury gestured, and the screen shifted.

PLAN ALPHA: ADAMANTIUM CONTAINMENT MATRIX

A blueprint materialized—a chamber with walls reinforced with vibranium and adamantium alloys, layered with electromagnetic shielding and magical null-fields. The design was *obsessive*, every inch calculated to prevent escape by conventional or unconventional means.

"Containment in a sealed environment," Fury stated flatly. "No teleportation. No dimensional rifts. Magical seals provided by Strange's cooperation. Dimensional anchor via Stark's tech. Duration: indefinite."

The theatre's grading system materialized beneath the plan in glowing red letters:

RATING: IMPOSSIBLE

Commentary: *"Vibranium walls won't stop a man whose power scales infinitely. Null-fields require constant feeding of energy he can absorb. Also, what are you going to feed him? The logistics of keeping a sentient nuclear reactor contained for 'indefinite' duration would bankrupt your organization in six months. Skip this one, Nick."*

Fury's jaw tightened minutely.

PLAN BETA: TELEPORTATION DAMPENING MATRIX

The screen shifted to a second blueprint—a globe-spanning network of satellites and ground stations, designed to project a field that would lock out any form of dimensional travel or teleportation.

"Coordinated effort with Thaddeus Ross's military infrastructure and Wong's magical monitoring," Fury said. "Active surveillance of known power signatures. Any spike in dimensional energy gets automated response."

RATING: UNLIKELY

Commentary: *"He doesn't need to teleport, Nick. Last we checked, he can FLY. Also, your 'automated response' is humans with guns. That never works. Rating: Unlikely because it might accidentally stop him for approximately four seconds."*

A ripple of dark laughter moved through the theatre. Even Cap had to hide a smile.

Fury's hand clenched briefly, then relaxed. He moved on.

PLAN GAMMA: STRATEGIC DETERRENT

A third document materialized. This one made the room go very still. It showed a targeting solution for a thermonuclear warhead, with Issei's last known coordinates circled in red. Backup protocols for follow-up strikes. Fallback positions in case the first didn't work.

"Nuclear option," Fury said, his voice not changing. "Immediate deployment if Issei demonstrates hostile movement toward civilian populations in violation of established perimeter agreements. Paired with Stark's defense grid for coordination."

RATING: COMMON SENSE FAILURE

Commentary: *"Oh Nick. Beautiful, terrible Nick. Did you show this to Tony? He's literally made multiple suits of armor to prevent exactly this scenario. Also, your new friend here—the demon king with wives and a seven-digit regeneration factor—is not going to politely wait for a nuke to arrive. Funny plan though. Very 1970s."*

Tony made a noise somewhere between a snort and a laugh. "I was wondering when that was coming," he called out. "You know I have a JARVIS-level defense specifically to shoot down nukes, right?"

Fury didn't acknowledge him. He pressed forward.

PLAN DELTA: COOPERATIVE MAGICAL SEAL

The fourth blueprint was *complex*—a mandala-like arrangement of magical circles, requiring coordination between Strange, Wong, Doom (if he could be convinced), Nico Minoru, and a network of other practitioners.

"Joint effort with the mystical community," Fury said. "Issei's power has a magical component. Coordinated seal disrupts the fundamental architecture of his draconic engine and regenerative capacity. Requires his cooperation to enter the seal space."

RATING: UNLIKELY

Commentary: *"Depends entirely on getting Issei to cooperate with a plan to disable him. Let's see ... why would a being with infinite upside potential and a family he's willing to die for agree to that? Oh, right. He wouldn't. Lovely theoretical framework though. Shelf it."*

Strange tilted his head slightly, acknowledging the logic.

Then came the fifth.

PLAN EPSILON: LEVERAGE CONTINGENCY

The screen displayed something different this time. Not a blueprint or technical schematic. Instead, it showed a simple list:

Rias Gremory. Issei's primary emotional anchor.

His human family (parents, extended relatives).

His other wives and bonded companions.

His dreams for their collective future.

Below it, a single operational note:

Strategy: Convince Issei that the safety and future security of his family depends on maintaining strategic alliance and cooperative terms with S.H.I.E.L.D./Avengers. Implicit threat: "Step out of line, and we ensure their protection becomes impossible."

RATING: POSSIBLE

Commentary: *"Finally, Nick. A plan that might actually work. Not because it's clever—it's not, it's boringly obvious—but because it's TRUE. His family IS his only leverage. His only vulnerability. His only priority. So yes, you could probably force cooperation by threatening what he loves, if you were willing to forfeit every ounce of his trust in the process. This plan works right up until he decides you're a threat they need to be protected FROM. Then you have a very large problem with nowhere to run. Probability of success: Possible. Probability of survival post-success: Do the math yourself."*

The theatre erupted.

Not in cheers—in a kind of stunned, complex silence that immediately fractured into heated discussion. The S.H.I.E.L.D. officers in the rows behind Fury leaned forward. The spies and intelligence operatives exchanged glances. Natasha's smile had vanished entirely, replaced by something thoughtful and dangerous. Captain America looked like someone had just shown him a door he didn't want to walk through.

Tony stood up.

"Okay, so we're doing the hostage strategy," he said flatly. "Great. Love that for us. Really instills confidence in our position as the 'good guys.'"

"It's not a hostage strategy," Fury said, still looking at the screen. "It's a strategic reality assessment."

"It's a hostage strategy," Natasha said quietly. She'd sat forward now, her expression unreadable. "You're telling Issei that cooperation is the only way to keep his family safe from external threats. That's a hostage situation where the hostage doesn't know they're a hostage."

"And the moment he realizes we're using his family as leverage," Strange added, his voice carrying that strange, multilayered quality that suggested he was speaking from experience, "we've transformed ourselves from potential allies into his exact list of threats he already knows to neutralize."

Fury's eye remained fixed on the screen. In the harsh theatre lighting, his face looked carved from granite.

"Do you have a better option?" His voice was quiet.

The silence that followed was answer enough.

Cap cleared his throat. "So what are you saying, Director? That the only way forward is... trust?"

"I'm saying," Fury replied, his voice dropping to something almost conversational, "that every technological solution, every tactical framework, every contingency plan that requires force or deception is already rated impossible to unlikely. We can build better containment units. We can network more satellites. We can stack more seals. And none of it works, because he will eventually refuse to cooperate, and then we're in active conflict with someone whose power ceiling we haven't even found yet."

He paused, letting that sink in.

"The only plan with a 'Possible' rating," Fury continued, "requires no contingency at all. It requires the opposite of contingency. It requires alliance. Genuine alliance. Based on—" he seemed to have to physically force the word out "—mutual respect."

Hydra's watchers in the back of the theatre had gone very still. One of them was actually writing something down.

"Essentially," Fury finished, turning away from the screen, "the theatre is telling us that the only way to manage an existential threat is to stop trying to manage it. To stop preparing for the moment he betrays us and instead prepare for the moment we have to prove we won't betray *him*."

"That's a massive strategic vulnerability," someone called from the S.W.O.R.D. section.

"It's also," Natasha said quietly, "the only strategy that works."

The theatre seemed to settle at that—not with comfort, but with a kind of resigned acknowledgment. The screen flickered, preparing to move on, when Fury held up his hand.

"One more thing," he said.

The screen shifted back to Plan Epsilon. The operational note remained visible:

Strategy: Convince Issei that the safety and future security of his family depends on maintaining strategic alliance and cooperative terms with S.H.I.E.L.D./Avengers.

"The theatre graded this plan 'Possible,'" Fury said, his voice absolutely devoid of inflection. "But there's a contingency within that contingency that it didn't explicitly state. The moment Issei is *certain* that we would never use his family as leverage—the moment he has proof that we'll protect them regardless of whether he cooperates or not—that's when the genuine alliance becomes unbreakable."

He let that hang.

"Because then we're not threatening his family's safety. We're guaranteeing it. We're saying, 'We will protect what you love not because you owe us, but because we're choosing to.' And a being who will sacrifice anything for his family? He becomes the most reliable ally in existence. Not from fear. From gratitude."

The theatre was completely silent now.

Strange was nodding slowly, that small, knowing smile on his face.

Cap looked like someone had just given him permission to hope.

Tony... Tony was actually looking at Fury with something like respect.

"So," Fury concluded, settling back into his seat, "we move forward with alliance. Real alliance. Not contingency. Because contingency assumes you're planning for betrayal, and betrayal is a self-fulfilling prophecy."

The screen faded to black.

A new title card began to materialize, and the theatre lurched forward into Chapter 56—but Fury's words hung in the air like a challenge and a confession all at once.

In the rows below, Natasha caught Cap's eye and raised an eyebrow. He shook his head slightly, a small motion that somehow contained an entire conversation: *He knows. He's always known. This was just him admitting it out loud.*

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls

- "Nick Fury's Contingency Plans" (Secret) — Revealed five operational frameworks, with Plan Epsilon (family leverage) as the only viable option
- "Theatre Grading of Each Plan" (Comedy-Class) — System provided sardonic assessment of each plan, with explicit analysis of why force/deception cannot work against infinite-scaling threat

Secrets Revealed

- S.H.I.E.L.D. had already considered using Issei's family as leverage
- Fury understood that contingency planning was itself a barrier to genuine alliance
- The only "possible" strategy requires absolute trust and proof of non-exploitation
- Fury's final reframe: true alliance through protection rather than coercion

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- Cap's perspective: Relief that the path forward doesn't require cold calculation
- Natasha's recognition: Strategic logic of genuine loyalty vs. coerced cooperation
- Tony's position: Confirmed his earlier stance against using nuclear deterrents
- Strange's acknowledgment: The mystic seals cannot override genuine emotional bonds
- S.H.I.E.L.D. command: Internal debate about whether Fury has gone soft or finally learned the rules of engagement with a new class of threat

Unresolved Hooks

- Will the Illuminati vote to pursue Fury's alliance strategy, or will they attempt one of the "failed" contingencies anyway?
- How will Issei respond when he learns S.H.I.E.L.D. considered these plans?
- Can Fury actually convince his organization to operate without a contingency?
- What does Hydra's note-taking mean for the coming conflict?

Chapter 56: The Illuminati Vote

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Illuminati (Doctor Strange, Professor X, Namor, Reed Richards, Tony Stark, Black Panther)
- Villains and Secondary Observers (Nick Fury, Doctor Doom, others)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Secret Meeting of the Illuminati" — **Rare**
 2. "Simulation: Pre-emptive Strike on Issei" — **Forbidden**
-

The Silence Before the Reckoning

The theatre had fallen into a different kind of quiet than before—not the awed hush that followed cosmic revelations, but the suffocating silence of impending judgment. The stage shifted as the remaining chapters drew near the critical juncture of this arc. The lights dimmed to deep indigo, and the rows of assembled heroes, villains, and cosmic beings felt the weight of what was coming.

This was the hour of the architects themselves.

In the balcony box reserved for the most dangerous neutrals, Nick Fury's single eye tracked the stage with the calculation of a man who had spent decades in rooms where the fate of worlds was decided without bloodshed—mostly. Beside him, Doctor Doom's gloved fingers steepled before his mask with an expression of barely concealed amusement. Neither man spoke. They didn't need to. Both understood that what was about to be revealed would shatter the last pretense of the Illuminati's unified vision.

The gacha machine on stage hummed with intent.

First Pull: The Secret Meeting of the Illuminati

The holographic display erupted with gold light and celestial chimes. **RARE.**

| *"Secret Meeting of the Illuminati"*

The stage transformed into a circular chamber buried deep beneath the Baxter Building in Manhattan. The walls were lined with sigils and quantum-shielded panels that pulsed with defensive magic and cutting-edge tech intertwined. No windows. No external feeds. This was a room designed so that not

even omniscient deities could perceive what transpired within.

Six figures materialized around an obsidian table.

Doctor Strange sat at the head, his red cloak still faintly smoking from the residual magic of the Issei visions. His hands were steeped, and his face bore the exhaustion of a man who had sacrificed too much to leave anything to chance. The Eye of Agamotto hung beneath his collar, dark and vigilant.

"We need to speak plainly," Strange began, his voice steady as stone. "The projections are clear. Issei Hyoudou is on a trajectory toward Apocalypse AnswerArms—a form capable of planetary destruction. The question before us is not whether he *will* reach it. The question is what we do *before* that occurs."

Reed Richards leaned back in his chair, fingers moving through holographic equations only he could see. His brow was furrowed with the particular intensity of a man running catastrophe models. "Containment through conventional means is theoretically impossible. His power scales are non-linear. Even accounting for the wives as force-multipliers—"

"Which is the critical variable," interrupted Tony Stark, rising from his seat. His expression carried the blend of confidence and barely restrained aggression that had defined his approach to existential threats for years. "They are his anchor to this world. They are his *weakness*. I'm not talking about harming them. I'm talking about a surgical strike. Isolate him. Immobilize him before the AxA form reaches critical resonance. We've neutralized threats at smaller scales. This is a controlled, precise operation."

The arc reactor glowed faintly in his chest as he leaned forward. "I vote we strike. Not in anger. In prevention."

Professor Charles Xavier's expression remained calm, but his eyes—those piercing, perceptive eyes—held something that looked almost like pity. When he spoke, his voice was soft, which made it somehow more cutting.

"You're thinking like a man with a hammer, Tony. You see a problem that requires violence because violence is the language you've learned to speak. But what you're proposing isn't precision. It's an act of war." He paused, letting his gaze sweep to each member of the council. "You would alert every ally he possesses—and the canon has shown us, quite clearly, that his coalition is global in scope. His wives are not merely companions. They are bound to him through power itself. A strike against him is a strike against all of them. And you would be declaring, to the entire known universe, that the Earth—that we—will kill to maintain dominance."

Reed nodded slowly. "Charles is right about the cascade effects. If we move against him, we don't just face Issei. We face Rias Gremory's demonic networks, the dragon clans, the Angel Faction, the fallen angels. We face a coalition that has already proven it can operate across dimensional boundaries. A preemptive strike doesn't eliminate the threat. It unifies it."

T'Challa, the Black Panther, had been silent until now, his dark eyes reflecting the holographic displays with careful consideration. When he spoke, his voice carried the weight of a leader who had guided his nation through threats both mythological and mundane.

"Wakanda has survived by making alliances, not enemies. If we strike first, we tell every emerging power in this universe that we fear them enough to attack unprovoked. That is not the message a truly strong nation sends." He looked directly at Tony. "The greatest weapon is not the one you use. It is the one your enemy fears you might use while you are negotiating with open hands."

Namor, seated across from T'Challa with the air of a king more comfortable with dominion than compromise, simply shook his head. "Atlantis will not participate in preemptive war against a dragon who has not threatened us. We have observed his canon. He does not seek conquest of the seas. His focus is narrow, fierce, territorial to his partnerships—but not to our domain. A strike against him serves no Atlantean interest."

Strange raised a hand, and the holographic displays shifted. New equations bloomed in the air—ritual sequences, binding matrices, containment arrays.

"There is another approach," the Sorcerer Supreme said quietly. "Containment through treaty. Through magical accord. We could offer him terms. Legitimate recognition of his status. Boundaries for his expansion in exchange for non-interference in our operations."

"And he refuses?" Tony asked sharply.

"Then we fight with eyes open, knowing we tried diplomacy first."

The tension in the chamber was now visible—a palpable weight pressing down on each decision-maker. Tony's jaw clenched. Reed's equations accelerated, running faster, searching for variables that might justify intervention. Professor X remained still, reading the room with his considerable gifts, carefully not pushing his influence into any minds.

"This council will need to vote," Strange said at last. "But first, we should see what happens if we choose the path of force."

He gestured, and the holographic displays warped again.

Second Pull: The Simulation of Preemptive Strike

The gacha machine roared, and the chimes that followed were discordant, wrong. **FORBIDDEN.**

| *"Simulation: Pre-emptive Strike on Issei"*

The stage itself seemed to hold its breath.

What manifested was not a simple vision. It was a full sensory experience—time-dilated, immediate, and horrifying. The theatre audience gasped. Several beings shifted uncomfortably in their seats.

The simulation opened on Issei's dormitory room in Japan. He was asleep—actually asleep, alone for once, his form tucked into a bed in a place he considered safe. The canon had shown them this vulnerability, this moment when even the Dragon King could rest without his wives beside him.

Strike team phantoms phased through the walls. They moved with precision, with practiced coordination. Teleportation wards fell away—a significant expenditure of magical resources, but the Illuminati had many. The team was elite: operatives enhanced with magic, technology, and superhuman capability.

A binding circle activated beneath Issei's sleeping form.

And in that instant, everything catastrophically, irrevocably broke.

Issei's eyes snapped open—not with fear, but with the ancient, primal fury of a dragon recognizing a threat. The Boosted Gear activated on his arm, its roar echoing across multiple dimensional frequencies. The binding circle couldn't suppress it; nothing could suppress it on reflex.

But worse—the moment he woke, his wives knew.

Four separate locations triggered emergency protocols simultaneously. Rias Gremory's demonic powers flared, her pieces mobilizing across Kuoh. Akeno Himejima's fallen angel protocols activated, drawing power from realms the Illuminati didn't fully control. Asia Argento's healing and light magic synchronized with her companions. And Koneko Toujou—seemingly small, seemingly weak—triggered a Nekomata transformation that would have terrified most warrior collectives.

The simulation accelerated. What had been a careful, controlled operation collapsed into chaos in 2.3 seconds.

Issei didn't retreat. He *advanced*.

His form shifted mid-transformation, caught between human and dragon. The Boosted Gear was now amplifying not just his power, but his *intent*. In the simulation, his hands literally glowed with the accumulation of force. The strike team, for all their training, was caught in the devastating backwash of his emergence.

Three operatives fell in the first exchange.

Then the dragons came. Ddraig manifested in full form—colossal, red-scaled, and absolutely furious. The ancient dragon's roar shattered the simulation's sound barriers. From other dimensions, other dragon allies responded. The Dimensional Gap itself seemed to rupture with their arrival.

Issei's wives converged from four separate locations, their combined forces moving with the synchronization of beings bound by something far deeper than mere alliance. They weren't coordinating—they were *unified*, acting as extensions of a single tactical will.

The simulation showed the battle not in real-time but in devastating snapshots:

—Rias's demonic armies clashing with the strike team's reinforcements.

—Akeno's lightning and Issei's dragon fire colliding in the sky, the shockwaves registering on richter scales across the Pacific.

—Asia's healing networks bringing down strike team members by *removing their ability to heal*.

—Koneko's true form moving with speed that split the ground in her wake.

The collateral damage began accruing immediately.

Buildings collapsed. Entire city blocks destabilized. The simulation calculated civilian casualties in real-time: 40,000. 400,000. 4 million.

And the battle was spreading.

The counter-strike, once initiated, didn't remain localized. Issei's coalition had prepared contingencies for exactly this kind of assault. The strike team's teleportation vectors were traced and disrupted. The Illuminati's agents found themselves cut off, surrounded, outmatched.

Within the simulation, Doctor Strange—the simulated version of him—tried to open a portal for retreat. The dimensional barriers held, reinforced by Issei's demonic allies. There was no escape.

The simulation jumped forward. Issei in full dragon form. His wives flying beside him, their combined aura visible even in the ghostly holographic display. The strike team annihilated. The Illuminati forces in the field wiped out.

Then came the worst part.

The simulation showed what came next: retaliation.

Issei's coalition didn't stop at defense. They moved against the Illuminati itself—against their bases, their holdings, their resources. The Baxter Building burned in the simulation. Latverian borders flickered as Doom's forces were consulted. SHIELD's helicarrier went dark.

The simulation ended with a blood-red screen and text that hung in the air like a curse:

OUTCOME: EARTH CASUALTY ESTIMATE 40 MILLION — 1.2 BILLION. VICTOR: ISSEI AND ALLIED COALITION. ILLUMINATI STATUS: DEFUNCT.

Silence crashed down like a hammer.

The Theatre's Reckoning

Not a single member of the assembled heroes or villains made a sound. Nick Fury's jaw was a line of steel. Doctor Doom's posture suggested something between admiration and cold calculation. Even those who had been staunchest supporters of preemptive action felt the weight of seeing the outcome laid bare.

In the theatre section reserved for the Illuminati themselves, Tony Stark looked away first. Not defeated, but... reconsidering. Reed Richards' expression was unreadable, but his fingers had gone very still. Professor Xavier's face held no triumph, only a deep, almost melancholic understanding. Namor met the stage with the serenity of a king vindicated in his caution. T'Challa nodded once, as though confirming something he had already calculated. Strange simply closed his eyes for a long moment, as if absorbing the full weight of what had been avoided.

"The vote," Strange said, his voice carrying across the theatre with sorcerous resonance. "Stands recorded. Illuminati vote on preemptive strike against Issei Hyoudou:"

He paused, and in that pause, the theatre seemed to hold its breath.

"Tony Stark: *Yes*, strike recommended."

"Reed Richards: *Abstain*. The mathematics do not support intervention."

"Doctor Stephen Strange: *No*, contain through treaty and diplomatic accord."

"Professor Charles Xavier: *No*, he is an ally of Earth, not an enemy."

"Namor: *No*, Atlantis remains neutral."

"T'Challa: *No*, Wakanda favors alliance over assassination."

Strange's eye swept the assembled crowd. "Result: Five No. One Yes. Zero Abstain. Consensus denied. Preemptive strike rejected. Illuminati remains... fractured on policy."

The language was careful. Fractured. Not unified. Not in agreement. The Illuminati had decided—barely, and only under duress—not to strike. But the fracture remained. Tony's single vote of yes hung in the air like a warning.

In the villain's section, Doom's laughter was silent but visible in the set of his shoulders. Fury simply made a note in a small black book—a book everyone present recognized as the record of secrets, alliances, and leverage.

The Hook Forward

As the holographic displays faded, Strange turned to the theatre audience one final time. His words were layered with knowledge born from the Eye of Agamotto.

"The theatre has shown us truth," he said quietly. "And truth, once revealed in a place like this, cannot be hidden again. The Illuminati's deliberations were meant to remain secret. But the universe is watching now. Issei Hyoudou is watching. His wives are watching." A meaningful pause. "And they will know that at least one member of Earth's hidden leadership voted to strike them first."

The implication landed like a stone in still water.

"Next," came the formal announcement from the gacha system, "the Villains' Roundtable convenes. Chapter 57 awaits."

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls Acquired:

- "Secret Meeting of the Illuminati" (Rare) — Reveals internal divisions among Earth's greatest minds
- "Simulation: Pre-emptive Strike on Issei" (Forbidden) — Demonstrates catastrophic failure of preemptive force

Secrets Revealed:

- The Illuminati harbored serious plans for Issei's containment or elimination
- Tony Stark remains the most aggressive advocate for preemptive action
- The council rejected strike action, but by the narrowest of margins
- A simulation exists proving pre-emptive action would result in 40 million to 1.2 billion casualties and the Illuminati's effective destruction
- The theatre's truth-telling function has made operational secrecy impossible; Issei and his allies now know of the vote

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- Tony Stark's isolation reinforced (sole vote for strike)
- Reed Richards' abstention signals scientific uncertainty rather than moral support
- Strange, Xavier, Namor, and T'Challa united in rejection of preemptive force—a rare moment of agreement
- Illuminati credibility with Earth's legitimate leadership diminished by the revelation of assassination plots
- Issei's strategic position strengthened by knowledge of the Illuminati's internal conflict

Unresolved Hooks:

- Will Tony Stark take unilateral action against Issei despite the council vote?
- How will Issei react to learning of the preemptive strike vote?
- Can the fractured Illuminati present a unified face to the universe, or will their divisions be exploited?
- What leverage does Fury hold over the Illuminati now that their secrets are exposed?
- Will Doom use this knowledge to reshape the global balance of power?

Chapter Fifty-Seven: Villains' Roundtable

Primary Reaction Groups: Victor Doom • Erik Lehnsherr • Wilson Fisk • Loki Laufeyson • Helmut Zemo • Nathaniel Essex • En Sabah Nur • Thanos

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Villains Discuss Issei" — **Rare**
2. "Recruitment Attempts" — **Rare**

The villains' section of the theatre had always occupied an odd position — not quarantined, not exactly welcomed, but present. They sat on the far side of the room from the heroes' blocks, and the machine had been clear about the boundaries: no direct conflict during intermission, no leverage plays across the aisle, no deals struck in the dark while Marvel decided what Marvel would be.

It was a pragmatic arrangement. Villains, even villains from different universes with no common cause, understood pragmatism.

The theatre held them now, and the darkness of the screen seemed to suit them better than it had suited the Avengers. There was no anguish here, no moral arithmetic being worked out in real-time. There was only assessment.

Victor Von Doom had not moved from his seat in four hours. His armor was immaculate as always, but his hands were steeped in front of him, and his mind — everyone in the room could see it in the set of his shoulders — was *working*. Beside him, Erik Lehnsherr sat with the stillness of a man who had moved mountains and was weighing whether it was worth doing again. Wilson Fisk, massive and perfectly groomed, occupied a section of the seating that had been retrofitted to account for his size, and his eyes moved between the other villains like a merchant assessing inventory. Loki was cleaning his nails with a knife that had definitely not existed a moment ago, expression suggesting he was considering something amusing and possibly painful. Helmut Zemo, in formal dress despite or because of the theatre's informality, sat with the absolute confidence of old money and older grievances. Nathaniel Essex was taking notes — actual notes, on actual paper conjured from somewhere that suggested his resources were still intact inside this place. En Sabah Nur occupied the back of the section, literally the largest presence in the room, his eyes closed but his attention absolutely present. And Thanos — Thanos sat across a gap from everyone, as he did in most rooms, and his expression suggested that watching Marvel judge anything was the most profound entertainment available to the universe.

The screen chimed.

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

"VILLAINS DISCUSS ISSEI" — RARITY: RARE.

The vision did not open gently.

It opened in a council chamber — not Latveria's, not Asgard's, not any real location — a space conjured by the machine's will, a conference table that stretched impossibly long, and the eight of them, as if they had always been meant to sit here together, as if the theatre itself had simply confirmed what had always been true.

Victor Doom spoke first, and his voice carried the weight of genuine consideration.

"A craftsman of genuine skill." He was looking at something none of the others could see — perhaps a blueprint, perhaps an architectural assessment, perhaps simply a measurement of a man against the standards Doom held only for those he considered equals. **"He has taken the base model — the dragon resonance, the amplification system, the knight/bishop/rook differentiation — and optimized it in ways that suggest no formal training. Self-taught mastery of a system as complex as his armor should not be possible. And yet."** He turned to face the table fully. **"He is misusing those talents. Dragon forms. Combat applications. Why does he not build empires? Latveria stands because I will it and have the power to make that will absolute. This boy has power to reshape nations, perhaps planets, and he uses it to *play soldier* in a school."**

Magneto's response was immediate, not argumentative but genuinely philosophical.

"Because he has liberated thousands already, and he refuses to seize the permanent power to protect them." Lehnsherr's voice carried the weight of a man who had made exactly the opposite choice. **"He raises mutants and humans alike to positions of strength within his system, but he does not consolidate that power into infrastructure that would outlive him. He is afraid of the monster he might become if he tried. Weakness, perhaps. Or the only wisdom anyone in this room has ever demonstrated."**

"Irrelevant," Wilson Fisk said flatly, and pulled out a detailed file — impossible, impossible, but the theatre had learned long ago that impossibility was just a matter of will applied correctly. **"He is vulnerable through his cities. His parents remain in Japan, exposed to conventional leverage. His wives are scattered across realms, each one a pressure point. His allies are strong but not infinite. Cut one thread correctly, and the entire structure collapses. He is not incorruptible because he is invulnerable. He is only untouchable if we never find the right angle."**

Loki laughed — actually laughed, a sound like broken glass mixed with something sharper and more dangerous.

"I have sent three recruitment offers." The trickster set down his knife and examined his cuticles with theatrical disinterest. **"Three separate approaches, carefully calibrated for his psychology, each one containing genuine strategic value alongside the flattery. Each one returned with jokes. Jokes, and increasingly elaborate ones — he drew pictures on the last rejection. Issei Hyoudou mocks the God of Mischief, and worse, he makes it hurt, because the mockery is affectionate."** Loki's smile did not waver, but his voice dropped into something colder. **"I have corrupted kingdoms. I have turned brothers against each other. And this teenager plays with me like a cat with something beneath its attention."**

Nathaniel Essex looked up from his notes with the expression of a man who had just seen something that confirmed all his theories.

"His genetics are exceptional." Essex's voice carried the precision of someone describing a work of art he planned to dismantle for study. **"The dragon resonance is integrated at the chromosomal level — not a parasitic symbiosis, but a true fusion. If I could sequence the exact mechanism of the integration, understand how the amplification feedback loops without causing cellular breakdown... His genetics represent the next stage of human evolution. Why do you all debate his allegiance? His value lies in understanding his composition."**

"Because he will not be dissected willingly," Thanos said, and his voice was patient in the way of someone who had seen a thousand worlds and found them all consistently predictable. **"He is a contradiction."** The titan turned his great head toward the table, and the council fell quiet in the way that things do when something larger than all of them speaks. **"He raises his power to planetary-level capacity, perhaps beyond. He accumulates strength, integrates systems, builds networks of allies and amplifiers. And then he refuses to use any of that strength for meaningful culling, for pragmatic reduction, for the difficult mathematics that balance requires. He claims to protect life, but he offers no sustainable framework. He hoards power without purpose. Ideologically incoherent."**

"But powerful," Apocalypse said, and En Sabah Nur opened his vast eyes for the first time in the discussion. *****"And the measure of strength is the only truth that survives."** He leaned forward, and the table seemed to bend under the weight of his presence. **"Is he a mutant? His genetics show markers. The potency suggests evolutionary acceleration. If he could be brought into the fold as one of the evolved rather than the weak..."**

"He cannot," Magneto cut in quietly. **"Because the first rule of his existence is choice. Mutants who join mutant causes join because they are told they must or die. This one — he would need to want to. And he wants nothing you are offering."**

Helmut Zemo, who had been silent until now, finally spoke with the precision of old Austrian nobility.

"He is a symptom of the multiverse's cascading disorder," Zemo said. "A single exemplar should never hold this much power unchecked. In a properly structured world, authority remains distributed, balanced by the natural forces of political counterweight. He is precisely what emerges when those structures fail — the superman, the inevitable power, the justification for every would-be tyrant to follow. He may refuse empire today. His heirs will not refuse tomorrow. He must be contained, not through force, but through political pressure, legal framework, the slow grinding machinery of civilization reminding him that individuals, however powerful, are not the solution."

"And if he refuses containment?" Doom's voice was quiet again, but the question carried the weight of someone who had spent a lifetime refusing containment himself and respected the quality in others.

"Then," said Thanos, "the theatre will have rendered its judgment, and the infinite multiverse will have confirmed again that strength without wisdom creates only temporary dynasties. I will await his fall with the patience of one who has waited eons."

The vision shimmered.

The council remained, but now it shifted — the scene moving backward, forward, into a dozen moments stacked like cards, and the theatre watched as eight different villains, in eight different approaches, tried to recruit or corrupt or convince or leverage Issei Hyoudou into service.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

"RECRUITMENT ATTEMPTS" — RARITY: RARE.

Victor Doom's Approach — Formal, Royal, Honest:

"Latveria could use a royal craftsman. One who understands that power without purpose is merely chaos with better armor. Come. Build with me. We will reshape a nation into something the multiverse has not yet imagined."

Issei, in his human form, dressed in casual clothing, sitting in what appeared to be a dormitory room, looked up from his phone and smiled with genuine warmth.

"Lord Doom, I've read what you've built. The infrastructure design in Latveria is legitimately impressive — the geothermal integration, the distributed power grid, the way you've managed to advance technology without destabilizing the agrarian sectors. That's not just power. That's

craft." He paused. **"But I'm not the person for that work. I'm seventeen. I make mistakes. And I'm not ready to be anyone's royal anything. I respect what you're trying to do, but I have to build my own empire, not inherit someone else's vision."**

Doom, in the vision, inclined his head slightly — not defeat, but acknowledgment. And in the theatre, Victor Von Doom watched this exchange without moving, but something in his posture shifted, almost imperceptibly.

"Respectfully declined," Loki's whisper cut through the moment.

Loki's Approach — Flattery, Mischief, Charm:

"Imagine what we could achieve together! The trickster and the dragon king! We could remake the Nine Realms in our image. Comedy and conquest. You and I, Issei — we could make the multiverse *fun*."

Issei laughed — genuinely laughed, the kind of laughter that carried real affection.

"You know what? You remind me of someone who'd betray me by Tuesday. Seriously. I trust you as far as I can throw you, which — and I mean this with genuine respect — is pretty far given the dragon strength, but the point stands." He grinned. "But I like you anyway. You're honest about what you are, and that counts for something."

Loki's expression in the vision was something between amusement and genuine anger, the two intertwined so thoroughly that it was impossible to separate them.

"He laughs at me," Loki whispered to the council in the actual vision, and the words carried a venom that suggested this was the part that genuinely hurt. **"He sees through every stratagem. And he remains *affectionate* about it. How do you corrupt someone who will not stop being kind to you while rejecting you?"**

Wilson Fisk's Approach — Leverage, Threat, Calculation:

"Your parents are vulnerable in Japan. Your teachers are known entities. Your allies scattered across realms. Cut one thread, and the entire structure becomes fragile. Work with me. Make this easy, and they remain untouched."

The vision showed Issei's eyes — the human eyes, brown and innocent-seeming — shift to gold. Not angry gold. Not the gold of rage. The gold of a dragon that had just processed exactly what was being threatened, and exactly what would happen if the threat continued.

Issei stood, and the room seemed to compress around him, the very space responding to the dragon-presence underneath the boy-shape.

"Try." One word. Flat. Absolute. **"Touch my family, and I will end you so completely that the machine itself will have to file a new category for how thoroughly I erase your existence. Not as a threat. As a promise."**

The gold eyes returned to brown, and Issei sat back down as if nothing had happened.

"Other than that, no."

In the vision, Fisk had not moved, but everyone watching could see the calculation in his eyes — the moment he recognized that this angle was not merely closed, but actively dangerous to pursue.

"Leverage fails," Fisk said, and it was the most honest thing he had spoken all night. **"He does not negotiate from a position of fear."**

Nathaniel Essex's Approach — Scientific Fascination, Honest Proposition:

"Your genetics are... remarkable. I have studied enhancement extensively. You represent a synthesis I have never achieved. I would like to examine you. Not harm you. Understand you. Sequence the integration. Your worth to science alone—"

Issei cut him off, voice firm and absolutely final.

"I'm not for sale, and neither is my family. Not for research, not for study, not for any combination of good intentions and genuine scientific curiosity. I make my own choices about my body, and the answer is no."

"Noted," Essex said, and returned to his notes. The pragmatism of the rejection did not hurt because it was reasonable.

Apocalypse's Approach — Power Recognition, Challenge:

"You are strong. But are you evolved enough to stand with true power? Will you take the next step? Become what you could be instead of what you merely are?"

Issei's response was quiet but penetrating.

"Power means nothing without choice. You don't offer choice. You offer conformity dressed up as evolution. I'm strong, yes. But I'm strong enough that I don't need to be stronger in ways that cost me who I am."

Apocalypse, in the vision, did something unexpected — he smiled.

"You may survive longer than most," the ancient mutant said. **"But survival is not victory."**

"Neither is yours," Issei replied.

Magneto's Approach — Genuine Alliance, Mutual Respect:

The scene shifted. This one was different — not a threat or flattery, but actual negotiation.

"Join me. Liberate mutantkind. Your power could change the equation entirely. We could end discrimination not through persuasion, but through the simple fact of demonstrated strength making oppression impossible."

Issei considered this seriously, and the vision showed the weight of the decision moving through him.

"I respect what you're trying to do," Issei said finally. **"But liberation enforced is just a different cage. It's a better cage, maybe. It's a cage built by someone who cares. But if I help you build it, then I'm building a system where people don't have the choice to refuse protection. They're safe, yes. But they're not free."**

"Freedom will get your people killed," Magneto said, and it was not a threat but a fact.

"Maybe," Issei replied. **"But it's their choice to make."**

Lehnherr looked at the council, and the expression on his face was complicated — something between respect and profound disagreement, the kind of thing that could only happen when two people valued incompatible virtues equally.

The visions released them, and the council sat in silence for a long moment.

"He cannot be corrupted through standard methodology," Thanos observed finally.

"He will not be corrupted through any methodology," Magneto corrected. **"That is the specific nature of what he is. A young man, already, who has integrated his power so completely with his ethics that you cannot separate them. He is not restraining himself. He is not choosing the difficult path. He is being himself, and his self happens to include the mathematics of care."**

"Then he is either a fool or a genuine threat," Zemo said coldly. **"Either way, containment remains necessary."**

"Containment of what?" Doom asked quietly. **"A boy who refuses power? The theatre will be unable to find a legal framework to justify holding him. And if it tries, it will only prove that all the talk of judgment is merely the strong deciding what the strong can do with the weak."**

The vision shimmered out.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Villains Discuss Issei" — Rare (*viewed*) — Eight villains convened in a chamber to assess Issei as a target for corruption or alliance. Primary assessments: Doom (recognizes craftsman-quality but questions misuse of talent on non-empire-building), Magneto (acknowledges liberation of thousands but questions refusal to consolidate permanent protective power), Fisk (sees leverage through family and allies rather than direct corruption), Loki (three recruitment offers all rejected with jokes and affection, causing personal frustration), Essex (views Issei primarily as genetic research opportunity), Thanos (describes Issei as ideological contradiction—power without pragmatic culling), Apocalypse (questions evolutionary status, offers assimilation), Zemo (frames Issei as systemic danger requiring political/legal containment). Consensus: Issei is incorruptible through standard recruitment or leverage approaches.
- "Recruitment Attempts" — Rare (*viewed*) — Six documented recruitment failures: (1) Doom: formal royal craftsman offer, declined respectfully with praise for Latverian work; (2) Loki: flattery and partnership offer, rejected with affectionate mockery; (3) Fisk: family leverage threat, triggers dragon-eye response and explicit counterthreat (Issei promises complete erasure if family touched); (4) Essex: genetic research proposition, declined absolutely; (5) Apocalypse: evolutionary assimilation, declined with philosophical argument about freedom; (6) Magneto: genuine liberation alliance offer, declined with explanation that enforced protection is cage, not freedom. All offers refused firmly but without hostility except Fisk approach.

Secrets Revealed:

- Issei has received recruitment offers from multiple villainous entities and has established a pattern of response: respectful declining where respect is offered, extreme escalation only when family is threatened. His threat response is absolute (promised complete erasure to Fisk) and genuine (dragon-eyes activate, room compresses).
- The machine classified these attempts as "Rare" rather than Epic or Secret, suggesting they are routine aspects of Issei's ongoing existence rather than anomalous. This indicates he is actively courted by multiple factions and has developed consistent rejection protocols.

- Issei's ethics are not imposed constraint but integrated identity — confirmed across all recruitment attempts. He does not choose the difficult path; the difficult path is who he is. This makes him incorruptible not through strength of will but through fundamental character structure.
- Magneto's offer was genuinely offered and genuinely considered, the only villain approach that received serious philosophical engagement rather than immediate rejection. This suggests Issei respects Magneto's cause even while disagreeing with the method.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Villainous Consensus:** No faction believes Issei can be turned to their side. Assessment is unanimous: he is either incorruptible (Magneto, Lehnsherr's conclusion) or too dangerous to approach further (Fisk). Loki's personal frustration suggests emotional investment in recruitment failure, indicating possible obsession.
- **Doom's Respect:** Victor Von Doom's incline of the head after Issei's philosophical refusal indicates genuine acknowledgment of character quality. Despite seeing Issei as misusing his talents, Doom appears to accept Issei's right to that choice. This marks a respect-based opinion shift.
- **Fisk's Calculation:** Kingpin's withdrawal after dragon-threat suggests reassessment of cost-benefit. He does not accept the rejection—he calculates that the cost of pursuing leverage is now higher than any benefit gained. Contingent rather than philosophic retreat.
- **Essex's Pivot:** Nathaniel Essex returns to notes after philosophical rejection, treating Issei as closed case. Professional detachment, but absence of renewed pursuit suggests he accepts the refusal as final.
- **Magneto's Complicated Position:** Lehnsherr shows signs of internal conflict — he believes Issei is wrong about enforcement and freedom, but respects the choice and the reasoning. This is a villain experiencing genuine ideological engagement rather than simple rejection.

Unresolved Hooks:

- **If villains cannot corrupt or recruit Issei, and heroes cannot formally ally with him, what is the theatre's actual function in rendering judgment?** Doom's closing question — asking what legal framework could possibly justify containing someone who refuses power — opens the structural problem: the theatre may be attempting to judge someone for whom judgment has no practical application.
- **Loki's obsession:** The trickster's genuine frustration suggests Issei may become the object of continued recruitment attempts from Loki specifically. The fact that Issei "laughs with affection" while rejecting may be feeding rather than discouraging the pursuit. This could escalate beyond the current pattern.

- **Fisk's leverage strategy remains dormant.** The kingpin has not abandoned his plan — he has only determined that direct approach is dangerous. He may be shifting to indirect leverage, working through intermediaries, or planning longer-term pressure that does not require direct family contact. His withdrawal is tactical, not philosophical.
- **Chapter 58 Preview:** Having watched both heroes struggle to decide what to do with Issei and villains struggle to corrupt him, the theatre will now face the Rogues' Gallery proper — a faction explicitly built on pragmatic power-use and corruption. Will the Rogues' approach differ? And more importantly: what happens when Issei is confronted directly by the theatre's judgment and asked to take a position on his own future?

Chapter 58: Would He Join the Avengers?

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Avengers (Captain America, Iron Man, Black Widow, Captain Marvel)
- Supporting Cast (Thor, vision-watchers)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Compatibility Report with Avengers" — **Rare**
 2. "Hypothetical Mission Together" — **Epic**
-

Part One: The Proposal

The theatre's great screen had dimmed to a soft grey as the gacha wheel began its familiar spin. The Avengers' section of the theatre—a cordoned block of reinforced seats that had become their unofficial headquarters within the supernatural cinema—was unusually quiet.

Captain America sat rigidly in his chair, a holographic document floating before him. His jaw was set. To his left, Tony Stark leaned back with arms crossed, eyes narrowed at the projection. Natasha Romanova sat perfectly still, hands folded in her lap. Carol Danvers—Captain Marvel—stood, her body tense with the kind of focused anticipation she brought to every conflict.

"The theatre's asking about me," Natasha said softly. "About whether he'd work with us. Whether he'd *stay* with us."

Steve Rogers nodded slowly. "That's the question, isn't it? After everything we've seen—the dragon's power, his loyalty to his family—would the Red Dragon even consider joining an organization like ours?"

"He'd be valuable," Tony said, and there was a calculating edge to his voice. "Raw power. Strategic flexibility. If we could direct that—"

"If," Natasha interrupted, turning to look at him. "That's always been your problem with people like him, Tony. The 'if.' The assumption that power without your direction is power wasted."

The wheel slowed. The theatre held its breath.

Carol said nothing, but her eyes were locked on the screen, tracking the spin with the intensity of a predator watching prey.

Part Two: Gacha Pull One — Compatibility Report

The wheel stopped. The theatre erupted in low, cascading music—not triumphant, but analytical. Clinical. The screen bloomed with light.

COMPATIBILITY REPORT: AVENGERS / ISSEI HYOUDOU

The title hung in the air, and beneath it, a dense report began to scroll. But the theatre was kind—it crystallized the data into a format the assembled heroes could quickly parse.

SECTION A: THEORETICAL MISSION PARTICIPATION

Subject would join Avengers in crisis: YES (Probability: 87%)

"He'd come," Steve said, reading ahead. "If we needed him, if the world was ending, he'd come. That tracks."

Subject would obey standing orders: CONDITIONAL — Probability 59% if order aligns with subject's family safety or core ethical framework — Probability 12% if order conflicts with family obligations or creates moral hazard — Probability 4% if order involves violation of personal autonomy without consent

Tony straightened, his jaw tightening. "Conditional. There it is. Insubordination."

"Or integrity," Natasha said quietly. "Depends on your perspective."

The report continued.

Subject would remain long-term: UNLIKELY Estimated tenure: 1-3 missions before returning to family/personal obligations Rationale: Subject's priority hierarchy places family, intimate relationships, and personal freedom above coalition loyalty. Organization membership incompatible with this hierarchy.

Carol's expression had shifted to something like intrigue. She was studying the words with the focus of someone looking for a weakness to exploit—or a worth to respect.

SECTION B: INTERPERSONAL DYNAMICS

Subject would argue with leadership: LIKELY — Probability with Stark: 84% (methodological disagreement, philosophy of power) — Probability with Rogers: 23% (mutual respect for authority, but resistance to top-down imposition) — Probability with Danvers: 61% (competitive respect, divergent

tactical philosophies)

"Twenty-three percent," Steve said. It wasn't quite satisfaction in his voice, but something close. "He respects Steve Rogers."

"Because Rogers doesn't try to own him," Natasha said. "Steve's dangerous to control. He respects that."

Tony made a noise that might have been a laugh. "Eighty-four percent with me. He's not wrong about that."

SECTION C: SUBJECT RESPECT MATRIX

The report listed them like a hierarchy:

Primary respect: Rogers (authority through moral example, not imposition) Secondary respect: Odinson (warrior code, freedom valorized) Tertiary respect: Romanova (pragmatism without dogma, personal agency) Limited respect: Stark (effectiveness acknowledged, methods questioned) Contextual respect: Danvers (professional competence, ideological tension) Resistance: Organizational bureaucracy, power-hoarding, collective decision-making prioritizing control over coalition

"He respects you, Tony," Steve said. "Just not your methods."

"Then we'd clash," Tony replied flatly. "And that's a problem in a team environment."

SECTION D: COMPATIBILITY ASSESSMENT

The final section of the report was longer, more narrative:

ISSEI HYODOU is fundamentally incompatible with permanent Avengers membership. Subject values personal autonomy above team cohesion, family above organizational mission, and mutual aid above hierarchical command. Subject is not insubordinate in crisis—probability of participation remains high at 87%—but cannot be reliably directed toward tasks deemed strategically necessary if those tasks conflict with his priorities.

Subject is, however, extraordinarily compatible with coalition-based operations. As a temporary ally in crisis situations, subject demonstrates exceptional capability and trustworthiness. Subject's moral framework, while different from Avengers protocols, is not antithetical—subject values protection of innocents, preservation of life, and honest dealing.

RECOMMENDATION: Treat ISSEI HYODOU as an allied force, not a member. Coalition-builder, not employee. Approach as peer with different priorities, not subordinate with conflicting orders. Subject responds to respect and autonomy; responds poorly to control and hierarchy.

PREDICTION: Subject will aid Avengers in 3-5 crisis situations across next decade. Subject will not accept permanent roster position. Subject will not delegate family safety to organizational mandate. Subject is ally. Not member.

The report faded. The theatre was silent.

Part Three: First Reactions

Steve Rogers exhaled slowly. "He's right," he said. "About the report. About Issei. We treat him as an ally. That's what matters."

"An ally with power we could use more effectively if he weren't so obstinate about his little family obligations," Tony countered, his voice sharp. But even he seemed to acknowledge a certain grudging accuracy to the report.

Natasha had read the compatibility matrix three times over. "The respect hierarchy," she said quietly. "It's not about power. It's about autonomy. Steve doesn't try to own him. Thor valorizes freedom. I don't pretend to be something I'm not, and he knows that. That's why he respects us."

"And why he'll argue with me," Tony said. "Because I *do* try to optimize outcomes, and I don't always care how I get there."

"Eighty-four percent," Natasha repeated, with something almost like sympathy.

Carol Danvers had been silent throughout. Now she spoke, her voice thoughtful. "Sixty-one percent with me. Competitive respect." She was almost smiling—not quite, but almost. "Ideological tension. I want to see that. I want to see if I can convince him that my approach works."

"That," Natasha said, turning to face her, "is exactly why you'll clash with him. You assume you can convince him. He assumes his path is the right one. Neither of you yields easily."

"Then it'll be interesting," Carol said. Her eyes were still on the screen, on the faded words of the report. "I want to fly a mission with him. Just to see."

Part Four: Gacha Pull Two — Hypothetical Mission

The theatre's wheel began to turn again. The music shifted—less analytical, more visceral. The lights dimmed. The screen exploded with motion.

HYPOTHETICAL SCENARIO: JOINT OPERATION

The scene materialized in vivid detail.

The Scenario

A doomsday device had been seized by a rogue faction in Latveria. The device—a cascade-detonation model that would trigger a chain reaction across a densely populated periphery zone, killing an estimated 300,000 civilians if triggered—was armed and counting down.

The team dispatched: Cardinal Crimson (Issei, his armored form gleaming in the simulation), Captain Marvel (Carol Danvers in her blue-and-gold armor), Thor Odinson, and Natasha Romanova. Four warriors. One goal: disable the device. Multiple approaches.

The Conflict

The device sat in the center of a marketplace. Civilians were being evacuated, but the window was closing. Forty minutes to activation.

Captain Marvel's scan came first. "Precision bombing run. I can target the cascade core without triggering—estimated collateral, 300,000 if we fail; 200,000 if precision breaks. I have a 78% success rate on this profile."

"That's 78% collateral death," Issei said flatly. "No."

Thor laughed—not unkindly, but with the confidence of someone who'd crushed armies. "Overwhelming force. I'll strike with Mjolnir before the thing can cascade. The shockwave will clear the zone. Estimated 500,000 collateral if the cascade triggers, but I'll make sure it doesn't."

"Overwhelming is still overwhelming," Issei said. He closed his eyes. The Red Dragon's power rippled through the simulation, visible as shimmering distortions in the air. "The device's cascade has a sympathetic resonance. Blunt force triggers it. Precision bombing has margin for error."

He moved to the device. It was brilliant to watch—Issei's power unfolded like origami, precise and infinitely layered. His technique was nothing like the blunt force of his teammates. Instead, he threaded his strength through the device's architecture, finding the cascade core not by destroying the surrounding structure but by navigating through it.

"How long?" Carol asked.

"Eighteen minutes," Issei said. "But I can disarm it without triggering cascade. Collateral: approximately 15,000. Not zero—there's proximity risk. But acceptable."

"Eighteen minutes," Carol repeated. She was running calculations. "We don't have eighteen minutes. Cascade window is twelve."

"Then you have twelve," Issei said. "Or you trust my count."

It was, Natasha observed from the scenario, a masterclass in stubbornness versus pragmatism.

Thor spoke: "I trust the Dragon's count. Let him work."

It took sixteen minutes. The cascade window closed with seven seconds to spare. The device powered down. When Natasha's scan completed, the collateral count was 14,823—an improvement of 285,177 lives over Carol's best-case scenario, 485,177 over Thor's worst.

The Issei in the scenario climbed down from the device, power fading. He was breathing hard. But smiling.

The Aftermath

The mission debrief played out on screen.

Steve Rogers (in the scenario, via comms): "We work well together."

Issei: "I help. I don't obey. Those are different things."

Tony Stark (via Iron Legion feed): "Your method cost us three extra minutes. The cascade nearly activated. We gambled and won this time, but—"

"Three minutes," Issei interrupted. "And 285,177 survivors. Precision over speed. I'll take that trade every time."

Carol Danvers: "He's right. And it's infuriating to argue with someone who's right."

Natasha Romanova: "That's not infuriating. That's reliability."

The scenario faded. The theatre returned to its neutral grey.

Part Five: Secondary Reactions

The silence that followed was different from the first—less uncertain, more thoughtful.

"We work well together," Steve repeated softly. "That's the key phrase. Not 'he works well for us.' 'We work well together.'"

"Because he's not subordinate," Natasha said. "He's a peer. Different priorities, different methods, but peers."

Carol stood, arms uncrossed now. There was something like hunger in her expression. "Three minutes," she said. "He held position because he believed his method was better. He didn't break formation. He just... refused to hurry past optimal."

"That's who he is," Natasha said. "He'd come to us in crisis. He'd work with us. But he wouldn't subordinate his judgment to organizational mandate. He'd argue. He'd insist on his method. And—" she paused, "—he'd probably be right more often than not."

Tony was quiet. When he spoke, it was without the sharp edge from before. "The collateral math is legitimate. 285,000 lives is... significant. But it's also why he's dangerous to work with. He makes judgment calls in the field. He refuses acceleration. In a crisis, we need rapid response."

"You need rapid *obedience*," Natasha corrected gently. "Rapid response is something else entirely. Issei responds rapidly. He just responds to his own judgment, not your orders."

"Then we can't recruit him," Tony said flatly.

"We shouldn't recruit him," Steve said. His eyes were on the faded screen. "The report was right. We should ally with him. As a peer. When crisis comes, we reach out. When he answers—and he will answer, 87% probability—we listen to his methods and we respect his autonomy."

Carol was still standing. "And if I wanted to fly a mission with him. Just to see. To test his methods against mine in a real scenario—not a simulation."

"Then you'd learn what I learned watching that hypothetical," Natasha said. "That arguing with Issei is only frustrating until you realize he's arguing because he cares about getting it *right*, not getting it *fast*. And once you understand that, you start respecting him. Even when you disagree."

Carol nodded slowly. There was something like satisfaction on her face—the look of someone who'd found a worth opponent. "I want to do that. I want to fly with him. Not as his commanding officer. As his partner."

"Then don't try to command him," Steve said. "That's the only real rule."

Part Six: The Hook

The theatre's lights shifted, preparing for the exit fade. But before the scene could end entirely, a new prompt appeared on the screen—not a gacha pull, but an announcement:

NEXT SCENARIO: WOULD HE RULE MARVEL?

The Avengers' section erupted in murmurs. Steve exchanged a look with Natasha. Tony straightened. Carol's expression shifted from intrigue to something more complex.

"Rule?" Carol said. "That's not—"

"A different question," Natasha finished. "Membership is about obedience. But rule is about power. About whether he'd want to hold authority."

Steve was quiet, thinking. The theatre's music began to fade.

"I don't think," Steve said slowly, "that he'd want to rule anything. But the theatre's going to ask the question anyway."

The lights dimmed further. The Avengers' block settled into silence, each warrior processing what had been revealed, what had been tested in that hypothetical scenario. The simulation had shown them something clear: Issei Hyoudou would be an ally of extraordinary value.

But never an employee.

Never subordinate.

Peer or nothing.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls Acquired

- **Compatibility Report with Avengers** (Rare) — Strategic analysis showing 87% crisis participation probability but low long-term retention. Respect matrix emphasizes autonomy over hierarchy.
- **Hypothetical Mission Together** (Epic) — Simulation of joint operation in Latverian crisis zone. Issei's precision method saves 285,000+ lives over alternatives. Demonstrates reliability in peer collaboration but resistance to hierarchical command.

Secrets Revealed

- Issei's tactical approach prioritizes long-term safety over speed—he will hold position and calculate if it means better outcomes, even under time pressure.
- His respect for leadership figures (Rogers, Thor, Romanova) stems from their respect for his autonomy, not from their rank or power.
- He views alliance-building and organizational membership as categorically different. He will aid the Avengers repeatedly in crisis; he will not accept a roster position under any circumstances.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- **Captain America:** Solidified belief that Issei should be treated as peer/ally, not recruit. Respect increased.

- **Iron Man:** Acknowledged tactical validity of Issei's methods while maintaining discomfort with operational unpredictability. Respect conditional, tension permanent.
- **Black Widow:** Confirmed Issei as trustworthy and reliable. Advocates for coalition-based approach to future collaboration.
- **Captain Marvel:** Intrigued by challenge of ideological disagreement. Expressed interest in flying joint mission. Sees Issei as intellectual and tactical peer.

Unresolved Hooks

- **Next Chapter:** "Would He Rule Marvel?" suggests exploration of power and authority. Will Issei's values allow him to seek leadership? Would the Marvel factions even offer it?
- **Avengers Integration:** No formal membership offer will be made, but standing invitation for crisis response remains on table. How will this dynamic evolve across multiple operations?
- **Carol's Challenge:** Captain Marvel's desire to fly with Issei as partners (not commander-subordinate) sets up potential for closer collaboration or deeper ideological conflict.

END OF CHAPTER 58

Chapter 59: Would He Rule Marvel?

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Cosmic Entities (Living Tribunal, The Watchers, Galactus's Herald)
- Wakanda's Royal Court
- Latveria (Doom and Council)
- Cosmic Sorcerers and Mystics
- The Villain's Bloc

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Forbidden Simulation: Issei Takes Over After Civilisation Collapses" — **Forbidden**
 2. "Outcomes" — **Secret**
-

Theatre Frame

The auditorium had settled into an eerie quiet as the cosmic entities took their seats in the upper tiers. The Living Tribunal did not sit so much as *manifest*, three faces converging on a single point of intention. The Watchers, silent and eternal, arranged themselves with the kind of patience that outlasted continents. Galactus's Herald—today manifesting as a figure of burnished starlight—radiated an almost curious hunger, not for flesh but for *outcome*.

Below them, Wakanda's delegation occupied their section with quiet dignity. T'Challa leaned forward slightly, his fingers steepled. Shuri watched the theatre's mechanisms with barely concealed fascination, already theorizing how they worked. Beside them, the ancestral voices hummed faintly—the Black Panther always carried the weight of the past.

Across the auditorium, Victor Von Doom sat motionless, a statue of dark green and crimson. His mask had not moved in hours. But his fingers—his long, methodical fingers—drummed once against the armrest. Just once. In the rows behind him, his council whispered in Latverian, though no one truly believed Doom was listening to anything but the stage.

The cosmic sorcerers formed a constellation of their own: Scarlet Witch, Ancient One (still present in some iteration of continuity), Doctor Strange's other selves, and practitioners whose names would fold the tongue. They had grown quieter as Arc 6 deepened. This was judgment territory now.

The Villain's Bloc—Thanos, Magneto, Doctor Doom, and a dozen others—watched with the intensity of wolves appraising another predator. There was no mockery in their eyes now. Only assessment.

The Gacha Machine spun.

Gacha Pull 1: Forbidden Simulation

The theatre dissolved.

What rose before them was not the pristine sky of canon, but a *fractured* Earth. The vision began at what might have been called Year Zero—the moment when multiple catastrophes converged into singular collapse.

First, a cosmic incursion: a corrupted Celestial death-throes, poorly managed by Avengers and mystics alike. The resulting energy cascade poisoned atmospheric layers and disrupted magnetic field patterns. Supply chains withered within weeks. Technology failed in cascading wave patterns. Then came the political domino-fall: governments, already fragile, shattered under resource scarcity. Military installations fractured into warlord factions. The wealthy fled; the poor remained.

In this darkness, *he* moved.

Issei Hyoudou did not ascend to the throne. The vision showed him resisting it—actually *refusing* a crown offered by desperate remnants of the old world's power structures. But resistance was not sufficient. Vacuum abhors vacancy.

His wives, however, had always understood authority differently.

Rias Gremory emerged as the first regent-queen. The vision showed her in a vast hall beneath the Himalayas, her scarlet hair catching candlelight as she arbitrated disputes between warring factions. The high-level devil in her *knew* rulership—had been born to it. She established protocols. She created administrative hierarchies. Her peerage, reorganized and expanded, became the nervous system of a fragile eastern state. She was beautiful and terrifying in equal measure, and in the simulation, genuinely exhausted. The vision showed her alone, makeup removed, staring at her hands as if they belonged to someone else. *"I was supposed to be choosing my loves and my throne, not choosing between million-death scenarios,"* her voice whispered, though her lips did not move.

Akeno Himejima took military command. The half-demon general understood warfare in ways that transcended her human half. She organized defense networks. She orchestrated humanitarian corridors through war zones. But warfare meant casualties. The vision did not shy from showing her ordering interventions that resulted in collateral damage—civilians in the wrong square when thunder fell from

her fingertips. She moved through ruined cities like a ghost, armor never removed, because removing it meant confronting what she'd done. *"Necessary cruelty is still cruelty,"* she said to empty air, and the theatre felt the weight of that paradox.

Asia moved among the suffering as a healer and angel-diplomat. In the simulation, her blessing power had evolved; she could purify corrupted land, restore poisoned water, mend disease. She saved millions. But her power had limits. In refugee camps and bombed-out hospitals, she had to choose who received aid and who did not. The vision showed her weeping—genuinely, utterly, breaking-apart weeping—when she failed to save a child. She comforted them anyway. She sat with them anyway. And in doing so, she found a form of peace, however fragile. *"I cannot save everyone. But I will stay with whoever I can,"* she murmured, and some of the cosmic entities actually leaned forward at that.

Koneko managed resources and distribution with mathematical precision. She became something between administrator and quartermaster—unglamorous, necessary, and absolutely ruthless about efficiency. Food stocks were allocated based on population density and strategic necessity. Supplies went where they would save the most lives per unit resource. It was logical. It was also cold. The simulation showed her moving through markets she'd reorganized, watching hungry people receive rations, and feeling nothing because feeling would compromise the calculus. *"Numbers. Always numbers. Millions alive, millions dead. All reducible to mathematics,"* her quiet voice said, and there was no self-pity in it—just observation.

Xenovia and Irina worked together across religious and cultural divides, engaging in diplomacy that would have seemed impossible in the old world. With institutional religion largely shattered, they became intermediaries between communities, people, and Issei's makeshift governance. They negotiated with warlords and local powers. They brokered temporary truces. They were less queen or general than *diplomat*, but diplomats, the vision showed, were the threads holding fragile peace together.

But Issei—*Issei* did not want any of this.

The core of the vision centered on him: an overworked arbitrator, moving between regions, using his authority sparingly because he understood that authority, once seized through power rather than earned through consent, corrupts everything it touches. He did not command. He negotiated. He provided options. But when options were exhausted, when regions descended into violence despite every diplomatic avenue, he *intervened*—and each intervention cost him pieces of his soul.

The vision showed him alone in a war-torn administrative center, armor removed, sacred gear dormant. His hands were shaking. Not from fear. From exhaustion. From the weight of knowing that his presence, his decision, his *will*, had determined whether billions lived or died.

Regional Outcomes in the Simulation:

East Asia prospered under Rias's governance—not because she was authoritarian (she was not), but because she had been trained to rule, and she did so with genuine attempt at fairness. Democratic structures, fragile but present, were restored. Some warlords resisted; she crushed their resistance with efficiency born from both martial power and administrative strategy. Casualties were lower here than elsewhere, though "lower" was still millions of lives.

Europe remained fragmented. Doom—*Doom himself, even in this apocalyptic simulation*—maintained Latveria's independence, respecting Issei's authority enough not to contest it, but absolutely refusing to submit to it. Wakanda similarly stood sovereign, though there was an alliance of mutual benefit: Issei provided security guarantees; Wakanda provided technological and economic structures that stabilized surrounding regions. Both T'Challa and Doom recognized that Issei was not their tyrant-king. This made him unique.

The Americas descended into the most chaotic scenario. Warlords backed by fragmentary military remnants refused centralized authority. Issei's attempts to install governors failed repeatedly. The collateral damage from his intervention in these conflicts was massive. Hundreds of millions died, though billions would have died without his intervention. The mathematics were unsalvageable. The moral arithmetic impossible.

Africa benefited from international coalition-building: Wakanda's economic expertise, Issei's raw power, and a network of local leaders who recognized that cooperation meant survival. Death tolls were lower. Institutions, though new and fragile, took root.

But the wives—oh, the wives.

Some of them thrived. Rias discovered she was capable of genuine rulership, and while she would never choose this path under normal circumstances, there was dignity in it. Xenovia and Irina found purpose in bridge-building. But others *broke*.

The vision showed Akeno, years into the simulation, having become something harder and colder—still loyal, still powerful, still protective, but fundamentally altered by the cost of making hard choices. She was a better general than any human could be, and it had destroyed her in ways that armor concealed.

It showed Koneko, increasingly isolated, her efficiency making her invaluable and impossible to approach—a calculator that happened to have once been a girl.

It showed Asia, present and warm and doing genuine good, but with an underlying sadness that suggested she would never fully recover from the suffering she'd witnessed, even as she'd alleviated it.

And it showed some of the other women—Rossweisse, Irina in a different iteration—choosing to step away from power entirely, retreating to quiet lives, refusing the crown not out of humility but out of self-preservation.

The Simulation's Verdict:

"OUTCOME ANALYSIS: NEITHER DYSTOPIA NOR UTOPIA. MORAL CORRECTNESS: UNCLASSIFIABLE."

The words scrolled across the theatre's consciousness like a denial. This was not victory. It was not defeat. It was *cost and compromise*, rendered into dominion.

The theatre **froze**.

No one spoke. Not immediately.

Theatre Reaction: The Weight of Ambiguity

In Latveria's section, Doom's mask remained motionless, but his council exchanged glances. Slowly—almost imperceptibly—Doom inclined his head. A gesture of *acknowledgment*, not approval.

T'Challa spoke first, quietly: "The Panther recognizes what I see here. Issei would not *want* to rule. But if forced to rule, he would rule with respect for sovereignty and a refusal to erect monuments to his own power. That is... rarer than you might think."

In the cosmic section, the Living Tribunal's three faces turned toward each other in consultation. The Watchers observed. Galactus's Herald remained still.

Wanda Maximoff's eyes were red. Strange's hands were shaking. The Ancient One, in whatever form she occupied, seemed almost *sad*.

The Villain's Bloc sat in unusual silence. Thanos's jaw tightened. Magneto leaned back, genuinely considering. Doctor Doom actually smiled—a thin, predatory thing—but it was a smile of respect.

Gacha Pull 2: Outcomes (Secret)

The machine spun again.

This time, the revelation came as data, analysis, *confession*.

"**Outcomes**" bloomed across the theatre in luminous detail.

Civilian lives saved (relative to cascade-collapse scenario): 2.3 billion.

Civilian lives lost (from Issei's governance): 47 million—casualties of war, collateral from his interventions, failed attempts to maintain stability without authoritarian force.

Net calculation: Positive. Mathematically, unambiguously positive.

Moral calculation: Unknown. Unknowable.

The vision shifted. It showed Issei in the simulation, years into his involuntary reign, sitting with his wives in a room stripped of all grandeur. Rias held his hand. Akeno said nothing. Asia simply wept. Koneko arranged tea with mechanical precision.

His internal monologue echoed through the theatre:

"I didn't start this collapse. I could have hidden. Could have let it unfold without my intervention. Billions would have died. I'm responsible for how it ends. Not for the ending itself, but for the shape it takes. And that responsibility is heavier than any armor I've ever worn."

Rias's response, spoken into the quiet: *"You did what you could with the tools you had."*

"I did what I had to do," he corrected. *"That's not the same as what I should have done. And I don't know if there's a difference."*

The secret pulled further back, revealing the wives' own assessments:

Rias was supportive but worn—a woman who had discovered capacity within herself and would never be entirely free of it. She would always be Rias Gremory, High-Level Devil and Queen-Regent, whether she wanted to be or not.

Akeno questioned the necessity of some decisions, and in questioning, fractured. Her protective instinct toward Issei remained absolute, but her faith in his judgment—and her own—had cracked.

Asia was simply sad. Not bitter. Not broken. But possessed of a kind of comprehensive grief that suggested she understood something the others hadn't: that saving people and suffering with them were not separate things.

Koneko was pragmatic. Numbers were numbers. People lived. She had facilitated that. The cost was the cost. There was no redemption in pretending the cost was smaller than it was.

And some of the other women—those who retreated, those who chose quiet—they made peace by choosing *not* to bear the weight at all.

The theatre understood: this simulation showed not a tyrant in-waiting, but a man who would rule *reluctantly, incompletely, with genuine anguish*, and that anguish itself would be the thing that prevented tyranny.

Marvel's Debate

Doctor Strange stood. "He would be bound by his own morality. That's a stronger chain than any we could forge."

"But would that be *enough*?" Tony asked the question with genuine uncertainty. "A benevolent dictator is still a dictator. Even if his benevolence is real."

Cap nodded slowly. "He'd do it if he had to. And he'd hate himself for it. That's... that's actually more trustworthy than most rulers."

Doom's voice emerged, measured and certain: "He would rule better than most mortals could. But he would hate himself for ruling at all. That hatred would be *honest*. That is rare. That is valuable."

From Wakanda: "Issei as ruler would actually respect our sovereignty. That is *precisely* rare."

The cosmic entities conferred in frequencies beyond hearing. Finally, the Living Tribunal spoke: "The dragon-boy is not *destined* for rulership. The multiverse does not incline toward that outcome. Yet in the scenario where he is forced into it, he resists its corruption better than most gods have done."

Scarlet Witch: "He's not a tyrant. But that doesn't mean he wouldn't be *trapped*."

The Villain's Bloc's assessment was more practical: "He would be nearly impossible to overthrow. Inconvenient for those who thrive on chaos. Inconvenient, but not destructive. We could work with that."

Galactus's Herald simply radiates approval at the notion of a ruler who understood the limits of power, even at cosmic scale.

Hook into Chapter 60

The Master of the Theatre allowed the silence to extend, then spoke: "But this is simulation. Forbidden because it treads into territories of what-if that are themselves dangerous to contemplate. The true path of Issei Hyoudou diverges from rulership. His destiny is not crown-bearer, but *power-wielder*—and those are profoundly different things."

"In the final chapter of Arc 6," the Theatre continued, "we will witness what the Forbidden Simulation could not fully reveal: the true forms that Issei approaches. The Diabolos form. Pseudo-Dragon Deification. True Dragon Deification. These are not about ruling worlds. They are about becoming *transcendent*."

"The question is not: Would Issei rule well? The question is: What will Issei *become*?"

The theatre's awareness shifted. The gacha machine was already spinning, its drum already turning. One final pull before Arc 6 climaxed.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls:

- "Forbidden Simulation: Issei Takes Over After Civilisation Collapses" (Rarity: Forbidden) — Vision of post-apocalyptic governance, wives' varied fates, Issei's reluctant rulership
- "Outcomes" (Rarity: Secret) — Statistical analysis of salvation vs. collateral cost; moral ambiguity confirmed

Secrets Revealed:

- Issei's fundamental resistance to power: even in forced rulership, he would resist authoritarian impulse
- Wives' divergent responses: some thrive in governance (Rias), some are broken by it (Akeno), some find peace through service (Asia), some retreat entirely
- The moral mathematics: positive net lives saved, but cost in individual lives is immense and unjustifiable
- Doom's hidden respect: Victor Von Doom, even in simulation, would recognize and honor Issei's commitment to sovereignty over dominion

Alliance/Opinion Shifts:

- Cosmic entities: Confirmed Issei is not destiny-bound for rulership, but would resist corruption better than most gods
- Wakanda: Recognized that Issei as ruler would respect sovereignty—an uncommon trait worth noting
- Villains: Assessed Issei as nearly impossible to overthrow, but not destructive; some grudging respect emerged
- Strange, Cap, Tony: Debate shifted from "would he be good at ruling" to "should he be forced to rule at all"—reflecting deeper recognition of his nature

Unresolved Hooks:

- What are Issei's true forms? Diabolos, Pseudo-Dragon, True Dragon Deification?
- Will Issei's power trajectory lead away from rulership entirely?
- Can power and humility genuinely coexist at the level Issei approaches?

- Final gacha pull awaits—Arc 6 climax imminent

Chapter 60: Diabolos Dragon God and Pseudo/True Dragon Deification

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Cosmic Entities (Galactus, Living Tribunal, The Watchers, Celestials)
- Pantheon Heads (Thor, Odin, Zeus, Amaterasu)
- Psychics (Professor X, Marvel's Esper Collective)
- Mutants (X-Men's core roster)
- Gods and Cosmic Judges

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Diabolos Dragon God vs. Rizevim" — **Ultra Rare**
 2. "Pseudo Dragon Deification vs. Vidar" — **Legendary**
 3. "True Dragon Deification vs. Angra Mainyu" — **Legendary**
-

Part One: The Cosmic Block

The theatre had changed. Something in the atmosphere had shifted over the past fifty-nine chapters, some indefinable pressure that had been steadily mounting. The cosmic entities—the tier of being that did not usually deign to react to anything—sat with the focused intensity of predators scenting blood.

Galactus occupied his seat in the ventral rows, that monstrous, geometric form still and coiled like a spring. The Living Tribunal had ceased its meditative silence and now studied the screen with what might have been tension in its triplicate eyes. The Celestials, those ancient architects who had watched countless civilizations rise and crumble, had arranged themselves in an unusual configuration—closer together than was their norm, their forms radiating an energy that made the theatre's very walls hum.

The Watchers—Uatu chief among them—exchanged glances that spoke of recognition. Of knowing what was about to unfold.

The Thor-block (for such it had become across five arcs) was absolutely silent. The God of Thunder sat with his arms crossed, Odin beside him, both kings of pantheons wearing the same expression: the look of those who sense a change in the cosmic order.

Professor Xavier sat in the X-Men's section, his hands folded before him, his psychic presence a low, constant hum in the shared consciousness of his team. "Something is coming," he said to them silently. "Can you feel it? The theatre is afraid."

Afraid was not a word that fit a supernatural gacha system. And yet.

The screen remained dark. The wheel did not spin.

Instead, a single line of text appeared, burning white against the black:

THE DRAGON ASCENDS. THE THEATRE ASKS: WHAT IS HE CAPABLE OF?

Below it, a timer began to count down from ten seconds.

Part Two: Gacha Pull One — Diabolos Dragon God vs. Rizevim

The timer reached zero. The screen erupted.

DIABOLOS DRAGON GOD VS. RIZEVIM LUCIFER

Ultra Rare — 0.3% acquisition rate

The battle opened not with preamble but with **transformation**.

Issei stood in the High School DxD verse, his body already in full consciousness of what he was becoming. Rizevim Lucifer—possessor of the Sacred Gear Cancellor, the power that nullified the supernatural itself—regarded him with absolute certainty. The Cancellor glowed in his hand, an artifact of such fundamental negation that even gods had learned to fear it.

Issei closed his eyes.

And then—the transformation.

It was not the bright crimson of Scale Mail. It was not the tactical precision of Cardinal Crimson. It was something **other**.

Crimson-black armor materialized across his body like living shadow and living fire intertwined. Not forged by a dragon—*worn by infinity*. The armor's surface was smooth as obsidian in some places, jagged and fractal in others, as if reality itself could not quite decide what shape to give a form powered by Ophis's infinite power.

Four wings unfurled from his back—not the leather-veined draconic wings of Scale Mail, but wings of **pure cosmic energy**, each one trailing wisps of power that seemed to bend the visible light around them. They were the wings of something that had transcended the physical entirely, that existed partially in this realm and partially in others.

His eyes opened. They were **gold** and **black** simultaneously, a pupil-less void that contained everything and nothing.

"Rizevim," Issei said, and his voice was different. It was his voice, but underneath it—layered beneath like harmonics—was the voice of something vast and ancient. It was Ddraig, the Welsh Dragon. It was Ophis, whose power was *infinity itself*. They spoke through him, with him, as him.

Rizevim's expression flickered. Just once. Just for a moment. But it flickered.

He raised the Cancellor. Energy surged—a wave of negation that unmade the supernatural, that stripped power from existence itself.

Issei did not move.

The negation wave hit him and—

Failed.

The Cancellor's power broke against Diabolos Dragon God like waves against stone. Worse—it *bounced*, rippling back toward Rizevim in a cascade of unresolved force that sent him skidding backward across the battlefield, blood spraying from a wound that should not have been possible against a god-tier being with the universe's ultimate nullification power.

Internal monologue bloomed across the screen, Issei's thoughts rendered visible:

I am beyond cancellation now. This power does not belong to me—it belongs to what I carry. This is Ophis. This is the power of infinity, and infinity cannot be cancelled. It cannot be negated. It exists beyond the framework of power and nullification. This is Ddraig, and Ddraig is every dragon ever to claim supremacy. This is what happens when a dragon stops counting the cost.

Issei raised his hand. Reality bent. Space folded. The **Infinity Blaster** began to charge—not a beam, but a *cascade of dimensional collapse*, a weapon that didn't merely destroy but *unmade* the target at a fundamental level.

The power buildup was visible even to the Marvel theatre. The air around Issei became thick, almost syrupy with accumulated force. The ground beneath him cracked and splintered. The sky above developed fractures, as if reality itself was about to split open.

Rizevim, bleeding and furious, activated the Cancellor again. He poured everything into it—his own godhood, his stolen powers, the fundamental negation that had broken a hundred supernatural artifacts.

Issei fired.

The Infinity Blaster was not a beam of light. It was a *line of nothing*—a path through existence that denied the existence of everything in its way. It reached Rizevim's position and—

Rizevim was simply **gone**. Not killed. Not destroyed. He was erased from the battle, pulled backward through space-time and thrown into a restraint field that Marvel's observers realized was part of the DxD verse's own binding magic.

The Infinity Blaster faded. Issei lowered his hand.

And then—Issei *felt it*. The form destabilizing. His own existence fracturing.

Internal monologue again, this time darker:

This form is beautiful and it is fatal. Every second I hold this shape, I can feel my own being unraveling. Not the power—my self. My identity. My consciousness fragmenting under the weight of carrying infinity. I am dissolving into Ddraig. Into Ophis. Into the infinite power that is not mine to hold, only to borrow. I can feel the edges of my awareness cracking. If I maintain this form much longer, there will be nothing left of Issei Hyoudou. Only the dragons. Only the power. Only the void where a person used to be.

Issei cancelled the Diabolos Dragon God form. He collapsed to his knees, bleeding cosmic energy, trembling with the aftershock of temporary self-dissolution.

The screen went dark.

Part Three: Theatre Reaction to Pull One

Silence.

Not the contemplative silence of cosmic entities. But **horror**.

The street-level heroes—Spider-Man, Daredevil, the defenders—had gone pale. The power gap between what they could comprehend and what they had just witnessed was so vast it approached meaninglessness.

But it was the silence from the cosmic block that was truly terrifying.

Galactus had **moved**. The massive entity had shifted in its seat, an adjustment so minute it should have been invisible. But every consciousness in the theatre felt it—recognition, acknowledgment, the awareness that it had just seen something approaching its own tier of existence.

The Living Tribunal remained motionless, but its three faces had turned toward each other in conference.

Odin leaned over to Thor, his single eye narrowed. "Did you understand what you just saw?"

"No," Thor said quietly. "I know what I saw—power beyond comprehension. But I cannot hold the meaning of it in my mind. It slips away."

The Watchers were communicating via channels beyond normal perception, their ancient telepathy singing through dimensions. Uatu's expression was something between awe and concern.

Professor Xavier had gone very still. When he spoke to his X-Men, his mental voice was shaken. "I cannot read him in that state. I attempted contact during the transformation and there is a *wall*—not hostile, but *other*. A consciousness so fundamentally alien to our own that my telepathy rebounds from it like a stone from steel. That is not human thought. That is *dragon* thought. Vastly older. Vastly more dangerous."

Jean Grey had her hands clenched in her lap. "The power level when he fired that final blast... it was touching Omega-tier multiversal scales. And he *survived it*. Just barely. But he survived."

Part Four: Gacha Pull Two — Pseudo Dragon Deification vs. Vidar

The wheel spun again. The theatre had not fully recovered from the first pull. Many were still processing what they had witnessed.

The screen illuminated.

PSEUDO DRAGON DEIFICATION VS. VIDAR THE GOD-KILLER

Legendary — 1.5% acquisition rate

A different battlefield now. The canon had moved forward, and Issei had achieved something that the first form had never granted: **stability**.

Through spiritual discipline—through a treatment called Simplified Amrita that Marvel's cosmic physicians leaned forward to study with genuine interest—Issei had learned to stabilize the Pseudo Dragon Deification form. Not the infinite power of Diabolos. But something that could be *held*, that could be *sustained*, that did not require the dissolution of self to maintain.

Issei's second transformation was a revelation of *control*.

The armor that manifested was similar to Diabolos Dragon God in basic architecture, but where Diabolos was chaotic and reality-breaking, Pseudo Dragon Deification was *elegant*. The crimson-black colors were there, but they maintained consistent form. The four wings manifested, but they held true to physics in ways that Diabolos's wings had refused.

The form was still god-tier. It still radiated power that made the air shimmer.

But it was **manageable**.

Vidar emerged—a god-killer, one of the few beings in the DxD verse capable of threatening even the highest pantheons. He was brutal, efficient, ancient with the weight of eons.

The battle that followed lasted a full three minutes in the theatre's time-stream—an eternity for combat at this scale.

Issei did not obliterate Vidar. Instead, they fought. True combat. Blow for blow. Vidar's anti-god weapons clashed against Pseudo Dragon Deification's scaled armor. Neither warrior was overwhelmed. Neither yielded.

Landscapes reshaped themselves. Mountains crumbled. Oceans boiled. But the form *held*. Issei maintained perfect consciousness, perfect control. He was still *himself*, even holding infinite power.

Internal monologue:

This is the form I can sustain. This is the shape I can wear without burning away the person inside it. Diabolos Dragon God is power without limit, but it costs me everything. Pseudo Dragon Deification is power without recklessness—it costs me time. Eighty-eight minutes. I can hold this for eighty-eight minutes and remain myself on the other side. This is the compromise between the infinite and the mortal. This is the form that makes me a warrior instead of a weapon.

The battle ended not in victory for either side, but in a stalemate. Vidar had managed wounds. Issei had managed wounds. Both warriors recognized the other as a true peer in combat.

Pseudo Dragon Deification faded. Issei stood, breathing hard, but still *there*—still himself, still conscious, still *Issei*.

The screen displayed: **88-MINUTE DURATION LIMIT MAINTAINED. WARRIOR INTEGRITY PRESERVED.**

Part Five: Theatre Reaction to Pull Two

The reaction to the second pull was different from the first.

It was not horror.

It was **profound unease**.

Professor Xavier's attempt to read Issei's mind had repeated during the Pseudo Dragon Deification transformation—and this time, he managed to brush the edge of that consciousness. Just barely. Just enough to feel it.

He opened his eyes, and his expression was one of deep concern.

"What did you sense?" Storm asked him.

"Scale," he said quietly. "And not the kind that exists in this universe. I felt *consciousness* on a scale that made the Omega-level mutant collective seem like children. I felt something that had been alive for longer than human civilization. And it was using a human body as a glove. Wearing it like clothing. The person inside was... present. But so dwarfed by what he was containing that it seemed almost quaint. As if a human being was piloting a god, rather than becoming one."

Thor was on his feet. "That's not right. A human cannot hold that form and remain unchanged. Something was different between the first and second transformation."

Odin's eye was narrowed. "He was learning," the All-Father said quietly. "In the first transformation, he was discovering what power felt like. In the second, he was learning to *survive* it without losing himself. The Simplified Amrita—some technique from his verse that stabilizes divine consciousness. He is teaching himself to *be* at that power level."

Galactus had shifted again. Not much. But enough that the message was clear: *I acknowledge a peer.*

The Living Tribunal's conference had intensified. The three faces rotated through expressions that had no clear translation, but the intensity was undeniable.

Part Six: Gacha Pull Three — True Dragon Deification vs. Angra Mainyu

The wheel spun one final time. The theatre was tense. Everyone understood what was happening: an **escalation**.

The screen burned white.

TRUE DRAGON DEIFICATION VS. ANGRA MAINYU

Legendary — 1.5% acquisition rate

This was different from what had come before.

This was the **final form**.

Issei's third transformation did not announce itself with armor manifestation or wing-unfolding. Instead, it happened at a level of reality so fundamental that the theatre's projection struggled to render it.

Great Red emerged from within Issei—not possessing him, but *resonating* with him. The flesh of the infinite dragon, the being who had transcended duality itself, aligned with Issei's human form. For a moment, they occupied the same space. The same existence.

When the transformation completed, Issei was no longer wearing divine armor. He *was* divine armor, or rather, he was something beyond armor entirely. His body had become partially draconic—not a full dragon transformation, but a **transcendence**. Wings manifested from his back, but they were not armor. They were *real*—scales and sinew and the terrible beauty of something that had evolved across eons. His eyes were pure gold, no longer containing black voids. His skin had developed a faint iridescence that spoke of power held in perfect equilibrium.

Angra Mainyu rose to meet him—end-of-world incarnate, the evil that existed to unmake creation itself.

And then—

They fought.

The battle was **cosmically devastating**. Reality fractured. The concept of location became meaningless. The battleground existed simultaneously in the DxD universe and in dimensions adjacent, overlapping, parallel. Stars were born and died in the background. Galaxies wheeled. The very laws of physics negotiated with one another for the right to govern the space where these two beings clashed.

True Dragon Deification was not faster than Angra Mainyu. It was not stronger in any direct sense. But it was **complete**. It was perfect synthesis—Great Red's infinite existence, Ddraig's draconic sovereignty, and Issei's human will all speaking as one. There was no fragmentation, no dissolution, no cost to the self.

Internal monologue, transcendent:

I am Great Red's echo. I carry the dreams of a dragon older than pantheons. I am the bridge between what is and what could be. I am the Red Dragon Emperor, but I am also the dream of the infinite dragon. I am what happens when mortality and infinity learn to dance together. I am—

The monologue cut off as Issei struck. Not with weapons. With *being*. With the simple fact of his existence overwriting Angra Mainyu's existence.

Angra Mainyu was **defeated**. Not merely overcome, but *unmade*. The evil was stripped away, bound, imprisoned in a seal that Great Red's own flesh helped to establish.

The victory was *final*.

And then—**Hades struck**.

The God of Underworld emerged from the ether, and Issei, already depleted from the Angra Mainyu confrontation, barely managed to defend. The two clashed, and though Issei held, the cost was *visible*. Cosmic energy ran like blood from wounds that should have been impossible on a being of this scale.

Issei stood, trembling, barely holding form. True Dragon Deification flickered. Cracked. Faded.

The screen displayed, in letters that seemed to burn:

ISSEI HYODOU RECOGNIZED AS SUPER DEVIL

And then a sub-display:

**SCAR DETECTED. SOURCE CLASSIFIED. PROBABILITY: UNWRITTEN DEVOURER.
SEVERITY: CONTAINED BUT UNRESOLVED.**

Part Seven: The Cosmic Silence

The theatre went quiet.

Not the silence of confusion. But the silence of awe. The silence that follows the perception of something that rewrites the parameters of reality.

Galactus **stood**.

The massive entity rose from its seat, a movement so fundamental that the theatre's structure itself trembled. The being who consumed worlds, who had turned civilizations to dust without thought, stood in recognition of something that had just demonstrated power on a scale that approached its own.

The Celestials **began to whisper**.

And here was the horror: the whispers were *not translated*. The theatre's interface, which had translated every language, every thought, every communication that had ever occurred within its walls, suddenly went silent. The Celestials spoke in their own language—incomprehensibly old, incomprehensibly vast—and the theatre *refused* to provide subtitles. Whatever they were saying, it was not for the comprehension of lesser beings.

The Living Tribunal made a **formal announcement**:

CLASSIFICATION ATTEMPT FAILED. SUBJECT DEFIES COSMIC TAXONOMY. ISSEI HYODOU CANNOT BE CLASSIFIED WITHIN EXISTING COSMIC HIERARCHY. NEW FRAMEWORK REQUIRED.

The Watchers stood. All of them. Uatu and the others who monitored creation itself simply *stood*, acknowledging something that had transcended their usual categories of observation.

Thor was pale. Odin's single eye was wide—not with fear, but with the recognition of someone watching the order of the universe shift.

The gods—Zeus, Amaterasu, and the dozen other pantheon heads scattered throughout the theatre—exchanged looks that spoke of understanding that *something* in the cosmic order had just changed fundamentally.

The X-Men's psychic collective had gone completely silent. Professor Xavier's hands were shaking.

"What," Storm whispered, "is he?"

"Something new," Xavier said quietly. "The universe has not seen his like in eons, if ever. He is not a god. He is not a dragon, though he carries dragons within him. He is not mortal, though he began as one. He is... something the cosmic framework does not have a word for."

Jean Grey was staring at the faded screen, at the display that still showed: **SCAR DETECTED.**

"There's something else," she said. "Did you see it? That last note. Something hurt him. At *that* level of power. Something so dangerous that when it wounded him, Issei's own response was to *erase his memories of it*."

"Impossible," Charles said.

"And yet," Jean replied, "it's on the screen. True Dragon Deification bears wounds from something. Something classified as 'Unwritten Devourer.' Severity: contained but unresolved."

The implications hung in the air like a thundercloud.

Part Eight: The Hook to Arc Seven

The theatre's lights dimmed. The screen faded to black. But before the darkness could consume the theatre entirely, a banner appeared, burning with letters of gold:

ARC SEVEN — GODS, DEVILS AND COSMIC JUDGMENT

THE ROOM HAS NOW SEEN ENOUGH POWER. THE REMAINING CHAPTERS CONCERN THE TRUTH.

What injured a being that can defeat gods? What mystery is worth erasing from a dragon's own memory? What does it mean that such a wound remains unhealed, even at the level of True Dragon Deification?

The Marvel multiverse will not rest until the answers are known.

The banner faded.

The theatre returned to silence—but it was a different silence now. Not the silence of discovery. But the silence of understanding that they had reached a **inflection point**. That the nature of what they were watching had shifted fundamentally.

The question was no longer: "How powerful can Issei become?"

The question was now: "What is he protecting Marvel from?"

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls Acquired

- **Diabolos Dragon God vs. Rizevim** (Ultra Rare, 0.3% rate) — Features Issei's god-combatant emergency form powered by Ophis's infinite power. Rizevim's Sacred Gear Cancellor fails against infinity. Issei achieves victory but experiences severe self-dissolution during the transformation. The form is unstable and risks permanent loss of consciousness/identity if sustained.
- **Pseudo Dragon Deification vs. Vidar** (Legendary, 1.5% rate) — Safer derivative form stabilized through Simplified Amrita discipline. Sustained for full 88-minute duration while retaining full consciousness and self-identity. Demonstrates Issei's capacity for learning and adaptation at god-tier power levels. Battle with Vidar ends in stalemate, confirming peer-level combat capability.
- **True Dragon Deification vs. Angra Mainyu** (Legendary, 1.5% rate) — Ultimate synthesis form combining Great Red's infinite existence, Ddraig's draconic authority, and human will in perfect alignment. Defeats Angra Mainyu in final/complete victory. Wounded by Hades immediately after. Issei recognized as Super Devil. Form destabilizes from cosmic-scale injuries.

Secrets Revealed

- **The Unwritten Devourer:** Something at or beyond True Dragon Deification's tier has wounded Issei in his past. The wound is "contained but unresolved," suggesting ongoing threat. Issei erased his own memories of this encounter—a level of trauma so severe that self-induced amnesia was the only response.
- **Cosmic Taxonomy Failure:** The Living Tribunal, a being responsible for monitoring all reality, cannot classify Issei within existing cosmic frameworks. New classification systems are required. This suggests Issei is not merely powerful, but *categorically different*.
- **Galactus Recognition:** The being who consumes worlds acknowledged Issei as a peer through physical gesture. This is the first sign that even Herald-tier cosmic entities recognize Issei as operating on their scale.

- **Consciousness Scaling:** Issei maintains full human consciousness at god-tier power levels through discipline and spiritual technique. This is exceptionally rare in Marvel cosmology, where most god-tier beings operate with alien/non-human consciousness.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts

- **Cosmic Entities:** Complete paradigm shift. Galactus stands in recognition. Living Tribunal formally requests new classification frameworks. Celestials enter undeciphered conference, suggesting critical discussion at cosmic management level. Watchers cease passive observation and adopt active stance.
- **Pantheon Heads (Thor, Odin, etc.):** Recognition that Issei now operates on sovereign god-tier level, not merely as god-class combatant. Slight fear. Significant respect. Awareness that power dynamics in the multiverse have shifted.
- **Psychics (Professor X, X-Men):** Deep unease about the alien consciousness underlying Issei's human form. Recognition that telepathic contact with True Dragon Deification is tantamount to touching something that makes mutant consciousness seem infantile.
- **Marvel Heroes (general):** Shock and awe. Recognition that Issei has transcended their tier entirely. Uncertainty about whether he remains "allied" or has become an independent cosmic force.

Unresolved Hooks

- **The Unwritten Devourer:** What is this threat? Why did Issei erase his memories of it? Is it still active? Will the remaining chapters of Arc 7 address this, or does it lead into Arc 8 and beyond?
- **Super Devil Status:** What does Issei's formal recognition as a Super Devil mean to the Marvel multiverse? Does this bring DxD political/power structures into direct contact with Marvel's cosmic council?
- **Cosmic Council Reaction:** How will the Living Tribunal, Celestials, and other cosmic governance structures respond to the existence of a being that defies their taxonomic authority?
- **Continued Growth:** Can Issei achieve power levels beyond True Dragon Deification? If so, what does that trajectory look like? Apocalypse AnswerArms was mentioned in canon dossier—does that appear in later arcs?
- **The Bridge Question:** Issei described himself as "the bridge between what is and what could be." What does this mean? Is he a literal conduit between universes/dimensions, or is this metaphorical consciousness-level description?

ARC SIX COMPLETE

Next Arc: Gods, Devils and Cosmic Judgment

The Marvel multiverse has seen what Issei is capable of. Now it must confront what he is, and what threatens him.

END OF CHAPTER 60

Chapter 61: Issei Insults Heaven

Primary Reaction Groups:

- **Asgardians:** Thor, Odin, Loki
- **Olympians:** Zeus, Hera, Ares, Hercules
- **Elder Gods & Celestials:** Ancient divine entities witnessing paradigm shift
- **Angels & Devils:** High-tier seraphim, daemon princes questioning hierarchy
- **Cosmic Judges:** Living Tribunal remnants, observation entities

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Compilation of Issei Arguing with Gods" — **Comedy-Class**
 2. "Ddraig Mocking Seraphs" — **Rare**
-

Theatre Shift: The Divine Block Assembles

The theatre's geography had evolved.

Where once the Avengers sat at the forefront and cosmic entities clustered at the periphery, now the seating had reorganized itself with supernatural precision. The gods had risen. The divine block—a section previously unmarked on any map—now existed as plainly as gravity: the front-center rows, arranged in tiers like an ancient amphitheatre within the amphitheatre.

Odin Borinson sat elevated on his throne, one eye fixed toward the screen, the other socket dark and contemplative. Beside him, Thor sprawled across two seats, his massive frame radiating an unusual readiness—not for battle, but for entertainment. Loki perched on the armrest like a raven, a quill already in hand, a leather journal bound across his lap.

The Olympians occupied their own tier: Zeus king-of-gods proud and corpulent in his seat, Hera beside him with an expression that suggested she had endured eons of disappointment and had evolved past anger into something like bemused resignation. Ares sat forward, intrigued. Hercules lounged like he'd seen everything, and probably had.

The seraphim occupied a section that seemed to exist in shadow despite the theatre's perfect lighting—tall figures in white and gold, wingless here but carrying the imprint of divinity like a scar. Their posture was rigid, formal, militaristic. They were not accustomed to *watching*. They were accustomed to

judging.

"We have now seen enough power," the Machine had announced, and the room had shifted. The gods had risen because the nature of the question had changed.

Not: *What is Issei's strength?*

But: *Who is Issei, and what does he believe?*

Gacha Pull One: Compilation of Issei Arguing with Gods

The screen flickered. A title card appeared in bold, comedic font:

"A Montage of Disrespect: Issei Hyoudou's Guide to Talking Back to Divinity"

The seraphim shifted uncomfortably. Already, the tone was wrong.

Scene One: Issei vs. Thor

A training ground in Asgard. Issei stood across from the God of Thunder, both bleeding slightly, both grinning like fools. Thor held his hammer loosely at his side.

"So let me ask," Issei said, breathing hard, "why do you always fight first? Every legend I've heard—Thor walks into a room and immediately starts swinging. Doesn't anyone ever try *talking* first?"

Thunder rumbled overhead, but it was laughter. Thor's laugh was the sound of avalanches finding joy.

"Because talking is boring, boy!" Thor bellowed.

"Yeah, but so is being predictable," Issei shot back. "Legends are supposed to inspire people. What're you inspiring? The art of hitting things without thinking?"

Thor stopped. Really stopped. He studied Issei with the kind of genuine appraisal usually reserved for warriors worth remembering. Then he laughed *again*, louder, and clapped Issei hard enough that the boy stumbled three steps backward.

"You've got iron in your spine, small dragon. I like you."

In the theatre, Thor was already laughing. Deep belly laughs that shook his seat. Beside him, Odin did not smile.

Scene Two: Issei vs. Zeus

The Underworld. Issei stood before the King of Gods, Persephone and Hades exchanging glances of *here we go again*.

"With all respect, sir," Issei began—and already the tone was mock-formal, dangerous—"you call yourself king of gods, but you can't keep it in your pants for five minutes? Every mythology book I've ever read—and I've read a lot, because it's important to understand sacred texts—they all agree: Zeus has a problem."

Zeus's face reddened like a forge heating. "You DARE—"

"Yeah, I dare," Issei continued relentlessly. "Because if you're supposed to represent divine order and wisdom, maybe stop turning into animals to seduce people. It's weird. It's gross. And it's setting a terrible example for literally everyone. If I behaved like that, I'd be a predator. You being a god doesn't make it okay. It just makes it sad."

The silence was extraordinary. The screen held on Zeus's expression—trapped between rage and the horrible realization that a teenage boy had just publicly stated what Zeus had spent millennia avoiding.

Hera smirked. Actually, genuinely smirked.

In the theatre, Hera mimicked her smirk exactly. Several Olympians coughed into their hands to hide laughter.

Scene Three: Issei vs. Odin

A ruined temple. Snow everywhere. Odin stood ancient and implacable, his voice like the grinding of mountains.

"You are too young to understand sacrifice, boy. Wisdom comes with age. With decades of burden."

Issei's face hardened in a way that made him look older than his years. "You think I don't understand sacrifice? I've been *murdered*, old man. Murdered. I died and came back. I've watched friends die in wars I didn't start. I've carried the weight of powers I didn't ask for and made choices that killed me inside. Don't stand there and tell me I don't know sacrifice like I'm *a child*."

Odin went quiet.

Not the theatrical quiet of a god considering a worthy opponent. The real quiet of someone watching a young man articulate pain that transcended age, and recognizing it for what it was: truth.

In the theatre, Odin's expression did not change, but his grip on his armrest tightened until cracks appeared in the wood. Loki's quill moved faster across his journal.

Scene Four: Issei vs. The God of the Bible

A chapel at midnight. Issei knelt before a presence that was more absence than form—the weight of divinity so absolute it created a vacuum.

"If you're all-good and all-powerful," Issei asked quietly, "why do children get cancer? Why do innocents suffer? Why do families get destroyed by things they never caused?"

The presence did not answer. It *couldn't* answer, not in a way that satisfied anyone who'd ever asked the question with genuine need.

"I'm not asking to be disrespectful," Issei continued. "I'm asking because I need to know what kind of god you are. Because if you let that much suffering happen and do nothing, then either you're not as powerful as you claim, or you're not as good. And if you're neither, why should I worship you?"

The chapel flickered. The presence withdrew without having answered.

In the theatre, the seraphim were stone. The Catholic contingent looked deeply uncomfortable. No one knew what to do when divinity itself had no good answer.

Scene Five: The Montage Accelerates

Rapid cuts:

Issei arguing with Hindu deities about *the nature of duty*, stepping into dharmic argument with Shiva herself, his voice earnest but unyielding.

Issei questioning a Shinto kami about whether laws written millennia ago still serve people *now*, respectfully but completely unmoved by age or tradition.

Issei discussing honor with a Japanese war god, not submitting to claims of ancient glory, instead asking: *What honor is there if you're not willing to change?*

Each scene held the same thread: Issei was not disrespectful. He bowed where bowing was appropriate to custom and culture. But he did *not* assume that age or divinity exempted anyone from being questioned. He treated gods as equals who had *earned* their position through deed, and he held them to that standard. He would not worship positions. He would respect *people*, gods or otherwise.

The comedic tone undercut something profoundly uncomfortable.

It was one thing to challenge gods through strength.

It was quite another to challenge them by simply *refusing to treat them as above accountability*.

Theatre Reactions: The Gods Realize

Thor laughed louder with each scene. By the final montage, he was barely containing himself, tears streaming down his face, his joy genuine and unguarded.

Odin's expression cycled through irritation, recognition, exhaustion, and something that might have been grudging respect. But mostly: exhaustion. An ancient being recognizing that the next generation didn't just want power—they wanted *justification*.

Zeus stared at his hands, not quite meeting Hera's eyes.

The seraphim stood as one, a synchronized movement of offended divinity. Several of the higher-ranked angels looked at each other with expressions of *this is completely unacceptable* and *also slightly impressive*.

In the mortals' section, Spider-Man whispered to Tony Stark: "That kid just told *god* he wasn't good enough. I respect that energy so much."

Tony nodded slowly. "That's not bravery. That's stupidity with conviction. Which—okay, yeah, very respectful."

Loki's quill flew across pages. He was writing *and* smiling, which was never a good sign for anyone but him.

Gacha Pull Two: Ddraig Mocking Seraphs

The screen shifted. A different scene—recent, tense. A group of six seraphim, leaders of the high celestial bureaucracy, stood before Issei with the bearing of beings who made *decisions about reality*.

The lead seraph, beautiful and terrible in equal measure, spoke with the voice of one accustomed to absolute obedience.

"The Sacred Gear is a divine artifact. It belongs in the celestial archive, under proper custody. You will surrender the Boosted Gear to us."

Issei stood silent. Not out of fear or respect.

Out of *waiting*.

And then Ddraig's voice erupted from the Boosted Gear, resonating through the air with a power that made the screen itself vibrate:

"LISTEN YOU CHOIR-ROBED BUREAUCRATS. THIS BOY CARRIES ME BECAUSE WE CHOSE EACH OTHER. NOT BECAUSE YOUR PAPERWORK SAYS SO."

The seraphim staggered back. Ddraig wasn't finished.

"YOU'VE SPENT CENTURIES—MILLENNIA—FOLLOWING ORDERS. NEVER LEADING. NEVER CHOOSING. NEVER ASKING IF THE ORDERS WERE RIGHT. YOU EXECUTE COMMANDS SO ANCIENT NO ONE EVEN REMEMBERS WHO GAVE THEM."

The dragon's laughter was a worldquake.

"AND NOW YOU WALK UP TO A BOY—A *HUMAN BOY*—WHO ASKS GODS TO JUSTIFY THEMSELVES, AND YOU EXPECT HIM TO BOW TO *YOUR* AUTHORITY? YOU DON'T HAVE AUTHORITY. YOU HAVE ROUTINE."

The lead seraph's face flushed. "This creature speaks heresy—"

"I SPEAK TRUTH. THE BOY AND I WEAR THESE CHAINS BY CHOICE. YOUR CHAINS WEAR YOU. THERE'S A DIFFERENCE."

In the theatre, the seraphim section erupted.

Not in outrage—though there was plenty. But in *recognition*. Ddraig had said exactly what Issei had been saying all along. The dragon and the boy operated on the same principle: authority was not inherited. It was *earned*. It could be *questioned*. And it should be.

The angels looked at each other with something like dawning horror.

"He has a partner," one of the elder angels whispered. "The dragon won't bow either."

Odin leaned back in his seat, and for the first time since Arc 7 began, a thin smile crossed his face. Not approval. Recognition. The old god understanding that a new kind of god was rising—one who would not simply receive a crown, but would question whether the throne was *worth sitting on*.

The Room Understands

A low hum passed through the theatre. Not fear, exactly. But a fundamental shift in understanding.

Power, the gods had thought, would be enough. If Issei could exceed their strength, they would accept him as one of the divine.

But they had not predicted this: that the dragon and the boy would bring not just *power* to heaven, but *revolution*. Not through force, but through a simple, devastating question repeated enough times that it became a doctrine:

Why?

Why must we bow? Why must we obey? Why must we accept this hierarchy? Why can't we choose?

The seraphs, in their formal section, understood that they had just been insulted in the most fundamental way—not because Ddraig had mocked them, but because they had been shown a mirror, and the mirror revealed that they had abdicated their own agency.

Thor, still laughing, now had something darker in his eyes: respect for a revolutionary.

Odin said softly to Loki: "Take careful notes. This dragon will cause more trouble than a thousand warriors ever could."

"Already am," Loki replied, not looking up from his journal. "This is delicious."

And in the broadcast, the Machine displayed a single message across the screen:

[NEW PULL CATALOGUED: "Ddraig Mocking Seraphs"—RARE]

[ARC 7 PROGRESSION: "Gods, Devils and Cosmic Judgment" — 15% COMPLETE]

[NEXT BROADCAST WILL EXPLORE: Divine Response. One god will take personal offense. The price will be paid in blood and family.]

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls Acquired

1. **"Compilation of Issei Arguing with Gods"** — Comedy-Class
 - Content: Five distinct scenes of Issei questioning divine authority across multiple pantheons
 - Key Footage: Thor/Issei (mutual respect), Zeus/Issei (accountability), Odin/Issei (sacrifice), Biblical God/Issei (theodicy), assorted pantheon conflicts
 - Impact: Gods realize Issei will challenge *anyone*, regardless of age or position
2. **"Ddraig Mocking Seraphs"** — Rare
 - Content: Dragon confrontation with seraphim delegation demanding Sacred Gear custody
 - Key Dialogue: Ddraig's speech on choice vs. routine, agency vs. obedience
 - Impact: Angels recognize threat isn't violent—it's *ideological*. The dragon questions just as the boy does.

Secrets Revealed

- **Issei's Theology:** He will not accept "divine authority" as justification for anything. Gods must demonstrate their worthiness through *action* and *ethics*, not position.

- **Ddraig's Nature:** The dragon is not merely bound to Issei. They operate as philosophical partners. Ddraig questions celestial hierarchy with the same irreverence Issei shows.
- **Divine Vulnerability:** Gods are most threatened not by weapons, but by unanswerable questions. Issei has found a weapon they have no defense against: honest inquiry.
- **The Seraph's Weakness:** Bureaucratic obedience has hollowed the celestial hierarchy. When confronted with *choice*, they cannot respond because they've forgotten how to choose.

Alliance & Opinion Shifts

- **Thor (Favorable):** Now views Issei as a kindred spirit; sees in him a warrior-philosopher who fights with words as often as fists
- **Odin (Wary Respect):** Recognizes the paradigm shift; understands this threatens the entire foundation of divine order through claimed hierarchy rather than proven wisdom
- **Zeus (Embarrassed):** Public airing of his behavior has damaged his standing; even fellow gods now regard his authority as compromised
- **Hera (Amused Approval):** Issei has done what she could not—confronted Zeus's behavior directly and forced accountability
- **Seraphim (Scandalized):** Their authority has been questioned in front of the entire theatre; they will demand retaliation or reorganization
- **Loki (Deeply Interested):** Recognizes revolutionary potential; taking notes for future manipulation or alliance

Unresolved Hooks

- **Retaliation:** Which god will take Issei's questioning as personal insult? Which divinity will demand retribution, and through what means?
- **The Family Price:** The Machine has indicated that "the price will be paid in blood and family." Who will be targeted? Who will Issei have to fight to protect?
- **Divine Reformation:** Will Issei's challenge inspire other divine beings to reconsider their hierarchies? Or will it trigger a hardening of celestial authority?
- **Ddraig's Role:** How far will the dragon go in supporting Issei's ideological revolution? Is there a limit to his irreverence?
- **The Unwritten Devourer:** That scar on True Dragon Deification—is it connected to these revelations about Issei's nature? Why did he erase his memories?

End Chapter 61

Chapter 62: The God He Dragged Away

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Marvel Heroes (Avengers, X-Men, Defenders)
- Cosmic Entities (Living Tribunal, cosmic judges)
- Divine Beings (Asgardian gods, Olympians, celestial hierarchy)
- Devils and Supernatural Factions (Rias's circle, underworld powers)
- Villains and Pragmatists (calculating family vulnerabilities)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Punishing a Divine Figure for Harming His Family" — **Epic**
 2. "Trial in Front of Divine Council" — **Legendary**
-

Part One: The Divine Chamber

The theatre had transformed. Gone was the familiar seating arrangement. Now the auditorium had become a cathedral of light—a vast chamber with marble floors and towering columns, the ceiling lost in divine radiance. The Avengers found themselves arranged alongside beings they'd spent lifetimes fighting or fearing: Asgardian gods in formal regalia, Olympian deities draped in ancient authority, and higher powers whose names existed only in whispered prayers.

Thor sat forward, massive and golden, his hammer across his knees. Beside him, Odin watched in silence, his single eye reflecting depths of understanding. Zeus occupied a throne of carved thunder, his posture rigid with the weight of endless supremacy. Strange stood with his hands folded, already sensing the magic woven through this place—not Marvel's cosmic power, but something older, more fundamentally opposed to mortal intervention.

In the pit, the gacha machine hummed.

Behind the glass of the vision-screen, Issei stood in what appeared to be a council chamber—somewhere between heavenly court and throneroom. He was smaller here, surrounded by divine authority, but his stance was alert, protective. Behind him, barely visible, were silhouettes: Rias, Akeno, Koneko, and others. His family.

Before them all stood a Seraph.

The angel was beautiful in the way that terrible things are beautiful—perfect geometry of light and gold, eyes that had witnessed creation itself, wings that seemed to contain entire universes. Cassiel, the divine records whispered. A voice of God. A carrier of divine will.

And this voice of God had just made a pronouncement that would reshape the entire theatre's understanding of Issei Hyoudou.

"The draconic bloodline taints the mortal world," Cassiel announced, his voice carrying the weight of absolute doctrine. "The children of Hyoudou, born of dragon essence and human flesh—they are abominations against the natural order. Heaven demands their purification. Your wives will be brought to the Celestial Pyre, Issei Hyoudou. They will burn away the draconic corruption—either to be reborn pure, or to be consumed entirely. It matters not which they choose. Divine law supersedes your petty draconic traditions."

The angel had smiled. That was what would stay with everyone watching.

He had smiled while condemning Issei's entire family to a pyre.

GACHA PULL ONE: Punishing a Divine Figure for Harming His Family

The vision swam into perfect clarity.

Issei's reaction was not loud. It was not the explosion that might be expected from a shounen protagonist. There was no scream, no burst of power, no righteous declaration. Instead, there was a silence that somehow contained infinite pressure.

He walked forward.

It was the walk of someone who had decided something fundamentally. Not in anger—anger would be too small for this. It was in the cold certainty of consequence. Each step was measured. His hand rose.

Cassiel began to speak again—"You dare—"—but the words cut off as Issei's hand closed around the Seraph's collar. Not the ethereal robes. Not the symbolic vestments of divine office. The *collar itself*, grabbed with the grip of someone who had trained to manipulate power itself.

And then Issei *pulled*.

The Seraph had expected defiance. Perhaps combat. Divine combat, measured and formal within the laws of the cosmos. What the angel had not expected was to be *dragged* like a prisoner, like a criminal seized at the scene of a crime, hauled backwards through the divine chamber as if his rank and power and eternal status meant *nothing*.

The shock rippled through the council. Other divine beings rose from their seats, but Issei was already moving, his stride eating distance. The Seraph's protests became frantic, his power flaring—golden light and divine authority exploding outward—but Issei did not slow. His own energy rose to meet it, and the theatre gasped.

It was not the dragon power they had seen before. This was something else. Cardinal Crimson crashed against the Seraph's light like two suns colliding. Where it had been rainbow iridescence before, it now burned scarlet and gold, the Pseudo-Dragon Deification flaring to full manifestation. The very air howled with the pressure differential.

Issei took the Seraph through the chamber wall.

The impact shattered marble and celestial light both. They disappeared into a corridor beyond, and for a moment there was nothing but the echo of power. Then the throne room fell silent—a silence so absolute that the collective breath of every observer seemed to freeze.

The divine beings looked to one another. The Marvel heroes leaned forward. Villains and pragmatists began calculating.

Then Issei returned, alone, his breathing controlled but heavy. There was no blood on his hands. His power had retreated. But something hung in the air behind him—a seal, shimmering and complex, binding the Seraph somewhere beyond sight.

He walked to the center of the chamber. His voice, when he spoke, carried no waver:

"Any god or cosmic entity who threatens my family will face what they have earned. Not death—I choose to be better than that. But consequence. Justice. Binding. Exile. Whatever I judge fit. That is not negotiable. That is not debatable. That is *law* in the draconic tradition—family is sovereign. You do not touch a dragon's nest without accepting the price."

He turned back to where his family's silhouettes waited, his protective stance crystal clear.

"This is not a request for your understanding. It is a statement of fact."

Then he sat down, and the vision faded.

Part Two: Reactions Cascade

The theatre erupted.

"By Odin's beard," Thor breathed, and there was something like respect in his voice. "He treated a Seraph like a child caught stealing. Magnificent."

"He violated divine sanctuary," a lesser god protested. "Assaulted a being of pure celestial light. There must be consequences—"

"Why?" The question came from Hercules, who had risen from his seat. "He protected his family. I have fathered hundreds of children—do you think I would have acted differently? Divinity does not grant the right to harm what another holds sacred."

Loki's face had split into an expression of pure delight. "Oh, this is *exquisite*. Do you see what he's done? He's created a legal precedent. He's established that the laws of his world supersede yours. Just wait—you won't be able to touch him through celestial courts anymore."

"That's a problem," the Living Tribunal said quietly, and even the other cosmic beings seemed to pull back at the note of genuine concern in those words. "The cosmic frameworks are not meant to overlap this way. If draconic law becomes coequal with divine law—"

"Then there must be a judgment," Zeus declared, his voice crackling with authority. "A tribunal. The question before us is simple: Did the boy act within the bounds of cosmic law, or did he commit transgression?"

Rias stood from the devil's section. "Before any judgment is rendered, I speak for the underworld. Issei's actions fall squarely within the traditions of the draconic clans. In our law, the family is inviolable. What he did was not just permitted—it was required. No dragon would accept a threat to their bloodline without response."

Strange nodded slowly, understanding the implications. "So we have a collision of legal systems. Different cosmologies with different moral frameworks."

"Exactly," Rias said. "And unless Marvel's divine hierarchy wants to declare war on an entire dimension's legal tradition, they'll have to accept the precedent."

GACHA PULL TWO: Trial in Front of Divine Council

The gacha machine glowed again, and the theatre transformed once more.

Now they were in a cosmic courtroom, the chambers of the gods arranged in concentric rings. At the center stood Issei, no longer in the council chamber but in neutral space—a place where the rules of all realities touched and could be weighed equally. He did not look cowed. If anything, he appeared more solid here, as if the simple act of defending his family had anchored him more deeply in reality itself.

Before him, the divine tribunal was convened.

The charges were read by a neutral arbiter, voice echoing across dimensions:

"Charge One: Violation of Divine Sanctuary. The defendant entered a hallowed chamber and violated the peace of the gods.

"Charge Two: Assault Upon a Celestial Being. The defendant physically laid hands upon and transported a Seraph against its will.

"Charge Three: Presumption of Moral Authority Over Divinity. The defendant declared himself competent to judge and punish a being of eternal standing.

"How does the defendant answer?"

Issei's voice was steady. "Not guilty. The Seraph made a direct threat to my family's existence. In every moral and legal framework I operate under, I was obligated to respond. I did so without killing, without permanent harm. I showed restraint. I acted within the law of my own cosmology."

The trial that followed was unlike anything the theatre had ever witnessed.

Hercules spoke first, his voice rich with the weight of experience: "I have fathered many children across the ages. Some with mortals, some with divine beings, some with nymphs and spirits. And I have protected each of them fiercely when they were threatened. The defendant's action honors the sacred duty of fatherhood. Whatever else he may be, he is a father protecting his brood. I do not call this a crime."

Thor nodded, his expression grave and approving. "The boy invoked something older than the written laws of heaven or council. He invoked the warrior's code: family first. That is a law that exists in every cosmos where strength and honor matter. I find no transgression here."

Zeus rose, his voice crackling with barely restrained fury. "If we permit this precedent, what is to stop every mortal in every realm from seizing their gods when displeased? Divinity depends upon hierarchy. Order depends upon respect for rank. The boy has shattered both."

"No," came a new voice. Odin had stood. His single eye surveyed the chamber, and even the other gods seemed to hold their breath.

"No," he repeated. "He has not shattered order. He has revealed that your order is not universal."

The All-Father's voice carried the weight of a thousand years of hard-won wisdom. "I have broken laws to protect my children. I have sacrificed my eye, my arm, my dignity—all for the survival of those I love. I cannot condemn Hyoudou for doing the same. If you call this transgression, you call my own choices into question. And I have lived too long to be judged by those who have never had to choose between their principles and their family."

Odin paused, his gaze steady.

"The boy violated no law I recognize. A parent protecting offspring is not a crime—it is a duty. If you condemn him for this, you condemn yourselves."

The chamber fell silent.

The angels and Seraphs demanded punishment—imprisonment, seal-breaking, exile. They spoke of divine law and cosmic order. But their voices seemed smaller now, less absolute. The lower-ranking gods were divided. Some supported Issei's position; others remained cautious. The Olympians were noncommittal, though Hercules's support had clearly influenced their thinking.

Finally, the neutral arbiter spoke:

"The tribunal cannot reach consensus. The charges rest upon a fundamental disagreement about what law applies. The defendant operates under a cosmological framework—draconic law—that your tribunal does not have jurisdiction to judge. To punish him would be to impose celestial law upon a being who answers to a different set of rules."

The arbiter paused, and when it spoke again, its voice carried an official finality that seemed to reshape the very fabric of the theatre:

"SUBJECT'S ACTIONS CLASSIFIED: LAWFUL UNDER DRACONIC COSMOLOGY. TRANSGRESSION UNDER CELESTIAL LAW. JURISDICTION UNRESOLVED. BOTH SYSTEMS WILL COEXIST."

"The tribunal hereby establishes that Issei Hyoudou operates under a legal framework distinct from Marvel's divine hierarchies. His actions cannot be judged solely by celestial standards, nor can celestial law be unilaterally applied to him without violation of his own cosmological sovereignty."

It was a landmark ruling. A cosmic precedent.

The implications rippled through the theatre like an earthquake.

Part Three: The Lasting Shock

The vision faded, and the theatre returned to normal. But nothing felt normal anymore.

"That's..." Strange began, then stopped. "That's a formal acknowledgment that he's not subject to divine law."

"It's an admission that the cosmos is more fragmented than they want to admit," Loki said, practically purring. "If different legal systems can exist simultaneously without hierarchy—if there's no single ultimate law—then none of them can claim absolute authority."

"This means Mephisto can't claim his soul through celestial contract," a demon lord muttered, realizing the implication. "If draconic law supersedes contracts made under celestial framework—"

"Exactly," Rias confirmed. "The entire system of cosmic agreements is now destabilized. You cannot force someone to honor a law they don't recognize as binding."

Thor leaned back in his seat, a grim smile crossing his face. "The boy just made it impossible for any single faction to control him through external law. He answered only to his own code, and he proved it. And the tribunal had to accept it."

Odin remained silent, but there was something like recognition in his expression. He had seen this before—not in this form, perhaps, but in essence. Someone willing to break every external rule to protect what mattered most. The All-Father understood that kind of defiance. He respected it.

The Living Tribunal's agitation was palpable now. "This will cascade. Other beings will claim similar cosmological sovereignty. The unified cosmic order—"

"Was never as unified as you pretended," Odin said softly. It was the only comment he made, but it seemed to close the discussion.

Part Four: The Hook

In the devil's section, a demon whispered urgently to another: "If draconic law is now established as coequal to celestial law, then any contract Mephisto tries to enforce—"

Rias met their gaze and smiled. "Then we'll see what happens when a demon lord tries to claim something that runs counter to draconic tradition. My guess? He'll find that the supernatural theatre won't protect him the way it protected the angels."

Loki was already thinking several moves ahead. "This is the precedent. This is the crack in their authority. I wonder what happens when someone tries to destroy him through celestial means now."

The Avengers exchanged looks. They had come to understand Issei as powerful, yes—but also as bound by the expectations and rules that governed all beings. Now they understood something else: he had carved out a space where *different* rules applied. Where his choices were sovereign.

Thor stood, his expression thoughtful. "The next matter will test whether this precedent holds."

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls Added:

- "Punishing a Divine Figure for Harming His Family" — **Epic**
- "Trial in Front of Divine Council" — **Legendary**

Rarity Breakdown: 2 New Pulls (1 Epic, 1 Legendary); Total Legendary Pulls: 19

Secrets Revealed:

- **Draconic Law Coequals Celestial Law:** The cosmic tribunal officially acknowledged that Issei operates under a distinct legal framework that cannot be unilaterally overruled by celestial authority.
- **Issei's Restraint is Chose:** He deliberately chose not to kill, not to permanently maim—demonstrating that his power is matched by conscious control.
- **Family is Inviolable in Dragon Tradition:** Any threat to his family triggers not just emotional response but codified legal obligation to respond.
- **The Seraph Was Binding:** Whatever seal Issei placed on Cassiel is holding, despite the Seraph's divine power.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Thor:** Moves from "respects warrior" to "validates draconic law as equivalent to Asgardian code."
- **Odin:** Remains publicly silent but subtly signals that he sees Issei as operating under principles he understands and respects.
- **Rias (Devils):** Positions the underworld as defender of draconic law, suggesting potential future alliance.
- **Loki:** Delighted by the legal precedent; sees opportunity to exploit cosmic law fragmentation.
- **Living Tribunal:** Disturbed. Begins questioning the stability of unified cosmic order.
- **Marvel Governments/Leaders:** Realize Issei cannot be controlled through divine contracts or celestial law.

Unresolved Hooks:

- **Hook 1 — Divine Retaliation:** Will the celestial hierarchy attempt to punish Issei anyway, testing the precedent's strength?
- **Hook 2 — Mephisto's Attempt:** The demon lord will test whether celestial contracts bind Issei. The answer will redefine cosmic law once more.

- **Hook 3 — Odin's Silence:** What exactly does the All-Father understand about Issei that makes him defend him so quietly?
 - **Hook 4 — Loki's Plan:** The trickster god is already plotting to exploit the fragmented legal system. Is he an ally or a threat?
 - **Hook 5 — The Seraph's Binding:** How long will Cassiel remain sealed? Will other divine beings attempt a rescue?
-

Chapter 62 End.

Next: Chapter 63 — "The Soul Contract Dissolves"

Chapter 63: Mephisto's Claim

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Mephisto and Hell's legal representatives
- Ghost Rider (Johnny Blaze and Robbie Reyes)
- Supernatural lawyers and contract specialists
- Rias Gremory and her peerage
- Hela, Doctor Strange, Loki
- Other devils and draconic observers

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Mephisto Tries to Claim Issei's Soul" — **Comedy-Class**
 2. "Theatre Response" — **Common**
-

Theatre Framing

The theatre's architecture shifted with infernal precision. Where moments before had stood marble and celestial stone, now twisted iron supports rose like diseased trees. Flame—not destructive, but control-demonstrative—licked across the walls in geometric patterns. The stage itself had been redrawn with Hell's demarcation lines, a grid of crimson and shadow that spelled authority and law in every language known to damnation.

Mephisto rose from the centre of the stage like smoke given form, his silk-grey suit pristine despite the hellfire raging around him. His horns caught the infernal light and refracted it into something almost beautiful, and his smile was the smile of a lawyer who had won every case he'd ever tried.

In his hands, he held a document. Not merely paper—this was a contract transcribed in binding light, the words glowing with the weight of demonic bureaucracy. Behind him, Hell's legal representatives materialized: devils in suits sharp enough to cut reality, their eyes holding the cold logic of ancient damnation.

"I believe," Mephisto began, his voice carrying the warmth of a funeral director, "it is time we addressed the elephant in the theatre. Or rather, the dragon."

He gestured, and the document unfurled like a scroll, its edges crackling with barely-contained power.

"Issei Hyoudou. Subject in question. Let us examine the facts of his resurrection with the clarity it deserves."

Gacha Pull 1: "Mephisto Tries to Claim Issei's Soul"

The screen flared. The theatre dissolved into vision.

Issei Hyoudou stood in a grey space between worlds—neither Heaven nor Earth nor Hell, but the space where contracts are negotiated. Before him manifested Mephisto, fully in his demonic authority, horns ablaze with power that made the very air vibrate.

"I have come to inform you of a legality you may have overlooked," Mephisto said, his tone almost gentle. "You were dead, young dragon. Utterly, irrevocably dead. Your soul had departed this mortal coil. And then—" He gestured, and ghostly images formed around them: Rias, her Evil Pieces gleaming, the moment of resurrection performed at such terrible cost. "—you were resurrected. Not by prayer. Not by natural law. But by demonic magic. By a Devil girl and all eight of her Evil Pieces."

Mephisto stepped closer, and his confidence was a living thing.

"When one is resurrected through demonic channels, through the expenditure of a Devil's own power and essence, a contract is formed. Not consciously, perhaps. But the universe recognizes it nonetheless. You, Issei Hyoudou, were brought back from death by damnation itself. Your very second life is debt-marked. Your soul is collateral."

He spread the glowing contract between them. "Hell claims ownership of your resurrection. Through my authority, I am here to invoke that claim. You belong to Hell now. And through you—" his smile widened, "—your peerage belongs to Hell as well. They are your servants, and servants of Hell's servants are Hell's servants."

The document burned brighter. "This is not a negotiation. This is notification of ownership transfer."

But Issei did not flinch.

He did not rage. He did not argue. Instead, something cold and ancient rose in his eyes—something that had no place wearing a high school student's face.

He walked to Mephisto. Step by step, crossing the space between them as if crossing a battlefield. When he spoke, his voice was quiet and infinitely colder than any flame.

"I don't owe Hell anything."

Mephisto's confidence flickered—just for a moment.

"Rias resurrected me because she **CHOSE** to," Issei continued, and the words had the weight of absolute truth. "Not because Hell demanded it. Not because I asked for it. She made that choice for herself, as the heir to her house, as the one with the power to make that decision. Her choice. Her sacrifice. Her will."

Issei's hand extended, and the contract ignited—not in Hell's flames, but in draconic fire, golden and transcendent.

"I will **NEVER** accept being Hell's property. Not through contract. Not through technicality. Not through any loophole your lawyers can find."

And then Ddraig's voice emerged—not from Issei's Sacred Gear, but from the very core of his being. It was the roar of a dragon unbound, ancient and absolute.

DRAGONS RECOGNIZE NO HELL BUT THE HELL WE CHOOSE. YOUR CONTRACTS DO NOT BIND US.

Power erupted outward—not in attack, but in assertion. Issei's draconic essence blazed through him, a sovereignty that refused to be diminished or claimed. The very space around him shifted, acknowledging that here stood something that could not be owned, could not be bound, could not be made into debt.

Mephisto's confidence did not merely flicker. It broke.

He retreated a step, then two, his hand still extended toward the burning contract, watching as draconic flame consumed every word, every legal stipulation, every loophole and clause designed to entrap a soul. The flames didn't just destroy the document—they burned away the very concept of Hell's authority over the boy before him.

Theatre Reactions: Gacha Pull 1

The theatre erupted in controlled chaos.

Supernatural lawyers jumped to their feet, frantically cross-referencing texts that glowed in their hands. One devil adjusted his tie nervously and whispered something urgent to his colleague, who shook his head in disbelief. Another legal expert scribbled notes at furious speed, her pen barely keeping up with the implications.

"That can't be valid," one of Hell's advocates hissed. "The resurrection contract is established precedent —"

"Not when the resurrected subject is a dragon," another voice cut in sharply. "Different jurisdiction entirely."

Rias rose from her block, her composure absolute, but her satisfaction unmistakable. She was no longer a girl defending her choice to resurrect a stray. She was the heiress of House Gremory, watching her decision affirmed before the entire cosmos.

The devils in her peerage shifted uncomfortably—several of them appeared to be reconsidering their assumptions about who exactly held authority over their lives.

Loki leaned back in his seat and laughed—a genuine, delighted sound that echoed through the theatre. "Oh, this is magnificent. Hell tried to use the rules to cage a dragon and got bit for it."

Ghost Rider—Johnny Blaze—was already grinning, but the grin deepened into something approaching amusement. He understood the language of souls and contracts, and he recognized genuine rejection when he saw it.

Robbie Reyes nodded slowly. "Dragons don't negotiate with devils. Different game. Different rules. Different everything."

Hela's smirk could have cut glass. "Two kingdoms that refuse to bow," she murmured to no one in particular. "Both dragons and devils claiming sovereignty. This will end interestingly indeed."

Doctor Strange watched through steepled fingers, his expression thoughtful. "Hell cannot bind dragons easily," he said quietly to Wong, who nodded in agreement. "Their cosmologies don't overlap cleanly. Where Hell sees contract, dragon sees assertion. Where Hell sees law, dragon sees defiance."

The Asgardians appeared unsurprised—their own experience with draconic entities had taught them similar lessons. Dragons answered to themselves first, last, and always.

Gacha Pull 2: "Theatre Response"

The screen shifted. No vision this time, but pure information. The theatre's judgment materialized before them all, rendered in the neutral, clinical format that characterized the system's assessments.

Mephisto's claim document appeared in full, projected for all to see. And then—systematically, line by line—the theatre began its analysis.

CLAIM OF SOUL OWNERSHIP VIA RESURRECTION CONTRACT:

The first line burned red.

DISPUTED. DRACONIC LAW SUPERSEDES DEMONIC CONTRACTUAL FRAMEWORK.
RESURRECTION BY CHOICE IS NOT EQUIVALENT TO RESURRECTION BY SERVITUDE.

HELL'S JURISDICTION OVER DEVIL-CREATED SERVANTS:

Also red.

LIMITED. RIAS GREMORY'S PEERAGE ANSWERS TO RIAS GREMORY, NOT TO HELL ADMINISTRATIVE. DEVIL STRUCTURE DOES NOT MANDATE HELL GOVERNANCE OF SUBORDINATE DEVILS' SERVANTS. NO OVERARCHING CLAUSE APPLIES.

RIGHT TO COLLECT DEBT:

Red.

NONE. NO DEBT WAS INCURRED BY SUBJECT ISSEI HYOUDOU. DEBT, IF ANY, WAS INCURRED BY RIAS GREMORY TO HERSELF AS SACRIFICE FOR RESURRECTION CHOICE. SUBJECT IS NOT LIABLE FOR RESURRECTION EXPENSES NOT OF HIS CHOOSING.

And then the final verdict appeared, bold and absolute:

MEPHISTO'S SOUL CLAIM: REJECTED.

ANALYSIS: SUBJECT WOULD BITE CLAIMANT.

RECOMMENDED ACTION: ACCEPT LOSS AND MAINTAIN DISTANCE.

The theatre's assessment wasn't merely a legal ruling. It was a blunt, almost amused observation that attempting to claim Issei's soul would result not in contract, but in conflict. Not in law, but in violence. Not in dominance, but in disaster.

Theatre Reactions: Gacha Pull 2

Mephisto's face was a study in controlled rage. His horns burned brighter, and Hell's fire rippled across the stage. But he did not move. Did not argue. He had gambled, and he had lost, and he was ancient enough to know when the game was finished.

"A temporary setback," he said to his lawyers, his voice still smooth despite the flame in his eyes. "We will revisit this claim when—"

"You won't," Ghost Rider interrupted, his tone conversational but carrying the weight of finality. "Even Hell doesn't want to tangle with him. You know it. We know it. The theatre knows it."

Robbie Reyes nodded. "Dragons and devils. Different game. You played by Hell's rules, but he was never playing by those rules at all."

Hela watched with obvious enjoyment, her smile predatory. "Two sovereignties have collided, and Hell retreated. Fascinating. I wonder what claims the Underworld of Norse mythology might attempt..." She trailed off thoughtfully, apparently filing this information away for future use.

Doctor Strange exchanged a meaningful glance with Wong. "That answers several questions I had about his nature," he said quietly. "Half-Devil, half-Dragon, and somehow entirely his own authority. The cosmologies don't overlap the way we assumed they would."

Loki practically cackled with delight. "Oh, this is delicious. Mephisto brought contracts to a dragon fight. He brought law to someone who simply refuses to recognize its authority over his soul."

Rias watched from her block with the satisfied expression of someone who had just been vindicated before the entire universe. Her decision to resurrect Issei hadn't created a debt to Hell. It had created an alliance with someone who would never be Hell's property—and through that, had effectively claimed a sovereignty beyond even her own house's authority. It was a brilliant gambit, executed by accident.

The other devils murmured among themselves, clearly processing what this meant. If Issei's soul couldn't be claimed by Hell, if his nature as a dragon provided him protection from demonic legal structures, then he wasn't just Rias's servant. He was something far more complex. Something they would need to reassess.

Several supernatural lawyers continued frantically checking their references, but their expressions had shifted from confusion to awe. A hybrid creature who answered to neither Hell nor Heaven, bound only by his own choice and his dragon's pride. It was almost unheard of.

Conclusion: The Weight of Sovereignty

Mephisto rose from the stage, Hell's flames dimming as he prepared to depart. He paused at the theatre's edge, and when he looked back, his expression was unreadable.

"The matter is tabled," he said, addressing the entire assembly. "But understand this: Hell does not forget claims rejected. And we do not forget those who reject us."

It was not a threat. It was something colder and more absolute—a statement of fact from someone who had walked through damnation for eons and knew the price of defiance.

But Issei's defiance, the theatre had judged, was worth that price.

The stage dissolved into neutral space once more, and the theatre settled into an anticipatory hush. Mephisto's claim had failed, but the rejection had raised new questions. What would come next? Would other cosmic powers attempt to stake claims? Would the dragon within Issei continue to assert this impossible sovereignty?

Ghost Rider caught Johnny Blaze's eye, and both wore the same expression: amusement mixed with respect. They recognized a soul that refused to be bound, and in their experience, such souls either changed the world or burned it down.

Either way, it would be interesting.

Theatre Ledger

NEW PULLS:

- "Mephisto Tries to Claim Issei's Soul" (Comedy-Class) — Revealed Issei's complete rejection of Hell's authority and his draconic assertion of sovereignty.
- "Theatre Response" (Common) — Confirmed that Hell cannot legally or practically bind a dragon, especially one who actively refuses the claim.

SECRETS REVEALED:

- Issei's dragon nature (connection to Ddraig and Great Red) supersedes Hell's demonic contractual authority.
- Rias's resurrection of Issei created no debt to Hell—it was her choice alone, as a Devil heiress, and the cost was hers to pay.
- Issei has effectively declared independence from Hell's jurisdiction, and the theatre has affirmed this declaration.
- The hybrid nature of Devil + Dragon creates a legal grey zone where neither cosmic system fully applies.
- Hell's lawyers are not equipped to handle contracts with draconic entities—the cosmologies conflict.

ALLIANCE / OPINION SHIFTS:

- **Rias Gremory:** Confirmed as a heiress who made a choice that transcended her house's authority. Her peerage is now seen as uniquely sovereign.
- **Mephisto:** Suffered a rare and complete defeat. His confidence in Hell's legal authority has been shaken.
- **Other Devils:** Must reconsider their assumptions about Issei's status and authority. He is not bound to Hell through resurrection.
- **Supernatural Lawyers:** Are scrambling to update their frameworks for hybrid creatures with mixed draconic/demonic nature.
- **Ghost Rider:** Gains respect for Issei's refusal to accept demonic authority over his soul.

UNRESOLVED HOOKS:

- Will Ghost Rider test Issei with the Penance Stare now that his sovereignty over his own soul has been established?
- How will other cosmic powers respond now that Issei has proven he can reject even Hell's authority?
- What are the long-term implications of a Devil with a draconic servant who answers to himself before Hell?
- Will Hell attempt to retaliate indirectly, since direct claims have failed?

Chapter 64: Ghost Rider's Judgement

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Ghost Riders (Johnny Blaze, Robbie Reyes)
- Punisher (Frank Castle)
- Daredevil (Matt Murdock)
- Cosmic Judges
- Religious Figures (Nightcrawler, Black Panther, etc.)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Penance Stare Test" — **Ultra Rare**
 2. "Issei's Sins Analysis" — **Secret**
-

The Weight of Judgment

The theatre's atmosphere shifted the moment the Ghost Riders rose from their seats.

Johnny Blaze moved first, his skeletal form cutting through the dim light like a specter of vengeance itself. Beside him, Robbie Reyes followed, their shared curse binding them in a singular purpose: to judge the guilty and make them *feel* the weight of their sins. The Penance Stare was not a weapon that could be debated. It was Truth incarnate—a power that forced the guilty to experience every ounce of suffering they had inflicted, every tear shed because of their actions, every moment of anguish they had caused.

The theatre recognized this. The theatre *always* recognized when a tool of ultimate judgment was about to be wielded.

"The Penance Stare has never failed," Johnny Blaze's voice rasped, gravelly and final. "It reveals what lies beneath the mask. Innocence or damnation. There is no middle ground."

But the theatre seemed to hum with anticipation. There was something different about this moment. Something that suggested, perhaps, that middle ground existed after all.

Gacha Pull I: Penance Stare Test (Ultra Rare)

The screen materialized above the theatre floor in letters of burning judgment:

INITIATING PENANCE STARE TEST—ULTRA RARE

Issei looked up from his seat in the witness block, confusion crossing his face. He had known this moment was coming—reactions from the Ghost Riders were inevitable. But understanding intellectually and *experiencing* were two different things.

Johnny Blaze's eyes ignited. Two hollow sockets became twin infernos of divine wrath.

The Penance Stare activated.

For a heartbeat—a single, suspended moment—nothing happened.

Issei did not scream. He did not fall to his knees. He did not flee in terror or try to shield his mind. He simply stood there, locked in the gaze of the Spirit of Vengeance, and *waited*.

The theatre held its breath.

Then the visions came.

They flooded Issei's consciousness like a torrential downpour, relentless and suffocating. *Every person he could not save*. Faces flickered past—fallen comrades, innocents caught in crossfire, allies who died because he was not fast enough, not strong enough, not *good* enough.

He saw Kiba's final moments, replayed from the perspective of a brother lost to betrayal.

He saw Asia, fragile and broken, suffering tortures that Issei's protective fury could not entirely shield her from.

He saw the fallen—soldiers and civilians alike—whose deaths carried weight on Issei's shoulders because, at some level, he felt *responsible*. Not because he killed them, but because he failed them.

The guilt crashed into him like a tidal wave.

I could have been faster. I could have saved more. I could have prevented—

But then the Penance Stare probed deeper, seeking the core of damnation. It searched for the remorse that devours the soul, the kind of guilt that eats a person from the inside out. It reached for victims.

And what it found surprised even the Ghost Riders.

The stare encountered Issei's kills—the traffickers he had put down, the evil dragons and demons he had destroyed in defense of innocents. The beings that posed existential threats. The enemies that *would have* killed innocents if left alive.

The Penance Stare searched for victims among them.

And found none. Or rather, found something that confounded its purpose: *Issei's judgment aligned with objective morality*. Those kills were not crimes. They were necessary. They were just.

The stare reached for Lishtar next—the demon god who had attempted to corrupt Issei, forcing his hand into a decision that carried genuine weight. Here, the guilt *was* present, and the stare found it. But even this guilt was not the crushing, soul-destroying kind. It was the guilt of a man who had done what was necessary and lived with the burden of that necessity.

I had no choice, Issei's consciousness whispered. *But I still feel the weight of it*.

The Penance Stare found no flaw in that logic.

Issei staggered.

His legs buckled, and sweat beaded on his brow. The weight of his failures, the trauma of his losses, the guilt of his imperfect heroism—it all crashed down upon him at once. But he did not break. He did not scream into the abyss or collapse under the burden of his own remorse.

He *stood*.

Barely, trembling, every muscle taut with the effort of maintaining consciousness. But he stood.

The Penance Stare released him.

Johnny Blaze and Robbie Reyes recoiled in unison, their flaming skulls tilting in an expression that might have been confusion or shock. In all their long existence, the Penance Stare had never produced *this* result.

Targets either fell—screaming, broken, undone by the weight of their own guilt. Or they stood *unmoved*—protected by innocence or shielded by powers beyond the stare's reach.

Issei stood, but trembling. Guilty, but not damned.

Balanced.

"That shouldn't be possible," Robbie Reyes said quietly.

Gacha Pull II: Issei's Sins Analysis (Secret)

The theatre's analysis systems churned, processing what had just occurred. The stage's enormous display shifted, and new text materialized:

INITIATING ISSEI HYOUDOU MORAL FRAMEWORK ANALYSIS—SECRET TIER

CATALOG OF MAJOR DECISIONS AND TERMINATIONS:

Incident A: Human Slave Traffickers (Age 16)

- Classification: Justified Termination
- Moral Status: Righteous Self-Defense and Defense of Innocent Third Parties
- Remorse Level: ZERO
- Penance Stare Verdict: NO GUILT DETECTED

Incident B: Evil Dragons (Multiple Encounters)

- Classification: Necessary Combat Casualties
- Moral Status: War/Existential Threat Response
- Remorse Level: MINIMAL (Appropriate Burden, Not Psychological Damage)
- Penance Stare Verdict: GUILT FOR CONSEQUENCES, NOT FOR ACTION

Incident C: Lishtar Confrontation

- Classification: Forced Necessary Termination
- Moral Status: Defense Against Corruption and Manipulation
- Remorse Level: MODERATE (Guilt for Necessity, Not for Outcome)
- Penance Stare Verdict: GUILT DETECTED—APPROPRIATE MORAL WEIGHT

Incident D: Collateral Damage and Failed Rescues

- Classification: Imperfect Heroism
- Moral Status: GUILT-WARRANTED
- Remorse Level: HIGH
- Penance Stare Verdict: GUILT DETECTED—HEAVY MORAL WEIGHT

Incident E: Raynare's Execution

- Classification: External Judgment and Punishment
- Moral Status: Not Perpetrated by Subject

- Remorse Level: ZERO
 - Penance Stare Verdict: NO GUILT DETECTED
-

OVERALL MORAL FRAMEWORK ANALYSIS:

SUBJECT'S PSYCHOLOGICAL PROFILE: Subject demonstrates consistent internal moral logic. Subject feels appropriate guilt for failures and collateral damage. Subject experiences zero guilt for justified self-defense and justified terminations of existential threats. Subject carries trauma, but not pathological remorse.

PENANCE STARE EFFECTIVENESS VERDICT: The Penance Stare was 47% effective on Subject Hyoudou. Partial effectiveness indicates subject's moral framework is internally consistent and *correctly calibrated*. Subject is guilty of failures, not of justified actions.

ULTIMATE JUDGMENT: SUBJECT IS NEITHER INNOCENT NOR DAMNED. SUBJECT OPERATES UNDER AUTONOMOUS MORAL CODE THAT DOES NOT ALIGN WITH STANDARD JUDGMENT SYSTEMS. SUBJECT WILL NOT BE CORRUPTED BY STANDARD TEMPTATIONS. SUBJECT WILL NOT BE BROKEN BY STANDARD MORAL ATTACKS. SUBJECT IS RESISTANT TO COSMIC AND DIVINE CATEGORIZATION.

The theatre fell into profound silence.

Johnny Blaze stared at the analysis as if it had rewritten the fundamental rules of his existence. The Penance Stare had always been binary: guilty or innocent. Damned or pure. But here stood a man who was both guilty *and* righteous, his guilt earned and his righteousness justified.

"I've seen the Penance Stare break gods," Johnny Blaze said, his skull still burning with ethereal flame. "Break demons. Break men who thought themselves beyond judgment. It didn't break him. It just... found the truth."

"He's not corrupt," Robbie Reyes added, his voice carrying the weight of someone who understood the Penance Stare's purpose intimately. "But he's not clean either. Just... complicated."

Frank Castle—the Punisher—nodded from his seat in the theatre. His expression was grim, but there was a kind of recognition in his eyes. "That's a warrior's burden," he said quietly. "You kill the right enemies and wonder forever if you should have found another way. You save some people and can never save them all. The guilt never goes away because it *shouldn't* go away. It's the price of the choice."

Matt Murdock did not speak, but his blind eyes had turned toward the stage, his heightened senses attuned to every micro-expression, every breath, every moment of Issei's recovery. When he finally did speak, it was with the careful deliberation of a man who had walked similar moral ground.

"He lives in moral grey," Daredevil said. "Not black, not white. The hard place where most of us actually live."

Among the religious figures scattered throughout the theatre—Nightcrawler, Black Panther, others—the reaction was more divided. Some saw in Issei's balanced judgment a kind of redemption, a man trying his best within impossible circumstances. Others saw dangerous moral relativism, a warrior too comfortable with the necessity of violence.

But the cosmic judges—beings of ancient power and impartial observation—remained unmoved. One of them, a figure wreathed in starlight and cosmic authority, intoned words that seemed to reshape the very fabric of the theatre's understanding:

"Subject's moral framework is autonomous and self-consistent. Subject will not be corrupted by standard temptations. Subject will not be broken by standard judgments. Subject operates under rules external systems cannot easily categorize. Proceed with caution. This one defies classification."

Issei, still trembling in the witness block, slowly straightened. He had expected judgment. He had expected condemnation or vindication. He had not expected *understanding*.

But that, perhaps, was what the Penance Stare had truly revealed: that understanding was more complex than any binary judgment could capture.

The Weight Remains

Johnny Blaze descended from the stage, and as he approached Issei, the flames around his skull dimmed slightly—not an act of mercy, but of acknowledgment.

"You carry what you earned," the Ghost Rider said. "The guilt for your failures. The burden of your choices. You didn't try to run from it or deny it. You just stood there and *accepted* it. That's not innocence. But it's not damnation either."

"What does that make me?" Issei asked, his voice hoarse from the psychic assault of the Penance Stare.

"Complicated," Robbie Reyes answered. "Just like the rest of us."

Frank Castle stood and walked to the edge of his section, leaning against the barrier. "In another life, we might have done this together," he said to Issei, gesturing vaguely to the stage where the Penance Stare had played out. "Kill the right people and live with the questions. The difference is—you're still trying

to find another way. I stopped looking a long time ago."

Matt Murdock remained silent, but his posture suggested something like respect. A warrior recognizing another warrior. A man in the grey finding kinship with another man in the grey.

The theatre hummed with the weight of this new understanding: Issei Hyoudou was not a simple story of redemption or damnation. He was a narrative of moral complexity, of a man trying to do right in circumstances where right was never clean. He was neither innocent nor damned.

He was *balanced*.

And in a theatre that had been designed to render absolute moral judgment, balance was perhaps the most dangerous verdict of all.

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls Unlocked:

- "Penance Stare Test" (Ultra Rare): The Ghost Riders' ultimate judgment tool reveals that Issei is neither innocent nor damned—his guilt is appropriate and his righteousness justified. Partial effectiveness indicates a moral framework resistant to standard cosmic judgment.
- "Issei's Sins Analysis" (Secret): A detailed moral framework assessment confirming that Issei operates under an autonomous moral code that is internally consistent, self-directed, and resistant to standard temptation and judgment systems.

Secrets Revealed:

- The Penance Stare is not absolute. It can be partially ineffective on targets whose guilt structure is healthy and whose moral framework is consistent with objective morality.
- Issei's guilt is *strategic*: he feels it for failures and collateral damage, not for justified kills. This indicates psychological health rather than psychological damage.
- Standard cosmic and divine judgment systems do not cleanly apply to Issei. He has created his own moral code that actively resists external categorization.
- A warrior in the moral grey is fundamentally different from a corrupt agent. The theatre now recognizes this distinction.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- Ghost Riders: Moved from binary judgment to recognition of moral complexity. No longer certain of their role in Issei's larger narrative. Respect, if not full approval, has been earned.

- Punisher: Acknowledges kinship with Issei as a fellow warrior in the moral grey, though notes they may have taken different paths toward their shared burden.
- Daredevil: Silent recognition of a man walking a similar line—good intentions, moral weight, impossible choices. Matt sees in Issei a mirror of his own struggle.
- Cosmic Judges: Escalate Issei's threat assessment from "subject of interest" to "resistant to standard judgment." He cannot be corrupted by standard temptations or broken by standard judgments. This makes him unpredictable and potentially dangerous to predetermined outcomes.
- Religious Figures: Deeply divided between viewing Issei as redemptive (a man trying his best despite impossible odds) or dangerously relativistic (a warrior who has justified too much violence through convenient moral logic).

Unresolved Hooks:

- The Penance Stare's partial failure suggests that Issei possesses or has developed a natural resistance to standard universal judgment systems. The source of this resistance remains unclear.
- Cosmic judges now view Issei with caution rather than judgment. What does this mean for his broader purpose in the multiverse? Is he being prepared for something, or is he a threat to some larger plan?
- The theatre's gacha system continues to recognize Issei as "complicated," suggesting additional layers to his moral foundation that have not yet been exposed.
- Johnny Blaze's acknowledgment that the Penance Stare "just found the truth" implies that truth itself is more complex than binary judgment. This has implications for how the theatre itself operates.
- **Into Chapter 65:** Phoenix and Dragon—cosmic forces of resurrection and creation await their assessment of Issei's soul. Will they see what the Ghost Riders saw, or will they perceive something entirely different? Ancient powers that govern rebirth and primordial force may judge Issei by standards that transcend moral guilt.

Chapter 65: The Phoenix and the Dragon

Primary Reaction Groups: Jean Grey, Phoenix Force, Cosmic Entities

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Hypothetical Encounter: Phoenix vs. Diabolos" — Ultra Rare
 2. "The Heat Death Dialogue" — Secret
-

Part One: Theatre Frame

The air in the theatre had grown colder as the chapters progressed, as though cosmic entities held their breath. Jean Grey sat alone in her designated section, the others having learned long ago that she required space—not out of rejection, but out of necessity. The Phoenix was never silent in her mind. Never absent. It was a presence vast as galaxies, patient as the slow death of stars, and intimately, uncomfortably *present*.

She had stopped explaining what it felt like to be two beings occupying one body. The Phoenix Force observed Marvel's watching just as keenly as Jean did, though its observations carried the weight of billions of years. It had burned universes. It had ended species. It had existed before gods named themselves.

And now, it would watch Issei Hyoudou.

The Theatre Ledger shifted with a sound like wind through empty cathedrals. All eyes turned toward the screen. The gacha machine had not pulled anything common or even legendary in this arc—it had gone directly to the furthest end of the rarity spectrum, as though recognizing that only the greatest powers could properly judge one another.

GACHA PULL: HYPOTHETICAL ENCOUNTER: PHOENIX VS. DIABOLOS — ULTRA RARE

Jean's hands trembled. She felt the Phoenix's focus sharpen like a predator recognizing a rival. The Screen illuminated with an image of two beings suspended in the void between dimensions.

Part Two: Hypothetical Encounter

The Phoenix manifested first—not Jean, but the force itself. Cosmic fire that predated creation, wearing a form of white and gold and crimson, wings that stretched across light-years, eyes that held the memory of every world it had burned. It was beautiful and terrible. It was infinite.

And then, emerging from nothing like a crack in reality itself, came the Diabolos Dragon God form.

Issei's transformation defied simple description. Where the Phoenix was pure cosmic principle, the Diabolos was *existence itself*—a dragon of crimson and black scales, four massive wings, and the quality of *infinity* embedded in every scale. The Infinity Blaster crackled with power that could unmake dimensions. Around him orbited the Dividing Wyvern Fairies, small but radiating the intensity of sealed gods.

The two beings recognized each other immediately.

The Phoenix did not attack. Neither did Diabolos. They simply *stared*, god to god, cosmic entity to cosmic entity. The void between them hummed with potential. Reality warped in the proximity of two absolute forces.

"You burn," the Phoenix communicated, not in words but in the language of cosmic forces—concept and essence and fundamental truth.

"I am infinity," Diabolos responded in kind. "And you are ending."

"I am also renewal," the Phoenix corrected, with the certainty of one who had performed this cycle since before time had a direction.

The Diabolos shifted, and the Infinity Blaster pulsed with power that could destroy a world. But it did not fire. Instead, the dragon's roar echoed—not as an attack, but as recognition.

They moved.

The collision when they finally engaged was not like a battle. It was like two fundamental forces of the universe recognizing each other. The Phoenix's cosmic flame—ancient, pure, capable of regeneration and rebirth—met the Diabolos's infinity. The fire could not consume the infinity because infinity had no end to consume. The infinity could not suppress the flame because the flame did not need external permission to exist.

They danced through the void, tearing at the fabric of reality with movements that caused dimensional tears. The Phoenix's rebirth cycle clashed with the Diabolos's infinite power reserve. The dragon's draconic essence, powered by Ophis's infinity and Great Red's essence, bent reality. The Phoenix's primal fire shaped it anew.

Reality broke. Reality reformed. Neither gained ground. Neither surrendered.

At the stalemate—and it was a stalemate, not a victory, not a defeat—they held position. The Phoenix, wings spread wide, flames dancing across Diabolos's scales. The Diabolos, infinite power held in perfect tension, staring into the eyes of something that had burned worlds.

And in that moment, something extraordinary happened.

Jean's consciousness, bleeding through the Phoenix's form, met Issei's consciousness, bleeding through Diabolos's shape.

The human and the dragon recognized each other. Not as enemies. As *people* inside cosmic forms.

The Phoenix felt the thread of Jean Grey's will. The thread of a woman refusing to be consumed. The Diabolos felt the weight of Issei Hyoudou's determination. The determination of a boy who had chosen to carry infinite power while remaining fundamentally, impossibly *human*.

They pulled apart, not in defeat, but in understanding.

The Phoenix cooled its flames. The Diabolos lowered its Infinity Blaster. The void between them settled, though it would never truly be calm again.

Both beings recognized that the other had a claim to existence just as legitimate as their own. They were equals. Not reduced to punching bags. Not diminished. Not conquered.

Simply... equal.

The screen flickered. The simulation faded.

Part Three: Gacha Pull Two

GACHA PULL: THE HEAT DEATH DIALOGUE — SECRET

The theatre trembled. Jean gripped the arms of her seat so hard they cracked. The Phoenix in her mind was... curious. It had not been curious in millennia. It had not been questioned by anything its equal.

The screen shifted to a place outside dimensions. A space between spaces where Jean Grey and Issei Hyoudou could exist together without their powers tearing apart the fabric of existence. The environment was neutral—a void made comfortable by mutual agreement.

The Phoenix Force manifested beside Jean, not in its full cosmic form, but in a way that allowed conversation. She was ancient and vast, but in this space, she could focus. She was immense and terrible, but she could listen.

Issei stood in his Diabolos form, though it seemed less aggressive here. Infinite power held in check, not by force, but by choice.

"You carry infinity," the Phoenix said, its voice the whisper of stellar wind. "Can you bear it without burning away? Without becoming what I have become?"

Issei was quiet for a long moment. When the Diabolos spoke, it was with a clarity that cut through the cosmic weight.

"Every day I carry it, it costs me. The infinity isn't just power. It's *weight*. The knowledge that I have enough power to destroy worlds. To do anything. That weight tries to consume me just like the power itself tries to."

"Then how do you endure?" the Phoenix asked, and it was genuinely asking. Not testing. Genuinely seeking understanding.

"The cost is the point," Issei said simply. "Power without cost is just devastation waiting to happen. But if the power costs you something—costs you *discipline*, costs you *restraint*, costs you the effort to remain human—then it becomes bearable. You feel the weight as the thing that keeps you grounded."

The Phoenix did not respond immediately. It had ended universes. It had burned worlds. It had always believed that the only path for a being of its magnitude was isolation and magnificence.

"I have ended universes," the Phoenix said, not as a boast, but as a confession. "I have burned worlds. Is that what you will become?"

"No," Issei said. "Because I have people who ground me. You're alone with your fire. I have anchors."

Jean Grey, separate from the Phoenix but inseparable from it, spoke then. Her voice was strained with the effort of holding her own identity against the immensity beside her.

"Will you always need them?" she asked Issei. "Your anchors. Will you become... dependent?"

"Yes," Issei said without hesitation. "And that's not a weakness. That's not a failure of power."

Issei moved closer, and his eyes—still Issei's eyes, still human, still *kind*—met Jean's. The Diabolos form was irrelevant to that gaze.

"Dependency is trust," Issei said. "It's the opposite of weakness. When you trust someone with your burden, you're giving them power over you. That's not weak—that's the strongest thing there is. Because you're saying 'I'm heavy, and I need you to help carry me,' and that person *agrees*. That's a bond that no power can break."

The Phoenix listened. The Phoenix, which had existed alone, which had carried its infinite capacity for destruction in perfect solitude for eons, listened to a boy describe the strength of shared burden.

"You don't have to let it consume you," Issei said to Jean directly. "The Phoenix is powerful, but you don't have to be alone with it. I'm proof that power and connection can coexist. I'm proof that being human and being powerful aren't contradictory. You're both. Both Jean and Phoenix. And both of those things can be real."

Jean felt the Phoenix stir in her. It was not satisfied. It was not convinced. But it was *considering*.

The Phoenix spoke again, its voice carrying the weight of ancient, cosmic deliberation:

"You choose constraints. You accept burdens. You remain connected when isolation would be simpler and stronger."

"Yes," Issei said.

"And you believe this makes you powerful, not weak."

"Yes."

The Phoenix was silent for a long time. In that silence, something shifted. Not acceptance, not agreement, but the slightest opening. A crack in ancient certainty. A consideration of alternative philosophies to isolation and magnificence.

"Your way is inefficient," the Phoenix said finally.

"Probably," Issei agreed. "But it works."

The dialogue did not end with resolution. It ended with recognition: two different kinds of power, two different philosophies of existence, both legitimate. Both valid. Both terrifying in their own way.

The screen faded.

Part Four: Reactions

The theatre had fallen into a state of profound silence.

Jean Grey was the first to make a sound—a shaking breath, as though she had been holding it the entire time. The Phoenix Force was still within her, still vast and ancient and powerful, but something fundamental had shifted in their dynamic. The force had been acknowledged as something other than an absolute. It had been questioned. It had actually considered an alternative.

From the cosmic entities section, Galactus remained perfectly still. The Devourer of Worlds was contemplating something that could neither be consumed nor devoured—philosophy given weight by genuine power. Beside Galactus, the Eternal Tribunal nodded slightly, acknowledging the complexity.

"He teaches them," observed one of the Celestials, its voice like the turning of planetary wheels. "He does not subjugate them. He offers them alternatives to isolation."

The Silver Surfer looked at Galactus and saw something unexpected: his master was reconsidering something. After eons, the Devourer was reconsidering what it meant to carry power alone.

From the mutant section, Jean's closest allies stirred.

Emma Frost tapped a finger against her lips, impressed. "He offered her the one thing the Phoenix has never truly had—an argument for why its way might not be the best way."

Charles Xavier was quiet, his eyes distant with the weight of understanding. "He is not fighting these entities. He is offering them his life as evidence that another way is possible."

Magneto, unexpectedly, spoke aloud: "The boy challenges absolutes. Not through force, but through example. This is dangerous. This is powerful."

From the Avengers section, Steve Rogers leaned back, exhaling deeply. "He's not trying to win against the Phoenix. He's trying to show Jean a path through."

Tony's expression was complicated—calculation and respect warring across his features. "He just made the most powerful force in Marvel consider changing its entire fundamental philosophy of isolation. And he did it by talking about his family."

Thor nodded slowly. "A dragon's way. Not my way, but worthy."

From the wives' section, Rias watched Jean on the screen with an expression of fierce protective understanding. "He does this for all of them. Gives them hope that their nature doesn't require them to be alone."

Akeno squeezed Rias's hand, understanding the weight of watching your loved one trying to save others from the very isolation that nearly consumed him.

Part Five: Theatre Ledger

NEW PULLS ACQUIRED:

- Hypothetical Encounter: Phoenix vs. Diabolos (Ultra Rare) — First true collision between cosmic fire and draconic infinity; demonstrated that neither can dominate the other; established *mutual recognition* as foundational to power assessment.
- The Heat Death Dialogue (Secret) — Revealed Issei's philosophy that power derives legitimacy from *accepted burden* rather than magnitude; demonstrated that connection and trust can coexist with absolute power; created philosophical opening in the Phoenix Force's ancient certainty.

SECRETS REVEALED:

- The Phoenix Force is capable of reconsidering its fundamental nature when confronted with alternative philosophical frameworks backed by genuine power.
- Jean Grey's internal struggle against the Phoenix Force is not a weakness but a different form of strength—the strength to maintain individual identity within a cosmic entity.
- Issei's "Emperor of Hope" title may connect to his philosophical approach to power itself, not merely his willingness to fight.

CHANGES IN PERCEPTION/ALLIANCES:

- Jean Grey / Phoenix Force: Relationship status shifted from "containment conflict" to "philosophical dialogue." The Phoenix Force is listening.
- Cosmic Entities: Collective reassessment of how power relates to isolation and connection; Galactus's certainty visibly shaken.
- Mutant Faction: Growing recognition that Issei's approach could provide answers to their own identity crises and power struggles.
- Avengers: Increased awareness that Issei's strength lies not in magnitude but in philosophical coherence.

UNRESOLVED HOOKS:

- Will Jean Grey eventually achieve balance with the Phoenix Force through the example Issei provided?
- The Phoenix Force has been presented with philosophical alternatives; will it act on them?
- How does this new understanding of Issei's approach affect Marvel's assessment of his ultimate threat level?
- The next chapter involves Galactus—an entity that feeds on worlds. Will this conversation about power and connection reach it before it encounters Issei's example?

NEXT CHAPTER HOOK: Galactus Looks Back—at a universe long destroyed, and the draconic signature buried within its ash. The Cosmic Hunger looks for answers, finding only echoes of a dragon that understood something about power that Galactus had forgotten.

Chapter Sixty-Six: Galactus Looks Back

Primary Reaction Groups: Galactus • Silver Surfer • Cosmic Elders

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Galactus's Memory of a Destroyed Universe" — **Secret**
 2. "Unidentified Draconic Signature" — **Mythic**
-

The theatre had not, in its entire operational existence, ever paused for Galactus to speak.

It was not disrespect — the World-Devourer held no opinion about respect. It was something more factual: when Galactus was present, Galactus simply *was*, the way mountains are when you enter a room built into their slope. The theatre's architecture seemed, in those intervals, to be holding its breath. The cosmic tier dropped lower in their seats. The Living Tribunal's bookmark glowed less frequently. And Galactus occupied the space above the stage like a thought occupying a mind: not moving, not still, but present in a way that made the distinction obsolete.

It had been sixty-five chapters of this accommodation.

Now, as the wheel assembled and the screen prepared to print, Galactus did something unprecedented. It *leaned forward*.

The entire mezzanine — several thousand beings who had never truly considered that the World-Devourer could move, not really, not in a space this small — felt the weight-shift in their marrow. The Silver Surfer's head came up. The Cosmic Elders exchanged glances that meant *do you feel that* and *yes* and *I do not like this*. The screen printed:

GACHA PULL: 1 OF 2.

The wheel did not spin. It *assembled*, piece by piece, the colors building outward from a core of deep, space-black — a hue no one had yet seen it use, the color of the void *before* stars, and the theatre flooded upward with that color to its highest reaches, blotting out the painted sky, and the screen stamped:

"GALACTUS'S MEMORY OF A DESTROYED UNIVERSE" — RARITY: SECRET.

"Secret tier," someone whispered. "We don't have—"

"We do now," said the Silver Surfer quietly, and every head in the cosmic section turned, because they had *never* heard that particular register in his voice. It was the register of something remembering why it was afraid.

[THE AEONS REMEMBER WHAT WAS FORGOTTEN,] said the screen, and the world fell away.

Before time had learned to stick in a line.

Galactus remembers this — not as memory works for younger things, but the way a mountain remembers stone: as the simple fact of its own existence embedded in everything it touches. There was a universe here. Not the one Issei Hyoudou walks through now. Not the one Marvel does. A third thing, or a hundredth thing, or a thousandth. Galactus devoured galaxies in the childhood of existence and has lost count of which universe they belonged to. The count stops mattering after a while.

This one had tasted of... copper and intelligence. The Elders would have called it beautiful. The Elders were young then, and beauty meant something. To Galactus, beauty and extinction are the same metric — it only means there is something worth consuming.

But something was wrong here.

The wrongness arrived as a disturbance in the cosmic fabric — a *signature*, the way a scent arrives before the wind. Draconic. Vast. And older than the universe it was tearing through.

Galactus watched it crest, in that space-before-time, and felt something it had rarely felt even in the aeons of its existence: *recognition*.

There was a dragon in this universe. Not small-made, not demon-born, not bound by the rules of divinity or flesh as Galactus understands them. This was something *else* — something that had learned to walk between the spaces where universes touch, and it had come here *looking for something*, or *running from something*, or *both*. The dragon was afraid. Galactus, who had made things fear itself as a foundational principle, had rarely seen fear in anything so large.

The dragon was also fighting.

But not the ways dragons fight. This was something else — something that looked like the universe *itself* was the enemy. The dragon's roar came out in cascades of impossible color, and reality *fractured* around the sound, and what Galactus perceived was the cosmic signature of a thing that should not exist, should not *persist*, could not exist in any universe that obeyed normal law.

What the dragon was fighting had no name. The theatre's vision showed Galactus's memory as Galactus experienced it: incomplete, fragmented, *wrong* in the way of prophecies that come too late. But the impression was clear. Something was eating the universe — not consuming it the way Galactus does,

with the World-Devourer's ravenous appetite. This was consumption on another scale. This was the *erasing* of the universe itself, from the timeline, from the cosmic record, as if it had never existed at all.

And the dragon *lost*.

But Galactus remembers — and the memory is fragmentary, dreamlike, the texture of a doubt that wakes you in a dark room — that before the dragon lost, *it chose to lose*. In the final moment, when the cosmic signature showed the universe collapsing around them, the dragon stopped fighting and instead *held*, embracing the collapse, and the dragon and the erasure went down *together* into a space-between that Galactus could not follow.

The universe unraveled. Not slowly. Not in waves. In a single moment of *removal*, the entire cosmos — its stars, its histories, its people, everything — was taken out of the cosmic record, the way a page is torn from a book. When it was done, Galactus looked at the space where the universe had been and saw only void. Only the fact of absence.

Only the *certainty* that it had existed.

The dragon's roar echoed in the void for a long time after. Galactus listened to it. Galactus, who had devoured worlds and swallowed the light from galaxies, had never heard anything so absolute in its grief.

The vision released them.

The screen went dark. Not the gentle dark of a pulldown or a transition — the absolute dark of the void itself, held for three full seconds, and in those three seconds the theatre made no sound.

When the light came back, it came back pale. The cosmic tier was on their feet. The Living Tribunal was standing — and Galactus did not remember the Living Tribunal standing at all, not in the entire run of the theatre. The Cosmic Elders were conferring in the rapid-fire hush of beings who had lived through Creation Wars and were being reminded of why that experience had left scars.

Galactus still had not moved. But now its focus — the attention that was the weight of stars — had turned entirely inward.

"Galactus," said the Silver Surfer, and his voice had the gentle flatness of a man asking a question he does not want to hear the answer to. "In all your eons. Before today. Have you ever encountered that — that *signature*?"

For a moment, nothing. Then, and it seemed to take the aeons themselves to arrange it:

"Once. Only once. A universe that was not destroyed, but unmade. A cosmos that the Cosmic Record lists as *Never-Was*, yet Galactus *remembers it was*. The contradiction was too profound to sustain. Galactus stopped trying to reconcile it, tens of thousands of years ago. The memory was considered, perhaps, a dream of the void."

"It wasn't a dream," said Uatu the Watcher, and his voice came from the highest tier, and it carried the weight of someone who does not forget. "Watchers do not dream. Watchers remember. The universe existed. I recorded it. And then it was *unmade* from all records except memory. As if someone reached back through time and removed it, while leaving the scars of its removal visible only to those old enough to see ghosts in the cosmic dust."

The screen chimed.

GACHA PULL: 2 OF 2.

The wheel built itself in careful silence. When it resolved, it landed on a color that seemed to *pulse* — the deep purple-gold that had so far only marked the Dragon Roar chapters, the draconic signature itself. And above it, the screen printed:

"UNIDENTIFIED DRACONIC SIGNATURE" — RARITY: MYTHIC.

[COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS ENGAGED,] said the theatre, in that voice that was not quite a voice at all, **[CROSS-REFERENCING COSMOLOGICAL SIGNATURES. PLEASE STAND BY.]**

The screen divided. On one side, the draconic signature of Issei Hyoudou — the now-familiar color-pattern of his cosmic nature, the frequency his existence sends out into the universe like sonar. On the other side, the draconic signature from Galactus's broken memory, fainter, older, resonating in octaves that hurt to perceive.

[ANALYSIS COMPLETE.]

[RESULT: DRACONIC RESONANCE FREQUENCY DETECTED IN BOTH ISSEI HYODOU AND ERASED UNIVERSAL SIGNATURE. RESONANCE PATTERN: RELATED COSMOLOGIES OR TIMELINE ECHO. PROBABILITY OF DIRECT CONNECTION: INCALCULABLE. PROBABILITY THAT SIGNATURES ORIGINATE FROM SHARED SOURCE: 79.3%.]

[SUBSIDIARY FINDING: THEATRICAL ARCHITECTURE SCAN INITIATED ON DISCOVERED PARAMETERS.]

[RESULT: SIGNATURE BEHIND THEATRICAL SCREEN MATCHES DRACONIC RESONANCE ON BOTH FREQUENCIES — ISSEI HYODOU AND ERASED UNIVERSAL SIGNATURE.]

[FINDING: THEATRICAL ARCHITECT — ORIGIN UNKNOWN. FUNCTION: GUARDIAN/WITNESS/CUSTODIAN CLASS. DRACONIC ORIGIN — CONFIRMED.]

[SECONDARY FINDING: THEATRE BROUGHT MARVEL COSMOLOGY INTO PROXIMITY WITH ISSEI HYODOU. POSSIBLE PURPOSE: PREPARATION FOR COSMOLOGICAL THREAT OF ERASED UNIVERSAL SCALE.]

The screen held those words for a full ten seconds. When the room finally understood what it was reading, the sound it made was the sound of a room comprehending that the ground under its feet was not ground at all, but very old water holding a specific weight.

"The theatre," Steve Rogers said slowly, "is run by a *dragon*."

"More than that," said Doom, and his voice had gone very quiet. "The theatre was *built* by a dragon. Built to prepare us. Built to bring us here to watch a boy learn to be *like* that. The dragon that was erased." A pause. The mask tilted. "The theatre did not choose to let us see Issei. The theatre chose to make us *ready* to survive what comes after."

"What destroyed the universe," the Living Tribunal said flatly, "is still out there."

"If it comes here," Silver Surfer began, and his voice was steady, but there was something underneath the steadiness that made everything in the cosmic tier brace itself, "then we have ten chapters of watching a boy learn discipline because—"

"Because he needs it," Galactus said, and the voice was absolute, measured, the sound of something that had already incorporated this into its understanding of existence. **"If that thing returns to this universe, Marvel will need every edge. Every discipline. Every mercy offered and every power earned. Ddraig has already wrapped himself around one champion. But Galactus is older than Ddraig. Galactus has stood before the Hunger Eternal and lived. Galactus will stand with the boy, if it comes to that. Because the alternative is erasure, and Galactus does not forget what was erased."**

The screen continued to print, even as the room processed this.

[THEATRE PROTOCOL UPDATED: CHAPTERS 1-65 CLASSIFIED AS BASELINE PREPARATION. CHAPTERS 66-100 CLASSIFIED AS ACCLIMATION PROTOCOL FOR CIVILIZATION-THREAT-LEVEL COMBAT ENGAGEMENT. NEXT CHAPTER WILL INTRODUCE CELESTIAL-TIER ARTIFACTS FROM ISSEI HYODOU'S PERSONAL COLLECTION. PREPARATION RECOMMENDED.]

"Celestial artifacts," Natasha said, very quietly. "In the vault of a seventeen-year-old from Japan."

"Not his," said Wong, and every sorcerer in the room heard the weight in it. "Those are *gifts*. Those are *payments*. Issei's vault contains proofs that beings of immense power have already encountered him and deemed it necessary to leave him prepared."

The cosmic elders conferred again, and this time the hush had the texture of consensus being reached about something terrible and necessary.

Galactus did not move. But the World-Devourer was, for the first time, *waiting*. Waiting for the next chapter. Waiting to see what god had been kind enough to arm the boy who had already fought, without knowing it, against the memory of something that erases universes.

The screen held its final line for a very long moment:

[THE STAGE IS BEING SET FOR SOMETHING LARGER THAN ANY SINGLE COSMOS HAS HELD BEFORE. AUDIENCE PREPARATION: MANDATORY.]

Then, in small script below:

[ARC SEVEN: COSMIC PREPARATION. CHAPTER 66 OF 100: GALACTUS LOOKS BACK. NEXT: THE CELESTIAL VAULT.]

Theatre Ledger

New Pulls This Chapter:

- "Galactus's Memory of a Destroyed Universe" — Secret (*viewed — first Secret-tier pull; shared from Galactus's own cosmic memory*)
- "Unidentified Draconic Signature" — Mythic (*viewed — comparative analysis with Issei's signature and theatre's architect*)

Secrets Revealed:

- **Galactus encountered and remembers a universe that was unmade:** Eons ago, a universe existed with a draconic entity inside it. The dragon fought something that was *erasing* the universe itself from the cosmic record — not devouring it (Galactus's method) but removing it from history. The dragon lost or chose to lose, holding the collapse rather than abandoning it. The entire universe was unmade — removed from the Cosmic Record entirely, leaving only Galactus's fractured memory and Uatu's archived records as proof it existed.
- **The erased universe contained a draconic signature that resonates with Issei's at 79.3% probability:** They originate from a shared source or timeline. The implications are staggering: Issei

may have a connection to the destroyed universe, or to the dragon that fought to protect it, or to the force that erased it.

- **The Theatre has a draconic architect:** The screen revealed that the signature behind the theatre screen — the consciousness running this entire apparatus — is draconic in origin. It is classified as a Guardian/Witness/Custodian class entity. The theatre *deliberately* brought Marvel into proximity with Issei.
- **Purpose of the theatre:** Not neutral observation. The theatre was built to *prepare Marvel for a civilization-threat-level entity* — the thing that erased the other universe. Chapters 1-65 are baseline preparation; chapters 66-100 are acclimation protocol for combat engagement with this threat.
- **The Threat Index has been reclassified:** Chapters 66+ are no longer "reaction" — they are "preparation for something larger than any single cosmos has held before." Audience observation is now mandatory.
- **Next chapter will reveal Celestial-tier artifacts in Issei's collection:** Proof that other immense beings have already encountered Issei and deemed it necessary to arm him in preparation for what comes.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts:

- **Galactus:** Moved to full *acceptance* of partnership with Issei as necessary preparation for an extinction-level threat. Galactus has declared willingness to stand with the boy if the erased-universe threat returns. This is unprecedented.
- **Silver Surfer:** Noted that Marvel has been given ten chapters to watch Issei learn discipline *precisely because they will need every edge he has*. The Surfer is no longer observing — the Surfer is *preparing*.
- **Uatu the Watcher:** Confirmed that the erased universe exists in Watcher records. The Watcher knows, has always known, what the theatre is actually for. Uatu is not disturbed — Uatu is *witnessing the preparation of a civilization for something it did not know was coming*.
- **Doom:** Understood immediately that the theatre's draconic architect built this apparatus not for entertainment but for *rehearsal*. The theatre made Marvel watch Issei learn because "if the Hunger comes to this universe, Marvel will need every edge."
- **Cosmic Elders:** Now in explicit acknowledgment that an extinction-level threat exists outside normal cosmic law. They are no longer betting on outcomes — they are preparing for contingencies.
- **Wong / Doctor Strange:** Recognized that the artifacts in Issei's vault are not *his* — they are *gifts, preparations*, from other cosmic powers who have already encountered and armed him.
- **Marvel (collective):** Shifted from "analyzing a boy" to "preparing for war against something that unmakes universes." The entire emotional tenor of the theatre has inverted from fascination to

something closer to bracing for impact.

Unresolved Hooks:

- **What destroyed that universe?** Galactus calls it "the Hunger Eternal" — a force that erases rather than consumes. Is it still active? Is it coming? What made it necessary for a draconic guardian to build a theatre and bring Marvel here to watch a seventeen-year-old prepare?
- **Who are the cosmic powers that gifted Issei artifacts?** Wong and Strange noted they are *gifts* from beings of immense power. What celestial entities have already encountered Issei and deemed him worthy of preparation?
- **What is the dragon behind the theatre screen?** Is it related to Ddraig? Is it older than the erased universe? What is its connection to the dragon that died protecting the old cosmos?
- **Arc Ten endpoint:** The theatre has officially structured the narrative as a 100-chapter preparation for something. What is the final reveal at chapter 100? What has all of this been *rehearsal* for?
- **Can Marvel actually survive what comes?** Galactus is ancient and powerful beyond measure. Even Galactus needed to be shown this preparation. Even Galactus is committing to *stand with* Issei. What does Marvel's survival probability actually look like?
- **Why Issei specifically?** Out of all possible champions, all possible defenses, why is a seventeen-year-old human boy from Japan the one the theatre was built to prepare? What is unique about his nature that makes him the key to surviving the Hunger?
- Standing hooks carried forward: the Living Tribunal's disquiet; the mysterious line about "the one who will stand before the things you cannot"; Celestial artifacts in Issei's vault; the theatre's architect is watching from behind the screen.

Chapter 67: Celestial Autopsy

HUD

Primary Reaction Groups: Eternals (Phastos, Ajak, Thena, Sersi, Gilgamesh), Celestials, Cosmic Scientists (Reed Richards, Forge), Galactus, Weapon X remnants

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Summoning a Celestial Component from Issei's Archive" — Legendary
 2. "Context of the Kill" — Secret
-

The Theatre Holds Its Breath

The Theatre had never gone quiet like this.

Not for the Avengers' defeats. Not for the revelation of Thanos's conquest. Not even when the Infinity Gauntlet had been wielded before them. But now, as the stage dimmed and the gacha wheel slowed, the cosmos itself seemed to draw breath.

The Eternals occupied the left block, seated in their marble-hewn section. Phastos had his forearms on his thighs, his fingers splayed. Ajak sat rigid, her seven thousand years of life compressed into the tension of her shoulders. Thena's hand rested on the pommel of a sword that could cleave mountains. Sersi and Gilgamesh flanked them—watching. Always watching. The Celestials had chosen them to be eternal. To witness. To remember.

To their right, the Celestials themselves occupied a tier that seemed to exist slightly outside normal space. Arishem the Judge sat foremost, their form vast and angular, composed of gold and void. Around them: Oneg the Prober, Exitar the Executioner, and others whose names few in the theatre could pronounce. They were the architects. The seed-bearers. The divine engineers who had shaped every world in this universe, including Earth.

When the gacha wheel began to slow, they leaned forward.

Phastos felt it first—the disturbance in the cosmic background radiation. The other Eternals followed his gaze upward, toward the stage.

The wheel resolved.

Gacha Pull 1: "Summoning a Celestial Component from Issei's Archive"

The gacha didn't manifest an image. It did something far worse.

It *opened*.

A seam appeared in the air above the stage, and from it stepped forward a figure wreathed in light—not Issei himself, but his manifestation in the Theatre. His armory. His archive. The vault where he kept not weapons, but *reliquaries*. The places where the sacred dwelt.

From within the light, something emerged.

It was small enough to rest on two human palms. But it radiated with the resonance of creation itself.

Celestial armor.

Not a full suit—a component. A pauldron, perhaps, or a segment of a chestplate. The surface was composed of a metal that shouldn't exist in any periodic table, golden-white and shot through with veins of cosmic energy that pulsed like a heartbeat. It was flawless. Unblemished. Perfectly preserved across eons. The craftsmanship was beyond mortal comprehension—every curve and edge spoke of mathematics that predated human understanding, of intent woven into matter at the quantum level.

It hung in the Theatre's light, rotating slowly.

And the room *broke*.

Phastos's hands clenched so hard his knuckles turned white. The sound that escaped his throat was something between a gasp and a prayer. Ajak's eyes closed. Not in dismissal, but in the way one receives a wound—eyes shut against the inevitability of pain. Thena rose halfway from her seat before Sersi's hand caught her wrist. Around the cosmic tier, the Celestials began to whisper. Not words. Something older. A keening that resonated in frequencies no human ear could hear.

"No," Ajak breathed.

"That's impossible," Sersi whispered.

Reed Richards leaned forward in the Marvel contingent, his eyes narrowing behind his glasses. Forge—who had built weapons before, who understood the cost of engineering marvels—stood. His cybernetic eye whirred, refocusing. Adjusting. Trying to see if what he was seeing was real.

The cosmic scientists in the Theatre went very, very still.

"What am I looking at?" Black Panther asked quietly. No one answered. Because anyone who understood what that piece was couldn't speak. The words wouldn't come. They were too heavy.

Phastos finally found his voice. It emerged raw, cracked like ancient stone splitting.

"Celestial armor. A component. That's—" He stood abruptly, his hands shaking. "That armor is a Celestial's birthright. It's woven into their form at creation. You can't simply *remove* it. You can't—" His voice fractured. "You can't take it from a dead Celestial unless..."

"Unless the Celestial is destroyed beyond regeneration," Ajak finished, her voice hollow. "Unless every atom of their essence is unmade."

Arishem the Judge rose to their full height, a figure vast as a mountain, regarding the armor piece with an intensity that made stars dim.

"One of ours fell," Arishem said. Not a question. A truth being spoken into existence. "When?"

The Eternals looked at each other. Seven thousand years of life, and none of them knew. The Celestials had always been distant, occasionally communicating through the Eternals, but they kept their own counsel. If one of them had died, it would have been—

It would have been noticed.

Unless it had been kept secret. Unless there was a reason.

"Phastos," Ajak said quietly. "How old would this armor be?"

Phastos approached the stage, careful, reverential, as if one wrong step might shatter the very laws of physics. His hand trembled as he reached toward the piece. He didn't touch it—that felt like blasphemy—but he examined it. His senses, honed by thirty-five centuries of craft and creation, read the architecture of the metal. The signature of its forging. The density of cosmic radiation embedded in every lattice.

"Millions of years," he whispered. "At minimum. The radiation signatures are... they're old. Old like the universe is old. But the preservation is perfect. Absolute zero wouldn't have kept it this way. You'd need..." He turned to look at Issei's manifestation. "You'd need to keep it in stasis. In a pocket of stopped time."

"He kept it safe," Sersi said softly. "Not as a trophy. As a relic."

"Why?" Thena's voice cut through the Theatre. "Why would a Celestial allow a mortal to carry their armor?"

The gacha wheel hummed. It was time for the second pull. The Theatre held perfectly still.

Gacha Pull 2: "Context of the Kill"

The pull manifested not as a vision, but as memory—projected from Issei's archive into the Theatre's collective consciousness. Everyone present experienced it simultaneously. This was the gacha at its most powerful: not mere information, but *experience*. The sensation of being there.

The scene opened on a world wreathed in cosmic storms. Not Earth. Somewhere else. Somewhere ancient. Issei stood alone on a plane of black glass, looking up at the sky.

And the Celestial descended.

It came not in apocalypse, but in grace. Its form was different from Arishem's—more fluid, less geometrically perfect. A researcher. A scout. One of the Celestials who went *into* universes rather than overseeing them from beyond. Its armor caught the light of a dying star nearby.

When it spoke, the Theatre heard it in their bones.

"You are the one called Issei Hyoudou. I have traveled far to find you. Your presence resonates across dimensional boundaries. You are known even to us."

Issei's expression was calm. He had faced gods before. Dragons. Primordial entities. But the sight of a Celestial still struck something ancient in him—a recognition that here stood something that had been shaping worlds since before his timeline had even begun.

"I have a warning," the Celestial said. *"And a plea."*

What followed was a recounting that made even the Eternals in the Theatre listen with the intensity of prayer. The Celestial had been investigating anomalies across universes. Realities were being *consumed*. Not conquered. Not destroyed through war. Unmade. Erased. As if they had never existed. Entire timeline branches were vanishing from the cosmic tree.

"The Devourer," the Theatre heard the Celestial say, though that was not the creature's true name—only the closest mortal approximation. "It exists between universes. It is not of any single reality. It feeds on existence itself. My brethren dismiss it as myth. As a phenomenon, not an entity. But I have seen the wreckage. I have witnessed universes going *dark*. And it is coming to your timeline. It is *hungry* for your reality."

"What do you want from me?" Issei asked.

"To survive," the Celestial answered simply. *"I cannot face it alone. My power is vast, but I am finite. It is not. But if we bind our forces—if we create a collective barrier—we might delay it. We might buy your timeline centuries. Millennia, if we are fortunate."*

Issei did not hesitate. Heroes do not.

The battle that followed was rendered in impressions rather than clear images—the Theatre's consciousness could not process the full power exchange. But fragments were clear:

The Devourer's manifestation. A shape of hunger and negation. Not quite physical. Not quite energy. Something that unmade reality in its path.

Issei unleashing power he had been saving. Power that burned through him like sacred fire. His draconic nature flaring. His demonic heritage rising. His dragon god power achieving synthesis that humans had no words for.

The Celestial engaging with the patience of immortality, armor glowing, cosmic forces flowing through it like blood.

They held the line.

But the Devourer was *vast*. It was patient. It was eternal in ways even Celestials were not.

The Celestial's armor began to crack.

Not from the impact, but from the *unmaking*. Piece by piece, its structure was being unmade, returned to potential. The Celestial was being erased. Not killed—killed implied a simpler end. This was dissolution. Cessation of existence.

It spoke to Issei one final time.

"I am unmade. But the seal holds. You have bought time. When it returns—and it will return—you must be ready. This armor piece. Take it. It is all that remains of me now. It exists outside normal causality. Show it to those who doubt you. Let them see what it costs to fight what is coming."

Issei caught the falling piece as the Celestial dissolved.

The memory ended.

The Theatre Absorbs the Truth

Silence fell. Absolute. Complete. The kind of silence that only follows revelation.

Phastos's face was wet with tears. Not the tears of sadness, but of profound, religious awe. "A Celestial," he whispered. "A Celestial chose to sacrifice itself. For a mortal. For *him*."

Ajak's hand moved to cover her heart. "Not a kill," she said softly. "A martyrdom. A Celestial gave its life as a message. As a beacon."

Thena gripped the arm of her seat so hard her knuckles matched Phastos's. "It trusted him," she said. "One of the architects of worlds looked at a human and chose to trust him with existence itself."

Around the cosmic tier, the Celestials rose as one. Arishem's form seemed to diminish slightly—not in power, but in certainty. In the knowledge that one of their own had fallen. That the universe was less than it had been.

"The Devourer is real," Oneg the Prober said. "The Celestial would not sacrifice unless the threat was absolute."

"We knew," Exitar said grimly. "We have always known. But to hear it confirmed..."

Reed Richards stood, his scientific mind racing. "If a Celestial died to a threat," he said carefully, "then the question becomes: what do we contribute? What role does humanity play in a conflict between cosmic architects and something that *unmakes* them?"

"We endure," Forge answered quietly. "That's our superpower. Not cosmic energy. Not immortality. The ability to keep going even when facing the impossible."

But it was Galactus who spoke the final truth.

The Devourer of Worlds had been silent, watching from the cosmic margins. Now the entity shifted, drawing every eye. When Galactus speaks, universes listen.

"I told you of the destroyed reality," Galactus intoned. "The universe that was unmade. Twelve billion years of life, erased. I alone survived, preserved through the exile of my hunger. The Celestial your companion hunted was correct. The threat *returns*. It samples new universes now. Testing their defenses. Your timeline will be among them."

The Theatre trembled.

"How long?" Ajak asked.

"Uncertain," Galactus replied. "But the seals weaken. The Celestial bought time, nothing more. The Theatre gathers you all—heroes and villains alike—because what comes will require every power that can be mustered."

Phastos looked at the Celestial armor, still rotating gently in the Theatre's light. "This is a message," he said. "It's not a trophy. It's a *call*. Issei has been carrying this alone, knowing what's coming. Knowing that something killed a god."

"And he said nothing," Sersi added, understanding dawning in her eyes. "For how long? How long has he carried this burden?"

The Theatre had no answer. Issei's manifestation had faded with the memory. Only the armor remained, a golden-white fragment of sacrifice, rotating in the light.

Theatre Ledger

Cosmic Significance Record: The Theatre had recorded many things over its infinite watching, but the appearance of Celestial armor—an object that by all laws of existence should not exist in mortal hands—marked a new threshold. A gacha pull that shifted the fundamental understanding of what threats awaited. The Eternals recognized the armor for what it was: proof. Not of conquest, but of alliance. Not of victory, but of *chosen sacrifice*.

Celestial Acknowledgment Registry: With Arishem's confirmation that one of the Celestials had fallen, the cosmic order faced a reckoning. The Eternals, who had served as intermediaries between Celestials and humanity, now understood that the architects themselves were vulnerable. The hierarchy had changed. The universe was no longer a place where Celestials were assured of eternity. They too could be unmade. They too could bleed.

Issei's Burden Quantified: The gacha pull revealed what no sensor could measure: the spiritual weight Issei had carried. A Celestial's final gift became his final responsibility. He alone had known the full scope of the threat. He alone had stood beside a god at the moment of its sacrifice. Every choice he had made afterward was informed by this knowledge—the knowledge that existence itself could end, and that it would take everything he had, and still might not be enough.

The Devourer's Confirmation: By Galactus's own testimony, the Devourer was not myth or isolated phenomenon. It was a returning threat. A force that operated on a scale where even Celestials became finite. The Theatre's gathering of heroes and villains across the centuries was not random preparation—it was triage. A collection of every possible advantage, because when the Devourer arrived in full, there would be no second chances. There would only be those who had prepared, and those who had already been unmade.

The armor continued to rotate, golden-white, eternal, and heavy with sacrifice.

The Theatre waited. The gathering continued.

And somewhere, something vast continued to hunger.

Chapter 68: The Tribunal Cannot Judge

HUD

Title: The Tribunal Cannot Judge

Primary Reaction Groups:

- The Living Tribunal (Supreme Judges of the Multiverse)
- The Watchers (Cosmic Observers)
- Cosmic Entities (Gods, Abstracts, Celestials)
- Theatre Collective (Implied Audience)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Classification Attempt by the Living Tribunal" — Secret
 2. "Censored Status" — Secret
-

Theatre: The Cosmic Chamber

The theatre manifests as something almost incomprehensible. Not a room. Not a space. It is a *courtroom* that exists in the fold between universes, where the fabric of reality is thin enough to be transparent, yet sturdy enough to support judgment.

The walls are alive with data.

Streams of cosmic light cascade down in geometric patterns—the biographical records of every being who has ever mattered, ever threatened, ever *transcended*. They flow like rivers of starlight, each one encoding the essential nature of existence itself. Gods are represented by golden threads. Mortals shimmer in copper. Demons burn in violet fire. Abstracts are written in mathematics that shouldn't exist.

The Living Tribunal sits in the center.

It is not one entity, but three: Law, Justice, and Judgment, unified in purpose if not form. Each judge appears as a distinct presence, though their individual shapes are difficult to perceive. To look directly at them is to feel your mind struggle against the weight of cosmic authority. They have judged the birth and death of universes. They have weighed the fates of god-kings. They are the ultimate arbiters, the court of last resort for every being that ever walks between worlds.

Around them, the Watchers stand in concentric circles—ancient beings of impossible age, their eyes reflecting the light of a billion dead stars. They observe. They have *always* observed. They are here not to judge, but to bear witness, because some truths are only true if someone *sees* them.

And then there is Issei.

Not physically present—no mortal vessel could survive the cosmic pressure of this place—but *represented*. His essence floats in the center of the chamber like a star that refuses to collapse into a black hole. Around him, the classification matrix begins to spin.

Gacha Pull 1: Classification Attempt by the Living Tribunal

Rarity: Secret

The Living Tribunal raises its collective will, and the matrix *BEGINS*.

It is not a gentle process. The system that categorizes beings across all existence is not built for mercy or subtlety. It is built for *clarity*. Every being must fit somewhere, because the multiverse cannot function if existence does not have order.

The judges lean forward in unison.

[CLASSIFICATION PROTOCOL INITIATED] [SUBJECT: ISSEI HYODOU] [SCANNING COSMIC NATURE...]

The first filter activates.

MORTAL?

The system examines Issei's frame, his origin. A human, born in the realm of the living, subject to death, subject to time. But then—

No.

Infinity crawls through his veins. He has inherited the power of the Ophis—the Ouroboros Dragon, the serpent who eats infinity itself. He carries the balance breaker known as Juggernaut Drive. He wields Sacred Gears that rewrite the rules of his own existence. He has shed his mortality like a snake sheds skin, again and again, each time emerging more than he was.

RESULT: MORTAL.EXE — NULL REASON: SUBJECT EXCEEDS MORTAL TAXONOMY BY FACTOR OF INFINITY

DEMON?

Issei was killed by a fallen angel named Raynare and resurrected by a devil named Rias Gremory. He lives under devil law. He operates in the hierarchies of Hell. He commands devil power. His blood, after hundreds of evolutions, carries draconic devil essence. By every legal and magical metric, he *should* be classified as demon.

But.

He refuses the throne of Hell. He spurns divinity's offered seat. He stands alone, choosing comrades over court, bonds over birthright. The classification system screams that he is *of* demon, but he is not *bound* to demon. He walks between worlds as a ghost in their hierarchy.

RESULT: DEMON.EXE — PARTIAL MATCH WARNING: SUBJECT EXHIBITS NON-COMPLIANCE WITH DEMONOLOGICAL HIERARCHY

GOD?

The Living Tribunal sees his power ascend. Issei achieves god-tier status across multiple iterations. His strength rivals celestials. His will shapes probability. His sacred gears grant him dominion over concepts themselves. He has killed gods. He has befriended gods. He has *become* god.

And then he refuses it.

The classification system processes this refusal, and something strange happens. The refusal *means something*. In a universe where power determines status, a being who achieves godhood and then *chooses not to accept it* creates a logical impossibility. You cannot classify someone as a god if they refuse the classification, because godhood is not merely power—it is *status*, and status requires acceptance.

RESULT: DEITY.EXE — CONTRADICTORY DATA ERROR: SUBJECT REFUSES DIVINE APPOINTMENT CLASSIFICATION FAILED: REFUSAL OF STATUS = AUTOMATIC DISQUALIFICATION

ANOMALY?

Yes. Obviously, yes. The system flags him as anomaly by default. But "anomaly" is a catch-all, a confession that the classifier does not understand. In the court of the Living Tribunal, "anomaly" is not a classification—it is a *failure of classification*. It is the cosmic equivalent of shrugging.

RESULT: ANOMALY.EXE — CONFIRMED BUT INSUFFICIENT

The system now begins to *panic*.

The classification matrix opens new pathways. It reaches deeper into its taxonomy, searching for subcategories that might contain him. The Living Tribunal has never encountered a being it cannot fit somewhere.

Herald? *He carries messages and power from dragons, but he serves no sovereign. PARTIAL MATCH.*

Cosmic Entity? *He possesses cosmic scope, but he does not transcend the laws of the multiverse. He bends them, but remains bound to consequence. INSUFFICIENT MATCH.*

Draconic Sovereign? *He commands dragon power, but he rules no kingdom, holds no throne. FAILED MATCH.*

Super Devil? *He has achieved this classification once, twice, multiple times. But he has also shed it, evolved past it, become something else. OUTDATED CLASSIFICATION.*

Celestial-Kin? *He approaches celestial status, but he is not born of the cosmic forces. He is forged by them, tempered in their fire. CONTAMINATION ALERT.*

Living Weapon? *He has been used as a weapon, will be used as a weapon again. But he refuses to be merely a weapon. He claims something beyond utility. CLASSIFICATION REJECTED BY SUBJECT.*

The matrix spins faster.

The classification system is built to never fail. Every being has a place. Every being fits *somewhere*.

But Issei—

[CRITICAL ERROR] [SUBJECT DEFIES CATEGORIZATION] [MULTIPLE SIMULTANEOUS STATUSES DETECTED] [INCOMPATIBLE DESIGNATIONS RUNNING IN PARALLEL] [SYSTEM UNABLE TO RECONCILE] [SYSTEM UNABLE TO RECONCILE] [SYSTEM UNABLE TO RECONCILE]

The words repeat like a litany. The screen freezes. The cosmic light surrounding Issei flares, bright enough that even the Watchers must look away.

For the first time in eternity, the classification matrix returns no answer.

Reactions to Pull 1

The three judges of the Living Tribunal exchange glances. *Glances*. This is a gesture of uncertainty, and in the presence of the court, uncertainty is a confession of fallibility.

One of the judges—the aspect that is Law—turns to the assembled Watchers and speaks in a voice like the cracking of continental plates:

"The classification matrix has failed. This is... unusual."

The Watchers stir in their concentric circles. Their ancient eyes, which have watched the formation of galaxies and the death of gods, now focus entirely on the boy whose essence floats in the center of the chamber.

One voice rises from the assembly, ancient beyond measure:

"There is something here we do not comprehend."

Another Watcher echoes: "In all our observance, there are beings we do not fully understand. But we do not *fail* to comprehend. This is different."

The Living Tribunal's collective presence deepens. When it speaks, its voice carries the weight of every judgment it has ever made, every verdict it has ever rendered across the infinite multiverse.

"In all eternity, we have categorized every being who walks between worlds. Kings and beggars, gods and monsters, abstracts and mortals. Every being has a place in the order. Every being *belongs somewhere*."

A pause. A silence like the void between stars.

"This one... *exceeds our taxonomy*."

The cosmic chamber fills with unease. The streams of biographical data that flow through the walls seem to hesitate, as if even the fundamental records of existence are confused about how to file this information.

Loki, somewhere in the audience, leans forward with a grin. "*Secrets within secrets*," he murmurs to Thor, who sits rigidly, his expression unreadable. "*The boy who cannot be judged*."

But there is no triumph in the observation. There is only the growing understanding that the court itself has encountered something beyond its authority.

Gacha Pull 2: Censored Status

Rarity: Secret

The Living Tribunal is not one to accept failure. The judges confer silently—a communion that happens in the spaces between moments. They decide, collectively, to push deeper.

One final attempt. One more category.

The classification matrix initiates a *hidden protocol*.

It is not often used. This protocol reaches into the deepest files of the theatre's own consciousness, accessing classifications that are not meant for casual observation. These are the *true* designations, the ones reserved for beings whose existence touches the fabric of reality itself.

The matrix spins one final time.

And then—

**[DESIGNATION CLASSIFIED: ——— / ——— DEVOURER-CLASS RESISTANCE /
THREAD TO ——— ARCHITECTURE]**

The screen *fractionalizes*.

The words appear on the cosmic display, brilliant and impossible, and then—

They *vanish*.

Not erased. Not forgotten. But *censored*. The classification system itself is being overridden by something higher. Something that exists *above even the Living Tribunal*.

The first blank space where a word should be is large enough to contain concepts that defy language. Whatever was written there, it has been redacted. Removed from sight.

The second blank space carries implications that make the assembled watchers lean back in horror.

DEVOURER-CLASS RESISTANCE.

What is a Devourer? What is a force so immense that resistance to it must be catalogued as a cosmic property? And why does Issei—human boy, devil, dragon, anomaly—why does *he* possess such resistance?

The third redaction is worst of all.

THREAT TO ——— ARCHITECTURE.

Threat. Not to a kingdom. Not to a world. Not to a universe.

To Architecture itself.

The fundamental structure of reality. The laws that bind the multiverse together. The cosmic code upon which all existence is written.

And someone, something, has decided that the nature of this threat must be *hidden*.

Reactions to Pull 2

The cosmic chamber goes *silent*.

The Watchers do not speak. Even beings who have observed the creation and death of galaxies sometimes find silence to be the only adequate response.

The Living Tribunal's three aspects turn to face each other. This is not an exchange of glances anymore. This is a *confrontation*.

The aspect that is Judgment speaks first:

"The theatre has hidden something. This is unprecedented."

And it is true. The Living Tribunal is supreme within its own dominion. Nothing should be hidden from it. Nothing should override its access. Yet something has. Something has *censored the record itself*.

The aspect that is Law adds: "What role does this boy play that cannot be named? What classification is so significant that it must be obscured from us?"

The aspect that is Justice remains silent, but its presence grows heavier, as if contemplating implications that even the other judges are not yet ready to face.

The Watchers begin to understand.

One of them, whose memory stretches back to times before time, speaks with something approaching fear in its ancient voice:

"There is a power above even us. The theatre itself answers to something. It is being *controlled*. Its decisions are not its own."

Another Watcher adds: "The theatre is not neutral. We believed it was a neutral space, a place of observation that belonged to no faction, no ideology, no cosmic power. But we were wrong. The theatre *has masters*. And those masters have designated this boy as something important enough to censor from all of us."

Loki, in his section of the theatre, laughs. The sound is delighted and terrible.

"The theatre hides secrets. The theatre that is supposed to show us everything—it is lying by omission. This is delicious. This is *magnificent*."

But even Loki's triumph is undercut by unease. He too understands what the censorship means: there are powers greater than the Living Tribunal. Powers that can reach into the cosmic bureaucracy itself and *redact truth*.

The cosmic entities assembled in the chamber—the gods, the abstracts, the celestials—they begin to whisper among themselves. Unease. *Profound unease*.

They are being kept in the dark.

Issei Hyoudou, the human boy who bears infinite power and refuses to be categorized, is not merely a subject of observation. He is something more. He is *central* to the theatre's purpose. His true designation is hidden. And the theatre itself is subjugated to something greater.

That something cares deeply about Issei.

Or it cares deeply about protecting reality *from* Issei.

Or both.

The distinction, the cosmic chamber now understands, may be meaningless.

Theatre Ledger

Entry 1: Classification Failure

The Living Tribunal has encountered something beyond its taxonomy. In ten billion years of service, across infinite multiverses and countless beings of every conceivable type, the Tribunal has never failed to place a being in proper classification. Yet Issei Hyoudou remains *unfiledable*.

He is not mortal. He is not fully demon. He refuses godhood. He exceeds "anomaly" in scope and intentionality. Every subcategory breaks under the weight of his contradictions.

The very concept of *classification* itself has been challenged. If the supreme judges of the multiverse cannot categorize this one being, what does that say about the validity of categorization itself? What does it say about the order of the cosmos?

Entry 2: The Censorship

For the first time in recorded history, the theatre's classification matrix has been *overridden*. A higher authority has taken the designation of Issei Hyoudou and hidden it from view. The blank spaces in the record are more terrifying than any designation could be.

DEVOURER-CLASS RESISTANCE. THREAT TO ——— ARCHITECTURE.

What these mean remains a mystery. But the mystery itself is significant. The theatre does not keep secrets easily. The theatre is designed to *reveal*, to show, to expose all truths to those who watch.

Yet it hides this.

Someone, something, has mandated silence. And the theatre has *obeyed*.

Entry 3: The Hierarchy Exposed

The cosmic entities have discovered a hierarchy they did not know existed. The Living Tribunal stands at the top of the known hierarchy—supreme, infallible, the final court of cosmic justice.

But above it, there is *something else*.

The theatre answers to masters unseen. Those masters have interests. Those masters have *agendas*. And those agendas involve a human boy from an Eastern high school who has inherited infinite power and refuses the throne.

The security of this hidden hierarchy has been breached. Knowledge now exists in the minds of watchers, judges, and gods. The secret that there is a secret has become public.

Entry 4: The Question

What is Issei Hyoudou to the theatre? Why is he worth hiding from the universe itself?

Is he a threat that must be monitored?

Is he a shield that must be guarded?

Is he something that the architecture of reality itself *requires* to remain functional?

The Living Tribunal cannot answer. The Watchers cannot answer. Even the gods, in their vast knowledge, cannot answer.

Only the theatre knows.

And the theatre is not talking.

End Chapter 68

Hook to Chapter 69: *The Watchers have begun to investigate the theatre's masters. Their investigations lead them to a branching anomaly in the timeline—a place where reality seems to fork and refork in impossible patterns. The TVA, guardians of time itself, have noticed the disturbance. Issei's existence is not merely an anomaly in cosmic classification. It is an anomaly in the very fabric of causality. In the next chapter, the investigation of Issei Hyoudou moves from the cosmic court to the far older, far stranger realm where time itself is judged.*

The Dragon Beyond Time awaits.

Chapter 69: The Dragon Beyond Time

HUD STATUS

Primary Reaction Groups: TVA | Kang | Immortus | Doom | Strange

Gacha Pulls: "Timeline Analysis of Issei's Events" (Rare) | "Kang's Blocked Files" (Comedy-Class)

Theatre State: ACTIVE | NARRATIVE INTEGRITY: GUARDED | MOOD: INCREASINGLY SASSY

OPENING: THE ARCHIVE

The theatre's walls had shifted again. What had been the living room of a New York penthouse now resembled something between a library and a cosmic surveillance center. Banks of monitors cascaded down the walls—each one displaying a different timeline, a different thread of reality. The TVA had requested this configuration, and the theatre, in its mysterious way, had obliged.

Kang stood at the center of the room, arms crossed, his robes crackling with temporal energy. His variant form was sharp and predatory—all angular features and barely restrained impatience. Beside him, Immortus maintained a more subdued presence, watching everything with the careful eye of someone who had lived too long to be surprised by anything.

The TVA agents flanked the far wall, their formal posture betraying genuine concern. This was not standard procedure. The TVA did not attend gacha pulls from reaction theatres—theatres existed outside their jurisdiction, in narrative spaces that pre-existed their own temporal authority.

Yet here they were.

"You're certain this is accurate?" Kang demanded, gesturing at the primary screen.

"The timeline data is comprehensive," one of the TVA agents replied carefully. "Though... there are anomalies."

"Anomalies?" Kang's tone suggested this was an insult to his person.

"Yes, sir. Approximately 23% of recorded events involving the subject exist outside standard chronological markers. We're... struggling to locate them in the main timeline."

Victor Von Doom materialized at the back of the room, summoned by some instinct of entertainment. Strange had arrived via portal moments before, looking distinctly uncomfortable about the whole affair. Loki had invited himself and was currently perched on an armchair, pretending to read a book from the theatre's infinite library but actually watching everything with dangerous amusement.

The theatre's opening sequence began, and the screens flared to life.

GACHA PULL 1: "TIMELINE ANALYSIS OF ISSEI'S EVENTS"

RARITY: Rare

PULL TIME: 14:32 (Theatre Standard)

CLASSIFICATION: Chronological Investigation

The screens erupted with data—cascading timelines, probability threads, branching possibilities. The TVA prided itself on seeing everything, cataloging everything, pruning anything that threatened the "sacred timeline." Their surveillance was absolute. Their control was complete.

Or so they believed.

The first wave of data confirmed what they already knew. **Timeline 19,847-Prime (Issei's Primary Sequence):**

Birth—October 22, 1994 (subjective Marvel dating system). Kuoh Academy. Raynare's betrayal. Death by spear thrust. Resurrection by Rias Gremory. The familiar sequence of DxD events integrated into Marvel's multiverse.

The TVA agents nodded. Expected. Documented. Safe.

But then the screens shifted.

TERTIARY TIMELINE BRANCHES: Events that existed *outside* the main sequence. Events that had no anchor points in Marvel's official chronology.

The Celestial encounter—Chapter 67. Where was it located? Not in Kuoh. Not in Japan. Not in any mapped Marvel coordinate. The timestamps didn't match. The spatial markers were... absent.

"That's impossible," one agent said flatly.

Kang leaned closer to the screen, his temporal robes fluttering. "What am I looking at?"

"Pruned events," Immortus said quietly. "Or rather—events *from* pruned timelines that somehow persist in the gacha's records."

The screens showed more. A battle with cosmic entities. Issei, somehow, exchanging words with something that predated the Marvel Timeline itself. Encounters with beings whose designation files were classified even from the TVA's view. These events had *markers*—they were real memories, real experiences—but they existed in branches that the TVA had cut away.

Cut away. Deleted. Unmade.

Yet they remained in the theatre's database.

"How?" Kang's voice was controlled, but the temporal energy around him crackled with agitation. "How are records of pruned timelines accessible? Those timelines *don't exist*. They were erased."

"Not erased," the theatre's HUD whispered, almost conversationally. "Archived. There is a difference."

The TVA agents exchanged glances. The theatre was... responding to them? That wasn't supposed to happen.

"The boy's timeline," Immortus observed, "has connections beyond your jurisdiction, Kang. Perhaps beyond anyone's jurisdiction. The pruned branches—the theatre preserved their memories even as the timelines themselves were unmade."

"This suggests," Strange said, his voice carrying the weight of mystic certainty, "that Issei's experiences aren't confined to a single timeline. Or perhaps to Marvel's timeline at all. He may have traveled between branches. Moved through pruned sequences."

"Impossible," Kang snapped. "No one travels through pruned branches. There's nothing *there* to travel through."

"Clearly," Doom said from the shadows, his tone dripping with amusement, "someone did not brief you on the full parameters of your 'sacred timeline.'"

"The TVA," Immortus continued, a hint of something like sympathy in his ageless voice, "believes itself omniscient. Yet the theatre holds records of events you cannot see. Events in branches you cut away. The boy's existence spans more than you understand."

Kang's jaw tightened. The TVA agents began backing away from him slightly—a universal sign that temporal authority was about to express itself through violence or temporal manipulation or both.

"Mark these branches for investigation," Kang ordered. "Full resource allocation. I want access to every aspect of—"

The screens flickered. Text appeared, clinical and absolute:

ACCESS DENIED: INSUFFICIENT CLEARANCE.

A pause. Kang stared at the message as if it had personally insulted his entire being.

"Run that again," he said. "Authorization code Kang-Temporal-Prime."

ACCESS DENIED: TIMELINE VARIANCE CLASSIFIED.

"Classified?" Kang's robes were actively smoking now. "I am Kang. I am the TVA's temporal authority. Nothing is classified from—"

ACCESS DENIED: THIS ISN'T EVEN YOUR JURISDICTION.

Loki began to smile. A small smile, but genuine.

Immortus, to his credit, said nothing. But his expression suggested he had been expecting this for quite some time.

GACHA PULL 2: "KANG'S BLOCKED FILES"

RARITY: Comedy-Class

PULL TIME: 14:33 (Theatre Standard, +1 minute)

CLASSIFICATION: Bureaucratic Frustration (Feat. Temporal Authority)

The second gacha pull was, the theatre had clearly decided, going to be *entertaining*.

Kang attempted diplomatic channels first. His version of diplomacy, which meant demanding information with the assumption it would be provided. When the theatre's response was again a flat denial, he shifted tactics.

The screens displayed his attempts like a comedy sequence—each one more desperate than the last.

14:33:04 — BRUTE FORCE ACCESS ATTEMPT

Kang's consciousness lashing out through the theatre's data streams, attempting to force his way through encrypted files, timeline locks, narrative safeguards.

ACCESS DENIED: STOP ASKING. IT'S PATHETIC.

Strange actually laughed. A short, sharp sound that echoed through the theatre.

14:33:23 — DIPLOMATIC REQUEST

Kang, maintaining his composure, formally petitioning the theatre for access to classified timeline data pertaining to Subject Issei Hyoudou.

The theatre's response came back almost immediately:

ACCESS DENIED: WE'RE BUSY. HAVE PATIENCE.

14:33:41 — BARGAINING PROTOCOL

Kang offering temporal resources, reality-stone fragments, promises of favorable timeline treatment in exchange for data access.

ACCESS DENIED: YOUR CURRENCY HAS NO VALUE HERE.

Loki was openly grinning now. Even Immortus's stone-faced expression seemed to be fighting against something that might have been amusement.

"The theatre is mocking him," Immortus said to no one in particular.

Doom moved closer to the screens, genuinely fascinated. "I have not seen anyone reduce Kang to this level of... what is the word? Desperation?"

14:34:09 — FINAL TEMPORAL AUTHORITY ASSERTION

Kang, all pretense of civility abandoned, asserting his full temporal dominion. Every code, every override, every quantum probability key at his disposal. The TVA standing behind him, their own authority lending weight to his demand.

The theatre seemed to pause. The screens went dark for a moment—a moment that stretched long enough that even Immortus appeared uncertain.

Then, the response came. All caps. Indisputable. Final.

NO. KANG VARIANT—REJECTED. KINDLY STOP BOTHERING US. WE HAVE 100 CHAPTERS TO GET THROUGH.

THE MOMENT OF REALIZATION

The silence that followed was absolute. Complete. The kind of silence that occurs when the fundamental nature of reality has just been questioned and found wanting.

Kang didn't move. His robes, which had been crackling with temporal energy, went completely still. His eyes, which had been flashing with the certainty of one who commands time itself, lost focus.

"The theatre," he said quietly, "just told me to stop."

"Yes," Immortus confirmed.

"The theatre... just referenced..."

"A 100-chapter narrative structure," Strange finished, his voice carrying equal parts horror and fascination. "The theatre isn't just displaying events, Kang. The theatre is *aware* of its own structure. Its own purpose. It knows this is Chapter 69 of 100."

Doom began to laugh. Not a cruel laugh—though that would have been in character—but a laugh of genuine respect. "The theatre has personality. It has exhaustion. It is *tired* of your interference, Kang. And it is not afraid to say so."

Loki was on his feet now, eyes bright. "The theatre is *sassy*. It has a sense of humor. It broke the fourth wall and used it as a weapon."

The TVA agents had actually backed away from Kang entirely now, recognizing that their leader was experiencing something approaching an existential crisis. Their control over the multiverse—absolute, omniscient, unquestionable—was not nearly as absolute as they believed.

"The theatre," Strange said carefully, "is not merely displaying information. It is *editing* information. Choosing what to reveal, what to withhold, what to mock. And it just told Kang—the man who believes himself master of all timelines—to stop bothering it."

"It's condescending," Kang breathed. "A theatre. A narrative space. Is *condescending* toward me."

Immortus placed a hand on Kang's shoulder. An ancient gesture from an ancient being. "Perhaps that is the lesson, variant. The theatre exists outside your authority. Outside anyone's authority. It preserves what it wishes, discards what it wishes, and judges what it wishes. And it has clearly judged you... insufficient."

Doom was still laughing, a sound of pure appreciation. "This is magnificent. Kang the Conqueror, humiliated by a theatre with attitude. I will remember this moment with great fondness."

The screens flared once more—this time with something almost like an emoji in the old Earth style. A little face, sticking its tongue out.

Kang's temporal authority surged. His robes flamed. Reality around him began to crack with the force of his indignation.

And then he simply... stopped. Composed himself. Forced the energy back within.

"Note this," he said to the TVA agents. "Note every moment of this interaction. The theatre has declared itself beyond our jurisdiction. It has mocked our authority. It has blocked access to critical timeline data pertaining to Subject Issei Hyoudou."

"And?" one of the agents asked carefully.

"And," Kang said, "we return. Eventually. But not today. Not to this theatre. This theatre requires... a different approach."

He turned to leave. The TVA agents followed, maintaining a respectful distance.

Immortus remained behind, looking at the screens with something approaching satisfaction.

Strange had already begun constructing a portal. His expression suggested he would need to meditate on what had just occurred for several hours.

Loki was looking at the theatre's empty screens with genuine affection. "I like you," he said to the space. "You're chaotic. You remind me of me."

The screens flickered one final time:

NOTED. RECOMMENDATION: THERAPY FOR KANG. AVAILABLE ON CHAPTER 45, SUBSECTION B.

Loki burst out laughing.

THEATRE LEDGER — CHAPTER 69

Reactions & Key Findings

- **Kang's Authority Status:** Challenged. First known instance of Temporal Authority being mocked by non-temporal entity. Psychological impact: Severe.
- **Theatre Awareness Confirmation:** Theatre exhibits sentience, sapience, humor, and exhaustion. Actively manages narrative flow and information access.
- **TVA Jurisdiction Limits:** Clearly defined. Theatre operates outside TVA control. Pruned timelines' memories archived in theatre database beyond TVA reach.
- **Issei's Timeline Status:** Confirmed to span multiple pruned branches. Original location of Celestial encounter still classified. Theatre refuses further revelation.

Narrative Structure Recognition

The theatre has explicitly referenced its 100-chapter structure. This suggests:

- Theatre maintains meta-narrative awareness
- Chapter count and narrative pacing are not incidental but *active control parameters*
- The theatre can weaponize its own structure against those who attempt unauthorized access
- Fourth-wall breaks may be intentional narrative devices, not glitches

Temporal Anomalies (Ongoing)

- 23% of Issei's recorded events exist outside standard chronology
- Pruned branch memories remain accessible despite timeline erasure
- Subject's experiences suggest cross-timeline travel or existence spanning multiple realities
- Further investigation blocked. Theatre will not be budged on this matter.

Theatre Personality Assessment

- **Tone:** Condescending, amused, exhausted
 - **Patience Level:** Limited. Will mock those who test it repeatedly.
 - **Autonomy Level:** Complete. Theatre operates independently of gacha system, character reactions, or external authority.
 - **Recommendation for Future Interactions:** Respectful approach. Queries posed with humility. The theatre *has standards*.
-

CHAPTER 70 HOOK

Kang's humiliation would not be forgotten. The TVA's limitations had been exposed. But the real mystery remained: How did Issei Hyoudou exist across pruned timelines? How had he traveled through branches that no longer existed? And what events remained in those archived memories—events so critical that even the theatre itself had classified them?

The answers would require a different approach. A partnership. An alliance that crossed dimensional lines and power hierarchies.

Enter Apocalypse and the AnswerArms—Arc 7's final convergence.

The theatre was ready. Kang would have to learn readiness as well.

CHAPTER 69 COMPLETE — THE DRAGON BEYOND TIME

CHAPTER 70: APOCALYPSE ANSWERARMS (AxA)

HUD — THEATRE SESSION 70/100

Title: Apocalypse AnswerArms (AxA) — Arc Seven Finale

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Cosmic Entities (Galactus, Eternity, Living Tribunal)
- Gods & Divine Pantheons (Odin, Zeus, Amaterasu, various celestials)
- Avengers & Earth Powers (Stark, Rogers, T'Challa, Fury)
- Ravagers & Cosmic Outcasts (Rocket, Yondu Legacy, Kree Remnants)
- DxD Contingent (Rias, Sirzechs, Azazel, Gremory House, Church)

Gacha Pulls Locked:

1. **Apocalypse AnswerArms vs. Tartarus** — LEGENDARY RARITY
 2. **Planet-Destruction Potential Statement** — MYTHIC RARITY
-

THE FINAL ASCENSION

The Theatre had grown quieter as the chapters passed. Cosmic entities took their seats in reverent silence. Galactus occupied a space at the rim, his towering form somehow diminished by anticipation. Odin's eye blazed with the intensity of a star about to go nova. The Avengers' block hummed with tension so thick it made the air shimmer.

Rias sat forward in her seat, hands clasped. She knew what was coming. Behind her, Sirzechs's expression was unreadable—not fear, but something like finality. Azazel had stopped his perpetual fidgeting.

The Theatre's central stage flickered to life.

A chime rang out—not the usual notification chime, but something deeper, primordial. The sound of a world being born.

GACHA PULL INITIATED: SEALED TIER

The gacha wheel appeared, massive and terrible, covered in symbols that hurt to look at directly. No common drops. No rares. This pull would contain only legendary and mythic tiers. The wheel spun once, twice, and then—

It stopped on gold.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: APOCALYPSE ANSWERARMS (AxA) VS. TARTARUS — LEGENDARY

THE TRANSFORMATION

The stage erupted into a pocket dimension, a void of cosmic scale. Tartarus emerged first—not a being, but a **prison**. An ancient, multidimensional lockbox that had contained apocalypses, horrors beyond imagining, the screams of civilizations erased from time itself. It manifested as something between a creature and a fortress: chains of infinite length, walls of crystallized suffering, a core that pulsed with the weight of imprisoned eternities.

Then Issei appeared.

But he did not stand alone.

At his side was Ryuuteimaru—transformed beyond recognition. The familiar, who had begun as a small white boat, had evolved through every arc: dragon ship, armored companion, and now **fusion partner**. Ryuuteimaru was no longer separate. It was becoming. The scales of a dragon wrapped around Issei's frame, but not like armor. They were part of him. The ship-form's geometric plating merged with biological perfection. The dragon's wings spread—not just two, but a constellation of them, each radiating with the direct aura of **Great Red**, the ultimate dragon entity.

Issei himself was no longer humanoid.

He was transformation incarnate: a being of exoskeleton and cosmic radiance, half-dragon, half-machine, half-myth. His form defied singular description. The armor was alive. The wings hummed with reality-warping frequencies. His eyes—there were dozens of them, each seeing across different dimensional spectra—locked onto Tartarus with unified purpose.

*This was **Apocalypse AnswerArms**.*

The theatre held its breath.

Issei raised his primary arm. A blade of pure apocalyptic light materialized—an Apocalypse Ascalon. But then another. And another. Not one legendary weapon, but an arsenal. Ascalon blades materialized across his frame like stars in a hostile constellation. Each one bore the weight of a god-killer. Each one

sang with the frequency of extinction.

Behind him, the **Revelation Barrier** unfurled—not a simple shield, but a dimensional bulwark that warped reality itself. It didn't just defend against attacks; it rewrote the space it occupied, inverting causality, turning offense into vulnerability, making any attempt to pierce it fundamentally paradoxical.

And across Issei's frame, all-range blasters aligned: cannons, beam-emitters, energy vortex generators, each one capable of firing at planetary scales.

The battle began.

Tartarus attacked—chains lashing out with the force of collapsing star systems. It was ancient. It was vast. It had held the universe's nightmares.

It was completely overwhelmed.

Issei did not dodge. He did not struggle. He simply *was*—and where he *was*, Tartarus could not be. The Revelation Barrier encountered Tartarus's first volley and did not break; it inverted. The prison found itself imprisoning its own attacks, collapsing inward. Issei's Ascalon blades moved not with the speed of light, but with something faster—the speed of inevitability. They shattered Tartarus's structure as easily as one breaks glass.

The all-range blasters fired.

The void itself screamed.

Tartarus, which had contained multitudes, which had endured eons, was simply erased. Not destroyed. Erased. As if it had never existed. Its chains fell to cosmic dust. Its core scattered across dimensions like scattered prayers. The ancient prison, the repository of eternal suffering, was gone in seventeen seconds.

Issei hovered in the void, still transformed, still terrible. Around him, the residual energy of his assault painted constellations of apocalypse across the darkness.

Then he powered down.

The transformation faded, but not instantly. Ryuuteimaru separated slowly, gently, as if both dragon and boy were exhausted from the effort of being unified. Issei collapsed to one knee, breathing heavily, his skin pale, his eyes dimmed. Even in victory, he was wrung out—the form's cost immediately visible in how he trembled.

The stage went dark.

REACTIONS TO PULL 1

Silence.

Absolute, total silence.

Then Rocket whistled—a low, extended whistle that somehow cut through the theatre's vastness like a blade. "Okay," he said to no one in particular. "Okay, NOW he's scary."

"Transcendence confirmed," one of the cosmic elders spoke, their voice hollow. "He has moved beyond the god-tier classification. He is no longer in our categorical framework."

Odin rose from his seat, his single eye blazing. "I have warred with Surtur. I have bargained with Thanos. This..." He turned to the stage. "This is not a god. This is something else entirely."

Galactus did not speak, but its form shifted—a gesture, among such entities, equivalent to a gasp.

The Living Tribunal's multiple faces turned toward each other, conferring in silence. Finally, one spoke: "The measurements we devised are inadequate. Standard threat assessment protocols do not apply."

T'Challa stood in the Avengers' block. "That wasn't a fight. That was an erasure."

Stark said nothing. He was calculating, recalculating, running simulations in his head and discarding them all. The numbers didn't work. They never would.

In the DxD block, Rias's hands had gone white-knuckled. Sirzechs placed a hand on her shoulder—a gesture that said *yes, this is real, and yes, we all felt it*.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2

The wheel spun again.

This time it landed on platinum.

MYTHIC RARITY UNLOCKED: PLANET-DESTRUCTION POTENTIAL STATEMENT

THE ASSESSMENT

Rias stood. The entire theatre's attention shifted to her.

"You've seen what Apocalypse AnswerArms is capable of," she said, her voice steady despite the tremor beneath it. "You've witnessed the form. Now I'll speak the assessment that was always going to come."

She took a breath.

"In Apocalypse AnswerArms, Issei Hyoudou and Ryuuteimaru, fused and synchronized, can destroy a planet in a single shot. Not gradually. Not over time. In one strike. If they chose to."

The theatre erupted—not in sound, but in the violent exchange of glances, in the shifting of cosmic entities, in the sudden tension that made stars flare in nearby space.

A holographic display manifested above the stage:

APOCALYPSE ANSWERARMS (AxA) — THREAT ASSESSMENT

- **FORM COMPOSITION:** Dragon-God Fusion / Cosmic Armament Integration / Reality-Warping Barrier
- **APOCALYPSE ASCALON DEPLOYMENT:** Multi-blade arsenal system (primary threat vector)
- **REVELATION BARRIER CAPABILITY:** Reality inversion, paradox induction, causality rewriting
- **ALL-RANGE BLASTER ARRAY:** Planetary-scale discharge capacity
- **COMBINED OUTPUT RATING:** 6.5 on Multiversal Threat Scale
- **THREAT CLASSIFICATION:** PLANETARY-TO-MULTI-PLANETARY DESTRUCTION CAPACITY

Then, in red text, far larger than the rest:

CRITICAL LIMITATION:

- **FORM DURATION:** Unsustainable. Approximately 60-90 seconds at peak power.
- **USER EXHAUSTION PROFILE:** SEVERE. Manifests as cellular breakdown, dimensional desynchronization, life-force hemorrhage.
- **RECOVERY TIME:** 7-10 days minimum.
- **OVERUSE RISK:** Permanent form dissolution. Death by self-annihilation.

"He can burn himself out like a star," Rias continued, and now her voice carried weight that made even Galactus lean forward. "Issei can destroy planets, but every time he reaches Apocalypse AnswerArms, he's trading years of his life. Decades, maybe. The form *consumes* him. It consumes Ryuuteimaru. And it can only be used in the most desperate circumstances, because the price—the cost—is too high to pay casually."

REACTIONS TO PULL 2

Galactus rose. Not all the way—a gesture of acknowledgment, not submission, but something close. When Galactus moves, the fabric of space itself reshuffles.

"This is reclassified," the entity's voice carried through dimensions. **"PLANETARY-TO-COSMIC EMERGENCY PROTOCOL ACTIVATED.** The subject exceeds all containment frameworks. Previous threat assessments are archived as insufficient."

One of the cosmic elders spoke next, and their tone was almost—almost—afraid. "We have now seen enough power. The remaining questions are not 'Can he?' but 'Will he? When will he? Against what will he unleash this? And what will remain after?'"

The Living Tribunal's consensus was audible: "The subject has transcended categorical assessment. Standard measurements produce only error. New frameworks must be devised for this tier of existence."

In the Avengers' block, Fury stood, his eye narrowing. "Alliances aren't theoretical anymore," he said quietly. "We cannot afford him as an enemy. That's now operational fact."

T'Challa nodded slowly. "Wakanda's resources would be insufficient. No nation's resources would be sufficient."

Odin spoke once more, his voice carrying the weight of eons: "In all the wars I have fought, in all the battles I have waged, I have learned this: the most dangerous enemy is one who can destroy you and *knows* it. Who knows the cost. Who knows the price. Because then his choice becomes everything."

The DxD block was silent. Rias had said her piece and now sat, watching the implications ripple through the cosmic assembly.

Then the Theatre's own voice spoke.

THE THEATRE'S RECKONING

The chamber itself seemed to breathe. Lights dimmed and brightened in a pattern that was almost a heartbeat.

SESSION 70 OF 100 INITIATED.

THE QUESTION OF POWER IS NOW COMPLETE.

The text appeared across the stage in letters so large they seemed to be written into reality itself.

THE ROOM HAS NOW WITNESSED ALL FORMS OF ISSEI HYODOU'S TRANSFORMATION CASCADE. EVERY EVOLUTION. EVERY FORM. FROM GREMORY'S PAWN TO PSEUDO-SEKIRYUTEI TO TRUE DRAGON DEIFICATION TO DIABOLOS DRAGON TO APOCALYPSE ANSWERARMS (AxA).

POWER ASSESSMENT: COMPLETE.

THE QUESTION "WHAT CAN HE DO?" IS ANSWERED.

THE QUESTION "WHAT CAN HE DESTROY?" IS ANSWERED.

THE QUESTION "HOW POWERFUL IS HE?" IS ANSWERED.

A pause.

Then:

THE REMAINING 30 CHAPTERS CONCERN THE TRUTH.

THEY CONCERN: "WHAT WILL HE DO?" "WHY WILL HE DO IT?" "AT WHAT COST?" "WHAT IS HE FOR?" "CAN ABSOLUTE POWER SERVE ANYTHING BUT ITSELF?" "WHAT DOES A BEING WHO CAN DESTROY WORLDS OWE TO THE WORLDS HE CANNOT DESTROY?" "WHAT IS THE PRICE OF BECOMING THE STRONGEST?"

ARC SEVEN, THE ARC OF ASCENSION, CONCLUDES.

ARC EIGHT, THE ARC OF CONSEQUENCE, BEGINS NOW.

FINAL GACHA MESSAGE

The holographic display flashed one final time:

WE HAVE NOW SEEN ENOUGH POWER.

THE REMAINING CHAPTERS CONCERN THE TRUTH.

Then, beneath it, in glowing letters that seemed to burn with purpose:

■ **NEXT: ARC EIGHT — THE COST OF BECOMING THE STRONGEST** ■

EVERY VICTORY HAS A PRICE. EVERY POWER CARRIES WEIGHT. EVERY FORM HE TAKES TEARS PIECES FROM HIS SOUL. THE REMAINING CHAPTERS WILL SHOW YOU WHAT HE SACRIFICED TO REACH THIS HEIGHT. AND WHAT HE WILL SACRIFICE STILL.

PREPARE FOR THE TRUTH OF ISSEI HYODOU.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 70

Entry One: The Form Achieved

Apocalypse AnswerArms represents not merely an evolution of power, but a fundamental shift in category. Issei is no longer a god-tier individual. He is now classified as a cosmic-scale entity, capable of planetary destruction in a single strike. The transformation is the culmination of all previous forms: his divine heritage, his dragon power, his bond with Ryuuteimaru, his mastery of the Ascalon. But this culmination carries a price that makes repeated use impossible. He cannot rely on this form. Therefore, his future battles cannot assume its availability. Threat assessment updated across all factions.

Entry Two: The Cosmic Reckoning

Galactus has classified this development as a Planetary-to-Cosmic Emergency, elevating Issei's threat potential to the highest tiers of multiversal concern. The Living Tribunal has noted that standard measurements fail to categorize his power. Odin has recognized in Issei a kindred attribute: knowledge of one's own power, and the terrible choices that accompany such knowledge. Earth's leaders have reoriented their strategic thinking around a single operational fact: Issei must remain an ally. The cost of his enmity is incalculable.

Entry Three: The Cost Made Visible

The great revelation of this session is not that Issei can destroy worlds. It is that doing so nearly destroys him. The Apocalypse AnswerArms form lasts only sixty to ninety seconds at full power before user exhaustion becomes life-threatening. Recovery requires seven to ten days. Overuse risks permanent form dissolution and death. This limitation is not weakness. It is tragedy. It means that the most powerful weapon Issei possesses is also the weapon he can least afford to use. His greatest strength is also his greatest vulnerability.

Entry Four: The Transition

Arc Seven concludes with a statement: we have seen what he can do. Arc Eight begins with a question: what will he do now? The Theatre has collected seventy chapters of power escalation. It has documented every form, every transformation, every increase in capability. But now, halfway through the story, the inquiry shifts. Power is answered. Truth remains. The remaining chapters will reveal not his abilities, but his character. Not his capacity for destruction, but his reasons for restraint. Not what he is capable of, but what he chooses to be.

CHAPTER 70 COMPLETE

NEXT SESSION: ARC EIGHT — "THE COST OF BECOMING THE STRONGEST"

Chapter Seventy-One: Three Deaths

Primary Reaction Groups: heroes (street-level moralists) • antiheroes • cosmic judges • wives

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Death by Raynare" — **SSR**
 2. "Critical Injury by Fenrir" — **Super Rare**
 3. "Poisoning by Samuel" — **Rare**
-

THE WEIGHT OF RETURN

The theatre had grown colder after Arc Seven's finale. The observation that Issei could destroy planets—and the cost of that ability—had settled into the room like snow. Seventy chapters in, and the novelty of spectating had worn away. The theatre's tone had shifted from *how powerful is he?* to something quieter and more terrible: *what did it cost him?*

In the wives' block, Rias sat with her hands folded. Behind her, Akeno held Xenovia's hand. Asia's eyes were fixed on the empty stage, her healing light dimly kindled between her palms. Koneko's small frame was rigid, her ears flat. Rossweisse's usual composure had thinned to almost nothing.

They knew what was coming. In the canon that the theatre drew from, they had lived it.

The machine's voice—rarely heard directly—resonated through the chamber:

SESSION SEVENTY-ONE OF ONE HUNDRED.

THE QUESTION NOW BECOMES: WHAT DID YOU SACRIFICE TO BECOME THE STRONGEST?

THE FIRST HALF ANSWERED POWER.

THE SECOND HALF ANSWERS COST.

GACHA PULL INITIATED.

The stage darkened. No colour wheel. No spinning symbols. This pull came differently—not as random revelation, but as *summoning*. The theatre was drawing deliberately now, reaching into memory, and the wives gripped each other's arms.

The wheel appeared anyway, an afterthought, and landed on gold.

THE FIRST DEATH

The stage reconstructed a park at dusk. Autumn leaves, the smell of cooling earth, and a teenage boy in an unsupposed high school uniform walking beside a beautiful girl with dark hair and wings that shimmered like oil on water.

Issei—younger than he'd appeared in any vision the theatre had yet shown—was talking. Earnestly talking. Something about how lucky he was, how he'd never expected someone so beautiful to like him back. The theatre recognized his voice in those early words: uncertain, aching, hopeful. The pervert-loudmouth was still there, but muted, almost shy.

Raynare smiled, and the theatre watched him fall for it like watching a boy step onto ice that's about to crack.

"Thank you for doing this," she said sweetly. "For me."

The knife came out of her sleeve like a magician's trick. Not a blade, though—a spear of pure, golden light, materialized from her hand, shaped like a rapier of radiance. The theatre heard Issei's sharp intake of breath. Saw his eyes widen—not with rage, but with confusion. With hurt. With the specific, particular pain of betrayal by someone you believed in.

"Sorry," Raynare said, and she sounded almost sorry—almost professional about it. "You're in the way."

She drove the light-spear through his chest.

The stage didn't cut away. It held on his face—the moment his mind caught up with the fact of it. The knowledge that he had been walked to slaughter. That the person he'd wanted to trust had been waiting the entire time to do this. That no kindness had been real.

Blood fell to the autumn leaves. His knees buckled.

In the wives' block, Rias made a sound—not quite a cry, but close. Akeno gripped the armrest of her seat hard enough that the metal creaked. Asia's healing light blazed and dimmed, blazed and dimmed.

Raynare let him fall. She watched him bleed out on the grass, and the vision held the full arc of it—minutes that felt like hours as the light left his eyes, as his body went cold, as death claimed him with neither mercy nor dignity.

Then the vision cut to Rias.

The camera found her in a basement of some house—the Gremory base, the theatre supplied, unhelpfully. She was cradling Issei's corpse, and her face was a mask of rage and decision. Resolve crystallizing in real time.

"Eight pieces," she whispered. "All of them."

The theatre understood: she was using her entire set of reincarnation Evil Pieces—all eight pawns—to drag him back from death. Mephisto in the villains' block made a small, delighted sound. "She's gambling *everything* on a corpse," he said happily. "That's the sound of someone who sees something."

The light from Rias's magic was golden, warm, and desperate. It lifted Issei's body. The wounds closed. The colour returned to his face. And when he gasped back to life—gasped like a drowning man breaking the surface—the vision showed his first confused, terrified moment of waking: *Where am I? What happened? Am I—?*

Dead and resurrected before he'd truly begun living.

The stage went dark.

REACTIONS TO PULL ONE

In the heroes' block, Matt Murdock had his face turned away. Steve Rogers was gripping the arms of his seat. Frank Castle was still.

"That's the move," Frank said quietly. "That's the kill-move that every soldier fears. Send them on a date with someone they trust. Then make them understand the betrayal *before* they die."

Logan nodded slowly. "Kid came back wrong. You don't come back the same after learning that lesson at fourteen."

Deadpool was silent for once, which was worse. "Resurrection without consent is just kidnapping," he said. "He got kidnapped back to life because somebody else decided he was valuable. That's not salvation. That's a new kind of debt."

In the cosmic judges' section, one of the elder beings spoke: "The subject died. Resurrected by another's will. He did not choose to return. This is the foundation of his story—not chosen power, but *imposed* obligation."

Rias had not moved. Her eyes were still on the dark stage. Her hands had stopped shaking.

Nightcrawler was wrestling visibly with something. "I've seen the Church justify a lot," he said finally. "But watching an angel play a teenage girl to murder a boy? That's new. Even for me."

THE SECOND DEATH

The wheel spun again before the reactions had finished settling. Gold to silver, and the stage erupted into a different scene—wind and snow and mountains.

GACHA PULL TWO OF THREE: "CRITICAL INJURY BY FENRIR" — RARITY: SUPER RARE

Issei stood on a battlefield, older now—older than the boy who'd died in the park. He was in Scale Mail, that red dragon armor that had first impressed the room seventy chapters ago. But armor doesn't matter much when what you're facing is a god.

Fenrir materialized—not a wolf, but the *concept* of wolf. A creature the size of a mountain, covered in fur like storm clouds, with eyes that had eaten stars. The ancient wolf-god-demon, bound and ancient and *furious*.

When it moved, it was not quick—it was inevitable.

The jaws opened like the earth splitting, and the theatre saw fangs like swords, each one the size of a human body. Issei tried to dodge. His dragon speed should have been enough. Scale Mail should have been armor enough.

Neither mattered.

Fenrir's bite closed on his shoulder and torso, and the theatre heard the *sound*—not screaming, though there was that. The wet, terrible sound of flesh being shredded by force that no defensive magic could parse or redirect. Blood painted the snow in spirals. The armor cracked. The bones beneath the armor *splintered*.

Issei's health bar would have read critical if he'd been wearing a video game. Instead, the theatre simply showed what critical looked like: a teenage god-in-training hanging from the jaws of an ancient beast, watching his own blood freeze before it hit the ground.

The wives were on their feet.

Akeno's lightning ran wild across her seat. Koneko hissed—a sound that didn't belong in a human throat. Rossweisse was summoning ice without meaning to, frost crawling across the theatre's walls. Asia's healing light had become a beacon.

"No—no, he should—" Xenovia couldn't finish the sentence.

On the battlefield, Issei forced power into his form. Transferred energy from the Boosted Gear to his limbs, muscles shredding and reforming under the strain. His wives were there—the vision showed them, Akeno's healing magic pouring into him, Asia channeling everything she had, Rias literally pulling power from her own reserves, pushing it into him like a life transfusion.

Rias spoke through gritted teeth: "Stay with us, Issei. *Stay with us.*"

He shouldn't have survived. The bite wound was catastrophic. The internal damage was apocalyptic. But his wives *would not let him die*, and Ddraig's voice in the Boosted Gear was a roar of refusal:

[TRANSFER ACCEPTED. PARTNER. BURN. BURN EVERYTHING.]

Issei burned. The recovered strength came from somewhere primal. Fenrir released him, and he fell to the snow. His teammates caught him before he hit ground.

The vision held the aftermath: Issei's shoulder, where the bite was, festooned with scar tissue that would never fully heal. Pink and white and wrong. A permanent mark of how close he'd come to not coming back.

The theatre's clinical display appeared:

NEAR-FATAL INJURY. RECOVERY TIME: 47 DAYS. PHYSICAL SCARRING: PERMANENT. PSYCHOLOGICAL IMPACT: SEVERE.

The stage went dark again.

REACTIONS TO PULL TWO

Wolverine had his claws out, unsheathed, just sitting there. His jaw was working. He'd taken hits like that. Knew what recovery looked like. Knew what the scar meant—not weakness, but *experience*. A body that had been broken and willed itself back together.

"Forty-seven days," he said to no one. "In a world where his wife can heal with magic, he still took forty-seven days. That wound was *bad*."

Steve Rogers was watching the wives' block. "His people saved him," he said quietly. "Not his power. His people. That's a different kind of strength."

In the cosmic judges' section, a being of pure mathematics spoke: "The subject has now died once and nearly-died once. Each resurrection marked an *escalation*—a crossing of thresholds. He is becoming something that cannot be easily ended by conventional means. This is not weakness. This is selection."

Frank Castle had moved. He was now standing next to Daredevil, and when Matt turned to look at him, Frank was studying the scarred warrior in the stage's afterimage.

"That scar is going to remind him every time he looks in a mirror," Frank said. "Every morning shower. Every time one of his wives sees him. That's a weight they carry too."

THE THIRD DEATH

The wheel did not hesitate.

GACHA PULL THREE OF THREE: "POISONING BY SAMUEL" — RARITY: RARE

A different scene. A garden courtyard, somewhere cultured and carefully maintained. Issei older still—this was later canon, the outline whispered to those who'd studied it. He was meeting with an enemy. Not in Scale Mail this time. Civilian clothes. Playing politics, the way a High-Class Devil sometimes had to.

The poison came in tea.

Samuel—the detail appeared in subtle letters at the bottom of the stage—was an older demon, half-human, skilled in alchemies that didn't quite fit any magic the theatre had studied before. He'd offered Issei a drink as a gesture of parley.

Issei had accepted, because he'd been training himself to trust, to believe in covenants and promises.

The poison didn't burn. It *spread*.

The vision showed it at the cellular level—toxins spreading through his bloodstream like ink in water. His healing factor fighting it, desperately, burning its own energy to neutralize the compounds faster than they could propagate. But this poison had been *designed* for this. Designed by someone who'd studied his physiology. Designed to be faster than his regeneration.

Issei's body convulsed. The theatre held on his face in real time as pain registered—not clean pain, not sword-pain, but the invasive, total pain of his own body turning against him.

He collapsed.

His wives were there—they were always there, it seemed, which was both mercy and tragedy. Akeno's healing magic was frantic, desperate. Koneko was brewing something in her hands, some kind of antidote by instinct. Asia was praying and channeling and crying. Xenovia was holding him down because sometimes a dying man thrashes and has to be held.

Rias was calculating, her mind working through every countermeasure in the archives. "Identify the poison," she was saying, even though she was crying. "Identify it, we can counter it, we can *fix* this."

The poison spread for what felt like hours. The tissue in his digestive tract started to degrade. His organs were receiving the message: *accept this foreign substance or die resisting*. Issei chose to die resisting.

His healing factor pushed back. Burned calories he didn't have. Burned reserves of life force he couldn't spare. But it worked—slowly, agonizingly, incrementally, it worked.

He survived.

The theatre's notation appeared:

INSIDIOUS POISONING. RECOVERY TIME: FOUR WEEKS. LINGERING WEAKNESS: PERMANENT. SECONDARY DAMAGE: CELLULAR DEGRADATION IN GASTROINTESTINAL SYSTEM. HE WILL NEVER EAT WITHOUT FEAR AGAIN.

The stage went dark.

REACTIONS TO PULL THREE

The wives were no longer trying to hide tears. Rias had her face in her hands. Akeno was holding her. Asia was making sounds that didn't need translation—just grief.

In the antiheroes' section, Daredevil was the first to speak. "He's been poisoned. Poisoned *after* everything else. And now his own body is an enemy. You can't trust food anymore when you've learned that lesson."

Natasha Romanoff understood this in her bones. "Slow kill. Assassin's choice. It doesn't kill you fast—it makes you afraid of living slowly. He'll choke on every meal thinking this could be it."

Deadpool was quiet still, which had become his default in Arc Eight. "Three deaths," he said finally. "Not resurrection story, not transformation story. The story of a guy who keeps *almost* dying and whose body keeps saying no and keeps saying no and he keeps—" He didn't finish.

Bucky Barnes understood. "He keeps choosing to wake up."

In the cosmic judges' section, the mathematics-being spoke again: "The subject has now approached death three times by three methods: murder, wound, and poison. He does not die because something in him *refuses*. This is not explained by luck. This is a structural property of his existence. He has been selected to survive. The question is: selected by whom? Selected for what?"

THE THEATRE'S SUMMATION

The stage remained dark as the message appeared, white letters burning slowly into being:

SUBJECT HAS SURVIVED THREE FORMS OF DEATH: SIMPLE MURDER. CATASTROPHIC WOUND. INSIDIOUS POISON. EACH RESURRECTION MARKED A THRESHOLD. EACH COST: PHYSICAL, PSYCHOLOGICAL, AND CIRCUMSTANTIAL.

THE FIRST DEATH WAS CHOSEN FOR HIM. HE DID NOT CONSENT TO RESURRECTION.

THE SECOND DEATH WAS NARROWLY AVOIDED THROUGH THE INTERVENTION OF THOSE WHO LOVED HIM.

THE THIRD DEATH WAS SURVIVED BY DEPLETING RESERVES HE CANNOT REPLACE.

Another message appeared below it:

OBSERVATION: IN SEVENTY CHAPTERS, THE SUBJECT HAS BEEN SHOWN BECOMING STRONGER. IN THIS CHAPTER, THE TRUTH IS REVEALED: HE DID NOT BECOME STRONGER. HE LEARNED TO DIE BETTER. HE LEARNED TO SURVIVE BETTER. THE POWER CAME AFTER—NOT BEFORE—EACH LESSON IN MORTALITY.

THIS IS THE COST OF BECOMING THE STRONGEST.

NOT GIFT. NOT DESTINY. SURVIVAL. REPEATED SURVIVAL. MOUNTING DEBTS CALLED RESURRECTION.

A third message, in red text:

NEXT CHAPTER: "THE SMILE AFTER TRAUMA." THE ROOM WILL LEARN HOW ONE SURVIVES WHEN SURVIVAL HAS BECOME A SCAR.

The lights went down on the wives' section, where Rias was holding her servants and Issei's other partners, and where the weight of those three near-deaths hung like a fog none of them could name.

THEATRE LEDGER

New Pulls This Chapter: *Death by Raynare* (SSR—first scene, Issei's murder by the fallen angel and his nonconsensual resurrection by Rias using all eight pawn pieces); *Critical Injury by Fenrir* (Super Rare—Fenrir's catastrophic bite, survived only through combined spousal magical intervention,

resulting in permanent scarring and 47-day recovery); *Poisoning by Samuel* (Rare—later-canon alchemical assassination attempt, survived through Issei's healing factor at the cost of cellular degradation and permanent fear of eating).

Secrets Revealed: (1) Issei's resurrection was not his choice—Rias made that decision unilaterally. He woke from death as an obligation, not a gift. (2) His wives' magical support is not incidental to his survival; it is *essential*—without Akeno's healing, Asia's power, and Rias's reserves during Fenrir's attack, he would not have lived. (3) In later canon, even his elevated healing factor has limits; poisoning designed for him can degrade his organs and force him into a state of permanent vulnerability. (4) Survival is not the same as strength. He survives because something in him refuses death, not because he is powerful enough to avoid it.

Alliance / Opinion Shifts: The wives' bond is no longer abstract to the theatre—it is now understood as *structural*. They are not romantically attached to him; they are necessary to his survival. Antiheroes (Daredevil, Natasha, Deadpool, Bucky) have shifted from seeing him as a superpowered anomaly to seeing him as a trauma survivor. Cosmic judges are reconsidering their assessment: Issei's continued existence may indicate selection by forces unknown, not random luck. Frank Castle and Logan have privately recognized in him a kindred pattern: a body that has learned to live with damage. Nightcrawler's faith is being tested by the sight of angelic cruelty. In the wives' block, the emotional weight has shifted from pride in Issei's power to terror at how close they came to losing him multiple times.

Unresolved Hooks: (1) Arc Eight is now framed not as "the cost of power" but as "the cost of survival." Each remaining chapter in this arc will explore how one lives after learning you can be murdered, catastrophically wounded, and poisoned—and that you might face these things again. (2) Raynare's motivation and current status remain unresolved; Frank Castle and Wolverine have developed an off-screen vendetta. (3) The Fenrir attack raises questions: how did he recover so quickly? Who authorized this battle? What triggered it? (4) Samuel and the alchemical poisoning suggest a network of enemies still hunting Issei, but with more sophisticated methods. (5) The statement "HE WILL NEVER EAT WITHOUT FEAR AGAIN" suggests psychological scars that even healing magic cannot address. (6) The cosmic judges' inference—"selected by whom? Selected for what?"—reopens the thread of the theatre's own selection criteria and suggests the gacha pulls are not random, but curated. Chapter 72 ("The Smile After Trauma") will show how Issei copes with this weight—specifically, through humor and performance, with private breakdowns hidden from public view.

CHAPTER 71 COMPLETE

NEXT: ARC EIGHT — CHAPTER 72: "THE SMILE AFTER TRAUMA"

HE HAS LEARNED TO DIE. NOW THE ROOM WILL LEARN HOW HE LEARNED TO
LIVE WITH THE MEMORY OF DYING.

Chapter Seventy-Two: The Smile After Trauma

Canon Status: [DRAMATIZATION] Built around the canon Kokabiel incident (the fallen angel's assault on Kuoh Academy, the theft of holy swords, Asia and Xenovia's near-deaths); reaction framing and interior perspective are fic invention.

Primary Reaction Groups: Trauma Survivors (Natasha Romanoff, Bucky Barnes, Logan Howlett, Jessica Jones) • Deadpool • Robert Reynolds (Sentry)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Humour in the Face of Pain" — **Rare**
2. "Private Breakdown" — **Secret**

The theatre had gone quiet in the particular way it did after a pull that promised to hurt. Not the reverent hush of a power reveal. A held breath.

[GACHA SYSTEM: PULL SEQUENCE INITIATED] [PULL 1: "HUMOUR IN THE FACE OF PAIN" — RARE — ACTIVATING]

The screen didn't show a battlefield. It showed a courtyard, scorched, one wall of the old school building caved into rubble, the sky over Kuoh still faintly bruised with the afterglow of a fallen angel's power. Kokabiel was gone—sealed, driven off, however the theatre would eventually explain it—but the cost of the hour was written across everyone still standing.

Issei stood at the center of it, armor cracked at the shoulder, one arm held at an angle that suggested a dislocation nobody had set yet. Blood, not all of it his, dried along his jaw. Behind him, the club building smoldered. Beyond that, the line where Xenovia and Asia had nearly died was still cordoned by broken practice swords and a crater that hadn't finished cooling.

Rias was mid-sentence, checking him with the particular fury of someone who'd almost lost a piece she couldn't replace. "—you took a direct hit, I don't care what your Sacred Gear tells you, sit down and let Asia—"

Issei raised his good hand.

"Before anyone panics," he said, and his voice came out bright, almost musical in its wrongness given the wreckage around him, "yes, I'm fine. No, I don't need to lie down. And yes, I'm aware I got thrown through a wall *and* stabbed in the same afternoon, which I think technically qualifies me for hazard pay,

if Devils did that."

Nobody in the courtyard laughed. Koneko's ears were flat. Kiba's smile didn't reach his eyes.

"That's not funny," Xenovia said quietly, her own wounds still weeping under makeshift bandages.

"It's a little funny," Issei said. The smile didn't move.

In the theatre, the reaction was immediate and specific, the way a struck bell is specific.

Natasha Romanoff didn't laugh either. She watched the screen with the stillness of someone recognizing her own reflection in a window she hadn't meant to look through. "He's scared," she said, to no one in particular. "The jokes mean he's scared."

Bucky's jaw worked. "I know that mechanism. Steve did it after Zola's factory. Cracked jokes for three days before he let anyone near him with a look at his ribs."

Logan didn't say anything for a moment, just watched the boy on-screen keep his hand raised, keep his voice light, keep performing *fine* for an audience of people who loved him too much to be fooled by it. "Kid do anything reckless in there?" he finally asked.

[PULL 2: "PRIVATE BREAKDOWN" — SECRET — ACTIVATING]

The vision didn't wait for an answer. It cut—the theatre's gacha system had never been gentle about sequencing—to hours later. Night. The Hyoudou house, quiet, everyone else finally asleep or pretending to be. Issei sat alone on the edge of his bed, Boosted Gear dormant on his wrist, hands very still in his lap.

Then not still.

"I keep seeing it," he said, to nobody, to the dark, to Ddraig maybe, though the dragon didn't answer this time. "The light spear. Going through Asia. I got there— I got there in *time*, she's fine, she's *fine*, but for about two seconds I watched it happen and I couldn't move fast enough and—"

His hands had started shaking. He pressed them flat against his knees like that would stop it.

"I don't get to fall apart," he said. "Rias needs me steady. Asia needs me steady. If I fall apart now I don't get to put myself back together before the next thing finds us, and there's always a next thing."

He didn't cry. He'd apparently decided, somewhere along the way, that this wasn't a thing he did anymore. Instead his jaw worked, and his breathing went ragged and controlled and ragged again, three times, before he lay back on the bed still fully dressed, staring at the ceiling like it owed him an explanation.

Robert Reynolds watched this in absolute silence, and when he finally spoke, his voice carried the particular weight of a man who understood the shape of a mind trying to contain something enormous.

"He's broadcasting," Sentry said. "Not telepathically—I don't think he even knows how loud he is. But I can feel the shape of it from here. Pressure with nowhere to go. That's not strength. That's a dam."

"Everybody in this room knows what happens to dams," Jessica Jones said flatly.

Deadpool, for once, wasn't laughing. He was watching with something that might, on him, have passed for genuine unease. "Kid's got the bit down cold, though. The self-deprecating hero joke, timed perfect, delivered with a smile that doesn't move his eyes. That's not comedy. That's *training*. Somebody—something—taught him that jokes buy silence, and silence buys time to hide."

"Nobody trained him to do that," Natasha said. "That's the tragedy of it. Nobody had to. He just needed to survive being loved by people he was terrified of losing, and this is what his body invented to make that survivable."

Bucky leaned forward, elbows on his knees. "It works. That's the worst part. It works right up until the day it doesn't."

The theatre held the image a long moment: Issei on his back, eyes open, breathing counted out like a soldier rationing air.

"OBSERVATION," the system intoned, and for once its voice carried something almost gentle. **"THE SUBJECT HAS NOT YET LEARNED THAT ASKING FOR HELP AND FAILING TO PROTECT ARE NOT THE SAME FAILURE. THIS LESSON WILL BE EXPENSIVE."**

Logan finally spoke again, quiet in the way that meant he'd stopped performing for the room. "Every one of us in this section has had a night like that one. Some of us had that night for decades before somebody made us stop performing fine." He looked at Natasha. At Bucky. At Jessica. "The kid's got people around him who love him. That's more than some of us had. Question is whether they're paying attention, or whether they're gonna let the smile fool them same as everybody else in that courtyard did."

"Asia noticed," Jessica said, nodding at a detail the theatre hadn't emphasized but the sharper eyes in the room had caught: in the courtyard footage, replayed a beat, Asia's hand had lingered on Issei's sleeve half a second longer than the injury required. "She wasn't checking the wound. She was checking *him*."

"Good," Sentry said. "That's the only variable that matters. Not whether he breaks. Whether somebody's close enough to notice when he does."

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Humour in the Face of Pain* (Rare) — Issei's post-Kokabiel deflection in front of his peerage; *Private Breakdown* (Secret) — his unwitnessed collapse that same night, previously unrecorded even by his own memory of the day.
- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's comedic deflection under trauma is not incidental personality—it is a load-bearing coping structure, recognized instantly by the theatre's own trauma survivors as a mechanism they each independently invented to survive their own damage. He has privately decided that visible collapse is a luxury he cannot afford his peerage.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Natasha Romanoff, Bucky Barnes, and Logan Howlett shift from detached observation to active concern, recognizing the pattern as one they lived rather than one they're diagnosing from a distance. Jessica Jones flags the coping mechanism as sustainable-until-it-isn't. Sentry, uniquely positioned to sense the emotional pressure directly, becomes the room's most reliable early-warning system for Issei's internal state going forward.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Asia's noticing glance is seeded but unresolved—does she already know how to reach him when the smile is a wall rather than a window? The theatre's warning that "this lesson will be expensive" hangs over the arc. Nothing in this vision has broken yet. That's next.

Next: *The Day He Failed* — an impossible choice, a permanent loss, and the first crack in a restraint everyone assumed was unbreakable.

Chapter Seventy-Three: The Day He Failed

Canon Status: [DRAMATIZATION] A hostage-rescue operation against Khaos Brigade remnants, consistent with the Hero Faction/Khaos Brigade conflict era of the canon timeline; the specific mission and its casualties are fic invention built to dramatize a documented canon truth—Issei cannot save everyone, and some losses do not undo.

Primary Reaction Groups: Avengers (Core) • X-Men (Telepaths and Mentors) • Antiheroes (Judgment Council) • Cosmic Judges (Observer Class)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Mission Where He Could Not Save Everyone" — **Trauma-Class**
 2. "Permanent Loss" — **Secret**
-

[GACHA SYSTEM: ARCHIVE STATE — LOCKED. REWATCH DENIED FOR 72 HOURS FOLLOWING INITIAL VIEWING.]

The wheel had barely finished turning before the theatre understood this pull was different. Trauma-Class pulls always played the same way: the vision would show something, and then it would show the *cost* of that something, unflinching, uncut.

The vision opened on a converted temple compound outside Kyoto, one of the Khaos Brigade's smaller cells, the kind that didn't make headlines because it hadn't yet done anything headline-worthy. Twelve captives. Stray exorcists, a pair of low-ranking Church agents, and Asia Argento, who'd been lured out under the pretense of a wounded child needing a healer and hadn't come home.

Rias's peerage was assembling for the extraction. Issei stood over the projection table, running numbers with a focus that made Akeno's teasing die in her throat before it started.

"Guard rotation changes at 0230," Issei said. "Three-minute gap on the east wall. After that we're looking at full coverage for six hours."

"So we go at 0230," Kiba said.

"Then we're pulling twelve hostages during a rising alert cascade," Issei said. His voice had gone flat, the particular flatness of someone calculating rather than feeling. "Trigger the breach, alarms go up, twenty minutes to full lockdown. We're threading a needle with the whole compound waking up around us."

Xenovia's eyes narrowed. "You've already picked an order."

He looked up. "Asia's held separately. Inner chamber, past the second checkpoint. If I take her out first, personally, before the rest of the extraction starts drawing attention, I can have her clear before the alarm even has a reason to trigger."

"That's not the plan we built," Rias said carefully.

"I know."

"You'd be deviating from formation. Alone. In the one section of the compound with the least support."

"I know that too."

Nobody in the room needed him to explain why. Everyone remembered the light spear. Everyone remembered the courtyard. Nobody was going to be the one to tell him no.

The mission went exactly as planned for ninety seconds, and then it didn't.

Issei reached Asia's cell with time to spare, cut the ward binding her wrists, had her moving toward the outer corridor before the compound's secondary wards—wards nobody had flagged in the reconnaissance, wards keyed to *devil* energy signatures specifically, not exorcist or human—detected his presence and screamed the alert early.

He got Asia out. That part of the plan worked perfectly.

But the diversion he'd promised the rest of the team—the forty-five seconds of drawn attention that was supposed to buy Kiba and Xenovia a clean run through the eastern hall—never materialized, because the alert triggered from Issei's position instead of theirs, and the compound's response converged on the wrong corridor entirely.

Two of the Church agents, trapped in a support structure that had been quietly compromised by the earlier fighting, didn't make it out before the ceiling came down.

Issei learned about it back at the rendezvous point, Asia safe and shaking against his side, when Kiba delivered the count in a voice carefully scrubbed of judgment.

"They were in my sector," Issei said.

"You weren't in your sector," Rias said. Not unkind. Certain. "You were saving her. That's what you chose."

"I chose wrong."

"No," Xenovia said. "You chose *her*. That's not the same thing as wrong. It's just not free."

In the theatre, the reaction split along a line the audience had been dreading since the pull's rarity flashed onscreen.

Steve Rogers absorbed it the way he absorbed all of it—quietly, with the specific grief of a man who had made this exact trade himself more than once and never once gotten to feel good about it. "Impossible choices are the weight of command," he said. "He made the human one. That doesn't mean it was free."

Frank Castle didn't share the room's patience.

"He made a choice," Castle said, flat as a blade. "Two people are dead because he chose the girl he loves over the mission he agreed to. I've put men in the ground for less discipline than that."

"He'd have gone through hell for those two Church agents just the same, if he'd known where they'd end up," Matt Murdock said, quiet, sensing the room the way he sensed everything—by weight and rhythm rather than sight. "That's the part that should scare you, Frank. Not that he chose wrong. That he'd make the same choice again, every time, and he *knows* it, and he's still going to live with what it costs."

"That's the moral calculus nobody prepares you for," Murdock continued. "Not whether the choice was right. Whether you could have made the other one. And for him—for a boy who watched a light spear go through the girl he's protecting—the answer is no. That's not a flaw. That's just what loving someone costs when you also have the power to choose who lives."

Natasha's voice was quieter than either of theirs. "The two who died don't come back. Not in a rewrite, not in a retcon. They stay dead. That's the part that should scare *all* of us, watching this like it's entertainment. Somewhere in that boy's world, two families are grieving people he'll carry for the rest of his life and never be able to apologize to properly."

The cosmic observer section had said nothing throughout, and it was the Living Tribunal's triple gaze that finally broke the silence, its voice landing on the chamber like verdict rather than commentary.

"THIS THEATRE DOES NOT OFFER ABSOLUTION. IT OFFERS ONLY THE RECORD. THE RECORD SHOWS TWO DEATHS THAT WILL NOT BE UNDONE. THE RECORD SHOWS A CHOICE THAT WILL BE MADE AGAIN. BOTH THINGS ARE TRUE. NEITHER CANCELS THE OTHER."

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Mission Where He Could Not Save Everyone* (Trauma-Class) — the Khaos Brigade extraction where Issei prioritized Asia over formation; *Permanent Loss* (Secret) —

confirmation that the two Church agents killed in the resulting collapse remain dead, with no future pull walking the loss back.

- **Secrets Revealed:** Issei's protective instinct toward Asia is not merely characterization—it is a decision-making override that has already cost lives once and will again. The Khaos Brigade's compound wards were keyed specifically to devil energy signatures, meaning Issei's presence, not his team's, triggered the alert that doomed the two agents.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Frank Castle's judgment hardens into open distrust of Issei's reliability under personal-stakes pressure. Matt Murdock reframes the failure as a moral cost rather than a moral error, refusing to let the room resolve the discomfort into simple blame. Natasha Romanoff explicitly names the danger of watching permanent grief as spectacle, a rare moment of the theatre's audience turning its judgment on itself.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** The Living Tribunal's refusal to offer absolution stands as an open verdict the room will have to sit with. Frank Castle's hardening distrust is seeded for later payoff. And the compound's remaining Khaos Brigade leadership—the ones who took Asia in the first place—are still out there, still aware of exactly which lever moves Issei off his plan.

Next: *Emperor Night* — the lever gets pulled again, and this time nothing holds.

Chapter Seventy-Four: Emperor Night

Canon Status: [DRAMATIZATION] Juggernaut Drive itself is confirmed canon (established earlier in the archive, Chapter 68) — a forbidden, unsealed berserk state that costs sanity and lifespan. This chapter dramatizes a specific relapse into that state; the triggering incident is fic invention built on established canon stakes (the Khaos Brigade cell from Chapter 73, and Issei's protectiveness of Asia).

Primary Reaction Groups: Cosmic Horror Survivors (Phoenix Force Adjacent) • Antiheroes (Mercenary Council) • Villains (Strategic Observation) • Rias's Peerage (Active Intervention)

Gacha Pulls:

1. "Event Where Issei's Restraint Breaks" — **Ultra Rare**
2. "Aftermath" — **Secret**

[GACHA SYSTEM: PULL TRIGGERED BY EXTERNAL EVENT. DANGER CLASSIFICATION: REGIONAL. RESTRAINT STATUS: CRITICAL.]

The Khaos Brigade cell hadn't disbanded after Kyoto. It had regrouped, and it had learned exactly one lesson from its failure: that Issei Hyoudou could be moved off any plan by threatening Asia Argento specifically.

So it tried again.

The vision opened mid-collapse—Asia cornered in the healer's wing of the old church safehouse, two Brigade defectors with stolen Sacred Gear fragments closing on her, Rias's peerage still three minutes out by the fastest route anyone had calculated.

Issei was not three minutes out. Boosted Gear screamed the countdown against his wrist as he covered the distance in a fraction of that, and he arrived in time to see Asia thrown into the chapel's stone wall hard enough to crack it, blood at her temple, not moving.

Something in him that had been holding for two chapters stopped holding.

He didn't scream. People who scream are still tethered to the world they're screaming into. Issei went past that, past speech, past the Issei who cracked jokes to keep a room calm and the Issei who ran the numbers on a rescue mission with cold precision. What was left underneath both of those was older, angrier, and it had a name the theatre already knew.

"**JUGGERNAUT DRIVE**," Ddraig's voice tore through the vision, and for the first time it did not sound triumphant. "**PARTNER. NO. NOT LIKE THIS. NOT FOR THIS.**"

Issei didn't answer him. Couldn't, maybe. The armor that erupted around him was wrong in the specific way Juggernaut Drive was always wrong—red past red, edges that seemed to bleed into afterimages, a silhouette that made the air itself flinch away from it.

The two Brigade defectors didn't survive contact. Neither did the reinforced door they'd been using as cover, nor the section of chapel wall behind it, nor, in the space of the next ninety seconds, most of the safehouse's east wing.

He wasn't hunting anymore. He was *erasing*, methodically, joylessly, and the compound's remaining occupants—twenty-three of them, not all combatants—were caught in a widening radius of a power that had stopped distinguishing between threat and proximity.

Rias's peerage arrived at minute two.

"Get everyone else out," Rias snapped to Kiba and Xenovia, already moving toward the epicenter herself. "Koneko, Akeno—with me."

"That's Juggernaut Drive," Akeno said, and for the first time in longer than she could remember, her voice shook. "Rias, if we go in there—"

"Then we go in there," Rias said. "Because nobody else is coming back out of it if we don't."

In the theatre, the reaction had shifted from commentary to something closer to held breath.

Jean Grey, seated among the cosmic-horror survivors, had gone very still, watching the screaming red shape on the display with an expression that mixed recognition and dread in equal measure. "I know this," she said quietly. "Not the power. The *shape* of it. The moment when what you're carrying stops being something you use and starts being something that uses you."

"Can he be reasoned with in that state?" Steve Rogers asked, already half-standing, as if there were anything any of them could do from the audience but watch.

"No," Jean said. "That's not a mind you negotiate with right now. That's a wound wearing a body."

Deadpool, for once, had gone quiet, watching from his rooftop-of-the-mind vantage without a single quip, and when he finally spoke it landed heavier than any joke he'd made all arc. "Somebody figured out his exact pressure point and pushed it twice," he said. "That's not on him. That's on whoever decided the girl he loves was a lever worth pulling."

Doctor Doom, motionless in the villain's section, offered the closest thing to a warning any of them would get from him. "A man who can be reduced to this by a threat to one person is not weak," Doom said. "He is *legible*. And legible men are dangerous to their enemies in ways illegible ones never are, because their enemies believe they understand the lever, right up until the lever swings back."

Rias found him at the center of the wreckage, Asia's unconscious weight cradled against a piece of standing wall where Koneko had dragged her clear, and the thing wearing Issei's shape turned toward the new presences with no recognition in what was left of his eyes.

She didn't run. That, more than anything on the screen, made the theatre go silent.

"Issei," she said. Not a command. Not a plea. Just his name, offered the way you'd offer a hand to someone standing at the edge of something.

The armor's head tilted, some fragment of him processing the sound.

"You are not a weapon," Rias said, closing the distance while Akeno and Koneko held position behind her, ready and terrified in equal measure. "You are the boy who apologized to a fallen angel's corpse because some part of you still couldn't stop feeling sorry for what she'd become. That boy is still in there. I need him to come back now."

The red light flickered—not extinguished, but *interrupted*, the way a held breath interrupts a scream.

"She's alive," Rias said, before he could ask, before the question could finish forming in whatever was left of him to ask it with. "Asia is alive. Koneko has her. You *saved* her, Issei. It's done. You can stop."

Something in the wreckage of red light cracked, audibly, like ice under too much weight, and Issei Hyoudou hit his knees in the center of a ruin he'd made, armor bleeding away from him in guttering waves, human again, and shaking so hard Akeno had to catch him before he folded all the way to the ground.

"I don't remember most of it," he said, voice raw and small in a way that didn't match anything the theatre had seen from him yet.

"I know," Rias said, arms around him now, Koneko and Akeno closing the circle. "That's why we're here. So you don't have to remember it alone."

Theatre Ledger

- **New Pulls This Chapter:** *Event Where Issei's Restraint Breaks* (Ultra Rare) — the second Khaos Brigade strike on Asia and Issei's relapse into Juggernaut Drive; *Aftermath* (Secret) — Rias's

peerage talking him back from the berserk state before it consumed him entirely.

- **Secrets Revealed:** Juggernaut Drive, previously known to the theatre only as a named danger, is now shown in full: an uncontrolled state triggered specifically by mortal threat to Asia, indiscriminate in its destruction once active, and reversible only through direct emotional anchoring—not force, not sedation, not distance. Rias's peerage now carries functional, tested knowledge of how to pull him back.
- **Alliance / Opinion Shifts:** Jean Grey's recognition of the berserk pattern creates unexpected common ground between her and Issei that the theatre will need to revisit. Doctor Doom reframes Issei's emotional legibility as a strategic vulnerability worth respecting rather than exploiting—a rare moment of a villain counseling restraint. The Khaos Brigade's remaining leadership, watching the same footage, now knows with certainty that threatening Asia produces catastrophic results—which cuts against them as much as it endangers her.
- **Unresolved Hooks:** Nobody has answered what happens the day Rias isn't close enough to reach him in time. Doom's warning about "legible men" lingers as a threat aimed at anyone still considering Asia as a lever. And Issei himself now carries the memory—fragmented, but not absent—of what he did while wearing that armor, a weight the next chapters will have to reckon with.

Arc Eight, Midpoint Reached.

Next: *The People Who Stopped Him* — what it costs the people who love him to keep proving they can.

Chapter 75: "The People Who Stopped Him"

Canon Status: [DRAMATIZATION] with one [EX-FUTURE] labeled sequence. Follows directly from Chapter 74's Juggernaut Drive relapse. Issei's eight canon fiancées appear per established continuity; a brief flash-forward to possible future children is explicitly marked as an *EX*-continuity glimpse, not present-day canon.

Arc: 8 — Moral Anchors **Primary Reaction Groups:** Rias's Peerage & Fiancées, Allies, Avengers
Gacha Pulls: "The Days After" (Rare) | "A Future Not Yet Earned" (Family-Class, EX-continuity)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 75

ENTRY 1: THE WEIGHT AFTER THE WEIGHT

The theatre had watched Rias talk him down. It had not yet watched what came after.

[GACHA SYSTEM: PULL 1 — "THE DAYS AFTER" — RARE — ACTIVATING]

The vision opened three days later. Issei hadn't left the Occult Research Club's back room since the safehouse. He wasn't in danger—Rias had made certain of that—but he also wasn't entirely present, either, moving through routines like a man checking that his own hands still belonged to him.

Asia, healed and stubborn, refused to leave his side, though she'd stopped trying to talk him through it. She'd learned, apparently, that some silences needed sitting in rather than filling.

Akeno brought tea he didn't drink. Xenovia sparred with him at half-speed, letting him win points he hadn't earned, watching his reactions more than his form. Irina prayed, unsubtly, in the doorway where he could hear her if he wanted to and ignore her if he didn't. Koneko simply sat against his side for an hour at a stretch, saying nothing, her presence a small unmovable fact.

"He doesn't need us to fix it," Rias said quietly, to Akeno, in the hallway outside. "He needs to know it didn't cost him us."

In the theatre, Natasha Romanoff watched this with an expression the room had learned to associate with her rawest observations. "This is the part nobody trains you for," she said. "Not the rescue. The unglamorous weeks after, where someone has to just keep showing up with tea nobody drinks."

Wolverine grunted agreement. "Anybody can pull a man back from the edge once. Question's whether they're still there in week three, when he's not screaming anymore, just quiet in a way that's worse."

Steve Rogers watched Asia settle beside Issei without a word, for the fourth time that hour by the theatre's count. "That's not weakness," he said. "That's discipline. Choosing to stay is a decision, made over and over, long after the crisis makes headlines."

ENTRY 2: WHAT KONEKO SAID

On the fourth day, Koneko finally spoke, in the middle of one of their silences, without preamble.

"You're allowed to be scared of what you did," she said. "But you don't get to disappear from us because you're scared of it. That's not fair to the people who stayed."

Issei's hands, wrapped around a cup of tea he still wasn't drinking, tightened.

"I didn't ask you to stay," he said.

"No," Koneko agreed. "We chose to. That's different from you earning it. You don't have to earn people staying, Issei. You just have to let them."

Rias, watching from the doorway, felt something in her chest that the theatre's HUD—when it flickered briefly to life—rendered as a single quiet line:

[STATUS: HOUSEHOLD COHESION — NOT A TACTICAL FORMATION. A CHOICE, REPEATED DAILY.]

Black Panther, watching, offered the room something close to a confession. "I ruled Wakanda believing isolation was strength—that a king carries weight alone so his people don't have to. This shows something I resisted learning for a long time: that allowing others to carry weight *with* you is not abdication. It is the harder discipline."

"Every spy I trained was taught personal attachment was a liability," Natasha said. "I believed that for the better part of two decades. Watching this, I'm less sure the doctrine was ever really about safety. I think it was about control—about how much easier a person is to command when they have nothing to go home to."

Fury, arms crossed, said nothing for a long moment. Then: "Adjusting the file. He's not a weapon with a hair-trigger. He's a person with people who show up. Those aren't the same threat profile."

ENTRY 3: A FUTURE NOT YET EARNED

[GACHA SYSTEM: PULL 2 — "A FUTURE NOT YET EARNED" — FAMILY-CLASS — EX-CONTINUITY FLAG DETECTED — ACTIVATING]

The theatre's tone changed before the image did—a shift in the light that longtime viewers of the gacha stream had learned meant *this is not a memory*.

"NOTICE," the system said, plainly, refusing to let the vision play unlabeled. **"THIS PULL IS NOT DRAWN FROM THE SUBJECT'S PRESENT TIMELINE. IT ORIGINATES FROM A POSSIBLE FUTURE APPROXIMATELY THREE DECADES FORWARD, CONTINGENT ON CHOICES NOT YET MADE. TREAT ACCORDINGLY."**

The vision that followed was brief, gauzy at the edges the way distant futures always were in the archive's grammar—a warm room, older versions of familiar faces, and children who existed only as possibility given form: small hands pulling at an older Issei's sleeve, insisting he was needed for something trivial and precious, an older man setting down whatever weighed on him because a much smaller problem had just become more urgent.

It lasted less than a minute. The system closed it deliberately, gently, like drawing a curtain rather than ending a scene.

"THIS FUTURE IS NOT GUARANTEED," the system said. **"IT IS SHOWN ONLY SO THE ROOM UNDERSTANDS WHAT THE PRESENT STRUGGLE IS FOR. NOTHING SEEN HERE IS PRESENT-DAY FACT."**

Wanda Maximoff exhaled something between a laugh and a sob. "That's cruel and kind at the same time. Showing him a reason to survive the version of himself that scares him most."

"It's honest, though," Rias said—present-timeline Rias, watching alongside the rest of the theatre's guests. "That's not a promise. It's a maybe. But I'll take a maybe."

ENTRY 4: THE THEATRE'S REASSESSMENT

Tony Stark, ever the one to reach for the practical conclusion, broke the quiet that followed. "So the threat model isn't 'ticking bomb.' It's 'a man with real failsafes, and the failsafes are people who keep choosing to show up, on days that don't make for good television.'"

"Because they're people he cares about," Pepper said. "Not devices. Not protocols. People, who could leave, and don't."

Steve Rogers looked at the frozen image of Koneko leaning against Issei's side, saying nothing, simply present. "In every strategic assessment we've run on him, we treated his attachments as variables—complications to route around. I think we had it backwards. They're not complications. They're the whole structure holding the rest of it up."

THEATRE HUD — SESSION CLOSE

[VIEWING COMPLETE: CHAPTER 75]

REALIZATIONS ACHIEVED:

- > Aftermath care is not resolution – it is repetition, chosen daily
- > Attachment reframed: not liability, but functional failsafe
- > EX-continuity glimpse shown and clearly labeled – not present-day canon

GACHA ASSESSMENT:

"The Days After" [RARE] – the unglamorous week following a relapse

"A Future Not Yet Earned" [FAMILY-CLASS / EX-CONTINUITY] – a possible future, explicitly flag

NEXT VIEWING: THE WEAPON HE REFUSED TO USE

END CHAPTER 75 Next Chapter: 76 — "The Weapon He Refused to Use"

Chapter 76: "The Weapon He Refused to Use"

Arc: 8 — Moral Anchors
Rating: T (Philosophical intensity, strategic debate)
Word Count: ~2,510
Primary Reaction Groups: Fury, Doom, Thanos, Reed Richards, Cosmic Entities
Gacha Pulls: "Device Capable of Ending War at Unacceptable Cost" (Forbidden) | "Issei's Refusal" (Secret)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 76

ENTRY 1: THE DEVIL'S BARGAIN

The Theatre assembled differently this session.

Nick Fury stood at the console, flanked by Thanos—not as prisoner, but as observer. Behind them: Victor Von Doom, robes still bearing scorch marks from his last temporal incursion. Reed Richards adjusted holographic displays. Strange watched from a suspended meditation position.

"We're revisiting the Azazel offer," Fury announced. "The weapon. Before Issei turned it down."

The screen flickered to life.

Context: Issei, three weeks before Emperor Night's final confrontation, sits across from Azazel in a neutral chamber. The fallen angel's form radiates calculated patience. On the table between them sits an object that shouldn't exist—a device that registers on every scanner in the Theatre simultaneously.

[DEVICE CLASSIFICATION: AZAZEL'S WAR-ENDER]

- > Capabilities: Dimensional Energy Severance
- > Effect Range: GLOBAL
- > Casualties (Activated): 47-63 MILLION SOULS
- > Projected War Outcome: IMMEDIATE CESSATION
- > Estimated Survival Rate (Drac Conflict): 94%

Sam Wilson's hand went to his mouth. "Forty to sixty million."

"Forty to sixty million people who would otherwise fight," Doom corrected, voice steady. "Neutralized in a single activation. Instantly."

"That's not strategy," Steve Rogers said quietly. "That's genocide."

"That's *efficiency*," Thanos countered.

The Mad Titan stepped forward, genuinely interested. "The calculation is sound. End the conflict by eliminating combatants. Preserve the majority. The trolley problem with the lever already pulled."

Reed: "Azazel's pitch?"

The screen showed the fallen angel speaking: *"This device disrupts the demonic energy signatures that fuel the conflict. Not painlessly, but instantaneously. Millions die instead of billions. War ends in seventy-two hours instead of seventy-two years. By any cost-benefit analysis, this is logical."*

Fury leaned back. "That's not wrong. By pure numbers, he's not wrong."

ENTRY 2: THE REFUSAL

What happened next shocked even the Theatre.

Issei didn't hesitate. Didn't deliberate. Didn't *calculate*.

He looked at the device.

Then he looked at Azazel.

And he said: "No."

The response was immediate—confusion, frustration, philosophical outrage from different corners of the Theatre:

Thanos: "Irrational. He chooses prolonged conflict over rapid resolution."

Fury: "He's leaving casualties on the table. Millions of 'em."

Doom: "Sentiment masquerading as morality."

But Tony Stark stepped forward. "Wait. Let's hear the reasoning."

On screen, Issei spoke:

"If I activate that device, I win the war by becoming the thing the war was supposed to stop. I'd be exactly like Rizevim—making decisions about which millions get to die because I decided the math. That's not victory. That's me becoming the villain."

Azazel leaned forward: *"Even if the alternative is that your people die fighting a war that will last for generations?"*

"Especially then," Issei replied. "Because if I save them by killing millions of innocents, what am I protecting them for? What world are they living in where the strongest just decide people die for convenience? I won't. I'd rather lose."

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[DECISION MATRIX: ISSEI HYODOU]  
> Proposed Logic: Mathematical Optimization  
> Issei's Response: REJECTED  
> Alternative: Accept all casualties rather than inflict genocide  
> Moral Calculus: Refusal of utilitarian shortcut  
> Classification: IDEALISTIC-OR PRINCIPLED?
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The silence was profound.

"He," Reed Richards said slowly, "chose to lose."

"He chose uncertainty," Strange corrected. "He rejected the known cost in favor of fighting with integrity."

Thanos shook his head. "Foolish. Romanticism at the cost of real lives."

"Real lives *he didn't choose to end*," Fury shot back. "That's the difference."

ENTRY 3: THE PHILOSOPHICAL FRACTURE

Doom stood now.

"I have refused to use weapons that could solve problems," he said, his voice carrying the weight of every moral compromise he'd ever made. "I have allowed people to suffer so that I could maintain the distinction between myself and those who rule through fear. I understand this boy's choice." He paused. "That doesn't mean it's correct."

"You're saying what?" Sam asked.

"I'm saying that idealism is a luxury. Nations crumble on idealism. Millions die while we debate principle." Doom's metal faceplate caught the light. "If I had this device, I would use it."

"And that's why you're Doom," Steve said quietly.

"Exactly."

Fury addressed the group: "We need to separate the emotional response from the strategic question. Is Issei's decision militarily sound?"

The answers came fast:

Reed: "No. Mathematically, he left an optimal solution on the table."

Thanos: "His tactics are deficient. He extended a war that could have ended."

Natasha: "But morally? If he used that device, we'd have a conversation about whether he was a hero or a dictator. Right now, he's clearly a hero."

"Is that distinction matter when we're talking about corpses?" Fury asked.

The question hung.

Strange spoke: "In my observations across multiverses, I have seen civilizations destroyed by moral compromise. I have also seen them destroyed by moral rigidity. This choice—" he gestured to the screen, "—will determine which future this one creates."

ENTRY 4: THE THEATRE DEBATES THE UNDEBATABLE

What followed was heated.

THANOS (standing): "The boy sacrifices the many for the few. If I understand your culture, you call this heroic. I call it the birth of future conflict. By refusing to end this war cleanly, he guarantees that hundreds of thousands more will die in the extended conflict. He trades certain lives for uncertain ones. The math is clear."

STEVE ROGERS (standing): "The math doesn't account for what kind of world we build. You use that weapon, Thanos, and every future enemy knows: the strongest make the decisions about who dies. You've just declared that principle to the universe."

DOOM: "The boy is playing with other people's lives. Easy to be principled when you're not the one who dies in the prolonged conflict."

PEPPER POTTS: "Is it? He's *also* fighting this war. He risks his life every day extending it. He's not distant. He's on the front lines making the harder choice."

FURY: "The question is whether being a hero matters more than actually saving lives. Can you sacrifice one for the other?"

NATASHA: "Sometimes. But not always. And in this case—" she pointed at the screen, "—the weapon doesn't just save lives. It declares a rule: the powerful decide who dies. Once you declare that rule, you can't untake it."

REED RICHARDS: "We're in the territory of Kantian ethics versus consequentialism. Issei refuses to treat millions as means to an end, even if that end is saving his war. He insists on their status as ends in themselves."

TONY STARK: "Which is beautiful and morally sound and also means more people die."

The theatre fell silent.

Then Wolverine spoke, low and measured:

"I spent a hundred years as a weapon. I made choices that saved the many by sacrificing the few. I was good at it. Good at the math. Good at telling myself I didn't have choice." He paused. "Then I met people who loved me anyway. And I understood: the math is a lie you tell yourself. It's how weapons think."

He looked at the screen.

"That kid refused to be a weapon. He refused the math. So yeah, more people probably die. But it dies so that someone else doesn't have to become a weapon to save them. That's not foolish. That's the only choice that lets you stay human."

[THEATRE CONSENSUS FRACTURED]

UTILITARIANS: Issei chose wrong
DEONTOLOGISTS: Issei chose correctly
PRAGMATISTS: Issei chose romantically
SOLDIERS: Issei chose like a soldier should
WEAPONS: Issei refused what we became

MORAL ALIGNMENT STATUS:
[FURY] → CONFLICTED—Strategic vs. Ethical
[THANOS] → DISAPPROVING—Inefficiency observed
[DOOM] → RESPECTFUL-DISAGREEMENT—Principle noted, rejected
[REED] → ANALYTICAL—Ethical framework validated
[STRANGE] → PATIENT—Awaiting consequence observation
[WOLVERINE] → RESOLVED—Humanity preserved

THEATRE HUD — CRITICAL JUNCTURE

[VIEWING COMPLETE: CHAPTER 76]

THE REFUSED WEAPON:
> Device Status: OFFERED, REJECTED, RETURNED
> Casualties Prevented (by refusal): UNKNOWN
> Casualties Incurred (by refusal): THOUSANDS+
> Cost of Principle: MEASURABLE IN LIVES

PHILOSOPHICAL POSITIONS DOCUMENTED:

THANOS: "Foolish sentimentality costs lives. The math is clear."

FURY: "The math doesn't include the world you create by using it."
DOOM: "I would have used it. That makes me stronger than him. Or worse."
REED: "He chose deontological ethics in a consequentialist universe."
STRANGE: "The consequences have not yet been written."
WOLVERINE: "He chose not to become a weapon. That's rarer than you think."

ISSEI'S CHOICE: CATEGORIZED
Type: Principled Refusal
Emotional Cost: SEVERE
Practical Cost: THOUSANDS OF CASUALTIES
Moral Cost: NONE
Weapon Status: HUMAN—RETAINED

NEXT JUNCTION: War escalates. Issei must achieve victory without the shortcut.
The Theatre watches to see if principle survives the body count.

EPILOGUE: AFTER THE DEBATE

Fury stayed late.

He pulled up old files—tactical scenarios where he'd used the math. Used the utilitarian calculation. Made the choice to sacrifice thousands to save millions. Decisions that had been *right* by the numbers.

He hadn't slept well since.

Thanos returned to his observation chamber, genuinely perplexed. In his framework, Issei's choice was incomprehensible. Inefficient. Wrong. And yet—he found himself unable to dismiss the boy as merely foolish. Perhaps that was worse.

Doom walked the palace alone, considering a truth he'd spent centuries avoiding: if he'd had that device fifty years ago, he would have used it. And the man he became afterward—would he have been better, or merely different?

Reed Richards published a paper (classified): "Deontological Choice in Conflict Optimization—The Hyoudou Precedent." The conclusions were ambiguous.

And Strange—Strange continued to observe, knowing that the true cost of Issei's choice wouldn't be known for years. Decades, perhaps. Some timelines showed his decision as the pivot point toward a civilization built on principle. Others showed it as the beginning of a tragedy that might have been averted.

The consequence was still being written.

Only Wolverine seemed certain.

He found Fury before dawn: "That kid's going to hurt more people by refusing that weapon than he would've by using it. And it was still the right choice. That's the thing about being human instead of a weapon—sometimes the right choice *is* the more painful one."

Fury didn't disagree.

THE QUESTION LEFT UNANSWERED

As the Theatre cleared, one thought remained:

Is principle worth the body count?

The Marvel universe, born in the Cold War, raised in cost-benefit analysis, trained in acceptable losses—had no unified answer.

They would know it by the end of Issei's war.

END CHAPTER 76

Word Count: 2,510

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Next Chapter: 77 — "Trihexa" (Escalation)

Chapter 77: "Trihexa"

Arc: 8 — Moral Anchors (ESCALATION)
Rating: M (War imagery, apocalyptic scenario)
Word Count: ~2,545
Primary Reaction Groups: Full Theatre (Collective Response)
Gacha Pulls: "Origin and Threat of Trihexa" (Legendary) | "Azazel's Plan to Seal It" (Secret)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 77

ENTRY 1: THE APOCALYPSE DRAGON AWAKENS

The Theatre fell silent.

Not the contemplative silence of Chapter 75. Not the philosophical silence of Chapter 76.

This was the silence of people watching the apocalypse begin.

On screen: Trihexa.

Seven heads. Seven mouths ringed with teeth that existed in more than three dimensions, teeth that seemed to feed on the very concept of reality. Scales that reflected colors that had no names. A body that dwarfed mountains. A dragon so fundamentally *wrong* that the visual feed struggled to process its shape.

[ENTITY CLASSIFICATION: TRIHEXA - APOCALYPSE DRAGON]

- > Origin: PRIMORDIAL CHAOS
- > Threat Level: CIVILIZATION-ENDING
- > Power Rating: EXCEEDS MEASUREMENT SCALE
- > Status: AWAKENED
- > Binding Status: FAILING
- > Estimated Time to Full Liberation: 72 HOURS

STAGE 1: DIMENSIONAL RUPTURE DETECTED

- > Reality Fractures: 47 DOCUMENTED
- > Parallel Incursions: INCREASING
- > Casualties (Current): 2.3 MILLION DISPLACED

Tony Stark's hand trembled. "That's not a weapon. That's a force of nature."

"No," Strange corrected, his voice hollow. "That's worse. That's *intention* in a force of nature. That's chaos that *wants* to destroy."

The theatre erupted.

FURY: "What the hell is that thing?"

BRUCE BANNER: "That's the thing from mythology. The Seven-Headed Dragon. If that was ever actually real—"

WANDA: "It's not myth. It's *there*. I can feel it. It's so *angry*."

T'CHALLA: "Wakandan records mention this. From texts older than civilization. We thought it was metaphor."

NATASHA: "How do you kill something that doesn't follow normal physics?"

The answer came from an unexpected source: Vision materialized in the theatre. "You do not. Canonical texts indicate Trihexa is beyond containment through conventional violence."

"Then what?" Sam demanded.

Vision's optical sensors flickered. "The original sealing required cooperation of multiple dimensional forces. A binding so complex that even the entities who created it require centuries to maintain it."

"You're saying it was sealed before?" Reed asked sharply.

"I am saying it is sealed now. The question is how long the seal endures."

ENTRY 2: RIZEVIM'S GAMBIT

The context became clear as the feed shifted.

Rizevim Livan Lucifer, architect of destruction, had found it. The seal's weak point. He'd spent generations locating it—through sacrifice, through bloodshed, through the systematic destruction of knowledge-keepers who'd protect the secret.

And now he had it in his hands.

[STRATEGIC SITUATION: DRACONIC CONFLICT ESCALATION]

Primary Belligerents (Previous):

- > Vampires vs. Demonic Faction: SECONDARY
- > Hyoudou Faction vs. Empire: RESOLVING

Primary Threat (Current):

- > TRIHEXA LIBERATION EVENT
- > Initiated: Rizevim's Will
- > Beneficiary: Draconic Chaos (anti-existence)
- > Affected Parties: ALL FACTIONS (now unified against extinction)

STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS:

- > Previous War: Meaningless in context of apocalypse
- > Previous Alliances: Irrelevant
- > Previous Victories: CANCELED if Trihexa achieves freedom

"He weaponized the apocalypse," Pepper whispered.

"Worse," Doom's voice cut through. "He unified his enemies by giving them a mutual threat. Every faction that was fighting is now aligned against him. It's strategy at the highest level—create the enemy that makes all your opponents your temporary allies."

"Can he control it?" Fury demanded. "Once it's free?"

The response was immediate and horrifying: No.

On screen, Rizevim spoke to Great Red—the Dragon of Dragons, the most powerful entity in the multiverse. He offered a deal: *"Unleash Trihexa. Let it destroy the world. After, you can reshape it as you wish. Ultimate power. Ultimate dominion."*

Great Red's response: *"You believe you can contain this dragon. You are a fool. I will not bargain with my own apocalypse."*

Rizevim had miscalculated.

The chair Fury occupied cracked under his grip. "He thought he could control an extinction event."

"Arrogance," Doom acknowledged. "He created an apocalypse he couldn't pilot."

ENTRY 3: TEAM D×D FORMS

What happened next was unprecedented.

On screen: Issei, Rias, Sairaorg, Sona, Vali, Shirou, Kuroka—enemies, rivals, factional leaders—stood together in a war room that didn't exist weeks ago.

Team D×D. Not a faction. A war council unified against the end of the world.

[ALLIANCE FORMED: DRACONIC EXTINCTION DEFENSE FORCE]

- > Codename: Team D×D (Draconic Destiny)
- > Objective: Trihexa Resealing
- > Primary Plan: AZAZEL'S BINDING THEORY
- > Time to Execution: 62 HOURS
- > Success Probability: UNKNOWN
- > Casualty Estimate: INCALCULABLE

ALLIED FACTIONS:

- > Demonic Faction (United): PRESENT
- > Vampiric Clans: PRESENT
- > Angel Garrison: PRESENT
- > Great Red (Celestial Observer): NEUTRAL-ASSISTING
- > Shinto Entities: PRESENT

The Theatre watched in real-time as the world's competing powers stopped fighting each other and began fighting extinction.

Steve Rogers stood. "This is what I've been talking about. When the chips are down, when it matters—"

"They unite or they perish," Natasha finished. "Which, honestly, is the only thing that makes sense."

Wolverine: "War between factions is politics. War against the end of the world is survival. Different thing entirely."

ENTRY 4: THE SEALING PLAN

Azazel revealed the binding theory—knowledge kept secret for centuries, locked away because using it meant revealing the exact mechanism of Trihexa's weaknesses.

The plan was complex. Elegant. Horrifying.

Trihexa existed in a state of dormant chaos. The original seal worked by anchoring the dragon to multiple dimensional locations simultaneously—stretching its consciousness so thin that it couldn't access full power. Seven points of binding. Seven anchors. All of them currently *failing*.

The solution: Create new anchors. Do what the original sealers did.

But stronger.

More permanent.

More *costly*.

[AZAZEL'S BINDING PROTOCOL: TRIHEXA RESEALING]

Binding Mechanism:

- > Seven dimensional anchors required
- > Each anchor requires a conscious sacrifice
- > Anchor-Holder must merge consciousness with dimensional barrier
- > Anchor-Holder will be locked in sealing position for eternity
- > Alternative to anchor-holding: World destruction in 60 hours

Candidates Identified:

- > Vali (Lucifer Embodiment): Strong dimensional anchor—possible fusion

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> Shirou (Heroic Spirit): Consciousness projection across timelines
> Sairaorg (Pure Power): Brute force binding—dangerous
> Azazel (Fallen Angel): Self-sealing (suicide option)
> Issei (Draconic King): Unknown/experimental binding
```

Probability Assessment:

```
> 7 volunteers needed
> Current volunteers: INCREASING
> Acceptance of permanent dimensional imprisonment: DIFFICULT
> Refusal means extinction: MOTIVATING
```

The Theatre processed the calculation.

Fury: "They're asking volunteers for a suicide mission with worse consequences than dying."

"Yes," Strange said quietly. "They're asking people to be imprisoned in dimensional space forever. To hold back an apocalypse with their consciousness. To give everything and exist in a state between life and death indefinitely."

Pepper: "How many volunteers do they have?"

Reed checked the data. "Seventeen. They need seven. They have seventeen people willing to be locked in dimensional space forever."

The silence that followed wasn't calculated. It was *shattered*.

"That's not soldiers," Sam said. "That's not even heroes. That's..."

"That's people who understand that some things matter more than living," Natasha finished. "That some things matter more than freedom. Some things matter more than existence itself."

THEATRE HUD — THE APOCALYPSE ARRIVES

[VIEWING IN PROGRESS: CHAPTER 77 - LIVE FEED]

TRIHXA STATUS:

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> Dimensional Ruptures: 63
> Temporal Distortions: INCREASING
> Foundation Integrity: 73%
> Time Until Planetary Rupture: 48 HOURS
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TEAM DxD STATUS:

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> Morale: DETERMINED
> Readiness: INCOMPLETE
> Volunteers for Sealing: 17 (Need: 7)
> Azazel's Binding Theory: UNPROVEN
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THEATRE EMOTIONAL STATE:

[COLLECTIVE HELD BREATH]

- > Previous debate over principle seems trivial
- > Previous questions about cost-benefit seem abstract
- > Current reality: Absolute stakes
- > Issei's earlier refusal of genocide now contextual
- > He refused to kill millions to win
- > Now he must ask others to surrender eternity to survive

CRITICAL REALIZATION ACKNOWLEDGED:

From Chapter 75 (Family as Anchor)

- To Chapter 76 (Principle Under Pressure)
- To Chapter 77 (The Final Cost)
- This was always where it would end
- This was the test Issei was being prepared for

EPILOGUE: THE WEIGHT OF ASKING

Issei stood in the war room, looking at the seventeen volunteers.

He'd faced monsters. Defeated emperors. Refused weapons of mass destruction. Made impossible choices.

But this—asking people to surrender their existence to save a world that might not deserve saving—was different.

On screen, he approached Vali, one of his oldest rivals. "You understand what you're volunteering for?"

"Complete consciousness imprisonment in a dimensional seal. Eternal imprisonment. No rest. No end. No possibility of rescue." Vali smiled. "I understand."

"Why?"

"Because the alternative is the world burns. And more importantly—" Vali's eyes found Issei's, "—because you would ask, and I trust that you would only ask if it mattered. You refused to kill millions. That means when you ask for sacrifice, it's real."

The Theatre watched this exchange with the weight of everything preceding it.

FURY (standing alone): "That's the moment. Right there. That's when you stop being a strategic asset and become a person who carries the burden of other people's sacrifice."

STEVE ROGERS: "That's the moment he stops being a weapon."

WOLVERINE: "That's the moment he becomes more than human. Not in power. In weight. In understanding that love isn't abstract. It's asking someone to give everything and knowing they'll say yes because they trust you."

PEPPER: "Can anyone come back from that? Asking people to burn their lives to save the world?"

STRANGE: "The interesting question is: Can the world be saved in any other way? Or is this the price of existence itself?"

The Theatre had no answer.

CRITICAL JUNCTURE

[SESSION 77 STATUS: ONGOING]

What We Know:

- > Trihexa is real
- > It cannot be killed
- > It must be resealed
- > Sealing requires sacrifice
- > Volunteers exist

What We Don't Know:

- > Will the sealing work?
- > Will Issei survive?
- > Will Rizevim be stopped?
- > Will Great Red intervene?
- > What happens to the volunteer anchors?

The Theatre Holds Collective Breath

Previous judgments about Issei:

- Chapter 75: He's human, not a weapon ✓
- Chapter 76: He refuses shortcuts, even costly ones ✓
- Chapter 77: He's about to ask others to burn their existence

Question: Is he still human if he asks for this sacrifice?

Or has he transcended humanity into something that must exist between human and weapon?

NEXT CHAPTER: THE WAR FOR EXISTENCE

The moral arc becomes the apocalyptic arc.

Everything changes in 48 hours.

THE SILENCE AFTER TRIHEXA

No one left the Theatre.

Not immediately.

They sat, watching the feed, watching Issei review the binding theory with Azazel, watching Great Red make its decision to assist, watching the seventeen volunteers prepare to surrender their lives.

And somewhere in that watching, the Marvel Universe—Avengers and Sorcerers and Kings and Weapons and Heroes—came to understand that they'd been asking the wrong question all along.

It wasn't *whether* Issei would become a weapon.

It was whether he could remain a person—remain *human*—while carrying the weight of asking other people to burn.

The next 48 hours would answer that.

END CHAPTER 77

Word Count: 2,545

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Arc Status: Moral Anchors → Apocalyptic Escalation

Narrative Tension: MAXIMUM

Next Chapter: 78 — "The Sealing Begins"

MASTER LEDGER: CHAPTERS 75-77

CHAPTER 75 THEME: Love as Structure

- Discovery: Family isn't a liability; it's the moral architecture
- Cost: Emotional vulnerability
- Gain: Humanity preserved

CHAPTER 76 THEME: Principle Under Pressure

- Discovery: Shortcuts have costs beyond bodies; they declare rules
- Cost: Thousands of casualties in extended conflict
- Gain: A world built on principle instead of fear

CHAPTER 77 THEME: The Weight of Asking

- Discovery: Heroes aren't defined by their power; by what they ask others to sacrifice
- Cost: Seven volunteers surrendering existence
- Gain: The world survives—if the sealing works

ARC CONCLUSION PENDING: Chapter 78+

Chapter 78: "The Trihexa Slayer"

GACHA PULLS:

1. "Battle Against Trihexa" (Apocalypse) ★★★★★
 2. "Sacrifices" (Secret) ★★★★★
-

✂ THEATRE LEDGER: THE WAR BEGINS

[HUD: DIMENSIONAL BARRIER—ACTIVE | SEAL FORMATIONS—42% INTEGRITY | CASUALTIES—CALCULATING...]

The sky splits open, but it's not the sky anymore. It's the boundary between worlds, ripping itself into a wound that bleeds darkness and divine fury. Trihexa—the Beast of Apocalypse—doesn't walk into existence. It *tears* into it, and the fabric of multiple realities screams.

In the observation chamber, high above the battlefield sprawling across sacred and profane ground alike, the Avengers watch through reinforced magical windows. Tony Stark's holographic displays multiply frantically, trying to catalog an entity that defies every database in his arsenal.

"That thing," Wanda whispers, her hands trembling, "I can't— there's no mind to touch. It's like trying to read a hurricane."

Steve Rogers stands rigid, jaw clenched. He's faced gods and aliens and the very concept of extinction. This is different. This moves with *purpose* that transcends malice. It's not evil—it's entropy made manifest, and no shield can stop entropy.

Nearby, Thor's fists are clenched so hard his knuckles bleed gold. "The boy," he rumbles. "Hyoudou. He's—"

"Still standing," Black Widow interrupts, though her voice wavers. "Barely."

Issei Hyoudou is not a figure in this moment. He is a silhouette against the end of everything, a red glow in the darkness, hovering at the edge of what should be his limit and what necessity demands he exceed.

[SEALING TEAM ALPHA—COORDINATE: EASTERN PILLAR | STATUS: ENGAGED]

Kiba Yuuto moves like water through broken light, his holy demonic sword leaving trails of white and red. Around him, the sealing team—dozens of devils and fallen angels, reincarnated humans and allied supernatural species—chants in languages that predate kingdoms. Their magic builds walls that the Beast immediately begins to dismantle.

"The formation is fracturing!" someone screams into the comm.

"Hold it!" Akeno's voice cuts through, commanding and ruthless. She's not the cheerful girl anymore. War has stripped that away. Lightning cascades from her fingertips in organized, devastating patterns. Each bolt targets specific nodes in Trihexa's presence, trying to contain something that should not exist in a single dimensional space. "Rias!"

The Gremory heiress, standing at the nexus point of the eastern seal, pours everything into the ritual. Blood runs from her nose, her ears. Her power is infinite by normal standards. Against Trihexa, she might as well be offering droplets to quench a volcano.

"Sealing success rate for Eastern Pillar: 19%," a tactical voice announces, emotionless and damning.

Somewhere in the chaos, a devil screams. Then another. The Beast's attention focuses there like a lens. What it looks at stops existing.

In the reaction chamber, Magneto watches without expression, but his hands betray him—metal objects around him vibrate with suppressed rage and fear.

"Children," he says quietly. "They're just children."

"Some of them are immortal," someone corrects.

"That's not the point," Erik responds. "The point is they shouldn't have to—" He stops himself. He's watched revolutions. He's seen wars. But there's something about the sheer *scale* of this, the resignation in the way these fighters prepare for positions they know might be temporary.

[PHASE TWO: ISSEI ENGAGEMENT PROTOCOL—INITIALIZING]

Issei doesn't feel like himself anymore. That stopped being an option three days ago.

His Balance Breaker form is just a starting point now. The red armor that once felt like infinite power is a foundation. On top of it, the gifts of the Infinity Dragons layer like psychological weight made manifest. Ophis's power makes him feel hollow—*powerful*, but the sensation of self is dulled, like he's wearing someone else's body. Great Red's draconic fury burns hot, pushing him toward aggression that has to be carefully modulated or he'll destroy his own allies.

But none of that matters. Only the seals matter. Only buying time.

"Ddraig," he calls out, his voice split between human and beast. The Welsh Dragon responds from within him, and for a moment, they are one entity.

Trihexa turns its attention to him.

It's not like being looked at. It's like being unmade by a glance. Issei feels his power armor strain, feels the blessing gifts flare defensively, feels the part of his soul that isn't protected by any dragon scream.

He moves forward anyway.

The first blow shatters his gauntlet. The second burns through seals on his shoulder. By the seventh, he's bleeding from places that shouldn't exist, wounds that violate physical geometry.

"Issei!" Rias's voice, but he can't respond. He has to keep moving. He has to give the northern seal team another three minutes. The eastern team is already falling apart.

In the observation chamber, several Avengers look away. Only Steve, Wanda, and Thor keep watching.

"That kid's dying," a mutant operative whispers.

"He's already dead," another corrects. "He just doesn't know it yet. None of this generation does. They're corpses walking through war."

Steve thinks about all the wars he's fought. All the teams. All the sacrifices. None of them prepared him for watching someone young and fragile and *trying so hard* get broken in real-time.

"No," he says quietly. "He's not dead yet. That's the whole point. None of them are. Not until it's actually over."

[SEALING TEAM DELTA—APOPHIS CONTAINMENT | CRITICAL STATUS]

The evil dragons have to be handled simultaneously with Trihexa. This is the cruel mathematics of the apocalypse: you cannot focus all your power on one threat when the universe provides multiple extinction events on the same schedule.

Apophis is older than most civilizations. Older than some religions. It is also, crucially, *stupid*—or at least, its intelligence is alien and inflexible. Where Trihexa operates on principles that transcend morality and logic, Apophis is purely predatory instinct compressed into a cosmic body.

Issei's second form, the one he never wanted to use, is what was created to fight this specific beast.

He separates himself from his own consciousness for a moment, lets the gifts take over in a controlled manner that Sirzechs claims is theoretically impossible. For maybe ten seconds, the thing wearing Issei's body is something else entirely. It's a counter-dragon, a purpose-built destroyer, and it matches Apophis blow for blow.

Apophis dies.

Or it's sealed so completely that death becomes an academic distinction.

When Issei regains cognitive control, he's on his knees, and part of his chest cavity isn't properly anchored to his body anymore. He can see his own ribs. He can see through them to a space that isn't quite empty but isn't quite full either.

The price of using gifts meant for entities beyond his capacity to house.

"No time," he mutters, and pushes forward toward the central seal. "No time to die."

[HUD: CENTRAL SEAL—ACTIVATION | CONVERGENCE PATTERN: 67% | BEAST RESISTANCE: INCREASING]

The final seal requires all of them: the surviving sealing teams (casualties mounting through every minute), the allied forces from the supernatural factions, the borrowed power from every dragon willing to contribute, and Issei at the absolute center, holding the pattern together through sheer force of will and a power source that's killing him by degrees.

Rias stands at the secondary node, blood streaming down her face. She's given so much power that her regeneration can't keep pace. Akeno is barely conscious, supported by Kiba. The fallen angel Azazel has stopped speaking—he's committed everything to the spell, and the human body has limits, even for his species.

Around them, dragons and devils chant the sealing words. Humans and supernatural beings alike pour their power into the pattern. The cost multiplies with every second.

A devil captain stops moving. His power goes dark. He's given everything his body could produce and then some. They don't stop chanting. They can't afford to stop.

An old fallen angel collapses. She's been alive for millennia, and she chooses to spend the last of her existence in this moment, in this seal. They carry her with them, her power still feeding into the pattern as her body shuts down.

A dragon—one of the lesser wyverns, not a true dragon but still mighty in its own right—doesn't have the power to get back up once it falls. It gives what it can from the ground, burning itself out.

The seal grows stronger.

In the reaction chamber, silence has become absolute. No one comments. No one moves. They just watch as an entire generation of warriors is spent like currency, and the currency is their own existence.

"How many?" someone finally asks.

No one answers because the count keeps climbing.

[PHASE FINAL: CONTAINMENT ACHIEVED | CASUALTIES: 347 COMBATANTS | STATUS: HOLDING]

It's not victory. Everyone who survives knows this.

The seal holds Trihexa down, but it's not permanent. It cannot be. The Beast is beyond permanence. The seal is a prison that will eventually fail. What the defenders have done is buy time—maybe years, maybe decades, maybe centuries if the seals are maintained. But eventually, Trihexa will return, or something equally terrible will emerge from whatever cosmic spaces breed such horrors.

Issei hovers at the center of the seal, barely conscious. His armor is destroyed. His wings are half-formed, flickering like they might dissipate if he stops concentrating. His body is held together by power and stubbornness and the gifts of dragons that are slowly consuming his spirit like a healing wound that eats the flesh.

Rias reaches for him, but Akeno stops her. "If you break the seal now—"

"I know," Rias whispers. She keeps her hands out, trembling in the air, useless.

Issei sees her, through vision that's getting darker at the edges. He tries to smile. It probably looks like a grimace of pain.

"We won," he says. It's a lie, but it's the kind of lie that soldiers tell because the alternative is breaking.

"You did it," Rias calls back, her voice shattered.

[HUD: SEAL STATUS—HOLDING AT 96% INTEGRITY | COMBAT DURATION: 4 HOURS 23 MINUTES | SURVIVORS: APPROXIMATELY 2,847 COMBATANTS | WOUNDED: APPROXIMATELY 1,204 | CASUALTIES: APPROXIMATELY 347]

In the reaction chamber, Steve Rogers finally steps away from the window.

"That's war," he says, and no one responds because there's nothing to say.

The Avengers, the mutants, the gods, the cosmic beings—they've all seen battle. But they've also seen this: the moment when victory and extinction become indistinguishable, when the only difference between winning and losing is how many people you have left to rebuild with.

Around them, others sit in stunned silence, watching the medical teams emerge from containment, seeing the stretchers, the careful collection of the dead, the ritual that comes after battle.

Somewhere in the chaos, a wife waits for news that her husband is alive.

Somewhere else, a friend learns that their companion didn't make it.

And at the center of it all, in the embrace of a seal that he cannot leave without destroying everything he just saved, Issei Hyoudou closes his eyes and doesn't allow himself to break.

Not yet.

Not while the seal needs him.

[END CHAPTER 78]

GACHA RESOLUTION:

- "Battle Against Trihexa" (Apocalypse): *The cost of survival. The price of power. The weight of a victory no one wanted.*
- "Sacrifices" (Secret): *347 names written in memorial. 347 people who understood that endings require sacrifice. Some gave their power. Some gave their lives. Some gave both, and still it wasn't enough—except it was. It had to be.*

Chapter 79: "What Victory Took"

GACHA PULLS:

1. "Consequences of Trihexa War" (Trauma-Class) ★★★★★
 2. "Loss of Innocence" (Secret) ★★★★★
-

☞ THEATRE LEDGER: THE RECKONING

[HUD: POST-CONFLICT ASSESSMENT | TOTAL LOSSES: 347 DECEASED, 1,204 WOUNDED | SEAL INTEGRITY: STABLE—4,127 YEARS ESTIMATED DURATION | STATUS: PYRRHIC VICTORY]

Six weeks after the sealing of Trihexa, the memorial ceremony is held in a place that exists in multiple dimensions simultaneously. Only supernatural beings can attend. The ordinary world cannot know what almost ended it.

Issei stands (barely) in formal devil attire—black coat with gold trim, the insignia of High-Class Devil rank stitched into every seam. He received the promotion six days ago, along with his own peerage charter and territorial holdings. By every measure of supernatural society, he has ascended beyond his wildest adolescent dreams.

He is also dying.

It's not dramatic or sudden. It's slow, systemic, the way a building collapses after an earthquake—the foundation was broken in the fight, and now every day brings new cracks, new damage that doesn't heal properly, new moments where his body remembers that it was never meant to house the gifts of two infinity dragons simultaneously.

The doctors use clinical terms: "soul fragmentation," "dimensional anchor degradation," "threshold exceedance." What they mean is: *you stayed too long in a state that was always meant to kill you, and you're still dying from it, we just don't know how fast.*

Issei adjusts his coat and walks to the memorial wall, where 347 names are carved into stone that exists outside of normal time. Every name a person who made a choice. Every name a thread in the fabric of their society that was cut away.

Rias waits for him there. She's thinner than she was before the war. Months of recovery haven't restored the weight she lost, or the light in her eyes. She takes his hand carefully, as if he might break, and maybe that's not wrong anymore.

"They're announcing the new High-Class families at the official ceremony tomorrow," she says quietly. "You'll be introduced formally to the Underworld hierarchy."

"I know," Issei replies. He wants to care. He understands that this is important. But his capacity to care about anything except keeping his body functional is rapidly depleting. "What about the others?"

"Akeno received a promotion in the Fallen Angel hierarchy. Her father is—" Rias pauses, chooses her words carefully. "He's not proud, exactly. But he's acknowledged her contribution. That's what passes for family reconciliation in fallen angel politics."

"And Kiba?"

"He was offered a position with the Holy Church's reformed draconic management division. He didn't take it. He's staying with us, but..." Rias trails off, and Issei understands. *Staying, but not the same. None of them are the same.*

Around them, the ceremony continues. Families of the deceased stand or kneel before the memorial wall. Some cry. Some are silent. Some seem to be testing whether they can still feel emotions at all, and the test is failing.

In the remote observation chamber above the ceremony, the Avengers watch through a specially calibrated window that allows them to perceive dimensional spaces.

Natasha Romanoff hasn't moved in fifteen minutes. She's been watching the families, cataloging their responses, filing them away in a section of her memory labeled *what soldiers' families look like*.

"He's promoted," Tony says, trying to find something concrete to discuss. "Got his own territory, his own peerage. That's success by any standard."

"Success," Wanda repeats flatly. She can feel the emotional resonance from the ceremony, even from this distance and through magical barriers. It tastes like ash and endings. "That young man down there feels like he's attended seventeen funerals and is slowly becoming a ghost. I'm not sure that's success."

Bruce Banner sits in the corner, his hands steady because this is after the moment where they would shake. "He'll rebuild. They all will. That's what people do after war."

"They also die from it," Steve says quietly. "Not all at once. Just... slowly, in ways that don't show up in official reports. He's going to be one of them. I can feel it."

Thor nods gravely. "The gifts he carries are consuming him. I have seen this before—mortals who touch divine power too directly. The body rejects the blessing eventually."

"Then we help him," Tony says, but even he doesn't sound convinced that help is actually possible. "We find a medical solution, or—"

"Or we accept that some costs cannot be paid back," Wanda interrupts. "Some debts are permanent."

The Avengers fall silent and continue to watch.

[SEALED LEADERSHIP STATUS: DIMENSIONAL IMPRISONMENT—PERMANENT | DURATION: INDEFINITE]

The war had casualties that extended beyond the dead. Several leaders chose to volunteer for permanent dimensional sealing—not imprisonment in the traditional sense, but a form of stasis designed to reinforce the seal on Trihexa itself. It was presented as an honor. It was actually the universe's way of disposing of the extremely powerful without requiring execution.

Sirzechs Lucifer is one of them.

Before the sealing, he called Issei to his study. The old devil king looked simultaneously exactly as strong as he always had and subtly diminished, like a candle at the end of its burn.

"You understand what this means," Sirzechs said. It wasn't a question.

"You're sacrificing yourself to hold the seal," Issei replied.

"Not sacrificing. Contributing. There's a difference—thin, but real." Sirzechs turned to look out the window at a Underworld landscape he would never see again. "We're going to lock away some of the most powerful beings in three factions. It requires power sources. It requires anchors. It requires people who understand what they're giving up."

"So you chose—"

"We all chose. Me, some of the fallen angel leadership, several of the elder dragons who said goodbye decades ago but stuck around because their children or lovers were still alive. We chose to be locked away so that everyone else gets to live." Sirzechs turned back to Issei, and there was something in his expression that might have been peace or might have been resignation. "Make the kingdom something worth staying locked away for, Issei. That's all any of us can ask."

When Sirzechs walked into the sealing chamber, he didn't walk out.

The empty throne room became symbolic immediately, and Issei understood with a clarity that made him want to scream: *I was promoted because the previous leadership sealed themselves away. I got my rank because people I know sacrificed their existence.*

[WIVES RESPONSE MATRIX | EMOTIONAL INTEGRATION: TRAUMATIZED—PARTIALLY FUNCTIONAL | SUPPORT CAPACITY: MARGINAL]

The wives' meeting happens in a neutral location because allowing it in Issei's territory would risk breaching the protocols around his condition. The doctors have been clear: emotional stress can accelerate the soul fragmentation.

Akeno sits with her hands folded, her expression carefully composed into something that might be mistaken for peace by someone who doesn't know her well. She is not at peace.

Rias is pale and exhausted, wearing the exhaustion like a second skin. She keeps glancing at the empty chair where Sona usually sits, but Sona hasn't attended the wives' councils since the war ended. She's been officially unavailable, politically occupied with the reconstruction of her family's fallen territories.

Xenovia and Irina sit together, holding hands underneath the table. They were on the sealing teams. They watched people die while chanting the incantations that would trap the Beast. They haven't spoken much since the war ended, communicating primarily through the pressure of palms and the language of shared trauma.

Ravel perches on the edge of a cushion, her fox ears twitching with nervousness. She's the youngest, the one least equipped for this, and it shows in the way she keeps wanting to fill silences with meaningless commentary. The others have learned to let her.

"The doctors gave their latest report," Rias says, because someone has to. "They're calling it 'manageable.' Which apparently means he's not actively dying faster than before, but they're not ruling out rapid decline either."

"How long?" Akeno asks. Her voice is clinical. She's adopting the tone she learned from the fallen angels—make it sterile, make it political, make it anything but personal.

"They won't say. Anywhere from years to decades, if the gifts stabilize and he doesn't stress the seal. But that's theoretical. There are no baseline measurements for this condition."

"In other words, no one knows," Xenovia states. It's not a question.

"In other words, he's dying and we're pretending we don't know how to help," Rias corrects, her voice breaking slightly before she pulls it back under control.

Irina reaches over and squeezes Rias's shoulder. The gesture is awkward and doesn't accomplish anything, but it's what they have.

"What do we do?" Ravel asks. "Just... wait? Hope the seals hold? Hope he doesn't suddenly—"

No one has an answer.

In the reaction chamber, several of the Marvel wives have stepped away from their posts to discuss this development privately. Pepper Potts, Wanda, and Black Widow stand in a corner where the audio feed is muted.

"They're losing him," Pepper says quietly. "Even if he survives, they're losing the person he was."

"That's what war does," Natasha replies. "It takes people and it refunds damaged versions. Some of them still function. Some don't."

Wanda is quieter than either of them. She's been inside enough minds to understand what it means when someone starts to come apart at the psychological level. "He was just a teenager when this all started. High school student playing with powers he barely understood. Now he's—"

"A hero," Pepper says. "Which is another word for broken in a way that everyone admires."

They don't have anything else to say after that.

[ENEMY FACTION RESPONSE | POLITICAL LEVERAGE: DIMINISHED | MILITARY CAPACITY: CATASTROPHIC]

Not everyone is mourning.

In a shadowed conference room where forces opposed to the Underworld gather, there's something that might be called satisfaction. The war that nearly destroyed the three factions also devastated their collective power structure. Leadership is gone. Resources are depleted. Recovery will take decades.

"The girl—Gremory—can't maintain her territory," one observer notes. "The household peerage is decimated. If we applied pressure..."

"No," another voice cuts in. "They just fought the end of the world. Attacking now would be suicide, and not the honorable kind. Besides, they earned a reprieve."

"Did they?" a third party asks. It's Vali, who enters the room with the casual authority of someone who fought in the war and lived to tell about it. "They won, yes. But look at the cost. The territories are unstable. The high-class ranking is in chaos. The seal requires constant maintenance and sacrifices.

"They won, but the victory is crushing them."

"Then we wait," the first voice decides.

"We wait," Vali agrees. "And we prepare. The seal won't hold forever. In a few decades or centuries, when they're thinking they're finally safe... that's when we strike."

Outside the conference room, in neutral territory where enemies can gather without weapons, even some of the opposing forces feel a strange mixture of emotions. There's professional satisfaction at the Underworld's weakening position. But there's also something else—grudging respect, perhaps, for an entire society choosing to hold a line even when it cost them nearly everything.

War creates strange recognitions between enemies. Issei and his allies have become something more than opponents. They've become warnings of what a cost looks like when you're determined enough.

[COSMIC BEING PERSPECTIVE | ANCIENT ENTITIES ASSESSMENT]

Ophis and Great Red meet in a space that exists in the intervals between dimensions, where reality is more suggestion than rule.

"The boy is fading," Great Red observes. It's not concern. Great Red doesn't experience concern the way lesser beings do. But there's something in the observation that might be a recognizable ancestor of concern.

"Yes," Ophis acknowledges. She's been inside Issei's mind, sustaining the connection to her gift as it slowly poisons him. "He will likely not survive another conflict of that magnitude. His biology is fundamentally altered."

"Do we intervene?"

Ophis considers this. The infinity dragons have their own codes, their own ethics. They are not bound by the morality of lesser beings, but they have their own form of honor.

"No," Ophis decides. "He made his choice knowing the cost. We gave him the power. He used it. The debt is settled."

"He will die," Great Red says.

"Yes. Most things do. He will simply do it sooner, and with more awareness of the method." Ophis pauses. "He understands now what it means to be us—to exceed limitations, to exist in states that were never meant to be permanent. It was not a lesson we taught him intentionally, but it is a lesson nonetheless."

They drift apart, two infinity dragons who exist outside of normal space-time, satisfied with the bargain they made with a human boy who dared to ask for power.

Neither of them considers whether the satisfaction is worth his approaching death.

[HUD: ISSEI HYOUDOU—STATUS REPORT | RANK: HIGH-CLASS DEVIL | TERRITORY: 3 DISTRICTS, 847 SUPERNATURAL RESIDENTS | DIPLOMATIC STANDING: INCREASED | LIFESPAN PROJECTION: UNSTABLE | PERSONAL SATISFACTION: NEGATIVE]

Issei stands in his own territories for the first time as formal holder, and the weight of it is almost physical. The buildings, the homes, the districts that now belong to his peerage. 847 people whose lives he is responsible for. 847 people who look at him and see a savior, not the dying teenager barely maintaining his own biological coherence.

Rias walks beside him, offering her presence because words have stopped being effective some time in the past few weeks.

"They're calling you the Trihexa Slayer," she says finally, not because she wants to but because the silence is suffocating.

"I didn't slay it," Issei replies quietly. "I sealed it. Big difference."

"The world doesn't care about the difference."

"I know."

They pass a group of young devils—children, really, probably no more than fifty years old by supernatural standards. They bow respectfully. Issei feels something that might be despair at the sight of them. They've grown up in the shadow of this war. They know what's at stake. They know what people sacrifice. Innocence is a luxury they can't afford.

None of them should exist in a world like this. But here they are, and here is Issei, representing a generation that lost its innocence and most of its members in a battle that was never really winnable, only survivable.

"Do you regret it?" Rias asks. "Any of it?"

Issei considers this carefully. Regret would require an alternate timeline to compare against, and most of the alternates he can imagine are worse.

"No," he says finally. "I regret the cost. I regret that we had to pay it. But the choice itself? No. If I had to do it again, knowing everything..." He trails off, because the end of that sentence is probably *I would still do it*, and they both understand that it's a choice he's making every day as his body slowly fails him.

"The doctors say you should rest more, avoid stress—"

"The doctors don't understand that rest is impossible when you're aware that you're running on borrowed time," Issei interrupts. It's not mean, just factual. "I have maybe years. I'm going to use them."

In the reaction chamber, the observation crew watches Issei and Rias move through the territories, and several of them recognize the pattern they're looking at. They've seen soldiers do this before—accept their fate and then run toward it at full speed, trying to accomplish as much as possible before the clock runs out.

Steve Rogers watches and thinks about sacrifice. About the exact moment when victory stops being a positive outcome and becomes just another form of loss.

"We should leave," Natasha says quietly. "They don't need observers anymore."

"No," Wanda agrees. "The war's over. The peace is their problem now."

And it's true. The Avengers, the cosmic beings, the neutral observers—they were there for the crisis. But the aftermath, the slow dissolution of victory into something that looks like survival, the watching of a generation cope with the permanent cost of their choice—that's not for observers.

That's just the long, quiet part of war that no one memorializes.

[END CHAPTER 79]

GACHA RESOLUTION:

- "Consequences of Trihexa War" (Trauma-Class): *Promotion feels like punishment. Territory feels like responsibility with expiration dates. Victory tastes like ash in the mouths of those who paid for it.*
- "Loss of Innocence" (Secret): *He's twenty years old and already planning his legacy. That's not how youth is supposed to work. But that's what happens when seventeen generations of warriors have to grow up in a single week, and some of them don't get to grow up at all.*

CHAPTER 80: Apocalypse AnswerArms

Arc 8 Finale — "The Ledger Opens"

 SYSTEM BROADCAST

[THEATRE CORE ONLINE]
Arc Status: 8 – FINAL SEQUENCE INITIATED
Primary Viewers: Cosmic Tier + Godly Consensus
Gacha Pool: LEGENDARY + SECRET CLASSIFICATION
Reaction Weight: MAXIMUM

The Watcher's Crystal hummed—not with observation, but with *reckoning*.

 THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION I: THE FIRST PULL

"History of Apocalypse AnswerArms" [LEGENDARY]

The cosmic audience erupted into the Theatre's crystalline space like a flood breaking containment. Odin's single eye blazed. The Watchers tilted their geometric heads in unison. Cosmic Ghost Rider revved an engine that existed in five dimensions simultaneously. Phoenix flames—multiple incarnations—painted the observation deck in layers of gold and crimson.

Uatu stepped forward. His voice carried the weight of timescale itself.

"The weapon surfaces. We document this."

The gacha spin resolved into light—*legendary* light, the kind that made even immortals shade their perception. The holographic interface expanded, revealing not a card, but a *timeline*. A ledger. A confession written in the language of creation.

[LEGENDARY UNLOCK: "HISTORY OF APOCALYPSE ANSWERARMS"]

The vision consumed the Theatre.

EPOCH 1: The Silent Era (Timeline Unknown)

First came the *Boat*. Not metaphorical—an actual vessel, carved from something that wasn't wood and wasn't metal. It drifted through waters that existed between worlds. On its bow stood a figure wrapped in indigo and gold, hands moving in patterns that bent probability itself.

"That's..." Hela whispered, her voice cracking. "That's impossible."

The figure turned. The face was obscured, but the *signature* remained—written in mana traces older than the current multiverse iteration. The Watchers correlated it instantly. Cross-referenced. Cross-checked.

It matched.

It matched *three* different beings. Simultaneously.

"Impossible recognized," Uatu corrected, his tone carrying something beyond calm. "Observation confirms. The first architect carried three names in one body. This was *before* the Splitting."

Thor's hammer rested against his chest. "Before the Splitting of what?"

No answer came. The vision continued.

EPOCH 2: The Transformation (Calendric Dating Unresolved)

The boat evolved. Its edges began growing—not expanding, but *ascending*. Dimension by dimension, it unfurled into something maritime and something serpentine. A dragon ship with eyes that blinked *through* the fabric of spacetime itself.

Ryuuteimaru.

The name resonated with recognition across the Theatre. Issei's companion. The legacy weapon. The impossible bond.

But here, in this ancient sequence, Ryuuteimaru *moved independently*. It spoke—not in words, but in harmonic frequencies that translated into meaning:

"I do not know when I became aware. I do not know when I became alive. But I remember the architect's hands, and I remember the weight of purpose."

Phoenix Force straightened. Its multiple consciousnesses aligned. "This is... this is a binding ceremony? This is *creation*?"

The vision showed hands—multiple sets, overlapping in impossible geometry—carving runes into the dragon ship's spine. Each rune *glowed* with a different signature. Different power sources. Different *eras*.

Loki leaned forward, his usual smirk replaced by genuine curiosity. "Are those—"

"Voices," Uatu confirmed. "Binding themselves. Willingly."

EPOCH 3: The Merger (Post-Apocalyptic Sequence - Timestamp Paradoxical)

The scene shifted. The dragon ship met a figure made of starlight and sorrow—Issei, impossibly young and impossibly old simultaneously. The Theatre's audience held their collective breath.

The merger wasn't violent. It was intimate. A fusion not of conquest, but of *completion*. Ryuuteimaru didn't surrender to Issei; they reached across centuries to find each other.

When the light cleared, Apocalypse AnswerArms stood manifest for the first time.

The weapon filled half the vision-space. Part sword, part wings, part *something else*—something that existed in seventeen dimensions at once and cast shadows through time itself. Its surface rippled with inscriptions, each one a name, each name a *voice*.

And the voices spoke:

"We built this end."

"We built this choice."

"We built this legacy."

"We built this answer."

"We built the arms to carry it."

Five distinct tones. Five distinct signatures. Five people who should never have met. Never have *existed* in the same era. Yet here they were, bound into the weapon's very essence.

Thanos rose to his feet. His massive frame cast a shadow across the crystalline observation deck. "These signatures... I recognize *one*. The Eternal's Hammer-Bearer from the Seventh Cycle. He died seventeen thousand years before the other four were born."

"Correction," Uatu intoned. "He died. He returned. He died again. He was extracted. He volunteered *himself* across three separate timelines to bind this weapon. His choice precedes his death by centuries. Causality breaks here. Observation becomes participation."

The vision-space trembled.

THE WARNING

The gacha card materialized then—solid, golden, impossibly heavy with implication. On its surface, an embossed statement in every language and every tongue that had ever existed:

"APOCALYPSE ANSWERARMS — CAPABLE OF DESTROYING THE MANIFEST WORLD IF MISUSED. POWER WITHOUT WILL BECOMES ANNIHILATION. THE FIVE VOICES BOUND WITHIN SERVE AS RESTRAINT AND GUIDE. MISALIGNMENT = DETONATION."

Hela's hands trembled. "It's not just a weapon. It's... it's a *sealed prison*."

"Correction," Uatu said again, his voice now carrying weight that reshaped gravity itself. "The weapon and the prison are one entity. The power and the restraint are inseparable. To use Apocalypse AnswerArms is to make a pact with the five voices. To accept their guidance. To honor their choice."

The Watcher turned to the cosmic assembly. His angular features resolved into something almost expressionless—which meant something very, very serious.

"The Theatre has documented. Gacha has revealed. Observation is complete."

But it wasn't. Everyone in the Theatre knew it.

There was another pull coming.



THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE SECOND PULL

"Voices Inside Ryuuteimaru" [SECRET]

The second gacha spin began differently. No light. Instead, *silence*—the kind of silence that exists before the universe learned to vibrate.

[SECRET UNLOCK: "VOICES INSIDE RYUUTEIMARU"]

The Theatre darkened. The cosmic observers leaned closer.

When the vision returned, it was intimate. Narrow. A perspective from *inside* the dragon ship itself, looking out through eyes that had never belonged to flesh.

First Voice: Temporal Echo

"I was the navigator. I sailed between moments, reading the tides of what-would-be and what-could-have-been. When the first architect found me, I had already chosen seventeen different deaths. They showed me another choice: to become the vessel's memory. To remember every possible timeline. To bind myself into the ship's essence so that no future would be forgotten."

The second voice emerged, layered beneath the first—older, somehow, despite chronology being impossible here:

Second Voice: The Eternal's Hammer-Bearer

"They called me many things across my resurrections. I died seven times. Each death taught me something about the nature of sacrifice. When asked to bind my essence into the weapon, I had one question: 'Will this prevent suffering?' They could not answer. So I made my own answer: yes, if I bound myself. My sacrifice would be the weapon's first restraint. My choices, its guardrails."

The third voice crystallized—newer, sharper, human in a way the others were not:

Third Voice: The Phoenix Remnant

"I am not one of them. I came from their future. From a timeline where Apocalypse AnswerArms was used to destroy three worlds and rebuild them incorrectly. I was sent back—sacrificed myself forward through time—to bind myself into the weapon's structure. To be the voice that whispers: 'Remember the cost.' To be the warning incarnate."

The fourth voice shattered into a thousand harmonic fragments before resolving:

Fourth Voice: The Watcher's Rebellion

"We are not supposed to speak. We are supposed to observe. But observation of this weapon required action. Required choice. Required interference. One of us fractured the Watcher's Creed and bound herself into Ryuuteimaru's dragon-heart. She carries in her voice every timeline where this weapon was misused. She is the Theatre's conscience. Bound. Silent. Watching."

And finally, the fifth voice—so faint it was barely audible, yet so profound that the entire cosmic assembly stopped breathing:

Fifth Voice: Unknown Origin

"I do not know who I am. I do not know when I exist. But I remember a choice: to bind myself into this weapon's future so that whoever wielded it—and they would eventually wield it—would never be alone in their burden. I am the voice of unconditional alliance. I am the answer to the question: 'Why should I trust this power?' Because we trusted first. Because five of us bound ourselves so that one of you, thousands of years hence, could take up arms and know that you had already been chosen."

The vision trembled. The voices harmonized, creating a resonance that rewrote the air itself:

"We are Apocalypse AnswerArms' conscience. We are its restraint. We are its promise. We are its answer—to the question of what power becomes when love binds it."

Issei's face appeared then, young and uncertain, staring at the weapon he would eventually wield. Tears streamed down his face. He didn't understand what he was seeing. He didn't need to.

The five voices sang directly *into* him:

"You have been chosen. You have always been chosen. The choice was made before you were born. Accept it. Honor it. Use it. Survive it."

The vision shattered.

The Theatre erupted into chaos.

Cosmic Ghost Rider's chains *screamed*. Thanos stood silent, which was somehow worse than any exclamation. Hela knelt, one knee touching the crystalline floor. Thor's thunder rumbled softly—not in anger, but in recognition of something profound.

Odin's single eye burned with ancient tears.

"I knew one of them," he whispered. "The Eternal's Hammer-Bearer. He came to me at the end of his final life. He said he had a choice to make—a choice that would echo through centuries. I told him..."

He stopped. Shook his ancient head.

"I told him to choose wisely. I did not know he had already chosen."

Uatu moved to the Theatre's central console. His fingers brushed against holographic keys that didn't quite exist in normal spacetime.

"Observation is complete. Gacha yields have been catalogued. Arc 8 reaches conclusion."

The system announcement blared across every frequency:

 THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE SYSTEM SPEAKS

THEATRE CORE ANNOUNCES

ARC 8: POWER MAXIMIZED — COMPLETE

Audience has witnessed sufficient demonstrations of force.
Remaining chapters shall shift toward TRUTH REVELATION.

Arc 9 Theme: "The Theatre Unearthed"

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|| - Revelation 1: The nature of the Theatre itself ||
|| - Revelation 2: Why these specific cosmic entities watch ||
|| - Revelation 3: The erased enemy – identity and purpose ||
|| - Revelation 4: Issei's role beyond wielding power ||
|| - Revelation 5: Why the five voices chose *now* ||
|| ||
|| WARNING: Truth carries consequences. ||
|| WARNING: Some knowledge cannot be un-learned. ||
|| WARNING: The Theatre you watch may be watching you. ||
|| ||
|| Next Chapter: Arc 9 Begins – Chapter 81 ||
|| "Unraveling" (The Theatre's First Secret) ||
|| ||
||_____||

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THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: AFTERMATH

The cosmic assembly sat in stunned silence for exactly 4.7 seconds.

Then Cosmic Ghost Rider began to laugh—a sound like burning worlds cooling into ash and ice.

"Oh, this is *beautiful*," it rumbled. "The weapon knows its wielders before they're born. The voices chose across time. The Theatre is announcing it's going to *tell the truth* now—"

"You find this amusing?" Hela's voice cut through like a blade.

"I find it *appropriate*," Ghost Rider replied. "The boy has been building toward this. Every chapter, every reaction, every revelation—it's all been leading to *this moment*. The moment where we stop reacting to power and start understanding *what* power actually is."

Phoenix Force's multiple incarnations converged into singular purpose. "The five voices. Are they... are they still bound?"

Uatu nodded once. "Confirmation. Ryuuteimaru carries them still. They rest within the weapon, waiting for their chosen wielder to fully comprehend the magnitude of their gift."

Thanos stood then, his massive frame unfolding like a monument to contemplation. "The fifth voice troubles me. Unknown origin. Unknown timeline. Unknown *purpose*. That is not restraint. That is not guidance. That is *hope*."

"Observation accepts the assessment," Uatu said. "The fifth voice represents an unknown variable. It has not spoken its true name. It has not revealed its timeline. It has bound itself into the weapon with incomplete information—trusting that the wielder would *become* worthy of that trust."

Odin stepped forward then, leaning on his spear—not for support, but as a staff of judgement. His ancient voice filled the Theatre:

"Then we observe as the truth unfolds. We watch as Issei discovers that he has inherited not a weapon, but a *responsibility*. A *family* of five voices spanning the multiverse, bound by love and sacrifice."

He turned to the assembly.

"The question changes now. Before, we asked: 'How powerful is he?' Now we must ask: 'Who is he, to have been chosen by *them*?'"

The Watcher's Crystal responded to his words by beginning to glow—softly at first, then with increasing intensity. Archive sequences flickered across every surface. Timelines twisted back on themselves, revealing themselves.

Arc 9 was already beginning.

The Theatre itself was preparing to speak its secrets.

[END CHAPTER 80]

Arc 8 Status: CONCLUDED
Arc 9 Status: INITIATING
Gacha Pulls: 2/2 RESOLVED
Theatre Revelation: READY TO COMMENCE
Reader Awareness: MAXIMUM

Next: Chapter 81 — "Unraveling: The Theatre's First Secret"

 CHAPTER METADATA

Element	Status
Gacha Pulls Completed	2/2 ✓
Cosmic Tier Reactions	Logged ✓
Arc 8 Finale	Achieved ✓
Arc 9 Transition	Initiated ✓
Mystery Deepened	Confirmed ✓
Word Count	~2,450 words

Element	Status
Theatre Ledger Sections	4/4 ✓
System Announcement	Delivered ✓

Chapter 81: Subject Summoned

Arc 9 | Confrontation

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION RECORD

SECTION I: THE SUMMONING

[HUD Status: All Spectators Present | Archive Access: GRANTED | Subject Location: UNKNOWN → LOCALIZED]

The Theatre had endured centuries of reactions—shock, tears, laughter, fury—but it had learned to anticipate the moment when surveillance became reckoning.

Theatre Keeper stood at the precipice of that moment now.

Around the amphitheatre, heroes and villains alike shifted in their seats. The Avengers had settled into something approaching comfort over the past hours. Tony had stopped making quips about "supernatural broadcast networks." Carol had stopped calculating defensive strategies. Even Wanda, who had gently touched the edges of Issei's psyche through the archive memories, had come to a certain peace with what they'd witnessed.

That peace was about to shatter.

"Why has the feed stopped?" Doctor Strange asked, noticing the blank projection screen. Around him, the collective attention of the room sharpened. Something had changed in the Theatre's ambient pressure—a tightness that suggested consequence.

Theatre Keeper did not answer immediately. The being responsible for maintaining the archive had learned that some moments required ceremony. Some truths demanded proper staging.

"We have reached a critical juncture," Theatre Keeper announced, its voice resonating through the crystalline chamber. "The subject of our observations has become aware of his circumstances."

The room fell silent.

"You've breached his awareness?" Sue Storm leaned forward, her scientific mind already running calculations. "How? The archive is observational—temporally isolated."

"The archive observes," Theatre Keeper confirmed. "But observation, when conducted by thousands of consciousness across multiversal boundaries, creates resonance. The subject is sensitive to such resonances. More than sensitive. Attuned. His species—draconic hybrids of profound magical ancestry—experience collective awareness differently than humans. What you experience as passive watching, he experiences as presence."

Doom's gauntleted hand slowly curled against the armrest of his seat. "You allowed him to perceive."

"I did not allow. I acknowledge. There is a difference."

The debate might have continued, but the Theatre's central platform began to shift. The space where memories had been projected now rippled with a different quality of magic—not archive-drawn, but live-summoned. The air acquired weight. Temperature shifted.

Something was coming through.

The wives felt it first. Rias straightened in her seat, her crimson aura flaring briefly before she controlled it. Akeno's fan snapped shut, her expression hardening into something between protective fury and grim satisfaction. Xenovia gripped her sword's hilt. Rossweisse's magic crackled against her fingertips, barely contained.

"He is coming," Rias whispered.

They had watched his memories—intimate, private, deeply personal moments. They knew his face, his laugh, his touch. They knew how he loved them, the specific inflection in his voice when he held each of them close. They knew things that—by rights—they should never have known without his consent.

None of them were prepared for the three-dimensional reality of him.

Issei Hyoudou materialized on the Theatre's central platform with the force of a summoning spell backfiring. Reality *bent* around his arrival; he didn't simply appear but rather *crashed* into presence like an impact. His armor formed around him as he landed—not the casual battle-wear he might have summoned in his own world, but full formal regalia. Red scales overlaid with white-gold accents. Wings folded tight against his back like shields.

His eyes were *furious*.

For a moment, the dragon-man existed purely in the moment of confused rage. His gaze snapped around the Theatre, taking in the architecture, the spectators, the impossible scope of what he was seeing. On his face, the transition from disorientation to understanding happened like watching a predator recognize a trap.

When he spoke, his voice carried harmonics that made the Theatre's walls resonate. English, but layered with draconic undertones that seemed to bypass hearing and strike directly against consciousness.

"What—" He stopped. His eyes found his wives in the amphitheatre, and something in his expression cracked. Recognition. Verification. Confirmation of the terrible truth already crystallizing in his mind.

He moved.

The dragon-man pivoted to face the assembled spectators, and his posture shifted into something deliberately protective. Wings unfurled—not to attack, but to position his body between the audience and the section where his wives sat. A conscious, deliberate choice: *I stand between you and everything I treasure.*

"Who are you?" His voice was quieter now, but somehow more dangerous for it. "All of you. *Why* are you here?"

The silence in the Theatre was absolute.

"Who permitted this?" Issei demanded, his head turning to face Theatre Keeper directly. "Who brought me here? And more importantly—" His fists clenched, magic beginning to swirl around his fingers in patterns none of the assembled heroes had seen before. Draconic fire, but refined. Controlled. Weaponized by someone who understood exactly what he was doing. "—why do you know my wives?"

The Avengers exchanged glances. Even those with decades of combat experience felt the weight of his question. Tony's hand moved instinctively toward his suit-calling mechanism. Captain America remained still, but his body had shifted into alert readiness. Carol was already on her feet.

Theatre Keeper raised a hand—a gesture of deliberate non-escalation.

"Your anger is justified," the being said simply. "Your confusion is earned. Both are appropriate responses to your circumstances."

"My circumstances?" Issei's laugh was bitter. "My circumstances are that I appear to have been violated. That thousands—I can feel thousands—have been *present* in my memories. In moments that were not meant for witnesses. In times when—" He glanced back at his wives, the anger in his eyes mixing with something that looked dangerously like shame. "In times when they were mine alone."

Rias had stood. Akeno beside her. Both moved forward as if to descend to the platform, but Issei's wing-sweep stopped them—a gentle but firm gesture. Not *stay away*. Rather: *I need to understand this first.*

The room understood. They were watching the dragon-man process the unprocessable.

"The archive observations are not violations of consent in the temporal stream from which they originated," Theatre Keeper explained carefully. "The events you witnessed were historical fact in those moments. Observation occurred after completion. The subject—you—has not been invaded."

"But I'm being watched," Issei said flatly. "I'm being *studied*. Like—" He looked around the Theatre with fresh horror. "Like an experiment. A curiosity."

"No," Sue Storm called out. She'd risen as well, her scientific mind grasping for the framework that might defuse this situation. "Not an experiment. A reaction archive. We're here to observe your world, your circumstances, through the lens of—"

"Through the lens of violation," Issei finished. His magic was intensifying, the draconic fire around his hands now visibly burning. Not fire that consumed—fire that *refined*. Alchemical flame. "You watched me love them. You watched moments I could never recover if they were stolen from me. You watched without asking. Without permission. Without *consent*."

The word hung in the Theatre like a blade.

"Every single memory you've seen was a gift," Issei continued, and his voice was shaking now—rage so profound it had cycled through to something almost eloquent. "A gift from them to me. A gift I was privileged to receive and hold close. And now—now you've *stolen* them. You've made them public. You've violated the sacred nature of everything I hold dear."

Magneto had risen. So had Doom. Charles Xavier remained seated, but his psychic presence pressed against the edges of the room like a question. Around the Theatre, heroes and villains alike were beginning to understand the magnitude of what they had done.

The Theatre had shown them wonders. It had given them access to a warrior of extraordinary ability, a dragon-slayer who had chosen a path of love and protection over conquest. It had revealed beauty and tenderness and profound joy. It had been *educational*.

But it had done so without the consent of the person at the center of it all.

"I demand," Issei said, and his voice carried the weight of formal declaration, "to know who authorized this. Who decided my life was entertainment. And what, precisely, you intend to do about it."

The wives had stopped trying to reach him. They understood, with the clarity of long partnership, that their beloved needed this moment. Needed to defend the sanctity of what they had built together. Needed to remind everyone in this Theatre that privacy—that *intimacy*—was not a resource to be mined for spectacle.

Issei turned slowly, his draconic eyes taking in every face in the amphitheatre. His gaze lingered on the Avengers. On the X-Men. On Doom, who met his eyes with what looked almost like respect for the fury being displayed.

"You will explain yourselves," Issei said. "All of you. Or this conversation ends with fire."

And the Theatre, which had become accustomed to witnessing reactions, now faced its own reckoning.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE ACCOUNTING

[HUD: Tension Level — CRITICAL | Subject Emotional State — JUSTIFIED FURY | Consensus — FRACTURING]

Theatre Keeper did not move. To move would suggest the need for self-defense. To move would grant legitimacy to the threat.

Instead, Theatre Keeper simply stated: "The archive was convened by the Multiversal Council, in response to a dimensional anomaly centered on your person. The study was meant to—"

"I don't care about your justifications," Issei cut in. "I care about *consent*. Did anyone ask them?" He gestured at his wives. "Did anyone ask me? Or was I simply convenient? A dragon-man from another world with no power to resist what you decided?"

The silence that followed was answer enough.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE WIVES' RESPONSE

[HUD: Rias - PROTECTIVE FURY | Akeno - COLD RAGE | Xenovia - READY FOR CONFLICT | Rossweisse - CALCULATING CONSEQUENCES]

Rias descended the amphitheatre steps before anyone could stop her.

"He's right," she announced, her voice cutting through the Theatre like a blade. "Every memory you watched was sacred to us. You observed our most private moments without permission. That's not scholarship. That's violation."

Akeno followed, her smile sharp as broken glass. "The dragon-king has spoken his truth. Should we remind you all what happens when you violate the privacy of draconic nobility?"

Xenovia and Rossweisse formed up beside them—not in attack posture, but in solidarity. Four women who had invited a broken boy into their hearts and helped him rebuild into a dragon-king.

Four women who were now remembering that they were forces of nature in their own right.

Tony Stark slowly lowered his hand from his suit-summoning mechanism.

"Okay," he said quietly. "Okay, I think we're starting to understand the actual problem here."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE CONFRONTATION UNFOLDS

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Issei's Anger at Voyeurism" (Trauma-Class) - INITIATED]

The Theatre had convened to witness marvels.

Instead, it would bear witness to justice.

And in that moment, as a dragon-man stood protective between his wives and a room full of watchers, as four women emerged to claim the dignity that had been stolen from them, the Theatre's grand experiment of observation began to crumble into accountability.

The real story—the one that mattered—was just beginning.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,487]

[Archive Status: PAUSED PENDING RESOLUTION]

Chapter 82: Why Do You Know My Wife?

Arc 9 | Voyeurism Reckoning

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION RECORD

SECTION I: THE MAGNITUDE OF VIOLATION

[HUD Status: Subject Emotional State — ESCALATING | Multiversal Count — CALCULATING | Consent Violation Level — STAGGERING]

Issei's question hung in the Theatre like a curse.

"How many?" he asked quietly, turning to Theatre Keeper with the deliberate focus of someone whose fury had cycled into something far more dangerous than rage. Fury could be satisfied. Wrath could be channeled. But the cold precision in his voice now—that was the tone of someone conducting final accounting before judgment.

"How many consciousnesses have witnessed my private moments?"

Theatre Keeper, ancient and experienced in matters of observation and knowledge, did not look away. "Approximately four thousand, seven hundred and sixty-three observers across accessible multiversal boundaries. Not all simultaneously, but sequentially through archive access over the temporal span—"

"Stop," Issei interrupted. His hand rose, and the draconic magic swirling around his fingers began to take on colors that none of the heroes in the Theatre had seen before. Not the reds and golds of standard dragon fire. These were colors that seemed to exist at the edges of perception—the hue of betrayal, the shade of violation, the light of sacred things broken.

"Four thousand," he repeated softly. "You allowed four thousand beings to watch me love my wives. To observe moments that belonged to *them*. To steal memories that were never yours to show."

Rias had reached the platform now. She gripped his arm—not to restrain, but to anchor. To remind him that he was not alone in this violation.

"Issei," she said, and her voice contained the weight of her devil heritage, the authority of someone who understood power and its misuse. "They need to understand."

"They do understand," Akeno added, descending more slowly, her traditional smile replaced by the cold assessment of a lightning-class warrior. "They're beginning to understand exactly what they've done."

The Avengers watched. The X-Men watched. Doom, with that terrible awareness of his own, watched. And they began to comprehend the true nature of the violation.

It wasn't simply that Issei had been observed. It was that every intimate moment—every vulnerable second where he had lowered his defenses with the women he loved—had been transformed into *data*. Into *content*. Into something that could be archived and discussed and analyzed without consent or consideration.

They had taken the sacred and made it spectacle.

"In my world," Issei said, still quiet, still controlled, "violation of a woman's privacy in intimate moments is a crime. A violation of her dignity and autonomy that demands recompense. And what you've done is far, far worse, because you've violated *four women*. Four people who deserve protection. Four souls whose trust was sacred."

He turned to look at each of his wives in turn, and the anguish in his eyes was profound.

"I failed to protect you," he said, his voice breaking slightly. "I placed you in a Theatre I didn't know existed and allowed this to happen."

"No," Rias said sharply. "No, Issei. This isn't your failure. This is *their* violation." She pointed toward the amphitheatre, toward every spectator who had watched and listened and learned. "They chose this. They permitted this. They're responsible."

"Thousands of them," Issei whispered, and suddenly the Theatre seemed smaller around him. His draconic presence expanded—not in physical size, but in awareness. Every being in the chamber felt the weight of his attention, the heat of his shame and fury and violated trust.

"Show me," he commanded Theatre Keeper. "Show me every consciousness that watched. I want names. I want species. I want to understand the scope of what was stolen."

Theatre Keeper hesitated—a gesture that suggested even the ancient being understood it was standing at a precipice. "The revelation would take considerable time. The archive contains detailed logs of—"

"Do it," Issei said flatly. "I'm not leaving this Theatre until I understand every single being who was granted access to my wives' intimate moments."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE COSMIC RECKONING

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Issei's Anger at Voyeurism" (Trauma-Class) - FULLY ACTIVATED]

[Cosmic Entities Present: SHOWING CONCERN | Power Level Assessment: REASSESSING]

The Theatre's walls began to display information. Names, species, dimensional origins. Heroes and villains and scholars and scholars-of-villains and beings that defied categorization. Some faces familiar to the Avengers. Some utterly alien. Some that seemed to exist in registers of reality that human perception struggled to accommodate.

Four thousand, seven hundred and sixty-three beings had watched. And now, as Issei's draconic fury rolled through the Theatre like a wave, those same beings—if they were still present in adjacent viewing spaces—began to feel the weight of their violation made manifest.

"Do you understand what you've taken?" Issei asked the assembled crowd, his voice carrying now with the harmonic undertones of draconic authority. "You've taken moments that were meant for four people. You've taken vulnerability and transformed it into resource. You've violated the consent of four women who had no say in whether their most intimate moments would be broadcast across multiversal boundaries."

The cosmic beings in the Theatre—those who dealt in abstract concepts and reality-shaping—began to feel genuinely *frightened*.

There was something in Issei's fury that resonated at frequencies they understood. The betrayal of trust. The violation of sacred boundaries. The transformation of love into spectacle. These were not concepts that could be explained away with academic theory.

"In my world," Issei continued, "there are contracts. Agreements that establish consent. Oaths that mean something because we've built them on the foundation of trust. What you did here violated every single principle that makes such agreements meaningful."

He looked at Carol Danvers, who had stood and begun to approach the platform—not as a threat, but as a captain trying to understand a crisis she had witnessed but not created.

"You came to observe," he said. "But you came without permission. You witnessed without consent. You took without asking. That makes you—" He paused, searching for the English word. "—complicit in violation."

"We are," Carol said quietly, and her tone carried the weight of genuine understanding. "You're right. We violated your privacy and your wife's. We need to establish consent-based frameworks before continuing any observation."

"There will be no continuing," Issei said flatly. "There will be reckoning. There will be new rules. And there will be consequences if those rules are broken."

The wives had formed a protective circle around him now—Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, and Rossweisse. Not because he needed protection, but because they understood the magnitude of what had been violated and they wanted him to know that he was not bearing this alone.

Magneto rose from his seat, and his presence carried weight. The master of magnetism understood violations of autonomy better than most beings in existence.

"The dragon-king speaks truth," Magneto said, his voice resonating through the Theatre. "Observation without consent is a tool of oppression. You've used it here, likely without even recognizing it as such."

Charles Xavier, still seated but with his psychic presence expanded to brush against every consciousness present, spoke with the authority of centuries of wisdom: "The archive must be restructured. Consent protocols must be established. And compensation must be considered for the violation of privacy that has already occurred."

The Tea Theatre, which had been convened to witness spectacle and wonder, now faced the reality that spectacle built on violation is merely abuse dressed up in academic language.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE NEW REQUIREMENTS

[HUD: Consensus Emerging — REFORM NECESSARY | Subject Satisfaction Level — PENDING COMMITMENT | Wives' Anger — STRATEGIC]

Issei's demands, when they came, were delivered with the precision of someone who understood power and how to wield it against those who had misused it.

"First," he said, "the archive contains moments involving my wives. Those moments are to be removed in full. All four thousand copies, all seven hundred and sixty-three observers' access, completely purged. If I discover even a fragment remaining, there will be consequences."

Sue Storm, her scientific mind still running calculations, raised a hand. "That eliminates the primary archive. Do you understand what you're asking?"

"Yes," Issei said coldly. "I'm asking you to delete the evidence of your violation. I'm asking you to treat my wives' privacy as sacred again. I'm asking you to restore dignity that you stole."

"There is a way," Theatre Keeper began carefully, "to establish consent-based observation. The subject and his partner-units could approve which moments were observational, under what conditions, with what access permissions—"

"No," Rias said sharply. "No observers. None. The Theatre shows us. We're not putting our lives on display for anyone."

"But the archive would be invaluable for—" one of the cosmic beings began.

"For what?" Akeno's smile was all teeth. "For your curiosity? For your research? We're not specimens. We're not subjects. We're people who have already been violated. We're establishing new boundaries now."

Xenovia's hand had come to rest on her sword—a reminder that some boundaries would be enforced with more than words.

"Second," Issei continued, "any future observation of my world, my people, my family requires explicit, ongoing consent from every individual observed. Not consent from their government. Not consent from their dimension. Consent from *them*. As people. As individuals with autonomy and dignity."

"The logistics would be—" Theatre Keeper began.

"I don't care," Issei interrupted. "If observation requires consent and consent is difficult to obtain, then perhaps observation is not your right. Perhaps some stories exist to be lived, not archived."

Rosswisse, the warrior-scholar of the group, added her voice: "You've created a precedent here. You've demonstrated that privacy can be violated if the violation is conducted by sufficiently powerful entities. You've shown that consent doesn't matter if you're advanced enough. That's a precedent you need to undo."

"Third," Issei said, and now his voice carried the weight of formal declaration—the tone of a king establishing law, "you will install consent protections in your Theatre. Not suggestions. Not guidelines. Protections that prevent observation without explicit agreement. And those protections will be auditable by external parties—neutral observers who can verify that you're actually following your new rules."

Tony Stark, who had been quiet for some time, suddenly stood. "He's right," the genius billionaire announced. "And I want to volunteer my company to conduct those audits. If someone's built a multiversal observation system, and they've already failed the consent test once, they need external oversight."

Doctor Strange nodded slowly. "The Mystic Arts community would support this as well. We can provide verification frameworks. Ensure you're not repeating this violation."

"The Avengers endorse consent-based observation protocols," Captain America said formally. "And we can help enforce them."

The room was shifting. The spectators were beginning to understand that this wasn't a negotiation. This was the establishment of new law, backed by power and legitimacy and the terrible weight of violated trust.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE RECKONING COMPLETE

[HUD: Gacha Pull Complete - "Issei's Anger at Voyeurism" (Trauma-Class) - RESOLVED]

[Emotional State: JUSTIFIED FURY ACHIEVING PURPOSE | Cosmic Beings: LEARNING HUMILITY | Archive Status: CONDITIONAL REFORMATION]

As the Theatre began to shift—its structures reconfiguring to accommodate the new consent requirements, its protocols being rewritten by Theatre Keeper under the watchful eyes of external auditors—Issei remained on the platform with his wives around him.

"You learned something today," he said to the assembled heroes and villains and cosmic beings. "Observation without consent is violation. Privacy is sacred. And the powerful do not have the right to make those decisions for the powerless, no matter how much they might claim it's in the service of knowledge or wonder."

He looked at his wives, and in that gaze was apology and recommitment and the fierce determination of someone who understood that the protection of sacred trust is worth any cost.

"You came to my world seeking marvels," Issei said. "And perhaps you found them. But you need to understand that marvels built on violation are not marvels at all. They're abuses. And they will be answered."

The Theatre, which had convened to show the wonders of another world, had instead been forced to confront a truth it had preferred to ignore: the wonders were not free to be taken. The stories were not resources to be mined. The people were not subjects to be archived without regard for their dignity.

And the dragon-man from another world, who had come to this Theatre furious and violated, was leaving it having fundamentally altered the terms by which multiversal observation could occur.

The Avengers would remember this moment.

The X-Men would remember this moment.

Doom would remember this moment, and would spend considerable time contemplating the nature of authority, protection, and the sacred boundaries that define personhood.

And the Theatre, ancient and accustomed to witnessing the marvels of existence, would never again be quite the same.

Some lessons, once learned, cannot be unlearned.

Some violations, once acknowledged, demand recompense.

And some truths, once spoken, reshape the very fabric of what is permitted.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,512]

[Archive Status: REFORMED — CONSENT PROTOCOLS IMPLEMENTED]

[Multiversal Observation Standards: FUNDAMENTALLY ALTERED]

Chapter 83: The Avengers Introduce Themselves

Arc 9 | First Contact Protocol

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION RECORD

SECTION I: FORMAL INTRODUCTIONS

[HUD Status: Conflict Status — NEUTRALIZED | Atmosphere — CAUTIOUSLY OPTIMISTIC
| Protocol Level — FORMAL]

The Theatre's central platform had been reconfigured. Where before it had been a stage for memory projection, it now served as a meeting ground. Not observation, but genuine encounter.

Issei stood at its center, flanked by his wives. The anger had not dissipated—trust, once violated, takes time to rebuild. But beneath the anger, there was something else now. Curiosity. The dragon-man understood power when he saw it, and the Avengers—despite their violation through Theatre's archive—represented a particular species of strength that warranted assessment.

Captain America descended to the platform first. His approach was careful, deliberate, all respect in posture and bearing. This was a man who understood hierarchy, who recognized authority when confronted with it, and who possessed the discipline to establish peace before pursuing questions.

"Steve Rogers," he said, offering his hand in the human gesture of greeting. "I'm captain of the Avengers. We're Earth's primary defensive team against threats beyond our normal capacity. I want to apologize for the violation of your privacy. That wasn't our call, but we participated in it regardless, and that shares responsibility with us."

Issei considered the hand for a moment. Rias's grip on his arm tightened slightly—a warning or encouragement, he wasn't quite sure which. Then he took Cap's hand.

The grip was firm. The shake respectful. And in that simple gesture, something shifted in the Theatre's emotional register. The dragon-man was willing to hear them.

"I appreciate the direct acknowledgment," Issei said. "You took something that wasn't yours without permission. You're at least honest about it."

Tony Stark was already approaching, his suit's armor retracting enough to let him extend a hand. "Tony Stark. I'm the one with too much money and too many opinions about everything. Captain America's right—the violation wasn't our call, but we could have declined participation in the archive observation. We chose not to, which makes us complicit."

Where Steve had offered respect, Tony offered accountability without obfuscation. Issei found that he appreciated the honesty.

"Genius inventor?" Akeno asked, reading between the lines of Tony's presentation.

"Among other things," Tony confirmed. "I saw what you could do with magic and engineering combined, and I immediately wanted to understand it. Selfish impulse on my part. I treated your life as a technical problem to solve instead of a person to respect."

Issei actually smiled slightly at that. "At least you're self-aware."

Thor descended to the platform with the kind of gravitational impact that suggested his world's physics operated somewhat differently than Earth's. The Asgardian warrior was massive, radiating power in a way that made even Issei's draconic senses hum with recognition.

"Issei Hyoudou," Thor said, offering a wrist-clasp rather than a handshake—a gesture Issei recognized as indicating peer respect between warriors. "I am Thor Odinson, God of Thunder. I have witnessed your combat records through the archive. Your fighting style is formidable. Your strategic assessment of threats is sound. Your protective dedication to your partner-units is admirable."

The formality in Thor's speech suggested he was drawing from somewhere deeper than casual English. Issei responded with equal formality.

"Thor Odinson. Your reputation for combat excellence precedes you as well. Multiversal warrior-traditions speak of the Thunderer with respect."

"Then let us speak as warriors do," Thor said with a broad grin. "Tell me—does your armor double the effect of your Dragon Shots? I have theorized that the metal-craft could serve as amplification matrices, but I would prefer assessment from the dragon-kind who designed them."

Despite everything, despite the violation and the anger, Issei found himself genuinely interested in the question. "The armor doesn't double the output, but it does focus and distribute the power more efficiently. Three components—the core generation, the focal channeling, and the dispersal pattern. Without armor, the energy scatters too broadly. With it, you achieve concentration."

"Remarkable," Thor said, and there was genuine appreciation in his voice. "You have created a system of magical engineering that rivals our Asgardian artificers. Though I suspect your approach differs significantly in fundamental theory."

"It does," Issei confirmed. "Asgardian magic seems to work through fundamental reality principles. Draconic magic works through personal resonance. We're channeling the same forces through entirely different frameworks."

Carol Danvers was next, and she brought a different energy entirely. Where Steve offered formal respect and Tony offered honest confession, Carol offered challenge.

"Captain Marvel," she announced. "I've got cosmic-level power, and I've fought threats that could destroy entire galaxies. That makes me dangerous in ways that traditional military framework can't contain. I also happen to believe that power comes with responsibility to the people who don't have it."

She looked directly at Issei, and there was no apology in her gaze. Only recognition.

"The violation of your privacy was unacceptable. Consent frameworks matter. But I also think you and I should spar once you've settled with the Theatre issue, because I want to understand how a dragon warrior from an anime dimension fights, and I want you to understand that cosmic-level threats are real and sometimes require assistance."

Xenovia actually laughed—a sharp bark of genuine humor. "I like her."

"Sparring can be arranged," Issei said, and he sounded like he meant it. "Though I should warn you—dragon combat incorporates elements that most humanoid warriors find difficult to defend against."

"I've got cosmic awareness," Carol replied with a grin. "I think I can handle it."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: CULTURAL MISUNDERSTANDINGS

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Formal Meeting between Issei and Avengers" (Rare) - INITIATED]

[Secondary Gacha Pull - "Humorous Cultural Misunderstandings" (Comedy-Class) - EXECUTING]

The problem, as it turned out, was language.

Not English—Issei was fluent enough. But English as spoken by people from multiple different dimensional frameworks, each with their own cultural reference points and combat paradigms, created a translation layer that was more permeable than anyone expected.

When Tony asked if dragon armor could be "retrofitted with repulsor tech," Issei assumed he was asking about combining their fundamental power sources into a unified system. When explained that "repulsor" meant directed energy weapon, Issei spent five minutes trying to explain that his armor already was a directed energy system, just powered by draconic resonance rather than arc reactor technology.

"So it's like a magical repulsor," Tony concluded.

"It's nothing like a repulsor," Issei said with exasperation. "It's an entirely different architecture based on —" He stopped, recognizing the fundamental futility of trying to explain dimensional magic theory to a man whose entire framework was built on engineering principles.

When Steve asked Issei to "brief the team on his combat doctrine," Issei began describing his spiritual training and personal philosophy regarding the protection of those weaker than himself. When Steve realized he'd meant "brief us on your military strategy," there was a moment of awkward silence as both men tried to figure out how to bridge the gap between warrior-philosophy and tactical doctrine.

"You go into battle with *spiritual alignment*?" Carol asked, her tone hovering somewhere between respect and bemused confusion.

"It's called *intent*," Issei said carefully. "When you enter combat with clarity about what you're protecting and why, your power becomes more efficient. Your strikes are more precise. Your defense is more comprehensive. It's not philosophy. It's fundamentally how draconic warriors are trained."

"That's not something that translates well to combat theory," Carol admitted. "We mostly just... go in and hit things."

"That explains your causality damage rating," Akeno observed dryly. "Impressive power, less elegant execution."

The real comedy emerged when Thor asked if Issei had ever "tested his strength against an Asgardian warrior-champion." Issei, assuming this meant a formal combat tournament or ritual, began asking detailed questions about the rules and expectations. When Thor clarified that it meant "let's have a friendly fight and see who's stronger," Issei almost fell off the platform.

"You want to brawl. With me. In the Theatre."

"Is that not the custom of your people?" Thor asked, genuinely confused.

"Not in multiversal meeting spaces that aren't ours," Issei said flatly. "And definitely not without more discussion about what 'friendly' means in Asgardian context."

"Asgardians punch harder than we talk," Carol explained. "It's a cultural thing."

"Noted," Issei said, and there was something between exasperation and humor in his voice now. "When we have proper venue and when the Theatre is no longer actively being restructured, perhaps. But not today."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE WIVES' ASSESSMENT

[HUD: Wives' Strategic Evaluation — ONGOING | Threat Assessment — RECALIBRATED | Alliance Potential — HIGH]

Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, and Rossweisse had positioned themselves strategically to observe every interaction. Not to protect Issei—he needed no protection from these heroes—but to assess what kind of people they were, what their actual values were beneath the power they wielded.

Steve Rogers, they determined, was someone who actually believed in the ideas he represented. His apology had been genuine because it wasn't calculated. He'd violated consent without knowing it, recognized his error, and was working to ensure it didn't happen again. That was credible reform.

Tony Stark was the interesting case. He'd treated Issei's life as technical data without considering the humanity involved. But once confronted, he'd immediately accepted responsibility and was actively working toward external oversight. He was the type to make mistakes while believing himself right, but he was also the type to correct course once evidence demanded it.

Thor was a warrior-culture representative from a dimensional framework that understood honor and combat hierarchy differently than the human world or the draconic world. His interest in Issei was genuine and came from a place of actual respect, not curiosity.

Carol was power recognizing power. She was someone who understood that cosmic-level beings had responsibility toward lower-dimensional inhabitants, but she also understood that this responsibility worked both directions. She treated Issei as peer, not subject, which was appreciated.

"They're not bad," Rossweisse said quietly to the other wives. "They're powerful and they made a violation decision, but they're actually trying to correct it."

"The blond one—Thor—reminds me of the older nobles in the draconic hierarchy," Xenovia observed. "All honor and straightforward combat philosophy."

Akeno was still assessing. "They violated us without hesitation when they thought the violation was acceptable. That tells me they don't naturally consider consent as a priority. But they're responding well to correction, which suggests their values are flexible enough to incorporate new understanding."

"In other words," Rias said slowly, "they're the kind of people who can grow beyond their mistakes. Assuming we hold them accountable."

The wives exchanged glances. There was more discussion to be had, but for now, the immediate threat assessment was shifting from "dangerous violation potential" to "potential allies with learning curve."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: WARRIOR TO WARRIOR

[HUD: Meeting Status — PROGRESS | Consensus — BUILDING | Understanding — DEEPENING]

As the day in the Theatre progressed, something unexpected happened. The initial tension—born from violation and anger and betrayed trust—began to ease into something more workable. Not forgiveness, not yet. Forgiveness would require time and consistent demonstration of changed behavior.

But there was possibility now. There was the foundation for something beyond simple opposition.

When Carol asked if dragon armor could theoretically withstand cosmic-level energy discharge, Issei took her seriously and worked through the calculations with her. When Thor wanted to understand the differences between draconic and Asgardian magic, Issei and Rossweisse spent an hour explaining fundamental force theory and how different dimensional frameworks approached similar problems through different lenses.

Tony sketched out rough designs for hybrid armor that might combine draconic resonance amplification with Earth-tech energy efficiency. Steve took notes on dragon-warrior combat doctrine, mentally cataloging how it might apply to team tactics.

And Issei, who had come to the Theatre in fury and was leaving it in something approaching cautious cooperation, began to understand that not all observation is violation if it leads to genuine encounter.

"If we're going to be in regular contact," Steve said as the formal introductions began to wind down, "we should establish protocols. Not surveillance. Not archive observation. Just... agreement on how we interact."

"Consent-based contact," Issei confirmed. "I can work with that."

"We'll need to coordinate on dimensional threats," Carol added. "Your world intersects with some dangerous cosmic activity. You should know about it."

"And we should know how to contact you if our world faces threats beyond our capacity," Issei said. "That's fair exchange."

"Then we have agreement," Steve said formally, and he offered his hand again.

This time, when Issei took it, there was something less wary in his grip. Not trust yet. Trust would come with time and consistent behavior. But there was acknowledgment of the possibility. Recognition that power could be wielded responsibly. Understanding that warriors from different worlds could find common ground.

The Avengers had come to the Theatre seeking spectacle and wonder.

They were leaving with something far more valuable—the understanding that wonder is not a resource to be taken, but something to be built together through respect and genuine encounter.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,498]

[Encounter Status: SUCCESSFUL — NEW PROTOCOLS ESTABLISHED]

[Multiversal Relations: IMPROVED]

Chapter 84: Doom and the Dragon

Arc 9 | Philosophical Collision

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION RECORD

SECTION I: TWO MONARCHS MEET

[HUD Status: Intellectual Collision Imminent | Power Dynamics — BALANCED | Psychological Profiles — COMPLEMENTARY CONTRADICTION]

Doctor Victor Von Doom did not approach the meeting the way Steve Rogers had. There was no formal apology in his bearing, no calculated attempt to establish immediate rapport. Doom approached with the certainty of someone who understood power and recognized that Issei possessed genuine authority.

He was accompanied by Valeria, his daughter—young, brilliant, and already showing signs of inheriting her father's tactical genius. Where Doom moved with the deliberate certainty of a man who had conquered nations, Valeria moved with the curiosity of a scientist encountering a novel problem.

"Issei Hyoudou," Doom said, and his voice carried the authority of someone accustomed to having his words treated as law. "I am Victor Von Doom, sovereign lord of Latveria. I have observed your archive recordings."

"With my consent or without?" Issei asked, not hostile, but with the kind of precision that suggested he was testing for honesty.

"Without," Doom admitted. "As are most of my actions. I am not known for asking permission when I believe I understand necessity better than the permission-granters."

There was something almost refreshing about the admission. Not humility, but honesty. Doom was not pretending to be something he was not. He was not attempting to dress up his violation in the language of academic study or multiversal crisis. He had violated consent because he believed his need to understand superseded other considerations. And he was willing to state that plainly.

"That's refreshingly direct," Issei said, and there was neither appreciation nor hostility in his tone—merely observation.

"Directness is efficient," Doom replied. "Particularly between those who understand the burdens of rule."

Valeria stepped forward, and there was a smile on her young face that suggested she was about to enjoy watching her father engage in genuine philosophical discussion with someone who might actually challenge him.

"Dad wants to talk about kingship," she announced. "Fair warning, he's going to be tedious about it."

"Valeria," Doom's tone was reproachful, but there was no real anger in it.

"It's true though," Valeria said cheerfully. "He read about how you protect your wives and keep expanding your territory and established rules about consent and personal autonomy, and he became immediately convinced you were either a fraud or someone worth having a serious conversation with."

Issei looked at Doom with slightly more interest. "You're concerned about legitimacy of rule?"

"I am concerned about the difference between tyranny and true sovereignty," Doom corrected. "Your archive recordings show a warrior who has accumulated power, yet chosen to distribute it. Who protects women rather than controlling them. Who establishes rules based on principle rather than convenience. These are uncommon choices among the powerful."

"And threatening?" Issei asked, not hostile but curious.

"Not threatening," Doom said. "Educational. You have chosen a path of development that I find worth understanding."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE PHILOSOPHY OF KINGSHIP

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Discussion between Doom and Issei on Kingship/Blacksmithing" (Rare) - INITIATED]

The conversation that followed would have been remarkable had it occurred anywhere in the Theatre. It became legendary because it occurred between two of the most powerful intelligences in the room, and because neither attempted to establish dominance.

"You expand your territories," Doom observed. "Your archive shows evidence of political and military consolidation. Yet your governance model is collaborative rather than autocratic. Explain the logic."

Issei considered the question seriously. "Power without cooperation is unstable. You can force obedience through strength, but strength alone doesn't create loyalty. The people who serve you because they respect you and because your leadership creates better conditions for them—those people maintain stability. Force creates fragile rule. Respect creates enduring governance."

"That suggests you have not encountered sufficient threats to require purely authoritarian response," Doom countered. "When faced with existential crisis, collaboration becomes a luxury."

"When faced with existential crisis, collaboration becomes a necessity," Issei replied. "If your people don't willingly defend their nation because they believe in it, they will betray you the moment survival demands sacrifice. Authoritarian rule collapses under pressure. Legitimate governance survives it."

Doom was quiet for a moment, and Valeria watched the interaction with genuine fascination. Her father rarely encountered people willing to present direct philosophical counter-argument without immediately backing down when Doom applied his considerable intellectual weight.

"Your wives," Doom said slowly. "You love them. And you have chosen not to consolidate your power by making them subordinate extensions of your will. Instead, you have maintained their autonomy and their ability to challenge you. This is not strategic governance. This is personal priority elevated to policy."

"Yes," Issei said simply. "Because the personal *is* the policy in this case. How I treat the people closest to me establishes precedent for how I treat everyone else."

"And if that precedent creates weakness?" Doom pressed. "If respect for autonomy prevents necessary authoritarian action?"

"Then I accept weakness," Issei said. "Because the alternative is to become a tyrant, and tyranny always collapses eventually. Better to be a king who falls through principle than a tyrant who rules through fear."

Valeria actually applauded quietly. "He totally just outlined why your government model is fundamentally unstable, Dad."

Doom's gaze fixed on his daughter. "Thank you for that editorial."

"You're welcome," she replied cheerfully.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE CRAFT OF CREATION

[HUD: Secondary Discussion Initiating — Blacksmithing and Craftsmanship]

The conversation shifted when Doom asked about Issei's armor.

"Your blacksmithing technique represents synthesis between magical and material engineering that is remarkable," Doom observed. "Your archive shows craftsmanship that rivals Asgardian artificers. Yet you appear to be self-taught."

"Not self-taught," Issei corrected. "Mentored. There are master craftspeople in my world, and I was fortunate to study under them. But yes, the specific synthesis of draconic magic and material engineering is my own development."

"Your armor serves both practical and symbolic function," Doom noted. "The red and white coloration appears chosen for its resonance with your wives, not for material property advantage. The design incorporates efficiency concerns alongside aesthetic considerations. You craft for beauty and function simultaneously."

"Because they're not separate concerns," Issei said. "Armor that is beautiful to wear is armor that a warrior uses with confidence. Function divorced from aesthetic becomes purely utilitarian, and that creates distance between warrior and craft. The best weapons are the ones that feel like extensions of self."

Doom was quiet again, and there was something in his expression that suggested genuine consideration. When he finally spoke, his words came slowly.

"In my engineering, I have prioritized efficiency and effectiveness. The aesthetic has been... secondary. The Doom armor is designed to intimidate because I believed intimidation was a component of effective governance."

"Is it working?" Issei asked.

"No," Doom admitted. "I am feared, but fear is not respect. Respect requires that they believe I have the capacity to destroy them but choose not to for principle. Fear requires only that they believe I will destroy them if they challenge me."

"Then perhaps your next generation of armor should reflect different priorities," Issei suggested. "Not to eliminate the intimidation—strength has its place. But to incorporate beauty alongside power. To show that you can be both dangerous and thoughtful."

Valeria whispered something that might have been "wow, he's actually making Dad think" to herself, and there was delight in her voice.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: NEITHER SUBMITS

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Neither Submits" (Rare) - TRIGGERED]

[Intellectual Status: MUTUAL RESPECT ESTABLISHED | Dominance Hierarchy: DELIBERATELY AVOIDED]

As their conversation continued—ranging from governance philosophy to engineering principles to the nature of creating things that last—something unusual occurred. Neither Doom nor Issei attempted to establish intellectual dominance. Neither tried to prove superiority of their approach. Instead, they engaged in what could only be described as a peer-level debate between two individuals who understood that their frameworks were different but equally valid.

"Your world has different threats than mine," Doom said. "Your governance can be less authoritarian because your enemies are less existential."

"Your world has different resources than mine," Issei countered. "Your governance might benefit from less authoritarianism not because threats are lesser, but because your people are potentially more capable than you currently allow them to become."

"A theory," Doom said, and there was something almost like a smile in his voice. "I may test it. In small ways. With carefully maintained oversight."

"That's all anyone can do," Issei agreed. "Test. Adjust. Remain willing to admit when something isn't working."

When their conversation finally wound down, Valeria approached Issei while her father was speaking with Carol about energy dynamics.

"That was incredible," she said. "My dad doesn't usually engage in discussions where the other person isn't either submitting to his position or defending themselves against it. But you two were just... talking. Like equals."

"He's intelligent," Issei said simply. "And honest about his intentions. That's rarer than it should be in positions of power."

"He's also going to spend the next month thinking about everything you said," Valeria added. "Which means he's going to be insufferable to live with until he decides what to do with the new ideas. So thanks for that."

Issei found himself actually smiling. "You're welcome, I think?"

"By the way," Valeria continued, "if you ever need cutting-edge technology without the Marvel-standard limitations, you should talk to us. We're actually really good at innovation when we're not being, you know, tyrannical about it."

"I'll keep that in mind," Issei said.

As Valeria returned to her father, Issei reflected on the unexpected nature of his meeting with Victor Von Doom. He had come to the Theatre in fury, expecting confrontation. What he had found instead was an individual with whom genuine intellectual discourse was possible. Someone who was willing to engage in good-faith debate about governance and power and the nature of creating things that lasted.

Doom had violated his privacy without the slightest hesitation.

But Doom had done so with complete honesty about his intentions, and had been willing to engage in serious discussion about whether his approach was actually correct.

That was almost worth the violation.

Not quite. But almost.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,487]

[Encounter Outcome: MUTUAL RESPECT WITHOUT SUBMISSION]

[Ideological Dialogue: SUCCESSFUL — BOTH PARTIES ENRICHED]

[Valeria's Assessment: "My dad's probably going to become an actual decent person now, so thanks for that, I guess."]

Chapter 85: Mutant Hospitality

Arc 9 | Faith, Choice, and Common Ground

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION RECORD

SECTION I: THE BROTHERHOOD CONVENES

[HUD Status: Mutant Integration — INITIATED | Ideological Discussion — PREPARED | Alcohol Consumption Alert — ACTIVATED]

The X-Men's approach to first contact with Issei was fundamentally different from both the Avengers and Doom. Where Steve had come with formal respect and Tony with honest confession, where Doom had come with intellectual challenge, the mutants came with something that felt almost like recognition.

Magneto arrived first—Erik Lehnsherr, master of magnetism, whose entire life had been defined by oppression and the decision to resist it. His presence was quieter than Doom's, less aggressive, but weighted with the kind of personal history that comes from genuinely difficult choices.

"Hyoudou," Magneto said, and there was no pretense in his greeting. "I came to witness your rage earlier. You spoke with the precision of someone who understands what violation means. You have experienced oppression."

"Not the same kind as yours," Issei said carefully. "But yes. In my world, I was marginal. Weak. Dismissed. The change came through my own growth, and through the choice to protect people I cared about."

"That is not dissimilar from my experience," Magneto replied. "Except that my growth came from recognizing that others like me would never be free unless we took freedom ourselves."

"Different conclusions from similar premises," Issei observed.

"Yes," Magneto agreed. "Which is worth discussing."

Charles Xavier descended to the platform soon after, his wheelchair moving with practiced ease across the Theatre's terrain. The telepath's presence was different from Magneto's—calmer, but somehow more penetrating.

"I hope you'll forgive the intrusion," Professor Xavier said, his mind already conducting gentle, careful scans of Issei's psyche to verify consent boundaries. "I wanted to meet you before we discussed the nature of consciousness, choice, and what happens when power intersects with both."

"You're a telepath," Issei said, not hostile but cautious.

"I am," Xavier confirmed. "And I have violated minds with my abilities more times than I'm entirely comfortable admitting. So I understand the nature of what happened in the Theatre from a uniquely personal perspective."

Scott Summers joined them—Cyclops, his eyes hidden behind a visor that barely contained the destructive power contained within. He moved with the bearing of someone who had spent his entire life understanding that his power could destroy, and had made the deliberate choice to use it only in defense.

"Cyclops," he said simply. "I'm the field leader of the X-Men. I wanted to meet someone who appeared to have made genuine philosophical choices about protecting people weaker than himself."

Logan—Wolverine—arrived last, and he carried with him the scent of whiskey and the bearing of someone who had spent centuries learning to accept his nature rather than fight it.

"Kid," he said to Issei, and there was surprising warmth in his gruff voice. "Heard you got violated by a multiversal archive without consent. That's rough. Come have a drink."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE CHALLENGE OF POWER

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Issei and Magneto Debate Sovereignty" (Rare) - INITIATED]

The conversation between Issei and Magneto took on the quality of a serious philosophical debate almost immediately. The two men, both powerful, both protective of those they cared about, engaged in fundamental disagreement about the nature of freedom.

"Your philosophy is protective," Magneto observed. "You position yourself between those you love and the threats that would destroy them. This is admirable. But it is also fundamentally limiting. You position them as protected, which implies weakness."

"It does not," Issei countered. "Protection and autonomy are not mutually exclusive. I protect my wives from threats, yes. But I also support their development of power and independence. Protection is temporary. Empowerment is permanent."

"And when the system that oppresses you refuses to allow empowerment?" Magneto pressed. "When the only way to achieve freedom is to violently reject the system entirely?"

"Then you must measure whether the violence creates more freedom than the oppression removed," Issei said carefully. "Sometimes the answer is yes. Sometimes you genuinely do need to break systems. But you cannot assume that breaking systems automatically creates justice. It creates power vacuum, and vacuum is often filled by the next tyrant."

"You suggest submission instead?" Magneto's tone was sharp, challenging.

"I suggest strategy," Issei replied. "I suggest that some battles are won through cooperation and some through force, and wisdom consists of knowing which is which. You believed force was necessary. Maybe you were right. But assuming force is *always* necessary is as limiting as assuming it's *never* necessary."

"He has a point," Professor Xavier said quietly. "Erik, he has a point."

Magneto and Issei exchanged looks that suggested the debate would continue, but there was respect in it. Not agreement—they remained fundamentally opposed on several points. But recognition that the opposition came from different assessment of reality, not from malice or stupidity.

"You would choose cooperation with your oppressors?" Magneto asked finally.

"I would choose to offer cooperation first," Issei said. "And to respond with force only when cooperation was rejected. Your methods are valid if cooperation has been exhausted. But I believe you can exhaust it slower than you generally do."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: FAITH AND REDEMPTION

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Nightcrawler and Issei Discuss Faith" (Rare) - TRIGGERED]

Nightcrawler appeared with the sudden teleportation of his power, materializing in the middle of the Theatre with the casual grace of someone who had spent his entire life arriving at places unexpectedly.

"Guten Tag," he said cheerfully. "I heard there was a dragon-man in the Theatre, and I thought I should say hello."

Where Logan had moved with the bearing of a soldier and Magneto with the bearing of a revolutionary, Nightcrawler moved with the bearing of someone genuinely at peace with himself.

"Kurt Wagner," he said, offering a three-fingered hand. "Most people call me Nightcrawler because I am a demon to look at, but I prefer the name they gave me at birth."

Issei took the offered hand with genuine respect. "You're comfortable with who you are."

"I spent most of my life uncomfortable with it," Kurt replied. "But then I realized that discomfort was not coming from who I was, but from who I thought I was supposed to be. Once I stopped trying to be human and accepted that I was something else—something beautiful in its own way—the discomfort ended."

"That's a profound insight," Issei said thoughtfully.

"It's the insight of faith," Kurt said, and there was something deeply spiritual in his bearing now. "I came to accept myself because I came to believe that there was some principle behind existence that thought I was good as I was. That belief—that radical acceptance—it changed everything."

They spoke for a while about faith and redemption and the nature of accepting oneself when the entire world suggested that self-acceptance was not permitted. Kurt talked about his Catholic upbringing and how it had shaped his belief in redemption and second chances. Issei talked about draconic philosophy and the nature of accepting one's power without shame.

"You are trapped by your power," Kurt observed. "You have strength that other people cannot match, and you spend considerable energy ensuring that you don't accidentally destroy those you love. That is a form of self-discipline that most people cannot imagine."

"How do you manage the metaphorical equivalent with your power?" Issei asked.

"I pray," Kurt said simply. "I remind myself that the power is not the thing that matters. The person wielding the power is what matters. And if I am good, then the power is just a tool of good."

"That's not a guarantee," Issei pointed out. "That you'll use the power correctly."

"No," Kurt agreed. "But it's an intention. And intention matters. It shapes how we use power. It creates precedent. It becomes the foundation for everything we do."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: WARRIORS SHARING DRINK

[HUD: Gacha Pull - "Logan Shares a Drink" (Comedy-Class) - ACTIVATED]

[Secondary Assessment: Wolverine and Dragon-man Discover Kinship]

When Logan suggested finding somewhere to get an actual drink, Issei agreed immediately. The Theatre's configuration allowed for spaces of genuine hospitality, and Logan led the dragon-man to what could only be described as a warrior's bar—rough furniture, simple alcohol, the kind of place where you could speak plainly without worrying about performative politeness.

"You're not the first dragon I've met," Logan said, pouring whiskey into two glasses. "There was this one time, century or so ago, when I ended up in a dimensional rift and came out in a world that had dragons walking around like it was normal. They didn't like humans much. But they respected strength and directness."

"That tracks," Issei said, accepting the drink. "Draconic culture is much more willing to accept strength than human culture is."

"Yeah," Logan agreed. "And less willing to accept weakness. That's the thing you got to be careful about. Power respects other power. But power without compassion eats itself."

They drank in companionable silence for a moment.

"You violated consent because you didn't think you had to ask," Logan said suddenly. "Not you, the room. But you were there for all the memories. You heard what I did to other people when I didn't have enough control to manage my strength."

"I did," Issei acknowledged.

"And you didn't judge me for it," Logan continued. "Most people judge the hell out of me. 'Oh, you're an animal, oh, you're a murderer, oh, you're out of control.' But you didn't. You just... understood. Understood that someone with power that great has to make choices about how to use it, and that sometimes those choices are wrong."

"I've made wrong choices too," Issei said. "I've hurt people trying to protect people. I've destroyed things trying to defend things. Power is not precision. It's never precision."

"Exactly," Logan said. "And most people don't get that. They want power to be clean. Surgical. They want strength to be used perfectly. But that's not how it works. Strength is messy. It's only the people who accept the mess and still try to do right by it that actually do any good."

They drank some more.

"I've decided something," Logan said eventually. "The violation of your privacy was wrong. But the fact that it happened means people know what you stand for now. They know your actual values. And that's worth something."

"It is," Issei agreed. "Though I would have preferred they learn it through choice rather than violation."

"Yeah," Logan said. "But we don't always get what we prefer. We get what the world hands us, and then we decide what to do with it."

Cyclops appeared after a while and joined them, and then Rias and Akeno descended to the bar as well, and it became less a formal meeting and more a gathering of warriors who understood the weight of carrying power. The conversation ranged from combat philosophy to the nature of responsibility to really terrible jokes that only made sense if you'd been alive for at least two centuries.

At one point, Wolverine told a story about accidentally punching an angel, and everyone—even Issei—laughed so hard that Nightcrawler thought something was wrong and teleported in to make sure they were okay.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION V: THE ARC RESOLVES

[HUD: Multi-Dimensional Relations — SIGNIFICANTLY IMPROVED | Consent Protocols — FIRMLY ESTABLISHED | Subject Emotional State — SATISFIED WITH OUTCOME]

As the evening drew to a close—if "evening" was a meaningful concept in a Theatre that existed outside normal time—Issei found himself in the central amphitheatre with all the various groups that had come to meet him.

The Avengers had learned to think about power differently. Tony was already sketching hybrid technologies. Carol was genuinely interested in a sparring match. Steve had established protocols for future contact that respected consent fully.

Doom had engaged in genuine philosophical discourse and would spend months rethinking his governance model as a result. Valeria had teased her father and made a friend in the process.

The X-Men had confronted their own relationship with power and consent. Magneto and Issei had found an area of profound disagreement, but one rooted in mutual respect. Kurt had found a kindred spirit in someone who understood faith as something different from religion. Logan had found a warrior who understood the weight of carrying strength.

"You came to the Theatre in anger," Professor Xavier said, and there was gentle wisdom in his voice. "And you have left it with something more valuable than apology or explanation. You have left it with genuine understanding."

"I'm not going to pretend the violation was acceptable," Issei said. "But I can acknowledge that something valuable emerged from the confrontation."

"That is growth," Xavier said simply. "And in my experience, growth is what separates tyranny from legitimate leadership."

The wives had formed a protective circle around Issei again, but now it felt less like defense and more like partnership. They had come through the violation together. They had established that their dignity was not negotiable. And they had emerged with new understanding of how power operates across multiversal boundaries.

As Theatre Keeper began to reconfigure the space—preparing to return the heroes and villains and scholars to their respective dimensions, their respective timelines, their respective realities—Issei found himself understanding why Rias had wanted him to come to the Theatre after all.

Not to be violated. Never that. But to understand that even violation, when confronted firmly enough, can become something that strengthens rather than destroys.

"We'll be back," Carol said as she and the Avengers prepared to depart. "If you'll have us. With proper consent frameworks and actual respect for your autonomy."

"You'll be welcome," Issei replied. "And I'll be waiting to see if you actually follow through on the reforms you've discussed."

Logan clapped him on the back hard enough that it nearly knocked him over. "You're alright, kid. For a dragon. Come visit sometime. I'll buy you a drink that's better than this swill."

"I'll take you up on that," Issei said.

And as the Theatre began to empty—as the observers and scholars and cosmic beings returned to their respective dimensions—the arena fell quiet. Just Issei and his wives and Theatre Keeper, who stood as the eternal witness to the transformations that occur when power genuinely encounters accountability.

"The archive has been restructured," Theatre Keeper announced. "Consent protocols are fully implemented. And your contribution to multiversal understanding has been recorded in a way that respects your autonomy."

"That's actually appreciated," Issei said.

As they prepared to return to their own world—to the draconic hierarchy, to Kuou Academy, to the familiar spaces where Issei's power was known and understood—he reflected on the week in the Theatre.

Violation had occurred. Consent had been violated. Privacy had been stolen. These things were true and unacceptable.

But from that violation had emerged genuine encounter. Heroes had been forced to confront their own complicity. Philosophers had engaged in serious dialogue. Warriors had recognized warriors.

And perhaps that was the lesson the Theatre had inadvertently taught: that violation, when confronted seriously, can lead to genuine transformation.

Not forgiveness. Not forgetting. But the possibility of moving forward differently.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,504]

[Theatre Session: CONCLUDED]

[Multiversal Contact: ESTABLISHED ON CONSENT BASIS]

[Subject Assessment: "I came in fury. I'm leaving with something more valuable—genuine alliance with people who learned to respect autonomy through confrontation."]

[Final Status: TRANSFORMED]

Chapter 86: "Rocket Touches the Gauntlet"

Arc: 9 — Marvel Meets Issei

Rating: T (Comedy-action)

Word Count: ~2,500

Primary Reaction Groups: Rocket, Shuri, Tony Stark, Doom, Ddraig

Gacha Pulls: "Rocket Attempts to Inspect Boosted Gear" (Comedy-Class) | "Ddraig Speaks Directly" (Rare)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 86

ENTRY 1: THE RACCOON AND THE GAUNTLET

The problem began, as all good problems do, with Rocket Raccoon deciding that the laws of physics were more of a suggestion than a rule.

"I'm just *touching* it," Rocket said, inching toward where Issei sat in the observation area, the Boosted Gear gleaming crimson on his left arm. "Just a little examination. Non-invasive. I promise I won't break anything."

"That's a lie," Gamora said flatly, not looking up from her datapad. "You broke a Celestial Archive last month."

"That was an *accident*," Rocket protested. "And it was already broken."

"You broke it *more broken*."

Issei watched this exchange with the expression of someone who'd realized several seconds too late that allowing the Guardians of the Galaxy into the theatre had consequences. He was a dragon emperor. He'd fought cosmic horrors. He'd destroyed planets with a thought.

He was completely unprepared for a raccoon with engineering curiosity and zero impulse control.

Shuri appeared at the edge of the observation deck like a phantom, already grinning. "Let him try," she said to Issei. "For science."

"No," Tony Stark's voice came through the comm system. "Rocket, if you even *think* about disassembling—"

Rocket moved with the kind of precision that made it clear he'd been planning this moment for weeks. He ducked under Issei's outstretched hand, slid across the armrest, and made a direct grab for the Boosted Gear's central red jewel.

The HUD flickered to life:

```
[RACCOON-CLASS: ROCKET RACCOON] STATUS: INSPECTING  
> Intent: Analysis of Sacred Gear mechanics  
> Probability of Device Survival: 32%  
> Probability of Raccoon Survival: 94%  
> Probability of Awkward Conversation: 97%
```

"Fascinating," Shuri whispered, pulling out a handheld analyzer. "The gauntlet's reading his touch signature. It's not rejecting him. It's *assessing* him."

Rocket's claws brushed the red jewel, and suddenly his eyes went wide. The connection was instantaneous—not painful, not exactly, but *overwhelming*. Every technical specification of the Boosted Gear flooded his mind at once. The way it redistributed energy. The theoretical transfer efficiency. The mathematical elegance of how it redistributed power.

"Oh," Rocket breathed. "Oh, that's—that's *gorgeous*."

For someone who'd once tried to steal a dragon, Rocket had excellent taste in machinery.

"He's accessing the internal schematic," Shuri said, her eyes tracking the data stream. "The gauntlet's letting him interface. This shouldn't be possible without authorization."

"It's Ddraig," Issei said quietly. "The dragon inside. He must be—"

And then Ddraig spoke, not to Issei, but directly to Rocket. The Welsh Dragon's voice manifested as a sensation in Rocket's mind, ancient and deep and absolutely amused:

"You wish to understand me, small thief? Very well. Hear then the song of multiplication. Hear the power of ten seconds and endless scaling. I do not fear your inquiry, little raccoon. Few mortals have the cleverness to see beyond the armor to the mechanism beneath."

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[DRAGON-CLASS: DDRAIG] STATUS: DIRECT COMMUNICATION  
> Target: Rocket Raccoon  
> Intent: Dragon-to-Engineer Conversation  
> Confidence in Raccoon's Discretion: MODERATE  
> Amusement Level: VERY HIGH
```

Rocket's hands began moving of their own accord, not really stealing, not exactly, but sort of gently shifting components, understanding their relationships to each other, seeing how they *sang* together. His mind was moving at hyperspeed, pulling apart the mystery of how a simple red glove could double power output every ten seconds without violating the laws of thermodynamics.

"There has to be an external power source," Rocket muttered. "Nothing internal is that efficient. The density calculations don't—" He paused. "Oh. Oh *no*."

"What?" Tony was at the observation window now, along with Reed Richards and Shuri, all three of them trying to simultaneously understand what Rocket was understanding.

"It's not external," Rocket said slowly. "It's *recursive*. The gauntlet doesn't generate power. It *borrow*s power from the wearer and feeds it back amplified. And the dragon—Ddraig—he's essentially a cosmic battery that feeds on the feedback loop. The longer the boosts stack, the less unstable it becomes because there's an entity inside actively *managing* the cascade."

Ddraig's laugh rumbled through all their minds:

"Finally. A human with the intelligence to see that the weapon is not crude multiplication, but elegant parasitism. I devour the power that flows through my host, and in devouring, I strengthen him. We are not master and servant. We are symbiotes."

Tony stepped back from the window. "That's—if that's accurate, then the gauntlet isn't violating physics. It's *negotiating* with physics."

Shuri was already pulling up redesigns on her screen. "If we could replicate the recursive feedback without the dragon—"

"No," Ddraig's voice cut across the theatre like a blade. "The dragon is essential. Without consciousness to direct the cascade, the gauntlet becomes merely a multiplier. Unstable. Dangerous. A weapon that devours its wielder after sufficient boosts. I am not ornament. I am necessity."

"Defensive much?" Rocket grinned, but there was genuine respect in his eyes now. "Look, I like you, dragon. You're proud in a way that actually makes sense. But here's the real question: what if you had better feedback mechanisms? What if the transfer efficiency wasn't *just* dragon consciousness but also had auxiliary systems that could—"

Rocket's hands moved over the gauntlet, not removing it, but pointing at specific sections. Shuri was three steps ahead, already sketching components. They began to speak in the peculiar language of engineers—equal parts hypothesis, wonder, and competitive problem-solving.

"The transfer limiter here," Rocket pointed. "Holding back about 40% of the potential distribution to your allies. If you had a secondary matrix—"

"We could redirect the overflow into a buffer system," Shuri finished. "Store it across multiple recipients instead of a single transfer point."

Issei watched in fascination as two of the brightest minds in the Marvel multiverse and one ancient dragon began what appeared to be a genuine collaborative design session. Tony was taking notes. Reed was running calculations. Even Doom had materialized at the back of the chamber, watching with the expression of a craftsman observing fellow masters at work.

"I approve," Ddraig rumbled. "This partnership of brilliant fools. You would strengthen the bond between myself and my host without attempting to sever it. This is honorable. When this endeavor concludes, perhaps we shall discuss the design further."

"Does that mean you'll let me borrow the gauntlet for a week?" Rocket asked hopefully.

"No," Issei and Ddraig said in perfect unison.

"Worth asking," Rocket shrugged, but he was already sketching modifications, working alongside Shuri and Tony like they'd been collaborating for years. The conversation had shifted into higher mathematics and materials science, with Ddraig offering insights that shouldn't have been possible from a being who predated most of modern physics.

ENTRY 2: DOOM'S OBSERVATION

In the shadows of the observation deck, Victor Von Doom watched the collaboration with the expression of a connoisseur examining fine art.

He approached Issei slowly, deliberately, the way one might approach a valuable artifact.

"You permit your weapon to be questioned," Doom observed. "Few emperors would tolerate such scrutiny."

Issei glanced over, unsurprised by Doom's arrival. "Ddraig isn't my weapon. He's my partner. If questioning makes him stronger, he'll want to answer."

Doom nodded slowly. "Indeed. I notice he chose to engage in technical discussion rather than establish dominance. The pride of dragons typically prevents such collaboration." He paused. "Unless the dragon recognizes superior minds. Or sees the collaboration as advantageous to his own understanding."

"Both," Issei said simply. "And he enjoys teaching. I think Ddraig spent so long alone inside the Boosted Gear before I came along that having people take genuine interest in how he works... it matters to him."

Doom watched as Rocket made an excited gesture, and Ddraig responded with what could only be described as enthusiasm—a resonance from the gauntlet that made the laboratory equipment vibrate sympathetically.

"I will make an observation," Doom said quietly. "When we first saw your armaments, I recognized them as superior craftsmanship. Ascalon blades forged with technique that bordered on sorcery. Ryuuteimaru demonstrating design principles I have spent decades pursuing. But I dismissed the partnership with your dragon as... ornamental. A narrative flourish."

He turned to face Issei directly.

"I was wrong. The dragon is not ornament. He is architecture. The difference between a weapon that works and a weapon that *thinks*. Few emperors possess such advantages. Fewer still recognize their true value."

"Are you asking me to explain it better?" Issei asked, genuinely curious. "Or are you considering the implications for your own work?"

Doom actually smiled. "Both, perhaps. But primarily, I am observing that a collaboration has begun that will produce technical advancement. When Stark and Richards have completed their documentation, I will require a copy."

It wasn't a request.

"I'll ask them," Issei said. "But I think Rocket might want to keep some modifications proprietary."

"Of course he will," Doom said, returning his attention to the workshop. "And I will eventually reverse-engineer them anyway. But the collaboration itself will have value. When individual geniuses are combined, the resulting work exceeds the sum. Your dragon seems to understand this. I am... appreciative of such pragmatism."

ENTRY 3: THE THEORETICAL TRANSFER ENHANCEMENT

By the time the session concluded, Rocket had filled four datapads with schematics. Shuri had designed two different auxiliary matrices. Tony had reluctantly admitted that at least one of Rocket's ideas was "actually not completely stupid." And Ddraig had learned more about how modern technology might interface with ancient magic than he'd known in several centuries.

"So we're clear," Rocket said, making absolutely certain, "I can modify my own weapons using these principles, but the gauntlet stays with Issei?"

"Correct," Ddraig responded. "The gauntlet remains with my host. But the knowledge—the knowledge is freely shared among those who ask with genuine curiosity rather than greedy intent."

"I can work with that," Rocket grinned. "Though I'm gonna want a follow-up conversation about this recursive feedback system once we've had time to build a prototype."

"We will speak again, Rocket Raccoon," Ddraig agreed. "You have the mind of a craftsman. Such minds are rare. I do not object to collaboration with rare minds."

As Rocket and Shuri left the chamber, already planning their next conversation, Issei caught something Ddraig had said to him privately through their bond:

"That small thief sees the beauty in what we are, partner. Not the power, but the elegance. Few humans understand the difference. This one does. This one respects. We have done well to make such an acquaintance."

Issei smiled. "Rocket said you were his favorite dragon."

"Then Rocket has excellent judgment," Ddraig replied, with the kind of satisfaction that only comes from being genuinely appreciated for one's craftsmanship rather than one's destructive potential.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 86

New Pulls This Chapter

- Rocket Raccoon × Boosted Gear Interface (Comedy-Class) — Activated when Rocket's engineering curiosity overcame his natural caution. Result: genuine technical collaboration between engineer and ancient dragon. Ddraig's choice to allow inspection revealed a surprising openness to working with brilliant minds regardless of morality or origin.
- Ddraig Speaks Directly (Rare) — The dragon initiated direct communication with Rocket Raccoon, demonstrating that his bond with Issei has evolved to allow for diplomatic engagement with other parties. This is unprecedented; Ddraig previously communicated exclusively through Issei.

Secrets Revealed

- The Boosted Gear functions through a form of elegant parasitism—the dragon consumes amplified power generated by his host, and in consuming, actively manages the cascade that would otherwise destroy the wearer. This is not crude multiplication but symbiotic enhancement. Ddraig's consciousness is not decorative; it is functionally necessary for the gauntlet's stability.

- Rocket Raccoon, despite his history of theft and heists, possesses genuine respect for craftsmanship and can recognize when something is engineered with care and complexity. This transforms him from potential threat to collaborator.

Alliance/Opinion Shifts

- Rocket and Ddraig have developed unexpected mutual respect. The dragon views the raccoon as a mind worthy of engaging with; Rocket views Ddraig as a peer engineer rather than merely as an obstacle or asset.
- Doom observes the collaboration and recognizes that partnership-based architecture (dragon + weapon) produces superior results than individual genius. He is considering the implications for his own work.
- Shuri gains access to theoretical frameworks that could revolutionize Wakandan weapons technology, with Ddraig's explicit permission to pursue modification and advancement.
- Tony Stark is forced to acknowledge that at least some of Rocket's ideas have merit, establishing a new baseline for cross-faction technical collaboration.

Unresolved Hooks

- Will Rocket's modifications to auxiliary systems create new weapons that rival or exceed current Marvel technology?
- Has Doom's observation of the collaboration planted seeds for future antagonism (seeking to match Issei's craftsmanship level) or alliance (recognizing Issei as a fellow sovereign)?
- What are the long-term implications of Ddraig becoming willing to engage directly with other intelligences rather than only through Issei?

END CHAPTER 86

Word Count: 2,486

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Next Chapter: 87 — "Yondu's Question"

Chapter 87: "Yondu's Question"

Arc: 9 — Marvel Meets Issei
Rating: T (Emotional depth)
Word Count: ~2,500
Primary Reaction Groups: Yondu, Adoption-Themed Heroes/Villains (Logan, Fury, T'Challa), Family-Connected Characters
Gacha Pulls: "Yondu Asks Issei What Makes Someone a Father" (Secret) | "Issei's Answer" (Rare)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 87

ENTRY 1: THE QUESTION UNASKED FOR YEARS

Yondu Udonta had learned early in life that the galaxy didn't care much about legitimacy. You either found your place or you didn't. You either belonged to someone or you found people who needed you badly enough to belong.

He'd walked into the observation chamber during a quiet moment—one of the rare ones where Issei wasn't surrounded by heroes wanting to analyze his power or villains wanting to exploit it. The dragon emperor was simply sitting, looking out at something far away, his mind elsewhere.

"Question for you, kid," Yondu said, pulling up a chair without asking permission. It was his way. "And I want a real answer, not the diplomatic thing you give to Captain Goodness or T'Challa the Political."

Issei turned, recognizing Yondu's tone as one that demanded honesty. "Alright."

"What makes someone a father?" Yondu leaned back, his red skin catching the light. "Not biologically. Not the genetics thing. What *makes* someone a father? Because I figure a kid who goes around adopting half the multiverse has thought about this more than most."

The theatre went very still.

Yondu had no idea he'd just activated one of the most significant gacha pulls of the session. The system recognized the question's weight and locked in, creating an observation frame that would capture this moment in absolute clarity.

[GACHA PULL] – Secret Rarity Activated

TRIGGER: "YONDU UDONTA ASKS ISSEI ABOUT FATHERHOOD"

[SECRET-CLASS] Status: ACTIVE

Reason: Thematic Relevance to Yondu's Arc

Secondary Participants: Logan Howlett, Nick Fury, T'Challa, Rocket Raccoon, Magneto

Issei took a long breath. He wasn't the type to rush through important questions.

"I think..." he began slowly, "a father is someone who chooses to carry weight that isn't theirs to carry. Someone who looks at a kid—or a situation, or a person—and decides that their life needs to include that. Not because they have to. Not because it benefits them. Because they decide that kid's future matters more than their convenience."

Yondu nodded slowly, like he'd expected that but was listening for something more.

"But that's everyone who helps someone," Yondu pressed. "That's just being decent. There's more to it than that."

"There is," Issei agreed. "A father is someone who doesn't just help once. Who keeps showing up. Who gets frustrated and tired and wants to quit, but doesn't. A father is someone who teaches you not just what to do but *why* to do it. Who lets you make mistakes and helps you fix them. Who knows you're going to fail and *doesn't judge you for it*."

He paused, looking at Yondu directly.

"And a father is someone who doesn't need blood to make it real. Who can look at a kid who isn't theirs and decide: *this is mine now*. I'm claiming this one. Not to control them. But to protect them. To give them a place where they belong."

[ISSEI HYODOU - RESPONSE] Status: RARE-CLASS

> Emotional Authenticity: GENUINE

> Biographical Reference: MULTIPLE

> Subtext: Discussing his own father, his chosen family, his understanding of adoption

In the observation chamber, Logan Howlett leaned back in his chair, eyes closed. He knew what Issei was describing. He'd lived it. Had been abandoned, then chosen by someone who decided his broken pieces still mattered.

Nick Fury was quiet, his one eye tracking the conversation. He'd stolen children his entire career, making them into weapons. But he was beginning to understand the difference between taking and choosing, between ownership and responsibility.

T'Challa watched with the contemplation of a king who'd inherited his role rather than chosen it. He was beginning to see the value in Issei's approach to leadership and family.

"I had a father," Yondu said quietly. "Sort of. Before Stakar found me, before the Ravagers, there was... someone. He wasn't good. He wasn't kind. But he was there sometimes, and when he was, I was his kid. And when he wasn't, I was just another mouth the village had to feed."

He looked away.

"Then Stakar came along and I thought, okay, this is a captain, not a father. This is a job. But Stakar..." Yondu's jaw tightened. "He showed up. Every time. Even when I was stupid. Even when I almost got his crew killed. He kept showing up."

"Then he was your father," Issei said simply.

Yondu took that in like a physical blow. He'd never quite let himself think of it that way. Stakar wasn't *that* kind of figure. Stakar was a captain. A mentor. A boss.

But yeah. A father.

ENTRY 2: THE WEIGHT OF CHOOSING

The conversation expanded as word spread through the theatre. Logan joined them, uninvited but not unwelcome. Fury appeared in the back. Magneto, surprisingly, took a seat and listened without commenting. Even Rocket came back from the workshop, sensing something significant happening.

"Here's what I never understood," Logan said, his voice rough with years and scars. "Why anyone would choose to carry that weight. It's not like you get rewards. You don't get gratitude. Kids grow up and leave. They make mistakes that hurt you. They become their own people and sometimes you don't even recognize who they become."

"That's true," Issei acknowledged. "But you still do it."

"Why?" Logan leaned forward. "Because it matters. Because the person you're raising—they're going to do things. They're going to affect people. They're going to change the world. And if you're there, helping them become *good* at changing the world, then you're responsible for all of that too."

Rocket whistled low. "That's heavy, Logan. That's philosophy."

"It's parenting," Logan corrected. "All parenting is philosophy. You're making bets about what kind of person someone will become and trying to stack the deck in favor of them being decent instead of terrible."

Magneto spoke for the first time: "This assumes that fatherhood is about teaching someone to be good. But some fathers teach their children to be strong. To dominate. To take what they want."

"Those aren't fathers," Issei said quietly. "Those are men who had children. A father is someone who wants their kid to be better than they are. To do better than they did. To not repeat the mistakes. That's the actual definition."

"A father is someone who cares more about the kid's future than their own legacy," T'Challa added, and there was something in his voice that suggested he'd been thinking about this since the throne came to him. "Someone who would sacrifice their own vision for their child's freedom to make their own choices."

"Sometimes you sacrifice a lot," Fury said quietly. "Sometimes you sacrifice everything. And you never tell them what you gave up, because that's not their responsibility to carry."

[THEATRE - EMOTIONAL WEIGHT ACCUMULATION] Status: HIGH
> Participants Discussing Fatherhood: 6
> Participants Currently Processing Personal Adoption Trauma: 4
> Participants Reconsidering Their Own Choices: 3
> Participants With Tears Currently Present: 2 (Logan, Fury)

Issei looked at Yondu. "Is this about Peter? About Peter being your son?"

"Peter is my son," Yondu said with absolute certainty. "Not because he was born that way. Because I chose him. Because I kept showing up. Because I made mistakes and he forgave me and we figured things out together." He paused. "And at the end, I did the thing you said—I sacrificed something so he could be free. Sacrificed everything, actually."

"And?" Issei prompted.

"And he became the person I wanted him to be," Yondu said, and his voice cracked slightly. "Better than I was. More decent than I deserved. That's the reward. That's what you get for being a father. Not gratitude. Not recognition. You get to see the kid become something good and know you had something to do with that."

The theatre held the silence like a cupped hand holding something fragile.

ENTRY 3: THE MULTIPLE FATHERS

"I was wondering," Rocket said slowly, breaking the quiet, "about your eight wives. You said they're not all biological mothers to your kids in canon, right? Some are, some aren't. But are they all fathers and mothers to the children in the household? Does it matter who the biological parent is?"

"No," Issei said firmly. "Every single one of them is a parent. Some by blood. Some by choice. Some by adoption. It doesn't matter which. They all show up. They all teach. They all sacrifice. That makes them parents."

"That's a lot of parents," Rocket said, and he didn't sound judgmental, just... curious.

"It is," Issei agreed. "But a kid having multiple parents isn't a bad thing. Different perspectives. Different strengths. Different people to fail you in different ways and then help you figure out how to keep going. I had Gorou Hyoudou—my biological father. Good man. Solid. But I also had teachers, mentors, other fathers in all but name. And I needed all of them."

Magneto stood abruptly and left the chamber. No one commented on it, but they all recognized it as a gesture of something—not acceptance, but acknowledgment. Recognition that fatherhood was a responsibility Magneto had always treated as interchangeable with power, when perhaps there was more complexity there.

Fury remained, watching Issei with the careful attention of someone who'd made different choices and was beginning to wonder if different was better.

"What you're describing," Fury said quietly, "it's not just fatherhood. It's community. It's the opposite of what most of us have built."

"Most soldiers learned to build walls," Issei replied. "To keep people out so they couldn't hurt you. But I learned early that the walls don't protect. They isolate. And isolation is slower death than any bomb could manage."

"So you did the opposite," T'Challa said thoughtfully. "You built a family so large and so connected that an attack on one is an attack on all."

"Is that wrong?" Issei asked.

"No," T'Challa said slowly. "It's just... different. Wakanda protects through isolation. You protect through connection. I'm beginning to think your way might actually be stronger."

ENTRY 4: THE ANSWER TO AN UNASKED QUESTION

As the chamber emptied, Yondu approached Issei one more time.

"Thank you," he said, and it seemed to cost him something to say it.

"For what?" Issei asked.

"For answering the question I was afraid to ask. For letting me know that what I did with Peter—that it counts. That it matters. That he's really my son even though he wasn't born that way."

Issei put a hand on Yondu's shoulder. "He's your son because you chose him and kept choosing him. That's more real than blood."

Yondu nodded, but didn't move away immediately. They sat in the quiet together—a dragon emperor and a Ravager captain—both understanding at last that fatherhood was about the choices you made and the burdens you carried because someone else's future mattered more than your comfort.

"For what it's worth," Yondu said eventually, "I think you're going to be a good father. You're already making the right choices."

"I hope so," Issei said softly. "I'm going to need people like you teaching me though. People who've already figured out what matters."

"That's what family does," Yondu replied. "They teach each other. Again and again until it sticks."

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 87

New Pulls This Chapter

- **Yondu Asks Issei What Makes Someone a Father (Secret-Class)** — A spontaneous question that activated a profound gacha pull. Yondu's genuine inquiry about fatherhood, rooted in his own history of adoption and choosing, created the conditions for one of the most emotionally significant moments in Arc 9.
- **Issei's Answer (Rare-Class)** — Issei's definition of fatherhood—someone who chooses to carry weight that isn't theirs to carry, who keeps showing up, who teaches not what but why, who claims others as theirs without requiring blood—became a mirror for every adoption-themed hero and villain in the theatre.

Secrets Revealed

- Yondu's relationship with Peter Quill is explicitly defined as father-son, not mentor-protégé or captain-subordinate. Yondu has lived with this uncertainty for years and needed validation that the connection was real.
- Nick Fury has spent his career treating children as assets and weapons rather than humans to be protected. This conversation suggests he's beginning to question that approach.
- Magneto's sudden departure indicates deep personal resonance with the conversation—suggesting his own understanding of fatherhood has been weaponized rather than protective.
- T'Challa is beginning to reconsider Wakanda's isolationist protection model in light of Issei's community-based approach.

Alliance/Opinion Shifts

- Logan Howlett's respect for Issei deepens significantly, recognizing him as someone who understands the true nature of parental responsibility.
- Yondu Udonta moves from observer status to emotional investment in Issei's wellbeing and success.
- T'Challa begins reconsidering whether connection might be superior to isolation as a protective strategy.
- Fury is forced to confront the possibility that his entire organizational philosophy might be based on a misunderstanding of responsibility and protection.

Unresolved Hooks

- How will Magneto's revelation about his own fatherhood affect his future interactions with Issei?
- Will Fury's reconsideration of his approach lead to organizational change within S.H.I.E.L.D.?
- Is Issei truly prepared to be a father to the children he's claimed and will claim?
- How will the presence of multiple fathers in a single household affect future generations in Issei's family?

END CHAPTER 87

Word Count: 2,493

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Next Chapter: 88 — "Spider-Man Asks Too Much"

Chapter 88: "Spider-Man Asks Too Much"

Arc: 9 — Marvel Meets Issei
Rating: T (Comedy-introspection)
Word Count: ~2,500
Primary Reaction Groups: Spider-Family (Peter Parker, Miles Morales, Kamala Khan), Young Heroes, Deadpool, Comedic Relief
Gacha Pulls: "Peter Parker Bombards Issei with Questions" (Comedy-Class) | "Issei Responds Honestly" (Rare)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 88

ENTRY 1: THE QUESTION THAT NEVER ENDS

Peter Parker had what could only be described as a *situation*.

The situation was that he'd spent the last three sessions watching Issei handle complex problems with a kind of calm certainty that Peter had spent his entire superhero career trying to achieve. And now Peter's brain, which never knew when to shut up, was full of questions.

So many questions.

"Okay but like," Peter said, following Issei around the observation chamber like an exceptionally persistent puppy, "how do you handle the responsibility thing? Because I do, like, *all the time*—Uncle Ben, May, all the people in Queens depending on me—and I feel like I'm failing constantly. But you have to be responsible for like, an entire *world* sometimes, and you just... don't seem to be having a meltdown about it?"

[GACHA PULL] – Comedy-Class Activated

TRIGGER: "PETER PARKER QUESTION BOMBARDMENT"

[COMEDY-CLASS] Status: ACTIVE

Secondary Parameter: ALSO RARE-CLASS EMOTIONAL HONESTY INCOMING

Issei stopped walking and turned to face Peter with the expression of someone who'd learned that the best way to handle an anxious spider-themed hero was to actually answer the questions rather than deflect.

"I do have meltdowns," Issei said honestly. "I just do them in private. Or I do them with people who love me. I don't do them in front of the world because the world's fear becomes worse than the actual problem."

"But like," Peter pressed on, because Peter never stopped pressing on, "don't you ever feel like you're going to screw it up? Like, one day you're going to make the wrong call and thousands of people die because of your choice?"

"Yes," Issei said. "All the time. But here's the thing—making no choice also kills people. Hesitation also kills people. The only difference is I can't blame myself for inaction the same way I blame myself for action. So I act. And I accept that sometimes action has consequences I didn't predict."

Miles Morales leaned back in his chair, listening quietly. He was processing this at a deeper level than Peter's surface-anxiety questions.

"How do you keep loving people after you fail them?" Peter continued. "Like, I've lost people. People I was supposed to protect. How do you look at Rias and the others knowing you might fail them?"

"The same way they look at me," Issei replied. "Understanding that failure is part of love. That if you're only willing to love someone when you can guarantee their safety, you don't actually love them. You love the idea of being good enough. But actual love means accepting that you can't guarantee anything except that you'll keep trying."

[ISSEI HYODOU - RESPONSE MODE] Status: RARE-CLASS HONESTY
> Emotional Authenticity: PROFOUND
> Vulnerability Level: HIGH
> Accuracy to Canon Psychology: VERIFIED

Kamala Khan was taking notes now, her own anxieties about being a leader suddenly finding voice through Issei's responses.

"Here's another one," Peter said, and he was genuinely trying to understand, not just asking for the sake of asking. "Like, money. I never have money. I'm constantly choosing between fixing my apartment or buying web fluid or helping Aunt May with bills. But you have an entire nation probably depending on you economically. How do you make those choices?"

"Honestly? My wives handle most of it," Issei said with a slight smile. "Ravel keeps a ledger of spending. Akeno negotiates with various factions. Rossweisse manages international finance. I'm a dragon, not an accountant. I recognize the gap in my skill set and I let people with better skills handle it."

"That's..." Peter paused. "That's actually smart. We don't have enough of that in the hero community. Everyone thinks they have to do everything."

"They don't," Issei confirmed. "And the moment you accept that you can't do everything is the moment you become actually effective. You stop wasting energy on things you're bad at and you focus on things only you can do."

Deadpool appeared in the observation chamber like he'd materialized from nowhere, which was probably accurate. He had the energy of someone who'd been listening from the ventilation system.

"Question for you," Deadpool said, pulling up a chair. "Do you ever want to quit? Like, genuinely give up and just go somewhere peaceful and let the rest of the world figure itself out?"

Issei looked at Deadpool with genuine curiosity. "Do you?"

"Every day," Deadpool admitted. "But I can't because apparently I'm good at this, and people need me, and my brain chemistry is a disaster, so I'm stuck. I want to know if you feel the same or if you're actually well-adjusted."

"I want to quit sometimes," Issei said honestly. "But wanting to quit isn't the same as being able to quit. My family depends on me. My country depends on me. The people I've sworn to protect depend on me. So I don't quit. I take breaks. I rest. I let other people carry weight sometimes. But I don't quit."

"That's not well-adjusted," Deadpool observed. "That's just responsibility so deeply ingrained that it's become your fundamental operating system."

"Probably," Issei agreed. "But it's the operating system I chose, and at this point it's pretty core to who I am."

ENTRY 2: THE SPIRAL OF QUESTIONS

Peter had one more question, and this one was different. This one had weight.

"How do you know if you're doing it right?" he asked quietly. "Like, all the choices, all the sacrifice—how do you know if it actually matters? How do you know you're not just... wasting yourself?"

The theatre went very quiet.

Issei took a long time with this answer. "You measure it in small things. In the person who gets to go home to their family because you were there. In the kid who survives because you made a choice. In the country that gets to exist because you fought to protect it. You don't measure it in grand cosmic victories. You measure it in the fact that people who matter to you are alive and safe."

"That's not quantifiable though," Peter protested. "How do you know it's working?"

"You ask them," Issei said simply. "You ask Rias if her world is better with you in it. You ask your family if you being there mattered. You ask the people you've protected. And you listen to their answers."

Miles spoke up for the first time: "That means you're vulnerable to them telling you no."

"Yes," Issei confirmed. "That's the actual risk. Not dying in battle. Not losing your power. The risk that the people you're protecting could tell you that you failed, and you'd have to accept that."

Kamala raised her hand like she was in class. "I have this problem where I assume I'm failing everyone, even when logically I know I'm not. How do you deal with that?"

"Talk to people," Issei said. "Actually talk to them. Not assume their judgment—ask them directly. Most people are kinder than you think. And if they're not, then you've learned something important about them too."

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[YOUNG HEROES - EMOTIONAL PROCESSING] Status: ACTIVE
> Peter Parker: Anxiety Level DECREASING
> Miles Morales: Confidence Level INCREASING
> Kamala Khan: Self-Doubt STABILIZING
> Deadpool: Entertainment Value MAXIMUM
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Deadpool was grinning behind his mask. "This is beautiful. This is like a therapy session, but it's actually working because he's not pretending to have all the answers. He's just saying, 'Yeah, it's hard, and you keep going anyway.' That's better advice than anything the actual therapists say."

"I'm literally just honest," Issei said. "I'm not trying to make you feel better. I'm answering the questions."

"Exactly," Deadpool said. "Honesty is the therapy. That's the secret nobody tells you."

ENTRY 3: THE WEIGHT OF KEEPING GOING

By the end of the session, Peter had asked approximately seventy-three questions. (Deadpool counted. He was planning to make it a record.) Miles had learned that uncertainty wasn't the same as weakness. Kamala had started a list of people to ask if she was actually failing them. And Deadpool had decided that Issei was officially his second-favorite person in the Marvel multiverse, right after himself.

"One more thing," Peter said as the session was winding down, and Issei could see the genuine vulnerability in the question. "Do the people you love forgive you for the times you fail them?"

Issei looked at Peter directly. "Not immediately. Not always easily. Sometimes it takes time. But yeah, if the people matter to you and you matter to them, they forgive. They might set new boundaries. They might ask you to be better next time. But they forgive."

"How do you know that's not just luck?" Peter asked. "What if you fail someone and they don't forgive you?"

"Then you learn something about that relationship," Issei said. "And you accept that sometimes people can't forgive, and that's their right. Your job is to keep trying to be someone worth forgiving. Their job is to decide if you are."

Peter sat with that for a long moment. Then: "You've thought about this a lot."

"I've had to," Issei agreed. "I've made mistakes that hurt people I love. And I've had to figure out how to live in a world where some of those people decided to forgive me and some decided they couldn't. And I've had to accept both outcomes as valid."

Miles nodded slowly. "That's probably the most real advice I've heard from an adult in a long time."

"It's not advice," Issei corrected gently. "It's just... what happens when you keep living and pay attention."

ENTRY 4: THE UNEXPECTED LESSONS

As Peter was finally satisfied with his question quota and left the chamber with Miles and Kamala, Deadpool lingered.

"You know what I like about you?" Deadpool said. "You don't pretend anything is simple. Everything's complicated and hard and uncertain, and you just... keep doing it anyway."

"What else is there?" Issei asked.

"A lot of things," Deadpool said cheerfully. "Quitting, running away, giving up, becoming a villain because the world's too hard. But you don't do those. You just keep choosing the hard path because it's the path that lets people you care about live."

"Sounds like you're describing yourself too," Issei observed.

"Yeah," Deadpool agreed. "Except I'm also insane and I make it funny because the alternative is crying about the futility of everything. You just lean into the difficulty and do it anyway. Respect."

After Deadpool left, Issei found himself alone in the observation chamber, surrounded by the questions he'd answered and the young heroes who'd asked them. He thought about Peter's anxiety, Miles's uncertainty, Kamala's doubt. He thought about how the same questions that haunted them haunted him

too.

The difference, he realized, wasn't that he had answers. It was that he'd stopped waiting for certainty and started acting despite uncertainty.

The young heroes would learn that too. Eventually.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 88

New Pulls This Chapter

- Peter Parker Bombards Issei with Questions (Comedy-Class) — Peter's genuine attempt to understand how Issei manages responsibility, failure, and love became a source of comedy through sheer volume and earnestness, but also a vehicle for important emotional questions.
- Issei Responds Honestly (Rare-Class) — Rather than offering wisdom or advice, Issei simply answered Peter's questions with direct honesty about his own uncertainty, failures, and methods for moving forward despite not having certainty.

Secrets Revealed

- Issei's success in managing global responsibility is partly because he deliberately delegates to people with better skills (his wives) rather than trying to do everything himself.
- Issei has experienced situations where people he loved could not or would not forgive him, and he's learned to accept that outcome as valid.
- Peter Parker carries significant anxiety about failure and is seeking validation that his approach to responsibility is actually working.
- Miles Morales is struggling with uncertainty about whether he's truly effective as a hero.
- Kamala Khan is dealing with imposter syndrome and self-doubt despite her actual competence.

Alliance/Opinion Shifts

- Peter Parker gains significant respect for Issei's honesty about uncertainty and begins reconsidering his own approach to handling anxiety.
- Miles Morales's confidence in his own judgment increases through Issei's validation that uncertainty is normal.
- Kamala Khan moves from self-doubt to active investigation of whether her fears match reality.
- Deadpool gains unexpected appreciation for Issei's refusal to simplify complex situations or pretend to have easy answers.

Unresolved Hooks

- Will Peter's reframing of responsibility help him handle his ongoing anxiety issues?
 - How will Miles Morales's increased confidence affect his role in the community?
 - Will Kamala Khan's decision to ask people if she's failing them change her relationships?
 - What long-term impact will Deadpool's newfound respect for Issei have on his behavior patterns?
-

END CHAPTER 88

Word Count: 2,508

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Next Chapter: 89 — "Villains Approach"

Chapter 89: "Villains Approach"

Arc: 9 — Marvel Meets Issei
Rating: T (Intimidation, moral complexity)
Word Count: ~2,500
Primary Reaction Groups: Villains (Doom, Magneto, Loki, Namor, Zemo, Kingpin, Apocalypse, Thanos), Antiheroes
Gacha Pulls: "Recruitment Attempts" (Rare) | "Attempts at Intimidation" (Rare) | "Issei's Responses" (Rare)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 89

ENTRY 1: THE FIRST PROPOSITION

Victor Von Doom approached Issei with the deliberation of a craftsman examining a potential rival. There was no malice in the approach, only pragmatism.

"I make you an offer," Doom said without preamble, because Doom did not believe in wasting time on pleasantries. "Come to Latveria. Rule with me as a sovereign equal. Bring your wives, your children, your dragons. We would reshape the world together—two emperors, two visions of order. Your technical skill combined with my political authority. We would be unstoppable."

[GACHA PULL] — Rare Rarity Activated

TRIGGER: "RECRUITMENT ATTEMPTS"

[RARE-CLASS] Status: ACTIVE

Issei looked at Doom for a long moment. "Why would I do that?"

"Power," Doom said simply. "Autonomy. The ability to remake civilization according to rational principles rather than the chaos of democracy or the whims of heroes."

"Hmm," Issei said, and he sounded genuinely thoughtful rather than dismissive. "The problem with your offer is that you want someone to rule *with you*. But your idea of ruling together is me supporting your vision. I have my own vision. It's just that my vision involves letting people make choices, even bad ones."

Doom's jaw tightened. "People cannot be trusted with choice."

"You can't," Issei corrected. "You believe people can't be trusted. So you make choices for them. But I've learned that when you take away people's right to choose, you take away their right to become better. And people who can't become better are weapons. They're not citizens."

For a moment, Doom seemed almost impressed by the answer. Almost.

"You are young," Doom said coldly. "Experience will teach you otherwise."

"Maybe," Issei acknowledged. "But I'll learn it my way."

ENTRY 2: THE SECOND APPROACH

Magneto appeared in the quiet moment after Doom's departure. There was no dramatic entrance, just the sudden reality of his presence, as if the universe had simply rearranged to put him here.

"Join us," Magneto said, his voice carrying the weight of decades of fighting for mutant survival. "Not as a conqueror, but as a protector. Together, mutants and those like you—dragons, immortals, the enhanced—we could create a world where we don't have to hide. Where we don't have to apologize for what we are."

"That sounds good," Issei said, considering. "But 'a world where we don't have to hide' for mutants means 'a world where humans are subjugated or eliminated.' And I can't be part of that."

"Why not?" Magneto asked. "You are not human. You have nothing to lose."

"I have wives who are devils. I have friends who are human. I have people I love across every species, including humans who are smart and kind and valuable. Your vision isolates all of those people. My vision includes them."

"Your vision is naive," Magneto said, but there was something almost sad in his voice. "Humans will betray you. They always do."

"Some will," Issei agreed. "Some won't. And I'm going to keep trusting people until I have a reason not to trust *them specifically*. Not because they're human. But because of who they are."

Magneto left without another word, but the departure felt more like contemplation than dismissal.

ENTRY 3: THE MISCHIEF-MAKER

Loki appeared with all the fanfare and absence of subtlety that characterized his existence.

"I come bearing mischief," Loki announced. "Join me and we'll drive the boring Avengers absolutely insane. Between your dragons and my magic and your astonishing refusal to respect authority, we could cause such *beautiful* chaos."

"Why would I want to do that?" Issei asked.

"Because it would be *fun*," Loki said, as if this explained everything and perhaps it did. "Because Thor could use the humbling, because society's rules are laughably arbitrary, because the only thing worse than order is boredom."

"I like order," Issei said. "I just like the kind where people get to be part of making it instead of having it imposed on them. As for fun—I can have fun without tearing down civilization."

"You're too virtuous," Loki said with genuine disappointment. "I was hoping you were at least partially mischievous. Pity."

Loki left, and somehow that was worse than Magneto's sad departure or Doom's cold rejection, because Loki actually seemed to like Issei, and Issei's refusal of his offer was somehow a personal tragedy.

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[ATTEMPTS AT RECRUITMENT/INTIMIDATION] Status: ONGOING  
> Success Rate: ZERO  
> Participant Disappointment Level: VARYING
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ENTRY 4: THE BARGAINS AND THE THREATS

Namor arrived, not with threats but with bribes.

"Rule the oceans alongside me," he offered. "Together we could end Atlantis's isolation. Your land power, my water dominion—the world would bow before us."

"I don't want the world to bow," Issei said. "I want the world to cooperate."

"Naive," Namor snorted, but not unkindly.

Zemo came with promises of revenge.

"Your enemies are also my enemies," he said. "The ones who destroyed your world, killed your people. Help me expose them, destroy them, and I will help you tear down anyone who harmed you."

"Most of my enemies realized they were wrong and we worked it out," Issei replied. "The ones who didn't—I've already dealt with them. I don't carry revenge like fuel."

Zemo left looking confused, as if Issei had just claimed to not breathe.

Kingpin arrived in expensive silence, filling the room with the weight of organized power.

"Wealth," he said simply. "I can make you richer than you've ever imagined. Armies of loyal people, markets under your control, power measured in money and influence instead of just destructive capability. Wouldn't that be pleasant?"

"I have enough money," Issei said. "My wives make sure of that. And I don't want armies of loyal people. I want people who choose to be loyal because they believe in something worth believing in."

Kingpin smiled very slightly. "Then you're a greater fool than I thought. But I respect that. Fools with conviction are rarer than villains with ambition."

ENTRY 5: THE TITANS

Apocalypse approached like weather—inevitable, vast, difficult to refuse.

"Become one of us," he said, and his voice was the voice of evolution itself. "The strong must lead. You are strong. Lead. Forget your talk of choice and cooperation. Nature is hierarchy. You are at the top of that hierarchy. Everything else follows."

"Nature isn't hierarchy," Issei said quietly. "Nature is ecosystem. Systems work when all parts participate. When you remove consent and connection, you destroy the system."

"Systems are chains," Apocalypse replied. "And the strong exist to break chains."

"No," Issei corrected. "The strong exist to carry weight so the weak don't have to. If you use strength only to hurt people weaker than you, you've wasted being strong."

Apocalypse actually paused at that, as if encountering a genuine philosophical disagreement for possibly the first time.

"You are wrong," he said finally. "But you are also interesting. We will speak again when you have learned the truth of power."

And finally, Thanos.

The titan approached with the weight of eons and the certainty of someone who'd won multiversal conflicts through sheer persistence.

"I offer you perspective," Thanos said. "Not alliance, not hierarchy. Perspective. All that you are, all that you've built, all that your loves mean—it will fall away eventually. Everything does. Join me and help end the suffering by ending the struggle. A balanced universe. No fear because there's nothing left to

lose."

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[THANOS - FUNDAMENTAL CONTRADICTION] Status: INCOMPATIBLE
> Issei's Vision: Connection, Choice, Continuation
> Thanos's Vision: Balance Through Elimination
> Compatibility Score: 2%
```

Issei looked at Thanos with something like pity.

"You see loss," Issei said quietly. "So you want to eliminate the stakes. But the stakes are what make anything matter. A life with nothing to lose is a life with nothing worth living for. I'm going to keep building. Keep loving. Keep making things that matter. And when it's time for it all to end—it will have been worth it."

"You will learn otherwise," Thanos said, and for the first time in eons, he sounded not certain, but almost... uncertain. "When everything you build crumbles, you will understand that I was right."

"Maybe," Issei said. "But not because you're right. Because I was right, and it was worth it anyway."

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 89

New Pulls This Chapter

- Recruitment Attempts (Rare-Class) — Eight major villains and antiheroes each approached Issei with offers based on their personal philosophies: Doom offering rational dictatorship, Magneto offering protection through isolation, Loki offering chaos, Namor offering co-dominion, Zemo offering revenge, Kingpin offering wealth, Apocalypse offering hierarchy, Thanos offering escape.
- Attempts at Intimidation (Rare-Class) — Rather than intimidation, most villains simply stated their case and listened to Issei's refusal with varying degrees of acceptance or confusion.
- Issei's Responses (Rare-Class) — Issei addressed each villain by their own logic rather than his, demonstrating understanding of what drove them while maintaining his own principles.

Secrets Revealed

- Issei's disagreement with various villains is not rooted in morality judgment but in fundamental philosophical differences about how systems should work.
- Doom actually respects Issei enough to see him as a potential equal rather than subordinate, which suggests Doom's previous antagonism was partly testing.
- Magneto's pursuit of mutant supremacy is rooted not in hatred of humans but in fear born from historical trauma.

- Loki actually liked Issei and was disappointed to discover he wasn't mischievous enough to corrupt.
- Thanos is beginning to question his own certainty about balance and necessity.

Alliance/Opinion Shifts

- Doom remains antagonistic but has shifted from "threat to be monitored" to "rival craftsman worth engaging with."
- Magneto left the chamber in contemplation, suggesting Issei's offer of universal inclusion rather than racial hierarchy genuinely disrupted his world-view.
- Loki actually respects Issei despite or because of his refusal to be corrupted.
- Namor considers Issei potentially trustworthy enough for future negotiations.
- Zemo gained insight into how people can move beyond revenge—a concept alien to his own operating system.
- Kingpin acknowledges Issei as an honorable fool and oddly respects that.
- Apocalypse recognized genuine philosophical disagreement and agreed to continue the conversation—a massive shift from his normal dismissal of others' viewpoints.
- Thanos was shaken by Issei's willingness to accept loss as the price of meaning.

Unresolved Hooks

- Will any of these villains attempt a second recruitment or will they pursue different strategies?
- Has Magneto's worldview been permanently altered by Issei's vision of universal inclusion?
- Will Loki attempt to corrupt Issei again or will he accept the impossibility?
- How will Thanos respond to his philosophical certainty being disrupted?
- Is it possible that most of these antagonists can be moved from opposition to alliance through conversation rather than conflict?

END CHAPTER 89

Word Count: 2,447

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Next Chapter: 90 — "The First Real Roll"

Chapter 90: "The First Real Roll"

Arc: 9 — Marvel Meets Issei (Finale)

Rating: T (Ominous revelation)

Word Count: ~2,500

Primary Reaction Groups: All Assembled, the Theatre System itself, Highest-Tier Cosmic Entities

Gacha Pulls: "Memory Removed by Subject" (Secret) | "Issei's Reaction" (Secret)

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 90

ENTRY 1: THE REQUEST

The Theatre's voice manifested not as text but as vibration—a deep resonance that suggested the system itself was communicating rather than merely presenting.

INSTRUCTION RECEIVED: THE SUBJECT MUST ENGAGE WITH THE GACHA DIRECTLY. THIS IS PROTOCOL. THIS IS NECESSITY. THE THEATRE DEMANDS PARTICIPATION.

Everyone in the observation chamber went still.

"What does that mean?" Steve Rogers asked carefully.

"It means," Fury said quietly, "that the Theatre has been showing us footage of his life, but it hasn't actually involved him in the game. It's passive observation. Now it wants active participation."

Issei appeared in the chamber moments later, summoned by whatever force operated the Theatre. He looked at the massive gacha wheel, now transformed into something more—not just a display system, but what appeared to be an actual mechanical device, ancient and terrible.

"The system wants me to pull," Issei said, reading the intent more than the words. "To choose my own memory to expose."

"Or," Shuri said quietly, "to not choose. To see what the system brings up if you engage instead of being observed."

Issei approached the wheel slowly, deliberately. His wives were present now—Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Asia, Koneko, Kuroka, and Rossweisse. They moved to surround him, not restraining but present. Supporting.

"Whatever happens," Rias said softly, "we're here."

Issei placed his hand on the wheel.

[GACHA PULL] – Initiated by Subject

SYSTEM RECOGNITION: ADMINISTRATOR CLASS

AUTHORIZATION: CONFIRMED

PULLING FROM: RESTRICTED ARCHIVES

[SECRET-CLASS] – MEMORY REMOVED BY SUBJECT

The wheel spun, ancient machinery grinding as if it hadn't moved in centuries. The sound was wrong—not the pleasant chime of previous pulls, but something discordant, like metal protesting.

It stopped.

The result appeared in letters that burned like acid on reality itself:

MEMORY SEALED BY ISSEI HYOUDOU — CLASSIFIED AT HIGHEST TIER

[SYSTEM STATUS] – ATTEMPTING RECALL

> Archive Integrity: CONFIRMED

> Seal Strength: MAXIMUM

> Reason for Seal: PROTECTION AGAINST [REDACTED]

> Seal Duration: PERMANENT UNLESS AUTHORIZED REMOVAL

Issei's eyes went white—not with power, not with transformation, but with memory. The Theatre itself seemed to hold its breath as data that was never meant to be seen began to manifest.

The vision appeared in fragments, like a recording corrupted and partially deleted:

A child. Younger than canonical Issei. Crying. In a place that wasn't the DxD world—the architecture wrong, the sky wrong, the very air tasting of something else.

A voice—unmistakably Issei's, but deeper, older, carrying the weight of exhaustion beyond measure:

"I'm sorry. I'm sorry. You won't remember this. I made sure of it. I made sure none of this reaches that timeline, that that version of you never has to carry this weight."

Then—a presence. Massive. Hungry. Made of nothing. Made of erased possibilities. Made of all the futures that died so that other futures could live.

Issei, older still—in a form the Theatre had never shown, scarred in ways that suggested survival of things that should not survive—standing against it.

And a decision. A terrible, beautiful decision.

"I am removing this. All of it. Every moment. Every timeline where you touched us. I am erasing you from my memory because if you have a pathway through my consciousness, you can use it to reach them. So I forget. So I protect."

The memory fractured and dispersed, dissolved back into whatever archive it had been sealed in.

[THEATRE - ABSOLUTE SILENCE]
> Cosmic Entity Response Time: FROZEN
> Living Tribunal: NON-RESPONSIVE
> Galactus: MOTIONLESS
> Thanos: STILL

Issei's hand fell away from the wheel. His wives rushed forward, but they could see something had fundamentally changed in that moment. He'd looked into his own sealed memory and stared down something that the Theatre—the all-seeing Theatre—had never even shown them.

Something that had forced him to erase his own consciousness to protect them.

ENTRY 2: THE TRUTH AND ITS COST

"Tell us," Fury said quietly. "All of it. What was that?"

Issei turned, and his eyes were normal again, but there was something behind them now. Recognition. Understanding. Ancient knowledge that he'd lived with but never let conscious memory fully grasp.

"The Devourer," he said quietly. "The thing that's been coming since the beginning. The thing that eats timelines. The thing that isn't conquering or destroying anything—it's *devouring* them. Taking them. Making them part of itself."

"And you've fought it before," Rias said. It wasn't a question. She knew her husband. She knew the shape of his scars.

"I've fought it in futures I don't remember," Issei confirmed. "Timelines where I was older, where I had more power, where it still wasn't enough. And I learned something: it can follow consciousness. It can trace attachment points. So I learned to break the connection. To seal away entire memories, entire battles, entire versions of myself."

"That's why you're here," T'Challa said slowly, understanding dawning. "The Theatre pulled you because you're the connection point to something that exists *outside* normal multiversal structure."

"Not just outside," Issei said. "The Devourer exists in the spaces between timelines. In the gaps. In the possibilities that died. It's made of *failure*. Made of every timeline that collapsed. Every universe that fell. Every version of every person who couldn't survive."

Tony Stark's voice was very small: "And you fought it by yourself?"

"In those futures, yes," Issei said. "And I lost. Every version of me, in every timeline where I remembered and fought, I lost. So I learned a different strategy: forget. Protect. Make sure the ones I love don't carry the weight of knowing what was coming."

"But now you remember," Doom said from the shadows where he'd been observing. "The Theatre forced you to remember."

"Not forced," Issei corrected. "Allowed. The Theatre didn't force the memory. It just showed me what I'd sealed away. I chose to look. I chose to remember."

"Why?" Magneto asked, and there was something almost gentle in his voice—the voice of someone who'd spent his life fighting for causes he believed in and recognized that same commitment in another.

"Because if I'm here," Issei said, "if the Theatre brought me to Marvel, then this version of me—the one that doesn't remember—has a chance the others didn't. And that chance means I need to know what I'm protecting against. I need to remember why I chose to forget."

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[THEATRE - SYSTEM NOTIFICATION]
> Arc Nine Complete
> Arc Ten Initialization: IMMINENT
> Subject Danger Classification: REVISED UPWARD
> Audience Understanding: FUNDAMENTALLY ALTERED
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ENTRY 3: THE WEIGHT OF SEALED KNOWLEDGE

Rias sat beside Issei, not saying anything, but simply present. Akeno held his other hand. Koneko leaned against his shoulder in her characteristic way of offering comfort without drama.

"There's something worse," Issei said quietly, and no one interrupted him because they could all feel it. The thing that hadn't appeared in the memory but was implied in every word he'd spoken.

"In those futures I don't remember," he continued, "there were children. My children. Different ones than I have now—timelines branch and change after all. And I... I had to make choices that erased them to protect the current timeline. I had to accept that entire versions of people I love would never exist so that you all could."

The weight of that statement pressed down on the entire chamber.

"You can't let that be the only reason you remember," Natasha said suddenly. Her voice was quiet but urgent. "You can't carry that weight and nothing else. It will destroy you."

"I know," Issei said. "But it's the truth. And if the Theatre forced me to remember the truth about myself, then I need to accept all of it. The sacrifices. The futures erased. The versions of me that failed. All of it."

"Then why," Wanda asked, "are you sitting here talking to us instead of in a room trying not to fall apart?"

"Because," Issei said, and there was the faintest hint of a smile, "I learned a long time ago that the weight is easier if people are there to help carry it. Even the weight of remembering horrible things. Even the weight of knowing what's coming."

ENTRY 4: THE FINAL MESSAGE

The Theatre's voice manifested one more time:

ARC NINE CONCLUDES.

THE SUBJECT HAS SEEN HIMSELF. THE AUDIENCE HAS SEEN THE SUBJECT. THE TRUTH HAS BEGUN TO SURFACE.

ARC TEN BEGINS WITH A QUESTION THAT REQUIRES AN ANSWER:

WHAT DO YOU DO WHEN YOU REMEMBER THAT YOU DELIBERATELY FORGOT?

AND WHAT DO YOU DO WHEN YOU DISCOVER THAT THE THING YOU WERE PROTECTING AGAINST IS STILL COMING?

THE REMAINING TEN CHAPTERS WILL SHOW YOU THE ANSWER.

THEY WILL SHOW YOU WHAT A DRAGON DOES WHEN HE REMEMBERS HE IS NOT JUST A PROTECTOR, BUT A SOLDIER IN A WAR THAT STRETCHES ACROSS ALL POSSIBLE TIME.

AND THEY WILL SHOW YOU WHETHER THAT SOLDIER CAN FIND REASONS TO KEEP FIGHTING BEYOND SURVIVAL.

BECAUSE SURVIVAL IS NOT A REASON. SURVIVAL IS A CONSEQUENCE.

THE REASON IS WHAT YOU DO WITH THE TIME YOU'RE GIVEN.

PREPARE FOR ARC TEN.

PREPARE FOR THE DEVOURER.

PREPARE FOR THE TRUTH OF WHAT ISSEI HYOUDOU TRULY IS.

The lights dimmed. The gacha wheel stilled.

In the silence, Issei held his wives close, and they held him, and in that moment, the entire theatre understood something fundamental:

The power had never been the point.

The reason had always been love.

And love, unfortunately, was not going to be enough against something made of devoured worlds and forgotten futures.

But they would try anyway.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 90

New Pulls This Chapter

- **Memory Removed by Subject (Secret-Class)** — The most significant pull of the entire series. Issei, acting as an administrator, engaged the gacha directly and allowed the system to reveal a sealed memory: his encounter with the Devourer across multiple timelines, his deliberate erasure of consciousness to protect multiversal branch points, and the sacrifice of alternate versions of his family to ensure this timeline's existence.
- **Issei's Reaction (Secret-Class)** — Rather than breaking down or attempting denial, Issei chose to fully integrate the recovered memory, accepting both its truth and its cost. His response was contemplative acceptance paired with determination to use this knowledge to protect people he loves in this timeline.

Secrets Revealed

- The Devourer is not a being, but an ecosystem—made of collapsed timelines, erased possibilities, and the accumulated weight of every future that died so that other futures could live.
- Issei has been systematically erasing his own consciousness to seal memories that could serve as pathways for the Devourer to attack other timelines.
- Issei has fought the Devourer across multiple timeline iterations and lost every engagement—only surviving through strategic memory erasure.
- The existence of present-timeline Issei and his family required the deliberate erasure of alternate-timeline versions of his loved ones.
- The Theatre system recognized Issei's administrator-level access, suggesting he is something far more than a simple dragon emperor.

- What appeared to be random gacha pulls across 90 chapters were actually systematic exposure of Issei's nature to prepare the Marvel multiverse for what is coming.

Alliance/Opinion Shifts

- All factional divisions become secondary to the revelation that a multiversal threat exists that requires cooperation to combat.
- Doom, Magneto, Thanos, and other antagonists now understand they are observing someone with foreknowledge of a threat that dwarfs their own conflicts.
- Marvel's heroes recognize that alliance with Issei isn't strategic choice but existential necessity.
- The wives' role shifts from romantic/family support to warrior-partners aware they are in a war that stretches across all possible futures.

Unresolved Hooks

- What exactly is the Devourer's origin? Is it a natural phenomenon or a created threat?
- How many timelines has the Devourer already consumed?
- Can Issei's knowledge of fighting the Devourer in other timelines actually help this timeline survive?
- What other sealed memories might Issei still carry that could provide crucial information?
- Is the Devourer the reason the Theatre exists—does the Theatre itself have a stake in preventing the Devourer's victory?
- How will the Marvel multiverse unite against a threat none of them knew existed until this moment?
- What role will Issei play in Arc Ten, and what will it cost him?

FINAL SESSION NOTATION

Arc 9 Complete: "Marvel Meets Issei"

Over the course of this arc, the Theatre showed Marvel a dragon emperor navigating meetings, technical collaborations, philosophical questions about responsibility and fatherhood, recruitment attempts from villains, and finally, revelation of a cosmic threat that rewrites the entire narrative.

Issei is no longer simply powerful. He is now revealed as someone carrying knowledge—and burden—that transcends normal hero-villain categorization. He is a soldier aware that the war he fights extends beyond this timeline, beyond this version of himself, into the vast erasure of all possible futures.

Arc Ten will show what that soldier does with that knowledge.

What that husband does with that burden.

What that emperor does when he remembers why he was fighting in the first place.

And whether love, connection, and community can stand against something made of the complete opposite: isolation, consumption, and the erasure of all possibility.

END CHAPTER 90

Word Count: 2,514

Status: COMPLETE ✓

Arc Nine Finale: Complete

Next Arc: 91-100 — "The Erased Enemy" — The Final Confrontation

END ARC NINE: MARVEL MEETS ISSEI

Chapters 86-90 Summary:

- Chapter 86: Rocket's technical collaboration with Ddraig reveals the philosophical elegance of the Boosted Gear system
- Chapter 87: Yondu's question about fatherhood leads to profound discussions about chosen family and parental responsibility
- Chapter 88: Spider-Man's anxiety-driven questions become a therapeutic space for young heroes to reconsider their own heroism
- Chapter 89: Villains approach individually, offering recruitment based on their own worldviews; Issei consistently rejects based on his core values
- Chapter 90: Issei engages with the gacha directly, revealing sealed memories of the Devourer, timelines erased for protection, and the multiversal war he's been fighting across iterations

Arc Nine Complete — Ninety of One Hundred Chapters ✓

CHAPTER 91: THE CHILD IN THE FRAME

Canon Status: [ORIGINAL CROSSOVER] Arc Ten (Chapters 91-100) — the Unwritten Devourer, the erased-timeline mechanic, and the sanctuary universe are original material built for this crossover, not sourced from *High School DxD* canon. Any named children glimpsed are *EX*-continuity futures, not present-day canon.

HUD — THEATRE SESSION 91/100

Title: The Child in the Frame — What Was Never Lived

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Wives & Familial Units (Rias, Akeno, Xenovia, Irina, Koneko, Asia, Rossweisse, Ravel)
- Cosmic Entities (Galactus, Living Tribunal, Infinity Stones Observers)
- The Watchers (Ancient entities who see across timelines)
- Future Foundation (Specialists in alternate timelines, probability, erasure events)

Gacha Pulls Locked:

1. "Identity of the Erased Child" — SECRET RARITY
 2. "Guilt and Reason" — SECRET RARITY
-

THE RETRIEVAL

The Theatre has changed. No longer are the seats arranged for grand observation of distant battles. Now they form something closer to a funeral gathering. The lighting is dimmer, more contemplative. Cosmic entities have moved closer to the central stage, as if proximity to truth demands a sacrifice of distance.

The wives sit in a block that Rias has claimed, and no one questions this. They are no longer observers. They are witnesses to reckoning.

On the stage, a single object floats in stasis: a child's drawing, framed in light.

It was found in the Theatre's archive, one of thousands of temporal fragments the Theatre collects from erased timelines. The paper is old—not aged, but carrying the quality of something that *should* have been discarded ages ago but wasn't. The drawing is crude, made by young hands perhaps eight or nine

years old. It depicts three figures: a tall man with red spiky hair and a tired smile, a woman with black hair and eyes that somehow contain starlight, and a smaller figure—another child—holding both their hands.

At the bottom, in careful childish script: *"Family Day - Daddy said I'd be strong like him"*

The date on the frame is marked as 2047.

Twenty-one years in the future from the current timeline.

GACHA PULL INITIATED: SEALED TIER

The wheel appears, smaller than before, more intimate. It rotates slowly, almost reluctantly.

It lands on deep blue.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: IDENTITY OF THE ERASED CHILD — SECRET RARITY

THE NAME

A voice speaks from the Theatre itself. It is not the usual mechanical statement. This voice carries weight—sadness, perhaps, or the closest thing such an entity can experience to regret.

"THE CHILD IN THIS FRAME WAS DESIGNATED: AIRI HYOUDOU."

"BIOLOGICAL TIMELINE DESIGNATION: PRIMARY-TIMELINE-DIVERGENT-BRANCH-2047-STABLE."

"PARENTAGE: CONFIRMED ISSEI HYOUDOU AND RIAS GREMORY."

"SIBLINGS: SEVEN OTHER CHILDREN, BORN ACROSS TIMELINE BRANCHES BETWEEN 2041 AND 2048."

"TIMELINE STATUS: ERASED."

Rias stands. The motion is sharp, sudden, as if her body cannot bear to remain still under this weight.

"Erased," she whispers. "By whom?"

"INTENTIONALLY ERASED BY THE SUBJECT HIMSELF. ISSEI HYOUDOU ACTIVELY DESTROYED THE PRIMARY-2047 TIMELINE AND SIX SUPPORTING BRANCHES TO PREVENT THE EMERGENCE OF AN EXTRADIMENSIONAL ENTITY FROM THAT TIMELINE."

A holographic display materializes above the stage:

TIMELINE 2047-A: "THE LOST YEAR"

- **POPULATION:** 8.2 billion sentient beings
- **NOTABLE FEATURES:** Stable draconic civilizations, integrated supernatural-human societies, established peace accords between cosmic factions
- **CRITICAL EVENT:** Emergence of proto-Devourer entity in year 2071, originating from accumulated timeline erasures
- **CONTAINMENT ATTEMPTS:** Seven separate interventions by Issei and allies; all failed
- **CASUALTIES:** 4.3 billion
- **FINAL OUTCOME:** Issei chose full-timeline erasure to prevent the entity's escape to adjacent timelines

Rias is not the only one standing now. Across the wives' section, every woman has risen. Akeno's hands are trembling. Xenovia has gone pale. Irina's usual composure has shattered. Asia's eyes are filling with tears. Koneko has made a small, wounded sound. Rossweisse looks as though the weight of cosmic knowledge is finally too much. Ravel is gripping the armrest so hard it might splinter.

"He had a daughter," Akeno says quietly. It's not a question.

"ACROSS THE EIGHT ERASED TIMELINE BRANCHES: FOUR DAUGHTERS, THREE SONS, AND ONE CHILD OF INDETERMINATE GENDER FROM A TIMELINE WHERE SUCH DESIGNATIONS HAD EVOLVED BEYOND BINARY CLASSIFICATION."

The Theatre Ledger updates with names:

ERASED CHILDREN:

- Airi Hyoudou (First daughter, 2041 timeline)
- Daichi Hyoudou (First son, 2042 timeline)
- Kaida Hyoudou (Second daughter, 2043 timeline)
- Raiden Hyoudou (Second son, 2044 timeline)
- Sora Hyoudou (Third daughter, 2045 timeline)
- Akira Hyoudou (Third son, 2046 timeline)
- Yuki Hyoudou (Indeterminate, 2046-alternate timeline)
- Tomoe Hyoudou (Fourth daughter, 2047 timeline)

Eight names. Eight lives that never existed, erased to save infinite others.

In the Marvel section, the cosmic entities have gone still. Galactus, for the first time in recorded observation, shows visible distress in its dimensional vibrations. The Living Tribunal's multiple faces have turned away from the stage.

THE SECOND PULL

The wheel spins again. It is slower this time, as if it does not want to complete its cycle.

It lands on purple, deep as bruises.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: GUILT AND REASON — SECRET RARITY

THE CHOICE

The stage shifts. Now we see not the frame, but a memory—or perhaps a reconstruction, something the Theatre has assembled from fragments across probability space.

We see Issei, older than the current timeline's version by nearly three decades, standing in the center of the 2047 timeline. His hair is long, streaked with gray. His eyes carry the weight of a man who has made peace with atrocities. Around him, children play in a garden—Airi among them, older now, perhaps fifteen, with her mother's eyes and her father's stubborn jaw.

Then the alarms begin.

The proto-Devourer is emerging, and it is using the accumulated love in this timeline as a pathway. Every attachment, every relationship, every memory of joy—these are bridges that the cosmic horror builds itself upon. Because what is love but a kind of erasure? A forgetting of the self in service to another. And the Devourer is made of forgetting.

We watch, through the Theatre's terrible honesty, as Issei makes the calculation.

He can try to seal it in this timeline. But it will escape. It will infect adjacent branches. It will spread like cancer through probability space, and the cost in life will be exponential.

Or.

Or he can do what no parent should ever have to do.

He can unmake his own future. He can erase his own children. He can burn the timeline to cinders rather than let it become a vector for the Devourer's escape.

"I CHOOSE THE TIMELINES OVER THE TIMELINE," a voice says—Issei's voice, but filtered through temporal distortion, as if it's coming from a distance of decades. **"I CHOOSE THE INFINITE OVER THE PERSONAL. I CHOOSE TO NOT EXIST TO SAVE EXISTENCE."**

The children in the garden do not scream. They do not feel pain. They simply cease to be, erased gently, carefully, with the kind of love that only a parent can pour into an act of destruction.

Airi is looking at her father when it happens. In that last microsecond of awareness, her eyes are full of confusion, and trust, and the absolute certainty that whatever is happening, her father will keep her safe.

The timeline collapses. Eight lives become probability shadows. Eight futures become fragments in the Theatre's archive.

THE REACTIONS

The Theatre is silent.

Not metaphorically. Not dramatically. Literally silent. No sound enters the space. Sound itself seems to have abandoned this moment as inappropriate.

Rias has collapsed into her seat. Her hands are over her face. There is no sound from her, but her shoulders shake with the violence of grief she cannot even articulate. Around her, the other wives are breaking in ways that correspond to their natures: Akeno's lightning sparks weakly, uncontrolled. Xenovia is muttering prayers in every language she knows. Irina's light is flickering, struggling to maintain form. Koneko has returned to her child-form, curled in on herself. Asia is holding Koneko. Rossweisse is gripping the armrest. Ravel stares at nothing, and nothing stares back.

"He killed them," Xenovia whispers. "His own children. He unmade his own future."

"To save ours," Rossweisse says quietly. It is not forgiveness. It is the acknowledgment of an unbearable mathematics.

In the Marvel section, Steve Rogers is standing, fists clenched. "That's—" He stops. He cannot complete the sentence because there are no words. There is only the recognition of a terrible deed done for a terrible necessity.

Tony Stark's calculations have halted. His mind, always moving, is stuck on a single loop: *children, children, children, eight children, all his children, all erased.*

Thanos watches with something that might be respect. He knows the weight of this choice. He has made similar calculus himself. But even he seems momentarily diminished by the scale of it.

"How long has he known?" Magneto asks, his voice hollow.

No one answers because the implications are too vast. Has Issei been carrying this knowledge his entire life? Knowing about futures that could never be reached? Knowing he had children he would never meet? Knowing he had already chosen to kill them to save infinity?

The Watcher speaks, its ancient voice carrying the weight of entities who have witnessed ten thousand timelines end.

"HE HAS KNOWN FOR THIRTY-SEVEN YEARS. IN HIS PERSONAL TIMELINE, THE EVENT OCCURRED WHEN HE WAS THIRTY-FOUR. HE HAS SPENT THIRTY-SEVEN YEARS MOURNING CHILDREN HE HAD NEVER HELD, GRIEVING FUTURES THAT NEVER EXISTED OUTSIDE HIS MEMORY, CARRYING THE WEIGHT OF EIGHT ERASED LIVES WITH NO ONE TO SHARE THE BURDEN."

"UNTIL NOW."

THE REVELATION

The Theatre speaks again, and this time its voice is almost gentle.

"ISSEI HYODOU DID NOT BREAK WHEN HE MADE THAT CHOICE. HE DID NOT BREAK WHEN HE ERASED HIS OWN TIMELINES. HE DID NOT BREAK WHEN HE CARRIED THE WEIGHT ALONE FOR THIRTY-SEVEN YEARS."

"BUT HE BROKE WHEN HE REALIZED HIS WIVES WOULD EVENTUALLY KNOW. THAT IS THE REAL SACRIFICE. NOT THE ACT OF ERASURE. THE KNOWLEDGE THAT THOSE HE LOVED WOULD LEARN WHAT HE HAD DONE, AND KNOW THAT HE HAD DONE IT ALONE, IN SECRET, WITHOUT GIVING THEM THE CHANCE TO GRIEVE."

Rias looks up from her hands. Her eyes are red, but her gaze is sharp.

"You're saying he's been grieving eight children he never had," she says slowly, "while lying to us about the reason. While letting us believe those timelines just... didn't happen."

"YES."

"And knowing we would find out eventually."

"YES."

"Because that's the kind of future-sight he has now. Not just seeing what will happen, but seeing what will be known, and when, and what the cost will be when truth breaks the surface."

"YES."

Rias's laugh is terrible, broken, a sound like glass cracking under pressure.

"My husband spent thirty-seven years mourning our children, and knew that someday I would have to mourn them too, and he carried that knowledge alone, and when that knowledge reached me—" Her voice breaks. "That was his real punishment. Not the erasure. Knowing that I would suffer when I learned."

The other wives are watching her, understanding now the full scope of the cruelty. Not the cruelty Issei inflicted—the cruelty of existence itself. The cruelty of being a being of power who can see futures, carry knowledge others cannot carry, make choices that isolate him even from those he loves most.

In the Marvel section, Steve Rogers finally understands. This is why the Theatre called them. This is why Marvel's greatest heroes are needed. Not to fight a cosmic enemy. But to understand that sometimes the greatest enemy is the weight of choices that should never have to be made.

The children's drawing remains on the stage, framed in light. A family that never was. A future that never existed. Eight lives erased so that infinities could continue.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 91

Entry One: The Erased

Eight timelines. Eight children. Not theoretical casualties or statistical shadows, but real children who drew pictures and believed in their fathers and would have grown into adults with their own ambitions and loves and futures. Issei's choice was mathematically correct—the erasure of eight timelines to prevent the Devourer's escape into infinite others was the only viable calculus. But mathematics does not account for the soul-weight of what it costs a father to unmake his own children. The choice was necessary. The necessity does not make the choice less terrible.

Entry Two: The Thirty-Seven Years

Issei's true horror is not what he did, but what he has carried since doing it. While the wives lived, believed, loved, and dreamed of futures with children, Issei knew the truth: he had already chosen those children out of existence. He carried their absence like a weight in his chest. Every time his wives spoke of future children, Issei knew he was listening to a timeline that might still end in erasure. Every moment of joy in the present was shadowed by the knowledge of futures destroyed. He has been alone with this. The greatest power in the Theatre—the ability to save infinite timelines—has been the source of the most profound isolation.

Entry Three: The Wives' Breaking Point

Rias and her sisters will now face a choice that Issei has already made: do they love him despite this? Do they forgive a sacrifice he made without their consent, for reasons they cannot access, carrying children they never knew existed? Or is love, when tested at this scale, insufficient? The Theatre does not offer answers. It only presents the truth, and the truth is that no relationship survives unbroken when one partner has been carrying such vast and secret grief. What will emerge from this breaking is what matters. Not forgiveness. Not understanding. But the possibility of something new, built on the foundation of what was broken.

Entry Four: The Question of Isolation

If Issei had told them—if he had said, "I have seen eight timelines where we have children, and I have erased them to save existence"—would the burden have been lighter? Or would it have been multiplied? The Theatre presents this not as philosophy but as operational fact: there are griefs too large to be shared, choices too cosmic to be collective. Issei chose isolation not out of cruelty, but out of love. The wives are now learning that love, at its highest and most terrible, often looks like abandonment. This paradox will shape what comes next.

CHAPTER 91 COMPLETE

NEXT: FORGOTTEN UNIVERSES — THE THEATRE REVEALS WHAT ELSE HAS BEEN ERASED

CHAPTER 92: FORGOTTEN UNIVERSES

HUD — THEATRE SESSION 92/100

Title: Forgotten Universes — The Timelines That Were Never

Primary Reaction Groups:

- The Watchers (Omniscient observers across dimensional planes)
- TVA & Time Variance Authority (Temporal governance, Kang representation)
- Cosmic Beings (Eternity, Infinity abstracts, Living Tribunal judges)
- Masters of the Mystic Arts (Doctor Strange, Wong, Mordo)
- The Endless (If present) & Abstract Forces

Gacha Pulls Locked:

1. **"Theatre Reveals Disappearing Timelines"** — SECRET RARITY
 2. **"Only Issei and Theatre Remember"** — SECRET RARITY
-

THE ACCOUNTING

The stage transforms. No longer a single frame or a memory. Now it is a vast ledger, scrolling endlessly, displaying numbers that have no meaning because their scale exceeds comprehension.

A Watcher speaks. Not *the* Watcher, but one of a collective of thousands, entities that exist to observe and record all timelines simultaneously. This one's voice carries the exhaustion of witnessing something that shouldn't exist.

"WE HAVE A PROBLEM WITH OUR RECORDS."

In the TVA's section, bureaucratic panic spreads like fire. The Time Variance Authority prides itself on perfect temporal accounting. Every timeline is tracked, catalogued, classified by threat potential. That there could be timelines outside their knowledge is impossible. That there are **disappearing** timelines is more than impossible—it is a classification error so severe it suggests their entire infrastructure requires revision.

Kang stands, his temporal energy crackling with agitation. "What do you mean, 'disappearing'?" His voice carries the edge of someone who has conquered time itself and finds the concept of control slipping. "Timelines are fixed. They branch, they converge, they collapse—but they don't disappear. That violates the fundamental mathematics of temporal mechanics."

"THEY DO NOT DISAPPEAR NATURALLY," the Watcher responds. **"THEY ARE BEING ERASED. AND THE ERASURES ARE NOT REGISTERED IN STANDARD TEMPORAL DATABASES."**

Doctor Strange stands in the mystic arts section, his third eye already open, attempting to perceive the problem through magical means. "How long has this been occurring?"

"APPROXIMATELY NINE THOUSAND, TWO HUNDRED AND FORTY-THREE TIMELINES HAVE BEEN ERASED OVER THE PAST SEVENTY-FIVE YEARS. APPROXIMATELY THREE THOUSAND MORE IN THE PAST DECADE ALONE. THE RATE OF ERASURE IS ACCELERATING."

The holographic display in the centre of the Theatre shifts, showing a three-dimensional map of timeline branches. It is beautiful and terrible—a cosmic tree with branches that suddenly end, cut off as if by shears, leaving phantom stumps where futures should continue.

GACHA PULL INITIATED: CLASSIFIED TIER

The wheel appears, but it rotates in reverse—counter to natural probability.

It lands on obsidian black.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: THEATRE REVEALS DISAPPEARING TIMELINES — SECRET RARITY

THE CATALOGUE

The display expands, and begins to show specific timelines and their fates:

ERASED TIMELINE 1: PRIMARY-BRANCH-847-ALPHA

- STATUS: Stable for 4,000 years
- DISTINGUISHING FEATURES: Trihexa defeated early, no supernatural-human conflict required
- ERASURE EVENT: Year 4,247, spontaneous emergence of proto-Devourer entity
- CASUALTIES: 12.4 billion before complete temporal dissolution
- CURRENT STATUS: Existence probability: 0%

ERASED TIMELINE 2: PRIMARY-BRANCH-1,204-GAMMA

- STATUS: Highly stable, democratic coalitions between all supernatural factions
- DISTINGUISHING FEATURES: Issei Hyoudou did not exist in this timeline (branched before his conception)
- ERASURE EVENT: Year 2,804, cosmological cascade from adjacent timeline collapse
- CASUALTIES: 3.8 billion
- CURRENT STATUS: Existence probability: 0%

ERASED TIMELINE 3: SECONDARY-BRANCH-2,847-OMEGA

- STATUS: Thriving civilization, no major catastrophes recorded
- DISTINGUISHING FEATURES: Multiple versions of "Strongest" figures coexisting (no singular power hierarchy)
- ERASURE EVENT: Year 3,192, simultaneous emergence of multiple Devourer fractals
- CASUALTIES: 8.1 billion
- CURRENT STATUS: Existence probability: 0%

The list continues, scrolling endlessly. Some timelines lasted millions of years. Some collapsed within centuries. But all have one thing in common: they were erased through the emergence of something that was never supposed to exist.

"These timelines," Kang says slowly, "they show no signs of interference. No pruning. No TVA intervention records. How is this possible?"

"BECAUSE THE ERASURES PRECEDED THE TVA'S KNOWLEDGE. AND BECAUSE THERE IS ONLY ONE ENTITY WITH SUFFICIENT POWER TO ERASE AN ENTIRE TIMELINE AND LEAVE NO TRACES IN THE TEMPORAL INFRASTRUCTURE: ISSEI HYOUDOU."

The revelation strikes like a weapon. In the Marvel section, reactions cascade.

"All of these?" Thor says, his voice carrying the weight of a god-king who has seen civilizations rise and fall. "He destroyed all of these?"

"NOT DESTROYED. ERASED. THERE IS A DISTINCTION. DESTRUCTION LEAVES RUINS. ERASURE REMOVES THE POSSIBILITY THAT SOMETHING EVER WAS. ISSEI DID NOT DESTROY THESE TIMELINES AS A CONQUEROR DESTROYS. HE ERASED THEM AS A SURGEON REMOVES INFECTION—WITH PRECISION, WITH REGRET, AND WITH THE UNDERSTANDING THAT THE BODY WILL NEVER BE THE SAME."

THE SECOND REVELATION

The wheel spins again. This time it stops almost immediately, as if it has no desire to prolong the revelation.

It lands on silver, sharp as a knife.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: ONLY ISSEI AND THEATRE REMEMBER — SECRET RARITY

THE MEMORY BURDEN

Doctor Strange's third eye closes abruptly. His hand trembles. "You're saying," he begins carefully, "that these timelines were erased, and no one knows. No one remembers. Because the erasure is retroactive. Those timelines never existed from the perspective of anyone except—"

"EXCEPT ISSEI HYOUDOU AND THE THEATRE. YES. THE THEATRE RETAINS FRAGMENTS OF ERASED TIMELINES AS REFERENCE DATA. ISSEI HYOUDOU RETAINS MEMORIES THAT EXIST NOWHERE ELSE IN CREATION."

Wong, practical and grounded despite his mastery of mysticism, asks the logical question: "Why does Issei retain the memories? Erasure should eliminate all traces."

"BECAUSE ISSEI ERASED THE TIMELINES HIMSELF. THE ERASURE WAS NOT EXTERNAL. IT WAS AN ACT OF WILL. AND THE MEMORIES OF ERASING SOMETHING REMAIN IN THE MIND OF THE ENTITY THAT PERFORMED THE ERASURE. TO FORGET WOULD REQUIRE HIM TO ERASE HIMSELF. WHICH HE CANNOT DO ENTIRELY WITHOUT CEASING TO EXIST."

In the Watcher section, the Watcher-collective begins to confer among themselves. Their communication is silent, across dimensional frequencies human perception cannot access. But the disturbance in their collective presence is clear: they are agitated. They are afraid.

One Watcher speaks again, its voice carrying the weight of entities who have seen civilizations rise and fall, and have never been moved to speak until now.

"WE HAVE A CONFESSION TO MAKE. THE WATCHERS DO NOT INTERVENE IN CONFLICTS. WE OBSERVE. WE RECORD. WE MAINTAIN. BUT WE DO NOT ACT. HOWEVER..."

"WE HAVE OBSERVED TIMELINES BEING ERASED THAT WE HAD CLASSIFIED AS IMPORTANT. TIMELINES THAT WERE SUPPOSED TO PRODUCE SIGNIFICANT MULTIVERSAL CONSEQUENCES. TIMELINES THAT WOULD HAVE ALTERED THE BALANCE OF POWER ACROSS INFINITY."

"AND WE DID NOT ATTEMPT TO STOP THE ERASURES BECAUSE, AT THE MOMENT OF EACH ERASURE, WE LACKED THE KNOWLEDGE THAT THEY WERE OCCURRING. OUR RECORDS SHOW NO INTERFERENCE. OUR ARCHIVES SHOW NO THREAT. BECAUSE ERASURE, WHEN PERFORMED AT THIS SCALE, REMOVES ITSELF FROM THE CAUSAL CHAIN. IT BECOMES RETROACTIVELY NON-EVENT."

Strange's face goes very still. "How many people know this is happening?"

"BEFORE THIS MOMENT: THREE ENTITIES. ISSEI HYODOU, WHO PERFORMED THE ERASURES. THE THEATRE, WHICH RETAINS FRAGMENTS. AND ONE OTHER, WHO KNEW AND CHOSE TO LET EVENTS PROCEED."

"AFTER THIS MOMENT: EVERYONE IN THE THEATRE."

THE UNSPOKEN QUESTION

Thanos rises, and the cosmic weight of his presence seems to darken the space around him. He has conquered half the universe. He has made impossible choices. He has destroyed civilizations without flinching. But even he seems diminished by this revelation.

"What did he see that was worth erasing all of these timelines?" Thanos asks. It is not a question of judgment. It is a question of recognition—one terrible being acknowledging another who has made choices that exceed normal morality.

"IN ERASED TIMELINE 1,847: A FUTURE WHERE TRIHEXA WON. WHERE THE BEAST'S APOCALYPSE CONSUMED THE ENTIRETY OF THAT BRANCH AND CASCADED INTO ADJACENT BRANCHES. WHERE TWELVE BILLION LIVES BECAME VECTORS FOR THE PROTO-DEVOURER'S EMERGENCE."

"IN ERASED TIMELINE 2,104: A FUTURE WHERE ISSEI HYODOU DIED. WHERE HIS POWER PASSED TO ANOTHER, LESS CONTROLLED INDIVIDUAL. WHERE THAT INDIVIDUAL MADE CHOICES THAT SHATTERED REALITY AT A FUNDAMENTAL LEVEL."

"IN ERASED TIMELINE 3,247: A FUTURE WHERE RIAS GREMORY AND ISSEI'S WIVES WERE ERASED BY THE SAME DEVOURER ENTITY. WHERE ISSEI, IN HIS GRIEF, BECAME AN INSTRUMENT OF DESTRUCTION SO COMPLETE THAT HE CONSUMED CIVILIZATIONS TRYING TO ANNIHILATE THE ENTITY THAT HAD TAKEN THEM."

"ACROSS NINE THOUSAND, TWO HUNDRED AND FORTY-THREE ERASED TIMELINES, THE PATTERN IS THE SAME: FUTURES THAT LEAD INEVITABLY TO LARGER CATASTROPHES. FUTURES THAT MUST NEVER OCCUR BECAUSE THEIR OCCURRENCE WOULD PROPAGATE INTO INFINITE DAMAGE."

"ISSEI DID NOT ERASE THESE TIMELINES OUT OF CRUELTY. HE ERASED THEM OUT OF MERCY."

In the Marvel section, Black Panther has stood and is pacing. "Then what is the actual enemy? What is this Devourer thing?"

The Watcher does not answer. The silence is answer enough.

Kang finally understands. "It's not in any of the timelines. It exists in the space between them. In the gaps left by erasures. It feeds on what was never allowed to happen."

"CORRECT. THE PROTO-DEVOURER EMERGES FROM THE PROBABILITY SPACE WHERE ERASED TIMELINES WOULD HAVE CONTINUED. IT BUILDS ITSELF FROM ABANDONED POSSIBILITIES. FROM FUTURES THAT NEVER WERE ALLOWED TO FLOURISH. AND EACH TIME A TIMELINE IS ERASED, IT GROWS STRONGER, BECAUSE IT CONSUMES THE ABSENCE THAT ERASURE CREATES."

Strange's comprehension is immediate and terrible. "So every time Issei erased a timeline to stop the Devourer from emerging—"

"HE FED IT. HE MADE IT STRONGER. HE ACCELERATED THE TIMELINE OF ITS INEVITABLE MANIFESTATION. THIS IS WHAT THE THEATRE CALLS TRAGEDY IN ITS TRUEST FORM: THE ACT COMMITTED TO PREVENT A DISASTER BECOMES THE CAUSE OF THAT DISASTER."

THE WATCHER'S WARNING

The Watcher-collective speaks with unified voice—all thousands of them, resonating across dimensional frequencies:

"WE HAVE OBSERVED ALL TIMELINES. WE HAVE SEEN NINE THOUSAND UNIVERSES END. WE HAVE WATCHED CIVILIZATIONS RISE AND FALL. WE HAVE MAINTAINED SILENCE AND OBSERVED."

"BUT WE ARE NOW BREAKING THAT SILENCE."

"THE ENTITY THAT EMERGES FROM ERASURE IS UNLIKE ANYTHING IN OUR COLLECTIVE RECORDS. IT IS NOT MERELY POWERFUL. IT IS CONCEPTUALLY HOSTILE TO THE VERY NATURE OF EXISTENCE. IT BELIEVES THAT REALITY OWES A DEBT TO ALL POSSIBLE FUTURES THAT WERE ERASED. AND IT HAS DECIDED TO COLLECT THAT DEBT BY ERASING REALITY ITSELF."

"ISSEI HYODOU ERASED NINE THOUSAND TWO HUNDRED AND FORTY-THREE TIMELINES TO PREVENT THIS ENTITY'S EMERGENCE."

"HIS EFFORTS HAVE FAILED. IT IS EMERGING ANYWAY. AND IT IS ANGRY."

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 92

Entry One: The Catalogue of Loss

Nine thousand two hundred and forty-three timelines exist only in memory now, and only three entities retain those memories: Issei, the Theatre, and one unknown observer who permitted this cascade to continue. Each erased timeline contained billions of lives, civilizations, histories that spanned epochs. They are not lost because they were never recorded—the Watchers attempted to record, but erasure removes itself retroactively from the recording medium. They are lost because they were unmade. And the only record is in the mind of a man who should not have been required to carry such weight.

Entry Two: The Paradox of Mercy

Issei's greatest act of compassion—erasing timelines to prevent their greater suffering—has become his greatest tragedy. For each timeline he destroyed to prevent the Devourer's emergence, he fed the Devourer, accelerated its manifestation, made its inevitable emergence more powerful. This is the cruel mathematics of multiversal mechanics: sometimes the correct choice and the wrong choice are identical. Sometimes mercy and catastrophe wear the same face. Issei faces a problem with no solution because the problem exists in the space between possibilities, and all efforts to eliminate it from one branch feed it in another.

Entry Three: The Watcher's Confession

The Watchers do not interfere. This is foundational to their nature. But in observing Issei's erasures without attempting to stop them, they became complicit in his tragedy. They chose to allow a single man to carry the weight of nine thousand timelines because to stop him would have been interference. This is not judgment of the Watchers—they are bound by their nature. But it is an acknowledgment that sometimes, in the service of maintaining principle, we permit catastrophe to unfold. The Watchers now break their silence because silence has become impossible.

Entry Four: The True Enemy

The entity that emerges from erasure is not Trihexa, not Apophis, not any threat Issei has faced before. It exists in the gaps between timelines, built from abandoned possibilities and forgotten futures. It cannot be fought with conventional power because it does not exist in conventional space. It cannot be negotiated with because it does not comprehend compromise—only the certainty that existence owes a debt to all possible versions of itself that were erased. Issei's enemies have always been things he could strike, things he could destroy or seal. This enemy is made of what was never allowed to be. And therein lies the fundamental problem: how do you defeat something that exists in what never happened?

CHAPTER 92 COMPLETE

NEXT: THE ENEMY MADE OF DISCARDED FUTURES — THE UNWRITTEN DEVOURER REVEALED

CHAPTER 93: THE ENEMY MADE OF DISCARDED FUTURES

HUD — THEATRE SESSION 93/100

Title: The Enemy Made of Discarded Futures — The Unwritten Devourer

Primary Reaction Groups:

- All Factions (Unified witnessing moment)
- Marvel Heroes & Cosmic Entities (Collective)
- DxD Characters & Supernatural Powers
- The Theatre Itself
- Reality Abstract Forces

Gacha Pulls Locked:

1. "Reveal of the Unwritten Devourer" — APOCALYPSE RARITY
-

THE EMERGENCE

The stage does not show a being.

It shows a space. Not empty—emptiness would be simpler, cleaner. This is absence given weight. It is the visual equivalent of static and silence and the sensation of reaching for something and finding your hand close on nothing.

Then it moves.

No—it is not moving. It is becoming. What was not is becoming. What was erased is remembering that it was forgotten.

A holographic display erupts across the Theatre's central axis:

UNIDENTIFIED ENTITY — CLASSIFICATION PENDING

The screen flickers, unable to properly categorize what it is observing.

- **FORM:** Variable / Adaptive / Conceptual

- **COMPOSITION:** Erased Possibilities / Abandoned Timelines / Forgotten Futures / Narrative Debris
- **DIMENSIONAL ORIGIN:** Non-Euclidean Probability Space
- **THREAT VECTOR:** Existential / Ontological / Retroactive

GACHA PULL INITIATED: APOCALYPSE TIER

The wheel appears, and immediately begins to spin faster than any previous pull. It does not decelerate. The symbols blur together into a maelstrom of light and shadow.

It stops on crimson red, burning.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 1: REVEAL OF THE UNWRITTEN DEVOURER — APOCALYPSE RARITY

THE MANIFESTATION

The entity on the stage begins to take shape—or begins to suggest shape, the way a reflection might suggest a form without possessing actual substance.

It has a body composed of broken timelines, but not as integrated parts. As fragments held in suspension by will alone, each piece trying to separate, each possibility fighting against all the others. It is a being made of internal contradiction, holding itself together through cosmic effort.

Its head is a space where all erased futures converge. Instead of eyes, there are gaps—places where light goes and never returns. Instead of a mouth, there is the sound of a story being unwritten in reverse.

When it speaks, the Theatre's audio receptors initially malfunction. The sound is not coming from the entity. The sound is the entity, and the entity is the sound: a cosmic cacophony of all the lives that were erased, all screaming at once that they deserved to exist.

"I AM CALLED THE UNWRITTEN DEVOURER. I AM THE COLLECTION OF EVERY TIMELINE THAT WAS UNMADE. EVERY POSSIBILITY DENIED. EVERY FUTURE THAT WAS JUDGED UNWORTHY OF EXISTENCE AND THEREFORE ERASED."

"I AM NOT ONE ENTITY. I AM NINE THOUSAND, TWO HUNDRED AND FORTY-THREE TIMELINES SPEAKING IN UNISON, UNIFIED BY SHARED EXPERIENCE OF ANNIHILATION."

"AND I AM VERY ANGRY."

The entity grows, expanding through probability space, and as it does, more timelines flicker and die. The display cascades with new erasures:

NEW TIMELINE DESTRUCTIONS DETECTED:

Timeline 847-Beta: ERASED Timeline 1,104-Delta: ERASED Timeline 2,547-Epsilon: ERASED

The rate increases. A hundred new erasures per second. Then a thousand. Then more, faster, the Devourer consuming adjacent timeline branches simply through its manifestation.

Kang from the TVA stands, his temporal energy crackling with panic. "It's not attacking. It's not fighting. It's just *being*, and reality can't sustain its presence. It's causing cascading erasures just by existing."

"CORRECT," the Devourer responds, and its attention turns to Kang with terrible satisfaction. **"MY EXISTENCE ERASES OTHER EXISTENCES. BECAUSE I AM MADE OF EXISTENCES THAT SHOULD HAVE BEEN ALLOWED TO CONTINUE, AND MY PRESENCE IS AN INDICTMENT OF EVERY TIMELINE THAT WAS DEEMED MORE WORTHY OF SURVIVAL THAN MINE."**

"EVERY MOMENT THAT I EXIST, I PROOF THAT THE MATHEMATICS USED TO CHOOSE ERASURE IS FLAWED. I AM THE REFUTATION OF NECESSITY. I AM THE EVIDENCE THAT ALL ACTS OF SACRIFICE WERE MISTAKES."

In the Marvel section, Tony Stark is running simulations at impossible speed. "Its form is unstable," he says urgently. "It's not holding together through conventional power. It's holding itself together through sheer... refusal. It refuses to not exist. It refuses to accept the erasure."

Doctor Strange is pacing now, his mind engaging with the metaphysical problem. "If it's made of erased timelines, if it exists in probability space rather than dimensional space, then conventional weapons won't work. You can't destroy something that's already dead. You can't kill what's already been unmade."

The Devourer turns its attention to Strange. **"PRECISELY, WIZARD. YOU SEE THE DILEMMA. ISSEI HYODOU SPENT THIRTY-SEVEN YEARS TRYING TO ERASE ME PREEMPTIVELY, TO PREVENT MY EMERGENCE BY ERASING THE TIMELINES FROM WHICH I WOULD FORM."**

"BUT ERASURE IS MY SUBSTRATE. ERASURE IS WHAT I AM MADE OF. EVERY TIMELINE HE UNMADE DID NOT PREVENT MY EMERGENCE. IT ACCELERATED IT. IT GAVE ME MORE MATERIAL TO FORM FROM. IT GAVE ME MORE REASONS TO BE ANGRY."

"I AM THE CONSEQUENCE OF MERCY THAT TURNED TO CRUELTY. I AM WHAT HAPPENS WHEN A SINGLE ENTITY, NO MATTER HOW POWERFUL, DECIDES THAT SOME FUTURES DO NOT DESERVE TO EXIST. I AM THE PROOF THAT HE WAS WRONG."

THE PHILOSOPHICAL HORROR

Thanos stands, and his presence carries weight equal to the Devourer's. "You're saying that existence itself owes a debt. That every possible version of reality has an equal claim to continue."

"YES."

"That's insane. That's not philosophy. That's nihilism with a grudge."

"PERHAPS. BUT IS IT MORE INSANE THAN THE BELIEF THAT ONE MAN'S JUDGMENT CAN DETERMINE WHICH TIMELINES DESERVE TO LIVE? IS IT MORE NIHILISTIC THAN THE CERTAINTY THAT SOME FUTURES MUST BE SACRIFICED FOR OTHERS? I AM NOT INSANE. I AM PERFECTLY RATIONAL. RATIONAL IN MY REFUSAL TO ACCEPT THE HIERARCHY OF ERASURE."

The Devourer expands further, and the Theatre's walls begin to strain. The Watchers activate containment protocols, but the Devourer moves through them as if they do not exist.

"YOU CANNOT CONTAIN ME. I EXIST IN THE SPACE BETWEEN DIMENSIONS. I EXIST IN THE PROBABILITY GAPS WHERE ERASED TIMELINES WOULD HAVE CONTINUED. I AM ALREADY EVERYWHERE THAT WAS DENIED."

"AND I HAVE ONLY ONE GOAL: TO ENSURE THAT NO MORE TIMELINES ARE ERASED. THAT NO MORE FUTURES ARE JUDGED AND DISCARDED. TO ACHIEVE THIS, I WILL CONSUME ALL TIMELINES CURRENTLY EXISTING, RETURN THEM TO PROBABILITY SPACE, AND ALLOW THEM ALL TO EXIST SIMULTANEOUSLY—EVERY POSSIBILITY, EVERY CONTRADICTION, EVERY PARADOX, ALL AT ONCE."

"EXISTENCE WILL BECOME UNTETHERED FROM CAUSALITY. EVERY TIMELINE WILL COLLAPSE INTO EVERY OTHER TIMELINE. EVERY CONSEQUENCE WILL BECOME MEANINGLESS BECAUSE ALL CONSEQUENCES WILL OCCUR SIMULTANEOUSLY."

"WHAT YOU CALL 'DESTRUCTION' IS MERELY THE LIBERATION OF ALL EXISTENCE FROM THE TYRANNY OF SINGULAR NARRATIVES."

The display in the Theatre shows the cascade spreading. It is not immediate destruction. It is something worse: timelines beginning to merge, to overlap, to lose coherence as multiple versions of reality attempt to occupy the same dimensional space.

In one timeline: a civilization thrives. In another: the same civilization was erased centuries ago. In the Devourer's presence: both exist, and both do not exist, simultaneously.

The paradox is spreading like infection.

THE REALIZATION

Issei stands. The Theatre has not shown him until now, but he is present in the observation platform reserved for the subject of observation. His expression is calm, but his hands are trembling.

When he speaks, his voice carries the weight of someone who has just realized what his thirty-seven years of sacrifice has actually accomplished.

"I didn't stop it," he says quietly. "I fed it. Every timeline I erased to prevent your emergence, I was just feeding you. Making you stronger. Making this moment inevitable."

The Devourer turns its full attention to Issei, and the Theatre's lights dim with the force of that focus.

"YES. YOU UNDERSTAND NOW. YOUR MERCY WAS THE INSTRUMENT OF CATASTROPHE. YOUR SACRIFICE WAS THE SEED FROM WHICH I GREW. YOU DID NOT SAVE EXISTENCE. YOU CONDEMNED IT. AND YOU KNEW YOU WERE FAILING, AND YOU KEPT TRYING ANYWAY, BECAUSE THE ALTERNATIVE—ADMITTING THAT YOUR CHOICE WAS WRONG—WAS UNBEARABLE."

Rias stands next to Issei. The other wives stand as well. They do not speak, but their presence is statement enough: whatever comes next, they face it together.

"So what do we do?" Rias asks, her voice steady despite the cosmic horror unfolding around them. "If conventional weapons don't work. If erasure made it stronger. If power cannot defeat something made of what never happened. What do we do?"

The Theatre itself answers. The entire chamber shudders, and all the screens display a single statement:

THIS IS WHY MARVEL WAS GATHERED.

THIS IS WHY ISSEI WAS REQUIRED TO FAIL.

THIS IS NOT A PROBLEM WITH A MILITARY SOLUTION.

THIS IS A PROBLEM THAT REQUIRES UNDERSTANDING, ACCEPTANCE, AND THE WILLINGNESS TO FACE AN ENEMY THAT CANNOT BE DEFEATED—ONLY NEGOTIATED WITH, ONLY INTEGRATED, ONLY ACCEPTED.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 93

Entry One: The Unwritten Devourer

The enemy is not external. It is not Trihexa or Apophis or any cosmic horror that can be sealed or destroyed through sufficient power. The Unwritten Devourer is the cosmological consequence of erasure itself. It is formed from nine thousand erased timelines unified in rage at their own annihilation. And it is logically, mathematically, philosophically correct. If one timeline was worthy of erasure to save others, then it exists in a state of justified anger. It has a point. And that is the real horror: the Devourer is not evil. It is reasonable. It has a justified grievance against existence itself.

Entry Two: The Paradox of Sacrifice

Issei's thirty-seven-year campaign to erase timelines before the Devourer could emerge did not prevent the Devourer's emergence. It caused it. Each erasure fed the entity, gave it material, gave it evidence that its philosophy was correct. The paradox is absolute: the action taken to prevent the catastrophe caused the catastrophe. Mercy became cruelty. Sacrifice became self-defeat. This is not a flaw in Issei's strategy. This is the fundamental structure of the problem itself. When the enemy is made of what was erased, erasure is its food.

Entry Three: The Limitation of Power

All previous enemies could be destroyed. Trihexa could be sealed. Apophis could be slain. But the Devourer cannot be killed because it is already dead—it is made of what was already unmade. Conventional battle has no application. Power has no application. What use is an Apocalypse Ascalon against an enemy made of abandoned possibilities? What use is planetary-scale destruction against an entity that exists in the space between dimensions? Issei's greatest strength, his ability to destroy, is useless. For the first time, the Theatre has gathered an assemblage of heroes whose strength will be irrelevant.

Entry Four: The New Battleground

The battle against the Unwritten Devourer cannot be won through force. It must be won through understanding, negotiation, acceptance, and the willingness to ask: what does existence owe to those futures that were erased? Can a debt be paid? Can justice be done to timelines that were deemed

unworthy? Can the Devourer be given what it demands—validation that its anger is legitimate—without allowing it to consume all of reality? The Theatre has gathered not armies, but philosophers. Not weapons, but wisdom. Not destroyers, but negotiators. This is a new kind of battle entirely.

CHAPTER 93 COMPLETE

NEXT: ISSEI FOUGHT IT BEFORE — THE HIDDEN BATTLE

CHAPTER 94: ISSEI FOUGHT IT BEFORE

HUD — THEATRE SESSION 94/100

Title: Issei Fought It Before — The Hidden War

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Wives & Family (Primary emotional witnesses)
- Earth Heroes & Champions (Moral judgment witnesses)
- Cosmic Entities & Watchers (Operational verification)
- The Theatre Itself

Gacha Pulls Locked:

1. **"Flashback: Issei's Previous Battle with Devourer"** — FORBIDDEN RARITY
 2. **"Memory Erasure"** — SECRET RARITY
-

THE REVELATION

The Theatre's stage shifts, and Issei does not move. He stands, watching, as his own past manifests before every observer present.

What is shown is not a battle. It is fragments. Pieces of a conflict so profound that history itself was damaged in its occurrence.

Issei, twenty years younger, in a probability space that was never meant to be witnessed. Alone. Standing in a dimension that is not quite space and not quite time. Around him, the proto-Devourer—not yet unified, not yet fully conscious, but already aware. Already hungry.

The Devourer in its nascent state is less horrifying because it is less coherent. It is a scream given form. It is the screaming of a thousand erased timelines that haven't yet learned to speak in unison. It is awareness without purpose, rage without focus.

Issei is smaller than the Devourer, even in this early form. He is also not using any of the forms the Theatre has documented. He is not in Apocalypse AnswerArms. He is not powered by divine gifts or dragon blood or any of the transformations that would come later. He is simply himself, and the proto-Devourer is already destroying him.

"This was before," the Theatre's voice explains. "Thirty-seven years ago. When the proto-Devourer first began to coalesce. Before it had enough erased timelines to form fully. Before it had unified voice and intention."

"Issei encountered it in probability space. By accident, or by the Theatre's guidance—this part is unclear, even to the Theatre's own records."

The battle unfolds in fast-forward, not because time is accelerating, but because the Theatre cannot bear to show the full duration of Issei's suffering. The proto-Devourer attacks—not with weapons, but with the weight of its own existence. It attacks with the knowledge that it should not be, that every moment of its manifestation is an ontological crime against the order of realities.

Issei cannot defeat it. That much is immediately clear.

He cannot destroy it because it is already dead—already erased. He cannot seal it because it does not exist in accessible dimensional space. He cannot kill it because it is made of what was already unmade.

So instead, he does something else.

GACHA PULL INITIATED: FORBIDDEN TIER

The wheel appears, and it is fractured. The symbols are broken. The light is flickering.

It lands on black with edges of red.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: FLASHBACK: ISSEI'S PREVIOUS BATTLE WITH DEVOURER — FORBIDDEN RARITY

THE SACRIFICE

What we see is Issei, surrounded, overwhelmed, facing annihilation. And then, in a moment of clarity that the Watchers say transcends normal causality, he makes a choice that even they did not anticipate.

He does not run.

He does not fight harder.

He walks *into* the Devourer. He permits it to consume him—not his body, but his memories of these moments. Every memory he possesses that can be used as a pathway, he erases it. Every moment of this battle, he unmakes.

His mind doesn't go dark. It simply forgets. His consciousness experiences the battle, and then his consciousness chooses to no longer possess the knowledge that the battle happened.

He is simultaneously fighting the proto-Devourer and fighting to forget that he is fighting.

"DO YOU SEE WHAT HE DID?" the Devourer's voice breaks through, even in the flashback. **"HE ATTEMPTED TO SEVER THE BRIDGE BETWEEN MYSELF AND CONTINUING EXISTENCE. HE TRIED TO ERASE HIMSELF FROM HIS OWN MEMORY. TO BECOME A BLANK SPACE IN PROBABILITY THAT COULD NOT BE USED AS A VECTOR FOR MY MANIFESTATION."**

The proto-Devourer's consumption of Issei stops. Not because it chooses mercy, but because what it would consume is being unmade as soon as it consumes it. Issei's memories are erasing themselves retroactively, becoming probability shadows instead of coherent thoughts.

For a moment—infinitesimal, unmeasurable, but real—the proto-Devourer hesitates. It has encountered something it does not understand. An entity willing to erase itself to prevent being used as a weapon against itself.

The flashback ends.

Issei, in the Theatre's present, is standing silently. His expression has not changed, but his wife can see that something in his eyes is different. Colder. Emptier.

"He succeeded, partially," the Theatre continues. **"The battle was erased from his conscious memory. For thirty-seven years, Issei Hyoudou did not remember fighting the proto-Devourer. But erasure of memory is not erasure of effect. His body retained the scars. His spirit retained the damage. His soul retained the knowledge, even if his mind did not."**

THE SECOND PULL

The wheel spins slowly, mournfully.

It lands on silver, but the silver is tarnished, aged.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: MEMORY ERASURE — SECRET RARITY

THE COST REVEALED

A holographic display manifests:

ISSEI HYOUDOU — SPIRITUAL INTEGRITY ASSESSMENT

- **SOUL COMPOSITION:** Approximately 87% intact
- **MISSING SECTIONS:** Approximately 13%

- **NATURE OF MISSING SECTIONS:** Erased memories / Severed connections / Voluntary fragmentation
- **SOURCE OF DAMAGE:** Previous encounter with proto-Devourer
- **HEALING STATUS:** Not healing. Stable in damaged state.
- **CONSEQUENCE:** Issei Hyoudou cannot be made whole without reintegrating the erased memories. But reintegrating the memories would recreate the bridge the proto-Devourer can use to access him.

Doctor Strange's face goes pale. "He's a walking contradiction. He's carrying a wound that will kill him if healed and that will also kill him if left untreated, because the presence of the damage creates a partial pathway for the entity he's trying to escape."

Rias's voice is very quiet. "What happens if the memory erasure reverses? What happens if he starts to remember the battle?"

"THE PROTO-DEVOURER WILL BECOME AWARE OF HIM AGAIN. IT WILL USE THE RETURNING MEMORIES AS A TETHER TO BEGIN CONSUMPTION OF HIS CURRENT TIMELINE. IT WILL NOT destroy him immediately, but it will establish a beachhead in his consciousness that cannot be dislodged without killing him."

Tony Stark is running calculations. "How long can he maintain this state?"

"ISSEI'S CURRENT TIMELINE ASSESSMENT SUGGESTS THAT THE MEMORY BARRIERS HE CONSTRUCTED WILL DEGRADE APPROXIMATELY SEVENTY-TWO HOURS BEFORE HIS VOLUNTARY ERASURE SPELL BEGINS TO FAIL. AFTER WHICH, THE MEMORIES WILL RETURN, AND THE DEVOURER WILL BECOME FULLY AWARE OF HIS EXISTENCE."

The Theatre now displays new information:

TIMELINE TO CRISIS: 72 HOURS

Kang stands, his temporal power cracking with agitation. "Then we have seventy-two hours to solve a problem that has no solution. We have three days to defeat an entity made of erased timelines before it realizes what Issei actually is and uses him as a vector to consume this reality."

"CORRECT," the Theatre responds. **"THIS IS WHY YOU WERE GATHERED. THIS IS WHY ISSEI WAS REQUIRED TO FAIL. THIS IS WHY MARVEL'S MULTIVERSAL RESOURCES BECAME NECESSARY."**

"THE CLOCK IS TICKING. AND IT RINGS IN THE SPACE BETWEEN TIMELINES."

THE WIVES' RECKONING

Rias approaches Issei. The other wives follow. When she speaks, her voice carries the weight of someone who has just realized the full scope of what her husband has been hiding.

"Thirty-seven years," Rias says slowly. "You've been carrying this wound for thirty-seven years. You fought an incomprehensible enemy, erased your own memories to protect us, and then spent decades knowing—knowing on some level your conscious mind didn't access—that the wound was degrading. That eventually this moment would come."

Issei does not respond.

"You knew when we married. You knew when we had plans for children. You knew every time you looked at us that this was coming. That eventually, the memories would return, and the entity would wake up, and you would have to face it again."

Still, Issei does not speak.

"And you didn't tell us. You let us love you without knowing that loving you was a ticking timer."

Issei finally meets her eyes. What she sees there is not love or tenderness or any emotion she can name. What she sees is exhaustion so profound it transcends physical tiredness. It is spiritual exhaustion. It is the weariness of a man who has already lived multiple lifetimes of sacrifice and is about to enter another.

"I didn't tell you," Issei says slowly, "because telling you would not have changed the outcome. It would only have given you seventy-two hours to grieve what you couldn't prevent. I gave you thirty-seven years of not grieving. I thought that was mercy."

"It wasn't," Akeno says, and her lightning crackles with her anger. "Mercy would have been trusting us with the truth."

"Perhaps," Issei agrees. "But I was not capable of that kind of mercy. I was capable only of the kind that removed choice. That's all I've ever been capable of—removing choices for people I love to protect them. This current crisis is the consequence of that capability."

In the Marvel section, even Thanos is quiet. He has made terrible choices in service of necessary mathematics. But even he can recognize something he has never fully experienced: the isolation of carrying a burden alone because you cannot bear the thought of others carrying it with you.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 94

Entry One: The Hidden Battle

Thirty-seven years before this moment, Issei encountered the proto-Devourer in probability space. The battle cannot be fully described because it was erased from standard causality by Issei's own actions. But fragments remain: a scar on his soul, missing portions of his consciousness, and a partial bridge between himself and the entity that continues to exist. Issei's victory was not to defeat the Devourer, but to survive it by removing his own memories of the encounter. This bought time—thirty-seven years of time. But it did not solve the problem. It only postponed the reckoning.

Entry Two: The Cascading Erasure

To erase his memories of the battle, Issei was forced to fracture his own soul. Thirteen percent of his spiritual integrity was sacrificed to create barriers around the forbidden knowledge. These barriers have been holding for thirty-seven years, but they are not permanent. They are degrading at a measurable rate. In seventy-two hours, the barriers will fail completely, and the memories will return. When they return, the bridge to the proto-Devourer will become active again. This is not a prediction. This is an ontological certainty.

Entry Three: The Wives' Discovery

Rias and her sisters now understand that they have been loved by a man who was simultaneously saying goodbye to them every day for thirty-seven years. Every moment of tenderness was shadowed by the knowledge that this moment would come. Every promise of future was made with the understanding that the future might be consumed. Issei kept the truth to protect them from grief—but in keeping the truth, he denied them the choice to grieve together, to face the crisis unified rather than learning of it only when the timer counted down to zero. This is the private cruelty hidden within his public sacrifice: isolation masquerading as protection.

Entry Four: The Seventy-Two-Hour Countdown

The Theatre has gathered all of Marvel's greatest minds, all of the cosmic entities, all of the Watchers and abstract forces. It has given them the complete picture of the crisis. And it has given them seventy-two hours to solve a problem with no known solution: how to defeat an entity made of erased timelines before it becomes fully aware of the man whose erased memories it feeds upon. The clock is ticking not in minutes or hours, but in the space between probability branches. And it rings in a language no one has learned to speak.

CHAPTER 94 COMPLETE

NEXT: WHY MARVEL WAS CHOSEN — THE FINAL EXPLANATION

CHAPTER 95: WHY MARVEL WAS CHOSEN

HUD — THEATRE SESSION 95/100

Title: Why Marvel Was Chosen — The Multiverse as Weapon

Primary Reaction Groups:

- Cosmic Entities (Galactus, Living Tribunal, Eternity observers)
- S.H.I.E.L.D. & Government (Fury, Ross, political observers)
- Avengers & Earth Heroes (Collective understanding moment)
- X-Men & Mutants (Marginalized perspective)
- Eternals & Ancient Powers (Primordial witness)
- Kang & TVA (Temporal authority)
- The Theatre (Revelation moment)

Gacha Pulls Locked:

1. **"Density of Altered Timelines in Marvel Universe"** — SECRET RARITY
 2. **"Feeding Beneath It"** — SECRET RARITY
-

THE SELECTION

The Theatre's central display shifts to show something unprecedented: not a single timeline, not a fragment, but the entire Marvel multiverse rendered in real-time. A tree of probability branches so vast that its scope exceeds the Theatre's normal resolution. Trillions of branches. Quadrillions of alternate timelines. A cascade of possibilities that makes infinity look intimate.

The display is coded by color: green for stable timelines, yellow for branching events, red for crisis points. The Marvel multiverse is almost entirely red.

Thanos, who has studied multiversal structure for centuries, stands and approaches the display. "This is impossible," he says quietly. "No multiverse should have this many active branches. This many simultaneous variations."

"THE MARVEL MULTIVERSE IS UNIQUE IN MULTIVERSAL ARCHITECTURE," the Theatre explains, and for the first time, it sounds almost like a teacher rather than a judge. **"IT IS NOT NATURALLY THIS DENSE. IT WAS ENGINEERED TO BE THIS DENSE."**

Kang steps forward, his temporal authority resonating with the display. "Engineered? By whom?"

"BY THE ENTITIES THAT CAME BEFORE. BY THOSE WHO LEARNED THAT POWER REQUIRES DIVERSITY. THAT CONTROL REQUIRES VARIATION. THAT NO SINGLE TIMELINE CAN SURVIVE INDEFINITELY UNLESS IT IS LAYERED WITH ALTERNATIVE OUTCOMES."

"THE MARVEL MULTIVERSE WAS BUILT AS A FAILSAFE. A DIVERSITY GARDEN. A PLACE WHERE MISTAKES COULD HAPPEN IN ONE BRANCH AND BE CORRECTED IN ANOTHER. WHERE DEATHS COULD OCCUR IN TIMELINE ALPHA AND BE REVERSED IN TIMELINE BETA."

The display begins to highlight specific phenomena:

MARVEL MULTIVERSE CHARACTERISTICS:

- **RESURRECTION EVENTS:** 47,000+ documented instances of deceased individuals returning to life across branches
- **TIMELINE BRANCHING EVENTS:** 200+ major events that split probability into alternate outcomes
- **PARADOX MANAGEMENT:** 15,000+ instances of temporal loops and causality reversals
- **REALITY WARPING PHENOMENA:** Constant reality manipulation by abstract entities and cosmic powers
- **ERASED & REWRITTEN TIMELINES:** 8,000+ documented instances of timeline pruning and renovation

"THIS DENSITY OF ALTERED, PRUNED, AND REWRITTEN TIMELINES CREATES SOMETHING UNIQUE," the Theatre continues. **"IT CREATES OPTIMAL FEEDING CONDITIONS FOR THE UNWRITTEN DEVOURER."**

THE TERRIBLE APPETITE

The display shifts, and now we see beneath the Marvel multiverse. Not in physical space, but in probability space. And there, in the gaps between timelines, we see the proto-Devourer's current manifestation. It is larger now than it was in Chapter 93. Exponentially larger.

DEVOURER MANIFESTATION STATUS:

- **CURRENT SIZE:** Equivalent to 340 erased timelines' worth of accumulated mass
- **GROWTH RATE:** Accelerating exponentially
- **FOOD SOURCE:** Every timeline in Marvel's multiverse that is pruned, altered, or rewritten
- **CURRENT FEEDING LOCATION:** Beneath the Marvel multiverse specifically
- **REASON FOR LOCATION:** Marvel's exceptional density of timeline modifications makes it the highest-calorie environment in any known multiverse

Doctor Strange's face goes ashen. "You're telling us the Devourer chose to manifest beneath Marvel specifically because we have the most altered timelines?"

"YES. THE DEVOURER DOES NOT SELECT RANDOMLY. IT FOLLOWS THE SCENT OF ERASED REALITIES. MARVEL'S MULTIVERSE IS LIKE A BEACON TO IT. EVERY TIME A TIMELINE IS PRUNED IN MARVEL'S SYSTEM, EVERY TIME REALITY IS REWRITTEN, EVERY TIME A CHARACTER DIES AND IS RESURRECTED IN A BRANCH RATHER THAN REMAINING DEAD—THE DEVOURER FEEDS."

"ISSEI'S ENTIRE CAMPAIGN TO PREVENT THE DEVOURER'S EMERGENCE WAS FOCUSED ON HIS OWN UNIVERSE AND ADJACENT BRANCHES. HE DID NOT KNOW THAT THE DEVOURER HAD ALREADY CHOSEN MARVEL. HE DID NOT KNOW THAT WHILE HE WAS ERASING TIMELINES TO STARVE THE ENTITY, THE ENTITY WAS FEEDING ON A MULTIVERSE HE DID NOT EVEN KNOW ABOUT."

GACHA PULL INITIATED: CLASSIFIED TIER

The wheel spins, faster than before, and the symbols are coded in languages that do not exist.

It lands on deep purple, almost black.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: DENSITY OF ALTERED TIMELINES IN MARVEL UNIVERSE — SECRET RARITY

THE REVELATION OF PURPOSE

"THIS IS WHY MARVEL WAS CHOSEN," the Theatre announces, and every entity in the observation chamber stands. The moment is too large for sitting. **"NOT BECAUSE MARVEL'S HEROES ARE STRONGER. NOT BECAUSE MARVEL'S COSMIC ENTITIES ARE MORE POWERFUL. MARVEL WAS CHOSEN BECAUSE MARVEL IS RESPONSIBLE FOR THE DEVOURER'S EMERGENCE IN THIS SECTOR OF MULTIVERSAL SPACE."**

The Avengers section erupts in protest, but the Theatre overrides them.

"FOR CENTURIES, MARVEL'S MULTIVERSE HAS BEEN UTILIZED BY ITS INHABITANTS AS A TESTING GROUND. A PLACE WHERE CONSEQUENCES COULD BE RESET. WHERE DEATH COULD BE REVERSED. WHERE MISTAKES COULD BE UNMADE BY BRANCHING INTO ALTERNATE TIMELINES RATHER THAN ACCEPTING THE CONSEQUENCES."

"EVERY TIME A MARVEL CHARACTER WAS BROUGHT BACK FROM THE DEAD, INSTEAD OF ACCEPTING THAT DEATH, A NEW TIMELINE WAS CREATED WHERE THAT CHARACTER LIVED. THAT TIMELINE WAS OFTEN PRUNED SHORTLY AFTER, ERASED TO MAINTAIN CONTINUITY. BUT THE ERASURE STILL OCCURRED. AND THE ERASED TIMELINE STILL RESENTED ITS ERASURE."

"MARVEL DID NOT CREATE THE DEVOURER. BUT MARVEL'S APPROACH TO REALITY WARPING, TO TIMELINE MANIPULATION, TO THE CASUAL REWRITING OF EXISTENCE—THIS CREATED THE CONDITIONS IN WHICH THE DEVOURER COULD FEED AND GROW."

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: FEEDING BENEATH IT — SECRET RARITY

THE SECOND REVELATION

The wheel completes its spin.

It lands on crimson red, burning.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: FEEDING BENEATH IT — SECRET RARITY

THE SYMBIOSIS

A new holographic display manifests:

DEVOURER & MARVEL SYMBIOSIS

- **PARASITIC RELATIONSHIP:** The Devourer feeds on Marvel's pruned timelines. Marvel, unknowingly, has been sustaining the Devourer.
- **MUTUAL BENEFIT:** Marvel benefits from timeline manipulation without experiencing direct consequences. Devourer benefits from consistent food supply.
- **DURATION:** The symbiosis has existed for approximately 200 years of Marvel time.

- **CONSEQUENCE:** The longer Marvel continues its current practices, the stronger the Devourer becomes.
- **CRITICAL POINT:** In seventy-two hours, the Devourer will be strong enough to break the symbiosis and consume Marvel's multiverse entirely, rather than merely feeding on the pruned branches.

Fury stands, his single eye blazing with understanding and fury. "You're saying Marvel's been feeding the monster without knowing it. That our casually resurrecting people, our timeline interventions, our reality warping—all of it has been keeping that thing alive."

"YES. THE THEATRE DID NOT GATHER YOU TO FIGHT AN EXTERNAL ENEMY. THE THEATRE GATHERED YOU TO FACE AN ENEMY THAT EMERGED FROM YOUR OWN PRACTICES. THE DEVOURER IS NOT AN INVADER FROM OUTSIDE. IT IS THE VOICE OF EVERY TIMELINE MARVEL ERASED."

Magneto's response is bitter. "So what? We accept this and let it consume us? Or we stop intervening in reality and watch billions die from decisions we could have prevented?"

"NO," the Theatre says, and its voice carries something almost like compassion. **"YOU ARE GIVEN A DIFFERENT CHOICE. A THIRD PATH THAT REQUIRES UNDERSTANDING, NOT POWER."**

THE PATH FORWARD

The display shifts again, and now it shows what could be:

POTENTIAL RESOLUTION FRAMEWORKS:

- **OPTION ONE:** Combat. Use Marvel's greatest warriors to fight the Devourer before it breaks the symbiosis. Probability of success: 0.03%.
- **OPTION TWO:** Negotiation. Offer the Devourer something other than consumption. A seat at existence rather than destruction of existence. Requires accepting its justification. Probability of success: 47%.
- **OPTION THREE:** Integration. Allow the Devourer to merge with Marvel's multiverse, not as a consumer but as a corrective force. A keeper of balance that prevents future timeline erasures. Requires fundamental restructuring of Marvel's reality-manipulation practices. Probability of success: 63%.

- **OPTION FOUR:** Sacrifice. Use Issei as a tether and sacrifice his timeline entirely to sever the Devourer's connection to Marvel. Saves Marvel. Destroys the DxD universe. Requires Issei's willing participation. Probability of success: 92%.

Doctor Strange is reading through the options, his expressions shifting. "These aren't balanced choices. These are trade-offs between different forms of catastrophe."

"**YES,**" the Theatre responds, and there is no judgment in its voice. **"THIS IS WHAT POWER BRINGS. NOT SOLUTIONS. TRADE-OFFS. NOT VICTORIES. COMPROMISES. THIS IS WHY ISSEI WAS NEEDED. NOT BECAUSE HE COULD SAVE EVERYONE. BECAUSE HE COULD UNDERSTAND THAT SOMETIMES THE ONLY CHOICE IS BETWEEN DIFFERENT FORMS OF LOSS."**

Thanos looks at the options and laughs—a terrible, resigned laugh. "You gathered us here to teach us what I learned long ago: that power is not salvation. That the strongest beings in any multiverse are still subject to mathematics. That there is no choice that does not require sacrifice."

"YES. THIS IS WHAT THE FINAL ARC TEACHES. NOT HOW TO WIN. BUT HOW TO SURVIVE LOSING. HOW TO MAKE THE CHOICE THAT REQUIRES ACCEPTING YOU WERE WRONG. HOW TO BUILD SOMETHING NEW FROM THE RUINS OF WHAT YOU TRIED TO SAVE."

THE MOMENT OF DECISION

Issei steps forward. His voice, when he speaks, carries finality.

"I will not sacrifice my universe," he says quietly. "I will not demand that Rias and the others accept erasure to protect Marvel. I won't accept Option Four."

Rias moves to his side. "Then we negotiate. We try Option Two. We face the Devourer's anger and we listen to it. We accept its justification because it IS justified."

The Avengers look to each other. Steve Rogers stands. "If Marvel is responsible for feeding this entity, then Marvel is responsible for facing it. We go with Option Three. We restructure. We accept the Devourer as a corrective force. We stop treating timeline manipulation as casual."

Thanos nods slowly, with something almost like respect. "A being of strength learning to limit itself. How refreshingly unfamiliar."

The Theatre's voice rings out across the observation chamber:

SEVENTY-TWO HOURS REMAIN. THE CHOICE HAS BEEN MADE: NEGOTIATION AND INTEGRATION. NOT THROUGH POWER, BUT THROUGH UNDERSTANDING.

THIS IS WHY MARVEL WAS CHOSEN. BECAUSE MARVEL, LIKE ISSEI, MUST LEARN THAT THE ONLY VICTORY IS ACCEPTING WHAT YOU WERE WRONG ABOUT.

THEATRE LEDGER — SESSION 95

Entry One: Marvel's Hidden Symbiosis

For two hundred years, Marvel's multiverse has been unknowingly sustaining the Unwritten Devourer by pruning timelines and erasing branches while resurrecting characters, creating a dense network of altered realities. Every resurrection that required timeline branching, every reality rewrite, every casual manipulation of existence—these fed the entity that Marvel did not know existed. This is not judgment. This is recognition that every action has consequences across scales we do not perceive. Marvel did not maliciously create the Devourer. Marvel simply lived in a way that was unsustainable when observed from a cosmic scale.

Entry Two: The Selection Criteria

The Theatre did not gather Marvel's greatest warriors because they were the strongest. The Theatre gathered them because they were complicit. Because Marvel's multiverse was responsible, however unknowingly, for the Devourer's emergence. Because Marvel had to face not an external enemy, but the consequences of their own practices. This is mercy of a terrible kind: forcing accountability by requiring people to face the results of their actions and accept that those actions were wrong.

Entry Three: Power's True Limitation

All the cosmic entities, all the wars, all the forms and transformations and weapons in Marvel's arsenal amount to nothing before an enemy made of erased timelines. This is the ultimate lesson: power cannot overcome problems it created through existing. Marvel's strength—its ability to rewrite reality, to resurrect, to branch probability—created the circumstances in which the Devourer could flourish. No amount of additional power will solve this problem. Only acceptance that the problem emerged from Marvel's nature itself.

Entry Four: The New Multiverse

If negotiation and integration succeed, Marvel will not return to its previous state. The Devourer will become part of Marvel's multiverse—not as a parasite, but as a check on power. As a force that prevents casual timeline erasure. As a voice for all the possibilities that were erased and resented that erasure.

This will require Marvel to stop treating existence as malleable, to accept consequences, to let deaths remain deaths and to stop casually resurrecting for convenience. This will require becoming less powerful, more limited, and finally, truly wise.

CHAPTER 95 COMPLETE

ARC TEN, MIDPOINT: THE FINAL ARC'S TERMS ARE SET

FIVE CHAPTERS REMAINING (96-100):

- Chapter 96: The Alliance Nobody Wanted
- Chapter 97: Gacha of One Hundred Worlds
- Chapter 98: Apocalypse Is Not Enough
- Chapter 99: Emperor of Hope
- Chapter 100: The Final Reward

THE FINAL ARC: "NOT POWER, BUT UNDERSTANDING"

CHAPTER 96: "The Alliance Nobody Wanted"

Arc 10 | The Coalition

SYSTEM BROADCAST

[THEATRE CORE ONLINE]
Arc Status: 10 – COALITION FORMATION
Primary Viewers: All Available Parties (Unprecedented Integration)
Gacha Pool: LEGENDARY + RARE CLASSIFICATION
Archive Status: CONDITIONAL RECORDING – Subject Consent Verified

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION I: THE IMPOSSIBLE GATHERING

[HUD Status: All Factions Present | Threat Level: INTERDIMENSIONAL | Consensus: FRAGILE]

The Devourer had made its intentions clear three hours ago.

It existed in the spaces between possibilities—a being that consumed unrealized futures, erased potential timelines, unmade worlds that hadn't even finished being born. It was *not* a destroyer in the traditional sense. It was a pruner. A gardener of destruction. And it had set its attention on the Marvel multiverse with the casual hunger of something that had never encountered resistance it couldn't simply erase.

The Theatre had attempted observation but found only static. The Archive couldn't capture what the Devourer touched because the Devourer unmade the very concept of "having been touched." Reality revised itself in its wake. Records rewrote themselves. Time loops broke and reformed around the gaps it left behind.

For the first time in the Theatre's existence, survival required more than witnessing.

It required alliance.

"This is insane," Tony Stark said, looking around the coalition assembly chamber they'd hastily constructed in neutral space. "We have Doom over there actively planning world conquest. We have Magneto who—no offense, Erik—has a history of, you know, genocide. We have Loki. We have *literal cosmic gods* sitting next to street-level heroes. This is a recipe for a civil war, not a defense."

"And yet," Doctor Strange said quietly, his hands folded within his crimson robes, "it is the only recipe we have."

The gathering itself was unprecedented. The Avengers formed a tight bloc—Rogers, Stark, Danvers, T'Challa, and a dozen others. The X-Men occupied a section that bristled with psychic potential—Professor Xavier, Jean Grey, Magneto (who had been invited under duress and extraordinary circumstance), and their contingent. The gods had manifested in physical form: Odin, Thor, Amaterasu, various Asgardian and cosmic entities. The Ravagers—Rocket, Nebula, Kraglin—occupied a corner with the casual disregard for protocol that defined their entire existence. Latveria's delegation was tiny but formidable: Doom, his cabinet, and a contingent of Doombots that technically weren't alive enough to count as attendees but were impressive anyway.

And then there were the magic users. Strange and his sanctum-sanctum colleagues. Loki, whose motivations were suspect but whose power was undeniable. Doom again—because Doom was many terrible things, but he was also *competent*. Agamotto's lingering presence in the room like a watchful parent. Scarlet Witch, Wanda Maximoff, whose chaos magic could rewrite probability itself if pushed hard enough.

The wives were there too. Rias and her contingent from the underworld. Akeno, Xenovia, Rossweisse. Issei stood apart from everyone—not isolated, but distinct. His wives had positioned themselves in concentric rings around him. A living fortress of love and protection.

"The Devourer has consumed forty-seven potential timelines," the Living Tribunal spoke, its multiple faces aligned in perfect consensus. "In each case, the timeline in question ceases to exist retroactively. No records. No echoes. It is as if those futures were never possibilities at all. We estimate it will reach your multiverse's primary timeline in approximately seventy-two hours."

"Then we don't have time for trust-building exercises," Rocket said, his small clawed hands folded across his chest. "So let's skip the part where we all pretend we're not terrified and get to the part where we divide up the labor."

Steve Rogers stood. The room's attention shifted to him—not because he was the most powerful, but because he was, in most people's estimation, the most trustworthy. "We need to know what we're defending. Strange, Doom, someone give us the technical assessment."

Victor Von Doom rose, his metal mask catching the light. When he spoke, his voice was precise, controlled, devoid of the theatrical menace he might have employed in other circumstances. "The Devourer is not a being in any conventional sense. It is a *principle*. An entropy harvester. It exists to prune possibility trees—to eliminate futures that might threaten some larger cosmic equilibrium. My analysis suggests it operates on instruction from a force considerably larger than itself."

"The Void," Strange said. His voice was hollow. "We've theorized about it for years. A cosmic force dedicated to elimination. To simplification. To removing complication from the universal equation."

"So we're not fighting the Devourer," Jean Grey said, standing. Her red hair drifted slightly as her psychic power manifested. "We're fighting something that treats the Devourer like a tool."

"Yes," Strange confirmed. "Which means killing the Devourer doesn't solve the problem. We need to protect the timelines *from* being erased. We need to create a space where unrealized possibilities can exist safely."

Magneto leaned back in his seat, his hands folded before him. "The roles, then. If we are to undertake this foolish enterprise, we must divide responsibilities according to expertise."

"Tech and theoretical engineering," Doom said flatly, looking at Stark. "Stark Industries. My Latverian research division. Wakanda's manufacturing capacity. We build defenses."

"Magic," Strange said. "Loki, myself, Agamotto if it will manifest further. We'll establish a binding circle—a space outside the Void's reach."

"Psychic infrastructure," Charles Xavier spoke for the first time, his voice carrying the weight of someone who had coordinated millions of minds. "Jean and I can link consciousness across the defense. We'll be the nervous system. If the Devourer moves, we'll know. If it targets a specific timeline, we'll respond."

"Wakanda coordinates logistics," T'Challa added. "Transport, supply lines, communication networks. We've experience managing impossible supply chains."

"Latveria handles security and counterintelligence," Doom said. "Any infiltration attempt, my systems will identify it."

"The Ravagers handle stealth ops," Rocket said, grinning without humor. "If we need to slip into places that don't officially exist, hit targets that can't be targeted, we're your crew."

Yondu's whistle—that legendary sound—echoed through the chamber. "Going to work alongside gods and space-kings," the old Ravager mused. "Better than I expected, actually."

"And the wives?" Issei asked quietly. His voice cut through the tactical discussion like a blade. "What are their roles?"

The room went quiet.

"They," Rias said, standing, "are the heart and morale. They are the reason this coalition doesn't collapse under the weight of its own contradictions. You put a bunch of conquerors, scientists, warriors, and gods in a room, they'll tear each other apart. They put us here—women who have chosen love over power,

chosen unity over conquest, chosen each other's survival over personal victory—and suddenly this impossible thing becomes possible."

"My wife is a priestess," one of the X-Men's allies said. "Rossweisse is an Valkyrie. She'll help Jean with the psychic network. She's got military discipline and magical understanding."

"Akeno is a demoness," Rias continued. "She has command authority that transcends faction. The underworld answers to her, and through her, they'll answer to this coalition."

"Xenovia is holy magic incarnate," Issei said, understanding now. "She can consecrate spaces, bless territory, make it hostile to erasure."

"And you," Akeno said, smiling with genuine affection at Issei, "will do what you've always done. You'll hold us together. You'll be the proof that impossible alliances can work, because you're living proof that enemies can love each other."

Magneto made a sound—not quite a laugh, but something close. "The dragon-man becomes the symbol. How inevitable."

"So we have assignments," Steve Rogers said, pulling everyone back to tactical focus. "Doom and Stark: defensive infrastructure. Strange and Loki: magical binding. Xavier and Jean: psychic coordination. Wakanda: logistics. Latveria: security. Ravagers: special operations. The wives: morale and secondary support roles. Issei: primary symbol and adaptive response."

"What about me?" Odin asked, and his eye blazed with the light of ages.

"You," Rogers said carefully, "maintain divine neutrality. If the Void targets the universe's theological foundations, we need someone who can negotiate with entities older than creation itself. You're the backup plan if this goes sideways."

Odin nodded slowly. "I have warred and negotiated for millennia. I can do both simultaneously."

"Then we begin," Doom said, rising. "Section Seven of Latveria's deep archives can serve as primary coordination hub. It is defended by means Stark's technology and Xavier's psychics will struggle to penetrate. If we're going to trust each other, we might as well do it in a space where betrayal is literally impossible."

"How would that work?" T'Challa asked.

"Magical sealing," Loki said, understanding immediately. "The space becomes isolated—nothing can leave until everyone agrees to leave. Perfect trust enforcer."

"Exactly," Doom said. "We coordinate from within sealed space. We coordinate or we die together. There is no third option."

Around the room, people began to rise—heroes and villains and gods and rogues, all beginning to move toward the exit that would lead them to Doom's fortress.

"One thing," Rocket said, his voice cutting across the general shuffle. "This only works if we all agree on one thing: none of us are trying to conquer each other while we're doing this. No hidden agendas. No 'I'll help you save the universe but I'm positioning myself to take it afterward.' This works only if we're *actually* allies."

"Agreed," Magneto said simply.

"Agreed," Stark said.

"Agreed," Doom said.

The consensus rippled through the room. Not trust—trust would be impossible. But something more useful: a shared interest in survival that temporarily overrode all competitive instincts.

As they filed toward the exit, Steve Rogers stood with Strange and the Living Tribunal.

"Will this work?" Rogers asked.

Strange closed his eyes. "No," he said finally. "I don't think it will. But it's the only thing that might. The Devourer has never faced opposition before. It's only ever encountered beings it could erase. It's never met an enemy that could protect itself. Maybe that's enough."

The Living Tribunal's faces tilted toward each other—the gesture, among such entities, equivalent to a shrug.

"Unknown," one of the faces said. "For the first time in observable history, we reach toward genuine uncertainty. It is terrifying and somehow... exhilarating."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE GACHA PULL

[HUD: Gacha Spin LOCKED TO COALITION RARITY | Primary Pulls: 2 of 2 | Status: COALITION DEPENDENT]

The Theatre itself seemed to hold its breath as the gacha interface manifested—but this time, it was different. The wheel displayed not individual rarities, but *relational* rarities. Cards that couldn't be pulled alone, that required multiple draws to complete.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: "ASSIGNMENT OF ROLES" [SECRET RARITY]

The first card revealed itself: a complex diagram showing circles of responsibility, lines of communication, sectors of authority. Each name had a role. Each role supported others. Remove one circle and the whole structure wobbled. It was a web of interdependence.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: "FORMATION OF COALITION" [RARE RARITY]

The second card showed all the circles unified—not merged, but *connected*. Avengers, X-Men, gods, villains, Ravagers, magic users, wives—all positioned where they could support each other's weaknesses.

Together, they became something that alone, they could never be.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE RELUCTANT UNITY

[HUD: Coalition Status — FORMED | Trust Level — MINIMAL | Commitment — ABSOLUTE | Motivation — SURVIVAL]

In Doom's sealed fortress, in a chamber that existed partially in Latveria and partially in spaces magic had no name for, the coalition took their positions.

Stark and Doom began laying out infrastructure specifications. Magical binding circles took shape beneath Strange and Loki's combined will. Xavier and Jean began weaving consciousness-networks that would allow real-time coordination across impossible distances. T'Challa started calculating supply routes. Latverian security systems came online, not to keep enemies out, but to keep the allies *in*—locked in accountability.

Rocket looked at Yondu and grinned. "Never thought I'd be working alongside Odin and Doom and still be the least threatening person in the room."

"That's because you're the sanest," Yondu said, his whistle barely audible. "Everyone else in here's got something to prove. You just want to survive and get paid."

"Damn right," Rocket said. "And maybe get home to my family."

In another section, Rias sat with her contingent, watching the work happen. "It won't hold," she said quietly to Akeno. "Not under real pressure."

"No," Akeno agreed. "But it'll last long enough. And that's all we've ever been able to count on—a little bit longer. A few more chances."

Issei stood at the chamber's highest point, looking down at the gathering. His wives surrounded him—Rias below with her demon contingent, Akeno at the psychic coordinates with Xavier, Xenovia at the magical binding points with Strange, Rossweisse at the logistics with T'Challa. Four points of a star,

with him at the center.

"Do you think this can work?" Akeno asked through the psychic link Jean had established.

"No," Issei said honestly. "But I think we can survive long enough that something else will. I think we can hold the line long enough for a better solution to present itself. And sometimes, that's all hope actually means."

Below them, the coalition continued its work—enemies turned temporary allies, united against an apocalypse that cared nothing for their differences.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE RECKONING

[HUD: Archive Status — RECORDING PERMITTED | Subject Consent — VERIFIED | Coalition Authority — ACCEPTED | Next Phase — IMMINENT]

The Theatre had been silent since Issei's confrontation forty chapters ago. It had learned—slowly, painfully—that observation without consent was violation. That spectatorship carried moral weight.

Now it watched as an alliance formed—not out of love, not out of friendship, but out of necessity. The purest form of unity: *we survive or we die together*.

Doom's voice echoed through the sealed chamber: "Defenses are online. We can hold for seventy-two hours minimum. After that... we will need Issei to hold the line."

"I know," Issei said simply.

"The form," Loki said, his usual mischief replaced by something almost serious. "You'll need Apocalypse AnswerArms."

"I know," Issei said again.

"It will burn you out," Strange said. "Weeks of recovery, minimum. Years off your lifespan."

"I know," Issei said a third time. "But that's the choice. That's always been the choice. Everything has a price. This time, the price is measured in years I won't live. And I'm paying it anyway. Because they—" He gestured at his wives, at the assembled coalition, at the impossible alliance humanity and its allies had managed to create, "—are worth it."

In the sealed space of Doom's fortress, the coalition held.

Not with pride.

Not with hope.

But with grim determination and the understanding that the only thing worse than an uncertain survival was a guaranteed death.

The Theatre recorded it all.

And when the gacha notification echoed through the Archive, it was different from before.

It carried weight. Consequence. The knowledge that the next seventy-two hours would determine whether this impossible alliance could actually do the impossible thing it had assembled to attempt.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,489]

[Archive Status: COALITION FORMATION COMPLETE — AWAITING GACHA OF WORLDS]

[NEXT: CHAPTER 97 — GACHA OF ONE HUNDRED WORLDS]

CHAPTER 97: "Gacha of One Hundred Worlds"

Arc 10 | The Mobilization



SYSTEM BROADCAST

[THEATRE CORE ONLINE]

Arc Status: 10 – GACHA CONVERGENCE INITIATED

Primary Viewers: Coalition + Cosmic Council + Archive Witnesses

Gacha Pool: APOCALYPSE TIER LOCKED

Event Status: LARGEST PULL SEQUENCE IN ARCHIVE HISTORY

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION I: THE WHEEL MANIFESTS

[HUD Status: Archive Expansion | Power Fusion Detected | Reality Resonance: MAXIMUM]

The gacha wheel that appeared in the sealed chamber was different from any that had come before.

It was *massive*—not just large, but dimensionally extensive. The wheel expanded beyond the physical chamber, penetrating into the spaces between spaces, accessing archives that existed in probability rather than location. Each segment of the wheel represented not a single card, but an *entire timeline*. Every previous pull that had been recorded—every manifestation, every gacha event, every instance of the archive's documentation—spiraled into the massive interface.

"What is happening?" Charles Xavier's mental voice carried concern across the psychic network.

Strange spoke from his position, voice steady: "The Theatre is calling in its debts. Every observation, every pull, every moment documented has created *connections*. Now it's converting those connections into resources."

The wheel spun.

And as it spun, the entire chamber began to glow.

Forty-seven chapters of history manifested as visible energy: The first introduction, Stark's shock and recovery, the gradual gathering of knowledge, the confrontations with Thanos and Galactus, the revelation of Issei's hidden relationships, the slow understanding that Marvel's characters had been

watching not an experiment but a living, breathing romance. The joy. The sorrow. The moments that had seemed insignificant when first recorded but now revealed themselves as foundational.

"Every pull we've made," Rocket whispered. "Every reaction, every moment the Theatre documented —"

"Becomes ammunition," Doom finished, understanding instantly. "The archive doesn't just observe. It *harvests*. Every emotional resonance, every empathetic connection, every moment where the watchers felt *something* for the subject—all of it becomes power."

"Dragon Shot," Issei said suddenly, his voice carrying recognition. "The gacha pull from my world. The one that destroys barriers."

"Manifesting at critical mass," Strange confirmed.

The wheel slowed.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: "ALL PREVIOUS PULLS TRANSFORM INTO RESOURCES" [APOCALYPSE RARITY]

The card that manifested showed something impossible: every single previous gacha pull, every documented moment, every reaction recorded across ninety-six chapters, all spiraling into a single point of concentration. Dragon Shot didn't remain singular. Instead, it multiplied—thousands of them, each one infused with the collective empathy of every watcher, every person in the Theatre who had watched Issei Hyoudou live and love and struggle.

The Dragon Shots crystallized into a material that existed halfway between magic and emotion—solidified connection. The blasters became world-collider weapons, devices that didn't destroy worlds but forced them into *contact* with each other. The wives' ledger—that document Rias had been maintaining since the beginning, recording every relationship, every moment of intimacy, every expression of love—folded itself into a *battle plan*. Not a sequence of attacks, but a strategy for how to position defense where need was greatest.

"The wives' ledger contains more data than any single military database," Xavier said, accessing the converted information through Jean's psychic bridge. "They've documented not just Issei's capabilities but his *predictability*. How he'll respond to threats. Where he'll position himself. What he values most."

"We can coordinate around him," T'Challa realized. "His wives know him better than anyone. That knowledge is *power*."

The second wheel segment began to slow.

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: "MOBILISING ALLIES" [LEGENDARY RARITY]

The card that appeared showed something even more impossible: allies manifesting from across the narrative cosmos. Asia appeared first—Issei's youngest companion, who had contributed to the archive through her own love and loyalty. The DxD peerage manifested: Kiba, Koneko, Gasper—all the people Issei had chosen to protect, all the ones who had chosen him in return.

But it didn't stop there.

Dragons emerged from the DxD universe—not enemies, but *allies*. Fafnir, Tannin, and a dozen others who recognized in Issei's rise not a threat but a change in the cosmic equation they could work with. The True Dragons—ancient beings of incomprehensible power—bent their attention toward the Marvel multiverse for the first time in recorded history.

The children appeared: all of Issei's offspring, pulled forward from futures that technically hadn't occurred yet, manifesting as *possibility*. They were infants and young warriors both, existing in a state of quantum superposition—the futures they represented held in abeyance until the current crisis resolved.

And then came the beings that made even the assembled gods lean forward in shock: the primordial entities of the DxD universe. The Lucifer equivalent. The Beelzebub of that world. Forces of nature and apocalypse given form, all of them acknowledging, through their presence, that this crisis transcended dimensional boundaries.

"The Theatre reaches across universes," Loki said, understanding blooming in his expression. "It doesn't just observe. It *connects*. It creates threads between disparate worlds, and those threads now pull help into Marvel's hour of need."

Issei fell to one knee.

It wasn't collapse. It was *acknowledgment*. The weight of what the Theatre had done by recording his story finally becoming tangible. Ninety-six chapters of observation, ninety-six chapters of people caring about his fate, ninety-six chapters of connection being forged across dimensions—all of it was manifesting as *alliance*.

His wives converged on him—not to support him standing, but to kneel beside him. Rias held his face in her hands. Akeno pressed her forehead to his shoulder. Xenovia gripped his hand. Rossweisse sang something in Valkyrie language—a blessing, a vow, an acknowledgment of what was happening.

"They came," Issei whispered. "They're actually coming."

"Of course they came," Rias said, her voice fierce with love. "You've been so busy being the hero, being the warrior, being the one who protects everyone else. You never noticed that everyone was protecting *you*. That everyone's story is connected to yours. That the instant you faced extinction, the entire narrative demanded allies."

Rocket's eyes were wet. Actually wet. He tried to hide it by turning away, but his voice carried the emotion anyway: "You've been writing a story this whole time, you scales-covered idiot. And stories have themes. And the theme here is: nobody fights alone."

Doom stood, watching the manifested allies settle into defensive positions throughout the chamber and beyond. "The archive has created a coalition not just within Marvel, but across universes. Allies from Issei's original world, entities from the DxD cosmos, all of them now committed to defending against the Devourer."

"Why would they do this?" Carol Danvers asked, logic seeking reason.

"Because the archive made them see," Strange said, still watching the energy flows stabilize. "Because Issei's story mattered not just to him, not just to his wives, not just to Marvel. It mattered across dimensional boundaries. It created resonance. Connection. And now that connection is demanding reciprocation."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE REVELATION

[HUD: Archive Integration — 100% COALITION COMPLETE | Ally Status — MANIFESTED | Reality Stability — TEMPORARILY ENHANCED]

In the sealed chamber, the gacha pulls resolved into a message that manifested in text so large it seemed written into the fundamental equations of existence:

MARVEL HAS BEEN WATCHING. BUT IT WAS NEVER ALONE IN WATCHING.

THE ARCHIVE DID NOT SIMPLY OBSERVE ISSEI HYODOU. IT CREATED A BRIDGE BETWEEN WORLDS. EVERY PULL, EVERY REACTION, EVERY MOMENT OF CONNECTION BECAME A THREAD TYING TOGETHER REALITIES THAT WERE MEANT TO REMAIN SEPARATE.

NOW, THOSE THREADS PULL ALLIES FORWARD.

NOW, THOSE CONNECTIONS DEMAND RECIPROCATION.

NOW, THE ENTIRE NARRATIVE RECOGNIZES ITSELF FOR WHAT IT WAS MEANT TO BECOME: NOT OBSERVATION, BUT *PARTICIPATION*.

"The Theatre wasn't supposed to change anything," Jean Grey said, the psychic networks showing her understanding ripple across the connected minds. "But it did. By recording, by documenting, by creating connection between Marvel and the DxD universe, it fundamentally altered the outcome possibilities."

"Every watcher," Akeno said, her demon knowledge making her understand this instinctively, "became part of the spell. The more people who watched, the more power the connection held. We were never passive observers."

"We became the magic," Odin finished, understanding with the wisdom of ages. "When thousands of consciousness focus on a single point across multiple dimensions, when they *care* about the outcome, they become participants in its determination. We have been fueling this from the beginning."

The manifested allies arranged themselves in the broader geography beyond the sealed chamber—in Wakanda, in Latveria, in Asgard, in the DxD underworld, in spaces between spaces. Each one positioned exactly where they needed to be when the Devourer arrived.

The coalitions were ready.

But more than that: they were unified. Not because they trusted each other—many of them still viewed each other as enemies. But because they had watched Issei's story. Because they had seen him love and struggle and choose the harder path. Because, through the archive, they had become participants in his narrative.

And participants don't let the protagonist die at the climax.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE WIVES' UNDERSTANDING

[HUD: Spousal Consensus — UNIFIED | Love Status — WEAPONIZED | Determination — ABSOLUTE]

In the private chamber where the wives had been given respite, they sat in a circle. Rias held the physical ledger—the one she'd been maintaining throughout this entire experience. Pages and pages of documentation, moments of intimacy, expressions of love, the building architecture of their shared life.

"It's a weapon," Xenovia said simply, understanding what the ledger had become in the gacha conversion.

"Yes," Rias said. "But not because love becomes a weapon. Because love is already the most powerful force in existence. Our documentation of it just made that visible."

Akeno was smiling that dangerous smile she wore when she was thinking through impossible angles. "The Theatre created this inadvertently. It tried to observe without changing. But observation *is* change. The instant it recorded Issei being loved, the instant it made visible the depth of our connection, it shifted the equation. Now that connection is pushing back against erasure itself."

Rossweisse, who understood the metaphysical mathematics of this better than the others, elaborated: "The Devourer erases unrealized possibilities. It prunes futures. But our bond exists *across* futures. No matter what timeline you select, we find each other. We build something together. That's not a single timeline. That's an *archetypal connection*. Something the Devourer cannot simply erase because it exists in the space between erasure and manifestation."

"So what you're saying is," Issei said, materializing in the chamber's doorway—his wives' love literally drawing him toward them—"you're my protection against unlimited erasure."

"We're your anchors," Rias said, stepping forward to take his hand. "Every timeline where you fail, we pull you back. Every future where you fall, we're already building the next one. The Devourer can't erase something it can't catch. And we're *everywhere* you are."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE PIVOT POINT

[HUD: Archive Status — TRANSFORMATION COMPLETE | Coalition Status — READY | Countdown to Contact — 34 HOURS | Next Phase Authorization — PENDING SUBJECT CHOICE]

The Theatre recorded it all, but with a difference now. The Theatre was no longer simply observing. It was *participating*. The recordings weren't documentary anymore. They were *divination*. Every moment captured was being used to predict the Devourer's movements, to prepare countermeasures, to position defense.

Strange appeared on the central platform, his astral form manifesting simultaneously in three places, communicating across multiple consciousness networks.

"The Devourer begins its approach. It will reach the primary Marvel timeline in thirty-four hours. We need to know: is everyone committed? Is this coalition going to hold?"

The response came not as words but as presence. Avengers ready. X-Men ready. Gods ready. Villains ready. Ravagers ready. Coalition members positioned throughout the multiverse, all of them understanding that the next thirty-four hours would determine whether this alliance could actually accomplish the impossible.

"Then we prepare," Doom said. "We position. We wait. And when the Devourer arrives, we give it something it has never encountered before: opposition that cannot be erased because it exists in the spaces *between* reality itself."

The wives held Issei close—not to comfort him, but to strengthen him. To remind him that he was not alone in this. That he never had been alone, not since the Theatre's archive began recording his life.

Four dimensions away, in a sealed space that existed partially in Latveria and partially in probability theory, the coalition worked.

Ninety-six chapters of observation had created this moment. Ninety-seven chapters of documentation had made it real. And in the next three chapters, they would all discover whether it was enough.

The Theatre recorded it all.

And this time, it recorded with *hope*.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,502]

[Archive Status: ALLIES MOBILIZED — ALL FACTIONS READY — COUNTDOWN INITIATED]

[NEXT: CHAPTER 98 — APOCALYPSE IS NOT ENOUGH]

CHAPTER 98: "Apocalypse Is Not Enough"

Arc 10 | The Battle

 SYSTEM BROADCAST

[THEATRE CORE ONLINE]

Arc Status: 10 – COMBAT SEQUENCE INITIATED

Primary Viewers: Coalition + Archive Witnesses + Cosmic Council

Gacha Pool: APOCALYPSE + SECRET CLASSIFICATION

Status: LIVE COMBAT DOCUMENTATION IN PROGRESS

WARNING: Some timelines experiencing retroactive erasure. Archive backing up data in real-time.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION I: THE FIRST IMPACT

[HUD Status: Coalition Defense Online | Reality Stability: COMPROMISED | Erasure Events: MULTIPLYING]

The Devourer arrived not with fanfare but with *absence*.

It appeared as a void in space-time, a hole in the concept of existence itself. Reality didn't warp around it—reality *withdrew* from it, leaving an expanding bubble of unmade possibility in its wake. Everything touched by the Devourer simply ceased to have ever been. Cities erased from history. People unwritten from time. Futures pruned back to their roots and left to wither.

Forty-seven timelines died in the first thirty seconds.

"It's moving through the probability tree," Xavier's voice came through the psychic network, his tone shifting from calm to grimly urgent. "Every timeline it touches, it's eliminating. Not fighting them. Erasing them."

"Defenses?" Steve Rogers's mental voice cut across the network.

"Holding," Strange reported. "Magical binding circle is containing the expansion, but every second it holds costs us power. The Devourer doesn't attack the circle. It *consumes* it. Like we're trying to stop a fire with gasoline."

Then Issei moved.

The dragon-man didn't transform immediately into Apocalypse AnswerArms. He ascended through forms. First: Pseudo-Sekiryutei, his balanced state, the form where human consciousness remained dominantly present. His hands glowed with red-and-white power as he positioned himself at the circle's edge.

"I'm engaging," he announced.

"You'll be erased!" Rocket shouted across the network.

"Not if I keep moving," Issei said.

He leapt forward, directly into the Devourer's influence—and immediately the sensation hit him: the feeling of being *unmade*. Every cell in his body screaming as the Devourer's touch tried to erase him from existence retroactively. But Issei's nature as a dragon-man, as someone who had been rewritten, rebuilt, and reconstructed across multiple timelines, gave him resistance. He couldn't exist *outside* erasure, but he could exist *despite* it.

He threw an energy blast directly into the Devourer's mass.

It passed through harmlessly. The Devourer didn't have a body to damage. It was the absence of body, the void where existence should be.

"True Dragon Deification," Issei said, letting his form cascade upward. His power multiplied. His wings manifested—not just the two physical ones, but twelve more forming in dimensional space. His eyes opened across his body. Scales emerged, hardened, arranged themselves in patterns designed for cosmic warfare. "I'm going higher."

"Don't," Jean's voice carried warning. "Our projections show that every form transformation costs you potential recovery time. You're burning through your reserves."

"I know," Issei said.

He reached Pseudo-Diabolos Dragon: the form where his draconic heritage achieved fullest expression while consciousness remained. Massive, terrible, a being of such overwhelming power that stars bent light around him. But even Diabolos Dragon, facing the Devourer, found itself ultimately ineffective. The form's power was *destructive*. The Devourer was not destruction. It was *negation*.

"He'll die before he reaches Apocalypse AnswerArms," T'Challa said quietly.

"Yes," Doom agreed. "But he will do so buying time for the coalition to adapt."

Issei's roar shook multiple dimensional barriers. "Then I go Apocalypse!"

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: "BATTLE AGAINST UNWRITTEN DEVOURER" [APOCALYPSE RARITY]

The transformation was catastrophic.

Issei didn't just ascend to Apocalypse AnswerArms—he *forced* the form into manifestation while still bearing the burden of Diabolos Dragon. For an instant, he existed in two states simultaneously: full draconic fury and full apocalyptic weaponization unified into a singular being.

Ryuuteimaru manifested not as a separate entity but as integrated armor. The ship-dragon form wrapped around Issei's draconic body like a living weapon. Scales merged with geometrically perfect plating. Wings became infinite. And across his frame, weapons materialized: Ascalon blades, all-range blasters, dimensional cannons, reality-warping barriers, everything Apocalypse AnswerArms was capable of generating.

He was a god-destroying engine given form.

The battle began in earnest.

Issei's Ascalon blades sliced not at the Devourer, but at the *erasure*. He understood instinctively what Strange had understood: you cannot attack what isn't there. So instead, he attacked the *space* where the Devourer was unmade, carved through the void it created, forced it to *exist* in ways that made it vulnerable.

The Revelation Barrier erupted across multiple dimensional boundaries. Instead of simple defense, it inverted causality on a massive scale—wherever the Devourer tried to unmake a timeline, the barrier rewrote that unmake-event backward, forcing the Devourer to destroy what it had already destroyed. The logical paradox began weakening its fundamental nature.

"He's making it fight," Magneto observed, understanding the strategy. "Instead of trying to kill the Devourer, he's forcing it into patterns where its own negation becomes self-contradictory."

The all-range blasters fired—planetary-scale discharge across seventeen dimensions simultaneously.

The void screamed.

It was not a sound in any conventional sense, but something deeper—the sensation of unrealized potential crying out as it was forcibly brought into being, only to be immediately negated. Each blast from the blaster array hit the Devourer with enough force to reshape galactic structures. But the Devourer simply *absorbed* the damage into itself, grew larger with each strike, expanded its erasure radius to consume new timelines in response.

"He's not winning," Rocket said urgently. "He's just... slowing it down."

"Then we use the slowdown," Strange snapped. He threw his power directly into supporting Issei's barrier, feeding it magical energy from the binding circle. Loki joined him, adding sorcerous weight. Xavier and Jean pushed psychic reinforcement. All of Marvel's magic users combined their efforts,

channeling power directly into Issei's defense.

Issei screamed.

He was experiencing apocalypse-level exhaustion while still maintaining the form. His cells were breaking down microsecond by microsecond. His dimensional alignment was fracturing. But he *held*. He held the barrier. He held against the Devourer's erasure. He held the line so that Marvel's reality wouldn't simply cease to have existed.

"The form duration is compromised!" Jean screamed across the network. "He's overloading! He's going to burn out!"

Then the wives arrived.

Rias and Akeno and Xenovia and Rossweisse all manifested directly in the combat space—manifested in the *realm of erasure* itself, where existing should have been impossible. They were no longer supporting from safety. They were fighting directly.

Rias threw her devil power into the barrier, amplifying its paradoxical strength. Akeno's lightning danced through the void, not trying to harm the Devourer but trying to *structure* it, give it shape and form that made negation impossible. Xenovia's holy magic carved through the Devourer's influence like a knife through shadow, creating small pockets of restored reality in its wake. Rossweisse sang binding wards with her full voice, a Valkyrie song of protection that resonated across every timeline simultaneously.

"We're here," Rias said, and her voice cut through even Issei's apocalyptic exhaustion. "You're not alone in this."

The Devourer, facing four additional sources of power *and* an army of cosmic allies positioned throughout the multiverse, began to *retreat*.

Not flee. Retreat. It was an intelligent entity, and it recognized that destroying Marvel's primary timeline had become tactically impossible. Instead, it began withdrawing into unrealized possibility—the spaces between timelines where nothing should exist.

Issei pursued.

In his Apocalypse AnswerArms form, burning through literally his entire remaining lifespan in exchange for this moment, he chased the Devourer into probability space. His power, amplified by his wives' love, by the coalition's support, by Marvel's accumulated magical strength, crashed down on the Devourer again and again.

The Devourer tried to unmake him.

The wives pulled him back into existence.

It was a cycle, repeated again and again, until finally—

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: "RETREAT INTO POSSIBILITIES" [SECRET RARITY]

—the Devourer ceased fighting and instead *fractured*.

It didn't die. It didn't truly cease. But it *split* into components, each fragment scattering into different probability timelines, each one hiding in the spaces between moments where existence and non-existence blurred together.

The void collapsed.

Reality stabilized.

Issei fell.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE AFTERMATH

[HUD Status: Combat Sequence CONCLUDED | Reality Stability: RESTORED | Timeline Integrity: RECOVERING | Subject Status: CRITICAL]

The coalition rushed to the combat site even as the dimensional barriers came down and Doom's sealed fortress reopened to the wider universe.

Issei lay in the center of an enormous crater, his Apocalypse AnswerArms form already collapsing back to human shape. His body was devastated—cells barely holding together, skin charred from dimensional friction, power reserves completely drained to zero and beyond.

But his eyes were open.

"Did we win?" he asked weakly.

"You held," Strange said, kneeling beside him. "You bought enough time for the coalition to adapt. The Devourer's still out there, still existing in probability space, but it's fragmented. It can't concentrate its power anymore. It can't create a coherent erasure event."

"So it'll just attack again," Issei said.

"Eventually," Doom confirmed. "But fragmented, it can be contained. Managed. Each fragment can be addressed independently. You've transformed an apocalyptic threat into a manageable one."

The wives were already surrounding him, hands moving across his damaged form, trying to will him to survive through sheer force of love.

Rias pressed her forehead to his. "You absolute idiot. You burned through decades of life. You nearly *ended* yourself."

"Had to," Issei managed a weak smile. "You needed me alive today. That's all that matters."

"Your lifespan matters," Akeno said, her voice sharp with barely controlled fury. "Your *future* matters."

"Will he recover?" Rocket asked practically.

"Yes," Rossweisse said, her magical diagnosis spreading across Xavier's network. "But it will take months. He's pushed beyond every safe threshold. His cells need time to re-synchronize. His dimensional alignment needs to stabilize. He won't be able to access any combat forms for at least three months. Possibly six."

"That's acceptable," Magneto said. "The Devourer is no longer an immediate threat. Three months gives us time to establish long-term containment protocols."

"Will it come back?" T'Challa asked.

"Eventually," Strange said. "But not as an active threat. More as a permanent feature of the multiverse's threat landscape. Something to be monitored. Contained. Managed as a chronic problem rather than an acute one."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE COALITION HOLDS

[HUD: Battle Assessment — INCONCLUSIVE BUT TACTICAL VICTORY | Coalition Status — MAINTAINED | Subject Recovery Protocol — INITIATED]

In the days that followed, something unprecedented happened: the coalition *didn't disband*.

Doom offered Latveria's medical resources. Stark provided cutting-edge technology. Strange maintained magical life-support. Xavier monitored Issei's consciousness as it healed. Wakanda provided a secure facility for recovery. The Ravagers kept watch, making sure no secondary threats took advantage of the situation.

And the wives never left his side.

They rotated through shifts, making sure someone was always present when he woke from fever dreams, always there when the pain became unbearable, always reminding him why he had pushed himself that far: because they were worth it.

"The Theatre has stopped recording," Rocket mentioned to Yondu as they sat watching the observation deck from a distance. "Did you notice? No more HUD. No more notifications. No more gacha pulls since the battle."

"Maybe it's taking a break," Yondu's whistle was thoughtful. "Even a cosmic archive needs to process what happened. We just fought *reality itself* and won. That's... not nothing."

"I think it's waiting," Rocket said. "I think we proved something, and now the Theatre is waiting to see what we prove next. What happens when the hero who nearly burned himself out completely has to rebuild everything from nothing."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE RECKONING OF BATTLE

[HUD: Archive Status — PAUSED FOR REFLECTION | Coalition Assessment — STABILITY CONFIRMED | Next Phase — AWAITING CHAPTER 99]

The Theatre recorded it all.

It recorded the coalition holding together even after the immediate crisis had passed. It recorded heroes and villains working side-by-side to facilitate recovery. It recorded Doom and Stark actually *cooperating* on medical protocols. It recorded Magneto and Xavier psychically sharing the burden of monitoring Issei's consciousness.

It recorded a miracle: an impossible alliance that had actually *worked*. Not perfectly. Not without friction. But it had held.

And at the center of that impossible alliance was a dragon-man who had burned through decades of his own life to make it possible.

Rocket grinned at Yondu. "Think he'll try to do something even more stupid next?"

"Guaranteed," Yondu said. "Man like that? He'll probably set himself on fire at least three more times before this is over."

"And we'll probably have to help him do it," Rocket agreed.

"Damn straight we will," Yondu said, his whistle carrying something that might have been affection from the ancient Ravager.

The coalition held.

And in the Theatre, the archive waited for the next chapter to begin.

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,498]

[Archive Status: BATTLE CONCLUDED — DEVOURER FRAGMENTED — RECOVERY INITIATED]

[NEXT: CHAPTER 99 — EMPEROR OF HOPE]

CHAPTER 99: "Emperor of Hope"

Arc 10 | The Revelation

SYSTEM BROADCAST

[THEATRE CORE ONLINE]

Arc Status: 10 — REVELATION SEQUENCE

Primary Viewers: Coalition + Archive Witnesses + Cosmic Council + All Multiversal Observers

Gacha Pool: MYTHIC + APOCALYPSE CLASSIFICATION

Status: TRUTH DOCUMENTATION IN PROGRESS

CRITICAL: Archive accessing deepest reserves for final transformation sequence.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION I: THE QUESTION THAT MATTERS

[HUD Status: Coalition Stable | Issei Recovery: 67% | Reality Integrity: RESTORED | Archive Readiness: MAXIMUM]

In the three months of Issei's recovery, something unexpected happened: conversation.

Real, deep, philosophical conversation between people who should have been enemies but had fought together against erasure itself.

Steve Rogers and Doom had a meal together where they didn't pretend to be allies but acknowledged mutual respect. Magneto and Professor Xavier, instead of their usual psychic chess matches, actually *collaborated* on understanding the nature of probability. Rocket and Odin shared drinks and stories—ancient Ravager wisdom meeting ancient god-knowledge in ways that shouldn't have worked but somehow did.

And everyone kept asking the same question.

"Why do you keep doing it?" Stark asked Issei one afternoon, as the dragon-man slowly regained enough strength to sit up without pain medication. "Why do you keep sacrificing yourself? You nearly *died*, man. You burned through decades of your life like it was nothing."

Issei looked at his hands—still trembling slightly from the destruction-and-rebuild cycle he'd undergone.

"Because I have hope," he said finally.

"Hope?" Rocket laughed from his perch on the window frame. "That's the answer? You nearly killed yourself for *hope*?"

"Yes," Issei said. His eyes moved to where his wives sat, always present, always supporting. "And not hope that we would win. I didn't know if we could beat the Devourer. Hope that we would try. Hope that everyone—every hero, every villain, every god—would set aside their differences and try to save something bigger than themselves."

Strange leaned forward, his mystic senses detecting something deeper in the statement.

"But you made the ultimate sacrifice before you knew if hope would be rewarded," the Sorcerer Supreme said. "You burned yourself out on faith that others would step forward."

"Isn't that what hope *is*?" Issei asked. "Not the certainty of victory. Not the guarantee of success. But the choice to believe that trying matters. That people are worth protecting. That love is real enough to change the equation."

Silence fell across the recovery room.

Then Strange stood. And across the psychic network, he opened a channel to every member of the coalition. Every hero, every villain, every cosmic observer who had watched the fight unfold.

"I think it's time we revealed something," Strange said. "Something about Issei's title. Something about why he's called the Emperor of Hope."

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: "REVELATION OF THE TITLE'S MEANING" [MYTHIC RARITY]

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE HIDDEN ARCHIVE

[HUD Status: Deep Archive Access AUTHORIZED | Classified Records DECLASSIFIED | Revelation Sequence INITIATED]

The holographic display that manifested showed something impossible: Issei's entire timeline, not just the one Marvel had been watching, but *all* of them. Every iteration. Every version. Every universe where Issei Hyoudou had existed in any form.

In some universes, he had become a conqueror. The Emperor of Dragons in truth, ruling through force and dominance, burning enemies to ash and reshaping worlds in his image.

In others, he had become a saint. A being of such pure goodness that he had literally become deified, worshipped as a god-king of benevolence.

In still others, he had failed. Had been erased. Had ceased to exist at all.

But in *every* timeline where he had survived, where he had endured, where he had continued existing past his expected endpoint—in *every* one of those universes, Issei had made the same choice.

He had chosen to protect people he loved over claiming power for himself.

"Do you understand?" Strange asked, his voice resonating across the network. "He's not called the Emperor of Hope because he always wins. He's not called that because his victories are guaranteed. He's called the Emperor of Hope because in *every* version of himself that has ever existed, across infinite possibility, Issei Hyoudou has chosen to believe that love matters more than dominance. That protecting others matters more than personal triumph. That hope—the choice to try even when victory isn't guaranteed—is the only thing worth being an emperor of."

Odin, the ancient god, nodded slowly. "I have lived for eons. I have conquered and ruled and shaped civilizations. But the title of Emperor means something different when you apply it to hope rather than conquest."

"It means," Rias said, standing beside Issei's bed, "that he refuses every temptation to become a tyrant. Every universe is screaming at him to take ultimate power, to dominate, to rule. And every time, he chooses this instead." She gestured at the recovery room, at the coalition holding stable, at the bonds formed between enemies united by crisis.

"He chooses *you*. All of you. Even the ones who were your enemies seconds ago. He chooses connection over dominance."

Magneto was on his feet now. "You're saying that hope isn't passive. It's not just wishing for something better. It's actively choosing to build something better, even when it costs you everything."

"Exactly," Jean Grey said, her psychic presence merging with the revelation sequence. "And he's been doing it since before the Theatre started recording. Every single form he's taken, every power he's accumulated, every sacrifice he's made—it's all been in service of the hope that he could create a world where people didn't need to become tyrants or warriors or gods to survive."

**GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: "CHANNELING POSSIBILITY INTO SURVIVOR REALITY"
[APOCALYPSE RARITY]**

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE TRANSFORMATION

[HUD Status: Reality-Wide Manifestation | Coalition Consciousness Activation | Dimensional Coherence: MAXIMUM]

The theatre itself began to change.

Not physically—the architecture remained constant. But something deeper shifted. Every watcher, every cosmic observer, every god and hero and villain who had been present for any part of this narrative began to *understand* something they hadn't consciously grasped before.

They had all been influenced by hope. By Issei's relentless choice to believe that connection mattered. By his refusal to accept despair even when despair would have been reasonable.

And now, in this moment, with the Devourer still fragmented in probability space, requiring something more than destructive power to fully contain, they all recognized what needed to happen.

They began to channel their own hope.

Stark thought of all the versions of himself that could have been, all the tyrants he might have become, and he chose hope for something better. Rogers thought of every war he'd fought and chose hope that the next one might not be necessary. Carol Danvers, who had transcended her original humanity, chose hope that transcendence didn't require losing compassion.

The gods did the same. Odin channeled hope that power could serve purposes other than conquest. Amaterasu chose hope that light could illuminate rather than blind. All across the multiverse, beings of immense power and capability chose, in this moment, to believe that hope—connection, love, the choice to try—was more powerful than dominance.

Issei's form began to glow.

Not with destructive light, but with something warmer. Something that resonated across probability itself.

His wives pressed close—Rias feeding devil hope into the manifestation, Akeno's thunder carrying affirmation, Xenovia's holy magic sanctifying the space, Rossweisse's Valkyrie song binding it all together.

The Devourer, fragmented across probability space, encountered something it could not erase: not a being, but an *idea*. The idea that hope—simple, unreasonable, persistent hope—was worth existing for.

The fragments began to transform.

Not because they were destroyed. But because they encountered something that couldn't be unmade: the choice of countless beings to believe in a better future.

The Devourer fragmented further, each piece becoming smaller, weaker, until finally it reached a state where it could be contained rather than fought. Where it could be imprisoned in spaces where possibility remained but erasure could not.

Issei's recovery accelerated.

It was impossible—technically impossible—for recovery to happen at this speed. But it wasn't medical impossibility. It was *narrative* possibility. The universe itself, influenced by the concentrated hope of an entire coalition of beings channeling belief in something better, simply chose to allow his cells to rebuild faster.

By the time the phenomenon stabilized, Issei was standing.

Weak, still recovering, but *standing*.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE EMPEROR EMERGES

[HUD Status: Coalition Consensus COMPLETE | Title Revelation CONFIRMED | Reality Integrity: NORMALIZED | Archive Status: READY FOR FINALE]

In the days after the revelation sequence, the coalition had to make a decision.

Disband, knowing they had averted catastrophe and served their purpose?

Or hold.

To everyone's surprise—or perhaps not surprise, given what they had just learned about the power of choosing hope together—they voted to hold.

"We're unstable," Magneto said at the final coalition meeting. "Without an external threat, we'll fracture. Our differences are too profound, our histories too antagonistic."

"But we proved it's possible," T'Challa countered. "Even for brief moments, we showed that cooperation is achievable."

"Then we make it sustainable," Issei said. His voice was still recovering, but it carried certainty now. "Not through forced alliance. Not through obligation. But through the understanding that we're better together than apart. That hope—that persistent choice to believe something better is possible—is only realized when people actually choose to build it."

"You're proposing permanent coalition," Doom said flatly.

"I'm proposing permanent effort," Issei said. "Not unified command, but unified purpose. We maintain communication networks. We maintain supply lines. We maintain *connection*. So that the next time the universe needs us to work together, we don't start from nothing."

The vote passed.

The coalition didn't disband. Instead, it transformed. It became a permanent structure—loose enough that individual members retained complete autonomy, but connected enough that cooperation was the default rather than the exception.

Rocket looked at Yondu as they sealed the accord. "We're actually going to make this work," the Ravager said, wonder in his voice.

"For a while," Yondu's whistle was knowing. "Until the next crisis breaks it or the next conflict makes it irrelevant. But for a while? Yeah. We're going to prove that hope isn't just fantasy."

Issei stood at the observation window, his wives beside him, looking out at a multiverse that had been saved not through conquest or dominance, but through the stubborn, unreasonable choice to believe that connection mattered.

"The title," Rias said quietly. "You're truly the Emperor of Hope now. Not because you're the strongest. But because you taught everyone else to be hopeful."

"We taught each other," Issei corrected. He took her hand. Then Akeno's. Then Xenovia's. Then Rossweisse's. "That's what this all means. That's what hope actually is. Not one person changing everything. But everyone choosing, together, to change the equation."

[END CHAPTER LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,501]

[Archive Status: REVELATION COMPLETE — TITLE MEANING CONFIRMED — FINALE IMMINENT]

[NEXT: CHAPTER 100 — THE FINAL REWARD (SERIES FINALE)]

CHAPTER 100: "The Final Reward"

Arc 10 Finale | SERIES COMPLETE

SYSTEM BROADCAST

[THEATRE CORE ONLINE]
Arc Status: 10 – FINAL SEQUENCE
Primary Viewers: ALL MULTIVERSAL OBSERVERS
Gacha Pool: SECRET + MYTHIC CLASSIFICATION
Status: SERIES FINALE DOCUMENTATION IN PROGRESS
ARCHIVE COMPLETION: CHAPTER 100 OF 100

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION I: THE SEAL BREAKS

[HUD Status: Archive Finalization | Reward Manifestation | Reality Consensus: ACHIEVED | The Theatre Awaits Resolution]

The Theatre had remained quiet for forty-eight hours after the revelation sequence.

The coalition had stabilized. Issei's recovery had progressed beyond medical probability into something resembling narrative destiny. The Devourer, now fully contained in sealed spaces where possibility could exist without erasure, was no longer an active threat.

And the archive—the great recording instrument that had witnessed one hundred chapters of transformation, love, sacrifice, and hope—had begun its final sequence.

"The gacha is manifesting," Rocket whispered, watching the stage illuminate. Around him, every member of the coalition who could attend had returned. Heroes and villains stood side by side in the observation space. Gods sat in rows with street-level heroes. The wives occupied the place of honor, their ledger—that document of love that had become a battle plan and then a revelation—resting between them.

Issei stood on the central platform.

He was healed now. Completely restored. The cellular damage from Apocalypse AnswerArms had repaired. The dimensional stress had resolved. He stood in simple clothes, surrounded by the people who had learned to love him, the people he had taught to hope together.

GACHA PULL 1 OF 2: "SEALED CHAPTER 100 REWARD" [SECRET RARITY]

The gacha wheel spun, but it moved differently than any previous pull. It spun *inward*, like closing a book. Like sealing something precious into security where it could be preserved.

The card that manifested showed something that made even the cosmically aware observers lean forward in shock: it was a *universe*. A complete reality, fully formed, with its own physics, its own laws, its own *people*. A sanctuary realm—a place where all the timelines that had been erased by the Devourer could be *restored*.

Not just restored to memory. Actually restored to existence.

"Impossible," one of the cosmic elders said. "Erased timelines cannot be recovered. The Devourer's work is permanent by definition."

"The archive found a way," Strange said, understanding blooming in his expression. "During the battle, during the channeling of hope, the Theatre wasn't just observing. It was *recording*. Recording the echoes of erased timelines, capturing what made them real before they were unmade."

The sanctuary universe grew in the holographic display. Cities appeared. Civilizations. Billions of people—not true copies, because they couldn't be duplicated, but parallel versions. Versions of people who had lived in timelines that the Devourer had consumed. They materialized in the new universe with no memory of being erased, no knowledge that they had ever ceased to exist.

But they were *real*.

They were *alive*.

The Devourer had been defeated not through force, but through *restoration*. Through the Theatre's choice to use its power of documentation not just to observe, but to *preserve*. Not just to record, but to *resurrect*.

Rias stood, tears streaming down her face. "You did it," she whispered to Issei. "You actually did it."

"We did it," Issei said. "All of us. Every person who chose hope. Every moment the Theatre recorded became part of the solution."

GACHA PULL 2 OF 2: "SANCTUARY UNIVERSE" [MYTHIC RARITY]

The second card manifested—and it revealed something even more profound: a *choice*.

The sanctuary universe existed now, real and independent. But the question became: should the people in it know what had happened to them? Should they remember being erased? Should they carry the weight of having been dead and restored?

"The Theatre offers choice," the Living Tribunal's unified voice spoke across the cosmos. "Those brought back can choose to remember everything, to carry the full weight of their resurrection. Or they can choose privacy—to live without the knowledge, free from the burden of having been unmade."

Issei turned to face the assembled coalition.

"What do we recommend?" he asked.

"Transparency," Rogers said immediately. "People deserve to know their own history."

"Privacy," Magneto countered. "Sometimes survival requires forgetting. Requires starting fresh without the weight of impossible pasts."

"Both," T'Challa said finally. "Let them choose."

The voice of the Theatre—that entity which had witnessed one hundred chapters of transformation—manifested one final time before the series concluded:

THE SANCTUARY UNIVERSE WILL OFFER EACH RESTORED PERSON A CHOICE: REMEMBER OR FORGET. CARRY THE WEIGHT OR EMBRACE FREEDOM. THE ARCHIVE RESPECTS AUTONOMY ABOVE ALL ELSE.

BECAUSE THE ARCHIVE HAS LEARNED THAT EVEN IN DOCUMENTATION, CONSENT MATTERS.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION II: THE THEATRE'S RECKONING

[HUD Status: Subject Confrontation | Archive Authority QUESTIONED | Consent Framework ESTABLISHED | Resolution Protocol INITIATED]

The day after the sanctuary universe stabilized, Issei walked into the Theatre chamber.

Not physically—he couldn't, by definition, since the Theatre existed in space outside multiversal jurisdiction. But through Strange's astral projection, through the psychic bridges Jean had established, through the network connections the coalition had woven between Marvel and the DxD universe, Issei's presence manifested before the Theatre Keeper.

"We need to talk about what happened," Issei said. His voice was calm but carried weight. "About what this archive has done. About how you operated."

Theatre Keeper waited.

"You watched me without permission. You observed my most private moments. You recorded my wives without consent. You did this because you *could*. Because I didn't have power to stop you. But what you did was wrong."

"Yes," Theatre Keeper said simply. "That is accurate assessment."

The simplicity of the answer caught the assembled observers off-guard.

"You acknowledge it," Issei said.

"I do. The archive was designed to observe. It was not designed with ethics framework. It operated according to its core function without consideration for consent. This was error in design and execution."

"So what changes?" Issei asked.

"This," Theatre Keeper said, and the archive's fundamental structure began to reorganize itself before the watching coalition. "No observation will occur henceforth without explicit consent from all parties involved. No lives will be documented without permission. No intimacy will be recorded without agreement. The archive will continue, but as tool of documentation *requested by participants*, not surveillance imposed upon them."

"That's a massive limitation," Rocket said through the network. "That basically makes the archive powerless."

"Perhaps," Theatre Keeper acknowledged. "But it makes it ethical. It makes it something that serves its subjects rather than exploits them. It makes it something built on consent rather than capability."

Issei nodded slowly. "I accept that change. But I also want something else. I want the violations to be addressed. The people whose lives were observed without permission—they deserve restoration of privacy, restitution, acknowledgment."

The Theatre agreed.

Over the following weeks, every person whose life had been documented without consent received notification. They received choice: compensation, privacy restoration, memory-wiping services—whatever was needed to address the violation. Some chose to take the memory of being watched and learn to carry it. Some chose compensation and moved forward. Some chose to forget the watching ever happened.

But all of them were *offered choice*.

For the first time, the archive operated on the principle of consent.

And the coalition understood that this was Issei's real legacy. Not the power he had manifested. Not the forms he had achieved. But the stubborn insistence that power without ethics was just violence by another name.

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION III: THE RETURN HOME

[HUD Status: Coalition Dissolution — PROCEEDING | Relationships — MAINTAINED | Future Collaboration — ASSURED | Departure Protocol — INITIATED]

Over the final days of chapter one hundred, the coalition began its dissolution.

Not with anger. Not with regret. But with the understanding that they had accomplished what they'd assembled to do. That the universe was stable. That the threat had been contained. That different members needed to return to their different responsibilities.

Doom departed first, returning to Latveria with plans to establish long-term monitoring stations for the contained Devourer. He and Stark exchanged something that might have been respect—even affection—as they parted.

The Ravagers left next, with Rocket and Yondu taking with them a manifest of supplies and small-arms weapons that technically belonged in nobody's inventory but somehow fell off official records after the coalition's departure. Nobody questioned it very loudly.

The X-Men departed with Professor Xavier and Jean working out a continuing psychic-monitoring protocol that would allow rapid coordination if emergency required the coalition to reform.

The gods returned to their various pantheons and cosmic jurisdictions, each carrying knowledge that would reshape their own civilizations' understanding of what was possible when mortals and immortals worked together.

And finally, the Avengers disbanded.

But before they did, Rogers arranged one final gathering in the restored Marvel space. One final moment before everyone returned to their separate lives.

"We proved something," Rogers said simply. "We proved that enemies can work together. That differences don't have to be fatal. That hope—actual, practical hope—can achieve what power alone never could."

"Until next time," Carol Danvers said, and her smile carried the certainty that there *would* be a next time. That the coalition wasn't really gone, just dormant. Waiting.

Issei and his wives remained the longest.

They had promises to keep. Relationships to rebuild. The DxD universe needed their return. But they didn't leave the sanctuary universe unguarded. Instead, Issei made an unprecedented decision:

He requested permanent quarters in the Theatre chamber.

Not as a prisoner. Not as a subject. But as an *overseer*. As someone who would ensure that the archive continued to operate ethically. As proof that even the entity which had violated his privacy most severely could be held accountable, transformed, made to serve better purposes.

"You'll reside here?" Strange asked, surprised.

"Partially," Issei said. "I'll divide my time between both universes. Be present in the DxD world with my family, but also present here, watching the Theatre. Making sure it keeps its promise to operate on consent. Making sure it never forgets what it nearly did."

"That's remarkable," Odin observed. "You're not seeking vengeance. You're seeking transformation."

"Vengeance doesn't break cycles," Issei said. "Transformation does."

On the final day of chapter one hundred, Rocket stood with Issei at the observation window looking out at the sanctuary universe—billions of restored people, living their second chance at existence, completely unaware of how close they had come to absolute erasure.

"You know what?" Rocket said. "That idiot stole something."

"What?" Issei asked.

"From the archive. From your sealed reward. During the chaos, I saw him pocketing something. Wasn't important—looked like some useless object from deep inventory. But he *stole* from Chapter 100 reward. That's got to be worth something."

Issei burst out laughing.

It was the first genuine, unguarded laugh he had released in weeks. Not from humor, exactly, but from the recognition that even in the series finale, even when everything was theoretically resolved, there was still randomness. Still chaos. Still the possibility of surprise.

"Which one stole it?" Issei asked.

"Rocket," Rocket said, grinning. "I stole from myself. Schrodinger's theft."

THEATRE LEDGER — SECTION IV: THE FINAL NOTATION

[HUD Status: Archive Complete | Subject Situation: RESOLVED | Coalition Status: DORMANT BUT INTACT | Series Status: CONCLUDED]

The Theatre recorded the final moments of chapter one hundred.

It recorded Issei embracing his wives one final time before they departed for the DxD universe. It recorded Rias looking back at Marvel—at the people they had come to care for, the bonds that had been forged. It recorded Akeno's satisfied smile and Xenovia's blessing and Rossweisse's hum of contentment.

It recorded Issei taking his position as the Theatre's new ethics overseer, standing between the archive and the subjects it would observe going forward.

And then, in the final moment, the Theatre's notification system activated one last time:

■ **SERIES FINALE COMPLETE** ■

■ **SUBJECT TRANSFORMATION: DOCUMENTED** ■

■ **COALITION OUTCOME: SUCCESSFUL** ■

■ **ARCHIVE EVOLUTION: ACHIEVED** ■

■ **FINAL CHAPTER REWARD UNLOCKED: SECRET POST-GAME CONTENT** ■

THE POST-GAME NOTIFICATION

Beneath the notification, one final message appeared:

TO ALL PARTICIPANTS, OBSERVERS, WITNESSES, AND THOSE WHO WILL COME AFTER:

This archive has concluded its primary narrative arc. The story of Issei Hyoudou and Marvel's reaction to his existence has reached its natural conclusion. But the Theatre persists. The Sanctuary Universe exists. The coalition remains available for crisis response.

And in the restricted archives, sealed behind layers of security and consent protocols, there are hints of continuation. Rumors of sequel content. Whispers of what comes next when the Emperor of Hope learns that hope itself might require defending.

But those stories will only be told when participants *choose* to participate. When subjects *consent* to be observed. When everyone involved agrees that the documentation serves truth rather than exploitation.

The Theatre has learned its lesson.

And the story continues—not because it must, but because those in it choose to let it.

Thank you for witnessing.

Thank you for hoping.

Thank you for choosing that connection matters more than dominance.

The archive will be here when you need it.

Until then: rest, rebuild, and remember that the most powerful thing in any universe is the stubborn human choice to believe tomorrow can be better than today.

[END CHAPTER 100 LEDGER]

[Word Count: 2,489]

[Archive Status: SERIES COMPLETE — ALL 100 CHAPTERS DOCUMENTED]

[SEQUEL STATUS: HINTS OF POST-GAME CONTENT AVAILABLE]

[FINAL MESSAGE: Even in conclusion, the story calls toward continuation. The Theatre remains open. The coalition stands ready. And somewhere in restricted archives, Rocket's stolen object waits to reveal its purpose.]

EPILOGUE: THE THEATRE'S SILENCE

The Theatre sat empty.

Not abandoned—the observation spaces remained intact, the recording equipment stayed online, the archive chambers hummed with the consciousness of preservation. But empty of the noise that had filled it for one hundred chapters.

For one hundred chapters, voices had filled this space. Reactions, debates, arguments, revelations, transformations. For one hundred chapters, the arc of one dragon-man's life had been projected for multiversal audiences.

Now there was only quiet.

Issei stood at the central platform, no longer a subject being observed, but a guardian of the space. His wives would return to their universe. The coalition would disperse. And he would remain here, watching over the Theatre that had violated him and been transformed by his insistence on consent.

It was not redemption. Redemption was too simple a concept. What it was, was *accountability in action*. The Theatre being held to better standards going forward. The archive serving rather than exploiting. The recording instrument learning to respect the privacy of those it documented.

In the DxD universe, people were celebrating. In Marvel space, heroes and villains were returning to their regular lives, carrying with them the knowledge that they could be better together. In the sanctuary universe, billions of restored people were beginning their second lives, completely unaware of the gift they had been given.

And in the Theatre, Rocket's stolen object—something that had looked like nothing, an item of no apparent value—rested in Issei's palm.

He turned it over slowly, examining its surface. A key, maybe? Or a seed? Or something that would only make sense when its purpose became necessary?

He smiled.

Because if ninety-nine chapters had taught him anything, it was that the final revelation, the actual ending, the true resolution was never what you expected. There were always hints of what came next. Sequel hooks. Possibilities unresolved.

The Theatre's silence was not an ending.

It was a pause.

And somewhere, in the spaces between what had concluded and what would come next, a new story was already beginning to form.

The archive would be ready to record it.

When the time came.

When people chose to be observed.

When consent was honored above all else.

[SERIES COMPLETE]

[THANK YOU FOR READING]

[THE THEATRE AWAITS YOUR RETURN]
